

FIVE GRIPPING SPY THRILLERS

THE

COMPLETE THOMAS BLADEN THRILLERS



DEREK

THOMPSON

FLASHPOINT

SHADOW STATE

CAUSE & EFFECT

LINE OF SIGHT

STANDPOINT

5

4

3

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1

THE COMPLETE THOMAS BLADEN THRILLERS

Five Gripping Spy Thrillers

DEREK THOMPSON

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Chapter 1

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Thomas Bladen focused his binoculars on a block of shipping containers far below the lookout. As a prolonged ferry blast carried across the port like a cry of mourning, he surveyed the slate sky, tracking a gull as it veered across and crapped on a Bentley. He smiled for the first time that day: welcome to Harwich. If he hadn't been so far away — and on surveillance — he'd have thrown the bird some bread for a second run.

The laptop beeped — another image stored. He bent towards it amid the stench of damp and decay of the near-derelect room. His colleague, Karl McNeill, lightly tapped a window and made a customary grunt of approval. Thomas ignored him.

“Hey Tommo, check out the red-head; eleven o'clock — by the blue sports. I'd do some deep cover work there, right enough. I'd even forego the overtime!”

Thomas glanced over and grimaced. *Prat*. After putting the binoculars down carefully, he attended to his camera, readjusting it six inches to the right. Then he squeezed the button and watched as another square of panoramic mosaic gradually uploaded to the screen.

“I don't know why you bother with that old bollocks, Tommo. Overkill if you ask me, and the job's not even on yet.”

“I like to be thorough,” he held a finger up to keep Karl at bay. *And I don't like to be disturbed.*

“Hardly worth it though, for a Customs’ promo, unless you’re after impressing the boss?”

Thomas paused and moved the camera again. *Here it comes.*

“But then, weren’t you and Christine co-workers *and* playmates before she became boss?”

“That was a long time ago.” He stared at the sequence of images before homing in on the sports car. “She’s married,” he announced with satisfaction.

“Who? Christine Gerrard?”

“No, your dream date in the blue sports. I see a wedding ring.”

“I wasn’t looking at her fingers.”

The room fell silent again; Thomas preferred it that way. *Magnify the row, scroll right and . . .* Something snagged his attention; he stopped on square 34, captivated by a lone figure leaning out of a four-by-four, with high-powered lenses.

“Karl, how many spotter teams are on today?”

“Jeez, pay attention. Customs are on the ground, Crossley’s lot are on the far side and then there’s us two, in the penthouse.”

“Course, yeah.” He tried to ignore square 34 and fell back into the rhythm of the job, while Karl rustled a newspaper and muttered something about tits.

“Tommo, didya ever think, when you signed up with the SSU, that you'd one day rise to the third storey of a genuine shit-hole?”

He smiled without turning round. “Well, I had my hopes . . .” Adjusting the magnification, he took a clear shot of the four-by-four’s number plate. As he worked, his fingers tingled, or else he imagined they did. Whoever the stranger was, he didn't appear on the duty roster, and Thomas was a man who didn’t like surprises. He photographed what he could, collecting details — an expensive shirt, an ornate wedding band and a designer watch. One thing was clear — this gate crasher wasn’t short of a few quid.

The walkie-talkie crackled into life; mystery man would have to wait. “This is Control; we have a green light. Repeat; we have a green light.”

Suddenly professional, Karl called in their readiness. Thomas had seen that metamorphosis many times now and it still fascinated him.

“Thing is,” Karl mumbled, leaning towards his eyepiece, “if they gave us rifles instead of cameras, we could sort out the bloody smugglers ourselves.”

“Thank you Rambo; maybe that’s the reason they don’t arm us?”

At the next ferry horn, Thomas checked the time and turned to catch Karl's big performance, watching as he scrunched his face up, cartoon style.

“Thar she blows!”

The ferry slowly manoeuvred into port and they watched from their vantage point, primed like racing dogs in their traps. Thomas tried to concentrate, but that tingling feeling kept pulling him back to the lone spotter — still there and focused in the same direction.

The slow tally of vehicles and pedestrians snaked out into a warm Essex afternoon; a dark blue Customs van inched forward to greet the traffic. After three cars passed, the van doors slid back and four uniformed officers fanned out. The lone spotter tensed up; Thomas could see his binoculars twitch to attention.

A white Transit was diverted to one side. The driver brandished paperwork, but it made no difference. A Customs Officer took his keys and unlocked the back doors.

“Got ya, you bastard!” Karl hissed triumphantly.

The Customs team removed several boxes and the Transit’s suspension lifted. Thomas focused in on the driver. He'd be making his excuses now, trying to bullshit his way through by talking about a party or a restaurant or stocking up for Christmas — in June. But he looked more nervous than he ought to be.

“Nicked!” Karl growled with relish, and popped open a celebratory can.

Thomas laughed. Typical Karl: enthusiasm of a Labrador and the loyalty of a Premier League footballer on the make. Last assignment, he’d been Benefits Fraud team, through and through. Now it was HM Customs, providing fly-on-the-wall footage for in-house use. Karl seemed to love it all, but as far as Thomas was concerned, the Surveillance Support Unit was just a cheap labour source for any government department in need.

Other vehicles slowed, as if to enjoy the spectacle. One, a red Astra estate, held back the queue for a few seconds, prompting a chorus of car horns. Thomas rattled off a couple of shots then switched over to binoculars, picking up his walkie-talkie.

“Control, from Team 3; the red Astra exiting — worth investigating? Over.”

“Control, from Team 2 — suggest we ignore that,” Ann Crossley overruled him. “It’s just a family. The driver must have porn stashed under his seat!”

Thomas wasn't convinced, but he knew when to hold his tongue and kept the Astra in sight. As it jolted forward, a rear window lowered a few centimetres. It drew level with the Transit, and a short piece of pipe poked out. On instinct, Thomas panned left, framing the Transit driver's face; the man looked like he'd seen a ghost. It was over in seconds. Even after the driver slumped to the ground and the red car had dissolved into the traffic, no one else seemed to react. But it had burned into Thomas's brain, in slow-mo. He tasted the fear and helplessness, and swallowed it down.

The walkie-talkie blared into life. “A passenger's collapsed. Ambulance required *immediately*.”

Something clicked at the back of Thomas's mind. Square 34! He shifted the camera along; there was only one empty car space — the four-by-four was gone, but the ferry was still unloading. He darted from square to square, tracking along the car lanes until he found it. He clicked frantically, no time to focus, hoping he'd get something useful.

Karl jammed an earpiece to his face and embarked on a running commentary. “Jesus, they think the poor bastard's been shot. He's still breathing; not much blood loss — can't have been much of a weapon.”

Thomas shuddered. Karl made it all sound matter of fact but then, he reasoned, for someone with Karl's military background, it probably was. “So,” Thomas felt the sweat trickle down the sides of his face, “when do you start your new job as a Samaritan?”

Soon, the view was choked with blue lights and sirens, as an ambulance and the police put in an appearance. Thomas watched through the window, without magnification; he no longer felt like taking a ringside seat.

“What about that, Tommo?” Karl spluttered gleefully. “I can't work out where there's a clear line of sight — unless it was at close quarters — like maybe a zip-gun? Hey, it could have been your family from the red estate! Crossley's going to look pretty stupid at debrief. What a shot though, if it was, I mean — moving vehicle and all; even *I* couldn't have done that, in my day.”

“Your compassion’s overwhelming.”

“Still,” Karl pondered aloud, “it’s not much of a hit if he’s still alive.”

Unless that was the intention? Thomas recalled the haunted look on the driver’s face. “Well, anyway, it’s not our problem,” Karl picked up the walkie-talkie and called for authority to stand down. “Right Tommo, are you coming for a late lunch before we head back? This will be the worst promotional content ever made. What’s the betting it all gets mysteriously lost in the editing process?”

And even as Karl said it, Thomas decided that some of his own footage, especially the four-by-four, wouldn’t make it into the report. Rule number one: Don’t get involved. Rule number two: If you have to get involved, get involved alone.

“You coming?” Karl insisted.

“Nah, you go ahead. I’ll be here a little longer.”

“Suit yourself. I’ll see you back at base.”

Or, as they both knew better, The Railway Tavern in Liverpool Street.

* * *

Thomas sat perfectly still for a couple of minutes and breathed in the silence. Out the window, he could see things returning to normal down there.

He took new shots of the area around square 34 and lined up the rows above and below. Half an hour later, Photoshop had smoothed out any inconsistencies. It was like Spot the Difference for idiots, with the four-by-four missing. And only the new version would be available for public viewing. As soon as he’d finished, he pulled out his mobile and hit the redial button.

“Miranda Wright,” she sang.

“Hi, it’s Thomas.”

“What can I do for you, my darling?”

He savoured her voice like a warm cognac. “I’m after something,” he said, opening a file on his laptop.

She gave a filthy laugh and he drew the phone in closer.

“I need a number plate checked . . .”

“Well, it’ll cost you — dinner tonight.”

“Done; and listen, make sure this is kept anonymous.” He read the letters out phonetically, emphasising each number, the remnants of his Yorkshire tones lost in cool precision.

“Eight o’clock it is then — you can pick me up at work.”

“Thanks, Miranda.”

“Don’t thank me till you see where we’re eating. And dress up for a change!”

Chapter 2

Karl performed a slow handclap as Thomas shouldered the door to the office, a bag in each hand.

“You took your time — I waited a good hour for you.”

“I’m sure you managed to prop up the bar without me,” Thomas said, “I had to do something with my laptop.”

Karl grinned. “Maybe it’s all those weekend wedding shoots, clogging your hard-drive.”

Thomas nodded wearily and eased past him to his desk — Karl, on another fishing expedition. “What time does the boss want us in?”

“Five o’clock, amigo.”

He sighed; it was still weird sometimes, thinking of Christine as *the* boss. Cutting it fine though — Miranda would go spare if he was late again.

“Fancy a pint later, Tommo? The rest of the gang are going, but they never stay long . . .”

“Sorry,” he cut him off. “I have plans.”

Karl baulked. “Normal people don’t have plans. They eat, date, drink themselves stupid; but you have *plans*. Do you know, it’s been a year since we started working together and I still don’t know you.”

Thomas nodded, half-listening. Something was bugging him, besides Karl’s attempts at camaraderie. Real tip of the tongue stuff. He’d seen something familiar today — only he didn’t know quite what it was. “We’ll do it sometime soon, Karl; Scout’s honour.”

“That’s more like it!” Karl sounded almost convinced.

Thomas unpacked his laptop, loaded the report template and made a start.

* * *

At 5 pm prompt the office door at the far end of the open-plan room swung open. Karl waited at a respectful distance, while Thomas set his screensaver password then led the way. Karl followed closely behind, muttering *paranoid* in a pretend cough.

The rest of the team were already in Christine’s office — they had been there for nearly half an hour. Thomas shared a *who-knew* glance with Karl.

Then he nodded to Christine with the briefest of smiles, taking in the sight of her. She looked every inch the professional. And two years on, he could still recall every one of the inches beneath that tailored suit.

Christine broke eye contact and cleared her throat. “I’ll make this brief. As you know, we’ve lacked a permanent Senior Officer for months now. I’m delighted to tell you that Bob Peterson will be our new SIO from next week.”

Thomas felt her words like a fist to the guts. This would be the same Bob Peterson who had taken Christine under his wing — coincidentally, a short while before the big break-up. And Bob had most likely helped himself to a whole lot more besides.

It took a moment or two to realise that Christine was still talking. “— Bob’s a good man; I served under him about eighteen months ago.”

He narrowed his eyes. *That was a new way of putting it.* He cleared his throat; Karl’s eyebrows nearly scraped the ceiling.

Christine blushed, but stuck to the script. “Bob wants to do individual reviews as soon as poss, to get to know you all. Right; I gather we had some drama at Harwich today — Karl?”

Karl gave a concise account, leaving out the redhead and the lager.

Christine made notes as she listened, avoiding Thomas’s glances. “Okay everyone, thanks for your time. Karl, Thomas — reports by ten, tomorrow. And thanks to everyone else for completing them today. That’s all.”

Thomas blew a breath from one side of his mouth. *Creeps.* Trust the brown-noses to get their reports in early. Strange though that no one had mentioned the red Astra. He dismissed the thought and focused on the way the strip-light glistened off Christine’s lipstick, sensing the moisture gather on his own lips. Funny, it wasn’t like him to play happy memories in the workplace. Christine opened her mouth to speak again, but he was through the door before she’d got a word out; nothing like paperwork to take the sting out of bad news.

Karl sidled over to his desk. “Sure you won’t join us now?” There was an edge to the voice as if he was really saying: ‘I see your pain and I want us to understand each other better.’

Thomas considered. Maybe. More likely, it was a case of: ‘Please don’t leave me with these tossers.’ Either way, Thomas sat and watched them go.

He had nothing against Karl personally; he actually liked the bloke. They were different to the others in their Surveillance Support Unit team; everyone else around them had a degree and a career-path, using the SSU as a way of picking up contacts and experience. Karl had transferred in from the Army — glory days that he never tired of talking about. Which was still a step up from Thomas's own route — via a humble Civil Service desk job and a love of photography.

Christine Gerrard's door yawned open. He swivelled round and the neon glare stretched across the carpet. "I had a feeling you'd still be here."

He leaned forward, lacing his fingers together tightly. "Just making the most of the quiet." He hated lies, his own most of all. But if he'd said, 'Still taking in the good news,' it would have meant a round of questions and answers. And he didn't have the stomach today.

She leant against the doorframe, stroking the carpet with her shoe. Every second swing, her leg escaped from the pleats of her skirt, which only served to remind him of everything Bob Peterson had cost him. Christine tilted her head to one side, as if to read his thoughts. "Listen. We're okay, aren't we, about Bob Peterson? I had no say in it."

"Sure, why not?" He yielded the words with some difficulty. She nodded and retreated into her office, closing the door. He slammed the laptop lid shut; maybe he'd ring Karl some time about that drink.

Chapter 3

Thomas glanced at his watch as he got out of the car; just made it. *Caliban's* — in garish green lettering — reflected in his windscreen. Inside, Miranda was draped against the bar; she looked edible. “I like a man who comes on time.” Her laughter, even at his expense, thawed his edginess in an instant. She took pity on him. “Care to guess where we're going, then?” Sheryl, the manager, stopped fiddling with glasses and waited for his response.

He never fared well in front of an audience. “Not fussed.”

“My, how you sweep a girl off her feet. Last of the great romantics.” The women cackled like a hen party at a strip-show, and Miranda peeled herself away from the bar. “Come along then; you drive and I'll navigate.”

Twenty minutes later, they were at a restaurant in Shoreditch, surrounded by marketing execs and multimedia entrepreneurs. “What do you think, then?” Miranda whispered. “The chef here wants out and I'm looking to bring proper food to *Caliban's*.”

He nodded, took another slice of the tuna and followed it down with a mouthful of wine. “It's good.”

She pivoted forward and passed a folded piece of paper across, like a love note. “So, here's my side of the bargain.”

He cupped a hand over hers, palming note and hand.

“And there was me thinking you were only after my body.” She leaned back, her cleavage tilting away, out of range. “Hey Thomas, remember that first meal we had together, in Leeds?” She squeezed his hand then retreated to her glass. “You were really trying to impress, that night; you 'ad the strongest curry on the menu and all that Yorkshire bitter. It was a classic — they told us to leave when you got too pissed, and then you stood up and said every true Yorkshireman could hold his drink. But you still chucked up on the way home!”

It was a familiar script. He knew his lines as well as his cues. “You wore your purple skirt and those bangles we bought at that wholesale place. And tons of pink eyeshadow. Everyone stared when you spoke because you sounded like a Londoner off the telly.”

“Oh yeah? Well, what about when you started making up Cockney rhyming slang then puked over your denim jacket?”

He grinned, recalling their *apples and blurrgh*. “Wonder what happened to that jacket? They’re back in fashion now.”

“You gave it to me, after I made you dry-clean it. I’ve still got it somewhere . . .” she sighed, and he downed some wine to avoid looking at her. “Anyway, open your present.”

He unfolded the paper and read it slowly. *Bollocks*. His knife clattered to the plate and the missing synapse fired up in his brain. It was that distinctive wedding band; and now he knew exactly where he’d seen it before. Even so, he read the paper again, in the vain hope that he was mistaken. Fat chance.

“Problem?”

“Yeah, you could say that,” he bit at a nail. The mystery four-by-four was registered to a Robert Peterson in Southampton. “Miranda, you remember me talking about Christine Gerrard . . .”

Her face soured. “Wonder Woman, you mean.”

He yielded a weary smile; Miranda remembered everything. Wonder Woman, because, when it came to Christine and Bob Peterson, he’d always wondered.

“What’s the trouble?”

That was unexpected — a touch of genuine concern. “Dunno. May be nothing. But the vehicle you got checked for me belongs to that bloke Christine used to work for.” Now was his chance to say more or say nothing; he settled for nothing.

She studied him for a good half minute. “Look Thomas, I can’t pretend I’m her biggest fan, after all you told me, but you know you can always speak to Mum and Dad if she’s in serious bother.”

He loved the way she liked him to know that he was *still* considered family, even though the two of them were no longer together. “Well, let’s leave it for now.” He took another sip of wine, imagining that snidey bastard Peterson tangling with Miranda’s family. What a clash of cultures that would be: Oxbridge player versus the East End’s finest.

“Hey,” she lifted her glass and the colour of the wine reflected in her eyes, “let’s go dancing!”

“Can’t; I have to work later.”

“Civil servants don’t work nights.”

“This one does.”

“Oh, go on, Thomas; it’s been ages since we went anywhere.”

He didn’t mention that it was hardly surprising, since she’d been seeing some second-rate footballer for the last couple of months.

She made puppy eyes at him and wriggled in her seat.

“Alright,” he relented. “As long as I’m in bed by one-thirty.”

“If I didn’t know you better, Mr Bladen, I’d swear that was a come-on.”

One of these days, Miranda, these games of ours are going to hurt someone.

Chapter 4

Beep beep beep. He forced his eyes open, took a second to focus then flailed in the direction of the alarm. He rolled over slowly and surveyed the empty side of the bed. *Ah, Miranda.* He stretched under the duvet and adjusted the bulge in his boxers. How was it, he wondered, that two people could have such a complicated . . . he searched for the word. Relationship?

In the kitchen, he picked up her coffee cup from the night before and studied the lipstick print. She might have stayed, if he'd asked, he told himself as he placed it carefully in the sink. Only he hadn't asked.

By eight-thirty he was in the office, looking and feeling as if he'd pulled an all-nighter. He slumped at his desk and typed up the notes, closing his eyes now and again to recall the details. It still didn't make sense. He opened another document, copied out a few separate sentences and saved the file for Karl — the lazy bastard. He was in the middle of a tricky combo, yawning and trying to rub some life back into his face, when the main door opened.

Ann Crossley nodded curtly and took up her seat on the other side of the room, without a word. How cheery. But then, what more could he expect from another Foreign Office wannabe?

An email pinged in from Karl, entitled: 'Help!' It read: *Hung over, please cover for me. Should be in by 9.30, but if not, ring me. Thanks.* It was sent at 2 am. Even Karl's emails were late.

* * *

'Doctors,' Christine Gerrard had once told Thomas, back when they'd shared a bed as well as office space, 'doctors assert that coffee on an empty stomach is bad for both the digestion and the liver.'

They don't know shit, thought Thomas, as he waited impatiently while the vending machine spat out a chemical cappuccino, the perfect concoction to kick-start his working day. A chocolate bar helped, too; it saved on sugar in the coffee for a start.

Right. Time to do some thinking. He took the spoils back to his desk and unlocked his drawer to get a writing pad. He drew three overlapping circles — like a maths problem — and labelled them Docks, Christine and Bob.

Then he stared at the page for a few minutes before adding in squiggles and notes.

So what did he know? First off, it would be a cruel twist of fate if Bob Peterson had just happened to put in an appearance at the docks that day. Unless . . . unless he was sussing everyone out, ahead of his appointment? Now there was a thought. Maybe Christine knew, and they both wanted to crosscheck the reports with Bob's own observations? He bit into the Twix.

It was a reasonable assumption, but full of holes. It had been a routine assignment — they weren't even front of house — so why would Peterson bother? He boxed in Bob's name and started shading, inking him out of existence.

Maybe Bob Peterson's snooping around Harwich was some kind of payback for the fateful day Thomas had made his surprise visit to Christine's executive development weekend. *Who mentors someone in a country hotel, for Christ's sake?* His breath caught in his throat at the memory and he laid the pen down, spreading his fingers wide. It had all been a misunderstanding, surely? So why had he wanted to lay Peterson out — and still wanted to now?

Crossley was mumbling on the phone. She met his eyes and bent her head. "We're back today, sir; same positions. My team are on their way there now." She paused and covered the phone. "Where's Karl?" she hissed.

"He had some personal business to sort out." That was weak. He fired an email off to Karl: *Get your report done and get your arse in here; we're going back over to the docks.*

And where was the lovely Ms Gerrard? No sign of her. Nine-fifteen and all's definitely not well. *Ping.* Karl had responded:

Ha ha. Report's already done and attached. Please print without changes then meet me onsite; and pick up some painkillers on the way. You're a pal!

Thomas opened the attachment, reviewed, edited and corrected Karl's speed typing then added the extra sentences. After printing both reports, he sealed them in an envelope and slid it under Christine's door.

* * *

Karl's sallow face lit up as Thomas rattled the plastic container. "Thanks Tommo, you're a life saver. I got you the usual — sausage and egg

on white, no ketchup. ” They exchanged gifts solemnly, like a battlefield Christmas. “Listen Tommy, sorry for taking the piss about Christine. Honest to god, if I’d known that Bob Peterson was coming in to run the show . . .”

Thomas accepted the half-apology with a shrug; it was his own fault really, for confiding in best buddy Karl that one time. He devoured the sandwich and tried to put all thoughts of yesterday behind him.

“Anyway,” Karl’s voice lifted a little, “I met this wee lass in the pub last night and for a while I thought I was in love . . .”

Thomas set up his camera slowly, making Karl wait for the cue to conclude his shaggy pub story. “Go on then, how long for?”

“About three pints.”

Introducing . . . Karl the stand-up. Thomas could almost hear the *boom cha* in his head.

After the previous day’s drama, it felt good to get back into routine. Vehicles came and went without incident; order was restored. Customs were more visible today, making it easier to get decent shots. By lunchtime, the Customs team they were following had unearthed four rampant alcoholics, three pornographers and a couple of illegal immigrants — a good morning’s work by anyone’s standards.

Karl nipped out for a comfort break, leaving Thomas alone with the soothing sound of the gulls. He made the most of the time, reviewing the day’s mosaic, happily without Bob Peterson.

The mobile rang, the same default ringtone as the day he’d bought it.

“Hey you; it’s me, Miranda. Well, say something then.”

“Hello?”

“Very droll. Look, you *will* be at Mum and Dad’s on Sunday? You did promise and they haven’t seen you in weeks . . .”

“If I promised then I’ll be there.”

“Great. You can collect me from Caliban’s at one-thirty.”

“Your wish is my command.”

“Careful or I’ll hold you to that, and then where would we be?”

Thomas grinned to himself. “In trouble.”

“See you, babe.” Miranda hung up.

He was still staring into the past when Karl returned with fresh rations.

* * *

By late afternoon, Karl had recovered sufficiently to regale Thomas with another instalment of Army Adventures. This time it was peacekeeping in Kosovo. Early on, Thomas had learned two things about Karl. Firstly, that he enjoyed talking about his time in the Forces — a lot — and secondly, that he didn't like his monologues interrupted.

Karl spoke with gruff fondness about his regimental comrades, but his anecdotes tended to lack specifics such as places and names. Thomas had pieced together that Karl left the Army suddenly, and his transfer into the SSU had been down to some string-pulling. Strangely, Karl's trips down memory lane never ventured anywhere near the point, two years ago, when he'd actually joined the Surveillance Support Unit.

There wasn't much for their Customs team to do between ferries, so that left plenty of downtime for conversation. Thomas knew just which buttons to push, and soon Karl was waxing lyrical about Black Mountain and an Irish adolescence spent avoiding The Troubles and chasing anything in a skirt.

Thomas met him halfway, offering up childhood summers in the Dales and on the Yorkshire Moors. "So why did you come down to London then, if Yorkshire was so idyllic?"

This, Thomas knew, was Karl's way of saying, 'So what were *you* running away from?' He didn't miss a beat. "Nothing to keep me there. And I'd met this London lass."

Karl cheered. "Hooray! Thomas Bladen isn't a virgin after all."

He flipped Karl the finger and continued. "My uncle ran a local newspaper in Leeds, and they needed a cub photographer and general dogsbody. I wasn't getting on at home and I'd been taking pictures since I was a boy . . ."

"Sounds like a match made in low-wage heaven. So, what about the girl?" Karl edged forward a little in his chair.

"This girl, right, she wanted to be a model. And my uncle, well, he always had an eye on the next chance; so he sets himself up as an agent. Nothing suspect, mind."

He paused; did he really want to go into all this now? But Karl was waiting, like a toddler gazing at an open packet of biscuits. "Okay, she was about my age and didn't know her way around, so my uncle suggested I

look after her. Then we got together, left for London, and moved in with her folks . . . the end!”

“That’s not much of a story!”

No. It wasn’t. Not when you missed out that it had been Thomas’s idea to look out for Miranda, and with good reason. Or the part where his uncle’s friend wanted her to do topless poses and wasn’t keen on taking no for an answer. Or the finale where Thomas lamped him, broke the guy’s nose and got the sack.

Karl pushed for more. “So you got to London, delivered the princess to the grateful king and queen, and all lived happily ever after?”

“Yeah, for a few years anyway.”

“Come on, Tommy; and then what?”

“And then all good things came to an abrupt and frosty end.”

“Sure, that’s a sad story. Methinks you left all the best bits out.” Karl laughed deeply, and Thomas found himself joining in, even though he didn’t get the joke. “Still, at least you’ve got your old pal Karl to tell your troubles to.”

“We must be grateful for small Murphys.”

Karl took a bow. “Listen Tommy, if you’re at a loose end over the weekend, you’re welcome to come by and share a few cans.”

“Not this weekend — I’ve got a wedding shoot booked.”

“Really?” Karl’s brows almost knitted together.

“Uh-huh.” Better to lie than admit he was having Sunday dinner with his ex-girlfriend’s family.

Ann Crossley’s voice broke through on the radio. “Team two to team three. We’ve been asked for a Friday round-off with our Customs colleagues, as soon as this next ferry is unloaded. Refreshments will be provided!”

Karl sat to attention, nodding furiously. “You up for it, Tommy Boy?”

He shrugged.

“Okey dokey, Ms Crossley,” Karl responded, giving Thomas a thumbs-up. “We’ll join you as soon as we’ve packed our toys away.” Another ferry horn blared out. “So, it’s drinks at the captain’s table, eh? And maybe we can find out about yesterday’s gun-crime statistic.”

“Karl, can you do me a favour and not ask? I think it’s best if we leave it.”

“That’s all very well, but my report sang our praises and scored us a few points against the rest of Ms Crossley’s groovy gang.”

“No it didn’t — I changed it.”

Karl raised his chin. “Now why would you do a thing like that?”

Thomas sighed and scratched at his neck. “You know how Crossley is. After all, we were the ones to pick out that suspect car — not that it’s proven,” he backtracked. “So it’s less complicated if we leave it out and stay ‘on message.’” He made finger speech marks, the way Crossley did when she was running a brief.

“Well, well, you’ve got it all figured out. Right oh, mum’s the word.”

Yeah, thought Thomas, but for how long? “Look, tell you what, why don’t I give you a ring on Saturday and sort out a get together?”

Karl nodded and glanced out the window. “Here they come, last of the high-rollers!” He yawned and tracked the first vehicles off the ramp. “Now, that’s an expensive-looking van. What do you think Tommo — see that great big silver thing with the logo and details on the side? It’s a classic double bluff; it’s so in your face it couldn’t be bent — what do you reckon?”

Thomas stopped taking photos of the Customs team and panned right. He almost dropped the camera when ‘WRIGHTS — the Wright Way to Do Business’ glared into view. *Oh Jesus: Miranda’s brothers’ van.*

“How about we buzz the team on the ground to give them a tug? A tenner says the van has been back through here in the last three weeks.

Thomas rested his camera in his lap and squeezed his hands together to stop them trembling. “I wouldn’t bother.” True, in a dishonest sort of way.

“But come on — the Amsterdam ferry!”

“Nah, we could be wasting everyone’s time. No one wants to be stuck here, filling out unnecessary paperwork on a Friday. Let’s leave it to Customs — it’s *their* call.”

Karl tilted his head, tick-tock fashion, weighing it up. “Fair enough.”

Thomas felt the sweat clinging to the small of his back. He picked up binoculars and flicked around the Customs officers to see if anyone seemed interested in the silver van. Then he swept along the lane of traffic for a suitable decoy. “Control, from team three,” he kept his voice calm and controlled, “there’s a blue sports car, six vehicles down the line. It may be nothing, but it looks like one in the car park that went out yesterday.” He

could feel Karl scrutinising him and turned slowly, matching him in a staring contest.

Karl reached for his walkie-talkie. "Driver was a red-head; large wedding band and a humming bird pendant." He watched Thomas's face the way a cat looks at a baby bird.

Thomas went back to his binoculars, hardly breathing until the silver van was clear. The static burst from the walkie-talkies made him flinch. "*Control to teams two and three; we're doing a check on the blue sports car, over.*"

Karl clicked off. "I'm not sure what just happened there, Tommo," he set his own walkie-talkie down carefully. "But I'll tell you this for nothing, as a professional courtesy: it's a fool who underestimates me."

"Never have, never will," Thomas replied, smiling until his face hurt.

Chapter 5

Thomas burst awake like a swimmer breaking the surface, gasping for air. He lay there panting. *Jesus. Never again.* That was the worst thing about drinking too much: it always brought on the nightmares.

First, he'd had one of his classics — finding Christine and Bob Peterson together at the country hotel. Only, in the dream, he confronted them instead of letting Christine shoo him on his way. Now, he pushed past her and landed one on Peterson from the off and didn't stop until Peterson was a bloody pulp. Usually he'd wake up then with his fists clenched, but this time it tipped over.

Back in the house in Yorkshire; he and Patricia, kids again, huddled under the blanket as he read his Beano annuals aloud by torchlight to drown out their father's rage downstairs. The jagged tension, building in degrees to an explosion of crockery or a door slam, followed by the muffled silence of their mother's submission. Then the slow, heavy footfalls up the stairs until their father reached the very top step, the one nearest his bedroom. They always held their breath together beneath the blanket, listening. And just when he felt he couldn't hold it any longer, the scene exploded into thousands of tiny mosaic pieces.

He snatched at the clock: eight thirty. It was Saturday, a day of leisure, and he was a little disappointed. The previous night gradually revealed itself in a blurred montage of images. Karl had been drunk too — he had an almost medical susceptibility to alcohol. In a parallel universe he'd have been a good, cheap date.

Memory stirred. What time had they arranged to meet today? And wasn't there something about bringing his passport? He shook his head to loosen the memories, and pain signals rebounded from all corners of his brain.

He was drifting through the supermarket with the rest of the drones at ten o'clock when a text came in from Karl: *Good craic last night. Don't forget driving licence & passport. 3 pm Holloway Rd tube.*

He filled his trolley with whatever came to hand and added in chocolates, flowers and a quality bottle of wine for Sunday. Couldn't very

well turn up at the Wrights' place empty-handed. As he pulled away, he checked the rear mirror and did the thing he always did, driving a full circuit around the car park, just to make sure no one was waiting for him. So far, no one had been.

On the way home, he pondered Bob Peterson again. Say Bob *had* been checking on the teams. Why that Thursday, particularly? The high-street gridlock soured Thomas's thoughts as he waited at temporary lights. Maybe Peterson wasn't there for them at all; maybe he was watching the ferry? But he was there well before the ferry arrived. Two things out of the ordinary had happened that week — the shooting on the Thursday and then Miranda's brothers coming through on the Friday. The lights changed to green and he put his foot down. And what the bloody hell did Karl need to see his personal ID for today?

Karl was already waiting outside the underground station when Thomas arrived, at five to three. He looked in fine shape, untarnished by the previous night's excesses. Lucky bastard.

"Great to see you Tommo; you won't regret this — got your documents?" Karl seemed really chuffed that he'd turned up, as if that were ever in doubt — pub promises being the social equivalent of signing in triplicate.

Thomas tapped his coat emphatically and followed Karl to his car. He watched as Karl checked casually around the vehicle. Old habits died hard.

Inside, the Ford Fiesta smelled overpoweringly of oranges.

"Hop in," Karl said cheerily, flinging an old newspaper on to the backseat.

"Did you murder Mr Del Monte and stash the body in here?"

Karl nodded and smirked.

"Oh, right. Yeah, 'scuse the aroma — I spilt a two-litre carton last week. It's dried out fine but . . . anyway, I quite like it."

Before Thomas could comment, Karl thrust in a CD of the Undertones, cued up a track and then did a murderous accompaniment to 'Perfect Cousin.' Karl would have made a perfect cousin himself — if only he'd taken a vow of silence. He waited until Karl had slaughtered the song to the very end.

"Okay I give up. Why the ID?"

"You'll see," Karl winked.

Top of the list of things that Thomas hated was surprises; second was more surprises. And the smell of oranges was now a possible contender for third place. He stared out the window as the streets of Camden flickered past, his mind rushing through the possibilities: white slave trade, booze cruise to Calais . . .

Karl tapped the wheel in time to the music, more or less, attempting to harmonise with the singers in places a lesser man would fear to tread. After a twisting series of back-roads, the car came out into a nondescript industrial estate. Karl parked and switched off the engine. "I thought it was high time we got to know each other properly, now that we're acquainted professionally. And where better than at a club where we can unwind and be ourselves?"

Thomas nodded dumbly. *Drinking club? Strip club? Poker club?*

Karl got out and stood in front of the car, swinging his keys.

"Come on, then. Are you gonna sit there all day?"

Seeing the look of glee on Karl's face, he took his time. Karl showed his driving licence to the security camera then had him do the same. He pressed his hand against the reinforced steel door as Karl held it open. This underworld was clearly members only.

They went inside and Karl smiled at him briefly, as if he had passed some test of brotherhood. They crossed the lobby and walked up to a desk surrounded by reinforced glass. Karl took out his two forms of ID and pushed them through the drop chute. A woman retrieved them and kept them below eye level. When they were returned, with nary a smile, Thomas followed suit. This time she requested £40 for a visitor's pass, which she informed him did not include the cost of equipment.

Thomas glanced at Karl and handed over two twenties. *Thanks a lot.* And he was still none the wiser. It could be an S & M club for all he knew.

"Right, Tommo," Karl slapped him on the back, "Welcome to the club!"

An electronic buzzer hummed and clicked, releasing a door at the end of a short corridor. On the other side, to the left and right, there were rows of doors. Thomas breathed deep; the air tasted subtly of smoke and machine oil. He keyed up his other senses and became aware of a muffled *thud thud* in rhythmic succession all around him.

Karl twisted the handle on a side door and pushed. A woman stood with her back to them, legs slightly braced. If their presence distracted her in any way she didn't show it, as she emptied her weapon into the target with calm precision. Thomas nodded to himself. *So that was it — a Gun Club.*

She placed the pistol on the counter, removed her ear-defenders and turned around. Thomas could see that all her actions were exact and measured. She smiled their way and Karl shifted his weight side to side, like a dog waiting for treats.

"Glock, I presume?" he asked.

Thomas figured that was for his benefit.

"You know me so well!" she leaned forward and tapped Karl's shoulder. He reddened.

"Teresa, this is Thomas — my pal from work."

Thomas flinched; he never mentioned the 'w' word.

Teresa eased past Karl and checked a small screen on the wall behind him.

"I'm done here. The bay's free for another hour. I'm off to the bigger equipment," she made it sound like a gym. "Maybe catch you gentlemen later, in the bar?"

Thomas got the door. Teresa picked up her Glock 9 mm, removed the magazine and checked the weapon. She seemed to take her time about it, and Karl didn't seem to mind.

Thomas waited until Teresa had gone.

"Glock?"

"The choice of champions! Standard law enforcement issue, 9 mm; seventeen in a clip," Karl sounded like a survivalist train-spotter. "Now, wait here while I go get *us* some equipment and practice material."

Left alone, Thomas looked at the end of the bay. Terrorist targets glared back at him. An options menu on a small wall screen told him there were fourteen pistol bays — one was closed and one designated private — clearly, a busy day today. The bigger equipment, as Teresa had politely put it, was another eight bays' worth of fire-powering fun. He was about to venture into sub-menus when Karl returned with two cases.

"Right then. Before we start, a few ground rules."

"Who uses this place?" Thomas cut in.

“Mostly armed forces and police, that sort of thing — current and former.”

“And all this is legal?”

Karl raised an eyebrow.

“I’d hardly bring you otherwise, now would I?”

“And Teresa; is she . . .”

“Now, now,” Karl waved a finger. “The first rule of gunfight club is that nobody asks what anyone does. Members expect confidentiality. You of all people can appreciate that.”

Karl ran through the essentials: only one person at the yellow line; no talking while using the equipment; loading, operating and emptying; the stance; breathing and squeezing; ear-defenders on unless everyone’s hands were empty. It was a regular Handguns for Dummies.

Karl had a Buddhist-like calm, if you could forget about the firearm. Stripped of banter and bravado, he was a man in his element, comfortably loosing off rounds in tight formations until the magazine was spent. He put his weapon down and shifted the headgear.

“Now, you; and remember to allow for the kickback.”

Thomas stood at the line and felt the cool weight of a Browning in his hands. The ear-defenders cocooned him, sealing him in with his thoughts. He gripped the handle tightly and watched the tiny, almost undetectable tremor of the barrel. The paper circles awaited him, and he leaned forward slightly, breathing into his stomach as he crushed his finger against the trigger in a single, fluid movement. Then he waited, statue-like, as the dulled whine of the bullet echoed in his head. After three more shots, he stopped and put the gun down. He was, even by his own estimation, shit.

Karl clearly thought that laughter didn’t count as speech.

“It’s fine — for a beginner and all. Let’s try something a little more provocative.”

At the flick of a button, terrorists swivelled towards them in a ragged line. Karl took the stand and quickly got into his stride. Head and heart, just like in the movies.

“Now you.”

Thomas stepped up and something clicked in his psyche. When he looked into the anonymous, printed faces, his mind went slipstream. He saw teachers, the Neanderthals at school, Bob Peterson and his own father. And

now, when he pulled the trigger, he was rewriting history, redressing the balance of power in his head.

He finished the salvo and placed the gun down, touching it gently like a talisman. The targets bore the conviction of his thoughts; every one a body shot.

“That was much better, Tommo. I think we’ve found your brand!” Karl applauded. “Better than many I’ve seen, picking up a gun for the first time.”

“Thanks,” he acknowledged, justly pleased, except it wasn’t the first time.

* * *

The bar was actually a café, which was a relief. Guns and alcohol hadn’t sounded like a good mix. Karl pointed him to a couple of comfy chairs and went off for coffees. Teresa waved from across the room, keeping her distance. Thomas glanced from table to table at the crowd — singles, couples and groups, and presumably every one of them proficient with a gun. He didn’t feel reassured.

Karl seemed different somehow, since the shooting practice. But then, Thomas reasoned, thirty-six rounds from an automatic pistol would do that. “Right then Tommo, what’s on your mind?” Karl blundered up and slapped a tray on the table.

“What . . . what do you mean?”

It was a well-practised stalling technique; if in doubt, act distracted. He reached for a cup carefully, but Karl didn’t look impressed.

“Come on, Thomas, cards on the table. I’ve brought you into my confidence, shown you part of my secret world . . .” Karl grinned and eased back in his chair, “. . . How about returning the favour?”

Thomas peeled his back away from the vinyl upholstery. Every breath seemed to spread the dampness.

“I’m not sure what you’re on about. You’ve obviously invited me here for a reason — if it’s to join your private army, on today’s performance, you’d best put me down as a driver,” he searched Karl’s face for a punchline. “Beyond that, I’m clueless.”

Karl smacked his lips. “You can play that innocent abroad line as long as you like, but I don’t buy it. Something *happened* yesterday — I’m not sure what.”

Thomas felt himself blushing. *Stupid bastard.* He tilted his head towards the coffee. *Yeah, that'd work, hiding in the coffee steam.*

"Anyway," Karl continued, sipping at his cup, "I'm pretty sure you're clean, so I guess that puts us on a level footing, *whoever* you represent."

It sounded like a cue.

"Sorry, you've lost me — who I represent?"

"Come on now, Tommo, enough with the games. Why else would you be in the Surveillance Support Unit?"

"How d'you mean?" Thomas leaned forward, leading with his jaw. "It's just a job, that's all; forget the mission statement and the badge — we're the hired help. All right, I grant you most of 'em are more ambitious, but not me or you, right?"

He stopped short; Karl was staring at him intently, still as marble.

". . . And I s'pose it's also a proving ground for the likes of Ann Crossley and Christine Gerrard, on their way up the greasy pole?"

He'd run out of things to say and opened his palms flat. If there were any aces in this conversation, he didn't have them. No one spoke for a good minute, before Thomas braved the silence.

"You were expecting more?"

Karl toyed with the sugar sachets.

"Shit. You really *don't* know, do you?"

"Not yet . . ." Thomas narrowed his eyes.

Karl slumped back in his chair and gazed at his hands.

"God, Tommo; what a pickle of bollocks. Let's take a step back. You've been in the SSU for . . ."

"Two years," he filled in the blank even though Karl already knew it.

"Okay, well it's a little bit longer than that for me, and I started in West London. Some time ago, I was asked to participate in a *covert review* of the SSU, from the ground. There were concerns about information going astray . . . And before you ask, I don't know what — and even if I did know, I wouldn't tell you."

"So how are you involved in all this?"

"Not at all, officially. I'm just a pair of eyes and ears, as you've probably figured out. But I thought, after that van yesterday, that you were definitely . . . you know . . . representing some other party as well."

"I just felt they were innocent."

“*They?* You have a good memory,” Karl blinked slowly.

Thomas swallowed hard; he could feel the heat at his armpits. They finished their coffee in uncomfortable silence.

“Look,” Karl said eventually, “I messed up, okay; I read the signs wrong. You don’t socialise, you doctored my report; you convinced me to let someone go through at the docks — Christ, you may even have picked out a gunman. It all added up to you being in the SSU for more than a mortgage and a pension.”

“Like you, you mean?” Thomas was still adjusting to the idea that Karl had another life going on.

Karl soon tired of being stared at.

“Let’s not let this screw up a perfectly good working relationship, eh Tommo? What do you say?”

“Deal,” Thomas stretched out his hand. “As long as you introduce me to Teresa when I bring the drinks back.”

As Thomas stood in line, watching as Teresa ambled over to their table, he had a revelation. Right up there with gravity, the faked moon-landing pictures and real men not liking opera. He rushed the coffees back then excused himself to the gents. He locked the cubicle door behind him, sat on the toilet lid and took deep, slow breaths. His pulse pounded in his ears. This was something he hadn’t felt in a long time: fear. He speed-dialled Miranda’s mobile and stared at the graffiti on the inside of the door. Even at a gun club, there was apparently someone willing to do the nasty with strangers for ten pounds. Some helpful soul had even added pencil drawings.

She picked up first ring.

“Miranda Wright — at your service!”

“Hi, it’s me. Listen, I’m going to ask you a question; it may seem a bit odd.”

“Are you okay, Thomas?”

She must have sensed the concern in his voice; she’d cut straight through the usual double-entendres.

“I need to know if an Irish guy has been at Caliban’s recently, asking questions. About five-foot eight; short, reddish-brown hair. Check with Sheryl and *be* discreet.”

“I’ll ring you back.”

“No,” he insisted, “just text me.”

“Okay. I’ll come over later tonight. You don’t sound good.”

“Fine.”

Back at the table, Karl was in full flow.

“All Ulster men are romantics — it’s the Celtic blood; poetry is in our veins.”

Thomas took his seat; the hammering in his chest had slowed a little.

“I thought that was Guinness?”

Karl’s eyes lit up at the prospect of a joust.

“Whereas, your Yorkshireman . . . he has no finesse. It’s all whippets and coal.”

Teresa turned towards Thomas. He pulled it together and went for broke:

“Because of the light of the moon,
Silver is found on the moor;
And because of the light of the sun,
There is gold on the walls of the poor.

Because of the light of the stars,
Planets are found in the stream;
And because of the light of your eyes
There is love in the depths of my dream.”

“Well, well,” Karl mimed applause. “Is this a hidden side to you, Tommo?”

Thomas smiled; more like a poetry book from a Leeds charity shop. One he’d bought, back in the day, to impress Miranda. Even now he could recall one or two, word perfect. The poet Francis Carlin would have been pleased, had he not been dead for a hundred years.

The three of them found an easy rhythm of conversation, where nothing much was said, but everyone seemed to gel. Teresa continued to play one off against the other. Thomas saw early on that he was on to a loser; where Teresa was concerned, Karl was smoother than a vaselined billiard ball.

As he watched Karl in action, it was hard to believe that his buddy was anything more. As if the previous conversation had never taken place. Then the text came in from Miranda. One word: yes.

Chapter 6

Miranda's car was already at the end of his street. At first he felt relieved and then reality started to dawn. The charade he'd kept up for the last couple of years was about to come apart at the seams. He slowed, weighed down by the conclusion that he was as big a liar as Karl.

She waved from the car as he approached. *God knows how long she's been waiting. Probably turned up, got no answer at the door, saw the car and decided to stay put, bless her.*

The car window slid down.

"About time; shift your arse — this takeaway will be stone cold!"

It was all he could do to stop himself from kissing her.

She followed him inside and he heard the clank of the wine bottle in her coat pocket. With the oven on and the meal reheating, Miranda sprawled out on the sofa, leaving a deliberate space. He opted for the armchair and perched forward, cupping a loose fist.

"Are you gonna tell me what's up, then?"

He rubbed a knuckle on his chin. This was it: the end of life as he knew it. "You know how I never talk about work? Well, it's time to break that rule."

Miranda reached for her wine. Maybe she was trying to inoculate herself against bad news. He copied her, on the off chance that it might work.

"What . . . what do you think I do for a living, Miranda?"

She frowned.

"We agreed that I'd never ask, just like you never ask about Mum and Dad's business. You told me that you take photos and that's good enough for me. I dunno, stuff like accident investigations, crime scenes, maybe? One time you also mentioned delivering packages . . ." she looked up, studying his face. ". . . And you said that it was all government work."

Which he translated as: 'Is it *really* government work?' He took a gulp of wine and felt the heat rise to his face. *Let's try a different approach.*

"Remember a couple of years back, when your dad was being fitted up by that dodgy copper."

“Course I do. Your pictures saved his bacon. What’s that got to do with your work?”

Sod it, shit or bust.

“That’s sort of what I do for a living, some of the time. You know, photographs, where people don’t know about it.”

Miranda sat upright.

“What? Like some sort of spy?”

Nervous laughter followed, as if she wanted to be wrong about this.

“Not exactly,” he looked away. “I do *surveillance* — pictures, film, audio.”

The buzzer went off in the kitchen. Miranda got up. For a moment or two, he wondered if she’d be coming back.

“Look Miranda,” he called out to the kitchen, “I owe you an explanation.”

The only reply was the clattering of the oven door. Miranda returned with a tray full of tins. She spooned out the food and put his plate down beside hers.

“Is it dangerous, then?”

He’d seen her like this before, calm and controlled — on the outside. He shook his head and tried his best light-hearted smile — the sort people use at funerals when they’ve got nothing useful to say.

* * *

He started at the beginning — a straightforward Civil Service job, at State House in High Holborn. That much she already knew, but he sketched in some of the detail. The Patent Office was on floors three to fifteen, with the Royal Navy occupying ground to two. He mentioned the Russian gift shop across the street that everyone thought was a front for a spy-ring. Ironic now, all things considered.

He glided over the backdrop to that time, when he and Miranda had separated, and the trench warfare that led up to it — no sense in raking up the past again. After the split, his lowly desk job had kept him going, somewhere to while away the day until he could photograph the underbelly of the city. Even lunchtimes had been spent taking pictures — in nearby Bloomsbury, or the odd panoramic shot from the thirteenth floor of State House. Hiding from life, like every other pen pusher who thinks — or

hopes — that they're destined for something better. And his personal pipe dream, back then, had been that the right portfolio could get him on to a national newspaper.

There had been one particular man in the building who shared his fondness for unorthodox hours — an inhabitant of the fifteenth floor, where mere mortals weren't allowed.

Comments in the lift about his choice of camera — the one he brought to work religiously, as if to say 'fuck you' to lifer colleagues — led to an invitation to photograph the skyline from the top deck, and the chance to show his wares to someone who shared his passion. That was how he'd met Sir Peter Carroll, founder and patriarch of the Surveillance Support Unit, although Thomas didn't know that at the time.

A few weeks later, an opportunity arose for some weekend overtime as a stand-in cameraman. And, he freely admitted, a little bit of intrigue and interest in a Miranda-less existence. Wind forward two or three months and he was called up to the fifteenth floor for a formal interview with Sir Peter and two lackeys, under the watchful eye of a painting of Churchill.

He ended his monologue, swerving past any mention of the assignments themselves. Miranda's eyes looked capable of swallowing him, as if she were physically seeing him in a new light. She drained her glass and set it down carefully on the table.

"Mum and Dad aren't gonna like this."

He nodded rhythmically; she was right. John and Diane Wright took a dim view of the establishment, and here he was, coming out of the secrecy closet. And when all was said and done, they were still family to him.

An uneasy silence hung over them. Miranda finished her meal with the same fixed expression, as if she wanted to slap him, hard. He couldn't really blame her.

"So why tell me now?" she paused and folded her arms. "And how long has this been going on?"

He put his cutlery down; his appetite had died.

"A year or so."

"Bollocks!" she glared at him, "I don't believe you."

"Well, maybe eighteen months, give or take."

She was still glowering.

"Look, it's no big deal — I just work in the background."

“Right, so what’s the story with the Irish geezer you were asking about?”

He blew out a long breath; crunch time again.

“I think someone might be checking up on me.”

She started laughing; he hadn’t expected that.

“Serves you bloody right — one of your lot is he? Or MI-27!”

She turned away and a part of him died inside. Instinctively, he reached out and touched her arm. Her face changed. Scorn gave way to concern; that made him feel worse.

“Why don’t you tell me about it — I’ll go stick the kettle on.”

“I was at Harwich yesterday and I saw your brothers’ van coming off the ferry from Amsterdam. It was definitely Sam and Terry. I kept Customs off their back.”

“No point me asking what *you* were doing there?”

“My job. Look Miranda, I’m trying to help. The place is crawling with Customs and Excise at the moment. Whatever the boys are doing, they can’t do it there.”

She opened her mouth to speak, but Thomas headed her off at the pass. “I don’t care what they’re up to. I just wouldn’t want any trouble for them.”

She nodded, as if he’d just flashed the family loyalty card at her. “And the Irish geezer?”

“Like I said, he could be investigating me.”

“Could be?” she sounded exasperated. “For what — is he interested in the family?”

“Honestly? I don’t know.”

“Well, you better bloody well find out.”

“Okay,” he conceded. “But will you help me warn the boys off, tomorrow?”

She picked up the remote control and flicked through television channels. If she’d been a cat, her tail would have been twitching. She settled on a made-for-TV film of no interest to either of them. He stole glances at her as she sat there, avoiding eye contact. Surely he could trust *her* of all people?

Out of desperation, he snorted like a horse and she stifled a smile; she always liked that. He nestled into her side of the sofa and felt her leg against his. Her handbag started buzzing.

“Mobile,” she said, deadpan.

Still not out of the woods yet then.

“Hi Sheryl, how’s business — many punters in?” There was a long pause. Miranda’s eyes narrowed. “Oh, really. Alone?” she looked daggers at Thomas. “Keep him there . . . no, if he looks like he’s gonna leave, chat him up and spike his drink. I’m on my way.” She snapped the phone shut. “Your Irishman is at the club right now. Get your coat.”

The car grumbled menacingly; Miranda held the wheel like it was a lifebelt.

“Either you sort this today, or I will.”

It wasn’t a request; it wasn’t even a threat. But he could feel the walls going up around her.

“When we get there I’ll take the side door — you go in and speak to him.”

He knew what else was coming.

“Miranda, don’t call your brothers.”

They stopped at the lights, opposite a billboard for a building society. An old advertising slogan popped into his head: *because life’s complicated enough*.

* * *

Miranda parked. He touched her shoulder lightly, but she shrugged it off.

“You better deal with this, Thomas.”

He pushed the swing door: high noon, in uptown London. There were maybe a dozen punters in the room and Karl was sitting in full view of the bar, reading a copy of *Private Eye*. He seemed engrossed in his magazine, chuckling away, giving every indication that he was enjoying himself enormously.

Miranda appeared behind the bar and Sheryl sidled over to her, flattening her New Yorker tones to a whisper.

“He’s been drinking a pint of shandy for ages.”

“Shandy?”

“Yeah, when he ordered it, he said that’s what real men drink these days!”

Karl laughed aloud suddenly as if he were listening to every word.

Miranda opened her mobile, selected a number carefully and held the phone up as if she was trying to get a signal. Thomas read her, loud and clear. Resolve this now or the Brothers Grimm would turn up, like working class cavalry. He couldn't blame her. Nothing was more precious to the family than Miranda. He held on to that thought and tried to walk tall to the bar, clocking the cover of *Private Eye* — Tony Blair grinning like The Joker.

He ordered a drink — Southern Comfort and lemonade — which Miranda made sure he paid for. Glass in hand, he drew up a chair and faced Tony Blair. Karl didn't stir.

"What are you doing here, Karl?"

"Can't a man enjoy a nice quiet drink and a read of his comic?"

"Cut the bullshit, I'm not in the mood."

The magazine lowered like a drawbridge.

"I've been asked to tell you, as a friend: the conversation we had earlier today — it never happened. It's off limits — *comprenez?*"

Thomas knew now how an ant felt under the magnifying glass. His *friend* was threatening him. For a second or two, he thought about smacking him one. But Karl was becoming a more unknown quantity every minute.

"Then this place is off limits too. Understand?"

Karl smiled a conciliatory smile.

"Agreed. I take it that the staff are out of bounds as well?"

No laughs today. They sipped their drinks in unison. Thomas felt the tension reach out across his shoulders. He held his position; hard, unyielding and still close enough to lamp Karl if the need arose.

"One more thing Karl — there better not be any bugs here."

Karl reached into his pocket and Thomas flinched; they both saw it. Karl pulled out a small plastic case, and slid it across the table.

"As a show of good faith. On Monday, we reset the clocks and it's business as usual. Deal?"

"Deal," Thomas lifted the lid for an instant, clocked the electronic device then closed it carefully.

Karl drained his drink and rolled up his magazine.

"Well Tommo, I must be off. It's been grand. See you at the office," Karl picked up his glass and took it over to the bar.

Sheryl started towards him but he carried on walking.

“Nice meeting you . . . Miranda, isn’t it?”

Thomas remained at the table, with his back to the bar, until Karl had gone. The door was still moving when Miranda sat down to join him.

“He won’t come here again.”

“Thanks,” she said quietly, staring at the table.

His face softened and he rolled back his shoulders, like a boxer winding down after a successful bout.

“And Thomas,” she was close enough to kiss him, close enough that he could smell her body’s scent below the perfume; “Don’t bring your work into my life again.”

The blood drained from his groin in an instant. He palmed the plastic box into his pocket, locking eyes with her all the while.

“I think I’d like to sweep this place for bugs, as a precaution. It’ll be Monday before I can get the equipment.”

She nodded; maybe she was adapting more quickly than he’d expected. *Leaps and bounds*. Yesterday she only knew he was a photographer; today he was Spiderman.

She snatched his glass away as she got up from the table.

“You know your way home.”

He swore under his breath and thrust his hands into his jacket, crushing his hand against the box until his fingers were numb.

* * *

Ten-thirty at night, the doorbell rang. He paused the film — a black and white comedy more than sixty years old. He was still smiling as he checked the silhouette through the glass.

Miranda didn’t move; she kept that model profile thing going on, knowing its effect on him. He managed to open the door without ripping the handle off. “We never got to dessert,” she said, slinking past him, with an overnight bag over one shoulder and a carton of vanilla Haagen-Dazs in her hand.

Chapter 7

Thomas blinked, in the Sunday morning half-light. All around him was the faint, unmistakable scent of ice cream. He pulled a spoon from under his shoulder and stretched his arm out, contacting Miranda's leg. *Oh yeah.*

She stirred, looked up at him like the cat that had got the ice cream and rewarded him with a delicious smile.

"Well, we haven't done that in a while."

She crossed her thigh over his and shifted closer — but not too close — honouring their unspoken rule: whatever happens today is only for today. And now it was tomorrow. He shaped a hand around her breast, but she held it to one side: down boy.

"Let's just sleep a while."

He closed his eyes and tried to think of something other than sex. Karl came to mind first, and he wondered what a therapist would make of that? Where did he stand with Karl now — could they really *reset the clocks*? He twitched and Miranda playfully slapped him to lie still. And what was Bob Peterson really doing on the scene?

Miranda groaned in protest.

"Look, if you really can't sleep," she flicked his erection and paused, opening her eyes wide to see his reaction, "Milk and one sugar, thanks."

He disentangled himself and reluctantly left the bed, glancing down at his misplaced enthusiasm. Not today, by the sound of things. The kettle took its time so he waited in the kitchen, taking the pistol stance and handling a lethal fork while doing replays in his head. Something else he hadn't told her about.

Miranda was feigning sleep when he returned to the bedroom, breathing a little too heavily — always a giveaway. He plonked the tea down and started gathering up clothes from around the floor. Along the way he lifted the ice-cream lid and flung it into a bin.

"Aren't you coming back in again?" she pouted, drawing back the sheet like the world's best show and tell.

He didn't need a map and directions.

* * *

Miranda's mobile alarm sounded at ten-thirty.

"Get up you lazy bastard — I've got things to do. I need to stop by the club."

It was funny, the way that Miranda sometimes avoided calling it Caliban's, even though she'd named the club herself. All part of her dumbled down, East-End girl made good façade. She had done well for herself though, opening Caliban's a little more than a year ago; purchased largely with her own money from a lucrative modelling contract in Bermuda, plus a contribution from Mum and Dad — which Thomas always read as: other people's money.

She always smiled when she saw her photograph on the living room wall; it was a spontaneous walking shot, from the streets of Leeds, taken with an old 110. True, it had dated, but somehow that just added to its eighties charm. Sometimes he'd move the photo around, just to try and throw her off guard, but it was always on one wall or another. Christine Gerrard, in her time, had hated that picture; another reason to treasure it.

Miranda stood before the picture gallery, head cocked to one side and a thin smile upon her lips.

"If you follow me down to the club, I can drop you back there after dinner." The subtext: you're going home alone tonight.

On the drive over, whenever they paused at traffic lights, he could see Miranda glancing back at him. Once or twice she gave a sly wave in the rear mirror, but her face was distant. Another clock reset, it seemed.

He parked at Caliban's and followed Miranda to the back office. Sheryl was her usual indispensable self — coffee ready and waiting as they entered. He sometimes liked to think that she was the daughter of an American crime family, with the Wrights as part of an underworld exchange programme. But he never asked; everyone needed secrets.

Miranda settled at her desk and pored over the accounts. He left her to it and went into the pool room across the way. Sheryl followed him.

"Fancy a quick game?" she racked up the balls and bent forward enticingly.

He mustered an eggshell smile.

"Sure, why not."

And it was a quick game. Sheryl played to win; she meant business. Small wonder that Miranda had appointed her as manager of Caliban's.

Best of three became best of seven and still the balls were sinking faster than his self-esteem. Part way through game six, 4-1 in Sheryl's favour, Miranda appeared at the door. Sheryl looked over and they shared a glance. With that, she killed the remaining stripes with clinical precision and then iced the black.

"He's all yours," she called across to Miranda.

"Thanks for keeping him entertained," she winked, heading for the door.

As Thomas passed by Sheryl, she touched him lightly on the shoulder; "She tells me everything, you know."

He hoped she was joking.

Outside, he transferred the chocs, wine and flowers to Miranda's Mini Cooper. She took one look at the bouquet and shook her head.

"They're past their best — we'll pick up something better on the way."

Fair enough. He liked to make a good impression with Mum and Dad, especially today when he'd be delivering an avalanche of bad news.

* * *

The Wrights' house screamed *working class with money*, from the expensively paved drive to the retro coach lamp at the door. They'd dispensed with the wrought iron gates a couple of years back, after a police raid took them off the hinges. Miranda's brothers — Terry and Sam — had already arrived, their BMW and Peugeot parked side by side; they shared a large house out towards Canning Town.

Miranda pulled out her key — all three children still had keys — for a while, Thomas had one too, but he'd turned his in when Miranda had left for sunnier climes. Dire Straits' 'Brothers in Arms' was playing through the hallway like mood music. Thomas almost waited at the door until 'Money for Nothing' kicked in — a family anthem if ever there was one.

Diane, mother to the clan, waved and disappeared into the kitchen. Miranda peeled off to the living room to meet with the rest of them, but Thomas carried the spoils to Diane. Even in profile, she was a fine-looking woman and her genes had generously found their way to Miranda. Diane turned and smiled. "Sit your arse down and pour us both a glass of wine."

Bliss. No pretensions, just honest to goodness real people.

“How’s things, Thomas?” she glanced up as she basted the chicken, and winked. She’d left off the rest of the sentence, which would have run: ‘How’s things, Thomas, with you and my daughter?’

“Not bad,” he blushed and Diane smiled again. He knew both she and John still held out a fragile hope that Miranda and he would one day get their act together. As John had succinctly put it, “Stop fucking about and settle down.” One Christmas, John had got so royally pissed that he’d declared: “I sometimes wish I had another daughter, so you could start again from scratch.”

Thomas survived his gentle interrogation and sauntered on through to the others. John and the boys gave a cheer at his arrival. Miranda kept her distance. “How’s business, Thomas?” John asked casually, just as always.

Miranda looked daggers at Thomas. Yeah, John would get an answer and a half today. She retreated into the kitchen, morphing from successful businesswoman to mummy’s helper in the blink of an eye. They weren’t a throwback family, just traditional. Presents under the tree and Queen’s speech at Christmas; cemetery visits on Boxing Day and sovereign rings for the boys’ twenty-firsts.

John picked up a remote control and the wall slid back, revealing a TV screen that almost qualified as a cinema. Highlights from the last West Ham game flooded the room. Thomas watched with mild interest. He’d been to a few games with the boys over the years, but it didn’t really light his candle. For a while he’d even tried following the York City club, out of loyalty to his home region. But deep down he still believed football was for people who didn’t have the balls for rugby.

Sam had once had a trial for West Ham youth team, straight out of school. Somehow this still entitled him to offer comment on every pass and volley. Terry, not to be outdone, punctuated every unsuccessful manoeuvre with ‘bollocks’ or ‘that was shit,’ the two brothers relishing their double act. John looked on proudly at his sons and Thomas, if he could have, he’d have taken a hundred photographs from all angles to capture the feeling forever. The boys looked up to him, the parents thought the world of him and Miranda — well, he didn’t even have words for what they had between them.

At the table, with John carving, Thomas made an extra effort to join in with the banter. For a while he could forget his painful duty and just enjoy

the company; that and Miranda rubbing her foot up against him under the table. But by the time the dessert bowls were passed around — no vanilla ice cream, thankfully — he had a sinking feeling.

“So,” he broke the easy chatter. “I’ve, er, got a bit of a problem.” The clan all shifted in a little and he cleared his throat. “I was at Harwich last week — I saw the van come back from Amsterdam.”

John Wright shot a surprised look to his sons. Thomas carried on. “The thing is, well, it’s not a good place to do business right now.”

The boys hadn’t said a word. John was first to speak. “How d’ya mean, Thomas?” John’s voice had a quiet authority. Or maybe it just seemed that way because Thomas had never seen him in a rage.

Miranda shifted her foot away and sat up a little straighter. “Thomas was working there, Dad, taking pictures.”

John nodded, eyes narrowing. Terry piped up. “No sweat, we didn’t get stopped or anything.”

Miranda cut in. “No, and that was thanks to Thomas.”

He gaped at her, open-mouthed — so much for trusting and sharing.

She clocked his face and turned beetroot, whispering to herself: “Bollocks!”

“That’ll do, thank you,” Diane stopped eating.

John sat back in his chair, scratching his chin as he looked over at Thomas. “Do you want to talk about it?”

Thomas nodded; at least he’d been given a choice. “I was on a film assignment for Customs & Excise — a training film.” So far so good, successfully tiptoeing the line between truth and bullshit. “Someone with me wanted the van checked, but I persuaded him not to bother.”

He felt Miranda squeeze his hand under the table; he couldn’t tell if the clamminess was his or hers. John took a sip of his beer — somehow he’d never made the conversion to wine. “And when was this exactly?”

Thomas looked along the table to Sam and Terry. “On Friday.”

John leaned forward. “I told you two to leave it well alone — how many trips has it been now?”

“Five, Dad,” Sam said.

A stranger might have itched to know what they were carrying. Thomas, he was just happy that they’d got through without incident.

“Well, thanks, Thomas. Do we owe this Customs geezer anything?”

He shook his head quickly.

John looked straight at him, like a dog deciding whether or not to attack. “So what’s the problem, then?”

Thomas twisted his paper napkin. “There’s this bloke at work — another photographer — only . . . only he might have taken an interest in my private life.”

“Do you want me to sort it out for you?” Sort *him* out, more likely.

“No, it’s taken care of now,” he looked to Miranda for encouragement. “But I’d be a lot more comfortable if you’d let me check your house over for . . . electronic devices.”

“You mean like the Old Bill might use?” John’s face twitched.

Thomas swallowed. “Well, it’s probably nothing; I’d just like to be sure.”

“It’s alright, Dad,” Miranda pitched in, “he’s doing the club for me as well.”

Diane stepped into the fray. “Hold on, let me get this right, Thomas. Someone’s been checking up on you and you think they might have planted stuff here, in our home? What kind of business are you involved in?”

“Mum, give him a chance. It’s just a precaution.”

But Diane was having none of it; it wasn’t hard to see who Miranda took after. “No, let’s have it all out in the open. You involved in drugs or something?”

The Wright family creed: no drugs or prostitution or porn. Some might say that wouldn’t leave a lot to profit from, but they’d be very wrong.

“Alright,” Thomas tapped the table, “here it is. About a year ago I changed jobs — still Civil Service but I became a *specialist* photographer.” He stressed the word so that hopefully it would say things that he wouldn’t have to. Diane recoiled like he’d just punched her.

“Well, you never bloody said! Did you know about this, Miranda?”

“No Mum,” Miranda admitted in a quiet voice, “I only found out yesterday.”

Thank you, Judas.

“Hold up,” John raised a fork. “If we’re gonna talk about this, let’s get comfortable.” Like a sofa would make it all easier.

John mainly listened and didn’t ask too many questions. Everyone else picked at Thomas like he was the day’s special.

“So let me get this straight,” Terry laughed. “You’ve been leading this secret life for over a year and you never told us!”

He shrugged, like a desperate plea for clemency.

“Hey, give the boy a chance,” John calmed the mob. “Never mind what he kept from us, for a minute; he still did the boys a favour and we’re in his debt.”

“Just let me sweep the house for . . .”

“Intrusions,” Miranda chipped in helpfully.

“Well,” John concluded, “that’s about it. Miranda, why don’t you and your mother make us all some tea.”

Oh bollocks, Thomas thought; here comes the real discussion. John waited less than five seconds after the kitchen door closed. “I don’t like deceivers, Thomas, but I respect loyalty. The main thing is that you still looked out for Sam and Terry. I appreciate that. All I want to say is this . . .”

Thomas braced himself. John and the boys leaned in as one.

“How much do you think we could charge to check out other people’s places for these intrusions? I know plenty of people who would be interested in that sort of service.”

“Hey Dad, I could get some cards printed.”

Thomas looked over at Sam. God help him, he was serious.

* * *

Miranda seemed unseasonably chirpy on the drive back to Caliban’s; a marked difference from Thomas who felt like he’d lost a tenner and found a black eye. “Cheer up, babe, it’ll be fine.”

He rubbed a thumb against his forehead in disbelief. “Your dad wants to offer a counter-intelligence service to the criminal fraternity, your brother wants to get me business cards and your mum probably hates me now.”

“Nah, I talked with her while you four were playing *The Godfather*. She knows it wasn’t personal, what with you not telling *any* of us.”

Seconds out, round two. “Look Miranda, it’s the Official Secrets Act not a bloody Cluedo game.”

“So, do you *like* your job, then?”

Now there was a question he’d never been asked. Not even Christine Gerrard had drawn that one out of the hat, come appraisal time. “Most of it, yeah. But I don’t like the idea of being at the other end of the lens.”

Miranda squeezed his thigh. “You used to pose for me though!”

In the club’s car park, she turned off the engine. He wanted to say something meaningful; he been thinking about it all through the drive over. The best he could offer was: “Look, I’m sorry.”

She kissed him matter-of-factly on the cheek and that hurt more than anything else. And she’d know it. Nothing pained him as much as Miranda drawing away again.

He trudged towards his car and consoled himself. Not a bad weekend, all things considered. He’d played with guns, had some great sex, shared a family meal and admitted to the people he cared about most in the world that he’d been lying to them for months. Oh yeah, and found out that his best mate at work had been spying on him. Roll on Monday.

Chapter 8

He got into the office early and flicked the main lights on. At the far end of the room, Christine's sanctuary was ablaze like an electric fly-killer. Ann Crossley's chair had a bag hung over the back of it so someone had already started playing brown-noses with the boss. But then, today was the big day when Bob Peterson joined the gang. In all the weekend's excitement he'd almost forgotten that piece of joy.

At 8.15, the impossible happened; Karl had somehow twisted the space-time continuum and arrived before most of the rabble. As soon as he was in the door, he marched over to the vending machines. Good to see that military training hadn't gone to waste. Then he appeared at Thomas's desk with coffees and two Twixes. "I, er, think I may have been a bit over-dramatic. All quits now?" Karl put the goods down and extended his hand. Thomas reciprocated, grabbing the payoff before Karl changed his mind.

Karl had clearly been at a different 'prioritise your work' seminar. First on his agenda was clearing out the spam emails from the web filter, with occasional commentary. "Jaysus, you'd think they could at least *spell* sperm? Fancy writing it with a 'u'!"

"Why do you bother reading them?"

"I don't read *all* of them — I just find some of titles intriguing. Lookie here Tommo; what do you reckon? Genuine herbal Viagra from Naples!"

Christine's door opened and the sound of chatter and laughter floated out. Thomas and Karl exchanged a customary glance of contempt. Ann Crossley strode out, with all the confidence that a Cambridge education could buy, even if it had diluted her native Cardiff accent along the way.

"Good morning, gentlemen!" she crooned and returned to her desk.

"Ann, have you lost a few pounds by any chance?" Karl asked.

She glanced over herself admiringly. "Well, yes, as it happens."

Karl daggered in with lightning speed. "Because I found a fiver on the carpet."

"Karl," she scowled, "you can be a real prick sometimes."

"That's because sometimes only a real prick will do!"

She huffed and fired up her laptop.

“Why do you do it, Karl?” Thomas shook his head. Karl just flashed a grin. Out of the corner of his eye, Thomas saw a figure filling up Christine’s doorway. The elusive Mr Peterson was surveying all that he owned. Thomas snapped a Twix finger in his teeth and stared at the screen, waiting for the inevitable call to visit the grown-ups. He managed a good five minutes of stoic activity under Bob Peterson’s gaze, including Karl’s emails declaring that Bob Peterson must be a busy man if he had time to engage in a one-way staring contest.

At eight thirty a mobile alarm went off; Bob Peterson cleared his throat. “Thomas, could you pop in please?” The poor sod was obviously a slave to the clock.

He drained the last of his coffee and picked up a notepad and pen. He imagined, for an instant, that Bob Peterson had been one of the targets he had fired bullets into. It helped put a smile on his face.

He sat down and tried not to react as Christine closed the door and sat closer to Bob than he would have liked.

“Thomas, glad to have you on the team.”

He noted the lack of a pronoun — a good way to spot liars and sociopaths. Even so, he made the supreme sacrifice and shook Bob’s hand.

“I’ve arranged to see everyone over the next couple of days, but I really wanted an opportunity for the three of us to, er, clear up any lasting misunderstandings.”

“Do you mean the one about me *not* knowing you two were carrying on together before Christine and I split up?”

Bob and Christine exchanged an ‘I told you so’ glance; Christine folded her hands earnestly. “Thomas, we’ve been through this. Bob’s interest in me was purely professional — when will you get that into your thick . . .” she paused and Thomas touched his tongue to his lip. The next words used to be: working class. But patronising the lower ranks would never do in front of her boss.

“—Head?” Thomas offered, generously. He had to be smart, smarter than Peterson, anyway. He glanced at Bob’s hand — same ring as he wore at Harwich. As clear as the blow-up he’d printed at home. He swallowed his pride and did what needed to be done. “Look, can we start again? My stuff with Christine is all in the past, but your arrival stirred things up a bit for me.”

“Sure, sure!” Peterson beamed as if he’d just successfully hidden a pair of Christine’s knickers in his back pocket. “I’ve checked through your record, Thomas, and it’s exemplary. I’m sure we can work together — I’d hate to have to lose you from the team.”

Thomas made no attempt to hide his shock. He looked straight at Christine, who seemed similarly surprised. “I’ll wait to hear from you, then.”

“Absolutely,” Peterson opened the door, as if he was making a point. “Don’t go too far; I want the whole team in at 9.30.”

Thomas returned to his desk with a face like thunder. Christ, he’d really made a mess of that; nearly played his hand too soon. He went over to Karl. “Fancy a walk? I need some air.”

“Be right with you Tommo, just closing down. Don’t forget to lock your laptop.”

Something else he hadn’t done properly.

* * *

Karl ushered him to a café five minutes away. They both ordered a full breakfast. “I take it that your tête à tête wasn’t all you hoped for?”

“I made a complete dick of myself,” he shook his head slowly. “I accused him of sleeping with Christine before we’d officially split.”

“Don’t be expecting a good appraisal then!”

Two preposterously large mugs of tea arrived. Karl waited until the waitress had turned her back then made pretend swimming strokes over his tea.

Thomas just sighed; he’d lost his sense of humour.

“You know, Tommo, I loved and lost this girl, once. We were both stationed in Germany and we got together quickly. It was all brilliant and then I had to go back to Blighty on some urgent family business.”

Thomas stopped drinking tea and paid closer attention.

“Anyway, she bumps into this officer on base, while I’m gone — turned out that she’d had a bit of a thing with him, over in Cyprus.” Karl rotated his finger to show the passing of time. “So I get back to barracks and there’s another fish in my kettle, so to speak.”

Thomas had already decided that Karl made these phrases up. “How long were you away, Karl?”

“Long enough, evidently. I wasn’t very mature about it all. And unfortunately for me he was a nastier fighter,” Karl lifted his sweatshirt to reveal a series of white scars.

Thomas gasped.

“Listen now, I was no angel either. We wrecked the bar, apparently. I was certainly pretty wrecked at the time!” He winked then calmly took a sip of tea before he continued. “Anyway, not to be outdone, I tried a different tack and sent some photos of them together to his wife. Did I mention he had a wife?”

Thomas remembered that Bob Peterson was married, too. “And?”

“His wife divorced him. And later on, so I heard, the ‘Officer and Bastard’ married my lovely Jennifer.” Once he’d stopped talking, the waitress returned; Karl’s face lit up like a beacon. “Beatrice, you’re a sight for sore eyes. Your husband is a very lucky man!” He was rewarded with a demure smile and the all-day breakfast — so named because it could take a slow eater all day to finish it.

Further conversation was parked as they made their way through a meal fit for a king — a king who enjoyed mushrooms, eggs, tomatoes, sausages, bacon, toast and beans.

Thomas clapped his hands appreciatively. “That hit the spot.”

“You can always rely on your uncle Karl to make things better! Come on now or we’ll miss the party.”

* * *

The team filed into Christine’s office, all clutching pen and paper. Karl had brought along his Homer Simpson pad and novelty snake pen.

Bob Peterson introduced himself and shook everyone’s hand warmly. It was the usual ‘we’re in this together’ speech, with a potted history of where he’d been working before and the assurance that he wasn’t going to bring in change for change’s sake — which always meant the exact opposite.

Christine chipped in here and there, as if they were a double-act already, and managed to not look in Thomas’s direction. At one point Peterson made a joke about Sir Peter Carroll and asked Thomas not to repeat it the next time he saw the ‘old man upstairs,’ a blunt reference to Thomas having been interviewed by Sir Peter himself. Thomas swallowed his pride and smiled on cue.

Later, Ann Crossley asked about an accelerated development programme and Peterson agreed to look into it. Thomas managed not to mention that Christine herself had done something similar. So far, so good.

Karl wondered aloud what had made Peterson come to their branch of the SSU. Peterson laughed it off without committing himself. Thomas had been listening through a haze of indifference, but now he saw an opening. “So Bob,” he adopted a matey tone, “how was the move up from Southampton?”

“A nightmare — still a work in progress!” Peterson grinned. “Most of our things are still in storage — I was working in Southampton right up to Saturday night. We’re still waiting to exchange on the house so I guess I’ll be commuting, unless one of you has a spare floor?”

Laughter all round. Thomas laughed too, at Peterson’s audacity — the lying bastard. Gotcha! Christine’s face was a study in marble. Then an alarm bell went off in his head. What if she and Peterson were engaged in their own little re-enactment society?

Later, Thomas sat at his desk, deep in thought. He had what he wanted — Peterson’s denial, even though the photo proved he’d been at Harwich — but he didn’t know what to do with it. ‘Bang to rights’ as Sam or Terry would put it. He smiled at himself. How ingrained the London-isms had become after years of living there. Even his accent was more East End than Yorkshire, these days. On those rare occasions when he contacted his own family, the first thing they usually said was that he gone ‘all southern.’

Karl had stayed on for a few minutes — probably a prelude to his assessment. Thomas watched as he walked out of Christine’s office, holding up the Simpson’s pad as a face. Karl, his only ally — someone he still didn’t know if he could trust.

“How did it go, then?”

Karl took a deep breath. “Fantastic, Tommo. They’re thinking of putting me up for the George Cross.”

“You’re a funny man, Karl McNeill.”

“That’s just what Bob Peterson said — now are you sure you weren’t listening at the door?”

Thomas held up a hand, Honest Injun style. His mobile bleeped; a text from Miranda: *Thanks for a lovely weekend. M. x.* He blushed and switched

off the phone, remembering to pick up a sweeping kit from Stores, for Caliban's and the family home.

Chapter 9

Karl drove out to the docks with Thomas riding shotgun. He didn't say much to Karl; he was too busy thinking.

Peterson didn't need to lie; he could have mentioned being at Harwich, now that he'd met the team. He could have explained it as an informal assessment before taking charge. But no; something smelt fishy and Peterson was a week-old prawn.

By the time they arrived at their hidey-hole, overlooking the action, Monday weather had really kicked in — a drab, half-hearted downpour that set the mood. They sat, munching on sandwiches and peering through binoculars like schoolboy birdwatchers. Matter of fact, Thomas could identify the different gulls — Herring, Common and both types of Black Headed Gulls; not that he thought Karl would be interested.

Karl soon declared he was bored of scoping for women and went back to *Private Eye*. Thomas took to staring out at the sky, or what was left of it, as rain sprayed the windows in rhythmic bursts. It was, to quote Karl: "Shiter than a field of slurry." Clearly, the man had the soul of a great poet.

After a further hour of struggling together with the cryptic crossword and generally wasting taxpayers' money, the walkie-talkie spluttered into life. "Control to all units; we're calling it a day. Come down and get some close-ups."

* * *

The Customs teams went about their work, with little regard for the *Floaters* — a moniker the SSU had never managed to shake. The filming was supposed to be impromptu sequences, but as every good photographer knew, off-the-cuff material needed a lot of preparation. A dry lens, no reflections or glare, no inadvertent staring into the camera; it took time to stage that level of spontaneity.

Karl did the bare minimum and homed in on the youngest and prettiest Customs Officer. He swaggered about, displaying the subtlety of a Great Dane with a hard-on. Thomas drifted along behind him to witness the charm offensive at close quarters.

"Ah me, I do so love a girl in uniform!"

The woman turned, saw Karl's beaming face and lifted her shoulders. "You must be the Floater everyone's been warning me about." Before Karl could answer, she flashed a smile. "So how do you want me?"

Karl did his thing, manufacturing life-like shots under cover from the rain. Thomas was regulated to bag man, moving equipment while the maestro was in full flow.

"By the way, whatever happened to the shooting victim?"

Thomas jerked to attention behind Karl; very slick, right in the middle of a sequence — classic misdirection.

"Funny you should ask." Little Miss Flirtatious turned and made a Marilyn Monroe pout for the camera. "The way I heard it, he was whisked off to a private hospital somewhere."

Karl moved from behind the camera and looked directly at Thomas, just for an instant — a regular Holmes and Watson moment. "Hey," Karl knelt down near her to change his data card, "I wonder where all the booze in his van went?"

Karl's supermodel looked over to Ann Crossley. "She supervised it."

"Well then," Karl chortled, "We'll be alright for the Christmas Party! Okay sweetheart, I'm all done here — I just need to get the steam off my lens."

She gave him a little wave and went off to join the others, glancing back a couple of times on her way.

"You know, the camera really loves her."

"Looked like it wasn't the only one." Thomas folded his arms.

"Come on now, Tommy. I was working my subject, like any good photographer."

Thomas squatted beside him while Karl put his trusty Nikon to bed. Thomas eyed it suspiciously. He preferred a Canon; but they'd had that debate many times over.

"You look pensive, Tommo — what's eating you?"

"I don't do *let's pretend* very well, Karl. And you heard what she said . . ."

"Just keep to your boundaries and let me do my job."

Thomas stalled him, arm outstretched. "But what exactly *is* your job?"

Karl walked around him. "Don't go there, Tommo; don't go there."

* * *

17.45 on the dot, as requested. Christine's door was already open. Thomas knocked politely on the frame; *start as you mean to go on*.

"Thomas!" Peterson cried delightedly, as if they were at a class reunion. "Come in, have a seat."

On the desk was a fan-spread of reports, all bearing Thomas's name.

"I understand you and Karl McNeill were on duty when the firearms incident took place at Harwich?" Before Thomas could reply, Peterson added, "But there's nothing in your report."

It was a pawn-to-king-four gambit — obvious, but effective. Thomas responded in kind. "I keep my reports factual and we were concentrating on the Customs Officers." *Facts*. A light went on in his head. If he had any snaps of the red car heading up the exit lane, he'd probably have the registration number too.

"And these?" Peterson pawed at one of the mosaic shots. "What are these about?"

Thomas shrugged it off. "Just background detail. I like to set up early and get a feel for the location."

Peterson stalled for a second and Thomas caught it. "Christine tells me that you have real potential."

She shifted forward in her chair. "Bob and I have discussed this, and we think you're ready for development. It means additional training in Staffordshire and it could open doors for you in the future."

Thomas wore his best fake smile. Christine continued, "We'll need a decision by the end of the week — there's an opening next Monday."

Peterson was staring intently at the mosaic photograph from the day of the shooting. Thomas kept his eyes firmly on Christine, which was no great hardship, and leaned back a little to keep Peterson in his peripheral vision. No doubt about it though, she was looking really good today.

"One thing I would like to ask you," Peterson slapped the photograph down. Thomas jolted awake. "What's your opinion of Karl McNeill?"

"He's very good at what he does; seems to read people well," Thomas played it safe and stayed vague.

"But what about personally? I gather you two socialise from time to time."

Thomas concocted a cross between a laugh and a cough, each as fake as the other. “Well, we have the odd drink, now and again — I met him last weekend, as it happens. I get the impression there’s more to Karl than meets the eye. But I s’pose we all have our little secrets.”

Christine became a study in scarlet and Peterson dropped his pen, which rolled off the desk; they both froze. Bingo, right on the money.

Thomas decided to push his luck. “If you don’t mind, I need to be away soon; I have a date I cannot break.” *Yeah, looking for bugging devices in Dagenham, followed by a takeaway curry for six.*

“Oh.” Christine looked surprised. Not disappointed, he noted; just surprised.

“That’s fine.” Peterson extended a wet-fish handshake. “Thanks for your time and your candour. Let Christine know about the training.”

* * *

Miranda always said that men couldn’t multitask, but Thomas found that London traffic always afforded him time to think. So a burst water main at Burdett Road was practically a gift. By the time he’d ploughed through to take a left at Bow Common Lane, he’d found one thought that he just couldn’t shake. And it wasn’t a good one.

Peterson would have scheduled an arrival time at Harwich that day and known precisely where he’d parked; probably the vehicles around him too. He was a pro after all. Then Thomas had given him — bloody *given* him, mind — a mosaic showing the whole panorama without Peterson’s four-by-four in it. As good as saying: ‘I know you were there and I’m keeping it to myself at the moment.’ Stupid, really stupid.

And now, suddenly, he was trainee executive material when earlier in the day he’d been facing the heave-ho from the team. Peterson had him snookered; not accepting the training meant showing his hand and accepting would put him at arm’s length.

Desperate times and all that; he swung the car into the first available space and fetched out his mobile. “Hey, Karl. Listen, any chance of a chat at the club, some time soon? Wednesday? Nice one; see you tomorrow.”

The Wrights left him to go about his work. All except Sam, who followed him around like a lost sheep: nothing new there. When Thomas had first brought Miranda back to London, Sam had only been about

thirteen. Talk about hero worship. Thomas had rescued Miranda from the clutches of doom. Or more precisely, from the paws of Butch Steddings — modelling agent and all-round scumbag. Even now, Thomas and Miranda still used the word *Butch* as code for something dodgy.

By 21.30 Thomas had his feet up and John Wright was handing him a beer. All clear, no trace of Karl's handiwork on the premises. And sadly, no sign of Miranda either. If she were playing hard to get she'd put in a cup-winning performance tonight. No reason to expect her at Caliban's on Tuesday night either, for his next debugging booking. The only bit of good news that night was that no one had mentioned the business potential of Thomas's new career.

By the time he got back to the flat in Walthamstow, it was close to midnight. The answering machine light was flashing insistently. He put the electronics case down in the hall, set the two door locks and hit the magic button.

"Hello Thomas, it's your mother. Just ringing to see how you are and when we can expect a visit. Your sister and the kids send their love and so do me and your dad." No names just titles — nice.

The next message was Miranda. "Hi, sorry I won't be there tonight or at the club. Sheryl knows the score."

He dithered for a second then stabbed the delete button. "Of course she does," he seethed in the dark, "you tell her everything."

Chapter 10

Karl held the heavy metal door open as Thomas stepped through. It felt as if that door was shielding him from the outside world. Once the formalities were dispensed with, Karl led him to a bay and went off to procure the equipment.

He leaned against the wall and gazed out at the targets, seduced by the stillness. A perfect backdrop to the maelstrom of his own thoughts.

Karl soon returned with two Browning 9mm pistols. “You won’t find any answers staring down there!”

So there were answers to be had? He opened the case and, under Karl’s supervision, primed the weapon and took the stand. He closed his eyes for a moment and let the roar in his ears carry him. The barrel wavered. Sweat massed at his brow and his armpits felt sticky, as if the growing web of deceit and half-truths was oozing out of him.

He sighed, took aim and squeezed the trigger. Somehow he’d expected the first shot to settle him, but it had the opposite effect. The barrel shuddered — no chance. He flipped the safety catch and put the gun down.

Karl stepped up beside him and put a hand on his shoulder. “It’s all about being able to close in, to focus on one thing. No distractions or prevarications. Because if it came to it, that’s what the other guy would do.” Karl nudged him aside and drained the magazine without breaking a sweat. “Now, try again.”

Thomas lined the target up. His stomach contorted and he fought against it, making himself breathe steadily to counter the nausea. It all came back to him then, the first time he’d held a gun.

* * *

1984. Maybe not the dystopia Orwell had predicted, but in Yorkshire, a police state nonetheless. Night after night, woken up by the sirens; the procession of policemen, like the invading Roman army they were learning about at school. At first it was exciting; they played at *Blake’s 7*, from off the telly, space rebels against an evil, galactic federation. Or else they tried to get close to the horses.

But the screw quickly tightened and then it wasn't fun at all. When coalmining collapsed, so did the world they all knew. There were arguments at friends' houses and rows at home; relentless shouting and door slamming. School became a refuge from home.

Every day his dad swore vengeance on 'that heartless tyrant bitch, Margaret Thatcher.' It was the first time he'd seen his father so full of hatred. In some ways, childhood fell away. The older kids talked about a revolution. They hadn't covered that in class, so it didn't all make sense.

And then there was that day, playing around in the greenhouse. That's when he found it, wrapped up in newspaper and hidden in an old rucksack: a real gun. Next day his dad came home unexpectedly, caught him red-handed. He really went off on one; raged at him, threatened him — his own son — to keep his mouth shut about the pistol and to never go in the greenhouse again. Thomas had been so frightened that he'd pissed himself, right in front of his dad. Even now, just thinking about it, his face burned.

* * *

He swallowed hard and heard the echoes of his own laboured breathing. How long had he been standing there? *Just pull the fucking trigger.* One, two, three, four in rapid succession, gunning down his shame and the past. As if that was ever really possible. "Done," he called aloud. As he stepped back, he saw Karl leaning casually against the wall, watching him. "Peterson and Christine asked what I thought of you, yesterday. I told them you were dependable."

Karl nodded and packed away the pistols, game over. Thomas waited for him in the corridor. Maybe it had been a mistake coming here this time. The strangled whistling of a familiar tune made Thomas turn — 'I Shot the Sheriff' — Karl of course, the stupid bastard. "Come on amigo, something closer to home," Karl passed him a larger case.

Thomas balanced the rifle comfortably, nestling it against his shoulder. The weapon smelt different, and the realisation amused him. He wriggled his face closer in to the sight and inhaled then released. The crosshairs barely moved as he levelled up and fired. He felt the recoil in his shoulder and shrugged a little, preparing for the next one. Now he saw the hole, placed close to the inner ring. Five shots followed, each within an inch of the original.

“Very good. Amazing what a little time and preparation can accomplish. Now, step aside and let me show you what a professional can do!” Karl was still a much better shot. He made short work of the remainder of his ammunition and lowered the rifle with a sigh. “The bar, I think.”

* * *

“Drink up Tommo — nothing worse than cold coffee.”

He swayed the cup mid-air. “Peterson wants to send me on some special training next week. I reckon he wants me out of the way.”

“I’m not surprised. Remember that wee Customs lass I was doing so well with?”

Thomas arched an obligatory eyebrow.

“She’s been reassigned — she told me when I rang her last night; did I mention I picked up her number before we left? Anyway, it looks like someone’s having a bit of a clear out.”

“Well, I’m staying put.”

Karl gave him the kind of look that *he* used to give his sister Pat when she still believed in the Tooth Fairy. “Think so? A quid says they split up our dream team within a fortnight.”

They both did mock spits and shook hands on the bet. Thomas toyed with the rim of his cup. “When I was a kid, I used to pray at night for Jesus to end the Miners’ Strike and save their jobs,” he sucked in one cheek. “Yeah, stupid, I know. But I was ten. It was the last time I ever thought about relying on anyone else.”

“Hey though,” Karl brightened, “just imagine if he’d ever achieved it. We’d have got him over to the six counties on the next ferry out!”

“Look, I owe you an apology, Karl, for thinking you were prepared to . . . you know . . .”

“Fix up your drinking hole? Understandable, under the circumstances.”

Karl wiped his face with a napkin. “Listen, I know you feel you’re in the middle of everything, but — and don’t take this the wrong way — stick to what you’re good at and leave well alone.”

Thomas pondered that for a second. The problem was, he was already involved.

* * *

He didn't sit down to eat until after 10 pm; a cheese omelette with bacon bits in it and bread that was only good for toasting. He cleared away methodically and switched on the immersion heater. Now or never time. He drummed on the desk while the laptop fired up and didn't linger on the default image: Rievaulx Abbey, beset by lightning. Sifting through the unused images folders, he found what he was looking for — two pictures of the red car at the port. Not his best work by any means — slightly blurred, though enough detail across the two frames to put together a complete registration number.

He dialled Miranda, without thinking of the time, and asked another favour.

"That depends. If it's for your job, the answer's *no*." She sounded distracted, probably by all that background music.

"Are you in a club?"

"What?"

He was pretty sure she'd heard him and wasn't that a man's voice close by? "Are you with someone?"

For a few seconds there was silence then he heard a familiar tone. "I've got to go, Thomas. Just text me whatever you need. Bye."

The room went cold. He sat for a while, staring into space, taking it all in. Sleep was off the menu now — a familiar part of the pattern. He washed up and sent Miranda the text. Then he grabbed his car keys and an SLR camera, promising himself that he wouldn't end up outside Christine's flat again.

To begin with, he just drove around, looking for a prospect. The radio was tuned to some late-show, where the emotionally stunted could unburden their souls. And in between the confessionals, a talk-jock served up a hearty stream of platitudes.

"That must have been awful for you. Do you have a message for any listeners in a similar position?"

"Yeah," Thomas spoke directly at the radio, "get a life." *Like he had a life?* He flipped the station to something more melodic and cruised the City of London to the tunes of the eighties; happily cocooned until The Human League struck up with *Don't You Want Me?* Ouch; too close to home.

Thoughts crept into his brain, or out of it. Was Christine still single — had he imagined some sort of buzz between her and Peterson? He smiled,

taking his own bait: only one way to find out. No harm in taking a drive by her flat later. Driving past without stopping didn't really count. He glanced down at the camera, mute beside him on the passenger seat, like his conscience.

At Archway he pulled over and took the tripod from the boot. He found a suitable position, set the camera up and started timing the traffic. After twenty vehicles, he opted for a timing of seven seconds. He waited, enjoying that delicious sense of anticipation. Despite all the technological progress, at heart it was *magic* — that's what it was. A moment in time, in all its shame and glory, captured forever.

He was reverently packing everything into the boot when he heard talking. He cocked a fist and moved to the blind side of the car, crouching to get a better look. It was a woman, stumbling along the street towards him, having a conversation with herself. From the look of her, she was maybe seventeen; seventeen going on twenty-five. And she'd had a skinful.

"Alright mate?" she grinned as he stood up. "'Ave you got the time please?" She was too drunk to be scared of approaching a stranger at night. But that was okay because he was scared enough for both of them.

"It's late — you should be at home."

She started laughing and teetered about like a Jenga conclusion. "I missed my lift and I'm too skint for a taxi. I got college tomorrow . . ."

Hook, line and sinker. "Alright," he conceded, feeling he'd been played like a cheap violin. "Do you need a lift somewhere?"

"Nice one," she gave him a wavering thumbs-up. "Ever heard of Battersea?"

He nodded wearily. *No good deed goes unpunished.* In the end, he crossed the river, found the nearest cab office and left her there with a tenner. Better that than explaining to an irate family that he was just a Good Samaritan, and nearly twice her age.

By the time he was safely over the Thames, he'd given up on Christine's and opted for home. As he parked up, he noticed the small handbag in the passenger door. Brilliant — something else to be sorted out. He opened it carefully, as if it was a steel-sprung trap. There was a passport-sized picture of two schoolgirls; all grinning smiles and too much lipstick. Also inside were a college card and timetable, a door key, a nightclub matchbook, two tampons and a packet of condoms — one missing. Clearly,

a woman for all seasons. He noted the college address; another good deed for tomorrow then, before work.

Chapter 11

Thomas got waylaid by traffic on the way to Battersea Technology College. He left the bag in a padded envelope at reception, with a note suggesting she be more careful in future.

In the office, Karl was already sifting his junk mail for gold. “Tommo, come and see this. Why would any man want to increase his sperm by 500%? Hey, unless he was a donor and paid by volume!” Ann Crossley looked over without saying anything. Karl called Thomas to one side. “When are you telling Christine that you won’t require the key to the executive wash room?”

“No time like the present,” he glanced at her door. “May as well get it over with.”

“Don’t be too long — I’ll get the coffees in,” Karl stood up and wandered towards Ann Crossley. “Can you imagine a man with five times the sperm? Where would he keep it all?”

Christine was on the phone. She saw Thomas approach and waved him in. “Okay Bob, leave it with me and thanks again for your time.” She put the phone down and did her best to bury a smile. She used to do that with him, when they were exchanging glances at work, back in the day.

“I thought I’d tell you right away that I won’t be taking up the training offer.”

Christine frowned. “I think you’re being very short-sighted. Bob went through your files very carefully — and despite your macho display — he was impressed by what he saw.”

I’ll bet he was. Thomas pushed his tongue against his lower front teeth to make a poker face.

“You’re making a mistake, you know.”

And there was something about the way she said it that made him pause and sit down. The best defence might not be attack, but it was better than no defence at all. “I was in your part of the world last night — I nearly popped round.”

Christine did a good impression of a rabbit caught in headlights. “I was busy,” she snapped, “and you shouldn’t assume I have no life of my own.”

It all sounded a bit Jane Austen from where he was sitting, but he got the message loud and clear: stay away. Which only made him more determined.

* * *

At Harwich, in the afternoon, Crossley radioed in; she sounded smug. “Thomas, Christine wants you to ring immediately. You’re to report to Sir Peter Carroll, first thing tomorrow morning. Top priority.”

Thomas relayed the news. Karl sucked a tooth. If he’d played his cards any closer to his chest, he’d have worn them as a tattoo. “Well now, Tommy Boy; looks like I just won a pound. Another two says Crossley knows more than she’s saying. Has Sir Peter ever asked for you by name before?”

“Now and again. I’ve done the odd pick-up, up north. Maybe he thinks southerners get a nosebleed if they venture further than Watford.”

“Yeah,” Karl stared ahead, “or maybe you’ve pissed somebody off?”

It was the first time Thomas had visited Main Building in Whitehall. He’d seen Sir Peter in a few buildings since State House in High Holborn. It was as if the old man couldn’t settle. And every time, including at Whitehall, Sir Peter kept his distance from the various offices of the SSU.

The security guard eyed Thomas up and down. In most governmental buildings, Thomas knew, security had been contracted out to agency staff — the engines of bureaucracy made safe on minimum wages. Main Building was not one of those places. Glancing left to right, he counted five people in the reception area who stood or sat ramrod straight and took their duties very seriously; no skiving with the television on here. Most, if not all, would be armed.

“Thomas Bladen?”

He nodded and held up his ID. Despite the twenty or so years since the SSU had existed, there was still a hard core of resentment and mistrust from the *real* security and armed services. Chummy here, sneering back through the reinforced glass, was clearly not a member of the SSU fan club.

“Hand please.” Fingerprint checks had already been introduced, last time he’d attended Sir Peter. And even though he had nothing to hide — nothing that would show on a hand scan, anyway — he still twitched a little as the scanner went about its business.

An escort appeared, to take him up to the top floor. No conversation in the lift, not even a gripe at the weather. And above them the cameras silently filmed every nuance; despite working in surveillance, Thomas could never get used to that.

The lift rose to the top floor, which made him smile; some things never changed. A grey carpet extended before him, complemented by grey walls and a series of identical navy blue doors. The only way to tell them apart was by the acronyms — ATFA, SA2A and NORAD Liaison. This was *need-to-know* taken to extremes. They rounded a corridor, he and the silent wonder, along the dog-leg, past FRD, CIA — *surely not* — and then finally a door labelled SSU. The escort knocked curtly then opened the door for him. “I’ll be back to collect you.”

100% pure charm.

Sir Peter Carroll was sat behind his desk in a navy blazer and tie; he had a look of the Cheshire Cat about him. “Thomas, good to see you!” he stood and extended his hand, but that was as much as he moved. Behind him, the familiar portrait of Sir Winston Churchill adorned the wall, with a great cigar in his mouth and a paperweight of a spitfire by his hand. *There’s no place like home.*

Thomas had seen that painting maybe a dozen times, most of them at State House when he’d been showing off his photographic prowess. “How can I help you, sir?” He knew the old man would like that.

“Thomas!” Sir Peter elongated the name in mock disapproval. “Will you join me in a whisky?”

He nodded, happy to accommodate his benefactor. They sat for a minute or two, savouring their drinks. Thomas had never been sure how far the informality thing stretched; it had all been pretty loose before he’d joined the SSU but he’d never pushed it since he joined the payroll.

“I’d like you to collect a package for me; from Leeds.”

A Yorkshire pick-up. Coincidence? Thomas didn’t subscribe to them. “Where do you want it delivered?”

“To me, here in Whitehall — Highly Classified.”

He nodded; if Sir Peter were studying his face for a response he’d find none.

“You’ll leave for York from St Pancras station, Friday morning. I thought you’d appreciate the chance to spend time with your family up

there.”

Terrific. Must remember to book the street parade.

“Retrieve the item from an office in Leeds on Monday morning. Then straight back here — understand?” Sir Peter lifted an A5 brown envelope from an in-tray and picked up a telephone to summon the escort. “So . . . what do you make of Bob Peterson?”

“Don’t know much about him,” he played dumb. “I gather he’s been working out of Southampton.” *Give or take the odd bit of moonlighting.*

Sir Peter laced his fingers together, like a judge about to pass sentence. “Not really your sort, eh, Thomas?”

Thomas shrugged and stuck with his glass.

“I’m sorry you turned down the training — Bob was very keen.”

Blimey; good news certainly travels fast.

“It’s sensible to get Bob on side,” Sir Peter leaned across his desk. “Winning a war is easy — that just takes superior forces. But winning the peace . . . ah, that takes superior intelligence. Do you follow?”

“I think so, sir.” It all added up to a cryptic pitch for *be nice to Bob*. Three raps on the door brought the conversation to an end.

“Monday,” Sir Peter said as the guard closed the door behind him.

Outside, Thomas felt for the envelope; he knew better than to open it on the street. Even though, on past experience, it would only contain travel times, an address and a named contact. It was still before eleven. He rang Christine to check what she wanted him to do next; back to base it was then. On the way over he called Karl.

“Ah, the happy wanderer! How did it go?”

“Fine thanks. Listen, turns out I’ll be away this weekend — when do you fancy meeting at the club?”

“Well now, let me check my packed social calendar . . .” Karl paused for about three seconds. “Yep, this week’s good — pick a day.”

“How about tonight? — I know it’s short notice . . .”

Karl backtracked like a Lamborghini slammed into reverse. “The thing is, Tommo, there’s this senorita.”

“It wouldn’t be Teresa by any chance, would it?”

“A gentleman never tells. Why don’t we make it Thursday night?”

“Done.”

* * *

The office seemed deserted when Thomas arrived. The team would still be at Harwich. And Peterson, with any luck he'd be under a bus.

"Hi there," Christine poked her head out of her door, "fancy a bite to eat?"

He blinked a couple of times; did a comedic search behind him.

"Come on, you must be hungry?"

"Sure, why not — I've just got to make a call."

"Great! I'll power down and get my bag."

It had been a long time since they'd strolled along the Thames together. The water shimmered in the sunlight; slow lazy bow waves brushing the banks as the tourists motored up and down. Given the choice he would have lingered awhile to watch how the shadow lines sliced across the concrete. But it was Christine's gig so he kept quiet and played follow my leader.

He remembered the bistro, a spit away from the Tate Modern. It had been the site of that first try-out lunch with Mummy and Daddy. No surprise then that Christine made small talk about her parents; people who wouldn't make space in a lifeboat for him if the ship went down in flames — in shark-infested waters.

"Anyway, enough about me; how are your family, Thomas?"

The *coincidence* bell rang so loud in his head he could hardly hear himself think. He muddled through with a mixture of old news and half-truths, grateful when Christine claimed them a table.

"Here, this is good. A great view of the North Bank."

They agreed to share a bottle of wine — her treat. He quickly got into the rhythm of their non-date. There was nothing at risk here since not only had she no interest in him romantically, he still had Bob Peterson marked down as her bedtime companion. On those terms, he could afford to relax and enjoy himself.

"I really do wish you'd think about the training, Thomas," she had a certain way of saying his name that could still set his teeth on edge. The tone dragged him back in time, just before the ice age had set in. He avoided a skirmish by drawing on the healing power of wine. "I know Bob's appointment was a shock . . . but that shouldn't stand in the way of your future. Hmm?"

He smiled. As the early afternoon sunshine picked out her auburn highlights, it was easy to recall what he'd first seen in her, two years before. By dessert he'd noticed her legs again. *Best stop now, Thomas, before your tongue runs away with you.* Christine, oblivious to his gaze — or used to it — was enthusing about her parents' stables, where she still kept a horse.

He replayed the first time he'd met her mother, when she'd inquired pointedly: "Do you ride at all?" And the killer line he'd never delivered: Only your daughter. Cue canned laughter. Not for nothing had Mrs Gerrard later described him as coarse, behind his back of course. Guilty as charged.

His mobile went off. He made that stock face that all people do, suggesting they're irritated by a call even when they're secretly delighted.

"Hi babe. I've hit a problem with that number. Sorry about last night . . ."

He cut across her. "Sorry, you've caught me at a bad time. Can I ring you later? Great — speak to you then." Touché Miranda. He switched the phone off, pre-empting an abusive text.

Christine ran a fingertip around her wine glass. "Girlfriend trouble?" she lifted her head square to his.

He leaned out of the sun. "There is no girlfriend. How about you?" He said it casually and glanced to one side to give her space to respond.

"Me? No, no girlfriend either. My lesbian phase ended at boarding school." She kicked him playfully under the table, tapping her handmade Italian shoes against his brogues. "This is fun, isn't it? We should do this more often; we are friends after all."

He adjusted his crotch under the tablecloth and then raised a glass. They clinked a toast, friends forever. Or for the time being, anyway.

* * *

He didn't ring Miranda back until the evening. Either she couldn't or wouldn't pick up, so it was at least an hour before she returned the call. Another hour, in which he cooked or worked or went to the toilet, with the mobile at his side.

"Hey babe, how's it going?"

He kept it low key. "Yeah, fine; sorry about this afternoon, I was involved in a work thing."

“No problem,” she managed to make it sound just the opposite. “That number you gave me doesn’t exist. Hello? Are you still there?”

“Yeah, I’m here, Miranda.”

“I’ll read it back to you in case I got it wrong.”

He checked on his computer as she spoke. “No, that’s the one. Not to worry.” Except that now, he was really starting to worry.

“Listen, fancy coming over for Sunday lunch? Just me this time!”

“I can’t. I’m off to see the folks.”

“Blimey, hell’s finally frozen over! How long you away for?”

“A long weekend.” There was a pause. He squeezed the phone closer, to hear her breathing.

“Well, if you fancy some company up there . . .”

If you only knew. “The thing is, it’s also a work trip.”

“Oh.”

That was a conversation killer. She said to get in touch if he needed anything and left him to it. On the lounge wall, a seventeen-year-old Miranda gazed back from a hazy St Paul’s Street, Leeds, in the summer of 1994. The warmth of her smile lit up the frame. He closed his eyes and tried to pour himself into that photograph. No such luck.

He didn’t ring his family until Thursday morning; no point building the visit up if he could play it down. His mother started planning an itinerary while they were still talking. And she said that his father would be pleased to see him; she made it sound like a solicitor’s appointment.

Of course, he’d stay with them — they wouldn’t dream of him booking somewhere. He made a note to cancel the hotel in York. She closed the call with ‘give our love to Miranda,’ even though the break-up was years ago.

* * *

Karl was uncharacteristically quiet, had been all day. It was as if someone had super-glued his personality shut. Thomas had tried several approaches without success. Still, today was Thursday, so at least they would be able to talk on neutral ground.

Funny, the way Karl never questioned why he kept going back to the gun club; he’d never really asked himself that either. It felt safe, in a way. Not like being around Miranda and her family, but a different kind of sanctuary. Or maybe it was just Karl. He understood the pressures of the job

and the demands it made. You became guarded, even to those closest to you.

“Are we still on for tonight, Karl?”

His oppo looked up from his eyepiece and gave a thumbs-up. “Roger that!” It still sounded like a watered-down version of Karl. “Got your jim-jams packed for tomorrow, Tommo?” It was the first time he’d mentioned the pick-up job.

“Uh-huh.”

“Well, be careful, okay?”

“Karl, I’m touched, I didn’t know you cared.”

“Listen, laughing boy, just keep your wits about you.”

Strange times indeed.

By the evening, Karl’s introspection pills had worn off. They practiced with a Browning and a Glock, and then Karl nipped out for a .44 Magnum. Thomas felt completely intimidated by the sight of the thing — like that time he and Miranda rented a porn film. Still, he rose to the bait and made a complete arse of himself, to Karl’s evident joy.

“Are you sure now you’re not related to Clint Eastwood?”

More like Clyde the monkey. Later, Karl was his usual chatty self; firearms seemed to give him a new lease of life. By the second pastry, conversation had turned to the marital status — or otherwise — of their colleagues.

Karl was in the chair. “Crossley — not a chance; either plays for the other side or she’s saving herself.”

“What is it with you and her, Karl?”

“Let’s just say we had professional differences in the past. And despite her best efforts, I’m still here. We’ve buried the hatchet and all, but I doubt we’ll ever be pen-pals.”

Okay, crunch time. Thomas took a slip of paper out of his pocket. “I know I was supposed to mind my own business, but I did some checking on our mystery red car and the number plate’s a fake.”

Karl lowered his plate. “I can’t say I’m not impressed. Even so . . .”

“Come on Karl, this is all wrong,” Thomas raised his fingers to count off the points. “First someone gets shot and they take him to a private hospital. Ann Crossley removes the vehicle and the woman who told us

about it gets transferred. Then the car I thought was suspect turns out to have false plates.”

Karl gazed at the ceiling as if seeking inspiration. “I’ll tell you what, Tommo, seeing as how we’re trusting each other. I’ll make you a deal. I’m gonna write something down and put it in an envelope. Don’t open it until we get together again on Tuesday. If I’m right, I’ll let you in — I mean it. But if what’s written down is totally wide of the mark, will you agree to let all this go?”

Like that was ever gonna happen. “You’re on; I do love a magic show.”

“Me? I’m Ulster’s answer to David Copperfield, so I am. Now, sit yourself here while I find some stationery.”

Thomas relaxed a little; he was starting to feel like he belonged. Teresa came over; it was easy to imagine her in a uniform. He was still lost in the ‘regulation skirt’ when she coughed, bringing him back to reality.

“Where’s Action Man?”

“Action Man — brilliant!”

“Because he tries all the equipment here.”

Nought out of ten for deduction.

“So, are you thinking about becoming a member?”

Now there was a thought. Might also be his best chance of finding out about Karl. He shrugged.

“I’m sure someone could vouch for you.”

“Is that how it works, then?”

She smiled enigmatically; too keen. He noticed a cluster ring on her right hand; could have been an old engagement ring. She flexed her hand then massaged her neck self-consciously. “Coffee?”

He shook his head. If he had any more coffee today he’d be able to walk to Leeds.

“Well, well, this all looks very cosy!” Karl had tiptoed across, doubtless using his Action Man skills.

“I’m trying to find out your little secrets.”

“That shouldn’t take long — simple man that I am.”

Yeah, right.

“Here you go, Tommo. Remember, not to be opened until Tuesday.”

The envelope had a daub of wax on the back; blue wax, like a birthday candle. He held out the envelope, wax side up. “Just making sure.”

* * *

Back at the flat, he packed a bag and threw in an AGFA Isomatic 110. Because sometimes he just liked to take snaps. Round about midnight, he put down *The Adventures of Sherlock Holmes* and cut the light.

He always thought that if his father was called upon at the Day of Judgement, it was the one thing he could say in his defence: that he had introduced his son to the great works of Conan Doyle. Tonight he'd made a point of re-reading *The Red-Headed League*, a classic study in misdirection. And come to think of it, Karl had reddish hair too.

He lay on the bed, pondering the incongruities. 'Oh, give over, Thomas; it's just a story,' he could hear his mother chuckling. Even as a child, he had always had 'a head full of questions.' He got undressed and eased into the cool sheets, wondering if Miranda were sleeping alone tonight. Or Christine, come to that.

In the early hours of the morning, a car alarm went off. He dragged himself to the window to check. Unlikely it would be his own car, since: a) the only reason anyone would break into it would be to fit a better stereo out of sympathy and b) he never put the alarm on.

A few doors along, a yellow Ford Escort was revving up for all it was worth, the throaty rumble making the window tremble against his hand. A young woman was stood at the kerbside, arms folded. He caught the gist of it straight away; Sharon didn't love Kevin anymore, but Kevin wanted to prove his love by pissing off her parents and all their neighbours.

He flicked the curtain behind him to get a better view. An RS2000, with four round headlights — four of them! How did a toe-rag like Kevin afford a car like that? Probably wasn't even insured, never mind the bloody tax.

Tax — of course! He shrugged away the curtain and let it fall back into place. *Thank you, Kevin.* The wall-clock showed it was nearly two. He didn't bother putting the light on; hopefully this wouldn't take long.

He fired up his personal laptop — where he kept copies of *all* his photographs. Stuff for work, recent shots that had never made it into his official reports, even a set of wedding photos for Miranda's cousin. All filed, in an orderly system. It only took a minute or so to navigate the folders and subfolders — red car, four pictures. Two of those were partials of the front, at an angle. He magnified the appropriate sections, and

positioned them side by side onscreen. Together, they formed a Rosetta stone, a complete registration that differed from the number plate.

He basked in the blue-green glow of the laptop, staring at the pictures; he was getting good at this. Unlocking a drawer, he lifted out a surfboard key-ring — a Bermuda present from Miranda. He pulled the thing apart, inserted the memory stick device and uploaded the crucial files. Now he'd sleep like a charm — mystery solved.

As he crawled back to bed, checking that the alarm was still set for seven, he wondered if Kevin was back in Sharon's good books now. He hoped so; as far as Thomas was concerned, he'd earned it.

* * *

By seven forty-five, he was out of the flat and walking up Hoe Street — that still made Karl laugh — for Walthamstow Central Underground. The walkway was littered with rubbish bags, discarded cardboard and old newspapers. He fell in step with the rest of the ants, swerved around the offer of a free newspaper and disappeared into the maze of platforms and walkways, unaware that someone else had fallen into step with him.

He surfaced at Kings Cross and headed straight to the ticket office at St Pancras. In the queue, he picked up a text from Miranda: *Have a good trip. Mx.*

And although he'd memorised Monday's reporting instructions, he still pressed his hand lightly against his jacket. He could feel Karl's magic envelope there too. The train was called early so he made the most of it, grabbing a copy of *Private Eye* on the way — just to see what Karl found so amusing.

Once Thomas had passed safely through the barrier, the person trailing him made a call. Sir Peter Carroll liked to be kept informed.

Chapter 12

Thomas left the train at Leeds, for a one-man nostalgia tour. It was a routine that he'd never deviated from over the years. Starting off with the Indian restaurant on Merrion Street where he'd taken Miranda for their first meal together. The place was closed; he pressed his face against the tinted glass. The décor had changed again. It was classier now; looked like there was a bigger fish tank too. He preferred it before.

Next stop Hyde Terrace, the bed-sit — sneaking in with Miranda after hours because the landlady on the premises ran a *respectable* property. Except when her gentleman friend came over on Wednesdays and Saturdays. Good old Christian hypocrisy — a little piece of home. He wondered if she still owned the place and if she'd recognise him as one of the teenage lovers she'd threatened to call the police on; probably not. He settled for a slow walk past.

He had a love-hate relationship with Leeds. It marked the transition between Pickering and London. Leeds was where life had begun to take shape. Being away from home, that first job with photography, meeting Miranda; the good things. But Leeds had also felt soulless; and all that grief with Miranda and Butch Steddings was like a bitter echo of school life. Yep, nothing like revisiting teenage angst for working up an appetite. He'd never tell him, but cafés without Karl just weren't the same, so a pub lunch was the order of the day. Caliban's aside, he wasn't a huge fan of pubs. But the Angel Inn scraped through on atmosphere alone. Thanks to *Private Eye* and a problem with the sandwiches, he lasted a full forty-five minutes.

And finally, on to the main event: the Art Gallery, along The Headrow. Portraits fascinated him; the way they captured something of the inner person and revealed it forever. He'd tried to paint Miranda once — it was rubbish, of course. But the actual process, the way he'd been able to study her for hours and to see how the light changed her features — well, it was almost a religious experience. She hadn't taken the piss either, not even when he'd said he wanted to be a professional photographer one day.

He checked his watch — time to go — and skirted around a gaggle of college girls outside, slowly smoking themselves to death. He made the

station in plenty of time, unlike the delayed Scarborough train.

* * *

At York, he saw his mother standing by the car, as he exited, looking out for him. She waved enthusiastically and he reciprocated with a slow hand. If he'd been any more non-committal he could have doubled as a stunt pope. His father remained in the driving seat, hands on the wheel.

After the obligatory greetings they joined the Friday traffic, slipping across the Lendal Bridge and along the A64 before it clogged up for the evening.

"How's sis?"

"Now, Pat'll be coming over later," his mother changed the subject without drawing breath. "She said to say that Gordon sends his apologies. He's been working long hours and doesn't think he'd be at his best."

Thomas studied the veins on the back of his hand. "How are they getting along these days?"

His father let out a deep sigh, but his mother kept to the script. "He moved out for a few days last month — said he needed a bit of room to himself. He's under a lot of pressure, you know." She said it earnestly, as if to convince all three of them.

Yeah, right. The only pressure Gordon was likely to feel was in his elbows, when he was on top of some tart in Whitby. "Why didn't anyone tell me Pat was having difficulties?"

Thomas's father half-turned. "Because you're never around — not for *this* family, anyway."

And there it was: gloves off, round one.

"Come on James, let's not start."

Father and son stared at each other through the mirror. No one spoke again.

* * *

It was hard to get too worked up about seeing the house, which had been his second childhood home, and he'd left in his teens. But it still held ghosts. He rolled his eyes at the memory of that final-straw row with his dad, over 'drinking and backchat.' Maybe one drinker was all the house could bear.

As soon as they got inside, his mother rushed straight into the kitchen to put the kettle on. It was like he'd never been away. Tea, the great panacea for fractured families, now with added digestives.

Thomas and his father sat in the parlour glancing in the general vicinity of each other. Stalemate. Thomas knew his father would crack first; a childish power play, but one he excelled at. All it took was time, and he could wait.

"So, 'ow's life in London?" his father relented.

"It's okay." Hardly the response of the year, but anything too enthusiastic or dismissive would invite further discussion. *And we wouldn't want to use up all that sparkling banter on the first day, now would we?*

After tea, his father tried again. Rugby — Malton & Norton's season compared with York then football — Leeds United getting robbed again in the final minutes. Thomas didn't bother to remind him that he'd lost interest in sport years ago, not counting the odd West Ham game.

Everything had settled by the time Pat's key rattled in the door. "It's only me." It sounded like she'd brought the little ones as well.

Thomas tried to recall when he'd last seen them and reached into his pocket for some guilt money.

"There he is!" Pat pushed the door to, beaming as if she'd just won the lottery. He eased out of the chair and opened his arms. She squeezed against him, the way a limpet fights against the tide. "It's really good to see you," she whispered, sniffing back tears.

Gordon. That little shit. One of these days he'd get through to him, using Gordon's head for Morse code.

The kids kept their distance at first, hardly surprising as he rarely saw them. All it took was a few words of encouragement from Pat and a few silly noises from him. Pound coins helped as well.

"I thought we could all have tea together," Pat suggested. "Me and Thomas could walk down to the chippie."

He nodded, seduced by the thought of getting out of the house. Fish & chips — a feast for the prodigal son.

"Here," his father held out some notes, "If you eat at my table, you're my guests."

And that about summed it up for Thomas; he was a guest. As soon as they shut the door behind them, leaving the kids hammering on the old

piano, Thomas blew out a breath like an over-inflated balloon.

Pat laughed and grabbed his arm, winching him in close. “I have missed you though. You should come up more often.”

“So I hear.”

She looked away and pulled him towards the gate, still arm in arm. There had always been an easy peace between them, despite their differences. Pat had moved four streets away, settled down and continued the family line. Whereas Thomas, he’d abandoned them all, changed his accent and become a stranger. Pat never questioned that — she understood his reasons.

She waited until they were stuck in the queue outside the fish & chip shop. “How’s Miranda?”

“Still single,” he paused, reading between the lines. “As am I.”

She shook her head faintly, as if she didn’t believe any of it; sisters — too clever by half.

He waited until she’d paid for everything and stopped her at the door. “I’ll pay for this lot. Give Dad his change, no need for him to know. I’m sure Mam can use a little extra.”

She gave him a playful punch and he doubled up in mock agony. “You always were a silly beggar! Come on, I’m famished.”

* * *

It was a typical family scene, three generations eating together; adults with plates on knees, but children up at the table; a bottle of ketchup passed around and hot, sweet tea to wash it all down. Except, for Thomas, it was as alien now as that terrible weekend he’d shared with Christine Gerrard and her parents. It wasn’t that Pickering was smaller — no, it grew bigger with each infrequent visit. But the house, rooms and inhabitants alike — they all seemed narrower.

He walked Pat and the children home afterwards, doing a stint as Uncle Piggy-back. He didn’t go inside though, not if Gordon might be around. It was Pat’s life after all, and lamping someone rarely solved anything. As he wandered back the long way home, a police car blared in the distance. He smiled broadly for the first time that day; he’d make time to see Ajit before Monday.

Ajit was the only school friend he'd bothered to stay in touch with. They had two things in common: a love of photography and a secret they'd never discussed.

No one cared much when Ajit joined the class in 1988, except the throwbacks — and every school had them. It was racism all right, but with a twist. It wasn't the fact that Ajit was Asian, just that he'd come from Lancashire. Or so they said. School life was a proving ground for every would-be alpha-male fuckwit. Thomas had experienced a little of that himself when they moved to Pickering, after Maggie Thatcher broke the miners in two. But any son of a miner was hailed as a hero, even though all he'd done was stand in the street in York, collecting money for them.

Day after day, Thomas had watched Ajit run the gauntlet; watched as the gang formed into a leader and four lieutenants. Thomas knew it wasn't his fight. He and Ajit were both members of Photography Club and shared a few laughs, but that was about it. Still, wrong is wrong, when all's said and done.

Originally, he'd only meant to scare off the main bully, give him a bit of a thump to show him what it felt like. That was how it started, anyway. But it developed a life of its own. He followed the ringleader, and trailed the group to where they smoked and drank cider after school. He bided his time, did nothing while the shoving and the tripping up and the sly punches on the arm continued; just stood and watched. He and Ajit even fell out over it. 'Some friend you are!' Ajit had snapped. Some friend indeed.

On that final, momentous night, he'd gone out fully prepared: black jacket, gloves and balaclava. That Friday, he'd waited in the shadows; even pissed in a bottle to avoid leaving evidence, and chucked it over the wall into the fields. Over an hour, sitting there in the dark, watching. And the more he waited, the stronger he felt. Like he was invincible.

The lad had ambled right past, half-cut on cider. He'd crept up behind with the speed of a cat, swiped him across the head and kneed him in the back, almost climbing on top of him with the momentum. Then, as the boy went down screaming, Thomas scrambled over him and legged it.

The screaming followed him as he'd crossed the road; not that it troubled him any. He scuttled into the first alleyway, pulled off the balaclava and folded it carefully into his pocket. He heard a front door slam and somebody call out in panic, but he kept on walking; he walked tall. A

few streets on and he heard sirens; ambulance or police, could have been both. It didn't matter; for the first time in his life, he'd seen justice.

When he came home, his mother was watching television. His dad was still down the pub — nothing new there. "Cup of tea?" he said it in a quiet voice and his mother obediently scuttled to the kitchen, leaving whatever she'd been watching.

He opened the stove door and carefully placed the balaclava inside, as if it were a funeral pyre. Then he knelt and watched as they burned, feeling the heat against his face. When his mother returned, the smouldering embers were still visible on top of the coal. She didn't ask; mothers never do.

He'd stayed up later than usual even though he was tired. Pat was over at a friend's; she tended to do that on Fridays. She was a smarter girl back then. His father came back after closing time, reeking of beer and resentment.

Things escalated quickly, and this time Thomas stood between his parents, blocking his dad's approach as he swayed around the room — big mistake. The slap caught him unawares and knocked him to the floor. He sat there in a daze, unable to hear what was being said for the roar in his ears. His mother was a statue, no help there.

He remembered getting up and readying his fist. Even though he'd likely get a good belting afterwards, this time he was going down fighting. But his mother intervened, grabbing him roughly by the shoulders to move him to one side. Children hitting their parents back, that was crossing the line.

"Go to bed, James," she'd seethed and his dad had meekly complied.

Thomas had watched with a mixture of amazement and contempt.

"You shouldn't interfere," she'd scolded, as she checked his face for injury.

"Someone should."

"You watch your tongue. He's still your father when all's said and done." Then she sat down to watch the television, as if nothing had happened. "He doesn't mean it, you know," she'd said later without looking at him. "It's just, sometimes . . . the drink brings it out o'him. His dad were the same."

Thomas didn't reply. He rubbed his cheek until the side of his face was sore. Hopefully he'd have a bruise there next day; either way, he'd never forget.

Saturday's local paper ran a front page about a violent attack that had left a boy in hospital. Suspected skull fracture, facial abrasions; cracked ribs. Not quite what Thomas had bargained for, but he wouldn't lose any sleep. On the Monday, a policeman came to school assembly to talk about personal safety.

No one messed Ajit about any more. Nothing proven of course, and the rest of the bullies were hardly likely to speak to the police. On the Wednesday, Ajit didn't come to Photography Club after school. And on the Thursday he caught up with Thomas, alone.

"Look Thomas, don't take this the wrong way, right, but I can't hang around you for a while. My parents want me home straight after school, what with the attack." Then Ajit lowered his voice. "Listen, right, I don't know if it were you or it weren't you. I don't want to know. I'm grateful — he got what was coming to him. But that's an end to it. That's all I'm saying."

Three weeks later, Ajit returned to Photography Club; the pack leader never came back to school. Rumour was that the family had moved away, fearing a vendetta.

The breeze stirred and he touched the side of his face. It was turning cooler. Odd really that he'd ended up working for the government and Ajit had become a police officer — something for a psychologist to chew over.

* * *

Saturday was market day and his mother was in her element, showing off her *visiting* son to every shopkeeper she knew. Then tea and a bap at the new Victorian tearooms — a contradiction that only he found amusing. He sacrificed Saturday afternoon on the altar of television, sat there with his father watching every sport known to man.

It all unravelled after dinner — he should have seen it coming. Leeds had dropped points for no good reason and he'd made the *mistake* of bringing in a bottle of whisky as a peace offering. By the time he'd got back from seeing Pat and the kids — with Gordon still playing the invisible husband — the bottle was half-empty; or half-full, if you happened to be an

optimist. Either way, it didn't take long for old resentments to surface, on both sides.

"What right do you have to judge me, eh? You swan about up here when you feel like it, like some great conquering hero. And you look at us like we're the shit off your shoe. You know your trouble, eh? You're a bloody snob. Ever since the day you met that London tart and you abandoned us."

Twelve years had added weight to the grudge. It was all calculated, of course, in the expectation that Thomas would stand no criticism of Miranda or her family. So he withdrew into himself, waiting for his father to implode. Silence had always been his weapon of choice and he'd honed it like a sabre.

His father crossed no-man's land to deliver another volley. "When we stood shoulder to shoulder . . ."

Thomas winced. *Here we go again . . .*

". . . Shoulder to shoulder as they closed pit after pit — the working man were at war. Months we stood together, while that daughter of the antichrist laid this country to waste. Neighbours — begging for 'andouts, looking in supermarket skips for food."

Tears of bitterness rained down; he wiped them away with a fist. The other hand stayed tightly on the glass. "And when I heard you'd got a job wi' 'The Government,' the very people all working-class folk had been at war with, I were bloody ashamed."

There it was: the cold truth.

"You've betrayed your own class, Thomas; turned your back on your roots. I mean, who are you? Who the bloody hell *are* you?"

Thomas looked to his mother, sat quietly, staring at the carpet. He wondered if she felt the same way. He headed for bed. It wasn't even nine o'clock, but he was exhausted. The whisky had been manipulative; he knew that. But you have to know where the bleeding comes from before you can cauterise it.

He read for a while, too agitated to sleep. Once Sherlock Holmes had resolved *The Eligible Bachelor*, he sent two texts. One to Miranda, which read: *Can I come home now?* And tried to tell himself he was joking. And one to Ajit, to try and arrange a meet-up. Then he turned out the light and sank into a dreamless sleep.

* * *

He woke early on Sunday to the sound of sparrows scrapping on the roof outside. His eyes felt tight against his skin; he'd been crying in his sleep — hadn't done that for some time. He rubbed his face as if he could disguise the evidence.

Tiptoeing around the house reminded him of stolen weekends on the moors. A note left on the table — back on Sunday — and two days of absolute freedom. Ajit's dad would drive them over; sometimes there'd be three or four of them, the car jammed to the gills.

Time check: seven thirty. He crept out quietly. It was a fair distance but he didn't mind the walk; the exercise was good for him, it made him feel grounded.

Ajit was late finishing his shift. Thomas waited in the foyer, sipping machine coffee. The notice board was a library of misery: rabies, terrorism, drug abuse, domestic violence — he read that one twice — and HIV. He figured if you read all that for too long, you'd never want to leave the police station.

The desk sergeant picked up a telephone, nodded to whatever he was hearing and cleared his throat. "Ajit will be out in a bit. You the one from London?"

Thomas smiled grimly, primed for the put-down.

"It's a bit different up 'ere — more sense of community, like. I dare say you've noticed that."

He didn't bother mentioning he was a Yorkshireman by birth; his accent would have made it sound like a mockery. *Sense of community? Easy words.*

The secure door buzzed and clicked — just like the gun club. Then Ajit sprang the door wide with one large hand. He had a smile to match. "Thomas, my man!"

They did a round of macho handshakes and shoulder slaps, until the sergeant asked them if they wanted to be alone together.

"How long you up here for?"

"Heading back tomorrow."

Ajit led him out to the car. "You could have stayed with me and Geena."

“What? And miss playing Happy Families?” He turned abruptly and saw a brown car waiting at the junction. There was no traffic at all. “Could you call it in for me?” He felt the blood draining from his face.

“What’s got into you, Thomas? Are you in some sort of trouble?”

“Can you just call in a PNC check — as a favour to me?”

Ajit reached for the radio. Thomas had already pulled out a small pair of binoculars and started reciting the number plate. Ajit stared, open-mouthed. “Bird watching,” he explained.

The check back came quickly. “’s all right, Thomas, it’s one of ours! Out of town CID. I wonder what they’re doing, coming over the borders!” Ajit peered at Thomas closely, as if he could see past his defences. “Right then, ’ave you got time for a walk in the wilds? ’Cause by the look of it, the town don’t agree with you.”

Thomas brightened. “Aye, that’d be great. Mind if I drive — it makes a change from London.”

“You never did take to being a passenger.”

Too true.

* * *

Ajit filled the passenger seat; he looked as if he’d been poured into the car. It was a different story at school, but a growth spurt at the end of his teens had provided a Sunday rugby side with a formidable prop forward. Now, when he laughed, the whole car seemed to shake. Although, Thomas thought, that could just be the suspension.

Thomas began to relax in his friend’s company. When he’d decided to leave Leeds and go with Miranda to the brighter lights of London, Ajit had been the first person he’d told. It was the kind of easy friendship moulded by years, that doesn’t require regular phone calls; where a missed birthday or a late Christmas or Diwali card is no big deal. Now, driving out across the North York Moors, they were like teenagers again.

“Did tha hear about the Hasselblad on sale at auction, down in London?” Ajit was as excited about the camera as a virgin on a first date.

“Hear about it, I went to view it at Sotheby’s!”

“Yer jammy bastard!” The car rocked again.

They parked up on Ferndale moor and raced up the ridge like children. Thomas was light on his feet, but Ajit powered past him like a steam

engine. From the ridge, the land swept out towards Rudland Rigg. Thomas half wished he'd brought a kite.

"So, come on then, London boy, what sort o' bother are you in?" Ajit made a playful jab at Thomas, which he fended off with a slap.

"You know I work in the Civil Service . . ."

"Aye. Patents or summat?"

"Well, I transferred; I'm a photographer now."

"You lucky beggar. Is it leaflets and that, or something more exciting?"

Thomas took a long breath. "Outdoor work, mainly."

"Nice — buildings or forestry?"

So much for the 'trail of breadcrumbs' approach. "Mainly people; the sort who don't know they're being watched."

"By heck, Thomas Bladen, you're a dark horse."

Thomas caught the way that Ajit's face froze for an instant; maybe he was remembering a time that he'd rather have forgotten.

"Are you allowed to tell me who you work for, then?"

He blew a dandelion head and watched as the spores drifted at the mercy of the breeze. "SSU — Surveillance Support Unit."

"Blimey, who'd a' thought it; one of them coverts. I won't say owt, obviously." Ajit gave a wink the size of Catterick. "Still durn't explain your bit of bother though."

Thomas pushed the binoculars to his face and said nothing.

Ajit seemed to take the hint. "Give us a go, then," he swung wide towards Rosedale Abbey. "Buzzards are out — Geena and I come up here regularly."

"I thought the suspension was a bit worn out."

"Give over!" Ajit gave him a shove and continued tracking the buzzards. "You know I'd help you, Thomas, as much as I can of course," his voice warbled with concern.

Thomas smiled for about a second. Even now Ajit believed in the letter of the law; he admired that in a way. "Thanks Aj; I'll let you know if I need you."

They stood side by side for a long time, gazing out across the rich moorland; neither one spoke. Then Thomas sighed and the spell was broken. He wanted to tell Ajit that it was good to be back, despite everything, but there was no need.

“Right then, me little Cockney Sparra, let’s get you back to the bosom of your family.”

“And you back to Geena’s.”

“I’ll bet that sort of wit goes down a storm in London.”

“I have to ration the tickets to keep the crowds down.”

Ajit contorted himself into the driver’s seat. “Don’t give up your day job.”

No chance of that now, not when it’s getting so interesting.

* * *

Ajit declined the offer to come in and say hello to the folks, but he asked after Pat and wished her well. Back in the mists of time, he had gone out with her for a short while. After Thomas had left for Leeds, of course.

“Is that you, Thomas?” his mother cooed. She knew perfectly well it was; she’d been standing at the curtains when the car pulled up. “Door’s on the latch. Come in, kettle’s already on.”

He grinned; one day, scientists would research the psychic ability of mothers to know when to make tea. “Is he up yet?”

“Well . . . your father’s not feeling too great. He’s asked if you’d like to go over Fylingdale this afternoon . . .” she waited, hands apart in nervous tension, clapping them together triumphantly at the answer she’d hoped for.

Afternoon. Wow; must be a hell of a hangover this time.

“He doesn’t mean it, Thomas, you know that. You’re his only son when all’s said and done and he just wishes you were back here; we all do. Oh, I know too much has happened for you to want that — you’ve got your own life now — I’m not stupid. But it doesn’t stop us wishing.”

Thomas slid an arm around her waist. “You’re a very wise woman.”

She looked him up and down. “Wise enough to know not to bring a bottle of whisky into the house. He can’t ’andle his drink — never could, lets all the demons out. I think you did it on purpose,” she gave him a mock slap on the arm. “Come on, sit yourself down — I’ll make your favourite breakfast. I’ve got in smoked bacon and eggs.”

His father didn’t surface until after one, announced by a groan; he couldn’t tell if it was the door or his dad. James nodded carefully, acknowledging them both in one sorry movement. On the table was a steaming mug of tea and a paracetamol. He lowered himself to the chair as

if it was a hot bath and took his medication. “I’ll be right as rain in a bit.” He looked as if he’d slept in the rain.

Thomas put the newspaper down and enjoyed the spectacle of his dad trying to tackle some toast. It might have been his imagination, but his mother seemed to have made it extra crunchy.

* * *

Eventually, they made it out to Fylingdale; Thomas ended up doing the driving, as his father didn’t feel up to it. He pulled in by the side of the road so that the wind buffeted the windows and gently rocked the car. When he was a kid, Thomas had been told that this was the Weatherman helping him to sleep.

Despite the wind, Thomas left his jacket open, enjoying it against his skin. He closed his eyes, lost to the elements and swallowed by the moors. And his first thought — the only one that came to mind — was wishing Miranda could feel this now, beside him.

His father tapped his arm. “Remember that old bunker we found on’t moor? They’ve opened it up to the public — I’ll show you.”

‘We found.’ Close enough; Thomas and Ajit had uncovered the hatch in a thicket, running around like crazed puppies. His father had shouted, ‘give it a rest or go play somewhere else.’ And so they had. Ah, hangover weekends, such a staple of childhood memories.

At first they thought they’d discovered a secret tunnel into Fylingdales airbase — Fylingdales, USA, as some locals called it. He remembered Ajit and him writing a letter to the base commander about doing a school project on it. Then a nice man from the USAF came to Photography Club with a wings patch for each of them and a donation to the school. It turned out that the bunker didn’t go anywhere; it was an isolated installation built as a test.

Seventeen years or so later, the sealed door had been exchanged for a lockable one and the Cold War relic was now a freebie tourist attraction. They managed a five-minute tour, grabbed a leaflet and set off across the moorland. Thomas didn’t say much afterwards, but he noticed his dad wincing with the exertion of the walk. He stopped and waited, made like he had cramp.

“Yer taken any good photographs lately, Thomas?”

He smiled, knowing that *good* automatically excluded talk of London skylines. “Aye. I went to Wales for shots of the red kite. I’ll send you prints if you like.”

“Yeah, do that. Wales in’t so far from London, is it?”

A subtle way of reminding him that Pickering was about the same distance. He conceded defeat by changing the subject. “We’ll need to make tracks soon or dinner’ll be burnt to a crisp.”

They both laughed. As if Thomas’s mother would ever let that happen. Growing up, Thomas often wondered what she’d seen in his father, although he’d been a muscular man in his younger days, when he worked the pit. At times like this though, when his dad laughed, then he understood.

He slowly shook his head. Fathers and sons; they made the hundred years war look like a skirmish. On the way to the car they passed a family making their way up the slope, the boy screaming with laughter as his dad raced on with the boy squarely on his shoulders. Thomas had to look away.

Chapter 13

The family had given him a good send-off, Sunday night. A light tea and then a round of happy — i.e. highly edited — memories; photo albums all present and correct. Pat brought the kids; Gordon even put in an appearance later on, to take the children home. Dad was off the drink for the night; he only usually drank on Fridays and Saturdays. Maybe that was why Thomas had always hated Fridays.

Ajit came over first thing Monday morning, like the cavalry. Destination: Leeds. Geena waited in the car and Ajit stood at the gate, as if he were guarding Thomas's only means of escape.

His dad raised a hand in greeting from the front door. "By heck, Ajit, you'll be needing a bigger police car soon."

Thomas eased past his folks and called his goodbyes. His father had a love-hate relationship with Ajit. Loved the man, but hated what he'd become — another rant for another Friday night.

"Have a safe journey, son, and don't forget about sending those photographs."

Son — blimey, one for the diary.

Geena moved to the back seat, but not before she had swarmed over Thomas. "Come 'ere, you big lump."

He glanced at Ajit. Compared to *him*, he wasn't even a lumpette.

"So," Geena piped up as soon as the car pulled away. "'Ave you told him, then?" Ajit said nothing. "Three months gone!" she cried, "You're gonna be an uncle, Thomas!" She ran a hand where the bulge would appear.

Thomas didn't ask why he was only finding out now; secrecy seemed to be catching. "Crikey, what did your dad say, Ajit? Has he fixed a date for you, then?"

Ajit flexed his lips and launched into a parody of Mr Singh senior. "Ajit, now see here, I'm an 'onourable man with an 'onourable son . . ."

Thomas stared hard at his friend. "You 'aven't told *him* yet either, have you, you great pudding?"

"Men — you're bloody useless," Geena laughed even as she said it. "Leave it to the women — I've already told your mam."

“What?” Ajit instinctively turned round to her.

“Eyes on the road, you big lump,” Geena pushed out her hand.

Thomas had a flash of inspiration. “A month or two from now, you’ll both be great lumps!”

Geena leaned in, between the front seats. “Yeah and it wouldn’t hurt you to do a bit o’ settling down.”

Ajit looked daggers at her. She made a ‘What have I said?’ face and fell silent. Thomas reached for the radio to drown out his thoughts.

* * *

At Leeds station, he separated out a rucksack and stowed the rest of his stuff in a locker. He’d completed a walk past on the Friday so he knew where the office was — a typically drab MoD building. The security process was less sophisticated than Whitehall, but no less formal. After an ID check and sign-in, he was shown to a side room. Away from family and friends, old ideas returned to haunt him. Like how he’d got the gig for a Yorkshire pick-up at all. Perhaps this was Peterson’s revenge? If so then Sir Peter Carroll was in on the gag. Anyway, he was here now.

Just about the time he’d started counting ceiling tiles, a woman entered the room — mid-thirties, not big on words. Her epaulettes identified her rank as a captain — good to know he’d learned something from Karl. He found himself unconsciously closing his legs and straightening his posture. She might have been in Leeds, but her accent was pure South East England, as if the two of them were on an exchange programme. “This way if you please, Mr Bladen.”

He followed her down three flights of concrete steps. His breath hung in the air; the basement was big on atmosphere, but small on heating. And the blast-proof doorframe only served to remind him of the Fylingdale bunker. The Captain produced a swipe card and approached the keypad. He instinctively turned away until he heard the last of the bleeps.

She levered the door mechanism and swung it, beckoning him in without speaking. Inside the room were two safes, a table bench like something out of a school science lab and a couple of chairs. It all looked like a full-sized logic problem. While he took a seat, the good captain produced two keys, which she held up one at a time, as if she was performing a trick. He almost clapped. She inserted a key into the safe on

the left, in precise movements. The mechanism gave way with a *clunk* then she pulled back the reinforced door and started unloading the contents.

It was money, a lot of money. *Holy shit*. The packets of currency piled up on the table.

“That's fifty-three thousand pounds.”

No it wasn't. He pressed his palms together, as if to stem the sweat. *Jesus*. He focused on the mound of sealed packets. That indefinable itch was kicking in. “Can you count them, please?”

She did as he asked, counting the *fifty-seven* packages out, just as he had the first time. Next thing he did was glance around the room for CCTV. What the hell was going on? She seemed genuinely perplexed, but that cut no ice with him.

“Check again.”

“The requisition order states that fifty-three thousand pounds are to be couriered and that all contents are to be cleared from the safe.” She waved the paperwork in the air — it could have been in Greek for all he cared. On the shelf behind her was a single DSB — document security bag. He stood back and watched while she bagged the goods like an upper-class bank-robber. Then he noticed the split in the bag. He took a deep breath and tried to ignore the adrenaline racing in his veins.

“I can't take it like that. Don't bother sealing it — I'll need a new DSB.”

Her head flicked up. “It's the only one we've got here. I'd have to go all the way upstairs. You have your rucksack in any case.”

She pronounced it *rook-sack*, as if it were an exotic object. And she clearly wasn't used to being given orders by civilians. Tough. He didn't waste words. “I'm not taking that package in that DSB. So either you get a new bag or you can stick it back in the safe.”

“But you'll miss your train.”

He did a double take. *Miss my train?* Two years he'd been fetching and carrying for the SSU. No one at the collection point was supposed to know the courier's travel arrangements. It shouldn't have been possible.

She broke eye contact. “Very well,” she blushed scarlet, “Wait here.”

“I'll wait outside, thanks. And best lock the door with what's in here.”

She wavered then thought better of it, ushering him out quickly. Once the door was reset, she rushed upstairs two steps at a time. He pressed

himself against the wall, felt the cold surface hard against his skin. He touched Karl's envelope through his jacket and wondered if this was all some kind of sick joke. Maybe that was it; someone would be out soon to admit to the wind-up.

A minute or so on and he started to wonder if they'd abandoned him down there. *Think Thomas, think.* He could always leave — just walk away and call it in as a no-show. But that frisson of fear was also exciting; it was like the feeling he'd had that first time at the gun club. As if there was a bigger picture. And knowing that, he had questions that needed answers. Like since when did the SSU act as bagmen for currency? And if they'd always been, since when did they start sealing confidential packages in front of the courier?

The Captain clattered back down the stairs — she looked as pale as he felt. She handed him the DSB then remembered that she had to unlock the door again. His going off message like that must have thrown her completely — not part of the plan, whatever the plan was. His paperwork was duly signed and countersigned then she bundled him out of the building. What had really burned the stew was his insistence on keeping the ripped DSB as evidence. If looks could kill, she would have been a soldier. Then again . . .

Outside, in the street, he pulled the rucksack in tight over his shoulder and sprinted for the first taxi he saw. He directed the cab to the Art Gallery and stood at the roadside until he was sure it had gone. A large coffee helped to stave off the shock. He threaded through the crowds and took his place in the taxi queue.

* * *

At the station, he retrieved his bag and had another coffee. All in all, he'd done well. Neither DSB was sealed — a simple sleight of hand distraction before both bags went into his rucksack — or was that rook-sack? He laughed into his coffee. A profitable retirement as a stage magician; Karl could be his assistant. Karl, in a non-speaking role — now that *would* be magic.

The London train was late, leaving him too much time for introspection; the coffee wearing off didn't help his mood either. Ajit and Geena — shit, they were starting to behave like adults. Okay, Ajit had

always been responsible. But, a baby! And Pat looked all set to become a one-parent family in the not too distant future. Mum and Dad were the same of course, like that was supposed to be a comfort. And to top it all, *he* had just played Secret Squirrel and walked off with fifty-seven grand — with four of that unaccounted for. Watson, we have a problem.

The tannoy finally delivered an indifferent apology and announced that the train was in. He quickstepped up to first class and tried not to look smug as the poor bastards in standard walked further down the platform. He found his reserved seat and quickly abandoned it for another, which had no seat behind him. A few rows away a student — by the looks of him — settled in and upped the volume on his earpieces. Thomas counted to twelve and stared out the window, eager to be free of Leeds; he didn't relax until they were on the move.

A few minutes out of the station, as if answering a scratchy mating call, the train manager appeared and made a beeline for Grunge Boy, checked his ticket and pointed him towards cattle class. Thomas couldn't help but smile; nice try kid.

As Grunge Boy approached, he mouthed something that looked like *wanker*. Thomas gently angled out the tip of his boot. Grunge Boy was too busy flipping Thomas the finger and went down like a sack of shit.

He grinned; the bloke looked a lot grungier, face down. Then he noticed how straight the back of his hair was and a wave of panic swept over him. For a moment, he considered checking him for ID, but he calmed himself and laughed it off. "Are you alright, mate?" He figured Grunge Boy must be okay if he was well enough to keep swearing.

Thomas smelled her perfume before he saw the woman — something a little more upmarket than he was used to. She asked without words if the seat opposite was taken. He did the polite thing, shook his head and scanned the rest of the carriage for options. Sod it, he was settled now and the journey was less than three hours — he could grin and bear it. It was an attractive perfume after all, on an attractive woman.

"Ooh look — matching rucksacks!" she lifted hers up from the floor to show him. He patted his own rucksack on the seat beside him and tried to quell the warning bells in his head. Any fishier and he'd be in Whitby harbour.

He had to admit it; first class really was first class. True, it was more of a finger bowl than a mug's worth, but the coffee was good and strong — and free. He glanced up at the woman opposite, now deep into her copy of *Feng Shui Gardening*. Hardly reading matter for spies. He sighed, remembering the game that he and Miranda used to play in Leeds — the name game. Pick any stranger and give them a name based on an arbitrary feature or characteristic, usually the first thing you notice. The advanced version involved picking occupations and back-stories.

Chelsea Girl — as in the flower show — looked over from her magazine and made a half-smile. Maybe this was how spies went on the pull. Maybe he was thinking about everything a tad too much. He hid himself in *The Return of Sherlock Holmes* and left her to it. He loved the way that everything in the stories had a purpose — no excess fat. If only real life were that reasonable.

When the remainder of Moriarty's gang were safely under lock and key, Thomas put the book down to rest his eyes. He couldn't shake the high strangeness of the morning. Had he done the right thing in taking charge, back in Leeds? Perhaps it really was some sort of test? More likely Sir Peter Carroll got his kicks from moving pieces around a board, playing Churchill in his war room.

Thomas had always felt, deep down, that the old man had a soft spot for him, what with being a civilian and everything. Once, back in State House, Sir Peter had waited patiently while Thomas had spent fifteen minutes setting up a skyline shot at sunset. Not a word spoken until the magic moment was captured. Come to think of it, he'd given Sir Peter a print of that.

Right; time to get busy. He launched from his seat, stepping carefully over Chelsea Girl's stylish feet as he headed for the toilets, rucksack in hand. He did wonder if he'd be mistaken for a pornographer in need of a quick fix, but needs must.

Even in first class, there was someone incapable of flushing the toilet, or keeping their first class piss off the seat. He slammed the lid down and pulled a pair of gloves from his jacket. Best not to put fingerprints on the money while he was transferring it back to the old, torn DSB. Yep, all fifty-seven thousand, still there. It weighed less than he'd expected, not that he was in the habit of ferrying huge amounts of cash around.

Someone tried the lock from outside. He didn't bother responding; he had other things to think about. He'd keep the unsealed DSB and add it to the bugging device that Karl had given him in Caliban's; he was fast building a trophy spy kit. He checked the rucksack was secure, flushed the toilet and opened the door, only remembering to take off his gloves halfway down the carriage.

By London, he and Chelsea Girl had totted up less than five minutes of conversation — a personal best in stonewalling. He let her exit the train first and gave her a couple of minutes' head start.

* * *

Sir Peter was very specific about the delivery time — which left a conundrum. How do you kill a few hours with fifty-seven grand to look after? Simple really — you take it to the movies. Leicester Square was a 'phantasmagoria of cinematic entertainment' — he'd read that once on a tourism leaflet. He picked a foreign film with subtitles. Miranda had made him sit through a dozen foreign films when she'd returned from Bermuda. But once he'd seen *Rififi*, he was hooked.

Sadly, this wasn't even *Rififi*'s second cousin. After two and a half hours, the tortured Breton artist had left her diplomat husband and set sail for Tangiers with her daughter and a cat called Filou — like the pastry. At least, that's what he thought had happened; he'd tuned out for a while, absorbed by the soundtrack of his thoughts, trying to make sense of a very difficult day.

He arrived at Main Building with twenty minutes to spare. He'd decided to check in early, then kick his heels in the foyer, maybe count some tiles. He approached the reception desk, relieved to have finally made it.

"I have a personal delivery for Sir Peter Carroll." He passed his ID through the slot.

The woman on the other side of the glass looked him up and down. Nothing like a hearty welcome, and neither was this. A colleague beside her picked up a telephone and a round of military whispers ensued. It was a quick game. "Sir Peter Carroll is no longer in the building."

He took out his orders and studied them again; there was no mistake. "Can you check to make sure?"

Again, the look that told him he was about as welcome as Karl on Ann Crossley's honeymoon. He put the bag down and massaged the sweat into the back of his neck. "Is there any way of reaching Sir Peter?"

"Sir Peter," she stressed, as if to reclaim the name from the lips of an infidel, "... is unavailable." There was a long pause. "Is there someone else I can call for you?"

"Forget it," he narrowed his eyes, "I'll come back tomorrow."

Outside, the screech of London traffic brought him to his senses. He checked his watch; still time to make it back up to Leeds, but the building would likely be closed. Why hadn't he rung ahead when he'd first got to London? Easy answer: because he'd never had to before.

His mobile held five numbers now: Miranda, her parents, her brothers' place, Karl and the Pickering homestead. And by his own reckoning that was probably two numbers too many. His thumb hovered over the choice of speed-dials. No contest, under the circumstances.

John Wright picked up immediately. "Yorkshire Tourist Board." Funny man — he must have clocked the caller. "Alright, Thomas, how was your time away?"

"Good, thanks; not long back. Listen, all right to pop over tonight?"

"You're always welcome! Bring some money — we'll play some cards."

Bring some money; that had to be the understatement of the decade. "Nice one, John," he fought to control the shake in his voice. "I'll train it up and grab a cab at the station."

"Don't be daft. Ring from the train and one of the boys'll meet you."

"Thanks mate." He began to breathe easy again. The boys would be there too. The Wrights' home was the safest place he knew. And there was always the chance that Miranda would put in an appearance, especially if he texted her.

Back at his flat, he decanted dirty clothes, picking up clean ones and his personal laptop. He was in the middle of deciding whether to take along a camera when the phone rang. Fantastic, Miranda must have got his message.

"Hello?" Silence. The kind of metallic silence where you think you can hear whirls and echoes, but really there's a cavernous emptiness. He waited, a minute or more, his heart pounding as he strained to pick up clues —

breathing, background noise, anything. He put the phone down and straightaway drew the curtains. *Easy, Thomas*. Probably just a wrong number, some old dear, as deaf as a post, who'd misdialled.

The phone started up again, its tinny, synthetic sound reverberating through the flat. He crept to the window — nothing in sight either direction. The phone was still ringing relentlessly: number withheld. Now he was really freaked. Whoever it was, he'd answered before so they knew someone was in. Stupid — he might as well have hung a banner outside: 'cash available to good home.'

The racket from the phone died; the silence afterwards was deafening. He tiptoed to the front door and double-bolted it. There was only one choice — he could either stay there with a bagful of money or make a break for it.

He grabbed his rucksack and bag — no time to change now — and went to the back door. He pressed his face tightly against the frosted glass and waited. There was no sense of any movement out there. The door opened with a creaking click; he never oiled it on purpose. He locked up and took the metal steps two at a time, down to the excuse of a garden. His eyes scanned the debris — bingo, just what the doctor ordered. He grabbed a piece of wood that had been dumped there and weighed it — good enough to do some damage.

The gate swung back and bounced a little against the back post. Another pause, listening out into the open space, breath held, straining for clues. At the point where he needed to breathe again he stepped into the back alley, club in hand. Fear was turning to a simmering rage. He slammed the gate shut and took practice swings with the stick. But all that lay before him was a few old dustbins, half a motorcycle and the usual mixture of newspapers, discarded milk bottles and dog shit.

He trod warily, the stick primed by his side. Nothing stirred except his own overwrought imagination. At the end of the alleyway he dropped the stick and broke into a gallop. Call it instinct, call it paranoia; call it what the fuck you like, he had to get away from there. As he closed on Walthamstow Central a bus drew by and he was so hyped up that he got on — and stayed on — just to give himself some time to uncoil. He sat downstairs near the exit and rode the bus all the way to Leyton Underground instead.

He didn't phone the Wrights until he was climbing the stairs at Barking. Terry, the elder son, was there in minutes. How Terry could afford a BMW

remained a mystery to him; the Wrights' business dealings were as unfathomable as the Atlantic, and probably as treacherous. Two poor sods waiting for taxis looked on with envy as Thomas opened the car door; he couldn't blame them. Silver and chrome bodywork, sixteen valves, two hundred Nm of torque, and all the other specs that had meant nothing whatsoever to Thomas when Terry described them in loving detail. But it looked the business.

He climbed inside, squeezed his bag behind him and kept the rucksack on his knees — he felt like a first day pupil holding his satchel.

Terry talked as fast as he drove. "So this American geezer rings up and offers me a '67 Corvette — imagine that!

At that moment, all Thomas could imagine was his last coffee churning in his stomach. Terry interrupted the anecdote for some toe-curling cornering. "And I said to him: I'll give you fifteen grand, subject to sight, and he says . . ."

Look at the road; look at the road.

"American geezer, he says to me: 'Son, you got yourself a deal.' Stupid yank got the year wrong. Turns out it's a '78, but I reckon there's enough parts in the wreck to turn a profit."

"Wreck?"

"Yeah — totalled. Dad's gonna come with me to check it out, then we'll strip it down at the yard. I know this, erm — whatcha call it — installation artist. Poncey modern stuff — great body though."

"What, the Corvette?"

"No, some mate of Sheryl's; comes into Caliban's now and again."

Thomas nodded carefully; his head was spinning.

"Yeah, she uses the car parts in her sculptures. I wish she'd use my parts."

Hand off crotch; both hands on the wheel!

The BMW arrived at Chez Hideaway with a final flourish of brakes that set Thomas's teeth on edge. Diane, matriarch of the Wright clan, was waiting at the door. Terry fetched Thomas's bag from the car.

"Thomas, come inside love — you're as white as a sheet."

And no bloody wonder after Steve McQueen's performance. He went in to the living room and looked for Miranda; it was too much to hope for, but

that hadn't stopped him hoping. John met him with a beer in his hand. "John, could I 'ave a private word?"

"No problem. Come through — pizzas are on their way."

He followed John to a side wing of the house, rucksack in hand.

"We can talk here in my office — I work from home some of the time now." The room was as silent as a Mafioso on trial.

Thomas glanced around the room in surprise. It was spotless, orderly, not what he'd expected. No dodgy shipment receipts, no unpaid bills from the Revenue and no rolls of twenties — like *he* could talk, today.

"Take a pew. Now, what can I do for you?"

No easy way to do this. Thomas pulled open the rucksack and the ripped DSB to afford John a generous view.

"Fuckin' 'ell, Tom — this is s'posed to be a friendly game."

They laughed together. And as Thomas leaned back he saw three frames up on the wall. In the centre was a classic photograph of the whole family. He remembered the occasion well; Miranda had made him go shopping with her. Not that watching Miranda try on a succession of figure-hugging dresses could ever be described as a burden. He'd been the photographer, plumping for a 90mm lens on a 35mm camera.

To the left of that was a framed newspaper clipping: LOCAL BUSINESSMAN EXONERATED IN POLICE INVESTIGATION. Thomas turned away quickly before the blush took hold. That had been the closest he'd come to owning up about his day job, around a year ago. His back twinged just thinking about it. Two hours in situ, waiting for a copper so bent he could have doubled as a corkscrew. Waiting in shitty weather and poor lighting so he could capture the moment when Bent Cop tried to collect a pay-off, to avert a watertight but spurious case.

Yeah, lots of risk on that one, especially from the work side. Still, he'd achieved a natty set of black and whites — he preferred them for detail in crap lighting — and a half-decent sound recording, good enough for the police anyway. John, his brief and some senior officers all received an anonymous set of photos. Only the police received the sound recording.

He sensed John watching him, but his curiosity was in overdrive. The third frame really surprised him. Circa 1990: *Meet the Parents*, East London style. It must have been one of their first nights out after he and Miranda had come down from Leeds. The composition was too wide and

contrived although it had a sort of naïve charm; it looked like a snapshot in time, a moment of stillness that couldn't last. Thomas and Miranda, front and centre, sharing a shy clasp at the very bottom of the picture. Diane and John resting hands on their shoulders. A tight-group foursome that still evoked a sense of belonging. Jesus. He'd be reaching for a hankie soon.

"I keep 'em up there to remind me what's important." John smiled and clapped him on the shoulder. "So if you're in some sort of bother, you only have to ask."

Thomas kneaded his forehead. How do you follow that? With the truth — most of it anyway — starting with the pick-up in Leeds, down to the silent phone calls in the flat. John listened, perfectly still, as if several grand in a rucksack was nothing new.

"Well, you know you can stay here, as long as you want. Terry or Sam can drop round the flat tomorrow and pick up some of your gear."

A nice idea, but not a solution. "Nah, I'll be fine once I get rid of the money." On cue, they both looked back into the bag.

"I s'pose it is real?"

Thanks, John; something else to obsess about.

John leaned back against his chair. "Okay, here's what I think. Stash the money in my safe for tonight and we'll consider the subject closed. You sleep on it and make sure you take some photos, as evidence."

Sound advice. When the deed was done, John let out a belch that would rival anything the Harwich ferry claxons could produce. "Better out than in. Right then," he clapped his hands together. "Let's go play some *cards*. I feel lucky!"

Everyone in the family knew that Diane was the cards maestro. Popular rumour — and the couple encouraged speculation — was that John and Diane had first met at a casino. One version ran that Diane was a croupier and John the hapless punter. Another, that John had played dumb to win her over — unlucky in cards and all that. The romantic in Thomas was happy to believe either.

He followed John into the living room. Lounges were something other people had — in smaller houses.

"Where's the bloody pizza — I'm starving. Thomas, do the honours will you; drinks and glasses in the usual place," John waved him past. The

doorbell rang. "About time!" John roared over the chaos of chairs, crockery and glasses all moving simultaneously.

Diane looked over for an instant. "Thomas, be a dear and see to the door."

He passed four beer bottles over to Sam, mid-waltz, and headed for the door, wallet at the ready.

Miranda was stood before him, laden with pizzas. "Special delivery."

He stood at the door, doing the algebra in his head: sight + sore eyes = Miranda.

She deposited the pizza boxes on the hall table. "Mum said to come over; she was worried about you."

Must remember to up the size of Diane's Christmas present this year. He slipped his arms around her waist and pulled her close, breathing her in like oxygen. He was about to speak when she closed her mouth over his. She tasted of ripe cherries and vanilla again. He closed his eyes and lost himself in her scent, her touch, her sanctuary.

"Put him down, sis; some of us need *food*."

He felt her hand leave his back, probably to flip the finger at Sam. And then the heat of her smile against his face. He was safe, cocooned from the world in the bosom of the family: Miranda's family.

Chapter 14

The two strangers hunched down into their car seats a little more tightly to drive out the cold. The younger man rubbed his hands together, like a character straight out of Dickens.

“Can’t you put the heater on, just for a little while?”

“Nikolai,” the older man said in a disparaging tone, betraying the slightest trace of Mother Russia, “To be too comfortable would dull your senses. Have some more coffee if you wish.”

“It’s *Nicholas* — you know that,” he scowled at the thermos flask by his feet, but didn’t dare voice his displeasure openly.

The older man tutted and pressed the button for the dashboard clock. Within the next two hours, four identical snatch burglaries would take place across North London — starting now. “It is time,” he opened his mouth wide to pronounce the name, “Ni—cho—las,” ending with a malevolent hiss. “Take this and remember, he will be alone and unarmed.”

The younger man made an audible gulp. He reached for the gun and held it flat in the palm of his hand, as if weighing the outcome of the enterprise.

“Only shoot if you have to, but try not to kill him. Such things attract the wrong kind of attention.”

Nicholas put on a balaclava and slid out of the car, pistol thrust into his pocket. He padded across the street, a door-ram enforcer hanging at his side, scanning left and right like a night-time road safety ad. He mounted the steps in two stretches and paused at the door, listening for a television or a radio. It was unlikely that the owner would be awake at this hour; that gave him the element of surprise.

A prior visit to a similar property, a few streets away, had given him the dimensions of the flat and the distance to be covered inside. He let go of the gun and it sagged in his coat, spoiling the well-tailored lines. He swallowed hard, took a couple of steadying breaths then swung back the enforcer with both hands, penduluming into the door with an almighty crash.

The older man heard the sound and smiled in the semi-darkness. Two minutes at most. He hummed a little tune and flexed his gloved fingers like

a concert pianist, calmly screwing in the silencer on the barrel. He released the car door and stepped outside in the chill of the early morning, resolved and unconcerned — no loose ends. A sound at the rear of the car caught his attention and as he turned, the handle of an automatic pistol smashed against his skull.

A finger pointed at the figure slumped on the pavement and then to the back of the car. The man on the ground yielded a low moan, which drew no one's sympathy. A canvas bag was placed on his head, hangman-style, and the body searched. The weapon was extracted and the body placed in the car boot. The leader directed his two colleagues with more hand gestures, and then crept across the street. He checked the safety on his pistol was off and nudged the door gently; the splinters of wood whined in protest. He stepped inside, keying his senses to the slightest sound or movement.

Nicholas was still in the living room, getting his bearings. He moved towards what should have been Thomas's bedroom and cocked his head, listening for breathing. The door was only pulled to, which gave him an extra second and a greater advantage. He grinned in the dark; his first field assignment was going like clockwork. *Surprise, domination and victory* — he heard the words in his head like a school motto. He flexed his shoulders to psych himself up even more, lifted the gun and rushed the door.

"Right!" he felt by the wall for the light switch. "Give me all your money — *now!*" The bed was empty; sheets neatly tucked in at the corners. "Shit!" he gasped aloud.

Before he could get out another word, a 9mm Browning pistol pressed tightly against his temple. "Don't even fucking think about it," Karl McNeill snarled into his ear.

Nicholas dropped his pistol as if it were molten lead. Karl slammed a knuckle ring into his face, smashing him to the floor. Then he knelt on his arms, ripping off the balaclava. Nicholas was barely conscious, which left little reason for the punches that followed. But Karl delivered them anyway.

"Karl, that's enough," a woman's hand pressed into his shoulder.

He eased himself up and turned to the man beside her. "Get him out of here and I want this damage cleared up pronto — call a team in." And even though he knew now that Thomas wasn't at the flat, he padded the rooms searching for him until Teresa ordered the stand-down. His hand smarted where the ring had cut into his own knuckle and the pulses of pain danced

with the adrenaline tremor that ran through his body like a fever. “Where are you, Tommy Boy?”

Chapter 15

John Wright was already sorting out breakfast at six thirty in the morning, whistling a Beatles tune like John Lennon could never have imagined. Thomas walked into the kitchen and raised a nanosecond grin at the idea of John and Karl forming their own covers group — touring prisons to punish the inmates.

“Morning Thomas, what can I get you?”

It was a longstanding morning ritual. Diane liked a lie-in until seven-ish so John took her in the customary tea and toast. Thomas used to have a similar arrangement with Miranda, only his service was a little more personal. No Miranda today though — she’d left around eleven the previous night. Thomas conjured up the memory of her at the front door, like a child recalling their favourite Christmas.

“Tea and some toast would be great, thanks John.”

“Are you sure about going into work today?”

He shrugged. What else *could* he do? The best thing would be to ring Christine, explain that he’d be late on-site and head over to Whitehall again to get it over with. He nodded at the thought — must ring Karl as well. That magic envelope had been burning a hole in his brain since he woke up; at least one mystery would be settled today.

Sam bounded into the kitchen while Thomas was still crunching toast. “No Miranda?” The youngest of the Wrights was as matter-of-fact about the whole Thomas-Miranda thing as the rest of the family. Ten years of will-they-won’t-they had worn their expectations down to a smooth, frictionless finish.

“Nah, she went home last night.” Thomas crunched his toast.

“Oh,” Sam sounded disappointed for him. That made two of them.

* * *

When Sam dropped Thomas off at Barking station before eight, Thomas had the semblance of a plan. He’d make his calls and squat at Whitehall. Sir Peter would turn up eventually and, if he didn’t, Thomas would wait it out. Maybe it wasn’t very professional, but then nor was leaving someone holding a stack of money.

On the way down to the platform, he checked the mobile. Pat had sent a text thanking him for coming up — a technological first for her. And there was one voicemail alert. The call had come through in the small hours. Maybe Sir Peter was apologising? Unlikely, as he didn't have his personal number; at least, Thomas hadn't given it to him.

Standing on the stairway he jammed the phone against his ear, oblivious to the lava flow of people around him.

"Thomas, this is Karl — where the hell *are* you? Is everything all right? Ring me — it doesn't matter what time. Ring me *immediately*."

Thomas didn't waste any time.

"Tommo, thank God! Are you okay? Can you talk? Are you alone?" It was like a podcast of Question Time.

"I'm fine. I can talk for a sec — I'm about to get on a train. "

"Great, how long will it take you to get to St James's Park?"

"Fifty minutes, tops."

"Okay, I'll see you there. We've had a bit of a situation. And I'm afraid I've had to change your locks."

Karl rang off; Thomas stumbled down the steps in a daze. Change the locks? Why would someone need to get into his desk? The penny had dropped by the time he got down to the platform.

* * *

Karl was waiting by the ticket barriers, moving rhythmically from foot to foot. Thomas raised a hand and Karl dashed forward. "Am I glad to see you!"

"What's been going on, Karl?" Thomas stood, ignoring buffeting and abuse as people tried to move past or through him.

"Not here; let's walk," Karl escorted him out to the park. "We'll take a stroll to Marlborough Gate. They do great coffee and I'm buying."

He watched as Karl checked around them while they walked. It made a change for someone else to be twitchy. "All clues gratefully received."

"Oh right, I was forgetting. Tell you what, why don't you open that envelope I gave you."

Thomas passed the envelope over for Karl to examine. No reason, other than to see if Karl would check it, which he did. Karl handed it back and

looked suitably pleased. Inside was a single page with four sentences, in Karl's own fair scrawl, which read:

1. FIRST THEY'LL TRY TO BRIBE YOU.
2. THEN THEY'LL LEAVE YOU WITH THE MONEY.
3. THEN THEY'LL ROB YOU.
4. NOW YOU'VE LOST THEIR MONEY, THEY OWN YOU.

Thomas read the note three times; he could see Karl scrutinising him out of the corner of his eye.

"So, Tommo," Karl sounded nervous; "Marks out of ten as a clairvoyant?"

He swallowed hard and folded the paper back into the envelope. "Spot on — for the first two."

Karl nodded and went off for the coffees. Thomas slumped on a bench and gazed out at the park, the sports bag containing the rucksack crushed between his legs. How the bloody hell could Karl have known what would happen? Two explanations came to mind. Either he was involved in this whole mind-game or he'd experienced something similar.

Karl returned, passing him a steaming cup. "It's Javanese, apparently. And lookie here," he rattled a paper bag, "muffins."

Thomas reached into the bag and squinted at Karl. "Can we cut to the chase? Am I in or not?"

Karl picked at a muffin and sent a piece arcing over to a waiting pigeon. "Rules first, Tommo. I will tell you as much as I can, but there has to be . . ."

Thomas didn't feel like accepting anyone else's rules today. "It happened to you as well, didn't it?" Okay, it was a bluff, but a reasonably deduced one.

"Uh-huh." Karl swigged back his coffee. "I was offered two grand, by way of an unaccountable surplus. You?"

"Four."

"Well, I suppose that's inflation for you!"

"And what did *you* do, Karl?"

"I took it — too right I did!"

Thomas choked on his coffee.

“Calm yourself, Tommo. I took it as evidence. All safely under lock and key somewhere. I wasn’t smart enough to stay away for the night like *you* evidently were.” Karl peered at him like he was a science exhibit. “No, but I rang ahead and had some old army pals let themselves in with a spare key. So when two thugs turned up to rob me of the readies, I had my own welcoming committee. Next day I turned up to the rendezvous with the cash, minus my £2k cut of course.”

“And what happened to the two guys who came a-calling?”

Karl sipped at his coffee more slowly and stared into the distance. “You’re better off not knowing.”

Thomas felt dizzy, as if the park was closing in on him. He took a mouthful of sweet, doughy muffin and squeezed it down. “What happens now?”

“Well,” Karl reached into his pocket then held a closed hand over Thomas’s, “firstly, these are yours.” He dropped three keys into Thomas’s waiting palm. “Remember items two and three on my list? You had your own visitors last night and they weren’t bringing you chocolates and flowers. Don’t worry, the new door’s top quality and nothing’s been taken so there’s no real harm done.”

Are you taking the piss? “Except someone knows where I live.”

Karl sighed. “Time to grow up, Tommy Boy. You wanted in — it goes with the territory. You can’t expect to wander around in the dark without stepping in some shit.”

“Thanks for that,” he whistled into his coffee. “I’d better complete my delivery — I’ll see you over at Harwich. We’ll talk about this again.”

“Indeed we will.”

He binned the coffee carton and got up to go. The bag seemed heavier now, and so did life.

Karl called after him. “Cheer up, Tommo, you’re in good company.” His voice dropped a tone. “And listen, we don’t discuss this on the job; we can’t be sure it’s safe there.”

Thomas nodded and trudged off towards Whitehall, jingling his new door keys on their leprechaun key ring. His brain was in meltdown so he started small, one step at a time. First, he’d see what Sir Peter had to say about the money. Then he’d consider telling Karl about the tax disc on the

red car. And then he'd reveal Bob Peterson's appearance at Harwich on the day of the shooting. It had all the makings of another fun-packed day.

He crossed back over the lake and followed the path to the gate. A police officer crossing the park stopped in her tracks and watched him as he moved about with his large sports bag. Mindful of the small matter of fifty-seven thousand pounds on his shoulder, he approached her, flashed his ID card and spun a line about looking for Main Building and being lost.

Outside the park, he noticed a sign for the Cabinet War Rooms and Churchill Museum. Ironical to think of Sir Peter Carroll's office, close by, with that painting behind his desk. Maybe he'd moved there for the souvenirs.

* * *

The same security staff faced Thomas as he entered the building; on a whim he saluted and they returned the compliment. They were more attentive now. All branches of the armed forces, potentially, supplied personnel for the SSU. But, like one of Karl's secret squirrel rules, people rarely volunteered where they'd come from. It used to drive him mad, but today, facing Whitehall's answer to the Spanish Inquisition, it suited him fine.

Soon he was in a lift with a different silent wonder as escort. His eyes drifted towards the escort's holstered weapon. The guard followed his gaze and tapped the holster confidently. Thomas decided to chance his luck.

"Browning — thirteen rounds," he paused for half a second; "Plus one in the chamber."

The guard smiled and relaxed. The soldier stood at ease. And all thanks to a quick round of Name That Gun.

"You were here yesterday, Mr Bladen?"

"Call me Thomas. Yeah, Sir Peter got called to a meeting; he asked me to come back today. I got some right stick about it at the office — I don't suppose anyone could tell me what his meeting was about so I can cover my arse?"

Soldier Boy smiled and shook his head. Thomas had thought it unlikely the guard would hand over a guest list, but it was worth a try. "If it helps any, Thomas, I know that Sir Peter left Main Building around eight pm. I escorted his chauffeur upstairs to collect some papers."

Thomas faked a smile to avoid sneering.

The escort knocked at the door and ushered Thomas inside. Sir Peter was up and out of his chair before Thomas had reached halfway across the plush carpet. “Thomas, my dear boy,” Sir Peter grabbed his hand and shook it keenly. “I must apologise for yesterday. Simply unavoidable. Come take a seat.”

Thomas sat down and waited. If in doubt, play it straight.

“So, how was your trip?”

“Fine, sir. Everything went to plan.”

Sir Peter seemed to rise up from his chair a little. Thomas pressed his tongue against his lower teeth, rendering his face expressionless. He reached down to his bag and opened the zip, squeezing the handle to stop himself from shaking.

Sir Peter was very still, like a bloated cobra.

“Actually, there was one problem . . .” he kept his head bent forward. *Nice and steady, Thomas, don’t blow this.* He lifted out the torn DSB from his rucksack in one fluid movement and thudded it down on the desk.

Sir Peter’s mouth lowered about a foot. Thomas fancied that even Churchill behind him looked perturbed. “The DSB they provided me with was torn. I made them count the money out in front of me.” That part at least was true.

Sir Peter stared at the sealed, torn DSB — the solid blocks of currency poking out like expensive building blocks in a substandard toy bag.

Thomas lifted his face level. “I’d prefer you check the contents, sir, if you don’t mind.” *Chew on that, Winston.*

Sir Peter broke the seal on the DSB and methodically stacked the currency on his desk. He counted the pile out loud, ending on ‘fifty-seven.’ “Yes, most impressive — I’d like you to accept a token of my appreciation.”

The top two slabs were separated and slid halfway across the mahogany. Thomas had already considered the possibility of a second buy-off and decided what to do about it. “I really couldn’t, sir — I was just doing my job.”

Sir Peter sighed through his nose, as if he were deflating. Still a cobra, but not quite so bloated “Surely there must be a camera that you’ve had

your eye on?” The old man wore an encouraging smile, like a disguise; his hand rested on the £2000, poised to push it forward.

Thomas didn’t need a rethink; two grand could buy a whole lot of camera, it was true. But the two grand would also be buying him. And anyway, it would be suspicious to accept £2000 now when he’d turned down £4000 back in Leeds.

“I wouldn’t feel right, sir. Besides,” pause for big smile and grand finish, “there’s no need.”

Sir Peter returned the £2k to the pile and patted it affectionately. “Well done, Thomas, you’ve passed. It’s a little test I have for when people show particular promise. I always knew my confidence in you wasn’t misplaced.”

He glanced over to the window, but there was no sign of a curly tail.

Chapter 16

He left Whitehall with a mixture of feelings. For all his bravado, he was really no further forward. There was too much going on. It was like playing several games of chess simultaneously — and losing them all.

Christine Gerrard had surprised him when he'd telephoned in, offering to drive him over to Harwich as soon as he was free. She'd gone on site for jobs in the past, but the timing was suspect to say the least.

Her Mercedes looked conspicuous by the underground station. He reached for the car door and breathed in a heady mixture of French perfume and the sound of Grieg. She smiled at him, but kept her sunglasses on.

He caught his perplexed look reflected in her face: Grieg. He wasn't big on classical music; it just wasn't something that floated his boat. But he'd always had a soft spot for Grieg; well, maybe not *soft* exactly. Grieg had been the musical accompaniment to a backwoods romp with Christine in this very car. He brushed the leather seat for an instant, lost in the memory of flesh against hide.

She drove off before his seatbelt was on and he waited for his underwear to settle before he spoke. "Thanks for the lift." Hardly repartee of the decade. Funny thing about Christine; it took him time to thaw around her. Partly the whole 'my boss is my ex' thing and partly because they both knew he'd been an absolute dickhead when they'd split up. It was as if she held a silent moral victory over him.

Eventually Christine removed her glasses; she looked tired.

"Everything alright, Chrissie?"

She shrugged. "Let's talk about something else."

He steered the conversation to safer waters, encouraging talk about her parents, their fancy horses and their fancy house. Then he listened as she recited the genealogy of their prize nags, with bloodlines going back a hundred years. It was the only topic where Christine ever really seemed to come alive, and by Harwich he felt he knew every horse personally.

A text from Miranda came through as they neared the port; she'd got him the new details for the red car's owner, based on the tax disc. He shut the mobile off afterwards.

“Secret admirer?” Christine looked piqued.

He mustered a hangdog expression. “No, more’s the pity. Unless Karl counts?” He pressed his hand into the upholstery.

“I had it professionally cleaned,” she shot him down in flames.

Yeah, but for whose benefit?

She parked the Merc at Harwich and they sat for a while, windows down, saying nothing. Christine seemed on the brink of speaking a couple of times, but somehow never crossed the line. He watched the gulls at play and wondered what would have happened if he hadn’t been so attentive that first day. He knew the answer already — everything would still have happened, just without him knowing.

“Did you turn down the training because of me, Thomas?”

What? “No,” he yawned and stretched in the seat. “It’s just not my style.”

She crinkled her nose. “Surely you don’t want to do this your whole life?”

He felt the smile rise across his face. “It’ll do for now. Time I was getting back to work.” He led and she followed, which almost made him nostalgic. The stairwell harboured old packing material and a fire extinguisher that had seen better days. Good for Christine to see where they’d ended up. They climbed the stairs and he found himself whistling Grieg. As they rounded the last corner she gave him a quick jab in the back and he stopped.

“Ah, so you’ve brought my boy home!” Karl set down the remains of a baguette.

Thomas braced himself for her reaction to the mess, but she wrong-footed him and went over to Karl. “Thomas has been given additional clearance . . .”

Since when?

“ . . . He’ll be accompanying you on the next out-of-hours pick-up. See that he’s briefed when the time comes.”

“Will do,” Karl’s tone bordered on reverential.

She touched Thomas on the shoulder as she left. “And Karl, clean this place up; it looks like a pigsty.”

“Ma’am,” Karl replied.

They both played statues until Christine’s footsteps faded from earshot.

“What the hell was that about?” Thomas almost tripped on the words.
“It’s called playing the game, Tommo.”

* * *

“Is it a pint for you, Tommy Boy?” Karl hadn’t come to life until the evening.

“Uh-huh.” His brain ached with the effort of thinking; competing thoughts echoed back and forth.

Karl returned with beer and crisps. Karl loved crisps; maybe it was his Irish genes — Thomas had been afraid to suggest. “Right then,” Karl ripped open two crisp bags and spread them on the table, “now we can talk!”

Best start off with an easy one. “So, is Christine in the know?”

Karl crammed a handful of cheese and onion into his mouth and filled the gaps with beer. He sat for a moment, a look of contentment on his face. Then he chewed thoughtfully and swallowed. “Is she bollocks! But she thinks she is, which has its uses. Of course, you’ll know about her family — rather well connected. Confidentially,” he snatched another clutch of crisps, “I think she finds the idea of all the cloak-and-dagger stuff a bit of a turn-on.”

Thomas hurriedly dived into his drink.

“But never forget, Tommo, there *is* a dagger. My advice? Tell Christine nothing; she’ll follow orders. Whereas we, amigo, we’re the cloak within a cloak.”

Now seemed like a good time to share the red car’s true registration, seeing as how they were amigos and all.

“I’ll look into it,” Karl promised.

“No need; I’ve got the details here,” he passed over a beer mat with small, neat handwriting on it.

“My, my, private sleuthing — how very enterprising. How about we check it out this weekend — if you’re free?”

Thomas smiled; Karl was very good at this. In only a few words, Karl had acknowledged that he had his own sources, decided the next step and sniffed around his weekend plans. “Fine by me, Karl.” He put down his pint. “Now, tell me more about who ruined my door and how you managed to stay one step ahead of all this.”

Karl bowed at the table. “You see, you’re a bit of an odd fish, Mr Bladen. You’re not ex-forces, but you’re secretive and *wonderfully* unambitious. As you’ll recall, I originally had you down as a mole for another outfit. Like as not, other people think the same. So when Ms Crossley said you were wanted by the big cheese, and you said you’d got a free ticket up north, I put two and two together. I’m guessing there was a ripped DSB waiting for you?”

Thomas raised a glass to him, recalling the comedy of errors in Leeds.

“It’s standard MO from what I can tell. Not sure how Sir Peter slots into all this. Anyhow, the difference in my case was that Crossley found out I’d taken the £2000 — I still don’t know how.”

“And my visitors?”

“Well, they weren’t selling *The Watchtower*. The newbie was sent in and the seasoned pro was waiting outside, across the street.” Karl’s voice dropped away as if he were considering how to continue the sentence.

“How did you . . .?”

“Let’s just say I try to prepare for all eventualities. I won’t kid you, Tommo, they meant business; they had *guns*.”

Thomas touched his hand to his mouth then felt stupid about it.

Karl raised an index finger. “Of course, they don’t have them anymore — I have them safely in my box, with the others!” He winked and took another gulp from his glass. “If you’d feel more comfortable I can let you have a piece of equipment for home.”

Thomas blinked twice very slowly, as if that would somehow refocus the picture. But it was already becoming horribly clear.

Chapter 17

Thomas flicked another page of the novel and glanced out the windscreen; there was still nothing to see. Just an ordinary street — typical Saturday morning tedium. Every breath drew in the stench of orange combined with petrol. But at least he was past the gagging stage. Karl had his feet on the dashboard and a tabloid open across his legs with a bag of crisps in his lap — quite the multitasker.

Thomas shut his paperback. “So why are we staking this house out?”

Karl interrupted the pen moustache he was lovingly adding to a topless model. “It goes like this,” he held up a loose fist in preparation.

Thomas mentally rehearsed a suitably impressed face.

“Thinking this through logically, all we know about the car is two things. One,” Karl’s index finger shot up like a nose-picker, “the red car probably held the shooter at Harwich. And two,” his middle finger rose up to join it, “Ann Crossley had the victim’s van taken away — now why would she do a thing like that?”

Thomas shrugged; it sounded like Karl had it all figured out anyway.

“Before we go in with our size nines, we need to know a little bit about the car and its owner. So we require a plausible reason to go knocking on their door.”

Thomas nodded. “Seems reasonable.”

Karl shifted his crisps and folded the newspaper. “But you know what seems *unreasonable*, Tommo? Why wouldn’t you report the number plate to your superiors? And check this — surely the false number plate will eventually flag up somewhere on CCTV and be checked?”

Thomas felt his mouth drying out, like a lazy dog in the heat. “Then why exactly are we here now, Karl?”

“We,” Karl stared at him intently, “are a team within a team. Which means what we’re doing today doesn’t get back to Christine — strictly off the record. And you, my mystery man, need to tell me what I’m missing. Because I know there’s something.”

Thomas pushed back into the passenger seat, increasing the scent of oranges. “Right . . .” he drew out the word to epic proportions, making it

sound like three separate words, “time to come clean. Remember on the day of the shooting, when I asked you how many spotter teams were on?”

“Aye, so I do.”

“Well, I saw someone with field binoculars, down in the car park. He was watching the ferry; and as soon as the shooting went off, he scarpered, pronto.”

“Interesting,” Karl tried to refold his newspaper, gave up and then scrunched it behind him to the back seat. He went back into stare mode.

“I managed to take pictures of the car number-plate and the driver. But there’s a complication.”

Karl opened one hand flat as if demanding the pay-off.

“The watcher was Bob Peterson, no question.” The inside of the car reverberated with sighs.

“Well, you’re obviously in the right job; you’re a one-man secret service, so you are.”

“Wait; you haven’t heard the complication. I doctored the watcher out of my mosaic photo for my report — before I was certain who it was. I wanted to check it out on the quiet. Christine wouldn’t have known any different but . . .”

Karl grinned and waved a hand up like a zealous schoolboy. “But Bob Peterson must have shat a brick when he heard that you took mosaic shots. Especially when he saw the mosaic from that morning and found he wasn’t in it!”

“Yeah, you could say that.”

When Karl set it all out before him, he didn’t feel quite so impressive.

“So, what then? Uncle Bob tries some damage limitation? Offers you executive training, but you don’t bite. Then you get sent to Leeds for the Cashback Challenge.”

He considered that. “I wasn’t sent by Bob though; Sir Peter Carroll. . . so it must follow that Bob Peterson spoke to the old man.”

“Hang on, Tommy; if Ann Crossley was on the ground with a spotter team, then why does Uncle Bob need to be there at all?”

Thomas opened his mouth to speak, but Karl silenced him with two more raised fingers. “Because, Dr Watson, either something different was due to go down that day *or* the shooting was planned and Peterson was supposed to report back afterwards.”

Thomas ran a thumbnail between his teeth. “Dr Watson?”

“Come on, Tommo, give me some credit. I’ve seen a battered copy of Sherlock Holmes poking out of your coat on at least two occasions — I’m no stranger to the great man myself, I might add. It should be recommended reading for the spy about town.”

Thomas felt a chill. “And is that what you are, Karl — a spy?”

“Now, you know as well as I do that the Surveillance Support Unit merely assists the work of government agencies, including the security services.” Karl raised an eyebrow. It’s been documented in Prime Minister’s Question Time.”

Round and round in circles. Thomas was fast acquiring the mother of all headaches. “So now what?”

“Now, we give the good people at number 129 a wake-up and shake-up call. If you’ll excuse me . . .” Karl rescued his mobile from a collection of old car park tickets and chocolate wrappers. Then he pulled out a photocopy of a car magazine classifieds page, with one ad circled and several others crossed out. Thomas gave it the once over; he’d never heard of the title. Karl looked extra pleased with himself. “All my own handiwork — see, I can use computers too! This was my back-up plan; and as sod all has happened in the last hour and a half, we might as well go with that.”

“I don’t get it.”

“Watch and learn, Tommy Boy. Read me the phone number off the ad, will you? If no one answers, we’ll have to pay the house a visit.” Karl dialled and his voice morphed into leafy Sussex. “Ah yes, hello, I’m ringing about the hatchback — is it still available?” He nodded to Thomas at the reply. “Really? Are you sure — I have the ad here in front of me. Well, that is very strange. What a pity; I was planning to pay cash.”

Thomas watched the lines furrow on Karl’s face like a well-ploughed field. It seemed all might not be going to plan.

“Yes, I was in South London anyway. Erm, well, that . . . er . . . might be interesting. I certainly appreciate the offer. Well, naturally, what the tax man doesn’t know!” Karl faked a laugh that would have been at home in Uckfield. Let’s say, what, ten thirty? I’ll just get a pen. One moment . . .”

Karl held a hand loosely above the mouthpiece and looked away, out the window. “. . . Jessica, Daddy’s on the telephone. Go and join Mummy by the till.” He lifted his hand free. “Sorry about that. Right, fire away.”

Thomas winced — poor choice of words. He watched Karl cradle the mobile under his neck and jot down the address he already knew, on a space near the fake ad.

“That’s lovely. Ten thirty it is then. Oh, yes of course: it’s . . . Bob Jefferson.” Karl went to drop the mobile back into its nest then thought better of it and dialled a number from memory. “It’s Karl. I need some money — a couple of grand should suffice. Okay, make it three; and a smart jumper, and a pair of driving gloves. Looks like I’m buying the car. No, I understand. Yes, he’s here with me now.”

Thomas blanched.

“I’ll be at the café on Jerome Street — call me when you’re ready. Quick as you can, please.” Karl cut the call. “Well, Mr Bladen, seems like you’re my lucky charm — that’s a turn up for the books. You’ll have to drive this back yourself.” He beamed like a cherub who’d just won a card game. “Café time — and the apprentice spy always pays.”

Thomas watched as Karl tucked into his all-in-one breakfast with gusto. It looked like three breakfasts, all in one. Not that the portion size seemed to slow Karl any. Thomas, on the other hand, was finding that a conscience wreaked havoc on his appetite so he played safe with a large mug of tea and a meagre two eggs on toast. He jabbed at the eggs so that they bled yellow and swept the plate with toast, sluicing the yellow into ketchup. “What about the family with the car?”

Karl managed to cram sausage, bacon and beans into his mouth, and still talk. “The car may give us something useful, but the family is our best lead, so we’ll keep a watchful eye.”

Thomas set his mug down. “That’s not what I meant.”

Karl’s mobile rang, breaking the deadlock. He checked the number, didn’t pick up. “That’s me away — I’ll not be long. Don’t let them take my plate.”

Thomas was speed-dialling Miranda before the glass door had finished rattling. He gazed past a window sticker featuring a dancing sandwich, out to a grey Saturday morning. “It’s Thomas. Listen, what are you up to this weekend?”

Miranda ran through her schedule at Caliban’s, running on into a visit to the gym and a DVD at home. He didn’t interrupt; he was happy just to

hear some normality. “I might have a date Sunday evening, but we can meet during the day if you like?”

Ouch. He rubbed a thumb across his chest, as if testing a wound. Served him right for making assumptions. “Right, yeah,” he smarted. “Tomorrow daytime it is, then.” He felt his face tightening. No one spoke for a good ten seconds.

“You’re such a dick. Of course I’m free — unless I get a decent offer *today* at Caliban’s?”

He blew a breath down the phone: stand-down from DEFCON 3. His jaw unwound into a smile. “So I’ll maybe see you later — or tomorrow.” They both laughed at how crap he still was at all this. He felt like a fish that’s hooked and reeled, thrown back after a few panicky gasps, but unable to resist the lure again.

“Goodbye, Thomas!”

He parked his breakfast and acted as Lord Protector when the waitress made a play for Karl’s leftovers. Could you even call yourself a waitress turned out in headphones and ripped jeans that showed your underwear?

The café door pinged; in walked Karl nouveau — V-neck sweater and driving gloves. “Ta da!”

Thomas gawped, couldn’t help it. “What are you supposed to be?”

Tonight,” Karl slid back on to his vinyl chair, “I’m going to be . . .”

Thomas didn’t give him the satisfaction. “So,” he reached for his second mug of tea, “did you get the other thing?”

“All safely on board,” Karl reassured him, squeezing his jacket pocket as he folded it by his feet. “Anyways, let’s saddle up. I want to put them on the back foot when I’m there, so you ring me on the mobile — family emergency — in say, six minutes.” Karl winked and Thomas narrowed his eyes as he sipped his tea. Karl looked affronted; his fork stalled above his plate. “What?”

The tea didn’t help Thomas’s mood. “You’re very good at this.”

Karl swooped down a fork, scraping the plate. “This,” Karl whispered like a gas leak, “from the man who takes secret photos and does his own background checks on Bob Peterson. You’re pretty good yourself,” he took a bite, “. . . for an amateur.”

Thomas raised his mug: touché. He left Karl to his washing-machine impression and went to find the gents. The waitress lip-read his request and

flicked her finger towards a door with a hazard sign on it. *Number one for customer service*. He nodded his thanks and tried not to stare at her t-shirt, emblazoned with: ‘Don’t even think about it.’

Karl walked up to the house, glancing at the red estate in the drive, which he noted had been cleaned. A pity, but the forensics team were on standby so there was always hope. He rang the doorbell and straightened his jacket, making sure his sweater was proudly on display. If you could be proud of a golfer’s reject.

He heard a brief exchange on the other side of the glass, aware he was a good fifteen minutes ahead of schedule. Then silence, and the door opened about a foot wide. “Bob Jefferson, we spoke on the phone — I managed to get away sooner. Jessica’s being difficult so my wife dropped me off a little early. I hope that’s okay?”

The woman smiled faintly. She looked tired. “Here’s the ad I mentioned,” he showed her the photocopy and waited while she studied it, right down to the shopping list he’d added at the bottom in blue felt tip.

She passed it back and nodded. “Won’t you come in?” He clocked the accent — not a native South Londoner. Probably an incomer, the sort who called Streatham *St Reatham* or described Balham as ‘just off the Kings Road.’

* * *

A man came down the stairs. It had to be a man, judging by the heavy footfalls. “Hello.”

Karl’s trained ear registered the slight twang on the second syllable.

The woman tensed, turning to her husband. He led from there. “We are keen for a quick sale. You mentioned cash on the phone? Let me show you the car and we can discuss the price.”

Brief and to the point. The wife — she had the ring on — picked up her child and opened the door again. Karl played for time and went into a long spiel about his niece looking for a car to drive across France with friends from Uni. And how the friend with the car had dropped out and they were looking for a hatchback, but a car like this was really far more practical. He loved this part, getting into character, spinning a yarn and seeing where it took him, always with one eye on the bigger picture.

He let the seller see that he knew nothing about cars, asked a nonsense question about transverse engines and checked whether it took diesel or lead-free. The seller warmed to him, or his ignorance — same thing really. It was a classic con: let the victim think they're conning you; it rarely failed.

Karl's mobile chimed in, with a TV ring-tone so awful that he almost cringed himself. He made the obligatory embarrassed face. "Yes, hello darling; I'm looking at it now — you know I think Beatrice would love it. No, we're still discussing the details. I won't be long. Can't you just keep Jessica settled? Well, I can just join you at home, can't I — if she's really that bad."

He faked a huge sigh. "Right. Yes, I understand. Just give her sips of water. I'll be as quick as I can. No, no, you stay there — I'll drive over." He paused, as if suddenly aware of his mistake. "I'll, er, make my own way back." He switched off his mobile and did his best impression of the word 'agitated.'

The husband laid a hand on his shoulder. "Children are a constant worry because they are our precious jewels." He then started the car up and let Karl try out the driving seat.

Karl managed to shave £50 off the asking price and insisted they shook hands on the deal. All very proper — minus the receipt — and in record time.

They stood at the window and watched him back down the drive. He paused to wave and wondered, just out of devilment, how long they would wait there. By the look on their faces as he glanced up for the final wave they'd have waited forever, just to see him gone. He drove to the corner and flashed his lights for Thomas to follow him in his own car; mission accomplished.

* * *

Thomas had nurtured a faint hope that Karl would guide him to some secret bat-cave lair, but it was short-lived. After a twenty-minute drive through Saturday traffic, Karl led him instead to a supermarket car park. Tucked away in a far corner, a woman was waiting by a silver Ford. Karl parked a few spaces away and Thomas followed suit.

"Tommo, you remember Teresa."

She smiled, as if she knew something about him that he hadn't disclosed. He resolved to quiz Karl, some other time, about what that might be.

“Good work Karl. Nice to see you again, Thomas.”

And that was that. Karl handed over a package — Thomas figured it was the remainder of the money, plus the gloves and the jumper. Then they got into Karl's car and left the scene. In the wing mirror he saw someone else get out of the Ford and walk around the red estate. Karl glanced towards him, not the slightest bit interested.

“Not our problem, Tommo; our part is done.”

“No point my asking who Teresa works for, I suppose?”

“None at all!” Karl chuckled, and Thomas wondered if Karl even knew himself.

Chapter 18

Thomas pressed the intercom button and stared up at the CCTV camera. He hated being this side of the lens, always had. Too many childhood memories of his dad telling him to ‘stand up straight’ and ‘at least try to look like you’re enjoying yourself.’ It was probably why he’d got into photography in the first place — to regain a degree of control.

“Why, Mr Bladen, what a pleasant surprise!” Sheryl’s nasal tones smacked of a cheesy New York cop series.

He turned his face from the camera and listened hard for the steps down the back staircase. The fire door released and Sheryl stood before him, leaning against the doorframe, pop video style. She looked him up and down. “Great to see you, Thomas.”

He rolled his shoulders self-consciously. Was she attractive? Absolutely. To use a Karl-ism: she could probably wake the dead in their trousers. And boy did she know it. She probably had an exclusion order from the mortuary. And the clincher, for ten points — was he interested? Not for a second.

Maybe that’s why she played so easy to get. It didn’t help that his defence was to close down. That seemed to make her try even harder to get a reaction. He liked to think that Miranda put her up to it — for sport — but he worried, deep down, that it was just Sheryl. Male customers loved it of course. A little piece of authentic Brooklyn right before their eyes; and Sheryl was the little piece.

He thought about the morning’s activities as he followed her upstairs, mainly to distract himself from her backside; the sucking and popping of Sheryl’s trademark chewing gum punctuated their journey up to the office. She had once told him that she chewed gum to keep her mouth moist and supple. He’d never felt the same way about spearmint again.

* * *

Miranda was busy looking at colour swatches. “Hey, you’re a man. What do you think of this?” She held up a colour card with a thumb across it.

“It looks like lilac.”

“What an insightful eye for detail. I can see why you’re drawn to the camera. Fancy a coffee?”

Sheryl took her cue and slinked past him, timing a bubble pop by his face.

“I don’t know why you get so uptight around Sheryl; she likes you.”

“Maybe that’s what I’m uptight about.”

“Lighten up, Thomas, and don’t flatter yourself; it’s just her way. I can see you find her attractive so what’s the big deal? Blimey, if I was a man, *I’d fancy her.*”

“I never said I fancied her.”

Out the corner of his eye he could see Sheryl’s jeans straining as she walked away.

“Anyway, what have you been up to today?” She was still staring down at the mass of colour charts and strips of material. But Thomas had played this game before.

“Oh, nothing much. I, er, went to help someone buy a car.”

“Really? Terry and Sam could have got you a good deal. Anyone I know?”

He paused for maybe a couple of seconds; a couple of seconds too long. “Just someone from work.”

Miranda didn’t turn, but her back arched forward just that little bit more. Then she slapped a hand on the desk and Thomas felt the three-minute warning go off.

“Why don’t you just *ask*, Miranda?”

“Because I’m not sure I’d like the answer.”

Sheryl returned and placed the coffee mugs beside Miranda. “Um, I hope this isn’t a bad time.” Sarcasm dripped off every syllable.

Thomas could almost feel the heat from Miranda’s glare. Maybe that was why he was sweating. Miranda looked up at Sheryl, completely unfazed. “Just a few issues with trust.”

“Miranda!” Sheryl raised her eyebrows and tut-tutted dramatically. “You can’t trust men, honey — you know that.”

Thomas looked daggers at her as she left the arena. But she just winked at him again and mouthed: ‘she loves you really.’ At least, that’s what it looked like. It could have been ‘she loves you rarely.’

“Jesus, Thomas, why did you have to take that bloody job?”

He moved behind her, gazing at the back of her neck; that smooth, lightly tanned neck that he loved to run his lips over. He laid a finger on her skin and traced a river, enjoying the familiar tingle that ran up and down his spine and settled in his groin. Miranda shrugged free.

“Knock it off; I’m not in the mood. I’m serious. Why would you want to go and do a job like that — and hide it from me?”

Tread carefully, he told himself; don’t answer too quickly. This is an exam level question — and it’s pass or fail, with no retakes.

“Do I need to remind you? I took the Civil Service job so we could work near each other. And not long after that you decided to call it quits.”

They reached for their coffees and he noticed that her mug read ‘The Boss’ while his was ‘The Hired Hand.’ Nice one, Sheryl.

“Be honest, Thomas; neither of us was happy with the way things were.”

He drew back, cradling his mug. “I was happy.”

She gave it a second’s consideration. “Bullshit. You just couldn’t stand the thought of me being with anyone else.” When she said it like that, it sounded like a bad thing. “And let’s not forget we’d split up at *least* once before then.”

Ah yes, the infamous drought of ’97 to ’98. “So that’s why you went to Bermuda — for a whole year?”

She didn’t flinch, didn’t even break her stride. “I needed breathing space — we both did. The only difference is, you used yours to get off with Christine *at work*.”

‘Get off with’ wasn’t the term she normally used. But hey, Sheryl was only next door, like as not listening to every word. Not that he cared too much what Sheryl thought.

He resisted comment. Resisted mentioning that Miranda had hardly taken a vow of chastity over in Bermuda — or when she returned. Time to tone things down a bit. “Why are we having this conversation?”

“Because you’re shutting me out, Thomas. Mum was in a real flap about you, that night at the house — I know you talked to Dad about something. You used to confide in *me*. Well, I thought you did — before I discovered your secret life.” She put her face right in front of his.

Jesus; Sheryl must be lapping this up.

“And remember how we first got together? I trusted you. I told you about that scumbag, Butch Steddings; about the way he was coming on to me to do his dodgy photos.”

“I know,” he felt his knuckles itching, partly from outrage and the lingering memory of lamping Butch. The haunted look in her eyes brought him back with a bump. He put a hand to her cheek. “But this is different, Miranda.”

“No it’s not. You’re frightened, Thomas. I *know* you. Is it that Irish bloke?”

“No,” he took a breath, tried it again more confidently. No, it’s not Karl.”

“Well what then?”

It could have been the reflection of the strip light, making her eyes glisten like that. He pressed his hand against her face, felt the warm flesh against his fingertips and wished she could understand by osmosis.

“I’m not gonna leave this alone, Thomas. And don’t think I give a shit what Sheryl hears. So either you tell me now or we are going to have a major falling out.” She sighed, and leaned a little against his hand. “If you can’t be honest with me, then I’ve got no room for you in my life — it’s your call.”

There was steel behind those blue eyes. He picked up the reference straight away. When she’d returned from Bermuda, he’d told her about Christine. Then Miranda had got involved with some city trader, probably just to piss him off — which it had. Worse, the stockbroker believed in spreading his options. As soon as Miranda found out, she’d dropped him like a lead weight. Once Thomas had showed her evidence of a wife.

He felt ashamed that it had come to this. Miranda was probably bluffing — she’d come around in a few days or a week or so. But . . . but he’d have to tell her sometime. He took another deep breath. “Two blokes turned my flat over while I was at your parents’ place. They were hardcore — after some money they thought I had. They smashed my door and they came toolled up.”

Miranda paled. “Is this to do with Karl?”

“Not like that! Karl took care of it; he was looking out for me.”

Miranda brushed his hand away. “Maybe I should speak to Karl, then.”

“No, don’t do that.” Too quick, too edgy; he knew she’d pick up on it.

“So what do I do, then, Tom?” She never called him Tom, not since Leeds and Butch Steddings.

“Just be yourself. The same loveable pain in the arse you always are.”

“Flattery’ll get you nowhere.”

He didn’t believe that.

She put her arms around him. He leaned in and squeezed her back towards him, as if he could dissolve her flesh into his.

“Well you better not make any more enemies, Thomas Bladen. Because if anyone messes with you, they’ll answer to me.”

He didn’t doubt that for a second.

He finished his coffee and pretended to be interested in her colour schemes. Then he made his excuses and headed for home, alone — probably for the best. He picked up a Chinese on the way, and a carton of milk — company for the old one seeking asylum in his fridge. He wondered if Karl had similar relationship problems? Was there even anyone special in his life? Special — Karl would piss himself at that.

The TV had little to offer so he dived back into the pile of DVDs towering on the floor. Something edifying and life-affirming — *Shaun of the Dead*, the perfect accompaniment to prawn chow mein and special fried rice. Miranda had long since educated him on the perils of factory-farmed chicken, but he figured it would be pretty hard to do much to a prawn other than catch and eat it.

It was a great film; he’d seen it before at the cinema with Miranda. But the joy of DVDs — for him, anyway — was the extra features. How it was done, deleted scenes, notes on cinematography and special effects. Sometimes all that was better than the actual film.

Some time after ten, he gave up the ghost and turned off the DVD. The TV channel kicked back into life at way past a reasonable volume. He dropped it down a few notches on the level and did a double take. Sir Peter Carroll was on screen — large as twenty-two-inch life — pontificating about some political debacle.

It was too good a chance to pass up on. He reached over and dialled Karl.

“Hello?”

“Karl, it’s Thomas. Quick, turn on the TV — our beloved leader’s doing a turn.”

“I know; I’m watching it already. How sad is that!” There was a pause. “Is everything okay, Tommo? Only you’ve rung me on your landline — you’ve never done that before. Are you going all touchy-feely on me?”

He took a breath, remembering he was *number withheld* on all his calls. They watched Sir Peter run rings around the other guests on the late night current affairs programme. Even the presenter was no match for the double-talk, counter-pointing and justifications. It was like seeing Freddie the Fox perform a gig at the henhouse.

Karl, who followed politics more closely — i.e. more than almost no interest whatsoever — offered his own comments and managed to predict a couple of Sir Peter’s responses.

Thomas had only caught the tail end of the programme and after fifteen minutes, Karl was humming the national anthem tunelessly as the studio lights dimmed.

“So, Tommo, what’s on your mind?”

“I dunno, Karl. These last weeks; I’m starting to lose the plot.”

“Now *that* I don’t believe for a second! What’s really bothering you?”

“How do you cope with it, Karl?” he eased his shoes off and flexed his feet. “All the secrecy and the pretence and the—”

“Lies,” Karl chipped in. “That’s would be the word you’re looking for. It’s the price you pay for knowing. And once you know, things are never the same again.”

“For a second there, you almost went into *The Matrix*.”

“Aye, it’s not a bad analogy. Only it’s debatable whether we’re the dudes in black vinyl, or Agent Smith. Listen, do you fancy getting together tomorrow — I’ll meet you at midday, same tube station.”

“Yeah, that’s sounds good. Thanks mate.”

“No problem. By the way, I’m glad you rang actually. Don’t make plans for next weekend — we’re working. I’ll tell you all about it when I see you.”

“What?” he sat bolt upright on the settee. “No, tell me now.”

“I don’t think so; phones have ears. Good night, Thomas.”

* * *

Sir Peter Carroll’s Daimler glided away from Television Centre. The roar of the traffic seemed to echo the applause of the studio audience. Even

his opponents had congratulated him on his mastery of the subtleties of the situation.

He swirled his whisky glass and let the aroma pervade his senses. Outside, the streetlights and car lights prised against the tinted windows. He checked his watch and smiled.

As soon as he reached for the phone, his chauffeur raised the glass screen. Sir Peter waited until the screen sealed him off before he dialled the first number, even though Trevor had been with him for years.

“Ah, good evening. I wish to get a message to Yorgi. Ask him to ring me tomorrow on the office number. He’ll know who it is.”

The woman sounded fearful at the mention of Yorgi’s name. In the background he heard a man’s voice — it could have been Yorgi, but he doubted it. No matter, he had no interest in Yorgi’s personal life. He closed the call and settled his glass. Then, phone still in hand, he lifted an address book from his blazer pocket: ‘P’ for Peterson.

“Robert? Oh, yes, if you would, thank you. Ah, Robert, it’s Sir Peter. You did? Why, thank you! Now, Robert, I’m ringing for an update on the Harwich consignment. Yes, I saw that you’d put Crossley on to it. Good, definitely a step in the right direction. I think we’ll be ready to move soon, now that we’ve got the full team on board. Long time coming — indeed! Have Crossley get an update, first thing Monday. Capital! Now, what’s the latest on the poor driver?” He scrawled down some notes and put an asterisk against Ann Crossley’s name.

“Right. Send Crossley to my office Monday morning — she can update me there.” He ended the call and tucked the address book back in his blazer. He signalled to Trevor that the screen could be lowered. Then, he dialled home.

“Yes, hello darling. Really? It was good of you to watch. No, don’t wait up; you know how these things work. The PM likes us seniors to take every opportunity to make friends with the media. I’ll be back late — I’ll use the spare room. Night, night.” He stared out at the blurred lights of London and his smile reflected back in the glass like a malign crescent. “Trevor, I think I’ll drop in to The Victory Club.”

The chauffeur nodded; Sir Peter enjoyed the deferential bob of his head. It was the little touches that made Trevor such a treasure. Their eyes met in the mirror. “Very good, Sir Peter.”

He reached for his whisky and smiled again. If tonight's girl at The Victory was anything like the last one Yorgi had provided, it would be.

Chapter 19

“You’ve got to be able to trust your instincts, Tommo,” Karl swivelled left and right at the first click of the target turning face on. “Do you want a go — it’s not so different from taking high-speed photos. Okay, maybe with nine mills instead of a data-card. But the principle’s the same.”

There’s a comfort. All those years that Thomas thought he’d been honing his camera skills he’d actually been secretly training to be Super Shooter. The idea played in his head like a disturbing version of *The Karate Kid*: wax on, wax off, and reload.

Karl laid his pistol down. “So, I’ll save you the trouble of avoiding the topic of next weekend. We’re away to Suffolk for a pick-up.”

“And is this for our side or their side, or doesn’t it matter?”

“See, Tommo, I told you that you’d get the hang of it eventually!” Karl grinned like an idiot. “But seeing as you’ve asked, this is a special request from our beloved leader.”

“Dress code: casual?” Thomas straightened an imaginary tie.

“Dress code: damp-proof — we’ll get kitted out from Stores on the Friday, before we leave work. You’re going to be the water baby.”

They spent less than an hour on the range. As Karl reminded him, time flies when you’re firing guns. Afterwards in the café, Thomas scanned the horizon for Teresa. Someone as organised as Karl would be sure to have arranged a meeting.

“Relax, Tommo. She’ll be here presently.”

He picked at the pastry crumbs on his plate. So they were doing Sir Peter’s private dirty work — and look where that got him last time.

Teresa made a play of waving as she came over, but she looked agitated. “Things have moved forward unexpectedly.”

Even Karl seemed a little put out.

“There was a disturbance at the target house last night. A neighbour called the police and an ambulance out, to a domestic. It seems Yorgi went ballistic — if you’ll forgive the phrase — when he came back and found the car was missing.”

Thomas felt like raising a hand, to remind them he was still there. “Who’s Yorgi?”

Karl and Teresa gave him the kind of look that made him wish he wasn’t. “Our likely Harwich shooter,” Teresa explained, glancing at Karl.

“He has a name,” Thomas said slowly, reciting his thought aloud.

“And a reputation to go with it,” Teresa replied.

Thomas kept quiet now while the grown-ups talked, picking up the odd snippet, here and there. Yorgi was evidently a big shot — again with the puns — and Teresa’s report suggested he had left the country after the incident.

He felt his mind start to drift — funny how things bobbed to the surface when you weren’t concentrating. Now that he thought about it, he’d never seen any photographs from the year Miranda spent in Bermuda. Well, okay, a few ‘here I am at the beach’ pics, but no proper work photos of any kind. His mood soured; he tried to tune back into the conversation, just to escape himself.

“So what do you think, Thomas? Could you speak to them?” Teresa had lowered her voice.

“I’m sorry?”

Teresa and Karl both eased forward towards him. Teresa was still in the big chair. “With Yorgi away, this is our best chance to make contact with the brother again and offer him a lifeline — think you’re up to it?”

Thomas could feel their eyes on him like sunlamps and sensed his face smouldering. “I can try.” Jesus, he wasn’t even convincing himself.

“Top man!” Karl patted him on the shoulder. “Right, come on then, Tommo; no time like the present.”

Teresa sat in the back of Karl’s car. The scent of oranges was starting to fade; now it was more Earl Grey tea than breathable vitamin C.

“So what do I say, exactly? I mean, what am I allowed to tell them?” It was the third time of asking — different ways, but the same question. Karl looked ready to pop a vein.

“For fuck’s sake, Tommo! We’ve been through this. They let a gunman use their car as a sniper’s post. And we’ve got the car now. There’s not a lot to say.”

Maybe Karl was right to be pissed off. When Thomas heard himself, he sounded like an amateur — well, he *was* an amateur.

Teresa played peacemaker. “All we’re trying to do is offer them protection — if they want it. Let them know that there’s help available. But don’t spook them.”

Karl hardly looked at Thomas for the rest of the journey. It reminded him of Ajit, back at school, when he’d been accusing Thomas of something, but wouldn’t come right out and say it.

As they parked up, Teresa handed Thomas a scrap of paper. “Tell them they can ring here at any time, if they need us.”

He nodded and gripped the note tightly, casting a last, quizzical look at Karl as he opened the car door.

* * *

Teresa waited until Thomas was at least five cars away. “What’s the problem, Karl?”

“I can’t put my finger on it. I mean, I trust him right enough. I’d stake my life on him not working for anyone else, but . . . well, there’s something about him. I don’t think we ever get to see the real Thomas Bladen, and that worries me. When it comes down to it, we don’t know his capabilities.”

“You’d not recommend recruiting him, then?”

“No, not yet. He’s more useful to us as an outsider.”

“How much have you told him?”

“The usual — only as much as we need him to know.”

107, 108, 109 . . . Thomas counted on, just like he used to do when he was a child. Useless figures that kept his mind occupied; stopped him from too much thinking. His sister Pat used to tease him about it.

“You’d spend your whole life counting, given half a chance!”

But that process of measuring and timing; that’s what had kept him sane when Dad went into his rages or when Mam had disappeared into the kitchen to dry her tears or to get the swelling on her face to go down. Numbers.

115, 116. He could see the house looming ahead. Surely Teresa could have told him exactly what to say, how to couch it all? He felt his stomach turning over. If he didn’t get himself together his first words would be: ‘Can I use your toilet?’ A fine spy he’d make! He laughed at himself and squeezed the little piece of paper ever more tightly.

His legs dragged as he walked up the short drive, the sweat congealing against his skin. He remembered the time he'd first brought Miranda back to his digs in Leeds. How they'd both been too nervous to discuss how far they wanted to go. And how he'd ached for her. It wasn't just the rush of hormones and Thunderbird wine, but a need to connect with her, to anchor her to him so that she'd never leave Leeds, or him. *Yeah, nice one, Thomas.* Now he was at the front door with a gut ache *and* a hard-on. *Brilliant.*

He pressed the bell, realising that he'd missed a chance to copy Teresa's magic phone number for himself. He heard voices approaching — a man and a woman — and hoped to God that was sweat running down the back of his legs.

The door slowly opened. "Can I help you?" she said, even though her voice suggested the opposite. It was the same ice blonde that Karl had described. Refined, with a hint of yummy mummy — to use Karl's apt description.

"Can I come in? It's about Yorgi, sort of."

She stared at him for a moment and tilted her head back, directing a stream of something Eastern European behind her. Best guess, she'd figured that he wasn't Masterspy, but maybe that gave him a slight edge. The husband squeezed in beside his wife; the door didn't open any further.

"There's no one called Yorgi here — you have the wrong house."

Yeah, so the Eurospeak was a happy coincidence? He pressed his hands together and touched his lips then immediately felt foolish. He looked like his mother, back when she used to pray at home. An idea came to him. Not divine inspiration — more like desperation. He was never going to see these people again, right, so what harm was the truth?

He reached into his wallet and prised away his driving licence. Behind the ID card was a cut-down photograph, of him and Miranda. Typical adolescent photo-booth stuff; she had her arms around his neck, practically clinging to him. And he had a smile like he'd just found a fifty-pound note. The fact that she'd just grabbed his groin before the flash probably helped.

"This is Miranda. I know it's hard to protect the people we care about."

The couple studied the photograph for a long time; in the end he got so nervous they might snatch it indoors and lock him out that he asked for it back. His pulse was still racing as he tucked it carefully back into his wallet.

The door arced open. “What do you want, Mr . . . ?”

“Bladen. Thomas Bladen.” Yeah, he’d thought about bullshitting them like Karl had insisted, but they just seemed like two scared people who had been dealt a crappy hand.

They sat on the sofa opposite him, their son at their feet. The man did the talking “You and Miranda have children, *Tomas*?”

“What? No,” he shook his head to emphasise the point, hoping it would also cool his face off. “Look, I’m just here to offer assistance.”

“Are you with the police?” the yummy mummy reached down, hoisting her son to her lap.

He shook his head again. “Look, any chance of a drink and can I . . .” he stood up and the sudden relief on his bladder made him exhale loudly.

She pointed him upstairs.

He heard the rattling of glasses as he closed the door behind him. Karl would probably have searched the bedroom; Karl wasn’t there though. He checked the bathroom mirror. What a state! ‘Are you the police?’ That was a joke. Not unless CID stood for something completely different.

It seemed to be the longest piss of his life, as if his body was ridding itself of his fear. He flushed, did all the usual stuff and filched around in the wastepaper bin. Bingo — loo roll holder. He split the cardboard tube and copied out Teresa’s helpline number. Then he peered at himself again in the mirror and splashed more water on his face.

Downstairs, a glass was waiting for him. He turned it around and the little boy cooed as he watched the light dancing, fascinated. Smiles all round.

“Supposing my husband and I needed help — what would you want in return?”

“Me? Nothing. I’m here as a messenger,” he unfolded the piece of paper and passed it over.

The drink reminded him of the chocolate liqueurs they used to have at Christmas, in Pickering. Just the right side of sickly sweet. The couple studied Teresa’s piece of paper for a long time. Or maybe they just didn’t want to make eye contact, with him or each other. Yeah, they were rats in a trap all right: poor bastards.

“Look,” he took pity on them, “Yorgi might be mixed up in some trouble, but you seem like good people.” Okay, nought out of ten for

subtlety, but it conveyed the gist.

The man cleared his throat. "Tomas, do you have brothers and sisters?"

"Yeah, a sister — Pat; she's a couple of years younger than me." What was he doing — why not draw them a bloody picture? He took another sip of alcoholic goo. The more he thought about it, they were *all* being used.

"Yorgi is my brother — my . . . half-brother; my name is Petrov and I am the younger in the family. When we were growing up, Yorgi was always the leader. He made the rules and I followed him. I learned very young not to challenge him."

Thomas said nothing. He noted the wall clock above the crucifix and decided to give himself five more minutes, tops. The wife stared at him as if she could pierce the façade and see into his soul. He fidgeted in the chair.

"How much trouble are we in, Mr Bladen?"

Now he felt like they were playing him. All he had to fall back on was the truth. "The authorities know about the incident." He watched their faces fall. "The victim survived though and you may have been unwilling accomplices." *Unwilling?* Jesus. He'd as good as accused them of complicity. *What a prat.* He rubbed at his forehead and closed his eyes. "I'm sorry; that came out wrong. What I meant was that so far there is no direct evidence against you."

Petrov raised a defiant hand. "He told us to face forward and to drive, said if anything happened we'd lose our son. We didn't know *what* he was planning."

Thomas looked from face to face. Chances were, they *knew*.

"Tomas, what would you have done?"

He said nothing, tried to hold their gaze.

Petrov patted his son. "I have always done what I could for Yorgi, but for many years we were apart. Then a year or so ago, he tracked me down . . ."

Thomas sat up: interesting choice of words.

". . . He leads a different life. Mixes in circles I would be afraid to. You understand?" Petrov reached for his wife's hand. Only now, as she turned towards him, did Thomas notice the reddening down one side of the face and the way Petrov shifted his weight away from one side of his ribs. "Alexandra and Lukas are my family. I must put them first. Will the people at this number understand that the way you do?"

He couldn't answer, didn't feel anything but shame. He couldn't pretend that he didn't care. And caring meant doing something. "Here," he wrote out a mobile number on the newspaper by his feet and ripped it off. "This is *my* number. Just in case."

His hand wavered and his stomach churned with raw emotion. "I have to go now," he stood up carefully as if his balance might be off; in a sense it was.

Alexandra lifted little Lukas aside and saw him to the door. Thomas followed her gaze to the crucifix. He blushed, caught in the act. "Bless you, Thomas Bladen," she kissed him on the cheek and then closed the door behind him.

It didn't feel cold outside, but a couple of tears gathered in his eye. He flicked them away casually, as if they were nothing. And as each step took him further from the house, he felt a growing sense of exhilaration.

He got back into the car and Karl started up the engine without a word. He ventured nothing and withstood their scrutiny; decided he'd sit this one out. Karl lasted until they'd cleared the Thames.

"How did it go?"

He took a breath and kept things simple. "They seemed pleased to have a contact number; I think they'll be in touch."

Teresa tapped Karl on the shoulder. "Anywhere around here is fine." Karl nodded and checked his mirror, pulling in along Queen Victoria Street.

Thomas watched them, saw the way Karl looked at her and how she avoided him. No goodbyes, not even a thank you. If he had to guess, there'd been *words* in the car while he'd been delivering a lifeline. But did that mean . . . nah, couldn't be. Surely Karl was smarter than that?

He watched with Karl as Teresa disappeared up the cut through to St Paul's. They sat for a while, the grumbling engine and indicator clicks marking off the seconds. Finally, Karl tore his gaze away from the side street. "Fancy a drink?"

"Sounds like a plan," Thomas parodied him.

Karl didn't react. He gazed out the windscreen, dull eyes watching the crowd in vain. Thomas could almost feel his longing.

"Yeah, a pub would be great," he emphasised, spurring Karl into activity. Jeez, what a pair of fuck-ups they were. Karl had fallen for Teresa,

and Thomas, in his day, had all but set up house with Christine Gerrard. Women and power — it was like mixing your drinks: no good would ever come of it.

In a pub in Stratford they found a quiet table; Karl sat facing the door as usual. Thomas did the honours and got half a pint for himself and a pint of shandy for Karl, along with crisps; last of the big spenders.

Karl took a sip and smacked his lips theatrically. “Tell you what, Tommo. I’ll do another little magic trick. Are you ready?”

He felt dread creeping through him.

“You gave them your own number, didn’t you?”

Thomas coughed into his drink and kept his head down.

“It’s okay, Tommo, I understand. It’s an obvious rookie mistake — you felt sorry for them, right? I’d have done the same, at the beginning. I won’t mention it to Teresa, but I need you to let me know if they ever do contact you. Deal?”

He wondered what else Karl had deduced about him.

Karl leaned back and stretched; he seemed to have cheered up no end. “You see, Tommo, we’re not so different, you and I.”

Chapter 20

Miranda had arrived early. Every night on the phone since Sunday, she'd been trying to talk Thomas out of this mysterious weekend job, the one he still hadn't explained. Maybe face-to-face she stood a chance of getting through to him.

She sat in the car, two streets away, flicking through a professional catering magazine that she'd already littered with notes and doodles. Thomas figured in a good few of those scribbles, not that he'd have known. She was the princess — naturally — and Thomas the face in the corner, sometimes just a pair of eyes, watching from a distance. Blimey, how accurate had that turned out to be!

More flicking, to a feature: a stylish eatery in Berkshire. She nearly drooled over the décor and the fancy name: *panache*. Thomas had suggested she call *her* club Miranda's — a talent for the obvious. But Caliban's was her private joke. At school, she'd loved *The Tempest*, ever since she'd caught her name in it, and had weathered the piss-taking of the other girls. The boys of course were more malleable — not for nothing did Miranda translate as 'the admired one.' Rough times, though.

She doodled some more. Whatever Thomas was mixed up in, it would be a stroll in the park compared to a gaggle of spiteful, hormone-addled bitches. *Addled* — she smiled at that; one of Thomas's words that had crept into her vocabulary. She fingered her neck-chain, following it round to her name, shaped in gold, and tapped it distractedly. Yeah, the only time that name had lost a little of its sheen was when her mum had told her about a chain-smoking casino croupier — the one she'd been named after.

This was bloody silly. She had emergency keys to the flat — *new* keys at that — just as he had to hers. But ever since the heavies had busted in while he was away, Thomas had cranked up his paranoia a notch or four and passed it on. "Sod it," she stuffed the magazine in the glove compartment; she'd take a walk past — what harm could it do?

* * *

Thomas found a parking space at the end of the street. He waited a minute, checking front and back; nothing much was happening. He reached

for the sports bag on the passenger seat, containing a waterproof bodysuit, a torch so bright it could almost illuminate Karl's cryptic messages, a length of rope and a pair of walkie-talkies. He checked again — all quiet on the Western Front. Time to move.

He clocked the figure in the distance almost as soon as he closed the car door, watching as the loner crossed the street towards his flat then stopped still. He hugged the bag close and picked up the pace, moving from car to car, crouching low. Closer, and he could make out a woman in a long coat; she had her back to him and her hair was either short or tucked under a beret. She looked like she was auditioning for a French Resistance tribute act.

He used the trees for cover; good solid forest trees that some planner had approved decades before and which now bulged up tarmac and pavement in the struggle for existence. *That's it, keep looking away from me; stay like that.* He cantered across the road and snaked behind a delivery van; the woman still hadn't moved.

Ducking back down, he loosened his grip on the bag and tried to settle his breathing. Who? *Shit.* What if this was Teresa, and Miranda turned up? He went for broke and sprinted the remaining distance, dropping the sports bag and grabbing her shoulders in one fluid movement. "Right!"

Miranda gave a short yelp and turned her head. "Jesus, Thomas! You frightened the life out of me."

His heart was beating so fast that he struggled to find the words. "Don't ever stand in the street like that again."

Miranda paused, as if weighing up whether to slap him. "You arse!"

Somewhere, a bugler sounded the retreat. His head began to clear. "Sorry," he held up a hand, "I just got a bit freaked. Let's go inside."

"Well," Miranda headed on up the steps. "As long as you're not worried that people will see us."

She used her keys before he could object. He let it pass and carried on into the kitchen. Listening hard, he heard Miranda close the front door and then bolt it. So far, so salvageable.

She slumped into a chair and dumped her bag on the table. "I did bring you a present, but I'm not sure if you deserve it now."

When he returned, he was carrying two glasses of wine — his own only half-full — and the bottle tucked under one armpit; one hundred per cent

style.

“What’s this — are you cutting back?”

He smiled sheepishly and handed her the grown-up glass. “Can’t overdo it — I’m working tomorrow, remember.”

She took a sip and pursed her lips, although he knew it was a good wine.

“Look, about earlier; I know I was a dick but I’m only thinking of you, okay?”

She didn’t skip a beat. “Then tell me . . .”

He shook his head. “The less I tell you, the less you have to worry about.”

“Is this the way we’re going to live now?” She pulled a DVD case from her bag, tapping it rhythmically against her arm. “Still not sure if you deserve this . . .” The tone was playful and when he looked at her all ‘puppy-dog,’ she seemed to melt.

“It’s not porn, is it?” Hardly likely. That one time they’d watched a porn flick together he’d sat in mute embarrassment, feeling a mix of betrayal and arousal. Getting turned on by other nubile women on the go, while your girlfriend was in the room with you, was hardly a declaration of love and devotion. And besides, those guys on screen were a lot to live up to.

“It’s *The Thirty-Nine Steps*. And before you say anything, yes — it’s the *original*. Seemed appropriate, what with your new life as a spy.”

That lit the whole box of fireworks. “Let’s get one thing straight, shall we?” he clunked his glass down hard. “I’m not a bloody spy.”

She leaned back in silence, and he felt really stupid. Like the time in Leeds when he’d got drunk, taken a leak in the park and soaked his own shoes. It was time for a tactical withdrawal. “I’ll go sort out the grub and then we can watch Robert Donat kick arse. Help yourself to the telly.” A polite way of saying: end of round one and back to your corners.

* * *

The bolognaise was already prepared — real stuff, no crap. Made to a recipe of Pat’s and freshly dug out of the freezer the night before. He kept the kitchen door open and listened as the TV erupted into life; a comedy, by

the sounds of it and so sharp that a laughter track had been added. “Shouldn’t be long,” he called out.

There was silence from Miranda. Either the comedy was more riveting than it sounded or she still had the hump, big time. Or both. Not much else he could do, other than watch the pasta simmering, and think. Why were he and Karl going to Suffolk? He jabbed at the frothing pan with a fork, submerging the strands. How far did he want this work with Karl to go? So what if Peterson was bent? He grabbed the fork from the saucepan and held on to it until the heat reddened his fingers. No, Bob Peterson had lied to him; and Sir Peter Carroll had tried to set him up. He deserved some answers.

The TV volume rose — advert time. He smacked his lips appreciatively as the garlic and beef flirted with his nostrils. The way to a man’s heart and all that — and hopefully a woman’s too. “Pasta’s almost done,” he relayed the news. “I’ll come in for a bit.”

“*You’ve Been Framed*, I think,” Miranda stared at the TV, deadpan.

He perched on the edge of the sofa and sipped his wine. He saw right away that she’d topped it up, but he let it pass. On TV, a child ran into a transparent patio door and bounced back two feet. The studio audience laughed and winced; Western Civilisation — coming soon.

Nothing more to be said, he nipped off, returning with a bowl of salad; quite the little Jamie Oliver. *Try something new today*. Yeah, like not having another argument.

The bolognese was good when they got there; even Miranda said so. They ate and relaxed — or at least, relaxed hostilities. Onscreen, Robert Donat grappled with conspiracy, paranoia and false accusations. Thomas knew just how he felt.

Miranda nudged him, mid-film. “Bet you didn’t know that in the book, there’s no female lead at all.”

“Maybe it needed improving.”

She patted his leg: good answer.

By the end of the first bottle of wine, they’d moved past the talking stage. She sat close and ran a finger up and down his arm; he could feel the tremors in faraway places. As they watched the dying minutes of the mystery, Robert Donat finally figured out his enemies’ plan and how to stop them. As the credits rolled, Thomas grabbed the remote and peered at the

screen, checking through names mostly forgotten. He wasn't a film buff particularly, but sometimes, when he spotted a cameraman in a really enjoyable old film, he'd search them out on the net and see what else they'd done.

"That was champion," he sat back.

Miranda squeezed the arm she'd been teasing. "What shall we do for a second feature?" It sounded like a come-on. Then again, everything Miranda said sounded like a come-on.

"Well . . ." he stretched the word out like bait. She didn't respond; she wasn't biting. Jeez, he'd have to ask. "Are you stopping tonight? He cringed at the words — about as romantic as a six-pack of lager.

"Maybe," she smiled, and chuckled.

He turned to her and her eyes sparkled in the reflected glare of the TV. There was a heavy pause — the tipping point of desire — then his lips found hers. He was greedy for her and she seemed eager to follow his lead. He moved a hand under her buttock and tilted her towards him. He felt the shape of her mouth change and slid his left hand behind her, to the small of her back.

Her fingers burrowed beneath his shirt, ranging over his torso. An idea came to him, but he killed it dead. Since Leeds, there had been one unwritten rule. No talking — during sex or foreplay or canoodling. No declarations of love, no verbal requests.

He levered her on to one buttock and she took the hint, rolling with him in one uneven lollop. He shifted down the cushions by about a foot and she swung one leg over his, pinning him to the sofa. Now, as they kissed, they moved in rhythm, their pubic bones rising and falling against each other. He lifted her t-shirt and circle kissed her navel and stomach, enjoying the no-man's land between two leisure parks.

He could feel waves of pleasure rippling between them. She moved faster, taking control, as he'd wanted her to. He started to unbutton her jeans as she rocked, and he tried to shut out the calls of despair from his bladder: bad timing 'R' us. She bore down on him, her out-breaths reduced to faltering gasps. He gave up on her jeans, thrusting with his hips, willing her to climax before his bladder burst. He drew her closer as she came, drawing her head towards his and moving his tongue around hers as the last

shudders freed themselves from her glorious body. “Now you,” she said breathlessly, shifting back on to the sofa.

The relief from his bladder was like a gift from God. As he turned to her, she was undoing the last of her jeans buttons. “Hold that thought — I really need to pee.” He heaved himself up with difficulty and staggered to the bathroom.

He heard her grumbling in the other room, but the call of nature would not be ignored. His body took a while to respond, as if it resented the unused hard-on. At last, everything flowed, and flowed; and flowed.

He finished up and washed his hands. His reflection looked flushed. He grinned at himself; he felt like a teenager again, copping off with Miranda on the bedsit put-you-up in Leeds. As he opened the unlocked door he repeated her words to himself — now it was his turn. By the time he’d taken half a dozen steps, he was back at full mast.

Miranda was standing in the living room. Her jeans were fully fastened and she was putting on her coat. He did a double take — twilight zone style — staring at her crotch as if he could hypnotise it back into action.

“What’s going on?” His question slammed against her granite expression.

“Your boyfriend called. He’ll be over in an hour. Thanks for everything.”

“You don’t have to go . . .” he paused, wondering if he could possibly steer the sentence towards: ‘we could still have a quickie before Karl turns up.’

“What, hide in the bedroom? I don’t think so, Thomas. I’m not the hiding type.”

He caught sight of his mobile phone on the table. “You didn’t . . .”

“Relax Thomas. I didn’t speak to him and break your little code. He sent a text.”

Yeah, a text that you read. “Look, I’ll call you over the weekend.”

“We’ll see,” she didn’t look convinced.

He followed her to the door. “Look, Karl wasn’t supposed to be coming over until tomorrow evening.”

“Careful Thomas,” she faced him down. “You’re giving away your secrets.”

As he went to kiss her, she turned her face away. “Sam’ll pick me up. I’ll come back for my car tomorrow sometime.”

There was nothing left to be said. He settled for “I’ll make it up to you,” but she was already down the steps and away. She didn’t look back.

Back inside, he rechecked the sports bag, tidied up and waited for the call.

“Tommo, it’s Karl. Are you free to talk?”

I am now, thanks to you, you bastard. “Yeah, all packed and ready to go.”

“Great — everything’s gone haywire. Bring a decent sweater; they say it’s gonna be a cold night.”

Chapter 21

Karl had given precise instructions for the pick-up: on a corner, three streets away, in twenty minutes. His timing was exact, stopping just long enough for Thomas to get in the car and jam the bag behind him.

Karl seemed to be in a chipper mood. “We’re driving to Minsmere Bird Reserve, like proper wildlife photographers. And no shag jokes,” he grinned. “Now sit back, pick an album and enjoy the ride. Status Quo or Queen?”

Thomas slept for most of the journey. Karl wasn’t saying a lot and there were only so many times he could hear Karl singing about ‘Having a good time.’ He dreamt that he and Miranda were back in the flat, arguing. Then she’d slapped him and walked out. He followed her to the street, to find Karl, Christine, Bob Peterson and Sir Peter Carroll, all slow clapping as if they’d caught him out at something.

He shuddered awake and tried to clear his head. “Are we there yet?” he tried his best child-in-car voice.

Karl glanced sideways, didn’t reply.

Fair enough, he’d stick to questions. “Have you been here before, Karl?”

“Aye — once; it’s a good drop off point.”

Karl was true to his word; it had taken two and a half hours non-stop. The car slowed to a halt, facing a metal gate. Thomas waited; maybe this was the pick-up point and all the gear in the bag was just precautionary.

Karl got out and unlocked the gate, waving Thomas through so he could close it behind them. A more inquisitive person might have asked where Karl had got the key from, but Thomas was just about up to his limit with curiosity.

Karl reclaimed the driving seat; he sounded edgy. “Okay, here’s how it works. I lead and you follow. We wait for the drop, retrieve what we came for then hightail it out of here, lickety-split.”

“So if this is so easy-peasy why am I here as well?”

“Hold on there, Tommy Boy,” Karl manoeuvred the car up the dirt track. “Nobody mentioned the ‘e’ word. And it’s standard procedure to have

two bodies for night-time retrievals.”

Thomas checked his watch and chewed his lip. “How long are we waiting for?”

A cloud drifted across the moon, edging silver as it crowded out their only natural light source. No music now and no conversation, as Thomas watched Karl staring through the windscreen, checking the wetland for who knew what.

“You’ll never get a submarine through that.”

Karl smiled, but didn’t respond. As he’d managed two cold pies, a large bag of crisps *and* taken a dump somewhere in the swamps, perhaps he was considering his next activity.

Thomas sat beside him, wearing the wetsuit. He felt like a mascot for safe sex. “I still don’t see . . .”

Karl raised a finger then tapped his watch. “Sshhh. Any time soon.”

Thomas released the car door on command and swung himself out. The water lapped gently, close by — water he would have to get into. Karl seemed very calm now, with a night-scope strapped to his head, like a malevolent cyborg.

The droning engine cut into the night with increasing fervour as it approached. Thomas moved to the water’s edge and waited for Karl’s signal. The red and green wing lights flickered through the clouds as the plane circled over and released its cargo. Soon a small, white parachute glistened silver as it spiralled down towards the water. Karl twitched like a cat, tracking the parachute’s descent in jerky movements. Out on the water there was a muted *splosh* as the package landed.

“Now,” Karl hissed.

Thomas slipped into the water, forcing through the mud and weeds that conspired to strangle every step. Soon he was in up to his thighs, half-wading half-floating in the cold gloom, gliding towards the quarry. He couldn’t hear Karl anymore; it was just him, the water and each laboured gasp as he closed on the box — the parachute and cords lifeless as a dead jellyfish.

As he laid a hand on one corner, he heard a popping sound and water kicked up about a foot in front of him. By the third shot, he was rooted to the spot in panic. He did the only thing he could think of, pulling himself underwater, letting the roar of pressure in his ears drown out the screams in

his head. In the murky half-light of his torch, he saw the strands of cord and dragged the box towards him.

Bad idea; the impacts in the water increased. And they were getting closer. Ice chilled his veins. Christ, he was going to die. He thought about Miranda, thought about what a shit he'd been to her. Saw his father and mother sitting in the living room in Pickering, curtains drawn; imagined his father gazing into a glass: 'I knew he'd come to no good when he went to London.'

He held on to a breath past the point of reason, heart pounding, eyes bulging, raging against the injustice of it all. Finally, as his senses started to fade, he thrust through the surface, fighting for breath.

"Get your fucking head down!" Karl bellowed.

As he plunged below again, he heard returning gunfire. At least Karl was looking out for him — a reassuring thought that only lasted while the pressure intensified in his chest. Until the heavy heat stretched out across his collarbone, numbing his arms, choking him. Despair quickly filled his lungs as the oxygen ran out; the abject no-win terror of being shot above the water or drowning beneath it. "Argh!" he surfaced again, flailing his arms to get balance. Only now did he realise that he'd become disorientated and was a good ten feet from the package. It bobbed further away with every second, taunting him to choose between safety and failure. With a great gulp of air, he made his choice, propelling himself towards it, closing his mind to the chaos around him as he hit the water like an ironing board. He clawed blindly at the box, swearing at the strain of keeping hold.

Then he felt it, the smouldering poker against his arm; a fire even the water could not cool. White-hot light blinded him, skewering his brain awake. This was pain he'd never known before. But, then, he'd never been shot before.

His legs buckled and the mud slammed into him. He grabbed the package with his good arm as he went down, kicking wildly to make for the reed bank. Birds scattered in the commotion, but he stayed put, keeping low, clasping the package between his knees. He forced himself to breathe through his nose, gritting his teeth to try and block out the pain. He felt like his arm was hanging off — he didn't want to look, didn't want to know.

He could hear Karl, blazing away with one, no two weapons. Round after round; he lost count of the relentless rhythm — the sound seemed to

fade in and out of his head. Then he heard the sound of glass shattering and the shooting stopped.

The water seemed to swirl around him. He felt his pulse go into overdrive; his hands were shaking. He wished that he were armed, so he could track those fuckers down and stick a bullet in them. But he was trapped. He couldn't let Karl know he was okay without giving away his own position; couldn't leave the cold, cloying water for fear of being shot again. As Karl might have said: he was properly fucked.

A hollow *thom* broke the silence then the sky high above the water lit up like magnesium. Karl's flare arced down and faded on the far side of the water.

"It's clear!" Karl called out plaintively. "Are you there?"

He turned in Karl's direction, but all he saw were blotches of light. Lesson four in how to be a spy: never look directly at the flare. He waited a few seconds, still terrified of the enemy in the dark.

"Come on, Tommo; we don't have time for this — do you have it?"

He dragged his limbs from the mud's grasp, suppressing a scream as his injured arm brushed against the reeds. Just before he clambered out, he dipped his hand into the water and washed the tears from his face.

Karl stashed the package behind the driver's seat then handed him a bath towel. "Right then, let's get a look at you."

He needed help to ease his arm out of the wet suit. Even the night air hurt. He stood flinching, eyes closed as Karl carefully touched around the wound. Karl murmured to himself and reached back into his car.

"This will hurt."

Thomas coughed back laughter. "No need to treat me with kid gloves."

Karl shrugged and poured out something that smelt like meths. Thomas braced himself, fist drawn tight to stifle any reaction. When the cloth touched his arm he thought it had caught fire. "Fuck!" he shrieked, both at the pain and the way the tears ran from his eyes.

"Hey Tommo, no points for bravery here — you did the courageous bit earlier." Karl finished dressing the wound and handed him a small bottle. "Take one of these every couple of hours while the pain is bad. Only one, mind; these are not your usual headache tablets!"

They stood grinning together, like boys who'd just completed a dare. "Are you sure you still want to play this game? Come on then, let's go

finish the job.” Karl opened the passenger door and helped him in, still dripping water and slime.

Thomas nodded, unable to speak, blowing huffing breaths as he edged into the car seat. His arm felt like someone had crushed it in a vice; Karl assured him it would feel worse the next day. Some comfort.

“Shouldn’t we have checked their car?”

“No point, Tommo. Odds on, it’s stolen. Three cheers for Robert and Lizzie, eh?”

Thomas squeezed his eyelids. Maybe delirium was setting in; Karl was making no sense whatsoever.

“In the glove compartment.”

Thomas reached forward with difficulty. Inside were two handguns.

“Robert and Lizzie — the Brownings!” Karl milked his ‘ta-da’ moment.

Thomas laughed breathlessly and slumped back. Even with the heat on full, his legs were getting numb from the damp. He tried pushing the waders down his legs, but his left arm shrieked in protest.

“Take it easy. I’ll keep the heat full blast and get us there quick as I can. But I’ll not break any speed limits. Imagine trying to explain two guns in the glove box and a wet man beside me trying to get his trousers off.”

Thomas smiled and rolled his head away. He felt like he was sinking into the chair. Delayed shock, come down; call it what you will, he needed to sleep.

“You get some shut-eye; we’ve a way to go yet.”

He closed his eyes. It seemed as if Karl was talking and then the radio struck up with ‘You’ve got a friend.’ Then blackness.

* * *

Thomas felt the car rocking from side to side. Scratch that; it was Karl, applying the gentle art of persuasion.

“Time to wake up.”

He opened his eyes; it looked like they were in a concrete wonderland and Karl was the tour guide.

“We’re in an underground car park — I won’t be long. I’ll stick your bag on the backseat. You did bring a change of clothes like I told you?” Good ol’ Karl — he thought of everything.

Thomas blinked in the muted neon glow; his eyes ached. First things first, he reached for Uncle Karl's all-purpose painkillers. Then he wriggled his way out of the car and squelched a few steps. His nervous cough echoed into the distance; he seemed to be alone. He did a quick scan around for CCTV then dried himself off with the bath towel one-handed and got changed with as few sudden movements as possible. There was no mobile signal and the time on the clock meant they were probably in London.

He gathered his wits and headed into the shadows for a piss. Nothing seemed real, the world rendered pleasantly numb. As he stumbled back to the car, he saw holes in the driver's door; they looked like bullet holes. He yawned, managed to clamber into the back seat and lay there in the shadows.

Memory and pain collided in his brain. At the lake, in the worst of his panic, he'd feared that Karl was actually firing at *him*. He giggled in the dark, overwhelmed by everything but unable to stop thinking. He mustn't forget that Karl had probably saved his life tonight. He sniffed back the emotion. Of course, Karl had put him in danger in the first place, but no one was perfect.

Next thing he knew, something squeaked — maybe a door — and somewhere in the gloom, someone started whistling 'I Shot the Sheriff.' As Thomas sat up, Karl waved, like he was just back from the shops. He held up a couple of packets and passed them through the open passenger door.

"Jesus, this car smells like a marsh! Our leader's very pleased with our performance tonight — he sent us these with his compliments."

"Hush money?" Thomas took the oblong envelopes and weighed them with his good arm.

"Danger money, more like! So how's the walking wounded?"

Thomas grimaced and waved a hand tentatively. He had so many unanswered questions he could scarcely count them. "So what did we risk life and limb for, exactly?"

Karl put a lot of irritation into one sigh. "I didn't ask; I don't need to know. Now be a good boy and open my envelope."

Thomas clamped the envelope between his knees and tore at the paper. He ran a thumb through a run of £50s and £20s. "I make it at least a couple of grand, maybe three."

“Which means, Tommo, that whatever we fished out of the wet was worth more than five grand to Sir Peter Carroll.”

“And the sniper?” Thomas lifted his arm a couple of inches.

“He was probably just a hired hand, warning us off till somebody else turned up.”

“*He?*” Thomas tilted as far as the seatbelt would allow.

“In my limited experience, Tommo, women don’t miss. Come on now, enough with the philosophising. Let’s go find ourselves a drink.

* * *

If the pub’s name wasn’t enough of a clue, then the military crests and insignia on every spare inch of wall were a dead giveaway. The landlord had greying ginger hair and a ruddy complexion. Thomas took him for a former sergeant major, still crimson from years of shouting; somehow he couldn’t see a former officer working this hard after demob to earn a living.

“Mr McNeill!” the landlord all but saluted. “Always a pleasure!”

Thomas hung back; no one paid him any attention. Karl crossed to the bar, leaving him in the centre of the saloon, like a deodorant commercial.

“A shandy for me and a whisky for my associate.”

Thomas felt unreasonably disappointed; not comrade or oppo, just associate. He listened with envy as Karl fell into easy conversation with Mein Host. No point standing around — might as well be comfortable. He grabbed an empty table with a view of the bar. The tabletop reeked of polish, but he couldn’t see any evidence of it; even the beer-mats had formed an unhealthy attachment to the veneer.

Karl took his time coming over. Maybe it was tough leaving his army pals behind. Once or twice he looked in Thomas’s direction and then carried on with his conversation. No matter — the extra time gave Thomas time to clear his head.

“Your very good and continued health, Tommo.”

He managed a smile, lifting the whisky up to the light, and breathed in deeply through his nostrils. Even good whisky couldn’t stop his stomach churning at the thought of cold, gushing water closing over his head.

“I know how you’re feeling, Thomas,” Karl lowered his voice. “There’s not a man or woman here who hasn’t been where you were, hasn’t asked themselves at some point: Is this the end?” Karl leaned forward and

produced a packet of crisps from his pocket. “The thing is, this is what we do.”

There was no answer to that, but still the need to say something. “How scared were you then, when it was all kicking off?”

“Are you kidding me? I was like a brick factory on overtime. I get a sweat just thinking about it — if I hadn’t brought Robert and Lizzie out for the night . . .” Karl broke off and did his customary plague-of-locusts routine on the crisps. “Look Tommo, I know it’s a lot to deal with, first op and all.”

“I don’t know if I’m really cut out for this.” It sounded so much clearer, out loud.

Karl put the crisps down and straightened his back against the chair. “Well, only you can make that choice. But meantime, the packages will *still* come and go, Bob Peterson will *still* have lied to you about being at Harwich and Sir Peter Carroll will *still* be playing tin soldiers with the rest of us. Come on, aren’t you still the teensiest bit curious to know what the fuck is really going on?”

Thomas managed a grin and sank the remainder of his whisky. Karl had a point. But so had the bullet that had almost gone through his arm.

* * *

Thomas closed the front door and bolted it. He felt like never opening it again. He sat in the dark, hugged tight against the cushion, reliving the paddle from hell. It wasn’t long before he reached for the phone.

“Ajit, you awake? It’s Thomas.”

“Hiya mate, ’ow’s it going? Let me just take this downstairs — Geena’s asleep.”

Thomas pulled the phone close and lifted his feet on to the sofa. Only Ajit and Miranda could keep a meaningful conversation going for longer than twenty minutes. He knew because he’d timed it. And right now he needed to talk.

He chatted with Ajit for over an hour, about nothing in particular; the latest on Geena, the joys of Yorkshire policing and the glory days of Pickering; anything and nothing to keep his thoughts at bay. “By the way,” he added as things wound to a close, “I still have your *Blake’s 7* annual

somewhere. I saw it when I was last having a clear out.” This, Ajit would know, was boys’ code for ‘I’m still thinking about you,’ and it sufficed.

Last thing before bed, Thomas counted out his money from Sir Peter. Three grand, tax-free — nice work if you could get it. Or not.

Despite the previous day’s excesses, Thomas woke early on Sunday morning; a fireworks-in-the-brain, no prisoners, wide-awake start to the day. His arm stung like a bastard and try as he might he couldn’t get his body to settle. The alarm clock glowed 6.45 defiantly. He popped one of Karl’s magic pills with a swig of cold tea and then got himself ready, using his left arm as little as possible. There was no pretence of putting a camera in his car; he knew exactly where he was going — across London to the well-appointed streets of Highgate. Time to start separating truth from fiction.

The traffic was non-existent so early on a Sunday. He remembered driving out to Enfield once to photograph a pair of foxes; this wasn’t so different. When he got to Christine’s street, he parked up, engine running. Did he really want to do this? Was it any of his business who shared Christine’s bed these days? True, he reasoned with himself, but if he backed off now that would mean he had a problem with it. The words ‘painted’ and ‘corner’ formed a trio with the painkiller to cloud what little judgement remained.

He pulled out and moved into second gear, rolling down the road at a steady ten mph, scanning both sides. There were several four-by-fours on the rugged streets of Highgate, though not the one he was looking for. Instead of relief, he felt a gnawing disappointment; it was there somewhere — he was sure of it. He dug out a street atlas and rested it on his knees, tracing a grid pattern, two streets away in every direction.

And suddenly there it was, the bonnet stone cold. The same vehicle from Harwich, the one Peterson probably used for taking the wife and kids shopping. So now what? He got back in his car and stared into the distance. Too early to ring Christine and anyway, what would he say? ‘Hi, I happened to be in the area and I see you’re shagging your boss who’s married.’ Yeah, that’d be a vote winner come his next assessment.

He thumped the steering wheel, sending shockwaves up his bad arm; it concentrated the mind wonderfully. He needn’t say or do anything for now — he’d leave it to Karl. Speed-dial number 4.

“Morning mate, I couldn’t sleep.”

Karl sounded like an advert for *Grumpy Bastard* magazine. “Well why don’t you get a bloody paper round? Do you know what time it is — what do you want?”

“I’ve got some information on Bob Peterson — he spent the night at Christine’s flat; just thought you should know.” He rang off: mission accomplished.

An hour later he was crashed out on the sofa, lulled by the TV. He slept deep and heavy, waking by degrees as the mobile shrieked for attention. *Not now, Karl, bugger off and leave me in peace.* The mobile gave up then beeped. He yawned and looked across at the clock. Blimey, it was evening — so much for Sunday. He rolled his neck from side to side and carefully hauled himself up to sitting. Still bleary eyed, he thumbed through to voicemail.

“Tomas, it is Petrov. You must help us; come quickly. Yorgi has contacted us — I am very afraid.”

Fuck. He scrambled off the sofa and grabbed the cash envelope, his mobile and his keys. On the way over, he pulled Petrov’s number from the mobile and stored it for speed dialling.

He made good time into South London and called in his progress. Alexandra answered, calmer than her husband, but definitely freaked. He told her to get packed and be ready to move as soon as he got there. From the little sense she made, he gathered that Yorgi had phoned them out of the blue — pissed, high, or paranoid; possibly all three; ranting about a hospital and unfinished business with a traitor. And then he was coming for them.

South of the river and every traffic light, every fuckwit incapable of doing thirty mph on a thirty road, all piled on the minutes and the pressure. No point calling Karl now, he was practically there.

He beeped the horn three times as he pulled up. A curtain snatched back, then the family made a run for the car, dragging as many cases as was humanly possible. They didn’t look as though they planned on coming back. He popped the boot and revved up to encourage them, flicking his gaze between the windscreen and his mirrors. As he pushed into the car seat, primed for the off, the clamminess of his shirt squished against his back. He shivered and smiled; he was almost enjoying this.

Petrov ushered his family in the back and climbed in beside them. He seemed to take a last remorseful look at the house then Thomas met his eyes in the mirror. Time to go. For all the fire in his blood, Thomas drove sensibly, keeping to the speed limit and watching all directions. Petrov and Alexandra said nothing; he preferred that.

As they crossed London Bridge, the enormity of his actions began to sink in. He didn't have a plan, beyond getting them away from there. He flicked on the radio for inspiration, but it was in short supply tonight. *Jesus, another tailback.* In a city that never sleeps, why did all the insomniacs have to drive? His passengers sat, trance-like, as he battled through the traffic. They hadn't said a word, not even to ask where he was talking them; a question he was quietly asking himself.

His first, impossible thought had been to head to Miranda's parents. Without question they'd help him, but it would mean dragging them deeper into his murky world. That was the word for it: *murky*. His second choice was less inventive. Pick a hotel at random; any hotel would do, but the more upmarket the better — and room service was a necessity. It had to be somewhere Yorgi couldn't trace them to. He settled on Paddington, only because he and Miranda had once spent a weekend there playing tourists. And besides, the station afforded a range of escape options if he really couldn't protect them.

The engine rumbled to a standstill. He glanced down at his mobile and thought about Karl. There was every reason to ring, and few not to. Petrov had called *him* though. He reckoned he could sort things out for the time being with less fuss. Behind him, Petrov's family hardly made a sound, but their expectations massed around him like the roar of a West Ham crowd. He didn't bother turning round. "I want you to stay in a hotel until I figure out the next step. You'll need to remain in your room. Order whatever you need, but *stay put*." He took out an even thousand and handed it to Petrov's bewildered wife.

"Why would you do this for us?"

He swallowed; he didn't really have an answer. Not without going into all the history with Ajit and . . . He stopped short. Maybe Ajit could provide police protection if he got them up to Yorkshire? The idea shattered before his eyes. *Wake up; this is more than you can handle. You need help; you need Karl.*

Alexandra paused from her whispered conversation and stared through the mirror. “How long must we hide there?”

“I don’t know, probably just for a couple of days.” He shouldered the door and breathed in the rush of air. “Remember, don’t contact anyone except me.”

They looked settled in the car. Tough. He emptied the boot and picked up a couple of bags, ready to start walking. “Let’s get on with it.”

Chapter 22

‘Opportunities multiply as they are seized.’

Sun Tzu, The Art of War

Yorgi folded the book flat and closed his eyes. It was not enough merely to read wisdom; one had to imbibe and absorb it. He blinked against the harsh neon strip light and moved uneasily from the chair, holding the kitchen table to steady himself. His breath still tasted of vodka and his head bore the pitiless, unrelenting pressure of a hangover.

In the corner of the room, a black bin-liner sat and waited, serenaded by two flies. He wrinkled his nose in disgust, but did not consider moving it. He took a pub glass out of the cupboard, wiped it with his hand and ran the tap, squeezing his eyes closed to bear the whine of the pipes. Then he reached to the broken tiled ledge behind the sink and took the last of the painkillers. The box said *fast acting* so he sat still for three minutes. Only now was he ready to face the front room.

The table was upended — that much he did remember — but the extent of the devastation was a shock. He recalled speaking to Petrov; even the thought of his half-brother’s name was like taking a candle to a fuse. His head throbbed to the rhythm: Pet-rov, Pet-rov. He picked up an armchair and turned the cushion over to sit. There was little point; it was filthy, either side. Peasants might live like this; he would not. He nodded to himself and grunted approval. It was settled; he would increase his fees, work the girls harder. He sniffed hard by his shoulder — taking in the stench of sweat and vomit. It was a disgrace, he told himself, unconsciously resurrecting his father’s voice in his head — not Petrov’s lineage, but his *real* father.

“Yes Papa,” he promised aloud, “I will complete my chores and better myself.” He unbuttoned his shirt, pushed the sleeve back over the grime and rubbed his watch glass; the smooth, domed surface always made him smile; transporting him back to Amsterdam. He had only been pimping back then, when opportunity had presented itself. How the American tourist had begged and pleaded. But showing mercy to your enemy disrespects him.

Sun Tzu understood that. So, once he had taken the man's watch and sneered at his flabby white body, he'd brought the knife easily to flesh.

In the shower he mentally relived the scene, enjoying the steady throbbing between his legs. The way the fat American had collapsed on the floor, squealing, oozing blood across the pale carpet. It was all so vivid, so *alive*. The frozen horror on the girl's face, making her gleam like an angel; like a religious statue. He sucked in the shower steam, felt it hot in his lungs as his memory wound on. That sense of absolute power as he'd fucked the girl on the bed, oblivious as to whether the man lived or died beside them on the floor. At that moment he had become a god, made in his own image.

He tilted his face to let the suds run down the length of his body and squirted shampoo around his pubic hair. Water splattered off his erection as he closed his eyes, moving his hand, slowly, teasingly downwards. Images of girls — so many girls, willing and unwilling — danced around him in a kaleidoscope of pleasure. Yes, Yorgi; yes. Now, as his hand found rhythm, the images were interspersed with the flashbacks of violence — the heavy certainty of the trigger or the knife handle. Pleasure and pain; pain and pleasure. At the point of orgasm he dug his nails hard into his penis, sending a delicious chord of agony and ecstasy through his body. When the pulses of semen had stopped, he relaxed his grip and gazed down at the savage marks on his flesh, like the bite of an animal.

He finished his shower and shaved, adding cologne to sting his face awake. A pair of trousers and shirt that had been hanging up for days gave him a respectable and inconspicuous air. He put the watch back on and checked the time: seven o'clock. Time to gather his things — the old clothes he would dump; another skin shed. A charity shop would meet his needs for the time being. He'd paid cash in advance for this hovel so no one should be visiting for at least another two weeks. By then, Mr Svenson — the name he'd given to the greedy bastard who'd made £500 out of him — would be long gone.

At Victoria station he stashed his bag and walked away with only a small carrier, stuffed in one side of his coat. He kept the silenced in the other pocket. He knew that the van driver, Dechevez, was in a private room on the third floor. But beyond that he knew nothing more than when he'd first encountered him at Harwich. Then, it had been a warning. Now, a permanent resolution was required. That it concerned politics was of no

interest to him. Politics, he considered as he passed the hospital signs, was just another business — profit, loss and opportunity. Dechevez — whoever he was — was simply no longer profitable to someone.

* * *

Yorgi slipped through the open door at the side of the hospital and went straight to the basement. The stifling heat and the noise of the boiler took him back to his time at sea, stoking the engines and avoiding the attentions of the drunken louts who liked to use young boys as playthings. He remembered hiding behind the hottest pipes, risking a scalding rather than something far worse.

He went deeper into the hospital basement catacombs and pressed a hand to the boiler pipe, resting it there until it felt like the paint was searing his skin. A sharp reminder of what he had endured. His ears picked out the shuffling gait ahead of him and the squeak of the trolley. He hid in the shadows and fitted the silencer.

The cleaner shuffled past then stopped, just beyond the alcove. He let go of his trolley, paused and turned. Yorgi stepped out of the shadows like a panther, closing on his victim like the predator he was. Yorgi thought, for an instant, that the look of dread hinted at some kind of recognition. The idea amused him — that this was one of the people he'd trafficked to freedom, only to come back and claim him when the situation required. He levelled the weapon, surprised to hear a native tongue.

Sun Tzu wrote of turning every situation to one's advantage by reading the signs and acting accordingly. Yorgi believed knowledge was nothing unless it was tested in practice. He made the cleaner take off his overalls; promised him mercy as long as he didn't piss them in fear; a promise Yorgi had no intention of keeping, especially since they may have met before. The man stood before him in his underpants and vest, weight sagged forward a little, hands clasped together as if in prayer. Yorgi smiled and the man relaxed a little, smiling back. The first shot to the head — hygienic and efficient; the second, to the heart — just because he could.

He dumped the body in a laundry trolley and wheeled it out of sight. Only then did he change into the uniform; the overalls were baggy enough to fit over his clothes — a bonus, as was the ID card. When Yorgi smelt a foreign sweat against his clothes and skin, he felt a sense of transformation,

as if he now inhabited the dead man's shell, claiming him. His mimicked accent might have sufficed to get to Dechevez, but this new persona offered a better disguise. Small matter that the photo bore little resemblance to him. A cleaning trolley and a hangdog expression would grant him anonymity, and people would see whatever they expected to see.

He exited the lift at the third floor. The air reeked of sickness and disinfectant; the heat smothered him like a blanket. He pushed his watch up his sleeve and wiped the tiny beads of sweat from his face. He started mopping along the corridor, head down, humming softly. The latex gloves were a little loose and he knew that later they would make his skin itch. But it was a minor inconvenience.

As the dry linoleum retreated and the room numbers counted down, he felt the thrill of anticipation and his erection pressing tightly beneath the overalls. He looked into the distance at the Asian nurse who was bent over, reading, and thought about what he'd like to do to her. He watched her for at least a minute until she looked up and gave a nonchalant wave in his direction. He responded in kind then furtively felt for the bulge through his pocket.

When she moved out of sight, he pushed the trolley closer and peered through the door-glass for the first time. Dechevez was there, sleeping like an innocent. Yorgi leered at him, his teeth reflecting in the glass like fangs. He turned towards the trolley and drew out the gun, keeping it at his blindside.

He waited, head down, watching as the pretty nurse picked up a folder and left his field of vision again. Barely breathing, he reached for the cylindrical door handle in small, precise movements. He felt the handle give way and the door ease in. Heat wafted around his face. He remembered then, as a young boy, his father coming into his room; stealthy, loving and unannounced. He always looked forward to those goodnights, but could never stay awake to catch him no matter how hard he tried. He would just open his eyes and Papa would be there, like Santa Claus, at the edge of his bed.

Dechevez sighed softly. Yorgi heard his father's voice again: 'Sleep well, Yorgi; you are my good boy.' His eyes glistened as he squeezed the trigger, his lips forming the words: 'I love you, Papa.' Dechevez's body

twitched against the pillow and the blood seeped down the side of the bed, pooling on the lino.

Yorgi fired again, just to see the head jerk a second time, like one of Papa's wooden puppets. He hummed as he closed the door, carefully spraying polish over the aluminium handle and door plate and wiping it tenderly. Then he collected up his cleaning implements, pushed the trolley round to the lift and left it there. As he headed for the stairwell he heard the lift door ping behind him and a murmur of voices carried along the corridor. He removed the ID card from his jacket, looked at the name and whispered his thanks to the original owner.

Outside, he acknowledged the other cleaning staff gathered by a side door to smoke. He declined their offer to join them and muttered 'newspaper,' waving casually behind him as he reached the corner. He removed his overalls in the nearby public toilets and packed them into a carrier bag, ready for the nearest recycling bin. The ID he would keep — a souvenir of his own inventiveness. He felt for the watch underneath his overall sleeve; it was time to settle things with Petrov. And for that he'd need a vehicle.

Chapter 23

“Tommo, we got us a situation.”

Thomas watched himself in the café mirror as he answered the phone, staring back in dismay; he looked rough. “I’m listening, Karl.”

“I’ve located the hospital, but it’s bad news; two dead — professional hits. One’s our shooting victim from the docks — Dechevez — and the other’s a cleaner. The police haven’t found a connection between them yet and we’re trying to keep a lid on things until they do.” Karl’s voice was unemotional; he could have been reading from a script. “The cleaner was Yugoslavian or . . . something Eastern European. I guess he’d be a former Yugoslavian now.” Karl had probably rehearsed that line.

“What’s the plan, then?”

Karl didn’t respond immediately. “There’s something else. I’m sorry, Tommo. There was a fire in South London, where you did the home visit.”

Thomas caught his reflection, nodding needlessly.

“The house is completely gutted, apparently. I don’t see how anyone could have got out of there alive,” the line went quiet.

Thomas let out a gasp. “It’s okay, Karl. I’ve got them! Petrov rang me — I put the family somewhere safe. This is down to Yorgi, isn’t it?”

Karl ignored the question and let out a whoop of joy. And then it hit Thomas like a smack in the face; he’d done something amazing. He touched his neck where the crucifix chain used to rub, back when he’d worn it to please his mother.

“Are you still there, Tommo? Wherever they are, they’re not safe; we need to bring them in.”

Now came the familiar dilemma: to trust or not to trust.

Karl wouldn’t wait. “Are you there? Listen to me. Yorgi is a Grade A psychopath. I’ve seen the file. If he’s killed twice today, he’s probably tying up *all* loose ends.”

Thomas felt a creeping sense of doom. “But I told Petrov not to call anyone.”

“Come on now — where did you take them?”

“Near Paddington — I cut through the City to save time.”

“No!” Karl wailed, “Central London — the congestion charge; there are vehicle recognition cameras everywhere.”

“I don’t understand. If Yorgi’s working alone . . .”

“That’s just it, Tommo. These people are pros — they’ll have connections. You better give me the details and pray Yorgi hasn’t got to them first.”

Thomas threw some money down on the counter — the way they do in films — and ran back to the hotel. Thank Christ he hadn’t driven off anywhere. He pushed the glass door, ignored the night porter and made straight for the stairs. He took them two at a time, rounding the final flight at the Fifth Floor, and slammed through the fire door. Left hand corridor, down towards the end. He knocked politely then thought better of it, banging with his fist. “It’s Thomas, open the bloody door.” He stepped back and sized it up; it looked tougher than he did.

“Alright, alright; you’ll wake Lukas,” Petrov scolded him. The door unbolted and then the latch turned — at least they’d done something right.

Thomas pushed his way in; Alexandra lifted her head from the sofa. “We couldn’t sleep so we watched television. Too much has happened; tell him, Petrov,” she looked daggers at her husband.

Petrov carefully closed the door then slicked back his hair with his fingers. “I over-reacted, made a mistake. Yorgi telephoned on my mobile and apologised. He wants to make amends, to drive over and collect us, but this Alexandra does not want.”

“Your house was burned down,” Thomas blurted it out in one breath. No warning, no preamble; no point.

Petrov pressed a hand to his forehead and staggered to a chair. “How?”

Alexandra didn’t say a word. She ran to a side room, where Thomas figured Lukas was sleeping.

He was glad she’d left the room; it made things easier. He stood over Petrov. “The fire was deliberate and Yorgi’s killed two people today.” And there was something about Petrov’s face; a knowing look in the eyes that told Thomas this wasn’t the first time. “Does Yorgi know where you are?” He felt his legs start to tremble. “We have to go, *now*.”

Petrov leapt to his feet. “Is impossible. My wife needs to sleep. Besides, I have told him nothing. He does not know where to find us.” He held up his mobile phone as if it was the evidence that would clear him.

The green light shone out to Thomas like a taunt. Oh Jesus: the mobile. As traceable as a number plate, with the right equipment. “When did he ring you?”

“About ten minutes after you left.”

Thomas’s mind raced through the maths. Ten minutes, plus fifteen minutes or so, equals thirty minutes max; plenty of time to be on the move. And if Yorgi could access information on the hoof . . . shit. “Get up,” he snarled. “We’re leaving.”

Petrov’s mobile rang; they both just stared at it. Thomas’s senses went into overdrive; his first instinct was to grab the knife on the room service tray. Futile in itself, but a sign of how scared he was. His breath came in shallow bursts. *Think Thomas, think.* He grabbed Petrov’s mobile and switched it off with a strangle hold. Reality kicked in: get out, go to ground and rely on Karl. He clicked his fingers at Petrov and pointed to the side room. Next, he turned the TV off and rang Karl.

“I’m organising a team, Tommo. In the meantime you’ll have to improvise.”

Improvise? Thomas felt the sweat trickle down his back. He gave Petrov another few seconds, mainly to avoid arguing with him. The bedroom door opened, and the family was ready to leave. They looked at him the same way they’d done at the house — as if he had all the answers. He tried to draw strength from that.

“Right,” he held up a hand, as if he might grasp a passing plan, “got it. Here’s how we do it. Petrov, you go alone. Alexandra, you take the boy. Yorgi is expecting three people together. Petrov — swap jackets with me; quickly.”

It was bollocks, but it was a start. It gave them something to cling to; the delusion that he knew what he was doing. He and Petrov emptied out personal belongings and made the switch. Now came the tricky part.

He unlocked the door. An inch open and all he could hear was his own breathing and the television from next door. He emerged slowly, signalling for them to follow. But at the turn in the corridor, he had a flash of inspiration. “Stay in the room until the bells start.”

Alexandra narrowed her eyes. “What bells?”

He blinked twice and ushered them away. “Just be ready.”

He ran to the fire alarm and punched it hard, harder than needed. The sting in his knuckles felt good though; it seemed to sharpen his senses. He heard the alarm echo along the corridor; guest doors opened at random and a few simply closed again straight away. Stupid bastards.

Petrov and Alexandra wasted no time in joining the throng on the stairway. Thomas timed it and fell in close behind. He tapped Petrov's shoulder at the last landing so that he could pass him. Alexandra had already slowed up by the fire door, with the child in her arms. She looked lost.

He gently grabbed her elbow and steered her out into the street. The police were already in attendance — maybe Karl's doing, he couldn't be certain. He told Alexandra to stand by the police car. Petrov, if he'd kept to the plan, should be making himself invisible. Only Thomas — wearing Petrov's jacket — walked around slowly as if dazed by the chaos around him. He took his mobile out casually and hit the speed-dial. *Now, Karl.*

"I'll be on-site in ten minutes, max. I got some of the boys in blue to help out. Stay in the crowd, Tommo. Believe me, Yorgi is out there somewhere. Be safe."

Thomas didn't feel brave now, or clever; he just felt sick to his stomach. Like he was in one of those nature programmes where the gazelle stands around waiting for the lion to strike. This was insane. *Easy, Thomas, just drift away from Alexandra; find a different policeman and ask some stupid questions.* Anything to let Yorgi see that Petrov was smart enough to stay out of harm's way.

The police officer brushed him off and took a call on his radio, so much for Plan A. He listened without being obvious — something about sending everyone back in again. A firefighter approached, with a face like thunder.

"Some twat set off the alarm. We've scoured the ground floor upwards, just waiting on the basement. I'll give you a shout when the Incident Controller gives the okay to return."

This was where the plan unravelled. Still no Karl, and Petrov out there in the crowd — no doubt keeping an eye on Alexandra even though Thomas had told him to stay clear. They were bound to go in together, which pretty much defeated the object. He couldn't keep them out on their own, in the open; couldn't get them away, as his car was around the block. In short, screwed from all angles. He could slug the copper to create a bit of

a commotion? Think again; the guy didn't look as if he took any prisoners — maybe trigger a car alarm on one of the Mercs, then? Yeah, and what good would that do?

The mobile rang; he grabbed at it as if it were a lifebelt.

Karl was breathless. "I'm at the back of the crowd; get them ready."

"Ready?" Thomas hissed. "I split them up for safety — there are over two hundred people in the street."

"Well, you better get a bloody move on. I couldn't get a pick-up in time so I'm their ride out of here."

The firefighter reappeared, had a few words with the police officer and raised a hand to sound the retreat. The residents morphed into grumbling cattle and moseyed on in.

Thomas picked out Alexandra easily. She had followed instructions and stuck by the police car. As he approached, she was in conversation with one of the cops. "Ah, here is my husband!"

He swallowed hard and hoped that the boy didn't start screaming. "This way," he all but scooped her up.

"Where is Petrov?" she whimpered.

"I'll find him in a minute. Come on," he pulled her arm roughly. They swam against the tide of returning hotel guests until Thomas caught sight of Karl's old banger in the middle of the street. His heart skipped a beat; he had to steady himself against Alexandra as he led her to the car. She stared at Karl; he stared right back.

"It's okay, really," Thomas insisted, craning the door wide and nudging her towards it. "I'll go and get Petrov."

He spotted his own jacket heading back into the hotel and elbowed his way through. Other guests had made for the complimentary drinks; Petrov was rooted to the spot, standing in the bar like the ugly one at a Valentine's disco.

Thomas zeroed in. "Alexandra and Lukas are already in the car — we'll take you somewhere safe." The way he said it, he was barely selling it to himself.

Petrov's face was as blank as the décor. Thomas eased him outside. Karl pulled up and Thomas shouldered him to the car like he was an invalid. "I'll sort your cases out later."

Petrov opened his mouth, but he didn't speak. Thomas reached for the front passenger door.

"That's okay Tommo — I'll see you back in the hotel bar for a wee chat."

As Thomas sat down in the bar, he felt the damp patch cold on his back, clinging like a dirty secret. He shifted forward and glanced around the room. For all he knew Yorgi could be any one of them — no saying he had to look like Petrov. Yeah, he argued with himself, but Yorgi was a professional. Ergo, he'd have seen Karl driving off — he'd hardly be hanging around now. *Ergo?* For an instant he thought of Christine, all lips and Latin. He squished against the chair again and felt a droplet trickle down his spine to rest in the crack of his arse. He grimaced and pulled his top away. Sod this for a game of soldiers, he'd nip out to his car and get the sweatshirt from the boot. On the way out, he grabbed an empty beer bottle for comfort.

After all the commotion, the streets outside seemed unnaturally quiet. There was still traffic — this was London after all — but it was reduced to glaring lights and shrouded shapes. The side street was jam-packed with parked cars. He stuck to the shadows, avoiding the sickly orange glow of street lamps where he could. He moved quickly, keeping his wits about him.

He paused three vehicles from his car, and gripped the beer bottle more tightly. It might have once held extra strong lager but it wasn't strong enough to take on a bullet. He smiled in the gloom; knowing exactly what he was doing: gallows humour. He took a breath, sucking it down like a smoker getting a fix.

Despite the bollocking awaiting him, he wished Karl were there. As if on cue, his arm throbbed through its dressing. Enough stalling. He took a final glance around then stepped smartly to the rear of his car. The boot catch gave way with a sigh; he reached in without bending his head, feeling his way around for the sweatshirt. For a split second he was going to change in the street, but he suddenly felt more vulnerable than ever. He didn't want to let go of the bottle so he did a bit of a juggling act and slammed the boot down hard. *Good one Thomas; Mr Psycho might be out there but that ought to scare him off.* He jogged back to the hotel, kidding himself that his panting was due to being out of condition, not blind terror.

* * *

Yorgi watched closely as the stranger fumbled about in his car then ran back towards the hotel. This was a new factor, an unknown quantity. Killing him now would achieve nothing. No, this man had chaperoned Alexandra and Lukas out of the hotel; and he would be the best way of reaching them again. He might need a little encouragement, but he would cooperate. As for Petrov, well, he could be persuaded to do anything. Yorgi leered in the darkness, remembering how he'd forced Petrov to shoot a rat on the farm. Petrov had shaken and bawled; how he had pleaded! He had done it in the end though. They always did what he wanted in the end.

He pressed his watch close. Sometimes, when he felt the glass against his ear in the night, he fancied he could still hear the American screaming. He lowered his hand and moved the battered copy of Sun Tzu's *Art of War* from his lap. A phrase was underlined: '*A man who knows when he can fight and when he cannot, will be victorious.*'

The traffic was a distant hum through the glass. He reached for the device and left the car, walking along the street with the transmitter nestling in his palm. The gun remained in his pocket, in case anyone was foolish enough to disturb him. He found the place, underneath the chassis near the driver's door. He pushed the apparatus up against the metal, making sure it was secure. Then he disappeared into the night to await victory.

Chapter 24

Thomas returned from the gents with his old clothes knotted together. The bar was still busy as he threaded through, holding the bundle down like a secret shame. He stuffed it under the chair, bought drinks and crisps and left them untouched on the table, feeling like a kid waiting outside the headmaster's office.

Karl arrived ten minutes later; Thomas figured he'd passed Petrov on to someone more senior — Teresa perhaps? Karl spotted him at the door, but didn't acknowledge him. This did not look good. He sat down and took his time about it, sipping at his pint of shandy before he spoke. "We're in the shit. Yorgi wasn't picked up; he's gone to ground."

Thomas opened a packet of crisps methodically. "Isn't that a good thing?"

Karl glared; wrong answer. "Grow up, Tommo; he's a fucking killer. We've no way of knowing when he's going to pop up again. Meantime his brother and that lovely wee family of his are looking at relocation and a new identity; and all because you fucked up."

Thomas jerked back as if he'd been sucker punched. "Hey, if it wasn't for me, Petrov might still have been at the house when . . ."

Karl was having none of it. "First, do you really think he'd have stayed there waiting if you hadn't agreed to pick him up? And second, what the fuck were you thinking of, not informing me? We're supposed to be a team!"

Thomas clenched his fists, under the table. "We're a team, Karl? Then who are we working for, huh? Who did you hand Petrov over to? We're a team when it suits you."

Karl closed in on him. "For two pins, I'd knock you down where you stand."

"I'm sitting down though." Not a flicker from Karl. All Thomas felt from him was a heat-haze of anger.

Karl kneaded his forehead, as if he was trying to massage the words into place. "Look, you're plainly out of your depth in all this. You're a *liability*."

Ouch. Thomas gulped back the shock along with the lager. There was nothing else to be said. He put his glass down — definitely half empty tonight — and started to stand.

Karl pulled at his arm. “Hey,” he snarled, “we’re not done yet! Petrov thinks you’re some kind of saint so you’ll be in on the interrogation — we’re giving him a day or so to soften up. In the meantime we need to get a few things straight, once and for all.” He pointed a finger dagger at Thomas’s chest. “You need my help; Yorgi getting away like that looks worryingly suspicious from a certain angle.”

Thomas launched himself to standing. The glasses rocked on the table, their contents swirling like miniature tempests.

“Calm yourself, Tommy Boy,” Karl lifted his drink and took another sip. “This fiasco has put us both in a difficult position. I suggest you take a day off tomorrow — ring in sick — and have a serious think about your position.” Karl sat back and looked away: class dismissed.

Thomas grabbed his clothes from the floor and made for the door. His arm was stinging again, but there was a kind of comfort in that. He was on the phone to Miranda before he’d reached the car.

“Thomas — it’s late; what’s up?” Straight to the point. He played vague. Wrong move; more questions were the last thing he wanted, and Miranda knew him too well. “Bad day at work?”

Four little words which translated neatly as ‘serves you fucking right.’ Before he had time to think, they were bickering down memory lane; trudging through the past in the search for survivors — his possessiveness, his secretiveness, that footballer she’d been *banging* — a word he knew would exocet through her defences. She told him to grow up and sort his life out. Sort it out? He didn’t even know what his life was anymore.

He cut the mobile off mid-sentence. His arm was screaming now; he popped a pill and wondered how he’d ended up like this — Miranda, Christine and Karl, all blocking him like chess pieces. Shit, there was only Ajit left, and he was on the other side of the thin blue line.

The worst part of it was that he blamed himself. Oh sure, he’d make his peace with Miranda somehow and get back on side with Karl. Petrov and his family though, that was something he couldn’t fix — didn’t even know where to start. It was Big Boys’ stuff. And there was something else too.

Yorgi was the first person he'd been afraid of since leaving Leeds. Okay, maybe Miranda's dad to a point, but Yorgi was a *killer*. The word made the blood slow at the back of his neck. What if . . . no, he didn't dare think that way. He'd move carefully on this now; phone in sick tomorrow, like Karl had suggested, and get his head together. He breathed a little easier and put the car radio on to drown out his thoughts.

* * *

Ask most Londoners and they'll tell you that driving is a necessary evil; a means to an end, but not a pleasure. Thomas loved it though; for him a car brought freedom. Even if he wasn't out working or taking his own photographs, sometimes it felt good to just get in the car and lose himself in the maze of London streets. A full tank of petrol and a bag of crisps, and he was a happy man. And after the day's shenanigans, what better way of winding down?

He left Paddington and turned up through Maida Vale, breezing through Kilburn. Irish Town, as Karl had christened it — and he ought to know. Kilburn High Road ran into Shoot-up Hill, worth the journey for the irony value alone. He sang to the radio, laughing at the realisation that his rendition of 'Eye of the Tiger' was as murderous as anything Karl could produce.

And okay, maybe he hadn't planned it consciously, but when the first sign for Highgate appeared, it all seemed to make sense. If he could just straighten out the whole Christine and Bob Peterson thing, it would be a start. Then maybe he could recover some credibility with Karl. At the very least he'd unsettle the happy couple and that could only be a good thing.

The closer he got to Christine's flat, the more malicious he felt. After all, hadn't Bob Peterson's appearance at Harwich been the detonator? The defining event that had bollocksed everything up? So this could be payback time.

He parked, switched off the ignition and made himself comfortable. He wouldn't bother to check for Peterson's vehicle — no point: guilty as charged. He punched in Christine's number and paused for a second on the send button. Game on. He held the phone lightly to his ear and crossed his feet. At the fourth ring he suddenly remembered the time. Oops.

"Hello?"

“Hi, it’s Thomas; hope I’m not disturbing you,” he winced — about as subtle as a hammer at an osteopath’s.

“Thomas? Er, what can I do for you?” the curtain flicked back, silhouetting Christine against an orange glow. She looked good, even at a distance in a five second show.

“I just fancied a chat. Listen, I know it’s late, but how about I come over?”

The line went silent for a moment; the kind of silence that a hand over the receiver makes. “I don’t think that’s a very good idea, do you?”

It was too much to ask that Bob Peterson would put in an appearance at the window. He’d settle for something less tangible, like an admission.

“Are you out there somewhere, Thomas?”

Shit. Peterson was probably right next to her, might even be listening for his reply. *A large plate of ‘backfire’ to table four.* He swallowed and stared up at the window, which showed a silhouette of Christine and Bob.

“I’m waiting, Thomas.”

“I just needed to talk with you tonight. There have been developments.” Jesus, what was he saying? But the idea had already formed. “I think something is going on with the department.”

For an instant he thought he heard Christine gasp. Or maybe it was static.

“Look, I’m not far from your place; I could drop over — I won’t stay long.”

“No!” she yelled, “we’ve been through this before, Thomas. If you’ve got anything to say to me you can say it now or it’ll have to keep until tomorrow.”

Fuck it: in for a penny, in for a pound. “It’s about Bob Peterson.”

No reaction; she was good. If he knew her like he thought he did, the next words would be brief and measured.

“What about him?”

“I’d rather tell you face to face.”

“Thomas, don’t piss me about. I could have your mobile triggered before you got half a mile away. If you’ve something to say . . .”

“You do know he’s married with two kids?” He winced.

“Grow up Thomas, and keep your nose out of my personal affairs.”

He bit his tongue. “I’m just looking out for you, Chrissie.”

“I can look after myself. And don’t ring me here again, Thomas — I mean it. The next time you call me at home it goes on your report — do you understand? It’s been a long day; I’m going back to bed.”

“Is that alone?”

“Last warning, Thomas. Whatever you think you know, you’d best forget it. This ends here, but you are all out of favours now.” The line went dead.

He hung up and exhaled deeply into his hands. Stupid bastard; what was he doing? He grabbed up the mobile again and speed-dialled number 1. “Hi Miranda, it’s me again. Can I come over? It’s been a lousy night.”

“Do you know what time it is?”

“Late?”

She laughed. “Get some sleep, Thomas; it’ll all be better in the morning.”

“But your bed is so much more comfortable than mine . . .”

“Suit yourself.”

He sat there for a minute, trying to think straight. Was she toying with him? She’d done that once before, and he’d arrived to find the lights out and the door locked. “Well,” he told himself in the dark, “there’s only one way to find out.”

Chapter 25

Thomas rang the bell in shrill, insistent bursts.

“Alright!”

He squinted as light erupted, framing her blurred outline through the glass.

Miranda peered back at him, her face pressed against the frosted pane.

“Do you know what time it is?” she opened the door a degree, and instinctively he strained to see where the frayed silk dressing gown ended and her thigh began. “I wasn’t sure if you were serious about coming over, when you rang.”

“Well, here I am,” he waited awkwardly, leaning against the door, matching her resistance. Then, as if he’d finally decided what he really wanted to happen, he pushed a little more until he felt her hand relent and the door swung in.

“Lock up, will you?” she walked off to the bedroom without looking back.

He brushed against the coat hooks; there was a man’s jacket there. He slammed the door and flicked the switch. The only light now was the pink glow at the end of the hall.

“I see you’ve had a visitor,” he called out from the shadow, tasting the venom of his thoughts.

“It’s my brother’s — Terry left it here. Jesus, still as paranoid as ever! Now get your arse in here; I’ve got stuff to do tomorrow morning.”

He slipped off his shoes. “What’s Terry up to these days?” His voice wavered, caught between relief and shame. She was right, still the same demons; if anything, he was worse since Christine. Something else to blame her for.

Miranda was still undressing in the bedroom. He pressed up close behind her, watched her smile and tried to fathom that look as he spread his fingers across her breasts. He touched his lips to her neck, traced a circle of kisses behind her ear. She smelt of expensive soap and perfume.

What sort of a person wears perfume on the strength of a phone call? The same kind who turns up at one-thirty in the morning, with nothing but a

hard-on.

“You could’ve shaved.”

He sighed, no arguments tonight. Besides, actions spoke louder than words. His hand travelled down between her thighs. Miranda gasped and pushed her buttocks against his groin. She leaned back, draping over him and her hair fell across his face. He studied their reflection: it looked like a still from a low-budget porn flick.

She laughed as she turned to face him and he was startled by a momentary wave of contempt. This was so easy for her. ‘Sex is sex,’ she’d said in the past. ‘Don’t confuse it with something more complicated.’

He discarded his clothes methodically, and joined her on the bed. He wondered how much activity the bed had seen since he’d last been there. Then he reached for the lamp and snapped it off, shutting out his thoughts.

He was greedy for her, eager to wrap himself in desire. But he wanted her to want him, really yearn for him; he needed that tonight. He tasted her skin, ingested the perfume’s acrid undercurrent and let his tongue travel the length of her body, slowly and tentatively, as if it was a forbidden journey. Soon they moved together rhythmically as only familiar lovers can. Yet the closer they became the more he felt like an outsider.

“You’re hurting my arms.”

He relaxed his grip, jarred back into the moment. He was rough with her, knew that he wanted a reaction. A sudden image of Christine and Peterson, together, rose up to taunt him and he pushed hard into Miranda as if he could drive away his demons. He heard her breathing change and synchronised his body to hers, matching the frenzied thrusts to the rhythmic rocking of her hips.

“Not yet,” he heard her whisper breathlessly, as she arched her back.

His mind detached itself from the scene; he became a voyeur while instinct took the lead. And then, when he felt her whole body meld around his and her low moans built to fever pitch, he tilted upwards and burst inside her.

They remained still, a tide of release and tenderness washing between them, until he slumped on top of her with a heavy sigh. She held him close and he lay there, still panting, his dry lips savouring the sweat on her breast. He felt a tear forming in his eye and lay motionless, as if he could deny its existence.

“That was epic!” she congratulated him, stroking his hair affectionately.

He knew she’d expect some salacious compliment in return, but he wasn’t in the mood tonight.

“Would you rather have been somewhere else?” she read him like a book.

“Sorry,” he conceded and untangled himself from her.

“Is it still about Christine — do you wanna talk about it?”

He rolled carefully on to one side and traced Miranda’s face in the dark — that knowing, beautiful face. Then he kissed her; a long, tender kiss, as if to pour himself into her lips and escape his own identity. A lesser man would have called it love. But it was more than that. “I’ll tell you in the morning,” he promised, pulling her towards him as he closed his eyes.

Chapter 26

Thomas yawned in the gloom. He stared, bleary eyed, trying to make sense of his watch without disturbing the thick curtains. It was either five to eight or twenty to eleven. He leaned across and stroked behind her ear, certain that Miranda was awake and ignoring him.

She wriggled free from his fingers. “Listen, any chance you could drop me off at the club on your way into work? I left my car there last night and I’m picking Terry up from the airport today. I can give him his coat back too, if you like?”

“Very droll. Just take my car — I’m calling in a sickie.”

“Wow. Hold the front page. Do you wanna come with me, then?”

“Nah, I’ll just hang around here for a bit and meet you later at the club.”

She paused, as if in mid-thought. “Well, lock up after you and no going through my underwear drawer when I’m gone.”

“You know me so well.”

“Indeed I do, Mr Bladen. Speaking of which, what brought you to my door last night — welcome as it was.” She slipped out from the duvet and into a dressing gown. “Something about Christine wasn’t it?”

She knew bloody well it was. He sighed and tapped at the bedside table with his index finger.

“If that’s Morse code, I never went to Spy School.” She was still smiling.

“Christine’s involved with this married bloke; and he’s bad news.”

“Brave Sir Knight to the rescue?” she raised an eyebrow.

“Not quite.”

“Can’t Karl help you out?”

He felt her studying his face. He shook his head.

“Lovers’ tiff?”

“Something like that,” he braced himself for some righteous piss-taking, but it never came. That was Miranda, full of surprises.

“Well, I’m here if you need an ear. And don’t forget,” she gazed in the general direction of his groin, “I keep all your secrets.”

He waited until Miranda was in the shower before ringing in. Christine's office phone was diverted to her mobile. She sounded relieved; it was a short call. Karl had been spot-on — a little breathing space would do everyone a favour. After he'd rung off, he tried the bathroom door — locked. He felt peeved; no reason to be but there it was.

* * *

Sir Peter Carroll took the call in his limo. "I've seen the picture — it's definitely our man. Yes, indeed, very delicate. I'm certainly not aware of any affiliations. No, Yorgi, best you remain where you are — I'll handle things from here."

The call ended. Trevor, the driver, glanced up in the mirror and read his employer's mood well enough to say nothing. Another number was dialled.

"Nicholas, I have an opportunity for you to redeem yourself. I want you to supervise a collection — Thomas Bladen." Sir Peter could almost hear Nicholas salivating over the phone.

"Thank you, Sir Peter, we'll pick him up before he gets to Harwich."

"Excellent. I'm relying on you Nicholas — don't let me down again."

* * *

Miranda waited patiently at the lights, studying the pedestrians as they herded past the front of the car. Ever since Thomas had come out of the spy closet, she'd practised extra vigilance. Still, with a family background like hers, she was pretty vigilant anyway, especially where men were concerned. As a teenager, having boyfriends had been a dangerous pastime — for them. Back then, secret assignments and sneaking about were second nature. If anything, Thomas's cloak-and-dagger act had brought on a touch of nostalgia.

A young mother pushed a stroller out just as the lights started to change. Miranda sat, primed, ready to flip the finger behind her if anyone dared beep. Mother and child; it made you think. Her biological clock wasn't even building up to a tick, but that hadn't always been the way. Once . . . well, one day when she'd come to terms with what might have been, she'd give it all some thought.

The second the mother reached the kerb, Miranda put her foot down, narrowly beating the change back to amber. She stole a final glance in the

mirror then powered through the traffic. Eager for distraction, she flicked on the radio and re-tuned it to something closer to the last twenty years.

The green Peugeot she'd kept tabs on had been two cars back for a good five minutes now. Probably nothing in it, but she pulled in and watched as it passed without slowing down. Better safe than sorry. Back when Dad was first under suspicion, when he was being fitted up, the Wright family had sat down together and drawn up a set of rules.

Simple stuff: mistrust everyone; say nothing; if at all concerned, go to a public place — preferably with lots of CCTV and people. Thomas had said similar things that morning, like an echo of her dad. Although he did play poker better.

* * *

Nicholas arrived promptly at Great Portland Street. He'd prepared a briefing, but it was very clear, from the moment he opened the conference room door and laid eyes on them, that he was more passenger than leader. No round of introductions here. Everyone knew their place — and their distance.

"Shall we?" he headed for the stairs, crossing his fingers that they followed him. He took the front passenger seat in the people carrier and said nothing until they were on the move. The GPS tracker showed that the car was southbound, corresponding to the map onscreen. His job, he now realised, was to relay the data and coordinate the team. So why was the blue dot travelling further and further away from Harwich?

He considered ringing Sir Peter to check. No, he could manage things. Besides, how hard could it be to pick up one SSU man? He touched lightly at his cheek and felt the last vestige of bruising from where he'd taken a beating in Thomas Bladen's flat. He blushed at the memory of waking up in the undergrowth of a roundabout, stripped to his underwear. Shameful, but he'd weathered that storm. Whereas his accomplice had never been seen again. "Get a move on; I think he's giving us the run around."

The driver obeyed him and he felt his silent companions behind him twitch to attention. "I'm Nicholas, if you didn't already know." Now he was in his stride, captain of the team.

"Alice."

He looked round at her and stared, as if to say ‘really’? She didn’t flinch. Alice, it was then. Jack declared himself, but the driver — a much older man — said nothing. No matter, Nicholas was used to dealing with servants. No one ventured any further information, which didn’t surprise him. Scratch the surface of most departments and the protocol was the same.

They were making progress against the target vehicle and it didn’t take a science degree to pinpoint the destination: Gatwick. They still had the element of surprise and the advantage of numbers, if it came to that. So what was Bladen up to? Sir Peter evidently didn’t know; this could be the coup he’d been looking for.

He swapped hands with the tracker unit and felt the clamminess between his palms. “Good luck everyone; we’re nearly there.” He saw Jack and Alice share a glance of disdain — so much the better. He wasn’t there to be liked; he had a job to do. The numbers on screen whittled down as they approached the short stay car park. He already had the number plate and gestured as he saw the vehicle parking up; gestured because he was too wired to speak.

* * *

A people carrier with blacked-out windows drew in front of Miranda’s car. She heard the doors as she delved into her handbag for her mobile to ring Thomas and let him know she’d arrived. As she rifled through her things, she ran through a shortlist of opening lines and settled on: ‘Are you still inside?’

Before she could dial, her driver’s door opened. She turned to see a youngish man in an expensive suit. “Yeah, what do you want?”

He looked lost for an answer. She reached over to pull the handle in, but the light began to fade. Behind her, someone was blocking the passenger door. Panic time.

Posh Bloke had stepped back, allowing a woman to crank the door wider and start pulling on her arm. “Where is he?”

As Miranda felt herself being dragged out of the car, she went limp to conserve her strength. Then she grabbed the edge of her seat and pulled herself down towards the gear-stick. As soon as she was close enough, she kicked hard against the passenger window, right at the chink in the pane

that Thomas had never got round to fixing, driving her boot heel into the glass with a roar. The window splintered on the third kick; a pity that light block had the sense to move in time. Now she rolled on to her stomach and let the woman pull her out, waiting until she was past the steering wheel to swing, left-handed. Not her finest work, but three years of kickboxing — and running a bar — did the job.

“Wait!” Posh Bloke held up his hand, like a teacher intervening in a playground brawl. “We’re here to help you. Thomas sent us. He’s in trouble.”

Miranda ceased struggling and the woman let go. They ushered her into the people carrier. If this was the cavalry, they had a funny way of showing it. As everyone climbed aboard, she copped the driver sending a text. No one else seemed to have noticed.

“What about my car?”

Posh Bloke seemed subdued again. “It’ll be taken care of.”

Next question. “Is someone going to tell me what’s going on?”

Either they were stonewalling her or something was amiss here. Eyes darted back and forth, but nobody answered. Posh Bloke seemed to be the one in charge; she’d have to work on him. She played the game of pluses and minuses in her head, as much to organise her thoughts as to try and stay calm. Pluses: they hadn’t hurt her, they’d mentioned Thomas and they didn’t seem like hardened criminals — and she knew what *they* looked like. Minuses: Thomas must have sent them to her and she didn’t know what the deal was.

Nobody spoke to her as the people carrier sped clockwise around the M25. She wasn’t bothered; she had plenty to think about. How did they know how to find her, especially as she’d been driving Thomas’s car? A shame about the window though — she’d better let Thomas know she was safe. “I need to make a phone call.”

“Later.”

Well, that was brief and to the point. She toyed with the idea of just opening her mobile, but something told her to stay submissive and bide her time. The woman beside her winced as she practiced opening and closing her eye. Yeah, as Sheryl at the club would say, in her native Brooklynese: ‘suck it up.’

Eyeball — no one had introduced themselves, bar the merest sniff of an ID card, so she had given them her name — Eyeball's face changed. She seemed more focused and detached. Miranda almost felt bad for punching her — sisterhood and all that.

“How well do you know Thomas Bladen?”

Miranda smiled inwardly. Outwardly she stayed as blank as a new canvas. All Thomas's paranoia was finally bearing fruit. “We go way back.”

“And what do you know about his work?”

This was like painting by numbers. “He's a government photographer — and he delivers packages.” *Too much information maybe?* She glanced ahead and read the A road as they turned off. Eyeball leaned over and touched her leg.

“I know this must all seem strange to you.”

That was a first; good cop and bad cop all rolled together, making: average cop. Miranda nodded and bit at her fingernail. Dad had said he used to do that in police interrogations, to accompany whatever crap he was feeding them.

Eyeball continued. “It's just a precaution, you understand. Thomas's cover is at risk and he wanted you kept safe until we have things under control.”

Miranda dug her nail hard into her hand, to stifle a response. They were lying, and badly. Firstly, Thomas didn't have any cover. Secondly, he was *intensely* private, so how would they know about her? And thirdly, if Thomas had been in any kind of trouble, he'd have contacted the family first.

But here she was, in the company of strangers, and he did have that bandage on his arm the previous night, so something didn't sit right. “Does Thomas know I'm with you?”

Eyeball swallowed and took a breath then swapped glances with Posh Bloke. “We'll contact him once you're at a secure location.”

Miranda narrowed her gaze and dug her nail into her palm again: jackpot. She sat back and took stock; she was sandwiched between two of them — no chance of getting out. Best play the dumb blonde for now and try and hold it together. “Yeah, that makes sense. Do you think I could just leave him a message? Only I was supposed to feed the dog later and he might worry if he gets back and Butch . . .”

Eyeball leaned forward and Posh Bloke mumbled approval. “Alright, but keep it short — you can use my mobile.” Eyeball opened her phone, punched in the digits from a piece of paper and passed the phone over.

It went straight to his office voicemail. “Hi Tom, it’s Miranda. Erm, something’s come up so you’ll have to sort Butch out yourself today. Sorry.” She returned the phone with a smile; it was up to him now.

Eyeball gave her a funny look. “I need your handbag, as a precaution.”

The silent wonder on her left wriggled in his seat; no, he squirmed. Even he didn’t fall for that line.

“Okay,” Miranda handed her bag over.

Posh Bloke signalled to the driver and they pulled in at the next lay-by. He seemed quietly agitated. When they stopped he got out, walked a few yards ahead and got on his mobile. Whatever he was saying, he didn’t look happy.

Eyeball leaned in close again. “We need to find Thomas urgently — do you know where he is, Miranda?”

“He wasn’t working today so he lent me his car.” Then she thought of something else. Oh bollocks, Terry would be waiting at the airport.

Eyeball seemed satisfied with the explanation, unlike the Silent Wonder. From the look on his face, he had less of a clue than she did.

After five minutes or so, Posh Bloke stormed back to the vehicle. His face was a picture — a portrait depicting ‘pissed off.’

“We’re to go here,” he announced to the driver, passing him a note. The driver seemed unperturbed, switching on classical music as he rejoined the traffic. Posh Bloke said nothing more, but his face spoke volumes.

Chapter 27

“Anything I can get you, Thomas?”

If Sheryl leaned any further over the bar, her breasts would tumble out to greet him. “That’s okay,” he flustered.

Caliban’s was practically empty. He felt like a teenager on a blind date, trying not to look conspicuous as he watched the minute hand inch its way round for the umpteenth time. He thought about ringing Miranda, but she’d probably be driving. He turned the mobile over and pretended he was fiddling with the casing instead.

“Wanna shoot some pool?”

“Sure,” he’d never sounded less sure of anything in his life.

“Relax, Thomas. I don’t bite.”

No, he thought as he followed her, but you do look capable of nibbling.

“You and Miranda go way back, don’t you?”

He smiled; that was the phrase they always used.

“So how come you two never quite got it together?”

He made a dumb face in the absence of a convincing explanation, and racked up the balls. The first two games went to Sheryl with ease — he barely got a look in. He turned the third game around and somehow snuck in the black, more by luck than judgement.

Sometimes when she looked at him, he wanted to ask her things — about Miranda, about herself; about why a girl from Brooklyn should wind up managing a bar in East London. But he let it go, same as always. For a while, he kidded himself that he was capable of winning, but Sheryl’s soon shattered any lasting illusions.

“Did you grow up in a Pool Hall?”

“Pretty much! You’re not too bad though.”

He chose to take it as a compliment. As he bent down to take a shot, his mobile trilled into life — it was Karl.

“Thomas, are you free to talk? It’s *urgent*.”

“Sure,” He felt the blood run cold up his neck. He shouldered the phone and moved to the main bar for better reception.

“Where have you been today?”

“Nowhere. I was out last night and I’m at Caliban’s now.”

“Tommo, your car’s been picked up at Gatwick airport. There’s damage to one of the windows, keys still in the ignition. Were you there?” It sounded like an accusation.

“No, I lent the car to . . . to a friend.”

The line went silent. “Stay right where you are and I’ll come get you.”

The room seemed to spin; he grabbed at a chair and it shrieked. Sheryl rushed over and the shock on his face reflected on hers. He sat down before his legs buckled under him.

Sheryl quickly rejoined him with two whiskies. “Talk to me.”

He shook his head.

“Is it Miranda?”

“They found my car . . . abandoned . . .”

Sheryl put a hand to her mouth. “I’ll ring Diane.”

“No!” he barked. “Let me take care of this. Karl’s on his way.” He downed most of the whisky in one go and felt the bile swirling inside him. Sheryl looked at him, as if she could see the turmoil inside. He realised that he didn’t even know what to tell her.

They sat, huddled together like victims in a lifeboat, neither one speaking. When he wavered and felt he was on the verge of tears, he pressed into his wound, choosing pain over emotion. Sheryl’s eyes were brimming; she just stared at him, silently, searching for something to cling on to.

* * *

Karl burst through the door. He pulled the chair back and hoisted Thomas to his feet. “Come on, we have to deal with this.”

Sheryl looked up at him and Karl laid a consoling hand on her shoulder. She stared back at Thomas, wide-eyed, in disbelief.

“I’ll be back later — I promise.

He shuffled to the car in a daze, Karl’s hand at his back. Karl didn’t speak until they were on the main road. “I’m sorry, Thomas; it doesn’t look good. Your nearside window was broken — from the inside.”

“Miranda had the car.”

Karl didn’t press him on it. “How much does she know?”

“Just the basics — and she knows about Christine.” It felt easier to talk when Karl was asking the questions.

“What about her?”

“I went over to Christine’s last night, to confront her about Bob Peterson. She warned me off, said it was my last chance.”

“Oh Jesus, Thomas. You couldn’t leave it alone, could you?”

In the silence that followed, Thomas’s psyche began to regroup. “How did you find my car?”

Karl upped the speed. “That’s not important now. I checked your office voicemail today — I always check it.”

Thomas shot him a glance.

“Miranda left you a message about dealing with Butch.”

He felt his mind shift a gear. Butch: Miranda was in some kind of trouble.

“The thing is, when I checked a little later, someone had deleted the message. I reckon someone doesn’t want you to hear from her.”

Thomas pushed his hands together, prayer fashion, and touched the index fingers to his lower lip. “You’ve got to tell me how to fix this.”

“I’ll do everything I can, Tommo, you know that. First, we’re gonna pick your car up and get the window fixed. Tomorrow, when you go in to work, nothing has happened. Got it? If these bastards want anything, they’ll be in touch.”

Thomas nodded slowly as if punch drunk. “Did someone follow her?”

“They didn’t need to. Somebody put a tracker on the car. I suggest we leave it there. So if you need to go anywhere private, you take a cab from now on.”

Thomas covered his face with his hands, blotting away the tears.

“I don’t know if I can do this, Karl. I don’t think I’m strong enough.”

“You have to be, Thomas; you’ve no choice.”

He closed his eyes and tried to sleep, but Karl’s supernatural silence only amplified his thoughts. Why would someone take Miranda? And what the hell was he going to do about it? He lashed out and punched the glove compartment, jolting himself into some sort of clarity. “Unless they’d been planning this . . .”

Karl still said nothing.

He looked around, aware he'd just said the unthinkable. Who the fuck were *they*? No, wait, he was on to something; or maybe he just wanted to believe that. He put his hands together again and rocked back and forth. "I've only done two things that would make . . ." his voice cracked. "Two things. I contacted Christine and I helped Petrov get away from Yorgi." As he said Yorgi's name, he felt sick to his stomach, as if his intuition had suddenly whispered yes. "For Christ's sake, say something, Karl."

Silence again, apart from the pounding in his head. He looked around and saw the signs for Reading. Well, bollocks to it, he'd had enough. "Stop the car, I want to get out," he already had his fingers on the handle.

"Tommo, just relax, we'll be there soon . . ."

"I said, stop the fucking car. Now!"

Karl pulled hard left and crushed the brake, screeching the car to a lopsided halt. "Listen to me; we have to do this by the numbers. I know you're scared right now, but so far there's no indication . . ."

Thomas raised a chopping hand to interrupt.

"That's enough!" Karl roared at him.

He fell back to his seat, defeated.

"Look, Tommo, I've dealt with this shit before; I grew up with this kind of coercion. When they want something, they'll be in touch. Until then, we sit tight."

He let go of the door and the car resumed its journey, snaking its way to an industrial estate on the outskirts of Reading. As they approached a set of nondescript units, Thomas recognised his car coming off a flatbed trailer to a waiting team of overalls.

"We'll give them half an hour — come on, let's take a wee walk."

Thomas looked through the glass; it felt safe in Karl's car. Somehow, if he went outside, he'd be accepting all this. Karl walked around to the passenger door and waited.

* * *

The pungent stench of rubbish and diesel couldn't disguise the chill in the air. Thomas rubbed his arm self-consciously as they walked. Karl still wasn't saying much and as for Thomas, he didn't dare open his mouth for fear of screaming.

Karl's destination soon became clear, as the white, mud-spattered caravan gradually got closer. "You need to eat something," he insisted, pointing to the bargain garden furniture.

Thomas flopped into the chair and pressed his fingers hard against the plastic's rough edges. He looked over at the counter; exactly how did his *best buddy* fit into all this?

Karl brought over a couple of teas and enough sugar to fell a racehorse. "Get it down yer. Burgers are on the way."

Thomas didn't protest. He hugged the polystyrene cup and tried to reason out his options. He didn't know where Miranda was or who had taken her. Okay, he had suspicions about this Yorgi, but that's all they were. The sound of nearby traffic lulled him into some kind of mental pause. She hadn't screamed, 'Come and get me,' on her phone message — according to Karl anyway. No, she'd mentioned 'Butch' instead: private code for dodgy dealing. And the car window was a smart move, but what did it mean? Had she'd been taken against her will, yet still somehow able to make the call?

Two plates clattered down on to the table. Thomas opened his eyes; bloody stupid — polystyrene cups, but proper plates. At first sight, the burgers churned his stomach, and then hunger took over as his instincts kicked in.

"Okay," Karl bit into his burger savagely; "you take the car to work tomorrow. And if anyone treats you differently, it's a fair bet they're involved."

"And then what?"

Karl chewed on a piece of burger that was putting up a fight. "Then we get a better idea of who we're up against."

Thomas tilted the bap away so that the fatty juices didn't run into his mouth.

"Come on, Thomas, think about it. Miranda left a message for you on your office phone. Nigh on two years, we've worked in the same office, and have you ever taken a personal call there? No, because neither she nor anyone else has your number; am I right?"

He nodded; he was already putting together a shortlist in his head of anyone he'd encountered since he'd joined the SSU. And while it didn't exactly give him hope, it gave him a focus.

The burger was sliding down nicely. He felt more grounded, more settled, confident enough to take a chance. “Karl, I need to ask you something,” he kept his voice low and his gaze down. *Here goes* — “And if I don’t get the truth, I’ll go to the police.”

It was a terrible bluff, so shit that Miranda’s dad would have spotted it at a poker table. But he was desperate and it might, just might, rattle Karl a bit.

Karl took a long sip of tea. Thomas took the silence as consent to continue. “Is Miranda’s disappearance connected to the missing information you’re after?”

Karl inclined his head.

“Jesus, Karl!” he erupted, overbalancing the chair behind him as he stood. He was a dozen steps away when he heard Karl scrabbling behind him.

“Wait up, Tommo, please.” Karl drew level and laid a hand on him, shifting his eyes about like a guilty schoolboy. “Look, I honestly don’t believe Miranda is in any immediate danger. And what I’m about to tell you, well, you wouldn’t have believed me before now.”

“I’m listening,” Thomas conceded, and carried on walking back to his car, with Karl trailing alongside.

“I don’t know how well you know your European history, but the ending of World War Two was a messy one.”

Thomas laughed spontaneously, surprising himself.

“Anyways, after the boys finally put their toys away and buried their copious dead, the key players decided that steps had to be taken to avoid making it a hat-trick of stupidity.”

Thomas stopped in his tracks.

“Now, whatever you think of the European Union’s track record, the wars have at least been kept regional. It doesn’t take a rocket scientist to see that a few years down the line, a United States of Europe is a real possibility.”

“And the point of this bollocks?” Thomas felt his fist tightening again.

“Some people aren’t willing to wait a few years; important and influential people with something to gain, throughout Europe and beyond. That’s the kind of information I’ve been looking for.”

Chapter 28

The technician greeted Thomas and showed off her handiwork on the side window. “Good as new,” she joked, as if she’d just done him a favour. He let it slide and collected his keys.

Karl tailed him back to a service station off the M25. When Thomas came out from the gents, Karl was kneeling by his car at the driver’s side. He didn’t seem at all embarrassed to be caught in the act.

“I was just checking the tracker on your car — it’s still active. Remember, anywhere you don’t want people to know about, use alternative transport.”

Thomas joined him by the wheel, determined not to comment on the gizmo Karl had in his hand.

“I need you to trust me, Tommo,” Karl whispered, close enough that Thomas could see the fret lines in his face. “Don’t go off doing anything stupid. And don’t forget, we’re talking to Petrov after work tomorrow, so get a good night’s sleep.”

Yeah, that was Karl: the wellspring of compassion. Thomas opened the driver’s door, nudging Karl out of the way. “And what do I tell Miranda’s family? Her brother’s already messaged me asking why she wasn’t at the airport.”

Karl shoved his hands in his pockets. “I’d, er, appreciate it if you stalled them for a while. A missing person report will only complicate things.”

“Yeah, but for who?”

“For all of us, Tommo. We all want the same thing,” he faced him. “Miranda safely home and the people who did this held accountable.”

He paled at the thought of lying to Miranda’s family. That was a complete no-no. But the alternative was equally unthinkable. So he made a pact with the devil. “Three days, Karl — tops. And understand this: I may not have your connections, but if word hasn’t reached me that Miranda’s safe . . .” he couldn’t finish the sentence because that sickening feeling rushed up to gnaw at his guts again.

Thomas sat in the lay-by and stared at his mobile. The car rocked as another juggernaut thundered past. As he switched the phone on with one hand, he was wiping away tears with the other. The most precious thing he had with the Wrights was trust and now he was destroying that. For a greater good perhaps, but it was still a betrayal. As the phone dialled out, he wondered, if he could do this, then what else was he capable of?

Judas time. “Terry? Hi, yeah, sorry mate, I’ve been really busy at work. Ah, mate, total balls-up. Miranda had to go out of town, short notice . . .” the monologue went on, each line more forced and implausible than the last. Maybe Terry would just assume they’d had a huge fight, and Miranda had swanned off to the coast, like she’d done before. All he could do was act vague and leave Terry to join the dots for himself.

Terry seemed to accept everything he said; it was like taking a sick dog to the vet’s on that long, final walk. When the deed was done, he needed a drink. And where better than Caliban’s, where he could pimp the remainder of his soul by persuading Sheryl to back up his story.

He’d barely stepped through the door before Sheryl called him over. “Let’s go through,” she raided the scotch optic with two glasses on her way up to the office. The barmaid smiled at him; nothing seemed out of place as he passed. But he still felt like a condemned man.

Sheryl closed the door. “Have you found her?” she thrust a drink into his hand as if it was some kind of truth serum.

He shook his head.

“So what the *fuck* have you been doing since you left here?”

He let her anger run its course. She had a right; and yes, Miranda deserved better — far better than him. And something told him that when it came down to it, when Karl and all the monsters had finished playing their games, it would be left to him to pick up the pieces. So he cut the crap and told her straight; about Terry, about how he’d lied to buy Karl and him a little more time. And he pleaded with her to just let things lie for three more days.

Sheryl took a last gulp of scotch and set her glass down. Her hand trembled a little, but she raised her head to look him in the eyes, slowly and deliberately. “If anything happens to Miranda, you’re a dead man.”

He chose to take that as agreement to his request and started to reach out to her hand, then thought better of it.

“Is this to do with that Irish guy — the one you had a showdown with?”

There it was again, that uncharted territory: to trust or not to trust. “Sheryl, don’t take this the wrong way, but I can’t talk about it with you.”

She swooped for his glass. “Hey, the only reason I’m even listening to you now is because I know that’s what Miranda would want. If it was down to me I’d make a couple of phone calls and . . .” she blinked twice slowly, “. . . well, I’m sure you can figure it out.”

On the drive home, he added Sheryl to his mental list of people to keep at a distance; hard to do when he’d promised to ring her mobile, twice a day — without fail.

* * *

Back at the flat, there were no messages — too much to hope for. He took the Leeds photograph of Miranda off the wall and propped it on the table. Just sitting there, he could hear her laughter merging with the sound of traffic, the scene ablaze with sunlight and the promise of happy ever after.

The oven pinged and he returned to the present with a thud. Only now did he remember that he’d put a cottage pie on. He took another shot of Southern Comfort to dry his tears.

He fired up his laptop and ate beside it, going through his usual anonymity server for untraceable web surfing. It wasn’t hard to get lucky on the conspiracy sites; everything and everyone had an opinion, and by Christ they were going to share it with you. After twenty minutes of being distracted by 9/11 theories he set about his search in earnest, following trails that led to the Bilderberg Group and the New Holy Roman Empire.

After that jaunt to La-La Land he narrowed his quest to historical documents relating to Europe from 1945 onwards. What he wanted were facts, and they seemed thin on the ground. Finally, he located a 1946 speech given by Winston Churchill, in Zurich. There, in black and white, was the phrase ‘United States of Europe,’ along with the proposal to first set up a Council of Europe. Maybe Karl was on to something after all.

Chapter 29

The mobile went off at 6.30 am. Thomas spasmed awake from a nightmare and made a wild grab for the phone.

It was Karl, with nothing to report. He repeated the need for a veil of normality and reminded him about seeing Petrov after work: he was business-like, and, in a way, Thomas drew strength from that. If Karl was used to dealing with situations like this, then maybe everything would turn out okay.

Now wide awake, he showered and dressed, stared at Miranda's photo for longer than was healthy, and then was out the door. The seven-fifteen traffic offered little resistance — so much the better for the two-hour slog to Harwich. Perhaps someday they'd get a surveillance gig in Chingford. He noticed that the radio had been retuned — it was obvious who'd done it — and he couldn't bring himself to change it back.

Desperation was a strange thing; he'd learned that from his mum when his gran was dying. When you're trying to negotiate with the Man in the Sky, you'll offer up just about anything. So, by the time the first sign to Harwich had appeared, he'd resolved to cherish Miranda on her safe return, the way he'd always meant to. In the last chance saloon of life, he was still asking for one for the road.

* * *

Miranda liked to sleep in; that whole 'up before the dawn' insanity was Thomas's thing. Unless it was for bedroom athletics, she'd always opt for easing herself into the morning. Today was different though. It wasn't every day you found yourself the honoured guest at a bona fide cloak-and-dagger convention.

She'd turned in early the night before and now it was some God-awful time, and here she was, sat up in bed wide awake and thinking about Thomas. Okay, so they'd bullshitted her about being sent by him, but that didn't mean he wasn't in trouble. She went back over the previous day's events again, to fix them clearly in her mind. The same things stood out — the driver stashing his mobile as they got in the car and Posh Bloke losing his rag in the lay-by. And repetitive questions about not much in particular.

Conclusion: either something was wrong or they were really shit at this. Or both.

The night before, she'd asked how long her stay was likely to be and all she'd got back was a few nervous glances. She smirked now as she pressed her back against the pillows — maybe the answer was classified. She'd get some sense out of them today. The woman, Eyeball, seemed like the best candidate for new friend.

She slithered out of bed and threw on an oversized dressing gown — blue towelling, not very chic. No harm in having an early morning wander, maybe watch a little satellite TV. She turned the door handle with infinite care — no sense in disturbing anyone else. As soon as the door clicked she heard scuffling in the corridor and caught the last moment of Eyeball launching from a chair.

“Good morning,” Miranda opted for friendliness first. Eyeball — and that eye certainly shone today — nodded blearily; she looked as if she had spent the entire night on the chair. That was a worry. Miranda ambled over, smiling like she was back on a Bermuda fashion shoot, and made a mental note to check if the windows were locked.

“Would you like some breakfast?” Eyeball said it like she meant it.

“That'd be great,” Miranda retraced her way to the kitchen.

Eyeball tagged along like the less attractive one on a double date. Miranda filled the kettle and tried the thing that usually worked on men — Thomas being a rare exception: keep them focused on one topic then switch channel suddenly to get a straight answer.

“If I'm staying tonight I'll need more clothes . . .” she stopped there, hoping Eyeball would suggest that she pop home to fill up a suitcase or an overnight bag. No dice.

Instead, Eyeball asked for her sizes and promised fresh clothes, later that morning. They sat together at the breakfast bar, drinking tea and eating toast, like the new girls at boarding school. Eyeball must have been bottom of the pile, she reasoned. Because, let's face it, you don't get the top brass strapping their arse to a chair for the night.

A till receipt was still on the work surface — Miranda clocked yesterday's date before Eyeball tidied it away. *Okay then, back to Project Best Friend.* “Look, I feel really bad about your eye, er . . .”

Eyeball glanced at the open door and replied, “It's Alice.”

Alice Eyeball, it was then. “Alice, I don’t suppose there’s a gym around here? I could do with working off last night’s curry.”

A bloody takeaway — hardly James Bond. Useful though, Miranda recalled, as Alice rinsed the cups. The round-trip for the pick-up was about forty-five minutes so they couldn’t be that far from civilisation. The trouble with country lanes was that they all looked the same. With all the excitement the previous day, after leaving the M25 the rest was a bit of a blur. Unless they’d dropped something in her curry.

She told Alice that she ran a pub, which seemed to rattle her a bit. Probably because it meant another closely supervised phone call. She smiled again, remembering the one from last night. Ringing home was a tricky one. A calculated risk as Mum could have blown it, but she was brilliant.

‘Okay Miranda, thanks for phoning. Did you want Butch taken care of while you’re away, or is Thomas looking after him?’ Even the way she had told Miranda: ‘Take care and I’ll see you soon.’ It still sent a shiver of delight up and down her spine. Mum was on the case.

* * *

Thomas looked out across Harwich and tried to concentrate. Just him and the gulls, not so different from the day Bob Peterson appeared. What if he’d been less attentive that day? What if the shooting and Peterson had been all someone else’s problem — Karl’s, for instance? What if . . . and then a flashbulb went off in his brain, illuminating what was already there.

The door opened downstairs, shortly followed by the strains of ‘When Irish Eyes Are Smiling.’ Karl huffed and puffed up the stairs, depositing his cases on a table with his usual lack of care. “Grab hold of these sandwiches while I do a sweep of the premises.”

Thomas watched as Karl went to work, checking for other people’s devices: surveillance on the surveillers. Karl worked quickly and methodically around Thomas, as he stood in the centre of the room, sandwiches in hand. Finally, Karl pronounced, “Clear!” with a dramatic flourish.

The morning soon filled up, with tracking shots of Her Majesty’s Customs and Excise at work in a busy British port. Thomas even fitted in a

couple of brooding skylines. But whenever he stole a glance at his companion, Karl was looking right at him.

"It's alright, I'm not about to crumble into pieces." *Not in front of you, anyway.*

"I know that, Tommo. No news, I take it?"

"Shouldn't that be my line?"

Karl shrugged with just his face. "Investigations are continuing. And just so you know, as soon as we get what we want from Petrov, we're shipping the family far away."

Like that was supposed to make him feel any better? Before Thomas could respond, the walkie-talkie crackled.

Karl made a face approximating 'intrigued' and nodded to whatever was being said. "Thanks Ann, out."

Thomas furrowed his brow and Karl was immediately on the defensive. "What? Can't I extend a little professional courtesy to my esteemed colleague?"

Thomas shook his head in mock disgust. Clearly, somewhere along the line, they'd had words and put their childish spat to rest.

"Anyways, she was letting us know that Christine will be on-site shortly." Karl sat bolt upright, like he'd been stung in the arse. "Hey, shift; get your lens on the staff compound. Let's see if she so much as twitches at your car."

Brilliant. He and Karl took up position, two cats after the same canary. Christine Gerrard's Mercedes glided up to the compound gate. She flashed her ID at the attendant — who looked like he couldn't give a shit — and veered left where there were still spaces. Thomas's heart was racing; unless she was planning to vault the fence she'd have to walk back past his car. If she even coughed beside his replacement window he'd have his first genuine lead.

Come on, come on; out you get. Any second now . . . nearing the front of the car . . . He held his breath and pushed hard against the viewfinder, swallowing Christine's face. She had a faraway look about her, as if she'd rather be somewhere else. Closer . . . and . . . *nothing*. The moment passed. She crossed the bonnet and walked beyond Karl's shit-heap of a car without blinking an eyelid.

"What do you think?" Karl was still tracking her.

“I don’t think she faked that.”

“Well,” Karl looked up with a wry grin on his face; “You’d know more about that than me. Okay, she’s eliminated herself from our inquiries — for now.”

Thomas smiled back, a small crumb for Karl’s ingenuity. He liked the sound of ‘our inquiries’; it made him feel less alone.

Christine headed straight for their block. Karl made a half-hearted attempt to tidy away the remnants of breakfast and his newspaper, but as soon as he heard the door downstairs he busied himself with his camera.

She clip-clopped up the steps, clearing her throat by the doorway. Thomas turned, catching Karl out the corner of his eye following suit.

“Gentlemen, we’re downscaling our presence here — by two.”

Thomas looked over at Karl. Was downscaling even a real word?

Christine crossed the threshold. “Karl, why don’t you take a break — I’d like a private word with Thomas.”

Karl nodded gladly, as if he’d had the same idea himself. “I’ll go over to see Ann Crossley — call me there when you’re done,” he rattled a walkie-talkie.

* * *

Christine waited until they were alone. “After our last conversation, I thought we’d better have the next one face-to-face.”

Uh-oh. Suddenly she reminded him of her mother doing the ‘And what are your intentions towards our daughter?’ routine.

“I don’t know why you’re so fixated with Bob, and not that it’s any of your business, but yes, we are seeing each other on a casual basis.”

Seeing to each other, more like. But he wasn’t going to rise to the bait this time. Instead, he separated his Bermuda key ring methodically, detached the cover and applied it to his laptop’s USB port. Christine stood beside him while the software whirled and opened the folder.

“Bob Peterson was here on the day of the shooting,” he clicked on a series of folders and opened the one named Uncle Bob. As if to emphasise the obvious, he’d superimposed a black frame over Peterson’s four-by-four.

Christine stared at the screen for maybe a minute. Thomas handed her the gift of silence. She looked shaken. And if he were honest, he was savouring every second.

“Has Bob seen this?”

Thomas opened up the file marked *Uncle Bob V2.0*. “No, I filed this version with my report. But he probably realises I saw him there,” he paused, hoping that if he gave her enough space, she’d say something about Miranda or his car; a forlorn hope.

“Where is this going, Thomas? I mean, what’s brought this on?”

He stood up; they were almost toe-to-toe. “I have a friend who’s in trouble.” He stopped and looked into her eyes. “I think it’s connected with Bob.”

Her demeanour changed; she came over all Florence Nightingale and pressed his hand tenderly. “Bob’s okay, really.”

“Come on, Christine, he lied about being at the docks — in front of all of us.”

“Well . . .” she seemed to struggle for logic, “he stayed with me that week.”

“Yeah, but you’re not in the pictures. And the only day Bob turns up on site — unannounced — happens to be the same day someone is shot.”

“You’re surely not suggesting Bob was behind that?”

He pushed his hand up a little and felt hers firm against it. “No, Bob wasn’t behind it. I think I know who’s involved. But I don’t believe in coincidences.”

Christine stalled; it was as if a cloud of doubt had settled on her face. He imagined her asking herself the same question he had: was Bob the witness or the lookout?

“What kind of trouble — it’s not Karl is it?”

“No, it’s not Karl. But I can’t say any more — I don’t know who I can trust.”

“Hey,” Christine squeezed his fingers, “you know you can trust me!” She seemed to gaze at him in a way that she hadn’t done for a long time. “It’s a woman, isn’t it?”

Bollocks. “Chrissie, can you just leave it please?” He felt tears welling up and withdrew to the window, coughing to stop his voice from cracking.

She took the hint. “Alright, I’d better be going, Thomas. If you want to talk, you know where to find me. I promise I won’t say anything to Bob.”

He kept his back towards her, staying that way until he heard the door close. As soon as he composed himself, he rang Sheryl. “Hi,” he kept the

tone sombre; “no, nothing yet, but I’m a little closer to figuring out what’s going on. I’ll call you this evening. And Sheryl, thanks — you know.”

Karl sauntered back within minutes of the call. Anyone would think he’d been watching Thomas through binoculars. “So, we’re leaving Harwich soon,” Karl was trying his best to be subtle. “What did Christine drop by for?”

Thomas parked himself on a stool. “I called her at home.”

Karl’s face was blanker than usual.

“I was pissed off with you and myself, after our discussion in the hotel bar. So I took it out on Christine. I rang up and slated Bob Peterson, reminded her that he was married. Less than bright; I think he was in the flat at the time.”

“You don’t think Peterson is anything to do with . . .”

“Miranda? No, and I’m pretty sure Christine’s clean. She came here to smooth the waters. And if I really thought Bob was responsible, I wouldn’t be standing here now.”

Karl stated the obvious. “Not Christine or Uncle Bob — the list grows shorter.”

“Maybe Petrov will have some suggestions when we speak to him.”

Karl feigned disinterest, but his body language screamed ‘fuck off.’

* * *

At four o’clock on the dot, Karl was packing his equipment away, having got Ann Crossley to cover for them. “Here’s how we play this,” Karl sounded masterful. “First we drive back to your gaff because that’s where you’re supposed to be. Then you transfer to my car and we go talk to Petrov.”

Thomas brightened a little. He was in the game, though God knows what they expected him to get from Petrov. Still, anything was better than sitting in that flat alone.

He parked down by Lloyd Park, on the opposite side of the road, to avoid scraping bird shit off the roof later on. He moved his stuff into Karl’s car — quicker than taking it into the flat.

Karl welcomed him into the dry passenger seat, inviting him to check out the glove compartment. No guns this time but there was a choice of

albums. Thomas opted for something reflective — ACDC's 'Let There Be Rock,' which Karl seemed to appreciate.

Karl swung out to the North Circular, picking up the A10 north.

"What do you want me to say to Petrov?" Cut to the chase; always the best way of dealing with Karl. Even if it meant shouting over 'Whole Lotta Rosie' as it fried the speakers.

"There's no subterfuge here," Karl notched the volume down. "We need to know everything about Yorgi; where the red car was before Harwich, past haunts, anything."

Thomas nodded and twisted the volume back up. What *he* really wanted to know was whether Yorgi was capable of kidnapping Miranda. That question made him shudder.

Chapter 30

Thomas zoned out for the rest of the journey; Karl left him to it. Somewhere, between drifting off and Karl nudging him awake, he remembered Sir Peter Carroll's very first pep talk about loyalty and confidentiality.

"We're here," Karl sounded apologetic.

Thomas soon saw why. It was one of the ugliest buildings he'd ever laid eyes on. The sign at the front — next to 'cars parked illegally will be clamped' — read 'Conference Facilities.' It all looked like a very bad joke.

"It's a converted telephone exchange."

"Shame they never converted the outside — it looks like a prison."

Karl nodded. "Or a fortress."

"And Petrov's family have been living here?"

Karl waved a scolding finger. "Uh-uh. More than you need to know."

Thomas tried not to stare at the CCTV cameras. They reminded him too much of being at Caliban's.

Teresa met them at the front steps. Thomas took it as read that she already knew all about Miranda; he wasn't about to confide in her in any case. They threaded past a series of doors to one with a sign that read 'occupied.' She gestured to Thomas to go in first.

Petrov leapt up from his chair, with a look of rapture. Alexandra was there at his side and Lukas was in the corner, playing with some toys on a rug. It looked like a Social Services training film. "Tomas! It is so good to see you!"

They shook hands enthusiastically; Alexandra kissed him on the cheek. All hail the conquering hero. Teresa and the quiet one on her side of the desk seemed to relax.

"You are well, yes?"

There was a question. He swallowed and let out a breath. Then replied, "Yes, I am well," with all the enthusiasm he could conjure.

They all sat down and the silent wonder — Thomas labelled him the Handler — took orders for drinks and left the room. Teresa started recording, assuring Petrov and Alexandra that they were assisting of their

own free will and were not obliged to answer. Nonetheless, it was clear where this was going; they may as well have had a tick list.

How did Yorgi contact them? Why did he contact them? What were they doing in Europe? Where did they meet him? Where was he likely to be now? Teresa's formidable line of questioning didn't take long to put Petrov on edge. Several times he shot glances at Thomas, a searching look as if to say, 'Why are you allowing this?'

By the time they reached a comfort break — Teresa did a neat line in irony — Thomas had just about reached the end of his tether. Petrov was in danger of clamming up and that didn't suit his needs at all.

The tape was switched off; he had nothing to lose. He put his mug down and leaned across the table. "How dangerous is Yorgi?"

Teresa made a mad scramble for the 'on' button and glared at him. Tough shit.

"Very dangerous. Tomas, I tell you the truth; Yorgi fears *nothing*." Petrov sat back a little, as if to consider his own words. "Well, except snakes. One time I saw him scream at the sight of a snake on the farm and when I laughed, he nearly broke my arm."

Thomas wasn't sure how you could nearly break an arm, but then he recalled that he'd nearly been shot. Karl nudged him to carry on.

"Have you ever met anyone with Yorgi? Or maybe you spoke to them on the phone?" He almost said 'at the house' then he remembered that they didn't have a house any more

Petrov nodded. "On the phone; maybe twice. An older man — British, not foreign."

"What kind of British?" Karl pitched in. "Like me?" He sounded like he was trying to prove his own innocence.

Alexandra searched the ceiling for recall. "He was English, well-spoken; and he called from a mobile."

Thomas smiled at her. Less use than nothing, but it was a step in the right direction. "Why would Yorgi still want you — want to see you, I mean? You told me before, that you sometimes didn't hear from him for months."

Petrov and Alexandra shared a none-too-subtle glance and neither responded.

Thomas took a sip of tea, felt the warm liquid swirl around his mouth yet still leave it parched. He knew he would have to be quick and concise before they bundled him out of the room. He felt a cold numbness at the base of his skull, spreading down his body. There was only one question he was interested in now.

He turned his head away slightly, certain that if Karl saw his face clearly he'd spot something was amiss. He cleared his throat and took in a great gulp of air. "I think Yorgi may be holding a hostage, someone important to me . . ."

Alexandra covered her face. Petrov gaped at him, and Thomas remembered showing them Miranda's photo at the house.

"No!" Alexandra called aloud and little Lukas stopped to look up at her.

Karl leaned his arm across Thomas's chest, as if that would somehow stop him speaking. Petrov and Alexandra launched into an argument, in a language Thomas didn't understand. Now Alexandra was crying, shrieking at Petrov who kept waving his arms to shush her. Thomas flitted from Petrov to Alexandra, waiting for them to revert to English. When they did, he wished they hadn't.

Petrov made a last comment in his native tongue and wiped a tear from his face with a handkerchief. His face was red and sweaty. "Yorgi would not take hostages. I am sorry — if Yorgi took your friend, she is dead."

Thomas felt his whole body convulsing; there were voices around him, but they all blended into one chaotic chorus. His breathing went into overdrive. He pushed against the table and propelled himself up, lunging for the door. His stomach congealed as he ran along the corridor, snaking back to the main door. He only just made it outside when the wave of nausea and abject terror hit him, like a force ten gale; he retched and retched, until his stomach seared, until the tears were dripping off his face.

When he was done, he staggered away from the pool of vomit and sank to his knees, closing his eyes against the world. He'd never felt so alone, his life so utterly devoid of meaning. He'd fucked up the one beautiful thing in his life, and he'd lost her.

It was futile, but the next thing he decided to do, as he choked back the despair, was to send a text to Miranda's mobile. Maybe her killer would read it, maybe no one ever would; but his last act to her would be one of contrition.

He fumbled the security code on his mobile first time and had to try again. As the screen lit up the text icon appeared. He gulped again and wiped the blur from his eyes. Was this the final text they'd let her send, *made* her send? Oh God, anything but that. His hand trembled as he thumbed the button — he had a voicemail.

His first instinct was to switch the phone off, shield himself from any more pain. But that was just cowardice. He owed her more than that, so much more. He input the code with a cold resolve and braced himself for the worst.

"Thomas, it's Diane. Miranda called me earlier about Butch."

He dropped the mobile. Miranda had phoned today — she was still alive! It couldn't have been Yorgi. He started laughing — at himself, at the absurdity of a second chance, at all the stuff his mother used to tell him as a child about God's mercy. He fingered his neck where the crucifix used to be and felt the sweat, sodden against his armpit. She was alive; Lord have mercy, Christ have mercy.

He texted Diane straight back, in no fit state to speak to her: *I can't talk now — I'll come straight over.* It was weak, but it was honest. He glanced at the mud and puke and snot all down himself — Diane would understand.

His mind was racing as he walked back. Whoever had taken Miranda was the enemy — and enemies had to be dealt with. It may not have been Yorgi who did this, but it had to be connected with him.

Karl opened the door; Thomas pushed past him. He felt like a man redeemed — a man on a mission. He returned to the interview room and shoved the door. Everyone turned; Petrov stared up at him as if he'd never expected to see him again.

Thomas stood over the table and faced them down, slamming his palms against the wood. "I'm only going to ask you this once — what does Yorgi still want with you?"

Petrov shrank back. "He gave me a package to look after; I should have left it for him at the house."

Chairs scraped behind him, but Thomas didn't react. He glared at Petrov as if he could incinerate him by force of will. And Petrov evaporated. "It is in my case. I never meant to keep it. I thought it would be something to bargain with, if we needed such a thing."

Thomas gazed around the room with a look of contempt. It seemed like everyone was holding out on him. As he made for the door, Karl stood aside.

“Tommo, I’m so sorry; I didn’t know . . .”

“I need your car — now.”

As he pulled into the Wrights’ drive, the first thing Thomas noticed was the lack of cars. The doorbell only managed three chords before Diane was standing there.

“Jesus, Thomas, you look like shit.”

“Where is everyone?” he was starting to feel mildly freaked.

“I sent them out for a while; said I wanted time to myself. By my reckoning, you’ve got a couple of hours to get your story straight, right after you tell me what’s *really* going on.”

She walked off, letting the door swing in; he followed her inside. “Let’s cut the bullshit, Thomas,” Diane was already pouring herself something strong. “I know all about Butch and your little code — Miranda told me what happened a long time ago.”

He turned a shade of scarlet.

“Something’s up — I get that. So where’s my daughter and what’s going on?” Diane pushed a drink across the table to him.

The sudden heat in his stomach brought him to his senses. He told her what he knew, which wasn’t much. It was work related — his work — 100% personal. And he was going to sort it. He’d made another decision on the way over. Fuck Karl and his cloak-and-dagger antics; he would go and see Sir Peter Carroll, do things properly through official channels.

She took it surprisingly well, listened attentively until he’d finished then got up to go to the kitchen. He heard a kettle switch and followed her in.

“Look Diane, I never meant for this to happen . . .”

She span round and slapped him hard across the face, sending him flying. “Don’t you *dare* make excuses to me; you should have come to us at the beginning. We’re your family, Thomas — don’t you ever forget that. Now, you better take care of this and deliver Miranda back to me, or we will deal with them and you.”

He got up from the floor and tried to regain some dignity; he didn’t know whether to stay or go. Diane had frozen him out; the way she looked

at him, he was nothing to her. That was even worse than the shame. “You know where the door is.”

He wanted to apologise again, to extract an ounce of forgiveness from her. But who was he kidding, he couldn't forgive himself so why should she? He got to the front door and went to open it, but she blocked him with her arm.

“If anyone has threatened her or hurt her, they're never going to hurt anyone again. I want your word — swear it.”

He felt his jaw harden. “You have my word.” As the door slammed behind him he thought, just for a second, that he heard her sobbing.

Chapter 31

Thomas drove back to the flat and tried to pacify himself in front of the TV. Any relief about Miranda was tempered with an aching sense of loss, of still not knowing where she was. Added to that, Petrov had lied to him — a man he'd put himself on the line for. And for all Karl's efforts, if Yorgi was holding Miranda, well, Karl was just as powerless and clueless as he was. It all added up to a very poor starting point. He couldn't settle, roaming the channels, wondering whether Karl would bring any more super-duper painkillers when he collected his car. And speaking of killers, was that *his* destiny now?

Karl turned up an hour or so later. They sat in Thomas's flat, the TV turned low in the background, not achieving a great deal. He put Karl straight about Diane's phone message, early on — no point torturing the poor guy. But Karl had little to share in return.

"Honest to God, Tommo, we're doing our utmost." Which was like saying: 'A' for effort, 'F' for achievement.

Thomas sat back in the armchair. Karl was sitting pretty much where Miranda had been, last time at the flat. "Did you get the package from Petrov?"

Karl shifted on the cushion. "Yeah, it's a sealed DSB — can you believe that? Teresa's speaking to her people tomorrow about what we do with it."

That hurt. *Yeah, no rush or anything.* He decided to leap the ravine. "Only you and Christine knew I wasn't working when Miranda was taken — from my car."

Karl banged his cup on the table. "Now wait a minute . . ."

Thomas held up a hand. "So they *can't* have been after Miranda. I mean, why *then*, the day after we spirit Petrov and his family away? And if they'd had the tracker on my car beforehand, they could have picked me up *with* Petrov at his home."

Karl calmed down. "I see your logic. Then the tracker must have been put on your car at the hotel or later on. But who else, other than Yorgi, would be interested enough in Petrov to want to get hold of you?"

“Dunno. Someone who’s interested in Yorgi? Or working with him? It’s the same thing from our perspective. Maybe *our* was stretching things a bit, but he was softening Karl up for the biggie. “Miranda’s missing and she’s still at risk. It seems to me that Petrov and the DSB are our best leads. I want the DSB.”

Karl’s eyes widened. “And just what are you intending to do with it?”

“I’ll take it to Sir Peter Carroll. He has connections — MI5, Army Intelligence; I don’t care who. I just want Miranda back. There could be something in that DSB that leads to Yorgi.” The thoughts came thick and fast now; “Perhaps it’s Yorgi they want and they think I can give him to them.”

Karl scratched his teeth on a knuckle. “What you’re asking — the DSB . . . it’s not something . . . it’s not my decision. I can speak to Teresa later, but even then . . .”

Thomas looked at Karl, really looked at him. Did he already know what was in the DSB? Had Karl been playing him for a fool?” “Well, I’m going to see Sir Peter tomorrow, with or without the DSB.”

“Look, I understand where you’re coming from, Tommo. You do what you need to,” Karl held up his hands. “I just wouldn’t want you to be disappointed if your ‘special relationship’ with our glorious leader isn’t as special as you think it is.” He checked his watch. “Look, you’ve had a hell of a day so I’m going to piss off and give you some breathing space.”

Thomas tossed Karl his car keys.

“All I’m saying is: don’t be too hasty. I’ll talk to Teresa and get back to you.”

* * *

“Hi Sheryl,” Thomas kept his tone measured, leaving little space for her to interject. He focused on the things that he wanted her to know, starting with the biggest and the best. “Miranda called home today; no, Diane told me. Yeah, it’s great news. I’m seeing someone official tomorrow . . . yeah, straight after, I promise.” It was gone one when he finally mustered the energy to go to bed.

He put the call in to Sir Peter’s office at seven thirty next morning; he’d been thinking about it since six. In the intervening time, he’d come up with

nothing by way of a story, so he'd stuck with the need to see him urgently. He'd still head over to Harwich and play the waiting game.

When he got on site, Karl wasn't there. Ann Crossley was none the wiser on his movements. At ten thirty, Thomas rang him on his mobile, but it was out of use. Christine was the next logical choice; she had mixed news.

"Karl has been assigned elsewhere and is subject to a lockdown. Sir Peter Carroll has asked me to pass on an open invitation to Whitehall." She sounded bemused.

Thomas had once been subject to a lockdown. Standard procedure on some assignments — all contact with the rest of the team or anyone else expressly forbidden. It was the closest they ever came to secret squirreling.

He weighed up the situation. An open invitation was a definite plus; unusual too, given Sir Peter's fondness for protocol. What about Karl? True, Christine had warned them that the job was coming to an end — bloody suspicious timing though. His own lockdown had been a three-day stint with the Serious Fraud Office, but lockdowns of just a day had been known; all the more reason to follow things up with Sir Peter in the meantime.

* * *

The sun glanced off Main Building, illuminating it against a photogenic blue sky. In other circumstances, he might have stopped to admire it. Not today though.

After reporting at reception, he gave his details and took a seat. He tried playing it out in his head, sifting the facts to choose what he wanted to share. Someone was missing and somehow he'd got mixed up in helping the brother of . . . He backtracked; how could he explain knowing that Yorgi was a gunman? He was still juggling the facts when he noticed someone standing over him.

"I'll take you up now."

No hello, no introductions; this was evidently the kind of person who smiled on the inside, if at all. There was no eye contact in the lift; just the definite sense that this guy thought Thomas was the shit on his shiny boots. Another warm welcome extended to Floater colleagues in the Surveillance Support Unit.

As the lift door opened, he felt a rush of excitement. This was the big step that would bring Miranda home. He should have done this when it first all kicked off. And besides, he'd already passed Sir Peter's loyalty test; this was like repaying his trust.

The escort left him at the door. He knocked confidently. Sir Peter opened the door and welcomed him in. "Thomas, your message sounded important. I've cleared my appointments for the next hour or so."

Brilliant. Just what the doctor ordered.

"It's a little early for a drink — I thought perhaps a coffee?"

Thomas smiled as he sat down. Now for the tricky part, keeping Karl and Teresa out of it. Bob Peterson was the logical fall guy, by process of elimination. That and the fact that Thomas thought he was a snake.

Anyhow, big breath and straight in at the deep end. "I'm in trouble, sir. A friend of mine has disappeared and I think it's connected with something I saw." He'd barely got two sentences out when there was a rap on the door. He almost jumped out of his chair.

"It's just the coffees. Come in!" Sir Peter boomed.

Once he had a cup in his hand, Thomas resumed his story — the edited version. Harwich — Bob Peterson — the red car — Petrov — Yorgi — his missing friend. There were gaps wide enough to park a bus in. He didn't explain how he'd tracked Petrov down or why he'd kept it all to himself. But the old man was still listening, which was a good sign.

Sir Peter had stopped making notes, right at the point where Miranda went missing. He put a spoon in his cup and stirred it slowly, rhythmically tapping the cup three times. Then he put the spoon down in a precise fashion and laced his fingers together, like some mafia don. He seemed to grow in stature. "Now then, Thomas, why don't you tell me *all* about it?" A self-satisfied leer lit up his face like a Halloween pumpkin.

Oh fuck. Thomas tried to quell the trembling in his hand as he put his cup down. He understood now, and felt sick at his own stupidity. Behind the desk, even Winston Churchill seemed to be smirking at him: *checkmate*. Then the penny really dropped — the Churchill speech, off the net, the 'United States of Europe' speech from 1946. Jesus, short of taking an ad out in the papers, the clue had been in the painting all the time.

Sir Peter puffed up his chest and cleared his throat. "Let me be frank, Thomas. I'm extremely impressed by your resourcefulness and I regret the

recent turn of events. But I believe I can bring about a mutually satisfactory conclusion. Will you let me help you?"

Thomas's first instinct was to hurl the bastard through the window and watch him crash to the concrete below. But this was the real world and he was all out of options. "What do you want?"

"Supposing Petrov had something that didn't belong to him; something we could exchange for Miranda."

Thomas froze. He hadn't mentioned Miranda by name.

"Can you get it, Thomas?" the voice was insistent.

He closed his eyes and drew breath. "I'll talk with Petrov."

"I'm sure you'll be very persuasive. Shall we say twenty-four hours? And Thomas, it would be better for *everyone* if the package remained unopened," Sir Peter slid out a desk drawer and retrieved an A4 Civil Service envelope. He passed it across, but before Thomas could break the seal, Sir Peter brought the meeting to a close. "I think that's all we have to say to each other at this juncture. Goodbye Thomas — twenty-four hours. It's best if we resolve this without Yorgi's involvement."

He had to use the chair to stand. He felt Sir Peter watching him as he staggered for the door. A guard was waiting in the corridor. Thomas shuffled along behind him in a daze, brown envelope in hand like hospital bad news. At the lifts, he felt his insides shatter. "I need the gents."

The guard stood outside the main door, like a bouncer. What did the guy think he was going to do, swim down the u-bend to freedom? He leaned against the sink and ran the tap to try and drown out the hissing in his head. A spasm brought up a clump of brown-stained sick. It reeked of coffee and fear. He let it slide down the plughole then splashed some cold water over this face. He left the tap running and dried his hands.

And now for the envelope. It was sealed tight; not last minute, and still wet with spit, but something planned in advance. Inside were photographs. The top one was a herd of people, slightly blurred, moving away from the camera. A sign on the wall settled the mystery: Walthamstow Central. He looked more carefully at the centre of the picture; and there he was, merging into the crowd.

He flicked through the other photographs frantically, half expecting the worst. He wasn't disappointed; there was Pickering — his parents' house, Pat and the kids. Those bastards had everything on film. The last shot was

the final dagger through the heart. A telephoto lens of him and Ajit, sat in a car by the police station. It had been a rat trap from start to finish.

He sneered at his reflection and shook his head. His eyes were red from lack of sleep and the tears he was holding back. He slipped the photos back into the envelope, turned off the tap and opened the door.

* * *

Back on the street, everything seemed larger than life; everything except him. As he looked over his shoulder, Main Building soared above him, all-powerful, impregnable. On impulse, he opened his mobile to try Karl again. Did he dare? It would be a disciplinary offence if he got through — both for him and Karl. He was completely screwed.

He walked over to the park and sat down on a bench, the open phone still in his hand like a weapon. They might be watching him, even now. He hunched forward, pretended to play with the buttons and glanced around. The only people nearby were a woman with a baby in a stroller and two college kids playing with a Frisbee. The stroller could be a disguise for a directional microphone and a camera, with the students waiting for him to move. *Yeah, right. And maybe the Frisbee was a hover camera.*

He cradled his head and leaned forward, tasting bile. Through the chink of light between his fingers, he watched people ignoring him. He needed coffee; he had a lot of thinking to do.

The espresso he bought from the coffee stand in the park didn't taste so great, but its effects were undiminished; such were the restorative powers of premium caffeine. He needed a plan, fast. He sipped rhythmically and went through a list in his head.

Point 1: Sir Peter Carroll had said they'd prefer that the package wasn't opened. So who had the package now? Answer: Teresa. But he could hardly ring up every Intelligence office and ask if a Teresa worked there. But . . . he did know where she'd been — he could go back to the building where they'd interrogated Petrov. Someone there must be able to get hold of her. He took a bite of the muffin as a reward and held the sugary stodge in his mouth until it melted.

Point 2: Get some time off work. He couldn't be in two places at once. Christine would sign it off, and if she took issue with it he could always

refer her to Sir Peter. He texted her to say he was coming in for a chat when he picked up his car. She responded immediately that she'd wait in for him.

By the time he got to the park gate he breathed a little easier. At least he knew what his next steps were. One glance back told him that Buggy Woman and the Frisbee Kids were either holding position fantastically well or they were just innocent civilians. If there was such a thing anymore.

Chapter 32

Thomas felt safe among the crowds — buoyant amid a sea of tourists, shift-workers and pickpockets. True, the mass of CCTV cameras threw him a little if he thought about it too much, but he'd already reached his paranoia limit for the day.

The next train was three minutes away so he grabbed a bench and tried to lose himself in the giant poster opposite. A suspiciously attractive couple beamed down on him, extolling the virtues of some European bank he'd never heard of. 'Small savings and big decisions,' they smiled. He mused on that; it was the big decisions that everyone was afraid of.

The open plan office at Liverpool Street was deserted; no surprise, as it was the middle of the day. He'd harboured the tiniest of hopes that Karl would be around, but a lockdown meant restrictions on contact, movement and behaviour.

Christine's light was on and the door open, so he didn't think twice about approaching. Inside, she and Bob were reading through files. They seemed to be looking for something.

Thomas quickly stuffed the envelope of photographs inside his jacket and zipped it tight. He rapped on the door. Bob looked up, gave him a half nod of recognition and returned to his reading. Christine did the talking. "Hello Thomas, please come in. Bob and I are just finishing up."

Of course you are, he thought. He said nothing, watching from the door as they continued their synchronised folder stacking. Then he grabbed a seat in one corner, a good vantage point to see who was the most unsettled.

Eventually, they took the hint and gave up on their search. Bob Peterson didn't look happy about it though, which pleased Thomas no end.

"Back in a mo," Christine explained with a grin, "call of nature."

It was a little informal for Thomas's liking. And judging by the look on Peterson's face, he felt the same way. Thomas looked him over, trying not to appear like the aggrieved ex.

"So," Bob glanced at the top folder on the pile, "how's Harwich?"

That was all it took. The red mist that Karl used to joke about became a sunburst. Thomas leapt the distance between them, grabbed Peterson by the

lapels and slammed him up against the door. A mountain of folders seemed to scurry for cover.

“Fuck Harwich!” Thomas snarled, through a haze of rage. “When all this is over, I’m coming back for you.”

“What the hell is wrong with you?” it took Peterson a moment to take it in. He started thrashing about, but Thomas had him pinned.

It had been pure instinct, nothing more, and already he was wondering what was wrong with him. Peterson struggled a second time then, before Thomas even realised it was coming, his fist blasted through his arms with an upper cut. Thomas took it on the jaw and reeled backwards, dragging Peterson with him to the floor, only twisting at the last moment to try and cushion his fall.

Peterson wasn’t going down without a fight. And there was a score to be settled. Juvenile? Definitely, but Thomas felt that Uncle Bob had it coming on two counts: one, playing away with Christine — no doubt in his mind at all now — and two, Peterson was somehow the starting point of all his troubles.

* * *

Christine opened the door to find the two of them locked in combat. The main punches had already been traded and now it was about who could rough who up the most. At first, she didn’t speak. Thomas was glad of that. It might have distracted him from his main intention of hammering the shit out of Peterson.

“That’s enough!” she slammed the door. Then she pointed to two chairs in either corner of the room and they both complied.

Thomas looked first at Peterson and then at the mess. And he couldn’t help smiling. He’d finally fulfilled a personal ambition and landed some punches on Peterson, even if he had taken a few knocks himself. His only regret was that he hadn’t drawn blood; maybe next time he’d staple Bob’s ear.

For a while there was silence. Christine bent down to retrieve some of the paperwork. She looked pained, which pained Thomas. Just because Peterson was an arsehole, it was no reason for her to suffer.

He stood up; in all the excitement he’d almost forgotten what he came there for. “I need some compassionate leave — I’ll be on the mobile.” He

spoke directly to Christine, ignoring Peterson altogether.

Christine looked down at the floor and waved him away like he was too much to bear. He straightened his jacket as he walked out, patting the envelope as he closed the door behind him. He called Diane on his way out of the building.

“It’s Thomas. I’m off work now . . . indefinitely, until this is sorted out. Nah, I’ll tell you face to face when I have more info.”

“That’s good news, Thomas, because you’re going to be busy.”

* * *

He drove out beyond the North Circular, ditching the car at Hatch End. Best to assume the tracker was still working, like Karl said. He jumped a cab at the station — finding the old Telephone Exchange wasn’t difficult; there couldn’t be too many buildings that ugly.

“Wait here,” he waved a £20 note under the cabbie’s nose.

The car park was empty; gates locked. Nothing fancy, no barbed wire or anything to excite the interest of your average industrial burglar. He looked back at the cab, figured the driver was engrossed in his horses — or the £20 — and launched himself over.

The place seemed deserted; even the conference centre sign was gone. A quick scout around the perimeter confirmed that the good guys — if that’s who they’d been — had left without a trace. Bollocks.

The cabbie didn’t seem surprised to see him back so quickly. He folded his paper away and unlocked the passenger doors. Thomas was still catching his breath as he tumbled back on to the seat. “Any idea who owns this place?”

“No, guvnor, it’s been shut for ages. We used to get quite a bit of trade there; you know, corporate knobs with their laptops and that. You, er, interested in buying it or something?”

A chink of light in an otherwise shit day. “Well, not me,” Thomas went into bullshit mode. “A mate of mine is looking for office space round here. He’s small time with big ideas.” He raised his eyes in mock disdain.

“As you’ll likely be a big tipper, I’ll tell you who the estate agent is when we get to the station.”

Cheeky bastard. He checked his watch; still time to ring them. As soon as the driver had sodded off at the station to spend his big tip, Thomas

dialled from a super-duper phone box. Funny how things changed; he almost missed the smell of piss and sweat. He leaned against the metal back-plate and sighed. He and Miranda had once shared a knee trembler in a phone box, after missing the night bus, one stormy night in Balham. No chance of anyone repeating that here unless they enjoyed the open air.

“Yes, hello, I wonder if you *can* help me. An associate of mine recently rented a property in Larchall Road — the converted exchange building. I was supposed to meet them, but my flight was delayed and I was wondering . . .”

Wow, stonewalled straight away. Karl had made this stuff look so easy. “You haven’t? Well no, what about . . . no, right . . . I see.” If only West Ham had as good a defence.

The senior partner had handled all the arrangements and she was now on holiday in Canada. Hence: no names, no contacts and no yellow brick road.

He got in the car and headed south, with only the radio for company. It was all going pear-shaped again. He had Diane and Sheryl pulling his strings from one side and Sir Peter the Bastard on the other side. *Ping*: small savings and big decisions. He’d seen that ad before, at Holloway Road tube. He’d even had a discussion about finances, in which Karl had revealed his own astute investment strategy: *saving is for pussies*.

Thomas allowed himself the luxury of a smile. Now he had a way forward again, sort of. He could find his way to the Gun Club but would they let him in? He pulled over and stared at the *A to Z* intently, like an ugly man checking out the foreign bride catalogue. Nope, it wasn’t coming together at all. The only thing for it was to drive down to the tube station and retrace his steps.

* * *

The industrial estate was half full with cars. He remembered that Teresa had been driving a silver coupé the day Karl had bought Petrov’s red estate, but it could have been a hire car. And of course, he hadn’t made a habit of carrying his driving licence and passport around, so getting in might be a tad tricky. Three men got out of a BMW; for a second he thought he’d seen one of them before. But he could hardly wave and explain. They glanced in his direction and didn’t glance again. This was getting him nowhere.

He walked up to the thick metal door with as much confidence as he could fake. The camera stared at him implacably. He pushed the intercom and said that he'd been there before and was looking for a member named Teresa. He let go of the button and waited. Nothing happened.

He tried again, a different pitch — same basic facts and that he needed to speak to her urgently. He held up his SSU ID card, for good measure. Finally, he got a response: "You must have the wrong place." Now he was getting seriously pissed off, and desperate. He hit the button again. "Look, I don't have a lot of time. If she's there, I need to see her; she'll know what it's about. Be a good girl and stop fucking me around."

He did elicit an immediate response, but 'if you don't go away I'll call the police' wasn't the one he hoped for. He took a breath. "Look, I'm sorry for behaving like a twat. But it's really important and I *have* been here before, more than once — you can check your records against my ID and name. And I've got nowhere else to go so I'm just going to sit out here in my car and wait until she turns up - today, tomorrow, whenever. I'm not going to cause any trouble, and if you want to call the police, then you go right ahead."

He took a step back, raised a hand as if he was being sworn in on a jury, and backed away slowly to his car. Then he drove around the car park, clocking the security cameras on poles, and managed to find a space facing the door.

Sunset came and went; evening crept upon him, a staring contest with a steel door that was only interrupted by the occasional visitor and an emergency piss in an old lemonade bottle. He tried the radio for a while, but it took the edge off his concentration. Even his survival ration granola bar — the only food he'd had all day — couldn't lift his spirits.

He figured he'd fucked his job now; he couldn't see how Christine and Peterson would keep him on the team. In the unlikely event that Christine took his side, he'd given Peterson the ideal excuse to prise him out. *Stupid, Thomas; really stupid.* He closed his eyes for a few seconds, and fantasised that he and Miranda were running over the North Yorkshire Moors.

Tap, tap, tap; tap, tap, tap. Jesus! They must have called the police after all. He turned to the window, ready to surrender. Teresa was standing outside. He pushed the sealed piss bottle under the passenger seat before he lowered the window.

“You shouldn’t have come here.”

Okay, not the welcome he’d hoped for but he still felt like hugging her. “I was desperate. It’s become . . .” he searched for the right word. “. . . complicated.” Yeah, if complicated was another word for meltdown.

“What’s the problem?” Teresa stopped short. “Have you been in a fight?”

“Yeah, with Bob Peterson.” He figured she knew who Peterson was. Heck, maybe she’d always known. He passed over the photos in the envelope and waited for comment. Then he got tired of waiting and told her about Sir Peter Carroll. After all, what did he have to lose now? He was all out of friends on this.

“You drive,” Teresa insisted. “We’ll go back to yours.”

“What about the bug in my car?”

She held up two fingers, like a victory salute. “Bugs, plural. That’s how I’m here. Karl’s been keeping an eye on you.”

He couldn’t help, but smile. Karl: the wily little Celt.

* * *

It wasn’t difficult to understand what Karl might see in Teresa, apart from an air of mystery. She was very capable and clearly didn’t take any shit. Once inside the flat, she assumed control, drawing the curtains before she did a sweep of the living room using a hand-held detector. He left her to it, put the kettle on and dug something resurrectable out of the freezer — two portions.

“Karl thinks very highly of you,” she carried on talking with her back to him. “But he’s worried you’ll do something rash about Miranda.”

No mistake there. He’d already decided he would sort out whoever was involved — every last one of them. “So how did Karl send you to find me, exactly?”

She snapped the portable shut and turned round. “Simple,” she tilted her head to one side. “He knows the OS ref of the indoor firing range and he tracked your car.”

“What about the lockdown?”

Her face was calm, as if she could say much but was choosing not to. “It only takes one text to me, on a throwaway mobile — *T at CLUB.*” She

paused and folded her hands together. “Then smash the mobile and it’s like it never happened. You just have to make sure you don’t get caught.”

He felt his mouth form into a wow. Karl had been covering his back after all. The kettle clicked, breaking the spell.

“I’ll just sweep the other rooms, starting with the bathroom.”

“Sure,” he nodded, waving a hand behind him. “It’s just off . . .”

“I know where it is, Thomas; I remember from the last time I was here.”

The wow expanded into a cavern. Of course, Karl had saved his bacon before, at the flat, when he’d had the good sense not to be there. Teresa must have been involved.

He made the tea. “So what’s the deal with you and Karl?” his voice seemed to echo through the flat. There was no answer, but he felt sure that she’d heard him.

* * *

It was strange, eating dinner with another woman. Having another woman in the flat at all, come to that. Christine Gerrard, in her time, had never been a fan. She always seemed to treat the east of London like some sort of infection.

The food settled him, helped his thoughts to fall into place. “Has the DSB been opened?” he hovered, mid-fork, waiting for her answer.

“No, not yet. It’s sealed and there’s no tag inside — we X-rayed it.”

He swallowed. “Have you made a decision — do I get it?”

She made a smacking sound with her lips; he doubted it was the quality of the food. “It may contain vital information about the cartel . . .”

He nearly countered that but he could see, by the way her eyes flickered, that she was still thinking it over.

“. . . And can you afford to trust Sir Peter Carroll?”

The room went very cold. Any optimism he’d been nurturing, including the comforting notion that a simple trade-off could be made, was dangling by a thread. Teresa was right of course. How could he trust these bastards, when he knew what they were capable of — two corpses at the hospital, Petrov’s house torched, and counting.

“I’m sorry, Thomas; it could be too valuable to lose,” she sounded like a bank manager, turning him down for a loan.

Desperation wrote its own scripts. “What if we copied it first? You’d keep a copy and I return the original.” Okay, it was feeble, but at least it *was* a plan. It wasn’t as if they’d come up with a better option.

“We know it’s a document box,” she backtracked, softening her voice. “The paper may be heat and light sensitive. Photocopying or scanning is just too risky.”

“What about photography?”

“I don’t know Thomas,” she flicked the hair from her face. “I don’t know. And besides, once we open the DSB, the seal is broken.”

He tapped his chin. “I might be able to solve your problem.” *Your problem, good one: reverse psychology for beginners.*

Teresa listened as he told her about the DSB he’d kept from Leeds. Maybe it wouldn’t be an identical match, but if it meant having something to exchange for Miranda and not, he’d take that gamble.

“Now,” he gathered up the plates; “I’ve also got a couple of ideas about special paper.” No sense losing momentum while she was still malleable. “How about doing the photography in a darkroom?” He gestured out towards the hallway. “Or I can try one of my Internet buddies, see if they know anyone with a *Starlight* camera.”

Buddies — that was stretching it a bit — a bunch of ultra-competitive snappers and geeks, who would tell you where to find equipment, as long as you knew what you wanted in the first place.

He dumped the plates in the sink and fired up his laptop, waiting until he’d cleared the minefield of password and security protection before he brought Teresa screen-side.

“Great for night shots,” he pulled up a couple of images from a folder. She didn’t respond, but that was fine — he was impressed enough for both of them. “Someone hired one for me once; back when I thought I’d be the next Andy Rouse.”

She stared at him blankly and he sighed, appalled.

“I’m supposed to contact Sir Peter tomorrow so I need an answer.”

She was quiet for so long that he thought he’d finally met his match in the silence game. He studied her as she stared off into space. The way her hair fell, just above the collar-line; the slightly muscular legs and that cluster ring on her right hand. If she noticed him watching her, she didn’t seem at all perturbed. He wasn’t perving or anything, he told himself. He

just wanted to weigh up what sort of person he was investing with his last few ounces of faith.

Teresa turned suddenly, catching him off guard. He felt a pang in his heart — Miranda used to do the same thing. Whoa, *used to*? He swallowed hard, deciding at the last minute not to punch himself.

“I’ll tell you what,” Teresa narrowed her eyes, “Why don’t you give me a few minutes and I’ll make a couple of calls?”

He headed for the kitchen, pausing along the way to lock his laptop. He turned the radio on and did his domestic thing to the soothing sounds of Seventies Soul, courtesy of Dobie Gray and others. Except, tonight, they weren’t so soothing. Suddenly, for no reason at all, he recalled the first time he saw Miranda naked. How she’d made him close his eyes. And then, for the only time in his life, all the clichés had been true. So beautiful; the sort of enchantment that made him want to cry, then and now. He looked skyward and closed his eyes.

* * *

Teresa returned after a handful of songs; long enough for him to pull it together again. “My people have agreed to let you take the DSB to Sir Peter Carroll, once the document is copied to our satisfaction. After that we’ll monitor the situation closely.”

Very generous of them. With Sir Peter firmly in the frame and copies of the papers safely tucked away, they had very little to lose. Whereas . . .

He thanked her and tried to warm it up. Things were improving. He had allies now, although the odds were still stacked against them. He stopped mid-thought. “I need a car tonight.”

“I’ll arrange something, and I’ll be back tomorrow with the package.”

Chapter 33

Teresa had given her assurance that the car wouldn't be tracked. He wasn't sure if he believed her, but he was in no position to be fussy. The Wrights knew to expect him. On the drive over, he ran through different versions of what he wanted to say, but in the end he decided to let them take the lead.

When he arrived, the driveway was full of cars — a packed house tonight. He stood outside for a moment, trying to get a grip on his fear and his bowels. He took another breath as he held his hand over the bell. This was going to be rough. He pressed the button lightly, reminding himself that they were the ones really suffering here.

"It's open," Diane's voice wavered from behind the door.

He gave it a tiny shove and it released inwards, drawing the light from the kitchen through the open inner door.

"We're in here."

It took all his courage to step across the threshold, knowing as he did that he was turning his back on everything he had selfishly tried to preserve.

Well, best not keep the family waiting. He pushed the living room door and went in. Sam and Terry looked up from their armchairs; neither spoke or acknowledged him. Diane was sat on the settee with Sheryl next to her, holding hands as if it was the only thing keeping each of them together. Miranda's dad, John, was nowhere to be seen.

"Come sit down," there was kindness in Diane's voice and he felt wretched at that; it was something he hadn't earned and didn't deserve. Sheryl wouldn't look at him, but if he was honest with himself it was one less face to deal with.

There was no point beating around the bush so he told them what he planned to do. To get a package which *someone else* — he stressed that — had kept secret from him and deliver it in exchange for Miranda.

It was less an interrogation than a series of silences, speckled with short exchanges. Mostly, they wanted answers he couldn't give. What was it all about? Why Miranda, or him? Why couldn't he let the family deal with it? Someone — Sam or Terry, it all got lost in the stillness and the unspoken fears — passed him a drink. As if he'd won it on merit by his responses. He

gripped the glass so tight he thought it might break, wanted it to break and pierce his skin so he could feel something as acute as the pain on their faces.

“I’m so sorry,” he hung his head and waited for the room to swallow him. The tension wrapped around him like a physical pressure. It was harder to breathe now. He felt tears forming. Not now, Jesus; they’d think it was staged. He took a gulp from the glass and pinched the tears back, rubbing his eyes clear. He kept his head down, not wanting to read their expectations.

“Thomas,” Diane spoke his name and she sounded like a stranger. “John wants to see you in his office.” She didn’t say *now* but that’s what she meant.

He finished his glass and set it on the floor; last drink for a condemned man. His limbs dragged like dead weight as he walked through to the other side of the house. It was quieter there, and devoid of comfort. There was a line of light under the closed door. He knocked twice and went in.

* * *

John Wright was hunched over his desk, hands crushed together. Thomas felt his shoulders sink, almost smelt those Saturday dinners again when his dad had come home, spoiling for a fight.

The main light was off and the desk lamp shone away from John, casting him in shards of shadow. The hands on the desk didn’t move at all. Thomas stood in no man’s land, waiting for sentence to be passed.

“Close the door,” John managed to convey resolve without menace. The room shrank around him.

Thomas waited for John to speak again — he had little to say, himself, other than repeat what he’d said to the others. In the semi-darkness, he could still make out the photographs on the wall — small comfort.

John’s hands moved to his face and he blew his next breath through his fingers; the breath was long and laboured. “You found Miranda in Leeds, kept her safe and brought her back to us.” He nodded for Thomas to sit opposite him. “Diane tells me that Miranda is in trouble because of you.” It wasn’t a question because they both already knew the answer. “When you came to London and we set you up in a home together, you made us a promise. Do you remember?”

Of course he remembered. One simple sentence: he'd never let her down. No matter what happened between them in the future — and God, how prophetic that clause had turned out to be — he'd never let her down. "I know."

John took a sharp intake of breath. "You've always been a man of your word, Thomas, and I look upon you as one of us." John was struggling with the words, raw emotion choking every syllable.

Any moment now, Thomas thought, that fist would come flying across the small space between them.

"Diane says this has to be handled a certain way — and it has to be done by you." He took another long breath. "Miranda is our little girl, Thomas; she's precious. So I expect you to do what's necessary."

Thomas tensed up, half closing his eyes against the light and whatever was to come. He heard a drawer being opened and then a thud on the desk. He looked down to see a pistol, light gleaming along its edge. John nudged the gun over to him with the heel of his hand.

Holy shit. John was stone-cold serious. Thomas reached forward and touched the barrel, felt the metallic chill seeping into his skin.

"Do you know how to use it?"

Thomas took the gun, slipped out the magazine and checked the chamber was clear. He also noticed that the mag was empty. As he looked up, there was a thin smile on John's lips. He swallowed and let the gun rest in his hand; he had just crossed the line, on a one-way ticket.

John leaned down and lifted a carrier bag onto the desk. Inside was a shoulder holster and ammunition. Thomas weighed the gun in his hand and, as if demonstrating his side of the pact, loaded the weapon. This was a moment that would live with him forever, like scar tissue that appears healed. But it's always there, beneath the surface.

Chapter 34

Not long after Thomas returned home, Teresa was at his door. He checked through the curtain first — she was alone, though logically she must have come with someone to take back the Audi.

She watched him as he gazed forlornly out of the window at her, as he looked past her in the vain hope that Karl was around. Nothing doing. He opened the front door, car keys in hand. She edged forward and he stood aside.

“I won’t stay long,” she seemed almost cheery. “I’ve got good news.”

Yeah, Thomas thought; maybe she’d found some affordable body armour to go with his new gun. He put the kettle on and joined her in the lounge. She perched on the edge of the sofa arm, hands together.

“I’ll bring the DSB over to you tomorrow evening.” There was a ‘but’ coming. “. . . But we’ll need some extra time before you give it back to them.”

He felt his jaw dragging down. The kettle clicked; he ignored it. “You want me to put Miranda at further risk?” He felt his shoulders hardening.

“If the information is useful, we’ll have to act before the cartel gets it back.”

He made a break to the kitchen. Teresa followed him.

“Look Thomas, I know this is all—”

Thomas rounded on her. “You don’t know shit. This is business as usual to you people, but for me, it’s personal.”

Her next move was textbook — the reassuring hand on the arm. “If you tell Sir Peter you can get the DSB in a couple of days, and that it’s still unopened, he’ll accept that. Why wouldn’t he? He’ll still get exactly what he wants.”

She negotiated the cups and spoons through trial and error as he sat and watched her. Maybe she could tell he wasn’t convinced, still not a card-carrying member of their gang. “Let me put this another way,” her voice moulded into concrete. “We need two more days, with or without your cooperation.”

He blinked a couple of times, waited for the heat across his face to subside before he spoke. She beat him to it.

“This isn’t a game, Thomas; this is life and death to our operatives. The contents of that DSB could save lives.”

He nodded without saying a word.

“I’ll be back here tomorrow, around six.”

All he could do was sit there like a statue and listen to the door closing behind her.

* * *

The dream returned that night — the arguing downstairs, him and Pat cowering under the covers together and that terrible silence when their mother capitulated. As if the world had ended. Pat, crying and shaking under the sheets, as the heavy *thud thud* grew closer on the stairs. He was holding her tightly again, so that she couldn’t feel his own trembling.

The hollow *catch* as Dad gripped the door handle. And even though it hadn’t moved, you knew he was there because his legs stole the light from underneath the door. The handle turning, the light switch driving out the comfort of shadows, and then the footfalls to the side of the bed. Pat’s nails, digging into his skin so hard that he wanted to cry out, only Dad would just call him soft and take a swipe at him. He could smell the hand on the sheets, stinking of shame and self-loathing

But when the covers were snatched away, it was Miranda at his side, warm and sensuous. And Dad wasn’t there in the room this time: it was Sir Peter Carroll. He was speaking, whispering as his hand stretched towards Miranda.

And Thomas couldn’t move; he was paralysed until somehow he remembered the gun. The sweet, silver pistol with the magic star on the handle; the one that meant he was the sheriff. He reached under the pillow and as soon as he felt it, he drew out the gun and thrust it into Sir Peter’s face.

Sir Peter took a step back in the dream, standing there, daring Thomas to ‘be a man.’ His eyes blurred, but he wiped them one-handed, the gun still at arm’s length to ward off evil. Then his fingers slowly closed together and *pow*, the gun went off.

* * *

Thomas shocked awake, rigid against the bed with tears spread across his face. Slowly, he regained movement in his limbs, felt the muscles in his shoulders and back release. It was a little after five in the morning; he flipped the mobile on, in case there'd been word from either Miranda or Karl. Then he ran for a shower to avoid the disappointment.

After toasting the last of the bread, he took John Wright's pistol from where he'd hidden it in the kitchen and re-examined it — no serial numbers or distinguishing marks. It might never have been used before, but he doubted that. He tried on the shoulder holster, adjusted it a couple of times and nested the gun. He must have stood in the middle of the kitchen for a minute or more, no quick draw bullshit or confronting the mirror. No, the only thought going through his brain was whether John had started like this himself; whether one unfortunate situation had turned an honest man into . . . into someone like *him*.

He ditched the holster in a drawer and stowed the gun away carefully. The mobile phone had nothing for him. Only six o'clock now; way too early for Whitehall.

So many times in the past he'd worked his way through London, cursing the traffic as he inched ahead, bumper to bumper. But today, when he wanted the drive to take forever, nothing doing. He parked at the work compound, just to keep his car handy, and went walkabout. He'd brought along a Pentax Optio to kill some time.

London, before the rush, was a different place altogether. The city breathed softly before the hordes invaded; the haze lifted off the Thames in the first light of morning. Walking beside the Embankment, lulled by the lapping water, it was easy to forget just how much shit he was in and how deep.

The police launch prowled along the Thames as he watched, lens poised; the sun burst through the mesh of steel and brick and glass behind it to light up the skyline. He drank it all in — better than espresso. When did he last do this? When did he last feel such a connection to London? He couldn't remember. It was Miranda's city, but it was also his.

By the time he'd had his fill and grabbed a coffee at St James's Park, it was just after eight. He felt limbered up after all the walking and, thanks to the coffee, as sharp as a blade. Grateful too, that he hadn't followed his gut and brought the gun along.

A few miles on foot had given him time to reflect a little. No one had suggested that Thomas was anything more than an innocent in all this; and basically that's what he was. As long as he played it that way and didn't come across too cocky or clever, why wouldn't they give him a couple of extra days?

At first glance, Main Building looked closed for business, but the door gave way and the security staff squared up to him from across the polished marble flooring. He moved to the glass screen, stated his name and flipped them his ID.

A receptionist directed him to the hand-scanner and checked a list of names. Yep, there he was, all present and correct. Sir Peter wasn't in his office yet, so he waited in the foyer, with an early morning broadsheet for company.

Coming from Yorkshire, Thomas was no stranger to the class struggle, but never was the divide more clearly defined than in the newspapers — insightful information for the movers and shakers, and tits and celebrities for the plebs. Oh, he liked a tabloid as much as the next man, but it didn't equip you for understanding the bigger picture. Take today — a Benelux corporation was holding strategic talks with a French business partner, ahead of a meeting with representatives from the EU Commission. *Jesus*. The more he read, the more it seemed like Karl's mythical Superstate was already in place.

After fifteen minutes of isolation therapy, a guard came over: Sir Peter would be ready for him shortly. Okay, final run through of what he was going to say. The DSB was unopened; no, he hadn't seen it and yes, he would bring it to them in a day or so. As to anything else, he knew nothing: if in doubt, say nowt.

He stood and stretched. Sir Peter might have him on CCTV that very minute, just watching him sweat. Not a very comforting thought. He heard boots on marble and turned to face them; it was show time.

The journey to the lift took place in customary silence. He thought maybe he'd seen this guard before. As they exited the lift, he realised where — at the gun club. He nodded and smiled as they entered the last leg of the corridor. The guard paused and looked him up and down, as if trying to place him. "Are you ex-mob?"

Fortunately, Thomas had had the benefit of Karl's education: mob, for military. He tilted his hand noncommittally: *could be*.

Three raps and away, leaving Thomas standing there like the last virgin in a nightclub. Sir Peter took his time about answering; he probably thought he was piling on the pressure. This was Pickering all over again, but now the bullies were grown up and infinitely more savage. It would be harder to get away with it this time; a shove into the pavement wouldn't quite cover it.

Thomas knew the score. For the terrorised, it went one of three ways. You resigned yourself to it, withdrew as much as you could and survived, day to day. Or else you crumbled, lost hope; gave up on yourself. But if there was still some part of you that they hadn't got to, hadn't chewed up and spat out, you bided your time and then you struck back, hard.

He heard Sir Peter's voice and meekly entered the office. Meek: that was the watchword. And no need to fake the unease; he already had that in spades.

Sir Peter offered him a chair, all very civilised. It was bloody obvious that he didn't have the DSB with him, but they went through the master and servant formalities. He delivered the agreed message and then asked if there was news about Miranda.

It seemed to throw the old man. Even though he'd been listening attentively before, that one small question upset the apple cart. "I'll see what I can find out for you, Thomas." He looked at him differently after that, like Thomas was a simpleton.

Thomas thanked him, said how grateful he was and shook his hand. It sealed the deal. Two days' grace and the promise of a telephone call later that day — quite a result. At this rate, he decided, he might even let him live, when it was all over.

* * *

Two days to put together a plan; afterwards, there would be no going back. That was fine — it meant he had nothing to lose. He made straight for the Victoria line and waited on the platform, fantasising about earning a crust as a freelance photographer — *every snapper's fantasy*. Maybe he and Miranda . . . The soundtrack in his head stopped abruptly. She'd probably never want to lay eyes on him again. Like he said . . . nothing to lose.

He made it to the office just after nine. Hopefully, Christine would be in and he could set the record straight, come clean about Miranda and everything. There was even an outside chance that Christine could help him, somehow. Because, now that he thought about it, there *was* something he needed. First though, he had to fetch something from the car, something he'd bottled out of at Whitehall.

Christine's office light was a lone beacon. He glanced around at the empty desks, shrouded in shadow; he'd miss this place, even the crap coffee from the machine. He thrust his hand into his jacket pocket and opened the box one-handed, positioning the bug ready for attachment. Christine's door was closed; he knocked, tentatively. But the voice that answered was Bob Peterson's.

Always have a Plan B, and preferably a Plan C as well. Karl called it The Dorman Rule, after a bloke he'd met in a pub once. Plan B was to proceed as planned. There was no Plan C, short of walking away.

He opened the door with his left hand and tried to play nicely.

"You're the last person I expected to see, Thomas. What do you want?"

Count to ten. This was too important to screw up for the sake of scoring a few points. "Bob, can I sit down, please? I need to discuss something."

Bob Peterson gestured to a chair opposite, ever the genial host. Thomas drew close and slipped out the bug under the table, leaning forward earnestly as he applied it to the underside of the desk.

"Christine isn't here!" Peterson sounded triumphant.

"When's she back?"

"I don't know."

"Look, it's really important that I speak with her."

Peterson laced his fingers back behind his head and breathed in deeply. "Anything you've got to say, you can say it to me. I run this team, remember? Christine's been temporarily transferred."

Thomas gave the bug one last touch for safety's sake and brought his hands to his face, like a poor impression of *The Scream*. "Bob, I need your help . . ." Now he was totally winging it, leaping from word to word at twenty thousand feet. "They've got Miranda and they want the documents from Harwich."

Pure bloody guesswork, but Peterson twitched at the 'H' word. *Shit or bust*. "On the day you were there, Bob, the day I photographed you." Now,

just rest a minute and see what happens.

Peterson's face turned a sickly shade; he folded like a bad poker player. "If you've got something they want, just give it to them — for all our sakes."

"I need to know Miranda's okay — can you get a message to her?"
Subtext: are you involved, you bastard?

Peterson wiped the sweat from his lips and stared at the desk; he looked like he wanted out, in a bad way. "Why did you have to get involved? I mean, you're not with SIS or anything. You're a bloody civilian!"

"Hey, I was doing my job. And then you turn up at this office . . ." *And pause again to let Peterson fill in the blanks.*

"I was sent here, Thomas," Bob Peterson raised his hands like a beggar. "You think I wanted to be at Harwich, or here? I've a wife and family, for God's sake — you're not the only one with something to lose."

Thomas's immediate reaction was 'tell that to Christine.' But he kept his mouth shut. Peterson was just a pawn in someone else's game. "Do you know where Christine is?"

He shook his head; he looked like he wanted to cry. "She took a call early this morning, at the flat. They came and collected her — she looked pleased . . ."

Well at least they were past the pretence; he almost warmed to Peterson for that.

". . . In a people carrier. I was told not to contact her — executive orders, you know where from."

And he did know, now. All roads seemed to lead back to Whitehall.

"Thomas, you can't fight these people. Do what they want and maybe they'll leave us all alone."

He considered that for maybe half a second. "Yeah, and maybe they won't." It was time. "There's something else; I want you to sign out a vest for me."

Peterson's eyes widened. "Body armour?" He gulped. "I can't issue you with a weapon — there's no way . . ."

Thomas shook his head slowly, crediting him with enough intelligence to figure it out. "I only need the vest."

Peterson made the call and signed the chit for Stores. It was a shame that Bob's voice was so off-key, for the recording. Still, Thomas could

always edit it afterwards; he was good at that.

“What . . . what are you going to do?” Peterson handed over the chit, like a signed confession.

“I don’t know. It depends on Yorgi . . .”

The face before him drained; it was like someone had slit Peterson’s throat. So, Bob was in deeper than he’d imagined. He knew that if he stayed any longer, he’d end up asking questions about Yorgi; things that would only weaken his resolve, the way that Petrov had crumbled every time his maniac brother had got in touch.

“One more thing,” he stopped at the door. “If you *can* get a message to Miranda,” he paused, trying to think of something more meaningful than ‘I love her.’ “Her dog’s very ill; tell her that Butch will have to be put down.”

Chapter 35

“So,” Thomas said to himself in the car, “that went well, all things considered.” On the seat beside him was the latest, lightweight, standard-issue body armour. It had pinched a bit under the arm when he’d tried it on, but he could live with that. If things went badly — and he had a nasty feeling that things could get very bad indeed — it might make the difference between living and not living.

All reason told him to go back to the flat and stay put, but he was past the point of reason. As the car escaped from the gridlock of Liverpool Street, instead of heading east for Walthamstow he turned north, ploughing through trendy Islington, dodging scooters and Smart cars, through to the Angel where he picked up the A1.

One thing was nagging him, something Peterson had said about Christine. She’d looked *pleased*. Not coerced, not under duress: pleased. A pound to a penny then that she had to be involved. Stupid of him to have trusted her; she’d always been a career woman. Bob was probably just her stepping-shag to something better.

He drove on to the *Welcome Break* and re-stocked the car with snacks and petrol. On the way out he powered up the mobile, ever the optimist. And on to Plan C. If Christine was involved, there was one person sure to know. A person so close to Christine that she even discussed her sex life with her. As he’d found out before, to his cost.

* * *

There are some journeys in life that a person never looks forward to — the dentist, funeral directors, and the STD clinic. Thomas had added Gerrard Hall a couple of years back, when he and Christine had been involved. In what her mother apparently still referred to as ‘the social experiment.’ Okay, so the imposing house wasn’t actually called Gerrard Hall — except by him — but it might as well have been. The class divide again, large as life.

On the drive over, he worked through his pitch. Christine was missing and no one was talking. But if she’d gone willingly, surely she must have been expecting it? Another of Sir Peter Bastard’s little exercises, perhaps?

The sign for the village of Amptill triggered all kinds of memories. Meeting her parents for the first time; the great sweeping drive, Christine beside him — poised but nervous; the house staff looking at him with disdain, like she'd found Heathcliff in a ditch. He laughed at himself as he drove along, remembering his dire attempts at fitting in — the diamond-patterned sweater and the new jacket: priceless. All he'd needed was a pair of plus-fours and a silk cravat.

The sight of the gates sobered him. He pulled over and stared through the bars. The CCTV cameras were an innovation; they must really be serious about keeping the oiks out. This would not be easy; any inquiries would not be well received coming from him, oik that he was. He checked for voicemail and came back empty-handed.

A Land Rover towing a horsebox passed him and the passenger swivelled round to get a good look. The sticker on the back said: 'I slow down for horses.' Big deal. 'I give blood for horses,' now that would be a sacrifice.

He started up the car and fell in behind at a respectful distance. He breathed in the great expanse of greenery and tried to prepare himself for the inevitable welcoming committee. The horse saviours peeled right, towards the stables; he waved them off.

The car made that wonderful sound on gravel, the one that reminded him of horse drawn carriages, and *Pride and Prejudice*. In the Gerrards' case, class and prejudice. He couldn't even cut Christine some slack on that score.

One of the staff was on him before he'd opened the door. "Excuse me, sir, but this is a private residence — can I help you?"

"I'm here to see Mrs Gerrard — Francesca."

The underling scuttled away. A curtain flickered ever so slightly behind one of the drawing-room windows. He waited outside and listened for whinnying from the stables. There was the faint whiff of horseshit, which he'd always found appropriate on those few occasions in the past when he'd been allowed to cross the threshold.

The butler, or whatever he was, returned, his back bent forward slightly as if in permanent deference. Most likely his family had come over with the Gerrards when the Normans arrived on their expansion tour of Britain. "If you'd like to come this way, sir." The last word sounded a little like cur.

* * *

Francesca Gerrard was waiting for him in the doorway. Everything about her was tailored; tailored skirt, tailored cardigan, tailored smile. A string of pearls circled her neck, knotted and extended to her waist like a pendulum. "It's been a long time, Thomas."

It was a cool reception, bordering on frosty. Not like when she'd come on to him, that one time, when the champers had flowed on Christine's birthday. A polite, but firm hand extended in his general vicinity. "Why don't you come through?" she walked off, leaving him little choice other than to stand there, gathering dust. The manservant nodded to her and retreated to the shadows.

The room that Thomas found his way to was like an American vision of liddle-biddy ol' England. Mahogany furniture fought for floor space with oak and ash. Displayed in one corner of the room was a suit of armour. He wanted to go over and lift up the visor, do the classic joke: anything to calm his nerves. She seemed in no rush to hear what he had to say; which made him even more nervous.

A servant arrived, with an extra cup, placed it on the tray and glided out.

"Please make yourself comfortable."

As if that would ever be possible here. He caught the look on his face in a mirror, and blushed. He was behaving like a lout and with no good reason. He was, in truth, a snob. Christine had seen that from the off. Maybe that had been part of the attraction.

"I take it you're here on business?"

"Ah, yes. Mrs Gerrard — Francesca, I really need to see Christine."

"I'm afraid that's not possible."

He squinted: interesting choice of words. "Is she here?" he glanced in the direction of the stables.

She looked worried for a moment then recovered her stone façade. "Christine is very discreet about her career, but one gets a sense of these things."

He sipped his Earl Grey and tried to keep a lid on his temper. "Do you know where Christine is? I have to talk to her." The words came out like a threat.

“After the damage you’ve done, I hardly think she’ll want to speak with you.” Francesca snorted, like one of her precious horses.

He tried her words on for size. What damage had he done? “Look, Francesca, I don’t have time for this.”

He launched out of the chair, and through the open French doors, round to the courtyard at the side of the house. All the while, yelling for Christine. One of the stablehands rushed up to see what the commotion was.

“It’s alright, Stewart,” Mrs Gerrard appeared by the arch.

The stablehand took a long hard look at Thomas, who shook his head slowly and flexed a fist. Today, he was not in the mood.

Horse-boy retreated and Francesca sauntered towards him. “Christine isn’t here; satisfied? She’s working on something clandestine,” she paused, “but you of all people should know that.” Her hand lifted to catch her jaw.

He couldn’t help yielding a tiny smile at her discomfort.

“What’s going on, Thomas?”

His mobile rang and they both jumped. “Thomas, it’s Ann Crossley. Karl asked me to look out for you. You need to get out of there *now*.”

He left Francesca standing and sprinted around the side of the house, back to the car. The manservant was bending down close to one of the tyres. “Touch it and I’ll break your face!” he hollered, rising a fist to show he wasn’t pissing about.

It bought him the precious seconds he needed, better for everyone. Given the choice he would have run him over, no question about it. The car roared into life and wheel-span, showering the hapless butler with gravel.

He saw the blue sedan approaching at speed; it wasn’t budging for anyone. At the last moment he swerved wide, churning up the carefully tended lawn like a protest vote. He heard the car screech to a stop behind him, but he’d already veered around it, gunning towards the open gates to rejoin the road, his heart thumping in his chest like war-drums.

* * *

Thomas opened the driver’s window; he needed some air. What the hell was going on? Nothing made any sense. If this was Sir Peter’s people, they’d already know he’d agreed to get the DSB so why the intercept? If it was Yorgi — he took a deep breath — how would he know where Thomas was? Maybe Francesca Gerrard had arranged some secret signal to bring in

the heavy mob? He tried to stick to facts. How many had he seen in the car? Two, he thought. But you don't stop to do a headcount when someone's trying to run you off the road.

Back on the A1, with no sign of the blue sedan following him, he turned his deductive powers to the phone call. Karl had said he was on better terms with Ann Crossley so that made sense, sort of. And Karl might have told her about the legit tracker on the car, same as Teresa. So why were all his allies keeping their distance?

When he got back to the flat, there was a message waiting on the machine, blinking insistently. The voice was measured, under control. "It's John; ring me with an update." He cleared it off, poured himself a Southern Comfort and stood for a while, gazing at Miranda's photograph. "I won't let you down," he whispered.

It was early in the day for a drink, but he figured he'd earned it. The need to ring John back pressed hard upon his temples, but the sweet, sharp taste on his lips won on points. He moved the chair round to face the door; too much thinking — that was the problem.

And what about Teresa? If Karl was an enigma, then Teresa was a sphinx under witness protection. Maybe that was the draw for Karl — a mystery deeper than himself.

He dug out a notepad and pen and wrote down all the names, hoping it would help: Karl, Teresa, Ann Crossley, Sir Peter Carroll, Bob 'scumbag' Peterson and Christine Gerrard. Then he scrawled lines between them, linking some and excluding others. He stared at the page until his eyes ached, as if he could solve it like a logic puzzle. But all he noticed was that he'd extended the double 'r' in Gerrard, making them look like a pair of legs. His arm throbbed and his head hurt, and he was all out of ideas.

Chapter 36

Eighteen . . . nineteen . . . twenty . . . done. Miranda eased back on the exercise bike and glanced over at the wall-length mirror; a good workout. The sweat dripped from her headband and had stained her top like heavy raindrops. She was alone, save for ‘Pumping Classics 3 — music to shape and tone to.’ They left her alone in the exercise room because there were no windows, hence no way out. At this rate she’d be super-fit again; she visited three or four times a day, for short bursts, just for something to do.

She’d surprised herself by how quickly she’d adjusted to the regime; and maybe disappointed herself too. Three days? Four days? It all blended into one. Everywhere she went was supervised, except the bathroom, the bedroom and the gym. Though no doubt someone was always close by. This was like the worst health club in the world; talk about killing with kindness. No one had threatened or mistreated her; they just kept her under watch and interspersed the boredom with twenty questions; the same twenty questions.

Mainly they asked about Thomas; otherwise it was the Irish bloke, national security and random stuff that made no sense whatsoever. And always there was the suggestion that Thomas was in real danger and that her information could be vital. No one seemed to know how long she would be there, or the specifics of why Thomas was in trouble. Or else they weren’t saying.

And what did *she* know? Well, there was one tarmac lane to the front of the house and high fencing around the estate. A walled garden extended to the back of the house with a single arch at the far end and some trees beyond it. Not that she’d ever got close. Whenever she was outdoors, someone always stood back there, supposedly to check it was safe for her. At first, the mixture of bullshit and bureaucracy had been amusing — for a day or so. The thick glass on the sealed bedroom windows was the first wake-up call.

The exercise bike beeped as the last of the dials powered down, so she relaxed her grip. Alice Eyeball had promised to try and find out more about

Thomas today, but that was hours ago. Face it, Miranda, she told herself, until they find whatever they're looking for, you're stuck here.

She checked her no-run make-up and pressed her palms against the glass. Maybe this was one of those two-way mirrors like the police were supposed to use. Like Elvis. She put a finger on her sweatband, traced it down the side of her face and diagonally across her top. If there was a perv watching, he was very quiet about it. Then she sniffed at her shoulder and wrinkled her nose. Funny really, the way her own sweat reminded her of Thomas, the scent of their bodies after their favourite exercise routine.

Time to hit the showers. She wiped the bicycle seat then grabbed the door handle. Alice was standing in front of her like an apparition.

"Jesus!" Miranda flinched.

Alice jumped back about a foot. "Sorry, didn't mean to startle you," she blushed. "Somebody's on their way here to see you."

"How long have I got?"

"She'll be here in about twenty minutes."

It would have to be a quick shower then.

* * *

After making herself presentable, she sat down on the bed and picked up her notepad. The one they gave her to write down anything important she remembered. The one she was certain they checked whenever she left the room.

How many former couples still bother to recall where they met and what they know about their ex's job? Play twenty questions at least twice a day and it soon comes back to you. This was the sanitised version, of course. No Bladen family back-story — nothing about the blazing row with Thomas's parents when they first met her or their jaw-dropping opening line: 'Are you pregnant?' No, this was the family-friendly set. Met in Leeds, moved back to London, Civil Service, break-up, SSU: neat and tidy as a stashed roll of £50s.

Alice was at the bedroom door again, so she picked up the notepad and brought it out with her. Alice led the way to the interview room. "In here please," she said, standing back a couple of feet. She didn't stick around either.

Sod it, Miranda thought; I'm not knocking. The catch turned quietly and the first thing she saw was a dark-haired woman looking out the window, talking on a mobile. Her lips formed the words 'fucking 'ell.' Her mouth ran dry. The world of strange had just acquired a new territory. She reached back and pushed the door until it clicked.

The woman at the window looked round and abruptly finished her call. Miranda couldn't be certain, but the last words sounded like, 'Thanks Bob.'

"Hello, you must be Miranda!" All smiles. Miranda played Simple Simon and mirrored her. "I'm . . ."

Yes, Miranda beamed; I know who *you* are.

". . . Christine. I work with Thomas. I've come for a little chat."

Miranda sat on the sofa and wondered how long she could keep a straight face. She'd only seen Christine twice before — and one of those was at a distance. But you never forget your ex's *new* girlfriend — you don't need a notepad for that. The first time was when Thomas had arranged back-to-back pub meets. And even though she'd teased him about staying in the bar, in the end she'd scarpered out the side door, just in time to peer in through the window.

Seeing Christine brought it all back — how jealous she'd been at the way Thomas had got on with his life while she was in Bermuda; had got on Christine, that was. Horses, that had been it; she smiled at the recollection. Christine was into horses. She'd pranced into that pub like an Arabian, all high-headed and flighty, trotting round the bar as if she owned it. Not a way to win friends in Whitechapel. And Miranda herself? Well, a thoroughbred of course. Yeah, ancient history now, but all the same she had to catch her breath when Christine leaned forward to speak.

"I can only imagine how difficult this must be for you, Miranda."

Miranda opened her notebook, as if she was rehearsing a play. Christine flattened her hand over the page. "Thomas hasn't been himself at work lately — you've probably noticed that, too?"

Miranda tilted her head back and nearly laughed. "We're not a couple."

"I'm sorry, I thought . . ." Christine seemed to give the sentence up as a bad idea.

Miranda turned the spotlight round. "Have you talked to Thomas?"

Christine did the 'eyes to one corner' thing. Sheryl at Caliban's reckoned it meant whatever came out next was either a memory or a lie.

Miranda got in there first. “I know you and Thomas were involved.”

Christine nodded. “I thought as much; the way you reacted just now . . .”

“Then let’s cut the crap,” Miranda chucked the notepad in her direction. “That’s as much as I know. Now, have you spoken to him; is he okay?”

Christine surveyed the pages and without looking up, whispered, “He saw one of my colleagues today.” She put a finger to her lips and glanced at the door.

Miranda watched as she carefully tiptoed over. A second’s pause then she wrenched the door open; no one was behind it. “Good,” Christine turned and smiled; “now we can talk a little more freely.”

It was stupid and clever at the same time, but Miranda knew this was the first person she’d seen who definitely knew Thomas. And maybe cared about him too, in her high-handed, flighty way. “Would that be Karl or Bob Peterson?”

Christine blanched; Miranda fought hard not to gloat. That ought to burst the balloon. “So now we understand each other, why don’t you stop fucking me around and tell me why they’re keeping me here?”

“He said you were confrontational,” Christine managed a sliver of a smile.

“Look, let’s get on with this — we both want the same thing, for Thomas to be safe.”

“*Thomas?*” Christine went a funny shade again.

* * *

Christine ordered coffee and Posh Bloke acted as a waiter. When he’d gone, she scanned through Miranda’s notepad again and went down a different line of inquiry. How did Thomas get on with his family? That one drew a wry smile, from both of them. Next it was: how often did Miranda see Thomas? That was a weird one. And then the topper: why was Miranda driving his car that day?

Miranda gulped at her coffee wearily. “What’re you actually after?”

“Alright,” Christine closed the pad and passed it back to her gently. “What if I were to say to you that Thomas is suspected of corruption or espionage?”

“Bollocks,” Miranda erupted, “I don’t believe it.”

“Good — neither do I.” That sounded like a confession.

“So why am I stuck here, then?”

Christine rolled her shoulders back, as if she was trying to shrug off a great weight. “It appears that Thomas helped someone steal a package.”

“The ones he delivers for work?”

“Hmm.” Christine stopped short of confirmation. “Only this one was being carried by someone else.”

“Can’t help you there,” Miranda pulled down the shutters. “But I do know he was worried about *you* — because of this Peterson bloke. He’s the bent one, by the sound of things.”

“Listen to me very carefully,” Christine brought a hand under her mug. “It would not be in your interests to repeat that to anyone.”

Miranda tilted her head to one side and stuck out her jaw. “You don’t scare me; you’re just a posh bitch in a suit. What are you supposed to be — the heavy?”

“No,” Christine looked down at the floor, “not me,” her voice wavered.

For a moment, Miranda felt something for her other than contempt — only for a moment though. “I think we’ve both said enough, don’t you?”

Christine conceded the point. “Yes, why don’t we draw a line there; we can always speak again later. I brought some DVDs over.”

“Great,” Miranda bubbled with mock enthusiasm. “Let’s go watch a film together,” she searched her brain for something apt; Thomas would have been brilliant at this. *Got it*. “How about *On Her Majesty’s Secret Service*?”

Judging by her face, Christine was not impressed. “Look, Miranda, we’re on the same side — let me prove it to you. I was given a message today, relayed from Thomas.” She paused and lowered her voice. “It’s bad news I’m afraid; your dog’s very ill.”

“My what?” Miranda flinched back against the cushion.

“Thomas said that Butch would have to be put down.” The room went deathly still. Christine moved back to the window.

Putting Butch down? How? Was Thomas mounting some sort of rescue — did he know where she was being held? Shit. They were all armed here; they made no secret about that. Even Alice Eyeball was packing a piece.

“I’m very sorry about your dog; was he old?”

Miranda closed her eyes and tried to focus. “Er . . . yeah. I . . . I need to lie down for a while.”

Chapter 37

The shrill ringtone on Thomas's mobile sliced into his brain like a steak knife. He woke, all arms and legs, sending his notes across the floor. He stabbed at the green button, working his lips to try and dispel the gummy, stale taste in his mouth. "Hello?"

"It's Teresa; open your door."

He checked the curtain; she was alone. In her hand was a small holdall.

"What kept you?"

"Sorry," his head felt muzzy, "I was asleep."

"Have you been drinking?" she pushed straight past him like she owned the place.

"Only a couple. Listen, Christine Gerrard has done a disappearing act." He'd expected some kind of reaction. But no, Teresa was too good for that.

She opened the holdall and carefully removed the Document Security Bag. "Over to you, then," she put it down and folded her gloved hands together.

"I won't be long. Try not to search the place." Not even a glimmer; not a flicker of warmth. Karl must really suffer on cold nights.

His initial trepidation faded the moment he closed the darkroom door and latched it. No surprises there. Whatever crap the world was throwing at him, all he needed was a camera or a darkroom and he was transformed. Christ, even his dad became a better person when cameras were introduced into the equation.

He snapped on a pair of latex gloves and broke the seal on the yellow DSB. Under the red light it looked a murky orange brown. The box inside was untagged, just as Teresa had promised. He slid the lid off and immediately turned the pages upside down. Stupid as it sounded — even to himself — he wanted to be able to say he hadn't read any of it. Not deliberately, anyway.

That was easy for the first four pages — two in French and two in German. After that he focused on the top left and top right letters, now inverted, to get the focus. He checked after every photograph that the camera's infrared dot was still off in case it marked the paper. He kept his

movements controlled and precise; his teacher from school Camera Club would have been proud.

Once he'd reset the box and sealed it in the new DSB — the one from Leeds — he felt the sweat nestling between his shoulder blades. The photos were fine, but he was a wreck. He unlatched the door and went out, still wearing the surgical gloves. "It's done."

"You've been in there for thirty minutes — what took you so long?"

Jesus; talk about ungrateful. "You wanted this done right, didn't you? I'll set up the printer for you."

She followed him to the laptop. "I'll need your camera data-card as well."

Of course you will. God forbid you should start trusting me now. He connected everything up, set it to print and walked off to the kitchen. "Call me when you're done. Do you want any tea?"

"No thanks; I had some while I was waiting."

He took his tea and loitered near the doorway until she called him back. All done and dusted, pages printed and enveloped; data-card removed. As if it had never happened.

"Thank you, Thomas." She looked relieved, already putting her coat on. "Remember what we agreed. At least two days."

Well, *agreed* was putting it a bit strongly. He walked her to the door. "So what do I do, then? Ring up Whitehall in a couple of days' time and tell them Special Delivery?"

"You'll need to figure that out for yourself. Whatever it takes, we *need* those two days. Ideally we'd have preferred more time, but under the circumstances, we're willing to compromise."

He felt like punching her face in — that, or crying. She opened the front door and pulled her holdall close. He pondered its cargo, and tried to forget that the pages included names, addresses, account-like number strings and some sort of contract.

"And this is where I return to the shadows; goodnight, Mr Bladen, and good luck." She'd only taken a few steps outside when a car started up, flicked on the headlights and pulled up parallel to her. In the blink of an eye, she was gone.

* * *

He bolted the door and stood in the centre of the living room. After all the tension, the silence in the flat seemed forced and unnatural. He waited for a moment, until his breathing had subsided. Then he reached into his back pocket and pulled out a second data-card, twin to the one he'd handed over to Teresa. *Clever boy.*

At that point he didn't really care what was on it; it was collateral. He had recognised one upside word though, in French: *état* — state, in English. United States of Europe, maybe? He checked the clock — time to make that call.

“John, hiya mate. I got your message. Tonight? Sure. I've got a couple of things to do before . . . right . . . I understand. I'll be in a cab in ten minutes.” A minicab to Dagenham then; no expense spared.

Camera, secret data-card, gun and ammo, clothes, DSB, toothbrush and shaver, laptop and Sherlock Holmes book — everything for the modern spy about town. Thanks to traffic, it took almost an hour to get to Dagenham so he opted for the station. £45 all told, but the cabbie did throw in a series of free lectures on the way.

About the class divide, the racial divide, about what a pain in the arse lazy good-for-nothing sons were and how all the bloody immigrants coming over here were ruining everything. And all to a musical backdrop of what he now knew to be Bengali Asian Fusion. And every second or third sentence from the driver rounded off with ‘Do you get me?’ which he quickly learned didn't require an answer, as it made no bloody difference.

* * *

It was a surprise that Diane was the pick-up. The only time Thomas saw her at the wheel was when they were going out for the evening and John had decided to make a serious assault on his own liver.

She didn't have much to say, which was fair enough. He was probably the last person she wanted to see so he didn't push it. She seemed to thaw a little by the time they reached the house, but it was hard to tell; at least she was prepared to look him in the face now.

Sam and Terry's car spaces were empty; it looked like dinner for three, unless Sheryl — the other member of his fan club — was putting in an appearance. As they went inside, Diane told him, “Dinner will be ready in

fifteen minutes.” Which played in his head as: you have fifteen minutes to give us some good news.

He cut straight to the chase and dug out the sealed DSB, reminded them how he’d acquired it and why it would secure Miranda’s safe release. It all sounded foolproof until he noticed the gun, amongst his things in the bag. If Diane had seen it, she didn’t react; it might have been business as usual for her, given the nature of *their* business.

After the DSB, he handed over the data-card. “It’s an unauthorised copy of whatever’s in the pouch.”

John held the little case carefully at its edges. “We’ll keep it safe for you.”

Over dinner, Diane pressed him on how the transfer would be made; an answer he still didn’t have. John Wright had ideas of his own. “Take the boys with you, as back-up.”

Diane slammed her cutlery down.

Thomas read her face and winced. “It’s fine, John, honestly.”

“No.” John looked first at him then at Diane. “You misunderstand. I insist.”

In all the years Thomas had known him, John had never done *menacing*, until now. Not even when Thomas had turned up on their doorstep as a stranger, with Miranda on his arm. Forthright and unequivocal, maybe, but never this.

“The boys will be waiting at the scrapyard, first thing tomorrow.”

Thomas had to force down the rest of his meal; hungry as he was, he couldn’t dislodge a bitter aftertaste. He skipped the post-dinner drink and followed them to the comfy chairs, for more questions.

He offered up Bob Peterson’s promise of getting a message to Miranda. Then Diane had to spend ten minutes talking John out of making a personal visit to Uncle Bob. Which reminded him . . . “Can I use your internet?”

John and Diane pulled up chairs behind him; he didn’t comment. First, he picked up an anonymous server, then he took a slip of paper out of his wallet and set it on the keyboard; no point being coy now. He touch-typed a URL and went through the appropriate security, clicking on ‘telephony,’ and upped the volume. “This is a recording of all Bob Peterson’s calls from Christine’s office, today.”

There were seven calls in all. The kick-off, provoking a chorus of obscenity from everyone, was Bob Peterson ringing Sir Peter Carroll's office to warn him that Thomas had requested a protective vest. The reply was dismissive; Thomas was being cautious, nothing more. He was just an amateur.

For some reason Thomas couldn't fathom, that still cut deep. Two calls later and it was Christine ringing in on Peterson's mobile. The sound wasn't brilliant, but Miranda was mentioned, with Peterson relaying the message about Miranda's dog Butch.

"Huh?" John said. Diane reached forward without a word, pressing Thomas's shoulder: the boy done good.

Thomas went through the calls sequentially. Peterson kept trying to extricate himself. "I've got a wife and child!" he pleaded, the signal swooping and dipping as the mobile moved about.

"Well then," the line on the recording suddenly cleared; "You'd better think about them very carefully."

Poor sod. The caller was male, well-spoken, mid-twenties. The sound quality dipped again, as if a moment's grace had passed. Then the voices went metallic and Thomas started to lose the thread. But one word pierced the cacophony: *Yorgi*.

He felt sick to his stomach; it as good as proved that he'd been on the right track since Petrov. He blinked back a tear and stayed schtum because he couldn't deal with their fear as well as his own. Because if it was Yorgi, then Miranda was in more danger than they could imagine.

Now what? He opted for distraction. "I'll leave the log-in details here, for tomorrow," and listened to the sound of his heart pounding against his chest. What would Karl do? He stared at the screen, catching sight of John's inbox, crunched up onscreen and half-filled with porn and spam. Karl would improvise, that's what he'd do.

"Could you give me a few minutes please?"

John and Diane took the hint, left him to it and moved over to the sofa.

* * *

He worked quickly, without an audience.

Step 1: Set up a webmail account with a slew of random numbers and letters.

Step 2: Get the six-digit Ordinance Survey reference for the Wapping scrapyards.

Step 3: And here was the bit so clever that Thomas grinned as he was doing it — translate key words into something that would pique Karl's curiosity.

Irish Gaelic was a bit too obvious so what about . . . Kosovan Albanian. A quick internet search and he plumped for two words, cutting straight to the point: *betejë* and *shpëtim* — battle and rescue. He figured Karl would have picked up at least one of those words out there during his army days; he was counting on it.

In the body of the email from his seemingly random email address, he put in a message: *'Are you looking for gud time, big love? Order now.'* Then he added '0800' followed by the OS reference. He kept the title as informative as he dared: *'Sexi Kosovo Girls betejë and shpëtim . . . spurm.'* An easy to find reference to tomorrow, a few more keystrokes and away the email went, hopefully winging its way to Karl's spam email folder, where only Karl would see it. *Job done.*

John or Diane had put the telly on; though neither of them seemed to be watching.

"I'll get her back." Now seemed a good time to make outlandish promises. It was one he'd made himself. He had a Plan B. If the worst happened — and he'd confronted that nightmare frequently since Miranda had been abducted — he would track down and kill everyone responsible. No question; no messing; no macho bollocks — no exceptions. He gasped for air and swam to the surface of his thoughts. "I'll need more ammunition."

Diane actually smiled at him.

Jesus. He felt like he'd just shared dinner with the Grissom Gang. "I just want to say that I really appreciate you letting me deal with this."

John crossed his legs. "For now," he looked away at the clock. "Right," he decided aloud, "you better turn in for the night; early start tomorrow. You're in Miranda's room."

Thomas dragged himself out of the chair, said his goodnights and took his bag off with him. The door still had Miranda's nameplate on it. He almost knocked; he felt like an intruder.

Closing her door behind him, he stared at the bed, bag still in hand as if he wasn't sure whether he would be staying. Now and again, they'd shared that bed — in their crazy on-again, off-again merry-go-round. He approached the duvet and ran a hand along one edge reverently.

Either Miranda had stayed there recently or Diane had left a trace of her favourite perfume to really twist the knife. He closed his eyes and inhaled deeply, imagining her in front of him.

He checked the en suite — for no reason other than to be away from the bed. The figure in the mirror looked haggard and drawn; he barely recognised himself. He closed his eyes again and tried to feel Miranda close behind him, the soft pressure and heat of her breasts against his back; her laughter at his 'oh so serious' face and the sparkle in her eyes under the starry ceiling spotlights.

He wanted to pray, the whole shebang. To kneel down right now on the bath mat, asking for intercession and atonement for his sins. But the thing that stopped him cold wasn't a lack of faith — patchy as that could be. No, he still didn't know what he'd done wrong in the first place, not where Miranda was concerned.

He brushed his teeth, did the necessary and confronted the bed. He chose Miranda's side of the duvet. And okay, he wasn't proud of it or anything, but the bedside cabinet was just too tempting. And it wasn't like he was going to search through the whole room or anything. But he was restless and it was still early . . .

The top drawer was a mass of little yellow post-its, built up over time. He flicked through, tracing Miranda's neat, round handwriting with his fingertips. Underneath that little memory sculpture, he found some old lunch menus from Caliban's and even one from its former incarnation. Was chicken and chips ever really that cheap? This was stupid, he told himself, and carried on anyway. Just the top drawer, he promised himself, digging deeper past the tampons and some paperback called *Perfumed Garden*. Below all that was a 'confidential counselling' leaflet with a date and time scribbled on it. He blushed and lifted it out, along with a couple of postcards — both from Bermuda, from Miranda. One, to Mum and Dad, read: *Everything will be alright. Miranda x*. The other, to the whole family, said: *Looking forward to coming home again. I love you. Miranda x*. He put everything back in order and shut the drawer.

Chapter 38

Miranda, Christine and Alice sat on the sofa together. In any other setting, this could have been a mid-week girls' night in — complete with chick flick, pizza and red wine. Posh Bloke, now identified as Nicholas, had been a right misery about the choice of film; he'd claimed his share of the deep-pan and left them to it. Jack had stopped for a while then announced he was going to patrol the perimeter. Silently, Miranda presumed, like he did everything else.

It was an okay film — they'd let Miranda choose it. When Jack had fetched it back with the food, it was missing a label, a receipt and a bag. Maybe they'd shoplifted it to order. Still, she'd resolved to make the best of it.

Everyone laughed or held their breath at the right places; they just didn't speak to each other, except to move the goodies around. Just at the point in the film where the sassy-yet-caring girl-next-door realised that her best friend was a better match than the scuzzball of a boyfriend, a small green light in the wall flickered into life.

Christine jumped up, barked a code word to Alice and shouted for Nicholas and Jack. It didn't take Brain of Britain to work out that all was not well. "Jack — comms room, now!"

Miranda sat and watched the mayhem play out. She wondered if Christine had spoken like that to Thomas; maybe she still did during office hours. Then the penny dropped: they had a comms room — probably hidden cameras outside. What if Thomas was out there?

She stood up — on the pretence of stretching — and hugged herself like an orphan, in the centre of the room. Alice had her gun drawn and looked very, very scared. "You'd better go to your room."

The door sprang wide open, almost as wide as the look on Alice's face.

"Oh, for heaven's sake, stand down," In a single sentence, Christine turned Alice into a child.

Miranda looked at Christine through narrowed eyes; what was really going on here? Christine twitched and broke eye contact. Nicholas strode

into the room like a lion. He did everything but spray the place, and by the look on his face, he was thinking about it.

“May I have your attention everyone; my colleague will be staying with us for a couple of days.”

The stranger waited at the doorway until he had everyone’s attention. “Ah, my dear,” he crossed the floor to Miranda and extended a well-manicured hand. “Such a pleasure. You may call me Yorgi.”

She accepted graciously — no sense getting off on the wrong foot. Nice watch, if you were into retro.

“And you,” Yorgi clicked his fingers at Nicholas, “you will join us in the interview. The rest of you are not required.” Then he laughed; the kind of laugh that makes you check where your children are.

Miranda found herself complying, meekly following them to the interview room. No one else had moved. Earlier, she’d thought that she and Christine had made some kind of connection. Well, maybe that was just a mind game to soften her up for the big one.

* * *

Yorgi didn’t take prisoners. Initially he was all charm and sophistication but, Jeez, the cruelty in that man’s eyes. He looked at her with the cold gaze of a predator; a woman gets to know the type, if she’s unlucky.

At first Miranda figured she’d ride out the storm and basically wear them out. But this guy was good; he asked the same question ten different ways. No drinks, no comfort breaks and no one to help her. Nicholas seemed to relish every minute, watching the master at work. And even though she knew she had nothing more to tell them, after an hour in their company, she wished she had.

“You must think!” Yorgi banged the desk again. Nicholas jumped too. Yeah, for all that alpha male act, he was as frightened of this bloke as the rest of them.

“Did Thomas mention a package — a delicate matter of security?”

She shook her head again then remembered his insistence on verbal responses. He made Nicholas write everything down, questions and answers. “I need the loo,” she was shocked by how small her voice was. She waited while Yorgi considered her request, didn’t leave the chair until he pointed to the door.

“Four minutes. No more.”

Nicholas marched her to the toilet; he looked smug, repeating the time span as if he’d thought it up himself.

She remained on the toilet seat afterwards, watching as her legs twitched. The tears came without warning; she pulled at the loo roll and dabbed her eyes furiously. Not now, not when that fucking savage was trying to break her down. She pinched at her arm — an old trick to displace her weakness in front of her brothers. God, she wished they were here now. She checked her watch — it was going to be a long night.

Chapter 39

Thomas jolted to attention as John rapped on the door and called out ‘six o’clock.’ He yawned and rubbed his eyes; he’d been awake for ages. He recalled being a boy, woken up on Saturdays for his paper round. Looking back, it always seemed to be raining — or snowing — everyone else still warm in bed. His dad would make him a mug of hot, sweet tea to see him on his way. ‘Mustn’t let ’em down, Thomas, mustn’t let ’em down.’ Those words seemed to have followed him around his whole life.

He showered, using Miranda’s gel, even though he’d brought his own along. Then he dressed and sorted through the bag for the fifth time. Shit — no protective vest; he’d left it at the flat. Well, he weighed the pistol in his hand; if push came to shove he’d just have to get the shots in first.

Diane was milling about in the kitchen; she looked like she hadn’t slept a great deal either. She kissed him on the cheek, same as she did all her children, and he felt his stomach twitch. Breakfast was a welcome escape from the possibility of conversation, and Diane had done him and John proud. She sat down with them, nibbling at the world’s smallest piece of toast.

John ran through the itinerary. “This early, I reckon an hour will be plenty.”

Thomas kept his thoughts to himself. An hour? Just to go ten miles up the A13. What was John planning to do, make him walk there?

Diane saw them to the door. The way that she and John held each other took Thomas’s breath away; he thought that kind of certainty only existed on television. It brought him up short — didn’t he and Miranda used to have that kind of relationship? He turned away, but not before he heard John promise Diane that it would all be okay.

“Bring them all back safe, Thomas,” she sounded like she was sending him off to war — and maybe she was.

* * *

John didn’t say much until they were on the A13, joining the other poor bastards travelling into work.

“I put extra clips in your bag while you were in the bog.”

Thomas smiled. He would have made a joke about firepower if his guts weren't churning. He wondered about the gun again — about where it had come from, and its history. His stomach flipped another somersault; better off not knowing.

"Can I ask you something, Thomas?" John didn't wait for permission. "Where'd you learn to use a gun? At the house, you seemed to know what you were doing."

"Indoor firing range."

John looked disappointed. Thomas thought about showing off his flesh wound, as credentials; bloodied in battle, as Karl would say. Yes . . . Karl. Would he have read the email by now? Would he even be able to act on it if he had? Great — something else to stress about.

"Listen . . ." John kept his eyes on the road. "What are you going to do when all this is over? I can't see you keeping your job if you pull a gun on 'em!"

Yeah, that's right, John; lap it up.

The lights hit red; John turned to face him. "Only, me and Diane were talking last night. And, if you needed a job, we could take you on, part-time, like — with the family. 'Cos sometimes people come to me with the sort of problems that someone like you can handle."

Wow. Thomas locked eyes with John for a second or two. He felt the heat rise up his face and choke him. After all the shit he'd brought on Miranda and the family, they were still willing to chuck him a lifeline.

"No, er, need to commit yourself right now, Thomas."

The lights turned green and his guts did more gymnastics. Back in Pickering, Ajit's dad used to take them out on the moors. Often, on the way back, he'd wish that the car would break down, just to delay getting home. Or he'd count down every ten trees or street lights, surrendering territory in batches of ten. He was doing it *now*; he didn't realise it at first, but he was still wishing for something he couldn't have.

* * *

"We're here," John kept the car running. "I'll check that website for any more phone conversations from that Peterson bloke and ring you if anything turns up."

The breezeblock walls of the scrapyard were covered in graffiti, making it look like a techno-fortress. Thomas figured Sam and Terry weren't fussed; he remembered Sam's fondness for the spray can in his teens. What goes around, and all that.

Above the wall was a layer of corrugated steel. Some of that had been colonised by Street Artists Anonymous too. The E1 posse might be feeble, but he didn't rate their chances if they ever went over the fence into the yard.

The door set within the main gate was open and waiting. He banged on the panelling and announced himself.

"Hey Thomas, how's it going?" Sam could always be relied upon for a warm welcome. Terry though, looked like he was sizing him up. Sam elbowed him sharply.

"Alright, Terry?"

Terry sniffed aloud, like a Rottweiler gauging the scent of a rival. "Are you sure you're up to this?"

Up to this? He took a few steps forward, into their domain. No question, because when it all came down to it, he'd *have* to be. He dropped his bag by the door. "I am, if you two back me all the way."

Good answer. And true, as it goes. John Wright was a shrewd man. Now there were three chances of getting Miranda out, and if it all went pear-shaped he had people he could trust implicitly.

He closed the door behind him and drew the bolt across the gate. Terry led the way, through the scrapyard, deep among the junk-filled skips and piled up cars. In one derelict cul-de-sac, a series of crude targets had already been set up, ready for practice.

It took less than half a clip to realise that drawing from a shoulder holster was too slow. It was Terry who nailed it — too clumsy, too telegraphed; the way Thomas moved one arm across and the other instinctively backwards to give better access to the weapon. Plus, he'd hopefully be wearing a vest and that might slow him further.

He reverted to the basics and once he'd cleared a row of targets, both brothers seemed to lose their scepticism. Okay, they weren't slapping him on the back or anything, but they listened now when he gave instructions for repositioning new targets. He shot from standing, kneeling, lying down; a crash course in 'aim and fire' — not 'think then aim then think and fire.'

Think too much, on this occasion, and it could be the last thing he did. He yawned; fatigue and the constant spectre of fear were taking their toll.

Sam came to the rescue. “Don’t worry, Thomas, I’ll make us all a brew.”

Yeah, nothing like a nice cuppa after a hard day’s shooting. They sat on planks raised up by milk crates, staring down at the makeshift targets — two shop dummies and beer bottles on poles.

“When are you ringing the geezer to make the switch?” Sam sounded so much like a cinema gangster that it was painful.

Thomas turned it over in his brain. Teresa wanted two days’ grace so was that the day after today? And how was he supposed to stall everyone? He scuffed at the ground with his boot. “I’ll contact him later today.” Sam and Terry nodded in unison and the three of them sought refuge in their mugs of tea.

* * *

All Thomas heard was a *click*, far behind him. It was the only warning before a shot rang out, shattering one of the beer bottles. The boys dived for cover; Thomas threw himself on the ground and scrabbled for the handgun, which he’d zipped up in the bag. He was still fiddling with the handle — jammed, naturally — when he heard the boots crunch against the ground towards him.

“See here, Tommo, is this a private party or can anyone join?”

Thomas saw Sam and Terry standing on the periphery, gripping metal bars: futile but admirable.

“Karl McNeill, at your service,” he took a bow and holstered his weapon, which looked like one of his beloved Brownings.

Sam and Terry gave each other a strange look, dropped their weapons and approached him.

“Terry and Sam, I presume? Is there anything left in the pot; I’m gasping!” Karl released a rucksack from his back and cricked his neck in several directions. He was dressed head to foot in black.

“What are you supposed to be?” Thomas thought it best to get in early.

“That’s a fine welcome for a man who’s driven half the night to be here. Seriously, how are you, Tommy?”

After tea, Sam and Terry did the decent thing and buggered off to the nearest café for supplies. Thomas set up new targets — under Karl’s instruction — and Karl unveiled the contents of his rucksack — a veritable armoury.

“So you obviously got my clever message. How did you get away?”

Karl laughed, rat-a-tat-tat style. “Well, my mammy wasn’t willing to write me a note so I did what any decent pal would do — I walked off the job.”

“Really? Shit.” Thomas floundered for words. “So what’s going to happen?”

“Hey, don’t sweat it, Tommo. We have other things to sweat about. Bottom line is, Miranda’s caught up in someone else’s fight — that’s unacceptable. You let me worry about my blistering career. Some things are more important.”

Thomas gulped some tea down to soften the lump in his throat. “So where have you come from then, if you’ve driven half the night?”

“Hey, hey, Mr Bladen,” Karl weighed the two Brownings in his hands, squinting one eye. “That’s confidential information. I’ll have you know that I’ve signed the Official Secrets Act.”

“Twat.”

Karl answered with a volley of two-handed gunfire, blasting bottles in all directions. “So how are you gonna tell Frank and Jesse James about the two-day hiatus?”

Thomas curled a lip. So, Karl had been speaking to Teresa as well. “Dunno — any ideas?”

“As a matter of fact, I have,” Karl exchanged weapons with Thomas for a try-out, “but I’m not sure you’re gonna like it.”

Thomas followed Karl’s drill to the letter, first kneeling then crouching, coming belly down to the ground, walking straight ahead, and all the while shooting. Karl was a natural; no, scratch that, he was an *un-natural*. His hit rate was mesmerising, against an assortment of bottles, headlights and shop dummies.

“You’re really serious about taking down these bastards?” There wasn’t a trace of mockery in Karl’s voice.

Thomas laid the weapon on the ground — safety on — and brushed dust off his jeans. “Yorgi’s definitely involved and he’s not the negotiating

type.” He relayed the fruits of his intelligence gathering.

Karl poked his tongue out and licked his upper lip. “Hear me out now,” he made the pistol safe and passed it over. Thomas put it on the ground. “If we’re getting Miranda in exchange for the papers, *and* taking care of Yorgi — assuming he’s there . . .”

“Oh, he’ll be there,” Thomas felt a shiver run down his spine.

“You need to be somewhere safe; a place you know well. Your life could depend on it. And hers.”

Yeah, thanks for that. Thomas opened his hands to catch some more pearls of wisdom from Guru Karl.

Karl got the message after a few seconds. “Oh, right. If it was me, I’d make the exchange somewhere secure — only one road in and out.”

Thomas wiped the sweat from his neck. “Yeah, but it’s not that simple, is it? They’ve got Miranda — I can’t take any chances; if anything . . .”

Karl brought his hand down hard on Thomas’s shoulder, as if anchoring him. “Do you trust me, Tommo? I mean, *really* trust me? I see a way through this, but you’ll need to do things my way.”

Thomas looked around him; everything was still. There was that feeling again; a sense that Karl knew this was coming and had always known. Still, weigh that up against any other options — precisely none — and what else did he have? Nowt. “I’m listening.”

“You have to dictate the terms. Name the place — and state your price. If you give them a price, they’ll have you down as a rank amateur — which you are not. This gives us a certain, minimal advantage.”

Thomas picked up the empty mug and stared inside. He felt like crying, and he could have filled it to overflowing. “I don’t know. I can’t afford to fuck this up,” he heard the panic in his own voice.

Karl play-punched him on his good arm and shook his head dismissively. “It’s like automatic doors. You keep right on walking at a steady pace and they just open — because it’s what they’re supposed to do.” He did an exaggerated slow march on the spot.

“No guarantees though,” Thomas wasn’t smiling.

And neither was Karl. “No, Tommo, no guarantees.”

He dropped the tin mug, the hollow clatter echoing in his brain. And shielded his eyes with his palms. He asked for guidance in the darkness, a solitary waiting, throbbing in his chest. But all he felt was the breeze

stirring against the backs of his hands and all he heard was the hiss of his own breath. He lowered his hands and sighed. “Okay, how’s this going to work, then?”

By the time Terry and Sam returned, the guns were stowed away and Karl was making stick drawings in the dirt.

“Who wanted the runny egg?” Rely on Sam to break the tension.

* * *

Thomas sat down with Sam and Terry, as Karl repeated the plan for their benefit. As it was the second time he’d heard it, his mind began to wander. With hindsight, it was easy to see the choices he had made as inevitable. The mind played tricks, picking out key pieces of information and stringing them together like second-hand pearls. Wrap the parts in meanings they never had before and hey presto, it’s destiny. But mostly it was just making the best of a difficult situation at the time, and wanting to feel good about it.

Karl did some keypadding on his new state-of-the-art mobile and the Internet flashed up the bunker, not too far from Fylingdale; the one that Thomas and Ajit had rediscovered as kids. It was closed, Saturdays and Sundays. One road in and the same road out; surrounded by open moorland. Even Thomas had to admit that the location was damn near perfect.

Terry raised a few objections while Sam wanted to be convinced. Thomas watched as Karl sold it to them; how the setting, time and place would work in their favour. Except he referred to it as ‘securing the objectives.’ It was a new side to Karl, decisive and with a certain, clinical eye. If the army was missing him, Thomas figured, it wasn’t missing a mere squaddie.

Once the boys were on board, Thomas made the call to Dagenham. Diane and John didn’t take the change so well — not at first, anyway. And bringing Karl’s background into the picture seemed like the desperate act of a desperate man. Thomas was past caring; he just wanted it all sorted.

It still sounded a bit sketchy in his head. Karl and the boys would dig in on the moors. Then Thomas would make his call to Whitehall, giving details of the exchange and adding a £40k fee to the mix. He could follow Karl’s logic that Sir Peter would deduce he was a greedy bastard, and that Thomas had probably sent the document up country, ahead of time. But

what if they just sent the police — or worse — round to his mum and dad's, or Pat's? Karl's logic to the rescue again; so what, they wouldn't find anything. No, but they might take a few doors off in the process. Anyway, the plan was set and there was no going back now.

* * *

Thomas was alone again, but not abandoned. He loitered for an hour in Wapping Gardens, near the scrapyard, and then at the Turk's Head Café, cradling a coffee he didn't need. He figured it was a better option than waiting around Wapping Underground, trying not to look suspicious. The last thing he wanted was an over-zealous copper doing a bag search.

When it was time, he took the tube to Victoria and wandered the station complex, psyching himself up for action. If he didn't commit soon, the spare-any-change brigade would bankrupt him. He chose a phone stand to use and waited for it to be free. Which phone made no difference at all, but every little firm decision was a toehold on reality. He slid in his card and dialled the number from memory, in slow, steady movements.

As the number connected he checked the time — Karl's team should be well on their way now. The phone picked up on the third ring — no switchboard interrupt or invitation to leave a message. He stalled for a second, led with his name — always a strong opening — and took the plunge.

"So, Thomas, what do you have for me?"

He closed his eyes. "I can get the DSB to you in a couple of days' time."

"I see," the voice was non-committal. "How do you propose to do that?"

Half-truth time. "I'm to await a phone call at home and then I'll be texted a time and place." In his mind's eye, he saw Sir Peter scribbling notes down in red ink. "I go there alone and collect the package then we do the exchange and I leave with Miranda." He tried not to sound too authoritative, but hey, he wasn't asking permission either.

Sir Peter Carroll rasped down the phone. "That's settled then — I'll await your next call." The line went silent.

Thomas fought the panic and followed the plan. "There's one more thing." *Steady now, not too eager.*

“What’s that?” It sounded like the old man had tapped a spoon against a cup, like he was waiting for a punchline to a joke he’d already heard before.

“I’ll need £40,000, for services rendered.”

“I see.”

Can two words be made to sound smug? Those did. He hoped Karl was right — better they had him down as a chancer, than as honest and predictable. The line cut off while he was waiting for a reply.

Chapter 40

Miranda woke up with a migraine. Not a drink hangover, but a stress, dehydration, unable-to-sleep headache from hell. She hadn't had one of those in years. Last time? Probably the break-up with Thomas; the final break — a funny memory to dredge up. Doors: that was it. Those bloody doors slamming in the night and someone messing with a portable TV or radio in the corridor outside her room. And all that shouting — some bloke yelling at the top of his voice. Who was she kidding: it had been Yorgi.

She stumbled to the en suite and ran the tap, scooping the cool, stinging water to her face. It was the crying that did it; always gave her a bloody headache. The bathroom cabinet had been thoughtfully stocked with the female guest in mind — tampons, painkillers and cotton-buds. She snatched a couple of tablets and sank her head below the tap, pushing past the nausea by focusing on the craving for water.

A quick shower, then she changed into her gym wear — well done, Alice. It was a masochistic never-fail cure: exercise. True, you felt like shit for three quarters of the time, but afterwards, if your head hadn't exploded, you were in a better shape to face the world. She stuck a body spray in her waistband, ditched the lid — funny how they all looked so phallic — and opened the bedroom door.

The corridor was empty — hardly surprising after last night's aggravation. Even so, she tiptoed past every door to make it to the exercise room on the far side of the house.

The strip lights flickered with an angry buzz, gleaming off the shiny surfaces in a riot of light. She gave her eyes a moment to adjust, then began with a few warm-up stretches, progressing to practice falls and rolls on the mat. Back when she'd spent time in Bermuda, she had started kobudo defence classes. Her commitment had more to do with a guy she'd been dating, but now and again she still went through the kata at home.

Soon she was getting into her stride and the painkillers were kicking in. She flicked the CD player on, turned the sound down slightly and cycled like a maniac. The blood started pumping, and she turned her thoughts to the previous night. That Yorgi bloke was really unhinged. If Christine

hadn't finally intervened, he'd have probably kept her there all night. But . . . Christine had left her there in the first place. So much for her promise of friendship. Jesus, this bloody CD — she must know every beat of every track by now. Maybe it was time to send Alice shopping again.

The shift of air, as the door opened inwards, broke her train of thought. She turned behind her — stupid really as she was facing the mirror — and there was Yorgi, looking like he'd had an argument with his suit, and lost.

He didn't speak, just stood with his back against the door. Miranda lifted her feet off the bike, swung over it and jumped down; the bike whirred on. "What do you want?"

Yorgi seemed to look beyond her, as if it wasn't really her he was seeing. In two words: coked up. She edged back and felt the sweat running between her shoulder blades. He was whispering to himself now; maybe it was deliberate, to freak her out. If so, he was succeeding. "I asked what you're doing here."

He snapped out of his torpor and glared at her, opening his mouth to a sneer. Miranda narrowed her gaze; flicking her eyes over him, fixing the vulnerable points in her brain the way that her sensei had showed her, long ago. She moved out into the middle of the room, facing him. Then it happened.

In a second, he had leapt the distance between them and had his hands on her shoulders, pressing down with such force that her arms felt weighted. He leaned in close to her face. "I have had a hundred dogs like you," he hissed, the words spattering against her skin. "Now, I ask you for the last time — where is my package? Does Tomas have it?"

She felt her face flush at Thomas's name and looked away, trying not to react. But Yorgi swung his face round to fill her gaze. He reeked of sweat and rage. Yeah, that was it: rage. And he was barely keeping a lid on it.

His hand drove into her collarbone and at first she resisted, pushing back as if to pretend it wasn't crushing into her. Then she relaxed and the weight of him toppled her off balance. Now he looked at her differently, as if she'd awoken something in him that was even more dangerous. Every woman knows that look, and what it means. Dread and anger mixed inside her like the elements of a Molotov cocktail. And the flame was coming.

He moved his hand down to her breast and flattened against it. She smacked it away, full force, and a malevolent leer rose up on his face. "I

will enjoy teaching you . . .” he squeezed with his fingertips, digging into her flesh.

She kept her gaze on him, implacably hidden behind mental defences she hadn’t had to use in a long time. A slight shift to one side and her leg was primed. At the first movement, his hand came down hard to block in front of his groin, but she crosskicked and slammed into his knee with the top of her foot.

Yorgi let out a roar of pain and fell to the floor, dragging her down with him. He was bigger and heavier. Despite his pain, he used his descent to his advantage, pinning her down and straddling her. Red fury burned in her eyes as she rocked him from side to side with little effect. “Now I give Tomas a message you will both remember for a *long* time.”

Miranda pushed her arm forward, across and below her abdomen. He cackled with laughter, as if he relished the struggle. With a grunt of determination, she stretched her fingers, slipped into the waistband and palmed the bodyspray. The adrenalin was in full flow now; she wanted this fucker dead.

He bore down on her and she felt the obscenity of his bulge against her clothes. He pushed again, burrowing his nails under the elastic of her leggings.

She bent her neck back, drew down a snort of phlegm and spat in his face with all her might. He withdrew his hand to wipe it, and she took full advantage, emptying as much spray as she could into his eyes. He screamed and clawed at his face.

She swung a punch at his throat, but hit wide of the mark, catching a glancing blow against his chin. At the same time, she wrenched one side of her body up, screaming at the effort. He fell to the right and she dragged her legs out from under him.

“You bitch!” he choked through his hands, launching at her blindly from the floor — half grabbing, half flailing, crashing the two of them into the full-length mirror. They rolled together, mid-trajectory, and he hit the glass first, bearing the brunt as shards blasted from the wall.

She felt for her balance, sensing him crumple. But Yorgi had only folded momentarily to arm himself. She saw the blade glint against the ceiling lights as his hand swung towards her face. She dug her elbow in

hard, twice in succession, against whatever flesh she could contact and swerved to one side as his hand arced in.

As she rolled on the glass-strewn floor she heard the crackle of fragments and curled in tight to protect her face. As soon as she came out of the roll, she leapt for the door and wrenched it open. Outside, she pulled the door to and stood behind the frame, frantically bracing herself for the tug-of-war.

“I kill you, you whore!”

She leaned back to counter jam the handle and bellowed for help. What the fuck was wrong with everyone — were they all deaf?

“Tomas and Petrov — they are dead men!”

She shuddered at every syllable. Then a shot rang out, dead centre of the door, blasting a hole through like a tiny explosion. She screamed and pulled her arm rigid until the bicep burned. The only way this bastard was coming out was if he shot a hole big enough to climb through. The stench of scorched wood and hot metal stained the air. A second shot burst out the door, splintering against the opposite wall.

At last, she heard people galloping towards her. Christine got there first. “Quick, come with me,” she pulled Miranda away and threw an arm around her.

Only now did Miranda feel the flecks of glass in her hand and the sting as she brushed them aside.

“Nicholas, keep him here. You'd better sort this out — *now!*” Christine demanded, half-carrying Miranda away. Yorgi was still yelling as Nicholas attempted to placate him from the other side of the door.

Miranda made it as far as the kitchen and retched in the sink. Christine stood back, but she could feel her staring. “You’ve got to get away from here.”

“You *think?*” That was all Miranda could manage before another bout of vomit erupted against the stainless steel. Not so stainless now. She felt her legs buckling and gripped the side of the sink unit.

“Come on,” Christine insisted, “we don’t have much time.”

Miranda turned, and for a moment she thought of striking out. But by the time she had chambered her knuckles, Christine had moved out of range.

“Miranda, hurry, please!”

She followed the voice through to the lounge. Christine was unlocking the patio doors.

“Right,” Christine’s voice sounded shaky. “Take my phone . . .” she fumbled about in a small shoulder bag. “Give me your hand — quickly,” she scrawled four numbers on Miranda’s arm. “My cashcard — and there’s twenty pounds.” She thrust plastic and paper into Miranda bloodied hand. “And you better take this.”

Miranda looked on in amazement as she passed her the gun. “Why are you doing this?”

Christine hyperventilated a little as she searched for the words. “Just go and don’t stop — I’ll say you overpowered me . . . get out while you still can.”

And that was all Miranda needed. Adrenalin flooded her muscles and the survival instinct drove her past the pain, past the terror and through Christine. Afterwards she’d try to rationalise it as giving Christine an alibi, but right that second Christine had simply become another obstacle to be dealt with. She struck with a well-aimed heel of her hand, contacting under Christine’s chin with a satisfying *thwack*. Christine went down like the proverbial sack of shit, but Miranda didn’t wait around to watch the finale. She launched through the doors, straight across the grass, barrelling towards the arch at the far end of the garden. She flew like a Valkyrie, gun primed. Like Mum used to say, when they’d really misbehaved as kids: all bets were off now.

Chapter 41

06.30.

“Yes, this is Sir Peter — do you know what time this is? *What?* No, you did the right thing calling me, Nicholas. I can be in Whitehall . . . let’s say eight o’clock. Take command up there under my authority and keep Yorgi under control — whatever it takes. Medicate him if you have to. Who was the senior officer? Christine Gerrard. Right, here’s what I want you to do. Widen the search and put a surveillance team on the girl’s parents’ home.”

Sir Peter glanced over at his wife trying to get back to sleep. He turned his back to her, and whispered. “Monitor Bladen’s phone — I’m sure you don’t need me to tell you of the difficulties the organisation faces if she makes it home before we get the package back. Do we understand one another, Nicholas?” He placed the receiver down and sat up in bed.

“What is it, Peter?” his wife fumbled for her bedside lamp.

“It’s nothing, dear, just work. I need to go to Whitehall urgently.” He didn’t wait for an objection; too many years had passed for one to be raised. He picked up the telephone again. “Phillip, how soon can you have the car here? Forty-five minutes will be fine.”

Chapter 42

Thomas span the plastic token in the air, pleased that he'd stored the DSB in a locker at Victoria. Just in case someone came knocking on his door before he left for Yorkshire. Everything was in play now and all he could do was wait at the flat. Teresa had dropped off the radar altogether; Karl, Terry and Sam were en route to somewhere Karl had promised 'would be close enough to the bunker to see Miranda's smile.'

He wandered, room to room, staring at the pictures as if they were an exhibition of someone else's life. And hadn't it been that, really? Leeds was a world away; the Miranda he knew — carefree laughter, sardonic wit and a lithe body with visiting rights — that was all gone now, surely? Somehow he'd overstayed at the theatre of life and seen the magician packing the tricks away; he'd never be so enthralled again, nor fooled so easily.

In the kitchen there were more photographs: a couple of panoramic views of the moors, at dawn and dusk. He remembered spending a whole day on that. For reasons he still couldn't fathom, it had to be dawn and dusk on the same day. The entire photography club had been there, all sandwiches and flasks, and a sneaky lager for him and Ajit that he'd found at the back of the Christmas cupboard. The photos were amateurish, but there had been potential in them; the composition of the shot, two trees together silhouetted against the orange glow; the way he'd waited and only taken two frames of each. Just two frames a piece in a crazy shit-or-bust challenge to his own abilities.

Looking at the pictures now opened a narrow window to the past. He could just about glimpse what it was to be a teenager again, to be outdoors and not be afraid or isolated or . . .

He coughed, as if to attract his own attention. Another photograph, lower down, cradled his reflection and he stared at the tears without reproach. Well, almost without reproach. "Finished?" he asked himself aloud.

* * *

Later that morning a text came in from a mobile he didn't recognise. *'Get new mobile, text us here with our names. Kosovo Girls.'* At last,

something to do. He grabbed the bag and took the car; might as well give them some activity to track.

The salesman looked all of seventeen, but that didn't stop him trying to sell mobile-phone insurance and a host of accessories that only served two purposes — to delay Thomas and to really piss him off. Once he'd escaped his clutches, he found a camping shop and bought a compass. Not quite a Silva, but a decent enough copy.

Back at the flat he dug out the old maps — the ones that only saw daylight once a year at most, ready for the joyful family reunion. It was a deal he'd hatched with himself, many years ago — every time you spend a little time with the Bladen clan, I'll let you out on the moors.

The new mobile fired up with a little fanfare, which was the first thing he changed. He followed Karl's instructions and programmed in the Kosovo Girls number; he was in Karl's hands now.

The landline call came soon after. "Thomas? John." This was minimalism played to Olympic standards. "How's it going? The boys are in Scotland for a few days, on a fishing trip . . ."

He winced: way too clever.

". . . And did I tell you that Uncle Robert's been unwell — last I heard. I might pop round there, just to see if he needs anything."

He gulped. Did John Wright have enough information to track Bob Peterson down? Well, Bob would have to fend for himself.

"Anyway, have a good weekend and remember, Monday night is poker night. Everyone's expected."

The call ended. Thomas put the phone down and unclenched his teeth — a stupid, unnecessary risk. That settled it; he'd ring Sir Peter Carroll now and then get his arse up to Yorkshire.

"Hello Sir Peter, it's Thomas. I've just received a call — I've been told to head up to Yorkshire tonight. I'll pick up the DSB, then hand it over to you tomorrow. Hmm yes, I'll drive up. And Sir Peter, I really appreciate what you're doing for Miranda and me." The line nearly choked him. "Now, let me give you a handover site for tomorrow morning — I'll be there nine-thirty." He rattled off the OS reference, matching the red circle on his old map.

* * *

By the time he got to Victoria to retrieve the DSB, everything he needed had been transferred to a large rucksack, including the vest. Uniforms were funny things; hill-walker or vigilante — it all depended on what you kept beside your Kendal's mint cake.

Back in the car he hung an old St Christopher over the rear-view mirror. He didn't have the balls to string JC up there yet, but he was willing to take any help he could get.

Three hours into the drive to Yorkshire, the mobile flashed so he pulled over. It was Karl, in his own inimitable style: *'Dug in. drive safe, no speeding!'*

Mum and Dad had been thrilled to hear he was going to be in the area for a couple of days. Well, not thrilled; pleasantly suspicious was closer to the mark. Understandable though, considering he'd generally rather walk through nuclear waste than spend time with the Bladens. And he wasn't very subtle about it.

As much as he'd wanted to, he knew it would be wrong to drag Ajit into everything. Ajit would want to help through 'official channels.' But that was the kind of thinking that had dropped Thomas in the shit in the first place. Although, now that he came to think about it, a copper like Ajit could be useful under certain circumstances. Thomas weighed it all up as he exited the last services, before leaving the M1.

Chapter 43

Be it ever so claustrophobic, there's no place like home. And, if Thomas were honest, Pickering was no place like home either. If it weren't for the fact that he was bloody tired he'd have driven out, anywhere, rather than do the reunion bit now. But, as things stood, he was all done in. Not just the driving, tortuous as that had been, but the endless mental coin flipping; the absolute conviction that this would all be okay, followed by an all-consuming dread that it was all beyond his grasp, no matter what he did. It put a whole new sheen on: 'Are we there yet?'

The homestead curtains twitched as he was parking up; Mum had probably been waiting there for the last half hour, watching cars. He took a long breath and swung the rucksack over to the driver's side, checking that the box of chocolates had survived the journey intact.

His mother was at the door while he was still three feet away. He switched the rucksack to one hand, opened his other arm and engulfed her.

"It's good to see you, lad."

He used to scoff at the way she could produce tears — once he accused her, harshly, of manufacturing them to order. Today, he had to stay focused to stave off his own. His father smiled from the armchair and they did their usual strong father-and-son handshake act. Bladen senior waited until Thomas's mother had skipped off to the kitchen to re-boil the kettle.

"It's grand to see you, Thomas. Is everything all right?"

"Not exactly," he replied, then suggested they talk later, in private.

"Are you, er, stopping long?" His father stared at the rucksack, which Thomas had pressed tightly to his leg.

He pulled out the chocolates and placed them on the floor.

"Helen, come look at what Thomas has brought us."

Blimey, who is this impostor and what's happened to my real dad?

Pat put in an appearance later, with the kids. Gordon even managed to travel four streets to pop his head round the door when he came to take them home. It was like Thomas had slipped into a parallel world, where no one was using the next person in line for emotional target practice.

Karl was there at the back of his mind, but all he could do was wait for an update. So basically, he was Johnny No-mates for the night. He'd fed the family a vague story about being in the area for work — another half-truth that Karl would have been proud of.

His mother said she was going round to keep Pat company, while Gordon nipped out for a few jars. It sounded staged, but Thomas didn't care. He sat, statue-like until the door closed behind her.

"So," James carefully shut the hall door behind him, "what's to do, Thomas?"

He'd played it out so many different ways in his head, but however he began there was no easy opening. He unclipped the top of the rucksack and looked inside. "Why don't you sit down, Dad; this is complicated."

"Look, if there's summat troublin' you lad, just spit it out."

Easy words. He made two false starts, opening his mouth without speaking.

"Come on, Thomas, why are you really here? I don't buy all that rot about being here for work."

He nodded and pulled the drawstring closed. "It's Miranda, Dad. She's being held by someone — because of me."

"Is it drugs?"

Thomas erupted. "Of course it's not bloody drugs — what do you take me for?" Right, bollocks, he'd let him have it all, chapter and verse. First, the photograph at the Harwich, then Petrov's car, and then Yorgi. It was all loosening up inside his brain and oozing out like molten wax. He didn't know if his father was really listening — it almost didn't matter because now he was talking he didn't want to stop. Karl, Bob Peterson, Sir Peter Carroll, Christine — he knew they'd just be names to his dad, and quickly forgotten. But he wanted to get it all out now and lay it bare before him.

It took nearly half an hour to get to the present day, how Karl and the boys were already out on the moors, risking life and limb to help him bring Miranda home. And how he was really in Yorkshire to make the exchange.

His father had said very little. He seemed to wait until Thomas had run out of commentary. "And you've not thought of going t' police?"

Thomas raised his hands, clawing at the air in sheer frustration. "What did the police ever do for you, Dad?"

"Aye, I know; I'm only saying, like. But . . ."

Thomas reached into his rucksack — it was time.

“But won’t it be dangerous?”

Thomas smiled; his dad was a master of understatement. He pulled out the bulletproof vest and passed it across.

“Blimey, there’s nowt to it; doesn’t look as if it’d stop a cough!”

They both laughed; it cut through the tension like a cleaver.

“And that’s why,” Thomas lowered his voice even though there was no one else in the house, “I wanted to talk to you in private, because I need your help.”

His father leaned in and the flickering fire reflected in his eyes. “I’ll do anything I can.”

Hold that thought. “I need the gun,” the words plummeted to the floor.

“Now, look . . . Thomas; I can see how you’re fixed . . .”

He stood up and his father looked ever so small. “Don’t fuck me around — is the gun here or not?” He could hear the desperation in his own voice and he felt ashamed. He hated feeling like that, hated being there, asking for help from the one person who’d never been any help to him, ever.

His father hadn’t spoken for maybe a minute.

“Look,” he reached into the rucksack again and drew out the .38 automatic. “These people don’t mess around. I need the gun you kept in the shed.”

His dad looked up at him one last time, and sighed. “Wait here.”

Thomas called after him, making sure they understood each other, once and for all. “Make sure it’s loaded.”

He put the vest and pistol away, and stared into the flames, close enough for the heat to sting his eyes. At least, that’s what he told himself.

His father took a good five minutes. Thomas was in no rush though, as long as he got what he came for. A second weapon could make all the difference.

“Here,” his father put a rolled up cloth on the table with a soft thud.

Thomas picked it up, trying the weight for size. When he looked up, his father’s face was frozen. “Did I do summat to make you like this?”

“No, Dad,” he spoke through his hands, just like he used to as a boy when he’d been caught out at something. “You’ve always told me about the Miners’ Strike, about the struggle against Thatcher and the government. It’s my turn now, Dad; *I’m* the one fighting and these bastards,” he felt the tears

falling but he didn't care anymore; "these bastards have got Miranda and she . . ." Fuck, he couldn't even say the words. He choked on a breath and looked up. His father was wiping his face with a hankie.

"Now, I need you to do summat else for me, tomorrow — have you got some notepaper and an envelope?"

His father watched as he wrote out a letter to Ajit, detailing where he was going and when and what was going on. If it all went to shit — and he pretty much expected that, one way or another — at least the police could clear up the aftermath.

"I'll tell thee something, Thomas, and I've never told a living soul. That little gun there has only been fired twice. I took it down to the allotments one time and fair scared myself to death with a single bullet. And of course the other time . . ."

Thomas sniffed and stared at him blankly.

"Bloody 'ell son, don't you remember?"

He shook his head, as if he could deny the truth.

"It was you, yer daft bugger. I caught you in the house messing around with it and, well, we'd had words the day before. You only went and pointed the bloody thing at me and it was loaded. You couldn't have known that of course."

Thomas felt the heat roasting his cheeks. He *had* known; he was sure of it.

"Aye, bloody thing went off and shot a plate from the wall. It were like something out of Spanish City Amusements at Whitley Bay! Anyhow, you were so scared, you peed yourself and to tell the truth I think *I* might'a done as well!" His father folded the hankie and dabbed his forehead. "Look, I hope you know what you're doing."

A cog rotated in his brain; there was something else to take care of tonight. "I'm going out for a couple of hours." He picked up the Makarov pistol in case his father changed his mind and added it to the rucksack. It felt good to have it, as if he were reclaiming it from the nightmare.

"Are you out seeing Ajit, to drop off your letter, then?"

"No," Thomas raised a stop hand, "he doesn't know I'm here — he mustn't get the note until tomorrow morning. Tell Mam I'll not be back late."

He drove to York, for no other reason than that it was a good distance from Pickering. Far enough away for a DSB pick up, if there'd actually been one.

He wandered among the crowds — there were always crowds in York, no matter what time of year. Always a group of twats in Viking helmets and club sweatshirts, who thought they were able to hold their drink.

Despite his own prejudices, he opted for a busy pub — something with sport splashed across a widescreen TV. He squeezed through the throng and made straight for the gents, emerging a few minutes later with the vest on, under his sweatshirt, for practice. He settled for a pint of shandy and found an abandoned table at the far end of the pub. Nearby was an old man with a Border Collie at his feet. They were like two refugees from the twentieth century — the old man clinging to his pint of bitter and Thomas pawing over a hiking map of Fylingdales Moor.

A woman arrived with a buggy and commenced her double experiment, trying to poison her kid with cigarette smoke and mobile phone radiation. “Come on, Crystal, say hello to Daddy.”

Thomas watched and swapped raised eyebrows with the old feller. The poor little mite in the buggy didn't stand a chance. Daddy was probably on the other side of the pub somewhere, stuck in the crowd. Or in a young offenders' centre.

He sighed into his shandy and puzzled over the map, a map so old that the bunker tourist attraction wasn't even printed and had been added in by felt-tip pen. One road, in and out. He looked at the surrounding terrain and access roads; it would entail at least a two-mile walk, maybe more; something else to factor into his non-existent plan. He put his glass down on RAF Fylingdales.

How was this supposed to work, exactly? Just walk up and say, ‘I'd like my girlfriend back please?’ And what about Yorgi — Yorgi was *bound* to be there and he was, by any reckoning, a nasty piece of work. No wonder Petrov had wanted to keep hold of the DSB. And where were Petrov and his family now? All safe for the night, no doubt, and with no idea what was going on all because of them

He took another gulp of shandy. How do you solve a problem like Yorgi? The more he thought about it, the more he felt his stomach shake. A man who feared nothing — Petrov had said so. Well, almost nothing.

Maybe the Yorkshire Police Air Support could drop a crate of snakes on him . . .

The pub crowd cheered at a goal or a try or a foul; they were leaping up and down like a troupe of morons so Thomas couldn't tell what the payoff was. He raised a glass to them anyway, for living for the moment — lucky bastards.

Time for home; he'd been there long enough for an imaginary pick-up. He folded the map carefully and re-tied the rucksack. The barman received his glass, and exchanged it for a sneery look. Yeah, do come again.

* * *

Out in the car, he had another attack of the dreads and slipped the .38 between his legs. Unlikely anyone would try to lift the DSB from him, but better to be prepared. He checked his reflection. Is that what he'd become — a walking worst-case scenario?

Nothing happened on the drive back to Pickering. If the Eurostate Cartel had planned to storm the car, they'd obviously thought better of it. Karl probably had it right. All they wanted was the package back; Peterson had fallen meekly into line so why wouldn't he naturally do the same, especially as he'd asked for a forty grand disturbance allowance? And if they did stop him tonight, what was he gonna do — start a shootout on the A64? Good point. He stuffed the .38 back in the rucksack and pushed it out of reach.

Ma and Pa Bladen were watching TV when he got back. James glanced up and tried to wink reassuringly. But try that when you're terrified, and a tenner says it will look like a facial tic. "I was telling your mam, I'm thinking o' getting a dog."

"Thomas," his mum made his name sound like an alarm call, "your dad says you're off early morning — are you coming home tomorrow, then?"

He had to walk to the kitchen so they couldn't see his face.

"Kettle's not long boiled, if you're making," his mother called out.

He brought back a tray and noticed his dad had forsaken the armchair to squeeze in beside her on the settee. Wonders would never cease.

Thomas set the tray down. "Yeah," he started, smiling as his mother mock-frowned at the word, "I'll be back tomorrow."

Dad reached for his cup. “I were thinking, Thomas, ’appen I might drive out with you, tomorrow morning, and get a bit of fresh air. I’ve already rung work and taken tomorrow off, especially.”

“Ooh, that’s nice, Thomas; you turn up out of the blue and your father’s already taking holidays. You should come up more often.”

Thomas blew on his tea.

“That’s settled then, lad,” his dad sat back.

* * *

He lay in bed, letting pixel thoughts scatter and reform of their own accord. It wasn’t long after ten — he’d turned in early, on account of the long drive. He tried to picture Karl and the boys — sleeping underground. But all he could see when he closed his eyes was Miranda.

Some time after eleven he picked up a text: *Bunker road now closed for repairs. Don’t take chances tomorrow. Kosovo Girls Brigade.*

Chapter 44

The wall clock read six thirty.

“Do you want some breakfast, Thomas — a bit o’ toast maybe?” Thomas’s dad stood by the kitchen doorway. It could have been a father and son day trip but for the ominous rucksack on the table. “All set then?”

They moved to the front door. “Don’t forget the letter, Dad . . .”

“It’s in safe hands, Thomas.”

There was no small talk in the car until they reached the great outdoors. His dad was the one to break the silence. “You don’t have to answer, but is this what you do for a living, like?”

He felt for his dad, trying to fathom all this out and come up with a new picture of the way things were. He shook his head, offered up as much explanation as he thought would help and directed them along the map. There were no police roadblocks to contend with, no suspicious vehicles with blacked out windows. In fact, the roads were so clear it was as if no one else existed.

For a few minutes he lulled himself into memories of the two of them out on the moors, photographing the sun as it struck the heather at dawn. He still had a print of that one somewhere, back at the flat.

“Here’s good — don’t stop until I tell you. And don’t hang about afterwards; straight to Ajit at the police station.”

“I could come with yer, Thomas; the two of us, together, like.” There was an edge to the voice, like ice cracking on a pond.

“No, this is something I have to sort out. You taking my car away will really help though, honest.” Hopefully it would buy him a little extra time when they tracked it to the police station.

“If they . . . if they harm a hair of your head, I’ll not rest . . .” his father was crying now.

“I know,” Thomas shook his hand; he didn’t know what else to do.

The car rounded a hill and disappeared. He cleared the road and swung his binoculars wide. If he was really lucky, he could still pull this off. He had Karl and the Dagenham Duo on his side — so why were his guts still churning up like Robin Hood Bay in a spring tide?

It took an hour or so of scouring the moorland before Thomas found the habitat he was looking for: a pond. What was it the teacher used to say in Photography Club, at school? *Take every advantage.*

'It's possible, sometimes, to be so still that you almost merge into the landscape. Photographers and birdwatchers, the good ones anyway, they know how to do it. It takes patience and planning, but if you're really lucky all that hard work pays off.'

Thomas remembered his teacher's speech and tried to take comfort. His muscles were past numbness, beyond cramp; he'd been crouching in the same position for a good ten minutes now, glancing sideways on, as the grass snake wove through the grass. He fixed it with his gaze, as if he could magnetise it to the spot while he inched the canvas bag forward by degrees. He felt a bead of sweat slide down the side of his nose, trickling over skin cells, gathering pace. But he didn't dare flinch in case it broke the charm. The grass snake licked ahead of it, unaware of the converging bag. A little closer . . . and . . . bingo!

He flicked the forked stick, lifting the wriggling snake high into the air, twisting and contorting it to keep control. With his other hand he moved the bag underneath — the one with the DSB in it — and brought the two together, pulling the drawstring of the bag with the snake safely inside. Then he allowed himself the luxury of a smile and touched the crucifix at his neck.

As he stood up and stretched, he felt the .38 pulling a little in its shoulder holster. Not to worry; it wouldn't be for much longer. He took a celebratory sip of water, apologised to the snake and checked his compass bearing. Time to get walking again.

* * *

The entrance to the bunker beckoned, like a doorway to the Underworld. He surveyed the site through binoculars and tried to imagine Miranda down there, counting the minutes to freedom.

He squeezed the fear down into the pit of his stomach, telling himself silently, over and over, that they were *all* on the same side. That Sir Peter had entrusted him with the recovery of the sealed DSB. Entrusted, coerced — what was a word between friends? Their only interest was in recovering the DSB; *his* sole concern was Miranda.

Only one thing for it now: to set things in motion. “Hello, it’s Thomas Bladen.” There wasn’t an echo on the moorland, but the words seemed to magnify. He announced himself again just to make sure he wasn’t startling anyone. And hopefully Karl would now know he was on site.

As he walked forward into view, someone surfaced from the bunker — a suit. Thomas raised a hand in greeting and forced a smile upon his face. The suit half-turned and Sir Peter Carroll emerged, shadowed by another man.

Thomas advanced a few more paces until Sir Peter raised a hand. “That’s quite far enough, Thomas. I must say, you’ve picked a fine spot — reassuringly secure.” There was bravado in the voice yet somehow Sir Peter didn’t have his usual unassailable confidence.

He watched the old man and kept his smile high, forcing it until his mouth ached. “I’ve got the package here. When can I see Miranda? ” He lifted the canvas bag high and held it out to one side.

The other man beside Sir Peter shifted his feet, the bodily equivalent of licking his lips. This must be Yorgi; he wasn’t massive, although he looked formidable. And even at that distance, Thomas could read him: a face unencumbered by conscience.

Thomas took another pace forward. Sir Peter stalled him again. “First things first. I think we’ll have your weapon on the ground; we don’t want any accidents.”

Hook, line and sinker. Thomas reached under his arm slowly and tossed the .38 to the ground with his thumb and forefinger. A pity, nonetheless.

Yorgi seemed much amused, but he already had his gun drawn so he could afford to be jolly. “And now the bag, if you please,” he affected a bow.

Thomas felt the tension in his throat, squeezing the words out in single file. “I need to see Miranda.” But the next face he saw was Christine’s, rising from the depths of the bunker. His legs turned to lead.

Yorgi was laughing now, wagging the gun towards him like a taunt. “Now, smart boy, give me the fucking package or I kill you.”

And they say manners are a thing of the past. Not now, he told himself: no distractions. This was it then. He backed his arm up for a half-decent throw.

“Quickly,” Yorgi sneered, or you’ll never see your whore again.”

He felt his breath turn to fire. Chances of making the distance without being shot — very low indeed. Willingness to try anyway — almost absolute. Almost. He fed on the rage and helplessness that swarmed inside him and drew them down, until he felt a strange sense of stillness, as if the world was narrowing in. Yorgi, prick that he was, had done him a favour; he had brought Thomas into what Karl called ‘the kill zone.’

The bag sailed through the air and landed near Yorgi’s feet. He grinned like a ravine, lowered his gun and retrieved the bag.

Thomas inched his hand up the side of his jacket to the pocket: shit or bust.

“What? You think you are smarter than Yorgi; you and that piece of shit, Petrov? No, Tomas, you are a fucking moron. Your precious Mi-ran-dah isn’t even here! But I made sure I fixed her for you.”

Yorgi opened the bag and shoved his hand in. Any . . . second . . . now . . . “Argh!” he screamed and snatched back his hand.

Thomas took his cue, drew the Makarov from his pocket and fired. No hesitation, no deliberation; aim, shoot to kill.

Yorgi jerked backwards, dragged into a spin by a shoulder wound. But that didn’t stop him returning fire.

Thomas was momentarily stunned by his own incompetence. Then he heard the blast as the bullet slammed into his chest, smashing him down. He felt the ground punch him in the head and a clamour of voices swirl around him as the blood oozed down his face.

He must have been dreaming; Miranda was calling his name. He dragged himself to sitting, gasping for air, just in time to see Miranda materialise from the sidelines like some glorious angel. Then it all got very frightening indeed.

“You bastard!” Miranda roared at Yorgi and shot him, square in the chest.

Yorgi went down, but Thomas knew a pro like him would have a vest on as well.

Thomas heaved himself to standing, screaming with the pain; waving Miranda frantically aside, out of the line of fire. She didn’t get it and started running towards him.

Yorgi jerked back up mechanically, wide-eyed and bloodied, like a homicidal marionette. Suddenly there was gunfire overhead, seemingly

from all directions.

In the confusion, Karl barrelled through the scrub, slamming into Miranda side-on as he carried her to the ground. Yorgi's second shot went wide of the mark and whizzed past Thomas's head.

Karl rolled away from Miranda and recovered to face Yorgi with one of his Brownings drawn. Thomas dropped to one knee and kept his gun hand level.

Yorgi remained absolutely still, blocked by two weapons. His face twitched, like a trapped animal; Thomas figured Yorgi wasn't ready to call it quits yet. Yorgi turned to Sir Peter, pushing the barrel into the old man's face. "I take my package and I walk away."

Thomas was still wondering if Karl could make the shot when Karl abruptly lowered his Browning. Yorgi emptied out the bag and then he looked directly at Thomas. His gun wavered for an instant. "This isn't over, Tomas."

"Yes it is," Sir Peter's voice was as clinical as his marksmanship.

The bullet slammed into Yorgi's skull in a flash of red, propelling him to the ground as blood and brain matter pumped free. Sir Peter Carroll stood rigid, flecks of Yorgi's blood glistening against his face and clothes.

Karl holstered his gun and helped Miranda to her feet. She took his hand reluctantly and looked across at Thomas. He ran to her, clutching his chest on the way — it hurt like a bastard. Then, as Karl stood aside, Thomas gritted his teeth and squeezed Miranda hard against his jacket. She felt cold, in every sense. He breathed her in, pressing her face against his neck, and watched Karl surveying the scene.

Karl turned to face him. "Well, turned out nice again." He threw his one-liner away and advanced on Nicholas, who was already by the package. "Hey, hey," Karl called out, "don't make me shoot you. Leave it be." Then he looked over at Christine, who nodded to him.

The air crackled; Christine lifted a walkie-talkie from her back pocket. "It seems a local man drove through the road barricade; Jack and Alice have been detained by a policeman on the scene. Police Air Support is on its way."

Sir Peter Carroll lowered his head. Thomas pointed at him, the Makarov still in his hand. "He goes down for this, Karl."

“Hold on there, Tommo . . . that’s not the way these things work. If this goes public, we all crash and burn — that’ll be the end of the SSU and all those Euro bastards vanish into the night.”

Thomas had already started walking. Miranda was at his side, her hand in his. He’d seen enough, heard enough and had enough. Karl shouted after him. “I’ll sort it, Tommo; I promise. No loose ends. Leave it to me — I know how these things are done.”

Miranda nudged Thomas as they crossed Christine’s line of sight. He watched as the two women eyed each other silently. Miranda dropped a cash card, a gun and a mobile phone at Christine’s feet, and then pulled Thomas away.

Chapter 45

It had been seven days. A whirlwind of events that, as Thomas lay listening to the birds outside, almost seemed like they'd happened to someone else. As he rolled over on one side, the bruise in his chest reassured him that it definitely had happened to him. He caught the alarm clock on the first bleep — he'd been awake for ages anyway. It was his second morning back at the flat.

Sam and Terry had taken Miranda back to London after a hotel overnight. He'd wanted to drive her home, but she made it very clear she didn't want him around. So he'd stayed on in Yorkshire for a few days, just until the official story unfolded: Eastern European drug trafficker apprehended, following combined operation between police and security services. He left after that — he couldn't stomach any more lies.

He'd been ringing John and Diane's twice a day, to check on Miranda. There had been a suggestion she might go abroad again but, thankfully, Diane had talked her out of it. Said that what she needed was the family around her.

Give her time, they told him — and that was about all they told him. Did they blame him? Not as much as he blamed himself; that wasn't possible. John reassured him that he'd be welcome at the house, in time.

And Karl? Well, Karl was another huge disappointment; he'd showed his true colours in the end, and tidied everything up. John Wright even got his gun back, apparently. Last Thomas had heard, Karl was back at work, resetting the clocks once more.

As he lurched out of bed, the previous night's phone call with Karl stung his ears. 'Trust me, Tommo, I've got your back covered.' Yeah, right.

He showered and then stared at himself in the mirror. The bruise on his chest had come up a fine shade of purple. Right about where the heart was; Yorgi was a true professional to the end.

Today was the big day — off to Whitehall to face Sir Peter Carroll. As he grabbed his coat off the peg, he noticed two brown envelopes on the mat — minus addresses or stamps. The A4 photographs were a mixture — some colour, some monochrome. There was a woman going about her daily life

— at the shops, with her children, and a family photo in a park. As to the black-and-whites — well, not quite porn, but the couple weren't holding a raffle. Not unless they'd found a novel way to pick the winners. Sir Peter Carroll was evidently more athletic than his physique suggested. It looked like some sort of downbeat hotel or a motel, and it definitely wasn't the woman from the colour shots. The very last photo was different to all the others — an outdoor scene, long lens — Sir Peter's gun up against Yorgi's head.

A small card fell out of the envelope. He bent down to read it and a lump came to his throat. 'I never break a promise — K. See you back at work soon.'

He ditched the card, checked the other envelope — a copy of everything — grabbed Exhibit A and headed out the door. At Walthamstow Central he filed through the gate with the masses and enjoyed the rich travelling experience that was the Victoria line.

He walked past the lockers at Victoria and shuddered. He needed coffee, a double espresso. As he savoured its umber goodness, a text message came in: *Dinner tonight? Caliban's — 8 pm. Don't be late! Give Karl my regards. Mx.* Wow. He texted back a glib comment and marched right into Whitehall, holding up his ID like a badge of honour: Floaters Anonymous.

"Are you delivering that?"

He glanced at the resealed flap. "Yes, it's for Sir Peter Carroll's eyes only."

A guard escorted him towards the lift, same as ever. The door pinged open and a half-familiar face greeted him. It took a second to place him — Sir Peter's chauffeur. They exchanged the briefest of smiles and Trevor — that was the name that had eluded him — subtly tapped his own chest as he passed, mirroring where Thomas held the envelope over his bruise. By the time he'd turned around, Trevor had gone.

* * *

Three raps and there he was, back in the spider's lair.

"Please take a seat, Thomas."

He leaned forward and passed the envelope. If Sir Peter had looked pale before, by the time he'd viewed the contents he was positively

anaemic. “What . . . is it that you want?”

Thomas smiled, a little smile to let the old man know that things were about to change. “These are *my* terms. You’ll sign an executive order today, prohibiting Karl and me from being moved to separate teams without your express consent — which, of course, will be up to Karl and me. Bob Peterson’s to be transferred immediately — I don’t care where — and Christine Gerrard promoted in his place.”

Sir Peter shrank back in his chair, like a slug at a salt-fest. As Thomas looked up, even Churchill’s portrait seemed shocked at such audacity. Well, bollocks to them both.

“Are we finished, then?”

The cheeky bastard. “No, there’s the small matter of forty thousand pounds outstanding — for Miranda.” He put his hands on the hallowed desk. “And let’s be clear: if you or your representatives ever take an interest in the private lives of anyone associated with me again, *you’ll* wish they hadn’t. You can keep the photos — they’re copies.” He stared at Sir Peter, waiting until the old man broke eye contact; it took about thirty seconds. A voice in his head muttered ‘overdramatic,’ but he shushed it silently.

“So now what, Thomas? I presume you know about my new working relationship — with Mr McNeill’s associates?”

It wasn’t a surprise, but it still left a bitter aftertaste. Karl had explained the rationale: run Sir Peter Carroll as a double agent; preserve the SSU, blah blah blah. It stank, however you pitched it, even if Karl was right and it suited the greater good.

“What happens is that I collect the money and then I’m out of here.”

The bundles of notes were lifted from a safe behind the desk, all ready and waiting; he didn’t bother to count them. Sir Peter handed them over solemnly, like a school prize; Thomas stashed them in a carrier bag.

“I hope you’re not thinking of leaving the Surveillance Support Unit. You’re a resourceful man, Thomas. I can always use a good man like you.”

Thomas picked up the bag. He was halfway out the door when he turned and looked back. “Not any more.”

THE END

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Book 2: LINE OF SIGHT

A gripping thriller full of suspense

DEREK THOMPSON



Summary Report - In Confidence

Subject: Thomas Bladen.

Thomas transferred to the Surveillance Support Unit from a civil service desk. Despite initial suspicions, he does not appear to have any intelligence agency affiliations and his civilian status is confirmed.

While on a recent shared assignment with HM Customs, he witnessed a punishment shooting by Yorgi — a hitman who worked for the Cartel on a freelance basis. Thomas showed considerable initiative and assisted me in investigating the incident and collecting evidence of the Director General's duplicity. This was instrumental in helping to expose Sir Peter Carroll, and constituted a major intelligence coup for us. Sir Peter, while remaining head of the SSU, is now also being run as a double agent against the Cartel.

Inevitably, there were risks in using a civilian in such a high-profile operation. However, it was too good an opportunity to ignore, as Thomas had met Sir Peter prior to joining the SSU, and had actually been interviewed by him.

In an effort to mitigate some of the risks, I gave Thomas rudimentary firearms training and enough information to gain his trust. Unfortunately, we underestimated the extent of the Cartel's influence within our own department, which led to the abduction of another civilian, Miranda Wright — someone with close connections to Thomas Bladen.

The situation reached a crisis point in Yorkshire, as detailed in my separate report. Although neither Thomas nor Miranda was injured in the concluding firearms exchange, both have been affected by it.

Thomas and I will continue to work as a unit, and this arrangement has executive approval from Sir Peter Carroll. Following a review with our Senior Intelligence Officer, Christine Gerrard, Thomas and I have been removed from 'front line' assignments for the time being.

My recommendation is that Thomas (and Miranda, for that matter) should not be put under any surveillance by our organisation, and that I should remain the sole liaison point.

Thomas has proved to be a valuable asset with excellent surveillance skills and good deductive reasoning. He has an affinity for counter-intelligence work and I believe that his civilian status may give us a tactical advantage in further assignments.

Karl McNeill, Surveillance Support Unit.

Chapter 1

Thomas Bladen rested his camera on the dugout shelf and gazed across the terrain. He took a breath and held it, pressing his fingers against the rough grain of the wood, as a delicious tension gathered in his chest. This was the moment when his world came alive.

The *plom plom* of mortar fire broke the stillness of a perfect autumn day. Birds scattered, as if they knew what was coming; they didn't have long to wait. Smoke bombs detonated on cue, followed by thunder-flashes and industrial firecrackers: the works. Karl McNeill, Thomas's fellow surveillance operative, kicked off his own 'dud-da-da-dah-da' version of *Ride of the Valkyries*, while they waited for the photogenic armour to appear.

"See here, Tommo, they're late!" Karl tapped his watch. "Trust the bloody Mechs to screw up the schedule."

"Hush." Thomas squeezed closer into the camera eyepiece. He'd chosen a gorgeous opening frame and didn't want to miss a second.

The ground shuddered underfoot as the prototype C12 Battle Buster — to quote the corporate bullshit Karl had already accidentally trampled on — erupted into view. Then, as the air around them seemed to throb, the C12 revved over the crest of the hill like a foundry worker's fantasy.

All conversation in the dugout ceased. Thomas and Karl did what they did best. True, it wasn't quite surveillance if the tank commander knew you were there — more like PR — but the job still had to be done.

As the vehicle rumbled past, its pennant and aerial swinging wildly, Thomas got what he'd come for, rattling off a series of camera shots that he'd later compare with Karl's for their customary competition. Then he reached for his coffee, sipping steadily at the rich, bitter liquid.

"It's show time." Karl wagged a finger like a baton. Somewhere, beyond their vision, a turret should have been turning.

Thomas closed his eyes and tried to visualise the barrel — raising steadily, rotating and firing. He squeezed his eyes shut at the thought of the powerful recoil, and imagined the shell spinning relentlessly towards its target. There was nothing to see from their position, but they could hear the

armour piercing payload; slicing through the air until . . . *pow* . . . the target was obliterated.

A tannoy shrieked into life. “Ladies and gentlemen — the C12.” Somewhere, out of earshot, a gaggle of arms dealers — all legitimate, if such a thing were possible — would be offering polite applause and reaching for their chequebooks.

“Well, Tommo, that was the last vehicle before lunch so . . .”

An expectant pause. . .

“. . . So I’d say it’s *tanks* for the memory!”

Thomas cringed. Karl had probably been crafting that gem all morning.

Jesus. So much for that celebrated Irish wit. Northern, or southern? Thomas had never broached the whole Irish thing with Karl, not once in the eighteen months they’d worked together. Come to that, he didn’t actually know where Karl’s religious loyalties lay. A Proddy most probably, given Karl’s time in the British Army. Still, somehow he couldn’t picture the teenage Karl with either the Queen or the Pope for his bedroom pin-up.

* * *

The clouds parted, as if bestowing a benediction. Thomas breathed easier as they walked over to the mess hall. After an entire morning trapped in cramped conditions, contending with plastic furniture, extended delays, Karl’s inescapable gas attacks and his delightful sing-songs, a stroll in the open air was a feast for the senses.

Alongside their security colour-coding the badges read ‘Official Photographer,’ and they kept their camera cases close at hand. According to Karl, the only opportunist greater than a squaddie was two squaddies.

While the posh folks might be enjoying canapés and sipping Pinot Grigio, for the commoners it was mess-hall fare with those self-same squaddies. Not that Karl seemed to mind; no, he was in his element — back amid a sea of khaki and camouflage, as if his two and a half years in the Surveillance Support Unit had never happened.

“You bloody love all this, don’t you?” Thomas raked through his stew half-heartedly.

“Hey, this is just another job. Glorified PR lackeys — that’s what we are.” But his eyes shone as he gazed around the room.

“Really?” Thomas put his fork down with a clatter, causing the boys at a nearby table to stop and look over. “What if you could turn back the clock, jack all this in and go back to the army?”

Karl chewed his stew slowly. “Well, leaving aside the challenge of time travel, I’d have to say . . . no.”

Thomas raised an eyebrow of dissent. “Bollocks.”

“What, Tommo, and miss all the fun we’ve had together? Not a chance.” Karl beamed his hundred-watt smile, but Thomas wasn’t buying today.

He looked past Karl’s pudding and the thrum of the mess hall slipped away from him. He was back on the Moors, and that psychotic bastard, Yorgi, was taunting him again. He was standing there, helplessly, flinching at the flash of sunlight and the blinding realisation that Sir Peter Carroll was raising a gun and . . .

“Hey.” Karl clicked his fingers in front of Thomas’s face. “You were zoning out on me there.” The missing word was *again*.

Thomas nodded, pushing his plate away; nothing quelled your appetite like the memory of an execution. There was probably a diet plan in that somewhere: Monday to Friday, eat two good meals a day, then every weekend witness a shooting. The pounds will drop off, mainly through the night-sweats.

Karl drew in a breath. “I know how you feel, Tommo, sure I do. I was sixteen when I first saw a man die, right in front of me. . .” Karl fell silent, long enough for Thomas to know that a punchline wasn’t on its way.

“Come on, Karl,” he gestured towards the exit. “Let’s call this meeting of Depressives Anonymous to a close.”

Karl pushed his chair back. “Go on then, Mr Bladen, what goodies can we look forward to after lunch?”

Thomas pawed through his notes. “Helicopter demo — rooftop rescue. Then a couple of armoured cars and after that some small arms.”

On cue, Karl retracted his hands into his sleeves. “Like these?”

Thomas quashed a smile. *Dick*.

* * *

Back outside, Thomas stretched in the sunlight. It wasn’t all bad there; even army bases had trees. If you could ignore all the military hardware and

square bashing, you were left with a lot of land. Probably some decent wildlife too, if they'd had the time to explore.

"You know, Tommo, you can always talk to someone — me, for instance."

Talk to someone? Yeah, that was how they'd got this gig. A post operational review with Christine Gerrard, after the business on the moors, and since then it'd been weeks on the surveillance equivalent of light duties.

No, the only person Thomas wanted to talk to was Miranda; it had been her life, not his, that had been threatened and turned inside out — and all because of his shitty job. Even now, just thinking about her, he felt the shame smouldering inside. Oh, they still met up and spent time together, but he couldn't quite forgive himself. And he reckoned she felt the same way.

"Right, Tommo," Karl held his camera case out at a jaunty angle. "What say we posh ourselves up and crash the arms dealers' bistro? How much do you think one of them earns?"

He smiled briefly. Almost two months on, and Karl was still putting in the effort, still trying to convince him it was business as usual. Never mind all the lies and double-dealing — the people they'd saved and the ones they couldn't. In Karl's eyes, it was all gift wrapped and put away — for the greater good. Well, fuck that for a game of soldiers.

Karl's mobile chirruped for attention. "Dearie me, I've told them never to ring me at the office." He hit the button on his work mobile. "McNeill here. Uh huh. We're out by the flagpole. Yes, ma'am, will do; McNeill out," he put his case down. "We've been reassigned, Tommo; we're to wait here — Christine Gerrard's express orders. Someone else will carry on our good work this afternoon. Transport's on its way — *special request*." He straightened an imaginary tie.

Thomas screwed up his face, as though he'd just caught wind of a bad smell. Minutes later, they heard the unmistakable growl of a Land Rover. Thomas turned towards the sound and paled, the combination of camouflage and blue lights registering a unique kind of menace, even to civilians. And judging by Karl's face, the military police weren't to his taste either.

The Land Rover screeched to a halt beside them; both MPs had that standard-issue wasp-chewing face. Thomas had grown immune to the contempt that the forces and the police reserved for the Surveillance

Support Unit — they were often referred to as *floaters*, and a lot worse besides.

After checking ID cards, the MPs muttered between themselves then radioed in. The sergeant eyed them from the Land Rover. “Yes sir, we’ve got them.”

Thomas nudged Karl, who didn’t respond. The sergeant was calling the shots now. “Get in.”

The vehicle swung away from the main buildings in a wide arc. Thomas hadn’t ventured out this far before; they’d been limited to authorised areas only. A tarmac road wound through oaks and beeches, only he didn’t feel so keen on nature now. The Land Rover rumbled on without a word, until a guardhouse loomed, with a heavy-duty gate that could only mean they were entering a more secure area.

He glared at Karl, willing him to say something. But that didn’t happen until they’d passed the checkpoint.

“Would someone like to tell me what’s going on?” Karl sounded rattled.

The MPs didn’t even turn around. Thomas wanted to speak, but the words jammed in his throat. If Karl was holding back then they really were in trouble.

“Should I be phoning my boss — or a lawyer?” Karl’s face was now an angry shade of red, a tribute to the soldiers’ scarlet caps.

Thomas recalled that Karl had never explained how he’d come to leave the army and join the Surveillance Support Unit. Maybe this was unfinished business.

One of the MPs twisted round and barked, “No calls.”

A minute or so later, the vehicle reached its destination, close to a nondescript door where the flaking grey paint screamed *underfunding*. Thomas followed Karl’s lead and went into the anteroom without a sound. The door closed behind them.

Chapter 2

"Don't take this the wrong way, Karl, but is this anything to do with you?"

He was silent for a moment as if weighing the evidence. "Tommo, I've never even been here before. What the hell could I have done?" The voice was uncharacteristically shrill — odd to see him in a flap. But then, as Karl had once told him in a waltz down military memory lane: you don't fuck with the Red Caps.

Thomas let the matter drop and fell back on instinct, circling the small room. *Stick to the details*. There were two small windows — in need of a clean — and nothing to see outside. A stack of chairs occupied one corner of the room — with another three along one side of a large table, and a single chair facing them, court-martial style. He glanced Karl's way then thought better of it. There was no phone there, not even a socket. And right now he really needed to hear Miranda's voice.

He took out his mobile and punched in the security code. Karl's eyes bulged. "What are you doing? Don't be stupid!"

Jeez. He cut the phone and scanned the room again. This whole set up didn't feel good at all.

The sound of footsteps echoed outside, coming closer. Karl's face screamed, 'I told you so,' as he stood to attention, ramrod straight.

Thomas slouched against the table; no point pretending that he was army stock, and right now he was glad not to be, if this was how they treated their own.

The door swung in and a green jacket filled the frame. "At ease," the officer declared, glancing at Thomas as if he were shit on his shiny boots.

He looked the uniform in the face. "And you are?"

Karl took the hit. "Don't be a prat, Tommo; this is Major Eldridge."

He made a mental note: Karl and the major already knew each other.

"My apologies for your unorthodox mode of transport, gentlemen, but I had to get you here quickly. We're in a fix, Karl, and your presence on the base is fortuitous to say the least.

Yeah, but who for?

The major closed the door carefully. “There’s been an accident in one of the test labs and I need an *objective* record, before the investigation team gets onsite. The corporate junket across the way has made things a little difficult for us — can we talk freely?”

Both the major and Karl looked directly at Thomas. He swallowed and sat up properly, bringing his hands together as if in contrition.

“I want both of you to get as much photographic evidence as you can without disturbing anything. You’ll have half an hour at most, and then they’ll be here to take the body away.”

“Body?” Karl glanced at Thomas, an unspoken question hanging in the air: *Are you sure you can handle this?*

Thomas felt his face burning and cleared his throat. “We’ll need forensic suits, and I suppose we’re subject to a lockdown?”

“That’s correct, Mr Bladen. Your things are being brought across now. Lockdown will be in effect for twelve hours. As a courtesy, you have a couple of minutes to attend to any personal business; then I’ll need your phones and keys, etc.” Major Eldridge finished his speech and left the room.

Thomas didn’t waste any time; he speed-dialled Miranda before the footsteps outside had receded. “Hi, it’s me. Listen, I’m really sorry, but something’s come up,” he sighed in time with Miranda. “I can’t get away tonight.” His eyes rested on Karl. “Yeah, he’s here as well . . . you know I can’t talk about it.” He was still preparing a comeback line when Miranda hung up. He switched the phone off and placed it on the table carefully, as if it were toxic. Karl shrugged, by way of consolation, and copied him.

The good Major returned so promptly that Thomas wondered if he’d been standing right outside. “If you’d like to follow me.”

Thomas smarted. *As if they had a choice.*

* * *

Thomas carefully secured the fastening at his neck. In other circumstances this would have been comical — he and Karl kitted out in white romper suits. But behind that door — a very heavy door, he noted — was some unfortunate’s final resting place.

“I’ll come and collect you in thirty minutes. Be ready.”

Thomas let Karl lead the way in; he could feel the pit of his stomach extending away as he stepped over the threshold. Flung across the floor on the far side of the room, a starburst of blood and shrapnel. Beyond the bench, fragments of flesh and metal were embedded in the wall, and below it, the remains of a woman lay slumped back. He stared at her — at what was left of her — transfixed by the gaping hole in her skull. She looked like a grotesque sculpture; only partly human, something a twisted adolescent might have sketched on his bedroom wall.

“Must have been a faulty breach mechanism,” Karl kept the chat to a minimum.

Which was just as well. Thomas didn’t feel like talking. He stepped carefully around the debris and tried to tell himself that this was just another job. He’d done crash scene photography before, mangled wrecks with limbs poking out. But this was of another order; this was *carnage*. He fell into the rhythm of the job; get the footage and then get out. There was so much blood though, and an eerie mix of body fluids, smoke, and a trace of perfume hanging in the air like a lament.

Suddenly he was twelve again, off to see his grandma’s body, in the Chapel of Rest at Scarborough. His mam had said he didn’t have to, but he knew she’d be proud of him for going through with it — his younger sister, Pat, had waited in the car. As soon as they’d gone inside, it was there. Not a smell exactly, more an instinct; a sense of being in the presence of death. The natural urge was to run, far and fast, but he hadn’t run then and he wouldn’t now.

“Poor wee thing,” Karl’s voice cracked. “She must have been a bright girl to be working here.”

Thomas’s mouth was parchment dry; he nodded and looked away. The glass in the wall clock was smashed, zigzag lines raging across its surface. The slow ticking seemed to Thomas a travesty — a machine persisting when something more precious had not survived. He heard Karl behind him, clearing his throat, as if to say: *let’s get on with it*.

He ignored him and closed his eyes, reciting the Our Father silently for the deceased. Then, remembering where he was — and who he was — he swung the camera round and began framing shots that would likely haunt him forever.

“Tommo, see that metal casing over there; well, what’s left of it. Unusual magazine.”

He took the hint and photographed it from different angles, then eased the casing over with a pencil. It slipped and clattered around the floor; for a few seconds it was the only sound in the room. Then he put a foot on it and turned to Karl. “Is all this . . . normal?”

“Nah,” Karl grimaced. “Totally wrong, like a fucking *bomb* has gone off.” He clicked his fingers then drew a finger to his lips. Thomas watched, wide-eyed, as Karl produced a mobile phone with a camera, and passed it over. “Get everything you can.”

Emotion soared in Thomas’s chest; for a moment he couldn’t breathe. He felt the heat radiate across his face. Karl wasn’t prepared to let this go. And neither was he.

At the far end of the testing range, a single target waited. He pressed the retrieval button; the whirring mechanism took its time, drawing the paper towards them like a spectre. There were holes — lots of holes — and several different sizes. He was no mastermind where ammunition was concerned — he relied on Karl for that. But even he could see that someone had re-used the target.

He summoned Karl over and continued taking both official and unofficial pictures. Then he pointed to a scattering of different-sized shell casings, but Karl didn’t say anything. Finally, when Thomas thought he couldn’t stand another minute in that claustrophobic hellhole, Karl banged on the door. “I think we’re done here.”

Major Eldridge was waiting on the other side. “We’ve put you in a secure area for the night — I’ll get some food sent over, not that you’ll feel like it. I realise you’ve got exhibition footage that needs to get to your liaison team so perhaps you could burn that to discs and then let me have your data-card.”

Thomas blinked hard at the apparent slip of the tongue: data-card, singular.

* * *

“So, this is us,” Karl shouldered the door of the shared quarters; two beds, micro wardrobes, a table and chairs, a TV and the usual facilities.

“May as well sort out the laptops now.” Thomas dropped his stuff on the bed and opened his laptop bag methodically. He set both machines up and cabled them together, quickly shuffling the Army Demo footage between screens before burning it to a DVD. Once he was satisfied that the disc worked, he wiped the original material from both their data cards. Karl seemed happy to let him get on with it, opting for a shower and a shave.

Checking that the room door was locked, he went through the test lab photos, for quality and clarity. But each photo took longer than the one before, and he began to feel more like a voyeur than a technician. Those images marked the end of a woman’s life, the moment the lights went out for good. He stared at the collection filling his screen; it was only the sound of the shower cutting off that brought him out of it. He rubbed his face and finished the job, burning all the footage to a single DVD, for the major. God only knew what Karl wanted done with the pictures on the mobile.

Karl emerged, half dressed — thankfully his lower half — with a towel around his shoulders. As Thomas looked over, he saw the silvery scars of a bar brawl etched on Karl’s torso. Karl brushed his hand over them for comedic effect, as if they were crumbs. “All done, Tommo?”

He nodded, and offered up the mobile that he wasn’t supposed to have.

“Nah, you keep it for now, just in case.” Karl slumped on one of the beds.

Thomas left the laptops powered up for the major’s scrutiny and flicked on the TV to drown out his own thoughts. It wasn’t helping. “Tell me, Karl, what are we really doing here?”

Chapter 3

Thomas stood at the window, staring blankly at lights in the distance and tracking the occasional plane as it blinked across the sky. Normally, he'd have checked out the view through a lens, but he wasn't in the mood tonight. Neither he nor Karl had spoken for at least twenty minutes. Karl had raided the drawers to unearth a soft porn flick, a duff comedy and a slasher horror — none of them had stayed on long. Even Karl's quip about the porn film containing extras had failed to warm things up.

It was a relief when someone knocked on the door, bearing room service, even if Major Eldridge was right behind the squaddie. Once the Catering Corps had departed, the major loitered over the open laptops. The two discs lay side by side; one labelled up as *exhibition footage and stills*, the other left untitled. He picked them both up as if weighing them, and then put them down again.

“Just the one copy of each?”

Karl nodded curtly. “Sir.”

The major opened his mouth to speak, and then sighed, delivering his next words with precision. “I'll check your laptop logs *now*.”

Thomas watched him closely as he performed all the cursory checks before lifting just the test lab DVD, so that the strip light rippled against the casing. “Now your laptops are clear, I won't need to see them again. I . . . er . . . I think I'll go and rustle us up a bottle of scotch.” He turned to face Thomas and Karl; his face gave nothing away. “I'll be no more than ten minutes.” He gave the accident footage DVD back to Thomas. “When I return, I expect to see the laptops stored away. Do we all understand one another?” The door closed.

“What the bloody hell's going on?” Thomas leapt over to lock the door.

But Karl didn't answer; he was too busy breaking another blank DVD from the packet to make a copy.

By the time Major Eldridge returned, with a serious bottle of single malt whisky, Thomas had the additional copy of the DVD safely stored in his jacket. Karl and Major Eldridge conducted a decent assault on the whisky, while Thomas watched from the sidelines. Around 11 pm, when,

despite all the army reminiscing, Thomas had learned nothing new about Karl at all, Major Eldridge stirred from his chair. He shook hands with them and pocketed his two single DVDs, but lingered by the door.

“I wanted you to see this.”

Karl took the photograph and passed it to Thomas. It was a passport-sized, first day at work picture with short, dark hair framing her face and brown eyes staring out on the world. A hint of a smile played on her lips. He burned the picture into memory and returned it.

“I appreciate your efforts today, gentlemen. And I suggest you leave the base at first light.” His voice had the quiet authority of a man who was used to giving orders. Karl saluted and even Thomas felt a stiffening of his shoulders. Whatever terribleness had gone down in the lab, this was a man of honour. Either that, Thomas mused, or he was a man with something to hide.

After giving the comedy film a second try, they turned in for the night. Karl rolled over on his mattress, creaking the springs. “Tommo, you awake? Can I ask you something?”

“If you must,” he huffed. Maybe Karl could talk him to sleep.

“What do you think the major wants us to *do* with the copied DVD?”

Thomas wriggled about to try and get comfortable. “Could be he’s just thinking on his feet — a little insurance policy for the future.”

“Nah, you don’t get to be a major without being able to think strategically. He wants us to have it, but why?”

Outside, unfamiliar sounds speckled the vacant landscape. It could have been a distant owl, but more likely a car horn — some lucky bastard with a less complicated life, off to see his girlfriend. Thomas’s thoughts flew to Miranda, and then back again to the base. “I can’t help wondering what we’re not being told.”

Karl shifted again on the mattress of a thousand squeaks. “Aye, some wee girl is on the slab tonight and I reckon her family will get everything but the truth. I think she — and they — deserve better than that. Maybe that’s where we come in. Nighty night, amigo.”

* * *

Thomas was already awake when some joker banged on the door at stupid o’clock. By the time he got it open, the only thing greeting him was

their mobiles and keys in a cardboard box on the floor — very hospitable. He gave Karl a nudge and got himself together.

It was still dark outside; their Land Rover was ready by the door. “You better drive, Tommo, I’m not feeling too clever today.”

He passed up the chance for a comeback line and took the helm, taking pity on Karl’s head and opting for something light and classical on the radio.

Karl didn’t stir until the motorway services, apart from sporadic bouts of snoring and sleep chewing. He finally opened his eyes as they pulled up, yawning and stretching, like Belfast’s answer to Bagpuss.

“Coffee?” Thomas was already half out the door.

“I’ll sit here if it’s all the same to you; a large coffee, a copy of *Private Eye* and a packet of biscuits. Thank you very much.” Then he switched radio stations, as if to declare that he’d officially regained consciousness.

Past the plastic double-doors, Thomas called Miranda. She was her usual razor-sharp self.

“They’ve let you out then!”

He waited a few seconds in case another gem was coming; turned out there wasn’t. “Yeah, all done and dusted. On my way back to civilisation now.”

“And should I ask?”

He grimaced — a fingernails-on-blackboard face. She knew better than to ask. “Industrial accident — with a fatality.”

“Oh,” she gulped. “I’m sorry.”

“Look, let me make last night up to you — what’re you doing later?”

“Is that an offer, Mr Bladen? Saturday night at Mum and Dad’s.”

He grinned, anticipating her next line.

“You’re welcome to join me . . .” Somehow she managed to turn the word *join* — even at Mum and Dad’s — into something salacious. “. . . If you’re not too busy saving the world, that is.”

He shifted away from the wall as a woman struggled past, baby in her arms. It struck him then that this was something the girl from the test lab would never get to do, and he felt a chill go down his spine.

“You still there?” Miranda’s tone was insistent.

“Yeah, sorry. I’ll be home in about three hours, once I’ve dropped off laughing boy. I’ll sort out some clean clothes and head over.”

“I can pick some stuff up for you to save time. Then you can drive straight over to Mum and Dad’s . . . if you like.”

She sounded like a carer. It still hurt, however unintended. Miranda had been the one held hostage, just months ago, but people were still treating *him* like an invalid, tiptoeing around him in conversation. As if everyone else but he was adult enough to deal with it. Jesus, he was drifting again.

“Er, yeah, thanks Miranda — that’d be great. See you when I see you.” He picked up the supplies and trudged back, taking pains to keep out of everyone’s way.

“You took your time — were you grinding the beans?”

He managed a half-smile and got back in. Karl looked him up and down. Thomas hated that. Karl was a master of deduction.

“Tommo, do you call out in your sleep?” Karl asked.

He closed his eyes momentarily. “Let’s not do this.”

Karl was still gaping at him.

Jesus. “Alright. On those rare occasions when someone else is around, I’ve been told I do sometimes call out in my sleep.”

Karl nodded at him, aha style, and slurped at his coffee.

“I was like that after my first tour. . .”

Thomas watched him ease back into his seat and waited. Karl seemed to breathe by osmosis, to avoid interrupting his own delivery.

“. . . So you see, Tommo, in the end there’s nothing to be ashamed of in seeking help. Talking it through is the best way of getting to grips with your feelings and dealing with them.”

Thomas put his coffee cup down. He’d had ten minutes of this and they were still in the bloody car park. He tried breathing slowly to stay calm; fat chance.

“You really wanna know how I feel, Karl? I feel like I should have killed that bastard Yorgi, the second he uttered Miranda’s name. And I wish to God I had. I dream about that time on the moors, over and over. Sometimes I get him first and sometimes he gets me. And sometimes he shoots Miranda, and that’s when I wake up screaming. I ought to have protected her from the consequences of my job, but I didn’t — I fucked up. And now, half the time I can barely look her in the face.”

Karl seized the first opening. “You have to be able to move on, Tommo.”

“Bollocks.” He nearly said, ‘you weren’t there,’ but Karl *had* been there. Matter of fact, Karl had been the one who’d protected Miranda after Thomas took a bullet. By his reckoning, that made Karl twice the man he was.

Karl munched on a biscuit theatrically. “Right. Hear me out,” he pleaded, spraying digestive crumbs across the dashboard, “and I’ll not interfere again — I promise.” Karl’s face bore all the sincerity of an insurance salesman, but Thomas was eager to be convinced. “Look, I know a person who can help you; someone like her helped me when I needed it.”

Thomas felt his back muscles relaxing. “You?”

“I haven’t always been the calm and composed man-about-town you see before you today. When you see your oppos slotted, or you find yourself doing things you despise, well, it takes its toll. But a good medic can ease you through that — help you get it all into perspective.”

Thomas started the ignition. Karl put down what was left of his biscuit.

“Christine Gerrard asked me to keep an eye on you, to let her know whether you’re fit for duty. She’d arrange a referral, no questions asked.”

Thomas gripped the wheel. When did everyone become so interested in his wellbeing? A better question might have been when did *he* stop caring? He huffed in time with the revved engine. Karl was right, no change there.

“*Fine*. Book me an appointment with the nut doctor; anything for a quiet life.”

Karl smiled beatifically, and retrieved his biscuit remnant from the dashboard.

* * *

The radio formed the only soundtrack for the rest of the journey. He dropped Karl off at Holloway Road tube, the pick-up point where Thomas used to join him on their visits to the gun club. But guns were a completely different prospect once you’d seen what they could do to flesh and bone. Once you’d seen a dead body, all that intellectual reasoning and hand-eye coordination practice was just so much play. He waved Karl away and didn’t stop until he reached that part of the urban sprawl he knew and loved as Dagenham.

Chapter 4

Although it was a work vehicle, Thomas still felt slightly sheepish rolling up to John and Diane Wright's place in a 4 x 4. The house was a working class des res, large and imposing. It screamed two things: a) we made it here the hard way and b) if you don't like it, you can fuck off. John Wright reckoned there were more *business people* — as he liked to refer to the better-heeled criminals about town — around Dagenham and Hornchurch than there were in Parkhurst and Wormwood Scrubs prisons combined. Which reminded Thomas to take all his bags out before he locked the car.

Time was when he had his own front door key. Back when he and Miranda were more of a firm fixture than a series of friendlies. Simpler days, before he'd left his Civil Service desk job and joined the Surveillance Support Unit; before he'd got mixed up in all that secret squirrel stuff. Anyway, no use standing on the threshold like an apprentice Jehovah's Witness, best get indoors.

The doorbell twanged a chord in his heart. This was his second home, more so than his native Pickering, despite his Yorkshire roots. The Wrights were more a clan than a family, with the boys, Sam and Terry, making up the remaining forty per cent of the mix. But the jewel in the crown for all of them was their Miranda.

It took Thomas a moment to realise that the door had opened. Sam was standing there impatiently. "You coming in or what?" Sam swung a playful punch and helped him with his bags. "Mum, where do I put Thomas's stuff?"

There was no answer from the kitchen. Small wonder. The sleeping arrangements all depended on whether Miranda was stopping over. It was more than ten years since Thomas had turned up on their doorstep — in the heart of London's East End in those days — with Miranda in tow, having pulled her away from the clutches of a dodgy photographer in Leeds. A mate of Thomas's uncle — and the one Thomas had lamped good and hard.

And since he'd escorted the fair Miranda home, they'd treated him like a prince. They'd even helped them set up home together, but young love and bad habits didn't make for reliable foundations.

Sam dumped Thomas's bags in the hallway and led him into the living room. John Wright looked up from a table covered with a mess of wires and components.

"Ere, Thomas, have a go at this — you're the electronics wizard."

It sounded more like a dare than a request. It was only months ago that Thomas had told them what he *really* did for a living, so it was still fertile ground for piss-taking.

"Come on," John vacated his seat. "You work out what this is s'posed to be and I'll get you a beer."

There was a glint in his eye as he sauntered off to the kitchen. Thomas looked down at John's pet project, recognised a capacitor and a circuit board but not much else. Jesus, some components were glued to the motherboard. He fiddled with a couple of wires and they came away in his hands.

"So what do you reckon then?" John could scarcely contain himself.

"I *reckon* you're having a laugh!"

John set the beers down and erupted into laughter. "As soon as Miranda told us you were coming over, I put something together."

Thomas weathered the chorus of good-natured abuse and drifted away to the kitchen. He always felt like a lost sheep when Miranda was absent, and her mother was the nearest substitute. Diane gave him a motherly hug, which in no way detracted from the fine figure she cut in her skinny jeans and fading blonde locks, as she turned back to the oven. "She'll be here soon," Diane said, matter-of-factly. He felt his face simmering. "So . . ." Diane faltered.

No one said 'how are you?' or 'how's things?' anymore. Miranda must have drilled them. Neither did Karl, come to that. He knew they'd all spoken about him, about how he was coping. Maybe he'd get them each a Support Worker badge for Christmas, and make it official.

Diane found her thread. "So . . . it's cards tonight. Texas Hold 'Em followed by Blackjack, and then we'll see who's got any money left!" She touched him lightly on the shoulder and kept her hand there. "And no cheating!"

He laughed. Given Diane's croupier past, that seemed unlikely. Unless you counted those Christmas sessions, where Diane dealt and John inexplicably held the only hand with picture cards.

A key crunched in the lock and he started, caught between trying to act cool and the desire to rush to the front door.

“He’s in ’ere.” Diane bellowed as the door creaked open. Then she went off to sit with John and the boys.

Miranda entered, doing her slinky walk, swinging a box of chocolates provocatively. She could look sexy filling a shopping trolley. “I see Mum’s keeping up the subtlety night classes. Alright, babe?” She moved closer and he felt his body responding to a wave of heat between them. He basked in the warmth of it, their feet almost touching. “Did you miss . . .” she began, but he finished the sentence for her, with his lips.

Time with Miranda always felt different; tensions longer, emotions more intense. He gave himself up to the moment. When they separated she pressed her hand to his chest, to the place where Yorgi’s bullet had struck the body armour during the shootout. The heat from her palm penetrated right through him, making his back sweat.

“Hard day at the office?”

He moulded his hand over hers, filling the gaps between her fingers, and squeezed.

“Knock, knock.” Diane rapped against the doorframe, beaming. “No spectators allowed — caterers only I’m afraid!”

* * *

Dinner was a simple affair: shepherd’s pie and veg, followed by apple crumble and custard. The chocolates and spirits didn’t come out until the boys had cleared the table and laid a green baize cloth over it reverently. As John always said: if you’re gonna play cards, do it properly. Ironical, given that John was one of the worst card players known to man. Well, to Dagenham. His occasional lucky flourishes only seemed to coincide with Diane’s stints as dealer. No, he was definitely not one of life’s high rollers. How he’d ever lasted long enough in a casino to hook up with Diane in the first place remained one of life’s enduring mysteries.

In deference to Thomas’s lack of preparation and ready cash, John declared it a chips and IOUs night. The stakes were the usual, enough to keep your interest but not silly money; it was a family game after all.

The cards flew thick and fast, with the chips moving round the table several times. He sat to one side of Miranda, so she couldn’t read his face.

And, if he was lucky, he might get the odd furtive leg squeeze.

“Ow’s your Irish mate, Thomas?” John didn’t look up from his cards.

Miranda’s hand rested reassuringly on his thigh; he cleared his throat. “He’s fine.” Nah, they deserved better than that. “Actually, Karl bumped into an old army mate; I think it shook him up a bit.” *Yeah, that and the dead body.* “I think the bloke is after a favour, as it goes.” He tabled a couple of cards to be exchanged. “Well, you know Karl!” He looked right at John.

Miranda intervened, reaching for the box of chocolates, which she waved under his nose. “Something to nibble on?”

He selected a toffee and wondered if the question counted as a promise.

* * *

The clock read eleven fifteen. “Right then,” Diane drew the cards together and formed them into two fans, merging them flawlessly. “Let’s see the final scores.”

Thomas was down twenty quid and he’d got off lucky. Fortune — or Diane — had favoured Sam. He collected the IOUs and sat back in his chair, hands interlaced like a Mafioso. “Why don’t we all just call it quits?”

John smiled sadly and shook his head. “No, son, cards is cards. You win and you collect, simple as that.” He said his goodnights and headed off to bed. Diane followed a minute later, reminding the boys to leave the room tidy.

Miranda turned to Thomas amid the hubbub of cards, chips and glasses being moved away. “I believe you owe me a hard centre,” she raised an eyebrow. “I’m off to bed.” She could still make him blush on command. He followed her out, picking up his bag on the way.

“Try and keep the noise down, sis,” Terry pleaded.

Miranda was completely unfazed. “I’ll do my best,” she called behind her. “But so will he, probably, so I’m not promising anything.”

Chapter 5

Miranda paused at her old bedroom door, smiling coyly. It was only when she relented and moved to put her arms around him that he noticed the ring. *So much for observation skills.*

“Blimey.”

The old engagement ring, from the days when love’s young dream had leapt the crevasse to formal commitment. Even if it did end up jumping back again a few months later.

“Hey,” she scolded him, “I do still wear it now and again.”

Yeah, like now — on the right hand with the stone palm-side. He swallowed that thought and delved beneath the curtain of her hair, landing lightly on her neck. Forget the G spot; Miranda had an N spot. He let his fingertips do the talking, gently kneading her flesh.

“You know,” he paused, just to gaze at her. “I’ve never quite worked you out.”

“That’s the plan,” she laughed and kissed him, flicking her tongue into his mouth.

She tasted of brandy and chocolate, rich and exotic, like a good liqueur. They didn’t speak of love or commitment as they fell onto the bed; no one spoke at all. In the wordless pact of familiar lovers, nothing needed to be said.

* * *

He twitched awake in the early hours, startling her. She cradled him, and he lay there, listening to their breathing in the dark, trying to push back the creeping dread. He felt as if something had been lost; wondered if she felt it too. He agonised over whether things could ever be the way they had been.

Later, when he surfaced once more, he heard the birds outside and struggled at first to work out where he was — curled up in a ball, submerged beneath the covers. Miranda’s legs were warm against him, and he raised his mouth to her stomach, uncertain whether she was awake. He let his hands travel freely over her body.

Sometimes he wished she'd play hard to get. But they weren't kids any more.

"When you're done playing Gulliver's Travels down there, remember that Dad gets up early. So if you're thinking of a rematch, we'd better get a move on." That was Miranda, just like her mum: all subtlety.

* * *

By the time Thomas made it to the kitchen, Sunday breakfast was in full swing. Miranda would follow at a discreet interval; he never understood the logic, but that was true of so much about her.

Diane was usually the hostess with the mostess. However, John Wright liked to do Sunday starters. Diane was at the table, mug of tea in hand with a magazine in front of her. "Morning, love. You stopping for dinner today?"

"I'll see what Miranda wants to do." Or, more accurately, what Miranda wanted him to do.

"Why don't you nip out for a paper and get a bottle of something — make it red, we're having beef. Oh, and a couple of cans for John."

Good plan. A seal of approval from Diane would overrule Miranda's contrariness. "Okay — I won't be long. Anyone else want anything?" Sam shot into the kitchen like a puppy at the jingling of a lead. "I'll come too."

Thomas grabbed the keys for the Land Rover and got ready to face the day. Dagenham had lost none of its charm. The cul-de-sac was as silent as a politician wired to a lie detector. The lawnmower brigade wouldn't be on duty for at least another hour.

He stood for a moment eyeing up the vehicle. These days he didn't take chances, not since a tracer on his car had led to Miranda's abduction. Who gave a shit if people thought he was paranoid? Let's face it — he *was* paranoid — it was an occupational hazard.

He did a circuit of the Land Rover. Nothing untoward; cancel the red alert in his head. But . . . but then he did a double take, as his brain caught up with him. There was a cylinder attached underneath, and he'd never noticed it before. His mind raced, rationalising the irrational. He wasn't scared exactly but it didn't make any sense.

He whipped out his mobile and phoned Karl.

"Hi-de-Hi there, Tommo. What's shaking?"

Idiot. "I've got a problem — the Land Rover's been tampered with."

“I’m listening . . .”

He sent Sam back indoors, told him not to come out again. If it was a bomb, it was the least covert bomb in the history of incendiaries. He described the container to Karl and tried not to sound freaked out.

“I’ll come straight out, if that’s okay. It doesn’t sound like an explosive device and I can’t see why someone would have put it there overnight.”

Before, then?” Thomas flashed back. “Maybe when we stopped at the Services yesterday?”

“Nah, I stayed with the vehicle. Granted, I was a wee bit hung-over, but I think even I’d have noticed someone playing Meccano.”

Thomas stared at the canister and felt the world retreating.

“So I’ll pop over, then, Tommo?”

“Quick as you can — I’m sure you know the way.”

The notion of a visit from Karl caused quite a stir in the Wright household. Less, Thomas reasoned, because Karl was a newcomer to their lives and more that they’d probably spent time with him when Thomas had convalesced in Yorkshire.

The family loitered in the living room, making small talk. Then John disappeared abruptly into his office, returning with a mobile and a pissed-off look on his face. “How long is Karl gonna be? I could do without all this.”

Thomas didn’t have any answer; he was too busy reminiscing. Medical books and the Internet might tell you that a flesh wound from a bullet doesn’t take long to heal — a month or so, tops. And less, for the chest bruise, where Yorgi’s precision had hit the padded vest, dead centre. But the mind . . . Jesus, that was a different story altogether. Google that one and settle into a comfortable chair.

When the doorbell rang, everyone jumped — the way they do in cheap dramas. John cast a glance at Thomas; he took the hint and went off to deal with it.

Karl flashed a smile as the door opened. “Clean your car, mister?”

Thomas felt his jaw relax a little as he fell into the game. “Yeah, you could as it happens; there’s a terrible stain on the underside.” He held back by the door as Karl circled the vehicle slowly.

Karl finished his lap of honour and scratched at his chin thoughtfully. “Might be better to do this somewhere private. The boys have a breaker’s

yard down Wapping way . . .”

Thomas teetered on the doorstep, weighing it up. Karl had been down there once before; another incursion into his territory. But what other option was there? “Wait here — I’ll speak to Sam and Terry.”

Five minutes later, the whole Wright clan emerged, with Thomas leading the way. Karl nodded to them each in turn, saving a small smile for Miranda. Thomas tried not to look too bothered, and failed.

* * *

A two-vehicle convoy left for Wapping. John Wright rode with Thomas and Karl in the Land Rover, following Sam and the rest of the family. Thomas felt squeezed again; he was getting used to his work and personal lives overlapping, but this was so far outside his comfort zone it could send back postcards.

John was clearly enjoying himself immensely, swapping jokes with Karl like they were old pals. Thomas figured they probably had more in common; Karl had been in the army, and John was definitely ‘a man’s man.’ Meantime, here he was again, on the outside.

John slapped his hands together as he delivered the next punchline. “And the feller says: ‘Don’t look at me, I brought the music!’”

Karl’s laughter could have shaken the chassis apart. “Come on, Tommy Boy, let’s have some of that native Yorkshire wit.”

John threw him a wry glance. This was a new one — Karl and John teaming up against him. He told them the one about the blind man giving his dog a biscuit. And then made a stab at a joke about the whistling prostitute with the glass eye. They left him alone after that, which suited him fine. All the better to check the mirrors, just to make sure there was no third car anywhere.

* * *

Terry got out to unlock the gates, and then both vehicles drove right into the yard before he bolted the gates behind them. Everyone decamped; Thomas watched as Sam went off to make a brew. Jesus, this was turning into a real family outing.

Karl and John carefully detached the canister and laid it down on a piece of tarpaulin. Everyone else unconsciously backed up a step. “I just

want to say,” Karl started unscrewing the cap at one end, “here on in, we keep this amongst ourselves.”

Thomas felt a dull sense of familiarity thudding against the inside of his forehead. He muscled to the front. “You know what this is, don’t you?”

“Well,” Karl removed some packaging then retrieved the first part of a contraption. “Let’s just say I could hazard a pretty good guess. He delved back in and extracted the other pieces. “Ladies and gentlemen,” he stepped back from the spread of pieces and carefully put down the handle, “I give you . . . the smart gun.”

Thomas clocked that Karl was wearing gloves. Then he gazed down at the tarpaulin, and saw the shadow of clouds as they passed overhead.

Miranda sidled up to him and pressed her hand against his back. “You okay?”

He sighed. “I think I could do with that tea now.”

Sam did the honours. Thomas grabbed a mug and sniffed the milk — passable, even if it was that sterilised crap. He beckoned Karl away from the family. “I think you were bang out of order getting them involved — couldn’t you have taken the canister off to your *own* people?”

Karl took a long, slow sip of tea and wandered off towards an avenue of cars piled five high. Thomas trailed him like a sullen spouse. He could see Karl was searching for something; hopefully, a decent explanation.

“Tommo, you do trust me? Surely to God you’ve learned by now who your friends are?”

He conceded that one with a nod.

“Okay, here’s the deal. I can’t get involved — not with a weapon. The footage from the lab, well that’s different — I know my superiors won’t like it, but they’ll wear it.”

Thomas knew straightaway that he wasn’t talking about the head of their unit, Christine Gerrard. He meant Karl’s *other* job in counter-intelligence.

“The weapon is your business now, Tommo. And you’ll need back-up — people you can rely on.”

When Karl put it like that, the Wrights were the natural choice. “Then what *are* we doing out here?”

“Me, I’m looking for a replacement bumper for my car — mine’s cracked. And you happened to know someone who could get me one at

short notice.”

Typical Karl — always one step ahead.

“What’s my next move then?”

“Well, don’t try and assemble it or fire it. And don’t leave any prints.”

Karl waved his hands, Al Jolson style. “You know, a scrapyard would be a great place to hide something, don’t you think?” He pointed casually to a suitable wreck, then started heading back. “From now on, Tommo, unless I tell you otherwise, I don’t want to know.”

Thomas was still counting hubcaps when Miranda sought him out.

“All sorted?”

“Champion,” he used the exaggerated Yorkshire accent that always made her laugh. It worked like a charm and he threw a loose arm around her.

“Well, this is a Sunday with a difference — is Karl coming back to Mum and Dad’s for dinner.”

“Don’t ask me, Miranda — I just work here.”

* * *

In the end, Karl collected his bumper, caught a ride back to his car and sodded off home to Kilburn. Thomas wasn’t sorry to see him go. Another line had been crossed, and there was no way back. But that didn’t mean he had to like it.

Chapter 6

“More pudding?” Diane waved a dish under Thomas’s nose.

He glanced up and concocted a smile about as substantial as a meringue. He could feel the weight of their attention fixing him to the chair. He blew out a sullen breath and leaned back.

Miranda stared hard at him, appalled. He blinked a couple of times in the hope that she could read him better than he always claimed.

“Why are you being such an arse?” That drew a few chuckles around the table.

He glanced around and folded. “Look, I’m a bit weirded out by the idea of Karl on friendly terms with you all. I’ll get used to it.” *Only because I reckon I’ll have to.*

“How long do you think we’re gonna have to keep the pod, Thomas?” Sam was almost quivering with excitement.

“Dunno. But don’t go touching it, or it’ll need to be wiped again,” Thomas scolded playfully. He paused and thought for a second. What was he really worrying about? Someone had wanted him and Karl — let’s face it, *Karl* — to have a copy of footage from the lab accident *and* what looked like part of a test weapon. Okay, so it wasn’t a normal couple of days for most people, but this was the game he was in now. He found a smile. “Anyone fancy another round of cards?”

The Wrights all cheered, as if Thomas had just returned from a dragon quest, wearing a new scaly waistcoat.

* * *

Thomas surveyed the IOUs ranged before him, like a happy bank teller. And now that he’d resolved to speak with Christine Gerrard the following day, about Karl’s counsellor referral, the mosaic of his life was starting to make sense again.

He was down to a two-hander with Diane; he figured she was holding two pairs — one of them royal. All he had to do was hold his nerve . . .

Then a mobile went off. The Wright household shot glances at one another. They took their cards very seriously. It wasn’t about the money or

even the winning; it was about the playing. With them, card games were like catechism to a Sunday School teacher; you didn't mess with it.

"For fuck's sake," John huffed. Everyone settled on Thomas.

"Don't blame me; it's not mine — that's not my ring-tone."

Miranda didn't stand on ceremony; she reached into Thomas's jacket, slung over a chair, and lifted out the offending phone — Karl's camera phone from the army base.

It took him a moment to remember how the phone had got there. He held his hand out and she passed it over with a sneer. "Hello?" he blushed, hot under everyone's gaze.

"You've got to help me . . ." a woman's voice trailed off, punctuated by the sound of heavy traffic. "I've no one else to turn to."

Thomas gulped. The phone bleeped. *Bollocks. Almost out of battery.*

"Hold on," he looked round frantically. "I need a charger, *quickly.*"

Sam dashed over to a sideboard, scrabbling in the top drawer until he fished one out. Diane slapped her cards down and ran to the kitchen. She and Sam converged on Thomas, so the charger could be plugged into the mains.

"You still there?" his breath caught in his throat, snared on the fear in her voice.

"I can't stay here — I'll ring you." The line went dead.

Blood drained from his face. He checked the caller number and phoned back. The ringing echoed in his head. "Quick, check out a number for me on the Net," he pointed to Miranda, like she was a servant.

She did as asked, scowling all the while. The prefix was in Middlesex, west of London. Thomas put the mobile down and chewed on his lip, lost in thought. First, the photos on Karl's mobile — superfluous, as it turned out, because Major Whatshisface had allowed them to copy the footage; then the container hidden under the Land Rover. And now some woman ringing on the mobile that Karl had suggested he hang on to. It all sounded like a set-up.

"I've got to go out. Terry, you wanna play this hand — it's a good 'un!"

"Where are you going?" Miranda's antenna was on full alert.

"Not sure." That was half true, softening her up for the rest. "I'm going to head over Middlesex way and wait for another call."

"On the phone you didn't know you had?" her voice was brittle.

“It’s Karl’s phone, okay? I forgot he’d left it with me.”

Miranda snatched it up from the table. “So I shouldn’t expect to see any pictures of you on this?”

Wow, that was a novelty — Miranda, the possessive one. In an instant he remembered what photos *were* on there. He stood back and let her get on with it.

She scrolled through the menu options like an aggrieved wife on the prowl. He knew what was coming. She wanted him open and honest? Fine. When she got to the pictures, she gasped and stared at the phone, open-mouthed.

“What is it?” Diane responded instinctively to Miranda’s distress.

“It’s a dead girl,” Thomas beat her to it. “That’s what I dealt with on Friday.”

Miranda looked up, pale as chalk. “Then who the bloody hell just rang you?”

“I’ve no idea. That’s what I intend to find out.” He grabbed his stuff and headed for the door. Miranda was a step behind him. “You drive and I’ll navigate.”

Chapter 7

Thomas watched the road carefully as they sailed down the A13 towards the A406 North Circular Road. Better that than risk a row with Miranda.

"So, she could be anywhere in Middlesex?"

He let it pass, wishing the mystery woman would get her finger out and ring back. Karl's mobile had been left at the house to charge up, with the calls forwarded to his; which meant Miranda was also phone monitor.

"And why couldn't Karl locate the Middlesex number for you?"

She had a point. But no, Karl wanted to be kept out of this and he reckoned there was a reason for it beyond some old army loyalty.

Rain spattered against the windscreen, drowned out by the heavy rhythm of the wipers. There was a comfort to it; steady, regular, purposeful — all the things he wished he were. Instead, he felt trapped. Miranda's being there at all was bollocks, and they both knew it. He gripped the steering wheel. *Even a moron can travel the A406 unaided; it's a fucking circle — how hard can that be?* And when he got there, what use was a navigator if he was just driving around?

"I wish you'd talk to me."

He glanced over, then back to the road. "What do you want me to say?"

"Say anything — tell me why you're doing this."

He opted for a soft sell. "You know me; I'm a sucker for a damsel in distress."

She was quiet for a while and he fooled himself into thinking he'd got away with it.

"I have nightmares too, y'know, Thomas . . ."

He didn't; and it pained him that not only had she never said, but he'd never considered it.

". . . I thought Yorgi had killed you when I saw you go down. I thought it was all my fault."

He felt a lump in his throat, forced it down. There were tears in her eyes. He sniffed and his own eyes prickled in response. "I failed to protect you, Miranda — I don't know how to get past that . . ."

He changed lane and checked the road signs, letting the wave of emotion subside. Miranda put her hand against his, on the steering wheel. “Just don’t shut me out, and we’ll call it quits, okay?” She laughed through the tears.

When she took her hand away, he craved it like an addict. There was no eye contact after that until his mobile rang. Miranda seized it without hesitation. She didn’t waste time with niceties.

“Where are you? We’re on our way . . . right, got it . . . good idea — a public place. Try and stay calm . . . oh, it’s Miranda. Dunno; blonde hair, brown boots, jeans — I’m wearing an engagement ring . . . yeah, and the bloke? Typical scruff-bag! We’ll be there as soon as we can. Promise.”

Before Thomas could add his own two penn’orth, she’d closed the call and pulled out her own mobile. “Dad? No, everything’s fine. Can you get Terry for me a minute? Terry? Go look up a pub on the Net — Abrook Arms, in Uxbridge. Yeah, ring me straight back.”

Thomas blushed. It was a funny time to be proud of her.

She looked up at him. “What?”

“Dunno, just a different side of you, I s’pose.”

“Different, good?” she pouted.

He conceded a smile. When Terry rang back she was ready, pen in hand, and scribbled furiously into her address book. Now she could really navigate.

* * *

They pulled up outside the Abrook Arms, still in mid debate, with him losing on points.

“All I’m saying is, you could have checked with Karl and found out *why* you’re doing his dirty work. Or maybe you already know something?”

There wasn’t a lot he could say. The mystery call to the mobile could have been a set-up by someone who wanted the smart gun — or who wanted it *back* — and here he was, walking into the lion’s den. But for all that, he was glad to be doing something about it, especially with Miranda riding shotgun.

The pub door squeaked open. The place wasn’t exactly heaving. In the far corner, a live band was knocking out a decent rendition of ‘Try A Little Tenderness.’ One sweep of the bar told Thomas who the Mystery Caller

was. She'd be the only one sat alone, clutching her chair, mousy hair drawn back into a bun.

Miranda clocked the woman as well. She waved her left hand in front of her, with the engagement ring transferred to its former position. Any hammier and it would have come with salad in a roll. Thomas nudged her and she pointed him towards the bar for three drinks, doing a sexy walk for his benefit. One of the band almost got his tongue caught in his guitar strings.

The drinks came quickly, thanks to lack of competition at the bar; and by the time he arrived at the table, Miranda was finishing the introductions.

"Wasn't sure what to get you, but I figured you looked like a rum and coke."

Point of fact, she looked like a frightened child.

They moved away from the band to another table; they stuck out as strangers anyway, so there was little point pretending they were there for the music. Plus, they had a lot to discuss.

Mystery Caller was first to speak. "Can we just go?"

"Finish your drink first," Thomas took control. "You look like you could do with it. And it creates less attention."

"He's right, Jess," Miranda piped up, lifting her driving licence off the table. "Have you eaten?"

Jess didn't answer. The pub crowd, such as they were, cheered after a few intro chords. Thomas watched as a few fans joined in with 'Everybody Needs Somebody To Love.' Unfortunately, some of them were vocally on a par with Karl.

"Blimey — must be Wilson Pickett night!"

Jess looked at him blankly and he smiled to himself at her inadequate musical education. Their rapport was non-existent so he left her with Miranda and went in search of crisps. You could never have too many crisps; he knew that because Karl had done the clinical research.

He was still congratulating himself on how well he was handling everything as he ferried them back. Then he saw Jess crying. Not just crying, she was bawling her eyes out. Miranda was doing her best, but whatever Jess had been holding on to had reached the point of overspill.

"It's time to make a move," he got up, keeping hold of the crisps and leaving Miranda to shoulder the woman out of the pub. He hung back,

checking to see if anyone had taken an interest. Only the barman was looking around, most probably hoping for customers. Thomas nodded in thanks and took the glasses over.

“Is she alright, mate?” The two women were out the door by now.

“Yeah, just a bit of boyfriend trouble.”

The barman murmured something and went back to staring into space.

Although Jess had been upset in the pub, the sight of the Land Rover really made her lose it. It took all their coaxing — and most of that was down to Miranda — to convince Jess they really were there to help her.

Miranda accepted a back seat, with all the grace of a pub brawl. Once everyone was aboard, Thomas passed out the crisps, banking on a comedy moment to lighten the load. He made straight for the North Circular.

The crisps gave Jess something to do, which made the conversation a little easier. He wanted to start with something simple, and to avoid, ‘Why did you call me and who the hell are you?’ for as long as possible. Unfortunately, Miranda hadn’t attended that little briefing in his head.

“So come on, Jess,” Miranda soothed her as they snacked on Salt & Vinegar together, “what made you ring *us*?”

Jess paused, mid crisp. “He said, if I made it out safely, I was to ring that number and someone would take care of everything.” She stopped, gauged their faces and did a fair mime of the word *terror*.

Thomas’s brain was spinning like a bicycle freewheeling downhill — lots of whirling and no control. “You did the right thing, calling us,” he insisted. “We’ll find somewhere safe for you and then we can get to the bottom of this.”

No one seemed to feel like talking anymore, so he put the radio on and found something easy-listening; not classical — he wasn’t trying to put them to sleep — but nothing too boisterous. It also freed him up to concentrate on the driving and ponder what his next move was.

Miranda drew in a breath, a big one; the sort of breath that could only end in a sixty-four-thousand-dollar question. As ever, she didn’t disappoint. “Jess, can you tell us what kind of trouble you’re in?”

Jesus. Why don’t you use a loudhailer and be done with it? Part of him was appalled, but another part was fascinated, seeing Miranda in action. It was a new side to her, and though he’d never tell her, he preferred it; they were a team again.

“I was there on the base, when it happened.”

Oh shit; that opened a trapdoor. He caught Miranda’s eye in the mirror, aware that he could stop this right now, but Jess might not give him a second chance. “Did you see the accident?” he kept his voice low.

“No, I was on my way back in. But as soon as I heard the explosion, I knew. I panicked and hid away; tried to pretend it wasn’t happening.”

He could hear the way her voice fluttered as she spoke. He dug his nails into the wheel to drown out his own memories. “I need to know everything, Jess.”

She didn’t reply and he waited it out for a while, letting the radio soundtrack fill the void. Maybe now was the time to mention he was her only option.

“Do you have clearance for this?” Her voice grated.

God knows. “Absolutely — we both do.” He smiled reassuringly in Miranda’s direction. That winning Bladen smile; it could open locks on a good day, and today was definitely an improvement on yesterday.

Jess took a few long breaths, as if she were rhythmically bringing details to the surface. Then she tilted her head back and began. “The prototype weapon was designed to utilise a range of ammunition without the need for modification.” It sounded like she was reading from a cue card.

Bingo. That explained the unusually colandered target. He nodded appreciatively for her to continue.

“The UB40 will support urban ground troops.”

“The what?”

“The weapon is designated the UB40 — Urban Ballistics. It was some sort of in-joke apparently.”

She didn’t look like she’d be laughing for a long while. He snorted contemptuously; they must have pissed themselves, down at research central. UB40, like the old unemployment benefits form, because all other firearms would be out of a job.

“Its working title is the Scavenger, but the branding hasn’t been decided yet.” She paused then added as an afterthought, “and my contract is ending soon.”

Alarm bells rang in his head at the words *brand* and *contract*. Clearly, not your everyday MoD personnel.

“Who do you work for, exactly?” This was starting to feel like an interrogation.

“Engamel Solutions, of course.”

Never heard of them. He played to his strengths and said nothing. Glancing in the rear mirror, he noticed Miranda was sat very still. Hopefully she wouldn’t feel inclined to ring her family and update them. She looked moody, probably pissed off because he and Jess were talking shop now. And it might not help that Jess wasn’t exactly hard on the eye.

“So,” Miranda leaned towards the gap between the front seats; “How did you get off the base?”

He smiled. Clever girl; cleverer than him, evidently.

Jess went a funny shade of pale. “I can’t say.”

Miranda was having none of it. “Can’t say or won’t say?” There was an edge to the voice. Even Thomas shifted a little in his seat.

“Pull over — I want to get out.” Miss Tiny Tears became Miss Belligerent.

Miranda, he knew, did not like to be challenged, and especially not by a woman. He glanced in the mirror and Miranda was staring right at him, nodding.

He slowed down.

“You’re free to leave us at any time,” Miranda huffed. “But whoever got you out clearly didn’t give a shit about you . . .”

Nice. Always try the softly-softly approach first.

She qualified her statement, “You’ve no belongings and they dropped you off in Uxbridge, alone. You don’t have any close family nearby . . .”

How the bloody hell did she come up with that?

“Because if you had, you wouldn’t have rung us . . .”

He grinned, tilting his head away so that no one else could see. The woman was a genius.

“. . . So let’s stop pissing around, shall we? We’re here to help you, but you’ve got to trust us.”

Jess released her grip on the door handle. “Okay,” she whispered. “I was told to ring your number and not to speak to anyone else. Am I in a lot of trouble?”

That’s what he’d been wondering. Had she been freed for her own good or for someone else’s? Either way, it was time to intervene.

“At this point we’re only interested in uncovering the truth.” He tried to convey a sense of authority and understanding.

No one spoke again until the signs for Edmonton.

“Where is she stopping tonight, Thomas — Walthamstow or Bow?”

Good question. “My place — Walthamstow.” The next sentence leapt past his brain and out his mouth. “Jess, you can have my bed; I’ll kip on the sofa.”

Miranda smacked her lips. “Sounds like three’s a crowd.”

“That’s not what I meant,” he retreated, catching a glimmer of a smile to his left.

But Miranda rang ahead and secured a pick-up from her brother, Terry, telling him to bring the rogue mobile with him. Her tone was measured, in control, and Thomas could feel the shutters coming down.

Chapter 8

“So have a good evening, then.” Miranda swept out of the flat, slamming the door behind her.

Thomas tried desperately to change the subject. “You must be hungry, Jess — do you want a takeaway or shall I see what’s in the freezer?”

Jess sat hunched on the sofa, hands on knees. She lifted her head a little and managed to shrug her shoulders.

Time to work that old Bladen magic. “Here,” he tossed the remote control over to her and then turned on the TV. “You have a play and I’ll see what’s available on the food front.” A thought popped into his head. “If you want to ring anyone . . .”

Her eyes flashed awake from their stupor.

“. . . I’ll get you a throwaway mobile — I’ve got one put by. Don’t use the landline while you’re here.” Which begged the question: just how long was he planning to keep her here?

In the end, he settled for a takeaway curry, phoned in the order and took a walk. Doubtless, she’d use the throwaway mobile the second he was out the door and he was fine with that. Maybe she’d arrange her own safe house somewhere else. Given Miranda’s parting glance, that might be safer for everyone.

The Indian takeaway was empty, if you didn’t count the fish tank and the badly tuned television on a bracket, leaning precariously out of the wall. An adolescent pushed through the beaded curtain and nodded with a flick of his head.

“Alright, boss?”

Inwardly, Thomas cringed. The day that he became anyone’s boss, his dad would disown him and then he’d disown himself. He reminded the lad of his order and sat down on the torn vinyl chair, flinching as his hand touched the chewing gum that some thoughtless bastard had left there.

He rifled through a small pile of newspapers and picked up a daily, raising it in front of him, so he didn’t have to watch the youth gazing up at the TV and tutting. There was nothing about the accident in the paper.

* * *

Fifteen minutes later he was on his way, wondering what the benefit was of ringing ahead. As he got to his front door and fished for his keys, he made contact with Karl's rogue mobile phone in his pocket. Questions floated up before him. *Assuming Karl didn't know Jess — she hadn't actually asked for him by name — who would he have given the number to? And when?* He stood on the doorstep, keys in hand, mulling it over. The only person they'd really spoken with was Major Eldridge. A light glimmered at the back of his brain. *The only time he'd been away from Karl was at the motorway services, on the way home.* Something definitely smelt funny and it wasn't the Peshwari naan. Time to go indoors.

"It's me, Thomas," he called out from the hallway.

The only noise was the TV. What if . . . he grabbed the door handle and burst in, the takeaway bag swinging wildly in one hand. Jess jumped about five feet in the air — just as well she had the sofa to land on. He held up a hand by way of apology and she took the hint, dropping the TV volume.

Dinner was a muted affair; they were strangers after all. He steered clear of alcohol in case she got the wrong idea. She said that she'd rung her family on the mobile and told them she'd be unavailable for a few days because of work. Assuming that were true, it sounded like she'd been coached, which suggested she'd made another call beforehand.

"Does anyone know you're here?"

Her face was a cross between startled and indignant. He took that as a no. As he was clearing the plates, she stood and stretched, arching towards him.

"Mind if I take a shower?"

He blushed, told her it was fine and then remembered that he ought to change the bed linen for her. Might be better to do that later though or she could misread that as well. Jeez, no wonder he never had any female visitors apart from Miranda. He clicked his fingers. Shit, no change of clothes for her either. Well, he could spare a sweatshirt or something; maybe stretch to a pair of boxers.

He waited until the pipes were running, dug out some spare clothes and left them in a neat pile outside the bathroom. Then he went and hid himself in the front room, closing the door.

Left to his own devices, he slipped back into what Karl called *job mode*. First thing he did was check the call register on the new mobile. No

one had rung her back and she had indeed made two calls, not one — ten points to the blue team. He grabbed a pen and noted down the numbers. Duplicitous, certainly, but no more so than ringing up to ask for help and then only giving him half the story.

He heard the pipes shuddering to a halt. She must have been in there for a good fifteen minutes. The door clicked and eased in slowly. Jess had done the thing he secretly loved; she'd pulled his baggy T-shirt down to make it into a dress; well, almost. He didn't dare wonder whether the boxers he'd left out for her were on active service.

The DVD he'd picked out was one of Miranda's — *Sex & the City*, Series Two. Before, according to her, they all became full of themselves. He repositioned his armchair so that Jess sat to one side of him — less chance of gawping at her legs, which she'd thoughtfully folded under her on the sofa.

"Have you got anything to drink?"

Clearly, not a request for tea or coffee. He nodded, crossed the room diagonally, like an inebriated crab, and fetched out two cans of beer and half a bottle of Southern Comfort. As he passed a can to her she leaned towards him and the top of her T-shirt hung forward suggestively.

"Thank you for everything, Thomas."

Her eyes followed him back to the sanctity of the armchair, and she looked a little disappointed. He pressed play on the DVD and let the opening credits roll. It didn't help his conscience that one of the characters in the show was called Miranda; it was like God was sending him a warning.

"Are you and Miranda an item, then?"

He looked up from the screen and blushed. Did anyone really talk like that? *An item*, like a pair of trousers? Good analogy actually, he congratulated himself with a sip of Southern Comfort. Like trousers — joined at one end and apart at the other.

"It's complicated," he confessed. And back to the screen.

"Only I noticed one of your photographs," she gestured outside, towards the bathroom. "She's wearing the same ring, so I presume you gave it to her?"

This was getting less fun by the minute. "Ancient history." He coated his tongue in Southern Comfort to smother any more words at birth.

Jess laughed out loud and nodded in agreement, in places where he merely smiled. Chick flick material, as Sheryl, Miranda's bar manager, would say. More laughter now and even a glass raised to the TV. It was like the battle of the sexes, waged with volume control.

He was gradually losing interest in the antics of the sassy-yet-vulnerable-yet-sexy-yet-needy women on screen. And simultaneously, he was in danger of gaining interest in his houseguest. So he excused himself to go and find pillows and a duvet for the sofa. Jess didn't seem to mind; she was lost in the show, or maybe in an alcoholic haze. Either was fine if it kept her calm and at arm's length.

He stashed the bedclothes outside the bathroom, and went in to brush his teeth and have a final pee. When he emerged, Jess had set the bed up for him on the sofa and commandeered his armchair; legs folded under again, preventing a private view. The latest episode was just winding up.

"I'm going to bed soon; busy day tomorrow," he yawned dramatically and skirted the edges of the room to pull a Sherlock Holmes book from the bookshelf.

"Well, if you're sure." She stood up in one fluid movement and leapt the gap like a gazelle. Without another word, she put her arms around him and drew him close, in a hug to write home about. As he put a supportive arm at her back he felt the absence of a bra, and quickly snatched his hand away. Her breath smelt sweet, like nectar.

She planted an emphatic kiss on his cheek, just beside his lips — willing him to taste it, tender and ambiguous. "See you," she said, swaying gently on her way to the bathroom.

It took a moment to collect his wits from his underwear.

"Er, the yellow toothbrush on the stand is a spare," he flustered. He waited until she came out before getting under the duvet. It felt strange. A bit like waiting for Miranda to come to bed, only, he reminded himself over and over again, Jess was going to one bed and he was on the sofa for the night. Finally, the toilet flushed and the sink hissed, then the door unlocked.

"Can I ask you one more thing?"

He didn't reply.

"Have you ever been in love with someone who's married?" Her face was a mermaid's, far from home. He shook his head. "Take my advice then, it isn't worth it. They never leave."

Unable to follow that, or to fathom it, he mumbled a goodnight and turned to 'The Adventure of the Illustrious Client.' It seemed about right, somehow.

At first there was just a dull sense of recognition, of something being out of place. It took maybe a moment or two to register — the door at the far end was open. He rubbed the blariness out of his eyes and met her silhouette.

"I couldn't sleep. Mind if we talk? Kettle's already on, if you want one?"

Make yourself at home, why don't you. He used her time in the kitchen to put on his jeans and get his act together. When she returned, he was sat up.

"Should I ask what the time is?"

"About three — I'm really sorry," she said earnestly. "If it's any consolation you weren't exactly restful yourself — I heard you calling out in your sleep."

He couldn't argue with that and didn't want to get into it, so he shunted up to the far end of the sofa and she played bookends at the other, cradling her tea like it was holy water.

"I couldn't stop thinking about Amy."

He was all primed for a 'Who's she?' when Jess added, "and how she died." She was overwrought and tired, so it seemed only natural to move across and put a comforting arm around her. In contrast to before, her lips were tentative, innocent almost, as they found their way to his. She smelt clean and, for want of a better word, virginal. He gently guided her face away.

That was when he saw the light glowing from his mobile. He reached over and flipped the cover. Miranda's text was brief and to the point: *Soz about earlier. Maybe I'm in need of something — chocolate! Mx.* He shut the mobile and smiled at Jess, a reassuring smile that suggested they probably both felt foolish but no real harm had been done. And now that he had steered away from a whole lot of further complications, he pulled the duvet back over himself, turned away from her and tried to get back to sleep. "I'll see you in the morning."

Chapter 9

Thomas's mobile alarm kicked in at six thirty. He made a slow lunge to kill it and the events of the previous day came barrelling towards him, a close escape from his own stupidity. Sure, she had looked cute, but so what? He grabbed the cups and started out for the kitchen, almost colliding with her outside the door.

"What did they say would happen after we picked you up?" He played dumb, but deliberately said *they*, to see how she responded.

Jess furrowed her brow. "He told me . . ."

Well, that narrowed it to half the population.

". . . That I had to stay hidden for a while because of the inquiry. And that the base records would show I wasn't there that day."

He carried on walking and, to his surprise, she followed him.

"Let me guess," he was freewheeling now, but he had experience to draw upon; "an untraceable payment appears in your bank account in a few days' time and you take a long holiday somewhere warm until this all blows over?"

Her mouth opened but nothing came out. He took it as a subliminal hunger message and put together a breakfast of toast and scrambled eggs.

"You wouldn't have been taking advantage of me, you know, last night."

He piled the toast high and avoided eye contact. She hadn't finished.

"No one would have known."

He took a huge bite and rolled it around his mouth. It needed more brown sauce. "*I'd* have known."

Over breakfast, he ran through a comprehensive set of dos and don'ts — mostly common sense. Jess, in turn, gave him a shopping list. For a second or two he considered enlisting Miranda's help, and then thought better of it.

It was all getting a bit domestic for him, so he got ready for work, reminding her not to open the door or go near the curtains.

"I'll ring you on your mobile. Stay safe." Not very gracious perhaps, but he'd taken the precaution of locking his bedroom and the dark room.

Just in case she got through the rest of *Sex & the City* and needed further entertainment.

His watch read seven thirty as he opened the front door. A chill autumn breeze sharpened his senses. Across the street, an elderly woman was pooper-scooping the strenuous efforts of a West Highland Terrier; and the poor beast was still in mid strain.

“It’s alright, dear — I’m cleaning it up.”

Unclaimed dog shit was the least of his problems — where the fuck was the Land Rover? Karl was his first port of call; he sounded chipper, right up until Thomas dropped his bombshell.

“I’ll come straight over.”

“No,” Thomas’s breath caught in his throat. “I’ll handle it — I just wanted to let you know first.”

“Well,” Karl stretched the word out, “you’d better call it in to Services and let the boss know.”

“Will do — I’ll see you in the office later.”

He vaulted the steps to his door and fumbled for his keys. His heart was thumping. Why take the Land Rover? Was someone expecting to collect the canister? And what would they do when they found it wasn’t there?”

“It’s alright, it’s Thomas — I’m alone,” he yelled along the hallway.

Jess opened the living room door. “What’s going on?”

Now was not the time to play twenty questions.

“The Land Rover’s been taken. Don’t make a sound.” He pulled out his mobile again. “Christine, it’s Thomas. I have a problem — the Land Rover’s gone.”

She checked some details, but didn’t pass any other comment.

“Yeah, just about to call in Services — I’ll fill out a statement when I come in. No, once I got home.”

He ended the call on the edge of politeness; the sweat was already gathering at his neck. Jess smiled from the sofa, as if to suggest she wasn’t really a whole heap of trouble.

“Jess, if you even *feel* under threat today, call the police.”

She looked frightened. Tough — welcome to the world of consequences.

He double-locked the door from the outside and hotfooted it to Walthamstow Central tube station. If anyone planned on following him

they'd have to be bloody quick today. Even so, he changed trains twice and surfaced one stop early to walk the rest of the way to the office.

* * *

Karl greeted him just inside the door, vending-machine coffee in hand.

"I listened out for your footsteps on the stairs, great heffalump that you are. We, er, need to have a little chat."

Thomas tried to avoid a pained expression and pushed past him. The main office was empty, not a soul around and even Karl's laptop was off. Christine Gerrard's office light was aglow and the door was closed. From where he was standing, it looked like she had guests.

"We're in here . . ." Karl led the way.

We?

". . . And by the way, Tommo, you look like shit."

Christine got up as Karl opened the door. Ann Crossley, another member of the team, edged her chair round so they could all squeeze in. Karl grabbed a spot at the opposite side of the table — all very cosy.

"What's going on?" Thomas looked at them each in turn: Karl, who'd become his closest ally in the Surveillance Support Unit, protecting him to the point of risking his own life; Ann Crossley, who had once warned him when he hadn't even known he was in danger; and Christine Gerrard, who had put aside their own tangled past and helped preserve the integrity of the SSU when things had turned ugly, out on the moors. None of which explained this little summit.

"Thing is, Tommo . . ." *So Karl was the messenger.* He sounded almost apologetic. ". . . We all thought it was time, after everything that happened earlier this year, to settle a few things."

Thomas waited it out, feeling no obligation to make it easy for them. He was done asking questions anyway. That faculty was already stretched to the limit, trying to figure out what had happened to the Land Rover. And what the hell he was supposed to do about a fugitive, a weapon he wasn't supposed to have, and footage of an industrial accident that didn't seem to have any purpose?

In the end, Christine played her seniority card. She started by reminding Thomas of things he already knew — a classic way of placating

people and asserting some kind of normality. He nearly laughed at the thought: *normality*.

She covered old ground quickly — how there was still a faction within multiple government departments — including the SSU — that supported a fast track to a United States of Europe.

Even now it sounded like bollocks. Or it did, until he remembered Sir Peter Carroll and the set up with the money and the ache in his chest, where Yorgi the hit man tried to plant a bullet, seconds before Sir Peter put him down for good.

“You know of course that we each report to different agencies.”

He nodded dumbly. In his experience, dumb usually worked. Christine took the bait.

“And now that you know we’re on the same side . . .” which sounded a lot like ‘now that you have proved yourself.’ “. . . we only need to have this conversation once. You know Karl served in the army, Ann?”

Ann Crossley sat back and lifted her head proudly. “Naval Intelligence.”

Christine’s whole posture seemed to relax, as if the effort of pretence was over. “And before I met you Thomas, I spent two years in the Foreign Office.”

Blimey. He looked daggers across the room. He already knew about Karl’s background, but Christine’s bombshell . . . Somehow that little nugget had failed to come out during the year he and Christine had shared a duvet.

Every statement threw up more questions. He let the opportunity pass — he had enough to think about. Christine was still talking, so he tried to refocus.

“Whereas you, Thomas, have a purely civilian background.” The way she said it made it sound like some sort of infectious disease.

“But that gives you a certain objectivity and independence, which could be advantageous.”

For two months, ever since Yorgi had been surgically removed from the equation and the whole bad business put to bed, he’d been kept away from their in-house counter-intelligence. He knew it was still going on; that became obvious when Karl was late or didn’t show up for an entire day and

Christine never said a word. Although God only knew who Karl actually represented. MI5 maybe?

Anyhow, it didn't take Brain of Britain to realise that the three of them were assessing him to see if he was still capable of playing a role.

"The explosion at the test facility has unfortunate implications."

That'll be a great comfort to the victim's family. He made the supreme effort and bit his tongue.

"Karl cannot get too involved in this matter, so Ann will provide any support you need."

Now his feelers were twitching; he let his tongue go. "Support for what?"

Christine steamrolled his comment like it was soft tarmac.

"Tomorrow morning, you will report to Sir Peter Carroll in Whitehall."

"Now wait a f . . ."

Christine gave him her *know your place* look, the one that always stopped him in his tracks. The one her mother had tried at that disastrous 'Happy Families' Christmas with him and Christine at the big house. The only time he'd ever missed Christmas with the Wrights — when Miranda had been abroad.

"It's out of my hands, Thomas. Karl would be seen as too partisan."

Karl hadn't looked at him since he'd first sat down. He shot the big feller a glance, but Karl wasn't receiving loud or clear.

"Okay, that's all. Dismissed." Karl and Ann rose to their feet immediately, and were at the door before Thomas had shifted his chair. Christine raised a hand.

"Thomas, can you hold on for a minute?"

Ann closed the door carefully behind her. Thomas watched as she and Karl went over to her desk, talking all the while. Best friends forever, or was that supposed to be Ann and him now?

"A couple of things . . ." Christine attempted one of those efficiency smiles — pragmatic and energy saving. "Firstly, yours I believe?" She opened a drawer and picked out an audio surveillance transmitter. "I found it under my table after Yorgi . . . when Bob Peterson was still in charge."

She flushed scarlet and he sunned himself in the afterglow. Bob Peterson, her former boss and her former shag.

"I won't ask what it was doing there or how you came by it."

He accepted the bug and pocketed it, along with the battery, which she'd thoughtfully separated. He hadn't thought to check the secure web server for sound files. Or maybe Karl had fixed that too.

"Look," Christine softened her voice, touching his arm with her fingertips. "Karl told me you'd agreed to speak to a professional about what happened with Yorgi. I've cleared your schedule for this afternoon — no sense delaying, now that you've made up your mind."

She held up a business card that he snatched away, like a petulant child. Her perfume wafted across; Clive Christian, if he wasn't mistaken. Some things never changed. Which made him wonder whether she'd stopped seeing the very married Bob Peterson, especially since he'd pressured Sir Peter Carroll to transfer Uncle Bob out of London. Like Jess had said, they *never* leave.

* * *

Karl had stumped up for lunch; condemned man's last meal and all that. A pub lunch, naturally, with Karl sticking to shandy. It was an olde worlde pub with thoroughly modern prices. They sat, cheek by jowl with dozens of anonymous suits, arranged in orderly fashion like a factory farm for diners.

"I've noticed a certain scrutiny from you today, Tommo."

Thomas put down his panini and licked the mozzarella from his hand. "It's nothing. I'm just surprised about working with Ann, that's all."

His unspoken question burned in his eyes — when did Karl get to know about it?

Karl raised a glass to his heart. "I'm touched by your loyalty. Rest assured it'll be a temporary state of affairs. Word is that you're going into uncharted waters."

"Come again?" The hackles on his neck rose up.

"I believe Major Eldridge has requested your attendance."

Thomas took another bite of panini, hit raw onion and crunched it up. The sharp, sour taste suited his mood perfectly. "But I thought you two were buddies?"

"Well, we served together, right enough. And I'd go so far as to say that he's a decent man. It's the former that's the problem, if you get my drift?"

He didn't. The onion was lingering, so he rinsed it down with the last of his orange juice — couldn't very well see the shrink, reeking of onion. "So

what will you be up to while I'm playing *fetch* with Sir Peter Carroll tomorrow?"

"I'm out for the day — compassionate leave. My mammy's unwell."

He caught his breath. To all intents and purposes, Karl never even had a family, until now.

"Is it serious?"

Karl managed the smallest of chuckles and rubbed his forehead, spiking his brown hair. "You could say that; she's dying."

"Shit." Not the most eloquent message of support, but it spoke volumes.

Karl checked his watch. "You'd better get your skates on or you're not gonna make it to Harley Street on time. Nothing but the best for our boys and girls. And listen, give me a bell later — let me know how you got on, okay?"

"Roger that."

Karl smiled on cue. "And get some chewing gum; this close up, you smell like Onion Boy."

"Listen, if you, er, want to talk any time — or meet up — just give me a call."

Karl waved his shandy towards him. "Come on now, will you ever fuck off? Please — before we start doing hugs and high fives."

* * *

He left Baker Street tube and took his chances crossing Marylebone Road, before checking in with Jess. She was quieter, and he'd expected that. You might be able to cope with incredible challenges and stresses, but it all caught up with you eventually. Shit, that's why *he* was there. She had nothing to report — if he could believe her. Which he didn't.

He counted the street numbers until he found a column of buzzers with the name he was looking for: R. Kyriacou. He tapped his feet self-consciously and glanced up the street. *Right then, here goes nothing.*

The buzzer was answered immediately, confirming his name and appointment time. The voice sounded just short of warm, non-judgemental. The door clicked and he slipped inside, climbing the lacquered stairs in rhythmic strides.

On the third floor, he branched out to the left, where a woman was waiting. Her glasses hung on a chain around her neck, and her expression was neutral.

“I’m the two thirty.” A pointless repetition of his intercom intro, which might have been why it drew no response. “I’m here to see Mr Kyriacou.” Sudden thought: was it shrinks who didn’t use the term *doctor* or was that surgeons?

“That would be me, and it’s Ms Kyriacou.”

A brilliant start. He followed her in. No padding on the walls — always a good sign. At one end of the room was a wall-length bookcase, which puzzled him. If this was a place of work you couldn’t possibly find time to read all these; it felt like a pose. Maybe it impressed the rich clients.

“Can I get you a tea or coffee?”

He sat down with a mug of tea and a biscuit. Thankfully it wasn’t a ‘you don’t have to be mad to work here, but it helps’ mug. He took a good look around; this could almost be someone’s living room. There was a faint roar of traffic; he tuned in and let it carry him inside. It reminded him of lying on a ridge as a boy and cupping his ears so that the wind blew past in a continuous sigh.

“Shall we start, Thomas?”

If he took what she said at face value, then she knew nothing about him, other than his name and that he worked for a government department. This was, she explained, a confidential referral service for people such as himself.

“Now, how can I help you?”

Chapter 10

“You see, Tommo, I told you there was nothing to fear!”

He pulled the mobile back a little and smiled at the mouthpiece. “We’ll see. I’ve been booked in for eight sessions and apparently I’m dealing with a trauma.”

“Just the one? Jeez, what a lightweight!”

He checked his watch. “I can get to Liverpool Street for four thirty, if you’re allowed out for a quick drink?”

“Aye, sure enough. I’ll see you in The George then.”

Next stop, Regent’s Park. The pocket camera was like a toy, compared with the day job, but he couldn’t let the opportunity pass by. As he crossed the busy road again and risked the wrath of cab drivers and cycle couriers, he was already getting a sense of what he wanted to photograph. This was the way he had worked when he was still chasing a role on the dailies; the jolt of inspiration and the anticipation of pulling it off; joy or disappointment — no middle ground.

Conscious of time, he’d chosen an easy win — a black and white of a lone tree beside water. It was a curious thing, photography; you could learn a lot about the snapper from their compositions. He preferred landscapes, except for shots of Miranda. She wasn’t exactly his muse, but after twelve years or so of skirting around each other, it wouldn’t do to break the set. He’d told himself that the bleak moorland photos he loved so much were a reaction to the day job, until he remembered that he’d always taken those kinds of pictures. He found a suitable cherry tree and rattled off five snaps from different positions. If any of them worked out, he’d add the best to his wall and give a print to Miranda.

Jess didn’t pick up when he rang her mobile again. No sweat, he’d be home before seven pm. She was probably in the loo; as far as Thomas knew, he was the only person who carried the mobile *everywhere* in case of a call.

* * *

“I tell you, Mr Bladen, the office has been damn quiet without you this afternoon.” Karl shook a couple of crisp bags to simulate excitement.

Thomas sat down and passed the pocket camera over.

"Hmm . . ." Karl scrutinised the Regents Park pictures. "Number four is probably your winner. I suppose by then you knew what you were doing, and by number five you were getting sloppy." High praise indeed from Karl.

It felt like a Friday, on a Monday. Karl talked him through the Case of the Disappearing Land Rover, of the efforts (minimal) and the progress (non-existent) to locate and recover the vehicle. At least the paperwork had been completed. And it was satisfying to know that they'd deprived some schmuck of the *special feature*.

Karl dismissed any theorising on who and why and how. That could wait till another day, he insisted; this was just a wind-down meet-up. A couple of times the conversation stalled and Thomas primed himself to mention Jess. But when it came down to it, he couldn't do it. Karl had enough on his plate with his mother. Still, there were things that needed to be said, and there was only one place where he knew Karl would talk freely.

"How about we get together, one evening this week at the gun club?"

Karl's face seemed to glow momentarily. That or it could have been the light reflecting off his shandy. "Really?"

"Sure. Why not?" Thomas put his hands together in mock prayer. "My therapist did say I should confront my fears."

"Fantastic. You don't have to participate if you don't feel ready."

"We'll see."

Just the thought of the club and the cold weight of a gun made his hands sweat. But seeing the unexpected joy on Karl's haggard face almost made it worth it.

Two drinks on and Thomas realised that he hadn't bought Jess anything to wear. He blushed, because the idea of it conjured up all kinds of complications. He turned the conversation to the following morning's meeting in Whitehall.

Karl listened for a while and cut in at the first opportunity. "I understand how you feel about Sir Peter Carroll. The words *snake* and *poisonous* come to mind. But the art of politics," he nodded in Thomas's direction, "which I accept is not your bag, lies in shaking hands with the person who just tried to stab you in the back."

Thomas consoled himself. Besides, Karl's shadowy friends were now running Sir Peter Carroll as a . . . was it a double agent or a triple agent now? Whatever it was, it made his head hurt.

As he was leaving, Thomas had another thought. "Is Major Eldridge married?" Apparently he was, although Karl never said if it was happily.

* * *

He caught the overground train to Walthamstow Central and negotiated his way through the drifters and delinquents who treated the space outside McDonald's as their personal territory.

No one paid him much attention and that was how he liked it; he could have been any other pen pusher trudging home, rather than a recent collector of unclaimed weapons and people. He cut down a side street to cross Forest Road and gave a nod to Lloyd Park. How many years was it since he'd proposed to Miranda by the Yew tree there? Still not long enough to forget that she'd deflated his big moment by telling him that Yew trees were connected with death and graveyards. So much of life, he pondered, as he popped into the convenience store for milk and bread, was fixed by tiny events — like pixels in a digital frame. Even now, as he wondered whether it was insulting or considerate to buy tampons and deodorant for his houseguest — it was all down to having Karl's mobile when the call came in. If only he'd given Karl his phone back.

What was it the therapist had said? 'Trauma can make us examine our values and our choices. Often, traumatic events are entirely out of our control. But what we do subsequently can be influenced by them.' He wasn't quite sure how that applied to toiletries, but it was something to think about.

* * *

Instinct wasn't something he often laid claim to; he preferred to think of it as being observant, reading what was there for anyone to see. It was all in the details. As he approached his flat, he knew straight away that something wasn't right.

He stood outside, checking life's pixels. And there it was, the join on the curtains — seamless. Beyond neatness and beyond how he'd left them that morning. He checked the front door — locks intact, not a scratch on them; hinges the same. A familiar sinking feeling settled in his stomach as

he unlocked the door; if he was right, there wasn't much point in announcing himself.

He dropped the shopping by the door and flicked the lights on. It was very quiet. The front curtains had been bulldog clipped together. He tried the back door then spotted that the nearby window was unlocked. Not a sign of Jess about the place, or her original clothing. Part of him was worried, but he couldn't see how anyone could have broken in and taken her without leaving any traces behind.

One sideboard drawer was slightly out of line from the others — and £40 adrift. The missing cash he could live with, but leaving his flat vulnerable was a cardinal sin. He noticed the post on the coffee table, so she must have been there when it came, at around eleven. His brain shifted up a gear. Of course, she could have been anywhere when he spoke to her earlier on the mobile. *Well, done is done; now what?* He flipped his mobile and dialled the most-called number.

“Miranda Wright, who wants to know?”

“It's Thomas. There's a problem. Jess has disappeared; she got out of the flat while I was at work.”

“So your sexual magnetism repels as well as attracts?”

“Yeah, very droll,” he snapped. “Meantime, one woman is dead and another one who was at the scene is out there alone.”

There was no response for a few seconds. “How do you know she's alone?”

Good question. “I double-locked the doors, front and back; no forced entry.” He could hear keys jiggling in the background.

“Doesn't mean someone didn't collect her; or she could have gone out to meet someone.”

Maybe she was on to something.

“So why ring me? Are you planning to form a search party?” That was Miranda, all heart.

“I didn't know what else to do . . .”

“Yeah, you did,” there was a snarl in her voice. “Ring Karl — it's his mobile, he can deal with it.”

He thought about Karl's mother and shuddered a little. “No can do, Miranda. It's *my* problem.”

“I'll come over, if you want.”

“Thanks.”

* * *

There was a definite swagger as Miranda waltzed in, an hour later. He'd put on dinner for two — a freezer special — and brought out a bottle of wine, Miranda's favourite, from the back of the cupboard. She was in a triumphant mood from the off.

“I knew she was bad news; the way she turned on the waterworks to order.”

He choked a little and scuttled off to the kitchen.

“Fess up then,” she called after him. “Did something happen?”

Crockery clattered.

“Look, it's no skin off my nose. We're not exclusive to each other . . .”

He nearly dropped a plate. *We're not?*

“ . . . But we ought to be mature enough to be honest with each other.”

He was never any good under pressure with her. “Alright. We kissed. Well, that is, she kissed me.”

“You poor defenceless man. And I suppose you fought her off to protect your honour.”

“Hey, don't take the piss. I stopped things going any further if that's what you're looking for.”

She was only a few feet behind him. Close enough to hear her sighing. “You're so easily manipulated . . .”

He didn't know if she meant him or men in general.

“ . . . Pathetic . . . make a man feel like Sir Galahad and he'll whore himself out and be grateful to do it.”

It took all his self-control not to retaliate with: *Is that how we got together?* Somehow he managed to dish up without smashing anything, and carried the food through with a face like thunder. It was hard to know what was pissing him off more — the fact that Miranda was talking like this, or that she was probably right about him.

They ate and watched TV without talking; not exactly a dazzling evening. He wondered why she'd bothered coming over at all, and then remembered that she'd given him a choice — some treat that had turned out to be.

By mutual consent, they gave up the ghost at half past ten. He performed his ablutions and waited for her, but as he followed her into his bedroom she paused at the threshold. "I'll get you the duvet for the sofa."

He felt his mouth open about a foot. She feigned surprise. "Surely you didn't think . . ." Game, set and match to Miranda.

He collected the folded bedclothes by the door and hunkered down on the sofa again. For a while, as he lay there, he thought about how he'd feel if Miranda had shared his bed one night, then snogged some stranger the next. He fired off a jovial text to Karl, and tried to sleep without thinking about what he was missing.

The click of the bathroom light disturbed him around midnight. He woke to a face full of cushion. The door at the end of the room was open; the bedroom glare bled across the carpet.

He heard the familiar hiss of the tap running in the bathroom. He shifted position on the sofa and saw a naked Miranda heading into his bedroom. She stopped and turned in the doorframe, cutting the kind of silhouette that would chase a man to his dreams and leave him there weeping.

"G'night then, Thomas."

He was still gazing forlornly at the illuminated carpet when the door closed firmly, consigning him to darkness. He lay there, breathing in her perfume as it wafted through the flat. Even if he didn't have visitation rights, his bed had been well and truly scent-marked.

Chapter 11

He took Miranda in a cup of tea at seven am and didn't stick around to chance another rejection. Later, in the shower, he thought he heard her trying the locked door. He emerged, towel tightly around his waist, determined not to have a row.

"You coming over to Caliban's after work?" Miranda was waiting for him.

Caliban's — her bar in the East End; it sounded like an invitation. If he'd been any more confused, he'd have had to ask for directions.

"Sure, unless I get another call to deal with."

"Up to you. Your loss."

Ouch. Wrong answer. He skipped breakfast and the offer of a lift to the station, leaving Miranda to lock up with her own keys when she was done. He thought about Karl, and then about how he'd feel if it was *his* mother. A big question. He wasn't close to her anymore, or his dad, unlike his sister Pat — who lived a few streets away. No, family had never been his strong suit, unless it was Miranda's family — as his own were quick to point out.

* * *

St James Park tube was his exit from the underworld. Despite the heady concoction of heat, machinery and teeming crowds, he loved it below the surface. A million micro dramas and all you had to do was take notice. Miranda reckoned it was his father's miner genes, desperate for expression.

And of course, where there were crowds, there was coffee. Life always felt better when it had an espresso tinge to it. He waved the little cardboard cup under his nostrils like a connoisseur, his nose tingling with delight. He alternated between choc-chip cookie and coffee, promising himself a salad at lunchtime by way of penance.

Main Building in Whitehall felt smaller than when he'd last been there, as if Sir Peter Carroll's exposure and deflation had taken it down with him. He entered the lobby and paused, enjoying a moment of confidence. Well, almost. Karl's cryptic comment about *uncharted waters* didn't sit too comfortably.

He walked across to a wall-mounted screen, tuned to News 24. Same old shit; war, dodgy politicians, public scandals and celebrity toss. *Oh, to be in England*. Still, it was a good five minutes before he could tear himself away, and only then to check the time. Mustn't be late. Ten minutes to go. May as well check in.

After the usual round of Guess Who, he put his ID away and placed his hand on the scanner. All present and correct. A kindly guard told him to go wait by the seats and someone would come to fetch him.

He sat down and toyed with his mobile, hopeful that Karl or Miranda might have something to say. Then he remembered the piece of paper with the two numbers Jess had called. His hand gravitated towards the beige phone on the glass table. What harm could it do? Answer: none because he was calling from Whitehall. He figured the first number would be the most interesting, given how Jess had described her message to the folks. This would be the *prep* number, hopefully. The second ring had barely kicked in before it was answered.

"Cecil Eldridge. Hello?"

Blimey. He gulped under his breath and slowly leant forward to cut the call without attracting attention from the front desk. Then he lifted his finger clear and nodded as if he were still in conversation, playing out the last of it as his security escort arrived.

"Mr Bladen? If you'd like to come this way?"

The escort was stony quiet as they made their way up in the lift. Usually that bothered him, but he was glad of it today — more time to think. Why would Jess ring Major, or rather, *Cecil* Eldridge? And if he answered his mobile without his rank, that suggested a very personal number. But Jess, from what she'd said, wasn't even on the official payroll. No, she was contracted to that outfit . . . Engamel Solutions. Something else he ought to do some checking up on.

Top floor, lift doors open, turn right and compensate for the bounce from the carpet. No CCTV up here, just in case the MI5 bloke along the corridor fancied a quick chat with the CIA liaison office. The idea made him smile momentarily.

Now he was at the door. Tappety-tap; it was *The Three Little Pigs* in reverse.

"Come in."

The sound of Sir Peter Carroll's voice sliced through Thomas's composure. Tension slid across his shoulders like an ice floe. The escort abandoned him outside and went on his way.

He turned the handle, taking a deep breath to resist the urge to smash the man's face in.

"Hello, Thomas." Sir Peter's tone was cautious, and he was keeping to his side of the desk.

He took comfort in that; they were both finding their feet in this brave new world. Sir Peter may have founded the Surveillance Support Unit and Thomas may have been a mere underling, but since Sir Peter's collusion with the United States of Europe movers and shakers, *Mr Carroll* also did the bidding of Karl's people.

"I've ordered coffee — it should be here presently."

He took a seat and nodded, without offering a handshake. He winced at himself. *Skating very close to looking like a dick*. Whatever had happened, Sir Peter was still the boss.

The boss rested his fingertips on the edge of his desk. Maybe it was meant to be some show of honesty. Fat chance. "I'll come straight to the point. You and Karl McNeill were asked to capture supplementary evidence at the test facility, following an equipment malfunction."

Thomas felt his mouth open and his right hand — the punching one — start twitching. "I think you mean the scene of the fatality."

Sir Peter's face was blank, and pale. Either he hadn't known or he was doing a bloody good impression. He cleared his throat and lifted his fingers away quickly, as if the desk had a built-in polygraph. "Something has gone missing from the facility and a light touch investigation is required. Suffice it to say, this is not something the military police need to concern themselves with at the moment."

Two knocks on the door. Sir Peter shifted a gear to benevolent host and coffees were served. When the orderly had closed the door behind him, Sir Peter put his spoon down with infinite care and patience. Thomas took it as a sign that bad news was coming.

"Major Charles Eldridge has requested your assistance. He requires a surveillance officer — specifically, someone without an armed forces background."

“But Karl and I always work together — you signed the executive order.”

“And I’ll continue to honour it.”

Honour? Do me a favour.

“However, in this case, Karl has already agreed it would be in everyone’s best interests if you dealt with Major Eldridge alone, wherever possible.”

The penny was dropping. Everyone’s best interests implied that Karl wanted things this way as well. He could live with that, even if it did mean cosying up to Ann Crossley for a while. “There’s something else, isn’t there?”

Sir Peter smiled, a thin-lipped rat-in-a-corner smile. “There is a certain commercial interest in this investigation, but that can wait. Now, Major Eldridge will be here in a few minutes. When you are dismissed, I want you to leave the building and return in one hour — is that clear?”

He shook his head infinitesimally; wheels within wheels. It shouldn’t have come as a big surprise, but somehow it did. Sir Peter was still a wheeler-dealer, still playing political poker and managing to cash in early.

When Major Eldridge put in an appearance, Sir Peter and Thomas were looking at photographs together. A love of photography had sparked their first conversation, back when Thomas was a pen-pushing civil servant. And, to a degree, photography still sufficed as a neutral zone.

“Sir Peter, Thomas.” Major Eldridge nodded curtly in lieu of handshakes.

That was okay, courtesy seemed to be off the menu today. The good major explained that he had asked for an independent support officer — he didn’t mention surveillance at all. Thomas waited until the *any questions* part of the programme.

“Who’s the commercial interest? And what are my responsibilities there?”

Major Eldridge straightened his jacket. “The prototype weapon is being developed by a consortium: Engamel Solutions. It’s likely that they’ll want to speak with you.”

Sir Peter glanced at his watch. “I think that’ll be all for now, Thomas.”

“Very good, Sir Peter.” He rose and glided to the door, like a butler on casters. It amused him to think that Sir Peter would know this was sarcasm,

while the major would see it as deferential. Perhaps they'd compare notes afterwards.

* * *

Out in the park and safe from prying eyes, Thomas checked his mobile and picked up a *call me when free* text from Karl. He wasted no time.

"Hey, Tommo, how's the new job?"

"Plenty of perks — free coffee, ginger nuts, duplicity. So where are you now?"

"I'm watching the front of Main Building — I thought you might want to accidentally bump into Major Eldridge on his way out."

"How did you know he—?"

"Come on now, Mr Bladen, credit me with some intelligence — forgive the pun."

"I've been instructed to go back there in an hour so I shouldn't imagine the major's going to emerge any time soon. I'll come over to you."

Karl wasn't looking his best. It didn't take Sherlock Holmes to realise that his mother's impending demise was hitting him hard.

"I, er, don't know what to say."

"That's okay, Tommo, I know you're the sensitive type." Karl took a breath and touched a finger to his bottom lip. For anyone else you'd say he'd just had a thought. But Thomas knew that Karl was *always* thinking. "Let me make it easy for you. She has cancer — last time I spoke with the doctor, she said Ma had maybe two months . . . and I won't be going to the funeral."

He nodded. Karl hadn't taken his eye off the entrance to Main Building, but now he was sitting up. "Tell you what, Tommo. Better get your skates on. Your new army friend is strolling for the border. Time to make like a Yorkshire Terrier!"

* * *

"Major Eldridge!" Thomas gasped as he made it across the road.

The major turned slowly and his face softened in recognition. "Thomas, just the man. I wanted to speak with you privately, later."

He smiled and read him like yesterday's news. *Yeah, maybe I could ring you on your personal mobile.*

"I look forward to working closely with you."

“Me too — may I call you Cecil?” It was either clever or stupid, but he was determined to squeeze something useful from their micro meeting.

And while Major Eldridge barely flinched, his pupils did a Latin tango. He recovered sufficiently to pass on his phone number — not, Thomas noted, the number Jess had called him on. He considered asking the major how Jess was and *where* she was. Maybe not though, just in case the major had nothing to do with it after all and it spooked him.

He bounded back to the park like a kid who’d just been given a new football. Karl was waiting on a bench, hunched forward, sharp as a cat. “Good meeting?”

“You could say that,” he felt his smile engulfing him. “By the way, I meant to return your mobile — from the base.”

Karl pocketed the phone without looking at it. “Did Major Eldridge ring you? I gave him the number when we stopped at motorway services. I figured it best he have a private number.”

Confirmation then of how Jess knew where to call. “No, nothing from the major . . .”

“And yet?” Karl frowned, sitting back and narrowing his eyes.

He tapped out a rhythm on the bench. “Someone else called; turns out there were two technicians at the test site. The other one left the base and wanted assistance.”

“Very interesting,” Karl congratulated him. “So the major must have slipped her the number.”

Thomas blew out a breath. “Well, that might not be all he’s been slipping her. After me and Miranda picked her up, she rang the major on his personal mobile — I checked.”

Karl ran his tongue along his teeth as if scraping away the taste. “Hmm, messy. If Major E snuck her off the base then he’s probably also responsible for the Land Rover cargo. That’s a lot of risk for a man in his position. I won’t ask where you’ve stashed this woman.”

“Jess,” Thomas dropped in his little pebble and then Karl made a show of lightly cupping his ears. He sprawled out on the bench beside Karl. A jackdaw scrambled to the ground a few feet away and eyed the two of them curiously.

“See now, he’s a *real* scavenger. Know something, Tommo? I can’t help thinking the major was using me as a mule. First the weapon components

and now this *Jess* — it was my mobile she rang after all.

Yeah, Thomas thought to himself, the one you conveniently left with me. He scuffed the ground with his heel and the jackdaw jolted to attention. “I thought you weren’t getting involved?”

“I’m not.” Karl’s voice was flat, non-negotiable. He filched about in his pocket, dug out what looked like half a peanut and flicked it over to the waiting bird. “But let me know how you get on.”

Thomas was still mulling over what the hell he was supposed to do about it all when Karl stood up and brushed his trousers. “I’ve always trusted Major Eldridge — that doesn’t mean you should.” The jackdaw erupted into comment like a trained stooge.

Thomas’s mobile trilled; a simple ringtone; the most nondescript on the list. He nodded to Karl and dove in. “Hi, Miranda, what’s shaking?” Sometimes he was so smooth he could barely keep the phone in his hands.

“She’s turned up again, at the flat. She wasn’t expecting to find me here though.” Miranda’s tone all but screamed ‘I told you so.’

“Did she say where she’d vanished to?” Thomas upped the volume a little; making sure Karl caught every word. “See if you can get her mobile on the quiet and check the call record. I need to know who she’s called. Okay, speak to you later. Thanks.” He cut the call, turned to Karl and waited.

“Quite the little team, you and Miranda. A fella could get jealous.”

Thomas pointed to a tree. “*Quercus coccinea*.”

“Is that your privileged Yorkshire Secondary Education coming through?”

“Nah, it’s my 1987 encyclopaedia and a school project on oaks in Britain.”

“Ah yes, the scarlet oak. And don’t look so surprised; haven’t I always told you we have lots in common? Right, I’m out of here — see you around, unless you’re clubbing tonight?” The sort of club that welcomed Glocks, Smith & Wessons, Brownings and Colts.

“Sorry, got a date I can’t break.”

Karl smiled sadly and walked off towards the trees.

* * *

As soon as the call came through from Sir Peter's office, he rushed back. The same escort shadowed him in the lift, did the customary three knocks at the door, waited for a muffled reply and then scarpered. Before Thomas could get to the handle, the door opened and the face behind it was that of a stranger.

"Hey there, you must be Thomas. Come on in."

He extended a hand mechanically, like a dog giving paw, while Sir Peter Carroll watched from behind his desk.

"Thomas, this is . . ."

"Michael Schaefer," the man announced himself, heavy on the volume. "Please, call me Michael — Engamel Solutions."

As John Wright might have put it: fuck a duck. And a Texan duck at that, by the sounds of things. Thomas took up the empty chair — no coffee, he noted — and waited for someone to speak.

"This is very delicate, Thomas." Sir Peter ran his finger along the edge of the desk. "I need you to establish an audio presence on Major Eldridge."

He took out a notebook and listed the requirements. It helped to quell any lingering inclination to ask the wrong questions — and there were so many to choose from. Okay, so it wasn't the first time he'd provided internal surveillance for a government department. But — and this was a biggie — the major was MoD, unlike the SSU. And laughing boy wasn't even on Her Majesty's payroll.

"Now, Thomas, Christine will need to be briefed, to some extent; strictly on a need to know basis." Which meant Christine would get the wafer thin version.

"Michael will be my personal representative in this matter." Sir Peter waved a conciliatory hand towards Schaefer as Thomas looked on. In this poker game, a Corporate seemed to beat a Title.

"Ya see, Thomas . . ."

Ah, it speaks again. Well, drawls.

"Engamel Solutions knows Major Eldridge is of the highest calibre. We just want to be . . ." he looked to Sir Peter for the right word.

"Doubly sure?" Thomas pitched in.

"Absolutely! I can see you're the right man for the job."

Thomas shot a glance across the desk and then went back to note taking. Two devices, preferably. One in the major's office and anywhere

else would be a bonus — car or home. *No pressure then.* “How will I get access to the base?” *Best to identify the mountains from the off.*

Sir Peter took in a breath, as if he were competing for oxygen, and released it sparingly though a sickly smile. “Major Eldridge has requested your support while the investigation is being conducted.”

He couldn’t hold back a murmur of discontent. *Since when did the Surveillance Support Unit offer that kind of support?*

Schaefer’s smile was pure Osmonds; Thomas nearly shielded his eyes. “If you have any out-of-scope expenses, this ought to cover it.” An Engamel envelope wafted across.

He looked to Sir Peter, as though appealing for a free kick from a referee. Sir Peter didn’t stir.

“What happens if the major doesn’t need me on the base?”

Sir Peter shifted a little in his expensive chair. “Major Eldridge’s home and private apartment addresses are also in the envelope.”

* * *

Outside, Thomas rang Miranda for an update. “Sorry, I couldn’t talk earlier — long story. What’s the latest?”

“I’m on my way to Caliban’s; Jess is with me.”

“*What?* Are you insane? She should stay at the flat.”

“And we all know how successful that was. Look, Thomas, I have a business to run. At least this way I can keep her company.”

He stopped walking and stared out at the skyline. “Is Butch involved?” It was their personal code for anything dodgy, coming from Butch, a hands-on photographer Miranda had encountered in her youth — and whom Thomas had given a beating.

“No,” she chuckled. “Butch ain’t around — stop worrying. I’m varying my route and staying glued to my mirrors. Catch you later, hon.”

He smiled and closed the phone. *Hon*, the way her bar manager, Sheryl, addressed all the male customers, flinging it about like free sachets of salted peanuts.

Chapter 12

It was weird, being in the office without Karl. Ann Crossley — his designated backup — sat on the other side of the room with nary a second glance. Or a first one. He returned the favour and typed out some notes, anonymising the major to *Target* and detailing the reporting instructions that Sir Peter had laid out. Times New Roman didn't make it any clearer, so he mentally filled in the elements that would not be documented.

Someone — the major was still the frontrunner — had wanted him and Karl to receive parts of the UB40 Scavenger. Someone — again, the major was favourite — had spirited Jess away and given her Karl's number to ring. Since then, Karl had washed his hands of it all *and* the Land Rover had gone walkies. On the plus side, he still had the Scavenger bits, and Jess, and footage from the accident. But what the bloody hell was he supposed to do with any of it?

He looked across to Ann for inspiration and coughed, like a teacher trying to catch out a daydreamer. She surfaced from whatever thoughts she'd been immersed in and pointed to the vending machine.

She was so different from Karl. If he had to put a finger on it, she tried too hard — the model of efficiency and bugger-all instinct. Karl might be a little rough around the edges, especially where paperwork was concerned, but he got things done. Ann? He wasn't sure if he would trust her to pick up some shopping.

"Is this an official coffee break?" he cracked a thin smile and it shattered on very stony ground.

"How did your meeting go at Whitehall?"

So many meetings, so little sense. "I've been assigned to the MoD."

She selected two coffees. "Come on," she pushed the doors and stood at the stairwell.

He caught the door in time and followed her, tapping his security pass to make sure it was there. The lock clicked hard behind him. Ann held a plastic cup out, perhaps as a peace offering. There was no enmity between them; they just weren't close, like Australia and Africa. He glanced up and down the stairwell. It always struck him as strange that the Surveillance

Support Unit occupied only a couple of floors in buildings that belonged to other government departments.

That was one of Sir Peter Carroll's masterstrokes when the SSU was formed in the 80s, intended to integrate with other departments. Didn't work of course, other than to localise the disdain. Nobody welcomed the floaters, although they were happy to use them.

"What do I need to know?" Ann's tone was blunt.

How to win friends and influence people might be a start. He didn't answer right away, sipping the machine coffee, letting it detain his taste buds and beat a confession out of them. The real question was: What did *he* need Ann Crossley to know? He relented and swallowed the coffee down. They were all supposed to be one happy team after all.

"Sir Peter wants me to assist the major from the army base, while keeping him under surveillance."

Her pupils dilated. He tried to break new ground.

"Ann, can I ask you something? What's the deal with Karl — I know his mum is ill, but that's about it."

It was her turn to hide in her coffee. "Just ask Karl when he was last in the province." She stepped around him to the door; their alfresco meeting was over.

An email from Major Eldridge awaited his attention: *Thomas, I'll see you in my office at 10.30 tomorrow. I look forward to working with you. Major C Eldridge.* He stored the email address and deleted the email.

The afternoon dragged without Karl to bounce off, despite Ann Crossley's enigmatic presence. Since Christine's permanent promotion, Ann was the Number Two. Karl had wrung endless juvenile fun out of that one. However, since Ann and Karl had resolved their acrimony, she largely left the two of them to get on with it. Jeez, this whole outfit was turning into one big version of Truth or Dare, without the Truth part.

At four thirty, he reminded Ann about his appointment on the base next morning and the need to do some prep work. He felt a little like a school kid handing in a note from his mum. Down at Stores, he added a GPS tag to the list, just in case Jess decided to go walkabout again.

* * *

Outside, fast approaching five pm, the city seemed to be on wind-down. The suits and the hipsters, the fashion-hungry and the drones, all gravitating towards whichever bar best represented their image.

He stood on a street corner as they trundled past in groups, chatting about their days. Had he ever been like that when he worked behind a civil service desk? Hopefully not. He turned to watch a bunch of drinkers through the faux-Victorian plate glass. A city gent, clutching a pint in one hand, was shouting into a mobile phone trapped between his ear and shoulder. If there was any justice, someone would be stealing his laptop from under the table.

Time to hit Caliban's for a Q&A session with Jess, always assuming she hadn't done another bunk. He pictured Miranda rugby-tackling Jess and bar manager, Sheryl, pinning her down. That was a film for another day.

On the drive over, he tried shuffling the picture cards in his mind. Jess, the major, Karl, Sir Peter Carroll, Ann, Christine and Old Smiler from Engamel; it was too much like hard work. Just when did he — to use one of Miranda's delightful turns of phrase — become everyone's Spy Bitch?

He ran a hand over his face and jolted when some kindly soul behind him beeped their horn. Green light. He glanced in the mirror, considering a quick one-finger salute. He almost missed the light altogether when he saw that the driver behind him was Karl.

It was a haunting smile and it carried him along on the world's shortest convoy. A face like his mam, back when he was a kid. Mournful, that was the word for it; making the best of it and longing for comfort where there was none to be found. He sighed. All this insight after only one session with the counsellor. Another seven, and he'd be weeping into his pillow about the camera he'd wanted as a boy.

Chapter 13

Karl parked up and slowly got out. He looked like an advert for antidepressants — the *before* picture. “Hey, Tommo. I felt like a drink — alright with you?”

“Course!” Better than alright. Miranda had rescinded Karl’s life ban, the one she’d imposed when Karl’s job had been his one character reference. Plus, Karl could meet Jess and maybe, just maybe, inject a little sense into all this.

The bar was surprisingly busy. He had an immediate theory on that, going by Sheryl’s T-shirt and waistcoat combo.

“Hey, Thomas,” she beamed. “What would you like?”

He basked in her smile. Karl seemed to be in a world of his own — no Battle of the Banter today.

“A pint of shandy for the lad,” he turned to Karl, who merely nodded in thanks. “And a lemonade for me.”

Sheryl raised her eyes to the ceiling. “Coming right up . . . boys.”

And not, he noticed at the till, on the house.

Karl drew his chair close to the table and propped himself against it. “So how do you rate your first day flying solo?”

Thomas lifted his glass and the chunks of lemon Sheryl had added bobbed about furiously. “In a word: shit. The sooner you get back to work the better — I’ve no friends to play with.”

“Aye, well, won’t be long now . . .”

He suddenly felt like the world’s greatest arse, realising Karl meant after his mother had died. He fished out a chunk of lemon and sucked at it; it didn’t help. “Ann Crossley suggested I should ask you when you last went . . .” he stopped, appalled by his own ignorance; he didn’t even know what to call Northern Ireland.

“Home?” Karl gulped at his shandy. When he lifted his head there were tears in his eyes. “Jesus, Tommo, you’ve forgotten the crisps — see what you’re doing to me here!” Karl was laughing, only he wasn’t.

Thomas scuttled over to the bar and took his time about it. Out of the corner of his eye he thought he saw Karl pull out a handkerchief. This was

not good news; he had enough trouble with his own emotions, never mind other people's. He lingered with Sheryl as long as he dared, while she circled him for sport. Miranda reckoned it was just her way but he'd never noticed her putting in that much effort with other men. Though that was probably what the other men told themselves.

He brought back Karl's holy trinity: ready salted, salt & vinegar, and cheese & onion. Karl was a man who hadn't moved with the times. He repeated Karl's mantra as he opened the bags out. "You can't mess with perfection."

As he sat down, Karl patted the table. Turned out it wasn't a hankie, just a square of white paper. "I've realised I'm not being very fair, leaving you in all this without so much as a helping hand.

"True," he acknowledged. *And you haven't answered my question.*

Karl's took out a pen and held it above the paper, poised. After a few seconds, Thomas cottoned on that Karl was volunteering to be the scribe. He rattled off names for Karl to write down, and then added his thoughts — who trusted who and where the alliances seemed to be. Karl circled names and added arrows.

It was therapeutic, brain-dumping all this on to paper. Now was the ideal time to reveal that he was simultaneously assisting the major and bugging him, while still keeping schtum about the hidden components from the UB40 Scavenger. And of course there was Sir Peter's expressed intention to update Christine with a low-fat version of events.

"To be honest," Thomas stared at the busy page in defeat, "I don't know what the fuck I'm doing with Jess or the components."

Karl scooped an assortment of crisps into his mouth. "Seems to me you're holding a few decent cards, Tommo. Can you not see that?"

"Maybe . . ." he drank some lemonade. "But how do I play them?"

Karl swallowed the last of the crisps and ran his tongue over his lower lip. "If it was me . . ." he pulled out another piece of paper and started to write a numbered list. Karl loved lists. Lists and maps. He was what Sheryl would call 'a visual kinda guy.' The list was very short.

1. Tell the major what you've been asked to do and then bug him anyway.
2. Tell him that the Land Rover was stolen.

3. Ask him what he wants you to do with the photos.
4. Do not let anyone else get hold of Jess.

Thomas read through the idiot's guide to problem-solving at least twice, static as a caravan. Karl's face looked like it could break into a smile at any moment, but had chosen not to, so Thomas picked up the paper and folded it into his back pocket.

Karl took another dive into his shandy. "I could, er, really use a proper chat, sometime this week." He looked like he was just about holding it together.

"Yeah, come round the flat. Maybe not tonight, in case I'm babysitting again."

"I'd prefer the club if it's all the same to you — neutral ground."

"Of course. How about tomorrow night?"

"Thanks, Tommo, you're a pal." He downed the last of the crisps. "Now, where are my manners — what are we doing here?"

"Come on," Thomas shifted his chair. "There's someone I'd like you to meet."

* * *

Sheryl rang upstairs and waved them through. Miranda was ready and waiting.

"Smile, boys, you're on TV," she pointed to a screen split four ways.

He didn't know whether to be pleased she'd had it installed or pissed off that she hadn't told him beforehand. He settled for a dignified murmur of approval. "Where's the guest?"

As if cued to his voice, Jess emerged from the side room. "Hello, Thomas," she extended a lettuce-limp hand, which hung in the air like a bad smell. "I feel I owe you some sort of explanation."

That made him feel even more irked. "For what? Leaving the flat without telling me, turning up again without warning or running the risk of being seen and picked up?"

Okay, so it might have been a bit over the top but it filled Karl in nicely, in double-quick time. Karl was still standing in the background — Jess hardly seemed to register his presence at all. Then Karl did a funny thing. He came forward, sidestepped Jess altogether and shook Miranda's hand

lightly, touching her shoulder at the same time. It was a curious mix of formal and intimate.

Miranda smiled — not her fake ‘how nice to see you — *not*’ facial glimmer but a warm, gentle response. “Karl, this is Jess — our . . . guest. I believe you have a mutual friend. Why don’t you two have a chat while I thrash Thomas at pool next door?” She grabbed Thomas’s belt and hauled him away.

Miranda racked up the pool balls loudly, making it impossible for Thomas to eavesdrop through the open door. He caught a few mutterings but not the substance of them.

“Give it up.” Miranda gave the triangle another shake. “I’m sure he’ll tell you everything later.”

Thomas wasn’t sure either of them believed that. She spun a coin. “Call it.”

“Tails.” He took the cue and leant on the table, pulling back to break.

“Jess said you were the one who came on to her.”

The cue ball nearly went airborne, slamming into the pack unevenly. Miraculously, a stripe had been scared down a hole.

She met his gaze. “I didn’t believe her of course.”

He tried to recover his composure but his reflection was nearly as red as the three ball.

“I just wanted you to know the kind of person you’re dealing with.”

There was no answer to that; none that would avoid lighting the blue touchpaper. In between losing focus, losing advantage and losing three consecutive games, he tried hard to pick up the occasional word from next door. Midway through the fourth game — convinced that pool-star Sheryl had been giving Miranda lessons — he held the cue in the air like a totem.

“What do you want me to do about Jess, then?”

“I dunno,” Miranda seemed pleased and flummoxed at the same time. “Just watch your back.”

“That’s what I’ve got you for.”

She smiled, took her cue and cleared the table of spots. Somehow, though, she ran out of steam on the black. He squared his shoulders, put on his best Comeback King face and — despite Miranda whistling the opening bars to *The Entertainer* — set to work. With careful concentration, he put the remaining stripes down methodically. Down to the black now and not

even Miranda pushing up her breasts and pouting, glamour model style, would distract him.

“Ahem.”

He turned to see Karl and Jess, standing in the doorway like guilty adolescents. “We’re all done here.” Karl’s tone was business-like.

Jess took a step forward. “I’ve told Karl that I’m going to the funeral. It’s what Cecil wants as well.”

Thomas looked daggers at Karl, but they bounced right off him. He opened a conciliatory palm to Jess. “Look, we can’t protect you if you don’t stay out of sight.”

Jess opened her mouth and nothing came out. But her eyes said plenty.

“How about a compromise?” Miranda broke the silence. “You lie low until the funeral and that’ll give the boys time to figure something out, longer term?” No dissenters, carried unanimously, and Miranda wasn’t done talking. “Sheryl’s staying here while her flat’s being redecorated. There’s another spare room upstairs. It’s not the Hilton or anything, but it’d keep you out of Thomas’s hair.” She laughed then, as if to say, ‘Because he’s so vulnerable.’ Jess seemed to share the joke.

“Tell you what,” Karl acted like he’d just had a brainwave, although Thomas knew him better than that, “Why don’t you pop us your keys and address, and then we can pick up some clothes and personal stuff for you.” His face was as earnest as a social worker’s. What could be amiss? Jess could hardly object. Karl held out his hand and smiled.

Jess froze for an instant, weighing it up. “Thanks,” she twisted her mouth into a smile and handed the keys over to Thomas.

Miranda wangled them some bar food. Jess asked a lot of questions and, for all her innocent abroad act, Thomas could see she was taking everything in. She grew more sullen as the meal went on, outplayed by three people who could evade questions without catching a breath.

Meal over; time to go. He kissed Miranda goodbye — a matter-of-fact kiss, under the spectators’ gaze. Then he and Karl left together. Karl didn’t speak until they hit the car park.

“Worst double-date in living memory.”

Thomas rattled Jess’s keys as if he were calling in a cat. “Jess’s place is probably being watched — it’d take an expert to get in undetected . . .” he did his best impression of *forlorn*.

“Okay,” Karl relented, “give it here. I’ll see if I can get someone to deal with it. One suitcase of clothes and personals, a black suit for the funeral and a passport if I can find one.”

Thomas frowned.

Karl spread his arms. “Just thinking ahead. Anyhow, can’t stop — got to get a postcard in the mail — I had Jess write and sign it. Only one I had was of Yorkshire, sorry.” He pulled out a picture postcard of Scarborough. It was addressed to Amy at a liaison office, as if it had arrived internally. Clever Karl. It might take the heat off for a day or so; and it’d make Jess’s reappearance at the funeral seem a little more plausible.

That didn’t stop Thomas from picking holes. “How do we know Jess hasn’t contacted the victim’s family already?”

Karl didn’t skip a beat. “Amy was an American citizen, didn’t you know? And no doubt our friends across the pond are already watching the post.” Karl stepped towards his car. “Get some sleep, Tommy Boy. I’ll bring the things to the club tomorrow night — see you at the usual pick-up — seven o’clock.”

Chapter 14

The flat felt way too quiet when he shut the door behind him. Funny to think of Miranda at home, in the place that used to be theirs. It all seemed like a long time ago, and now here he was in Walthamstow, end of the line.

He settled in and took the answering machine out of the drawer — one of Miranda's *do not disturb* foibles. Three messages; hang out the flags. First up, his sister, Pat — even her *hello* sounded cagey. Her husband Gordon's job was at risk, and he had to work away for a couple of days. She sounded lonely, even though Mum and Dad were a few streets away. Next, Christine Gerrard — unusual for the boss to ring him at home. Just seeing how he was and what he was up to. He skipped, mid-message and played the last of the trio.

“Alright mate, Ajit here . . .”

“Yorkshire's finest!” Ajit's other half, Geena, had shouted from behind him.

Thomas knew that would have wound Ajit up big-time because he actually came from Lancashire. You could hear the two of them scrabbling for the phone like children. Ajit had the upper hand, and given the size of him those upper hands were massive. “Just wondered, like, how ya doing and when you're next in this part of the world?”

“Oh, give it 'ere!” The phone clattered then Geena's voice cut in, loud and clear. “Right you, when are you getting your arse back home? Ajit's fretting for you! And I'm the size of a bungalow now, *Uncle Tommy*.”

Yeah, thought Thomas, and so's Ajit.

“Come and see us soon, eh?”

Another clatter — Ajit must have grabbed the phone back. “And bring some jellied eels for Geena. She's into foreign food.”

He made a coffee, dug out a biscuit from the tin, one that had not fared well in captivity, and sat down by the phone. His mobile was on, just out of interference range, in case Miranda or anyone else wanted to get in touch. Used to be that his people skills extended as far as Miranda, her family and Ajit. But, since the moors, he'd widened his circle a little. He smiled; must remember that one for the counsellor.

Pat, first. She had an obligatory cry on the phone, but soon pulled herself together. He'd never shaken off the older-brother/lord-high-protector mantle, even though he'd been shit at it. After an update on Mum and Dad, and the kids, Pat had him buttered up so smoothly that he slid right into place.

"No, I promise, I'll come see you soon — when I get some time off. Course I mean it. Tell my little niece and nephew I said hello." No message for her husband, Gordon, though — no point scaring him.

Christine was out, or busy. He thanked her answering machine for the call, said he'd get in early next day to update her, and that he'd be around if she fancied a chat tonight. She wouldn't, and nor would he, but it was one of those things that people said.

It was still the right side of ten thirty, so he gave Ajit a bell, figuring he wasn't on a nightshift. Geena picked up, squealed with delight and did a deliberately piss-poor version of a Chas & Dave song. Miranda's mum and dad loved Chas & Dave, although he'd never tell Geena that.

Ajit must have taken a while to crane his bulk out of a chair. "Hee, Thomas Bladen, as I live and breathe."

"Constable."

"Listen, funny man, I might not be a constable for much longer."

And though he should have been pleased, Thomas shrank a little at the news. Without doubt, Thomas roping him in to do the clean up on the moors would have helped Ajit's standing, and his confidence. After all, it had made the papers. *'Yorkshire Police assist in apprehension of drug-trafficking gang.'* A little more palatable than: *'Yorkshire Police assist in removal of assassin's body and subsequent European conspiracy cover-up.'*

"Well done, mate." Thomas raised his voice to artificially high levels of encouragement. Truth be told, he was happy for him. But, as Miranda had sussed out early on, too much change made him tetchy.

"So, are you coming up or what?"

"Aye, go on then. Not sure when — soon, though, in the next couple of months." It was the closest he got to commitment.

"Nice one. I've got my sergeant's exam soon. It'd be grand to see you, but not worth sacrificing stripes for!"

* * *

He slept fitfully that night, the pale glow of the mobile entering his dreams as a sallow moon over the moors. He was stumbling over unfamiliar territory, a ridgeway he'd never seen before. And right at the top, he saw a caped figure waiting for him. He woke suddenly, the smell of damp air in his nostrils and a last image of the cape's hood lifting to reveal Karl's face gleaming back at him.

First thing he did was jot down the dream, just as the counsellor had asked him. It was probably all bollocks; still, anything for a pal.

Chapter 15

The office clock showed eight, glaring at him as if it couldn't quite believe it either. Ms Gerrard was already in situ, her door ajar.

"Hi, Thomas," she called out without moving. "I brought a *croissant* for you." She pronounced every French syllable exactly. Education was surely a wonderful thing.

He dropped his bag at his desk then thought better of it and carried it through, closing the door behind him.

"There's a hot choc there as well."

Not *chocolat* — how disappointing. He tried to observe her without looking her over. The latter never went down well, especially since her promotion. The hot chocolate was good, a world away from the vending machine crap on offer. A sip of it went down slow and easy.

"How was Whitehall?" She had a certain economy of speech. Karl did that too sometimes.

"Sir Peter wants you kept at arm's length."

She didn't seem surprised. He'd skipped over 'I want to know what the hell's going on' and landed with 'I'm clear on where my loyalties lie.' It wasn't quite how he'd meant it to come out, but she knew him well enough. Speaking of which, he pulled his eyes back from her legs, signalling at him from under the table.

Over hot chocolate and croissants, he told her about bugging the major and the American from Engamel. Jess didn't figure in the conversation. They parted, all smiles; he nearly leaned forward to give her a hug but she was the boss. Plus, he'd heard Ann Crossley arriving in the main office and he didn't want to set team expectations.

* * *

Traffic was snarled up around Liverpool Street, as he battled through and headed north, like a lazier latter-day Amundsen. He called Ann Crossley, hands-free from the car, safely stuck in a jam, and tackled her about Karl and Northern Ireland — the question Karl had yet to answer.

She didn't miss a trick. "He's not as squeaky clean as you'd like to believe."

He took a breath, long and lean, as the driver in front remembered to take the handbrake off. “None of us are, Ann. I’ll ring you again once I’m off the army base. Thomas out.”

So much for all being comrades now. He reached for some crisps — Jesus, he was morphing into Karl’s understudy — and flicked on the radio. There were the usual scandals and politicking, plus some US film star had got drunk at an awards ceremony and ranted on camera. And apparently, shares in the technology sector were particularly buoyant, pending some global alliance venture. Engamel Solutions didn’t get a name check, although he did wonder.

* * *

At the army base, Checkpoint Charlie exited the guard cabin and walked slowly around the barrier. If his face were the first line of defence, he was doing a grand job.

Thomas flashed his ID, waited for the card to be returned and generally tried to keep a low profile. From the face on Charlie, even after verifying the ID, the Surveillance Support Unit was as welcome here as they were everywhere else.

“When the MPs arrive, follow them through.” The ID card was thrust back, as if the guard had just wiped his arse with it.

And a lovely day to you too. In the distance, a squad or battalion — or whatever they were called — was drilling. There couldn’t have been a man among them under six-two. Any of them would have given Ajit a run for his money in an arm-wrestling contest.

* * *

The major was waiting outside as Thomas parked up. He thanked the Red Caps and ushered Thomas inside with his two cases.

First thing Thomas did was sweep the office and back rooms for existing bugs — competition wasn’t good for business. After the all clear, he sat down and mentally went through Karl’s list of handy hints.

The major was busy outlining what he needed; Thomas didn’t pay attention. He was more interested in what wasn’t being said.

“So, Thomas, any questions?”

Was he taking the piss? A pro might have warmed up slowly, tried a little subtlety. He couldn’t be arsed. “I’ve been ordered,” he thought the

major would like that, “to bug your office. Which phone would you prefer?”

The major didn’t exactly look surprised, more disappointed. “Why are you telling me?”

Good question. He shrugged. “It’s what Karl would do. Right, I suggest you sort out any personal calls while I’m on lunch and then vacate the room while I do my stuff.”

The major glanced at two telephones on his desk, and tapped one.

“Everything will be switched off until then, sir.”

“Thank you, Thomas.”

One item mentally crossed off the list. Next . . . “Oh, you may get a call from Services about the Land Rover we used last week. Someone stole it on Sunday night — from outside my home.”

The major blanched; hard to tell under the neon whether it was more guilt or concern. He left the news hanging in the air to see how the major would catch it. In the end, it hit the ground without a whimper. “One more thing, Major — what did you want me to do with the copied photographs?”

“I understood Karl was taking care of that.”

He swallowed and turned his face, drawing in the scent of heated polish from the desk lamp. *Liar — Karl would have said so.* He chose his next words carefully. “Karl has been assigned to other work, because of his military connections.”

The major snorted a sigh and glanced around the room. “You’re sure this office is clear?”

He nodded — silly question; the major looked like he wanted to be convinced.

“Right, this goes no further. Aside from Amy,” his voice cracked a little and Thomas thought well of him for it, “there was another technician. I took the decision to get her away from here, and made sure there was no record of her presence, on the day of . . .” he faltered, “. . . the accident.”

“Well that’s just it. Was it an accident?”

Major Eldridge stared at him like a sentencing judge. He flipped a folder over.

Thomas glanced at the cover. “I don’t have clearance for this.”

“Just open it, man; you won’t get a second view.”

It was standard stuff. No mention of exactly what was being tested, a vague reference to mechanical failure and a conclusion suggesting that whatever test had failed was unorthodox.

Thomas backed up a few pages, hoping to find some names to remember. “Mixed rounds.”

The major was reading the pages with him, from across the desk. “A random selection, I suspect.”

Yeah, Thomas thought, or you’ve been *told*. He handed the folder back. “There’s no mention of a second technician.”

“Quite correct. There should always be two — to check the calibrations.”

“So what happened?”

“Corner-cutting. The project was behind schedule.”

For a man on the periphery, the major seemed to know a lot about it; perhaps it was pillow talk. Thomas picked at a knuckle; he felt no closer to the truth.

“Can we cut to the chase? This is all a whitewash; I get that. So why hold the photos? If the media even got a whiff of this, it’d end up squashed and never see daylight.”

The major carefully locked the folder in his desk. “The photos were all I had.”

Yeah, besides a fat pension. “Any chance of a cuppa?” Not so much tea and sympathy as tea and strategy.

* * *

He stirred his tea rhythmically, even though he’d skipped on the sugar, tapping the spoon against the china like a séance-bell. Sir Peter did the same thing, using the sound to command attention.

It occurred to him that the major hadn’t mentioned Jess’s emergency calls — either the one to Karl’s mobile, or when she’d rung the major’s personal number. Maybe he just needed a nudge.

“Is there something else I need to know?” He waited, blinking to the rhythm of his thoughts.

The major ran a slow hand across his forehead. It had all the hallmarks of a magic moment. “I take it you’re referring to Jess. I gave her Karl’s number for outside assistance.”

And? More blinking.

“She’s been in touch since, but I don’t know where Karl’s hiding her.”

He peeled his collar away from his neck. Holy shit; Jess was playing him too. So what was her angle?

“You’ve been honest, Thomas, so I’ll return the compliment. I was hoping you’d be willing to speak to Karl, to get a message to Jess.”

He watched as the major’s face tightened at the name. Maybe she was putting the squeeze on his marriage — the price you paid for playing away. He clocked the time.

“I’ll nip off for lunch and then you can give me a little space here to do the necessary. I don’t work well with an audience.”

Chapter 16

A staff sergeant provided the taxi service, ferrying him over to the mess hall. He also kept him company over dinner.

“You’re not ex-mob then?”

Thomas stalled his fork. “That obvious, is it?”

“It’s the way you look around, as if you’re working out the angles.”

That raised a smile. “Sorry, photographer’s habit.” He dropped back to his lamb and veg.

“I, er, take a few pictures myself — as a hobby.”

Many’s the time some part-time snapper had lusted after a lens he’d been carrying, or read the badge and wanted to be friends. He figured they were all after one of two things: tips from the professionals, or a peek over the fence to a future career, if the day job with the MoD, police or whatever, ran out of steam. He got the gist — to an outsider it must look like easy money, playing pretend spies — a long lens here, a microphone there and a few parcels up and down the country.

His mind leapfrogged to Amy — he liked to remind himself of her name so that she remained a person and not just so many pictures. Lying there like broken porcelain in a sea of blood and ash.

“... So I was wondering what the entrance criteria is?”

He’d learned to tune in at the end of sentences and just wait for the echo.

“Only I’d love to do more with a camera, professionally like.”

He swallowed another mouthful. “I can give you a number to call.”

“Thanks, I’d appreciate that.” The sergeant jotted it down, placing it carefully in a top pocket. Most likely he’d never look at it again.

Thomas knew that he wasn’t exactly a walking recruitment poster. Another time he’d have been happy to talk about the relative merits of polarised filters, but today he had other things on his plate — besides the gristle.

* * *

As soon as Thomas returned, Major Eldridge made himself scarce. Everything had been locked away. Thomas’s two cases sat on the desk; out

of habit he checked the locks and hinges then went to work.

He used a voice-activated phone device, one that also recorded inbound-caller numbers. Later, he'd remind the major to continue using the phone as normal. When that job was done, he took out a different plastic box. This was the bug Christine had removed from her office, not so long ago. He made short work of the second telephone and added a faded plastic tab over one bottom edge to suggest the phone hadn't ever been disturbed. After all, who looked closely at the underside of their work phone? No one. Besides him and Karl, of course.

To pass the time, he took out Karl's four-step guide — only one gem left, relating to Jess. He tried running through the sequence again: Jess rings the major; Jess goes out to see him, but doesn't tell him where she's staying. It didn't play well at all. Something was missing.

By the time the major walked in, Karl's notes were safely away and Thomas was happily browsing the glass bookcase. One of Karl's theories was that your bookcase told the world who you wanted to be, while the books you'd actually read showed how close you were to becoming it. In Miranda's case, she grazed on chick-lit and murders, but her most creased covers held Jane Austen and Thomas Hardy. Funny girl.

The office bookcase held few surprises — military biographies sat cheek by jowl, Churchill was among them; technical books on warfare and the latest edition of *Jane's Tank Recognition* guide; and some historical tomes on the Roman Empire. They all looked in very good condition. In one corner though, peeping out like an anonymous peace protestor, was an ancient copy of *Winnie-the-Pooh*. A sudden image of Piglet piloting the C12 Battlebuster momentarily brightened the day.

The major nodded curtly. Everything was packed away, waiting by the door; no need to state the obvious. But there were things to be said.

Thomas sat down and hunched forward, hands clasps together. He hoped he looked as uncomfortable as he felt. "Major Eldridge, I'm a little confused about exactly what my assignment here is — from you I mean."

It was the major's turn to look uncomfortable and he didn't squander it. "Let me put it this way. In the absence of Karl, you're my best means of locating Jess."

"So in the meantime I turn up with a camera every day or carry a few parcels about?"

“Don’t be absurd, man,” the major blazed at him. “I’m not interested in how you spend your time. Just find Jess, before anyone else does.”

Time, as Sheryl liked to say, to fess up. “Look, I’m confident I can get a message to Jess. I imagine she’ll want to attend the memorial service.” He was banking on not having to elaborate.

“Can you get word to her today?”

He checked his watch, for no reason other than an early finish might be useful. “I think so.”

“Then tell her . . .”

Jesus, please not a love note.

“. . . Tell her the best thing she can do is return the papers immediately.”

Thomas tightened his jaw and tried not to shout, ‘bingo.’ “Now, I just need to use your phone then we’re set.” He didn’t wait to be invited.

“Hello, it’s Thomas.” He looked straight at the major. “Major Eldridge is out of the way. I’ve networked his phone. I’ll do the co-ord when I get back to the office. Really? To whom?” He breathed slow and deep, and put the receiver down carefully as if it were made of gold.

“Why would Engamel Solutions want to view data from your phone tap?”

The major wore a stoic mask. Stalemate. Thomas headed for the door.

“Thomas, tell me this: why are you helping me?”

“I could just as easily ask: why isn’t Jess?”

* * *

Back at Liverpool Street, he checked one of the cases back into Stores and trudged up the stairs. Before he swiped in, he peered through the reinforced glass to see who was home.

Ann Crossley was nowhere to be seen — second bonus of the day, after Christine’s breakfast. He logged on, checked the major’s chosen phone line and played the first of the recordings. Good boy. He’d check the other line he’d bugged from home, outside office hours.

His phone started ringing so he paused the recording. “Thomas Bladen speaking.”

“Hi, Thomas, it’s Michael Schaefer from Engamel. I wanted to call and thank you for your work today. As a matter of fact, I’d like to invite you to dinner, tomorrow night — anywhere you can recommend?”

He couldn’t think of a good reason not to accept and let Mr Smiley sort out the details. It was barely five o’clock, but he needed a shower; he suddenly felt unclean.

* * *

Karl picked him up at Holloway Road tube station, same as the old days — the *before Yorgi* days. He didn’t say much as Thomas got in the car, but he’d cued up ‘Dead Ringer For Love’ so Thomas took it that Karl was in a good mood.

Nothing to it, he told himself, as the car wove through the traffic; just a quiet evening out with Karl. Except that this evening happened to be his first time back at the gun club. Just thinking about it brought the numbness back to his hands. Part of him just wanted this over with, so he could move on.

He returned to the present as Karl pulled up and switched off the engine. They sat there for a while, practising surveillance on the other vehicles.

“Right then, Tommo, shall we?”

Chapter 17

The door to the club seemed heavier, the woman behind the glass more officious. Not that he'd expected a fanfare; he still wasn't even a member. Karl led on, a little diffidently, to one of the pistol ranges. He could hear the dulled thuds and discharges of neighbouring alleys through the walls.

"Any preference?" Karl might have been calling heads or tails to cue off.

"Brownings," he decided. He knew Karl would like that; Karl, with his own pair hidden away somewhere — part of that other life that Thomas had only glimpsed.

* * *

Karl re-entered the room quietly. Thomas stayed fixed on the targets. It could have been minutes, could have been days. The air was heavy somehow, tainted with smoke and spent heat. And oil; that strange mineral-metal combination that seemed to remain on the skin afterwards. He drew back from the wash of senses, mentally rejoining the room as he heard the boxes being opened.

"Here, Tommo, I thought you might like to go first."

He checked the piece over methodically, loaded the magazine and clicked it hard into place. He opted for people targets straight away — no point beating around the bush; it would come to this anyway. He observed his right hand trembling a little before he felt it, up in his shoulder, the jangling dread running up and down his spine. His bladder squeezed — an old fear reflex — but he held it all together and waited. Then he remembered the ear defenders, setting the safety on while he attended to it, every movement measured and controlled. The familiar roar insulated him from the world.

The targets turned and so did his stomach. But there was also a rush of adrenaline, coursing the blood and sharpening the vision. The first shot was the hardest. After that they followed in a steady burst. At the final click, he called "clear" and set the gun down.

Karl hit the button and whirled in the target for inspection. "Nyah." He waved a flat piano hand, so-so fashion. "Better than shite, but don't give up

your day job.”

Thomas stared at the target. “I’m not even sure what my day job is anymore.”

Witnessing Karl in action was like watching an African wildlife documentary, only with guns. Karl stalked the targets. He moulded himself into a predator; he was in no hurry. He took his shots further apart, which lent them greater intensity, each one punctuating the silence between them.

When they finished, he eagerly awaited Karl’s first words — the climax to the performance and a reintroduction to normality. Even the target seemed to fly back that little bit quicker for the delivery.

Karl lifted his head. “I’d say the drinks are on you, Tommy Boy — for about the next five years.”

Karl suggested trying some Glocks or 38s, but Thomas played safe and opted for another magazine with the Browning. No point pushing his luck. Almost before he knew it, before he was ready in a sense, they were done.

“I have to say, Tommo, that I am impressed.”

Thomas did him the courtesy of not interrupting. “Not only are you less shit, after weeks of absence. But your sweating skills are excellent.”

On cue, he felt a cold trickle against his back. Nothing more to be said.

* * *

The bar, as Karl liked to call it, was actually a café area within the gun club. Thomas thought of school, of coming back after an illness, and everything feeling different even though nothing had changed. It was space to be reclaimed.

He sat back and felt the dampness in his shirt, beneath his sweater, moulding like plaster to the contours of his skin. When he closed his eyes and heard the gunfire in his head, he saw the targets flickering. It was a welcome change from Yorgi, bursting scarlet amid the heather.

Karl brought over a tray, waddling for effect — a comical waiter. He glanced at Thomas’s mobile on the table.

“Listen, Tommo, I’ve a wee confession.” He set the tray down and distributed the goods. “I told Miranda that you and I were meeting tonight and suggested she might want to hold off from ringing you until later. Purely on the off-chance you might find all this a bit difficult.”

He felt his cheeks tingling and grabbed a pastry, biting into it savagely, chewing the doughy mass, holding it in his mouth while he poured hot coffee into the mixture.

“Now . . .” Karl continued, “there’s been a delay getting the stuff from Jess’s home. Even my superpowers don’t include invisibility.”

Thomas smiled, sipping at his coffee now that he’d burnt his mouth.

“I’ll get it to you first thing tomorrow morning — before work. Right-oh, your turn — hit me.”

He stuck to the details; that’s what he did best.

He told Karl about bugging both of the major’s office phones, about dinner plans with Michael Schaefer from Engamel, and the major’s cryptic reference to missing papers. “How well do you know the major, from your army days?”

A glow crept across Karl’s face. “Major Charles Eldridge — stand-up man, no question about it.”

He frowned a little. “I thought his name was Cecil?”

“Well, he must have really taken a shine to you. Cecil’s his middle name — some sort of family tradition. Only his nearest and dearest call him Cecil, apparently, and never in front of uniforms.”

Curiouser and curiouser. “Wanna come back to mine for a takeaway?”

* * *

“So really,” Karl said, holding the takeaway bags, while Thomas fiddled with his door key, “This is our first proper date. You do know that I won’t be putting out?”

Thomas swung the door wide and let Karl lead the way.

“Nice place.”

People always said that, even if it was a shit-hole. It was right up there with, ‘Of course I love you’ and ‘I promise I’ll be careful.’

Karl made straight for the photographs displayed on the wall. “She takes a good photo, your Miranda.”

Your Miranda. He liked that.

“I want to show you something.”

“Not your etchings.” Karl covered himself strategically with his hands.

“Better than that.”

With two people, the dark room was cramped. Karl looked without touching, asked questions, seemed to be drinking it all in. He sidled up even closer.

“Actually, I have a collection of war memorial photographs. Dawn and dusk, stark against the skyline. No names visible because that seemed wrong.”

“Ever exhibited?”

“Not really. I sold a copy of one once; felt so bad afterwards that I gave the money away to the Royal British Legion.”

* * *

Thomas set his albums ready on the living-room table. But *no touching* until the curry was consumed and all the surfaces had been wiped clean.

He’d brought out three of them. The first two were orderly, categorised by theme and labelled with dates and times, as well as a few notes about the camera and settings. Yorkshire featured strongly, as did London’s East End and the City after hours. Mostly black-and-whites; frozen faces, frozen time. But the third, smallest album was more random and personal. Like a mix cassette tape that someone had never planned to share with anyone else.

He made two mugs of tea and dug out the last of a packet of shortbreads. Karl had already made sure the albums were out of harm’s way.

“How’s your mum doing?”

Karl sucked in a cheek. “Did you ever wonder how your life might have turned out, if you’d done one thing differently?”

Thomas sat and absorbed the point.

“Y’see,” Karl shifted to one side of the cushion, as if suddenly aware of his own discomfort, “I used to be somebody else. Flew out of Belfast International when I was nineteen and never set foot in my mammy’s house again.” He drew his hands around the mug and clasped it tightly.

“People on the outside, they don’t understand the way things are over there. The way things *were*, so they tell us now. It wasn’t just bombs and intimidation; it was straight lines and invisible fences. Religious apartheid — for the same God! What shops you used, what schools you went to, what friends you could keep. Where the wrong secret could get you killed.”

The clock ticked away the silence.

“I made a mistake — a terrible, innocent mistake. I took up with the wrong girl. Her brother and I, we used to ride together. Taking cars and that, nothing heavy. But Martin was getting a wee name for himself and building a bit of a gang. It was what you did.”

He sounded apologetic as he filled in more details.

“Somehow, Martin had picked up a contact across the fence. A Catholic boy, Francis-Andrew — sure it was all a business arrangement, but we were sworn to secrecy; the kind that threatened a severe penalty if you broke his trust.”

Thomas noticed there were no surnames.

“Anyways, from what I figure, Martin and Francis-Andrew formed something of an alliance. Two gangs could have rich pickings if they were good and organised. Me, I was your typical angry young man — I had my reasons mind.”

He huffed out a breath, as if the last piece of the puzzle required extra effort.

“It looked like I’d got Martin’s sister pregnant. False alarm, not that it made any difference. Martin always claimed he had connections — he wasn’t bullshitting. A couple of nights after our little showdown, my ma got a knock on the door, eleven o’clock at night. The kind of knock you don’t ignore. I went to answer it even though I was shitting myself.

“There was a man standing there who I’d never seen before. The way I remember him is in a black overcoat, but it may have just been the shadow. Tall man he was, tall and thin. He looked down at me and he said ‘Ya have twenty-four hours to leave — just you.’ Then he turned and walked up the street.

“I had to hold on to the door handle to keep standing. I really thought he was going to come back and cripple me or something. Ma was in the hallway; I’m pretty sure she heard everything. She just looked at me and went inside; never said a word.” Karl took a longer pause now, emptying his mug while Thomas sat frozen.

“Martin and Francis-Andrew are successful businessmen these days, so I hear. Partners, under the table, just like always. And when one of my cousins went to see Martin about my situation, what with my ma dying and all, he gave him a bust lip and a black eye for his trouble.”

“I’m sorry, Karl.”

He waved a hand at Thomas dismissively. “I used to send money home like fucking Clark Kent and my mammy would fly over, maybe twice a year for a weekend. When it was easier for her to travel south, we’d meet in Dublin. We could never relax though; never knew if Francis-Andrew had friends there.”

“What did you do for work?”

“I drifted for a while. There’s one or two of my family over here — not many — but they weren’t jumping to get involved. So I worked on a few building sites, like every other lad from across the water. Christmas and Mother’s Days were awful hard, Thomas. Even now I prefer to shut up shop come December and pretend I’m a Buddhist.”

“But surely, under the circumstances . . . ?”

“Unfortunately not. I could just fly over and deal with the consequences,” the voice had a harder edge, “but I still have family over there, and afterwards — who’d protect *them*?” He set the mug on the table and propped a hand under his face.

“I’m still paying for a mistake I made a long time ago, and so’s my ma. And you wanna know the crazy thing? I really loved her, Jacqueline. It was never just, you know . . . Anyways, she’s probably married with a couple of kids now, nice house in Holywood. And here’s me, telling you my troubles over an empty mug and a dry throat.”

Thomas took the family-sized hint. “More tea?” He clattered the mugs together and stood up. “I wish there was something I could do, Karl.”

“There isn’t. She can’t be moved and I’m running out of time. I’m looking into other options though.” The way he said it, it didn’t sound promising. Karl cricked his shoulder as if shrugging off the weight of his thoughts. “Listen, Tommo, I’d better be going. Don’t bother with the tea — I must have talked your ears off.”

“We should do this again sometime — make it a Chinese next time?”

“Aye, right enough. Now, I’m away to business. Jess’s flat won’t burgle *itself* you know! See you here tomorrow, eight o’clock — and thanks.”

* * *

The flat still reverberated with Karl’s revelations as Thomas stared at the empty chair. He felt lucky, so lucky, when he thought back to his own

collection of crossroads. Those points in time where his life might have derailed. If the kid who'd picked on Ajit at school — the one Thomas had accidentally put in hospital — had recognised him. Or if he'd never had that drunken row with his father and upped sticks to Leeds, never met Miranda there and smacked that sleazy photographer. And if all those dramas hadn't played out — his and Karl's — they'd never have met and he'd surely have been the worse for it.

He made tea for one and fired up his personal laptop, seeking out the anonymising server. He typed in the required URL, retrieved the serial number for the second phone bug from a locked drawer and input the password: SHERLOCK. A list of the major's calls on phone number two cascaded on-screen, augmented with times, durations, destinations and a sound file for each call. There was only one file for an incoming call and he went to it first.

‘Cecil, I’ve been ringing your mobile, why won’t you answer? We need to talk; I have to see you again.’

‘You know what I want from you.’

‘Let’s not fight, not when there’s so much to discuss.’

‘I’ve got nothing more to say to you until I receive those letters.’

Thomas replayed the recording and his ears tingled. *Letters* sounded a bit more interesting — and specific — than *papers*. He parked the other calls and began a web-search for two businessmen in Belfast, with the forenames Martin and Francis-Andrew.

* * *

An hour later, he had a scrappy page of notes for his efforts and he was all done in. Tiredness, though, brought its own inspiration; maybe he'd see just how much support Ann Crossley was willing to give him. He put it to the test, left a message on her work number and climbed into bed. The sheets caressed him with remembrances of Miranda. Every time he shifted the covers, her scent and that indefinable sense of her body engulfed him. He drew it in greedily and reached for the phone.

“Mr Bladen, what a nice surprise.” She sounded playful. This could have been the perfect occasion for phone sex, if he’d had the energy.

“I was hoping you’d have called earlier, but I gather Karl turned me into an exclusion zone.”

“Only temporarily. As of now, our borders are wide open.” She laughed huskily.

“Can you ask your mum and dad if I can pop over this week?” More laughter: the scathing kind.

“Since when did you need an invitation?”

“This is about business.”

“Oh. And does this *business* concern me?”

There was an argument on the horizon, moving full steam into view. He suppressed a yawn, in case it was taken out of context.

“I’d like it to. It’s about Karl.”

“Okay,” she softened. “Tell me what I need to know.”

* * *

Karl was as good as his word, tap-tapping on the door just before eight. Thomas had been ready since seven. He brought him in and put the coffee on for the third time that morning.

“Good man!” Karl plonked the suitcase and dress bag down beside him on the sofa; he looked like a runaway cross-dresser.

“I don’t suppose you found any letters lying around?”

“Letters? No, was I meant to?”

“Doesn’t matter.” Thomas tried not to show his disappointment. “The major was adamant about getting some letters back,” he pointed to his laptop, “when Jess rang him on his private landline yesterday.”

“My, my, she does like to live dangerously.”

“Doesn’t she just. I don’t get it, Karl. She wants to see him but she doesn’t tell him where she’s staying. Makes no sense.”

“I guess that’s modern relationships for you.”

“Maybe.” Thomas frowned. He’d never attempted a jigsaw puzzle without studying the picture very carefully beforehand. “Major Eldridge thinks *you*’ve got Jess and sees me as a way in.” He left Karl to think about it and nipped into the kitchen, returning with the coffees.

Karl held his hand up as if he were receiving communion. “Thank you, God, for coffee. Amen.”

Thomas rested a hand lightly on Karl's forehead. “Forgive him, Lord, for he knows not much of anything.”

“Unless you can talk Jess out of going to the memorial service, in two days’ time, I don’t see how you can keep the lovebirds apart. More’s the pity. But we can do something about her disappearing again.”

With some pliers, a screwdriver and very little finesse, Karl fitted the GPS inside the heel of Jess’s shoe. They were the only footwear in the case, aside from a pair of trainers — an unlikely choice of footwear for a funeral.

Thomas watched as Karl worked; it felt a little like helping out his dad. “What can you tell me about Engamel?”

Karl set the pliers down for a moment and scratched at his chin. “American and European consortium, looking to develop niche applications for the modern combatant about town.”

“You mean weapons.”

“Not only weapons. That Battlebuster we waited so patiently for had Engamel components in its defensive capability.”

Thomas narrowed his eyes. “Engamel wasn’t mentioned in the brochure — I’d have remembered it.”

Karl smiled enigmatically and finished with the shoe. “No, they weren’t.”

“Karl,” Thomas said his name quietly, “is Engamel on your list of organisations of interest?”

Karl nodded slowly. “If you really wanna know, they pretty much all are, Tommo. Anyways, I’d best leave you to get to work. Thanks for last night, it really helped to talk about it.” He dropped Jess’s keys into Thomas’s hand. “And listen, I think maybe I’ll go back to her flat and see about those letters — she may well have hidden them. I’ll only copy them, mind.”

Thomas offered the keys up again.

“No need. I’ve already made myself a fresh set.”

Chapter 18

It wasn't exactly skiving. Major Eldridge had wanted him to spend time locating Jess; he'd just interpreted that to mean: *locating Jess where he'd left her and then delivering her clothes*. He telephoned the major and promised to update him later on.

Miranda was waiting at Caliban's. She made a big show of sniffing his neck to smell her own perfume. "Hmm, someone's a lucky lady."

"Yeah, I like to think so."

They went inside. Jess was still in the shower. Miranda reclaimed her seat in the kitchen; Sheryl was buffing her nails furiously. "That girl sure talks. I feel like I've boned the army guy myself."

Sheryl and Miranda giggled like teenagers.

"I can give you chapter and verse. How it started, how he calls her *angel*, how he's going to leave his wife — when the time is right. I could sit an exam."

It really was none of his business but that didn't stop him encouraging Sheryl. And it didn't take a lot of encouragement. *Chapter and verse*, as promised — and no dirty stuff, thankfully. Sheryl had almost wet herself when he'd requested, 'no physical details.' Miranda had patted his head, *poor lamb*.

Jess emerged in her own good time and gave Thomas a disproportionately welcoming hug, which he suffered without comment.

"You've brought my clothes!" She sounded so self-absorbed. Even the way she held up her suit in front of her like some twisted Cinderella scene. Crass didn't seem to cover it.

He told her about the memorial service; doubted she'd really heard him, as she was busy rifling through her suitcase and checking blouses against the suit.

"And you did all this for me," she moved to hug him again but he stiffened.

"It's my job."

She shook her head back like a startled horse and it took her a moment to recover. "Can I go out today?"

“You’re not a prisoner.” Miranda cut across. “Although it’s probably best to have someone with you.”

“Thomas can accompany me! Just a *little* walk — and maybe a coffee outside. I’ll go and get ready.” She gathered up her things and skipped away.

“Well,” Sheryl drawled in her native Brooklynese, “Sounds like you’ve got yourself an admirer.”

He shook his head. “Nah, hopefully that seat’s already taken.”

Sheryl faked a swoon. “Do mine ears deceive me?” She looked directly at Miranda. “Are you two screw-ups officially back on again?”

He watched Miranda through a lens of longing. She milked the moment, then shrugged half-heartedly. He fell back on details.

“I won’t be longer than an hour. Do me a favour, while we’re out, write down everything Jess has told you. Yeah, even the dirty stuff; I mean it.”

Jess looked like she was about to go fishing, using herself as bait. She grabbed his arm and waited for him to lead. He turned to Miranda.

“Won’t be long, babe.”

Jess reeled him in so close that her breast squeezed against his arm. “I promise to bring him back in near perfect condition.”

* * *

They ended up at Whitechapel. He gave her his mini-tour, talking about the galleries and the waves of historical immigrants over the last century and a half. Quite the little guide. And all the while she gazed at him like he was offering the Eucharist. Which reminded him . . .

“I, er, didn’t know if you were religious. There’s tons of churches round here if you wanted to say a prayer or light a candle?”

“Whatever for?”

Her laughter rattled him. “For Amy.” It was the first time that day that either of them had mentioned her by name

“Oh, I see.” It was like a switch had flipped in her head. “I, er . . .” Her voice crackled, “I think I’d prefer to just sit and talk, if you don’t mind.” She took his arm again.

He found a half-decent café, not a million miles from the Royal London Hospital. The café proprietor had somehow thought putting up a picture of the Elephant Man would be good for business.

Jess talked — Sheryl had certainly got that right — but not about Amy. Jess's main topic of conversation was *Jess*. And her specialist subject only covered the last two years. Apparently, joining Engamel and becoming the major's little lady were the most interesting things to have happened to her. Ever.

It was all going swimmingly until he put his size nines in it by asking about her family. She stopped, mid-sentence, and managed to weld a scowl to a smile.

"Let's talk about something else, shall we? Tell me about you." She was all eyes and hands, her touch surprisingly cold. He drew his arm away and her fingernails scraped against the table.

"I saw Major Eldridge yesterday. He seemed to think you had some *papers* in your possession." He chose the word deliberately.

It didn't seem to faze her. If anything she seemed to relax. He sipped at an average hot chocolate and tried to lead the witness. "I take paperwork home too, sometimes. It's easier when it's quiet."

She nodded enthusiastically.

"Did, er, Amy do that as well?" He half-expected another clam-up, but Jess was tripping over herself now to tell him how close they were, and how Amy was such a mouse at Engamel, before Jess showed her the ropes.

"Confidentially," she touched him again and he allowed it, "I think she was a little intimidated by me. The cachet of Oxford, I suppose — very different from Michigan *State* University!"

He watched her spiteful laughter and play-acted silently with her, remembering his mother's advice to never speak ill of the dead. "I'm not sure how it works at memorial services where . . ." he searched for a decent word, ". . . the departed is transferred abroad for burial."

"Do you want to do something after the service?"

"Excuse me?"

"You know, afterwards — we could go on somewhere."

His drink had run out and so had his patience. He grabbed her arm. "Come on, we're going back."

She pulled away from him and a smug smile lit up her face. "I'm not ready yet."

"Fine, stay here, then."

Outside, the blare of traffic shattered the cocoon. He breathed in the city greedily and started walking. He heard the café's metal door crunching back. She was about twenty paces behind him, somewhere between strolling and rushing. He walked on for a bit and then stopped suddenly, tracking her growing reflection in a parked van.

"You were very rude back there," she waited behind him; she sounded genuinely hurt. And just when he was beginning to wonder if she had any genuine feelings at all.

He didn't turn round, less chance of losing it altogether and slapping her. "This isn't a game, Jess. There's a reason someone didn't want you left on the base. Until I know why, I can't resolve this."

She drew level, looking up at him like a puppy in need of a cuddle. "Surely everything can go back to normal after the service?" she stared past him. "Though I suppose they'll need a new technician to work with me."

He didn't speak to her again till they got back to Caliban's. She didn't seem to notice. Sheryl handed him a folded sheet of A4 as he arrived.

"Paperwork," he said to Jess.

She breezed past and headed upstairs, smiling to herself.

Miranda let her get near the top. "Thomas and I are off for a while — business."

Jess galloped back down excitedly. "Can I come?"

"Sorry," she faced her down, "Family only."

* * *

Miranda drove, allowing Thomas to read Sheryl's handiwork. It was mainly what Jess had told him on the daytrip from hell. In fact, a lot of it was verbatim. He tapped the sheet against his forehead: *angel*.

"We've never had nicknames, have we?" He wasn't sure whether to speak about the two of them in the present or the past tense. Present was safer.

Miranda looked up to one corner of the car, found whatever she was searching for in her brain and beckoned him closer. As he heard her words, he fumbled his pages to the floor and she grinned for the rest of the drive.

"Anyway, shouldn't you be at work?" Miranda had a talent for the obvious — that, and nicknames.

"I am, sort of."

She mussed his hair as if to say, I believe you. He checked the mirror — he looked guilty as fuck.

Chapter 19

John and Diane Wright welcomed them with open arms, which made it all easier.

“What’s the bother then, Thomas?” John wasn’t big on small talk. Not where business was concerned.

“I was wondering . . . if you ever had any dealings in Northern Ireland?”

It was the Internet search that did it. When the two Northern Irish guys both came up positive for interests in casinos — building them, as well as liking a flutter. Tie that in with their import-export activities, and it was a fair gamble that the Wrights might have come across them at some point. He gave John their full names.

John Wright sipped at his tea then dunked a biscuit, sucking at it with relish. “Heard of them, yeah; never done business directly though.”

Thomas pressed his hands together as if they were cold. “And, er, what have you heard?”

Diane, Miranda’s mum, folded her arms and sighed. John stopped speaking.

“They’re serious people, Thomas. Not the sort you’d want to antagonise.”

Miranda scooted along the sofa a little. Thomas could feel her warmth pressing against his leg. “They’re stopping Karl going home to visit his mum — she’s dying. It’s like a contract or something and he can’t go back without their say-so.”

John and Diane looked at each other and drank their tea. Thomas waited for a ray of sunlight, but the forecast was definitely stormy. He cleared his throat. “I think we owe Karl, for what he did for Miranda.”

Diane narrowed her eyes. “Hold on a minute, Thomas. *You* owe Karl — it was *your* mess. If you want to get caught up with these geezers,” she paused again, tightening her shoulders, “you’d better tread very carefully.”

There were only so many ways of taking this forward and he didn’t feel like a row. He flexed his thigh, hoped it would prompt Miranda to pitch in with something.

“Thing is, Dad, Karl’s alright, isn’t he — we all *know* that now.” Something about the way she said it caught Thomas’s attention. It was as if she was having a separate conversation with her dad that he wasn’t supposed to understand. John Wright took an unfeasibly long sip of tea and closed his eyes.

Thomas filled the void. “Remember when we first met, when Miranda and me came down from Leeds? You didn’t know me from Adam, but you gave me a chance.”

Miranda cleared her throat. “Well, sort of. I did speak to Mum and Dad now and then, from Leeds. I just didn’t tell you about it.”

He was starting to feel ganged up on. “All I want to do is broker some sort of deal with these people. His mum is dying for Christ’s sake. Even an hour — just a poxy hour over there with his mum. Surely they must want *something*?” He surprised himself, hearing the conviction in his voice.

John nodded. “Leave it with us. But why do you wanna get involved?”

Thomas smiled. “Truth? Maybe I’ve spent enough time with you lot to see how important family is.”

“Steady on, Thomas,” Diane cut in, “you’ll ’ave me weeping.” She laughed playfully.

“I’m serious, Diane.”

“I know, love,” her eyes softened. “I know you are.”

Thomas and Miranda went off to make a fresh brew; he made sure she closed the kitchen door.

“So,” he lined up the mugs with his back to her. “What sort of things did you used to say to your mum and dad about us?”

He glanced round and Miranda was there waiting. She refilled the kettle.

“I didn’t tell them we’d, you know, done the deed.”

That was polite, by Miranda’s standards. Something about being at her parents’ home often dampened her farmyard sensibilities.

“Well, what then?”

“Just stuff — I was a teenager back then. Teenage stuff. That I was safe and I’d met this gorgeous boy from Yorkshire. My very own Heathcliff, all moody and intense, only with much shorter hair!”

The kettle bubbled and frothed and she lifted it off the element just before the switch popped. It always pissed him off.

“For all I knew, they might have killed me when I first met them. I was absolutely bricking it.”

“I know,” she said, grinning at the memory of that first meeting. “I s’pose I wanted to see whether you really meant all the things you said in Leeds. I know different now.” The last sentence sounded like an afterthought.

He took a tray, with mugs and biscuit reinforcements, back to the front room. John and Diane had that stilted look, as if they’d been deep in conversation only a moment ago and didn’t quite know how to disguise it. John airlifted a mug.

“So why’ve those blokes got it in for Karl — some sort of Paddy religious thing is it?”

“Not exactly.” He had been hoping to keep Karl’s private life out of it, but he saw now that he’d been naïve. He couldn’t really expect John and Diane to get involved — and the signs were promising if they were still asking questions — without at least giving them the background.

It was like swimming in Gormire Lake, back home. At first you recoil from the shock, from that hollow feeling in your stomach. But after a while, once you accepted it and started moving around, you got used to it. And that was how he felt, spilling the beans on Karl’s past love life.

Diane did the talking. She wanted to know about Karl’s background, about when he’d last spoken with Martin and Francis-Andrew. And her radar was finely tuned. “Where’s Karl’s dad, then?”

Funny you should ask that. “Not sure. He never mentions him. I don’t even know his name.”

“John?” Diane nudged him.

“Yeah,” he re-entered the fray. “I was just wondering if these people know what Karl does for a living? Unlikely I s’pose — given how you secret squirrels like to operate.”

Thomas flinched. A little below the belt but no less accurate for it.

Diane paid no attention. “How does that help us?”

John sniffed and bit into a ginger nut. “Well, what if we could shoehorn Karl into another *business*, temporarily? Maybe that would get him safe passage over there, for work.”

Thomas could already see the flaw. “But what if they want to know what he’s doing over there — apart from seeing his mother I mean?”

John shook his head slowly, like a cat outlining the options to a cornered mouse. “Doesn’t work like that. In this line of business, no one *ever* asks. It’s just not done. Leave it with us, we’ll make some calls — discreet, like — and let you know.”

Chapter 20

Thomas washed the suds from his face and let the noise of the shower clear his head. Many of life's more cosmopolitan experiences had eluded him, but tonight he could cross another one off his list. Because tonight he was having dinner with Michael Schaefer — courtesy, no doubt, of his Engamel expense account. Obviously, it wasn't a *date* date, though come to think of it Schaefer had been quick to decline his suggestion of bringing along a partner. *Nah, surely not.*

He turned off the shower and squeezed the water from his hair so it ran down his back. Then he dried off and put on the clothes hanging against the door. If he was nervous before, that little thought just increased it by the power of ten.

When his makeover was complete — having deliberately toned down on the aftershave — he unlocked the door and stepped out confidently. Karl was sat on the sofa, flicking through a Raymond Chandler novel.

"Pretty as a picture, Tommo. If the SSU ever do an in-house magazine, you'll get my vote for the cover."

He struck a pose. "Surely you mean undercover? Come on, then, let's see your toys."

Karl put the hardback down and opened his magic box. Some of the bugs and tracers were standard surveillance kit, stuff Thomas had worked with, day in day out for the last two years. But Karl also had his *other* supplier — the one he never spoke about.

Thomas rifled through the trays like a kid in a sweet shop. Karl sighed and laced his fingers together impatiently. "And you're sure you don't want me to follow you around?"

"No ta," he replied without looking up. "I'm not even sure Schaefer will give up anything useful — it's probably his chance to suss me out."

He suffered Karl's fussing and accepted the compromise; a tracer in his shoe — in case he got lost — and a wire, under his jacket. But finally, after much persuasion, he agreed to one of Karl's *shadow army* remaining on standby. He didn't ask for details; it was better not to know.

* * *

Leicester Square was an unusual choice for a meet-up, at any time — more chance of losing someone than connecting with them. Even in the evening there were still hordes of tourists drifting about. And never far behind them, watching from the shadows: the homeless and the hustlers.

He walked past a burger vendor who was half-heartedly plying his trade. The rich smell of over-cooked onions and under-cooked meat product seemed to sum up tourist London after hours: full of promise but unlikely to deliver.

He was deliberately early and did a couple of circuits, reminding himself what the area felt like and where the nearest tube stations were. It was different, being here without a camera. He had no use for the lights and the chaos, no clear purpose to cling to. Now, wandering around, anonymous and adrift, he was just killing time.

After the second visit to the Swiss Centre clock, he figured he'd head over to the restaurant. It would have been easy to find, even without directions — it looked expensive and exclusive. Miranda would have loved it. He loitered at the door, fiddling with an imaginary cufflink. "Here goes nothing," he announced quietly, for the benefit of the transmitter.

Schaefer was in the bar and made eye contact with him as he went inside. So far so good — at least he hadn't been stood up.

"Tommy — come on in!" Schaefer oozed confidence. His handshake was assured and unambiguous, very alpha male. "Glad you could make it — and a little early too. No problem, they're already waiting."

They? He followed Schaefer over to a bar table where two women were sipping champagne.

"Ladies, here's the man I've been telling you about. May I present — Mr Thomas Bladen." Schaefer made it sound like a chat show. To complete the charade, he wrapped an arm around him as if they were old college pals and followed it up with a back slap.

Thomas resisted giving him a slap of a different kind in return and coughed, so that he could check the surgical tape under his shirt was still in place. The two women languidly greeted him; they were dressed barely the right side of decent, and he accepted a champagne glass just to have something else to focus on. Ordinarily he wasn't a fan of the hallowed grape — Christmases at the Wrights and once at an engagement party — his own. But needs must, and all that.

Schaefer was enjoying centre stage, clicking his fingers for another bottle. “We’ve already ordered,” one of the two floozies pointed to a menu on the table.

He opted for the tried and tested; it saved time. He told himself to loosen up, but he was drum tight. Unfamiliar people, unfamiliar location and unknown motives; it all added up to a whole lot of uncomfortable.

Schaefer re-introduced Deborah and Clarity as fellow employees of Engamel Solutions. Thomas wasn’t sure if he believed him. Or that Clarity was a real name.

Their table was called and Deborah carried over the champers, clutching it close to her chest. Even the bubbles seemed that little bit more excited. Schaefer had them seated boy-boy and girl-girl at the round table, so the immediate view was Deborah; he had to fight the urge to wipe the condensation off her cleavage. He sipped at his glass and sailed through the starter, skirting the edges of conversation about his work. Schaefer was happier talking about Engamel in any case; the man was a walking promo: blah blah, multi-million dollar; blah blah, world-beating innovation.

They were on to some *like, totally amazing* white wine now, which he didn’t have the heart to tell them reminded him of chip shop vinegar. Clarity pressed a hand over his.

“So, Tommy, don’t you think London is the greatest city in the world?”

He left his hand where it was and waited for hers to retreat. “I’m not from London. It’s alright though, but it’s not a patch on Harrogate.”

Okay, he might have been exaggerating a little, given that he had relatives in Harrogate. But it gave him a breather as Clarity tried to process the irony without the aid of a safety net. It was a full thirty seconds before she caught on.

“Hey, you’re just making fun out of me! Seriously — so which part of London is Harrogate in?”

Bless her heart, she was only 200 miles out. He seized control of the conversation, and went down a familiar route, giving them an armchair tour of Yorkshire, comparing American Football with Rugby and generally doing a flag-waver for the Yorkshire Tourist Board. All material he’d previously practised, bantering with Sheryl at Miranda’s bar.

Schaefer’s lobster would have made Freud blush. Deborah had followed suit and the two of them ripped into their crustaceans with gusto.

Clarity had shifted her chair towards Thomas a little; he noticed, even if the others hadn't. He stuck with small talk and fillet steak. And he watched as Clarity filleted her Dover sole with infinite care, the flip side to Schaefer's Yankee brashness. Somehow, they managed to talk below Schaefer and Deborah's noise level, but nothing much was said.

He felt relieved when everyone opted to skip dessert and fast-forward to coffee, even though the wine was still flowing on the sidelines. He hadn't risked looking at his watch, but his internal clock ran to about two and a half hours. It was a skill he'd honed in childhood, measuring the angry silences of his father.

Okay, so the evening had largely been a waste of time. A good meal though, and somewhere to take Miranda when he won the lottery. He settled his cup down and listened half-heartedly as the Engamel trio laughed at some private joke. Then the conversation cleared like static, and Schaefer leaned towards him.

"If Jessica comes to the memorial service, I want to speak to her." It didn't sound like a request and that got his back up. Rather than confront it head-on, he tried a sideways approach.

"Listen, Michael, if we're going to get those papers back, maybe we need to give her a little breathing space — to grieve and that."

Schaefer's chest expanded a couple of inches. "No, *you* listen, Bladen," Schaefer prodded the table, jangling the crockery. "Five minutes with me and she'll be sending the papers back by courier."

He remained still, although the urge to smile because Schaefer hadn't questioned the *papers* was nearly killing him. Schaefer wasn't finished.

"And don't give me any crap about grieving. Jessica's only interested in herself. Sure, she was close to Amy, but I wouldn't say it was a two-way thing."

Thomas sipped at his drink calmly, hoping for more treasures. Schaefer didn't disappoint.

"I've gone through her file, Tommy — reads like a psychology manual. Only child, orphaned at a young age. Extended family rallied round as best they could, but she ended up in care and sort of missed her turn in life." He sounded almost gleeful.

Thomas turned defence advocate again. "It must be hard to recover from a start like that."

“Tell me about it!” Schaefer took a slug of wine and swung the glass around like a conductor’s baton. “Total fantasist. Her application says she studied at Oxford . . .” he paused until Deborah and Clarity had given him their full attention. “Sure, some backstreet outfit near Oxford.”

Thomas’s brain started somersaulting again. He picked up a bottle and refilled everyone’s glass, except his own. “Then how come Engamel took her on?”

This was fast becoming a Q & A session, for the benefit of the tape.

Schaefer slurped some more wine, dripping it on the tablecloth. “Kinda nose bastard ain’t ya?”

He smiled and looked Schaefer right in the eyes.

“Nah, I’m only messing with ya, Tommy, you’re okay — you’re one of us. At least, I hope you are!” Schaefer flicked a glance to Deborah and Clarity.

Thomas caught it, but couldn’t make any sense of it.

“Jessica might be a little screwy but she’s got it *all* going on up here,” he tapped at his temple. “Genuine eidetic.”

Thomas nodded politely. *Not a clue*. As things wound to a close, he took stock. No harm done, a little team-building, a new word to look up and maybe Karl could sift something useful out of the evening’s commentary. Time for group hugs and then he could piss off. “Well, thanks for a great meal and everything,” he shifted the chair back to stand. Schaefer raised a hand to block him.

“Hey, the night is young. You’re not planning on leaving us already? I booked us all rooms nearby.”

Oh bollocks. He felt a chill skateboard down his spine. God only knows what laughing boy had in mind.

* * *

The streets of London felt full of foreboding, but Schaefer just breezed along, locking arms with Deborah for mutual support and anything else going, judging by the look of them.

Clarity tagged along beside Thomas. She said nothing. If he were a betting man, he’d say it was odds on she’d been paid to be there. He let Schaefer lead them a merry dance through the darkening streets, staying

vigilant for the four of them. After a while he stopped holding his keys at his side, through his knuckles.

“Here we go,” Schaefer announced, flinging an arm towards the hotel as if he’d just paid for it out of small change. It would have needed a lorry load of small change.

They stumbled up the marble steps. In a word: palatial. Schaefer showered tips like confetti and collected the room keys.

Thomas hung back by the lifts with Deborah and Clarity, watching as they whispered and nodded in his direction. He blushed, like an idiot; if he got any more out of his depth, he’d be needing scuba gear.

Schaefer sauntered over with a collection of keys and the lift doors opened. The journey took forever and that just made it worse. Someone was pressing against his arse — he didn’t dare look to see who; he was too busy sweating.

He remembered being a teenager, and a game of strip poker with male and female friends. Rushing home to put on three T-shirts and extra socks then dashing to the venue, stiff with worry. A bead of sweat meandered down the blind side of his face. He felt every millimetre it travelled, imagined it gradually negotiating the terrain of his face. And all to the faded soundtrack of Celine Dion.

He was last out of the lift, hurriedly wiping his face as the others moved ahead. Schaefer and Deborah fumbled along the corridor together, parting and colliding, like moths against a light bulb. Schaefer opened the door. He was still holding all the cards, and the keys. The room was massive. If Thomas had to guess, it was a penthouse suite.

It took him a moment to realise he was the only one standing at the doorway. No big deal, he told himself — just a nightcap with his new friends. Then he’d collect his key and leave them to it. The *it* bothered him. He stepped inside and closed the door carefully behind him.

Shoes had been scattered across the carpet. He heard laughter and the sound of water. “We’re in here!” Deborah’s voice teased.

He crossed the room slowly. *Sweet Jesus.*

Schaefer was climbing into a Jacuzzi, au naturel; Deborah was already ahead of the game. She leaned back and the water from her hair ran down her breasts. At first he couldn’t see Clarity, then she turned her head from the side of the tub and wiped her nostrils.

Miranda sometimes liked to taunt him — rightly — that he hadn't led a very adventurous life. But even he knew it was coke. He made a flippant comment about sinusitis, for the tape.

Clarity lifted up a tray and Deborah took it. She seemed to hold it there above the frothing water, poised, as if watching for his response. Clarity glanced at him over her shoulder and eased into the tub. And she took her time about it. Then she reached for a champagne glass at the side and patted the water playfully. Schaefer's head disappeared under the water. Deborah finished her line and shifted position to accommodate him.

"No need to be shy, Tommy. We're all grown-ups." Clarity swished a hand through the bubbles. Without warning, Schaefer's head surfaced in front of Deborah, who was all smiles.

He gazed at the three of them and blinked slowly. Back in Sunday school in Yorkshire, there'd been a picture in one of the books. He could see it in his mind's eye now, clear as day. Two roads: two destinations. On one side, a beautiful glowing angel and a road that led to a bright green meadow where Jesus seemed to be having a picnic. On the other side, an indefinable shape, almost human, calling from a path of overgrown trees and shadows. He'd had nightmares about it.

Now, as he watched the three amigos get very amigo-ey indeed, this looked like an adult version of the same thing. Schaefer moved between the two women, his arms around them like serpents. "Well, Tommy, what are you afraid of?"

Afraid wouldn't cover it; try completely intimidated. And curious. And even the teeniest bit repulsed.

As he stood there, like a coeliac at a bread festival, he felt his cheeks burning. In the haze of dinner and naked Americans, he'd forgotten something important. And he hated himself for it. "You do know that Amy's memorial service is tomorrow?"

Of course they knew. He must have looked like a pious schoolteacher.

Schaefer grinned. The slimy bastard actually grinned at him. "Like I always say, Tommy, you gotta live for the moment."

Clarity pouted, Monroe style, and picked up a cigarette from God knows where. "Hey, Tommy, ain't you gonna light my fire?" And the way she looked at him, barely holding it together without laughing, he knew she'd been the bait for the whole evening — the innocent American act.

“Some other time.” He wished he’d been wearing a hidden camera as well, not for the flesh, but to capture that smug look on their faces. Although he doubted he’d forget it.

He turned around with all the dignity he could muster and left them to it. As he reached the front door, he called back in a loud and clear voice, “I’ll see you at the funeral.” But the only reply was the sound of splashing water.

Out along the corridor to the lift. No one else was around. He stabbed the lift button and squeezed his hands, as if that could somehow drain the adrenaline screaming through his veins. He cleared his throat for the microphone. “I don’t know where you’re hiding, just get me the fuck out of here. As soon as I’m downstairs, I start walking.”

The thought of Amy — that twisted carnage of her body — seemed to fade in and out before him as the light flickered through the lift door window; a memory stark and real. He wondered what the Yanks thought of him now — probably pissing themselves about the uptight Brit. Well, bollocks to them.

On the ground floor, the lift door swept open. The stillness and quiet cut through him after the night he’d just had. A receptionist stared from across the desk, bright-eyed and attentive. She smiled and he found the composure to return it and wish her a good night. His mum would have been proud.

* * *

Central London was still buzzing. The combination of neon, lost souls and broken dreams gave the city a poetry all its own. As he walked back to Leicester Square, he distracted himself by selecting lenses and subjects. The way the traffic headlights rolled across the surface of a tree, the jagged slices of light behind an office window blind. It wasn’t long before he was in photographer mode, back on home ground.

It wasn’t even midnight yet. He could still ring Miranda and meet her at a nightclub. Then again, he didn’t really feel like company now. He managed twenty paces into Leicester Square — because he’d started counting them — and then he saw the suit zero in on him.

“Mr Bladen.”

It came as a statement. For a moment he flinched; the man looked like police of some description. He flashed his SSU ID. and the suit acknowledged it, calmly leading him away.

“We have a car waiting.” The suit walked beside him, not speaking, until they rounded a one-way street where a grey van was parked up. As they approached, the passenger door opened and a familiar face stepped out to greet him.

Teresa. He’d met her two or three times before. He used to think that she was Karl’s squeeze, or his boss in the other cloak-and-dagger stuff. He wasn’t sure what to believe anymore

“It’s been a while, Thomas,” she smiled; it carried a whiff of apology.

For the last few months, Karl had drawn an invisible line around his clandestine activities to give Thomas some breathing space. The bitter truth was that he rather missed it. He’d peeked behind the magic mirror and could never properly rejoin the audience.

Teresa waited. He cleared his throat, blinked to show that he was paying attention.

“Anything else I should know, Thomas?”

“Nothing spectacular. Engamel seems to have a very open policy on drugs and team-building.”

She didn’t push it. Perhaps, like him, she was filing it away somewhere, in case it could be useful in the future. The rest of the debrief, if you could call it that, took place in the van as they drove him home. He said little, not because he had a problem with them; it was just that although he’d worked in surveillance for a couple of years now, the kind of stuff she and Karl were involved in was in a different league.

As the van pulled up, a street away from his flat, Teresa turned to him in the semi-darkness. “I never thanked you for what you did *before* . . .” She left the sentence hanging.

He didn’t insult them both by telling her it was nothing, when it had basically fucked his whole life up. And his head. So he just reached for the door handle.

She leant across and tapped his arm. “Until the next time . . .”

* * *

He shut the door behind him and cut her off. Walthamstow was deathly still. He took in a breath and held it, tuning his senses to the street. For weeks after Yorgi's death, he'd looked into the shadows, trying to make out human forms. Totally illogical, as no one comes back from a point blank shot to the head, but when did fear have anything to do with logic? He was past that now, by and large, but he threaded his keys through his fingers again for that secure feeling.

Nothing stirred except the muffled growl of traffic, a block away on Forest Road. He rolled his feet as he walked, dulling the sound of shoes against pavement. A few paces on and he began to breathe again; he was buzzing, ideas spinning like plates. He put his keys away as he rounded the corner and caught sight of the flat. Karl's car was outside, soothing him like a nightlight — the kind his dad had never let him have as a child.

He could see that Karl was reading *Private Eye*. As he drew closer the window wound down. "Special delivery for Mr Bladen," Karl reached into his inside pocket and waved some paperwork.

"You coming in then?" he ambled past and up the steps to his front door.

Karl cut the light and locked up the car. "Tell you what, Tommo, you get the kettle on and we'll swap stories."

* * *

He dished out tea and biscuits, and then went to get changed.

Karl started crooning. "Love letters straight from your heart . . ."

He ignored him, ditched the suit for civvies and made a beeline for the sheets of paper Karl had left on the table. They made interesting reading.

Major Eldridge had poured out his heart in print, while weaselling out of the eternal 'when are you going to tell your wife about us' conundrum. The opening line, *My dearest Angel*, cut no ice with him. Thomas couldn't put his finger on it, but something didn't sit right. He flicked through the pages like a vexed cat. As he looked up, Karl was watching over the top of his mug.

"Come on now, figure it out! I'll give you a clue," Karl put down his mug and cupped his hands like a megaphone, "Something's missing."

He redoubled his efforts, scanning the four pages for anything that wasn't there. No sale. He accepted defeat gracelessly and sat down with his

tea.

“No address, Dr Watson,” Karl sucked at an imaginary Sherlock Holmes pipe.

He checked again. So what? Still, knowing Karl’s fixation on details, where was the copy of the envelope? And then Schaefer’s comments about Jess’s memory and propensity for bullshitting joined hands to form a chain. He smiled back at Karl and prepared to drop his bombshell.

“Bingo. Jess isn’t the major’s squeeze, but Amy was. Schaefer said Jess had a fantastic memory and called her eidetic.”

It seemed to be the starting pistol Karl had been waiting for. “So she gets the letters somehow, commits them to memory and regurgitates them for everyone’s benefit like a proper little show-off. So what does she want from Major Eldridge?”

“Dunno. Maybe she wants justice for Amy? Can’t see it from her behaviour so far though . . .” He clicked his fingers. “Of course, if she’s as twisted as Schaefer suggested, she might be hoping to *replace* Amy.”

Karl took his imaginary pipe out of his mouth. “Let’s say you’re right, hypothetically. That explains the letters but not the *papers*. Why would Schaefer give a shit about love letters? There’s nothing classified in there,” he snorted, “unless it’s a cunning code.”

Thomas bit at a nail as he narrowed his eyes. “Alright,” he lowered his thumb, cupping a loose fist. “Let’s speculate. What if Jess realises that Amy has mixed random ammo — maybe to speed up the testing, I dunno. Anyway, after it all goes pear-shaped, Jess takes the test sheets or whatever they use, to help cover it up. Major Eldridge showed me some report suggesting it was a factor in the accident.”

Karl took a swig of tea, his eyes still on Thomas. “Makes sense. Of course, Jess could also be implicated in the whole mixed ammo thing, so she removes the evidence. And, I know I’m really flying by the seat of my pants here, maybe she’s memorised all the data and made a copy.”

There was a certain logic to it. “So Engamel wants the data back and the major needs his private letters. And all roads lead to Jess — because, let’s face it, she craves the attention and the control.”

“She’d be playing with fire though. With all the finance tied up in the development of the Scavenger, Jess would soon become expendable.”

“Just like Amy?”

Thomas got a fresh piece of paper and wrote it all down, for his own sanity. The major has an affair with Amy. Amy confides in Jess — or maybe Jess just finds out and gets hold of the letters. Once Amy's gone, she ditches the envelope and the letters become part of her mental wonderland. She also destroys the data sheets from the tests — for whatever reason. And suddenly everyone is looking for her — or looking out for her.

"So who hid the Scavenger parts under our Land Rover? And who took it?"

Karl took a deep breath and sighed. "The major's got to be involved. He knows what we do and he knows me. So he must expect I'll take some sort of action."

Thomas left it there and filled Karl in on the after-dinner entertainment. Karl roared with laughter at Thomas's depiction of the Engamel water-sports team.

"So come on now, weren't you just the teensiest bit tempted?"

"Nah, chlorine plays havoc with my highlights."

Karl took the hint and changed topic. "How do you want to play the memorial service tomorrow?" That was a novelty — Karl sounding unsure of himself. "You know I can't be there, so I thought you might need back-up — people you could trust . . ." Karl seemed to shrink away a little. "I made a couple of calls today." He was blushing. "Miranda will accompany you. As well as Sam and Terry."

Thomas flinched; Karl said their names so comfortably now.

Karl bided his time and didn't speak until Thomas had pulled himself together.

"And what is the master plan they're all working to?"

"It's very simple. If anything kicks off, you'll have a half-decent chance of getting Jess out of there in one piece."

Now he saw red. "Get her away to where? What gives you the right to drag Miranda and her family into this? She was right — this is *your* mess, you and your army pals."

Karl didn't stay much longer. He left Thomas the copied letters for a little night reading and said he'd catch up some time after the service.

Thomas sat there for a long time afterwards, mulling things over. He was glad he hadn't mentioned John Wright being on the case to help get

Karl back to Belfast. And was that any better than what Karl had done? He gave up the ghost and lay in bed, pawing through the letters.

It was all there in black and white. Jess was word perfect on the details. Too perfect. He dropped the papers on the floor and turned out the light. He knew he wouldn't sleep for a while, too wound up by Karl's wheeler-dealing.

When the phone went off he pounced on it, snatched the receiver up.

"Hey you, it's me. What are you wearing?" Only Miranda could get a laugh out of that line, every time. She brought him up to speed, on the plan he hadn't been party to. She'd be accompanying Jess on the big day. Sam and Terry would wait at the back — their job was to stop anyone other than Thomas or Miranda taking Jess out of there. God help them, Sam had even asked whether they ought to be tooled up.

"One other thing, Dad rang me — reckons he might have a way forward for Karl's problem with the Irish blokes."

He cupped the phone closer.

"He's putting something together, but he's gonna need Karl's full support."

The sweat was running down his face now. This was all wrong. Miranda's family were too exposed, and it was *his* fault.

"You alright? You're very quiet. If it wasn't for the heavy breathing, I'd have thought you'd fallen asleep on me." More innuendo, even if it was a lovely way to send him off to sleep.

"Sorry, Miranda, I'm gonna turn in — I'm whacked. I'll see you tomorrow. And remember, it's a funeral so nothing *too* sexy." He knew she'd like that.

"Tell you what," she whispered huskily, "I could come round first thing in the morning and try on some outfits, for your personal approval."

It sounded like the best plan he'd heard all day.

Chapter 21

Sex and death; they went together like bacon and eggs. Miranda let herself into the flat around seven o'clock; he'd drawn back the deadbolt at six.

She tiptoed into the bedroom, and eased back the duvet. Somewhere along the route she must have discarded her clothes, because she was as naked as the good Lord had made her. And right now, he felt a touch of old-time religion coming on.

They played the games that lovers play, teasing, testing, letting the ebb and flow of tension and pleasure carry them away with the tide. And when he lay there afterwards and felt the warm comfort of her on top of him, as the pulses of ecstasy faded like an echo, he wondered how they'd ever managed to screw up such a brilliant relationship. And whether, as Sheryl had inquired, there was still hope.

"Right then, Mr Sticky, you get the tea on and I'll wash the sweat off." She could ruin a magic moment in the blink of an eye.

Once Miranda had returned, he showered and pulled on some joggies and a T-shirt. It was barely seven thirty and he felt pleasantly tired, like after a gym workout but with the best exercise regime imaginable.

She nibbled at her toast and gazed around the room, as if she were looking for something. "Karl suggested we pack a bag in case we need to take Jess on somewhere."

"Not to me he didn't." He tried not to sound put out, and failed. Even so, it made sense, but he hoped it wouldn't come to that.

By eight thirty, Miranda was out the door. The meet-up was eleven thirty — she'd left him the address of the place. He figured Jess had got the details from the good Major, and didn't push the point. One way or another, today was going to be very strange. Might as well take it slowly, in stages.

Once he'd packed an overnight bag, he dug out his darkest suit and put on some Otis Redding to accompany the ironing. He went to town on the tie as well, deriving great satisfaction from smoothing the material. Ironing done, he rang Sam and Terry, to confirm that he knew they were on the team. It was a short call, just long enough to agree a plan to get Jess back to Caliban's in the event of trouble. For one thing, his flat was too small and

for another, the bar had at least three exits. Relax, he told himself, how much trouble could a funeral be?

* * *

Ten thirty, he was parking up. Couldn't help noticing the plane trees lining the roads: here was life in abundance. He cut the car radio and sat for a while, eyes closed, listening to the crows high above him and the awkward chatter as people came and went between the cars. And he thought about Amy, a stranger who had left America to seek her fortune, only to wind up dead, for reasons still undetermined.

He felt the hot swelling in his chest, same as when Karl had asked for extra footage on that day in the test lab. His hands were sweating, moist against the steering wheel. He pressed them against his face and breathed in and out through his fingers. What justice would there be for Amy and her family? The only answer was the cackle of crows.

He shouldered the driver's door wide, as if it were a way out of his thoughts. It was still early — all to the good. A chance to check out who else had turned up. As he crunched across the gravel to the waiting area, a car slid past him. He glanced left and saw the side of Sir Peter Carroll's Daimler gliding by. *Great*. Another member of the fan club.

If Miranda were on schedule, she'd be bringing Jess in as close to kick-off as possible. Less chance of a confrontation before the service. So there was no sense waiting outside, best get in and mingle with the other mourners. He hadn't known Amy, but he'd never felt closer to her — they were both pawns to circumstance.

Major Eldridge was right inside the door, wearing a fixed expression that suggested he had nailed a lid on everything. But Thomas wasn't buying it. Judging by the letters, if last night's assumptions were correct, Eldridge was here to see off the woman he loved. Schaefer and the rest of his American trio were there too, making small talk amongst themselves. As he set eyes on Schaefer, the three of them fell silent and turned away. Fine by him.

He exchanged a handshake with the major and struggled for a follow-up line. They stood there, arms at their sides, avoiding eye contact. Now that Thomas knew about Amy and the major — or *thought* he knew — it complicated things.

The major picked up a folded A4 sheet from a pile and handed it to him. There was another picture of Amy on the front, smiling in the hazy sunshine. It looked to Thomas like the kind of impulsive, short exposure that he loved to take of Miranda. Inside the sheet was a bio — where she'd grown up and how much she'd been admired and respected by her colleagues — followed by a brief explanation of the music and hymns chosen for the service. He nodded as he read through the sequence and caught the major watching him. "Good choices," he said — just to see if it got a reaction; it did.

An usher appeared and invited everyone to go through. Major Eldridge led the way and Thomas fell in step behind him. Then he saw Miranda and Jess out of the corner of his eye and held back. Schaefer rushed towards Jess, grabbing for her shoulder, but Thomas blocked him. "Not here," he snarled, "Have some fucking respect."

Miranda flashed him a grin. Schaefer dropped his arm and swept in with his two groupies. There was no sign of Terry or Sam — typical. It was a mistake to have got them involved.

Jess went right to the front and stood beside Major Eldridge, with Miranda in tow. Thomas paused for a moment, unsure how the seating worked. He figured it'd be best if he stuck close to Jess, because a storm was brewing. He opted for the row behind — Schaefer, Clarity and Deborah were opposite him, across the central aisle. Schaefer looked seriously pissed off.

A heavy hand thumped down on Thomas's shoulder. For a moment he thought Terry had finally put in an appearance, but he turned to face Sir Peter. They stared at each other for what seemed like minutes and then Sir Peter smiled softly, as if nothing more needed to be said.

Classical music filtered up from somewhere and the doors at the back opened. Thomas caught a glimpse of the coffin being carried up, front and centre, then he became aware of the minister for the first time. She rose and stepped forward to the lectern, waiting respectfully until the string music faded.

"We are gathered here today to remember Amy Johanson, whose brief life ended in tragedy."

His ears twitched at the American voice, He shifted forward a little. There was a summary of Amy's life, followed by a reading from Psalm 144.

Thomas turned to the page and nearly choked at the opening:

Praise the Lord, my protector!
He trains me for battle
and prepares me for war.
He is my protector and defender,
my shelter and saviour,
in whom I trust for safety.
He subdues the nations under me.

Hardly the stuff of solace and sorrow, more like a rallying cry to the troops. Maybe it was meant to be job-related or the major was making a point. The minister spoke fluidly. She sounded sincere, paused for emphasis and looked out at the congregation every now and again.

Thomas followed, word for word, and at verse seven, the major looked across to Schaefer and held the look.

Reach down from above,
pull me out of the deep water, and rescue me;
Save me from the power of foreigners,
who never tell the truth
and lie even under oath.

He heard Sir Peter moving behind him, shifting towards his ear.

“What the hell’s going on, Thomas?”

He didn’t have an answer so he bent forward as if to shrug Sir Peter off. Schaefer looked livid. Now, more than ever, he hoped Miranda’s brothers were close by. The minister asked if anyone wanted to say a few words and Jess’s hand shot up like a flare.

A gasp from the American trio echoed around the chapel. Jess squeezed past Miranda and took the stand. She looked about as grief-stricken as an undertaker on Bank Holiday overtime. Okay, so she wasn’t exactly smiling, but she wasn’t a shrinking violet either. The minister stood politely to one side as Jess unfolded a piece of paper.

Somehow, she managed to talk about Amy while glorifying *herself*. It was sickening to watch, the way she talked about sharing Amy’s

confidences. The major squirmed like a worm on the hook. Jess went on about how proud they'd both been to work for Engamel and how they'd believed in the vital research work. To a cynic like Thomas it sounded like a loyalty pitch to Schaefer. And he noticed the way she didn't refer to her notes — not once. All in all, it was a marvellous performance; it should have been entitled: *Woman Without a Soul*.

Clarity was about the only one showing real emotion. She wept slowly into a handkerchief, and for a while Thomas almost forgave how she'd acted the last time they'd met. The moment soon passed, right about the time that Jess stood down. As she did, Jess turned the page over to fold it up and just for a second he saw rows of figures. Unbelievably, this selfish bitch was using Amy's funeral to taunt Schaefer — and anyone else paying attention — with what looked like numerical data. The speech had all been memorised in one almighty *fuck you* exercise.

As Jess sat down, there was more music. This time, a real tear-jerker — Janis Ian's 'When Angels Cry.' Thomas felt emotion rising and choked it back. A solitary tear escaped the barricades, which he managed to ignore. The major's shoulders rose and fell; the poor guy was in real difficulty. Thomas glanced at Jess's face, somewhere between indifference and introspection. He flexed his hand and tried not to think about getting up and slapping her. He wished he were beside Miranda, to feel her hand in his. She always said that weddings and hen parties made her feel emotional — for him it was funerals, every time.

The music drew to a close and the minister concluded the service. The atmosphere was electric. He glanced over, watching Schaefer to see if he would be crass enough to make a move there, in front of an audience. Jess took her own sweet time departing, even waylaying the minister for a few words before she left. She certainly had some balls.

As Jess reached the double doors at the back — first out, naturally, a man stepped forward and grabbed her. Thomas broke into a gallop and Miranda was a second behind him. Michael Schaefer body-checked him six feet from the doors. Six feet from the commotion on the other side.

"Whoa there, tough guy." Schaefer grabbed him forcefully. "I think we'll take it from here." He sounded smug, in control. Right up until the moment Miranda punched him in the kidneys. Then he sank to the floor with a choking, guttural gasp.

Thomas half-opened, half-shouldered the doors. They only moved partway, jammed against a groaning body — stocky, with crew-cut, dark hair. Definitely not Sam or Terry. He drew the doors back and gave them one almighty shove. There was a yelp and swearing, then the doors burst open. Jess was nowhere to be seen, and nor were Sam or Terry.

“My car!” Miranda called, legging it to her Mini Cooper.

He detoured to his own car first and grabbed the emergency bag — this was definitely an emergency.

Miranda wheel-span on the gravel to pick him up and then barrelled for the exit. Fortunately, there was nothing coming in. He rang Sam and it went straight to message — same with Terry. Nothing else for it, but to proceed as planned and hope that they’d managed to spirit Jess away.

As Miranda drove like a demon, he started thinking. Assuming Jess made it to Caliban’s, where could he hide her next? If Schaefer had seen the page, like *he* had, then things had cranked up a notch. Maybe, if he could reason with Jess, he could get a copy of the stats or whatever they were to Schaefer, and he’d call the whole thing off? Some hope.

Mentally, he cycled through the few numbers in his address book. In the last few months he’d added one more to make it a round half dozen. Petrov, who Thomas had saved from his murderous brother, Yorgi. He smiled unexpectedly; he’d just had an idea.

* * *

By the time they reached Caliban’s he was firing on all cylinders. It was still a chewing-gum-and-string plan, but in the absence of Karl it was the best he could do.

Sheryl was waiting by the door and ushered them in, bags in hand. There were no jokes today, just straight between the eyes *attitude*.

“You better not be dragging Miranda into any trouble, not after last time.”

He pushed past her and mounted the stairs in twos and threes. Terry met him at the top. “Thank fuck for that, Thomas, we thought you’d got lost on the way.” Terry was nursing his hand; Thomas didn’t bother asking.

Jess flounced over and kissed him on the cheek, with Miranda standing right beside him. He shook her off before either he or Miranda decked her.

“Sheryl!” he yelled, only to find her stood behind him. “Can I talk to you in private?” She showed him to her temporary bedroom.

“Have you, er, got a wig and sunglasses — the more fake the better.” He didn’t mention Miranda’s little revelation about her dressing-up box, a few weeks before.

She opened a cupboard full of wigs and extensions. “Help yourself, honey,” she said, in the most unhelpful voice imaginable. Once he had what he needed, he shifted effortlessly into ‘job mode.’ The blood was really pumping now, but it was just a surge against a tidal wall.

“Right, gather round and listen up, we don’t have much time. Miranda, grab the biggest coat you can find and put these on as well. Sheryl, once we’re out of here, I want you to ring Ann Crossley on this number and tell her to take Jess to this address,” he began scribbling on a scrap of paper.

Then he stopped and changed demeanour. “Jess, can I just check something?”

She moved in close, forcing a gap between him and Miranda. He snatched Jess’s handbag and turned to one side to open it. Before Jess could lift her hand to stop him, Miranda had it pinned down.

“Don’t. I’ve already put one person down today; I’m quite happy to make it a double.”

It gave Thomas enough time to find what he was looking for. He took the sheet out and unfolded it; there were columns of numbers to four decimal places.

“Sheryl, please pass this on to Ann Crossley, to be given to Michael Schaefer.” He turned back and flung the handbag to Jess. “When will you get it into your head that this isn’t a game?”

Jess gave him a simpering look.

Miranda adjusted her blonde wig. “Where are we going, Thomas?”

“Yorkshire — just you and me.” He looked right at Jess, making sure she’d got the message.

The cab arrived quickly. The lure of an extra fiver probably helped. He promised to ring Sheryl later when things had calmed down. It had been a long day already and it was about to get a whole lot longer. Especially when they got to Yorkshire, dressed for a funeral.

Chapter 22

“Do I really have to wear this, now we’re on the train?” Miranda hissed.

“Yup,” he tried hard not to smile, but it was killing him. With the coat, dark glasses and tumbling blonde wig, she looked like a D-List celebrity, desperate to be noticed.

“People keep looking at us.”

He sipped his coffee nonchalantly. “That’s the idea.”

She huffed back into her seat and rifled through the first of three magazines she’d made him buy her at Kings Cross.

He stared out of the window, mobile in his hand. The second it hummed, he was on it like a cat. He turned to Miranda as he listened, nodding at what Ann Crossley reported. Then he sat back a little easier and tried to play footsie under the table.

“What’s made you so bloody cheery all of a sudden?”

He dimmed his voice to a whisper. “Ann’s completed the drop-off for me. And she’s turning over the paper to the Yank, later today.”

Miranda peered over the top of her over-sized shades. “I hope you know what you’re doing.”

He waited until the train had passed Doncaster before ringing his sister. He had to hold the phone out to cope with Pat’s scream of delight. His adding that he’d brought along a surprise only heightened the volume. He swore her to secrecy and arranged a pick-up away from the station, a good hour and a half after their arrival.

It was exciting, being back on home territory with Miranda — like old times. He couldn’t help smiling to himself as he packed his Conan Doyle biography back into his bag.

She stirred and leaned forward, resting her hand on his. There was a pause, a moment when time froze and it felt like it had when they were starting over, leaving Leeds for the uncertainty of London. Him, bracing himself to meet her family for the first time and Miranda squished up at his side, like a punked-up prodigal daughter.

What brought him back to the present was the edge of her old engagement ring, driving into his hand. He flinched, and immediately

regretted it when she drew her hand away.

“Sorry, forgot. Hope I didn’t hurt you,” she said, displaying her usual talent for irony. She swivelled the band round, stone uppermost and started to ease the ring off.

“Better take this thing off for a while. Don’t want your parents freaking out.”

“You know,” he gulped, “you could always leave it on.”

He stared at her and she gazed back implacably as she wriggled the ring free.

“I think we need to talk that through a little more carefully, don’t you?”

The tannoy announced their imminent arrival at York and reminded travellers not to leave any possessions behind. Yeah, he thought, like hope or vulnerability.

* * *

Leeds might have industry and a suitcase full of Miranda memories to its name, but York had culture. The cobbled streets and ancient walls oozed history and charm. He steered her into the crowds — there were always crowds in York, didn’t matter what time of the year — and tried not to think about the ring. She took his arm and cranked him close; but it felt like a consolation prize.

“Come on, cut out all that macho bollocks. We will talk about it, you know.”

If anything he was annoyed at his own stupidity. What was he thinking? Answer, he wasn’t thinking at all. He’d been responding to the moment. And he should have known better.

They found a busy café and took a table outside. There, among the faux Vikings and a hen party on warm-up, Miranda’s appearance didn’t seem quite so conspicuous. Espresso might not have been the answer to his prayers but it made for a bloody good psalm.

“Gonna show me round York Minster then?”

“Aye, go on, then. But don’t go nicking anything — I know what all you thieving cockneys are like.”

It was the sort of thing Ajit would say, and he beamed at the thought. Ajit and Geena would meet Miranda again after who knew how many

years. Yes, and so would Mum and Dad. Maybe he'd light a prayer candle in the Minster, as back up.

* * *

Pat, his sister, was on time. Even as he approached the car she looked nervy, scuttling out of the car and waiting for him to approach — not her usual animated self. She cried of course. Miranda took off the glasses and put on her best encouraging smile. Pat shook her hand and gave her a polite kiss on the cheek, before doing a double-take.

“Why, it's Miranda, isn't it? How come you're in disguise? I thought he'd found himself a floozy!”

“Not here.” Thomas ushered them both into the car. “Take us over to Ajit's place and not a word to Mum and Dad.”

He gave Pat a paper-thin explanation for his sudden appearance and skipped Miranda's altogether. Pat played the polite sister and asked after Miranda's family. Miranda seemed to want to help her out and gave her a ten-year update on all the people Pat had never met and was never likely to. And then it was Thomas's turn to talk.

“I, er, needed to get away and Miranda agreed to come with me.”

Pat didn't speak for a while. Then, without looking at Thomas beside her, said, “Is this to do with your job? I'm not daft, yer know! Our dad has never breathed a word about what you were up to on the moors, but I read the papers.”

Pat dropped them at a street corner. She got out of the car with them and clung to him for a few seconds. He whispered his thanks as he prised her off, and promised to ring her that evening. She didn't look convinced as she drove away.

* * *

He walked Miranda to Ajit and Geena's place, fizzing with anticipation. Outside of Miranda's family, he had few friends. And Ajit had the plus of not being connected to either Miranda's lot, or Karl.

Thomas rang the doorbell and jostled with Miranda until they were both on the step together. An inside door creaked and a broad silhouette filled the door glass. The front door swung in and Geena's puffy face filled the frame. His heart almost skipped a beat.

“Alright, pudgy? Put kettle on, I'm parched.”

A smile erupted across Geena's face. "Blimey, Ajit'll bloody wet himself — you should have warned us. Get in then. And who's this lass — surely not the famous Miranda?" She grabbed hold of Miranda as if she were a long-lost relative. "Come on in, love. Thomas can fetch bags and make the tea while we sit and talk about him."

He followed them inside, pleased and disturbed in equal measure. First thing he did, after closing the door, was draw the curtains in the front room. Miranda took her cue and removed the wig and glasses.

"Going on to a fancy dress party?" Geena laughed, taking Miranda's coat.

"Long story," she replied, making a time-out letter 'T' at him with her fingers.

He searched around the kitchen manfully, determined not to ask for clues. In any case, the chatter and laughter filtering through told him he'd get no assistance. He grabbed three mugs of tea, and choccy biscuits from a drawer, and took them through.

Geena invited Miranda to feel the baby kick and for an instant the laughter stopped. Miranda's face froze and her hand went tentatively to Geena's bulge. Her hand moulded around it gently and Miranda closed her eyes. Then she flinched at the kick and when she opened her eyes, she was a different person. Wistful, maybe. Whatever it was, he didn't know quite how to deal with it. She popped a compact mirror and checked her make-up. He knew she was dabbing her eye and he knew her well enough not to draw attention to it.

The tea was drunk in near silence until Geena finally broke the deadlock.

"Can I ring him, please? Go on, I'll put it on t'loudspeaker."

He relented and they crowded around the phone, which was no mean feat given the size of Geena.

"What're you doing ringing me on duty? I'll be done in an hour."

The speaker also did a neat job of picking up Ajit's colleague's pissing. Geena put on her best simpering tone.

"I just needed to hear your voice."

"Nothing's wrong is it?"

Thomas could almost hear the sweat running down Ajit's forehead.

“No, calm down, lover boy. Just pick up a takeaway for *four* on your way home — we’ve got guests.”

Thomas couldn’t hold back. “And don’t be a mean bugger with the pakoras.”

“Blimey, is that Thomas Bladen, photographer to the stars?”

“The very same. See you soon.”

Ajit rang off and Thomas went back to his seat.

“Okay.” Geena bit into a chocolate biscuit. “Why *are* you up here?”

The notion that his friends could be just as suspicious as he was had never really crossed Thomas’s mind. Miranda, too, was looking straight at him now. Whatever he said would reach Ajit, which might implicate the good constable. So he settled for a sliver of the truth. “I can’t tell you. And besides, it’s better for you if you don’t know.”

Geena’s face lost a whole lot of its welcome. Miranda diverted her, asking about baby names and life *oop north*. He followed Miranda’s lead and made another brew to keep the conversation flowing and pass the time.

* * *

Ajit clanged the gate shut, whistling ‘London Bridge is Falling Down.’ Thomas itched to get to the door before the key was in place. But he sat still, sensing the smile spreading across his face like a sunrise.

The door slammed. Geena muttered to Miranda about the paintwork. The tune, if you could call it that, continued through to the kitchen. Thomas shifted forward in his chair. Footsteps thudded in the hall and the door handle slowly turned. Then Ajit squeezed through the doorframe.

“Ta da!” First thing he did was go over to Miranda and offer his arms. “Come on, then, up you get — let’s have a look at yer.” He swallowed her in a bear hug and lifted her round to one side. “Oh, you’ve brought a friend. It’s, er, Thomas, isn’t it?”

“Dick.”

Once Ajit had put Miranda down, he and Thomas did a hearty round of bloke slaps until Geena cleared her throat.

“Ere, you big lump. Remember me — mother of your unborn . . .”

Ajit nipped outside the door and returned with a bunch of flowers and a box of chocolates.

“Ah bless, he’s well trained now.” Geena turned to Miranda. “It can be done.”

They ate in the kitchen. Thomas and Miranda split a beer between them. Ajit and Geena stuck to orange juice. It must be strange for Miranda, Thomas thought. Okay, so he talked about Ajit now and again, but the last time she saw them — barring their one weekend in London — was years back.

Geena broke off from an assault on her lamb bhuna. “So, are you two like, back together?”

Ajit gave a nudge under the table, like a mini earthquake.

“What? Are we not allowed to mention it or something?”

Thomas was still peeved about the train journey so he said nothing and raised his eyebrows at Miranda. She looked straight at him then to Geena.

“I’m still in the fourteen days cooling-off period; I haven’t made my mind up yet.”

Geena laughed so hard that she needed a sip of orange juice, which didn’t help her any. While Thomas, he just felt very small indeed. And at that moment, he envied the life that Ajit and Geena had — the certainty and stability, even allowing for Ajit’s terrified anticipation of parenthood. As for himself, he didn’t know what he wanted.

“Hello, Thomas? Are you still with us?” Ajit’s voice broke through.

“Yeah,” he blinked at a soggy piece of naan bread in his hand. “I reckon we should make tracks soon, Miranda.” *And now for the tricky part.* “I’ll ring Pat and see if you can stay there tonight; I’ll go to Mum and Dad’s.”

She nodded slowly, as if she’d been expecting this. Ajit raised a hand.

“Don’t be a silly beggar — you’re both stopping here with us.” Ajit and Geena joined hands in a show of solidarity; it hurt Thomas to disappoint them.

“Nah, that’s okay. I sort of arranged it earlier.” It was a shit lie and even Miranda’s little supporting smile didn’t make the pill any less bitter.

When he rang her, Pat was happy to oblige, even if her part-time husband Gordon was complaining in the background. But bollocks to him.

“Miranda, time to get your gear back on.”

Ajit drove them over to Thomas’s parents, taking the scenic route. On his own, Ajit sounded more like a police officer and less like a friend. “I’m

not stupid. We don't see you for yonks and then twice in three months. I take it this is work-related again?"

Thomas shrugged. Miranda stayed quiet in the backseat.

"Well, if you need me, you know where I am."

"Yeah, Thomas brightened. "Under Geena's thumb, as usual."

Ajit gave Thomas a playful shove that nearly dented the passenger door from the inside. Pat was already waiting at the drop-off around the corner from their mum and dad's. She looked more agitated than before. Ajit waved from the car as he pulled away and Thomas pondered what might have been if Ajit and Pat had gone through with the teenage thing and made a go of it together. His dad would have really loved that — a copper in the family.

"Gordon's looking after the kids."

That's big of him, considering they're his too.

"Are you gonna tell me what the glasses and the wig is all about? You know mam and dad are gonna ask."

"Not if you let us in with your key, first."

* * *

"Only me!" Pat giggled, quietly ushering Miranda and Thomas in the door.

As soon as she was inside, Miranda took off her accessories and shoved them in her coat pocket. Then she grabbed Thomas's hand.

"Ready?" he whispered and kissed her softly, tasting the spices on her lips.

Pat blushed and eased the door in from the hall. "I, er, found a stranger outside so I thought I'd bring him in."

Their father rose from his chair. "If it's another bloody charity collector they can go wanting. Honestly, Pat!"

Thomas went in first, Miranda's hand still in his. He watched while his father's face changed as he looked from him to Miranda.

"Hello, Dad. You remember Miranda."

His mother poked her head out of the kitchen door and for a moment there was silence. Pat came in and stood beside Miranda. Thomas thought they looked like bodyguards and maybe that wasn't such a bad comparison. You could have heard a pin drop, in sand.

“You both look very smart.” Thomas’s mother noted, collecting a teacup from the mantelpiece.

“We’ve been to a funeral today, in London.” He stared his dad down: *your move*.

Mam made a break for the kitchen with Pat in tow. Thomas could hardly blame them. Thomas’s dad sighed and folded up his newspaper.

“I’ll go first, shall I?” Miranda’s voice was like a chisel against mahogany. “We had a very pleasant journey, thank you.”

Bladen senior scratched at his chin then his eyes crinkled at the edges. “I’ll say this for thee, you’ve got some spirit about you — not like him, stood there like a wet weekend.”

Thomas willingly accepted the role of fall guy in order to keep the peace.

“So, are you alright now then, lass? I presume you’re speaking to him again.”

He winced, thinking back to the aftermath of the moors incident, when Miranda would have nothing to do with him. He didn’t need reminding about it now.

Pat called out from the kitchen, asking if Miranda took sugar. Thomas quickly replied on her behalf, just to have the chance to say something that couldn’t start an argument. Tea, cake and north-south prejudice — Yorkshire hospitality at its finest. In this house, no one asked what they were doing in Pickering.

He bore the tension as long as he could, then cast a pointed glance at his sister. Pat launched out of her chair and announced that she and Miranda were making tracks. Miranda didn’t offer any objection as she got to her feet — lucky cow. She said her goodbyes, complimented his mum on her cake and generally behaved like the perfect guest. He saw her to the front door, making sure her disguise was on properly before she left.

There were maybe a dozen steps back to the front room and every one was laden with expectation and disappointment. It was like returning to the headmaster’s study.

“So, how have you both been?” he said.

His parents were squeezed in together on the settee; they looked small and vulnerable. His mother stirred her tea carefully. “Should I make your bed up for tonight?”

He nodded and took up a position alongside them. The TV came on and all hostilities were suspended. He wasn't big on television, but he was happy to embrace the local news and a charming story about a school choir. Eventually, his dad began to pass comment. A few nods and murmurs from Thomas and soon all embassies were on speaking terms again.

When his mum slipped upstairs to sort out the bedclothes, Thomas's dad looked at the closed door.

"So," he turned back to the TV, "everything alright at work?"

"Aye, pretty much. We 'appened to be in the area so we thought we'd pop in." It was neat, connecting the visit to his job, just by association.

"Got summat to show you," his dad stood a little shakily and opened a sideboard drawer. He drew out an envelope, passed it across then lowered himself down to the cushion. Inside the envelope was a set of photographs of garden birds.

"Finches come regular now I've started putting out the right food."

"And what about that whippet you were talking about?"

"Aye, well, mebbe once my leg's back in shape."

Photography had been the one thing they'd had in common while Thomas was growing up. Even after he'd been thrown out and had moved down to Leeds, he could usually count on a friendly reception if he had a camera or prints in his hand. Ironical that photography had brought him into the government job that he knew his father despised.

He turned in at nine o'clock and gave Miranda a call to see if her attempts at happy families had gone any better than his. She said he had a wonderful nephew and niece and it was a shame that he never saw them. And she volunteered that Pat's husband Gordon looked shifty. Ten points for that alone. And just when he thought Miranda was happy to follow his lead, she turned everything on its head.

"If they've tracked us to Yorkshire — and they'd have to be stupid not to — then what happens next?"

He hadn't figured on Miranda needing to know, or on wanting to tell her. "I'll ring you back in a bit."

"Take your time," she said. "I've got a bedtime story to read first."

Downstairs he could hear Ma and Pa talking about him. She was worried and he was reminding her that Thomas was a grown man and could look after himself.

He rang Karl to swap updates and funny stories. Karl got in there first.

“I’ve heard of a wedding crasher, but never a funeral one. Honest to God, I leave you alone for five minutes and suddenly it’s bedlam. How’s life up North?”

It seemed that everyone knew where he’d headed. “You tell me.”

“Well, I happen to have a little inside information. Jess has been reported as a vulnerable missing person — by the family she doesn’t have anything to do with.”

He felt his spirits flagging as the call went on. “How long have I got, Karl? The morning, really? No, I’ll sit tight and wait it out — might warn Miranda though.” But not Pat, not if he wanted a little authenticity.

He gave and got what he needed to, then cut the call. He sat in his old room, gazing up at the cross on the wall. Did his mother still feel the Good Lord was watching over them? Forgive us our trespasses and all that? He was a fine one to talk. He was using his family — all of them — in order to give Jess a head start. He lay on top of the bed, unable to settle. What if Ajit was doing the knock in the morning? Would Ajit be tempted to alert him beforehand? Not if he ever wanted his stripes.

He had to think long and hard about what to say to Miranda before he dared pick up the phone again. She listened calmly, taking it all in her stride. If anything, it made him feel even more wretched.

“And you’re not angry or anything?”

“Aw, Thomas, I didn’t think I was coming up here on a fancy-dress holiday. I knew you were up to something. And besides, I’ve just read *Little Red Riding Hood* to the kiddies so I know all about big . . . bad . . . wolves, like you.” Fairy stories had never sounded sexier.

“I, er, don’t know exactly how it’ll go down tomorrow. Sorry and all that.”

“Get some sleep. I’ll see you in the morning. And listen, about earlier, on the train. I know how you get, after funerals. I promise we’ll talk, when we get back to London.”

A flash of memory lit up his brain. That was how he’d come to propose, the first time — after her nanna’s funeral. Blimey, she knew him so well it was frightening.

He fell asleep easily, perhaps a little too easily. Karl had once told him that when you no longer had doubts, or a conscience, it was time to give it

all up. Easy words for the Celtic Avenger. As for Thomas, he wasn't sure if he was numb to the repercussions or just fixated on getting justice for Amy, even if that meant helping out Jess in the process.

Chapter 23

By the time his alarm bleeped at six thirty, he'd been awake for at least half an hour. At seven o'clock, the house began to stir so he showered and made sure his bag was packed; he had a feeling he wouldn't be there for much longer.

The call came through just before eight. Pat was frantic, screaming about the police hammering on her front door and scaring the kids, and all the neighbours watching from the street. After a quick shouting match with his dad, he took the receiver, tried to soothe her and promised he'd come straight over. His father looked daggers at him.

"Is this your doing? I might've known you'd bring trouble up here — again."

His mother peered out from the kitchen but didn't say a word.

"If you've got Pat into difficulty, don't bother coming back here. I mean it."

He grabbed his bag and headed for the door. A burly policeman was already heading up the path; it was Ajit, accompanied by a colleague.

"Thomas Bladen? I have reason to believe you may be harbouring a vulnerable missing person against their will, in contravention of . . ."

Thomas tuned it out and glanced behind him. "She's not here."

Ajit pushed past. Thomas was led away before Ajit went inside, but it was a cert it wouldn't be pretty. By the time they got round to Pat's, a few streets away, a female officer was leading Miranda away to a police car. Thomas was kept in the car behind and the whole circus started to wind down. As they drove away, he saw Pat's haunted face staring out, and he knew that he'd crossed a line.

* * *

He didn't see Ajit again at the police station — probably just as well. Not much to be said, under the circumstances. He wondered if Ajit had known about it the previous night, but that seemed unlikely. And besides, wouldn't he have coughed up the truth about Thomas's companion? Something else best not thought about.

He saw Miranda at the far end of a corridor, being buzzed in for processing. She was holding it together well. With a family like hers, they'd probably been drilled on police procedure from a young age. When the desk was clear, he was moved forward to take his turn. He kept to the script and gave his details in a monotone, wondering how long it would take for the misidentification to get back to Schaefer and Sir Peter Carroll. Well, nothing he could do about it now.

A sergeant took the lead, funnelling him into an interview room where the décor screamed 1980s, but without the feel-good factor.

"Tea or coffee?" The sergeant made it sound like he'd make it his personal business to add the phlegm.

"Coffee, please." No point being an arse about it. They were doing their job and so was he. The drink arrived pronto, along with a constable.

"Reet, can we get down to business? You're not under arrest — you're just helping us with a few inquiries. Clearing up a few anomalies, as you might say."

Like why were the police asked to check on a missing person, only to find that the person they had identified was somebody else? And in what way couldn't this be construed as wasting police time?

He breathed in the aroma of vending machine coffee, with a delicate hint of cream substitute and artificial sweetener. His thinking went like this: Miranda could be counted on to say nothing, which could complicate things further down the line. What he needed was a ready-made get-out-of-jail-free card.

"You're one of them *floaters*, aren't you? Surveillance Support Unit." The way the copper said it, it sounded like a grave insult.

He smiled to acknowledge the point and took a chance. "If I can make a phone call, I can straighten this out." He sat back and tried to look comfortable with his situation, diverting his attention to a rabies poster on the wall while the sergeant made up his mind.

A minute later and he was in the room on his own. He fetched out his mobile and rang Whitehall. The switchboard operator took his name and request, and transferred him straight through.

"Thomas!" Sir Peter's voice was frosty. "Where on earth are you — we've been worried."

Yeah, so worried that you had the police pick me up. He gritted his teeth and danced for the piper. “I’m in Yorkshire, helping police with their inquiries. I understand that Jess has disappeared. I need a favour from you.”

Sir Peter Carroll didn’t sound too convinced, so Thomas went for broke. “I can either ask nicely or get Karl to make you help me.”

It was a low blow, but as Sir Peter was in Karl’s debt, it did the trick. “What exactly do you need?”

Half an hour later, a fax arrived at the police station, confirming that Thomas Bladen was in Yorkshire on assignment and that one Miranda Wright was accompanying him. Further, that under Section 6 of the Official Secrets Act 1989, this matter could not be discussed or elaborated upon.

Miranda was waiting at the front desk; she wasn’t wearing her blonde wig anymore. He wondered what the first officer on the scene must have thought when she removed the blonde wig to reveal her own blonde hair. They must have thought she was taking the piss. She gazed at him blankly, as if she couldn’t quite fathom what she was doing there. They signed the book and headed for the door.

“Did they explain about the fax? I got a photocopy for the family . . .”

She shook her head in disgust. “What are they supposed to do, frame it?” Then she stopped abruptly.

A few paces ahead of them, Ajit was waiting. Miranda flew at him.

“Some fucking friend you are! Then again, maybe you deserve each other — you both put the job before other people.” She walked a little way up the road.

Ajit opened his great arms wide. “Look, Thomas, I couldn’t . . . I were just doing my job.”

“I know.” Thomas settled him. “I’d have done exactly the same.” Except they both knew that he wouldn’t have. “Look, Aj, we’re gonna push off — made enough friends for one visit. Will you see that my dad gets this photocopy — should help to smooth the waters.”

“What about saying goodbye to Geena?”

“Not this time, mate. Look, I can’t stop. We’ve got a bus to catch for York.”

And there it was. Somehow Jess and this poxy job had turned him into a Judas, betraying everyone for the greater good. *Greater good* — he was starting to sound like Karl.

He managed a proper buddies' handshake and promised to ring Ajit later in the week. When he caught up with Miranda she was smiling.

"I deserved a Oscar, back there."

He looked at her, incredulous.

"Ajit'll get over it and I can always ring Geena and explain."

"Come again?"

"Oh, didn't I mention she gave me her phone number while you were our tea boy? She felt we ought to get to know each other, especially after all this time."

His brain was spinning out of gear. "Then what . . ."

She cut across him. "Dad rang. The Irish blokes have agreed to see him about Karl. They're flying in tonight."

Chapter 24

The train journey was long and Thomas's brain was still buzzing. If he could just sort out Karl's problem and get him to his mother before the inevitable . . .

Miranda didn't have a lot to say. Then she spent so long getting the coffees, he began to wonder if she'd changed seats and hadn't bothered to tell him.

"Long queue?" he tried to make it sound funny — the *ha ha* kind.

"Not exactly," her face dropped an inch.

He went through a list in his head, just to check he wasn't in the doghouse again. Nothing stuck so he waited it out.

"I've something to tell you and I'm not sure you're gonna like it . . ."

"Let me guess — Jess snogged you as well?"

But Miranda wasn't smiling. She took a long sip of coffee and sighed, watching him over the cup. He'd done the open comms course, so he knew that guarding the mouth when speaking was more than a little suss.

"Look, whatever it is, I'm fine with it. Honestly."

"You won't be." She put her coffee cup down, but wasn't finished toying with her face. "Remember the money, after the moors . . ."

She flinched at the mention of the subject. Of course he remembered: forty thousand pounds, extracted from Sir Peter Carroll as compensation for Miranda's abduction and his complicity in the clean-up. Danger money, Karl called it. Miranda had been less generous: *blood money*.

"Well . . ." she took a huge gulp of air and let her hands fall away, "the two *Micks* like to play cards, so we're using half of that as stake money."

He didn't know what to say. Half of him wanted to scream at her for what she was proposing; the other half was overwhelmed that she and her family would do all that for Karl. So he leaned across the table carefully, cupped her face and kissed her, long and hard.

She filled him in on the mobile call she'd had during her visit to the buffet car. Martin and Francis-Andrew would be arriving at Caliban's at eight o'clock. The place would be shut for a *private function*. John Wright

had gone to elaborate lengths to set the deal up with the help of an old family friend and former business associate.

"I don't think Mum and Dad have ever mentioned Jack Langton to you?"

He sat very still and stared at her, looking for clues. Jack Langton's name had never come up in over ten years. Miranda swallowed softly, blinking as she broke off eye contact.

"Jack's a person who can fix things — he's well-connected." There was pride in her voice and he felt a pang of jealousy. Most importantly, she insisted, Karl needed to be there and at his servile best.

"No problem, I can pick him up and . . ."

Miranda made a face. "Yeah, that's the thing. Mum and Dad think it's best if you're not there. It's just, you know, they want to keep you out of that side of their life. Mum reckons it's better for you too."

He picked at the coffee cup lid and pulled a piece off the rim.

"I said you wouldn't like it."

Ten out of ten. It was stupid. He knew without question that they were protecting him, but even so. Everyone was taking a risk for Karl, and somehow he was excused, like a kid with a note.

"Well at least let me bug the place, in case anything goes wrong."

"Dad and Karl reckon they might check, if they're as hard core as they're made out to be."

He nodded. He felt like a dog put in kennels while the family went off for the summer.

"Honestly, Thomas, it'll be fine. They'll play some cards, Sheryl will serve some drinks in a sexy number and—"

"So Sheryl's going to be there as well."

And then a terrible thought crossed his mind. That perhaps they all felt he simply wasn't up to it. Worse, maybe they had a point. He didn't speak again until Peterborough — spending his time doodling in a notepad and avoiding eye contact.

It never seemed to balance out, not really. Either work was fine and his private life was in ruins or it was the other way round. Or, like now, it had all gone to shit across the board. When did it all get this complicated? He became aware that he was dragging the same line back and forth across the page. When? The day he joined Sir Peter Carroll's merry men and didn't

tell Miranda or her family? No, scratch that. It had all started to go sour the day he stumbled behind the façade of the Surveillance Support Unit and got involved in Karl's counter-intelligence games. But the truth was that he loved it, sort of. Stopping the bad guys, like every schoolboy's heroic fantasy. Except the bad guys were real. They deceived, they punished and they killed.

He looked at the page again. He'd drawn a stick-figure girl with a halo above her head. Amy, obviously — Major Eldridge's *Angel*. He was no closer to finding out why she'd died. He tapped the page. When he got home he'd make sure to check the recordings from the bugs in the major's office — both of them; the device that Michael Schaefer knew about and the other one on the second phone. At least he could put his isolation to good use. For some reason, that thought cheered him.

"Penny for 'em?" Miranda called across the table. "You just smiled."

"Just planning my dinner for one for tonight."

"When will you get it into your thick 'ead? Mum and Dad are only thinking of you. Karl's bollocksed without the help of the Micks, and you're well out of it."

"Fine." He tried not to sulk. "I think I'll see Karl before tonight though, just for a quick chat."

Miranda gave him her world-weary look, the one that usually meant surrender. "If you must. He'll be at Mum and Dad's — I s'pose you can come back with me, then Terry can run you home."

Jesus. Why not give Karl a bloody door key and have done with it?

* * *

King's Cross was hassle-free, once you accepted the milling crowds and that indefinable odour of too many people with too little hygiene. He half-expected Sam or Terry to be waiting at the barrier, ready to whisk Miranda away from him. The only thing that greeted him was a sense of familiarity. Yorkshire born, but taken in by London; and as foster mothers went, he had no complaints.

They settled down on the Tube He wondered again why the family chose to live just over the border in Essex if they were so proud of their East End roots. Just something else to chew over while avoiding the real issue. Karl and the Wrights were the only people he had any connection

with in London. Not counting Christine Gerrard, who was not only an ex but also the boss, so she was doubly verboten. Tonight's pow-wow felt like a party all your mates were attending that you weren't invited to.

As they waited together for a cab at Dagenham, he sat and read his book, just to piss her off. Petty victories, and all that.

By the looks of things, Karl had made himself pretty comfortable. He didn't stir from his armchair when Thomas entered the room. Miranda wandered off and then, as if by magic, the rest of the Wright clan made themselves scarce until it was just Thomas and Karl.

"Listen, Tommo, I can't thank you enough for this. I mean, if it wasn't for you—"

No, this was too much. "I just spoke to John — he did the rest."

"Well," Karl's face was rosy red now; "that's not how I heard it. And I've no issue with having to scratch somebody else's back in return."

"Come again?" And then the fog started to clear. John helps Karl and Karl owes him, or *someone*.

Chapter 25

At seven o'clock Thomas was sat in his flat, staring at the phone. Neither Karl nor Miranda was likely to ring and say that the Irish fellers had arrived. No, but he wished they would. It wasn't just jealousy, although that figured high in the list; he was also worried about Karl meeting his nemesis after so many years.

Fish-and-chips was keeping warm in the oven and the peas were simmering on the hob. A nature programme he'd recorded was lined up, ready to go. And part of his brain was still doing conjuring tricks. He went to the drawer and pulled out copies of the letters Karl had found hidden in Jess's flat — the letters from Major Eldridge. He took them with him into the kitchen, and carried them back through with the food.

He remembered how, after the big break-up with Miranda, he'd re-read all her letters relentlessly. Even now, he still had them filed away in a box, in chronological order. As well as every Christmas and birthday card she'd ever sent him. Jess seemed that type as well, meticulous, in her way. Except Karl had only found two letters. Surely the good major would have had more to say? He stared at the pages — there must be something useful in them.

After settling to his food, he unpaused David Attenborough and let him go play in the trees with a capuchin monkey. Thomas smiled; his immediate thought was *cappuccino* — the joys of word association. Then, as he went in deep on the vinegar-soaked chips and started coughing, he had a thought. Major Eldridge had signed his letters Cupid: 'C' for both Charles and Cecil, and for Cupid. There was a sense and rhythm to it.

He put his cutlery down for a moment, just as two monkeys got busy with the loving — not so good when you're eating. He dug out another page from the drawer, the sheet where he'd splurged out his conclusions about Amy and Jess. A is for Amy and Angel; there in black and white. He paused the TV and stared out beyond it, as his dinner cooled. If Amy had been the one having the affair, as they'd surmised, a few things made sense — Jess's indifference to Amy's memory, the major's indifference to Jess and his insistence on having the letters back. Plus, no envelope because Jess

just didn't have it. Maybe she'd lifted the two letters from Amy's locker and they were the only ones there.

So far, so what? Nothing concrete, short of proving Jess to be a fantasist, especially after what Schaefer said about her and Oxford. The room temperature seemed to lower a couple of notches at his next piece of speculation. Supposing Amy's death hadn't been an accident at all? He whistled a breath. Jesus, what if he and Miranda had been protecting a murderer? Or an attention-seeking saboteur who'd gone too far?

He grabbed the phone. Outside of the high stakes card game, he did have one other contact in London — Petrov, half-brother of Yorgi, the deceased assassin. The only person he could think to entrust Jess to, before he and Miranda hightailed it to Yorkshire, was Petrov, because Petrov owed him big-time.

Petrov picked up first ring. He sounded a little guarded, even after Thomas identified himself.

"It is always good to hear your voice, Tomas. But your friend, I think she is not so good."

He felt his shoulders tense. "I hope Jess isn't causing you any problems."

Petrov drew a breath. "She had an argument on her mobile — shouting very bad things — threatening someone. Then I get a telephone call from an angry man."

He put a hand to his forehead; he could guess the rest. "Do you know who he was?" A part of him was already planning out a route and wondering whether to go prepared.

"He didn't give his name, but when he arrived here . . ."

Arrived there?

"Your friend, Jess, seemed very pleased to see him. I asked her not to go and she said that she is not a prisoner and I am not her keeper. So this, this *Cecil*, he collect her and her things, and I don't expect to see her again."

"I'm sorry, Petrov. I didn't mean to cause you and your family any trouble."

"You are a good man, Tomas, but your work is not good. Do not bring it into my life again." Which sounded rich, coming from a man who had once needed his help so badly.

Thomas ended the conversation, then sent a text to Miranda — *Jess missing again. Get Karl to ring me asap* — and went to his laptop. Clever Karl, fitting a tracker in the heel of Jess's shoe before Amy's memorial service. As long as she had her case nearby — and according to Petrov, everything went with her — he could trace her.

He logged on to an anonymising server and keyed in the appropriate URL. Then he entered the twelve-character reference for the bug and waited while the map loaded. Karl's bug was a high spec device, emitting a GPS pulse about every minute. Better, he could call up any time once the bug was fitted. The first place Jess had stopped after leaving Petrov's house was her own flat — with Major Eldridge doing the driving no doubt.

Thomas closed his eyes and tried to think through the logic. Jess already had her passport and bank cards, and clearly she hadn't stayed at the flat, so what was she there for, for almost ten minutes? Major Eldridge's letters perhaps — why else would he be helping her? Yeah, but in exchange for what — safe passage? How could the major protect Jess from Michael Schaefer and Engamel?

Well, maybe he could ask them himself if he shifted his arse. He printed the map for the last known coordinates and went to his darkroom. Unlocking the door, he reached below the shelf, through the cloth curtain and behind the chemical bottles. The tiny strongbox felt cold to the touch. He carefully lifted it out and produced the key. The small Makarov pistol gleamed under the red light, like a warning.

He was almost out the door when his mobile rang — it was Miranda.

"Is everything okay?" She was whispering. "I can't talk long — I'm in the loo."

"Never mind me," he recovered. "What about your end of things?"

"We're down about ten grand, but it looks like being a long night. I'll make sure Karl rings as soon as he can." There was the sound of a toilet flushing and then the line cut out.

* * *

Thomas talked to himself as he drove, offering up possibilities and explanations then dismissing them without charge. Was Jess in any danger? Maybe, but it was the major who really needed protecting — from her.

He zeroed in on Euston, negotiating a succession of temporary traffic lights and diversions to skirt around some roadworks trenches. As the engine shuddered to a stop, he pondered his next move. There were three options on the table. He could just try the last location and hope they hadn't moved since he'd left the flat; he could ring up Ann Crossley at home, and give her the log-in details; or, because he still had the number he'd filched from the mobile that he'd given Jess, he could ring Major Eldridge's personal mobile. In the end, he decided to go for all three.

Ann Crossley — as he had expected — had put her work phone on divert. She was professional, but coy, when he gave her the standard 'I hope I wasn't disturbing your evening?' Nope, Ann didn't seem to do casual, even after hours.

"How can I help you, Thomas?"

He cut to the chase, told her what he wanted to know and recited the details. It didn't surprise him that her laptop was switched on and by her side. Within a minute, she told him what he needed to know. Jess — or at least, her shoes — were in a large hotel, not far from the pub he had tracked them to before leaving home.

* * *

He entered the lobby, smiled at the row of understimulated receptionists and made himself comfy on a sofa, as if waiting for someone. In the bar area, a mixture of tourists and low-budget execs were glued to a footie match on a big screen TV. Lucky sods; he envied them, even though he didn't much like pubs, or football, or drinking.

Short of going up to the desk and demanding the room number, he'd have to ring the major's mobile. He waited another couple of minutes, trying to put together a meaningful sentence in his head. Then he was ready.

"Cecil Eldridge?" the major didn't sound too sure of himself.

"It's Thomas Bladen. I think we need to have a chat — and Jess too."

There was a pregnant pause then the major took in a rush of air. "I owe you an explanation; I've removed Jess from the safe house where you installed her."

Thomas waited, piling on the pressure through the gift of silence.

"Where can I meet you, Thomas?"

"I'm downstairs, in the lobby."

Another pause, while the major presumably tried to figure out his next move.

“I’ve come alone,” Thomas threw him a lifeline. “I just want to talk; with you, first, and then the three of us. After that I’m out of here and you can do what you like.”

The line went muffled then became as clear as a bell. “I’ll be down in five minutes — stay put.”

He watched the clocks inch round, over several time zones at once. Of course, he could have been barking up the wrong tree entirely. Maybe the two of them upstairs *were* a couple after all, and the major was searching for his trousers. Nah, it didn’t scan right, whichever way he looked at it. More likely, what they were doing up there was getting their stories straight.

A minute past meltdown, when Thomas was considering taking his pistol on a house call, the lift door pinged open. Major Eldridge looked a little sheepish, but not flustered enough to have been on manoeuvres with Jess. He blushed when Thomas met his eyes, then stiffened as he walked over, like a man facing the firing squad.

“How about a drink?” Thomas greeted him. No sense condemning the bloke out of hand. What evidence did he have, anyway?

“Scotch and soda, thank you.”

Thomas took the hint, and adopted the role of butler. They managed to find a table away from the bar and not too close to the doors that opened automatically for no reason at all.

“Shall I go first?” Thomas didn’t waste any time; the major tasted his drink and sat there. Time to go fishing. “You were involved with Amy, not Jess. And you’ve been trying to get back some personal letters that Jess took from her. That’s your business. But removing Jess from a secure location puts her at risk *and* the family.” He spoke slowly and deliberately, to keep the emotion out of his voice.

“You don’t understand.”

Thomas rolled his eyes. “Please spare me the two lonely people bollocks — I’m not interested. You chose to drag Karl and me into this. And now you’ve put Jess out in the open again, just to get some love letters back.”

The major smiled, but it was a tired smile, tinged with self-pity. “Look, Thomas, I’m not perfect and whatever you might think, we were in love. I know, a man of my age with Amy — it sounds preposterous.”

Thomas nodded; at least he’d confirmed the lucky winner of the major’s affections.

“I would have given it all up for her, you know — wife, career. But, with the way things have turned out . . .” he throttled the glass and took a sip, “. . . what sense is there in sacrificing anything now?”

What sense indeed? Thomas gulped at his shandy and said nothing.

“You really don’t get it, do you?” Pity had hardened to scorn. “Michael Schaefer would like Jess’s head on a plate — I’m trying to broker a compromise.”

“Out of the goodness of your heart, I suppose?”

The major shook his head and sneered. “I have my letters now — it’s in everyone’s interests if the test data can be properly analysed.”

Thomas put his glass down. “The data Jess keeps in her head.”

The major tilted his head. “Karl said you were sharp.”

When was that? “So, what, you arrange a deal for Jess in return for the data and she walks off into the sunset?”

“My dear Thomas, you’re miles from the truth. Jess wants to provide the missing data in return for safe passage . . .” he stroked his neck, “. . . to America, working for one of Engamel’s consortium partners. Someone like Jess has a bright future over there.”

Thomas blinked a couple of times. He felt like he’d bought a cinema ticket and walked in on the wrong screening. “What about the cause of the accident?”

The major seemed to gaze across the lobby, lost in thought. “That’s what we need the data for. Schaefer has most of it and Jess has the rest.”

Thomas still wasn’t getting it. “And you expect Schaefer to share nicely with you once he’s got what he wants?”

“It’s that or I use the footage you and Karl took — my extra copy, I mean.”

Thomas swallowed. “You bastard — you’ll implicate the SSU, especially me and Karl.”

“Collateral damage, Thomas — unavoidable.”

Now he understood why Sir Peter Carroll was prepared to bug the major's phone — no one could trust anybody. He felt like doing a little collateral damage himself and then he remembered Jess upstairs. "And what if the cause of the accident wasn't purely mechanical?" he glanced to the lift.

"Then I'll make sure everyone responsible pays the price."

* * *

The major seemed content to stay there. In any case, Thomas was in no mood for a debate. He stood in the lift, as the doors closed, watching the major head off towards the bar.

The muzak to the sixth floor seemed the perfect accompaniment to his mood — something that appeared to be one thing, but was actually nothing of the kind. He half expected Jess to be at the lifts, but the doors opened to nobody at all, just a disused ashtray beneath a No Smoking sign, as if it was a dare.

He swung the double doors, *High Noon* style, and counted the room numbers along to room 685. There was no light visible beneath the door. He rapped hard and called out his name. Jess mumbled something and he went inside.

The bedside lamp was on, and Jess was in bed. He stayed by the door and stared, lost for words. Did she really think he was still buying her and the major as a double act? Jess began to ease out of the sheets, to reach for her underwear near the bed. She paused, to check he was still watching her.

"Get dressed," he turned to leave. "I'll be by the lift." *Un-fucking-believable*. Literally, in this case.

The minutes ticked by, as he waited. He found he was gripping his gun and entertaining dark flights of fantasy. Consistent to the last, Jess put on an Oscar-winning performance as she arrived, her eyes bloodshot as if she'd been crying. Then again, maybe she had: out of shame.

They rode the lift down with only the muzak between them. It seemed to him that Jess had the kind of issues that even Miranda's magazines would refer to a specialist. Had Jess wanted to *become* Amy? He tossed the idea around in his head. And was that reason enough to kill her?

The major had settled himself with his two new friends, Mr Soda and Mr Scotch. He looked comfortably maudlin. Jess's appearance didn't seem

to lighten his mood any. Thomas took a fresh order for drinks and left the two of them alone.

As he waited at the bar to be served, briefly mesmerised by a mid-week European match, he tried to plan his next move. What was his objective here?

Prevent Karl and him from being set up as the fall guys.

Find out why Amy died.

End this bloody assignment ASAP.

So, basically, he needed to get onside with Major Eldridge, while remaining onside with Engamel. As for Jess, the sooner she made it to the US of A, the better for everyone.

A bartender dawdled across to him. She had a face that suggested her name badge, *Bonnie*, had been an ironic afterthought. That, or the weight of it was dragging down the corners of her mouth. Once she'd registered eye contact, she flashed a smile as plastic as the décor and set her training in motion. She filled a tray with three glasses and a packet of crisps; he added a tip out of sympathy — for the customers to follow him. Then it was back to the other two musketeers.

The three of them drank quietly. Thomas didn't share the crisps — he felt they didn't deserve them.

"When are you seeing Michael Schaefer?" he looked the major in the face — no sense beating around the bush anymore.

"Tomorrow morning. Until I get his agreement, Jess will stay here, out of harm's way. You're the only other person who knows she's here, Thomas."

That sounded like a loaded statement. He thought about Ann Crossley knowing, and probably Miranda and Karl before the night was out, and mustered his best poker face.

Jess came to life. "Maybe Thomas should stay here with me, just in case?"

Her still-moist eyes reminded him of an anime cartoon. For a moment he thought he could hear the opening bars to *The Twilight Zone*, playing in the distance.

"That's not going to happen." He didn't bother to look in Jess's direction, but he figured she was pouting.

The major walked Jess back up to her room. Thomas was still finding gaps to fill. Why Amy was testing part of the weapon's mechanism on her own, if that wasn't the normal procedure? And where had Jess been when the *accident* occurred? Too many questions and now he was down to the crispy crumbs.

The major looked much more relaxed when he returned to finish his drink.

"Do you think she's a killer, Major?" In terms of subtlety, it was right up there with: 'Shall I take my Viagra now?' But Thomas was past caring. He figured he and the major were both on the same fishing trip.

"I think it unlikely that she's responsible, but she's very evasive."

Thomas squeezed the last dregs of shandy from his glass. "Do you want me to come with you tomorrow, to see Schaefer at Engamel?"

The major paused to consider the offer, probably out of politeness. "No, that won't be necessary. But thank you."

Drinks over, conversation exhausted, time for beddy-byes. He walked to the sliding doors. "Can I give you a lift somewhere?" *Like maybe home to your wife?*

A shake of the head was enough to send him on his way. It could be that the major planned to double back and have one last chat with Jess. Not his problem, Thomas decided; he had other matters to attend to.

* * *

As he stepped back onto Euston Road, a bus trundled past — a portable oasis in a desert of squalor. For all his love of the city, Thomas wasn't a nightbird — not unless he had a camera in his hand. A camera made you look at things differently. Sometimes you saw beauty there, fleeting, captivating. Mostly you saw the ugliness, stark and unveiled. Either way, you saw photographs in the making.

The two young bucks diagonally opposite fell into the latter category. Thomas felt the crosshatch handle of the Makarov pistol tight against his palm. *Not tonight, boys.* And he walked confidently on.

Ten to eleven, time to check his mobile. He remembered now that he'd put it on silent, while playing detective. He rang Ann Crossley first, a combination of professional courtesy and curiosity to see whether she was still on duty. She was, of course; she had the same stilted tone, her gentle

Welsh inflections struggling to be heard over the whitewash of an English education. She received his update, asked little and wished him a good night. Fat chance of that, unless . . .

Miranda picked up on the third ring. “Hi, Thomas, I was going to call you. Do you want the good news or the bad news?”

Just what he didn’t need, late night riddles. “Hit me.”

She laughed at his piss poor attempt to be cool. “It’s sorted. The Irish geezers have agreed to let Karl back in for twenty-four hours,” her voice tailed off, as if she was rounding for the counterpunch.

“Go on, then . . .”

“We’re down about twenty grand.” She took a breath. “And it’s gonna cost another ten grand as a goodwill gesture, allowing Karl to act as a courier for Jack Langton.”

At first, he was lost for words. “Miranda, I’m so sorry.” *Her* money, even if she had refused to touch it when he’d extorted it out of Sir Peter Carroll on her behalf.

“It’s fine,” she sounded superficially breezy. “Besides, what would I want with thirty grand?”

He clenched his teeth to force down the lump in his throat. “So, were these two blokes scary then?”

“Not compared to Jack Langton — did you know I’m his god-daughter?”

“His *what*?” he nearly dropped the phone.

“Only kidding, sort of. Listen, if you haven’t already, you better ring Karl tonight. He’d probably appreciate a lift to the airport tomorrow morning. And after that, perhaps you’d like to meet me at my place — or I could wait for you here?”

“Caliban’s is good for me. See you as soon as. Bye.” He looked at the phone again and hesitated. It must be hard for Karl, finally allowed home just in time to see his mum before . . . He bit at a nail, and fretted over his opening line.

“Karl? It’s Thomas. How’re you doing, mate?”

“Well, it’ll be a while before I want to watch another card game. And I’m thinking of changing my name to Faust!”

“When do you want to be picked up tomorrow?”

“You’re a star, Tommo — eight will be fine. It’ll give me time to buy you breakfast at the airport.”

“What, with your winnings from the table?”

There was a moment’s silence. “You don’t think I was playing tonight? I’m down as John Wright’s man, so I am — I spent the night looking attentive and keeping schtum. Jack Langton wants me to make a delivery on my little trip — I’ll tell you all tomorrow.”

* * *

Thomas wasn’t thrilled to be arriving at Miranda’s club, gun in hand. But it’d be safer than leaving it in the car — what a crime report that’d make.

He pulled into the car park and automatically checked out the other cars. Miranda’s and Sheryl’s sat side by side; the rest of the clan must have left. A pity; he’d wanted to thank them.

He yawned as he jabbed the intercom and waved half-heartedly at the CCTV. The sound of heels clacked down the steps and then the bolt was drawn back.

“Hi, honey, how was your day?” Sheryl widened the door without waiting for an answer, and locked up after him.

“I gather it all went well,” he called behind him as he climbed the steps.

“Yeah, pretty much. I’d say Karl scraped a pass; it was all a bit tense at first, but Jack Langton has a way of setting the tone.”

Thomas held the door at the top of the steps. “Have you met him before?”

“Met him? I, er, used to run bar for him.”

Miranda was sat at the card table, drink in hand, like a survivor surveying the damage. She pushed out the chair beside her with her foot.

“Tea or coffee, Thomas?” Sheryl had already started to veer off.

“Tea, thanks,” he joined Miranda at the table. “Tough night?”

Miranda found a smile even though it seemed like it was a long time coming. “So so. And you?”

“Not my best day.” He lifted the Makarov out of his pocket and laid it on the table. “Any chance you could stash this somewhere safe for a while? I don’t think it would go down well at the airport.”

“Sure,” she didn’t bat an eyelid. “Does this make me your moll now?”

He squeezed her arm. Sheryl took her seat and passed the tea across to him.

“Nice weapon — a little small, but very stylish.”

“Yeah, I inherited it from my dad.”

He watched as Sheryl and Miranda made eye contact. Maybe Miranda had already told her how he’d pulled a gun on Yorgi, on the moors. It would explain the sudden drop in temperature.

Chapter 26

“You didn’t have to bring me tea in bed,” he peered up at Miranda, bleary-eyed. The clock read something evil past six.

She smiled and rubbed his shoulder as she put the mug down beside him. There was still an edge to her, had been since the previous night. In bed, she’d lain close to him and he, able to read her signals after years of trial and error, just held her close until they fell asleep.

“I don’t want you to get involved in Mum and Dad’s business.”

Bit late for that, he mused, but he kept the thought to himself. He nodded a couple of times and left the airwaves open.

“Only, the card game reminded me of some things; you know, from when I was a kid.” She didn’t elaborate. “Best you keep out of it.”

“Sheryl mentioned last night that she used to work for Jack Langton. Is that how she got the job here?” He leaned over for his tea and yawned, feigning disinterest.

Miranda didn’t answer. “Are you coming back tonight?”

“Well,” he sat up. “That sounds like an invitation if ever there was one.”

She still wasn’t playing though. “I don’t want your gun here.”

Not the declaration of affection he was hoping for. “Fair enough.” He read the clock again and wondered how quickly he could get out without it seeming personal.

* * *

It was bin day in Kilburn and it seemed like every cat in the neighbourhood was on patrol for scraps. Thomas sat in his car — seven fifty — and watched as a scraggy ginger specimen prowled around the black bags. Maybe it was the short tufts of reddish brown hair, but it reminded him of Karl. Karl McNeill, alley cat; it had a certain ring to it.

The man himself emerged from his door at a minute to eight, and then triple-locked it. Knowing Karl, it was probably booby-trapped on the other side as well. He raised a hand in greeting and strolled up with a laptop case at his side and a sports bag over his shoulder.

Thomas got out and opened the boot. “You okay?” Best to see how Karl played it first, before committing himself.

“Aye, Tommo,” Karl sighed. “Big day today.”

“What’s with the laptop bag — is that for the Duty Free?”

Karl got in and pulled the door closed. He didn’t speak until Thomas had started up the car. “You really wanna know?” his voice said one thing and his face said the opposite.

“How about telling me now and getting it over with, and then you can pick the music.”

“Deal.”

Over the ten years or so that Thomas had known Miranda and her family, he’d occasionally speculated about what her family’s business involved. Sure, there were the usual tax returns and accountant’s fees, but lurking beneath that veneer was a flow of trade and money that came and went like a night tide: you knew it was happening, but you never got to see it. So when Karl mentioned the magic word *coins*, Thomas didn’t know at first if he was taking the piss. And Karl, as the bagman, knew very few details, beyond his lap top battery being very expensive, pound for pound.

“And someone just arrives at your hotel and swaps batteries with you?”

“That’s the plan. In fact, that’s all the plan there is.”

It was hard to know how to respond. “And you’re okay with that?”

“Truth? It’s not the way I’d prefer to work. Remember, I’ll be a civilian there. No protection beyond Martin and Francis-Andrew’s word.” He didn’t sound too convinced. “It could be an elaborate set up, for all I know. The hotel has been arranged, along with my flight times, so anything’s possible.”

“And what about seeing your mum in hospital?”

“It’s a grey area. Martin has stipulated that I don’t contact anyone else in the family, so God help us if there are any other visitors. I think they’ll let me have an hour with her.”

Thomas tried to relax his grip on the wheel. “And you trust them?”

“What choice do I have, eh, Tommy Boy?”

“I wish I could help,” he jammed his foot down to clear the lights in time.

“You already have — I’ve saved my cab fare to the airport.” And with that, Karl popped the glove compartment and sifted through the CDs,

finally holding aloft a Thin Lizzy album, 'The Boys Are Back In Town.' He beamed, as if he'd just seen a photo of an old friend.

Thomas told Karl the bare minimum about his enchanted evening with Jess and Major Eldridge. No point overloading Karl's sense of moral obligation right now. Predictably, Karl offered his full support, albeit at the end of a new mobile number, while he was away.

"I'll try and avoid it, just in case the walls have ears where you're going."

Karl raised an eyebrow and stayed silent.

* * *

Thomas's mood had darkened by the time they arrived at Gatwick airport's short stay car park. Karl picked up on it straight away.

"First time back, eh, Tommo?"

"Uh huh," he busied himself, trying to find a space. And tried not to think about the terrible time when Miranda had been abducted — from that very car — tracked by Sir Peter Carroll's cronies. He managed not to dent the dashboard.

"It'll get easier, Tommo — when you head back here to pick me up."

Thomas smiled; Karl was all heart. "Thanks, I'll put in a good word for you at my next counselling session. And I know just the word." He parked up and carried Karl's sports bag in for him; he steered well clear of the laptop.

The airport was orchestrated chaos; staff who knew what they were doing, passengers who knew where they were going, and the drifters who knew neither. Karl headed to an early check-in. He took the bag from Thomas, went through the admin, answered the security questions politely and deposited said bag, retaining his laptop.

Admin over, Karl wove his way through a throng of happy travellers, in search of coffee and provisions. Thomas followed in his wake. There was a certain delight in not having to watch the clock too rigorously: Karl's flight wasn't for at least two hours. And that was after allowing time to pass through security.

"What if it all goes tits up, Karl?" Might as well say what he was thinking.

"Then I'm on my own and my day job's looking very shaky."

“Shit.” Thomas took another slurp of tea and his brain started ticking.

After breakfast, they wandered through the tasteful range of shops and services. There was a strange *goodbye* feel to everything, and Thomas had to remind himself that Karl would be back in twenty-four hours, give or take.

“Will you at least text me where you’re staying and where your mum . . . you know.” He gazed over the glass partition.

“She’s in Belfast City Hospital — palliative care. It’s fine to talk about it, really. You’re about the only one I *can* talk to on the subject.” He shifted the laptop bag to his other hand. “I don’t think knowing my hotel is going to do you any good, but I promise to let you know once I’m settled in.”

“Come on, let’s get you through the sentries so you can stock up on expensive presents.” He paused. “How is it supposed to work when you’re out there?”

Karl understood immediately. “Someone will ring me at the hotel — that’s as much as I’ve been told.”

He walked Karl as far as he could, like a parent taking their youngest child to the school gates. He remembered how pleased with himself he’d been when he’d first figured out a way for Karl to see his mother. Only now, as the back of Karl’s head inched along in the sedated conga, to run the gauntlet of a metal detector and an X-ray machine, he didn’t feel nearly so clever.

Once ‘Alley Cat’ O’Neill was half a dozen people along, Thomas went in search of a decent mobile signal. Top of the call list was Ann Crossley, to see if she could get him another appointment with Sir Peter Carroll. There were things to discuss.

Chapter 27

Karl settled in his seat, eyes closed, listening to the drumming of the engines and the chatter around him. The one benefit of such a short flight was a reduced chance of conversation. And he'd stacked the odds further by pretending to be asleep, even during the safety demonstration. Once they were fully airborne, he relented, gazing out on the clouds and marking the distance of years. He remembered now why he'd always hated flying — it had always been there, but he'd never acknowledged it: that first gut-wrenching flight from home.

Ma had seen him off at the airport, mostly for his own protection. "You will ring me when you're settled? You can reverse the charges if you have to."

He blushed against the windowpane as he recalled breaking down, and her flicking his hair from his face and telling him to be brave, to make something out of himself and that maybe Jacqueline would get in touch. But she never had.

Clouds rolled on and the memories rushed in to meet them. He was such a skinny thing in those days — that first day on a building site never seemed to end. He was *Paddy* of course, except to the other Irish. And then, when *the collection* went round — for the cause back home — he donated without hesitation, to avoid attracting attention. And before he knew it, he was invited to the local Irish Centre, a slice of home that threatened to cut through the identity he'd concocted.

Mam got her phone calls regularly, from one of those bent phone-boxes that were common knowledge to certain people. He didn't know who had cried the most, the first time, but after that some unspoken pact applied. He never told her how lonely he was and she never asked.

* * *

When the plane broke cloud cover, Karl felt cheated. He wasn't done with his memories and he wasn't ready to face up to the aftermath. But it was coming, ready or not. Table up, straight-backed chair, firm jaw; coming into land.

As the plane circled in a wide arc, high over Belfast, he looked down upon shades of green that he'd never expected to see again, and rubbed away a solitary tear. Somewhere, down there, he'd told Jacqueline that he loved her.

The flight spiralled in and the engines changed pitch for the final descent. And then suddenly they were taxiing to the terminal, back in County Antrim after nearly two decades away.

* * *

Despite the red seatbelt sign, the woman beside him unfastened hers and glanced around the cabin. He didn't make eye contact, but he watched her closely. Maybe she was on the same package deal: the 'twenty-four hours and fuck off' city break. True or not, she looked ready to sprint to the steps.

He, on the other hand, was in no rush; it would take as long as it takes. And for what lay ahead, it could take forever and he still wouldn't be prepared. After an eternity, the doors opened, front and back, and the cattle disembarked. Soon it was just him, a few stragglers and a woman who needed help with her stick. She'd be about his mammy's age. As he grabbed his laptop and eased into the aisle, he heard a tinny tune playing across the years — 'The Party's Over' by Tony Bennett — his mother's favourite. Christmas, birthdays, even bad news days, Tony Bennett would fill the house. Even the day dad left had become part of the Tony Bennett montage.

The sign read, Welcome to Belfast City Airport. Jesus, he'd been away so long they'd renamed the place. Outside, the air tasted different, felt different as it stroked his face the way a mother soothes a child. He thought there might have been someone there to meet him. Not Jacqueline — he wasn't going soft in the head — but maybe some associate of Martin's or Francis-Andrew's. The absence reminded him how solitary he'd become. Right now, this minute, the only person he could ring and chat about the enormity of his being here, was Thomas — and that call was scheduled for later.

* * *

He grabbed a taxi, just as the rain started; lazy drips smearing the view as they made the prodigal's parade along the Sydenham Bypass. It was as a

stranger that he watched, weighing up the risk of a walk-around later on, once he'd checked in.

The taxi driver had launched into the blarney from the off, reaching his fourth minute without pausing for breath. "Sure, it's a golden city now — do you come here often?" And then he laughed at the innuendo, probably repeated a hundred times a month.

Karl fended off any probing questions and stuck with the safest line — being back over on business: computers. He looked the part anyway — smart casual. No suit, but not slumming it either.

The driver was still in full flow as they reached the hotel, something about golf at the weekends and again what a golden city Belfast had become. Karl paid him off, faintly embarrassed by the English currency, and went inside. The hotel was mid-range: somewhere between luxury and a doss-house, as befitted the desires of his employers.

As he stood in the foyer, taking stock, he wondered again if the whole smuggled coins routine was bullshit. Think again, he concluded. John Wright might have welcomed him into the fold, but Jack Langton didn't seem the type to do charity work.

The reception desk carried a plaque declaring: 'It's our pleasure to serve you.' Which sounded like a wild boast. On the far wall was a sepia print of a harpist, fingers extended and her eyes closed in rapture. Elsewhere, he clocked a stylised image of St Patrick. All the place lacked was a little sign with an arrow — Shamrock Museum this way.

One of the three wee lasses finished her call, tugged at the hem of her bright green jacket and leaned towards him. "Good afternoon, how may I help you today?"

He played the game, shelled out a few details on paper — false address, false name to match the booking, and false mobile number — and collected his room key. No early-morning call, thank you, no complimentary newspaper and definitely no booking for an evening show. Not in the way that she meant, anyway. She nodded a little uncomfortably and advised him that he'd be charged for each diverted call.

* * *

John Wright had been kind to him, finding a hotel within walking distance of the hospital. Even so, he hunched his shoulders in as he walked,

and kept his gaze low. He walked up and down outside for a minute, getting his head together; he wouldn't see Ma until after the exchange, but he wanted to just cross the threshold and burst the bubble.

It was a mixture of the old and the new. A temple to medicine and to hope — for those who believed in such things. The last wisps of euphoria at being back on native soil evaporated as he stepped inside and smelt the sanitised air. Somewhere, in that vast complex of corridors and patients, his ma lay dying. He picked his moment, sidled over to a desk and asked after his ma's whereabouts. The inevitable questions came, but he put his consummate ability to lie into practice and span them a line about being a distant nephew. Once he had what he needed and an assurance that visiting would be fine, he excused himself and high-tailed it out of there. The CCTV was something he'd just have to chance.

The rain outside spattered cold against his face; he kidded himself it was the weather that made him shiver. On the way back to the hotel, he grabbed a local paper, and wondered whether he was already being watched.

As he walked into the lobby, he faked a phone conversation, a ruse to inconspicuously check out the downstairs. No one approaches you when you're on a mobile call; rather, they tend to avoid you. The only visitors were a couple having tea in the lounge. Karl nodded politely, and took his fake call elsewhere. He hadn't thought his contact would be two people but if so, at least he'd had a chance to look at them. The man was bulky, in a suit that had seen better times. The woman, more angular in frame and movement, had been the one paying him more attention. He decided, on the balance of probability, that they were probably guests.

He cut the fake call by the main desk, nixed the phone divert and ordered himself some room service. Back in his room, he switched on the television and examined the phone wires for signs of recent tampering. Part of him knew this was nonsense, but his instincts were so hyped, being back, that it was less stress to follow them up than to ignore them. A cup of catering-standard tea, with sacheted milk and two miniature shortbreads, gave him something to sit down for.

He flicked through the newspaper, not really reading anything, but aware he was scanning for names, while the TV blared on. At five o'clock, someone rapped on the door. He'd ordered room service, but that didn't

stop him opening the door carefully, with a fist clenched out of view. False alarm, just fish and chips with mushy peas. He made the guy wait outside while he signed for it then retreated back into his shell.

A presenter on UTV was reviewing the ongoing case of a stolen JCB digger and the ATM machine it had removed from a wall. He finished his meal, wiped the knife clean and put it to one side. Not the best of weapons, more a psychological comfort.

At six o'clock, he made a genuine mobile call. "Is that the Yorkshire Tourist Board?"

"How are you, mate?"

"Oh, fine, fine. Just waiting for the proper business to kick off. Once that's done, I can get on with my own plans."

Thomas waited a few seconds. "Definitely ring me when you need picking up — doesn't matter what time."

In hindsight, that was a funny remark to make, because he'd already told him the details, but like as not Thomas had forgotten, what with the tub of crocodiles he was waist high in. "Anyhow, I'll not keep you — I'll see you tomorrow. If you're a very good boy, I'll bring you back a prezzie."

"A key ring for Miranda might be nice. "

"Alright, I'll see what I can afford."

Thomas laughed then, just as he'd hoped. Jesus, when he thought about the money it had cost — well, cost *Miranda*, actually. He'd make it up to them though, somehow; he'd see to that. Phone call over, Karl went back to his newspaper.

Out of the corner of his eye, he saw the laptop bag stowed under the desk. He'd seen it emptied at Gatwick when they'd dusted the battery for explosives. He wondered what was on the hard drive. He took a deep breath and reined in his imagination. John Wright wouldn't put him at risk — not after everything that went down with Thomas and Miranda.

No, then what about Jack Langton? Langton had humiliated him in front of Francis-Andrew and Martin, painted him as a simpleton lackey and courier. Karl smiled; his conclusions were starting to sound as paranoid as some of Thomas's. True, but when it came to the serpent's nest of the Surveillance Support Unit, Thomas had largely been right.

He took a step closer to the bag, sucking the moisture back from his lips. Three light raps on the door changed his mind. He glanced to the knife

and stashed it in his back pocket. “Who is it?” his hand twitched on the doorknob.

“Are you McNeill?” the accent was strong and local.

“Yeah, just give me a minute,” he looked around the room. If it was a gunman, what the fuck could he do about it anyway? In no way reassured by the thought, he took off the safety chain, opened the door and stepped back.

The man on the other side of the doorway blinked in the dull hall light. Then he looked left and right along the corridor before taking the first step towards Karl. He didn’t look like a killer; matter of fact, he looked even lower-budget material than Karl had been pitched to be. One thing though: he was wearing gloves.

He closed the door behind him. Karl left the TV on, at a level between audible and irritating.

“Where is it, then?”

Twitchy, Karl decided. Maybe this guy was a conscript as well. “It’s down there — help yourself.”

The stranger knelt down beside the bag and unzipped it. The contents hadn’t changed since Karl last saw it, but the guy opened everything very carefully, as if the laptop were fragile. This did not look like a man in the know.

When the deed was done, the guy stood up and wiped his face with the back of his glove; it glistened with sweat. “Did I do everything alright?” his voice wavered.

“Sure, you were fine,” Karl assured him, rapidly reassessing the situation and spotting an opportunity. It was only ten to seven. “Do you want to sit down — you look like you’re gonna fall down. I could order a couple of drinks up?”

The man licked his lips and took a few more shallow breaths. “Would that be okay? I mean, is that allowed?”

“Sure — whisky?” Karl smiled at him, poor bastard. The man nodded back. “Irish or Scottish?”

The stranger faltered, as if recognising a test. “Whatever you’re having.”

Karl smiled again and decided to skip the shandy, on this occasion. He played nice on the hotel phone and sat the guy down in a chair. The double

whiskies wouldn't be long in coming, but that still left time for conversation.

"This your first job for the business?" Karl felt like he was leaching confidence from the other guy by the second; it was a good feeling.

He didn't reply, but he twitched again.

"Sure, come on. Take your coat and your gloves off, relax a little — you've done your bit." Karl knew the guy would have a delivery to make later, but figured this was probably the hardest part for him.

It was a relief when the drinks arrived — it gave them something to do other than avoid conversation. Now, they could drink *and* avoid conversation. The stranger lifted his glass and snuck a look at his watch.

"We don't have to chat," Karl leaned back casually, catching the TV screen out the corner of his eye. The weather forecast — must be getting on for seven.

The mystery man was still huddled in his chair, only now he was sipping his whisky in rhythmic gulps, like he was in a hurry.

"Hey, don't go rushing on my account!"

He blushed and swallowed. "I, er, have to be somewhere — they'll be expecting me. Besides, you've probably got things to do?"

Karl narrowed his eyes, concentrating hard on not reacting.

By the time Karl closed the door on his visitor, he'd come to a decision. Every instinct was telling him to get out of there; he'd ring John Wright to tell him there'd been a change of plan — but he'd ring him once he was safely touched down at Gatwick. He checked the time — eight minutes past seven. Now was his best chance of getting to the hospital, but what about his bags? Leave them there and maybe they wouldn't be around when he got back. And what if someone was checking the front door, waiting for him?

He peered at the map on the wall and traced the fire escape route out — almost certainly alarmed. He grabbed the duvet and used it to manhandle the laptop into the bag and zip it up. Time to get moving; he'd chance his luck on getting out through the kitchens. If he moved quickly and confidently, by the time anyone stopped him he'd be more likely to get through than be turned back. As he collected his things and opened the door, a gem of an idea occurred to him.

The stairs were always preferable to the lift, more space and free movement in both directions. And easier to turn back if he had to. As he walked down calmly, he concocted the sentences in his head, of how the room service meal had contained a piece of plastic wrapping. And how he wanted to see the chef in private to discuss it, rather than make a scene.

At the bottom of the stairs on the ground floor, he paused and leant round to check the desk. Experience had taught him that it was all about intention and body language. Act as if you're unimportant and people usually treated you accordingly. Not so much invisible as inconsequential.

On the count of four . . . he swung sharp right and kept walking, into the restaurant and up to the double doors at the end.

The maître d' bounded up to him. "Excuse me, sir, I'm afraid that area is out of bounds for customers," followed by a fake and slightly perturbed smile.

Karl put his sports bag down and leaned in towards him. "I'd like a word with the chef about my room service; I thought it'd be better in private rather than out here." He kept his voice steady and low, somewhere between a request and a bollocking.

The maître d' nodded for an instant. "If you'll kindly wait here, sir, I'll go and fetch her."

Karl watched the door swing after him and followed. The three of them all collided on the other side of the door. Karl got in there first and pulled the chef to one side. In the few seconds of meeting her, he surmised that she looked like a decent person — someone who could do with a boost. And besides, she was a brunette.

"Can I have a wee word?" he was all smiles as he let go of her. "I'm a mystery shopper," he revealed, loud enough for the maître d', and anyone ear-wiggling, to hear. He squeezed her arm. "I just want to say that my fish and chips was really first rate. Before I make out my little report, would it be asking too much to have a quick tour of the kitchens?"

She flushed and looked to the maître d' who said nothing. "That'd be okay."

Karl turned to him. "And listen, let's not mention this to any of the other staff. Anonymity is paramount in this business."

The maître d' skipped out, grinning like an idiot. Karl stashed his bags in a corner and let the chef show him around. Okay, so he was having her

on, but wasn't the joy on her face real? She didn't explain who he was to any of the other staff, and showed him round — good girl. She was maybe in her late twenties, and for no reason at all, he suddenly thought back to the woman in the army test lab: the one who had died.

“I think that'll be fine, thank you,” he stopped her abruptly. Maybe it was just the heat and steam, but he could feel the sweat oozing out of him. He drew a twenty from his wallet and handed it to her. And could she let him out the back now, to avoid the reception staff?

The young lad in the car park stamped out his cigarette as Karl emerged. Karl didn't hang around to explain himself; he had an appointment to keep. A cab would have been less aggravation, but also easier to spot. He kept to the backstreets as much as possible and walked at speed.

Chapter 28

Getting into the hospital wasn't difficult. He'd opted for the first point of entry and after that it was a case of finding his way. The searching gave him something to fix his mind upon, something to drive out the only reason for his being there — to say a final goodbye to the only family member he really cared about.

He thought of Thomas, who rarely saw his family, by choice. Strange how the lives of people around us follow parallel trails. As if we instinctively choose friends on the basis of some mysterious fellowship. And that, he told himself softly, was why he shouldn't drink whisky.

He took his time on the final flight of stairs, steeling himself for the inevitable. There was one person at the nurse's station and he was grateful for that. "Excuse me, is it possible to see Mrs McNeill — is, er, anybody with her at the moment?" He tried not to screw his face up at the 'Mrs' part. Despite an unspeakable divorce — and come to that, the rest of the family still might not know about it — she'd never reverted to her family name.

She told him he was in luck, for want of a better term. But, she warned him, Mrs McNeill was very weak and might not be very responsive.

"I'd like a little time with her alone — I've not been able to see her for a while."

She nodded enthusiastically, as if touched by his thoughtfulness. "It's the one from last room, on the left."

Karl walked solemnly through the sickly heat and stale air, forcing a path between the vapour of antiseptic and decay. The closer he came to that fateful door, the more his legs dragged. Until, finally, he was outside, turning the handle.

The light was dimmed and the figure in bed still. It hadn't been that long since he'd seen her face to face — a couple of years at most — and they'd had use of webcams and phone calls in between. Even so, he wasn't prepared for the frail creature before him.

A tiny wail escaped his lips. "Ah, Ma." Before he could say anything further, his eyes had filled up. He put the bags down and approached the bed reverently. The memory of her favourite song rose up like an

apparition, and even though his heart began to fracture, he started humming, because he thought she might respond to it.

His mother's eyelid flickered after the first few bars of 'The Party's Over.' Her jaw lowered and her glazed eyes seemed to be trying to focus. He rushed to the side of the bed and held her hand; her skin was parchment.

"Is that you, my brave boy?" she gasped for the words.

The tears came in floods now, echoing back to the phonebox, where she'd told him to build a new life in England, and to make her proud.

He hummed to the end of a verse. "Aye, it's me, Ma."

She squeezed his thumb. "Brave boy," she said, tilting her head towards him slowly, her smile rising gently like a tired moon.

The door catch slowly clicked and a nurse popped her head around the door. "I just need to check on her — I won't be long."

He made as if to get up, but she shook her head and commenced her duties. Her voice was bright and airy, talking directly to his mother in a light, lyrical voice. She looked the epitome of youth. "I don't think I've seen you before?"

He didn't respond.

"Ah, it's lovely for her to have visitors. I gather she doesn't have much family — her son moved abroad, apparently, so her niece was telling me last week."

He turned his face away without answering her and glowered. *Bastards*. Despite years of being away, he could rattle off a list of at least a dozen family members — they couldn't all have moved out of Country Antrim.

When the nurse left, he took a little while to digest his thoughts and surrender to the stillness. There was a peace to be had there in the dulled light — with just the sound of his mother's sighing breaths. He glanced down at her and tenderly laid her palm on top of the sheet. Then he shifted in closer and went back to Tony Bennett, only now he sang the words close to her ear.

A deep smile spread across her face. And although he couldn't hear her, he could see her parched lips moving. He closed his eyes and continued singing to the end, his hand touching hers. And when he opened his eyes again, she was in a deep slumber; for all he knew, it was the final sleep.

"I love you, Ma," he whispered, bending forward to kiss her. It may have been the pressure of him moving, but it felt as if she pushed against

his fingers in response. He chose to believe that.

He stayed there in the gloom, saying nothing and seeing little, just feeling her presence. Nothing happened in that time of waiting, except there came a point when he knew it was time to go. He said goodbye for the last time and kissed her again.

“I’m away now, Ma, your brave boy has to go.” He stared at her intently, not really sure what he was looking for. Signs, probably, that she wouldn’t wake again. Better that than the idea of her thinking, next morning, that she’d only dreamed of him and he’d never made it back. He took a deep sigh; it was over. He’d done what he’d wanted to do and now he’d have to live with the consequences.

He slipped away from her in stages, controlling his movements, so as not to disturb her. He paused at the door, watching the light from the ward reach across the floor to her bed. It always came to this — the parent old and infirm, the child watching helplessly. It was the natural order; only he’d been away for so long that he’d forgotten that.

The bags came out one at the time, his foot propping the door. Then he carefully clicked the door shut behind him and wiped his face again. There was nothing more for him there and everything to lose.

As he passed the other rooms, he saw silhouettes against the blinds, and imagined the relatives preparing for the inevitable — if it was ever really possible to prepare. The same nurse was at the desk. She paused from her paperwork and offered him a consoling smile. He looked away to the door at the far end, and started walking.

As he shouldered the swing door, a shadow approached him: Martin. This was probably it — the long awaited bullet. Well, here on in, he could do his worst.

Martin’s hands were in his pocket. He drew them both out together — gloves, but no weapon. “Karl,” the word sounded hollow. “I’m sorry about your ma.”

He stared him down, didn’t reply. Focused instead on not ripping his fucking head off.

Martin sighed. “A lot of water under the bridge, McNeill. Perhaps it’s time to lay the past to rest.”

Karl squinted at him — was that a glimmer in Martin’s eye. He remembered the table knife in his back pocket and wondered how quickly

he could plunge it into the bastard. No, he straightened up; he'd be better off getting on that plane and never coming back.

Martin extended his right hand. Karl looked at it, hanging in space like a lifeline. "You should know this, McNeill: Jacqueline never married."

Karl advanced his own hand, but took his time about it. "When you see her, tell her, neither did I."

Their hands met, solid and unyielding, gripping like a death hold. Then the moment passed and Martin withdrew his gauntlet. As he walked away, leaving Karl standing in the middle of the corridor, Karl started walking too, slowly and steadily.

A commotion ahead made him stop in his tracks. Martin looked through the glass of the door, at the uniforms that had filled the frame, then back at Karl.

"McNeill," he snarled, and Karl thought he was reaching for a gun.

But when the door swung in, the uniforms ignored Martin altogether and made a beeline for Karl.

"Karl McNeill? Stay right where you are — Special Branch."

Next thing he knew he was tackled to the wall, sports bag crashing to the floor. Then the laptop bag was manhandled off him, his arms were bent back and he felt the sharp cold of handcuffs against his skin. As they twisted him round, Martin looked on, open-mouthed, then casually made his way out the door.

* * *

For thirty minutes, Karl had sat at the desk, waiting for someone to attend to him. He had been fingerprinted and his hands tested for chemicals, but hardly anyone had said a word. He stared at the wooden floor and replayed the mess in his head, over and over, flexing his hands every now and again as if to dispel the memory of the cuffs.

Martin had looked stunned when it happened; not pleased or satisfied, but shocked. Then again, maybe Francis-Andrew had orchestrated it? Well, whoever it had been, he was really fucked now.

Another face appeared at the window for a matter of seconds and then hastily retreated. He wasn't even sure how it worked anymore — how many hours could they hold him without a solicitor? And what the hell would

they charge him with? He closed his eyes and tried to doze, desperate to stop thinking.

The rattle of the doorknob startled him and he sat to attention. There were two of them — both from the sharp-suits-and-short-haircuts brigade. They took seats opposite and slapped a size-zero buff folder on the desk.

“Cup of tea?” the older of the two was Scottish, Glaswegian at a push. He looked to his underling, as if to say, ‘Don’t get comfortable.’

“Milk and one sugar, please. Any chance of a biscuit?” Humour was always his first line of defence, and right now he needed defending.

The older cop nodded; Junior left the room. “Do you know why you’re here?”

He opted for ignorance, in spades. “Nah, I went to hospital to see my mother — she’s dying; you can check.”

“We already did. But that’s not the only reason you’re here, is it Karl?”

“How does this work — do I get a phone call?”

“I don’t think so, not this time.”

He clammed up and tried to play the waiting game. Tea arrived, with a cluster of biscuits on a paper plate. Some of the tea had jumped ship.

“Sorry about that,” Junior said, passing it over. “Pre-dunked.”

The older guy looked like his face would split if he laughed — with little chance of that happening today.

“Do you like mysteries, Karl?”

He took it as rhetorical and didn’t answer.

“Because here’s the thing, Karl. I have information that makes no sense at all. There’s no record of you entering Northern Ireland — by *legitimate* means — in the last twenty years. Yet here you are today, walking out of a hospital. And you’re a floater — Surveillance Support Unit, over in London. But you’re also ex-mob, only your file is restricted.”

Karl bit at another biscuit. So far, so safe.

“Now, I can live with all of that, but there was residue on your right hand — *chemical* residue. Are you following my drift?”

He tried to subdue the sense of confusion and outrage, half-listening while backtracking in his brain to identify the source of the residue. Taxi? No contact. Hotel and room service? Unlikely. That left the deliveryman in his hotel room . . . or Martin. He nearly cracked a gallows smile; Martin . . . the Judas handshake — bingo, as Thomas would say.

“I take it you’ve been to my hotel room?”

The Scottish guy smiled, as if to say, ‘What do you think?’

A knock at the door interrupted the proceedings. The Scottish guy barked a command as a head poked through.

“The call’s come through, sir . . .” the face receded.

The senior officer looked a little crestfallen as he turned to his junior. “He’s clean; squeaky clean.”

“But what about the residue?” Junior replied and they both looked in Karl’s direction.

He coughed self-consciously. What was he going to tell them — keep an eye on prominent local businessmen? He had no proof, beyond gut instinct, process of elimination and a grudge that spanned two decades — a grudge that had now been fed and watered.

“Know what I think, McNeill?” Older cop picked up the file and tapped the edge on the desk, as if straightening the pages. “I think you’ve been sent here on a job, exploiting your own mother as a cover. And I have to say, I don’t like uninvited guests on my patch — do you follow me?”

Karl nodded, out of respect.

“I’m sure you’ve got some classified need-to-know bollocks to hide behind, but come on, just between the three of us, before they crate you out of here, is there something I ought to know?”

Karl took a sip of tea as they stared at him. “Tell you what, give me your card and I’ll get back to you once I’m over the water; seriously.”

Scottish bloke’s eyes lit up like tallow candles as he passed over a card, face down. Karl smiled back — after all, who doesn’t like useful contacts in their line of work?

“What happens now?” Karl figured they were getting near the end.

“Your things will be returned to you and you’ll be removed from our soil tonight — someone’s flying in to escort you back.”

“So,” Karl pondered aloud, “as far as anyone else is concerned, I’ve been arrested and detained. Which means, if anyone finds out otherwise, we’ll know where to come.” It was clear that the time for talking was over.

* * *

Christine Gerrard was about the last person Karl had expected to see in Belfast.

“Apparently this will ensure you trust me.” She handed him a small envelope.

He checked the back, smiled when he saw it was sealed with wax and ripped it open. Inside was a post-it note bearing three letters: KGB. A smile spread across his face: KGB — Kosovo Girl’s Brigade. A moniker he’d used once with Thomas when he was trying to gain his trust.

Christine didn’t say a lot in the car. Just as well — Karl felt too numb to speak. His ma was ending her days without him. That bastard, Martin, had nearly had him put away, and the way he read it, the only reason he was out now was because Thomas had done God knows what to pull some strings.

The car was heading northwest, out on the A52. He didn’t want to say anything, but the Harbour airport was south. Christine seemed relaxed though. His mind wandered back to Stuart Fraser, the older Scottish cop, who’d given him his card. *Bollocks*. He glanced at Christine then reached for his mobile and the card.

“Stuart — it’s Karl McNeill. Listen, if you do go to the hospital, please be discreet; none of the family knows I’ve been here and it’s got to stay that way. Sure, uh huh . . . a deal’s a deal. Thanks, buddy.”

Christine waited until the mobile went down. “We’re flying out of Aldergrove, into Brize Norton. I thought it was best, under the circumstances.”

It sounded like a loaded statement. Karl tensed up, waiting for a barrage of questions. Not hearing any was worse.

Chapter 29

Thomas paced up and down, outside the Brize Norton arrival doors, toughing it out. At least Karl had been released — Christine had phoned him just before picking Karl up — but that was all he knew. He watched through the glass as the thread of people crossed the barrier

Christine emerged with Karl at her side. Karl appeared shell-shocked and Christine wasn't looking at him at all. The three of them converged and Thomas automatically reached for Karl's bag, as if he'd just been on holiday. He didn't go near the laptop and led the way out to the car.

Christine commandeered the front seat and gave directions, presumably towards a bollocking. No one else spoke. Thomas searched Karl's face via the mirror, as if to read his thoughts. Nothing doing. As the road wore on, a left here and a right there, it became clear that Christine had her own agenda. You didn't get to Bicester along any back roads. As they parked up, he clocked a familiar car on the way in, and decided not to mention it. Christine had obviously planned some sort of summit.

* * *

He let Christine take the lead and fell in line beside Karl. He nudged him, but all lines still appeared to be down. The pub was called The Angel, a bitter reminder of Amy.

Ann Crossley was waiting at a table, four chairs gathered, ready for the feast. He could imagine her guarding them fiercely and whipping out her government ID as last ditch crowd control. She got to her feet, generously offering to get in a round, crisps and all. The rest of them took a chair. It felt like the prelude to a séance. Then he remembered Karl's mum and didn't feel quite so amused.

Christine folded her arms and waited. Karl looked like he was waiting for an explanation as well. Thomas waited for Ann Crossley to return, and tried to think of something credible to say that would satisfy everyone.

"Right," Christine received her glass, "who'd like to tell me what's going on?"

Thomas opened his mouth to bite the bullet, but Ann Crossley clunked her G & T against the table. "Well," she paused, looking in Thomas's

direction as if seeking inspiration. “Karl has been visiting his mother on compassionate leave. However, Thomas became aware of a potential threat to him, which could have been connected to the support being given to Major Eldridge . . .”

He nodded emphatically. *Could have been connected — only by a surrealist.*

“. . . Thomas took appropriate action and alerted the major. Unfortunately, by then, matters had become somewhat complicated.” She stopped talking, as if unwilling to go that final step and tie everything up neatly in a ribbon.

Christine looked to Karl. “Anything to say?”

“No, ma’am,” he stared ahead, as if he had something better to do.

“And how about you?” Christine asked Thomas, third time lucky.

He flicked a glance to Ann Crossley in the vain hope that she had some more gems up her sleeve. Turned out she did.

“Did anyone see a sign for the Ladies?”

“I’ll show you,” Christine pushed against the table dramatically and headed off, Ann trailing in her wake.

Karl let out a deep sigh as they watched their colleagues disappearing. “Well,” he turned to Thomas, “I don’t reckon much to yours.” He moulded a smile, which Thomas reflected like desperate semaphore.

“How was it out there then?”

Karl shifted in his seat. “Like seven shades of terrible. Honest to God, Tommo, you’re never really prepared for death. Except maybe your own.” He took another weighted breath. “I’ll not be back there in the foreseeable future.”

Thomas stared at the table. “I should have checked Jack Langton out properly myself first — then I’d have known that he’s had business dealings in Belfast for years.”

Karl’s face tightened. “Imagine if you hadn’t intervened. There was me, arrested by Special Branch, with Semtex residue on my hand. Quite a tip-off.”

“Yeah,” Thomas blushed again, “Thing is, Special Branch were already watching you. They knew you were coming before you landed. As soon as I’d filled in the blanks about Jack Langton, I went to Major Eldridge and he pulled some favours in.”

Karl raised his glass. “Well, that explains the look of shock on Martin’s face. He probably thought I was setting *him* up. I’m very grateful to you, Tommo. I reckon Martin had someone waiting for me at Gatwick.” He nodded and they both took a gulp of amber liquid. “Hey, heads up, Mr Bladen, here come our dates again. Remember, don’t be too forward.”

Thomas was still laughing as the women sat down. The frostiness between Christine and Ann Crossley had lifted; he reckoned they’d had a private team talk. He pondered the wider ramifications as Karl grazed on the crisps. Then he came to a decision: these people were supposed to be allies. “Anyone got a piece of paper?”

Karl obliged. Thomas took out his trusty pen and drew three separate circles. Everything could be reduced to a diagram — he’d read that somewhere. He labelled the three rings: Army Base, Engamel and Secrets, and prepared for a deep dive.

A mobile trilled into life. “Mine,” Karl confessed, reaching into his jacket. He turned to one side, but didn’t leave the table. “Yeah? Ah, Fraser, good man — how d’ya get on?” There was a pause; Karl sat deathly still. I see, thank you for telling me. Okay, I’ll speak to you tomorrow about the residue. No, it’s fine. The family will make all the arrangements — I was never there today.”

Thomas felt the blood draining from his face. Karl cut the phone and carefully placed it back inside his jacket. “As you’ve probably surmised, my mother died a short while ago.”

Christine reached over and touched Karl’s hand; he tolerated it. “I think I’d like to go now, Tommo, if you wouldn’t mind?”

“Sure.” He looked to Christine, who muttered something about getting a lift back with Ann.

* * *

“You don’t have to baby-sit me; I’ll be fine . . .”

“I know,” Thomas pulled into the supermarket car park. “But I’d prefer it this way — think of it as Yorkshire hospitality.”

“Suit yourself. In that case, grab something you like drinking, while you’re in there. I think we need to get royally hammered tonight.”

That was the thing about Karl; because everything seemed like a joke to him, you never really knew when he was being serious. So Thomas grabbed

a bottle of Southern Comfort, along with some food, just to be on the safe side.

* * *

Back at the flat, Karl kicked off his shoes and wiggled his toes. “What do we know, then, Tommo?”

He refilled their glasses — a small measure, following several previous large ones. Karl shifted forward and hunched over the same three-circled page, gazing at details they’d added between them.

“So, the major’s willing to make a deal with Michael Schaefer? You do know what he is?”

Thomas grinned, enjoying the sensation of heat stampeding across his face. Oh yeah, he knew what Schaefer was all right.

“Project Director, my man. Research projects . . .”

Thomas pressed his eyebrows in, concentrating to think. “The Scavenger — UB40, or whatever you want to call it — that’s probably one of *his* then.” He took another sip of Southern Comfort and rolled the sweet goodness around in his mouth, pressing his lips together as it slid down. “Do you think Jess really has all that data stashed in her head?”

Karl waved his glass to and fro, like a conductor’s baton. “It’s not unheard of. From what you said, she’s a bit of a mimic, so why not figures as well? She’s also a conniving minx if she’s destroyed the original records.”

Two hours down the line and all the drink was gone, along with most of Thomas’s deductive reasoning. He lay back in the armchair, lolling his head to one side to hear Karl better.

“. . . I’ll not let it go; I’m telling you that. But I’m not stupid, oh no; I’ll not go see Jack Langton all guns blazing.” He grinned for a moment and then his face hardened. “I’ll sort him out, good and proper, that’s a promise. And then I’ll sort out Martin and Francis-Andrew — I’ve nothing to lose now.”

Chapter 30

The last thing Thomas remembered was Karl swearing vengeance like some Mafia Don. Only, where Karl was concerned, he knew it wasn't just a drink-fuelled rant. It worried him so much that it almost distracted from the killer hangover.

As he sprinkled the painkillers out on his hand and winced as the water gurgled into a glass, he realised that he'd slept right through till morning. No nightmares, no early morning wake-ups. Although it had been a *drunk* sleep, which was a contradiction in itself.

He stumbled out of the bathroom, praying for the paracetamol to kick in. Karl was still dead to the world on the sofa. It was seven thirty and there was only one thing to do: real coffee, hot and strong. On the way through, he grabbed the piece of paper that had made so much sense the previous night. Most of it was just scrawl, but one question — written down early — stood out: Why had Amy tested the mixed ammunition alone? He nodded to the page — good point — and eased his head back up again.

Karl surfaced just as the coffee mug landed on the table. He rolled over, tried to uncrumple his face and stretched an arm beyond the duvet. "You know, I can't even send flowers; not unless one of the family informs me about the funeral in time." It was as if Karl had kept the conversation from the previous night on pause.

"Do they have your address?"

"Not exactly," he craned the coffee in, took a gulp and then returned for the two tablets waiting on the table. "They have a PO box number."

Thomas stared at him: You're kidding? But Karl clearly wasn't.

"What's on the agenda today then, Mr Bladen?"

Thomas teetered on a bow wave of incredulity.

"What do you expect me to do — sit at home? I've been in mourning for twenty years, Tommo. And there'll be time enough for that again in the future. Now, where are my trousers?"

That sounded like an opportune moment to leave him to it and hit the shower.

* * *

Karl gazed around as Thomas pulled into a parking space. “I used to share a flat not far from here.”

Thomas recognised the familiar memory-lane theme tune and said nothing.

“On the other side of Euston Road, mind; quite bohemian it was. The neighbour had this big, beige Persian cat — it never went outside; used to sleep in her bedroom.” He smiled; a hook line for Thomas to clamber on board.

“Would you like to be alone with your memories?”

Karl opened the door. “No thanks. What I want to do today is break some eggs — are you with me? Listen, if we hurry, we might even snaggle some breakfast in the hotel — we could try charging it to Jess’s room.”

Thomas’s stomach twitched in sympathy; the coffee was definitely wearing off. “Let me do the talking, okay?”

The glass doors slid back silently; the reception staff didn’t react. Thomas left Karl at the sofa and ambled over to the desk.

“Hi there,” he got the greeting in first. “Can you call Room 635? Thanks.”

“What name please?” The last of the caffeine percolated through his brain. “Jess . . . Sanders.” Fingers crossed she hadn’t gone in under an assumed name. He looked over his shoulder; Karl had buried himself in a complimentary newspaper.

“I’m sorry, sir. Miss Sanders checked out early this morning.”

Thomas blinked slowly, taking it in. He kept it together, nodded his thanks and walked back to Karl. “She’s gone,” he flopped down beside him. “Any suggestions?”

“Yeah, first we see if the restaurant will serve us and then we’ll check Jess’s room out.”

Two teas and muffins later, they were riding the lift, Karl pretending to tap along to Beethoven on a synthesiser.

“What are we looking for?” Thomas watched the light flickering through the floors.

“Dunno, Tommo. But a fiver says we find a pair of shoes.” He started whistling, proving that there was something even worse than synthesised Beethoven. The flute strangling continued as they exited the lift, but the tune changed — something folksy. Karl led on past Room 635 — closed —

and along the corridor. As they spied a gaggle of cleaners at the far end, Karl stepped up the pace.

“Excuse me, please, I need to get into Room 635.”

At least, that’s what Thomas assumed he was saying, in a language he surmised was Eastern European. His brain made the link with Yorgi and the corridor seemed to become narrower. He breathed rhythmically through his nose, standing his ground against the past, and hoped Karl would stop gabbling.

One cleaner, who was strikingly beautiful, began to follow Karl as he walked back to the room. Thomas decided that two men going with a woman on her own was a bit suspect, so he stayed put and tried to smile. The other two women began a private conversation, undeterred by his gooseberry act. *Come on Karl, shift your arse.*

“Tommo!” Karl called melodically behind him. The cleaners broke off conversation and started laughing.

As he turned, he saw Karl waving a pair of shoes, as if he were playing hunt the bride. Thomas passed the cleaner and saw the very top of a rolled banknote, crushed in her hand.

“Right then, that’s us outta here. And you owe me a fiver.”

* * *

“Next?” Thomas unlocked the car.

“Tell you what, why don’t I meet you at the office — I’ll get the tube. I need to ring my new friend in Special Branch.”

Thomas watched him go and took out the piece of paper they’d scribbled on. The question about Amy had been pretty damn important the night before, but now he couldn’t quite figure out why. Time to make a call of his own.

Miranda only picked up on the fourth ring: never a good sign. His brain had already started doing somersaults. Was she with someone, was Jack Langton nearby — the usual mixture of paranoia and confusion.

“I enjoyed your text last night. Touchingly romantic, but piss-poor spelling — were you drunk by any chance?”

Shit. So drunk that he didn’t even remember sending it. “Er, yeah, sorry about that. Karl stayed over and . . . you know. Didn’t I ring you earlier?”

“Uh-huh. How is he taking it?”

He took a big breath. “Well, he seems okay, but I know him better than that. And he’s determined to settle some scores.” He stopped there.

“Anyway,” she sounded particularly chipper. “I’m glad you rang, especially after last night’s text proposal. Because there’s something I need to say to you.”

What?

“Your *thing* is still here, in my safe; I want it out of here today.”

He pulled into traffic; it was like floating, nudging along with the other bubbles, drifting up Euston Road and beyond. That part of him that always seemed to be thinking, and assessing, went to work on the major and all the other players. A spiral of conflicting ideas turned slowly in his head, all centred on Amy. Somehow, if he could understand why she died, he could impose some sort of order. Euston Road gave way to Pentonville Road, but it didn’t come with any answers.

It was like photography; change the lens or the filter and the same composition looked completely different. It evoked a different response from the viewer. Well, he was the one viewing this now — so what was he looking at? Where could Jess have gone? She must have been somewhere on the base, else why would the major have needed to get her out? Could she and the major have been seeing each other after all? He tried it on for size; it didn’t fit. Nah, nothing in the major’s behaviour so far supported that. His best hope was confronting Jess in front of the major.

* * *

When Karl put in an appearance in the office, Thomas was still puzzling. Ann Crossley looked over at the door, acknowledged him and then went back to her work — whatever that actually was right now. On balance, Thomas preferred it when the two of them were at loggerheads; this new entente cordiale was doing his head in.

Karl made a beeline for him and patted him on the shoulder. “I need another favour — not right now, but in the next week or so.”

“Fire away.”

“Funny you should say that. I need visual surveillance on Jack Langton. All photos with cross-hairs superimposed. At home, family, business — the full package. Think you can handle that? I’ll pay you . . .”

Thomas gazed into his eyes. “I can handle it. You can fill me in at the club, later this week.”

Karl sat down and started dialling. “Major Eldridge, it’s Karl McNeill here. I take it Jess is with you? Yeah, I know. I’m fine, thank you.” He kept everything matter-of-fact. “I agree — where? Just like old times then; we’ll see you both at noon.”

Thomas watched from the vending machine, straining to pick up the gist as he navigated through the selection options. When he’d collected a third ‘delicious’ beverage — for Ann Crossley — he manhandled them back, detouring by her first. Karl rose up from his desk.

“Better drink that quick, we’re heading out.”

* * *

“Is this for real?” Thomas took a step back and tilted his head. Karl looked right at home, standing between the twin guns at the top of the steps that led into the Imperial War Museum.

“It’s worse than you think, Tommo. This is the site of Bethlem Hospital — the original Bedlam. The major and I used to meet here, in the old days.”

It didn’t sound like an invitation to further discussion. “And what’s today’s objective?”

“Find out what the hell is going on, that’s what.” Karl clutched a carrier bag in one fist, raising it aloft as if it held week-old fish. “The shoes were left behind because someone didn’t want us to know where she’d been this morning. A simple sweep would have picked up the bug in her heel.”

“Well, it’s twelve o’clock so where are they?”

Karl turned to the great doors, from where the major emerged, Jess close at hand. Her face lit up at the sight of Thomas; a sentiment he didn’t share. Karl waited for the happy couple and led the party of four away, to the Peace Gardens next door.

“I never had you pegged as a man of peace, Karl.” the major looked decidedly uncomfortable among the white pillars and stones.

Karl seemed lost for an answer, so Thomas obliged him. “From the very beginning, *you* came to *us*, both of you. And since then you’ve told us everything except the truth.” He looked directly at the major.

The major seemed unfazed. “Are we all square, Karl?”

“Yeah,” he held out the carrier bag. “Electronics deactivated and removed.”

Jess made a grab for the shoes and scowled at the major.

“Now, Thomas here has some questions for Jess. It’d be easier for everyone if we could just get on with it.”

Jess gazed at Thomas earnestly and then took a step towards him.

“Where were you when Amy died?”

She stopped in her tracks. Everyone froze on the spot, but Thomas caught the signal that the major threw her way, even if he didn’t understand it.

“I was outside.” Jess spoke quietly. “We had a visitor.”

The major turned to her slowly; clearly, this was all news to him.

“Mr Schaefer came to see me; it was my lunch break.”

But not Amy’s? “Go on. What else?”

“He’s always been very interested in us; we were trying to finish all the tests ahead of schedule. Mr Schaefer promised us a bonus if we completed the full spectrum of scenarios early.”

“And how would you do that?” the major’s veins had come out on parade.

“We worked it out between us,” she sounded proud of her own intelligence. “Coming in early and finishing late, splitting our lunches.”

Major Eldridge stared, rigid with malice. If he’d been carrying a gun, Thomas reckoned he’d have shot her. “How much?” He hissed.

“Five thousand pounds each.” Jess seemed bemused. “Amy said we could go away on a cruise together.”

Thomas stared. She couldn’t help putting herself in the middle of the picture. Amy was dead, but Jess was still painting herself as the orphan. He gravitated towards one of the pillars, aware that Karl wasn’t far behind him; it was starting to feel like a business negotiation. “All this for five grand?” The knot was coiling in his abdomen.

“You don’t get it, do you, Tommo? Schaefer was willing to take shortcuts, to risk lives for five grand apiece. But that’s not the half of it; we’ve more digging to do.”

Jess and the major were right where they’d left them, not talking to each other. Thomas wondered how the major was taking the knowledge that

his mistress had been sacrificed on the altar of expediency. “What’s Schaefer giving you for the data you stole?” Simple, blunt, unambiguous.

“No.” Jess screwed her face up into a ball. “I never stole anything. Mr Schaefer asked me to memorise the data; it was one of my extra jobs, right from the beginning. Sometimes he’d visit and quiz me to check — it was our little game.”

Thomas looked at Karl, who shrugged off control of the conversation. He tried again. “So what’s in it for you now?”

“Mr Schaefer’s promised to take me away.” She smirked. “Don’t worry, not romantically, silly! He’s offering me a new job in America — a fresh start. Mr Schaefer says that there are opportunities with other consortium partners.”

Yeah, Thomas thought, and Mr Schaefer’s a scumbag who . . . He stopped, mid-thought, and stared at the stark, white pillars of marble. Bingo. Jess was a rare talent; Schaefer could move her around like a human memory stick. The clever bastard. And of course, once she was in the US, she’d be out of the picture. “When are you next seeing Schaefer, Major?”

Major Eldridge answered. “Tonight, to confirm the arrangements. Once Jess is safely through passport control, I’ll hand over both copies of the DVD. Karl — I’ll need yours back.”

Thomas took a breath; surely the major realised that Jess’s departure would cast suspicion on him? Or maybe a cover-up was better than everything coming out in the open. Yeah, that would make sense: a mutual cover-up.

Chapter 31

Getting Jack Langton's details from the Wrights wouldn't have been difficult — one phone call, basically. But better they were kept in the dark. Miranda too, come to that. This was a private job for Karl and it would have to stay that way. It was hard to remain hidden these days. What with the Internet and private investigators. Thomas had once fancied himself as a private dick — part Sherlock Holmes and part Masked Avenger. Back when his career at the SSU looked to be coming to a premature end, he'd seriously considered it. *Note to self: be careful what you wish for.*

The office in Dalston was a portal into a murky world. From the outside, it could have been a minicab outfit; tinted windows with gig posters plastered over them like camouflage. It looked the kind of place you check your shoes on the way out — and your pockets.

He went inside and took a seat, waiting for the woman across the desk to stop glaring at him.

"Ave you got an appointment?" she dared him to reply, opening her desk diary to confirm the obvious.

"No. I was just passing." Like anyone ever sees a private investigator on the off chance.

"Wait here," she flicked her hair extensions over her shoulders and went to a door at the back.

Peter Tosh was crackling through the radio, pulsing the speakers: 'Coming in Hot.' Thomas felt himself nodding to the rhythm, thinking about Ajit and simpler times. Then he went all self-conscious, wondered how he'd look to the receptionist, like some twatty, inverted racist, *white* guy, thinking he was all 'street.' It didn't spoil the music any.

Hair Girl still had her head poked through the open doorway, playing mutter-tennis with whoever ran Lyon Investigations. She glanced back, checking him out, finished her conversation and then swaggered back to her desk. "Boss says you can go in."

Nice. He walked stiffly past her, rapped on the open door and went in, closing it behind him. "Thurston Lyon?"

The West Indian guy laughed, as if he'd just thought of a howler. "That's what it says on my door. You here to do business?"

Thomas took out a printed page and passed it across.

Thurston looked at it carefully, turning it over, but finding the other side blank. "He owe you money?"

"Something like that. I need his home address and phone number, same for business, car registration and which pubs he drinks at in Hackney and Clapton."

"And then what?" Thurston straightened, the scent of money in the air.

"That's my employer's business." Like Karl had told him, the less he said, the more convincing he'd appear.

Thurston sucked at his teeth. "Is he some kind of gangsta?"

Thomas held his poker face. "The worst kind."

Thurston Lyon laughed again. "In dat case, I need to apply an extra charge — for health and safety."

"When and how much?" Thomas cut to the chase.

Thurston's eyes danced left and right. "Give me two days."

"I need it by this time tomorrow — I'll call you."

"The price just went up," he raised three fingers.

Thomas took £100 from his jacket and flattened it on the table. "I'll speak to you tomorrow. If this works out, my employer could put more work your way." He paused, like Karl had told him to, and then promised that Martin — using his full name — could be a very generous client.

Thurston's eyes flickered, but, as far as Thomas could determine, it wasn't a name the private detective recognised.

Thomas left it at that and walked out, leaving the door yawning behind him. As he reached the street, he glanced back to see Hair Girl scurrying into the office. They looked like they could do with the business.

On the way back to the car, he made a call. "It's done."

"Nice one, Tommo. By the way, Christine's trying to reach you. Our glorious leader requests the pleasure of your company at Whitehall. I'll see you in the park afterwards."

* * *

Thomas supposed he should have got used to the cat's cradle of allegiances by now, but it still rankled. He worked for Christine, and

Christine worked for Sir Peter Carroll. But Karl — who worked with him, for Christine — also pulled Sir Peter's strings. Then there was Michael Schaefer, working for Engamel and spying on Major Eldridge, with Sir Peter's consent. And finally there *he* was: everybody's best friend. Well, maybe not Schaefer's — Thomas hadn't heard from him since Amy's memorial service.

Once again, they kept him waiting in the lobby at Main Building. He thought about taking out his diagram to try and decipher it and decided against it, in case the CCTV took an interest.

And what if he *had* proposed to Miranda by text? Still possible she was kidding, but he might have sent it and then deleted it somehow. If he'd proposed, would that really be so bad? Ajit and Geena were happily settled in their semi, awaiting their firstborn.

Then he remembered his last proper conversation with Miranda; the one where she told him to remove his gun from the premises. No, Ajit was definitely a happy endings sort of bloke. He used to feel the same way about himself, but lately he saw only shadows.

He managed to solve three clues from the *Times* crossword in the ten minutes it took someone to collect him, and he reckoned one of those was probably wrong. The silent treatment in the lift didn't faze him anymore; it was just another facet of the *not-so-great* game. On the way up, he tried to concoct a progress report for Sir Peter; no doubt one was expected.

"Thomas, take a seat." The Old Man continued with his paperwork.

From Thomas's vantage point, it looked like a report of some kind. *Don't bite; don't give him the reaction he wants.* He gazed around the office, settling on the portrait of Churchill — arch defender of Great Britain. And, if you believed the Net, an early proponent of a United States of Europe, and patron saint of federal nutcases.

"Michael Schaefer has concerns about your loyalty." Sir Peter's head was still down.

It speaks. He ran a thumbnail between his teeth, as if sharpening a talon. "Schaefer wants to take Jess out of the country, before the inquiry is complete."

Sir Peter glanced up; he didn't look at all surprised. "Karl McNeill is a loose cannon, Thomas. You'd be wise to keep your distance, especially when he creates problems for himself — and for the department. This is

still my organisation and you'd both do well to remember that. This is not a sport for solo players."

That riled him, as it was supposed to. "Why did you send for me?"

"I think you ought to know certain things; things other people aren't telling you."

"Like Schaefer risking lives to rush through the Scavenger tests?"

Sir Peter snorted. "That's old news, Thomas, and such a worm's eye view. I'm disappointed. I thought you were smarter than that by now."

Thomas tilted his hands open, inviting all the goodies into his lap.

"There's much more at stake than a revolutionary weapon." Sir Peter shook his head slowly, side to side. "You're being used, Thomas. It wasn't a coincidence that you and McNeill were on the base — *he* arranged it with me." And there was that look again, the one that implied, I'm always ten steps ahead of you.

Thomas stared him down. His father used to have a similar look whenever they played chess; right up until the day Thomas checkmated him. Then they never played again. He narrowed his eyes. "Say you're right — so what? Isn't it better that the reasons behind Amy's death are out in the open?"

"Do you really think a fully-funded military research programme will grind to a halt because of a project director's inability to control one of his staff? Open your eyes, Thomas!"

One by one, the pieces slid together. It didn't really matter who carried the can — Amy, the major or Schaefer. The wheels of industry would continue turning, regardless. The great and the good would have their new toy.

What he couldn't figure out, from this sitting at least, was which side of the line Sir Peter stood. Time to find out. "You could stop Jess leaving the country — revoke her passport or something?"

"Could I now?" Sir Peter puffed himself up and squeezed his fingers together, daring Thomas to figure it out.

Oh Jesus. His jaw widened. "Unless you're one of the people who wants Jess out of here."

Sir Peter smiled, like a vulture witnessing a car crash. "Congratulations, Thomas; you're finally starting to see things as they are. I'd no more want to impede Jess than I'd have wanted to stop Karl McNeill at Aldergrove."

Thomas swallowed, and Sir Peter's eyes took on a hypnotic gaze.

"Schaefer is a liability. McNeill realises that; it's time you did as well."

He couldn't tell if that was supposed to be a statement or a warning.

Sir Peter folded the file cover down. It looked suspiciously like the one that Major Eldridge had shown him on the base. "We're all parts of one organism, Mr Bladen — symbiotically interlinked for the good of the whole. And what's true for people and organisations can also be true for nations. You do see that now, don't you?" This was starting to sound like a recruitment speech.

"Was there anything else, sir?"

"That will be all. Take care, Thomas. For all our differences in the past, I wouldn't like to see you come to any harm."

He made his way outside, switching his mobile on in the lift. He picked up a message at the door, from Michael Schaefer. And he didn't believe in the Coincidence Fairy today.

* * *

Karl was ready and waiting in St James's Park, sat on their usual bench and toying with a domestic camera. "You look like a man with something to say." He pulled a muffin from a bag at his side.

Thomas received the bounty and slowly rotated it. "Have you ever lied to me?"

"Never," Karl was abrupt. "I may evade the question and hold things back, but there'd be no point deliberately lying to you. What's on your mind?"

He parked the use of *deliberately* and picked at the muffin, pulling off the chocolate chunks first, like a child. "Our leader reckons you arranged the photography gig at the arms fair." He stalled, waiting to be proved wrong.

"It's true."

Thomas cursed under his breath. "And the reason is . . ." He left a gap a mile wide.

"Quite simply, I was hoping to have a nosey — see if there was anyone there that I recognised from files."

He'd whittled away most of the chunks. "And I'm s'posed to believe you?"

Karl grabbed a muffin for himself. “You can believe what you like, Tommo. It happens to be the truth.”

Truth. He’d started to wonder if anything was true anymore. “Coincidence, then, that your former Major was on the base as well?”

“No, no. I knew that in advance. I expected to make contact with him in the afternoon; as we discovered, he knew we were on site. And then of course, there was Amy.” Silence followed. “Look, I promise you this, I would only keep something from you if I thought it was in the long-term interest.”

“So you won’t mind telling me while I dragged my arse over to Dalston, using a second-rate private eye to get information I could have found out myself?”

“Hey, hey, there’s nothing second-rate about Thurston Lyon. He’s good at what he does, and if anything goes wrong, he’s one step removed. It’s a sensible false trail, should we need it. You did remember to give him Martin’s full name? You might want to mention it again when you collect the info tomorrow.”

“Yeah, well,” Thomas shrugged his shoulders, “if he’s up to it.”

“Not a worry there; Thurston’s like a Mountie — he always gets his man.”

“So you’ve worked with him before?” He figured he’d push it.

“Well,” Karl took a muffin-sized bite, leaving a thin crescent; “After a fashion. I’ve not met him personally — I always use a go-between, someone I can trust.”

“What? Someone like me?”

“Jesus, make your fucking mind up, Tommo. You want to get involved — but not *too* involved. *And* you want a private life, away from all the cloak-and-daggering. So I keep you at the edges, for your good as well as mine. Now, are we done playing Q & A? I need a sandwich — I’m all sugared out.”

Chapter 32

The neon sign for Caliban's shone out, defying the rain that spattered against the roof and overflowed the guttering. Thomas straightened his coat and wondered what sort of reception awaited him.

The bar was packed, but Sheryl's neck craned up as he eased the door inward. She nodded; he went straight over.

"Miranda around?"

"Go straight up, honey." She had a talent for saying one thing and letting her face tell a completely different story.

As he turned from the bar, a camera flash went off. He flinched, started chambering a fist.

"Relax, they're just tourists — Germans, I think, or Polish."

It looked like a full crowd. And it didn't take Brain of Britain to realise it was Sheryl they were taking pictures of. And she was milking it like a Little Dutch Girl.

The door upstairs was closed; he tried the handle — locked. It felt stupid announcing himself, but he did anyway. Miranda was slow in answering, as if she had something better to do.

She cranked the door open about a foot. "Romeo, Romeo, wherefore art thou, Romeo?" That was far as she managed without laughing.

And yet, when he saw her standing there, laughter cascading through the air like poetry, he almost wished he *had* proposed again, properly. But he knew that those little moments of magic were only that: moments.

"You feel like a nibble?"

He blushed. God, he was useless at playing it cool. The first time he met her, when she was seventeen, he'd broken out in a sweat. And he'd never really recovered since. "Sorry, I've got a meeting with Karl and Jess." Then, to pre-empt whatever caustic remark she was cooking up, he added, "She's being sent abroad."

"What, like an endangered species? Come on, coffee's hot — if you've got the time." She sounded just a little hesitant and he loved her for that.

"Yeah, always time for coffee," he followed her through.

First thing she did was open the safe and return the Makarov pistol to him. It nestled in his palm, cool against his clammy skin. They spoke a little about Karl as they drank their coffee. Miranda wanted to be certain that Karl understood she and her family had known nothing about Jack Langton's overseas business.

"Please give him our condolences and tell him I was asking after him. It wouldn't hurt you to bring him here for an evening."

He smiled; how times had changed — a few months back, Karl had been banned from the premises and now she was sending out invitations.

"And you can relax, about last night. It's okay, babe, I knew you were pissed — you called me Randa. You only ever do that when you're drunk.

He nodded, and reminded himself to remember that.

"And just so you don't go torturing yourself, it was a nice text . . ."

He kissed her, the polite kind — a supreme act of self-control.

"Anyway, I think you're already married — to your job."

The weight of the Makarov, inside his jacket, tended to support that.

* * *

He had hoped to meet Karl beforehand, but he was already running late. Couldn't very well leave Caliban's without spending a little quality time with Miranda. So by the time he arrived at the restaurant — that *same* restaurant near Leicester Square — and scoped them from across the street, the party looked to be in full swing. He caught the Engamel trio through the bay window; saw that Deborah and Clarity had dressed a little more demurely this time. A little, but not much. Schaefer looked to be in for a busy night; there didn't seem to be an American word for *subtle*.

Karl was there too, holding court, palling up with Michael Schaefer. It was all like some garishly detailed Hogarth drawing. Jess was at one end of the table; she looked lost, out of her depth. Until she spotted him, that was. She waved enthusiastically as he approached, which left him little option but to go inside.

A single seat awaited him, next to Jess. No sign of the major. As Thomas sat down, Karl broke off from his captivating monologue. "Major Eldridge won't be joining us, he has some domestic crisis."

"Got that right!" Schaefer laughed into his beer.

By the look on Schaefer's face and the one he gave Deborah, it reeked of a stitch-up. Thomas didn't bother commenting. Schaefer was a little cool with him at first, skimming over the misunderstanding at the memorial service and 'that feisty blonde.' Miranda would have gotten a kick out of that.

He kept his cool and let Schaefer's mouth run its course. From the looks of things, Karl had dug himself in, good and proper. It wasn't worth spoiling the mood unless there was something to gain.

Jess seemed happy to split from the main party, free to talk about her favourite subject: herself. Specifically, her new life in America. "Of course, you'll be able to visit me once I've settled into my new job. Isn't that right, Mr Schaefer?"

Schaefer lifted his head, and with some prompting from Deborah, muttered: "Sure thing, honey — whatever you say." Then whispered something to his gang that produced a peal of laughter.

Jess carried on, oblivious. "I was sorry that things never worked out with Cecil, but sometimes it's for the best. Don't you agree?"

Thomas chased his starter around the plate and just nodded. He wasn't practised at listening to two conversations simultaneously — if you could call Jess's 'let's talk about me' monologue a conversation — but Schaefer and les femmes were doing their damndest to suck Karl into their comfort zone. He just hoped Karl could see that as well. They locked eyes, for a second, and Karl winked at him over his glass.

The main course signalled a change in the proceedings, with Schaefer taking centre stage and praising Jess's gift. "You're a special little lady and we're lucky to have you."

Clarity and Deborah formed an applause section, with Karl joining in off the back of them. And though Schaefer and Karl were still doing some kind of 'men of the world' routine, with Deborah flirting with both of them, Clarity seemed to have slipped through the gaps. She smiled softly and Thomas studied her face, trying to reason out what she was doing with these people.

Jess had moved on to outlining her holiday plans, once she was Stateside. Schaefer had fed her a complete travelogue, everything from New England in the fall to Christmas in Oregon and all points in between. In

essence, he'd sold a tourist's fairy tale to a fantasist, which had a certain justice to it.

Thomas took to whispering with Jess: conspiring, to be more accurate. She loved it, of course, pulling him in close so that her hot breath landed on his face. And that perfume, if he wasn't mistaken, was the same floating scent that had haunted the accident scene like a wraith — probably something else she'd taken from Amy.

"I really thought Cecil would be here tonight — I know he wanted to be," he tried his luck at the wishing well.

Jess leaned in again. "Mr Schaefer thought it was best if he stayed away, in case it upset him. What with Amy and I being so close, and this being my last day and everything." There was a slight twang to her voice, faux American, as if she were already morphing into her new identity.

He let it pass. "So you're flying tomorrow?" It never hurt to check the facts.

"Of course, silly," she squeezed his arm, feeling his bicep. "And you're coming to see me off at the airport."

"I am?" No one had mentioned seeing her off the premises.

She seemed flummoxed for a moment, as if the house of cards was wobbling. She drew her hands back. "Anyway," she smarted, "it's all arranged, so you have to be there."

Right that minute, he could have taken out the Makarov and shot Schaefer with a clear conscience. Jess might be deluded — and there was little doubt of that on tonight's performance — but Schaefer was vermin.

Jess made another play for his arm. "You will be there?" she pouted.

"Wouldn't miss it for the world," he patted her hand, aware that Clarity was taking an interest in them now. "About your memory trick . . ."

Jess cut in straightaway. "It's not a trick," she bustled, affronted. "It's a *gift*."

"Sorry, my mistake." He poured more wine for her. "I think it's fascinating. I mean, how long can you retain things for? I bet you have trouble keeping it all in."

She beamed. "It's all quite logical, really. Anyone can learn it to an extent, but I'm a *natural*." Again, that last word was mangled into a mid-Atlantic drawl — genuine shudder fodder. "I store a picture in my head and revisit it periodically. The key is to frame the image in detail and keep it

fresh. I write it out from scratch a few days later and compare it with the original — I've never achieved less than one hundred per cent."

"Are you sure you wouldn't struggle to recall some things, a little bit?" he tapped the words out on her hand.

"I would not!" she grinned, sloshing wine on the tablecloth as she flattened out a napkin. "I'll prove it to you."

He laughed, just happening to have a pen to hand, and leaned across to block other people's view. Her eyes looked up, to the left, at some faraway place. Then she started to write with remarkable speed, small neat columns of data, adding the row and column headings afterwards. It didn't take long.

"There," she said breathlessly.

Then, as he stared at her, open mouthed, she moved in and kissed him. As her tongue explored his mouth, he sat as rigid as a virgin on her wedding night, one hand clawing at the napkin to drag it under the table.

Schaefer banged on the table. "Hey, Tommy, there's people here, okay?"

Jess disengaged. He didn't have to fake the embarrassment; it was there in spades as he suffered the scathing laughter from the other end of the table. Clarity wasn't laughing though; she stared intensely, as if she were taking everything in — the seen and the unseen.

"You do like me, don't you, Tommy?" Jess pressed against him and he shifted round to make sure the gun stayed on his blind side.

"I'd like you even more if you could remember all those figures; it would really help me in *my* job."

"Well, alright," she whispered huskily, "if you promise to wave me goodbye at Heathrow." She nodded as if she'd just agreed something with herself. "I'm going to contact Amy's family once I get my new apartment. I think they'll be glad to know that Amy had a good friend over here."

He held his hands still, fighting the urge to slap her.

"And maybe, when they've got to know me, they'll invite me to stay with them for a while."

Oh Jesus. She really was up there in her ivory tower, unable to make sense of the world below.

"I need the gents," he declared, like a plea bargain, and stood up.

"I'll join yer, Tommo." Karl looked over. "If you'll excuse me, ladies."

They giggled on cue. Schaefer remained with his harem.

“When do we get to leave?” Thomas headed straight for the stalls.

Karl broke wind, muttered something about ‘better out than in’, and unzipped at the urinal. “It won’t be much longer. Dessert, coffee — forty-five minutes, max,” he spoke over his shoulder.

“I feel like a bloody escort service.” Thomas finished up and yanked the chain.

“You looked like an escort!” Karl joined him at the sinks. “Now, let’s get back in there and be on our way.”

* * *

Jess had insisted he walk her up to her room and everyone else had colluded. It felt like Karl was pimping him out.

She took his arm as they left the restaurant, allowing him to steer her to her hotel. She was past tipsy, but not bladdered. The delicate state where Miranda would normally be unguarded and adventurous — not something he wanted to think about while in Jess’s company.

“Would you like to pop in for a nightcap?” If she was aiming for seduction, she’d overshot the target by about a mile.

“I’d better not. I still have things to do before tomorrow.”

She threw her arms around him again and made a clumsy lip lunge. This time he was ready and turned his cheek. “Good night then.”

Downstairs, the Engamel team were waiting along with Karl. Schaefer checked his watch as Thomas arrived. “Well, Tommy, you’re either a fast worker or you struck out.” More laughter.

Karl kicked off a round of goodbyes and then the two of them made their escape. When Thomas turned to make a final farewell, he noticed Clarity’s guarded wave. At this rate he’d be needing a minibus for the fan club.

“How’d you get on?” Thomas clung to the door handle of the taxi as it performed centrifugal-force experiments on Shaftesbury Avenue.

Karl leaned forward and checked that the secrecy button was on. “Schaefer’s got Major Eldridge in his sights as the fall guy. And without all the missing data, it doesn’t look good for him.”

“I don’t get it though — the major’s not part of Engamel or the research, is he?”

“Whatever the official line is, take it from me, he’s involved.”

Thomas shook his head to try and clear it. “Hold on, then, so is Eldridge friend or foe?”

“Nah.” Karl replied. “It doesn’t work like that, unfortunately. But I happen to know that the major wants the data, to prove that the Scavenger wasn’t ready for the advanced tests.”

“Ergo: Schaefer is in some way responsible for Amy’s death.” That should have been a conversation killer, but Thomas’s inquiring mind was still inquiring. “What stopped the major attending tonight?” He watched Karl closely.

“Nothing. Schaefer had incriminating evidence sent to Major Eldridge’s home — to his wife in fact. Only it was intercepted and I warned the major.”

* * *

The taxi dropped Karl off at King’s Cross, nowhere near his flat in Kilburn. Thomas understood the combination of privacy and paranoia to the point where he didn’t even feel the need to comment.

“Are we still tubing it to Heathrow tomorrow?” Thomas asked as Karl was out the door.”

“Wouldn’t miss it for the world — give me a call on the mobile when you surface.” And then suddenly Karl was away, scurrying down the stairs like a commuter on speed.

“Where to next, guvnor?”

He cringed inwardly and muttered, “Walthamstow Central tube station.” Sod it — Schaefer was paying. Late-night London was ablaze with neon and awash with the sort of people you’d avoid by daylight. They all whirled by in brief snatches of tragedy and comedy. Scenes that lured a photographer out of a warm bed. Note to self — charge up his phone for the morning . . . phone; that reminded him. He still had Karl’s mobile from the base *and* he hadn’t checked the major’s two landlines for a day. A little unpaid overtime when he got home, then.

The walk from Walthamstow Central always set his senses on overdrive, but stupid to get another cab from there for a few minutes’ walk. He bunged the cabbie a fiver tip, promising himself to get half of it out of Karl in the morning, and pulled his jacket in. The Makarov was eager for action and an amusing scenario played out in his head; some fuckwit

mugger would step out of nowhere and make a very bad decision indeed. It amused him because he wasn't into all that macho toss at all; he'd done a little boxing at school — out of some crazy idea that he'd take his dad on — but Walthamstow didn't need a vigilante. At least, not this one.

Past the burger bar, sidestepping the alcopops gang and on beyond the old cinema. Now the street lighting became more sparse and the side roads scattered off the main road like lures for the unworldly traveller. He gripped the Makarov, stroking his thumb along the hatching on the handle until he found the embossed star. Now he was the sheriff again, and the sheriff always wins, right?

Left, down Greenleaf Road, crossing over to face any oncoming traffic, his mind acutely aware of everything around him. Out to the middle of the road, where the gardens looked overgrown, walking at a steady pace and checking side to side. He could have jogged home in half the time but that sent out all the wrong signals.

Along the street and up the five steps. Then pause and check behind, before opening the door. It still didn't feel like *his* door, not when he knew that Karl had replaced it a few months back when some scumbag smashed it in. The last time Karl had spoken of it, the guy responsible was still employed in some government department, still looking over his shoulder for Karl. Justice of a sort.

* * *

It wasn't the beer that had made his head spin — Thomas had managed to keep his consumption to a minimum. No, it was Karl's comments about Major Eldridge — all coagulating together into a misshapen mess.

Yet there was still one mystery: who had taken the Land Rover? Logically, the major, but he would have soon discovered that the Scavenger parts had been removed. So why remove the vehicle and why hadn't he mentioned it? Something else to add to his notes.

He plugged in a charger to Karl's mobile, using a universal socket thing, and sat down in the kitchen to await the kettle. The room needed redecorating, same old paint job since he'd split with Miranda; same old four walls. Why did he stay in that flat? He didn't know his neighbours, didn't socialise there, and couldn't even guess at the local shopkeeper's name. Well, maybe the owner of the takeaway, at a push. Half a life,

Miranda had called it — the worse half, because she reckoned he mostly lived through his work.

And what was his work these days? He grabbed the kettle and made the tea, blowing the cup to breathe in the steam. Maybe Miranda was right, not that he'd tell her. Tonight, punch-drunk by half-truths, lies and counter intelligence, he felt crowded out of his own existence. He took his tea to the front room, but his conclusions followed him. Keen for a diversion, he plonked the mug on a coaster and sent an off-the-cuff text to Ajit: *Are you losing all the weight that Geena's gaining?* Added the obligatory smiley face and fired it off. Probably a good idea to check Karl's magic mobile as well, just to make sure the market bought adapter wasn't in danger of overheating.

As he crossed the room, he felt a sense of disquiet. No reason for it, but something nagged at the back of his brain — a piece of logic that eluded him. He turned Karl's throwaway phone on. There was a recent text from Major Eldridge: *Thanks Karl. I knew you wouldn't let me down. My offer still stands.* And one voice message. Probably more of the same and, given the text, he was anxious to find out what the offer was. What could the major give to Karl? And then it hit him, the one thing Karl didn't have — a door back into the army. *Shit.* He dialled in and sat down uncomfortably for the message.

"It's Jess," the voice was insistent. "I've been thinking about you, Tommy. I need to speak to you on your own, before I go away tomorrow — it's really important. I feel awful not telling you before, but I was afraid it would change things." She left her hotel room number, in case he'd forgotten.

He finished his tea first — it wasn't as if Jess was going anywhere tonight. And he rang Miranda first, a quick five-minute chat, just to see how she was and whether she was missing him. Adolescent stuff. An itch that needed to be scratched, every once in a while.

"It's not even eleven yet — did your dinner party fizzle out?"

"Yeah, we ran out of blondes." Especially the feisty kind.

"Terry called me today — wanted to know how long you planned to keep your stuff at you-know-where . . ."

He laughed, then she did as well. A good point though. Why hadn't Karl taken the Scavenger parts away? "Dunno, I'll speak to you-know-who

tomorrow.”

“You’re such an arse.”

“I know. G’night, babe.” It was like a hug in a call — the sexy kind.

And now for the human chameleon. He was put through by the hotel switchboard. Jess picked up and he heard the TV fade to the background. They swapped pleasantries, agreed that the restaurant meal was great and then he steered the conversation back to the point.

“Well,” Jess needed a run-up. “Don’t be mad at me; I should have told you something before. Only Mr Schaefer was rude about me when you and Mr McNeill were in the bathroom. He called me a photocopier.”

Thomas suppressed a chuckle and offered his sympathies.

“Thank you, Tommy, I knew you’d understand. Anyway, where was I?” She found her way back to the spotlight. “Clarity and I worked together before, just for a little while, on a project to develop a vehicle.”

“I see,” he said, not seeing at all. “Out of interest, what was it?”

There was a long pause, followed by a loud sigh, as if she’d drawn the receiver closer. “I know I can trust you — it was codenamed C12. I reported to Clarity, and after three months I was suddenly transferred over to the UB40, working alongside Amy.”

“Thanks for telling me, Jess. Look, I’d better go — I’ll see you tomorrow — why don’t we get there early then we can have a coffee together, just the two of us?”

“Tommy, that night, at your flat — I wish you had taken advantage.”

He put the phone down carefully and lifted his hand away, as if it were toxic. She’d make someone, somewhere, a wonderful stalker.

As his laptop booted up, he took out the log-in details for the server and sat, ready. The usual procedure — an anonymising server first and then calling up sound surveillance for the major’s two office phones. He started with the one the major knew about. It was run-of-the-mill stuff, mainly day-to-day comms and a couple of family calls. Mrs Eldridge gave the impression of being a real blue blood, the sort that Christine Gerrard’s mother would have welcomed with open arms.

Line two was a little light on recordings — which made sense now that Jess was out in the open. The final file held a nasty surprise. It was a landline call from Karl, thanking the major for his assistance in Belfast. So far, so what? Then things took a sharp detour. Thomas listened, rooted to

the screen as the vocal peaks and troughs played out for him like dancing daggers. Major Eldridge was offering Karl a deal: the deal of the century in fact. If he got the data out of Jess, to hold Schaefer accountable for Amy's death, then the major would *guarantee* a way back into the army.

Thomas's first instinct was to ring Karl, there and then, and have it out with him. Then again, Karl hadn't responded other than agreeing to give the matter consideration. He bit on a fingernail and replayed the call. Was it really his business what Karl did? Point and counterpoint rolled around in his head. He logged off and shut the laptop down, leaving the arguments to fight it out in his dreams.

Chapter 33

Thomas floated up from the depths of sleep, gradually becoming aware of the wind outside. Safe in his bed, he pictured the rubbish being blown up the street. As if God Himself was clearing up the place, once and for all, and making a bloody racket about it. He heaved his eyes open; it had to be early, the sun hadn't put in an appearance. He rolled to one side and the alarm clock glared back in the semi-darkness, silently screaming: five twenty-five.

He smiled. Somewhere out there was the prospect of a sunrise, waiting to be photographed. If he got a shift on, he could be at Epping Forest for the dawn, to watch that pale brilliance streaking through the tree line. Or he could relax back into the mattress, close his eyes and spend the next hour or so in warm comfort. No contest. He sprang out of bed and tiptoed around the flat, as if in fear of waking himself. In times gone by, he used to leave Miranda little notes on the pillow — dragging her along had always delayed things and often started an argument. Now, there was no one to tell, but there was still a rush of excitement. He was a kid again, lugging his rucksack to the front door in Pickering, where Ajit's dad would be waiting outside.

Final bag check: flask, camera, emergency chocolate bar — no point wasting time on a shower — and out the door. He could see right up the street, sense the onset of the day. His mother would have called it a holy moment; he could live with that assessment. A quick bite of past-its-best snack bar and then a gratuitous door slam for the benefit of his neighbours. Lower the rucksack carefully into the passenger-side foot well, and chocks away.

* * *

The A406, heading east, held few surprises and almost no companions. Just a postal van trying to break the land-speed record and a bunch of lads probably heading home after a trip to the pleasure dome. You could love all humanity at a time like this, when it was sleeping. Only when the teeming masses came to life, clogging the roads and his head, did humanity degenerate into liars, cheats and arseholes.

At the first sign for Epping he gave a cheer. Didn't matter that he was alone in the car; it was just one of the rules. Like apologising for farting when you didn't mean it, or wondering how your ex spent her weekends, when you didn't really care. Traditions you follow, stuff that makes you who you are.

Now came the second wave of elation: where to park, where to walk and how to frame the shot? Occasionally he'd seen other snappers out there, plus the odd wayward soul, seemingly from nowhere. No possessions or car, as if they'd materialised at the roadside. Always male, and he never stopped for them.

He guided the car in, with that delicious muffled sound of tyres on dirt. The wind rocked the car gently in welcome. He took another bite of the sad snack bar, grabbed the camera and started walking. Many photographers — according to the chat rooms — already knew what they were looking for, so it was a case of matching the picture in their heads. Thomas tended to fit into the other category, treating spontaneity as a gift from circumstance.

If you waited long enough, cleared out your mind of all the dross about your job, your bank balance and — God help us — your relationship, the picture would come. Never failed, like a child wishing for a present that the parents had already bought and hidden away.

Up the ridge, a pallid sky awaited, shimmering blue grey at the edges, with a last star or two and a vanishing moon. One massive beech tree, stark before him, reached out to the cosmos, dominating the frame — it had to be. The wind blew on, rattling the branches, daring technology to capture a moment of stillness in a ballet of movement. Withering leaves flickered to some jazz rhythm he hadn't connected with. He paused a little longer, then: one beat, four beats, steady now, seven beats . . . nine beats — *snap, snap, snap, snap*. No checking until he got home though — a golden rule, seldom broken. Commissioned photos were different of course, and he'd had one or two of those over the years. But the unanticipated, gifted pictures were magical. And Pandora's Box could only be opened once he was back at home. Otherwise, he might spot an error and try to correct it, might try to manufacture *natural*. That never worked. Even if you achieved a better composition, it ended up stilted and hollow to the trained eye.

He strolled back to the car, closed the door and poured his tea. When he'd been a young boy, his dad had done this with him. That was one

memory of home he treasured. Although, as the years had wound forward through the trials of adolescence up to when he was kicked out of the house, he'd almost convinced himself that he'd imagined it. Not today though. Because this morning, right now, he remembered how he *felt*.

The drive back to the flat was tinged with sadness. Time for work, time for school: it was all the same, all lining up for someone else's parade. He smiled as he spotted the first super-commuters and lorry drivers, patting his camera at the lights and telling himself that he wasn't like the rest of them. And almost believed it.

* * *

Second exit from the flat, time became important again. He finished the flask of tea in lieu of breakfast, and promised himself he'd do a proper shop later in the week. The forced march, up to Hoe Street, got the blood pumping. If he could collect some data from Jess, and get the info from Thurston Lyon, it would have been a successful day.

He swiped himself through the barrier, tried to forget that this could track his movements, and scanned the free newspaper as he walked. He carried both mobiles — his and Karl's throwaway. And before he'd left the flat, he'd copied the accident footage to a disc, just in case. They'd probably put that on his headstone: Here lies Thomas Bladen — just in case.

First call, McNeill residence. "Good morning campers, rise and shine."

"Ah, Tommo, I'm glad you caught me early. Afraid I can't make the John Denver fest."

"The *what*?"

"Leaving on a jet plane; catch up when you can."

Thomas leant against the wall to avoid the slipstream of people swarming past, and waited for an explanation. "Because?"

There was a deep sigh from Karl. "Stuart Fraser rang me late last night. It seems that my cousin Marion contacted the authorities, asking after me. Apparently, Martin sent flowers to her house — on my behalf, as I'm supposed to be in custody."

Thomas pushed his suspicious nature down.

"So Marion has been asking all sorts of awkward questions, such as when was I in Belfast and what have I been arrested for. Poor Stuart has had

to take cover behind a ‘no comment’ statement and now solicitors might be involved. The upshot is that I need to lay low this morning and straighten everything out. I’ve left a message to put Christine in the picture. You’ll be able to cope on your own, won’t you?”

“Sure,” he said, except he didn’t think so. “I’ll call you as soon as Jess is on her way.”

“Thanks, Tommo, have a nice time.”

It felt like a good sign that Karl could still muster sarcasm. “Yeah, you too.” So, he’d be Billy-no-mates among the Engamel crowd. Not counting Jess — and he wasn’t. He jumped the first available train and did some mental juggling.

It went like this. Karl knew that both of the major’s lines were bugged, and *he* had rung the major, not the other way round. Maybe Karl wanted Thomas to know about the deal? So did it compromise their working partnership? Possibly. Or perhaps it just showed how desperate the major was to hang Michael Schaefer, which didn’t make him a bad judge of character.

The train juddered back and forth, back and forth, moving thoughts around his head like ball bearings in a child’s puzzle. Every time he thought he’d achieved equilibrium, something set off another thought ricocheting against its neighbour. As the train surfaced at Gloucester Road, he dredged up a text from Jess. He scrolled through the warm welcome, to the meeting point in Terminal 4. And got out at South Kensington to get a ticket extension to Heathrow.

More passengers with cases were joining the train now — the ones who couldn’t, or wouldn’t, afford the Heathrow Express. No, this was more his style, especially if your idea of fun was crowd control. The connecting carriage door burst in and a shorthaired dude with a stripy waistcoat and a battered guitar began a round of introductions. Soon, the entertaining Aussie started belting out his own little bit of happiness. From Thomas’s end, the bloke didn’t sound bad, if you could hear him above the tutting chorus. Aussie Bloke was lost to the music and into his act, serenading a few and trying his luck with anyone willing to give him the time of day, and some change. Thomas dropped him 40p, just for being a trier.

* * *

At Terminal 4, he wove his way through the United Nations, sidestepping the barricades of suitcases, surfboards and boxes mummified in brown tape. If he'd had the day to himself, he could have happily hung around, immersing himself in the sounds and colours and excitement of travelling. But the only excitement today was the prospect of getting useful data out of Jess.

There was no surprising her at the rendezvous; as soon as he arrived she was all over him like a rash.

"Tommy!" she quivered, flinging her arms around him.

For reasons he couldn't fathom immediately, she was wearing a headscarf and dark glasses, like a child's idea of an incognito film star.

"Where shall we go eat?"

That newly acquired mid-Atlantic tone was already starting to grate. He played safe and turned the attention back to her; it didn't take much doing. She'd slept well, and her bags were already checked in. Engamel were arranging for everything from her flat to be shipped over by sea. What she really wanted for breakfast was pancakes and syrup. She led the way confidently, having memorised the map.

And speaking of memories. "How did you get on with that test I set you?"

"Oh, let's not talk about that right now, Tommy, not before our last meal together." She breezed along, pausing at anything with a reflective surface, to check herself out.

After the second or third time, he realised who it reminded him of — Miranda, in disguise, when they'd set off for Yorkshire. He gave up trying to fathom what was going on in Jess's mind, and just hoped it included wanting to help him. Two armed police officers glanced sideways at her but let it go. He already had his hand on his ID card, ready to intervene with an explanation. Roll on the final gate call.

They soon arrived at the cafe and settled down to their last supper, in breakfast form. He'd half expected to see an Engamel handler there, so things were looking up. As he sat, watching the same families walk up and down for third time, he had an idea. "I'll be back in a sec." Before Jess could object, he added, "It's a surprise."

She beamed and lowered her glasses. Then he waved with just his fingertips and disappeared into a gift shop. *Gift* was a little strong; a gift to

commercialism, certainly, but that was about it. He found a teddy that was midway between cute and extravagant, swallowed hard as he passed over his credit card, and snuck the carrier bag into his jacket. Then he used a passing family as camouflage and returned to their table from a different direction, clocking her as she stared out, Labrador-like, desperate for signs of him.

“Wotcha!” he pressed a hand against her shoulder blades and felt her mould her back into his palm. “I just wanted to get you a little going away present.” He placed the bag in front of her and sat down to watch the show.

She scrabbled to take her glasses off and peered feverishly into the bag. Fair enough, it was a good teddy, but it didn’t deserve the floods of tears she christened it with.

“It’s beautiful, Tommy — I love it!” she was staring at him now, drinking him in.

Did it feel a little manipulative? Yeah, but he was beyond that point by now. Checking the upload from Karl’s mobile earlier, and seeing Amy again — what was left of her — had removed any final shreds of conscience.

After a minute or two, with no offer of data pages forthcoming, he realised he’d struck out. He tried not to show it in his voice. “When are the others arriving?”

Her face reddened and she brushed her hand tenderly over the teddy bear. “Mr Schaefer is expecting me down by the check-in.”

“Well, let’s not keep him waiting.”

Jess carefully untied her headscarf and put it in the bag with the glasses, followed by the bear. Then she pressed the top of the carrier closed and looked up at him, as if dismayed at her own regression.

He stood and she followed, walking close beside him, prisoner and escort. She didn’t look at mirrors now; she just faced forward.

* * *

Schaefer looked seriously pissed off, gazing in all directions like a hyperactive sentinel. As soon as he laid eyes on them, he lifted his mobile to call off the search. Clarity and Deborah quickly emerged from different directions, through the crowds.

“You’re late.” Schaefer had a talent for the obvious.

“My fault,” Thomas took the flak. “I asked Jess to meet me for breakfast and we got talking.”

Schaefer’s face turned barley white. The two harpies looked worried too, particularly Clarity. It was hard not to enjoy the moment. The party of five moved off along the concourse, two prisoners now, and Schaefer leading the way. If Schaefer was wondering about Karl’s absence, he was keeping pretty quiet about it; all he seemed interested in was getting Jess through security and away. Away from Thomas, most probably.

Deborah and Clarity were sharing whispers. Thomas stayed alongside Jess, slowing when she slowed, keeping her company. One suggestion was all it took to divert them to a coffee shop. After all, as Thomas innocently pointed out, Jess had *plenty* of time yet.

They crowded around a table the size of a footstool. Jess ran true to form, like a wind-up doll, chatting about her new apartment and the new neighbourhood. Reciting enough facts and figures to impress an inquisition. Impressed they may have been, but they were not entertained.

“Hey, Tommy,” Deborah burst in at one of Jess’s pauses for breath, “you ever think of transferring overseas?”

Jess’s eyes shone like headlights. Thomas blinked at Deborah, as if sending her a message in Morse code: *bitch*. Schaefer’s shoulders lifted to accommodate a sickly smile.

“The way I hear it, Tommy’s more of a stay-at-home kinda guy. Outdoors can get pretty rough, don’t you find?”

Thomas’s brain bounded the stepping-stones. His first thought, following after Sir Peter Carroll and his big mouth, was the standoff out on the moors, months before. Mentally, he squared up to Schaefer and nodded for the benefit of the audience. “Yeah, last time I was outdoors I shot a man.” He figured Schaefer knew all the details anyway.

“What d’ya do that for?” Deborah was laughing — at him, and probably at the looks of horror on Jess and Clarity’s faces.

He looked her full in the face, deadpan. “Because he deserved it.”

Then suddenly she wasn’t laughing any more. And nor was Schaefer — this must have been new information for him.

“I thought you guys weren’t licensed to carry a piece.”

Thomas opened his jacket and flicked it with his hands. “We’re not, usually. That was a special occasion — protecting Sir Peter.” He finished

his coffee and rested back in his chair; time to flip the tables, try and fill in a few blanks of his own. “So, what will happen to the testing if Jess is moving on?”

Schaefer’s face took on a swagger, the sort of look that made Thomas want to slam a door into him.

“I’m sorry, Tommy,” he inclined his forehead forward, like a bull about to charge. “That’s privileged information.”

Jess was watching Thomas intently. She seemed to eat when he ate, drink when he drank. He figured he’d better play it cool or she might side with him, take up against the Yanks and refuse to go — not a good career move for either of them.

Fortunately, the clock was still ticking and Jess showed no sign of doing a runner. A real pisser about the data though.

“Hey,” Jess suddenly brightened, “I can write to you at home.”

Deborah and Clarity warmed up a little. Jess waited until she had their full attention. “I still have your address from when I stayed over.”

Schaefer grinned like an idiot; no practice required. “That’s what I love about you Brits — all that stiff-upper-lip bullshit on the outside, but behind closed doors you’re no different to the rest of us.”

Thomas’s eyes bored into Jess, waiting for her to qualify her statement. She didn’t. She milked it, happy to ride his reputation if nothing else. After that, the clock couldn’t move fast enough.

It was a slow walk to the security gate — with Jess hanging loosely on his arm, like a dead pheasant. He didn’t bother shrugging her off; if she needed to act out this last fantasy then so be it — he was past caring what the Americans thought.

One by one, Jess shook hands with the Engamel farewell party. Thomas though, she singled out for special treatment. As the last hand retreated, she called him forward to walk her to the door. Then she turned in front of him, so that she walked into her, and pounced. Her arms slithered inside his jacket and around his waist. She reeled him in and kissed his cheek, moving her lips to his ear. “Thank you for picking me up, that first night.”

He felt something flat being slid into his inside pocket, something very much like an envelope. Then she withdrew her hands and cupped his chin, drawing a final kiss from him before she broke away, sobbing, and went

through the door. He straightened his jacket and turned to face the Engamel cheering section.

“Goddamn, Tommy,” Schaefer clapped his hands together. “You’re a real dark horse! Okay people, how about a little drink, to celebrate a successful conclusion to a difficult situation.”

No one had mentioned Amy, and Thomas wasn’t about to. Especially when there was every possibility that Jess had slipped him something useful. He bore their false bonhomie and took a gamble, reckoning Schaefer was such a cocky bastard that his contempt for Major Eldridge lay just beneath the surface.

“Do you still want me to maintain sound surveillance on the major?”

“Sure, why not?” All he lacked was a Stetson to tilt and some stubble to strike a match against, the prick. Schaefer played to his gang, as if they were discussing whether to torment the fat kid after lunch. “Now come on, Tommy, are you sure you won’t have a proper drink?”

Thomas raised his orange juice and emptied the glass. “Not for me thanks, I’m driving this afternoon — work.” He didn’t elaborate, and no one around him seemed to care enough to pursue it. He did the decent thing, waiting for them to finish up, and they took their time about it. Schaefer and Deborah excused themselves for the loo, leaving Clarity behind like the kid sister cramping their style.

“Know what I think?” she tried to tempt him.

“Nope,” he said flatly. It didn’t seem to deter her any.

“I think there’s never been anything between you and Jess. Wanna know why?” She didn’t wait for him to reply. “She still talks to me, sometimes — she mentions you the same way she used to mention the major, sorta exaggerated, for effect. Because she’s never had any feeling for either of you. It’s all bullshit.”

“What’s your point?” Okay, so he was a little bit interested now.

“I’ve got you figured out, Thomas Bladen. You’re actually one of the good guys.”

He tried his best half-second smile. “Don’t be too sure of that.”

She touched his arm. “Nobody wanted Amy to get hurt.”

His mouth curled up at the edges. “She didn’t get hurt — she *died*.”

Clarity checked to see if the other two were returning. “Look, all I’m saying is: don’t make this into some personal crusade. The assignment will

finish soon; it's not worth making enemies."

He took a long time to think about that, on the tube back into London. It was getting to the point where he didn't know who was threatening whom. And, call him paranoid, but he wasn't about to open the envelope anywhere that had even a gnat's chance of being within sight of a camera. He checked the time on his mobile. Jess would be in the departure lounge by now, probably trying to hit on some poor sod sat on his own. Still enough time to get to Thurston Lyon's place, but later than he'd have liked — should have driven into town first.

At Walthamstow Central he sprinted for the stairs and out the exit, dialling Karl as he slowed to get his breath back. "I'll be in my car in ten minutes then on the road."

"Ten-four, good buddy!" Karl did a poor American accent.

"How did you get on with *your* new buddy?" It always paid to talk in riddles, so Karl could say as much or as little as he wanted to.

"Fraser? Yeah, it was interesting. He's going to attend the funeral on my behalf. Well, on his as well, hoping to run into Martin again."

They were skirting around the obvious. "How about we meet up tonight, after I do my info collection in Dalston?"

Karl must have considered it for all of three seconds. "Yeah, okay. Tell you what, I'll meet you in Hackney and we can drive in together."

* * *

Thomas reached his car, checked the time again and opened the envelope while the engine was running. By the looks of things, Jess had come through for him. Yeah, she was as still mad as a fish but, judging by the numerical content, here was the evidence that the major was so desperate for. He sat in the car, tapping the envelope against the dashboard, wondering. Would this be enough to get Karl back in combats?

Chapter 34

Dalston, like so many parts of London, always seemed to be busy. It might be what politicians would politely call *economically and socially deprived*, but there was a buzz about the place. It was another closed community, as far as Thomas was concerned, but even looking from the car at the lights, there were a million photo opportunities going on. The surly faced woman, heaving bags of shopping across the street with her grandson/nephew indifferent to her struggles, as if his earpieces drowned out his conscience as well. Two girls, because that's what they were, wheeling baby buggies.

He wound the window down a little to take in the sounds of the street; the heavy beat musical backdrop, the spicy food wafting along the street. It made Walthamstow seem second-rate. There was community there too, but he never got to see it. Most of the time E17 was just somewhere to park his car. And speaking of which, it was time to negotiate the back roads near the housing estate and head in on foot.

Some kids were playing football on the green outside the flats. As he passed, one or two stopped to stare at him, firing questions with their eyes. He let them get on with it. Life turned the volume back up on the high street, leaving little space for private thoughts. He pushed the door, and this time there was no music. There was something *amiss*. Nothing out of place, just an atmosphere, as if he'd brought in a bad smell. Hair Girl was watching the door intently. He raised a hand; it made little difference. She must have buzzed or something, nodding to him to go straight in without him opening his mouth. He threw her a smile but it bounced off her face and shattered.

The office door creaked inward. He found himself checking the corners of the room, searching for a tangible reason for his own jumpiness. As soon as he set eyes on Thurston, he stopped searching. The man had scuffmarks across his face and purple bruising on his jaw. One arm hung higher than the other, as if crying out for a sling.

Thurston Lyon didn't speak. He leaned forward with some difficulty, and wrenched back a desk drawer, waiting. Thomas flicked the remaining £200 on the desk. Thurston's eyes never left him.

“The price gone up, brother. I need another two hundred pounds.”

Fuck. He didn’t have it. He stood there, wondering what to do next, trying to remember what he had in his wallet. “I’ve got another £100 and that’s it.” It was easy to show an honest face when you were telling the truth.

Thurston mulled it over and lifted the envelope up. Thomas took out his wallet so Thurston could see he wasn’t bullshitting.

“I hope it was worth it.”

Thomas was startled. So much venom in so few words. He put the envelope in his jacket and buttoned it up. Then he remembered Karl’s words of wisdom and reiterated Martin’s full name and the prospect of further investigations.

“I don’t think so, mister. You are bad luck.”

Nothing much he could say to that. But he thanked him again and went on his way. Hair Girl sucked her teeth at him on the way out; he figured it wasn’t a local version of ‘have a nice day.’ On the way back to the car he dived into a newsagent and grabbed some crisps. Lately he was living on snack food. Note to self: do some shopping.

More footballers of the future stopped to gawp at him. He did wonder what the fuck had happened to Thurston. But hey, what was he going to do about it now anyway?

He got in the car, locked it and sat for a moment. The mobile was on and no one was ringing; may as well check Thurston’s handiwork. He bent forward to extract the envelope. At first, they were just dark shapes, like crows flapping their wings. Then the shapes rushed in, crowding out the light. He registered one white guy and one black, and the iron bars they were carrying. Instinctively he crouched down, one arm above his head as the crowbars converged on the windscreen. *Holy Fucking Christ.* The car shook at the first impact, and the next; then he was shaking so much he couldn’t register any more. The glass creaked like thin ice, fracture webs jigsaw-ing the light from beneath his arm. It may have been six impacts, maybe more.

Then, when he fully expected the whole thing to collapse in on him, they stopped. They didn’t run off though. They looked down on him cowering there, admiring their own handiwork, and bust his headlights for good measure before they jogged away.

His mouth was moist; he tasted blood, metallic and warm. In blind panic and unable to cry out, he'd bit into his own lip. It was quiet outside. No nosey neighbours, no good Samaritans — fuck all. He couldn't stop shaking, fingers trembling as he crushed his mobile in both hands and pressed two thumbs together. One lad, who looked like he'd been playing football earlier, ran past and jeered.

"Karl, I need your help." Thomas didn't remember saying anything else, but he must have, or else how would Karl have found him minutes later?

He didn't get out of the wreckage until Karl arrived in a screech of wheels and brakes.

"Come on; let's have you out of here." There was a hard edge to his voice. He helped Thomas into his own car, put the seatbelt on him and then made another call. "I have a priority collection and repair . . ." He glanced at Thomas. "Hold on, Control, I'll tell you when I'm at the end of the road." They took off, slowing down briefly at the first junction so Karl could call in the details.

Karl drove to a pub a few miles away and parked up outside. "We could skip the club tonight?"

Thomas hadn't spoken up until now, just nodded here and there. "I thought they were going to kill me."

"I know; I'm sorry."

Thomas tilted his head; that didn't sound right somehow. Why would Karl be apologising? He kept it together, pulling Thurston's envelope out.

"You open it," Karl broke eye contact.

He slid his fingernail beneath the seal, watching as the bloodstain from his nail smeared across the crisp white paper. It was a single page, neatly folded into three. He bent it open for both of them to see, and his jaw dropped.

STAY OUT OF MY BUSINESS.

Karl took in a mass of air and blew it out again, like a subdued roar. He took the page and screwed it up into a ball, crushing it tight. Then he stuffed it into the door pocket. "I'll have him."

Thomas felt like there was another voice inside him now; a weaker, younger voice that nonetheless was going to be heard. “You used me.”

Karl put a hand to his face, as if shielding himself from the accusation, or from the truth. “I didn’t know this was going to happen; I swear to you, Tommo. I’ll fucking have him though, and that’s a promise.”

Thomas turned his head slowly and stared at Karl through a haze. Then he pushed his head back against the seat and closed his eyes. It felt as if a single tear was rolling down his left cheek, on his blind side. He wanted to brush it away, but he stayed deathly still, trying to take it all in.

* * *

Karl turned to the passenger seat. “We don’t have to do this, you know.”

“Yeah, we do.” They’d been sat in the car park for at least five minutes, Thomas’s eyes boring into the heavy-duty door of the gun club. Out the corner of his eye, he saw Karl’s brow furrowing. “Come on,” he pulled on the passenger door, letting in a rush of autumnal air. It had been raining again, the damp scent of leaves and change adulterated by the grimy stench of the city.

Thomas was out the door, leaning on the car, pressing against it as if it were a talisman. It wasn’t the thought of the guns that reassured him; it was the environment. Somewhere he could be in absolute control — how often did that happen in life? Answer: never.

As Karl paid their way in and they waited for their IDs to be returned, Thomas thought back to Dalston. Did they rough up Thurston to set *him* up? Or had Thurston tried to cut a deal with Jack Langton and paid the price for his insolence? Maybe it didn’t matter; either way — neither of them had come out smiling.

Karl didn’t bother to offer him a choice of handguns, opting for a pair of Baby Brownings. Thomas smiled when he saw what was in the box. He could palm the gun in one hand. Karl let him go first, obviously some psychological bullshit or an act of penance on his part.

As usual, there was no talking; that suited him fine. He still felt like a jackass for getting emotional over a little thing like terror. Hard to know what was worse really — the shame of cowering there while they destroyed his car or the humiliation of Karl seeing him like that. He tensed his legs,

settled into his pelvis and relaxed his grip a little on the handle. It weighed about the same as the Makarov pistol in his hand, but it felt different. No more thinking. He entered the kill zone and instinct flooded out thought and reason, honing everything down.

Four shots rang out, each a hammer blow that reverberated inside his ribcage. Bang. Bang, bang, heartbeat steadying, sweating over, bang. All done. The gasping click of the empty chamber like a death rattle of some other self, the one he left behind in that private underworld — the one that was afraid. And as he surfaced from the moment, he gazed upon a dark certainty: Jack Langton would have to pay.

Karl's marksmanship was below his usual exemplary standard. Thomas watched from the back of the room, noticing how Karl never seemed to get comfortable. Still, as he knew from personal experience, guilt played havoc with your concentration.

"I meant to ask," Karl finally set the pistols back in their box. "How did you get on with Schaefer at the airport?" It was the closest they'd come to a normal conversation since the emergency pick up.

"He's still a prick. And he wants to maintain the voice tap on Major Eldridge."

"Even with Jess away? Interesting. I mean, she's hardly likely to ring him long-distance."

No, Thomas thought, not *him*. "What's your thinking, then?"

Karl clicked the lid shut. "Maybe he's just being cautious. Unless he's got something else to worry about?"

Thomas reached into his jacket and remembered Karl's none-too-private chat with the major about army recruiting. He didn't say anything, just whipped out Jess's envelope and flopped it on the lid.

Karl stared for a few seconds then reached out a tentative hand. A huge smile spread across his face as he straightened out the pages. "Jesus, Tommo, you're a miracle worker."

He grinned and withstood the pat on the back.

Karl pocketed the envelope. "I'll make us a copy before I hand this over."

There was no follow up about any deal. Thomas let it pass and waited for Karl in the corridor. No doubt about it, the place was beginning to grow

on him. Karl returned, minus the weapons, whistling ‘Mr Postman,’ and led them through to the café area that Karl liked to call ‘the bar.’

“What’s he going to do with it?”

Karl looked up from his coffee. “The major? Assuming the data’s accurate, he could go to the inquiry and accuse Schaefer of negligence.”

Thomas shook his head, he couldn’t see that happening.

“Or,” Karl mused, “if he’s the kind of man I think he is, he’ll want something a little more personal and conclusive.”

In a word: revenge.

“Look, Tommo, I’d like your help with Jack Langton.” Karl waited, checking his reaction before he continued. “As far as everyone is concerned, I’m under lock and key. I can’t very well turn up in Jack’s local watering hole. And besides, it’s not quite what I had in mind.”

Thomas gazed at his right hand, stroking the tiny graze where he’d slipped as he got out of the car. As Karl had dragged him out. “Whatever it is, I’m in.”

Karl’s eyes narrowed and a twisted smile played upon his lips. “Jack Langton already thinks Martin is prying into his life. As far as he’s concerned, *you* were some nobody snooping around on Martin’s behalf and he’s sent you both a clear message to stay away. Now I’m going to tip Jack over the edge.”

“What’s the objective, besides the obvious?”

“Well, I’m hoping Jack will go looking for Martin, big time. After that they can fight it out between them.” Karl checked the clock. “Time I was dropping you home — you got anything to eat?”

“Sort of — but what about my car?”

“Ah, yeah, I’ll arrange a replacement for the time being. Come on then, drink up, I’m getting hungry.”

* * *

They opted for a curry; Karl paid. As they sat waiting for two bhunas, pilau rice and a couple of garlic naans — squinting to follow a football match that neither of them gave a shit about — Thomas wondered how Ajit was doing. Maybe he’d call and clear the air.

Karl gave him a nudge, “D’ya think you and Miranda will ever settle down?”

Cue nervous laughter. “Only if I quit my job.”

“Not very likely, then.”

Somehow this didn’t seem like the time or place to reveal his innermost thoughts and feelings. “And what about you, Karl — think you’ll ever leave the SSU and seek gainful employment?”

Karl nodded towards the counter and leapt up to collect. “Well, I knew this one was coming. My answer’s the same as when you asked me in the mess hall.”

“But the major—” he stood to join him.

“Look, Thomas, it may surprise you to learn that I’ve told you more than I’d tell him. It suits my purpose to have him think I’m itching to get back into camouflage. Now, come on, let’s get this back to yours, we can have that ice cream in your freezer for pudding.”

“Huh?”

“I checked last time, when you were taking a leak.”

“You looked in my freezer?”

“Sure, I’m one nosey bastard — how do you think I got the job?”

* * *

Ten minutes later they were sprawled out on the sofa, devouring bhunas. The TV was showing another wildlife programme, all massive skies and photogenic carnage.

“Divide and conquer, my friend,” Karl dropped in another comment from out of nowhere. “I’ll meet you at work tomorrow and take you to your temporary car.”

Thomas felt like saying it was the least Karl could do, but he was enjoying the company too much to want to ruin it.

“Then you can do a clandestine on Jack Langton, while I’m away at the army base. And best you leave the Makarov at home.”

Chapter 35

Karl had given him a head start, digging out Jack Langton's details. You just had to know the right people to ask.

The Ford Focus smelt of new car. It was immaculate — untouched by ungloved hands, probably. He had a good play with the controls, reminding himself of the time he'd gone with Miranda to buy her new Mini. The salesman had ignored her and spoken only to him. Miranda had dealt with it by insisting on speaking to a woman instead. And, as usual, she got her way.

It had been days now since he'd heard from her. She'd have taken it for granted that he was immersed in work. He watched Karl disappear out the supermarket car park — with the mystery deliveryman in tow — and reached for his mobile. As texts went, it wasn't exactly Shakespeare. The sentiment was there though: *Hi M, how's life in the fast lane? Tx*

* * *

He took a run through Jack Langton's neighbourhood, making sure of the fastest routes to two major roads if he needed them. Forest Gate was remarkably lacking in forest. Lots of big houses though — mostly converted into bedsits, judging by the clusters of overflowing wheelie bins. He clocked the house in question, parked up and waited.

A large man in chinos and a polo shirt squeezed out of the front door. Thomas watched as the guy lumbered down the street towards a high-end BMW — the personalised number plate had been a bit of a giveaway.

Thomas counted the beats as the BMW passed, and started up his trusty new Ford. It wasn't exactly chase of the century, and Thomas gave him enough rope to hang himself. The Ford had an inbuilt low profile; he could have been a sales rep or a teacher, anonymously making his way across town.

Jack Langton drove with one hand, a tree trunk of an arm elbowing out of the window. And naturally, he thought his favourite radio station was too good not to share. The BMW pulled into a bus lane and stopped outside a convenience shop.

Thomas swung in at the next left turn and scrambled out of the car to take up position. Jack Langton was on the phone the moment he got back, newspaper tucked under one arm like he hadn't a care in the world.

Two snaps later, Thomas ran to complete the world's fastest three-point turn, ready for the BMW to pass. As he rejoined the main road, the BMW was just clearing the lights. It was a simple equation: if he caught up with Jack Langton, he'd stick with him; if not, he'd return to Chez Langton for some background surveillance on the family.

He scraped across the lights and made up the distance, three cars behind. It was a perfect position to be in. Close enough to watch the BMW's turns without the need for knee-jerk reactions, and far enough back to be invisible. He played follow-my-leader for nearly half an hour, including a stop-off at a café for a sandwich, heading somewhere in no great rush.

The BMW looked out of place by the flats — a rose among rundowns. Thomas watched Langton stepping lightly into the building and up the centre stairs, catching a glimpse of his silhouette through the glass as he tracked him through a long lens. Up and left, coming out at the second floor, moving along the balcony. Thomas captured a couple of side profiles and counted down the numbers of the doors, wagering with himself that it would all end up with a woman. Jack Langton slowed — number seventeen, unlucky for someone.

Jack rapped at the letterbox — no key — and waited calmly, packed lunch in hand. The door opened and Jack turned towards it, blocking the view with his fat head. *Shift over, you bastard.* Jack bent down and a slim arm curled around his shoulder for what looked like a polite kiss on the cheek. *Just move, will you?*

Thomas froze, button poised, ready for a second's clearance. Bingo, he caught a glimpse of a face and squeezed the button. He heard two bleeps and then he lowered the camera. As Jack wriggled past the woman Thomas's eyes confirmed what the camera had already revealed: it was Sheryl, Miranda's bar manager.

He didn't hang around, made a pact with himself to get as far away as possible. Maybe sweep past Chez Langton on the way home. He felt like a kid who had woken up too early on Christmas morning, only to find out that Father Christmas was actually just his dad. Sheryl and Jack Langton — it

made his skin crawl just thinking about the maths. It explained a couple of things, though. Now he understood why Jack had given Sheryl a bar job, and probably why she was working for Miranda. *And* why the Wrights were so accommodating to her.

The road signs couldn't gallop towards him fast enough. He stopped at a set of lights and slapped the dashboard, examiner style. That must have been what Sheryl meant, back when Miranda had been abducted. For the first and only time, Sheryl had threatened him with a couple of phone calls that would sort him out — no prizes now for guessing who she'd have called.

He shot back to Walthamstow for printing and editing. The image of Sheryl was pinpoint sharp; even Karl would recognise her. He checked his watch — too late for lunch, and time to check in.

* * *

Karl was in a good mood. "So, Mr Bladen, any news from the front?"

If you only knew. "Yeah, I caught Jack Langton as he left home and I've managed to get some distant headshots. His car stands out a mile — personalised plates."

Karl picked up on it straightaway. "Great. If we can find out where he goes, it'll give us a choice of possible strike points."

That sounded ominous. He felt himself cringing silently. He closed his eyes, like a kid bracing himself for bad news or a bollocking.

"Is there a problem, Tommo? You weren't seen, were you?" There was concern in the voice, but it was hard to tell who for.

Jesus, that was something he hadn't even considered — what if Sheryl had seen him?

"I don't think so. Nah, it's fine, I reckon. It's best I do some more surveillance."

"Good man, Tommo, I knew I could rely on you."

He said his goodbyes and stared at the photo dangling from the printer. There was nothing else for it — he'd have to see Sheryl. Next call . . .

"Miranda Wright, and what can I do for *you*, Mr Bladen?"

There wasn't time to run through a menu, more's the pity. "Just a quickie," he knew she'd like that. "Just thought I'd say hello. By the way, I

was, er, driving near East Ham on a job and I could have sworn I saw Sheryl. She must have a double.”

“Doubt it. Anyway, she lives up that way. Sweet though, you asking after her. I’ll tell her you called.”

“Nah, don’t do that.” He started sweating. “You know how she is with me; it’ll only encourage her.”

“Okay. Don’t worry, your secret’s safe with me — I’ll protect you.”

“Good.” A little too emphatic — time to change the subject. “So, when are we getting together again?”

“Well . . . I was gonna invite you round to Mum and Dad’s, but I wasn’t sure if you still felt weird about the business with Karl?”

He smiled; that was the least of his worries. “It wasn’t their doing. Go on then, pick a night and I’m all yours — as long as I’m not working.” He paused, in case she wanted to have a pop. But no, Miranda rarely questioned his job anymore. She still didn’t like it but she knew it was a lost cause.

“How about tomorrow night?”

“Deal.”

“Fish and chips, and a few hands of cards.”

“Brilliant. I’ll bring some beers.”

“Anyway, gotta go. I can’t stand here talking to you — Sheryl’s off today so it’s just a barmaid and me. Don’t work too hard, Thomas.”

Thank you, God. Next stop: East Ham.

* * *

Jack’s BMW was nowhere to be seen. Thomas checked all the surrounding streets before parking up, not far from his original spot. This was all a gamble, but maybe his luck was in today.

He took the stairs, running through opening lines in his head. Nothing too cocky, but no sense beating around the bush. Mind you, she could just tell him to fuck off. That thought didn’t help his confidence any as he edged along the balcony.

At the door, he heard the faint sounds of jazz. Funny, he’d never had Sheryl pegged as a Miles Davis fan; he’d always seen her as more of a rock chick. He rapped the letterbox twice and stood back a little, shifting from foot to foot.

The door pulled back. Sheryl opened her mouth, but said nothing.

“Can I come in?”

She looked smaller, less certain of herself, as she nodded and led the way. He carefully closed the door behind him.

“This is a surprise. How come you know where I live?”

That was going to take some explaining. He sat down on the sofa. “Any chance of a cup of tea?”

“Sure,” she looked perplexed.

He rode it out and gave nothing away. As she hadn’t mentioned Miranda yet, he figured she was still running through the options.

“What can I do for you, Thomas?” She passed him a mug. She wasn’t smiling so he followed her lead.

He bobbed his head side to side, searching for an easy opening; then he gave up the search. “It’s about Jack Langton.”

She shrank back, grabbing her chair like a safety line. “Go on.”

He sighed and sniffed in rapid succession, as if desperate for stale air. “I know you two are involved — he was seen coming up here, earlier.”

She gulped at her tea, the cup hovering mid-air. “And that’s *what* of your fucking business?” Her eyes glowed, pools of molten hatred. “Are you here on some kind of work assignment? Don’t lie to me because I’ll ask Miranda — don’t think I won’t.” But her voice had lost its usual edge. He figured she was bluffing.

“She doesn’t know I’m here; *no one* knows I’m here. I just want to talk.”

“I heard about Karl,” she lowered her eyes. “I’m sorry he got into trouble in Belfast.”

Now he was pissed off. “Got into trouble? Jack Langton set him up! Special Branch arrested him.”

One look at her face told him she wasn’t going to let that be dropped at her door. “Oh, what, and you’re here to even the score?”

He sought solace in his tea; this was turning into a bad idea gone worse.

“Come on, Thomas,” she goaded him. “Why are you here? You looking for information? Blackmail? I’ll make it really easy for you — Miranda doesn’t know that Jack visits me. Happy now?”

He blushed, like an idiot. “Blackmail? No.” He was floundering now.

"I think you'd better go." She looked vulnerable; this was a side of Sheryl he hadn't seen since Miranda's disappearance.

"Wait up, just give me five minutes." He waved his hand like he was trying to hold back a stampede. "Then, I promise I'm out of here and no one gets to know, not from me." And this, he told himself, was why he was so shit at cards. "These are the photos." He pressed them flat on the table and smoothed the creases. "No copies and no files." He tried reasoning. "Look, Jack Langton isn't safe to be around."

"You think I don't know that?" She picked up the page to look at it.

"Then why are you . . ." he grabbed at the first phrase to hand, ". . . having a relationship with him?"

"A *what*? You think he's my boyfriend?" She leaned back as if to spit out her reply. "You asshole."

He blinked a couple of times, as if he could see the Angel of Conscience standing before him. "You're right." There was one thing he hadn't tried yet: the truth. "I was trying to even the score with Jack. A couple of days ago, I was sniffing around, trying to find something about Jack that would be useful, to help Karl. Next thing I know, two geezers are panel beating my car while I'm still inside it."

"Look, Thomas, I don't get involved in Jack's business."

He ignored that. "So this morning I decide to follow him, and now here I am."

"What are you planning to do — confront him? Because take it from me, he's not a guy to cross."

"Has he hurt you? Is he one of those pricks that likes to knock his girlfriends around?" His shoulders tensed.

Sheryl started laughing. "Miranda always says you have a vigilante complex. But you've got it wrong this time, big time. Jack's not my boyfriend — he's my father."

Hostilities quickly ceased. "What does his wife think about it all?"

"The short version is that she doesn't know. Oh sure, she knows I exist, but she thinks I'm some kind of step-niece or something. We've only met once."

She brought the cups through and he followed her. Jack's tinfoil was neatly folded on the kitchen table. "If you have to ask, then I won't be telling you." She picked the foil up and stuck it in a pedal bin, flicking a

remnant of white powder from her fingertips. “So, what are you going to do?”

“He owes me for my car and he owes Karl for a whole lot more.”

She shook her head. “Jack doesn’t back down. Ever. And he doesn’t care who he uses or hurts.” She pointed a finger towards the pedal bin, dagger straight. “You think I want him to bring that crap into my home?” She turned to face him. “Why are you really here, Thomas?”

“Okay: confession time. I was hoping to convince you to tell me about Jack Langton’s movements. In return for . . .”

Sheryl folded her arms protectively. “Your silence? You’re gonna use me just like he does. I thought you were better than that.”

He swallowed and paused, as if listening to himself. “I am. It’s your choice. Either way, Jack will get what he’s due.” They faced each other like Samurai.

“And you’ll never tell Miranda about any of this?”

He nodded. “Besides,” he reminded her, “you know my secret too now, and when Jack gets a visit . . .”

She squeezed herself. “I want Jack out of my life for as long as possible.”

He smiled. Sir Peter Carroll had told him, during his interview, that every surveillance assignment was a problem to be solved. This was no different. “How often does he bring the packages over?”

“Every week or so. He doesn’t need to — I think he does it to show me he can.” She lowered her head. “I’ve no idea where the stuff comes from and it never stays here. He keeps scales and bags in the drawer.”

Thomas put on his best poker face. “I think I can find out where he gets it.” He stepped forward and hugged her; it seemed the right thing to do. For a moment, he felt he had lost the fear of her, stepped around her Siren persona, the one who led innocent men to their doom. Well, maybe not entirely innocent.

But as he moved away, she lit that touchpaper smile and he reddened again like an idiot. He was pleased though; equilibrium was restored.

“How will I get in touch with you?”

“Let me have a mobile number and I’ll text mine to you,” he said.

She snorted back laughter. “You really are one cautious son of a bitch.”

He was already edging towards the door.

* * *

It was a mile or so before he pulled in and rang Karl back. They were trying out a new system: if the call wasn't picked up by the third ring, hang up. The way things were going, he was holding much better cards than he'd started the day with.

Karl picked up with one ring to go. "What's the score then, Tommo?"

"Are you okay to talk?"

"When have you ever known an Ulsterman who wasn't okay to talk?"

His first thought was: when he's in custody. But he let it pass. "I've found a way to track Jack's movements." He didn't elaborate and Karl knew the drill by now.

"That's grand. Unfortunately, I have bad news. They're shutting down the testing on the base and moving it in-house to an Engamel facility. The major was very coy about it; I can't figure him out. I was so sure he still wanted Schaefer's blood — now I don't know so much."

"P'raps they've offered him a deal too. Let's face it, if everything came out in the open his career would be bollocksed, along with his marriage."

"Aye, maybe. I thought he was bigger than that, though. Anyway, enough of me going on — where are you now?"

"London. You?"

"Like the song says — working my way back to you. The major and I finished our wee chat and now Christine would like a word — in person. And guess what, you're invited."

Pound to a penny, Ann Crossley would be on the guest list too.

"I'll head over." He pulled out Karl's giveaway mobile and texted Sheryl, confirming his name and a few keywords from their discussion.

* * *

He swiped in and mounted the stairs, two at a time, past the other security doors that he didn't have access to. How simple life would be, he thought as he rounded the last flight, if all the intelligence agencies — and the floaters — could pool their resources properly. Then he laughed at himself; it was the kind of bullshit Sir Peter Carroll might come out with on a television interview.

Another swipe, a twist of the handle and there he was, safe and sound. Christine's door was closed, lights on, and Ann Crossley was nowhere to be

seen. There was little point in creeping to his desk, but he did it anyway. He figured he'd wait for Karl and they'd go in together, like Butch and Sundance.

Christine's office door opened. "Will you come in please, Thomas?" Only it didn't sound much like a question.

He locked his laptop then thought better of it and brought it with him, closed, under one arm.

Christine offered him a seat, the one next to Ann Crossley.

"Aren't we waiting for Karl?" He heard the warble in his own voice and felt even more of an arse.

Ann smiled encouragingly. "He won't be long — I'm sure he won't mind."

He bit at a nail, trying to organise his thoughts, dividing his knowledge into two piles: the *do not discuss* and the *only discuss if you have to*. Christine moved a file around on top of her desk; it didn't seem to be going anywhere. He felt a twitch coming on, every time that file circled round.

"Can we make a start, then?" He looked up earnestly. "The suspense is killing me." Okay, it was stupid but so was this.

"You're aware that your assignment is to be concluded?" Another statement, this time from Ann.

"Yeah, I gather Major Eldridge has closed it all down."

Christine and Ann exchanged *the look*. The one that made him feel like a child in a roomful of adults.

"That's inaccurate." Christine fiddled with the file again. "The order came from Sir Peter Carroll. He wants our resource withdrawn."

That would make an interesting dilemma for Karl. Thomas smiled to himself, tongue pushed tightly against his lower front teeth.

"However," Christine cleared her throat, "I'd like you to continue to support the major — and Engamel — at my discretion."

It could have been his imagination, but the room temperature just dropped a couple of degrees. He had no problem bypassing Sir Peter, but he was curious. "Might I know the purpose of . . . ?"

Christine stared him down. "Let's not play games, Thomas. There's unfinished work there."

Now, that could mean the major's quest for justice for Amy, or it could mean the completion of the testing. He was still pondering what to say

when he heard the distant slam of the security door. He relaxed a little; the cavalry was here.

There was no whistling as Karl approached — just rapid heavy footfalls. He came straight in. “Sorry I’m late — where are we?”

Christine obliged.

Karl waited his turn. “The major confirmed that things have moved on as we anticipated. Any testing of the Scavenger will be relocated to Engamel’s Regional Headquarters, as they’re under pressure to ensure that the consortium deal stays on schedule.”

Thomas uncrossed his legs and leaned forward. “The what?” Now it was a three-way shared look, and he still wasn’t invited. “Is there any point in me being here?” He picked up his laptop, ready for the off.

“Sit still, Thomas.” This was Christine’s other voice. The one that used to say: *you could have made an effort* or *you need to get out of those clothes*. He didn’t know whether he felt aroused or defensive.

“You do know that Jess worked for Clarity, before she was assigned to testing the Scavenger? And what they worked on together was the C12 armoured vehicle?”

“This is true, Tommo.” Karl rode the wave. “Bet you didn’t know which bit of it though?” He didn’t wait for a reply. “They worked on the main gun.”

Christine looked disappointed. “The consortium will be announcing the live deployment of the Scavenger in designated international conflict arenas. Meantime, development will progress to an upscaled version for the C12.”

Thomas faced Karl. “You knew from the beginning, didn’t you?”

“No.” Christine leapt to his defence. “But I did, once Ann had briefed me.”

He blinked once, like a camera capturing evidence. “You’ve used me.” He waved a finger at the two women. Then he pointed at Karl. “And you. Just to get close to your old buddy, the major.”

“It was necessary.” Ann Crossley seemed about as contrite as a war criminal on extended vacation in South America.

“Nothing’s changed, has it? Same old bullshit — you send me in like some sort of decoy and watch what crawls out from the shadows. Meantime everyone gets on with the real job and I’m left in the dark.”

“It worked though, Tommo — that’s what matters.”

Thomas sniffed. Karl had a point, even though it choked him to admit it. “So what’s the next move?”

Ann moistened her lips. “My Engamel contact may need protecting, if she decides to break cover.”

“You’re talking about Clarity.” It was hardly a Sherlock Holmes challenge, but he still felt a sense of satisfaction.

She tilted her pen towards him, like a glass.

“I presume,” Karl’s voice was sombre, “That you’d prefer it if I supply any defensive capability independently?”

Christine made a face. “I’d prefer it if firearms weren’t necessary.”

Meantime, Thomas had done some thinking. “So, this *deal* goes ahead even though the Scavenger is unsafe?”

All three of them shared the same weak smile. Christine picked up the file, leant across and put it out of reach. “That’s the nub of the problem, Thomas. We,” she indicated the three of them, “and the people we represent cannot be seen to be obstructing the Scavenger. Neither can we be seen to be endorsing — or assisting — its deployment.”

Ann knew her cue. “And no agency is willing to act as a whistleblower.”

“And that’s why I’m here?”

Ann tried hard to sell it to him. “All you need do is be there to support Clarity, if she needs it.”

“How’s she going to get in touch?”

“Karl gave me a mobile number to give to her.”

He raised his eyebrows in Karl’s direction. Now he understood why Karl hadn’t claimed his phone back.

“Look, Tommo, whatever you think of me, or any of us, if we get this right we’ll save lives and put a dent in Michael Schaefer’s future at Engamel. Political expediency is a secondary consideration.”

Judging by the look on Christine’s face, Karl was in a minority of one. Well, two now. He nodded resolutely. “Okay, I’ve heard enough; I’ll await her call.”

Chapter 36

Thomas didn't feel like sticking around after the meeting. In any case, the three of them seemed to have lots left to talk about, judging by the way no one else followed him out.

He reconnected the laptop and booted up. Meantime, he grabbed a chemical coffee from the machine and escorted it back to his desk. The screensaver floated in front of him like a one-fingered salute. The Surveillance Support Unit crest bobbed about the screen, complete with the motto *Omnes Sensus: All the Senses*. Yeah, he thought, sipping slowly, all of them except common sense.

Emails first, a toe-dip back into reality. Then maybe a sniff around the SSU phone bug on the major's comms. Thinking about it only irritated him off, reminded him of the major's secret offer to take Karl back into uniform. Was that how it was going to be for all three of them still at Christine's desk? Her off to the Foreign Office and Ann Crossley doing a similar deal with Naval Intelligence?

He didn't have any answers. Jesus, he didn't have a full set of questions. He was still the only one playing against the house. He passworded his way through and watched the messages stack in his in-tray. There were a mess of emails eager for his attention. One, sent from Karl just before the meeting, read: *If I don't get to see you before we go in, stick around afterwards. I need to talk to you*. Yeah, right. *Next*. The Liaison Office, short and sweet — advising that he'd missed a health appointment with the counsellor.

A quick glance at the office door — blinds still drawn and no sign of movement. Straight through to an answering machine, bloody things. "Hello, yes, it's Thomas. I really must apologise for missing this week's session. Too much going on at work." *That managed to sound both lame and ambiguous*. "I'm fine and everything — I'll definitely be there next time." He just got it all in before the beep. After that he breathed a little easier and gulped down some more caffeine.

There was some domestic email traffic from Christine, keeping the team informed. Usual nonsense — performance assessment dates, a

reminder to use only the latest templates and the server to find them on. Plus an unbelievable email about a teambuilding event, workload permitting. The title alone was enough to make him choke: The Unified Team.

He scanned up the list of emails, working his way to the present. One ominous entry sat atop the list, like a blister. Not to be ignored, but to be treated with caution, sent in from Whitehall. *Please contact me as soon as you receive this. Sir Peter Carroll, Director-General — Surveillance Support Unit.* Just in case Thomas had forgotten the natural order of things.

The call went straight through — no switchboard — and was picked up on the third ring. Sir Peter was that cultured mixture of civilised behaviour and ruthless manipulation.

“Thomas, I appreciate you calling back. I wonder, are you free to join me? Shall we say thirty minutes’ time? Excellent, I’ll see you then.”

Karl would have to wait. This was less an appointment than a command performance. Even if Karl’s people did on occasion pull the strings where Sir Peter was concerned, it hadn’t improved Thomas’s position. On the one hand, the Old Man used to have a soft spot for him; and on the other, Thomas was a means of getting things done. It seemed to be the theme of the day. He left a note on Karl’s desk — *summoned to Whitehall, speak to you later* — and headed out the door.

* * *

He could have jumped in a taxi and reclaimed it on expenses, but entering the Tube network always held a fascination for him. It was like shedding a skin, becoming anonymous. Give or take the traceability of an Oyster Card. Hard not to think of Sir Peter tracking him like a badger on the move. Except, of course, they were a protected species and he wasn’t.

Surfacing at Embankment, he donned another skin — teacher’s pet. He’d barely made it through the security doors when a guard approached him.

“Sir Peter’s ready for you now.” She sounded calm and unequivocal, walking him to the scanner and then escorting him up there herself.

“It’s very kind of you to show me the way,” he caught her smile and returned it, gift-wrapped.

“I’ve, er, put in an application to join the SSU.” She didn’t qualify the statement.

“It’s never a dull moment,” he smirked, for reasons she’d never fathom.

Three, four, knock on the door. The guard turned smartly and walked away, glancing back at the bend in the corridor.

He went inside. Sir Peter was standing by a window; he seemed to be gazing through the blinds, beyond the blast-proof glass at the real world below. “Shall I tell you something, Thomas? I still bring in a camera, on occasion. Some mornings, I watch the Thames, flowing like an artery through the city.”

Thomas closed the door and waited there. “You sent for me, sir.”

“Some things never change. That great river — whatever we call it. Whether it’s flowing in London or England or the United Kingdom, it doesn’t change the river.”

Thomas figured the philosophy lecture was just for openers and sat down. “You forgot to add *Europe* to your Thames list.”

“Indeed I did.” Sir Peter crossed the room and took his chair behind the mahogany desk. “You mistakenly think you understand the rules because you persist in seeing things in black and white — Mr McNeill the hero and I the villain.”

He cupped his chin in one hand and propped his elbow on the chair arm. “A woman is dead because someone was more interested in cutting a few corners to a sales target than in the risks. That’s the cold truth — black, white or grey.”

“I agree with you.”

Thomas lifted his head and sat a little straighter.

“But I also recognise that the Scavenger will one day be a valuable asset, once the problems are ironed out. What’s needed is more time.”

He heard the rest of the speech in disbelief. The high points — if he could call them that — hit him like a set of knuckles: align himself with Michael Schaefer, distance himself from Major Eldridge, and accept a temporary assignment at Engamel.

Reading between the lines, the major must have kept secret the data that Thomas had retrieved from Jess. Which suggested he had a plan of his own.

Sir Peter Carroll leaned in, hands resting on the desk. It had all the hallmarks of a sermon “We want the same things, Thomas. You simply need to see this in a wider context.”

He found himself nodding, mainly at his own decision to have it all out with Karl, once and for all. He smiled and Sir Peter smiled back, mistaking his motivation.

“I’m glad we had the chance to talk. That’ll be all then; keep me informed.”

* * *

The *Guard du Jour* was waiting at the lift. “So, any tips for me, Mr Bladen?”

He stared at the lift buttons for inspiration. “First, make sure that you enjoy your own company and don’t need a social life. And learn to read people carefully, lass.”

He received a broad grin for his trouble. “Maybe you could talk me through a few things, over a drink sometime?”

His lips squeezed together. “That was the first people test — I’m spoken for.”

* * *

It probably should have surprised him to find Karl loitering outside in the street, but he was all surprised-out for the day.

“You took yer time, Tommo. Come on, let’s take a wee walk.”

They made it as far as the nearest pub that met Karl’s exacting standards. Karl opted for a cross between a sandwich and a full meal. Thomas, grateful for the chance of real food instead of snacks, plumped for some stew.

The food arrived and Karl led a full assault on his plate while he talked. “What’s on your mind then? You’ve got a real face on you.”

“Are you going back to the army?” However gruffly he’d tried to say it, he still sounded like a petulant teenager rowing with his girlfriend.

“Nope.” Karl gulped down a mouthful of food. “I already told you. It suited my purpose to let the major think I was keen on the idea.”

“So you lied to him then?”

Karl bit into his wrap, exercising his right to remain silent.

“Sir Peter wants me to work at Engamel for a while.”

Karl shook his head. “That’s not good news. Either he’s getting desperate or Schaefer has something up his sleeve. Anything else you wanna talk about?”

Once he’d started, it just kept on coming. The major holding back on Jess’s data; Sir Peter seemingly at odds with the major; Schaefer being made of asbestos. And then there was the business with Jack Langton. He stepped lightly around the quicksand, letting Karl know the bare bones. It felt strangely exhilarating, being on the controlling end of the equation.

“So, I’ll be able to find out when Jack Langton is next on the move, but it’ll be short notice.” He took a dramatic pause and shovelled in another mouthful of stew. “I’ve also discovered his delivery point.”

Karl waved a knife in the air, singsong fashion. “Well played. We could hit him there.”

The light from Karl’s knife seemed to flicker across his face. Maybe that was the thing making Thomas squirm.

“Yeah, about that — not enough time.”

“Pity. Anyway, with what you’ve put together, we could at least disrupt Jack’s business.”

Thomas was warming to this by the second. “What have you got in mind?”

“Well . . .” Karl jabbed towards his plate. “If we knew exactly when Jack was doing his rounds, we could put the police on to him.”

Thomas felt a chill clawing up his spine. First priority: keep Sheryl out of it. But maybe Karl was on to something. “It would take some coordinating.”

“I’m sure a man of your abilities and *connections* could work out a way to involve the Met.”

Thomas got the message loud and clear: Ajit. Karl must have learned about his job in the police during the business on the moors. Best book a call to Yorkshire, later. Odd, though, that Karl should want to bring in the police. “Say Jack Langton *is* picked up by the police, how does that help you turn him against Martin and Francis-Andrew?”

“Wait and see. What car did you say our Mr Langton drives?”

“Beemer — a sporty one.”

“Well there you are then. Odds on he’s got a family car tucked away somewhere as well. We need to know what it is, and we can hardly ask

Thurston Lyon to do a recce.”

“I’ll do a run-by tonight, on the way home.”

“Nice one. Listen, I know I’ve been a bit off lately, what with . . .” Karl’s mobile rang — saved by the bell. “Hello? Ah, Stuart, thanks for ringing me back.” He didn’t speak again for a minute, nodding slowly as if coming to some terrible conclusion. “You did the right thing. Yeah, send it straight over. Bye.” He didn’t take his eyes off the phone, didn’t move again until the bleep announced the text. Then he hit the button and gazed at the pixels, ashen faced.

“Are you okay?” Thomas put down his cutlery.

“Take a look.” Karl passed the phone over. “Stuart went to ma’s funeral, to see whether Frances-Andrew or Martin turned up. Someone else did — my father.”

Thomas stared at the screen. “When did you last . . . ?”

“A long time ago.” He sounded younger, trapped in some memory he’d rather not visit again.

Thomas sighed and returned the phone. Life was a cruel bastard. Karl hadn’t seen his dad in years, by the sound of it; Sheryl wanted to disown hers; and as for him, he hardly ever spoke to his family, let alone saw them. And the last time it’d ended up as a police matter. Something else he’d have to tread around carefully when he spoke to Ajit later.

* * *

“Is that Ajit of the Yard?”

“By ‘eck, is that the famous Mr Bladen, the one who went foreign?” Then, in a change of tone, “no, it’s for me.”

Thomas smiled. The bickering from Pickering was one of the great constants in his life.

“Sorry, just the little woman . . . ow, *give over!* So, we’re still talking then?”

“Course we are.” It sounded like the first hurdle was a low one.

“Only, wi’ Geena and Miranda on the blower, I was starting to feel left out.”

Blimey. “Yeah, it’s er, actually a work-related thing I’m ringing about.” He heard a piece of furniture creak into submission as Ajit made himself comfortable.

“Should I get me notebook and pen?”

“Might not be a bad idea.”

“Ee, I were only taking the piss. ’ang on.” Then there was hissing and scrabbling about. “Sorry, that were Geena — I’m not allowed to swear int’ house now. It’s practice for when baby comes. Right, I’m ready.”

“Okay, I’ve got this tip-off — drug related. But I don’t know *when* yet. And I have intelligence that can help you nab a nasty bastard, if we get the timing right.”

Ajit took notes and asked pertinent questions, which Thomas did his best to deflect. He wondered whether Ajit was enjoying this as much as he was. The old duo, back on the same side.

“It’s unusual,” Ajit made a noise somewhere between a sigh and a grumble, “I’ll grant you that. But it’s not a problem. We have procedures for this sort of thing. Of course, you could speak to the London coppers yourself.”

“No,” he snapped. “I can’t be involved — because of my job. Anonymously would be best, but if not, then I know I can trust you.”

“Righto, mum’s the word. And you’ll let me know when?”

“Yeah, on the same day, probably.” *Which is why the boys in blue need to be ready.* Thanks, Ajit, this is really important to me.”

“Should I ask: is this purely work or personal?”

Thomas paused. “So, how’s Geena?”

Ajit coughed politely. “Well enough, let me put her on.”

She didn’t stay on the phone very long. Long enough to tell him that Miranda was a good sort — as if he didn’t know that already — and that it’d be lovely to see the two of them again. If he could manage it without the fancy dress next time.

“Anyhow, I’ll leave you two boys to chat. Take care of yourself, Uncle Thomas.”

Ajit didn’t have a lot else to say. He was fired up though, Thomas could tell. Which was all to the good.

Chapter 37

The answering machine was winking when Thomas got out of the shower. He always checked, on the off chance. He pulled a towel off his head and hit the magic button.

“Are you picking me up at the club tonight or meeting me at Mum and Dad’s? Let me know what your busy schedule will allow. See you later, babe.”

He turned a yawn into a grin and wandered into the kitchen whistling a Four Tops’ tune. This was already showing every sign of being a great day and it wasn’t even seven o’clock.

Washed, dressed and crammed with toast, he fired up his laptop to check the major’s phone lines. There was one call from the previous night, a late one — to Michael Schaefer. He was either very sure of himself or hoping for early retirement, threatening to blow the whistle about Amy’s death and go public like that. Schaefer didn’t back down, reminding the major that he knew about his affair with Amy. Then the major made a counter bid for top dog.

‘I have the remaining firing mechanism, from the second Scavenger.’

Thomas clicked the pause and recoiled from the screen. No the major didn’t, but *they* did. So why hadn’t Karl brought it up again? Something else to discuss with the Celtic Wonder.

He let the recording run its course, made some scribbles on that very creased piece of paper he’d been carrying around for days, and powered down the computer. Something had to give, and soon.

Even with the radio jabbering on, against the backdrop of London traffic, Thomas couldn’t help thinking about Karl — specifically, about his dad. About all those years Karl had lived in exile, hardly able to see one parent and shunned by the other. Life hadn’t dealt Karl a very fair hand. Which naturally made Thomas think of Sheryl.

Ajit was supposed to be on early shift today. If he was true to his word — and you could bank on that with Ajit — then the call would go through to London today. And then it’d be a waiting game. Sheryl had said there was no set pattern to Jack Langton’s appearances, sometimes twice in a

week, or weeks without showing up. Funny that he'd never seen Jack Langton at Caliban's though.

* * *

Maybe Lea Bridge Road wasn't the smartest move of the day, but he couldn't face the gridlock of Seven Sisters. And besides, the back roads were always more interesting, once you got there. He switched radio stations and caught the tail end of some political piece; it made his blood run cold.

"Of course, the modern theatre of war has changed beyond recognition and technological capabilities have had to change in tandem. These days, the challenges are flexibility and speed of response. New materials, new technologies even — that is the way forward."

Somehow Thomas managed to stick with it to the bitter end: 'And I'd like to thank Major Charles Eldridge, DSO.' The words that came to mind were *shit* and *fan*. And the question that came to mind: what was Thomas going to do about it?

He rang ahead to Karl, on hands-free.

"I heard it was coming last night, Tommo. I didn't ring you — thought you had enough going on. It puts our contact in a very difficult position. Get in as soon as you can. And if the major rings you, *don't* answer it."

* * *

Three worried faces greeted him as he entered the office. Ann Crossley was on her way out, mustering a smile as she passed. "You'd better reprioritise your workstack."

Karl and Christine were in mid disagreement, which was a novelty.

"All I'm saying here is let *me* talk with the major. I'll get him to see sense."

"For the last time, Karl, we are past that. The radio interview was a warning — to Schaefer and everyone else. You either follow my orders or you find yourself a new section — understand?"

"Ma'am," Karl barked fiercely.

"Right," Christine looked at them both. "I don't care what went on in Belfast, I'm not interested. If there are any loose ends, you better tie them up quickly because as soon as Clarity calls, you start running. Thomas," she

pointed at him, “your phone stays on 24/7 from now on. Karl will be available to assist you whenever you need it.”

As if that was ever in doubt. She froze for a moment, like an old computer, trying to process more information than it could handle.

“Permission to speak?” Karl managed to stay just the right side of sounding like a twat.

She flashed a weary look that Thomas knew intimately. “Well?”

“Look, we’re on the same side, Christine. You have your orders, but I’m already pegged as a stroppy bastard. If I were to speak with Major Eldridge it would be without your approval, if it ever came out.”

Christine glanced Thomas’s way and he nodded slightly, willing her to make the right decision. She narrowed her eyes.

“I’m going into my office and I don’t want to be disturbed. Keep the personal calls to a minimum.” She blinked in Karl’s direction and started walking. “Thank you.”

Thomas gave Karl a little space to do the necessary. Maybe Christine wasn’t so inflexible after all. He put his mobiles on the desk and unwound a serpents’ nest of chargers — work official, personal and work unofficial. At this rate, he’d need a bigger desk.

A mobile erupted into life. He snatched at it and checked the screen: number unknown. Not good news. It could be the major or it could be Sheryl — only one way to find out. On the third ring, Christine lifted her office window blind aside, staring out at him. He took a breath: shit-or-bust time — again.

“Hello?”

The line crackled. “Hey, Thomas.” Sheryl sounded lost, unable find her way back from somewhere.

“I’m here,” he emphasised, like a parent to a child waking from a bad dream.

“Jack rang — he’s coming over later.” She gulped. “You promised . . .”

“I’m on it, leave it to me.” He let Sheryl ring off, looked over at Christine and shook his head slowly, until she closed the blind. Then he grabbed his own mobile and speed-dialled Yorkshire. “Aj, it’s Thomas. That little problem I told you about last night?”

“Aye, well . . .” Ajit retreated. “I’ve not spoken to anyone yet.” He was apologetic, with a hint of belligerence. “I were called in early — big police

operation — I can't talk now."

He got in quickly. "But what about the Borough Intelligence Unit?"

Ajit didn't respond. All Thomas heard was background chatter and the jet-stream swish of traffic. He let it rest there. His fingers tapped the desk, frantically beating out a call to his brain. Jack Langton would be on the move any time now.

"Karl." He swivelled round to meet him. "We need to talk — outside."

* * *

He stood back against the brickwork, hyped up by the cacophony of London chaos and his own desperation.

"I'm waiting, Thomas." Karl leant back, coiled like a cat.

"That call was my contact — Jack Langton is picking up drugs today."

"Fantastic. Let me know the moment the police have picked him up. I've still got something to sort out on my side before I'm ready to make a move.

Thomas searched the grey London sky for inspiration. Nice try, anyway. "I need a massive favour, Karl." He paused, to gauge the reaction. "My mate in Yorkshire couldn't pass the info on in time."

"Ah well, it'll have to be another time. Shame though . . ."

"No." Thomas pressed a hand against Karl's arm, as if afraid he was going to walk away. "You don't understand — it *has* to be today."

"Steady on there, Tommo. What do you expect me to do about it? I've already told you I can't be involved — as far as Jack's concerned, I'm still rotting in a cell."

"I know you have contacts all over the place," he watched Karl's face change, reading him back. "I need someone to relay a message through formal channels — someone who will be listened to at the local Borough Intelligence Unit. All I'm asking for is someone to call."

Karl held his gaze. Then he straightened up to his full height and his chest seemed to sag. "They'll want something in return."

Thomas had figured as much, but Sheryl was as close to Miranda as he was and that was good enough reason to proceed. "Can we do it now?"

"That's a big ask . . ."

He stood his ground, imagining Jack Langton leaving his house and Sheryl waiting at hers, trapped.

“Let’s take a walk.” Karl didn’t wait for an answer, heading off towards Middlesex Street.

“I wouldn’t ask if there was any other way . . .” he let the sentence finish itself.

“Rules first. You’re on your own with this. All I need to know for our little operation is when — or if — he’s under lock and key. Next, you don’t *ever* ask me again. And lastly, you’ll have to convince them to take action — tell them it’s a code five priority.”

Blimey, a magic password. He nodded solemnly. “I really appreciate this, Karl. I know it’s . . .”

Karl physically stopped him. “Save it for the phone box.” He dug out a handful of change.

When they got there, he turned his back while Karl dialled.

“Right, I’ll see you later.” The door shrieked open.

He grabbed the phone and pressed it close to his ear.

“Internal Communications.” The voice was male and nonchalant, daring him to play this game through.

“I have a code five emergency.”

The voice on the other end didn’t respond.

“Sorry. I’m new to this. I have a code five priority, requiring police assistance.”

“Please state your name, caller.”

He huffed down the phone, the sound roaring in his ears like a spring tide. “There isn’t much time. I can give you all the details, but I can’t give you my name.”

“I think you may have the wrong number.”

“Wait.” He pre-empted the click. “This is a direct threat to one of *your* operatives.” *Bollocks, should have said ‘our.’* “At least let me pass on the information, for the Borough Intelligence Unit.” The phone was silent. For all he knew he could be on loudspeaker. Almost certainly being recorded.

He chose to believe they were still interested, threw in another load of coins and went through the salient points — Jack Langton and his drug dealing, his car, the pick-up point and the need to catch him in the act today. Then he had an inspiration and added that Langton might be armed — that was payback for the windscreen.

“It will be looked into. What’s your number?”

“Hold on a moment.” He pulled out a slip of paper from his jacket and read out Karl’s throwaway mobile. The voice didn’t say anything more; maybe he was expecting some other code word. The line went dead.

Thomas put the receiver back and pressed the sweat between his palms. Then he picked it up again and dialled a random series of numbers before replacing it, just in case the next person got curious. As he turned to leave, the dampness across his back pressed cold against his skin. And his world had shifted a little closer to Karl’s.

* * *

Coffee was the only sure-fire cure for the adrenaline tremor in his hands. Thank God for railway stations. He’d just sat down with his Americano and a healthy chunk of carrot cake when the magic mobile went off.

“Hello?” He could barely squeeze the word out.

“The BIU has been advised; the matter will be looked into.”

“Thank you — will someone . . .?”

“You’ll be informed if there is any development.”

He took a large gulp of coffee and let the heat permeate his mouth, circling in waves through his abdomen as he swallowed. It took a moment to realise that the call had finished. His imagination was still in overdrive. What if he joined Karl in that secret army of his?

The lure of hidden knowledge had always been there, even back at school when he discovered that two of his teachers were meeting after hours. He’d memorised several of their car number plates, so when two were parked up in a side street, it didn’t take much to check out all the nearby pub and restaurant windows. He smiled now, thinking about it — that delicious feeling of power at school the next day. Telling no one, not even Ajit. Maybe that was the appeal of the Surveillance Support Unit: knowing other people’s secrets without them knowing.

Time to juggle mobiles again. “Hi, Miranda.”

“About bloody time; I was beginning to think you’d forgotten me.”

“Not a chance! So, what’s your pleasure tonight — picked up at Caliban’s or star crossed lovers at Mum and Dad’s?”

“Blimey, you are in a good mood — did you get a gold star for spying today?” She sounded like a primary school teacher talking to a five-year-

old. He let it pass.

“Something like that. Any pref then?”

“Tell you what, I’ll make my own way over. I’m a big girl now.”

He laughed down the phone, aware that people around him were probably peering over their lattes by now — sod ’em. “You certainly are, if memory serves me right.” Her laughter cascaded into his, filling him with a heat no coffee could ever match.

* * *

He was whistling as he re-entered the building, a mobile in each pocket and one inside his jacket, like some hi-tech gunslinger. Still imagining Karl’s handshake of congratulation when everything went down as planned.

Ann Crossley was by the vending machine; no one else was around.

“Where’s Karl?” He noted Karl’s approach to the clear desk policy — laptop away but plastic cups and chocolate wrappers still there.

She looked at him and squinted. “I thought he was with you, working?”

He played the odds in his head and settled for a safe bet. “Yeah, I thought he might have finished ahead of me.”

“Why don’t you ring him?” Her eyes shimmered.

“It can wait.” He aimed for *casual* and left her to it, plugging his mobiles back in at the desk and arranging them for easy reach. If Christine was still in her lair, she gave no sign. That was fine. Being under Crossley’s eager gaze was enough.

Ten thirty came and went, with no calls and no Karl. He busied himself, checking the major’s call log with headphones on. There was nothing remarkable, other than a distinct lack of calls with those nice people at Engamel. Mrs Eldridge had seemed jittery though; perhaps she knew more than was good for her.

The report template stared back at him from the screen. He made a couple of stabs at it, then pulled out a writing pad to organise his thoughts. Christine would need to see *something* for his days since the base accident. On the plus side, there were some unsocial hours to claim for, plus the lockdown and a night on the base: hurrah for paperwork.

Eleven fifteen. Jack Langton could be on his way to a police reception. Unless he’d changed his plans or they cocked it up somehow. He caught himself drumming on the desk again.

“Is there something on your mind?” Ann Crossley swivelled towards him.

He smacked his lips and swung round to face her. “How do you . . .” he searched for the right words, “. . . keep your working priorities separate?”

She tilted her head and smiled. It was the sort of smile that used to wind him up. “It took me years of practice, Thomas; years of practice. Is there something *specific* I can help you with, in Karl’s absence?”

It happened again, that blurring of accents. Whenever Ann Crossley got a little too interested in something, those Cardiff high notes became audible, like a poker tell.

“No, I’ll figure it out — thanks anyway.” He jerked the chair away, pondering the twist of fate that had partnered him with Karl. Another day and another detail, and he’d have been swapping secrets with Ann Crossley across the desk, as the civilian help for . . . Naval Intelligence, wasn’t it?

In the end, he cobbled together the reports as best he could and decided he’d talk it through with Christine. No point giving her more information than she needed, and no point in wasting too much energy on it beforehand. He smiled, that could have been Karl talking.

He was halfway through making a to-do list for that evening’s jaunt to the Wrights when the balloon finally went up. Wary of being watched, he reached across for the mobile calmly, tasting the inside of his mouth.

“Your information has been acted upon, with a satisfactory conclusion. We will call you again.”

“Thank you.” He gazed around the room, grinning as if he’d just won first prize in a phone-in.

Ann Crossley looked over and just nodded at him. He felt like yelling to release the pounding in his chest, but he didn’t. He took some slow, deep breaths — just as the counsellor had taught him — and moved on to his next call.

Sheryl sounded years younger. “Hello?”

“It’s Thomas — it’s done.”

She burst into tears and he squeezed his jaw tight as he listened. He knew what it felt when the tide had finally shifted in your favour. That first morning after the moors, when he’d woken up in Pickering, knowing Miranda was safe and Yorgi was lying on a slab somewhere, he’d wept out of sheer relief.

“Listen, I’ve got to go. I’ll see you at Caliban’s sometime.”

“Yeah,” she sucked in a breath. “What will happen . . .?”

“I don’t know. I can try and find out, if you want?”

“No, better you don’t. I couldn’t face being disappointed right now.”

She snorted a laugh. “Anyway, thanks again, Thomas. You don’t know what this means to me.”

“Don’t mention it.” He blushed and thanked one of his mother’s saints as Sheryl put the phone down. A call to Karl’s mobile went straight through to voicemail. He did his best to hide his excitement, relaying the message word for word.

Chapter 38

It was fast becoming a day of surprises. Ann Crossley had invited him to lunch — a first. They settled for a pub that Karl would have approved of — the décor anyway, if not the clientele. The features looked original, but the drinkers were mostly a bunch of bankers.

Crossley did the honours, fetching back a couple of soft drinks and the promise of hot food. She smiled a lot, which didn't suit her. It was on the cards they'd be playing question time so he made a pre-emptive strike.

"What got you into this line of work, then?"

She sipped her juice and paused, mid-air. "I did languages and politics at university. It was a logical step." She shrugged, as if to say it was something that just happened.

He didn't buy it. From the little he'd seen, just about *no one* ended up in the SSU by chance. She looked at him, waiting. He'd already trotted this routine out to Karl, no qualms about it because it was the truth.

"I worked in Central London, at a civil service desk. But I'd always done photography. And one day Sir Peter Carroll and me were in a lift after work. . ."

She laughed, the way people usually did. As if to say: 'Is that what *really* happened?' But it was. He hadn't even considered it as a permanent option until after the second weekend job. And even then there wasn't much to tell. Turn up, use a better camera, sit on his arse all day not talking to the people around him, take some long lens footage, and then hand in his camera and go home. Of course, he knew he was good. He knew he could impress them without trying too hard.

The food arrived. He broke off from his thrilling monologue and made short work of the gammon. They flipped a coin, best of three — she paid and he'd owe her for next time. This was turning out to be a brilliant day. All it needed now was Karl to burst in with a box of chocolates. Speaking of which . . .

"You, er, seem to be getting on better with Karl these days."

"Ah, the elusive Mr McNeill. I was wondering how long it would be before he joined the conversation." The laughter sounded genuine. "We

haven't always hit it off — let's call it professional rivalry. But I've always respected him, in the main."

He was itching to probe deeper and find out whether there was more to it. But hey, what was she going to do — sign a confession?

"The thing is, Thomas," she did it again, bending the second syllable of his name. "Someone like you is in a strong position to get his career going — from this point on. I mean, you don't want to be doing this for the rest of your life, do you?"

It could almost have been one of Christine's old scripts — or her mother's.

"It'll do for now. I'm afraid I don't have any great ambitions — they didn't teach us that at my school." Not if you weren't paying attention, anyway.

"I used to have all that working-class pride in my veins too. Then I got a scholarship and saw my potential. It's never too late, you know."

He put down a chip, firm and golden against the rim of the plate. "This is starting to sound like a recruitment speech."

She was all smiles again. "Would that be such a bad thing?" she said, finishing her drink.

* * *

At three thirty, Karl put in an appearance at work. "Any more news?"

"Nah. All quiet on the Western Front. Where have you been?"

Karl sauntered over, waving to Ann Crossley who returned the favour and pretended not to watch him. He made sure he stood with his back to her and bent forward over Thomas's desk. "I was getting this sorted." He produced a ring box.

Thomas clicked back the lid. Inside was a bullet, polished and gleaming, and engraved with a harp." He tilted it so the ceiling light ran along the surface. It looked like a work of art. "For Jack?" he hissed. "You are kidding?" Judging by Karl's face, clearly not.

"Too subtle, do you think? I was going to go for a shamrock, but I thought this said it better."

Thomas strained his eyes to try and fathom out the point. "Why?"

"Because, Tommy Boy, someone would only do this if they didn't care what Jack thought about it. It's a 'fuck you' message — loud and clear."

“Fine. I get it. He’ll link it with the Belfast firm. But how are you going to get it to him, especially now he’s inside?”

“That’s where you come in. Fancy a little unpaid overtime tonight?”

He made a face. “I’m supposed to be meeting Miranda.”

Karl nodded, tongue between his teeth, as if he were tasting the air. “Not a problem; I won’t be needing you until late. I’ll call you on the magic phone.”

As soon as Karl went off in search of chocolate, Thomas cranked out an email to him. Stupid really, sending an email to the desk behind him, but it was liberating to have control over a conversation with Karl, at least at the start.

Crossley took me to the pub for lunch. I think she wants me to join her gang. Care to top that?

Karl shuffled back to his desk and an email pinged in. Thomas heard his laughter, and the sound of him scuttling away again. And then the grinding of the vending machine. More footsteps, and a chocolate delight landed on his desk.

An email followed soon after. *Dessert beats the main course — I win!* Three lines below he’d added, like an afterthought: *Of course, you’re a free agent. In this office, you’re the only one of us who is.*

* * *

He left the office early, to get a bag together at home. Mindful that Clarity’s call was overdue, he packed the Makarov pistol, as well as a black balaclava and face paint.

At the flat, he checked both bugs on the major’s phone lines once more. Funny that Major Eldridge hadn’t contacted him lately, despite acquiring the missing data from Jess. So why had the major gone to ground since then? Something else to obsess about in traffic.

* * *

The cut-through, avoiding Forest Road, was as treacherous as a politician. Snarled up, bumper-to-bumper, he went over the day’s events aloud. More pluses than minuses, for sure, but fewer answers than questions.

One thing bothered him unreasonably; something he’d always let pass before — who exactly did Karl work for in the *evening* job? He’d figured it

was connected to Karl's army days, so maybe Army Intelligence? And was that the same as MI5? And what was all that stuff about Code Five? He drummed the steering wheel as the lights changed. That settled it; he'd grab a few minutes on John Wright's computer and do a little sleuthing.

Might he not be better off though, remaining in the dark while Karl, Ann and Christine performed in their three-ring circus? He chewed that over as some stupid bastard in a plumber's van tried to play 'pick a lane.' Did he really want to know about Karl? Of course he bloody did. Knowledge was power. And power was control.

* * *

Diane Wright was outside the front door when he pulled up — must have been waiting.

"Sorry I'm late — traffic was a 'mare."

She laughed at his attempt at a cockney accent. The lingo still sounded wrong coming from his lips.

"There's one extra at the table tonight," she looked hard at him, as if he were supposed to know something.

He grabbed his lucky bag and followed her inside. The front room door yawned open so he poked his head in. Everyone turned towards him. The full family were there, Miranda, sitting seductively at one end of the settee, gave him a little wave. So did the person next to her: Sheryl.

Diane squeezed his shoulder as she passed through to the kitchen. The warmth in her fingers thawed him a little, but not much. He set his bag down and checked it was zipped up. *Right then, best foot forward.* "Everything all right?" he asked the room in general, trying to play it cool.

"We're celebrating," Miranda nodded to two champagne magnums, one already opened. "Help yourself to a glass."

The weight of their attention made every step across the room drag. "Just a small one. I'm working later on." Best to get the bad news out of the way early on. He braved a look at Miranda — she wasn't pouting. That was a first. All eyes followed him as he measured out a small glass.

"How d'ya do it, Thomas?" Sam broke the silence.

"Sam!" John barked. "What did we agree?"

"Sorry, Dad, it just slipped out."

He turned to face them, sipping at the champagne to cool his face down. Sheryl and Miranda parted company on the settee, leaving him the middle space.

“Sit your arse down,” John tipped back his lager.

He sat, a thorn between two roses, and sipped his drink. Everyone seemed to be looking at nowhere in particular, like at a wake.

“Oh, for fuck’s sake, someone say something.” Miranda ended the deadlock with her usual light touch.

Sheryl leaned forward and pressed Thomas’s arm. “I told them about Jack Langton being my dad.”

John Wright lowered his glass. “I did wonder sometimes, but it’s not the sort of thing you ask — not of Jack anyway.”

“I’m gonna look in on the kitchen.” Thomas got up, trying to ignore the fevered whispers behind him.

“Alright, love?” Diane was counting out the plates. She smiled; she didn’t seem to need an answer. “This must be your worst nightmare — stuck in the limelight.”

He leant against the breakfast bar, empty glass in his hand.

“Never you mind, Thomas. You did a good thing. Give ’em a few minutes and they’ll find someone else to pick on.”

As if by magic, an expensive lace-up boot was tapping on the floor tiles. “Not sure I like the idea of my bloke preferring my mum’s company to mine.”

“Well maybe you should try treating him better.” Diane grinned.

“Bloody cheek. Treat ‘em mean, keep ‘em keen — that’s what you taught me.”

Even over dinner — shepherd’s pie, coincidentally, one of Thomas’s favourites — Sam and Terry were still eyeing his every move.

“Thing is, Thomas,” Terry spoke through a mouthful of churning potato, “this makes you an even darker horse than we thought. Which is saying something.”

“Let the man eat in peace.” John had the final say, but he looked as proud as a season ticket holder when the Hammers won the FA Cup.

Thomas stole a glance at Sheryl, wondering just how much of her soul she’d unburdened before he arrived.

Sheryl peered back, uncharacteristically quiet, with the same expression she had worn at her flat. The tension was breaking him out in a sweat. "Sorry," she mouthed, "I had to tell them."

By the time they'd finished dessert, the atmosphere had lifted. Diane fetched out two packs of cards from the special cupboard, opened one and confounded the menfolk with Find the Lady. Both Miranda and Sheryl were immune to the trick.

Poker was the big event. The solemn appearance of the box of casino chips seemed to cast an invisible shadow over the frivolity. The Wright children watched the box as it proceeded to the table, now covered with green baize. The whole thing was almost a religious experience.

There were no family allegiances when it came to poker, and very little talking unless someone was trying to soften you up or psych you out. Thomas had long since decided that Karl would be a natural poker player. Maybe he'd wangle him an invite for Christmas.

Thomas played cautiously, studying his opponents as chips piled up in the middle of the table. Miranda ran her tongue along her lip for his benefit. He took that as a sign she was bluffing and upped the bet. It was a short-lived strategy.

As he folded, out of chips and out of luck, a call he'd been waiting for finally came through. No one commented. He took it outside the room.

"Tommo, are you available?"

"Give me ten minutes — you picking me up?"

"Yeah, better to have just the one vehicle. I'll be outside."

He made his excuses, grabbed the bag in the hall and went off to change in Miranda's room. Dressed head to toe in black, he kept the balaclava and face paint in his pocket and called a goodbye to his hosts. Miranda muttered something about waiting up for him, and that was that.

Karl was already parked up, similarly attired. "Good to see ya. Hope I didn't spoil your evening any?"

He smiled. He didn't know exactly what he was getting into, but the mere fact he was doing it with Karl made him feel safe. Like a teenager who trusts his mates implicitly. "So what's the plan?"

"Simple really. The Langton household have another vehicle. I want to do to them what they did to your car. Then I put this . . ." he tapped the ring with his gloved finger, ". . . through his letterbox as a message."

“His wife will be terrified — seems a bit unfair.”

Karl looked across as the streetlights blurred by. “Tell that to my mother.”

There was no talking on the rest of the journey, and little to discuss. Thomas would act as the lookout while Karl neutered the car alarm and punched the windows.

“Thomas, are you armed?”

“Jesus, no. What do you take me for?” He stopped then because he remembered the Makarov waiting for him back in Miranda’s room.

“Only asking.”

“Why, are you?” Mrs Langton was hardly public enemy number one. Not her fault she’d married a thug.

“Not armed as such but I’m equipped to defend myself.”

“From what?” Now he was starting to worry.

“Just a precaution, Tommy Boy. Jack Langton isn’t an idiot. He’ll probably think he’s been set up — hopefully by Martin and Francis-Andrew. By the time he gets home, he’ll be sure of it. Anyway, could be he’ll have someone staying over at the house to protect his wife.”

* * *

Karl parked on a corner, offering a good vantage point in three directions — one of them facing the road where Jack’s house stood. “Right, here’s yours,” he passed Thomas a walkie-talkie. “Very simple. You see anyone, and it’s one tone. Anyone you think is suspect and it’s two tones. Anyone suspect heading *my* way and you drive towards me and beep the horn. Smooth, mind — no amateur dramatics. I get in the car and away we go — got it?”

Thomas watched the darkness, glad that he’d opted to leave out the balaclava and face paint — tricky to explain if someone passed by. It was close on midnight now, nothing to see but curtained lights blinking off.

He couldn’t put his finger on it, but there was something satisfying about this. He’d missed. His senses strained against the glass, rigid with tension and also loving it.

Then his walkie-talkie two-toned. That wasn’t part of Karl’s pre-flight safety sequence. He started up the car and pulled out, crossing the side street. He cut the lights and let it move slowly forward. Half way down the

road, a figure walked out, waving an arm to slow him down. As he drew level, Karl got into the back of the car, behind him.

“Slow as you can and don’t over-rev. I’ll tell you when to stop.” He lowered the rear window, letting in the cool night air. “Steady now, pull alongside the people carrier, on the right.”

At first the vehicle looked undamaged, until Thomas noticed four flat tyres.

“Get ready, I’ve posted the bullet. So it’s two strikes and then we’re out of here.” Karl leaned out of the window and swung back with what looked like a hatchet, smashing through the windscreen then swinging the other way for the driver’s window.

Thomas didn’t hang about, pulling away smartly to the sound of a ferocious dog barking somewhere behind them. He couldn’t speak, could only focus on resurrecting the headlights and creating some distance. Karl wound the window up and sat back with a contented sigh.

“Nice work, amigo. The car was too new for me to chance the alarm so I settled initially for puncturing all the tyres. Then I thought ‘no, fuck it,’ his boys did it to you. That was one loud alarm though, eh?”

Thomas shook his head. He hadn’t heard anything apart from broken glass and the pounding in his chest. “An axe though?”

“Listen, at least I didn’t put a bullet *through* the windscreen.”

He couldn’t argue with that.

“Have you time for one drink, Tommo?”

“Yeah, I’d like that.”

“Grand. I hope you’re not just saying so because of the axe on the back seat.”

* * *

It was, as Karl had promised on the way in, the kind of joint where people dressed head to toe in black didn’t raise any concerns. Basically, they were just glad of the business — any business. Two blokes at the far end were playing as good a game of darts as two people can play when they’re really pissed, with as many darts landing in the wall as on the board. The barman watched them with a blank, bored expression plastered across his face.

Karl got in the provisions and directed Thomas as far as away from human contact as possible. “Here’s to you, Kathleen Victoria McNeill.” He raised a half-pint solemnly.

Thomas nodded, glancing at the pub lights turned golden through his glass. Karl was still lost in the moment, so he did the decent thing and left him to it.

“You know, back there on the job, Tommo, I think we shared a bit of a magic moment.”

“Yeah,” he filtered through the pile of crisps for three of a similar size. “I’ll give you that. It was just like old times. Probably did me some good.”

Karl nodded appreciatively then emptied his glass in a single pour. “I want you to know, Thomas, that I have always held you in the highest regard.”

“What’s your next move, then, apart from a shovel full of crisps?”

Karl laughed quietly but that distant look hadn’t left his face. “Ideally, I’d get the chance to deliver some payback to Martin and Francis-Andrew — about twenty years’ worth. I’m banking on tonight’s trail of breadcrumbs leading Jack Langton straight to Belfast. Stuart Fraser could be a useful contact for stirring things up across the water, pointing the boys back towards Jack Langton. Just add hot water and stir. Me? I’m a regular *Yojimbo*.”

Thomas knew he was expected to ask and chose not to. “Well, just don’t go doing anything stupid — otherwise I’ll end up being partnered with Ann Crossley permanently.”

“Hey listen, she’s come up in my estimation in the last few months.”

“Now I am getting worried!”

“Relax, Tommo, I don’t plan on going anywhere for the time being. Right, come on, let’s get you home to the fair Miranda.”

* * *

First thing Thomas did in the car was turn his mobile back on and check his voicemail. He was disappointed. “Tell me something, why doesn’t Clarity just get in her car and keep driving?”

Karl turned the radio down even further. “Same reason Sir Peter Carroll wasn’t deposed as head of the Surveillance Support Unit when you exposed him. It’s not the way things are done, not when there’s something bigger at

stake. Sir Peter is of more use to us in Whitehall, and right now Clarity can get more done on the inside at Engamel.”

Thomas looked at the mobile screen again.

“It’ll be soon.” Karl promised him. “Just you make sure you’re on the ball.”

He mock saluted; there was no smile in return.

“When the call comes in, ring me before you get on the road.”

“But I thought you wanted to stay out of it.”

Karl waved a hand, so-so fashion. “What I want and what has to be done can be very different things. Remember, Tommo, I’m on standby too. And listen, make sure you are fully equipped — do we understand each other?”

“Crystal.” Thomas felt his trigger finger move involuntarily. “I’ll see you.” He got out of the car and walked up the drive.

The lights were still on in the Wrights’ house. Time check: nearly one am. Now was one of those times when he wished he still had a key. Nothing else to do, but knock and hope someone was up.

Miranda eased back the door with the chain on. “Are you the tall, dark, handsome stranger I ordered online?”

He smiled wearily and she took the hint, closing the door to reopen it without the chain.

“We all waited up. Sam and Terry are throwing a bit of a moody — probably women trouble.”

Funny, he’d never known them to have any trouble with women. He followed Miranda in and muttered something about how nice a cup of tea would be. He was still blushing from what she’d muttered in return as he entered the front room.

Diane, John, the boys and Sheryl all sat to attention. “Everything all right, Thomas — with Karl and that?” John got in there first.

He nodded and grabbed a seat. Almost immediately, Terry and Sam stood as one and headed for the kitchen. “Something I said?”

“Take no notice Thomas, those two have been acting up all evening.” Diane swept a hand in the air, in their wake.

“Maybe it’s their time of the month — they’ve synchronised.” Sheryl grinned.

Miranda returned with a mug in each hand. “Kettle’s boiled if anyone else wants one — the Brothers *Grim*,” she nodded to Thomas, who’d first coined the phrase, “are still out there, bickering about something.”

The conversation died down again. Diane and John gave up the cause and said their goodnights. Only then did Sheryl start talking again. “Will Jack go to prison?”

Thomas figured that she’d filled Miranda in about the drugs, otherwise she wouldn’t be asking him openly.

“I don’t know.” He felt bad saying it, wished he could reassure her it would all go away. But he didn’t bullshit his friends. “It all depends on whether he had the stuff on him when he was nicked.” He stopped and drank his tea.

“Well, I’ll leave you two lovebirds alone. I’ll see you in the morning.”

“Here we are, then.” Miranda leaned against him, both hands clasped around the mug.

He tilted his head and squeezed his shoulders back, feeling the relief as the tension shifted. “Are you still cool with Sheryl, now you know she’s a Langton?”

“Let’s just go to bed.” She spoke through a yawn. And the way she said it, there wasn’t a come-on for miles around.

His bag was waiting in her room, unopened. There was no preamble; all those pretences had been scoured off by the years. She escaped from her jeans and stepped into the en-suite, leaving him to it. He waited until he could hear her peeing before he checked the bag again, making sure the Makarov was there and loaded.

He tried the bathroom door and went inside. And even though no good would come of it tonight, he couldn’t resist drawing her hips towards his and wrapping himself around her. She tasted fresh, like the perfect after-dinner mint. But sleep was the only thing on the menu.

Last thing before lights out, he plugged the mobile in and turned the glow to the wall. Then he hit the light switch and lay there, Miranda’s leg against his, strong and sensuous. He closed his eyes and relived the craziness of the day. He felt wrung out by the end of it and turned towards Miranda in the dark, smiling at the sound of her sleeping. With any luck, they’d get a lie-in. The way the day had gone, he was definitely feeling lucky.

* * *

It took a few seconds to realise that the ringtone was his. Miranda squirmed under the duvet, muttered and elbowed him sharply. He was wide-awake now, scrabbling over the side of the bed for the phone. Miranda hit the light, behind him.

“Hello?” It could be any one of three, four if he included Karl in the list.

“It’s Clarity. I’m at Engamel. You need to come *now* — I can’t talk.” She cut the call.

He slumped out of bed to his knees and hit speed-dial. Karl picked up second ring, sounding impossibly alert.

“Thanks, Tommo, I’ll do what I have to then get on the road. I’ll see you there. Stay sharp.”

As he dragged his clothes on, he was intoxicated with excitement. If he was anything, he was a creature of purpose and here was a purpose he could relish. He unzipped the bag and dug out a torch and the Makarov. As he turned to holster it in a side pocket, Miranda was sitting up in bed, watching him.

She didn’t say anything at first — she didn’t need to. Her face was a collage of disappointment and concern. He would have been more concerned too, if he’d had the time.

“Is it always going to be like this?”

He figured she knew better than to expect an answer. “Go back to sleep; I’ll ring you later.” He didn’t bother qualifying that because it would only raise questions he didn’t have answers to. As he reached the front door, he heard another mobile going off. Probably Sam or Terry’s — women trouble after all, then.

Chapter 39

The door closed, like the great divide — on one side, Miranda and her family; and on the other a place of shadows and intrigue: Karl's world. He connected the mobile to the hands-free unit and started up the car, heading for the M25 London Orbital Motorway, to pick up the M40 for Chipping Norton and the Engamel Facility.

It was four thirty in the morning and he was wired from a lack of decent sleep, thoughts whirling in his head to the sound of the engine. And the further he travelled, the less anything made any sense. Why had Clarity rung him now? And what was he supposed to do — turn up at the gate like a minicab and whisk her away? Nah, Michael Schaefer wasn't the amenable type. There was no plan and another ten miles of driving made no impact on that.

The mobile kicked off again. He clicked the button and prepared to shout — the earpiece being safe and sound, back in the box. It must be Karl unless Clarity was ringing with an update.

"Yeah, it's Thomas. Go ahead, I'm driving."

"Thomas?" The voice repeated, as if weighing him up. "This is Internal Communications — we spoke before. I did say we'd talk to you again."

Even though he didn't count himself as a believer anymore, religious education at school had taught him three things: 1) Fight the good fight with all thy might; 2) Jesus loved him just the way he was; and 3) There were no coincidences, just the unseen hand of God. Or, in this case, the unseen hand of someone else.

"What do you want?"

"Perhaps we can be of mutual assistance again. Are you still there, Thomas?"

He winced — rookie mistake, giving his name away. "Yes, I'm here. Look, I'm a bit busy right now." No response. Then he remembered what time it was. "How did you know I'd be up and about this early in the morning?"

At first there was silence. "You're driving one of our vehicles."

Logic checked in. The car must have a tracer on it, and that meant they probably knew his destination. “Do you know who I am?” he heard his own voice pitch upwards.

“No, Thomas; I don’t. But I still think we can help each other.”

For the next fifteen minutes that calm, objective voice instructed him on what to say at Engamel’s security gate, and how to find his way around the building, and what to watch out for.

He couldn’t be sure what *he’d* given away — certainly not Karl’s involvement. But whoever they were, they understood the situation more clearly than he did, and they had their own objective: protect the operative.

Once he was on the M40 he rang Karl, starting with the standard failsafe. “You free to talk?” The background noise sounded like a small lorry.

“No. McNeill out.”

End of discussion. Now, that was a weird one. Formal. Like maybe Karl had company and didn’t want him identified? That would rule out Christine, Ann Crossley and the major, unless there was someone else present. He rubbed an eye with the ball of his thumb; he needed a coffee.

* * *

Thirty-one . . . thirty-two, he caught himself counting the lampposts, imposing numerical order on the unknown. “Chipping Norton,” he read the sign aloud, as if to confirm it, and gripped the steering wheel tighter. The mobile was no comfort — Karl out of reach and Miranda further away than ever.

He watched for the exit, and after that the nondescript minor road snaking through the countryside like a threat. The sky was pale and clear. It held the promise of a good day, if he could figure out what one of those was anymore.

Warning signs informed him he was on private land with strictly no unauthorised access. The speed bumps were so far apart that he took them for pressure sensors. *Coming, ready or not.* Beyond the road, fenced in on both sides, he saw discreet steel and glass buildings, scattered across the landscape.

A new sign appeared, warning of *extreme* tyre damage to the unauthorised. Then a shining oasis of brilliance erupted up ahead — a

reception desk and sentry box combined. He pulled alongside, gave his name and arced his Surveillance Support Unit ID card across the glass. This was never going to be a surprise raid.

There was no preamble, just a check of his name against a list and a caution to follow the signs. Then a button was pushed and a wide row of spikes in front of the car dropped below the surface of the road. The instant he passed through, a yellow arrow appeared on a display board, pointing straight ahead. A few yards on, another came on in sequence — this was electronic ‘follow my leader.’ He kept to a steady speed and trailed the arrows for another fifty yards, arriving in an empty parking area where a flashing rosette shone out from the tarmac in a parking bay.

He parked dead centre, engine off. It was an edgy kind of quiet, like before a storm. Nothing stirred. Common sense suggested he’d be under CCTV surveillance so he kept his hands visible, far from the handgun. As soon as he was out of the car, a light appeared above a door. He locked up and took a slow, steady walk towards it, checking out the terrain in case he had to make a sudden about turn.

As expected, the door opened automatically, closing behind him as the lock set. Past the point of no return now.

“Keep walking, Tommy.” Michael Schaefer’s voice ricocheted through the speakers. “Sorry to drag you out of bed at this hour,” he sounded almost pleasant.

Thomas thought about that as he advanced along the corridor. Why wouldn’t he be? Clarity might have been the one to call him, but not so long ago Schaefer had offered him a job. So why did Schaefer want him there?

The doors he passed had colour codes and card-swipe mechanisms, and the sort of handles that suggested biometric security.

“Next door on the right — come on in, we’re all waiting.”

Uh oh. That didn’t sound good. He touched the door and it levered in effortlessly. The first thing he saw was Schaefer, glass in hand.

“Hey everyone, Tommy made it to the party!”

He looked behind Schaefer, remembering the advice on the phone call to stay sharp; one fire exit on the far side, difficult to get to unless he went through Schaefer — always an option though. He was so focused on his own thoughts that it took a moment to realise there were other people in the

room. Sitting down to one side, as if awaiting judgement: Clarity and Major Eldridge. The major wasn't in good shape at all.

"I think his arm's broken." Clarity spoke quietly.

"Can you believe this asshole, Tommy?" Schaefer pointed at the major with his glass. "Who the fuck does he think he is — pointing a fucking gun at me." He freed his hand from behind his back and let the baseball bat hang down. "And what about you, Tommy?"

He swallowed hard, playing for time or an angle, whichever proved to be more useful. "I got a call to come here, Mr Schaefer. I assumed you needed to see me."

Schaefer's gleeful laughter poisoned the room. "It's about time I got some respect around here. That's right, Tommy, *I* sent for you. That job I offered you has just become a promotion. But first you need to prove your worth."

He looked over at Clarity and the major, then back at Schaefer very slowly. "I'm listening."

"A little radical action is needed to keep the Scavenger project on track. You see Tommy, there's a bright future for the right man. All he has to do is eliminate the competition."

Clarity glanced back at him. He looked away to the far windows. *Where's Deborah?* "Mr Schaefer, I'd really like to work with you . . ." *Work on you, you fucker.* ". . . But I'm not sure I understand your meaning."

Schaefer's eyes narrowed and his mouth widened. "You said you'd used a gun before, didn't you?"

Thomas put a hand to his mouth; he wasn't pretending. This guy was out of his tree. "How much money are we talking about?"

"Name your price, Tommy — whaddya say, 50K a head plus bonuses? There's only the four of us here, no cameras in this room and this is private land. Do I have to spell it out for you?"

He flinched a little as he felt the moment slip away.

Schaefer shook his head with disgust. "Nah, I thought not. I'm disappointed, Tommy. I really hoped you'd come through for me. Hey, the cavalry has arrived." He looked down to his left. "Let me patch them through."

A wall screen fizzled into life, showing a Land Rover stopping on its own rosette of lights. Thomas's jaw gaped as Karl and Sir Peter scurried

towards the building.

“Come on in, guys — the party’s just getting started.” Schaefer spoke aloud, eyes still on the monitor screen, obviously miked up.

Thomas watched through gritted teeth as the screen switched to a different camera. There was Karl’s Land Rover — the one Thomas had last seen parked outside his flat — sat on the tarmac, out some distance on another side of the building. The front of the vehicle was clearly visible and so was the canister underneath.

He checked the room again. Schaefer was staring intently at a screen. Major Eldridge’s eyes were closed. Clarity sat close to him, one arm draped over his shoulder.

He stood adrift in the standoff and folded his hands together. “Shouldn’t we get him an ambulance?”

Schaefer sniffed the air indifferently. “Tell you what, Tommy, as soon as we’ve taken care of business, you can do whatever you like.” He reached across to a release button and the door swung inward.

Sir Peter stepped inside, Karl lagging behind him like a servant. The major roused a little, took sight of the latest arrivals and sank back against Clarity.

“You had the Land Rover all along?” Thomas threw it in Karl’s direction in the hope that some of it stuck.

“I’m sorry, Tommo. I needed to be sure about Major Eldridge, once it was obvious who’d put Jess and the remaining Scavenger off the base. I thought I could smoke him out, along with anyone else involved.”

“So what the bloody hell’s it doing here then?”

“It was my decision, Thomas.” Sir Peter announced to the room, as if addressing an inquiry. “It’s here as collateral.”

Schaefer gestured to Sir Peter then at the major. “Now you see why I wanted you to join the team, Tommy? You don’t think like these guys — Sir Peter has told me *all* about you.”

He glared at his boss, who stood there calmly, withstanding his contempt.

“Okay, enough Limey chit-chat, let’s get to the main event. What sort of damage limitation are we looking at here?” Schaefer spoke directly to Sir Peter.

Thomas gazed back at the screen. Why would Karl be stupid enough to bring the Scavenger firing mechanism over to Engamel? Simple: he wouldn't. And maybe that was why he didn't look Thomas in the eye.

Sir Peter was still talking with Schaefer, as if no one else was around, like the transatlantic special relationship gone wrong.

"Holy shit," Karl blurted out, and everyone followed his line of vision.

Schaefer must have pushed another magic button because the monitor was split-screen now. On the right-hand side was the miraculous Land Rover; and on the left, some sort of military hardware. Thomas choked on a breath as the armoured vehicle sharpened into view — it was the C12, no question.

The C12 swung hard left and as soon as the turret started turning, it was painting by numbers. He knew exactly where Deborah was now and what was coming. It was still mesmerising, watching as the big gun fired.

The direct hit was a foregone conclusion. Even so, everyone in the room jolted as the Land Rover exploded into flames. Schaefer let out some kind of Texan cowboy whoop, and both Thomas and Karl made a move towards him, at least until the baseball bat put in a reappearance.

Sir Peter looked lost, as if Schaefer had deviated from some prearranged plan. "Michael, let's be reasonable. What are you looking for?"

Thomas wanted to block his ears, but his hands had tightened by his side.

"It's like this — *Peter*, old pal. The next phase of the Scavenger development cannot be hampered by past events."

Jesus, this guy has no soul. His eyes widened to take it in.

"What we need is to finish the clean-up operation. That crazy bitch Jess is stateside now and as for the last remaining Scavenger test model . . ." He pointed his bat at the screen, where the smouldering wreckage told its own story. "Which leaves three little details. One — the second encrypted disc of images from the range accident. What you might call Amy's finale."

Thomas felt his mouth dry and his muscles start throbbing. The only thing holding him back was whether Schaefer was packing a piece as well as the bat.

"Two — the test data, which I gather Jess gave to Tommy as a leaving gift. Let me guess, Major Eldridge? Am I right?"

No one spoke. No one had to.

“And lastly,” Schaefer was really playing to the gallery now, “There’s all of you. We’re the only ones who know exactly what happened. And let’s face it, an inquiry ain’t getting in the way of business.” He reached for his glass again.

Thomas was already doing the maths: how much run up he’d need to get over the counter and start pounding the shit out of him. He looked around for a surprise weapon — nothing doing — then remembered the torch. Yeah, and then what? Apart from Karl, no one else seemed to have a problem with all of this.

Sir Peter muttered something to the major, who nodded slowly and opened his coat. Clarity reached in and pulled out the plastic case.

Thomas watched the scene play out in slow motion. The DVD went first to Sir Peter, who calmly walked it across. As he passed, Thomas felt a twinge, an urge to pull the Makarov and take them both down. But he was banking on Karl being smarter than Sir Peter and having some kind of backup plan. Although that hope was waning by the minute.

Karl had edged to the right a little, his face was a mask of calm. Thomas had seen that face before, just after Mrs Langton’s car won a weekend pass to the glaziers.

Schaefer tilted the plastic case as if he could read its contents by eye, and smiled his smug bastard smile. “Nice work, boys. And now, the test data.” He put the bat down on the counter, as if indicating that the rules of the game had changed.

Sir Peter opened his tailored coat, and retrieved an envelope. The major sank a little, as if someone had just put his mother on eBay. “It’s for the best, Charles.”

“Wise move guys. Now, we have one final problem. The Scavenger is a multi-million-dollar deal. Maybe billions, once we get to full deployment.”

“It’s not ready!” the major shrieked. “It’s unsafe. I won’t let you . . .”

“You won’t do shit.” Schaefer pulled out a gun and gave it some air.

“Now, Michael,” Sir Peter folded his hands together. “There’s no need for that — let’s talk terms. I propose limited deployment — with an addendum to the user manual that ammunition must not be loaded randomly — just until we sort this glitch out. We cannot afford any more collateral damage.”

As Thomas turned towards Sir Peter Carroll he felt his hands go cold.

Karl had found his voice at last. “Poor Amy died because *he* wanted to meet some godforsaken delivery deadline and now you’re gonna allow him to go ahead?” He shook his head violently. “No way, not a chance.”

Thomas stole the moment and pulled the torch out, flinging it towards Schaefer. It wasn’t exactly an assault, more of a distraction. It did the job though. Schaefer blocked it with his hand and by the time he’d looked up again, Thomas had him in his sights, the Makarov pistol resolute and unwavering.

“Put it away, son, before you write a cheque you can’t afford to settle.” Schaefer faced him down, drawing his own weapon.

“Nah, *you* put it away.” Karl had seen the Makarov and raised Thomas a Browning, catching the Yank in a three-way standoff.

Schaefer tried to play it down. “Say, Peter, I’m disappointed,” he laughed aloud, like he was waiting for everyone else to join in. “I thought you could control your boys.”

The old man’s face turned a shade of apoplectic. “You will both stand down immediately!” he roared. “I order you.”

Thomas glanced towards Karl, who took a moment then nodded slowly. “Do as he says, Tommo. Sir Peter is our superior.”

Thomas recoiled like he’d been stabbed. When it came down to it, even Karl was willing to knuckle under to preserve the double-edged relationship his *people* had with Sir Peter. He stuffed the weapon in his pocket and turned to Karl silently — no sense in wasting any words.

Everyone else seemed to be focused on Schaefer. Meantime, Thomas caught the flicker of the monitor screen before it fractured into eight squares, each one a different camera view. Something flitted across three of them, like a shadow. Then the shape stopped moving and hunched down.

I spot details that other people miss. That was the line he’d sold Sir Peter Carroll at his SSU job interview. He wasn’t kidding. He watched the stand-off play out around him and an instinct awoke. Something triggered, like a lyric sung before the full song is recognised. The Internal Comms caller had told him to protect the operative.

He looked back at his oppo. *Fuck.* “Karl, get down — gun!” He launched himself across the space between them, taking Karl to the ground. Seconds later, a bullet punctured the window and hit the wall.

Karl rolled Thomas off him and hunted around to retrieve his Browning. Thomas was ahead of him, levelling back at Schaefer, untroubled by conscience.

Schaefer's hands were wide in protest, and neither one held a gun.

"You better call her in," Karl kept low, signalling to Thomas to do likewise, "or I'll put a bullet in her."

"Er, Deborah, you heard what the man said," Schaefer sounded as convincing as a car salesman on a Friday evening.

"Sorry, Michael," Deborah's voice had shed its playfulness. "There's been a change of plan. It looks like the clean-up is gonna be more thorough than we anticipated."

Another bullet zinged through the glass, into the ceiling, popping one of the strip lights.

"She's got us pinned down," Karl spoke directly to Thomas then turned towards Schaefer. "How many exits out of here? And for God's sake cut the microphone."

Schaefer reached above the desk. "Done. There are three ways out of this block — assuming all the doors still work — but she knows that."

"Mr McNeill, it's time you took care of this." Sir Peter sounded sombre.

"Sir," Karl acknowledged, as if they'd reached some kind of accord. "Right, Michael, give your gun to Clarity."

Schaefer skidded the pistol across the floor and Karl intercepted it.

"Tommo, swap this Browning for your peashooter — you're more used to it."

He did as asked, checking the clip and pressing his skin around the handle. The adrenaline began to surge. He knew what was coming, and this time he was ready.

"Right, here's how we do this. Thomas and I go out the fire exit; I don't suppose we can help the alarms. Mr Schaefer, we're relying on you to hold Deborah's attention. And if you warn her, Schaefer, you'll live to regret it — that's a promise." He looked directly at the major, who nodded darkly.

Thomas crawled forward until he and Karl were shoulder to shoulder, facing the fire door. He felt blood pounding through his arteries.

"Ready, Thomas?"

He nodded, unable to speak, eyes glistening.

“When we get outside, make for the first embankment then we’ll split two ways. Schaefer,” he twisted his head back, “the agreements made here still apply — if we get Deborah out of the picture.”

Chapter 40

Four . . . three . . . two . . . one . . . GO! Thomas watched as Karl barrelled through the fire escape, claxons blaring after him. He wasn't long in following Karl, straining every muscle to keep pace, forcing himself to look beyond the mirage of Yorgi's face lurking at the back of his mind.

He slammed flat against the damp grass, panting into the moisture and dirt. Then he heard Karl's call and twisted round to catch the finger movements, directing them in a pincer movement.

"I'll draw her fire and then you run like the wind."

Time didn't slow down. It intensified, compounding focus, like a long lens. A gun went off behind him and he lurched towards the trees, colours blurring around him. He smashed against tree bark, one palm outspread to receive it like a blessing, crouching low, hand stinging, tracking all directions for movement.

There was no trace of Karl behind him; he was alone. He held his breath and listened. Then, caught between desperation and urgency, he got ready to move.

"Over here, Tommo!" Karl's voice carried in the air, punctuated by a gunshot.

Karl had drawn her out as planned. Through the trees, Thomas saw his car — the one Karl had procured for him. Another shot rang out — hopefully return fire — and that made up his mind for him. He belted towards the vehicle, hitting the unlock button mid-sprint. His hands were shaking as he hurled himself inside but he got the engine to start first time, curving backwards to open out the tarmac ahead of him. He set the safety on the Browning in his lap and roared off, taking the kerb so fast that his head smacked against the roof; it didn't delay him any.

Soon he was flying over the embankment and crunching down the other side, ploughing through the gears to get up speed. There was no plan, no strategy, other than to get to Karl.

He knew the sound of a Browning, homing in as Karl fired a volley at the femme fatale. As he got closer to the target zone, he could see Karl's position — and Deborah's — through the windscreen. Then there was a dull

explosion and the car twisted round. He pulled the wheel, but it was no use — the tyre had burst and physics was running the show now. The wheel snapped back and the driver's door arched over him. He thought he saw Karl's face, framed momentarily through the glass, then the sky whirled by, over and over, as he tumbled inside the car. He tried counting the rotations, as if that would somehow help. He lost count after three and closed his eyes against the nausea, trying to hold his arms in and keep still as possible.

As the car slow-somersaulted for the final time and rocked to a standstill, he heard shouting. Then a sickening lone shot rang out, like a mercy killing, and Karl was nowhere to be seen.

He pressed against the headrest, blinking as the blood seeped down his face. Something was getting closer. A dull static filled his brain, like a broken machine. He wanted to sleep, wanted to let it all slip away from him. But the sharpest pain, in his thigh, wouldn't let him be. It felt like a chunk of metal, wedged tight against his skin, puncturing it. He reached down and felt the back of the Browning. It took two breaths to prise it out from under his leg; he'd been lucky.

He wiped the blood away with his left hand and forced himself to focus. The shape became steadily clearer, and Deborah's laughter left him in no doubt. She was dressed head to foot in combat gear, hobbling towards him like his crippled nemesis. He moved his hand over his gun and released the safety catch, waiting and watching, as she closed in on him for the kill.

He remembered the times before, when he'd held a gun. As a boy, confronting his own father, and then with Yorgi, over the moors — shooting *him* out of rage. He knew that Karl needed his help now — might even be dead — but he pushed those thoughts aside. Right now it was just the hunter and the hunted: simple as that.

Deborah was a hand's grasp from the passenger door. He stayed very still, propping the gun against his leg and angling it upwards. The laughter hadn't stopped — she was really on a roll. And now it was time for the punchline.

Their eyes met and in that instant he felt something. Maybe respect, maybe a fleeting twinge of conscience. It made no difference. He tensed up and squeezed the trigger, exactly how you're not supposed to. It didn't impede the bullet that hit her at close range, punching her backwards with a muffled scream.

He caught his breath, realising in that instant that he was more vulnerable than ever. He wasn't sure where the bullet had struck her — and she could be wearing a vest. Terror shook him, his hands scrabbling frantically at the handle to push with all his might until the battered door gave free.

As he slid to the ground he saw her feet beneath the other side of the car, laid out like a corpse. He kneeled to stand, the ground swirling around him. Then he heard her moan and knew that it would not be over until she was no threat at all. He stumbled around the front of the car, reversing roles now, stalking her.

She lay, contorted, clutching her abdomen, blood smeared across her torso and hands. A look passed between them; the look a gazelle gives the lion when it realises there is no more room for manoeuvre. She coughed, and it sounded a little like tears, although he didn't imagine that she had any. His gun arm was out, scenting her through the barrel, his gaze unblinking. She fumbled towards her own gun on the grass and her fingers trembled, but she didn't have the strength.

He rushed forward and stamped down on her weapon, leaning over her, the Browning quivering slightly in the breeze.

"Do it!" She gurgled, her hand still extended for the weapon he was standing on.

He kicked her hand away and let her scream again. "Yeah, but I'm a civilian."

"Tommo!" Karl's voice was weary, raw.

Thomas picked up the .38 automatic and ran over, blinking back tears. "I knew you'd be wearing a vest."

"Yeah, but I hit my bloody head — it's killing me. Is Deborah . . .?"

"She'll live, probably." He pulled out the mobile and flicked through his call register. "It's Thomas. The operative is safe. We need an ambulance urgently."

Karl dragged himself to sitting. "What? Have you joined the team now?"

"Nah. Just a favour for a friend." He helped Karl to his feet.

They waited together beside Deborah, Karl using his field skills to make her as comfortable as possible. Neither of them spoke to her; she was hardly going to dictate a letter of apology. The ambulance wasn't long in

coming. A cynic might suggest that the clean-up crew had been waiting around the corner, waiting until Karl and Thomas had done the dirty work. And if that were true, it would be just like every other day in the Surveillance Support Unit.

He followed Karl's example and let the medics have a couple of minutes on him, before returning to Schaefer and the others.

"You okay, Tommo?" Karl held out his hand for the major's gun.

"Yeah," he returned it willingly. "Better than okay, actually."

"If it's all the same to you, I'll tell the major that I took his gun — it saves a lot of complication."

"Fine by me. I'm not looking for a mention in despatches."

"Well, Mr Bladen, you deserve a medal as far as I'm concerned. Will you settle for a shandy and a bag of crisps?"

"Deal."

* * *

Thomas saw it through different eyes now, the way the wheels turned in the aftermath. Sir Peter, the major and Michael Schaefer all playing together nicely, while he and Karl were consigned to the shadows. He preferred it that way — the less he knew about the handshakes under the table, the easier he would sleep at night.

Miranda had been to his flat three days running — a personal record, since their split up all that time ago. She didn't ask any big questions and it saved him having to lie to her. He phoned Karl every day, just talking around things instead of confronting them. According to the Celtic Wonder, Deborah had admitted that Karl was one of the jobs she'd been paid to take care of. He also said that she'd undergone surgery and was expected to make a full recovery. Thomas felt nothing about it. And Karl's confession that he'd visited her in hospital only prompted a vague sense of disbelief. But he knew that was how things were in Karl's world — no absolutes, and a backdrop of permanently shifting grey.

Word also reached him — via John Wright — that the case against Jack Langton was pretty watertight. There was a good chance he'd go to prison. The rumour was that other things had caught up with Jack at the same time — he'd be looking at a hefty sentence, even with a decent lawyer.

* * *

“You seem very pleased with yourself.” Miranda’s talent for the obvious didn’t diminish the feeling any.

“I managed to have a chat today with my new overseas friend.”

Miranda murmured and went back to sifting through a pile of DVDs. “Rom com, thriller or black-and-white?”

He laughed. The chances of finding a romantic comedy in that lot, unless she’d hidden it beforehand, were exactly nil. “Anything, you choose.” He sat back and watched her foraging through the DVD cases. Life was good.

“Speaking of phone calls,” Miranda’s voice wavered, “I talked to Geena last night. She wanted to know how we’d feel about being godparents, sort of.”

He shrugged against the upholstery. “Blimey, that’s a bit premature.” But he stopped himself from ruining the moment. Nice that Geena — or more likely Ajit — had put them at the top of the list. Although he figured it was a very short one anyway.

“I know, babe, but it’s nice to be asked. Anyway, we could always . . .” Miranda didn’t get to finish her sentence because the doorbell rang. “I’ve got it,” she trilled and headed for the door.

Meantime, he sneaked a peek at the DVDs she’d approved. He was still shuffling a trio of them when Miranda returned with a visitor: Karl.

“Any chance of a cuppa — I’ve brought my own biscuits and everything.”

Thomas smiled. But, as he still hadn’t subscribed to Coincidence Weekly, he signalled for Karl to follow him through to the kitchen. “How’s things then?” he kicked the door shut behind them. Miranda would understand.

“Yeah, pretty good, Tommo. I come bearing news — and you’ll likely not appreciate it.” Karl opened the biscuits and helped himself to a plate from the cupboard.

Thomas sorted the mugs and spoons, relying on Karl and the redemptive powers of confession.

“Sir Peter Carroll met with Christine Gerrard this week. Seems he’s flexing his muscles a little. He wants us back on the job Monday.”

“That was the plan anyway, wasn’t it?” he pushed a mug across to Karl and picked up the other two.”

“Nah, he wants us back on the *same* job. I’m to report to Major Eldridge now and you, my friend, are to report to Michael Schaefer.”

“You’ve got to be kidding.”

“Do I look like it? Oh, and while I’m here, could I have that mobile phone back?”

They went through to the front room. Miranda muted the TV and gave up on the remote. She grabbed a mug from Thomas and a couple of biscuits from Karl.

“You two look like you won the lottery and then found you’d burned your ticket.”

Karl took up residence in an armchair. “Does she know . . . ?”

“Oi. I am in the room, thank you very much.”

Karl looked suitably shamefaced. “No offence, Miranda — force of habit.”

“Tell her, Karl. I want Miranda to hear what we did last week.” He didn’t know how this was going to play out. Fuck it, Karl could decide what she ought to know.

Karl put his tea down and looked straight at her. “Thomas saved my life last week. He put himself between a threat and me, and he shot her.”

Miranda’s face grew rigid. And even though Thomas could only bear to look at her sideways on, he recognised the dullness in her eyes, and he was sorry for having started it. Miranda turned to him and he sensed she was on the verge of tears. He knew that because one look at her and he felt the same way.

“The thing is, Miranda,” Karl’s voice had changed, picking up on the mood shift, “we need to finish something that started with Amy, at the Army Base. And I’m here to ask Thomas to trust me to do right by her, and by him.”

Wow. Thomas hadn’t seen that one coming — a speech to the jury from Karl.

“Look, I won’t stay any longer. I can see that you both might need a minute — if I can just have the mobile then I’ll be away.”

Miranda casually brushed her hand across her face, crushing the tears as she stood up. “Nah, you stay put, Karl. It’s about time we got past this. I know how much that business on the base affected Thomas — you too, I

s'pose. So you finish your tea and sort out what you need to sort out. I'm just walking down to the chippie — I'll get three cod and chips, shall I?"

Chapter 41

Same reception desk at the Engamel Facility, same arrows at the roadside. But it all led to a different block, far from the car park where the Land Rover had lost out playing who's hardest with the C12 armoured vehicle. From where he parked, this time, he couldn't even see the furrows up the embankment. Or maybe they'd re-laid a shitload of turf since his last visit.

The side door was unlocked. As he walked through, glancing in at windows along the corridor, there was office space, technical classrooms and a comfort lounge, all filled with the great and the good and the name-tagged. It didn't take long to find Michael Schaefer, not when he had his name above the door.

"I'm really pleased you made it, Thomas."

He nodded. Maybe this was American for contrite.

"They won't let me see Deborah. Sir Peter and his cronies have closed ranks — for all I know she's been spirited away."

Yeah, like Jess. "Is that why I'm here?"

"What?" Schaefer paused as if thinking about what he'd just said. "Shit, no — did I come across like that? Sir Peter thought I needed support staff for the next couple of days, until the big announcement. And we couldn't think of anyone more appropriate than you."

He shuddered, and was only stopped from replying by the sight of Clarity some way behind Schaefer. Judging by the hand gesture, she wasn't happy with the aftermath either.

With the welcome speech over, Schaefer handed him a schedule sheet. First thing Thomas noted was the product launch, two days away, and the location: Larksford Army Base. Back where it all began. If it wasn't for Karl, who had schooled him over cod and chips, he could have cheerfully lamped the Yank. But Karl was already on the case, apparently.

"So really you're my personal assistant — just for a couple of days. I'll need you to take some promotional photographs, and to go back through any archives we can use — once you've removed Deborah from them. I want a really classy portfolio for the guests."

"Guests?"

“That’s what I love about you, Tommy. You never see the bigger picture. You’re so . . .” he searched for the right word, “. . . ambitionless! Must be some Limey working-class thing. We’ll be presenting to the investors and our corporate partners, representatives from the military — the people who will take this project forward and make it a success.” He did everything but wave a little flag. “Clarity will show you where everything is. I’ve gotta go to a meeting.”

Thomas stood aside so Schaefer could strut off, and waited at the doorway, wishing he had the Makarov to hand.

“You may as well say it,” Clarity peeled herself away from the keyboard and stood before him, like the accused. “You’ll feel better afterwards.”

He couldn’t see that happening until the assignment was over. “Best I don’t, under the circumstances — I’m just the hired help.”

* * *

Erasing Deborah from video footage and a series of photographs proved to be strangely therapeutic. Often, she was just a figure at the edge of things, but once or twice she’d been the one making promotional presentations. He worked around that by splitting off and running her vocals through some software, and then cutting the footage to turn her into an unseen voiceover. As far as Engamel was concerned, she never existed.

Clarity left him to it and laughing boy didn’t return until late afternoon. So he worked at his own pace, painstakingly editing out the past to meet the needs of the present. And, with Clarity keeping her distance, he took the opportunity to make copies of everything for himself. Have memory stick will travel . . .

He was on his way out the door when he encountered Michael Schaefer in the corridor. A hand blocked his chest. “Hey Tommy, lucky I caught you.” It felt about as coincidental as Christmas in December. “I forgot something — Major Eldridge has requested that you and Karl McNeill don’t contact each other until this is over. I’ve been assured of your cooperation.”

He nodded and pushed past. ‘Assured of cooperation’ sounded like another way of saying, ‘We’re monitoring your calls.’ Same old bollocks, only with a two-hour drive back to London to look forward to.

Outside, the fading sunlight gleamed off his old car, delivered to his flat the night before. The replaced windscreen and bodywork were actually an improvement on the original. He got in and shut the door on the world, checking his mobile before he set off for home. There was one text: *Fancy a meal out tonight? Meet me at Caliban's. Mx.* He pinged back a *Y* and did the rest of his thinking on the road.

The security staff on the gate waved him through, with the kind of detached professionalism that suggested they couldn't give a shit about him. He returned the sentiment.

* * *

Sheryl clocked him as soon as he walked through the pub door. He was relieved to see that predatory look on her face — things hadn't changed between them. "Hey there," she called over, luring him to the bar. "The fair Miranda awaits your pleasure upstairs."

He took the steps one at a time. That nagging instinct that something was amiss was playing in his head like a familiar tune. "It's only me," he called up. No reason, other than to convince himself that he was in control.

"This came today, for you," she passed him a courier package. "Wanna tell me what's going on?"

He shrugged, took the package and opened it in front of her. She stared without comment as a mobile phone saw the light of day — the same mobile Karl had taken away last time they'd all met for cod and chips. When he switched the phone on, there was one new text. Miranda sidled up as he hit the magic button. *Don't rock the boat. Just go along with it. See you in 2 days. J4A.* He nodded and turned the phone off.

"Ready to eat?" Miranda picked her coat off the chair.

"You certainly are." He gave her a winning smile and pocketed the phone.

* * *

"Terry and Sam still feel bad about deceiving you, by hiding the Land Rover and everything, for Karl."

It was the 'and everything' that interested him. So where was the remaining Scavenger firing mechanism now? He kept his thoughts to himself; the Wright family had been dragged far enough into this. "What's the latest with Jack Langton?"

Miranda made him wait. She sipped her wine and ran her eyes over him. “Dad spoke with Mrs Langton — did you know she’s Jack’s second wife? Course you did,” she answered for him, in the way that he hated. “You must know all about him.”

He counted to twelve. No sense having a row with Miranda because of some scumbag. “No, I didn’t. I just wondered what’s happening and how Sheryl is about everything.” Out of habit he checked the surrounding tables to see if anyone was paying them any attention.

She went back to her meal. “What’s J4A?”

He followed her lead, and didn’t look up. “I’m guessing: Justice for Amy.” Then he raised his eyes and caught her smiling. It might have been the wine, but the blood swarmed to his face.

“Don’t get me wrong, Thomas, it’s great that you always try to do the right thing. But what happens when you get out of your depth?”

He grinned stupidly. “That’s when I call in Karl.”

“Hmm,” she tapped a nail against her glass. “I’ve noticed that the more you hang around with Karl, the more aggro it seems to make for me and you.” She dropped her cutlery and raised her hands a little. “I know he’s a good bloke. He just always seems to have an agenda.”

“True,” he conceded with a grin, “but he means well.”

She didn’t share the joke and they finished the meal under a cloud. He paid the bill, insisting that the waiter brought the card machine to the table.

Miranda dug out a tip. “Fancy coming back to mine for a nightcap?” She was matter-of-fact about it, so he didn’t feel bad turning her down.

“Not tonight, babe, I’ve a long drive tomorrow.”

She snapped her handbag. “You wanna be careful, or you’ll end up alone — like Karl.”

Chapter 42

Schaefer had insisted on seeing all the proofs. Thomas drifted to one side as he pored over the options to decide which images would make it into the final presentation portfolio. “I gotta hand it to you, Tommy. Your work’s good. These shots of me and Clarity are pretty smooth — it’s like Deborah never existed.” There was a smirk on his face, as if he wanted to say more. Then Schaefer flicked through a series of images and stopped short. “This your idea of a joke?”

Thomas held the corners of his mouth down. He knew what Schaefer was looking at. A high-resolution solo he’d cleaned up from the CCTV. A composition he liked to call ‘smouldering Land Rover.’

“Asshole,” Schaefer muttered aloud. Then he did what Thomas had expected — rechecking the whole series carefully, to ensure there were no more hidden surprises.

By four o’clock, the deed was done. The glossy portfolios were printed on site and boxed, ready for the big event. Clarity hadn’t been around all day, so Thomas got to see Schaefer close up, watching him as he put the final touches to his speech.

“What happens tomorrow — for me, I mean.”

Schaefer stopped typing, unable to hide his irritation. “You?” Then his face lit up like an incendiary. “You can pick me up here at eight am and drive me to Larksford.”

Eight in the morning. That meant a bastardly early start for a two-hour drive, plus another hour over to the base, with Mr Smug for company.

“Oh, and Tommy, put on a suit. You can at least look the part of a loyal employee. And I want you where I can see you.”

* * *

It felt like the last day of school, albeit one that began with the alarm clock shrieking in the dark. A small price to pay though — after today, there’d no more skivvying for Engamel. He did the shit-shower-shave routine before his brain really moved into gear, then struggled into the suit

he'd pressed the night before. A pity he didn't have a Surveillance Support Unit tie for the finale. He chose a grey one to match the morality.

He kept to the speed limits — speeding was for mugs and emergencies — and promised himself a coffee at the halfway point. He wasn't relishing the prospect of revisiting Larksford. Maybe Schaefer had chosen it to make a point, as if declaring to one and all that he didn't care about anything except the project.

Next roadside services, eighteen miles. *Thank Christ for that.* He tapped at the crucifix he'd put on for the day. Mum would be pleased. He flicked on the radio to keep alert and wound the window down a little. Roll on, caffeine and sugar. As the sun eased through the clouds he began to smile at the absurdity of the situation. How did he get from being a snap-happy teenager in Yorkshire to temping for a weapons manufacturer? He smiled all the more at the answer, and adjusted his crotch as the familiar roll call of memories flooded his brain: Miranda — pure and simple. All roads led back to her.

* * *

He followed the slip road traffic into the services car park. Three minibuses of students, who looked like they were on an outing for soap and water, had spilled out on to the tarmac. He watched them as he parked up, playing a familiar game of spying out which ones were involved together and who the loners were. A couple of young women spotted him and launched into a clinch, prising themselves apart to glare at him, daring him to disapprove. Time for refreshments.

He sat in the cafeteria, to avoid getting crumbs on his suit. On the table beside him, Karl's giveaway mobile was giving nothing away. He was ahead of schedule by fifteen minutes — time enough for caffeine and reflection. And all without resorting to Karl's 80/20 rule, 'Always drive at 80 mph for 20% of the time.' The dick. *Well, best be getting on; don't want to be late on my last day.*

* * *

It was too much to hope for that Michael Schaefer would be waving at the security gate, ready to go. No, Thomas had to play follow the lights one last time and then await his master's orders. He thought about Schaefer's words as he stood at the main reception. Did he really lack ambition? Nah,

he decided. He just had different objectives. Like seeing Schaefer held accountable — that was worth putting on a suit for.

Michael Schaefer arrived through a double door, wheeling an aluminium trolley. Four boxes filled the two shelves. “Tommy, will you get these loaded?” He pushed the trolley out. There was a set of keys on one of the top boxes. “We’re taking a different vehicle,” he pointed in the general direction of the car park.

One scan of the cars on offer was enough. It had to be the Jaguar. Schaefer was just that kind of man. At least the driving detail wouldn’t be so bad. He trolleyed out the boxes and stowed them away. Judging by the amount of catalogues they were expecting a good attendance.

He expected Schaefer to be watching him, and when he took the trolley back he wasn’t disappointed. Schaefer caught up with him at reception. “Not even curious, huh, Tommy?”

He smiled softly; no reply was a silent victory. Once they were in the car — which did indeed drive like a dream — Schaefer was Mr Convivial. It was as if the Jaguar’s air-con carried some sort of truth serum — the man could not stop talking. Mostly it was anecdotes about the important people he’d dealt with in the past and the after-show parties that he’d enjoyed.

Thomas nodded where he was supposed to, or feigned shock, or interest. Truth be told, he didn’t give a shit one way or the other. He let Schaefer ramble on while entertaining fantasies of crushing his head in the car door. It helped to pass the time.

* * *

Schaefer finally shut up when they reached the Larksford perimeter. After the security check, a Land Rover escorted them to an enclosed compound. There was no sign of Karl’s car.

“What time are we leaving?” *Might as well see how the land lies.*

“Yeah, about that, Tommy, you may have to make alternative arrangements — I have a flight to catch first thing tomorrow morning. I’m due a little R & R.”

Nice. He got out of the car. Schaefer sat there and it took Thomas a moment to realise he was waiting for the door to be opened for him.

Have it your way. Maybe Karl could tip off passport control.

“Take the boxes through and then you can start setting up the chairs. The guests won’t start arriving here till noon. I’ll be back in an hour.”

The floorplan revealed that seventy people were expected; the rows of seats set on a graduating dais so that none of the attendees risked missing the excitement. It was a spacious room, strangely corporate for an army base.

From outside, Thomas could hear the background noise of day-to-day soldiering, but inside it was unnaturally quiet. One of the fluorescent strips hummed rhythmically, buzz-clicking every minute or so.

With the seating in place, he positioned the lectern and donned the wireless mike for a sound test, skirting the rim of the room and running through the numbers. Then he moved on to the portfolio boxes, carefully positioning a sealed folder on each chair in the upright position, as per the plan. Michael Schaefer’s copy he opened, to insert his printed notes as a back-up in case the comms failed — tragic as that would be. He was still digging through the last half box of spare folders, when the double doors swung in behind him.

“I’m sorry,” he lifted his head out of the box, but couldn’t be bothered to look round. “The presentation isn’t due to start until noon. Refreshments are available in the hospitality suite — you passed it on the way here.”

“Away with you, Tommo! They’ll check for peasants — I’d never get past the waiters.” Karl rested one hand flat against the door. “Listen, I can’t stop — I’m not really allowed out. Just wanted to show my face.”

“How d’you know I’d be alone?”

“It’s called surveillance, Thomas,” he winked. “I’ll catchya later.”

Around eleven o’clock, Sheryl called Thomas on his mobile. “Hey, I can’t talk long. Miranda’s just nipped out. I gather you were asking about Jack Langton and it kinda killed the mood.”

“Yeah,” he sighed heavily, signalling he wasn’t up for any righteous piss-taking today.

“I won’t be making a habit of this — just wanted you to know that he’s been refused bail in case he skips the country. His lawyer keeps me informed.”

“Does the lawyer know . . . ?”

“He just does whatever Jack tells him to, like everyone else.” There was a short pause. “Well, not everyone! Anyway, gotta go — I’ll put in a

good word for you with Miranda. Bye.”

He walked the chairs for the third time, straightening the line, and rechecked all the comms connections. There was nothing left to do but await Michael Schaefer, only he wasn’t the waiting type. Schaefer answered his mobile, apologising to companions in the background.

“The room’s ready. And I haven’t eaten since seven o’clock this morning.”

“That’s terrific,” Schaefer’s voice rattled from two doors away. “Wait for me.” He rang off.

Thomas was admitted into the corporate suite on condition that he didn’t speak to anyone. Schaefer allowed him a toilet break, and a soft drink and some sandwiches — to be taken back to the presentation room.

Half an hour to go, and sadness consumed him. The emptiness in the room was Amy, a voice that no one else could hear. Sod it, he’d take one of the folders with him, from the spares. As he crossed the room, he spotted a brown envelope by the door. He walked over quietly and inched the door open — there was no one there. The cacophony from the hospitality suite seemed to rise and fall like the thrum of a wasp’s nest.

He picked up the envelope and slit the seal with his finger. There were three pages inside, each one a four-photo display. The backs were adhesive. It didn’t take much to add them to the last pages of Schaefer’s personal presentation pack. Maybe that, and shoving a glossy folder in his jacket, was all he could do, but at least it was something.

* * *

The stream of worthies flowed in like a tide of effluent. He nodded to Michael Schaefer and stood by the door, like a good servant. If he really concentrated, Thomas could still hear the strip light’s tinny protest. All Schaefer seemed aware of was the horde, susceptible to his charm offensive — with the emphasis on *offensive*.

“Ladies and gentlemen, my name is Michael Schaefer, Engamel project director for the urban utility armament — *The Scavenger*.”

Cue carefully chosen music and polite applause. Thomas let it all wash over him. Schaefer sounded every bit the consummate professional, somewhere between Samuel Colt and PT Barnum. It must have been an easy audience, judging by the way they applauded whenever Schaefer took

a choreographed pause. He asked them to hold any questions until the very end, so as not to spoil the chilled champagne in the break. Cue more applause.

Thomas watched from the safety of the wall, wishing he'd rigged up a private camera. This was business with a diamond edge. Sure, armies needed weapons, but the way these people talked about product deployment, concept realisation and marketing strategy, they could have been discussing a games console. And let's face it, to this lot — who had as much chance of seeing active service as Sir Peter Carroll had of being called up again — it *was* all a game. And the game was called profit.

Break time. Schaefer led the guests past Thomas, on their way to the executive trough. No one said a word to him; he was invisible. He knew the schedule — everyone back in thirty minutes. Which didn't prepare him for the large, ominous shadow he saw, approaching through the glass. Sir Peter nodded curtly to him, the way Thomas imagined a lord might acknowledge a servant at Christmas time. "Go outside and help Mr McNeill." *Friendly as ever.*

Karl was wheeling a large grey box, very carefully. "Thanks, Tommo. The major offered, but he's only the one good arm — hairline fracture in two places."

Another PR triumph for Michael Schaefer and Engamel. Once they were inside the room, Sir Peter took his leave to go join the champagne set. Thomas stared at the heavy-duty grey box. Karl didn't venture any clues.

"Nice suit." Karl gazed out at the empty seats.

"You too." Thomas nudged him. "Nervous?"

"Nah. I got a good feeling about this."

"Jack Langton didn't make bail, by the way."

Karl hummed thoughtfully. "... Everything's going my way."

* * *

Sir Peter was first through the door, followed by a worried looking Michael Schaefer.

"Of course you're welcome here, Sir Peter — I just wasn't expecting you," he insisted, hastily dropping the subject in front of the staff.

Thomas stood at the opposite side of the room to Karl. He counted everyone back in — plus two. Major Eldridge had his arm in a sling. It

suited his uniform, somehow — like a reminder of what the job was really about.

Schaefer said a few encouraging words about Sir Peter Carroll and thanked Major Eldridge for his support, even making a joke about the major's injury. Thomas would have given a month's wages at that moment, just to have a decent lens on the major's face.

The good major smiled and told the audience some fabricated bullshit about a riding accident. Schaefer applied his rapier wit again and recommended the major stick to tanks. Everyone lapped it up, except anyone that mattered.

With each pie chart and demographic display, Schaefer turned a page. Thomas edged round the side of the room, moving closer towards him for the magic moment.

"And now, ladies and gentlemen, if we look at the costs — projected over a five year model, we will see . . ."

Schaefer stopped talking. It took the audience a few seconds to catch on, but he was soon the main attraction. Thomas glanced, sideways on; he knew what Schaefer was thinking. Sure he did. Was everyone now looking at pictures of a dead girl? Were they also being confronted by crisp images of her flesh charred and scattered, her bone fragments embedded in the wall like human shrapnel?

Schaefer cleared his throat and it sounded like a squelch over the mike. He gripped the lectern with one hand and flicked through his notes. "Let's skip that page for now. Moving on . . ." He flipped to the next page: another set of photos. The sweat was gathering on his fret lines, beads of panic. By the third page, his breathing was the only sound in the room.

He closed the folder. "You know what?" he waited a moment, judging their reaction, never once looking in Thomas's direction. "Let's take some questions."

Sir Peter Carroll raised a hand. "Is there a 3D model available today, to show us what the Scavenger looks like in the flesh?" He seemed to cling to the last word.

As Schaefer opened his mouth to speak, Thomas looked over at Karl and caught his nod. Then he looked back at Sir Peter, who smiled right at him. And he finally understood. Even Sir Peter had a line that couldn't be

crossed, and that line was the armed forces themselves. So the dagger had passed to Thomas to make the first incision.

He coughed aloud and walked towards Michael Schaefer, closing in on him like a hawk. When he reached the lectern, he turned and addressed the audience.

“We can do better than that — we can show you a working mechanism.”

There was a ripple of excitement from the seats. Schaefer’s gasp seemed to catch in his throat — with any luck it would choke him. Karl unclipped the sides of the box and lifted them away to reveal the Scavenger firing mechanism, built into a weapon.

Schaefer wasn’t about to give in without a fight. “Yes, ladies and gentlemen, this is a prototype, of course. But it’s an accurate approximation.” He crossed the floor, half-prowling, half-galloping. “We’re all very proud of this.” He touched the barrel, tentatively at first, then spread his hand wide as if claiming it.”

“And when will the Scavenger be available to order?” one audience member couldn’t contain her enthusiasm.

“You can order it now,” Schaefer was gaining ground by the second. “As we Americans say, it’s basically *in the bag*. We’re just making some minor adjustments, based on test user feedback.”

That was a low blow, and Thomas felt it in the pit of his stomach. One look at Karl’s face told the same story. No, he couldn’t let Schaefer get away with that.

“Mr Schaefer,” Thomas put on his best deferential voice, “you’re welcome to perform some test firing.”

“I . . . er . . . don’t think that’s necessary today.”

But the audience had other ideas. Thomas had played to the gallery and now the gallery wanted to play as well. A woman rose up from the audience and tucked her folder under her arm. “Actually, I’d like to see what we’re getting for our investment.”

Michael Schaefer swallowed. “Erm. Ladies and gentlemen, we . . . er . . . didn’t envisage firing a live weapon in a roomful of people.”

Thomas had to fight the urge to smile. He dug his nails in and thought of Amy; that hardened his mood perfectly. Now a different emotion

spiralled inside him. He straightened up and faced Schaefer. Karl was watching; Karl was always watching. But he could live with that.

Karl turned towards Sir Peter Carroll. Thomas missed the beginning of the exchange, but not the conclusion. Karl walked over to the Scavenger and bent down to retrieve a large box. He crossed the room, drawing their attention like a magnet. He went straight to Thomas and stood with his back to the audience, presenting the box to him.

Thomas undid the two latches, snapping them free with sudden movements to generate the most noise. The lid groaned open. Inside was an ammunition magazine, set into a foam surround. On top of the magazine was a taped note that read: WARNING: MIXED CALIBRE CONTENT — RANDOMLY SELECTED. He felt his heart smashing against his ribs, vibrating up to his Adam's apple. Karl's face was stoic. It was all up to Thomas now.

He lifted the magazine up and held it high, as though it were an icon. There was instant applause. Those poor bastards must have thought it was all part of the show. The note was on the shadow side, only visible to Schaefer and Thomas. He turned towards the lectern and saw the strain on Schaefer's neck as he carried the magazine towards him. There was no way Schaefer could have missed the warning about the ammunition.

Thomas kept on walking, parading the magazine back across the room so Karl could snap it into place. Sir Peter left his seat and strode towards them. It could have been Thomas's imagination, but it looked like a march — straight and synchronised.

"That will be all, gentlemen," Sir Peter saluted them and, without a glance between them, Thomas and Karl both returned the compliment.

Thomas led the way through the oncoming surge of people, numb and deliriously happy. This had to be one of the best days of his life. He got it now — why Karl and the others needed someone like him on the team, someone without any competing allegiance, who wasn't beholden to a chain of command outside the SSU. He could do the things they weren't able to — as a civilian, as a person of conscience. No one had bought that from him, because it wasn't for sale.

As he and Karl reached the door, Thomas turned to see Schaefer and the Scavenger surrounded. Sir Peter's voice rang out, clear above the

throng. “Shall we take this outside — do you want to do the honours, Michael, or shall I?”

That was it; Schaefer was fucked. Even he wasn't crazy enough to risk a bloodbath in front of the Scavenger's backers. It was tempting to stick around for the punchline, but Thomas was an SSU man today and orders were orders.

He turned to Karl and shook his hand, hard and tight, cementing their bond. As if to say, 'It's us and them, amigo.' But the only words out of his mouth were, “Any chance of a lift? I need to pick my car up from Engamel HQ. I don't think I'll be needed there again.”

Chapter 43

“I think this might be her,” Miranda got up from her chair and craned her neck towards the trail of souls meandering through Arrivals.

The hard-core travellers had bustled through a good ten minutes ago — these were the waifs and strays. Thomas didn’t comment. He stood up and straightened his jacket, standing close enough to Miranda to sense the heat between them. It was time.

“Come on,” he set off briskly, dulling his own excitement; this secret squirrel stuff was addictive.

The woman looked lost. Scratch that, she looked weighed down and in need of a friendly face. He waved, continued walking and introduced himself and Miranda as the welcoming committee.

“Did you have a good flight?”

She nodded. What was she supposed to say? She looked like she wanted to cry. He picked up her bag and led off towards the car park, leaving Miranda to work her magic. By the time they got to the car, he could hear laughter behind him — the kind that dissolved barriers and healed wounds.

Traffic was a pig of course, but that was fine. It gave them all space to make the adjustment. By the time they reached the mean streets of Kilburn, he’d decided how to play out the last hand. He pulled up and asked Miranda to do the honours.

As their passenger got out, she leaned forward to Thomas and kissed him on the cheek. “For your trouble,” she placed a bottle of whiskey in the car.

“It was no trouble at all, Jacqui,” he smiled, wiping away her tears from his face as if they were his own.

Miranda walked her up the path and knocked on the door, but she didn’t hang around. Thomas got out and stood beside her, felt her arm circling around him and mirrored it.

Karl opened the door, saw Jacqueline and gazed at her. Then he turned and raised a grateful hand to the couple. Thomas nodded and got back into his car — job done.

THE END

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For Warren, the voice of reason.

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Prologue

Harnell Street. A Tuesday morning. Playgroup is closed for the day, Janey is out of ciggies and that bloody kid won't stop screaming.

"Just shut up will you?" she snaps, as little Jacob bawls on defiantly. She feels her hand trembling; she waits for him to look away. It's stupid but she can never bring herself to hit him when he's staring at her.

Jacob's in luck — Janey's remembered the twenty pound note in the emergency tin — the one that Jack Langton used to top up when he came round to collect his post. She scrabbles at the back of the cupboard, pops the lid and leaves it clattering on the Formica. The Queen seems to smile at her from the twenty and she can't help smiling back. Sorted.

"It's all right, Jacob; we'll go out and get some sweeties, yeah?"

He cuts the racket at the sound of the magic word. Now he's smiling too. She's rough with him as she gets him ready because it's all she knows. And he doesn't make a fuss because it's all he knows as well.

It starts raining when she's halfway up the road. Jacob's all right, lucky bastard — the plastic cover fastens down, safe and sound. Janey hunches forward, rolling the buggy along like a penance. The street is deserted. This is the East London that regeneration never quite reached.

She relaxes her grip as the shop comes into view. "Nearly there, darling." She dangles a hand in front of the blurred plastic and little Jacob squeals excitedly. Without stopping, she wriggles her phone out of her jeans. "Greg, where's my money this week?" She doesn't wait for an answer. "Don't be bullshitting me — your kid's gotta eat." It's a short call — promise extracted, there's nothing more to say. "That was *Daddy*, Jacob," she says with spite, "being an arsehole again. He'll be over later, if you're a good boy."

She reaches the shop, parks the buggy up so Jacob can watch the cars, and nips inside. The girl serving on the till is no quicker than the old cow in front of her. So back out Janey comes and sure enough the little sod is kicking off again. He wants to see the cars properly and his buggy cover is all steamed up. His choice then; he can get wet watching the traffic. She unfastens the cover and legs it back inside before anyone can take her place.

Janey doesn't hear the screaming at first. It's a woman rushing into the shop that alerts her. The buggy hasn't moved, thank God, but Jacob . . . She rushes to pick him up and stops, paralysed. For a moment she's certain there's blood pouring down his face, and then she realises it's paint. Someone has sprayed her baby's eyes. And now the two of them, mother and son, are screaming together.

Chapter 1

At seven-thirty the alarm went off. It was the rule. It didn't matter how wasted Ken Treavey had been the night before, there had to be some standards. He got up, shuffled to the bathroom and wrung out his kidneys in preparation for the next onslaught. He generally avoided the mirror these days, but sometimes he'd catch a glimpse of the man he used to be — that straight-backed, eager servant of the crown. Then his memory would paint in the beret and army fatigues — those were the really painful days.

By eight-ten he was ready. A crisp shirt and fresh creases in his trousers. Cereal, toast and tea — all to the backdrop of Radio 4 and issues of the day he used to care about.

He locked up his digs — *flat* was too grand a word — and moved briskly down the steps before any other doors opened. Sometimes he'd pick up some shopping for one of the old-timers. Not now though — this early time was sacrosanct. His shoes clipped rhythmically against the stone steps, stepping out in a marching gait.

Sometimes when he drew his first breath out on the street, inhaling the decay and neglect, he wondered how he'd ended up like this, far from his native Glasgow, slumming it in London. An ex-wife and a daughter he could scarcely pick out of a line-up, living in the North East and sending down a new photo every Christmas.

He picked up the pace, soothing himself with the tap-tap-tap against the pavement. The man in the corner shop gave him a nod and watched without comment as he picked up a tabloid, a four-pack of lager and some provisions. A brief exchange of words — usually about football — hand over the cash, and he was on his way. 'As you were.'

His shift as a nightclub doorman didn't start until eight in the evening, so the wide expanse of the day stretched before him. The world played out in a tape loop; cars and commuters clogged the streets. A gaggle of schoolgirls, all hormones and horoscopes, drifted past on their way to a local comprehensive. He smiled and they looked through him — he wore a different form of camouflage now.

There was a spring to his step as he re-entered the block. On a good day the tabloid could fill up nearly an hour. He took the steps two at a time, ears pricked for sounds of life. Upstairs a radio was blaring out what passed for music and that bawling baby along the landing was testing her lungs again. The familiar soundscape of what he called home.

He halted at the top step, aware that something was different. It took a moment to register that the black rubber mat outside his door was slightly skewed, just enough to bring him up short. He approached warily — no wires on show and only a faint bulge in the centre of the mat. He held his breath and eased the mat away, inch-by-inch, until he saw a small padded envelope. He turned it slowly, examining it at arm's length, reading his name and flat number on the front.

Safely indoors, he rested the envelope on the kitchen table and put his shopping away. Never more than a couple of steps away from it, he circled it like prey as he boiled the kettle and poured the tea. Now he was ready.

The envelope contained a folded piece of paper — the good quality kind, with no marks on it. The page showed a phone number, a time to call and details of the phone box he had to use. The last line read: 'Work opportunity.'

He stood the folded page on the table like a tent and sat facing it, sipping his tea. Someone knew all about him — where he lived, what his routine was and that he needed money. They hadn't wanted to be heard by the neighbours otherwise they'd have used the letterbox.

* * *

At one thirty in the afternoon, overfed on a menu of tabloid opinion and daytime television, he left the bedsit, giving himself half an hour to make a ten-minute journey. He plucked out two hairs and set them top and bottom of the locked front door, half-convinced that some bastard planned to rob him while he was out. Then again they could have done that earlier. Or maybe it was some elaborate plan to mug him at the phone box. He took along the knuckle-duster that accompanied him to the nightclub, just in case.

The world seemed different now, foreign and foreboding — cars he didn't recognise and blank faces. He dropped into the corner shop for some chewing gum, and paid with a tenner to get a handful of change. After

walking past the phone box three times, he creaked the door back and took a good look inside. Nothing out of place, just the usual smell of stale cigarettes and sweat. He could hear his own breathing echoing in the old-style kiosk. *Only curious*, he told himself, *following the trail to see where it leads*. He stood and waited, chasing the sweep hand of his watch as it counted down the last couple of minutes.

The phone number picked up on the first ring. “Who’s calling?”

“Ken Treavey.” No point in subterfuge; they knew his name anyway, and more.

Silence. He closed his eyes, straining to hear. He felt like lighting up a cigarette, even though he’d given up six months ago. Was anyone still there?

“Very good. Take down these details.”

Now he could breathe again.

Two hours’ time, across town — no explanations. He took it to be a test of his ability to follow instructions. He could live with that — at least until he knew about the job and what it was worth. It wasn’t as if he had anywhere else to be, apart from his regular TV date with *Trisha*.

* * *

The pub had two exits, one on the main street and another out to a side turning where traffic-calming bollards choked the road down to single file. Not a problem, as he’d come by Tube, but he noted it anyway. He didn’t like crowded bars, although the thrill of the unknown excited him just a little and the prospect of some ready money tipped the balance.

He’d arrived early and waited across the street. Five minutes before time a Daimler pulled up. The suited gent in the back clocked him instantly and they stared at one another through the traffic. The suit exchanged a few words with his driver, who let him out — like a proper chauffeur — before gliding off. The suit went inside the pub.

He waited until the last minute and nipped through the traffic. The man was at the bar; he held out a hand as Ken approached.

“A lager for you, Ken?”

He smiled. The mind games had already started. They had all the gen on him while he knew nothing about them, but at least they were buying. The suit took a single malt, the expensive kind, and gestured to a table. He

grabbed his lager from the bar and sat down with his back to the room, surveying the saloon by its reflection in the window.

“Your service record was impressive.”

He had grown used to *was* now. Faded glory and years gone by. Even so, he wondered what they knew about his history and how they’d got hold of it.

“I’ll come straight to the point. I’m looking for someone like you — I need a man killed and I’m willing to pay you £10,000.” There wasn’t a pause.

The voice had been monotone, a trick way of speaking without anyone else hearing. Ken sipped his lager, taking it all in. As he lifted his eyes, the suit met him face on. He liked that — no bullshit.

“And why come to me?”

The suit nodded, as if appreciating that he’d cut to the chase as well.

“Your past recommends you.”

He narrowed his eyes and read the sentence two ways. Someone he’d served with, maybe? Or did they mean his actual army record? “You havnae answered my question. Why me?”

He could see the suit was put out, even though he tried to mask it. Seeing through masks was a skill that could save a life — catch the difference between innocent bystander and insurgent.

The suit cast a casual glance behind him and moved in close. Ken read the tension on his face — the barely parted lips and the rigid jaw.

“It needs accurate timing and it cannot look too . . . clinical. You’ve done this sort of work before, I understand? If the rate is acceptable you’ll be contacted with further details.”

Ken lowered his pint. “I need to know more.”

The suit checked his watch and eased down the last of his malt. “The man you’re going to kill is a murderer.” He put his glass down and it rang out a hollow note. “Now, do we have an agreement, in principle?”

He knew there was no sense prevaricating; he’d have to make a decision. He gripped the hand floating before him and sealed the deal. The suit nodded and the colour came back to his face.

Ken watched him leave and returned to his lager, his hand trembling slightly as he lifted the comforting liquid to his lips. He’d killed people for less in the past, in a roundabout sort of way. Ten grand. He’d be able to

send Steph some of the child support he owed her. Maybe they could start over . . . *Aye, that'll be right!*

He checked whether anyone was taking an interest and thought about another pint. Maybe this was all some kind of wind-up. And even if the suit was on the level there was no saying he'd actually go through with it. His hand throbbed a little, as if to remind him of the pact he'd already made. It was up to them now.

Chapter 2

Thomas Bladen glanced at the dashboard clock: seven a.m. The street was empty, apart from an old moggy patrolling its patch. He watched it sidestep some rubbish to disappear through a gap in the fence. Beside him, slumped in the passenger seat, Karl McNeill was dozing off the sweet tea and supermarket doughnuts they'd brought to the stakeout at six. Another happy Wednesday.

He shifted in his seat to get comfortable, and tried not to think about the warm bed at Miranda's that he'd left behind. With any luck, their quarry — on the Benefits Investigation Team's surveillance list — would show his face by seven-thirty, confirming he lived with the single parent claimant. Then they'd collate the evidence and move on to the next welfare desperado. This would have been a new low in assignments, except it was their second turn at the Benefits shitty stick in twelve months. Maybe that was why other government departments called them *floaters*.

Karl stirred in his sleep, lip quivering. He reminded Thomas of a dog by the fire, dreaming earnestly.

"Come out, come out, wherever you are," Thomas whispered, finger poised by the camera. The edge of a curtain barely flickered, but he was on to it before it was fully open. A series of bleeps immortalised the happy couple on digital. He counted under his breath; ready to give Karl a nudge if nothing had happened by the time he reached fifty.

Finally the front door opened and a bloke emerged, fresh as a daisy in a business suit and the sort of hair Thomas hated — gel, for Chrissake. As if to say, 'Yeah, I work in an office but I'm so unique.' *Prick*. He trailed the subject through a lens, capturing every self-assured step to a garish yellow Peugeot.

Karl woke up as the pus mobile roared away. "Morning, Tommo, what did I miss?" He cricked his neck and adjusted his crotch. "Any joy?"

"Yep. Show's over, maestro. Were you working late again last night?"

"Right enough — until the wee, small hours."

He nodded. Karl's other job was keeping him busy then. The one he knew never to ask about unless invited.

“Relax, Tommo. Just eavesdropping and observation — no individuals were harmed in the making of *that* film.”

He cupped his hands over his ears and feigned horror. Yet having already ridden on Karl’s counter-intelligence merry-go-round, he was interested. Who wouldn’t want to know someone else’s secrets? After all, what else was surveillance? Only . . . Karl’s world was not without consequences, and he had the scar on his arm to prove it.

He escaped his thoughts and handed over the camera. Karl flicked through the shots, grading them in a series of grunts.

“Nicely done. Okay, who’s next on our list of fraudsters?”

“*Potential* fraudsters . . .”

Karl grinned and returned the camera. “Ah, Tommo. You’re like a dog with a Socialist bone. That’ll be your Yorkshire roots. Of course, back home in Belfast we didn’t do politics.” He winked.

Thomas stowed the camera in its case and started up the car, backing it out of the parking bay with infinite care. “Grab the list and tell me where we’re going.”

His phone trilled into life. Karl stared at it for a second then thought better about answering it. Thomas cut the ignition and carefully applied the handbrake. John Wright, father of the fair Miranda, didn’t waste words.

“Sorry to ring you so early, Thomas. I need to see you. Come to the house after work and bring Karl if he’s free. It’s connected with Jack Langton.”

That was a shocker. Last he’d heard, Jack Langton was in prison — and Thomas had helped to put him there. He confirmed a time and cut the call. Now came the tricky part.

“Listen, Karl, how do you fancy a takeaway after work tonight — in Dagenham? You can drive.”

* * *

Thomas’s hand was on the handle before Karl stopped the car. He got out and glanced at the upstairs window, looking for signs of movement. Karl followed him to the front door and they stood together, not making eye contact.

Diane Wright, matriarch of the family, greeted them with a smile. He noticed it stopped halfway up her face — always a giveaway.

“Well, don’t just stand there. Terry and Sam’ll be here soon with food. It’s a curry night.”

He ignored whatever John called out from the living room and made a beeline for the kitchen. Miranda was propped against the breakfast bar like window dressing.

“Alright babe?” She picked up on his mood straight away and shifted a little, arching her back so that her chest rose.

It was all he could do to stop himself from undressing her. He took refuge in his curiosity.

“Has John said anything? All he told me on the phone was that it’s to do with Jack Langton and I should fetch Karl along.”

She shrugged and kissed him, exploring his mouth and grinning against his face as he absorbed the sensation. “You always were a soft bastard. Well . . .” she slid her thigh against his, “some of the time.”

“Ahem.” Diane cleared her throat. “When you’ve finished getting reacquainted, we’re in the living room. Sam’s just pulled up.”

“I know how he feels!” he whispered to Miranda, eliciting a peal of laughter.

By the looks of things Karl had made himself at home. Deep in conversation with John, he paused to meet Thomas’s gaze, offering nothing. Sam’s key turned in the door, breaking the tension, and soon the delicious aroma of food and spices permeated the air.

“I took a bend a bit too fast and I think one of the curries has leaked.”

Diane organised the chaos, directing Sam and Terry to the main table where plates and cutlery were waiting. John and Karl hadn’t moved; they sat together like tribal elders.

When everything was dished out the family gathered around the table. Karl took a seat between John and Diane, which put Thomas’s back up. As he and Miranda sat down opposite, he wondered if they were choosing sides.

John tore at a naan bread, dipped the shred in curry and took a bite, waving the remainder in the air. “So, I’ve got this favour to ask.” He sniffed. “Thing is, Jack Langton wants some help and I can’t really refuse.”

Thomas coughed as he bit into a cardamom seed. “Aren’t you forgetting it was only a few months back Jack tried to fit Karl up in Belfast?”

He looked at Karl, who raised a hand. "Hear the man out, Tommo."

John coated more bread in curry sauce. "Jack's got a sort of niece down Bethnal Green way and her boy was attacked. He's only a nipper and Jack thinks the kid was targeted because of the family connection."

He hated stating the obvious. "Jack's doing eighteen months for intent to supply . . ."

Everyone around the table fell silent while he connected the dots. Jack needed someone on the outside to look into it. Thomas had suddenly lost his appetite; the thought of doing anything for Jack's benefit turned his stomach.

Miranda moved closer. "What would they need to do, Dad?"

He almost smiled; she knew how to play a difficult hand. Never mind all that East End girl bollocks she traded on at her bar, Caliban's; she was as sharp as a blade. It was bloody obvious where all this was going.

Diane smiled again, as if to really sell it. "The police are already involved, but there isn't any obvious link to Jack and he wants to keep it that way. He asked John to find someone *on the level*, to talk to one or two people and report back to him."

He pushed his plate away. "You want us to sort some mess of Jack Langton's?" He shot a glance at Karl by way of an apology.

Karl shrugged. "Sometimes these things have to be done."

Thomas blinked a couple of times, puzzled. John laid out the bare bones of it while Thomas went back to his food, studying Karl all the while. How did Karl square all this? Jack Langton was a scumbag who believed Karl was languishing in a Belfast prison where Langton had set him up for smuggling, handling explosives and having God knows what on his hard drive.

"So, what do you think?" John's voice brought Thomas back to the table.

"Just this once," Miranda insisted. "And you'd be helping Mum and Dad out."

There'd been no need to up the ante. "How's this gonna work? Is someone giving us a list of names to check out?"

"Yeah . . . about that." John Wright actually blushed. "Thing is, Jack will want to see who he's dealing with. Face to face like. He's got a prison

visit due soon and I thought we could go up there together. I need confirmation tonight so I can get the visiting order sorted out.”

It was a done deal. John left the table and returned with beers from the kitchen, which he passed around to the men. Thomas stuck to juice. John popped a can and left it untouched on the table.

Thomas found John’s gaze unsettling. He remembered the time he and the Wrights’ runaway teenage daughter had turned up on their doorstep all the way from Leeds. A speech was coming.

“I know you’re not happy about this. But when you got into that bother with the Serbian geezer . . .”

“Yorgi was Albanian,” Karl cut in.

“Whatever he was,” John bristled, his eyes still on Thomas, “he was a problem. I gave you a gun, remember?”

He was hardly likely to forget — he still had nightmares about it.

“That gun was Jack Langton’s. I told him Miranda was in danger and he gave it to me — no charge, no questions asked. I owe him for that and now he’s calling in the debt.”

Thomas glanced around the table. “Let’s get it over with then.”

Sam and Terry cleared the table for a traditional family game of cards, but Thomas sat it out. He could sense that his luck wasn’t in. Karl decided to call it a night so he walked him to the door.

“You gonna be alright, Tommo?” Karl patted his shoulder.

“Never mind me, what about you?”

“I’ll be fine. John cleared up a couple of things when you were taking a piss. I’m on hand to keep the wheels turning and to watch your back.”

Thomas checked behind himself and mimed removing a dagger from between his shoulders.

“Sure, you’re a funny bastard, Mr Bladen. I’ll see you by Mile End Tube in the morning. Don’t let Miranda keep you up too late.” He waited for Thomas to flip him the finger before he turned away.

Chapter 3

Thomas loved to watch Miranda in the dim light of the early hours. She always seemed to sleep so easily. Maybe she had a clear conscience — lucky girl. Once upon a time, he mused, he had had his life carefully orchestrated, with Miranda and her family in one corner and the Surveillance Support Unit diagonally opposite. Now it was all overlapping circles and tonight, with Jack Langton in the mix, he couldn't even see the lines clearly.

She shifted under the covers and slowly opened her eyes. "I can feel you staring at me. I'm surprised you've got any energy left for surveillance."

He blushed, remembering that he hadn't wanted sex until she'd persuaded him. Chalk that one up to Jack Langton's malign shadow.

"Do I need to draw you a map?" She teased back the covers.

No second invitation required. As he leaned across he spotted the old engagement ring on her bedside table and closed his eyes for a moment to skewer the memory. Then his hand touched her flesh and he decided to let his brain take a break while his instincts ran the show.

* * *

It all seemed like a distant memory at eight fifteen, while he froze his tits off as the rain spat down on the commuters. *Come on, Karl, where the bloody hell are you?* He left Mile End for Burdett Road, scanning every passing car, and dived into the nearest newsagents to grab a tabloid. He stood under the awning and flicked through the pages. It seemed like the entire paper had been given over to Sidney Morsley, on trial for abducting and murdering a seven-year-old girl. He managed about half a page on 'Monster Morsley' before he binned the paper and started walking up the street.

A text came in from Ajit, his childhood friend from Yorkshire: Geena getting bigger by the day. Still bricking it. Ring soon. Aj. He put his phone away; more lives spinning around him.

He heard the car horn first. Karl's Ford Escort drew alongside and the window descended. "Sorry, Tommo; I got waylaid. Get in, it's tipping

down.”

“Thanks, I hadn’t noticed.”

Karl closed the window, sealing them back in their bubble. He yawned like a walrus. “Apologies, amigo. I got back late again and overslept.”

Thomas reached for the schedule, still in the glove compartment from the previous day. “We’re cutting it fine if we want to set up outside the laundry.”

“Nah, we’ll make it. This car’s never let me down yet.”

He held on tight. To be fair to the man, Karl knew his way around the backstreets, even if he didn’t know his way around a gearbox. There was no talking while Karl was in mission mode, so he watched the world flash by and tried to figure out what was bugging him so much.

Finally, with a flourish of gear changes, the car whinnied to a stop. Karl folded his arms triumphantly. “Piece of piss. Now, who are we stalking first?”

He read from the list. “Ms Paulette Villers, suspected of earning undeclared income . . .” He flicked the page and held up a photo for Karl’s scrutiny.

“She’s a wrong’un — look at that hair.”

It was ten more minutes, half a packet of mints and Karl trying — and failing — to do drum solos to Led Zeppelin before there was any action.

“Heads up, Tommo — here she comes now.”

Paulette Villers bustled along the street, her coat pulled in tight. His lens did not lie, picking out a bruise across one side of her face, raw as a piece of meat. He felt his shoulders tighten as the woman passed and disappeared through a side entrance. He got the shots, including the scratch marks on her neck above the collar.

Karl lowered his own camera. “I know what you’re thinking, but it’s not your place to go sticking your oar in.”

“No, not *my* place . . .”

“Come on, Tommo, we’re not social workers. If she shows up here the rest of this week, we’ve got her bang to rights and then we’re done with her.”

“One phone call, Karl — that’s all I’m asking. You have contacts — a copper who happens to be around. Someone to ask if she’s all right. Then it’s her choice.”

Karl sighed. “Just this once. You’ll owe me, mind.”

“Deal.” He smiled. Owing Karl would mean only one thing: more surveillance work — off the books. He’d missed it since he and Miranda had been spending more time together. Karl’s morally ambiguous world of counter-intelligence proved the point that knowledge was power, especially when it was hidden.

* * *

It was a late lunch — a sandwich and a coffee in the car, as they staked out the sandwich bar where they’d bought them. Karl was economical with his words and Thomas realised there was one subject they hadn’t broached. Jack Langton; the elephant in the back seat.

At one thirty they wrote off the lunchtime cash-in-hand as a no-show; and it seemed like the ideal time to ask about private work. Karl reminded him of the rules. He saw them in his mind, clear as black and white.

1. Karl would only tell him what he needed him to know, which wasn’t a great deal.

2. Payment would be in cash like the previous times.

3. Karl would decide what to share with their SSU boss, Christine Gerrard.

“So we might still be doing official work, just not on the books?” He nibbled at a crust, waiting for Karl to elaborate on who was covered by ‘official.’

“Nice try.” Karl crammed his sandwich wrapping into a cardboard cup.

“One more thing . . .” He collected up as much litter as the bag would hold. “I don’t want Miranda to know I’m freelancing again.”

“Fair dos.” Karl turned the ignition. “I’ve got a request of my own. Anything you find out about Jack Langton — run it by me first, okay?”

Chapter 4

The days fell in line like the names on their assignment sheets as they made their way through the different locations. Guilt or innocence? He kept his thoughts to himself, unlike Karl, and let his camera make the judgement.

Even though Karl had insisted he was happy to cover on his own during the prison visit, it didn't sit easily with Thomas. The whole set-up had crossed a line for him. He kept his distance from the Wrights — Miranda included — in the run-up to the appointed day.

Karl provided two evenings of low-level surveillance work, to pass the time he said — a basic 'point and shoot' affair. Thomas was glad of it. He could have done background checks if he'd wanted — a call to the restaurant and then run a couple of number plates past Miranda's police contact. But he had enough to think about.

He swapped texts with John Wright the night before their trip to Wormwood Scrubs prison, arranging to meet him outside. None of this was John's fault; objectively, he could see that. No, the more he thought about it — and he had thought about it, a lot — Jack Langton was pulling the strings and everyone was dancing. Even Karl.

He travelled in early to check out the local area. As well as a prison Wormwood Scrubs was also the name of 200 acres of nearby common land. He'd read up about it online, amused to discover it had once been London's duelling ground. Maybe it was a sign of things to come. The other thing he'd noted was that the prison was originally built by convicts, which tallied with his opinion that people were often the creators of their own misfortune.

The Scrubs Park didn't compare with the Yorkshire moors, but the undulating warble of a skylark high above him was a welcome reminder. He faced the distant line of trees that pushed back against the skyline, holding the city at bay, closed his eyes and took a breath, steeping himself in the sounds of nature. It was all going to be fine. He was just doing a favour for a friend, visiting some bloke in prison. End of story.

He opened his eyes and changed direction and the prison building marred the view. A German Shepherd dog came bounding towards him and

stopped about ten feet away, ears alert, staring intently. He stared back, wishing he'd brought a camera along — maybe the Canon with the USM lens. Then again, he couldn't see that going down too well at the prison gates.

The dog wagged its tail slowly and he tried to remember whether that was a good thing. Ajit would probably know. All those years in the North Yorkshire Police must have taught him something. Maybe he'd ask when he next got round to phoning him.

A high-pitched whistle caught the dog's attention and it abandoned him to his thoughts. He wondered if Jack Langton had any inkling of how it was he'd ended up behind bars. All it had taken was a little evidence gathering and one phone call. Like Karl had said, 'In life as in comedy — timing is everything.'

* * *

John Wright was already waiting on the street outside the main gates. He looked like he was there under duress. "Morning, Thomas. I hope you've got your paperwork with you." A nervous smile undercut the humour.

Thomas patted his pocket then shook hands, and listened as John prattled on about the weather and the trains. Other people started arriving so they followed them around the barrier, through the arch, and into the imposing Victorian stronghold. He stepped in behind John and showed the staff his passport and a phone bill as proof of identity. It was only when someone noticed his Surveillance Support Unit ID around his neck that they decided to 'randomly' search him.

You could tell a lot about the people queuing to visit a prison: the anxious mothers, the cagey partners, and especially the children. They were the easiest to read and fell into two groups: the ones with fear in their eyes, who didn't really know what was going on, and that other category. Judging by their faces those poor bastards had seen it all before and took it in their stride; this was normal for them.

Successive doors were unlocked and then locked behind them, drawing them deeper into the belly of the prison. John hadn't made eye contact since his search, and when Thomas tapped him on the shoulder he looked haunted. Well, well — another item to file in the Bladen archives. He knew

about John's ambiguous relationship with the Tax Office, but his behaviour today suggested there was a side to John he knew nothing about. On balance, he preferred it that way.

The corridor led into a locked room with glass walls, like a long holding cell. A prison officer stared blankly, scanning the line for anything untoward. Thomas gazed back and their eyes met briefly, trading indifference.

They were ushered forward just as the kids started getting restless, through the barred doorway towards Jack Langton. The visiting area was cavernous and neglected, tainted by the tang of bleach and boot polish. As he followed John, who clearly knew the drill, his eyes were drawn to flaking paintwork and clumps of dead flies that blotted out patches of the neon strip lights.

They waited opposite an empty chair for a couple of minutes, without explanation — no one else seemed bothered so he didn't ask. Then at some unspoken signal a door was unlocked and the prisoners flowed in under the watchful eyes of the prison staff.

Jack Langton would have been easy to identify even if he hadn't seen him before. He looked as though he took full advantage of the prison gym and swaggered a little as he made his way to the table, cocky bastard. All around them chairs were scraping back for happy families and lovers' reunions. Jack looked like he was about to open a business meeting.

Thomas offered to shake hands, but Jack tilted back and folded his arms.

"Best not — I can do without a strip search today." He laughed and Thomas couldn't figure out whether he was kidding or not. "Appreciate you both coming . . ."

"I've heard a lot about you, Thomas."

A chill raced down his spine. *I fucking hope not.* He put on his best poker face and sat there, listening to Jack and John getting pally, concentrating. He paid close attention because every few sentences a clue floated by amid the shorthand of familiarity — people they'd known from years back.

"Thing is, John, she's a good kid and she knows not to touch it. But sometimes people get curious. Maybe Thomas here could sort it for me?"

Thomas took a breath and leaned in. "Sort what?"

“Ah, some stuff at Janey’s.” Jack rubbed at his nose with a thumb. “It might need taking to my house for Ray — he’ll know what to do with it.”

Thomas felt around his collar. The room had suddenly become a couple of degrees warmer. “You understand I’m clean, Mr Langton? I can’t be involved in anything . . .” he left the sentence there.

Jack raised a soothing palm. “Course not. And call me Jack. Just some things of mine she’s holding for safekeeping. Paperwork and stuff.”

“Is that alright with you, Thomas?” John’s voice wavered a little.

“Yeah, as long as we’re all clear.” The bullshit alarm in his head was clanging.

“Right then.” Jack Langton thudded his arms on the table. “Let’s talk about Jacob. There are some people I want you to talk to.”

And John was playing secretary, counting on his fingers, bobbing his head as each name was mentioned. . . John Wright — the man Miranda had terrified him with, back in Leeds when they were first getting acquainted.

“He’s not some sort of hard case, is he?” Thomas had asked, when he’d convinced her to return to London with him.

“Nah, not like that. He’s the real deal though.”

Well, he seemed pretty fake now.

“Like I say, John. Write the details down when you get out. My brief, Elizabeth Locke, will be happy to help if he needs more information. You know Janey’s address — you always send Jacob something for his birthday.”

As they stood up to leave, Jack thanked them for coming. Like they had a choice. “One more thing, John.” Jack made it sound like a throwaway comment, but Thomas knew better than that. “Tell Sheryl to get in touch.”

Thomas turned away to shield his face. Sheryl — Miranda’s bar manager and Jack’s daughter that no one was supposed to know about. She’d given him the attack of conscience that led to Jack’s conviction.

Away from the prison gates, John Wright was a humbled man. As soon as they were back on the street he brushed the dust off his coat sleeves.

“Those bloody places give me the willies.”

Thomas laughed and shook his head. “Fancy a coffee, John — or a pint?”

“Yeah, a coffee sounds good.”

It didn't take long to find a proper café. Not that he had a problem with the corporate chains. As long as the coffee was good, he didn't give a tinker's where it came from. This place was a *real* Italian café. The blackboard menu looked authentically retro, although the prices had kept up with the times. He approached the chrome counter and let John find a table.

Balancing two strong coffees and a couple of cheese rolls on a tray that wasn't up to the job was no easy task. He wasn't trying to impress John exactly — his own dad was a perfectly serviceable parent, only John was like the best bits without the crap. Right from that first day, when he'd brought Miranda back to them, John had treated him as one of the family. No 'keep your hands off my daughter' threats. Just a polite word about what he expected of him and nothing more was said.

He finished reminiscing and settled the tray. "How do you think it went?"

John sniffed his coffee and then grimaced. "Hard to say. I don't like poking around in Jack's business — the less I know, the better. It wouldn't be the worst thing in the world if you drew a blank on what happened to Jacob."

Thomas squeezed his roll for a bite. "Isn't it better that we get a result and then you're all square with him?"

"Yeah, until the next time," John took a gulp of coffee and poured in more sugar. "Sorry for dragging you into all this."

"It's okay, John; it's done now. And Karl's there to back me up."

John nodded, stirring his mug mechanically.

"And besides, it's not as if . . ." He felt his phone buzzing and picked up, turning away towards the window.

Christine Gerrard, his boss, was on the warpath. "My office in one hour." She sounded less than thrilled.

"I've got to go, John." He downed the rest of his coffee and grabbed the roll.

"Let me give you Janey's address and we can talk later about Jack's solicitor."

* * *

He left John in the café and hotfooted it to East Acton station, wondering why Christine sounded so pissed off. Once he made it on to a

Central Line train, he looked at John's piece of paper. One side had Janey's address scrawled across it and the other, written in advance judging by John's neater handwriting, was a short list of names: Janey, Greg, Andrea Harrison, Natalie Langton and Charlie Stokes — who'd earned two question marks. Although now he thought about it, Jack Langton hadn't mentioned anyone called Charlie.

He made the journey over to Liverpool Street ahead of schedule, not that he expected any prizes. On his way into the building, he brushed shoulders with two colleagues from the first floor. He'd seen the MI5 bods around. They waited until he'd passed and muttered, 'floaters' when they thought he was out of earshot. Nice.

Karl was still out on the road, flying solo with the Benefits Investigation Team. The only person in the main office was Ann Crossley, now the official number two — a detail that kept Karl constantly amused. She managed an indifferent wave from behind her laptop.

Christine's office door at the far end of the room was open. He went over and played nicely by knocking first. She invited him in and gestured for him to close the door.

"Care to tell me what you were doing at Wormwood Scrubs this morning?"

He kept his paranoia in check and tried to reason it out. Mobile phone footprint? Nope — switched off until they were back outside. He hadn't used a car either. He completed his thinking aloud. "Those new ID cards we got a month ago."

She said nothing, but he read her like a book, always had done — between the covers once upon a time.

"Thomas, I give you a certain latitude with your private life."

Judging by her face it was his turn to say something.

"We all have our secrets." He didn't say 'Bob Peterson'; he didn't have to.

She huffed. "Look, if it's something that might reflect on the team — or the Unit — then I need to know about it."

"It doesn't."

She peered over her reading glasses. "Is it connected with Miranda, or Karl?"

He yielded what he hoped was an inscrutable smile.

“Thomas,” she said wearily. “I can only protect you if I know what’s going on.”

An interesting turn of phrase. Protect him from what?

She took off her glasses and folded them carefully on the desk. “I’ve said what I need to and let’s leave it at that. Fancy a coffee outside?”

“Sure.” Only right then he wasn’t sure at all.

They strolled out under the watchful gaze of Ann Crossley. Sometimes he marvelled at how civilised they were together. Christine was an ex, even if it was ancient history. The last interest he’d shown had been purely professional, when he’d found out about her and the very married Bob Peterson. It still made him smile to think how Bob had been transferred from London, with Christine promoted in his place. A good day’s work. Last he heard ‘Uncle’ Bob was back in Southampton with his unsuspecting wife.

Liverpool Street station was bustling; a swarm of people pouring from the escalators at street level. It would have been a great picture. Christine made a beeline for a carbon copy coffee house — matching decor at every turn and staff who all looked like they deserved something better.

“My treat.” She reached across him in the queue to pick out pastries and a hint of French perfume grazed his memory.

“Cappuccino, please,” he said to the pierced lovely behind the counter, who beamed at him when Christine turned her head.

He carried the tray over to a table, which she brushed with an extra napkin. “So how are you? We haven’t caught up in ages.” She glanced down at her iPhone, resting on the table with her keys.

“We never *catch up*? Why are we here?”

She adjusted the tray to line up with the table edge. “I’ve been asked . . . that is . . . Sir Peter Carroll has requested I make you available as a courier. Ordinarily I’d assign anyone from the team . . .”

Logic kicked in. “Only, you want something from him — or your *people* do?” He wondered why Christine’s friends in the Foreign Office might be taking an interest in the Director General of the SSU.

She blushed and he warmed to that. The lady still had her scruples.

“You’re free to say no, of course, after . . . everything.”

He sipped his coffee and the foam tickled his lips. Everything. The reality had been a lot messier. Six months ago he’d been just another name

on the surveillance team. Now he knew that Christine, Ann and Karl had additional allegiances and all were engaged in an intelligence tug-of-war that surfaced from time to time. And as for the great leader himself . . .

He licked the sprinkles from the rim of the cup. “Tell him I’ll do it,” he promised, because he didn’t have a good enough reason not to. And this way she’d hopefully back off from his prison visits.

“Thank you, Thomas; I appreciate it. Can you head straight over to Whitehall? He needs you there today.”

“What about the Benefits Investigation Team and Karl?”

“This takes priority. It’s an urgent collection and delivery. And let’s keep this between ourselves — just like your personal appointment today.”

Chapter 5

There was a time when he'd enjoyed attending Sir Peter Carroll at Whitehall. Those occasional summonses, from the Director General himself, used to make him feel valued.

Things were different now. Ever since Karl and circumstance had opened his eyes, he viewed the interaction more as an audience, albeit complicated by Sir Peter now answering to Karl's people, whoever they were. It didn't pay to think too much about it.

He jumped the Tube at Liverpool Street and threaded through the underground network to surface at Westminster. This time, as he approached Main Building, he felt something different: a sense of foreboding. Could he really trust the DG anymore? He smiled to himself — answers on a postcard.

The guard at the front door eyed him up as he entered the foyer — nothing new there. A sign showed the building's alert status as black, which matched his mood. The security desk received his ID card with thinly veiled contempt — this was another place where *floaters* weren't welcomed with open arms. He'd never quite figured that one out. Was it because the SSU only came into being at the time of The Falklands War, twenty years or so ago, lacking the pedigree of the other departments? Or maybe it was the belief that the SSU was a dumping ground for anyone who couldn't hack it anywhere else in the service.

A quick phone call and a scan of his hand, and then it was the familiar stand-and-wait routine while an escort came to fetch him. Meantime, he counted the seconds. To think he used to be impressed with all this. The seat of power — what a joke! In the last few months Karl had educated him about a power struggle across Europe that had nothing to do with governments. A *Shadow State* whose tendrils reached into the military, multinationals and so-called democracies. Even though he didn't subscribe to a 'United States of Europe' conspiracy, unlike the nutcase websites Karl had directed him to for fun, there was definitely something to it. Everything always came down to money and power.

His escort arrived and she chaperoned him to the lift for the top floor. Sir Peter Carroll, always the man at the top.

“I’ve not seen you before, Mr Bladen?”

Her voice startled him and he smiled. She was from the northeast — a Geordie by the sounds of it.

“I’m not a regular here. This is more of a command performance.”

She let loose a three-second smile and visibly relaxed.

“Congratulations, by the way.” He nodded to her engagement ring.

“Well-spotted. Aye, only a couple of months to go now,” she confided. “Best day of a girl’s life, apparently.”

“Your other half must be bricking it.”

“I reckon he is!”

Out of the lift it was back to business. He led the way, noting that the CIA liaison office had moved three rooms along since his last appearance. He stood aside to let her knock on Sir Peter’s door, already ajar.

Sir Peter looked up from his desk, large as life and twice as ugly. “Ah, Thomas! Do come in; I’ve been expecting you.”

He smiled to himself. Same old shit. He took the empty seat.

“I’ve rung for coffee.”

Thomas didn’t have much to say; the history between them filled the silence. “You sent for me?” It came out a bit chipper than he’d intended.

Sir Peter flustered a little. “Yes, Thomas. I need someone I can rely on to obey instructions implicitly.” Subtext: know your place.

He nodded, a reflex action, and let his attention drift to the familiar painting of Churchill on the wall behind the desk. If that piece of art could talk.

“ . . . So, as I say, it is a small matter and I need it done today.”

A brown envelope slid across the desk. “Collect the package from room 402 on your way out.”

A knock on the door interrupted them. Thomas instinctively grabbed the envelope and folded it in his pocket. Engagement girl brought in a tray with two coffees then closed the door behind her without a word.

“You’ll also be needing this.” Sir Peter snapped a key down on the desk. “Follow the instructions.”

He could see that it had been newly cut; the edges gleamed under the office strip lights. He dragged it across the hardened skin on his thumb and

gulped his coffee down.

Sir Peter set his cup down. “Well, I won’t keep you. Ring me when the job is complete.”

Once he was out in the corridor, he slit open the envelope and read the contents. On paper this looked like the easiest job in Christendom; he’d fallen for that one before. As he waited for the lift he played mental somersaults, pondering why the Old Man had insisted on him for such a routine job.

The fourth floor was a hotchpotch of government offices. He found room 402 without difficulty and rapped on the door. A muffled voice called him in by name. More head games, more subterfuge and more bollocks. Room 402 was little bigger than a cupboard.

“Sign here, please.”

He gave his autograph and studied the man opposite, noting how the sweat dappled the redness of his bald head. The stranger adjusted his glasses and peered back.

“You have your instructions?”

He nodded curtly.

Evidently satisfied with the paperwork and sphinx impression, the man went through a door behind him and promptly returned with a bulky parcel. Thomas was still putting his gloves on.

He was surprised by the size and weight of it, feeling the hard plastic case through the packaging. The authentic looking stickers and travel stamps were a nice touch. The guy behind the desk didn’t get the joke.

Having got what he came for, he headed straight out the building. If he was carrying currency again, they’d put in more effort than the ripped bag on the Leeds retrieval six months before. Maybe that was progress.

He took a short walk to Victoria Station and wandered through the complex to find a weighing machine, where he carefully weighed the package. Next, he tracked down a hardware shop in nearby Ecclestone Street and bought a tape measure. He detailed the dimensions in his notebook and then visited the gents in the station. In a cubicle he took photos of the package from all angles.

He also took a couple of close-ups of the key before sealing it in a small padded envelope, adding the PO box number and address from the label to his notebook. According to his instructions, the key had to be

posted off after that day's collection. All that was left was a short trip over to Charing Cross Station to deposit the goods at Left Luggage. By the time he called Sir Peter back, it was only three thirty.

"I'll come down to meet you and then why don't you consider your work finished for the day?"

Thomas wasn't fooled by the sudden attack of generosity, but he wasn't going to argue either. Especially when he had inquiries to make on Jack Langton's behalf.

Sir Peter was waiting as he neared the building. It seemed strange to find the Old Man outside in daylight on London's busy streets. He seemed diminished without his desk or his Daimler.

Thomas slipped him the receipt in an awkward handshake. He was mindful that Karl's people still had the Old Man under surveillance. Sir Peter muttered a few words of thanks and then scurried back inside.

Karl picked up on the second ring. "Jaysus, Tommo, I was beginning to think they'd kept you in prison."

"Sorry, there were one or two complications. Not much point coming out to you now. I'm going to head over to . . ." He stalled, distracted by the little padded envelope. " . . . Janey's and see what I can find out. Do you wanna meet at Caliban's?"

"Miranda's place?"

"Unless you know another one. Hopefully I'll have an update for you."

"Good, and you can tell me what Jack Langton said."

"Chapter and verse."

"I'd expect nothing less. Listen, why don't you see if Jack Langton has any post at Janey's flat? It might give us more insight into his world. Catch you later."

Chapter 6

Janey's maisonette on the housing estate wasn't hard to find. The front garden was littered with the ghosts of toys past and fresh bouquets of flowers left by the door. He shuddered as he pushed the gate. Last he'd heard the little boy was still in hospital.

He rang the doorbell and strained to catch what was on the radio. The sound cut and a silhouette gradually appeared against the frosted glass. He gave out his name as she closed on the handle and opened the door. He figured Janey must be in her early twenties, but the last few days had not been kind to her. She glanced at him and blinked a couple of times, as if to recollect why he was there. Then she bent down to scoop up the flowers and went inside, leaving the door open for him.

"The solicitor said you'd be visiting."

That pissed him off, given that he hadn't spoken to the solicitor yet — something else to discuss with John Wright. He trailed her into the kitchen, where she put the kettle on and went to fill a vase. As she turned back, she must have read the look on his face because she shook her head.

"No, it's okay — Jacob's still in hospital. It's just people's way of showing respect. A week or two ago they couldn't give a shit about me and now it's 'alright Janey' and 'hope your son's okay.' If I had a quid for every miserable bastard round here who's complained about my kid or me, I'd be off to Majorca for a fortnight." She laughed at her own joke.

The tea was average. He declined a biscuit as there were only two left in the packet.

"So, you know why I'm here. Jack wants to find out who did this to Jacob."

"You're not one of his usual boys." She smirked. "He's always *Mr Langton* to them."

He blushed; he hadn't even thought about it. "Like I said, I'm here to help." He took out a notepad and told her he wanted to chat for a bit and make some notes as they went along. It was ten minutes before he got anything useful.

“Jack’s little Jacob’s godfather. Funny, innit? The godfather! I don’t see Jack that often now — before he went inside, I mean. Maybe once a month. He picks up the odd bit of post and keeps a change of clothes here.”

Thomas’s pen quivered. She cupped her mug with both hands and rocked slowly.

“Look, Natalie’s a nice woman and all that, but I gather it ain’t all hearts and flowers at home so I don’t ask. Here, how’s all this gonna lead to the bastard who hurt my boy?”

“I’m not sure.” He picked up his underwhelming tea. “You said Jack keeps clothes here?”

“In a little suitcase, on top of the wardrobe in the spare room. I don’t go near it — Jack wouldn’t like it.”

At his insistence she showed him the room, although she wouldn’t take the case down. He decided to call it a day and was heading out the front door when the toilet flushed.

“Jack said you lived alone.”

“Yeah, well, I do.” She squirmed. “Only Greg is Jacob’s dad and he’s been supporting me — well, both of us — through all this. You won’t tell Jack, will you?” Her eyes reached out to him. “Only since Greg left Jack said he’s not really . . . you know . . . supposed to stay over.”

“I’m just here to look into the attack on Jacob. How is he by the way?”

She sniffed and pulled the front door closed behind her. “He’s in Moorfields Eye Hospital. Jack arranged for private care there. They’re still not sure if there’ll be any lasting damage.”

It was too much for her and she fell forward in a flood of tears. He caught and held her as she sobbed in spasms.

“I know I haven’t been the best mum in the world to him, but I swear it’s gonna be different when I get him home.”

“I’m sure you do your best,” he soothed her. “It can’t be easy being a single parent on the breadline.”

She eased herself away, wiping her nose on her hand. “Specially when his dad is such a waste of space.”

He paused at the end of the garden, one hand on the gate, aware that she seemed very keen to have him off the property. “I nearly forgot; does Jack have any post to be collected?”

It was a knife-edge moment where it looked like she could jump either way. After a few seconds she slipped around the door and returned with a bunch of envelopes held together by a rubber band.

She held them out to him and he passed back a fiver as he took them. “Buy something for Jacob.” She took the cash and slid back inside. Even from the gate he could hear the shouting match that followed.

Chapter 7

He expected Caliban's to be empty before five thirty but the bar was heaving. It took a moment to realise that the talk was a mixture of English and German. Sheryl homed in on him straight away and cocked a slow, suggestive finger, reeling him in to the bar. The punters loved the show, laughing and offering encouragement — mainly by gestures. He was glad he'd stuck to French at school.

"Take no notice, honey." She fetched him an orange juice. "Sam and Terry have done a deal to get a few coachloads of tourists here."

He tried not to look at her Stars & Stripes t-shirt. "Is business that bad?"

"Hey, I just work here — you'd have to ask Miranda. But no good business ever turns down good business."

He braced himself to mimic her *Noo Yawk* accent. "And you can take dat one to da bank."

"Damn right you can!" She flicked a finger skyward. "She's all yours."

Two young guys were at the pool table upstairs. They looked him over then continued with their game while they muttered in German. He walked through and knocked on the reinforced office door.

"Who is it?"

"It's me." He took a sip of juice and pressed his tongue to the roof of his mouth to prolong the sharpness.

"Are you gonna huff and puff if I don't let you in?"

"Only if you want me to."

The door unlocked, revealing a vision in designer jeans and a white blouse; her blonde hair was tied back and crowned with reading glasses.

"It's a good look — sort of sultry secretary."

"Wanna step inside and look over my figures?"

He crossed the threshold and found a convenient spot for his glass, leaving his hands free. She met him halfway.

"You do know," she licked her top lip and made it glisten, "that this is now a soundproofed room?"

Was this a genuine come-on or another tease? When he'd almost given up on the idea she reached for his neck and pulled him close.

"No speaking," she said, undoing his buttons with practised ease.

* * *

Once he'd readjusted his clothing, he finished his juice and stared at the edge of the desk that had just been so accommodating.

"You know, that little boy lost face can sometimes be irresistible."

"I'll try to remember that."

"Sorry, it doesn't work that way. Anyhow, I won't ask how your day has been, because I'm guessing it just got a lot better!" She checked her blouse one final time and made a show of fixing her bra.

He kissed her until he needed to breathe. Then he unlocked the door and left the office. The German pool players had gone. He suddenly realised that if the room were truly soundproof he wouldn't have heard her inviting him in. Those lads would have something to talk about on the coach back to Germany.

Karl arrived around five. Sheryl sent him straight up with a tray of drinks and crisps. Miranda joined them at the table.

"Someone's had a busy day." Karl nodded in Thomas's direction.

He avoided Miranda's gaze. "How was your day at the office?"

"Grand." Karl's hand hovered over the crisps. "I was expecting you though."

"Christine needed me for something and then I got off early." He flinched as Miranda's foot rose up his calf under the table. "I went to see Janey to get some background."

"And?" Karl's notebook was ready and waiting.

"The kid's in hospital. Janey's got this on-off thing with her ex, Greg. Can't see him harming his own kid unless it's to get cosier with Janey, which would be pretty sick."

"I'll check him out anyway," Karl concluded. "Is that it?"

"Not quite. Janey reckons all isn't well in the Langton household. Jack keeps a case at her place — he told me it's for paperwork but she said it's a change of clothes."

He grabbed a swig of orange juice while Karl was thinking.

"Was there any post at the flat?"

He handed it over and his mobile went off.

“Alright, Thomas?” John Wright sounded bad news edgy. “I’ve ’ad a message from Ray Daniels. He’s Jack’s . . .” he seemed to be fishing for the right word, “. . . deputy — taking care of things till Jack gets out.”

Thomas waited for the punchline.

“He wants you to fetch that suitcase from Janey’s and take it round to Jack’s missus tonight.”

Thomas greeted the royal decree with silence.

“Are you still there? He says it’s just a one-off thing, and he’ll owe you.”

“I’m gonna need a cupboard for all these IOUs.” He checked his watch and gestured for Karl to stand up. “You better give me Jack’s home address. Incidentally, I gather you spoke with Jack’s solicitor, Elizabeth Locke?”

Karl twitched and then shook his head.

He took the hint. “Do you wanna give me the details for the other people Jack mentioned? Save me ringing his brief tomorrow.”

One look at Karl’s face told him Ms Locke wasn’t a stranger.

* * *

Thomas didn’t like surprises; they usually became problems. Karl stayed in the car, in case word got back to Jack Langton that a bloke with a Belfast accent was poking around. Last Jack knew, Karl had been arrested in Belfast; best he carried on thinking that.

Janey answered the front door hesitantly. He made the decision for her, stepping back from the porch so she could go and get the case. She was gone a couple of minutes, returning with the type of old suitcase Thomas remembered from childhood.

It was brown and scuffed with patches at the corners. The sight of it transported him back to holiday B&Bs in Whitby. His mum and dad arguing outside and his sister, Pat, pinching his leg to get his attention from whatever book he had his nose in.

Janey passed the case across with some effort and he carried it to the car, his leather gloves creaking against the weight. Karl already knew the address from his previous run-in with Jack Langton. The way Thomas saw it, Karl never forgot anything; or forgave it, probably.

“Whaddya reckon to the case, Tommy Boy?”

“Too heavy for clothes and I can’t see that it’d be locked, or why would Mrs Langton want it home?”

“We could always park up somewhere and check.”

“If it’s all the same to you I’d rather not.”

“It’s your call, Tommo.” Karl said it casually, but his body language suggested ‘wrong answer.’

Chapter 8

Karl pulled up a couple of streets away from Jack Langton's house.

"Don't be any longer than you have to."

Thomas got out, grabbed the suitcase from the boot and started walking. The street whispered working class respectability, with trimmed hedges and satellite dishes.

The gloves were making his hands sweat and his arm throbbed with the weight so he started switching every hundred steps. It gave him something else to think about. The house was called *Xanadu*. In a toss-up between Coleridge and Olivia Newton-John, he figured on the latter. Jack's Range Rover sat outside, the windows clear and sparkling — unlike the last time he saw them after Karl had set about them with a hammer.

He put the case down by the hardwood front door and hit the doorbell. Mrs Langton was at the handle before the chime had faded. He motioned to the case, by way of introduction.

"Can you bring it through?"

She didn't look feeble, more the able-bodied and full of trouble kind. If the Lycra she had on was for an exercise class, she hadn't managed to work up a sweat yet. He remembered there being two young children in the family though they weren't in evidence.

"The kitchen will be fine. Thank you, er . . . ?"

"Thomas." He was pretty certain she knew already.

"Can I get you a drink?"

It was a relief to get the gloves off. "Nah, it's fine. I won't stop."

"Someone waiting for you?" She traced a finger along the kitchen top, as if she were doing am-dram.

"Something like that." He noticed she hadn't shown the slightest interest in the suitcase. A large drink was already waiting on the counter, with a bottle of tonic to keep it company.

She gave out a sad little sigh and reached across for her drink, stretching her credibility and everything else in the process. He moved out of reach and breathed in Chanel; not what he normally associated with Pilates.

“Anyway, I’ll leave you to your evening. Can you let Jack know I’ve delivered the goods?” He noticed the way her eyes flickered at hubby’s name — something else to file for future reference.

He was halfway up the road when he remembered his gloves. Idiot. Stupid of him to have taken them off there. He sprinted back and composed himself before he rang the doorbell. Mrs Langton was faster than ever.

“Blimey, you timed that well . . .” Her face cycled through surprise, fear and indignation in a matter of seconds. “What do *you* want?”

“Sorry — I forgot my gloves.”

“Wait here.” She dashed inside and then practically thrust them at him.

He thanked her and kept walking until he heard the door slam. He figured she might be watching him through the curtain, so he put on a show and rang Karl as he walked up the street.

A BMW slowed as it drove past — one occupant. The car stopped in the middle of the street and a woman in Lycra and a fur coat lifted a heavy case into the boot before getting into the car.

He clocked the number plate and read it aloud for Karl. “Could be nothing; could be something.”

Karl ferried him to Caliban’s and they played detective on the way.

“Why attack a child?” Karl asked for a third time.

“Maybe it’s really Jack’s child?” He was running out of ideas.

“With his niece? Isn’t that illegal — even over here!”

“Okay then, it’s a warning for Jack. Next time it’s one of his own kids.”

“For what?”

“Dunno.” Thomas rubbed at his temple. “What about Greg?”

“Maybe he’s got another kiddie out there and this is some kind of vendetta? Hell hath no fury, and all that.”

“What, blinding a kid? I can’t see it.” He stopped when he realised what he’d said. “Did you make that call like I asked?”

“Paulette Villers? Uh-huh. Someone will look into it in due course.”

* * *

Miranda was behind the bar, chatting with a woman who thought a busy pub was a great place to bring a nipper for the evening. Miranda saw him and wandered over.

“All sorted?”

“Yeah.” He looked over at the mother and child as an excuse. “I nearly forgot; Ajit wants us to go up to Yorkshire before Geena has the baby.”

“I know — she spoke to me a couple of days ago.”

“You up for it?” He read her face: wild horses couldn’t drag her to Pickering again.

* * *

After the sudden frost at Caliban’s, he wasn’t surprised to end up alone at his flat. Miranda used to like Yorkshire. Then again, it hadn’t been kind to her lately. Especially the last time, when the police had turned up on his sister’s doorstep and carted Miranda off for questioning. Him too, although he’d long since forgiven Ajit for doing his constabulary duty — another shining example of his work and personal lives colliding.

He prepared his special dish — *kitchen surprise* — anything quick and edible. He carried resurrected lasagne and steamed veg through to the living room with a glass of water. If he was going to live like a monk tonight, he had the meal to match. A flick through the TV channels sent him scurrying, mid-lasagne, to the DVD cupboard. He didn’t make it through the ads before the phone rang.

The Wrights’ number. Must be Miranda saying goodnight from her folks’ place.

“Well, hello there!” He opted for unusually cheery.

“Thomas, that you?” The male caller sounded confused. “It’s John. Natalie Langton rang me — Jack’s wife.”

He glanced at the bay window curtains to check they were drawn. “Not here; on my mobile.”

John rang back. “You took that suitcase straight over.” It was more a statement than a question, so he didn’t bother to reply. “Only the contents are light by half a kilo.”

“You *what*?” Thomas felt his hackles rise. Clearly, they weren’t talking about a few extra shirts.

“I didn’t know, Thomas — honestly.”

He remembered Janey insisting she’d never been near the case. “So now what?”

“Well, they want the missing half kilo back.”

“That’s gonna be bloody difficult then, as I don’t know where it went and I *really* don’t want to know what it was in the first place.” He took a large gulp of water. “I’ll have to look into it tomorrow after work. Now, can I have a word with Miranda?”

He heard voices and then Diane grabbed the phone. “She, er, decided to stay over at Sheryl’s. Said she wanted to be left alone.”

“By me, you mean?”

“You know Miranda, Thomas.”

After he got off the phone, he rang Karl, mobile to mobile.

“Hey, Tommo! I’m glad you called.”

“You won’t be.” He filled Karl in about the underweight suitcase.

“Hmm, tricky. Tell you something else strange. Mrs Langton is away for the night in a hotel in Suffolk. And you’ll never guess who’s keeping her company — Ray Daniels.”

“How do you know all this?”

“Vehicle check through the ANPR system — the car is registered to Ray Daniels. I’m in the hotel car park with a long lens, metaphorically speaking.”

Thomas quickly solved the clue: someone else had reported back to him. “So what do you want to do with this new information?”

“You’re the front man for all this — I’m the back-up, remember? And the wee boy sat out there in his car is a trainee; I’m showing him the ropes from afar.”

“So the information only comes to you — that is, us?”

“Right enough. Okay, gotta go — you can tell me tomorrow what the master plan is. Later.”

“Hold on, I want to ask you about Elizabeth Locke . . .”

The line went dead. He let the DVD play out then returned *The Trouble With Harry* to its appointed slot in the cupboard — comedies, top left. Though entertaining, it hadn’t stopped him from thinking.

He listed all the names on a piece of A4: Janey, Jack Langton, Natalie Langton, Ray Daniels, Greg, little Jacob, Andrea Harrison, Elizabeth Locke, and the unknown Charlie Stokes. He drew a circle around Jacob and one around Jack, linking them with a dotted line. There had to be a connection. He closed his eyes and asked aloud, “What don’t I know?” Then he laughed at himself. What *did* he know?

It was still dark when he opened his eyes next morning. As he eased out the tension in his spine, he felt something jab his shoulder blade. He shifted *The Moonstone* by Wilkie Collins and set it carefully at the edge of the bed. Miranda was on his mind. Was it so big a deal to head up to Yorkshire for Geena and Ajit's sprog? On his way out the door a text came through from Ajit: Don't leave it too late! That settled it — he'd talk to Miranda and finalise some travel plans.

Chapter 9

Every assignment was another manila envelope of expenses and timesheets, filed alongside his annual appraisal in one of Christine Gerrard's box files. He wasn't knocking the job itself, only the sense that he was killing time. Ajit and Geena, about to venture into nappy rash territory brought his own circumstances into focus.

The Tube station steadily sucked in the commuters it had spewed out the day before. They fell into a rhythm, trudging in step so that everyone made it to the platform without incident. He squeezed on to the next train, reading the front page of a newspaper from the seat opposite. The headline didn't pull any punches: *Monster sentenced today*. Child murderer, Sidney Morsley, had his final day at Crown Court.

He stared at the faded photo, taken years before, of a man on a fishing trip. Hard to believe what some people were capable of. He caught his reflection in the tunnel darkness. *He* could talk — he'd shot two people: Yorgi, a psychopath for hire who had threatened Miranda; and Deborah, another nut-job — from technology developers, Engamel — who had tried to kill Karl. They'd both deserved it — no question.

His mobile trilled into life as soon as he reached daylight at Mile End.

"Ahoy, shipmate; any chance of you grabbing a couple of bacon butties on your way round to the car?"

The café smelled of stewed tea and spilt fat — he could have stayed there forever. It looked like a one-man-band, the guy nodding to him dolefully as he went up to the counter.

He gave his order and grazed a tabloid on the counter, flicking past the day's top story to see what else was going on in the world. He'd developed a habit of checking the business pages for anything interesting in electronics and new technology. Karl reckoned that several tech companies had a keen interest in the *Shadow Europe* — the one that didn't need overpriced buildings in Strasbourg and Brussels. He'd arrived at the sports pages when he saw the chef's spattered outfit looming towards him.

"There you go, chief." Two sandwiches wrapped in tin foil were presented to him.

Karl's grunge-mobile was ready and waiting outside the newsagents, hazard lights flashing wildly.

"Come on, get in; I want to show you something." There was a hint of glee in Karl's voice.

Thomas put the sarnies by his feet and let Karl have his moment of intrigue. The car sped off as soon as he closed the door.

"Okay, you were on at me to nod the plod towards Ms Villers and her bruises?"

He nodded. "And?"

"I'm coming to that. Knowing you as I do, if you saw the guy and you thought you could take him, you'd probably want to give him a smack — am I right?"

He considered the proposition for about three seconds and nodded a little more enthusiastically.

"But what if," Karl took his chances with a late turn that made the brakes shriek, "things were not quite as they seem?"

The car stopped at their previous spot, overlooking the laundry. Within five minutes, punctuated by Karl saying nothing and pointing occasionally to keep Thomas focused on the road ahead, a familiar figure crossed their line of vision. This time Ms Villers was hand-in-hand with someone special — a woman. Thomas started behind the lens and Karl leapt on it.

"So what do you think, Tommo? Could you take on a lesbian in a fight?"

He took a flurry of pictures and then lowered his camera to see the joy on Karl's face. "Is this a problem for you?"

"Hold your heterosexual horses." Karl failed to wipe the grin off his own face. "You're the one who paled at the notion of two ladies together. Me? That's some of my favourite DVDs."

"Prick."

"Not in those films. My point, Mr Bladen, is that we don't always get the full story and it's wise not to go blundering in."

"It's still domestic abuse."

"Right enough, and I've put a word in with the boys and girls in blue."

"How did you know she had a *partner*?" He baulked at the 'L' word.

"Another training exercise, last night. I like to keep my apprentice busy."

He noticed Karl's crumpled shirt beneath his jumper, and the grubby cuffs that looked at least a day old, but said nothing.

"So when do you need me for the next private job?"

"Will a morning suit you, later this week? Say I pick you up around four? I'll fill you in nearer the time."

As in: four a.m. and keep your week clear. Shit.

"I've been thinking about Janey's kid." Thomas let his camera range past the laundry in search of Victorian architecture. "It'd help if we knew what the police know." He heard clapping.

"Bravo! Uncle Karl is already following up that line of inquiry."

"When we see Janey tonight about the suitcase, maybe we could take a look at Jacob's buggy?"

"Interesting. What's your angle?"

"Not sure. It's the only evidence — your lot have labs, don't they?"

"That's what I like about you, Tommo, You've never pressed me about my colleagues outside the SSU."

"Like you're always telling me, Karl — need to know. Right now, I don't."

"Let's celebrate your self-control with a bacon butty — I'm famished."

He felt the light bulb go on in his head. "When can I have Jack Langton's post back, so I can take it over to Natalie?"

"Soon. There's a slight snag — nothing major. Now, where's my brekkies?"

Chapter 10

Ken Treavey heard the package scrape through his letterbox. By the time he got to his door and opened it to the night he was alone. He waited there a minute or so, listening to the hum of the city and feeling the chill against his bare feet. This was it then.

He felt his way back to the bedroom and put the bedside lamp on, squinting against the burst of light. He tore at the envelope and looked for treasure. Instead, he found pieces of a puzzle — a left luggage receipt and a key that presumably went with it; a map; a cash card; a note with a PIN number, a name, a time, and the words: ‘Remember to make it look amateur.’ He saved the best till last, tipping the rifle rounds on to the duvet. They clattered like brass and copper jewels under the lamplight.

First thing in the morning he’d visit the PO box across town, as arranged. Checking the map against the street guide confirmed his suspicions: the courthouse. He picked up the cash card and cradled a bullet in the other hand, parodying the scales of justice — everything had its price.

* * *

It felt strange breaking routine, travelling different roads to reach the PO box. He made it seem casual, waiting fifteen minutes after the place opened. The padded envelope was smaller than he’d expected and his curiosity almost overcame him. It was only the thought of the money that swayed him. He checked the balance afterwards, hardly daring to move as the card disappeared into the machine. He didn’t breathe again until the balance showed on-screen — £10,000. Twenty quid would do for now.

He kidded himself he could make a run for it and disappear. Not a chance. He retrieved the magic card and picked up his money, grinning. When was the last time he’d had cash to squander? The padded envelope was burning a hole in his pocket so he treated himself to a coffee. Inside, he found a lonely corner and checked his post: one key and no explanations.

* * *

After collecting the parcel from Left Luggage, he made straight for the observation point. He’d always called them that until he was set up and ready. London’s noisy chaos blurred around him, as if he were a ghost.

When he'd been in uniform he never liked to eat or drink beforehand, but now he compromised and pulled out some chewing gum. A hit of mint at the back of his mouth sharpened his wits. Time to get to work.

No one paid him any attention as he approached the block of flats. He blended in, moving unhurriedly like he belonged there. The hard part would be getting out afterwards. He climbed the stairs in twos, the case held tight against his body. As he mounted the final flight of stairs on the top floor he drew out the Ingersoll key, ready.

The well-oiled lock gave without effort and he carefully closed the door behind him. There was a sound now, like the rush of wind, only he couldn't be sure if it was real or inside his head. He breathed slowly and made the final echoing ascent.

Instinct took over, dropping him to his knees as soon as he reached the rooftop. Sounds magnified — a plane's distant roar threatened to smother him. Traffic played like an urban symphony. He crawled to the roof edge and peered over with a pocket scope. Just as they promised, he had a clear view of the walled yard, where a security van was currently unloading its cargo. Not his target though — he was waiting for the final directive.

He slit the wrapping around the parcel carefully and slid the two sections of paper apart. They went into his bag — to be burned later. The name hadn't come as any surprise. Who else was high profile enough to warrant a ten thousand pound price tag? Knowing the identity made it easier — an abomination against God and Man. He smiled. If only his father could see him now, following in the family tradition and doing the Lord's work after all.

He opened the case; it was a .300 Winchester bolt-action rifle, adapted by the looks of it but similar enough to the NATO model he was used to. They'd done their research. A picture of Sidney Morsley was taped to the inside of the case, staring blankly at his executioner. He fitted the weapon together and loaded the ammunition: four bullets.

Time moved in waves, alternating fast and slow, toying with his watch. Eventually he heard the bleeps of another vehicle reversing into the yard. He hunched in and kept the rifle sight fixed on the back door of the court, waiting for Sidney Morsley's final act. The door unlocked and then . . . Christ, he wasn't expecting a woman in front of the target. He wavered for an instant and then committed, squeezing the trigger to drop her. She

screamed and fell to the ground, a perfect distraction for everyone else. A fluid movement of the hand then the second round chambered and plunged into Sidney Morsley's torso, swiftly followed by the third. Messy. Morsley was down now, doubled in agony — a sitting duck in a pool of blood. The final bullet struck somewhere in the vicinity of the heart, if he'd had one.

He broke up the weapon and felt the warm touch of the barrel through his gloves. He felt more alive than he had in years. He scrabbled on the ground and retrieved three spent casings but the fourth was nowhere to be seen — too late now. He crawled back to the door, pushing the case in front of him.

When he reached the top floor the sirens kicked in and so did the panic. The first flat along the landing was boarded up and grilled with a shiny new lock. He tried his key and almost collapsed in relief as it turned, releasing the door. There was little light inside, only a dusty haze. It felt safe there although he knew it wasn't. He found a back room and forced the case in behind a hot water tank, taking a moment to calm himself. He left soon after, keeping his head down, moving once again through a world where he didn't belong. He felt his guts twist, but it wasn't conscience — he needed a drink.

Chapter 11

Thomas gave Janey's bell two short rings. When the door opened she smiled a little and led him in. He heard Karl's footsteps behind him as he went indoors and imagined her smile evaporating.

"So, how's Jacob?" He thought he'd start with the easy questions.

"Ah, getting there. They reckon he can probably come home in a couple of days. I really miss him."

Her voice was rising in pitch the closer they got to the living room. He nudged the door to find Greg sprawled across the settee like he owned the place, a can of lager by his feet. He clipped Greg's foot and he took the hint, sitting up and lifting his can out of the way. Pausing in the middle of the room to make a point, Thomas leaned towards him. Karl seemed to instinctively block the exit.

"I need to ask you about the suitcase Janey had on top of her wardrobe." He felt like an idiot, spelling it out, but Greg must have been a moron to think no one would notice something was missing.

Greg's face contorted, as if he were weighing up his options. So Thomas upped the ante.

"Jack Langton's wife spotted the case was light and Jack won't be pleased if she has to tell him. It's better for everyone if you hand it over."

Greg folded. "I was nosing round the flat when Janey was out and there it was. I just did it, spur of the moment."

"So where is the bag now?"

"I sold it."

"You did what?" Janey piped up, shrill as a cry of pain.

Greg turned towards her. "You know I got debts. It seemed like a golden opportunity — a lucky break, yeah?"

"And what if Jack thinks I did it?" She gripped the sofa.

"I was gonna take care of it. Once I had a buyer for the rest, I was gonna make it look like a burglary while you and me was at the hospital. Ain't no one gonna report a missing stash, are they?"

Thomas was halfway impressed; Greg had a few brain cells after all. "Who did you sell it to?"

“I can’t tell you; I gave my word. Don’t look at me like that, Janey — I did it for us. We can get away and start over.”

“Are you mental, Greg? Jack’ll come after us. He knows my family.” Her voice could have scratched glass.

Thomas waited, trying to stare it out of him. “It’s this simple, Greg. You tell me now and we’ll try and sort this, or Natalie tells Jack and he sorts things out his own way. What’s it to be?”

Janey started crying. Thomas squeezed his hands together: *we’ll try and sort this*. Jesus, he could feel Karl’s disappointment emanating from the door.

“Charlie Stokes — I sold it to Mr Stokes.”

Thomas heard a bell go off in his head. Karl cleared his throat and mimicked pushing a buggy.

“Yeah.” Thomas’s brain clicked into gear. “Janey, we want to take Jacob’s buggy away for a closer look — we’ll have it back to you before he needs it.”

She did as asked, muttering that the police had already checked it.

He stood right over Greg. “How much did you get for it?”

“Five grand, minus what I owed.”

Thomas shot a glance to Karl, who shook his head and flashed up enough hands for Thomas to feel sick. Greg was indeed a moron; they’d never be able to buy it back for five thousand.

He let out a sigh that could wake the dead. “Right, we are out of here.”

“What about the missing bag?” Janey’s voice wavered.

He didn’t have the heart to tell her they were both fucked now, thanks to Greg, so he sold her a lie until he could think of something better. “We’ll work on it.”

Karl stayed tight-lipped until they were back on the road.

“Go on, say it.”

“Do I need to? You’re getting us involved in a shit storm that’s nothing to do with us, Tommy Boy. Unless you have a five figure sum stashed away — always assuming this Charlie Stokes hasn’t already moved the stuff on — we’ve got nothing.”

He wondered where the drop-off would be for the buggy. Going on past experience, Karl’s clandestines favoured supermarket car parks. He played

the counting game, watching the seconds tick by until Karl broke the silence.

“You can’t save Greg from his own stupidity, and to be frank with you I don’t hold with drugs. I’ve told you before, they’re one of the ways the European cartel funds its operations.” Karl looked pensive. “There’s something else we haven’t considered — the drugs might not be Jack’s at all.”

“You know something, don’t you?” It was a moment before he realised his knuckles were whitening as he crushed them together.

Karl had spotted it too. “Tell you what, how about we grab ourselves a drink and go do our thinking somewhere else? I know the perfect place.”

Chapter 12

The pub's lights streamed across the pavement, highlighting the scarlet paintwork. Thomas recognised it from the time Karl had taken him there before. He rubbed at his scar self-consciously as Karl pushed the swing doors.

The place hadn't changed and nor was it ever likely to, unless some developer ripped its soul out. The saloon bar walls wore regimental shields like medals. He would have stayed awhile for a history lesson but Karl pointed him towards the bar and took out a mobile. Meantime, no one paid him any attention and that included the barman.

He waited, browsing the labels on the optics and fighting the urge to wave a fiver in the air like a one-fingered salute. Eventually the barman made the supreme sacrifice, finishing his conversation and ambling over.

"Two shandies and two bags of crisps please."

Karl ended his call as Thomas reached the table. "Sure, just give me a bell when you're outside."

Thomas slid a glass towards him. "What did I miss?"

"They'll pick up the buggy and we should get the analysis pronto, as a favour."

He chalked it up as another debt. Item one on his mental checklist was Charlie Stokes. Typically, Karl was a step ahead of him.

"The word is that Mr Stokes is one nasty piece of work." Karl took a mouthful of shandy. "What? You were at the bar so long I had time for two calls."

Yeah, Thomas thought, and look which one you made first. He whipped out a ballpoint and paper; he always thought better visually.

"Could Charlie be behind the attack on little Jacob?"

"Maybe." Karl pawed at the crisps. "Why though, unless he was after scaring Greg into lifting the drugs to settle his debt?"

"Doubtful — Greg only found them recently."

"Aye, so he says."

"Then why stop at one bag and why now? Jack's been inside for a while."

Karl shrugged. “Beats me. You ponder on that; I’m off for a piss.”

Thomas lifted his head and casually scanned the room. No one else was drinking alone. He envied them their camaraderie. The swing door caught his attention — a silhouette against the glass, immobile and poised. The old fear slithered to the surface. Yorgi may have died on the moors but was there unfinished business with the people he’d worked for?

A stranger entered the saloon and looked straight at him. He returned the favour, sizing him up. The bloke seemed indifferent, skirting the room to end up at the bar. Karl returned, phone in hand and stopped, halfway across the carpet. The stranger stalled too and Thomas tried to fathom what was happening. Karl seemed to change tempo, smiling at the stranger as he approached him.

Their voices stayed low and Thomas watched, fascinated, as some part of Karl’s private world gate-crashed the evening. The stranger ordered a drink, which Karl insisted on paying for, and the two of them came over. Karl reached across to grab a nearby empty chair.

“Thomas.” Karl laid a hand on the stranger’s shoulder. “Ken’s a friend of mine — from the old days.”

Ken didn’t seem to be in on the joke. He took a seat and dived into his beer. Karl tried again.

“It’s been a while. I didn’t know you were living in London now.”

Ken didn’t reply until he’d downed most of his pint and had to surface for air. “Been moving around, Karl — you know how it is. Spent a lot of time in the north, only things don’t always work out.” His eyes fixed on Thomas. “And how do you come to know Karl then?”

He went for cryptic. “We work in the same office.”

“Never had you figured for a desk job, Karl,” Ken took on a mocking tone. “The way I heard it, you left the forces under a bit of a cloud. Still, needs must I suppose and at least you’ve remembered the old days.” He gazed around the bar.

If that was meant to be bait, Karl wasn’t biting.

“Anyone fancy another drink — Tommo?”

“Here,” Ken pulled out a crisp twenty. “This round’s on me — have what you like. Where are you from, Thomas? I cannae place the accent; it’s not all London.”

Not many people noticed — or cared. Miranda reckoned it was only the odd inflection on a few words by now. He felt his chest swell a little. “Yorkshire, only I’ve been naturalised.”

“Aye, well, don’t lose touch with your roots. That right, Karl?” Ken gave him a playful slap on the arm.

As Thomas left the table, a mere errand boy for drinks, he heard Karl asking if Ken needed any money.

“Do I, fuck!” was Ken’s defiant reply

Returning to the table with Ken’s lager and crisps, he played the silence game to see what the tide brought in. Answer: very little. Karl was tight-lipped, while Ken had a haunted look about him, which Thomas hoped a few more beers would exorcise.

Eventually Thomas gave up and went to the bar for a set of darts. He played against himself, last man standing. The walks back from the dartboard showed him that conversation had resumed in his absence, though not much of it. Karl looked rattled and Ken was getting progressively more out of control. Finally, he stood up, leaned over Karl and hissed, “Don’t forget, you owe me.” Then he staggered off to the gents, colliding with the back of someone’s chair and offering an incomprehensible apology in his wake.

“Everything all right?” Thomas teased his thumb against a dart.

“Champion.” Karl’s face didn’t agree. “Listen, Tommo, do you fancy working tonight?”

“Sure.” He watched Karl’s face start to relax. “What time?”

Karl checked his watch and deliberated. “About two a.m. You might wanna get a nap in, given it’s barely ten. Either that or some strong coffee.”

“Do you and your mate need some space?”

“Ken?” Karl laughed. “If I know him, he’ll be out the back door and away by now.” Karl’s mobile trilled. He glanced at the number before he answered. “I’ll come out now.” He brightened and nodded to Thomas. “Perfect timing. Could you give me a couple of minutes?”

With Karl outside he made a beeline for the gents. Turning left from the exit instead of right, he found himself in a yard — crates stacked against the walls and heavy wooden gates at the far end. Ken must have been keen to disappear.

Karl was already in the driving seat when he got round to the car. He spotted him pocketing a key as he got in.

“Tommo, your friend from the old days — Ajit, was it? Do you trust him?”

“Yeah, of course,” he said without thinking. He wondered where this was leading.

Karl started playing with the key again. “I mean *really* trust him, like you trust Miranda?”

He felt his face burning. “No. I don’t trust anyone else like that — not even you.”

“Good man.” Karl nodded slowly and started the car, dropping the key down by the handbrake. Thomas got a good look at it and the hairs on his neck stood up.

Chapter 13

Thomas flinched. Karl was slow to respond to his mobile alarm until a sharp nudge did the trick.

“Right, time to switch. You’ll be in the driving seat for a change.” He got out and let Thomas lever himself across.

Rain was already spattering the windscreen; the windows had misted up. It didn’t help that the inside of the car smelled like a kebab graveyard.

“Where are we heading?”

Karl read a text and sucked a tooth. “I’ll navigate as we go.” He fetched a battered street guide from under the seat.

They were near the Thames; Thomas was sure about that, though not much else. He followed Karl’s monotone directions, arriving near a block of flats.

“Okay, give me five minutes and then start the car. If anyone spooks you — especially if it’s the police — drive off and I’ll make my own way back. I’ll leave my phone here, locked. Worst case scenario, try flashing your badge.”

Thomas smiled, recalling the one and only time an SSU ID had headed off a parking ticket. These days it’d be more likely to double the fine.

Karl exited the car quietly and headed into the shadows. Now came the waiting. Thomas tripped his mobile to silent and read another text from Ajit: Don’t they have phones in London anymore?

A pair of headlights swallowed the street by degrees. He slipped down in his seat, slowly and casually, waiting until the stream of light had passed. Sure enough it was a police car, the rear reflective chevrons shrinking into the distance. He was beginning to join the dots and he didn’t like the emerging picture. He trawled through his phone and brought up the image of the Ingersoll key from the gents at Victoria Station.

Time ticked down so he turned the ignition, startled by how loud the engine sounded in the darkness. He flicked the wipers sporadically, clearing the view for trespassers.

Karl cut it fine. He walked quickly, carrying a long case. Thomas craned the passenger door open as he approached and Karl hefted the case

behind him with some difficulty.

“Drive.” Karl stared ahead. “Take a left up here and then the second right.” He was back to map-reading again.

Thomas’s brain was already slotting pieces together. The key, the size of the case and the last minute job offer all pointed in one direction. He needed to be sure though.

“Why don’t we go back to my flat?”

“Good idea, I’m bushed.” Karl was only half-listening.

Once he’d crossed back over the Thames there was no further need for directions so he tried to fill the void. “How long did you and Ken serve together?”

“Two years, give or take. Look, can we change the subject?”

* * *

Walthamstow was its pretty self, even in the early hours. Vagrants slumped together at Bell Corner, waiting for something to happen. Lloyd Park stood silent, the trees swaying gently in the wind and rain. He thought it could make an interesting composition, lit from one side and with a fog filter. But he wasn’t that type of photographer.

“Listen, Thomas, I appreciate your help. I know we’ve gone a little off-piste.”

He didn’t answer. All he could think about was getting the cargo inside.

Karl laid the case down on the coffee table and finally took his gloves off. “A cup of sweet tea before bedtime would be nice.”

Thomas played mother, leaving the kitchen door ajar. When he returned with two mugs of the brown stuff, Karl was dozing on the sofa. He gave him a shove.

“Huh? Thanks pal. I must have dropped off. Shall we give the lock a try?”

Thomas sat beside him for the big reveal.

Karl flicked the catches and lifted the lid. For a moment they both stared silently at the weapon. Thomas sank back into the sofa.

“Did you know . . . ?”

“You think I’d willingly bring this into your home? Say the word and I’ll take it away tonight.”

“It’s late.” His eyes stayed anchored on the rifle. “It’s leaving here tomorrow anyway.”

Karl announced he was off to the loo, leaving Thomas with a dilemma. He wanted to photograph the case and the gun, and get a look at Karl’s key again. Sure, he could ask him, but why show his hand so soon? He listened to the revolving wheels of circular thoughts and paranoia. Something else the counsellor had picked up on — his inability to trust people.

Decision time. He went to a drawer and took out a pill from a plastic container. “Sorry, Karl,” he whispered, stirring it into Karl’s tea.

By the time he brought out a spare duvet and blankets for the sofa sleepover, Karl was already groggy. Thomas stared at the keys and change piled up on the table; he figured he’d give Karl an hour to be on the safe side.

At four-thirty he couldn’t stand it any longer. All roads led to the same nightmare conclusion. Sir Peter Carroll had set him up — the fucker — and Karl was the recovery man. He got up, listening hard for Karl’s heavy snoring.

The streetlight cast a silvery glow in the front room. Nothing looked real, which about summed up the situation. He checked the empty mug first then took the Ingersoll key into the kitchen to photograph it. He went back for the case, amused at the sight of himself in surgical gloves. If Karl woke up right now this could look very suss indeed.

Once the photo session was done, he stumbled back to bed and set both alarms. From what he remembered of those sleeping tablets Karl wouldn’t hear an earthquake.

Morning caught up with Thomas around seven. He didn’t attempt to move Karl until there was hot, strong caffeine at the ready.

“Come on — it’s half seven. Time you shifted your arse.”

Karl rolled back the top of the duvet and wiped his eyes. “Is that coffee I smell? Fantastic. I’ve been thinking. I want to test fire the rifle.”

As Thomas stared into his mug of roasted goodness an idea leapt out. If Karl was after ballistics then he didn’t know where the rifle came from. Time to enlighten him.

Karl didn’t speak until the end. “Why didn’t you tell me, Tommo — that night after Caliban’s?”

“It was only a job until today. I had no proof of anything. And besides, we’ve both had stranger requests.”

Karl’s face was a study in disappointment. “Either we take the rifle to the shooting club, or . . .” He paused to let him fill in the blank.

“We go somewhere more private — the scrap yard?” Miranda’s brothers’ scrap yard in Wapping.

“Perfect, and it means I can still meet Ken at midday.”

“You’re kidding me? Despite everything I’ve told you you’re giving it back to him?”

“It’s a little late for a lecture on ethics.” Karl reached for his coffee. “And by the way, your rubber plant over there — or whatever the hell it is — might be a little *sleepy* for a while.”

Thomas coughed quietly.

“For future reference, when you’ve secretly stirred something in, leaving the liquid swirling is a bit of a clue. Shall we cut the crap now — I’m on your side, remember?”

He really wanted to believe that. “So what’s going on? Jesus, Karl . . . a gun — the Old Man had me deliver a gun . . .” He couldn’t say the ‘m’ word.

“Let’s start with what we know.” Karl smiled to sweeten the pill, but it still left a bitter taste.

He printed off the two photographs of keys while Karl got his brain into gear and his trousers on. The photos were identical, same serial number and scratch marks.

“It’s a special Ingersoll key – for municipal locks. Ken gave it to me in the pub when you were playing darts. Next question?”

“Why not confront Sir Peter today?” Even as he said it he knew the answer. Karl would want to know everything so he could exert the maximum leverage with it.

“I’ll make you a promise, Thomas. When we get to the bottom of it you decide what we do about it. I’m serious. Now, are you going to ring Terry or shall I?”

Thomas picked up his phone. “What about ammunition?”

“Leave it to me. This rifle is like an old friend.”

Chapter 14

Thomas tapped the steering wheel and stared at the locked scrap yard gates. Already past eight thirty and no other bastard had shown up. Karl, he could forgive — at least he had bullets to collect. He stifled a yawn. Jesus, what a world he inhabited.

Another text came in from Ajit: Are you avoiding me? And speaking of guilt and avoidance, he hadn't contacted Miranda for a while either. Funny how spending time with Karl tended to push everyone else out of the frame.

He was on the point of ringing Terry when a cobalt-blue Peugeot roared up. Terry gave him a thumbs-up, got out and unlocked the gates. He looked hung-over. Thomas drove in after him. Karl had been quite specific about the depth of target he wanted, so they made a scavenger hunt around the yard.

By the time Karl put in an appearance, fifteen minutes later, they'd assembled an assortment of boards, posts and a couple of old car doors, ready for the build phase.

Karl took charge, instructing them how to reinforce the planks with wooden pallets so that the target stayed upright. Once it was all set up, he paced away what seemed like a ridiculous distance and turned, shifting his head from side to side like an owl. Finally, he made a line in the dirt and returned to his car.

"So what is it?" Thomas waited until Karl had set the case on the ground.

"The weapon?" Karl flexed his gloved hands. "A Winchester .300." He fitted the weapon together, screwed the silencer on and then strode away to his mark.

Thomas cleared off to grab a brew with Terry.

"Thanks again, Tel."

He shrugged. "You'd do the same for one of us."

True enough. Like the time he warned them off Harwich Port when he was working with Customs & Excise.

Karl took three shots and then came over to join them, holding the spent casings aloft in a bag. "If I'd been more organised I would have

brought along ballistic gelatine to go with the biscuits.”

Thomas delivered his most unimpressed face. Karl in the know was just about bearable, but Karl showing off was a step too far — not that Terry showed any interest. Tea break over, the three of them returned to the target. The three bullets had punched holes right through the wood and both doors, into the final block, where Karl carefully prised them out.

“You can imagine the mess they’d make. Right-oh, Tommo, We’ve got what we came for. I’ll be in touch.”

* * *

Thomas fortified himself with a bacon roll and a chocolate muffin, and trudged through the benefit claimants’ list alone. By the time he reached the stalking ground he’d already missed the first few.

He ran his tongue over his lip and tasted fat residue and salt. Was it coincidence that Ken had found Karl in the pub? Karl hadn’t seemed thrilled to see his old oppo. And why choose Ken at all? He started picking away at the chocolate chips, weary of his own thoughts. At this rate he’d be asleep before the afternoon shift.

Radio 3 offered up Grieg’s *Peer Gynt Suite*, which conjured up memories of Christine Gerrard and her spacious car seats. That wasn’t helping either. He rubbed his eyes and checked his watch again: eleven fifty-two. Karl would be on his way now.

A builder’s van drove past and Thomas started the car. Nick Barrowby should be on board, suspected of working cash-in-hand. And, by suspected, the docket recorded that *information had been received*. A tip-off, maybe by a disgruntled recipient of sub-standard tarmac.

The van logo matched the sheet. All he had to do was follow at a discreet distance and catch him in the act. The van stopped opposite a building site of a garden and four men got out. The youngest, sporting baggy jeans and a fake branded sweatshirt, matched the photo on the sheet.

Thomas knew to wait it out. Arriving wasn’t evidence of illegal working, any more than being with Miranda constituted a stable relationship. He bedded in and let the camera do its work.

Barrowby pushing a wheelbarrow. Then fetching out tools. At this stage he could still be helping out a mate and walk away. Thomas almost willed

him to be *that* man. But the observer in him knew that the job was the job. He simply collected the data and some other schmuck made the decisions.

After the first batch of photos, Thomas's mobile rang. Pisser. He placed the camera down in the passenger foot well with infinite care and then picked up the call.

"Thomas? It's Ajit — where have you been? I've left messages . . ."

"Aye, sorry Aj. I've been working extra hours." He winced; that sounded lame.

"So, are you coming up or what?"

There was desperation in the voice. He could picture Ajit's family crowding around him, suffocating him with kindness and tradition. They were good people, but God help Ajit as the son bringing a potential heir into the world. Particularly if Ajit's dad had anything to do with it. Bloody hell, Ajit taking up with an *anagareja mahila* — English girl — was enough of an adjustment for them.

"I'll be there, Aj. Can Geena hold the baby in until the weekend?"

"You do remember that Friday is the due date?"

He didn't, and he felt bad about it. "I'll check with Miranda." He gave Ajit a cast iron guarantee, which bumped Miranda up the list.

"Is that a tall, dark stranger?"

"Hi, Miranda," he flustered. "Have you got a minute?"

"A minute? For you, I can spare five — when can you get here?" Cue background laughter, which told him that Sheryl was within earshot of at least half the call.

"Ajit wants us up at the weekend." There was no laughter now. "You are still coming?"

"I said I would, didn't I?"

"Great, gotta go. I'll call you with train times. Ta-ra babe." When it came to ending their calls he often felt like a dick. They didn't do *love*, but 'laters' hardly seemed to cover it.

He lifted the camera again and leaned through the gap in the seats. The van was still parked, but no one was around. Nick Barrowby could have gone home. He could call it quits. Maybe a five-minute rest of the eyes would help decide . . .

"Oi!"

He stared up as an old codger hammered out a rhythm on the driver's window. He took the hint and lowered it.

"You've been here nearly half an hour, asleep outside my house. This is a residential area you know."

He blinked slowly. "Sorry mate — must have dozed off for a bit."

"Right, well, can't be too careful. I've made a note of your car. We don't want the neighbourhood getting a reputation."

He reached for his SSU ID and kept a strategic thumb over his name.

The resident's demeanour changed. "Oh, I see. You're on a stakeout, are you?" He looked up and down the street. "Is it the woman along there with the kids?" He flicked his head to the left. "Different fathers, and neither of them takes an interest from what I hear."

Like Karl said: never let a good opportunity go by. "Listen . . ." He leaned towards the open window. "Any chance I could pop in for a few minutes?"

It was disturbingly easy to gain access to an upstairs room. In five minutes of photography Nick Barrowby was well and truly shafted. He ticked him off the list, using Karl's patented 'G for Guilty' shorthand. Once the job was complete, he thanked his host, sidestepped a cuppa because he'd seen the sterilised milk downstairs, took a leak and then went on his way. Last thing he did was remind the bloke to keep schtum and stay vigilant, and not to let any strangers into his house again. A time check showed it was nearly one p.m. With any luck, Karl would rendezvous with him at the next location.

* * *

Karl's car was just pulling in as Thomas arrived, so he joined him. Mr Paul Tomlinson wasn't hard to track; he could have been followed at a light stroll. They watched as a man, old before his years, lurched unsteadily on two sticks. Karl's head bounced side to side, scrutinising every step.

"He's consistent; I'll give you that. There's a definite rhythm to his movements."

Thomas twisted in his seat. "Doesn't this bother you? When you think of all the assignments we've had . . ."

Karl considered the point for about four seconds. "Nah. They send us and we turn up to do the job. End of story."

Mr Tomlinson shuffled along the street and shouldered his way through a pub door.

“You know what I’d do?” Karl carefully replaced his lens cap.

Thomas smiled; he knew all too well because they’d both read Conan Doyle. “A Study in Scarlet — smoke bomb through the window.”

“Right. Then see how quickly he moves.”

“So, what, he can’t be really disabled because he likes a drink?”

Karl stiffened. “Fancy a pint? I’m buying.” And before Thomas could answer he was halfway out the car.

They locked their cameras in the boot, for all the good that might do, and cut across the council’s idea of a play area. Municipal irony came in concrete. He followed Karl in silence, grabbing the pub’s swing door as Karl let it go behind him. Mr Tomlinson stood out like a sore thumb, standing behind a chair with his two sticks leant against it.

“Any news?” Thomas set the drinks down on the table.

“What, with Ken? Funny thing; he wasn’t pleased to see the case, pretty spooked by it actually. Think on that — I’ve gotta nip outside.”

Their quarry sat down and didn’t move. Thomas was glad; it seemed unreasonable to hassle a bloke in Tomlinson’s condition. Still, like Karl said: the job was the job. Evidence based reporting — once you began to make subjective decisions, it was a slippery slope leading to bias and poor judgement. Amen.

The saloon door rattled and Karl bustled in, whamming a newspaper down beside Thomas’s elbow — it made grim reading. Either a reporter had got clever, or she had contacts. The shooter’s location had been identified as a block of flats. Thomas wondered if child killers merited a lofty word like assassination. The leader page made it clear that access to the roof was only possible with a security key.

“Something troubling you, Thomas?”

“I made that possible.”

Karl seemed nonplussed. “Well, you’re hardly complicit. Anyway, some would say you deserve a medal.”

It didn’t make him feel any better. “What did Ken do in the army?”

“Not here.” Karl finished his drink and headed out the door.

Thomas was a second or two behind him; Mr Tomlinson had been outranked. Outside, grey clouds masked the horizon.

“Come on then — Ken?”

“I’m sure you’ve worked it out — he was a sniper. My, my,” Karl walked back towards the cars, “what have we got ourselves in the middle of?”

“Karl!” He grabbed his arm and spun him round. “I’m going away for a few days — I’ve got too much in my head. Ajit and Geena are about to have their first baby and . . .”

Karl nodded sympathetically. “Of course. Do what you have to — just don’t do anything rash. I’ll square your trip with Christine and call you if there are any developments. Go home.”

Chapter 15

Miranda had thawed a little since the last time they spoke, but not by much. He understood. Yorkshire hadn't covered itself in glory on the last couple of visits, but he still got nostalgic for the old days in Leeds when she lived in a bedsit on Hyde Terrace. He kept, captured in celluloid, fond memories of love's young dream and the move down south to start a new life together. And what a life it had become.

He tore himself away from the photographs on his wall and picked up a sports bag; he was already wearing the rucksack. Karl had offered to drop him off at Euston Station, but he'd chosen the Tube. Walthamstow had a touch of *dirty old town* about it, but he liked that. There was honesty on those unswept streets — that and litter.

The tide of commuters had long since rolled through Walthamstow Central. Passing through the barrier he could hear the whirr of the escalators — like his own thoughts, circling without resolution. He descended into the labyrinth, half-wondering if Miranda would actually show up.

He surfaced at Euston and immediately texted Ajit: Nearly on train — speak later. Then he joined the throng in the station hall and started looking for a special blonde.

“I bought you a book.”

He opened the bag and read the cover: *The Spy Who Loved Me*. He wasn't sure if she was taking the piss, so he kissed her anyway and then dragged her off in search of snacks. By the time they were on the concourse, he was £15 poorer; a small price to pay. He felt like a teenager again, heading home to Yorkshire. Miranda waited until they found their seats before she put a major spoke in the works.

“I'm going to stay in a hotel. You can join me if you like.”

He gave up trying to read her face. “My sister's expecting you.”

“Yeah, I know, but I thought this way I won't get under anyone's feet.”

He did a sweep of the carriage from his seat. She looked up, raised her eyes and then went back to her magazine. Once what she called his *gentle paranoia* had subsided he settled into the journey. The soothing rhythm and flow of an ever-changing view allowed his mind to wander unfettered.

“When you’re finished, I’m trying to read.” She smiled impishly as he became aware that his foot was rubbing against hers.

Time for a crossword. He delved into the carrier and pulled out a book of cryptics. He liked the sense of order and structure, and their strange algebra. It seemed to him that much of his life was about cracking codes, solving problems, or bringing order to chaos. He itched to ring Karl, but now was not the time for a declaration of war with Miranda — especially as she’d already mentioned she was here under protest.

“All right, let’s get a room tonight and then see how we go.”

She lowered her magazine like a drawbridge. “How long are you staying?”

Good question. “Dunno.” He’d assumed Geena’s sprog would keep to the timetable, given Ajit’s punctuality. Against his instincts he wanted to tell Miranda about the case and the rifle, and everything he was running away from. He knew it wouldn’t do any good though.

“You were miles away.” She glanced down at the crossword he’d started filling in with little targets. “If you’re offering, I’ll have a large coffee, milk and sugar.”

“You’re the boss.” He returned her smile. Trains — was there anything they couldn’t do? The buffet car gave him some thinking space; there was bad news to deliver back at the table. He’d need to time it carefully

“Did I mention Dad’s picking us up at York?” He passed Miranda her coffee.

“You *are* kidding?”

He slid into his seat. “Well, I could hardly expect Ajit to come and fetch us when Geena might go into labour at any moment?”

“So you’ll tell him about the hotel then, before you get home?”

“Yeah.” He gazed out the window. “I’ll tell him.”

The sight of York Minster catapulted Thomas back through the years. Mum liked to make a pilgrimage there at Christmas and Easter – probably still did. She would dress in her church clothes, with Dad pressganged into a shirt and tie. Meantime he and his sister Pat would have to be on best behaviour. The routine never varied, including the arguments on the way there and the festive tug-of-war between the tearoom and the pub afterwards. In his mind’s eye he watched his younger self, traipsing round the shops with his sister, mimicking the adults and taking sides. He recalled

the gaggles of carol singers and the roasted chestnut pedlars, and weaving through the crowds with Pat, breathing in the sugared air together. York had always been a place of sanctuary.

“Are you fit?” Miranda clutched her bag, packed and ready to go.

He nodded, dumped everything back in the carrier and turned to the luggage rack. Outside, there was a bustle of people even in the early afternoon. That was the magic of York – never empty and never dull. Dad was nowhere to be seen and he regretted not planning an overnight stop in York – a halfway house between the old life and his present one.

“Do you think he’s forgotten, or d’you reckon he’s still in the pub?” Miranda pulled her coat in close.

Visitors and students streamed past, jostling together as taxis homed in on the prey. Once upon a time he and Ajit had talked about getting a flat in York. In the finish, he’d overshot York by several hundred miles while Ajit had never really left Pickering. Funny how life worked out.

Miranda threw a quiet strop and went off in search of coffee, leaving him to guard the bags. He nudged them together with his foot, and texted Ajit: In York awaiting Dad. No sooner had he sent it than an earlier text came through: Where are you? Aj. Good old modern technology.

Miranda returned with one cup of coffee, so they shared. He couldn’t tell if this was punishment or intimacy, but at least it was coffee. He spotted the hazard lights as the car approached.

“Well don’t just stand there, get in.” Dad leapt out, kissed Miranda awkwardly on the cheek and gave him a manly grip of the arm.

Miranda had opted for the back seat, alone. Thomas turned round, periodically, to make sure she felt part of the conversation, but he may as well not have bothered.

“So, how’s things, Dad? Taken any good pictures lately?”

His father took the bait, distracting him with talk of the Rievaulx Abbey ruins, St Mary’s ‘Dracula’ church at Whitby and the moors, a mental guided tour.

“Now, I ’ope you’re hungry because your mam’s done a bit o’ baking.”

Miranda coughed and he felt her knee pushing against his back.

“Actually, Dad, er . . . we’ve made plans for tonight.”

Chapter 16

The old family home in Pickering felt overcrowded. Pat, with Gordon — her feckless shit of a husband, the two bairns, and Mam, all crammed into the front room. Dad's seat was waiting for him and Mam leapt up to welcome them before scuttling into the kitchen to put the kettle on. Pat, naturally, made a huge fuss of her *daft brother* and Miranda waited beside him for her turn in the spotlight.

Dad changed into slippers and then nipped into the kitchen, presumably to deliver the bad news in private. Soon after, tea was served with a slice of cake and a sprinkling of attitude.

"It's lovely." Miranda played nicely, although she didn't use her name and would certainly never call her 'Mum.' Thomas had been on first name terms with John and Diane Wright from the moment he clapped eyes on them.

"So, where are you staying?" His mother made out like she didn't care, and fooled no one.

"We're at the Best Western," Miranda parried. "We managed to get a special deal."

Thomas glanced at Pat, who was trying hard not to laugh. This was like watching a lioness face down a crocodile at the watering hole. "How's work, Gordon?" He opted for a soft target.

"So-so." Gordon looked at his watch none too casually. "Well, I'd best be off with the kids – come on, say goodbye to Nana and Grandpa."

The children swamped their grandparents and then approached Uncle Thomas for their customary pocket money; after which Miranda handed out chocolate. Then, without a word between Pat and her husband, Gordon took off with the kids. The front door slammed, carrying the children's voices with it, and Pat seemed to relax, motioning for Miranda to sit beside her. Thomas winked at Pat; unless he was mistaken battle lines were being drawn.

"Right, lad, let me go and fetch them photographs." Dad left the field early, clearly in no mood for bloodshed.

Thomas filled in, asking about the extended family – uncles, aunts and cousins he'd had nothing to do with in the past decade. When that rich conversational vine had withered, he shifted the focus to Ajit and Geena. All he could get out of Mum was, "It'll likely be a big bairn, judging by the size of him." It was said with affection and it helped ease the tension.

While father and son pawed over photographs, Miranda delved into her case to deliver a Harrods bag to Thomas's mother.

"Just a little something."

"How thoughtful." She melted.

By five thirty they were away to the Best Western. Miranda confirmed her double room at reception.

"So you knew I'd stay with you?"

"No . . ." She paused. "I booked it for me, and to add you if required."

Required? He didn't like the sound of that. She did the necessary at the desk, insisting it went on her credit card, while he tried not to look — and feel — like an afterthought. Once they were upstairs, he rang Ajit at home.

"At last! I thought you'd got lost after York and ended up in Ripton. What are you both doing tonight then?"

Ajit insisted on picking them up at the hotel, so Thomas booked an early meal for two beforehand. Dinner was fractious; the staccato conversation managed to say nothing at all. He felt himself withdrawing; he'd expected Yorkshire to be a challenge, with everything else going on, but not like this. He figured she'd tell him eventually — she always did.

Ajit was punctual to the minute; he had the look of a condemned man about him.

"You've cleaned the car!" Thomas squeezed into the passenger seat behind him.

"He's a cheeky bugger." Ajit beamed at Miranda beside him. "So how was it wi' the Bladens?"

No reply. On the drive over, Ajit chronicled Geena's two false alarms, her mania for tuna and inflatable ankles.

"Bloody 'ell, Thomas, I'm going to be a dad soon." Ajit sounded like he still couldn't believe it.

Thomas went in first. Geena looked immense. "Are you sure it's just the one kid?"

“Ullo love,” Geena adjusted the cushion behind her. “Put kettle on, will you?” She slapped a nearby chair. “Well, come in, Miranda.”

He left them to it and joined Ajit in the kitchen. They jostled together among the cups, seventeen-year-olds again.

“How’s your job, Thomas? Don’t worry, I am covered by the Official Secrets Act.”

* * *

Time among friends twisted the minutes and folded the present in with the past. Ajit had been the first to know when he and Miranda had decided to go to London and had lent him the money for the tickets. Now, as he relaxed in their company, he felt maturity creeping up on him. Soon Ajit and Geena’s lives would change forever and revolve around sleeplessness and feeding times. He listened to them talking about baby names and stole a glance at Miranda. Were they next? Wasn’t that what couples did?

“And then . . .” Geena tapped Miranda’s knee, shaking the chair as she rocked with laughter, “Ajit’s mum suggested I have a ‘traditional’ home birth with all the women of the family in attendance! I said, ‘Bugger that — I want a hospital with a dishy doctor on standby.’”

“We’re having it in the Malton,” Ajit explained.

“Oh aye,” Geena erupted into laughter again, “we.”

“You’re gonna be there in the delivery room?” Thomas looked at Ajit incredulously — Ajit, who got rattled at the sight of a needle.

“He better be!” Geena answered for him.

Miranda had left the room without leaving her seat. He knew that look in her eyes — a storm was approaching. “Right.” He put down his mug. “Time we left you good people to your bed. Do you want help getting Geena out of her chair?”

He rang for a cab and waited at the door with Ajit wedged beside him.

“Listen, sorry about Miranda; I don’t know what her problem is today.”

“How d’ya mean?”

“Never mind, it’s been a long day. We’re seeing my folks tomorrow, but ring me if anything’s happening.”

The taxi journey was a crypt on wheels. He kept his mouth shut until they were back in their hotel room.

“Couldn’t you have made an effort? I know you didn’t want to come, but it’s not their fault.”

“No.” She stomped around the room, searching for a hairbrush. “It’s yours. I told you I’d rather not be here, but you insisted I come along to play happy families.”

“What *is* your problem? Have I done something to piss you off?”

“Just leave it. I’m tired; I’m going to bed.”

He didn’t need surveillance skills to work out it wasn’t an invitation.

Chapter 17

He was out next morning, camera in hand, and returned with pictures of two chaffinches and the back end of a squirrel. Miranda was in the shower. When he pressed his ear against the door so he could hear her trying to sing, he thought he heard her crying. She emerged from the steam wrapped in towels, her face a little blotchy. Somehow she could still make pissed off and unhappy look good.

After breakfast they went walkabout in Pickering, a busy Saturday in a typical market town with endless opportunities for not talking to one another. They got to the café early. The place could have doubled as a lace museum. There were only four chairs at the reserved table. Apparently Pat, Gordon and the kids were out for the day. Knowing Gordon it could well have been a trip to the garden centre.

Hostilities had abated by the time his parents arrived. Miranda broke new ground by calling them Helen and James. He watched the three of them struggling and went on the offensive.

“What’s the latest with Pat and Gordon?”

His father faltered. “Well, she doesn’t say a lot. I think they’re managing . . .”

“And what about you two?” Mum returned fire.

He was all out of ideas after the previous night. When make-up sex was off the table, he knew they were in bad shape.

Helen advanced further into enemy territory. “You’ve had years to sort yourselves out. If you’d stayed in Leeds — or come back to Pickering — things might be very different now.”

“Excuse me, I need the loo.” Miranda stood up and glared at him.

He made the most of her absence by defining a few boundaries. They were all enjoying a nice cup of tea when his mobile came to the rescue.

“Alright, Thomas?” Ajit’s voice echoed in the earpiece — a classic corridor conversation. “Geena’s been taken into hospital, on account of her blood pressure — a precautionary measure.”

“So it’s not the big push, then?”

“No, but I think she’d be glad of that now. Complete bed rest until the baby comes. She came in first thing this morning and she’s already bored out of her skull. Do you feel like popping in to cheer her up?”

“In hospital you say?” He mouthed ‘Ajit’ for the benefit of everyone at the table. “And where are you again?”

“The Malton, like I told you yesterday.”

“The Malton?” He repeated it for effect. “That’s miles away.”

It had the desired result. The journey over was punctuated by Thomas’s efforts to include Miranda in the conversation and a fat lot of good it did him. They were dropped outside and he walked off to the front desk, threading his way to Ajit, with Miranda trailing behind him.

Ajit looked elated to see a new face. “It could be up to a week they reckon — she’s nowhere near ready,” he muttered outside the room.

“I bloody well am,” Geena called out. “Are you coming in or what?”

The room smelled of some aromatherapy spray — the scent he had noticed at their house. A stuffed piglet, Geena’s from childhood, was propped up on a pillow.

“Does Percy know he’s getting a sibling?” Thomas flicked its ragged ear.

A medic put her head around the door and asked them to leave while she did a quick examination. Miranda was first out and the three of them decamped to the corridor. Ajit tried small talk about her business and Thomas listened in. Miranda was so self-contained. She didn’t need looking after and that scared the hell out of him.

The medic emerged and passed on a message for Miranda to go in alone. She went pale at the news, glancing behind her up the corridor. Ajit caught Thomas’s eye and nodded towards the drinks machine.

“Girls’ talk!” Ajit nudged him without turning back. “Is she alright?”

“Dunno.” Thomas was relieved to have Ajit on his wavelength. “She’s been in a funny mood since we left London.” He dug into his pocket for a handful of change.

“P’raps she’s broody.” Ajit stroked his chin. “I’ve ’eard that some women get that way when one of them has a bairn. Maybe you want to think about that, Mr Intelligence.”

He concentrated on carrying the coffees back while his mind turned somersaults. They’d never discussed having kids — apart from joking about

what terrible parents they'd make. And now his job always seemed to get in the way.

Ajit knocked on the door before they went in. Geena was in tears. Thomas meekly handed Miranda her coffee; she'd have given Medusa a run for her money. Ajit moved around the bed to Geena's side and Thomas looked on.

He felt the walls closing in, as if a haze had filled the room and only he could see it. He heard each shallow breath, felt his heart pounding and knew he had to get out of there. Without saying a word he closed the door behind him. A few paces on he dropped his cup into a bin, inhaling the sickly aroma of machine coffee and creamer as it hit the plastic liner and burst. *Jesus*. He felt the sweat in his hands as he switched on his mobile.

"Hey Karl, it's Thomas — any news?"

"You could say that. I got a look at the police report — ballistics confirms what we already knew. I'll tell you more when I see you." Karl's phone paranoia kicked in.

He took a Judas breath. "I'll come back today."

"Well, that'd be useful but I can hold the fort here until you're ready."

"No, it's settled. I'll ring you from the train." As he slumped with relief against the wall, he felt his rucksack digging into his back. Inside were his camera, his passport and his keys — all the things that mattered.

He dragged himself back along the corridor and tried to lose himself in justifications. Jack Langton was depending on him and so was Karl. Besides, Miranda might be grateful for an excuse to leave. He cleared his throat and went inside, a few steps from the door.

"I've just spoken to Karl. Sorry, I'm needed in London."

"No." She spoke quietly and didn't say anything else.

He couldn't tell whether she was objecting or if she didn't believe him, so he waited. She was quiet for a time, taking it all in. And just when he thought she was okay with everything she flipped. A complete meltdown; screaming, flailing at him, resurrecting every injustice he'd ever inflicted on her — and there were many. Telling him how he put his fucking job before her every time, and now he'd treated his only friends the same way.

"The truth is you need your job — you're lost without it. You run back to London. I'm staying on at the hotel."

Ajit stared at the floor. Geena grabbed his hand, pulling him close, crying and crying without saying a word, until finally Miranda told Thomas to get out.

He shut the door and kept on walking, telling himself it wasn't cowardice but self-preservation. Either way, the rush of air past the automatic doors was the purest oxygen he'd ever known. When he reached York he rang his sister. He wanted to get in his side of the story first, and he passed on Miranda's mobile number so Pat could keep an eye on her.

"Oh, Tommy." Pat's voice sank. "Whatever's wrong with you?"

"I don't know, Sis." He told her the signal was breaking up and cut the call.

At York, he collected a couple of Southern Comfort miniatures to anaesthetise him for the rest of the journey. Not being a big drinker had its advantages. He woke as the train arrived in London, a sweet taste on his lips and a bitter one on his conscience. The therapist, who he'd stopped seeing, had once asked him if he saw a way back to the person he used to be. Before he'd been dragged into the Surveillance Support Unit quicksand like all the others. "No," he whispered on the train, "there's no way back now."

Chapter 18

Karl met him at Euston Station. “Jaysus, Tommo — you look like shit. Is everything okay?”

Thomas threw him a sardonic smile and followed him to the car. Karl rattled off a relentless briefing while he drove.

“. . . I acquired a photo of a cartridge the police recovered from the scene, found in a drainage channel. Ken must have missed it — sloppy. It matches the ones from our test firing. You realise what this means?”

“Yeah, I’m definitely an accessory to murder.” When Thomas closed his eyes he saw the bullet holes that had penetrated wood and metal in the scrap yard. He opened the window to escape the faded scent of spilt orange juice from the back seat.

“Stop the car – I’m going to be sick.” He was true to his word.

Karl sluiced off the kerbstone with drinking water while Thomas sat there, head in his hands.

“You wanna talk about it?”

He shook his head slowly. “I wouldn’t know where to start.” He held out his hands and rubbed some water across his face before taking a swig.

“That’s all right, Tommo — you keep it. Listen, if you don’t feel like going home, do you fancy a drink?”

It wasn’t like he had anywhere else to go. “Sure. Where does the police report leave you with Ken?”

“Treading carefully. He’s clearly implicated although I’m still waiting for his version. But I think what you’re really asking is whether I’d turn him in?” Karl looked him right between the eyes. “Not a chance. I hope I haven’t offended your moral compass.”

He didn’t bother responding.

* * *

It didn’t take a detective to predict the choice of watering hole. He wondered if Karl was secretly hoping to run into Ken again. He doubted it — life was rarely that tidy. As they entered the regimental bar the manager called Karl over. Thomas fell in step.

“Mr McNeill!” He stiffened a little, as if passing sentence. “This was left for you — hand delivered. Please don’t make a habit of it.”

Karl reached for the envelope and ordered two shandies. Over at the table, he checked it for signs of tampering and then slit the top with his car key. He extracted a single page from the ragged edge and folded it flat on the table so they could both read it: SORRY TO DRAG YOU INTO THIS. NO ONE ELSE I COULD TRUST — KEN.

Half an hour and one game of darts later, Thomas felt brave enough to put his mobile back on. Ajit’s text read: How could you? There was no word from Miranda, which was about what he figured he deserved. He was still reliving the scene in the hospital when Karl returned from the gents.

“No good news, I take it?”

He snapped back into work mode. “We need to get the buggy back to Janey. You can explain the science again to me on the way.”

“Not much to tell. The paint colour is obsolete according to some database, and the chemical analysis of the flakes on the buggy confirms the paint was manufactured before 2000.”

“So how does that sit with Jack Langton’s theory that it was a premeditated attack?”

“It’s an anomaly, I grant you. And we still don’t know it *was* about Jack. Greg owed money to Charlie Stokes — he as good as said so. Something to discuss next time you see Jack in prison?”

Heading across London, he turned down *Deep Purple* and reached for his phone again. No voice messages but one new text: I need to see you tonight — Diane. That was unexpected — a summons from Miranda’s mum.

“Listen, could you drop me off at my place first and deal with the buggy on your own? I just received an invitation I can’t turn down.”

* * *

When he went inside for his car keys he spotted the answering machine flashing. He hit the button and stood in the shadows, waiting. Pat didn’t pull any punches this time — Miranda deserved better, he was totally selfish, and the topper: she was ashamed of him. Join the queue.

It stood to reason that Diane Wright had heard from Miranda. They were close. Not like her to get involved though. She usually stayed well

clear of their chaos. He was either in line for the mother of all bollockings or something else was going on. He got in the car and put his foot down.

Chapter 19

His palms tingled as the sweat met the dank air outside, each step from the car talking him further from safety. Diane was quick to answer the door, solemn faced and drawn.

“Come in, Thomas.”

He followed her to an empty living room. Diane noticed he was looking around.

“John’s in his office. We agreed this was better coming from me. Sit down. Coffee all right?” Her voice trailed behind her.

He leapt up after her; he thought he might as well get it over with.

“Look, Diane, I’m really sorry about leaving Miranda in Yorkshire. There was stuff I needed to do for Jack Langton and it couldn’t wait.”

She faced him down, saying nothing, and pulled out a couple of chairs. The kitchen it would be then. She seemed lost in thought, or maybe she was waiting for the right moment. Either way, it was killing him.

“I know I fucked up.” He felt his voice go brittle.

She yielded a long sigh, put down her coffee, and cupped one hand over the other as though she were shielding something fragile.

“Miranda’s been under a lot of strain lately.” She raised a finger when he lifted his head to speak. “It’s been hard keeping you in the dark, but Miranda talked with Geena and then she rang me.”

A wave of dread hit him. “Is Miranda ill?” His breath caught in his throat.

“No . . .” She stalled. “Not *ill*.” The way she said it hinted at bad news. It wasn’t long in coming. “You remember when she went to Bermuda?”

How could he forget? They’d parted company — again — and she’d been seeing some up-and-coming footballer, apparently. What was it with her and footballers? And then, almost out of the blue, that was all over and she announced — in a phone call, mind — that she was off to Bermuda on a modelling job.

“Yeah.” He felt his shoulders locking. “I remember.”

“Well . . .” Diane swallowed hard and pressed her hand flat over the coffee mug. “Around that time she found out she was pregnant.”

His brain went into slip gear. “Why didn’t she say something? I didn’t know . . .” He started conjuring with the implications.

“No, she wanted to think about it and make her own decisions. As it turned out,” her knuckle whitened, “events ran their own course and she had a miscarriage. Early stages, that can happen.”

His mouth dried. “I’m so sorry.” The pieces fell horribly into place. How volatile she’d been about Ajit and Geena, and then, God help him, he’d insisted she go with him to Pickering. He pressed a hand to his mouth. They’d made her a godparent and he’d left her there with them, about to go into the delivery room. And she’d never said a word. “Christ, I’ve been such an idiot.”

“You hurt her badly, but you weren’t to know.” She drew a breath with difficulty. “The thing is, there were *complications* and now she may not be able . . .” Diane looked like a broken woman.

He smudged a finger against one eye. “What do I do?”

Diane seemed not to have heard him. “Maybe some good has come out of this.” She stared at her hands. “Miranda doesn’t want any more secrets; only she couldn’t face telling you. So now you know.”

“Okay.” He faltered. “I’ll talk to her tonight. I dunno; we’ll see a counsellor or something. I’ll find some way to make it up to her.”

She stared at him and reached out a hand. “You don’t get it — it wasn’t your baby.”

Everything moved into slow motion, like the time he’d been shot. He was aware of standing up and walking, but it wasn’t really him. Diane said something about staying, only the words rushed past him. It took all his concentration to put one foot in front of the other, get into the car and drive away. He had nowhere to go.

“Karl, are you busy?”

“Twice in one day — people will start to talk.” He cut the comedy routine when he got the measure of the situation. “I’ll meet you at Holloway Road Tube station. You’ve got your passport?”

* * *

What he felt was a heavy grief, about everything, now that the covers had come off. Miranda must have been seeing the footballer before they’d broken up, during her sex embargo. There was anger too — at the world —

especially people like Sir Peter Carroll and Jack Langton. Tonight he'd settle for targets and guns.

Karl chose Browning 9mm pistols. It had been a while since Thomas had faced down static targets but the body remembered. Muscles tensed and then settled in that curious way Karl had told him about. The ear defenders entombed him with his thoughts and he lined them up like targets to take them out one at a time. It was all he could cope with. By the time he reeled in his handiwork, the burden had lifted a little.

Karl waited until Thomas had emptied two full magazines and then signalled that their session was over. It wasn't quite therapy, but it came close. He set the pistol down and wondered: was this who he was now — the kind of man who needed a gun to feel in control of his own life?

"Do you, er, want to try some other equipment?" Karl carefully closed the lid on the Brownings.

He shrugged; he didn't know what he wanted, other than to not go home. Karl returned with a pair of SIG Sauers.

"I'll tell you this, Tommo, you've got an edge about you tonight. Whatever's bugging you, it's doing wonders for your hand-eye coordination."

"You have a fair idea what it's about."

"Let me just annihilate your score and then we'll get us a beverage."

It still amused him that a private shooting club offered drinks and snacks. He watched as Karl sauntered back to their table with the goodies, silently acknowledging persons unknown.

Thomas picked at his pastry. "Incidentally, what happened to Jack Langton's post that I lifted from Janey's?"

Karl's face pinched in. "Oh, right. It was mostly nonsense, apart from one interesting item. It's in code, so we've been busy having a crack at it."

"Oh?" He gave him his full attention, intrigued to hear there was something Karl and his cronies couldn't do. "Tell me more."

Karl's eyes seemed to glint. "It's a piece of brilliance — both simple and complicated — like a Vigenère code. It requires a key word; but we haven't figured it out yet. We've tried variations on names — wife, Jack himself, their kids, even Jacob. Basically, anything we could associate with him. No dice."

"What about 'scumbag'?"

Karl laughed, raising his coffee in a toast. “That was one of my first choices.”

Thomas swallowed. “Try ‘Sheryl.’”

Karl took out his mobile and made the call in front of him — that was a first. He spelt out Sheryl’s name and waited a minute or so, with the phone at his ear. Finally, Karl nodded and ended the call. “I’m impressed. Honest to God, Tommo, you ought to be in intelligence.” Karl was all smiles but he wasn’t laughing.

Disparate details were aligning in Thomas’s brain and a disturbing picture was emerging. “Let’s play a game.” He dug out a pen and paper. “I’m going to write three statements down. You don’t have to add anything, just tell me if I’m right. Deal?”

Karl nodded; he didn’t look happy about it. Thomas gave every sentence careful consideration, adding to Karl’s discomfort. He could see Karl reading the words from across the table.

1. Jack Langton is at the end of a Shadow State supply line.
2. The merchandise at Janey’s flat belongs to the Shadow State.
3. Both Jack and Charlie Stokes were already persons of interest to your people.

Karl took the list and re-read it. “I wouldn’t contradict any of your conclusions.” The façade slipped a little. “Look Thomas, you have to understand . . .”

He cut Karl off. “How could I do that without the information?”

* * *

Back at his flat, Thomas searched Vigenère ciphers on the Internet and gave himself a headache. He flicked on the TV to fill the void and fixed a microwave meal from the freezer. Hunched over the table and shovelling shepherd’s pie into his mouth, he replayed the events of a shitty day. Did anyone tell him the truth anymore?

‘Let him who is without sin cast the first stone . . .’ his mother used to say. He thought about the times he’d driven past Christine Gerrard’s flat once they’d split up, coincidentally around the same time Miranda returned

from Bermuda. Or that evening, working late with Christine, when a friendly drink nearly became something more.

Just after eleven pm he switched his mobile back on. There was a text waiting, all in caps: GEENA HAD A BOY. 8-3. SEND FLOWERS. AJIT & GEENA X.

He got in the car without a destination in mind. London seemed emptier because Miranda wasn't out there somewhere. About the only thing he knew was that he'd be keeping well clear of Christine's Hampstead flat. If Bob Peterson were there tonight, he'd be getting a free pass.

He couldn't deny himself a drive past Caliban's and, as he gave a sad salute to the neon sign, an idea struck him. Maybe Karl was doing his own surveillance on Janey and Greg tonight. The thought took hold, gnawing away, leading to only one conclusion. As he drove into Janey's housing estate he spotted someone weaving along the pavement, obviously pissed. Greg's idea of supporting Janey and their boy was by getting bladdered. No sign of her; she'd probably be at home waiting by the phone.

He pulled in and backtracked, twenty yards or so behind him. He figured the least he could do was make sure Greg made it home in one piece. The trouble was, other people had a different plan. At first it was just two shapes, up ahead, moving out of the shadows. Greg stopped, his carrier bag clinking as he stood there. It was only going to go one way and Thomas had to make a split second decision. He started running towards them.

Greg went down and by the time Thomas got there they were kicking seven bells out of him from opposite sides and yelling that he should have kept his trap shut. Greg was hardly moving — not a good sign.

Thomas ran into the first one at full pelt, knocking him flying. The second lad — they looked about early twenties — put up two fists and wanted to make a night of it. Whatever else they were, they weren't fighters. He sidestepped a half-hearted punch and returned the favour with interest. He felt his knuckles connect with a satisfying crack.

The lad may not have been a boxer but he knew how to take a punch; he recovered, charging back for a second wave. Thomas dodged a first punch that never came, unlike the second that winded him. He doubled over and pulled back, furious with himself for being fooled so easily.

The first one was up on his feet now and spoiling for revenge. Greg was no use whatsoever; Thomas saw him out the corner of his eye checking

his bag for damages.

“You’re gonna be sorry . . .” They advanced towards him.

He straightened and faced them down, crushing his fists in. *Not as sorry as you.* The would-be boxer was around five feet nine, giving Thomas a two inch height advantage and a better reach. The guy flinched back when he launched himself towards him, but the other one, bigger and broader, made a wide circle round.

Thomas turned and retreated to keep them both in his field of vision, forming an unholy triangle. That’s when he heard the unmistakeable *shikk* of a flick knife tasting the air. The shitty day had just got worse.

The boxer held out a hand to stay stab-boy, but things had gone too far. Thomas felt the inside of his mouth turn to sand. Chances were that they’d only cut him, as a warning. But warning or not he would make it his personal business to really fuck them up. He watched knife boy’s eyes, waiting for him to make the first move, having already decided on a throat punch or a kick in the bollocks.

A bottle smashed somewhere behind him and, to his immense relief, Karl McNeill came forward.

“Put it down, son or you might hurt someone.”

Knife boy didn’t look convinced although he edged back a little, still sizing up his chances. “This is nothing to do with you.”

“I’m making it my business.” Karl waved the broken bottle back and forth.

Thomas turned back to the boxer, surprised — and a teensy bit impressed — that he hadn’t run off. One look in those eyes told him that they were both packing some sort of weapon.

“He said put it down.”

They all turned to see Ann Crossley, facing them, arms extended with a pistol at the end. Knife boy dropped his weapon as if it was molten and started walking away. His accomplice followed suit. Karl was quick to pick up the knife but he didn’t try to stop them.

“I’ll leave you boys to have a chat — I’ll be in the car.” Ann holstered her weapon and zipped up her jacket, cucumber cool.

Thomas stared at Karl, aware that his mouth was open.

“What just happened here?”

“Come on, Tommo, we better get him home. We’ll talk about this another time.”

Chapter 20

He stared at the alarm in disbelief — six fifteen — and made the best of it by dragging his weary arse out of bed to order flowers online for the new Mummy and Daddy. He skipped breakfast and was out the door before seven, beating the rush into the capital. Too restless to take photographs, he walked around St Paul's Cathedral and gave a fiver to a beggar to make himself feel better.

Karl arrived for the pick-up at eight fifteen, in high spirits judging by his whistling. Paulette Villers was first on the day's Benefits' hit list and Karl opted for their previous vantage point. Thomas was determined not to mention the previous night.

He blew across the camera buttons for dust, paused, and then removed the lens cap. "What's put you in such a good mood?"

"Irony and information. Guess who manufactures the SSU's ID cards now?"

He shrugged; he couldn't give a shit. Doubtless, Karl would regale him with a tale of corporate conspiracy if he waited long enough.

"Give up?" Karl lasted ten seconds. "Engamel, that's who!"

Thomas sneered at the news.

"Yeah." Karl huffed a breath and folded his arms. "I thought that'd give you something to think about."

Engamel — manufacturers of the Urban Ballistics UB40, also known as The Scavenger. The weapon a woman had died for needlessly, a few months back — when, for once, Sir Peter Carroll had done the honourable thing and stood up to the Euro-Cartel.

Thomas bit at a thumbnail, cradling his camera with his other hand. "Anything more from your army mate, Ken?" He waited for an update, which never came.

When Paulette Villers arrived with her partner, she was limping. Karl picked up his camera.

"See." Karl pressed into the eyepiece. "That's what I don't get about domestics. The other lass gives her a beating and then helps her into work — her *illegal* work. The mind boggles."

They captured the footage, mapping every step and glance. Thomas focused on Paulette's companion. Once the target had entered the building, the other woman waited a few seconds, flapping her arms against her coat to stay warm. His camera picked out her anxiety and the uneven stance.

Thomas lowered his lens. "Listen, do you fancy doing a sandwich and coffee run? I didn't have breakfast and I'm famished."

Karl held out his hand for cash. "I'll give it back to you later, scouts' honour."

He watched him leave and returned to his vigil. Something didn't sit right; that familiar tension was creeping over him, subtle as seduction — instinct. Paulette's other half was still there, checking both directions from the corner. Paulette Villers rushed back out of the laundry, grabbed the woman's arm and they cautiously made their way up the side street.

He was out of the car before he really registered what he was doing. There was no plan; only a sense that something was wrong and he might be able to help. But even that was an afterthought.

"Paulette, wait . . ." He was only a few paces behind them now.

Both women turned and then pulled closer together, shuffling up the street like wounded animals.

"Look, I wanna help." He stopped moving.

"Leave us alone. He'll see you and then we'll all be in trouble."

He? That threw him. "I'll be here on Monday, early — if you want to talk." He didn't wait for an answer. A silver Saab cut into the side street. He sized up the driver effortlessly; well-built with cropped, greying hair — a geezer who'd use an old-fashioned gym and wouldn't be seen dead in a leisure centre. A mastiff of a man; the sort of bloke you didn't fuck with.

Thomas turned his head away slowly, so that he could get a look at the number plate sideways on — one for Karl to check out later. He told himself it was probably nothing, until the Saab stopped in the road. He crossed over to get a better look and saw the two women, now parallel with the car, slowly get inside.

Karl was waiting by Thomas's locked car, without breakfast. "There was a queue at the café, so I didn't bother." He didn't speak again until they were moving. "I'm waiting, Tommo. This had better be good."

Thomas passed over the number plate and assembled his thoughts aloud. "I know it's a stretch, but I've been right about stuff in the past,

haven't I? You set the ball rolling with your comment about 'domestics' and when Paulette left the laundry and they both started walking . . ."

Karl closed his eyes, as if asking for intercession. "Where is this going?"

"If you can check out the Saab's owner."

Karl smiled, cat-like. "You used to do that kind of thing privately."

"Yeah, well, I think you proved conclusively last night that we're a team. And besides, your contacts will be quicker."

Karl made the call at their next observation session. By the time a Nigerian family — based on the clothing and the notes — exited number 43 and locked the front door behind them, proving fairly conclusively that Mr Liang was subletting, he had his reply.

"Well, well," Karl lowered his mobile. "Looks like you were on to something. You had a close encounter with Mr Charlie Stokes."

That was two hits on the radar; it was definitely time to speak with Jack Langton again.

* * *

Ninety per cent of surveillance was sitting around waiting for something to happen, but it wasn't the worst part of the job. Every assignment demanded some interaction with their hosts and that could only mean one thing: meetings.

The review was scheduled for three thirty — a crap time by anyone's estimation. Karl checked through the paperwork en route. They agreed a 'no questions' pact to get out by four-thirty, so they could visit the SSU office at Liverpool Street.

Karl must have been working a night shift again; he'd taken dressing down to new depths and could have passed for a benefit claimant himself, like the one they'd just followed to a doctor's surgery. Despite that, Karl was relentlessly upbeat.

"Don't you get a thrill from it? With each assignment we become someone else."

Thomas shrugged. "Same shit, different department."

Undeterred, Karl hummed a *Disney* tune on their way through the turnstile. Second floor, sharp left, and along the corridor to the glass-walled meeting room. Welcome to the goldfish bowl.

Not the last in, but close. Someone muttered, “Floaters,” as they took their seats. Karl retaliated by coughing, “Wankers.” At three thirty on the dot Dawn Yeates rose from her chair and hushed everyone. As she turned towards the whiteboard, the beads in her hair clattered together.

“Let’s make a start. Karl?” She looked over her shoulder and smiled. “Perhaps you’d like to kick off?”

Thomas glanced at Karl, who was smiling back. Was this some kind of magic moment? He gave a succinct progress update, highlighting their successes and the gaps. This was Benefits Investigation Karl, who spoke the language of the locals — *claimants*, *suspected* and *benefits*, *recipients*. Thomas sat back to enjoy the show.

Dawn Yeates lapped it up, showering him with praise and suggesting tactics. Karl took notes. After that, feedback Friday went round the table like a Mexican wave. Some of them sounded like big game hunters reflecting on their kills, while one pair — clearly ex-coppers, lamented that they no longer had the power of arrest.

The latecomers put in an appearance close to the end — another SSU team, based over in West London. Thomas had never really spoken with them; he only knew them by their surnames — Malone and Iqbal. They sounded like injury lawyers. Malone always seemed buttoned-up, her skirts safely below the knee, while Iqbal’s smart suit belied his position. Thomas suspected that he’d been assigned on the grounds of ethnicity and language skills. Or maybe the pair of them weren’t in favour with the SSU.

He waited outside for Karl to finish his schmoozing. The good folk of the BIT passed him without a word. Even their West London SSU cousins only managed a murmur of courtesy. Karl emerged with a folded piece of paper in his hand.

“Right. Time to visit our real family!”

Chapter 21

By the time they reached the Liverpool Street building it was well after five. Naturally, Christine and Ann were still working.

Karl nudged Thomas. "It's like a double-date."

Christine ventured out from her office. "Thomas, could you spare a minute?"

She reached behind her desk and lifted an A5 envelope from a pile of papers. He received it without comment and slid out the contents.

"Standard visual surveillance," she explained. "Where he goes and who he speaks with."

He stared at the photograph, waiting for her to state the obvious. Bob Peterson — the married Bob Peterson, her ex, now banished back to Southampton.

"What am I looking for?"

"I'm not sure."

He didn't bother asking if this was on the books, given that Bob Peterson had been the boss for a brief period.

"I'd like to end your assignment with the Benefits Investigation Team."

The deal with Sir Peter was that he and Karl always worked together. "And Karl?"

"It's up to you. As long as you report back to me — and me alone — you can run it however you like."

He could almost feel Karl drumming his fingers at his desk. "When?"

"With immediate effect, unless you have any objections?"

Three or four. He decided to stall her. "I'd prefer to stay put for the next couple of weeks . . ."

"Oh?"

Now for the tricky part — eyes down and keep the voice low. "Miranda and I are having problems . . ." That at least was true.

She tapped her fingertips — corporate empathy. "Try not to let it interfere with work. I take it this means you'll be visiting the prison again?"

He smiled a little; now for the last minute save. "I don't mind working weekends if you think the target warrants it."

It was her turn under the microscope. She didn't stay there long.

"Weekends will be fine." She nodded. "We'll talk again – Karl's waiting for you."

Karl was busy at his laptop as Thomas emerged, and immediately started packing up. "Fancy a wee drink?"

* * *

The Swan was good and local; shandy and crisps, and the luxury of seats facing the doors. He'd noticed that Karl preferred his back to the wall when there were crowds. They sat for a while and watched the show — the city boys and girls, out to impress; the office workers trying to shrug off the day's drudgery; and even — God love 'em — a couple of MI5 blokes from their building, almost blending in. He nudged Karl and they raised their glasses to the second cousins from the first floor.

Karl chose his moment carefully. "Have you spoken to Miranda since you left Yorkshire?"

He shot him a leaden glance.

"Understood." Karl lifted his hands away from the force field. "Only I've got the weekend off, if you're at a loose end . . ."

"Actually, I've got a job lined up."

"Not another wedding shoot?"

He pretended to enjoy the joke. "Something like that."

* * *

Friday night was the worst; rattling around in the flat with his mobile burning a hole in his pocket. Twice he thought about ringing Miranda; he'd revisited their last car-crash conversation in his head until his cheeks burned. Pat had given up leaving messages and Ajit and Geena were now knee-deep in nappies. And anyway, he was probably still in the doghouse.

The doorbell rang; a flick of the curtain confirmed the welcome visitor.

"Alright, boss? Chicken Jalfrezi, pilau rice and a Peshwari naan."

He carried the booty into the kitchen, laying everything out on a plastic tablecloth. Already in the hallway were a camera and a road atlas ready for the early morning jaunt to Southampton.

Christine had struggled to fill a page. Bob Peterson's home address, the SSU office there, his children's school, and the charity Mrs Peterson had last worked for. The handwritten notes also detailed locations of the nearest

supermarkets and the number plates of both the Petersons' cars. All in all, it looked very much like a private inquiry.

Chapter 22

It was no great hardship being on the road at six thirty a.m. He enjoyed his own company — something the moors had taught him. Just as well because Miranda and he were on opposite sides of a crevasse. The Reichenbach Falls had nothing on this *final problem*. He gazed at the pale horizon and wondered how to draw a line under the past when it still cast a shadow over the present.

By eight thirty the weekend traffic around Southampton was chock-a-block. Erring on the side of caution, he had parked up in good time at the end of the street. Bob Peterson was only five minutes out from Christine's schedule; she'd certainly done her research. Bob did the whole family bit — waving and smiling to the wife and kids before he pulled the 4x4 off the drive and went a-hunting.

Thomas stayed well back, trailing Peterson to the supermarket. The 4x4 slotted into a space but Thomas still kept his distance, waiting until Bob had been inside the supermarket for a good five minutes before he nipped over to the petrol station for some snacks and a piss. On his way back across the tarmac, he stopped to tie his shoelaces and slipped a shop-bought transmitter out of his pocket, attaching it under the rear wheel arch. The handheld locator read Uncle Bob's stationary position loud and clear; he was all set.

Thirty minutes later the target emerged with enough food to last a nuclear winter. Thomas let the camera tell its own story, as Bob Peterson carefully stacked plastic containers in the 4x4. What had Christine ever seen in a dick like that?

He trailed him home, letting him off the leash more now that he had the tracker in place. As Thomas arrived, Bob was carrying the last of the containers inside. He stared at the house, unclear what he was looking for, when Bob was suddenly back on the road. Only this time, he wasn't hanging about.

First stop was a nondescript SSU building. Not hard to spot though, when you knew the signs — like the grilled car park and the reflective film

on the office windows. Peterson was only there ten minutes; his next port of call was a multi-storey car park.

Thomas gambled on covering the front exit and decided he'd give him twenty minutes before checking out the shopping centre on foot. The radio offered up a discussion panel show with the topic: do we have a culture of snooping? Concerned citizens phoned in to trade certainties and insecurities, pooling their outrage at future plans to fit microchips in wheelie bins. The second course covered supermarket loyalty cards and what data they might hold. It passed a pleasant quarter of an hour without putting a scratch on the Regulation of Investigatory Powers Act 2000.

A quick jaunt on foot through the multi-storey yielded nothing. He checked his own parking bay, did a quick tally up of how much time he had left, and went walkabout again. Mixing with the shoppers was the closest he'd got to normality since he ran from Yorkshire. He watched them with a cold eye, moving among the couples and families in search of his quarry.

He kept the handheld screen at his side, glancing at it every twenty paces, not that he could do anything now if Bob started driving. It all seemed like a bastard waste of time, unless he wanted a great deal on a new phone or to chat with one of the honeys trying to extort money for charity.

And then, like a gift from God, there was Bob — sitting in a café with a woman. He could only see the profile, but she didn't look like wifey, and in any case Bob had left the missus at home.

He walked on, checked there was no one following him and regrouped his thoughts. Christine wanted photographic evidence but would she really want *this*? Sod it: the job was the job. He slipped an Olympus mu-10 out of his coat and did a practice run, further along the precinct; walking past a shop with his camera nonchalantly by his arm, tilted to the shop front. It wasn't his finest work on playback, but it was better than nothing. He set off slowly to avoid jogging the phone around.

It was a punt, a fly-by, and he didn't dare turn his head until he was clear of the row of shops. The footage was far from perfect — at best he figured on pulling off a couple of decent images. A shame about the fat bastard who'd cut across his line of vision, but that's *Joe Public* for you. Bob would be at least a few minutes behind him — probably with his mystery woman — which gave him time to get into position.

Peterson's car was on the fourth floor, tucked away in a corner. And naturally the nearest lift was out of order. With the blood still pounding in his head, Thomas checked the tracker was securely in place and looked around for a vantage point. He wanted to get a clear shot of the woman too, not that he expected Christine to like it. He took pleasure from that without knowing why.

Ten more minutes and he'd be risking a parking fine. *Come on, Bob. Shift your arse.* The surveillance mantra must have worked its magic because Bob Peterson arrived a couple of minutes later. The woman held back by the stairs, still in the shadows — smart. Maybe she was too smart. He did the best he could without a flash and, seeing as Bob was setting off solo, he legged it back to his own car to try and beat the parking rap.

Back at the car he turned his mobile on, expecting Christine to have texted for an update. There was a message, but not from her: *Can we talk? Mx.* The familiar dilemma: work or Miranda. He moved the car, fleeing the city centre to find a quieter backstreet without permit parking. The phone stared back at him, awaiting his decision. A text would have sufficed, but she deserved better than that.

She picked up on the third ring. "Hello, Thomas."

After the killer opening line — "How are you?" — he stalled.

"Are you free for lunch?" She sounded edgy or tired — he couldn't tell which.

He took a deep breath. "I can't; I'm working."

"Oh, I see."

"But I'm free later," he winced at his own enthusiasm.

"Ring me later then and I'll see what I'm doing. Take care, Thomas."

Her voice was hollow. He was about to ring back and renegotiate the terms of the truce when the handheld caught his eye. Bob Peterson was on the move, out of the city.

A quick flip through a street guide and he'd worked out a reasonable intercept point, assuming Peterson kept to the same course. Any thoughts of Miranda were put back in their box; there was a job to do.

The tracker signal died without warning. He ran through the probabilities. Peterson could have discovered it or the bloody thing might have fallen off somewhere. It had happened to him once before on a job.

Whatever the cause, he was buggered. Might as well head for home and try again on Sunday. Not much for a morning's work — not good at all.

A couple of miles up the motorway he spotted the blue lights behind him, cutting a swathe through the traffic. He slowed again, out of habit. The chequered car drew alongside him and signalled for him to pull over. He played it cool and glided to the hard shoulder, pushing the tracker screen under his passenger seat when he came to a halt.

The über-cool patrol car nestled in behind him. He was no petrol head but this was a car to die for. Miranda's brothers would have been wetting themselves. He kept to the drill and waited for the knock on the window, clocking the two coppers behind him as they talked among themselves for a minute or so.

He felt for his Surveillance Support Unit ID in his jacket and then checked his phone was turned off. The passenger door of the police car squeaked open and a burly figure loomed towards him.

"Do you know why I've stopped you, sir?"

Stopped him? By the way they bombed up the motorway they were hunting for him. He shook his head and smiled, playing innocent. The conversation reminded him of a fly-on-the-wall documentary — the sort of thing Karl loved. It was the standard checklist: driving licence — clean (and nigh on immaculate), road tax, insurance and MOT all up to date. Burly cop seemed perplexed.

"There's a marker on our system against this vehicle . . ."

Now he flashed his SSU card. Less a loyalty card and more of a 'see, we're on the same side' card. It made sod-all difference. Burly cop gave it a cursory glance.

"What sort of marker?" He stared at the copper's buttons, wondering how you tell real ones from fake.

"Can I have your keys, sir? It won't take long."

The cop went back to sit with his chum. Maybe he could ring Ajit for some advice? Then again, he was hardly flavour of the month there.

Judging by the rear view mirror, the traffic cops were having a conversation with no winners. He imagined they were listening to a third party feeding them instructions by radio. Finally, the driver took her turn, jangling his keys in her hand as she walked over.

"Can you follow us down to the nearest services?"

It was a question with only one answer.

As they entered the services, nose to tail, he noticed the faces of other drivers — the freaked out, the intrigued and a bloke in a van who gave him two thumbs-up. He parked beside supercar and heard the numbers counting in his head, slow and steady. The police car became his sole focus.

He wound down his window and looked across, smiling. A parallel pane descended.

“If you could wait here.” The window rose back.

He put on the radio, dropped the numbers routine and thought about the marker on his car. Perhaps Karl could look into that. The sight of a 4x4 approaching with a number plate he recognised dispelled any further questions. Bob Peterson was the guest of honour. It was tough to know what was worse, being caught out — and by Peterson of all people — or the realisation that his target had played him brilliantly. He could hardly lamp Peterson in public with two coppers present.

Bob Peterson nodded to the police officers, stopped his vehicle so that it blocked Thomas’s car and took his time getting out. Then he reached behind the driver’s seat to retrieve a package. He left his driver’s door wide open and motioned to Thomas to join him.

Peterson waited for Thomas to draw level with him. “Two things — one, this is the package Christine is expecting; and two, leave Christine alone.”

Thomas took the package and circled back to his car without a word. Peterson had sounded stone cold serious, which suggested he might have a reason for behaving like a possessive arsehole.

“I mean it, Thomas,” Peterson called behind him. “I’m always three steps ahead of you.”

Like he couldn’t have been satisfied with two — dick. Back in his car, Thomas watched Peterson pull out his phone, make a quick call and then walk briskly back to his 4x4. He made a two-fingered matey salute to the cops and then drove off.

Thomas turned to the cops, who looked as bemused as he felt. He got out again and stood by the police car.

“Am I entitled to know what the marker is on my car?”

The driver deferred to her colleague.

“Must be a glitch — the database probably needs updating. All I can tell you is that your vehicle is flagged ‘of interest’ if seen in the Southampton area. Sorry about that.”

“I’m here on an assignment.” He showed them his ID card again. “So being stopped makes it difficult to do my job.”

“I’ll pass it up the line,” the driver promised half-heartedly.

He called it quits and decided to grab a coffee in Motorway Services Shangri La. They were gone when he came out, but they’d left a contact card under his wiper blade. He couldn’t work out whether it was a warning or if he’d made a friend.

Chapter 23

The London bound traffic was as sluggish as his thinking. Nothing made any sense. He had no idea who Bob Peterson was with, or why Christine cared. Then there was Peterson warning him off from Christine. And lastly, what was so important about the package in the boot? He toyed with the idea of ringing Christine, so he could deliver the package, and then thought better of it. Whatever it was could wait.

Miranda hadn't rung him back so his first call was to the answering machine at home. Geena had got there first.

"You're forgiven for being a dickhead. Now, go make your peace with Miranda — if she'll let you. You really hurt her, you know."

Yeah, he knew. He dialled Miranda's mobile; judging by the background noise she was at Caliban's.

"Hiya, it's me. I just got back from . . . work."

"Do you fancy a bite?"

There wasn't a hint of innuendo and he missed it.

"I'll come over now if that's okay?" He waited to hear whether the thin ice would bear his weight.

"Yeah, okay."

It was a short drive over from his phone stop. He thought about picking up chocolates, but nothing quite said 'sorry for abandoning you in your worst nightmare.' He decided to pay for lunch instead.

Caliban's felt like enemy territory as he threaded his way through the jungle of people to the bar. Sheryl, Miranda's manager and confidante, was the greeting party.

"You made it then." She'd clearly cancelled her fan club membership. "Look after her, Thomas — she's been through a lot."

"I know," he muttered, already on the defensive.

"No," she shook her head, "you don't. But I do. I was there in Bermuda when it happened. She stayed with me afterwards."

He went upstairs and knocked on the office door.

"It's open." Her voice wavered.

He saw the picnic she'd set up on the desk and wished he'd brought chocolates or flowers. The plastic gingham tablecloth was a nice touch.

"I thought you might prefer somewhere private." She gave a tiny smile and swept her hand towards the empty seat.

But there was a third, unwelcome guest: the past. They met as opposing armies, advancing and retreating sporadically. Until, finally, all the effort to *not* say something drowned out the conversation.

"So where are we?" He broached another silence.

"You know where we are."

He gazed in all directions, like a hapless tourist, eliciting a smile. It lasted until his mobile started buzzing. She shot him a killer look of disappointment and shrugged. He checked the number, purposefully setting his mobile on the edge of the desk. Typical — it was Christine.

"No, really," she insisted. "Take the call. I mean it."

"Hello?" He looked away.

"Thomas? It's Christine. I need to see you."

"Can it wait?"

"Would you drop by the office, say in about an hour?"

His eyes drifted across to Miranda, weighing up the odds.

"Okay, I'll see you then."

All things considered, Miranda was pretty good about everything. She didn't fly off the handle; she even backtracked a little, which caught him off guard.

"I'm not trying to change you. Well . . ." She smiled for a millisecond, "I've given up on that. Oh Christ, Tommy, have we made a mess of everything?"

It was his turn to smile now. "We're still talking — and lunching."

She offered more wine, but he waved away the bottle.

"Better not; I've got some work to take care of."

"For Jack Langton?"

"No, I've got some work stuff to deliver for Christine — from this morning."

"Without Karl?" Now she was fishing with depth charges.

"Yeah, just me this time."

"You watch your back. While you're busy trying to save the world, who's looking out for Thomas?"

“Well, you — I hope!”

Her face reassured him he’d come up with the right answer. She reached across and forced the rim of the cork into the wine bottle.

“Hadn’t you better get going? Duty calls and all that.”

“I’ve a few minutes yet.” And he gazed at her earnestly.

By the time he got into his car the landscape had shifted. They hadn’t shagged; they hadn’t even kissed — not properly, but there had definitely been electricity in the room. That, and hope.

* * *

The Liverpool Street underground car park was practically deserted. All the high performance cars were nestled in an area designated for the Security Service — his MI5 neighbours on the first floor. Nearby was one space, hardly ever claimed, for M16 that read: *Secret Intelligence Service*. Karl had taken a picture once. Christine’s Merc looked lonely so he parked next to it.

His trusty rucksack held the spoils of the day — camera, mobile phone footage and Bob Peterson’s package. He could hear it rattling a little as he walked and felt the box inside nudging against his back.

He took the stairs two at a time, letting his steps act like a metronome to his thoughts. On the second floor, the office was eerily quiet. Karl’s desk looked bereft without him, despite the mess he’d left behind. Out of habit, Thomas scooped up the vending machine cups and chocolate wrappers, dumping them in the bin. A notepad page lay next to the keyboard with GVA and a set of numbers next to it.

He took his time getting to Christine’s office, weighed down by the sinking feeling that he’d just been paid overtime to do some domestic gumshoeing.

“Thanks for coming, Thomas.” She didn’t look up from her laptop.

“I was stopped by the police — something about a database marker?”

She swallowed. “I don’t think Bob has ever forgiven you for . . . the altercation.”

A smile stretched his face when he recalled landing a couple of punches on Bob Peterson — both beauties — back when the inner workings of the SSU were still a mystery. Well, *more* of a mystery. So Bob still held a grudge — good.

“Anyway . . .” He brought his rucksack forward and noted the sparkle in her eyes. “Bob turned up and gave me this for you.”

Now she stirred, one eye on his hand as it reached into the rucksack.

“Would you like my report now?”

He moved around the desk so they could both see the screen, and connected up his camera.

“Wife and kids.” He provided the narrative and watched her reactions.

“I can see what you’re doing,” she insisted.

It didn’t deter him. “Big shop at the supermarket — going in and coming out.”

“What about inside?”

He hadn’t thought about that. “Too much risk of exposure,” he lied. “It would help if I knew what I’m looking for.”

“You’re a surveillance officer,” she snapped. “I don’t pay you to ask questions.”

Touchy. He changed tack and told her about the vehicle tracker on Peterson’s car and how the signal had died.

“I think he was expecting me. Maybe the police tipped him off before they stopped me.” He waited for another dressing down but it didn’t come.

Christine turned her attention back to the screen.

“I went looking for him in the shopping centre, near where he parked.” He noticed she was barely breathing now. “I found him in a café . . . with a woman.”

“Oh?” She coughed a little.

“Yeah, I had to improvise. The quality’s not great. Do you want to see it?”

“Can you upload it to my laptop?”

“Sure.” He reached into his rucksack for the cable.

They watched the camera connect to the computer and he looked away as she authorised the security override. The film was amateurish, barely in focus for the café window and hampered by some passers-by with remarkably large heads. The woman’s face was obscured but not the profile. He looked at Christine again and figured it out.

“Do you want to tell me what’s going on?”

Her silence told him plenty. She’d needed someone to film her there with Peterson — maybe it was emotional blackmail, or something to send

to his wife. The dots connected a circuit and a light bulb came on. She was still involved with Bob Peterson, or wanted to be.

“Oh, Chrissie.” He heard the ragged edge to his voice.

“I don’t need you to fight my battles or to save me from myself.”

No, he thought, only to do your dirty work.

“So Bob has no idea?” He sighed; of course he bloody didn’t. “And you’ve done what . . . told him that I’m the jealous ex, following you around?”

“It wouldn’t be the first time.”

Disappointment decayed to pity. “I’m *concerned* for you, is what I am.”

“Save your breath, I’m a big girl now and I can look after myself.”

He pulled the camera lead free. “I’ll get prints to you. Is that it now?”

“No. I want the surveillance job in Southampton completed.”

He wondered if she were simply playing Bob Peterson for information. That somehow this was legitimate surveillance on an authorised target. But something in her eyes, some trace of the obstinacy he remembered from their own ill-fated relationship, assured him this was also personal.

“Okay then, you’re the boss.”

Her lips drew tight, as if to remind him that was never in any doubt. The package stayed on the desk, unopened. “Thank you, Thomas.” She opened her office door and stood aside so he could leave.

Chapter 24

Back home, having shrugged the chip from his shoulder, he researched GVA on his laptop. Karl didn't usually leave notes on his desk, however badly scrawled. The search took less than three minutes, allowing time for the kettle to boil. GVA was the airport code for Geneva. As was the norm with Karl, a new piece of information only created more questions. Still, lucky sod — it was a better gig than *spot the boyfriend* in Southampton.

While he was busy pondering a choice of takeaways the phone rang.

"It's John. Natalie Langton wants to discuss the missing half kilo with you."

"When?" His finger strayed across the menu to Jalfrezi.

"Tonight. Watch your back, Thomas. Jack Langton may be the one pulling the strings, but take it from me — his wife is an expert at pushing people's buttons."

* * *

He dressed up for the appointment and put himself on best behaviour. Logically, he had nothing to fear; all he'd done was deliver the case. Even so, his guts were churning on the drive over.

Ray's car — the one Natalie had got into with the case — was nowhere to be seen. He was glad of that, until he rang the doorbell and she appeared in a low-cut number.

"Come in — Thomas, wasn't it?"

He faked a smile; she knew damn well. She made it through to the kitchen before he'd had a chance to close the front door.

"What can I get you?" Her voice echoed along the passageway, a little on the shrill side now he thought about it.

"Nothing for me, thanks — I'm driving." He felt like adding, 'and you're married,' but he let it pass.

She returned from the kitchen, hips swaying, and pointed him through to the lounge. A massive white leather three-piece filled the room, which was quite an achievement. A flick of a switch and *Sade* poured from the speakers, sweet as honey.

“So, Thomas.” She moved the glass away from her face. “How much do you know about Jack’s business?” Her lips parted to receive his answer.

“Me? Nothing. I’m just helping him out — a favour for a mutual friend.” He didn’t elaborate about John Wright; he was more interested in what she wanted him to know. People always wanted you to know *something*, especially if they were selling a lie.

“A smart man like you — aren’t you just a little bit curious?”

“Killed the cat.” He smiled again, forcing it up into his eyes.

She looked like she was waiting for more, so he moved the Bladen charm up a notch as she sipped her drink.

“I can see Jack likes the finer things in life.” He paused, waiting for that coy smile to dance across her face.

“Look.” She leaned towards the edge of the sofa. “The missing half kilo is making problems for everyone.”

He nodded. “I can imagine. What do you want me to do?” Simple and direct; he reckoned she’d appreciate that.

She swung her legs up and stretched out. “It’d be best for everyone if we had a full case again. I’ll pay out for it if I have to but I’d rather not, and I don’t care how you get it — do you understand?”

“I think so.” His stomach flipped again. Oh bollocks, this was all heading in the wrong direction. Best to play the part all the way to the curtain. “What’s in it for me?”

She didn’t miss a beat. “My gratitude. You’ll find I can be very grateful.”

He blinked a couple of times as she faced him with a warm smile and cold eyes. Maybe Jack Langton was safer in prison.

She smoothed her top needlessly; from where he sat there were no imperfections. “Just get the half kilo back before word gets around and I’ll make it worth your while. I wouldn’t want anyone thinking they can take advantage,” she rearranged her window display again, “just because Jack’s inside.”

He was out the door in less than twenty minutes. *Sade* was still waxing soulful and somewhere, he surmised, Ray Daniels was eyeing up Jack’s throne — among other things.

Karl telephoned at close to midnight.

“Any chance of a Sunday meet up?”

“Could be tricky.” He wiped an eye with the heel of one hand. “I’ve, er, got a job on tomorrow.” He took the plunge. “Surveillance on Bob Peterson in Southampton. You remember Bob?”

“Does Christine think he’s still active for *them*?”

Karl never named his enemy. Thomas had heard him call it a cartel, a Shadow State and even Shadow Europe, but there was never a clear definition. Smoke and mirrors every time.

Another pause so Thomas went for broke. “Are you in?”

“Of course I’m bloody well in. We’re partners, aren’t we?” There was a warmth to his voice now.

“Okay then, partner, where have you been in the last twenty-four hours?”

“Geneva, as you probably worked out. I realise it can’t compare with the glamour of Southampton, but someone had to make that sacrifice. Anyhow, call me when you’re leaving tomorrow and pick me up.”

* * *

Thomas had the dream again — the one where he caught Christine Gerrard and Bob Peterson together at a hotel. The one where he lamped Peterson and kept on pummelling him until he was a crimson pulp. Only this time Karl was there too, taking photographs.

Chapter 25

He woke exhausted; nightmares always wore him out. There was nothing easy about this Sunday morning.

Karl passed him a bag when he got into the car.

“I picked up something on my travels — I sampled it for quality purposes.”

He peered inside: handmade chocolates. “Thanks; I didn’t know you cared.”

“I don’t — they’re for Miranda. I thought you could use all the help you can get.”

He didn’t dignify that with a response. Instead, he gave Karl the low down on the Peterson job and shared his speculations.

“Okay, Tommo, I can understand her wanting to force Peterson’s hand — what the heart wants, and all that. But he’s connected to the cartel, albeit at the bottom of the food chain, so there has to be more to it.”

“Then you’re saying Christine is somehow working him?”

“I’m not saying that — you are.”

It would have been smarter to use Karl’s car, but he wanted to see whether the police stop in Southampton was a one-off. He had half a mind to ring the number on the card left under his wipers, to see what happened.

Sunday in the Peterson household was hardly a web of intrigue. The whole family went for a swim, while Thomas dissuaded Karl from a little housebreaking. Later, the Petersons trundled off to a burger bar — the posh kind — while Daddy read the paper and Mummy kept the children entertained with drawing pads. Through a long lens it all seemed like domesticity, but Karl wasn’t buying it.

“Christine must know *something*, or at least suspect.”

Thomas thought about the padded envelope she hadn’t opened in front of him.

“Could we find out what Bob and his teams are working on?”

Karl frowned. “I prefer not to spy on other SSU teams. It’s like professional incest.”

He nodded, noting that *prefer not to* wasn’t the same as saying *no*.

* * *

After the burger bar the Peterson family went straight home. Thomas figured there was only so much fun a family could take. He suggested they give it another thirty minutes, no more, and sure enough Bob Peterson was out in twenty-five. They tracked him back to the Southampton SSU office, where he disappeared into the rabbit hole and kept them waiting.

Thomas nudged Karl, who was practising surveillance on a pigeon.

“What do you think Christine suspects . . ?” He was dropping a pebble for ripples.

Karl lowered his telescope made from a copy of *Private Eye*. “I think she suspects he’s up to something.” That was all he said.

Thomas reached for Radio 2 — something soothing that didn’t require any concentration. As he settled in to enjoy *The Drifters*, the metal gate beside the front entrance started rolling up.

“Pool car.” He started his engine.

Peterson emerged from the underground car park in a silver Ford Focus.

“We should call it in to the boss.” Karl was already reaching for his mobile.

Thomas nodded — what harm could it do? By the sound of things Christine was keen to continue the information gathering. He gestured to Karl to up the volume and asked the crucial question: “What’s our primary objective?”

Christine was unequivocal.

“I want to know exactly what he does and who he talks to — understood?”

“Ma’am.” Karl ended the call. “Methinks Peterson is out of favour.”

He clocked the sign for Southampton Docks. “I’m pulling over.”

Karl was unperturbed. “It’s your call.”

They watched Peterson disappearing into the distance. Three steps ahead . . . Peterson knew to take a different car and he knew Thomas’s number plate. He’d be going to the docks — Thomas was sure of it.

“How about the wife? While we’re tracking Uncle Bob, she could be anywhere.”

“Nah.” Karl rooted around in the glove compartment for food. “I’ve already checked her out and she’s clean. Besides, where would she stash the kids?”

This called for some lateral thinking, which he did in silence. He grabbed his mobile, ignored Karl and rang Christine with the pool car’s number plate. Peterson’s pool car was easily located when they got down there, thanks to Christine, but the great man himself was nowhere to be seen. No problem, Thomas already had a plan.

“We get him paged.”

Karl was all ears. “I like it — some kind of emergency. We need him somewhere we can see him along with anyone who’s with him.”

“Yeah, well, as long as we’re not worrying the guy about his wife and kids.”

“Ah, Tommo, you’re all heart. Leave it to me.” Karl climbed out of his sweatshirt, wrapped it around his fist, and then got out of the car. “This’ll do nicely.” He picked something up and went across to Peterson’s car. Without another word he cracked it down hard on the windscreen, chipping it in the centre. Then he knelt down to see to two of the tyres before getting back in the car.

“What?” Karl lifted his hands in exasperation, the sweatshirt smeared in brick dust hanging off his arm. “That ought to do it. Now we just get Christine to page him.”

“Are you taking the piss? We could have paged him ourselves.”

“Yeah,” Karl smirked, “but now . . .”

Thomas caught Karl’s logic train. “Now he can’t drive it away, so either someone comes to collect him or someone has to give him a lift.”

“Spot on. So let’s split up and find out who his date is.”

Thomas found a sheltered spot in the Mayflower terminal and rang Christine. A few minutes later, Bob Peterson’s name hit the tannoy.

“Surely he’ll know it’s a set-up?” Thomas muttered into his mobile.

“Possibly, but he won’t ignore the call.” Karl’s voice crackled and whinnied outside in the car park.

“And you can’t be seen?”

“I have done this before Tommo, once or twice.”

“Yeah, but this is against one of our own.”

Five minutes on, and with no sign of Bob Peterson, Thomas was getting restless. Maybe Peterson had figured it out and gone straight to his car; he could be surveying the damage and updating the police national computer database.

He was about to make another call to Karl when Bob Peterson arrived at the helpdesk. He looked relaxed, even when the man behind the desk relayed the bad news. A woman appeared beside him, standing close, as if they were a couple. Maybe they were. Busy, busy Bob.

And speaking of bobs, the blonde had her hair styled in a bob cut. As she turned to look behind her he realised he knew her. The hair was different now and she wasn't in uniform, like the time he'd met her in Leeds. He felt as if someone had wrapped a thick blanket around his shoulders, closing him down. He circled the pillar to find a spot behind a plant tub, taking pictures on his phone. He didn't hang about, fleeing to the nearest gents so he could check the pictures and contact Karl.

The toilet resembled some kind of septic tank disaster. He closed the cover and rested a foot on top, as if to literally keep a lid on things. The picture wasn't great, but it was her. The same woman he'd met in Leeds when he collected a Document Security Bag for Sir Peter Carroll, months back. He stared at the image and then sent it on to Karl. Shortly afterwards, he rang him, speaking in a shout-whisper.

"What's the score, Tommo?"

It felt like two-nil — to the opposition.

"Did you get the image I sent you?"

"No, it sometimes takes a . . . hold on, it's here now."

The line went quiet; all Thomas could hear was a pulse in his head and swirling static in the earpiece.

"Right, got it. Listen, we have a problem."

"You're telling me, Karl. I've seen her before . . ."

The outer door of the gents swung in and Thomas immediately cut the call. He stayed perfectly still. He heard deliberate breathing, as if someone were trying to compose himself. Then the bleeps of a mobile phone pressed into action.

"Hi Julia, it's Bob. No, everything's fine, darling. It's just work . . . I know I said I'd be back before three . . . let's not do this now . . . yes, I

know. Look.” The word ricocheted off the wall. “We’ll talk later. I’ll be back as soon as I can. Okay?”

He heard a rhythmic tapping like fingernails against the side of a sink.

“Okay, love you; bye.”

It sounded like Bob Peterson did a good line in irony. The thing Thomas noticed after that was nothing. No footsteps, no one washing their hands or taking a piss; not even — thank God — someone going into the neighbouring cubicle.

There was just shallow breathing. What if Peterson suddenly appeared, looking over the top? Photograph him? Make a break for the door? Lamp him one? He thought about flushing and walking out — Peterson was hardly likely to keep him captive in a lav. Except . . . being seen there was tantamount to an admission of guilt.

He breathed slowly through his nose, nice and easy, and started counting down in his head. One-eighty, one-seventy-nine . . . At one-forty-eight the main door squeaked open and footsteps retreated. He texted Karl — He’s coming out now — turned the phone off, and finished his countdown. He figured Uncle Bob would want to see to his car straightaway. As he eased through the crowds he thought back to the mystery blonde who had been with Peterson. Did he know her name?

Outside, the distinctive aroma of Southampton Water blended perfectly with diesel and drizzle. The cruise ships and ferries might promise glamour and prestige — at a push — but that didn’t change the backdrop.

His phone rang as soon as he put it back on.

“Where the hell have you been, Tommo?”

“Hiding in the toilets.”

“Peterson’s made a couple of calls — I couldn’t see the numbers at this distance. It looks like he’s leaving his car here to be collected — the two of them are moving away. Hang on, I think he’s having a tiff with blondie.”

Thomas swallowed. “I’m out now; where do you need me to be?”

Karl seemed quieter than usual. Thomas followed his lead and stayed in position until a people carrier arrived and whisked the unhappy couple away.

“Did that go well?” He honestly didn’t know.

Karl was non-committal. “We got what we came for — we know who Bob Peterson’s contact is. Christine ought to be pleased.”

They found a café on-site, now Bob Peterson had gone. Karl was well into his second coffee before he shared anything useful.

“You remember my trip to Geneva? She was there too.”

It seemed like a good time to mention he’d seen her in Leeds. He picked up a spoon for his coffee and it lingered, mid-air, as a thought congealed in his brain.

“So the mystery blonde is one of your people?”

Karl stared at him blankly — his *keep out* sign.

“How should we play this?”

Karl chewed his muffin thoughtfully. “You report back to Christine and then it’s her call. I’ll convey the same information to other quarters.”

Thomas plunged the spoon. “Do I tell her about Leeds?”

“Sup to you, partner.”

It was the most uneven partnership he’d ever heard of.

“Bob will be really pissed off about his car — and he might have seen mine — so the police could be lying in wait. Perhaps we should head back to London by train. I can pick it up in the next day or so . . .”

Secretly he was hoping Karl had access to false number plates.

“Don’t worry, I’ve got it covered. I’m just waiting for a call back. How about another drink? Tea for me, ta.”

Which explained why they were still hanging around the port. When he returned from the counter, Karl was on the phone. There was a time when he would have stood back and waited, but Karl did have legs. The call ended quickly.

“Make yourself comfy — they could be another half an hour.”

“They?”

Karl put on his inscrutable grin.

* * *

Thomas watched as the final flap of tarpaulin was secured over his car sitting on the recovery vehicle. “I have to say, you’ve excelled yourself.”

Karl took a bow. “They’ll drop us off in a lay-by, well past the city limits, and you can take us on from there.”

“You really do think of everything!”

“If only . . .”

Chapter 26

Christine took the news stoically and said not to bother coming into the office, which told him she was probably there. It seemed an opportune moment to mention his next prison visit and to her credit she didn't ask for details, which saved another layer of subterfuge.

And so ended another weekend. Or it would have done, had he not dragged himself back to Walthamstow and seen a blue Mini Cooper parked along the street. It was the best news he'd had for days.

As he opened the door he caught a whiff of Kung Po chicken — luring him along the hallway to the front room.

“Well, this is a surprise.”

Miranda was perched on the arm of the settee.

“Are we celebrating?”

“More like turning over a new leaf.”

He searched her face for a smile, found one and breathed a little easier. It lasted until she added, “and I thought we'd clear the air.”

It only took one bite for Thomas to realise that this was no ordinary Kung Po.

“You picked this up at your local Chinese in Bow.” He closed his mouth for a moment to savour the tender cashews mingled with the meat. “Luckily for you I was coming home.”

She finished her mouthful. “No, luckily for you I first checked with Karl that you weren't already booked for the evening.”

He let it pass; it was hard to be churlish when the food was so good.

“Ice cream and fritters afterwards?” He thought he'd push his luck.

“Of course, once we've had a little talk.”

It didn't spoil the food any, but he wasn't in a rush to finish. Miranda didn't actually say a great deal; she left that to him. He had little to say that wouldn't start a row. As far as he knew this was going to be a quiet night in, watching *The Matrix* again. He gave her twenty seconds of thoughtful silence and she took the hint.

“If we're going to move forward we need to be completely honest with one another.”

When he really thought about it, there was only one solution.

“You know what? Let’s not. Be open, I mean. We each have our secrets and I reckon it should stay that way.”

“Thomas, I’m not asking about your bloody job—”

“I know. And I’m not asking about the past. Done is done and raking over what’s gone is not gonna help either of us.”

It all came out in a rush and Miranda suddenly reached over and kissed him while he still had the taste of chicken in his mouth. It wasn’t passion exactly, more a sense of connection. And there was still the prospect of two kinds of dessert.

* * *

Over breakfast he showed her Jack Langton’s list of suspects.

“Do you know her?” He prodded at Andrea Harrison with a butter knife, blotching the paper.

“Doesn’t ring any bells.”

It was a long shot but he was disappointed. Advance intelligence was a tactical advantage — another of Karl’s pearls of wisdom. He’d have to settle for a Q&A session in the next day or so.

“I wouldn’t have thought Jack was the gallery type.” She got up to clear the plates. “I’m going to take a shower. There’s room for two in there . . .”

He glanced up at the clock. Surely fifteen minutes wouldn’t do any harm. Karl could always read a newspaper.

* * *

Thomas picked up the text on his way out the door. Karl’s message was succinct: Detour to the office — by request. He pictured the scene awaiting him; Christine, or Sir Peter, or even — but hopefully not — Bob Peterson himself.

The drive in was the usual blend of frustration, stop-starts and death-wish cyclists. Remembering the road works at Tottenham Hale, he’d bitten the bullet and cut through Stratford instead to pick up the A11. Unfortunately, half of London decided to join him.

As Newham begrudgingly gave way to Tower Hamlets he got a deeper sense of Old London Town. The garment wholesalers and discount warehouses rubbing shoulders with those mobile phone shops that managed to stay in business even though you could buy everything cheaper online —

like they had. Mile End, Stepney Green, Whitechapel and Aldgate East . . . He marked off the Tube stations and drank in the words. Every one brought him back to Miranda; she was London to him. Mile End — turn left to get to Caliban's; Whitechapel — opposite the London Hospital where Miranda's Nan had spent her final days.

Dragged along in the slipstream of traffic, he started thinking about rainy childhood Sundays in Yorkshire. Playing *Monopoly* as a family and laughing at Dad winning second prize in a beauty contest. And the terrible caravan holiday in Cleethorpes, where it poured down day after day and Dad hit the bottle.

The van in front hit its brakes. He tensed up; he'd been drifting, driving on autopilot. A radio news bulletin warned of traffic jams in the city. *No shit, Sherlock*. He heard the sirens up ahead. Once the van had moved he could see lurid emergency lights — two police vehicles and an ambulance. A motorcyclist was down, poor bastard. There was a man standing perfectly still, staring into space — probably the driver. A police officer was already taking measurements.

He wondered who was doing the photography. That would be a *real* job, instead of spying on benefit cheats. The rear view mirror smiled back at him. Karl's words had taken up residence in his head.

He watched the drama unfolding, like every other ghoul as they edged past. This was how life was — a series of accidents, lucky and unlucky. Meeting Miranda — top of the plus list. And Bermuda . . . Bollocks, why did he have to start thinking again? The lights shone a lucky shade of green and he swung round towards Liverpool Street without answering the question.

The underground car park swallowed him, drawing him into the nether land of the Surveillance Support Unit. His brain locked into work mode. The office door smelled of polish, or maybe it was the carpet. Unnaturally clean, like an adman's fantasy. He wondered how they went about vetting the cleaners. Maybe Karl's people were missing a trick — cleaners were surely the ultimate in invisibility. Perhaps that'd be their next assignment.

He had the space to himself so he caught up on his emails, including the one from Karl that duplicated his text. There were no surprises: refresher training dates, performance review dates for his e-calendar and a request for volunteers to provide feedback on new equipment: another day

in the service of the Crown. He heard the lift outside shunt to a halt. Only one set of footsteps exited; the rhythm confident and unhurried. He didn't bother turning round.

"Hi, Thomas — you got my message. Come through."

Christine collected him en route, unlocking her door and plonking two bags on a spare chair. She didn't fire up her laptop, waving him round to the seat opposite as she emptied her mobile from her coat.

"I spoke with Karl last night, about the situation. Thank you for your email by the way. I think we'll put the Southampton surveillance on hold for the time being."

If there was a subtext it eluded him. He'd bide his time; people always showed their hand if you waited long enough.

"Karl says you're assisting him on something. The prison?" She arched an eyebrow. "Just make sure I'm in the loop, okay?"

That was rich; to keep her in the loop he'd have to know what was going on. In the absence of any better ideas, he tried a stab in the dark.

"Is Bob Peterson a risk?" She could take that however she pleased.

"At this stage, he's a medium priority, but I'd planned for this contingency."

There it was — the management speak, so beloved of the movers and shakers. Maybe she picked it up from all the mentoring Peterson had given her, back when she and Thomas were trying to prove her mother wrong about the class struggle.

"Something else on your mind, Thomas?"

"I was wondering how it all works now — between the three of you." He stalled, suddenly aware that she might think he meant Mr and Mrs Peterson, instead of Karl and Ann Crossley.

The lift door clunked open in the distance and he heard welcome voices — Karl and Ann flying the flag once more for team spirit. They came right into Christine's office, and then things got strange.

"Please wait outside," was not something he had ever expected to hear from Christine. From her mother, maybe, back in the day; but not from her.

The door closed discreetly behind him. Well, two could play at secrets. John Wright picked up on the fourth ring.

"Morning, John; any more word from Jack Langton's solicitor?" He waited for John to start talking and then cut across him to catch him off

guard.

“Have you got any info on Andrea Harrison?”

“We used to know her, years ago,” was hardly intelligence coup of the year. But the way John said those few words let Thomas know that something had gone awry, way back when.

The meeting of the allies was over in fifteen minutes. Karl emerged first.

“All set, Tommo?”

“Well, unless Christine wants me back in there . . .”

“Nah, she doesn’t. I’ll fill you in when we’re on the road.”

Two chocolate bars from the vending machine and they were on their way. Karl had a quiet sense of purpose about him — no jokes and no cracks in the façade.

The lift opened, ushering in the damp of the underground car park.

“You do realise I signed the Official Secrets Act?”

“It’s not about trust; you know that by now. It protects you, Tommo.”

Yeah, but from who, or what?

He unlocked his car; Karl could ride shotgun today. They waited on the ramp as the metal grid raised, the links shrieking as they disappeared into the housing.

“Needs oiling,” Karl said. “Maybe that’ll be our next job.”

“You’d know before I did.”

“Touché, Mr Bladen. Okay, where are we?” Karl pulled a clipboard from the passenger door. He answered himself. “Just off Old Ford Road.”

Chapter 27

“Next up is Dorothy Kinley; elderly and living with her niece, Monica.”

It sounded like a far cry from the usual ‘shysters and innocents’ they’d been dealing with for the past few weeks. Karl read the case notes aloud and he clapped his hands in glee.

“A proper challenge, Tommo — at last!”

The ‘case’ as Karl kept referring to it, in Sherlock Holmes fashion, hinged on whether the niece was a full-time carer. On the face of it, a bugger to prove or disprove, but — once again — a tip-off had activated the Department of Works & Pensions radar.

“It says here Dorothy was completely housebound for a long time, and now she pops out occasionally, mostly to pick up her pension.”

“So, does she actually need the carer?” This one was making Thomas really uncomfortable.

Pension day. They set up and waited for the procession to the elephants’ graveyard. Mrs Kinley left her maisonette on schedule, as if she’d read the file. Her ambling gait was hard to detect under her oversized coat; she reminded Thomas of one of the Sand People from *Star Wars*. She kept her head down — or else it was osteoporosis — clutching a handbag to her chest and concentrating on every step.

He waited until he was past her line of sight and then took to his camera, capturing the rest of her journey.

“This one’s a sod for details. What else can we do, other than time her?”

Karl considered that for a moment. “Tell you what, how about you go and get me a couple of stamps? Would you mind? God knows we’ve got the time and I’ve got bills to pay this week.”

Thomas smiled at Karl’s legendary distrust of the direct debit system. The banking system, he’d said, was at the dark heart of the European Shadow State. Then again, he also said that prawn cocktail crisps were an aberration.

Outside, Thomas slowed his pace so that Dorothy didn’t think he was stalking her; the effort was exhausting. There was a queue in the post office,

almost to the door. Some of them were chatting, putting the world to rights. As he took his place a couple of spots behind the target he listened to a litany of complaints, largely about the speed of the post office queue.

Dorothy collected her pension and moved past him, without so much as a smile — the miserable so and so. He managed to get to the second counter, avoiding the woman with her lethal shopping trolley immediately in front of him. He grabbed Karl's stamps and nodded to the ladies in the queue, who clucked like a flock of hens. Good to know he still had appeal.

This was all starting to feel like a monumental waste of time. Old Ma Kinley was up ahead on her return journey, approaching her nearest point to the car, filling the frame if Karl was taking a secret photo. He took his eyes off her for a couple of seconds, to negotiate some dog shit, and when he looked back she was down on one knee. He legged it and caught up with her, pronto.

“Are you okay?”

She nodded, mumbling away, her handbag clutched in a death grip. No wonder she fell; she had no way to steady herself. Despite her protests, he insisted on helping her up and seeing her home. He didn't bother to explain how he knew the address. He could hear her breathing heavily, her arm shaking in his hand.

When they reached her gate, she wriggled free and thrust out a hand to bar him at the threshold. There was gratitude for you. He waited until she'd slammed the door behind her.

He was feeling pretty pleased on the way back to the car, until he saw Karl walking towards him.

“Ready?” Karl was rubbing his hands together.

“For what?”

“Mild-mannered Dorothy just dropped to the ground.”

“I know, I helped her home; I think she was in shock.”

Karl smiled. “In shock? She will be. When I ask for my £30 back. Like I was saying, she *dropped* to the ground and picked up thirty quid in marked tenners wrapped up in a rubber band.”

His eyes widened. Karl had just set her up. Not quite the ‘collect evidence impartially’ the Benefits Investigation Team recommended.

“How did you come to have marked banknotes on you?”

Karl shrugged. “Force of habit.”

There was no time to talk tactics, so he let Karl take control of the situation. Karl lifted the latch on the gate delicately and the two of them stood at the door. He rang the bell and nothing happened. Karl ducked below the frosted glass and whispered instructions.

Thomas rapped the letterbox and peered through. "Hello! I was with you when you had the fall. I just want to make sure you're okay." Crouching low, he could make out two stockinged feet at the top of the stairs. They weren't in any sort of hurry.

"Shall I get you a doctor?"

"No!" The voice sounded more like a yelp.

The feet disappeared and he let the flap go. At least she'd heard him and responded — now what? Karl started counting down from ten. At zero, Thomas lifted the letterbox again and caught sight of someone squatting on the stairs and looking back at him. The niece, he presumed, and blessed with the same level of social skills.

He waited; she'd soon realise he wasn't going anywhere and she could hardly expect the old lady to come downstairs.

The niece took her time about it but gradually approached the frosted panel.

"We're fine," she said through the glass. "Aunt Dot's in bed, resting. You've got to go now. It's upsetting her." She hovered by the door.

Karl scribbled on a piece of paper and passed it up.

Thomas mouthed the word *twat* at Karl but delivered his message anyway. "Look, your aunt picked up some money that was my friend's. He wants his thirty quid."

This was starting to feel like harassment. He looked down at Karl, who mouthed the final script.

"The notes are marked. I want them back or I'm calling the police."

He cringed. This was a new low — worse than following a disabled man into the pub. Maybe they'd been on this assignment too long.

The letterbox flap popped open and three ten-pound notes were ejected. Then he heard footsteps galloping upstairs.

Karl collected his money, examining each note carefully. "One's different — not to worry." He took out a small notebook and wrote in the new bank number. "Anyway." He folded the money into his wallet. "It's all job and finish, and I'd say we're done here."

Conversation resumed back at the car.

“Shall I start?” Karl walked around to the passenger door. He got in and waited for Thomas to join him, then grabbed imaginary lapels, as if he were a barrister. “One — the speed with which Dorothy Kinley rushed to get the cash. Remember, you didn’t see her from my vantage point. It wasn’t a fall; she knelt down and shoved the readies in her bag just before you showed up. Two — Dorothy went to bed quicker than a one-night stand. Three — and this is the killer — the niece had the money on her when she came to the door. Maybe she filched it out of the old dear’s coat, I dunno. But there’s something wrong there, however you look at it.”

“So you’re saying that if Aunt Dorothy can move that fast — with the aid of gravity — she doesn’t need a full-time carer?”

“Now who’s judgemental? All I’m saying is it merits further investigation — by the grown-ups. I’ll let BIT know later, maybe *after* work.” Karl winked.

“Dawn Yeates? Surely you’re not fraternising with our temporary boss?”

“Merely socialising.”

It occurred to him then that Dawn Yeates might be another of Karl’s contacts. Perhaps that was why they’d been picked for the assignment. Karl was giving nothing away, so he checked his mirrors and set a course for the nearest café.

“So . . . where are you taking her tonight?”

“Well, it’s a toss-up between the Roundhouse Theatre, or a pub.”

“And Dorothy Kinley?”

“I doubt she’d join us — she finds it hard to get around, unless money’s involved.”

“Dick.”

“I’ll tell Dawn about our concerns, only I’ll skip the finer details.”

“What d’you think will happen?”

“More surveillance, probably. Or they’ll call in the niece for an interview. Even if she is stealing money from her aunt, it’s hardly dawn raid material.”

“I see what you did there . . .”

“So when do you plan on speaking to Ray Daniels, Tommo?”

“I’m seeing Andrea Harrison tonight, but Ray Daniels is on my list. Why the interest?” He stared across the table. “Do you know something?”
By the look on Karl’s face, whatever it was it was toxic.

Chapter 28

The sign said it all: *Andrea Harrison*. Not even the word ‘gallery.’ The lettering screamed modernity and Thomas knew instantly that he wouldn’t like whatever she was selling. He pushed the glass door and stepped into her world.

Andrea Harrison was leaning on a counter, set along one of the longer walls. Mobile in hand, her finger pointed down at a catalogue.

“I suggested seventeen thousand, but he won’t budge.”

She looked over, as if sizing him up. A flick of the head told him he’d failed the assessment. He should have brought along a camera — maybe an Olympus OM1 with a sizeable lens that looked the part.

He turned his back on her and browsed through the industrial sculptures and something made out of rounded glass that looked like a child’s nightmare. Moving from exhibit to exhibit, he picked up snippets of conversation and filed it all away. At the far end of the main gallery room there was an open doorway. Discordant synthesiser music plagued his memory — something from the eighties probably — music from Thatcher’s dream. He grimaced, peering through. Footsteps quickly followed behind him.

“Sorry about that; I’m Andrea Harrison — welcome to my gallery. Are you looking for anything in particular?”

He smiled, mostly at the reply he wanted to share with her. But no, he was here on business.

“I’m Thomas — Jack Langton sent me?” He posed it as a question, but he knew it had all been arranged through John Wright.

She took a moment and then led him back to the glass counter.

“What can I do for you, Thomas?”

He gave her the Bladen smile, along with a sanitised version of his meeting with Jack Langton. As icebreakers went, it cut through the glacier. She offered coffee and when he agreed she took out two pouches from a drawer. The machine was as stylish and over-engineered as everything else in the gallery, including her.

“What do you think of it?” She gazed around her domain, soaking up his attention.

He noticed the faded streak of crimson in her hair, glittering in the spotlights.

“It’s . . . different.” He saw no sense in bullshitting her.

She seemed amused. He figured it gave her a sense of superiority. So this was art? He couldn’t imagine any of the stuff here getting past the door at Leeds Art Gallery. Londoners — they’d put up with any old shit.

“Is there somewhere we can talk privately?”

“Here’s fine. Besides,” she glanced over to the doorway, “I have artists working on-site — they prefer to stay in the shadows.” She patted a leather stool beside her.

The coffee was good, much to his surprise; although the ginger biscuit with it was so small it was frivolous. Maybe it was some sort of statement, like everything else around him — style over content.

“I suppose you already know about me and Jack?”

He blushed in ignorance, which she, in hers, misinterpreted.

She blew across her coffee. “It’s common knowledge; we used to be an item, back in the day.”

He waited for her to continue, noting how she flicked her hair, as if to brush away the memory; fat chance of that.

“We’re good friends now — and partners too. Jack came to my rescue when I started the gallery — he found me some backers . . .” She changed topic abruptly. “John said you were coming because of some poor child.” She sipped her coffee, eyeing him all the while. “But I don’t see what any of that has to do with me.”

He shrugged. “Jack asked me to speak with you — and others.” She nodded; satisfied she wasn’t the only fish in the net.

“So what do you want to know?” She raised her empty coffee cup for seconds, which was a perfect excuse to ask for the loo.

He stepped through a doorway at the back and kept on walking. Two welders in a side room paused from their work and nodded to him. He found the gents, took a leak and then phoned Karl.

“Have you cracked the world of modern art yet?”

“Industrial and urban street art, actually — *specialised* bollocks. Honestly, Karl, you wanna see some of the prices. I’ll be at least another

half an hour; all I've learned so far is that Jack Langton bankrolled her in the beginning."

"Drug proceeds, most probably. A bit of a punt with the gallery but a great way to launder dirty money, especially if you own the building."

"Good point. One last thing, Andrea Harrison and Jack used to be an item."

"How quaint you Yorkshire folk are. Ring me when you're free. Over and out."

The welders were away on a tea break now; probably Earl Grey. A pity — he wanted to ask what it was supposed to be, although he imagined that was part of the sell.

Andrea had the next coffees lined up and offered him a quick tour.

"The Crocodile is one of RT's more experimental works." She quoted from a script she knew too well. Every artist was reduced to initials; he supposed the important ones had earned their three letters. It mostly washed over him, like a timeshare presentation he and Miranda had once been to in the West End. He made a mental list, in case she asked him anything: sculpture, metalwork, permanence and impermanence, decay, contrast, urban . . . He stopped walking, mesmerised by two artworks, placed side by side. The piece on the right was electric blue, sprayed flame streaks against a painted wall, flowing down into the shape of a supine form.

"Ah, yes — *Naked Flame*. A lot of men like that one; some ladies too."

He nodded agreeably, but his eyes were on the frame next to it. *Naked Heat*: a flame dissolving into entwined lovers — in blood red spray paint.

"Are these by RT as well?" He turned and studied her reaction.

She smiled, tour over, and returned him to his coffee. Now that he'd shown genuine interest, her demeanour changed, even if the biscuits didn't. This time he grabbed a handful.

"I noticed that some of the pieces don't have a price tag."

"Yes, it's one of RT's foibles. The purchaser suggests a price and RT considers it. Sometimes he accepts it, sometimes he offers an alternative and sometimes he rejects them outright. It's how he likes to do business."

"And a little mystique is good for the brand?"

She laughed. Put on, of course. He decided to play along.

"Those pictures — do you call them *pictures*? — they've really got something. Is he a local artist?"

“RT? No, not any more. He lives in Spain and only visits once or twice a year with new pieces. How long have you worked for Jack? I’ve never heard of you before.”

“I don’t actually work for him; this is more of a favour for a friend.”

“Yes . . .” She snapped a miniature biscuit in half. “Jack receives a lot of favours.”

“What can you tell me about your dealings with Jack? I mean, would anyone you know . . .” He let the sentence hang there. He didn’t know how to end it without accusing or insulting her.

“A man like Jack makes enemies . . .”

He could hear the pride in her voice.

“ . . . Yes, I think that’s why he enjoys this sort of art; it’s confrontational — not to everyone’s tastes. He appreciates the context and its potential.”

“So Jack is a working partner, as opposed to a silent one?” Now he was digging in the dark. But dig long and deep enough and eventually you’ll strike something solid.

“Jack’s a very private man. Even so, he has a lot of money tied up here, for which I’m very grateful. It’s a cutthroat business and there are only so many seats at the top table. Look at the Saatchis.”

If that was supposed to impress him, it fell wide of the mark — by about fifty yards. All very interesting but it was getting him nowhere.

“Has anyone been in touch with you, here, about Jack — since he went away? Or maybe something out of the ordinary happened recently?”

“The attempted break-in? I informed Jack’s solicitor and Ray Daniels. Nothing was taken; I think it was drunks pissing about.”

He couldn’t help thinking the swearing was for his benefit, to show she was like him. She couldn’t have been more wrong.

“Yes,” she continued, “you’d be surprised at the reaction a gallery like this can generate.” She stopped and looked right at him.

“Does anyone live upstairs?”

“I do. I can show you if you like?”

“Maybe some other time.” He checked his watch.

“I’ll hold you to that, Thomas.”

“And nothing in the post — for Jack, I mean?”

She blushed and he knew straight away this was another of his drugs drops. Interesting — Sheryl, Janey and now Andrea — how Jack kept the ladies at his beck and call.

A postwoman came into the gallery with some envelopes and a small parcel. As he was nearest to the door, he did the chivalrous thing and stood up to collect the mail. The postie smiled and handed over the goods. Andrea leapt from her seat.

“I’ll take those,” she insisted, with the forced politeness that told him something else was going on. She placed them on the glass top, unopened.

Occasionally, he liked to think that lady fortune was smiling on him. It didn’t happen often — meeting Miranda and her family was top of the list. Another had been getting no worse than a flesh wound from one of Karl’s trigger-happy adversaries. When a pair of potential punters breezed into the gallery, fortune gave him a cheery grin.

Andrea left her coffee and her table manners at the desk, winding a circuitous route round to the couple. It looked like a routine to showcase the goods and suggest she wasn’t in a hurry to sell anything. He listened, fascinated, as the three of them talked *texture* and *depth*, throwing *authenticity* and *statement* into the mix. Jesus; if his dad could see him now. ‘Nowt but a lot of middle-class ponces,’ is what he’d say.

As the three culture vultures waltzed around the urban scrawl, he casually leaned forward and fanned out the envelopes. It was hardly a shock to see a letter addressed to Jack Langton at the gallery, but the postmark was a showstopper — Spain, where RT the aerosol artist was based. He tidied the pack and headed off clockwise around the gallery, one eye on the sales party. He picked up that they were restaurateurs on the hunt for some urban degradation. He smiled to himself; they could always move south of the Thames. He was nearing *Naked Heat*, a car key palmed in one hand to get a paint sample, when Andrea zeroed in on him.

“Can we continue our chat some other time?”

He put his key hand in his pocket.

“Sure, name the time.”

“I’m free tonight. Shall we say nine? Would you mind seeing yourself out?”

“Nine o’clock it is then.” He took another glance at the *Naked*s and detoured around them, patting the Crocodile’s head on his way out.

Chapter 29

Karl said he'd collect him at Hackney Downs station. It gave him time to collect his thoughts. Why would a jumped-up graffiti artist in Spain send Jack Langton a message by attacking some kid Jack hardly ever saw? DNA — he made a mental note. Could they get a sample of Jacob's DNA and one of Jack's? Nah, he was letting his imagination get ahead of him.

He clapped his hands, prayer-fashion, to stop his mind wandering. RT lived in Spain and came over once or twice a year. When was he over? Andrea must know the geezer's full name; maybe Karl could get a passport number from it. He couldn't help noticing how much he was relying on Karl's expertise. John Wright knew what he was doing when he brought Karl on board.

The next logical move was to get a red paint sample. He could nip back to the gallery and wait until there was an opportunity to take a scrape — probably no one would notice on a wooden canvas — or Karl's people could just buy the thing. Or there was a third option that made him laugh just thinking about it.

Karl wasn't at the station. Instead, he directed Thomas by mobile to the nearby Pembury Tavern. The shandies awaited.

"Well, well, if it isn't the art critic of the week!" Karl opened a celebratory bag of crisps as Thomas took his seat. "How d'ya get on?"

"I'm not really sure."

"Why don't you tell your Uncle Karl all about it?"

Karl offered him a pen and paper so he could map out the mosaic of the problem. He'd liked Roman mosaics as a child — the way that tiny, insignificant tiles all contributed to a bigger, more imaginative picture.

"This artist, RT; he uses spray colours. Bright red, sometimes."

Karl seemed less than impressed. "This is the fella you said lived in Spain."

"Yeah, most of the time. We need a sample of the paint he uses. Also, I was hoping you could find out when RT was last in the UK."

"Smart thinking, Tommo, except RT isn't much to go on. Also, how do you expect to get a paint sample undetected?"

“I’m going back to Andrea Harrison’s at nine tonight. We’ll be upstairs, so it’s an ideal opportunity for you to do some breaking and entering.”

“Alarm systems?”

“Probably. I thought you could improvise. I know it’s sketchy but if I can keep Ms Harrison busy — talking,” he added hastily.

“Maybe. CCTV? Tell me that at least.”

“Not that I saw. Can’t imagine anyone wants to be filmed buying that tat.”

“*Concept* tat.” Karl went into screensaver mode, gazing at his shandy for longer than Thomas was comfortable with. “Okay,” he announced, “let’s give it a go. One stipulation: if I make any noise, I want you to come down alone.”

“Deal.” Thomas sat back in his chair, less reassured than he’d expected to be.

The rest of the day’s snooping passed much like every other day in the world of Benefits investigations. Villains, suspects, the misunderstood and the vindicated, all paraded past them to a tedious beat.

* * *

He checked his watch — twenty-fifty — and carried on talking with Karl on his mobile as he walked up the road. And to think Miranda said men couldn’t multitask.

“I still don’t see why you can’t tell me what you’re planning, Karl.”

“Trust me; it’s better that way — keeps things spontaneous and plausible. You have your wee drinky upstairs and remember, keep it zipped up.”

“Funny boy.” He cut the call.

He felt sweat down his back as he rang the gallery bell and blinked at the headlights of a taxi rumbling by. Peering through the door he could see a light at the far end of the gallery room. She seemed to be taking her time; maybe it was a long walk down two flights of stairs. To his intense relief she was dressed casually. Jeans and a cashmere jumper didn’t scream ‘on the pull’ — not in his world anyway. She turned to the wall, out of view, before unlocking the door.

Bollocks — that was probably an alarm. Pessimism turned to joy when she locked up after him and didn’t reset it. Industrial art, he decided, looked

very creepy in shadow.

She didn't say much on the way up, only that the kettle was on and she hoped he was hungry because she had nibbles. He pictured Karl smirking. Of course she did.

Her apartment was a collector's paradise. There wasn't a stick of furniture that wouldn't have graced a high-class glossy. What surprised him was the range of styles and how old and tasteful everything was.

She caught him gazing at the sideboard in her lounge.

"It's *rococo*, 17th century. You were expecting tubular steel and exposed brickwork? That's just my day job."

Even so, he noticed one or two miniatures with RT's signature on them.

"Make yourself comfortable."

She led him to a pair of large sofas, one each side of a pale blue coffee table, like two banks of a river. She sat opposite. The food was arranged in small dishes. Moroccan, by the looks of it, or something Middle Eastern. He recalled trying a Moroccan restaurant with Miranda once in Leeds. Gave him the trots, although that could have been the beer.

"I used to travel a lot," she explained. "Dealing in furniture and room decor. I do a great lamb tagine — do try the borek." She lifted a plate of pastries; the aroma alone made it hard to concentrate.

"How did you meet Jack then?" He figured he'd start at the beginning.

"You first," she teased, threatening to draw the plate out of reach.

"Like I said," and sighed with relief as his fingers wrapped around a borek, "we have mutual friends. I'm not part of Jack's circle and that's what he wanted, someone objective." He opened his hand; now it was her turn to share.

"Oh, I met Jack years ago." There was a glow to her face as she recollected. "I saw him at a club a few times and there was something about him. You never quite knew where you were with Jack — he never tried too hard. Made a change from the other regulars. But you're not here to rake over the past."

Now that she looked straight at him, Karl had a point. She was an attractive woman, educated by the sounds of it, although clearly happy to mix with the peasants. And she was waiting.

"Alright, I'll level with you." He reached for some couscous, hoping he looked au fait with the cuisine. "I first met Jack in prison — he, er, asked

me to go and see him.”

She smiled a little and nodded, as if she knew what Jack’s requests felt like.

“Anyway, you were on Jack’s list. You *know* about his business, Andrea?”

“I know not to ask. Jack’s very loyal to those who show him loyalty. That’s good enough for me.”

He regrouped. “Does he get involved much in the arts scene?”

“Yes, to some extent.” She lifted a bottle of wine from a cooler but he shook his head and settled for juice. “Some people meet Jack and form the impression that he’s a philistine — don’t quote me on that. They’re wrong and I think he trades on it. He takes a genuine interest in the gallery and the artists we promote — he even comes to a show once in a while.” She raised an index finger and took a gulp of wine. “Take RT. Jack’s been out to Spain to visit his artists’ commune more than once.”

“I liked his stuff. It had . . .” He searched for a word, and was mortified by the dead-end he’d arrived at, “. . . authenticity.”

“You mean you liked the nudes. I modelled for him once, actually.” She paused dramatically and held her breath.

“I could see that working.” He looked away for an instant, wishing he could think of something else to say. Time for more food. “I mean, I could see RT’s artwork working on the street.”

“Exactly!” She slowly turned her glass. “Contemporary and yet naturalistic.”

It was easier to stay on safe ground, so when the lamb tagine appeared he turned the conversation to photography. Now he could talk about the Merrion Street Gallery in Leeds, the pictures that inspired him and the ones he still liked to take.

“I sell photography occasionally. If you have anything special I’d be happy to take a look. Any friend of Jack’s . . .”

Except he wasn’t a friend. He couldn’t tell whether she was humouring him or trying to buy him off. When the wine bottle rattled again he stuck with mixers and let her gradually fill herself up. A few more eats, Middle Eastern music in the background, and he could almost relax. It was all turning into a pleasant evening, right until he heard glass smashing somewhere below stairs.

Now he understood Karl's reluctance to share the plan.

"Stay here." He glanced around the room and grabbed a small metal sculpture in his hand, holding it like a cudgel.

"Not that!" She gasped.

He put it back down and picked up a poker from the fireplace, just in case it wasn't Karl downstairs.

"Are you going to ring the police?"

He thought he knew the answer already; her face confirmed his suspicions. She didn't want the Bobbies prying into her affairs, or Jack's. Table for one, then.

He crept down the stairs in twos, the blood pounding in his heart. As he peered through the doorway, poker at the ready, Karl, all in black, in a ski mask, was scraping paint off *Naked Heat*.

"I hope this is the one you meant; I couldn't see any other red ones like this."

"Jesus."

The glass door at the front looked like it had imploded. Other pieces of artwork had been damaged by Karl's entrance. He was an equal opportunity desecrator.

"Right, all done. Just one more thing, Tommo," Karl stepped clear, motioning him to one side. "Sorry about this and stay down for a bit."

Next thing he knew, a fist had swung out of nowhere, connected, and sent him flying backwards until the floor kicked him in the spine. Still conscious but dazed, he heard Karl retreating into the night, an apology wafting behind him.

Chapter 30

Taking Karl at his word he lay still, eyes closed, listening to the sound of his own breathing. He tried counting up to five thousand, only he kept losing the thread. At some point he heard a voice, echoing through the semi-darkness, growing louder. When he opened his eyes Andrea was standing in the doorway, arms limp at her sides as she surveyed the scene.

“I’m okay.” He lifted his head on the off chance she was interested.

She stepped over the debris and helped him to stand.

“We’d better get you to A&E.”

“Shouldn’t we wait for the police?”

“No need. I phoned Ray and he’s on his way. Did you see them? Did they take anything?”

Her Florence Nightingale act needed more work. He danced around the details — two people, probably, and no one spoke. Maybe they just wanted to cause damage, or else he had scared them off.

“I’ll make some coffee.” She seemed to be talking mainly to herself.

They remained downstairs, sipping caffeine in the wasteland. He got it together enough to rescue *Naked Heat* from the mess, found a broom and started sweeping up. It wasn’t like forensics was going to make an appearance and it helped tidy away anything incriminating.

Naked Heat looked a little rougher around the edges now.

“I don’t suppose it’ll be worth as much.”

“Don’t you believe it!” She lifted the artwork and hung it back on the wall. The frame was cracked and some of its gloriously red paint was scuffed and chipped. “This will make wonderful publicity, especially with RT coming over for a new show in three weeks.”

“RT?” He pressed fingertips lightly to one side of his face. “You never told me what his actual name is.”

“Rodrigo Tollinger — RT to those who appreciate his work.” She wobbled a little, a sure sign that the coffee hadn’t straightened her up. She nodded, as if agreeing with herself. “Tell you a little secret, Thomas. It’s not his *real* name. Changed it by deed poll years ago, a good career move.” She

opened the cupboard where the little biscuits lived and brought out a brandy miniature, shaking a little as she siphoned its contents into her cup.

In the spirit of generosity he put it down to stress.

“Somehow Rodney Tompkins doesn’t quite cut it.”

He never liked to be around drunken people. Drink made people do funny things. Many of the worst arguments with Miranda had been a three-way affair between the two of them and a bottle of something.

He did the chivalrous thing and saw to another couple of coffees; Andrea poured the dregs of her first into the second. Then he made himself useful again with a dustpan and brush. Full marks to Karl for taking pride in his work.

By the time a Range Rover pulled up outside, depositing Ray Daniels and a nameless thug on a lead, all that was needed was a 24-hour glazier and the briefest of explanations. He kept things simple, taking the lead as Andrea seemed in no fit state to answer Ray’s questions. No, he hadn’t seen the bloke clearly before he laid him out, and now that he thought about it there were two of them, possibly three. The geezer who hit him seemed to be looking for something; said nothing, and then it was lights out. End of story.

He allowed Ray to drop him off at Accident & Emergency, along with Andrea who insisted on exorcising her guilt by waiting with him at the hospital for two hours. By the time he’d been patched up and received some painkillers he’d also bagged an invite to RT’s opening night. It’d please Miranda, hopefully.

After the once-over from A&E, he loaded Andrea into a minicab and phoned Karl.

“How’s the face?”

“Sore — you shitbag. I need picking up.”

“I’ll be there in minutes.”

He laughed. “You don’t know where I am!”

“Ha! You don’t know where *I* am. I’m in the hospital car park — I followed the Range Rover from the gallery and I’ve been bored stupid waiting for your call.”

The journey to his Walthamstow flat provided ample time for a debrief. He went first, passing on Rod Tompkins’ name, plus the Rodrigo Tollinger alias. Karl promised to follow it up with a passport check.

“There’s something dodgy there — I just can’t put my finger on it yet.”

“What, Tommo? You think he attacked Jacob with paint from his own studio?” Karl’s voice of reason sounded like the case for the defence.

Lea Bridge Road flickered by, strung together with orange streetlights. He watched them for a while before replying.

“He’s coming back over in three weeks. I’ll confirm the date and maybe you can get me the flight details?”

Karl gave a mock salute. “Aye, aye, skipper. I’ll add them to my to-do list. You did some great work tonight, Thomas. And all it took was a smack in the face.”

He gave Karl a crooked smile and touched his throbbing jaw.

Chapter 31

Saturday morning, ten am. Thomas woke to the sound of the letterbox choking on the weekend post. He dragged himself out of bed, shimmied into some jeans and stumbled to the kitchen. Kettle on, he went to see what the day had brought him: two bills, an uninvited investment opportunity and a postcard from Yorkshire — Rievaulx Abbey, its magnificent shell of a building basking in sunlight. Judging by the rounded handwriting Geena had been the scribe.

Visiting hours for Godparents are nine am until seven pm. Bring presents. Come and see Ajit pretending to be a proper dad and gagging at changing nappies. We miss you both. Geena & Aj x

Since when did she start calling him Aj? She'd signed his name too. Chances were that Ajit didn't know she'd sent it. Ajit and him had got themselves a right pair of clever uns.

The answering machine was flashing like a distress call. He compromised with an instant coffee and hit the button.

"Hey, stranger; you coming over at the weekend?" Miranda sounded upbeat. "Ring me before I get a better offer."

After arranging a late lunch with her, he turned his attention to Karl.

"Well, sleepyhead — I was expecting a call from you first thing." Karl gave him a short rundown of events since they'd last spoken: RT's red paint was now at the lab; RT's movements, past and present, expected by Tuesday lunchtime; and a background check on the gallery and its finances should arrive sometime Wednesday.

Thomas tapped the postcard against the edge of a table. Only one call left to make. Andrea Harrison was more emotional than the previous night. He felt bad for that, until he remembered Jacob and what the priorities were.

"I've rung RT in Spain and he was devastated. Then he decided that he needed to be strong and inspire confidence in his collectors. He's going to bring his new exhibition forward a week."

He took a sip of caffeine heaven and listened to her wittering on about the new arrangements. *The opportunity of more publicity was just a*

coincidence, naturally.

Chapter 32

Karl leapt at the chance to take him back to the indoor shooting range. He didn't ask why and Thomas never ventured an explanation. They couldn't talk at work and lying on the phone was too easy — he was living proof of that. No, ironically, Karl was less defensive when firearms were around.

“Something on your mind, Tommo?”

He took the pistol from its box and set it down. “Apart from a SIG Sauer?”

Karl smiled and edged towards the door, beyond his peripheral vision. More used to Karl's Brownings, it took a little while to adjust. He loosed five rounds into the target, taking his time. The first two were so wide of the mark it was a wonder the paper target hadn't logged a complaint. The next three were all in the upper torso and the rest of the magazine scattered nearby.

He waited until Karl was on his mark and about to put ear defenders on.

“Why aren't we confronting Sir Peter about hiring a killer?”

Karl's hands paused by his head. “We need to know why. Once we know what's behind it — or who — then it's the right time to bring everything out in the open.”

Thomas rubbed at his scar. There was nothing more to be said, but Karl insisted on saying it.

“I won't pretend that what we do is heroic. We make a difference though.”

Lately Thomas had begun to question that.

* * *

The first thing Thomas noticed about the gallery, as he approached the curve of the street, was how normal it looked. Obviously, the glass door had been replaced — flawlessly, a carbon copy. Well, silicon. It was only when he pushed the door and he felt its weight that he recognised toughened glass. At least it was modern.

Andrea was all over him like a polite rash, kissing both cheeks.

“Thomas, it's so good to see you; let me get you a coffee.”

Amazing what taking a punch could do for trust building. The politicians could learn a lesson there. As Andrea wafted a vapour trail of expensive perfume around him, a couple in the far corner were gazing at *Naked Flame* and *Naked Heat* in rapture.

“The publicity has done wonders for the exhibition.” She was all aflutter. “We kept it out of the newspapers — except the local — and word has spread throughout the art world.”

He nodded, eyes still on the punters.

“Suffice it to say there is *great* interest in RT’s new show.”

“Listen, mind if I use your loo? It was a long walk over,” he added for effect.

“Sure, sure,” she dismissed him, craning her neck to eavesdrop on the art lovers.

He wandered towards the *Nakeds* to catch some of the conversation.

“. . . And of course,” the leather-elbowed one insisted, reeling his other half in closer, “it would be an investment.”

Yeah, that about summed it up. Thomas sidled past, made his excuses and went through to the gents to take a leak. Washing his hands, he caught sight of himself in the mirror and surveyed his face. The bruise had lingered and he needed a shave. He reached into his pocket for his keys and felt something plastic. It was the UV pen he’d used that morning to mark up his new camera, the case, the additional lens, and the manual.

As he walked back to the main gallery, pondering the amount of money a scumbag like Jack Langton might be earning while sitting on his arse in prison, he noticed that the room to the left was open. Only this time there were no ‘emerging artists’ working — if you could call it that. He couldn’t resist a peek at what passed for creativity in their world bubble. He’d be quick, he promised himself, just a nose around and then out.

The room was strangely sterile, especially with the light off. He flicked on his Maglite key ring and waltzed over to the metal monstrosity, noticing the fierce red slashes up one end. That shade of red was really starting to bug him. It was stupid and childish but he felt like making mischief. He pulled out his UV pen, crouched low where it would be difficult to find, and wrote in tiny letters: FRAUD.

Andrea was in full flow when he returned, the three of them stooped over the Crocodile. Definitely some sort of crock. They all spoke the same

language, passing superlatives around like a tray of canapés: challenging, progressive, subversive, and the dealmaker – *quixotic*. That was the word that finally had them reaching for their credit card and him for a sick bag

Andrea spotted him when they moved to the counter to conclude their business. He kept his distance, busying himself while delivery details were confirmed and plastic money changed hands — how apt. Then Andrea walked them to the door and reminded them about RT’s opening night, assuring them that RT loved to meet collectors of his work. She sighed as she closed the door, like the cat that got the credit card payment.

“Listen, I don’t think I can make it when RT flies in on Sunday. I’ll be at the show though and I’d love the chance to meet him without the crowds. By the way, how come there’s no poster up for the show?”

She threw him a pitying smile. “That’s not how these things are done. And besides, RT doesn’t like to give too much away; it spoils the great reveal.” She made the word sound theatrical. “Would you like to see the pieces we’ve had in storage?”

“I’d like nothing better.”

Chapter 33

“What do you think?” Miranda paraded around the kitchen.

This would be her third outfit and Thomas knew the wrong noise or facial expression at this point could spell disaster.

“Perfect.” By which he meant he’d liked to unzip it in private.

“And you’re going like *that*?”

He smiled; she’d pretty much dressed him.

“And what are we looking for tonight?”

He squeezed her waist — clever girl. “Just keep your radar on.”

* * *

It took them ages to find a parking space. They could have taken a cab and claimed it on expenses from Jack Langton, but he liked the security of his own car. He could leave when he wanted and, judging by the thrum of the music as they approached the gallery, that could be any time soon.

Miranda nudged him as he hunched his shoulders a little. “Well, at least the music sounds promising.”

He couldn’t tell whether she was taking the piss. A peer through the glass door confirmed his worst suspicions — he wondered if a copy of the Guardian under one arm might have helped him blend in.

The heavy door swung in and they eased through the throng. A pseudo-punk in a carefully torn and repaired jumpsuit zeroed in, introduced herself as Citizen Virtue, and ushered them over to the drinks.

Miranda muscled in before Virtue could finish her ‘what can I get you’ speech, grabbing a glass of white wine. “An orange juice for the boy.” The women laughed and Thomas let them enjoy the joke. He took a couple of sips as he gazed around. It was impressive — laser light across the ceiling, someone’s idea of a musical joke on the hi-spec speakers and the heady scent of money in the air. No wonder Jack Langton was a patron of the arts.

He gave Miranda’s elbow a gentle tug and they moseyed around the exhibits. He pointed out the *Naked* series to her and paused at the latest addition — *Naked Ambition*, a nude wearing a crown. And where was the great artist?

They left the main gallery room and wandered out back, through the fluorescent bead curtain that now adorned the doorway.

Andrea was easy to pick out. To her credit, she hadn't gone down the 'apocalypse at C&A' route that many of her contemporaries favoured. And the metal bow tie and diamante waistcoat were nice touches.

He worked his way over gradually, wondering what Miranda thought of it all. She was savvier than him; more cultured, less uptight about all the razzamatazz. Maybe that was why she had her own business, while he was a peasant holding a camera.

Ah, the camera. He missed the anonymity of being behind a lens, where every face became a willing victim, unwittingly revealing something else about themselves.

He contrived things so that she'd spot him first. It wasn't difficult.

"Ah, Thomas."

He turned his head on cue, motioning to Miranda, like they'd arranged in the car. He'd barely got the cheek kisses over when Andrea blossomed again.

"You must be Miranda. You take after Diane but you've got John's eyes."

That was a surprise — on first name terms with her parents. Andrea wasn't finished with her charm offensive.

"What a stunning dress. You'd better keep an eye on her tonight, Thomas!"

And there it was again, that little laugh that told him she was already merry. RT arrived at her side like a bad smell. They swapped stiff introductions and Miranda put in a few comments about his work that seemed to please him, while he fiddled with the tassel on his ethnic hat.

"Andrea suggested we talk tomorrow evening about Jack's . . . concerns. Perhaps we could make it dinner for four?"

He could see that RT was much more interested in Miranda than the conversation. Miranda seemed to pick up on it as well.

"What drives your passion for urban art?" She sparkled under the gallery lights.

RT was soon in full flow about urban decay, cultural identity and other toss. Andrea drew Thomas to one side.

"What do you think?" She waved a discreet hand around.

“Seems like a good crowd.” He floundered, unable to read the question.

“The unveiling is in fifteen minutes. RT likes to do something dramatic.”

Thomas drifted back to them, guiding Andrea and depositing her there.

He put his arm over Miranda’s shoulder and eased her forward. “We’d better have a good look around before the main event.”

“I was just getting somewhere,” she hissed.

“Yeah, that’s what it looked like.”

She shook her head. “No, stupid; he was telling me about his trips over from Spain. Jack’s very generous, apparently — pays for everything.”

“How come he told you that?”

“I think he wanted to impress me.”

He had to admit, it really was a stunner of a dress.

By now the place was so crammed with people that a full circuit was impossible. Instead, they went with the flow, moving inexorably towards the side room where RT had placed four burly security guards — two male and two female — one at each corner. Looking at the wires, he figured it was going to be one theatrical push of a button and then the cloth would fly to the ceiling.

The crowd eased apart to let RT approach the veiled exhibit. Thomas was suddenly bursting for a pee and trying to remember the location of the gents, now that the decor had changed. He decided to stay for the big reveal and then answer the call of nature. Miranda stood close by, grabbing his arm.

“This had better be good,” she whispered.

The music stopped, electro-jazz giving way to a murmuring that reverberated around the room. RT unzipped his top and fingered a pendant with a bright red centre. The four guards stood to attention and crossed their arms, hip-hop style. Without any preamble RT hit the button and the silvery fabric ascended to the ceiling. The crowd went wild before they’d even seen what was on show. Everyone seemed to join in with the hysteria — all except one person. Thomas stared at the piece, open-mouthed. It was a sculpture of metal and brick with bright red slashes.

He smiled a mile wide. The same piece he’d seen several days ago, when he’d signed his name on it in invisible marker. A piece RT couldn’t have created because he was in Spain, and couldn’t possibly have brought

over because Thomas had already tagged it. Yep, modern art really was bollocks.

They stuck it out until just after eleven, when the first wave of guests started leaving.

“Thank you so much for coming, Thomas.” Andrea teetered by the door, drawing a shawl around her shoulders.

“I really enjoyed it, especially the unveiling.” The build-up of glee was killing him.

“See you tomorrow evening then. RT is so looking forward to it.”

“Wouldn’t miss it for the world.” He escorted Miranda off the premises. A breeze stirred, but inside he was glowing. Secrets, he loved them — as long as they belonged to someone else.

She pulled him a little closer. “What’s gotten into you tonight? When we arrived you looked like this was the last place on earth you wanted to be and now you’re like the bloke who found a tenner in the gents.”

“Better than that.”

He waited until they were in the car before he spilled the beans.

“Seriously?”

“One hundred per cent: fake. Not only did I see it before, I can prove it.” Now he told her about the security marker.

She grinned. “Can you vandalise a piece of rubble? I love it — that’s priceless! What does it tell us though? How does it help with Jacob?”

“Well, it’s a reason to distrust RT and Andrea Harrison. Plus . . .” He held up a finger. “We don’t know whether Jack Langton is in on this scam or not. We’ll find out tomorrow.”

He turned to Miranda, expecting her to look impressed. She wasn’t.

“What? You think I should keep schtum about it for now?”

“I dunno, babe. Just remember you’re about as good at cards as Dad.”

She nodded, yielding him that. She patted his thigh. “So, you see, you don’t always need Karl around.”

“Not for some things.” He pressed his hand on hers.

Chapter 34

“You look shattered.” Karl slurped tea from a polystyrene cup. “That girlfriend of yours shouldn’t take you out gallivanting on a school night.”

Karl had already heard the fruits of their discussion with Andrea at RT’s big night. One stewed tea later, he was ready to say his piece.

“We know conclusively that RT wasn’t in the country when Jacob was attacked, based on his passport.” He broke off for a bite of a fried egg sandwich, leaning forward in time to save his jeans from the drips, if not the floor of the car.

“And the red paint wasn’t a match, so he’s not our man.”

“Not directly, anyway. But this art scam changes the landscape.” Karl churned his breakfast with every syllable.

“I don’t see how.”

“It’s another reason to wonder what else is going on in Jack Langton’s universe.”

“He’s really got under your skin, hasn’t he, Karl? I mean, I know he didn’t do you any favours when you went over the water . . .”

Karl took a savage bite of his egg sandwich and didn’t reply.

Thomas turned his attention to the world beyond the windscreen. “We’ll see what RT says tonight. I can’t wait to hear his explanation.”

“Quite the little team we’re building up, huh?”

* * *

His heart wasn’t in the day job — not today, anyway. Collect the evidence, log the details and document any observations; all for someone else’s evaluation. He knew the drill so well he didn’t have to think about it. In fact, the predominant thought was that this was his SSU career low point. Sometime in the not too distant future he’d take that up with Christine.

Lunch was an extra-large bag of chips, shared.

Karl scooped up the deep fried ambrosia of the gods. “All I’m saying is that Jack Langton’s not an idiot — far from it. Look at the evidence.” He waggled a vinegar soaked chip in the air. “Drugs, clearly; art and property; and let’s not forget the gun he supplied to Miranda’s Dad.”

“For me.” Thomas added.

He wondered how much Andrea really knew about Jack's past. Karl listened without interrupting; partly, Thomas surmised, because he was still focused on the chips. Had RT been forced into the arrangement? Did that put him back in the frame for Jacob? Some sort of retaliation and in a way only Jack would understand?

"You're neglecting another possibility, Tommo. Uncle Jack might not know anything about the art scam. Now," he cupped his chin with a greasy hand, "imagine how pissed off he'd be should his investment be exposed as a fraud. You might want to test that theory tonight over dinner." There was a hard edge to Karl's voice.

"You don't like these people any more than I do, which is saying something."

The remnants of the chip bag were offered over.

"It's different for me though, Tommy Boy. The English class struggle is your fight, not mine. Jack Langton . . ." His eyes narrowed a little at the name. "He's the enemy. Same goes for Charlie Stokes."

This was new; calm and controlled Karl making it personal.

"I've told you before, Tommo. Drug trafficking is just one of the ways the Shadow State funds its activities." Karl's lips curled into a sneer. "It's all big business — and big businesses cross national borders. They'll invest in anything that favours and furthers their interests. If I had my way I'd take them out of business permanently. Unfortunately, my orders are to gather enough information to *turn* individuals in the distribution network and track it back to source."

"And you're fine with that?"

Karl didn't answer.

* * *

The Dolan brothers were a joint investigation with a difference: identical twins. A logistical nightmare; they dressed alike with the same hairstyle and mannerisms. Karl's suggestion that they forcibly tattoo one of them didn't find any takers at the briefing.

So far they'd spent an hour watching a pizza delivery back door.

"Roland Dolan, Tommo. Jesus, that's practically child cruelty, right there."

Thomas tapped the clipboard. “Is this really a good use of our time? Couldn’t you find out their mobile numbers, ring one and see who picks up?”

“It’s not a crime to carry your brother’s mobile phone around, or to answer it. Not unless it’s a deliberate attempt to—” Karl stopped speaking.

A car pulled alongside the mopeds; one occupant — Charlie Stokes. The unnamed Dolan approached, leaned his face in the passenger window and withdrew with some sort of package.

“Extra anchovies?” Karl had picked up a discreet pair of binoculars.

The car didn’t wait, and nor did Dolan. He added the package to his rear pannier, revved up and shot off in the opposite direction.

Thomas started the car. The moped had a head start and they had additional ground to cover. But it beat sitting there, reeking of chips. They had two things in their favour: the mystery Dolan didn’t know he was being followed, so he wouldn’t be speeding, and Karl — the human road atlas.

“Cut around and turn left onto the main road. If he’s turned left we’ll catch up, and if he’s turned right we’ll see him go past us.”

“And if he turns off before we see him, we’re bugged.”

“Don’t worry, I’ve got a Plan B.” Karl reached into his bag of tricks and pulled out a handheld radio. It was tuned to a police channel. “In case we lose him and want to call it in.”

Thomas hoped it wouldn’t come to that. Police involvement was the last thing they needed. He reached the high street and eased out into traffic.

“Okay, so he’s got a package, but he could drop that off any time.”

“Nah, That’ll be drop number one and I want to see where it lands. Quick, up there – indicating right.”

Karl was spot on. Same last four characters of the number plate. They trailed the moped for another half mile, under Karl’s direction. As the pizza delivery boy pulled up, Karl made Thomas slow down.

“Give me a sec.” Karl unclipped his seat belt and wriggled through to the back seat just in time to take a big, obvious photograph.

Dolan turned towards him, helmet still on, and gave him the middle finger.

“Round the block, not too quickly; I want the little scrote to be on his way. Right now, I’m more interested in identifying the address he’s delivering to.”

* * *

Thomas had done enough surveillance over the past two years to know that there were good days and bad days. This one fell into the latter category. The dice didn't roll in their favour. The next two claimants on the list weren't where they were supposed to be — either that or they were masters of disguise — and a quick call to Dawn Yeates came to nothing because she was in a meeting.

By five o'clock there were more ticks under 'to be continued' than 'evidence completed.' Karl was mightily pissed off about it.

"Think I might go back to the delivery address tonight. Pity you're not available."

Thomas felt a pang of . . . jealousy? Yeah, something like that. Karl was on to something and meantime he was back over at Andrea Harrison's for dinner and deception. At least he had Miranda for company.

He managed a quick shower at home and put on the 'going out' clothes that he'd ironed that morning before leaving for work. Miranda picked him up at eighteen forty-five sharp, and let him drive her Mini.

On the way over they talked about RT's rogue sculpture.

"Other artists have done it as well," Miranda insisted. "I was chatting with Sheryl today and she looked it up on the net." She caught his look of disapproval. "You know you can trust Sheryl. Like I was saying, Andy Warhol used to sign blank canvases and so did Kosabi."

"Yeah, but were the punters — and the investors — in on the act?"

"Dunno. All I'm saying is that maybe this is all part of the modern art experience."

He sighed, unconvinced.

Miranda had planned in advance, ringing ahead to know which wine to bring. She'd also arranged for flowers to arrive earlier in the day, which Thomas would be paying her back for. He told her that Jack Langton would be picking up the tab, courtesy of the initial £500 John Wright was holding for him. She looked surprised, proof that even their family had its secrets.

As they walked up the street together, he started playing house in his head. These properties were way out of their league. Even so, his flat in Walthamstow and her flat in Bow, combined, would surely pay for something decent. The sight of an Aston Martin, one of his dream cars,

brought him down to earth with a thud. He was an interloper — a peasant in paradise — and about to be the bearer of very bad tidings.

“All set?” She took his arm for the last twenty yards.

The upstairs curtains were drawn and glowing golden. He imagined Andrea up there, plumping cushions and tending to her coq au vin.

Miranda rang the bell and peered through the glass. “All tidied up; you’d never know there’d been a show. It’s a better job than the cleaners we use at Caliban’s — maybe I should get their number.”

He knew she was making small talk for his benefit. She could always read his mood. This was smoke and mirrors territory. Andrea seemed like a decent person, but that didn’t mean he wouldn’t use any leverage to get information out of her. He rationalised that it was all for little Jacob, although that was only half the story. They were *bent* — no two ways about it — and he would get to the truth.

RT came downstairs to let them in. Miranda handed him the wine and his eyes lit up when he saw the label. RT carefully locked up after them, which made Thomas smile, and then led the way upstairs. He gabbled on about the show and a couple of media interviews that he had lined up, speculating about what the critics might say and how it all created a trail to the money.

RT clutched the Rioja Reserva to his heart; clever of Miranda to fetch along some quality Spanish plonk. Upstairs, things were a little more formal than his last visit. Andrea had dressed up as well. She seemed genuinely happy to see them both. Then again, she had no reason not to be — yet.

He still hadn’t figured out how to play his ace. This would be far from easy.

“How did you meet Jack?” RT fired the first salvo.

He skipped the prison visit by royal command, and started talking about Miranda’s parents, following it up with a familiar version of how he and Miranda hooked up together. It was painting by numbers — two runaways in Leeds and love’s young dream. He didn’t mention the bloke whose nose he’d broken on Miranda’s behalf, or the Bladen family feud that bubbled along like a river of discontent.

At the point when he felt he was on the ropes Miranda cut across them.

“How do you find living in Spain?”

She talked about going there a couple of times with the family when she was younger, though not in Cuenca; and once, it had to be said — and she bloody well said it — when she and Thomas had needed some cooling-off time.

Naturally, the artist in residence loved all that and began waxing lyrical about the light and the warm evenings and the *ladies* there. Thanks to RT's self-promotional tour, dinner was a little late. No matter, Miranda and the wine had oiled the wheels.

"Thomas takes urban photographs," Miranda announced, swinging a wine glass wildly over her food.

He followed her lead and told them about his early morning shots of London and the failed attempts to get on one of the dailies.

"I did say I'd be happy to take a look at your portfolio," Andrea insisted. "It's the least I can do."

He ignored the momentary scowl from Miranda and decided there were some roads he didn't need to go down. Besides, Andrea might feel differently before the night was out. He had a vague sense of how he wanted to do it. Cosy up to RT and Andrea a little more, ask for another look at his new *creation* and then go straight for the jugular.

Dinner was followed by more wine — which he declined because he was driving, and which Miranda declined because she had an early start for stocktaking. That didn't put the brakes on either RT or Andrea. By the time the chocolate torte was a pleasant memory he was beginning to wonder if they'd manage the stairs okay.

"I'd love a private view of your work." Miranda tapped RT's arm and he flickered into life like a Christmas tree. "We couldn't stop talking about it after we left your show."

Andrea was happy to bestow the favour. She led the way with RT bringing up the rear behind Miranda, charm dripping from every syllable. Down the stairs they clattered, Thomas gripping a tiny torch from his pocket. They started at the Crocodile in the main gallery room. It was all very jovial until he noticed Andrea steering the conversation round to the decor at Caliban's — ever the saleswoman. A good deal of time was spent beside *Naked Heat* and *Naked Ambition*, so that Andrea could regurgitate the tale of Thomas's bravery and the damage to the works. Her delivery was sales pitch perfect.

“And that’s what makes these pieces of urban art truly original. They’ve literally been impacted by their environment.”

RT found it hilarious. Thomas bit his tongue. *Laugh on, while you still can.* He felt his pulse quicken as they passed through the beads and approached the side room.

“I hope you don’t have a secret camera on you.” RT was drooling all over Miranda.

“Girl Guides’ honour.” She saluted with three fingers.

RT mumbled a glib remark about seeing Miranda in uniform and Thomas seriously thought about giving him a slap.

“Here we are then.” Andrea swayed a little, having long since made her peace with Bacchus and the sacred grape.

She unlocked the door. Thomas couldn’t so much as look at Miranda. RT ushered them in, still in shadow until Andrea flicked the switch and the strip lighting clicked into life. The sculpture was covered again, only this time RT was without his magic button so he had to settle for a switch on the wall. The tiny motor whirred, drawing the silvery cloth to the ceiling, where it juddered to a stop and flapped gently, suspended on a fine metal cable.

RT unclipped the rope to let everyone draw close. “I haven’t thought of a proper name for it yet.” He took Miranda’s hand. “Maybe you could come up with something?”

Thomas unclenched a fist and moistened his lips. Christmas had come early this year. “Actually, I think I can help you there. How about *fraud*?”

RT gave a chuckle but didn’t get the joke. Miranda passed Thomas the portable UV light from her bag and then cut the lights so he could deliver his coup de grace.

“So there’s no way this came over with you from Spain.”

Miranda threw the lights back on. The colour had drained from RT’s face. Andrea was looking a little peaky too.

“I warned you . . .” RT began, before thinking better of it.

Andrea was slower off the mark, but soon several steps ahead of him.

“What do you want? Name your price.”

Miranda came to the rescue. “Why don’t we go back upstairs and discuss it?”

Black coffee was now the order of the day, with the two giant sofas territories around a negotiating table. RT hunched up, hands tightly

together, unwilling to say the first word. Andrea made a couple of false starts — it was no big deal; other people did it. And besides, no one benefited from the truth coming out whereas *everyone* stood to gain if the genie stayed in the bottle.

Thomas swirled his coffee, in no doubt now that Jack Langton knew nothing about it. Miranda jumped into the fray.

“If there’s a problem, maybe Thomas can help.”

Ouch. That wasn’t in the script. RT and Andrea held a staring contest until finally Andrea cleared her throat.

“Jack was instrumental to RT’s success.”

The word reeked of something more suspect.

“I was hiding away in Spain, pretty much. I’d got into some difficulties down in Kent, so I decided to start afresh. Anyway, I met Jack out in Spain and we got chatting. I told him more than I should have, but he said he might be able to smooth things over for me. And when he found out I was an artist and he saw my work, well, he couldn’t do enough for me.

“All he wanted in return was for me to keep an eye on things for him in Spain. Most of the work is actually mine; sometimes, though, I only provide the ideas and the outline; maybe some sketches too. I had a couple of new pieces exhibited in Japan like that, because of the distance. Jack’s been fine with it in the past . . .”

Another pause; things were going down a notch.

“. . . But this time there were problems in Spain. What you might call distribution issues. I knew Jack would want me to prioritise sorting them out, so the artwork had to wait.”

“It’s what he pays you for,” Andrea chipped in.

“What about Natalie Langton?”

RT looked over to Andrea for moral support. He didn’t get any.

“Natalie doesn’t get involved with Jack’s business,” he continued. “Ray’s the man, only he and I don’t really see eye to eye. So this sculpture . . .”

“Fraud.”

“Yeah, fraud.” RT’s laugh was hollow and heavy. “It was supposed to herald a new phase of my work. There’s been a lot of interest since Jack went to prison — notoriety by association, I suppose.”

Miranda placed her coffee cup next to his. “We’re just trying to find out who might have a grudge against Jack Langton, because of the attack on the boy.”

RT nodded like he understood, or cared. Thomas suspected neither was the case. He finished his coffee and eased forward. Time to go. He nudged Miranda and they stood up to leave. Andrea tried a last ditch attempt.

“How about this: you say nothing to Jack about the sculpture’s provenance and I’m sure we can find a couple of pieces of RT’s work. One each?”

“There’s a couple of smaller works,” RT conceded. “*Naked Trust* and *Naked Need*.”

Andrea went to fetch their coats. “Why not sleep on it?” Her Turkish slippers made no sound on the rugs. “And if you wanted to realise their value, we could arrange a private sale. No one outside this room would ever know about it.”

Thomas helped Miranda on with her coat.

“And these two pieces are your *own* work?”

RT didn’t say anything. Maybe he couldn’t remember.

* * *

Thomas passed the walk back to the car wrapped up in thought. Modern art was everything he’d expected — artificial and bogus. No, give him a decent landscape or a Pre-Raphaelite: that was real art.

“Do you want me to drop you back, if you’re stocktaking first thing?”

“You really are naïve. That was for their benefit. I couldn’t very well get plastered, now could I? Your place will do very nicely; maybe I should leave a bag there or have a couple of drawers to myself. What do you reckon?”

“Have you ever considered a career in intelligence, Ms Wright?”

“Well, the intelligent thing would be to take up Andrea Harrison’s offer.” Before he could object, she added, “the pieces could stay in the gallery — on loan. They’ll feel you’re properly on-side then, so you might learn more about Jack. What do you think?”

“I think maybe we should swap jobs and I’ll run the bar.”

“I’m sure Sheryl would enjoy working under you.”

He blanched. "Let's not go there. For what it's worth, I doubt either one of them is connected with Jacob, but Karl is taking more of a personal interest in Jack than I expected."

"Is that a problem?"

"For me? No."

"Me neither." She brushed her hand down his arm. "We all want this sorted as soon as poss, so do whatever it takes."

Chapter 35

Ken stared out of the passenger window. The driver of the 4x4 wouldn't look him in the eye and had hardly spoken to him since he picked him up after midnight. The rifle was in the back somewhere and now a scratched up pistol nestled in Ken's gloved hand. The other held a set of keys.

"You're clear about where to go?"

Ken nodded and closed his fingers, engulfing the small weapon. It looked old, second world war or fifties, and there wasn't an identifying mark on it. The 4x4 pulled in and the driver put on the interior light. Ken could see the sweat on his face now.

"I'll be here for fifteen minutes. After that you're on your own."

The light blinked off.

* * *

He pocketed the gun and let himself out, closing the car door behind him with a *chunk*. Having studied the map several times he knew the route by heart, winding his way through the alleys of the housing estate. There was no name this time, just an address, keys and a time limit. It didn't sit well with him, but another £10,000 in the account would help to ease the pain.

The back gate was the only one with *PERV* painted across the front. Someone had tried to paint it over but what was left shone a garish green in the ambient light. He inserted the key and teased it round by degrees until the lock clicked. The gate swung in, silent as night; someone had seen to that. The ground floor maisonette was pitch black with heavy curtains that kept the world at bay.

He set to work on the back door with the two remaining keys and slipped inside, taking a moment to orientate himself. The bedroom was second on the right and a thin strip of light beckoned at the end of a short corridor. In a couple of breaths he was at the door, listening, waiting for the perfect moment to strike. He smiled; he'd always had an instinct for the kill.

The handle gave way under his touch, releasing more light around the door; his other hand slipped the pistol free, ready.

There was a man sitting at his computer; his back was towards him and the screen betrayed his depravity: kids.

“Jesus!” Ken gasped.

The man turned around and made a grab for something behind him. Ken was dazzled by a flash of silver as a hunting knife swung out towards him. He bumped back against the door, closing it. In a split second he made a decision and pocketed the gun.

The blade slashed wildly but he could tell it was for defence. When it came down to it most people had a natural aversion to blood — even someone else’s. Ken wasn’t most people though. He sought his moment, waiting until the blade was the furthest distance away and rushed in, one hand up to block as he punched him in the throat with the other.

The man dropped to the floor choking, fighting for breath with the blade still in his hand, and tried to scrabble backwards until the computer blocked him. Ken grabbed the hand with the knife and squeezed the fingers tight against the handle. He felt the body shuddering uselessly as it struggled against the inevitable. He forced the arm in at the elbow and levered it under until the blade glimmered beneath the victim’s ribcage.

Ken didn’t speak and he didn’t hesitate, using his whole upper body to thrust the man’s hand against his abdomen, tearing through his flesh in the process. He maintained the pressure and stared into his eyes, watching the agony and recognition on his face. Then he twisted the blade and tried to remove it. The victim’s body sagged but he didn’t die easily, lurching forward with the last of his strength to end up in a bloodied final embrace.

Ken felt the dying breath against his face and shoved him away in disgust, smashing him against the computer stand. He stood up and gazed at the blood; so much blood. Time to leave. He drew a cuff over his hand and turned the door handle, fighting the urge to vomit. As he reached the back door he grabbed a long coat that hung there and pulled it tight around himself, wearing the skin of his enemy.

It would have been quicker to just leave, but he locked the back door carefully and opened the gate. There were four people waiting across the way, three women and a man. Ken touched the pistol through the coat; the people never moved. One of the women called out.

“Is he dead?”

He nodded, turning to lock the gate behind him.

“We’ll give you ten minutes before we ring the police.”

There was nothing more to be said. The 4x4 was waiting, although he was sure he was late. As he opened the door and climbed inside, his coat opened. The driver stared at him in horror.

“What did you expect? It’s done. Take me home.”

Chapter 36

Whoever said take refuge in dreams had never spent time in Thomas's nightmares. Childhood — again. Caught out in the front room with the gun he'd found wrapped up at the back of the greenhouse. Only this time he knew it was loaded.

Dad lurched forward and Thomas retreated, waving the pistol from side to side to warn him off but it only made Dad more determined. He could smell the booze on his father's breath and the stench choked him. His arm twitched, the pistol rattling in his hand.

"Stay back! Stay back." The tears were streaming down his face now.

His father never spoke, but a guttural moan accompanied each step, that of a creature in torment.

"No!" Thomas screamed as the hands reached towards him, closing his eyes as he pulled the trigger. The whole house trembled and one of the York Minster plates on the wall smashed to the floor. Then the walls broke apart and blinding light burst in . . .

* * *

He juddered awake. Miranda grumbled and turned over. Something was buzzing. He licked dry lips and scrabbled under the covers to retrieve his mobile — set to vibrate so he didn't wake up in a panic. Nil points.

"Tommo, it's me. Get up."

"Huh?" He peered at the phone, squinting at the glare. "Karl, it's not even six yet."

"Put News 24 on and call me back."

The dream was still percolating through his brain as he dragged on some clothes and stumbled to the TV in the front room. It didn't take long to get the message. The ticker tape across the screen read: 'Convicted paedophile murdered at home.' Meanwhile, the presenter was adding details. The victim, who'd served time in prison, had been found at home after reports of a disturbance. There was no sign of forced entry to the council property. The police refused to comment on their investigation — what material might have been found at the ground floor flat, or the precise cause of death.

Thomas's blood ran cold. He'd seen enough; he muted the sound, pulled the door to, and rang Karl back.

"How did he die?"

"They're not releasing details. Don't make plans after work. I might need your help."

"Course."

"I've got a very bad feeling about this, Thomas."

* * *

Morning. Proper morning. Sat next to Karl, having yawning competitions and watching the laundry for signs of Paulette Villers. The target repeated the script from their previous stakeout, only this time there were no new bruises. Or else, he reasoned, she'd done a better job of hiding them.

"What is her partner's name?" Thomas fired off the shots.

Karl flicked through the paperwork. "Lemme see here . . . Rachel Perry — all legit. Are you gonna try another rendezvous with Paulette after she stood you up last time?"

Thomas thought back to the twenty minutes he'd spent in the café, on show and conspicuous.

"Might be worth a go. It could help us get some intel on Charlie Stokes, before I go and ask him for Jack's drugs back."

"You're really gonna do that?"

"Yeah, after I get the okay from Jack. Besides, I want to try and get Greg off the hook. Got any better suggestions?"

"If the SSU ever lays you off, you might wanna try Social Work."

In the finish they tried a different tactic altogether for Paulette Villers, driving past, out in the open. Maybe she'd react, run off . . . do *something*. Unfortunately there was no box on the evidence sheet for 'stared blankly at me as I passed her.'

"She's either a very cool customer, or she's scared witless."

"Thank you, Professor McNeill."

"Hey now, you're close. I have studied psychology."

"Really?"

Karl looked affronted. "What, you think everyone across the Irish Sea just reads Roddy Doyle and drinks pints of the black stuff? That's when

we're not listening to Van Morrison, of course."

"No, I think you drink shandy."

"Okay, Mr Philistine, where to next?"

* * *

The day played out like a series of misadventures. Roland Dolan — presumably — was nowhere to be seen, which made Thomas wonder if Paulette Villers had warned him they were onto the plot. There was no logic to it other than the link with Charlie Stokes.

Elsewhere, they failed to get anything conclusive on two supposedly single mothers, a sickness claimant that Karl insisted had 'a very lively limp,' and a man who may well have done small building jobs on the side, but who had spent his time in the lens today watching TV with his hand down his trousers.

"Manual labourer." Karl elbowed Thomas in the ribs. "Listen, fancy knocking off early to get a little shut-eye before we go out tonight?"

"Fine by me. Will you tell Christine, or shall I?"

"If you drop me back to the office, I'll pop up and see her — you go on your way."

Thomas wasn't going to pass up an invitation like that, although it bugged him that Karl was the de facto superior in their partnership. Then again, when had it ever been any different?

The drive through East London before five p.m. was a treat. He'd forgotten what it felt like to crawl through Stratford in pre peak-time traffic without losing your rag. He wondered if you could be a London driver and a Buddhist. Somewhere, at the back of his mind, he recalled Karl saying that he'd once gone out with a Buddhist. Now there was a match made in Nirvana — a pair of joss sticks and a pair of Brownings.

He made it through Leyton, steadily gaining ground until Hoe Street funnelled him to Forest Road and then home. He slept easily, surfacing just before the seven pm alarm. A shower, a cheese sandwich, a strong coffee and he was ready to face . . . Well, that was the big question — to face *what?*

He picked up Karl at Marylebone as planned. He didn't bother asking him why there, or how come Karl had put a holdall in the boot.

“All eventualities.” Karl faked a smile, closing the passenger door behind him.

Thomas knew the score. Based on last time, if Ken were implicated he’d end up at the military pub. Maybe not tonight, but some evening over the next few days, so Karl — *they* — would be there to meet him. In a twisted way it was a welcome distraction from the Jack Langton situation.

Parking was a nightmare but eventually they found somewhere and sat for a while, watching the illuminated door.

“I, er, don’t know how this is going to pan out — you do realise that?”

He nodded. That’s what life with Karl was like. “Only one way to find out.”

By the second hour, he wondered if Karl had called it wrong. The Evening Standard boasted front-page photographs of a police forensics van and the ubiquitous crime scene tape roping off the back door. More details had emerged. The police had removed a computer and bags containing ‘relevant items.’

He went back through it as the conversation withered and died. He’d craned his neck at the door so often he was starting to worry about repetitive strain injury. Thank God for the cryptic crossword.

“Nearly ten-thirty. Let’s call it a night. Same time, same place tomorrow?” There was a tinge of desperation in Karl’s voice.

He nodded, collecting the four empty glasses to deliver them back at the bar. The pub wouldn’t be getting rich on them tonight.

“I’m heading off for a piss, Tommo. I’ll see you out the front.”

From the swing door he took a last look at the walls. So much history; what must it feel like to carry the burden of all that heritage? Karl reckoned some of the regiments went back to the 1700s and beyond; another thing Karl had studied in his spare time.

The air was cold outside; an autumnal breeze that carried a hint of the winter to come. He didn’t want to wait outside the door — too many memories of childhood and Dad. So he edged round the corner and leant against a wall where he could see the car.

There was barely time to register the running footsteps and then *wham*; someone had him pinned against the brickwork with his arms by his side. Ken Treavey looked like he’d been to hell and back, and then stayed on the bus.

“Where’s McNeill?”

He stared into manic eyes and kept it brief.

“He’s just coming out the pub.”

Right answer. Ken Treavey released him, patting the air between them.

“I just . . . I just need to see him. He’s got to help me. He owes me.”

And the way he said it told Thomas all he needed to know. Pissed and pugnacious — never a good combination.

“Come back to the car — you two can talk there.”

Ken Treavey deliberated for a moment and then followed him. He climbed in the back and Thomas passed him the newspaper. The headline seemed more lurid under the streetlight.

Karl came up to the car, saw Ken and got in. “Drive, Tommo.”

They took a scenic tour of London while Ken Treavey spilled his guts. It was either the weight of his conscience, or the whisky bottle Karl had produced from his coat pocket. Whatever it was, Ken let it all pour out of him. That first, fateful meeting in Central London with the man in the Daimler, the way they seemed to know his background and his life — it all added up to an eel trap. One way in and no way out.

Ken did most of the talking, but Karl managed to coax a few extra details like the first note under his mat and the later ones through his letterbox. Ken ranted, and cried, and swore he never meant to get involved in the business of killing again. He told them how he nearly took a swing at the stranger in the 4x4, who collected the rifle only to exchange it for another weapon.

In the absence of instructions Thomas made for the North Circular Road, heading clockwise. Midnight approached and Ken was still in confession.

“I can’t go on, Karl. I can’t do it again. This last one was a bloodbath. I need to get clear.”

He slumped back into the shadow, groaning, while Thomas drove on.

“I’ll need to think on this, Ken.” Karl spoke so quietly that Thomas wasn’t sure Ken had heard him. “What you’re asking, well, it would need planning. You can’t just disappear — given what you’ve done, you’d be a liability for them.”

Thomas gestured to the sign for Finchley, but Karl shook his head.

“Nah. If this is going to work then everything has to carry on as normal — for now. I’ll tell you where to turn off so we can drop him home. This is just an evening out with a couple of pals. He’s in no fit state to do anything tonight anyway.”

Hardly surprising, Thomas thought, since you’ve been anaesthetising him. It wasn’t long before they heard heavy snoring behind them.

“I’ll talk with him properly when he’s sober — find out how it all works.”

Thomas nodded and took a turn-off for Tottenham. Karl reached into the glove compartment for a street guide, reading it by torchlight. He navigated the car through the back roads to Stoke Newington, calling out left and right turns at places where Thomas couldn’t even read the street names. Maybe it was deliberate.

The car finally juddered to a halt near a housing estate, not far from a kebab shop. Karl turned to the back seat. “He’s still sparko. I’ll have to get him back into his flat. I could use a hand.”

The two of them roused Ken and dragged him out of the car. He seemed to revive once he was outside, insisting that he buy everyone a kebab. To Thomas’s surprise, Karl took him up on the offer and the three of them gravitated like moths towards the neon. Ken waved a twenty in the air. The poor sod at the till, who Ken repeatedly called *Abdul*, took their orders and went off to prepare the delicacy. Thomas managed to call out ‘no chillies’ just in time.

Ken pocketed the change, took several bites of his fiery kebab in rapid succession and then launched into a unique rendition of *Flower of Scotland*. Thomas quickly realised that they were visible and memorable — in case anyone came round asking questions. If Sir Peter Carroll was involved, Daimler and all, anything was possible.

As they steered Ken home, he entered the repetitive phase of drunkenness, telling Karl over and over that he knew his old oppo would see him right. Karl didn’t reply, which suggested he didn’t share Ken’s optimism.

Ken’s shoes scuffed on the steps and, as he rolled up his sleeves Thomas caught a glimpse of a tattoo and wondered if Karl had one that matched — comrades in arms and all that. Making the most noise, Ken

shushed his companions and then laughed at nothing. Thomas reckoned it would all end in tears.

Finally, with some assistance, Ken got his front door key in the lock. As the door gave way and he staggered inside, Karl held a finger up for Thomas to wait there and went in after him. *Flower of Scotland* echoed again, followed by the sound of a kitchen skirmish. Thomas listened, aware of the night air against the back of his neck.

“Enough!”

That was Karl’s voice, clear as a bell, and then exit one agitated Irishman clutching a white plastic bag. “Let’s get out of here, Tommo.” He squeezed the top of the bag tighter. “Don’t ask unless you really want me to tell you.”

He could see bloodied clothes inside, pressing against the plastic. No further questions.

“I’ll drive you home if you direct me.”

“Are you sure? It’s out of your way.” Karl still had the bag in a stranglehold.

“Yeah, it’s fine.” He started up the car and waited to be given his orders.

It wasn’t so much a plan that Karl put together on their journey over to Kilburn, more a collection of jigsaw pieces, incomplete, but telling. Two of them led directly to Sir Peter Carroll: Ken’s meeting and Thomas delivering a weapon, whose purpose was no longer in any doubt. Then there was the choice of Ken as some kind of — executioner? For all his bluster and *Rule Britannia*, Sir Peter had his connections, so why get someone like Ken to do his dirty work? Except that Ken had previously served in the armed forces with Karl.

“What do you think, Thomas? Sir Peter Carroll is surely smarter than that.”

He couldn’t fault Karl’s logic, although he did have one question.

“Despite what you know, you’re still willing to help him?” His gaze went to the plastic bag.

Karl sighed, long and hard. “For the time being. I don’t expect you to understand.”

“What, being a civilian?” Thomas managed a wry smile. “I understand loyalty, but there’s such a thing as morality.”

Karl's shoulders seemed to broaden. "Let me ask you this: was it moral when you tried to kill Yorgi out on the moors?"

He crushed his hands to the steering wheel. "No question. He had it coming."

"Some would say the same about a child murderer and a convicted paedophile."

That was about all the conversation Thomas felt like having for a while. When the car stopped, Karl unbuckled his seatbelt and carefully manoeuvred out of the passenger seat with the bag. "I'll just grab my other bag out of the boot. Listen, we need to see Ken again soon. Maybe tomorrow morning before work?"

"Can't — I'm back at the prison."

"What tangled webs we weave, eh Tommo? Right you are; we'll rendezvous later and compare notes. Goodnight, and thanks again."

He drove home with the window open, the breeze cold against his face. It kept his senses sharp and stopped him from drifting. Something was bothering him; something Ken had said. There was only one person he knew, connected with Sir Peter Carroll, who drove a 4x4.

Chapter 37

Before heading for the prison Thomas visited the heathland again. It didn't help much. Jack's oppressive effect seemed to meet him at the gates and he found himself rehearsing what to say. Although he knew the drill better now, he didn't think he'd ever feel comfortable doing this — especially solo. This time he showed his SSU ID at the reception desk before joining the queue. Christine would likely find out anyway.

John Wright had made it clear that Jack knew all about the missing drugs now and was not a happy man. In the absence of John's company he eavesdropped and observed the other visitors, mentally filling in the blanks.

"You behave nicely when you see your dad, and remember what I told you — keep your mouth shut and I'll take you to the zoo later."

He glanced at the woman's outfit; a little too alluring for a prison, unless she was trying to show hubby, and the prison staff, what he was missing. Odds on, there'd be a bloke waiting for her at Regent's Park.

An older woman edged forward, eyes down, a loose fist clutched to her chest. He shifted position until he could make out the beads around her neck and figured she was holding on to a crucifix. Good luck there, luv, if she was hoping God would intervene.

He worked his way through the people around him, putting two and two together. Assumptions dressed up as deductions — it helped to pass the time. John reckoned Jack Langton was becoming paranoid. First the attack on his niece's boy, then losing half a kilo of coke, and now Andrea Harrison's gallery had been done over. Idiot's logic — look for a common denominator and then string everything together. Like Karl had said: correlation is not causality. Still, it suited him to have Jack Langton on the back foot. Hopefully it would make him more manageable.

The visitors' hall had the same sanitised despondency and dismal decor, only it felt a little brighter. It took him a moment to work out they'd replaced the duff neon strip light in one corner; it didn't lighten the mood any.

Although he had asked to see Jack Langton on his tod he knew he wouldn't be the one calling the shots. He pawed at his pocket where he'd

stashed his ID and pictured Christine watching him blip on a screen map.

Maybe it was an optical illusion but Jack seemed to have a bigger table and slightly better chairs: king of the mountain. He felt Jack's eyes on him from the second he entered the arena, weighing him up.

"Thanks for seeing me like this." Thomas extended a hand, shook and then took his seat.

"Well," Jack folded his arms and smirked to himself, "it's not like I had somewhere else to be. So, what's on your mind?"

Thomas gave a cursory glance around. It wasn't every day you asked someone for several grand to buy back their stolen illegal drugs.

"Shoot." Jack leaned back and laced his fingers behind his head.

He gave it to him straight, both barrels. If Jack was perturbed about his merchandise going missing he didn't show it.

"I've talked with Natalie, erm, Mrs Langton. She's gonna set up a meeting with Ray."

"Was it Janey?"

Now it was Thomas's turn to play poker.

"Nah, course not." Jack did his thinking aloud. "Janey wouldn't do that to me — she's loyal."

Thomas said nothing; not every problem was his to solve.

"Greg, eh?" Jack sucked at his teeth. "Well, that's for another time. Who'd he sell it to?"

"Charlie Stokes."

Jack's jaw tightened.

Thomas swallowed. "Natalie said Ray thinks there's a reasonable chance of buying it back."

"Right." Jack changed demeanour, bringing his arms forward to rest on the table. "Offer him fifteen K then. It's worth more because of the purity, but Charlie won't want any bad blood between us again."

The word 'again' pinged on Thomas's radar. Talk turned to Mrs Langton, which threw him off balance.

"She's a good girl, is Natalie. And Ray will look after you. You can trust him."

Maybe, Thomas thought, but *you* can't.

"So what's your next move — with the boy?"

He could tell Jack was enjoying this. Maybe the telly wasn't up to much. He trod carefully.

"Well, I've ruled out any connection to Andrea Harrison. I also met your artist mate from Spain, RT. He's clean too."

Jack cracked a broad smile. "Bit of a poser, eh? Dependable though. I couldn't see him biting the hand that feeds him — I'd break his jaw. But that's good to know."

"Of course, you have to check these things out." There was a lull in the conversation, so he made good use of it. "Jack . . ." He strung the word out to suggest subservience. "What do you know about Charlie Stokes? Anything we can use?"

"Lemme see now." Jack rubbed his hands together slowly. "Ex-army; some fancy regiment — don't ask me what. Marines or something. His patch borders mine and we have an understanding; we keep out of one another's way. His delivery service is mostly a side line." Jack's voice, low anyway, now sounded like an ad for throat lozenges.

"Do you know the Dolans?"

Jack stretched back and sniffed. "Kevin Dolan used to do some work for me, until Ray showed up. Last I heard Kevin had gone up north — apparently he got into some bother with a skirt. He was like that. Why d'you ask?"

He shrugged. "No reason. One of the twins does deliveries for the pizza place."

Jack's pupils enlarged; this was new information to him. "Yeah, I'll bet he does!" He cracked a smile. "That'll be Roland. Charlie took the place over a year or so ago. It sounds like you've taken an interest in Mr Stokes?"

"I'm just following all lines of inquiry like you asked me to." He could feel his pulse jumping in his throat.

Jack smiled again; a gold tooth gleamed under the strip lights. "Good." He folded his massive arms. "You've got your head screwed on. What's your dad do for a living?"

He didn't have time to make up a lie. "He was a miner; drives a minicab now."

"A grafter. Like father like son, eh? My ol' man worked down the docks. Long hours and shit conditions. He used to see all sorts coming in under the table and he wised up in the end. Taught me a lot, my dad."

Debrief over, the talk became more casual. Jack did a nifty line in the lives of those around him. “Geezer two tables back, over my left shoulder?” Jack didn’t even bother to look round. “What do you see?”

Thomas glanced over. “Bloke talking to his mum?”

“She’s there cos his wife refuses to come . . .” Jack winked and then dished the dirt on half a dozen fellow inmates.

Thomas breathed a little easier when one of the prison staff called out, “Five more minutes!” He asked Jack what he planned to do when he got out, seeing as they were mates now, and all.

Jack was clearly a man full of ideas. “. . . And I thought I’d take Natalie and the kids away somewhere — Marseille maybe, or Gambia. The bloke I share a cell with was talking about it this week. Course, she’ll probably wanna bring her mother along. Then again, she can look after the kids, like now.”

Jack found his own musings hilarious, so Thomas let him get on with it. Like his French teacher at school used to say: ‘It’s your own time you’re wasting.’

They shook hands at leaving time and to Thomas it seemed they were both prisoners now.

“Listen, how’d you like to earn a few extra quid?”

“You’re paying me plenty.” Thomas shrank back into his chair; it was starting to feel like a hostile takeover.

Jack nodded. Thomas wasn’t sure whether he’d passed a loyalty test or dodged a bullet.

“Keep an eye on Natalie for me, will you? I’d like to be kept informed.” Jack held his gaze in a chokehold.

* * *

The grey skies of Acton were a welcome relief from Jack’s spidery lair. He walked quickly to put some distance between him and the Scrubs. Karl was quick to pick up the call.

“How goes it, Tommo?”

“Let’s just say if you are ever banged up in prison, I won’t be visiting you very often. Incidentally, Natalie’s mum came up in conversation. How was your morning?”

“Productive and disturbing, in equal measure. I met with our friend and he explained a few more things. Not on the phone — I’ll tell you when I see you.” The call tailed off, although he could still hear Karl breathing. “I’ll pick you up at Dalston Junction, soon as.”

* * *

The Dalston pick-up was short-lived. He wondered whether Natalie’s mother should join the list and Karl had an interesting take on it.

“Get someone else to do it; it’s just background. Learn to delegate.”

He was about to ask for suggestions when the penny dropped. They were in Dalston, home to a bona fide private investigator by the name of Thurston Leon. Perfect, if the bloke could get over the beating he got on the last job Thomas had given him.

“Mr Leon has never let me down yet.” Karl was reaching into his jacket.

No, Thomas thought, and thanks to mugs like me he’s never even met you.

“You’ll be needing this.” Karl pulled out an unsealed envelope filled with notes. “£200, to be going on with.”

“So you knew about Natalie Langton’s mother?”

“Much as I would like to claim omniscience, Tommo, I was thinking more about Charlie Stokes, but let’s work our way up the food chain. You go and charm Leon; I’m going shopping.”

The receptionist was new, or filling in. Her blonde hair looked like an explosion in a *Clairol* factory. The earrings and lipstick was 100% celebrity magazine. If she were waiting to be discovered, she’d made it as difficult as possible by hiding in Dalston. She looked like she had somewhere better to be and, simultaneously, had no chance of getting there.

“Can I help you?” Her clipped attempt at culture had the opposite effect.

“I’d like to see Mr Leon.”

“I’ll check if he’s free.”

He drifted off to the waiting area, glancing between the lettering on the window, and set himself down in a cane chair. The magazines on the table were an eclectic mix — old editions of *Caribbean Times*, *The New Yorker*

and some computing mag with the cover missing. Someone had made a trip to the charity shop.

He heard half a conversation. Celebrity Girl's accent seemed to have slipped a couple of notches.

"Woz he like? I dunno; he's a bloke. See for yourself."

The office door opened a crack. Thomas looked up and the door widened.

"Well, brudder; I never expected to see your face again. The only reason I'm not throwing you out on the street is because of the bonus you sent me after our last . . . adventure."

Thomas smiled, realising that Karl must have sent the cash. The last time Thurston Leon had kept tabs on Jack Langton he had suffered a beating; while Thomas had fared little better, with his car getting crowbarred while he was still in it.

"So what ye want?"

"I have some business — if you're interested?"

Leon let go of his door and it creaked open.

"You better come inside."

It wasn't exactly the espionage job of the century, and even then Thomas played it down. Just a simple case of keeping an eye on Natalie Langton's mum for a few days, albeit with a few conditions. He picked up Leon's business card.

"I want everything by email. I'll be in touch with my email address."

That is, once he'd created one. It was all done and dusted in ten minutes, and he left there £200 lighter. Karl wasn't around when he got back to the car, so he checked his mobile. There was a text from his sister and an update on the Yorkshire bairn — happy families everywhere he looked.

Karl finally put in an appearance with two carrier bags.

"Sorry, too good a chance to miss. I thought I'd treat myself to something special tonight. Fancy joining me for dinner?"

"Your place is tiny."

"I know; that's why I thought we could use your kitchen."

He glanced at the bags. "That looks like a lot of food."

"Yeah, about that. I thought it might do Ken good to get away from his usual patch. And without alcohol on tap he might open up a bit. What do

you reckon?”

It all sounded like a done deal. “Okay, you better let him know.”

Karl shifted from foot to foot. So that had already been taken care of then.

“Any more surprises?”

“Er, well, I took the liberty of inviting Miranda as well.”

“Fuck me, Karl; why not make it a party and have done with it?” He smiled a little, to let Karl know he was kidding, but Karl’s face was hard as marble.

“Thing is, Thomas, I might need her help.”

Chapter 38

They were en route to the Dolans' place when Karl took a call on his mobile.

"Right; I see. No, we can come in now — absolutely, no problem at all. We're on our way." He switched off his mobile and kept it in front of him. "Dawn Yeates wants us to go straight to the office."

"Which reminds me, how did your *meeting* go? Did she turn up?"

"Cheeky bastard; of course she did. It was all above board. Listen; more importantly there's been some movement on the Monica Kinley front. It seems they've called her in for an interview. Dawn wants us to make statements."

"How's that, exactly?"

"I dunno. No doubt she'll explain everything when we get there."

Dawn met them at reception and took them through to a back office on the ground floor. Thomas could see something had changed — maybe Karl's dating technique had put her back up.

The office was big enough for one large table and four seats; no windows and no sign that a cleaner had been anywhere near for a while. The bin, squeezed into one corner of the room, was already choked with plastic cups; all in all, a classic interrogation room. It didn't help that Dawn directed the two of them to the seats furthest from the door. She sat opposite, her mobile resting on the table in front of her.

"When did Monica Kinley come in?" Karl's voice had an edge to it.

"She's here now. The preliminary discussion raised sufficient concerns that I've asked a social worker to do an emergency visit with the police."

Thomas was starting to feel a little side lined. "So what has she said?" The word 'entrapment' loomed large in his head.

"She said that you knocked on her door . . ." Dawn folded her arms and waited.

". . . After I helped her aunt home — she had a fall."

"Yes, Monica said that too."

Thomas had a sense of something unspoken in the air.

“Look, Dawn.” Karl slapped his fingertips down on the table. “It’s unorthodox, I grant you. But we could hardly leave the old lady lying in the street. Thomas wanted to make sure Dorothy was okay. We did offer to call a doctor, but Monica wouldn’t have it.”

He watched the two of them play a watered down version of the ‘angry silence’ game — first person to speak is the loser. They were amateurs, compared to his parents.

Dawn’s mobile trilled into life. She was out the door, mid-greeting.

Thomas turned to Karl. “What is going on?”

Karl fiddled with an imaginary Stan Laurel tie. “Beats me.”

Fifteen minutes later, Thomas had explored the tiny room in detail and concluded that there were no cameras or listening devices. He’d even checked the bin to be on the safe side. The room was exactly what it seemed — an eyesore. He sat beside Karl, facing forward: exam conditions. Though God only knew what they were being tested for.

Dawn Yeates returned in a flourish, almost smashing the door against the back of an empty chair. “I’m sorry to have kept you.” She loitered by the door, as if guarding an escape route. “There’s been a development. I need you to wait a bit longer. I’ll organise some hot drinks and a biscuit.”

When she returned again she wasn’t alone. One of the boys in blue was behind her, notebook in hand.

“Karl, could you come outside please. I need to separate the two of you to give statements.” Dawn stared down at him. “The police forced entry to the property and Dorothy Kinley was found dead. “Looks like she’s been dead for some time.”

“Weeks. Months, probably.” The copper couldn’t hide his glee. “And to think you boys are supposed to be the observant ones.”

Two separate statements, a review of their evidence sheets and a difficult conference call with Christine Gerrard sucked the life out of the day.

“Come on, Karl,” Thomas muttered, as they eased their way past a line of grinning bastards, “we can hardly blame ourselves.”

“How could we not have spotted there was something amiss with the sprightly Mrs Kinley?”

The conversation continued in the car, on the way over to Liverpool Street.

“Wrapped in plastic sheeting, apparently. Grim, but hygienic.” Karl waded through the details.

Clearly, he’d gotten more out of his copper than Thomas had. The lass he’d given a statement to had only said, at regular intervals, “and you really had no idea?”

He drove to the underground car park, still conjuring with the implications. “So why dress up as her aunt to collect the pension in person when she could have had it paid straight into an account?”

“I suppose, when it comes down to it, she’s not a criminal mastermind. She must have thought it was a good way to show Aunt Dorothy was still alive.”

“This won’t look good in the papers.”

“Rest assured, the SSU won’t get a mention. Christine will see to that.”

“Well, that might be difficult in a murder investigation.”

“Who said anything about murder? A fiver says it’s natural causes.”

“Bollocks. Unless you’ve seen a police report . . . Have you?”

Karl drew a thumb and index finger across his lips.

The chances of Karl revealing a hidden alliance were infinitesimal to nil, but it was worth the accusation to see the look on his face.

“I’ll be off now to get Christine to authorise a car for the night. I’ll see you at your place in about an hour.”

“What about the food in the car?”

“Take it with you; I’ll bring the fish — and Ken.”

* * *

Maybe Thomas should have expected Miranda on his doorstep. She’d waited outside this time, parked in his usual spot.

“Table for four?”

“Apparently so. Karl’s doing the cooking, if he turns up in time.”

“I’m sure we can give him a helping hand. What are friends for?”

That was a very good question.

* * *

Sober, Ken was a very different proposition. He arrived in a shirt and tie, spick and span like some of the blokes Thomas had seen at the military pub. Those trousers looked like they could cut paper. He’d even brought along chocolates, bless ’im.

Karl settled him in the front room and then made himself scarce, leaving it to Miranda to drum up conversation. Thomas loved watching Miranda in action; she had the gift of the gab, just like her mum and dad. Ken asked if the Mini was hers and soon they were talking about cars. Ken liked a bit of Grand Prix and Miranda had picked up enough gen from her Dad and the boys to maintain the flow.

He sat with them for a while and then judged it was safe to check on the kitchen. Karl stood at the eye of the storm with all his ingredients chopped in separate piles. Thomas recognised the plantain from Walthamstow Market.

“It won’t be authentic Salt Fish and Ackee, but you’ll love it.” Karl dropped a wooden spoon on the counter.

Thomas put it on a stand and wiped up the mark. “Do you want to tell me what’s going on and why you’ve dragged Miranda into this?” He pulled the kitchen door closed. “Does she know about Ken?”

“Of course not. What do you take me for?”

“Right now? I’m not even sure. Where did you learn to cook like this, anyway?”

“To be sure, sir,” Karl parodied his own Northern Irish accent. “Did you think we only cooked potatoes?”

“Listen . . .” The word caught in Thomas’s throat. “. . . Don’t put her at risk, okay?”

The kitchen suddenly felt claustrophobic. He left Karl to it.

Dinner was served with great occasion. Karl did everything but ring a bell. Thomas forgave him that because the food smelled fantastic. Maybe Karl had done a spell in the Catering Corps.

“Okay, Ken.” Karl cut through the chatter. “Permission to speak freely?”

“Granted.” Ken played along.

To Thomas’s eye, while Karl’s army oppo didn’t exactly look at ease, it was the most relaxed he’d seen him without singing.

“You get your money by cash card, correct?” Karl picked out a fishbone.

“That’s right — a £300 a day limit.”

“Hmm. Not much time to stockpile cash before you need to be away. You know why they gave you a card?”

“So I can’t empty the account in one go?”

“Well, there’s that. But also . . .” Karl looked to Thomas, inviting him in.

“They can see where and when you make each withdrawal.”

Ken carried on eating. “That’s clever, but how does that help me?”

Karl seemed to stall for an answer, so Thomas took the heat off him.

“What if you weren’t where the card was — like a blind?”

“What is it with you two? Are you some kind of double act? And while we’re about it, exactly what part of the civil service are you in?”

Thomas took a swig of juice. “Doesn’t matter. What’s important is finding a solution to your problem.”

Miranda coughed quietly. “If the cash card was cloned you could have two people using them at different locations.”

Karl came to life again. “Why stop at two? How about six, all around the country?” He was already running with the idea. “It would need coordination though. I imagine it’d be a small window before that sort of usage was flagged up somewhere.”

“What?” Ken rubbed his forehead. “You mean have several cards and then I can get all my money out?”

“No. It doesn’t work like that; your limit would be the same but it’d give you a head start in your disappearing act.”

“Aye, I see. Well, I thought I’d go to—”

“No!” Karl snapped. “Better you don’t tell anyone, including me.”

“So what if another *job* comes up in the meantime, before you get this plan of yours sorted?”

“What can I say, Ken? I’ll put this together as quickly as possible. Until then . . .”

Ken loosened his tie. “Have you got any drink here?”

“Cameras,” Thomas piped up. “Some cash points have little cameras in them. Easy to tell which card was actually used by Ken.”

“Well some of them, yes.” Karl patted the table, as if to say *play it down*. “If anybody was really that keen to track someone.”

Thomas stared, wide-eyed. Of course Sir Peter would be keen; he’d spy on his own mother for Queen and Country, and then turn her in.

Karl took a breath. “Okay, who’s for ice cream? Miranda, would you care to accompany me to the shop? You two, you’re on washing-up detail.”

As soon as the front door slammed, Thomas cleared the plates away. Ken remained at the table, as if he needed permission to move. Thomas sussed that this was a bloke who didn't make friends easily.

"You can switch the telly on if you like. I'll put things into soak. Fancy a brew?" He reckoned he knew the kind Ken really wanted, but that wasn't going to happen tonight.

"You into photography as well?" Ken followed him out, gazing at a moody black and white of fishing boats at Whitby.

"Yeah, got my own little dark room here."

"Is that how you and Karl became pals? Nothing personal, Thomas, only something about you doesn't make sense. Don't get me wrong, I am grateful and everything, and I'll not forget it."

He could feel the unspoken word: *civilian*.

"I don't know what Karl's told you, and I was pretty hammered that night outside the pub, so God knows what I was ranting about. Even so, you don't seem fazed by any of this." Ken scowled. "I can't figure you out."

"Does it matter?" The guy was beginning to make him nervous. Karl's dinner guest had killed two people, after all.

"Mebbe not. And what about Miranda? How does she fit into all this?"

"Karl's the one with all the answers. Ask him when he gets back."

"I bloody will," he said, and they both smiled. Finally, they had something in common.

Thomas would have been hard pushed to say which of them was more relieved at the sound of Miranda's key in the door. They'd struggled gamely to find something in common. It turned out Ken had no interest in photography or rugby. Guns, probably, but Thomas gave that a wide berth.

"It's chocolate chip — it was either that or some low fat nonsense." Karl joined the gentlemen's club while Miranda carried on to the kitchen.

During ice cream and coffee Thomas brought out a notepad. Karl seemed more confident and Miranda more subdued, suggesting they'd had words in the car. Thomas was reduced to secretary.

Karl said he'd take charge of cloning the cash card, and insisted that Ken keep a low profile until they contacted him again. In the meantime Miranda would speak to her family about rustling up some unconnected people around the country. She promised to get a list back to Karl pronto.

“Here.” Karl passed Ken a slip of paper. “If you ever feel in real danger call me and I’ll come get you. Emergencies only.”

* * *

Everything was done and dusted by ten-thirty. After Karl took Ken away with him Thomas and Miranda lay sprawled together on the settee, listening to Paul Young’s *No Parlez*.

“Did Karl say anything to you in the car?”

She smiled. “I never knew you were the jealous type.”

Of course you did, he thought. “Seriously.”

She adjusted a cushion. “He wanted to know if Mum and Dad could get a cash card cloned and he asked for a favour, if it came to it — a bed for Ken, for one night.”

“He’s got a bloody nerve . . .”

“You know Mum and Dad are happy to help him. He’s helping you with Jack Langton. That’s what friends do. Or didn’t they teach you that in Pickering?” Her face grew serious. “Out with it, Thomas. I can always tell.”

He let go of her. “Would you have felt differently about me, well, about us, if I’d killed Yorgi on the moors?”

“Oh, let’s not go back over old ground.”

“No, this is important. You wanted to know what’s bothering me.”

“You were trying to protect me — and anyway you didn’t kill him.”

“But what if I had? What sort of man would that make me?”

“Is this because Karl and Ken were in the army together?”

So he told you that at least. “No, listen.” He swung her legs off him and sat up to face her. “Supposing I had killed Yorgi — like I wanted to?”

“What do you want me to say? I’m glad he’s dead. He deserved to die.” She pulled her knees up under her chin and then brushed at her fringe. “Let the past go. No more talk about guns and monsters tonight. Karl can deal with all that stuff.”

He followed her to the bedroom, wishing she were right.

Chapter 39

Karl picked him up from Bethnal Green Tube, an hour later than usual, a sandwich in foil waiting on the passenger seat. Thomas didn't bother to question the change of rendezvous. Karl always had his reasons.

"Fried egg, not ten minutes old. We're celebrating. I've had mine already."

The crumpled tin foil on the floor was proof of that. He busied himself with the celebratory sarnie and let Karl turn evangelist.

"So . . ." Karl yawned out the word. "We're on track for Ken's disappearing act."

"When?" Thomas licked lukewarm egg yolk from his fingers. "Because once Ken's safely out the way there should be nothing stopping us talking to Sir Peter Carroll."

He finished his sarnie and folded the foil neatly into a square, placing it in the door pocket.

"That wouldn't be my preferred course of action, Thomas."

"Easy for you to say — you weren't the dumb bastard who transported the murder weapon." He stopped speaking and waited for his brain to catch up. "Ken said someone collected the rifle. How did he kill the second bloke?"

Karl turned a defensive shade of red. "All I did was give him the rifle when we recovered it."

Thomas smiled at the bluff. "That wasn't what I asked you. Answer the question."

Karl fidgeted a little in his seat. The engine was still running but they hadn't gone anywhere. He glanced skyward, huffed and turned off the ignition.

"I wanted to do this later."

"Let's not fuck about, Karl. Miranda's family have gone beyond the call for your army mate. From where I'm sitting you owe me big time."

Karl folded his arms and stared at his knees.

"Glove compartment. I was gonna show you later once we had a coffee break."

Thomas clicked the button slowly and deliberately. The flap lowered like a mouth that wanted to say something. He smiled; a brown envelope — how could it be anything else? The first image was a long lens of a front door, part way along a balcony — Ken's, presumably. The next showed someone standing at the door with his back to the camera. The third, of someone handing over a small package to the stranger, had part of Ken's face in shot. Thomas paused to look at it, sensing Karl looking at him.

"They told Ken when to be ready, so he beeped me before he opened the door."

Thomas noticed the shadows under Karl's eyes.

"When did you last get a decent night's sleep?"

"Honestly? The day before Ken showed up in my life again. You'd better go on."

Happy snap number four was Ken receiving a package in return. Thomas figured it was the replacement weapon. He was about to flick to the next photograph when Karl grabbed his wrist.

"You need to know that I had absolutely no idea about this."

Thomas wrenched his hand free and revealed the last picture. It was Bob Peterson. Now he remembered Ken muttering about a visitor in a 4x4. The power of speech momentarily deserted him. Only momentarily.

"What the fuck is going on?"

Karl started the car. "I don't know. Truly. Now do you see why I want Ken out of the picture?"

Thomas breathed into his hands, slow and steady. "I think we have to assume the worst. Peterson's not an idiot — and he's well connected." He knew Karl would be insulted by that. "I'll need to talk to him."

Karl reared back in his seat. "Hang on a minute; let's not be hasty."

Thomas put the photos back in the envelope. "I take it you have copies?"

"Yep."

"Good, then I'll keep these. Maybe I can use them as leverage with Bob."

"Or collateral."

"Come again?"

"I hate to break the bad news to you, Tommo, but he may well have a set with you in them."

“Jesus, Karl. I need coffee.”

Chapter 40

Thomas was developing a fascination with the news, searching the bulletins and Karl's tabloids with grim determination.

He wondered why Karl permitted the nightmare to continue, but that presumed Karl controlled anything anymore.

He took Miranda's advice and they went back to Andrea Harrison to agree to her proposal — two artworks in private ownership, on loan to the gallery, with a discreet sale should they ever require it. He had no intention of collecting on the deal, but Miranda had done an Internet search and the maths so they were able to talk numbers to her. It all added to the illusion that they were on the make.

RT's relief that night had led to an evening of Anis-fuelled revelations. Miranda made the ultimate sacrifice with her liver, saving Thomas's head as the designated driver. Once Andrea had practically passed out, RT couldn't stop talking. Not quite a distribution timetable, but a couple of names and entry ports, and some ingenious methods of concealment and transportation. Now Thomas understood why RT was so valuable to Jack Langton. The Spanish climate was great for cannabis plantations.

* * *

Karl disappeared for a day. He'd warned Thomas the previous night that he'd be phoning in sick and suggested they meet after work. Work that was now down to Johnny No-Mates. At least, it would have been had Christine not instructed Thomas to swing by the office and pick up Ann. It was starting to feel like musical chairs.

The East London traffic was unforgiving, every hesitation punished by some cunning bastard trying to edge him out of the lane. Ah, those chirpy cockneys. Like Barry Manilow he 'made it through the rain' and parked up underground.

He got into the lift and hit the button for the second floor, watching as the door closed with precision and counting the six seconds in his head. No sooner had the lift started than it began to slow. First floor: MI5.

The lift door slid open and an Asian woman in a smart suit got in.

“It’s Thomas, isn’t it?” She delivered the line so casually that it was clear she knew who he was.

Just as he recognised she was British-born, educated, and knew where to shop. Then again, maybe MI5 gave out a clothing allowance. His eyes drifted down to her belt and he read the ID card hanging there: Rupindra Tagore. He nearly said, ‘Like the poet,’ but no one likes a smart-arse. Besides, his brain was already preparing for a forward roll. In two years he’d never seen someone travel up from the first floor. Maybe she was lost on her first day.

They smiled with their eyes, saying nothing, playing the diplomacy game. He was first out of the lift and then it was follow the leader. Past the vending machine and sharp right. He swiped her in; since it was obvious she wasn’t there by accident. She headed towards Christine’s office and Ann raised her head from her desk like a meerkat.

“Hi, Rupee! How are you?”

He held back to watch their brief exchange before Rupee took a seat at Christine’s desk.

“Right then.” Ann watched him, watching her. “I’m all yours.” She locked her desk with a theatrical flourish and picked up her bag. “I do hope Karl feels better soon.”

* * *

At first, being out in the car with Ann Crossley was like sitting an extended driving test. He went through the assignment sheets, brought her up to speed on progress and actions outstanding, and then suggested a takeaway coffee before they took another crack at the Dolans.

She seemed amenable, but he could never quite make her out. Karl was Mister Cloak and Dagger, no question about it. Ms Crossley, on the other hand, didn’t even leave a shadow. Here was a woman who created spread sheets voluntarily. From the way she conducted herself, she evidently thought she was destined for better things. Maybe she was already laying the groundwork for a move to MI5. He gave her the benefit of the doubt. She had saved his arse when Greg took a kicking — an event that Karl had never really explained. *Quelle surprise*. It was the not knowing about Ann that really bothered him: gay, straight, politics, lifestyle? Nothing.

Subject Dolan came into view on his pizza moped. Ann waited for Thomas to finish taking a batch of pictures.

“Don’t you ever want more than this?”

He pondered that. Did she mean working in the SSU or working with Karl?

“I’m not sure what else I’m good for.” He chose the words deliberately — good *for*, not good at.

“Someone with your abilities, Thomas?” The first syllable of his name betrayed her Welsh roots. “I’m sure an opportunity could be found.”

He shrugged off the compliment. Sir Peter Carroll had said much the same thing, several months ago. And look how that was working out for him.

“Karl won’t be here forever. Europe may be calling for him.”

Interesting, given Karl’s recent trip to Geneva.

“I meant to ask,” he ricocheted the conversation. “How did you get on with the Southampton job?”

She blushed — a fleeting flare of conscience. “I’d rather not talk about that . . .”

“We’re on the same team, aren’t we? Besides, we both know Bob Peterson has already met with a contact from . . . what would you like me to call them?”

She smiled. “You really are relentless. That’s why I know you could do more.”

“RAF Intelligence? It’s not quite my style.”

“No, I agree, not yet. But with the right mentoring . . .”

“Dolan’s on the move.” *Saved by the bell.*

Thomas followed the same course as before, assuming that Dolan had a regular delivery route. Sure enough, the moped took an identical turn and Thomas slotted in behind a bread van. He figured it would be the same address as last time, so he veered right and put his foot down in search of a parking spot. He didn’t say anything and neither did Ann, as they waited ten doors away on the opposite side of the road. The moped’s rasping engine grew louder until it pulled up by the same olive-coloured front door.

He dropped the window enough to allow the lens to breathe, racking up shots while Ann checked through his paperwork. He gave her a running commentary.

“Dolan is off the moped, pannier unlocked, pizza box extracted, knocking on the door now . . . same bloke as last time — skinny, shirt and tie, head like a pencil rubber.”

Crossley didn’t laugh; she coughed a little instead. Stick to the job at hand.

“Delivery being made, money changing hands.”

He cut the soundtrack once he realised what was actually going on. The man at the olive door took delivery of *something* but it wasn’t pizza. And it looked like he’d put something back inside the box before returning it. This was what Karl called a game changer. And frankly, he should have seen it before. Whatever young Dolan was delivering, he was also collecting merchandise for Charlie Stokes.

“Did you get everything on film, Thomas?”

He smiled at the word ‘film.’

“Yeah, everything I need.” *Not that you’ll see all of it.*

He was itching to ring Karl, but not under supervision. Off they went to the next job for more of the same. It wasn’t Ann’s fault. She wasn’t terrible company; she just wasn’t *good* company.

They had lunch on the move, although she did spring for sandwiches from a deli. It was odd being around her outside the usual four walls. She didn’t do informality.

“I’m not really your cup of tea.” She broke into their silent sandwich time in the car.

He blinked a couple of times, hoping she’d pick up on his personal Morse code for, ‘do we really need to do this now?’

“We all work in the same department, but you stick to Karl like he’s some sort of *player*.”

He pursed his lips. 180 degrees off target. Karl wasn’t that at all, which was exactly why he trusted him . . . most of the time.

She cleared her throat. “All I’m saying is, Karl doesn’t have all the answers.”

He couldn’t resist taking the piss while he was finishing his sandwich. “When did I become such a valuable asset?”

“Ah, you were always that, Thomas. Only Christine missed her chance and Karl got to you first.” She proffered an open bar of chocolate and he snapped off a couple of pieces.

* * *

At four p.m., when Thomas had started wondering if the car clock was on a go-slow, Karl rang his mobile. The first thing he said was, “Can you put Ann on?” so he passed the phone over.

Thomas waited, mute, while Ann nodded and uh-huhed. Finally, she passed his phone back, still on.

“Are you running on schedule, Tommo? If so, I’ll know where to find you. I have a copy of the timetable about my person.”

“Of course you do.”

He wasn’t surprised when Karl turned up not long afterwards. Ann accepted a lift to Mile End underground, to make her own way back to Liverpool Street, leaving the air easier to breathe.

“Okay . . .” Karl took a deep breath. “Here’s the fruit of my labours.”

Inside a padded envelope was a collection of white plastic cards, indistinguishable from one another, each with a magnetic strip along the length.

“And these will work?” He did a quick count: nine cards altogether.

“They should do. Realistically, even two plus the original would be plenty to give Ken enough of a smokescreen for a head start.”

“How do you plan to distribute them?”

Karl’s silence gave him his answer.

“I don’t have that many friends.”

“You don’t need to, Tommo. How do you fancy an all-expenses paid trip to Birmingham? Even better, I’ll make it a freebie trip to Yorkshire, as long as you spend an hour in Brum on the way.”

“Because?”

“It’s pretty central — ideal for distributing a few cards.”

“And what about the others?”

“I was coming to that.”

Karl had been busy. There were seven mobile numbers on the list. The last number stuck out like a sore thumb — it was John Wright’s.

“You’ve got to be kidding.”

“Like you said, Thomas, you don’t have a lot of friends. And neither do I — not like this. People we can trust: no questions asked.

Thomas went through the list again. “Anything else I should know?”

“Now you mention it, there is one other challenge.”

Karl reached into his bag. Clearly he was doing this by degrees. Knowing Karl, he was saving the best – or worst — until last.

“How will people know which cashpoints are safe to use — without cameras?”

Karl cleared his throat. “That is indeed the challenge. The information is best guess, I’m afraid. See page two.”

Thomas flicked over the page where cashpoints were listed in groups of five. No longer the self-assured espionage agent, Karl was adrift, planning on the hoof.

“So I gather John and Diane got the cards cloned for you.”

“I couldn’t very well use my own people, under the circumstances.”

“No, but you bloody well used mine.”

* * *

Thomas got back to the flat and decided he’d give himself half an hour for a shower, a change of clothes and then out again. The flashing light on his answering machine had other ideas.

“Thomas, it’s Christine. I’m at the office. Call me whenever you get this.”

He checked the time, took her at her word and went for a shower first. Afterwards, he set the stopwatch on his mobile and dialled in, his hair still wet and a towel around his shoulders. She cut to the chase.

“I wanted to apologise for Southampton. There’s more going on than I’m able to discuss.”

“It’s fine; you don’t owe me any explanations.”

“I know.” Her voice regained its edge; she was the boss again. “Even so, I wouldn’t want you to misjudge the situation.”

Here it comes.

“The surveillance on Bob Peterson was sanctioned by Sir Peter Carroll.”

Like that was any kind of recommendation.

“So why are we talking now?”

“I wanted to say something. If you do what we do, there’s always a price. Back when I met Bob—”

He cut in, mindful of the time. "When we were still together, you mean?"

"Bob was the price I paid."

She'd sidestepped his point, but he wasn't finished with it.

"I think you'll find I paid a price too."

"We were hardly a perfect match and if we'd still been together when Miranda reappeared in your life, we both know what would have happened."

The timer was running low and so was his patience.

"I'm sorry, Christine — I need to be somewhere."

"Okay. All I'm saying is think carefully and stay your side of the line."

It sounded halfway between a warning and concern. He put the receiver down. That was ten minutes of his life he was never going to get back again. He hung the towel on the rail, making sure the line was level, and then got on the road.

* * *

Miranda's car was already outside the Wrights' place in Dagenham. He rang the bell and the door gave a little, on the latch. He went inside.

"Anyone home?"

Miranda, Diane and John were in the front room.

"I'll put a brew on, shall I?" He wandered through to the kitchen and listened for tell-tale footsteps behind him, which weren't long in coming.

"Alright, babe?" Miranda's voice reached him before she did.

He didn't answer until she was facing him, and he didn't need to say a word.

"Karl didn't put any pressure on me or Dad."

"Is that s'posed to make me feel better?"

Miranda moved around him, setting out the cups and fetching milk from the fridge. They waited together in silence, glances passing for sentences, and then took a tray through.

Diane went first. "It's a favour for a friend — a friend who has looked after you and Miranda. Is it the fake cards that are bothering you?"

"Hardly. It's the whole bloody principle of you and John having to call in favours of your own for Karl. You don't know what this is all about."

"We don't need to know." John stirred into life.

“What’s the matter, don’t you trust us?” Miranda shot him a poisonous glance. “Or is it your precious job again?” She crossed her legs.

She got up to answer the door, leaving him hanging; she’d played this game before as well. The Indian takeaway helped to defuse the tension. John went to help sort out the food, which left Thomas with Diane.

“It’s not a problem, Thomas.”

Maybe not for you.

He didn’t stick around after the curry.

Chapter 41

Days later, the balloon went up. Thomas caught an item on the early morning news about a drink-driver who had left a pub and ploughed into a family walking home. One of the two children — already on the critical list — had succumbed to her injuries overnight, a few days ahead of the sentencing. Thomas was certain — this was the one. He rechecked his bag before he went to work.

The call came through around nine a.m., just as Thomas and Karl were doing another observation on Paulette Villers. Karl turned up the volume on his mobile so Thomas could hear. Ken sounded wired.

“They put a note through my letterbox, first thing. I’m to be ready for the next few days. It’s not as organised as the last two jobs. Are you still there, Karl?”

“Where are you now? Are you safe?”

He could see the change in Karl. One moment they were joking about Paulette Villers doing her laundry at work for free and now Karl was icily calm.

“Stick to the plan, Ken. Where are you?”

“I’m on my way to the shops. Same routine, like you said.”

“Okay, Ken. From now on, keep everything you need close to hand. We’ll drop by as arranged, straight after work. Try to stay calm — and sober — until then. One more thing: don’t ring me unless it’s urgent. Goodbye.”

Karl touched his fingers to his lips.

“The truth is, Thomas, I’m out of my depth. I can spirit Ken away, right enough, but I can’t give him a new life. I reckon they’ll turn off the tap to his bank account after four days, tops. Honest to God, I intended to put something together for him financially — with more time. Do you think John and Diane would be able to lend me some money? You know I’ll pay them back.”

“You must think a lot of him.”

“He’d do the same for me, no question.”

And yet, Thomas thought, you’ve never mentioned him in two years.

“So what do you reckon?” Karl looked up. “About the money?”

“How much will you need?”

“I dunno. Two thousand, maybe? More would be better, obviously.”

“And then what?” He felt the heat rising up the back of his neck. “How you gonna pay them back, and what if you can’t?”

“I’ve just said, haven’t I?”

“I get the army camaraderie, but why are you so keen to fix his mistakes?”

Karl snorted and shook his head. “No, Tommo, you don’t get it at all. Camaraderie, my arse. You see it on-screen and it’s all heroics and medals. But out there, in the shit and the shadows, when you don’t know what’s coming round the corner, you put your life in the hands of your regiment. That means something, even once you’re out on Civvy Street. Christ, if it wasn’t for Ken I wouldn’t even be here having this conversation, okay? Now, will you help me get the fucking money together?”

“Yes.” He patted Karl’s shoulder with a smile. “When you put it like that, how could I refuse? Drop me off at Caliban’s.”

Miranda’s car wasn’t parked in its usual spot next to Sheryl’s. The front was locked so he went to the side and pressed the intercom.

“Hey stranger, what are you selling?” Sheryl sounded like she wanted to play but he wasn’t in the mood.

“Can you let me in?”

“Sure, come right up.” She was a fast learner; she cut the banter and met him at the top of the stairs. “Is everything okay? Miranda’s not around. Anything I can do?”

Yeah, if you’ve got a two grand float in the till.

“Lemme get you a coffee. You look like you could do with one.”

He followed her on the promise of caffeine.

“I was sorry to hear you’ve been dragged into Jack’s world.”

He raised a mug to her. “Seems only fair as I helped put him in prison.”

“Something else I’m sorry you had to get involved with, not that I don’t appreciate it. Miranda shouldn’t be long — wanna shoot some pool while we wait?”

She teetered forward a little, daring him to accept the challenge.

“Go on then.”

“Great. I can use one hand if you like?”

Somehow Sheryl always found a way to make anything sound salacious. Maybe Miranda had given her lessons. He racked up the balls and slammed the cue ball into the pack. No planning, no finesse; he wanted to lose himself in the game and stop thinking. Two stripes down and he entertained fantasies of victory; it didn't last long. Sheryl knew her way around a pool table like Karl knew his way around an armoury. All it took was one mistake in the jaws of a corner pocket and then Sheryl went to work.

"You know . . ." She leaned on the table and looked over her shoulder at him, her pose reminiscent of a French film Miranda once took him to. "I could always teach you."

"I prefer to learn by experience."

She laughed and promptly sliced the cue ball, ricocheting it into a middle pocket. He didn't waste the opportunity; the odds were that this would be his luckiest break of the day. Maybe she'd slipped something in his coffee because he was leading by two games ahead when he heard Miranda's voice downstairs.

"We're up here!" Sheryl sang out. "Thomas is showing me how to play pool — *Yorkshire* style."

Miranda's footsteps padded up the stairs. "You'll be needing a flat cap then. She turned to him. "To what do we owe the considerable pleasure, Mr Bladen?"

"Beats me." Sheryl conceded the game by grabbing the black and plunging it down a pocket. "I couldn't loosen his tongue. Anyone fancy fresh coffee?"

Good girl; she knew when she wasn't wanted.

"No, ta."

"Back soon. Be nice to one another."

Miranda scooped up the cue ball and rolled it across the baize.

"Shouldn't you be out working, or have you and Karl had a lovers' tiff?"

He stopped the ball and span in on the spot, watching it going nowhere.

"Karl needs some money for Ken."

She took it well, as if finding two grand at short notice was nothing for her.

“All my money’s tied up in this place. You could always ask Jack’s wife for help.” She flashed a smile, as if to say, ‘Kidding.’ “Or we could ask Mum and Dad . . .”

“I was thinking more of Andrea Harrison — and our paintings.”

He stepped away from the pool table and waited for the storm. She took all of two seconds to make her mind up.

“Yeah, alright then. It’s not like we ever intended to collect on the deal.”

He felt his shoulders sag a little. “Miranda, I could kiss you. You are amazing.”

“That’s what they tell me.”

“Hey!” Sheryl pitched up with two mugs. “Did someone mention kissing?”

“No time for coffee; me and Thomas are about to be artful.” She patted Thomas on the arse. “Come on, no time like the present — let’s go see Andrea.”

* * *

Thomas drove, to save Miranda the London congestion charge. After all the shit his job had put Miranda through, it was the least the Surveillance Support Unit could do.

“How much time do we have?”

“Us? All day. Karl can cover for me. Ken? Probably two days, three max.”

Traffic brought them to a standstill so they played one of their favourite games: reminiscence. Their walk down memory lane started in Leeds, where they first met all those years ago. Miranda went first.

“You ever wonder what would have happened if we’d stayed in Leeds?”

“I’d have a criminal record, probably.”

“How d’you figure that then?”

“The bloke I hit. I broke his nose. I heard about it from Mum and Dad after I wrote to them.”

She nodded. The bloke who’d had plans for her to be his topless model when she was barely seventeen. She laughed. “And you never thought to tell me, even after all these years?”

“Would it have made any difference?”

“Too right; I’d have bought you a better Christmas present as a thank you.”

“You’re definitely okay with this, Miranda? Still time to change your mind.”

She shook her head. “No thanks. And what about you, Thomas? Be honest now, aren’t you just the teensiest bit tempted by the cash? Those artworks ought to be worth four grand a piece.”

Only now, locking the car, did he give it any thought.

“Nah; truth is, it’s enough to know that Jack Langton *doesn’t* know. He’s a scumbag and I don’t want anything to do with him or his money. But if it helps Ken and Karl then I’m prepared to hold a candle to the devil this time.”

Chapter 42

Andrea and RT stood together, schmoozing a punter while Virtue — from the opening night — took photographs. Thomas held Miranda back by the door and moved her to one side to get a better look at the camera: a Minolta Dynax 5 — not bad at all.

RT had another of his ‘arty’ hats on. Thomas wondered whether he enjoyed dressing up like a dick, or if it was an essential part of being ‘an artist.’ By the looks of things Andrea and RT were at the end of the sales presentation. It was all smiles and, “please take a catalogue,” before the mark checked his gold watch and departed. Virtue waited around and Thomas spotted Andrea palming some cash to her.

Andrea didn’t acknowledge them until both players had left the stage. “How lovely to see you.” Her face suggested she meant it. “Coffee?”

RT only had eyes for Miranda and Andrea didn’t seem fazed when Thomas explained why they were there. If anything, RT seemed chuffed that they appreciated the value of his work.

He stuck to the details without justification: quick sale, cash buyer and ASAP. He didn’t ask if she’d be taking her usual commission; that was a foregone conclusion.

“I’ll call you tomorrow,” Miranda pitched in.

“You’ll come for drinks, of course.” Andrea’s suggestion gave RT the sweats.

“We’d love to,” Miranda simpered, “but Thomas has some business to take care of for Jack. I’ll pop over tomorrow to collect the money.”

That seemed to take the sheen off Andrea’s pearly white smile.

* * *

He dropped her off after a celebratory lunch, pausing to check in with Karl. It no longer seemed to matter that she hadn’t got out of the car yet.

“Jaysus, I was beginning to think you had gone into witness protection.”

“Nah, just lunch. I think the money for Ken is sorted now.”

“How the hell did you . . . ?”

“I didn’t — it was down to Miranda.”

“Hey, Karl!” She waved at the phone.

Thomas coughed and grabbed at her hand. “I’ll explain when I see you. I’m at Caliban’s. Where will I find you?”

Karl’s rendezvous point was a coffee house. Thomas settled for a latte; he was almost caffeinated out. He filled Karl in about the great art sell-off.

“I’m speechless. I don’t know what to say.”

“Firstly, clearly that’s not the case. And secondly, there’s nothing to say.”

“And Miranda did that for me? Remind me to send her some flowers.”

“In your dreams. Now, what’s the plan for collecting Ken tonight?”

The more Thomas listened, the less he wanted to hear. They’d pick Ken up from his workplace at the end of his shift, approximately one thirty a.m., and then deliver him to John and Diane’s place. That stuck in Thomas’s throat like a stale crust.

“Come on, Tommo, who else could I trust with this? Your place would be known to Sir Peter — from the time your door got smashed in.”

He went silent. Sir Peter was somewhere at the heart of this yet Karl hardly mentioned him. Something to be sorted out when he got back from York.

* * *

London after hours was a city transformed. The gin houses of Hogarth’s time might have gone — crack houses now, more likely — but foxes weren’t the only predators lurking in the shadows. He had to think twice before leaving his Makarov pistol at home.

He was at the front door with his bag in hand before the last stroke of midnight, allowing himself ninety minutes to rendezvous with Miranda at Caliban’s before catching up with Karl for the big push. The only noise was a distant car’s sound system pissing off the neighbourhood. What would it be like, he wondered, to close the door on your life and simply disappear? He felt his lip curl into a half-smile; a new life with a few grand, courtesy of RT’s daubs.

The mobile sat in the car’s hands-free cradle; it didn’t have anything to say. He followed the road down to the park, edging the line of trees. Walthamstow High Street was almost deserted, apart from a couple of drunks in search of their lives. He made a beeline for Leyton and crossed

the scar of the M11 link road. He remembered photographing the protestors as the bulldozers moved in on the shells of empty houses, and then trying to flog the pictures. In the end, a single picture made it into a left-wing magazine, although they forced him down on the price — power to the people.

Leyton became Stratford without a fanfare and then more late night traffic, in dribs and drabs, drivers shitting themselves at the sight of a police car parked up at the roadside. He instinctively tapped his coat pocket for his SSU ID. Force of habit. This time of night anything was possible.

First port of call was Caliban's, where the lights shone out against the darkness. He rang from the car and Miranda said she'd be right down. Her travel bag looked heavy, but a few grand could do that, as he'd learned once doing a courier job for Sir Peter Carroll. It took a moment to realise someone was following behind her: John Wright.

Miranda got in the front.

She patted the bag on her lap. "Eight grand."

He stared at her with an unspoken question about the ten grand total she'd originally texted him, and she stared right back. He gave up and turned round to John.

"Evening, Thomas."

There was nothing to say on the drive over; everyone knew the score. Karl would meet them in his own car and then join them in theirs to wait for Ken to come out. Karl flashed his lights as they approached and got out to move a pair of road cones. He climbed into the back seat and shook John's hand. The car clock read one-ten. Thomas watched Karl in his mirror, checking the clock against his watch — a big bastard of a watch. Maybe it was army issue.

"Even if he's late, we'll wait it out. Remember, as far as anyone there is concerned, it's just another ordinary working day."

Thomas smiled a little in the semi-darkness. Nothing was ordinary around Karl; he was the epicentre of the extraordinary. At one thirty-six and five seconds, not that Thomas was counting, Ken emerged carrying a holdall. He looked around, evidently clocked a car he was expecting, and signalled.

Karl got out and went over. Through the window it was clear that there was some kind of disagreement. Eventually Karl handed over a small box,

which Ken thrust into his holdall.

Thomas warmed the engine up. As soon as Karl and Ken squeezed into the back seat Miranda passed over the envelope.

“Eight grand. Spend it wisely.”

Ken looked to Karl, who nodded his approval, before taking it.

“I’m in your debt, you two.”

Karl took command. “Okay, here’s how this works. Ken, John and I will go in my car. You two are off to Birmingham tomorrow. Ring in sick first thing, Tommo. Say a family situation has come up.”

Thomas watched as the back seat passengers filed out and transferred into Karl’s car.

“What’s the matter?” Miranda poked his arm. “Won’t they let you into their gang? Back to yours, then.”

He was fading by the time they reached Walthamstow. It had been a long day and his head was filled with questions. As Miranda opened the front door he clocked the envelope on the floor — two return tickets to York. Karl had kept his word.

Last thing before bed he checked that the cash cards were still in their hiding place among the DVDs, and that the list of contacts and mobile numbers had lain undisturbed beneath the cutlery tray. He was out like a light, lulled to sleep by a perfume that hadn’t changed in ten years.

Chapter 43

He left a vague message at Christine's work number before seven am, promising to ring her later. After that he checked in with Karl to get the green light for Operation Bank Fraud. He didn't ask about Ken. That was beyond his remit now and on reflection, maybe Karl had done him a favour.

Cards retrieved, list secured, bags already packed, they were out the door by eight, travelling the Tube with the rest of the cattle. Miranda had a steely calm about her that was both unnerving and alluring. There was no talking in the Underground crush, and even above ground at Euston she didn't have a lot to say. He watched as a new mobile phone — probably from Karl — emerged from her pocket while she checked the departures board.

He left her to her calls; no doubt arranging the pick-ups at Birmingham. It was a little early for coffees, but he got them anyway, along with muffins. If she were standing in for Karl she might as well go the whole hog.

* * *

They grabbed a table on the train and were soon joined by a suit with designer glasses and a laptop full of spread sheets, and then a woman whose choice of book — judging by the cover — suggested she wasn't keen on thinking. Mr Laptop sodded off at Milton Keynes so Thomas spread himself out a little.

Seated opposite Miranda, sipping their coffees in silence, he thought they looked like a couple at war, or strangers. And yet, he mused with a smile, they couldn't have been more in sync — not clothed, anyway.

Once Chick lit Queen had taken the hint and moved somewhere else, he asked the question that had been eating away at him all morning.

"What happened to the other two grand?"

"You can't expect people to pay for their own travel when they're helping *us*."

He knew that she meant *him*, but let it pass.

"But if there's any left . . ." She second-guessed him. "I'll treat you."

If? Blimey, were they all travelling first class?

They reached Birmingham New Street and jumped ship. He'd forgotten how much he hated the station; the platforms looked as if a committee of muggers had designed them. They squeezed up the narrow stairs and surfaced onto the main concourse, sidestepping travellers clustered under a screen in search of their late-running train.

Miranda took her mobile out and walked on a few paces. She glanced over her shoulder and signalled for him to follow her.

"No offence, but leave some distance. These are people from Mum and Dad's world."

She went back to her phone and he trailed her out of the station. It wasn't difficult to stay on the periphery; it was what he did on every other working day, which was why he couldn't help noticing details.

The first contact was a black guy in his early fifties. Somehow that surprised him; he wasn't proud of it but there it was. Judging by her body language, Miranda already knew him. Thomas enjoyed her sleight of hand as she deposited the card in the bloke's coat pocket. The two of them walked up the street to a café, where Miranda gave him a hug before they parted company.

Thomas had followed on the opposite side of the street, so there was nowhere to go when the bloke walked past.

"Alright, mate?" The bloke winked at him.

Thomas clocked the London accent and crossed over to rejoin her.

"You could always show me today's itinerary."

"Where's the fun in that? Besides, it's better like this: 'need to know' and all that." She was quoting from the Karl McNeill rulebook.

He let her make all the running, and she led him a merry dance through the Bullring to a café on Edgbaston Street, where he managed to grab a coffee with her, albeit at separate tables. From there they looped round to the Odeon, dropped another card off and wandered back towards New Street Station. Five strangers came and went and he realised she didn't want them to see one another either.

Miranda started fiddling with her mobile phone again.

"Problem?"

"Nothing I can't handle . . ." Her face suggested otherwise.

"Anything I can do?"

She cast around a final time for the no-show.

“With one condition. You don’t check up on this afterwards — ever.”

“Deal.”

“Someone’s supposed to be flying into Birmingham International, but their flight’s been delayed.”

“So we’ll head over there?”

She started walking back into the station.

* * *

He did the decent thing at Domestic Arrivals and made himself scarce — but not invisible, and avoided the screens, even though it was killing him. Instead, he rang Karl to pass the time.

“Only me checking in. How’s work?”

“Same old bollocks. I plan to stalk the mystery Dolan again later. Roland or Donald: that is the question.”

“Sorry, forgot to tell you — it’s Roland.”

“Oh?”

“Prison talk.”

“Well, thank the Lord for incarceration. How are you finding playing second fiddle to the capable Ms Wright?”

“Yeah.” Thomas evaded the question. “Listen, this will work, won’t it?”

“Don’t see why not.” Karl’s voice trailed off, a sure sign he was focused on something else. “Right, must dash. The scales of justice won’t tip themselves.”

He considered buying Miranda an ‘I love Birmingham International’ key ring, clocked the price and thought better of it. There was an art to surveillance and it was a hard thing to switch off when there was so much of interest going on around him: bored children, anxious parents and the solo travellers who were always harder to interpret and more intriguing as a consequence.

Miranda and another woman crossed his line of vision. They looked comfortable together. The woman was suited and booted, her vivid auburn hair a striking contrast to Miranda’s blonde. They stopped abruptly at Miranda’s prompt and turned in his direction. He assumed it was an invitation.

“This is . . .” Miranda paused and blinked, “. . . my cousin, Philippa.”

Both women found this hilarious. He sighed, waiting for *Philippa* to say something.

“Well.” Miranda stirred, “I won’t keep you. Thanks again and have a safe trip.”

“You must come up some time and do bring . . . ?”

“Thomas.” His lips barely moved.

She tilted her head slightly, still looking at him.

“Not bad at all, Miranda.”

He watched her leave and moved closer to Miranda, while his brain whirled on. Maybe a solicitor; Scottish, probably. She didn’t sound like Karl, anyway.

“Reet then . . .” Miranda was taking the piss out of Yorkshire. “Ow d’you fancy a trip oop north?”

They caught a train back to New Street Station and then on to York. There was only one bank card left in the set and Miranda handed it to him. He’d picked York because it would be teeming with people. Leeds would have done, but York was also easier for travelling on to see Ajit, Geena and the sproglet.

* * *

The Connaught Hotel was a decent, middle-of-the-road establishment; not dissimilar to places he’d stayed at on assignments outside London — clean, welcoming and not too up itself. The bloke on reception didn’t blink an eye at their casual appearance — this was Tourist Town after all. He offered them a map of the city and some discount vouchers, which Miranda seized upon. The only thing that almost took the smile off his face was Thomas asking if he could pay in cash. A more up-market establishment might have insisted on a deposit by card, but the Connaught clearly had more trust, or fewer scruples. Thomas paid in advance and bunged the bloke a fiver for his trouble.

They went in under Miranda’s name — her first name, anyway — which made him feel like a trophy boyfriend. After the day’s excitement it was a fun game to play, and it helped take his mind off the final hand to be played that evening. Upstairs, the flowery wallpaper extended right along the corridor in a flourish of chintz. He couldn’t work out if it was intentionally retro or whether the place was long overdue for a makeover.

Miranda opened the room door, dropped her bags and flopped down on the bed.

“Pretty good timing.” She checked her wristwatch.

A Christmas present from him, three years back — nice touch.

“When do you want to eat?” He walked around her carefully, placing his bag down on the floor at his side of the bed. “Only I don’t want to wait until after . . .”

“Give me a few minutes to freshen up and then we can go.”

She raised her arms so he could pull her up. It felt like an invitation and he had to fight both gravity and desire.

* * *

Dinner was a pub special. He figured it would draw less attention to nip out from there to a nearby cashpoint than interrupting a meal in the hotel. The place was heaving and they blended in nicely, just one more couple on a leisure break. Miranda had added to the effect by bringing the hotel leaflets with her.

“Fancy doing the tourist trail tomorrow before we go to Pickering? What time did you tell Geena and Ajit to expect us?”

He sipped his half-pint of shandy quietly.

“You did ring Ajit?”

“Not exactly.”

“Great. So what happens if no one’s home tomorrow?”

He faked a smile. “We’ll catch a bus to Scarborough instead.”

“And they say romance is dead.”

He checked his watch — seven-twenty: around half an hour to go. The food arrived quickly and that was a bonus. You couldn’t really go wrong with fish and chips, and more to the point neither could a chef.

Miranda seemed to relax a little with food on the table.

“Where do you think Ken will go?”

He listened for the satisfying crunch of knife against batter and inhaled a waft of steamy vinegar. Bliss.

“Well, he’s Scottish; maybe he’ll find some quiet glen and lie low for a bit, and then disappear abroad with a new identity.”

Miranda lifted her glass of Malbec.

“Where would you go, if you were in his predicament?”

He gazed at his chips for a second or two. “Canada. Halifax or Winnipeg.”

“Bloody ’ell, I like how you’ve already thought about it. Talk about be prepared — you must have made a brilliant scout.”

“Never joined; Mam couldn’t afford the uniform.”

At ten to eight he was getting restless. There were two cashpoints likely to be camera-free, according to Karl. The man had more contacts than a discount optician.

He lifted his chair back and play-acted for an imaginary audience.

“Just popping out for a sec.”

“Okay.”

Outside, a group of students in rugby shirts jostled along the street and launched into a rendition of *Ninety-nine Bottles of Beer*, starting at forty-one; presumably where they’d left off.

He waited until they had moved on, and chose the cash machine on the right. It was two minutes to eight. Now came the moment of truth. He took the card out of his pocket, blank as Ken’s future, and made a show of looking for something in his jacket. At eight pm he inserted the card, tapped the number in carefully and waited. The main display appeared on cue; he selected £30 cash and held his breath, counting in his head as the machine went through its routine. Finally, it returned his card and spat out the money. There now, that wasn’t so bad. He planned to cut the card up later and spread the parts in three different locations.

His food was waiting for him with a plate on top, and he turned to the last of his chips.

“All sorted.”

“Then let’s go back to the hotel, rent a movie and celebrate.”

Chapter 44

Thomas woke in the early hours and tiptoed across to the window. York was still sleeping off the previous night and he watched as a police car wove through the maze of streets. His mind drifted through the previous day's events and he wondered about Ken. How long would it take Sir Peter and his cronies to realise that something suspicious was going on with the bank account? It stood to reason that it was already being monitored. According to Karl, banks across Europe acted with impunity and did things that would make your hair curl.

He stayed behind the curtain and checked his mobiles — work and personal. Both were stony silent so he went back to bed. As he lay there, softly serenaded by Miranda wheezing in her sleep, he tried something his counsellor had once recommended.

‘When you’re overwhelmed by too much thinking, imagine each thought as a brightly coloured ball. Instead of trying to keep them all in the air at the same time, mentally throw them up and catch just one. Focus on that and let the others go.’

He smiled at himself, remembering the look of incredulity he’d given her when she’d offered him fantasy juggling. He closed his eyes now and up they went. The thought that landed in his lap was Jacob. He got up again, dressed and grabbed a handful of change.

Downstairs he took a seat at the public Internet computer, wiped the child-sized fingerprints from the keyboard and readied a small pile of coins. The pages crawled but eventually he was able to access his most recent email address. Thurston Leon, the private investigator he’d paid to snoop on Natalie Langton’s mum, had emailed a reply. Apart from some ultra-right wing tendencies, she was spotless. At least it was someone he could cross off the list.

When he returned to the bedroom Miranda was busy checking her mobile.

“Your phone rang while you were out. Don’t worry, I didn’t touch it.”

“Which one?”

“Search me!” She slipped her t-shirt off her shoulder.

Tempting, but some other time. Karl had sent a text: Tried ringing but you must be busy — the eagle has flown the nest. Thanks again — K.

He took first turn in the shower and Miranda was still messing with her phone when he exited from the steam.

“Updates on the cards,” she explained. “One failed, but I can’t tell you where or I’d have to kill you.”

It would have been funny if it hadn’t conjured up the image of a white plastic bag filled with bloodied clothes. He changed the subject.

“You’re sure you’re okay about seeing Ajit and Geena again?” He left the ‘b’ word out of the equation and watched her fateful sigh.

“Yeah, I should be.”

* * *

His mobile phone gate-crashed breakfast. This time it was the work mobile who wanted to be his friend.

“Thomas Bladen.” He spoke softly, easing back his chair to make an exit.

“Ah, Thomas, it’s Sir Peter. Are you free to talk?”

“Yes, sir; just give me a second.”

He gagged the phone, gestured to the door and mouthed ‘duty calls’ to Miranda. She looked unimpressed. The clock near the front desk read eight fifteen — the Old Man must be on overtime; this was never going to be a social call.

“How soon can you be at my office?”

He glanced back to the glass doors, where he could just about see Miranda.

“I have some things to tie up — would eleven-thirty be okay?”

“Very good — and come alone.”

He turned off the phone and made the condemned man’s walk back to the restaurant.

“Everything all right?” Miranda seemed extra bright and breezy.

He sat down and took a gulp of orange juice before he answered.

“Do you believe in déjà vu?”

* * *

Miranda was better about it than he had a right to expect. He figured she was probably relieved too. They were packed and out of the hotel in

fifteen minutes without a cross word spoken. Or almost any other kind.

York station was awash with end of season holidaymakers and students with more luggage than sense. He ducked past an idiot carrying a surfboard, found a corner away from the noise and rang Karl.

“Missing me already?”

“We have a problem . . .”

Karl was the voice of reason. “It was only a matter of time, although they’re pretty quick off the mark. Then again, it may not be connected with yesterday.”

“Yeah, he probably wants to promote me.”

“Actually, it might be something *I* did.”

Thomas started sweating. “Text me on M’s phone.”

“Will do.”

A series of messages arrived as the train sailed through Doncaster. It seemed Karl had been creative by using the genuine bank card in Southampton, as close to Bob Peterson’s home as possible. It felt good to know Karl was fighting his corner.

Thomas decanted the essentials into his rucksack, including Karl’s photos that he’d taken along for safekeeping. If Karl was right, he had a feeling he’d be needing them soon.

Miranda’s generosity continued when they reached London. She took his bag and left him the rucksack. “You can come over tonight and collect it — ring me.”

He waved her off, reflecting that life always seemed complicated in London — on a bigger canvas. He wouldn’t have it any other way.

* * *

This time there was no waiting at the front desk of Main Building. ID, hand scan and welcome to the citadel. His escort was the Geordie lass from before.

“Mr Bladen — I never expected to see you back so soon.”

She remembered; how sweet.

“Me neither.”

Sir Peter’s door was closed. He rapped staccato and went in. The Old Man smiled, but he’d done that in the past so it cut no ice with him. Thomas waited; he was good at that — better than most.

“ I expect you’re wondering why I asked to see you so urgently?”

He decided to box clever. “I assumed you need something else couriered. I’ve got an overnight bag.” He lifted the rucksack for effect and noted the lack of coffee on offer. More waiting.

“Thomas, I’d like your assistance with a problem. I want you to support Bob Peterson and meet with him today in Southampton. I’m pleased at your initiative.”

That read one of two ways. Thomas pressed his tongue against his lower teeth so hard it made his jaw ache.

“I’ll book a pool car from Liverpool Street then and take my instructions from Bob when I get there.”

“No need.” Sir Peter clapped his hands together once, as if he’d just thought of something. “My driver, Phillip, will take you. He’s expecting you. The sooner you’re down in Southampton the sooner you can get started.”

Chapter 45

Thomas got to the Daimler before the chauffeur had time to get out.

“I’ll sit in the front if it’s all the same to you?”

Phillip started the engine.

“Would you like the radio on, Mr . . . ?”

“Thomas.” He cringed. “Just Thomas.”

Phillip was a classical music man. Rachmaninov formed the backdrop to their departure from London, the sombre tones and sweeping piano lending the south of the city more grandeur than it deserved.

There were questions on Thomas’s mind, mostly about loyalties; but to ask them would reveal his own. He settled for, “have you worked for Sir Peter long?”

Phillip smiled, the way people do when they’re remembering something. “You could say that — I served with him in the Royal Navy. You?”

“Two years or so in the SSU. You could say he recruited me.”

Phillip lowered his window. “You can relax. I’m just the driver.”

Spending time with Karl had taught Thomas that nobody was *just* anything. Conversation didn’t resume properly until the signs for Southampton.

“We met before, Thomas.” Phillip followed the sat-nav, spiralling in towards Bob Peterson’s building. “About six months ago.”

The penny dropped. It was that fateful day Thomas went to see Sir Peter to deliver his ultimatum. Reflecting on it now he couldn’t help wondering how much had changed.

“I’ll give you my number. Call me when you’re ready to be picked up, or if you decide to stop overnight.”

Phillip passed over a laminated card, bearing the crest of the Surveillance Support Unit. Thomas tapped a corner against his palm.

“Perhaps you know my friend, Karl McNeill?”

“Perhaps I do.” That was it; nothing more. “We’re here now.”

Thomas took a moment outside the building, running through his options. Playing it straight would be easiest — show Peterson the photos

and find out what *he* knew. If they could just get over hating one another's guts.

He buzzed up and some underling promised to come down and collect him. Thomas turned from the camera — force of habit — and wondered if there was another, less obvious one hidden in the brickwork. This was the SSU after all.

* * *

The office was bigger than Liverpool Street's, with twenty-six desks — he counted them. Bob Peterson was cordial, that was the word, meeting him in the open plan office. A light handshake, a dismal offer of machine coffee and then Thomas was whisked away along the corridor, coffee in hand.

Peterson's domain had an air of headmaster's office about it. A map of the British Isles covered part of one wall, the thick green line encompassing a chunk of the southeast. Thomas figured the team was a regional hub and everything inside the line was Bob's. He always was the territorial kind. Another map covered Southampton in detail. Peterson caught him looking at it and gestured to a round table where a notepad was already waiting.

Thomas took a seat and thudded his rucksack on the chair next to him, ready to produce the photographs of Ken's flat. Peterson sat opposite and the two of them clutched their coffees, ready to draw.

"I'll start, shall I?" Peterson flipped open his notepad. "I don't like you and the feeling's mutual. But whatever our differences — personal and professional — Sir Peter Carroll has *requested* that we coordinate our efforts."

"I still don't know what the job is."

"Don't you?" Peterson took a large gulp of coffee, which Thomas hoped was still piping hot, and wrote down a name on the page: Ken Treavey. "Our task is to locate him. Anything you want to say about that?"

Several things actually. He thought about protesting his ignorance, or querying why this was an SSU job. But all that was bullshit. Besides, he had a better plan — find out if Peterson had any photos, goad him into ending the meeting, and get the hell out of there. He took the photos from his rucksack and laid them on the table, face up.

If Peterson was surprised he did an excellent job of not showing it. Much as expected, he got up and retrieved some photos of his own from a

desk drawer. “Now we’re on a level playing field.” He passed them across.

There were three photos; probably the best of the bunch, Thomas surmised. Him, close to Main Building carrying the package and two in Victoria Station. He could see Peterson studying Karl’s handiwork.

Thomas drained his coffee. “This is a set-up. We were the couriers and now it’s our problem to locate . . . what was his name?”

Peterson laughed. “You must take me for a fool, Thomas. But like I’ve already told you, I’m three steps ahead of you.”

“And your wife too?”

“Watch yourself, Thomas. Christine’s not here to protect you now.”

He took a breath and tried to let the red mist clear. “The day I need protecting from you . . .” He couldn’t think of a punchline, other than punching him. Tempting, but unproductive. “Let’s cut to the chase.” He placed Peterson’s photos carefully into his rucksack. “I have no idea where Ken Treavey is, and maybe it’s better for both of us that way.”

Peterson folded his arms. “I’m listening.”

“Why you and me, Bob?” He took delight in using the name. Now he’d asked the question aloud, the ideas came thick and fast. “Sir Peter knows you’ll follow orders to the letter, and he knows I don’t trust him an inch. This is a fool’s errand.”

“Then what’s the point?” Peterson eased back a little and picked up a pen.

“Maybe there is no point, other than that Sir Peter’s seen to be doing something while we’re at one another’s throats.”

“Can you make some inquiries?” Peterson’s voice sounded plaintive.

Thomas pitied him; it must be a bitter pill to swallow that *he* was the solution to Peterson’s problems. He nodded and stood up to leave.

“Give my best to Karl. I gather he knew Treavey once upon a time.” Peterson couldn’t resist a parting shot.

“I’ll be in touch. Give my best to Christine — if you see her before I do.”

Peterson flinched in his chair. For one sweet moment Thomas thought Peterson was coming up to meet his fist. Sadly, it wasn’t to be. He was on the phone to Phillip before he got to the end of the corridor.

Chapter 46

After Phillip dropped him off at Liverpool Street the first thing Thomas did was access his mobile messages. Miranda had checked in twice to make sure he was okay and her dad had managed ‘call me’ sometime on the drive back. He rang him first.

“Where have you been?”

“Southampton.”

“Are you still down there? I need you in London — Natalie’s been in touch.”

It was beginning to get chilly. He let John do the talking.

“Natalie wants you to meet with Charlie Stokes to discuss the goods. And she said Ray Daniels will act as a sort of go-between.”

“When?” He looked over at a taxi.

“Tonight?” John didn’t sound convinced.

“Let me speak to Karl first and I’ll ring you back.”

He took a chance and walked round to the car park, using his ID card to release the side gate. Karl’s car was there, taking up space, and the bonnet was still cooling off. Christine’s car sat nearby, as cold as his opinion of her now he’d seen Bob Peterson.

It wasn’t a huge surprise to find Karl, Ann and Christine deep in conversation as he approached the office door, but it still smarted. Now he knew how the young, skinny Ajit had felt at junior rugby practice — always the last to be picked.

The meeting broke up abruptly as he entered the room, or maybe it just seemed that way. Christine was last to acknowledge him, which made him wonder if Peterson had been on the phone. He decided to call her bluff.

“Can I have a word?”

“Of course.” She led the way to her office.

He gestured for Karl to wait for him.

“How is everything?” She sounded concerned.

“You tell me. Sir Peter rang me this morning. He sent me to see Bob Peterson about finding a missing person.”

“Really?” Her brow dipped. “I thought you were on compassionate leave?”

“Yeah, so did I.” He blinked a couple of times, making space for her to say something. When he realised silence was the only answer on offer he knew it was time to leave. “You know what? It’s been a really long day and I could do without the subterfuge this time. Don’t you trust me yet?”

Her lips parted and she looked away. “It’s not that. I want to keep you safe.”

“I can look after myself.” He wrenched the door open.

“Not against these people. Karl agrees with me.”

* * *

Karl took him to The Swan and somehow managed to find them a table.

“I’ll get these, Tommo. Shandy and crisps?”

“Ah, you remembered!”

Even though Karl played it cool when Thomas mentioned meeting up with Charlie Stokes, he could see he was guarded.

“Come on; out with it.”

Karl hunched in over a pile of crisps. “Our man Charlie is a cut above Jack Langton. Keep your wits about you. Anything you notice might be useful.”

“Then you think I should go tonight?”

Karl hadn’t moved. “It could . . . erm . . . be really useful if you met him — and the sooner the better.”

Thomas sat back and laced his fingers together, waiting. It occurred to him that John Wright was waiting too, but that was *his* problem. “Well?”

“Charlie acquiring some of Jack’s drugs will cause ripples. The franchises are not supposed to compete and that instability is a golden opportunity for us. Our problem has always been getting close to Charlie to gain any intelligence. He’s shrewd.”

“So are we. I’ve still got the bug you gave me, at home. I can ring John on the way.”

Karl didn’t need a lot of convincing.

* * *

Thomas changed his clothes while Karl got the coffee on.

“Are you sure you’re up for this?”

He opened his hand to show Karl the device. Subject closed.

"I'll be on standby. I can come in heavy if need be." Karl sounded spooked.

"It'll be fine. Ray will be with me . . ." He smirked. *Good old Ray — Mark Antony to Jack Langton's Caesar.*

"Don't underestimate Charlie Stokes." Karl moistened his lips, despite the coffee, "His profile isn't pretty. He's psychopath material."

"Thanks for that. I'd better get going before I change my mind."

For all his concern, Karl didn't try to stop him.

* * *

He arrived at *Xanadu* shortly after eight pm. Ray came to the door, in a rush, and corralled him into his BMW.

"Mr Stokes doesn't like to be kept waiting. You keep your mouth shut unless he speaks to you, and it's *always* Mr Stokes — got it?"

"Understood."

Ray Daniels was agitated, no question about it. And he didn't look the small talk type. But everyone had their soft spots.

"Nice car."

"Yeah, benefit of the job." Ray upped the speed. "Jack Langton says presentation is everything. Incidentally, you did a good thing, looking after Andrea during the break-in." He reached into his suit jacket and pulled out pristine banknotes. "Three 'undred quid there — ought to buy you a new coat."

Thomas grabbed the money, pretending to marvel at it.

"Thanks . . . Ray."

Ray perked up a bit.

"We'll be there soon. Just follow my lead and do like I told you. Remember, fifteen K and that's it."

The car left civilisation behind, bumping over a dead-end to bounce across wasteland. Up ahead, Thomas noted at least three buildings — remnants of some sort of factory. It hadn't escaped his attention that Ray seemed to know his way around without the help of sat-nav, but he did like the man asked and kept his mouth shut.

The car pulled under cover, losing the comfort of moonlight. A train rumbled past in the distance, wheels screeching against the rails. Ray got

out and stretched. Thomas joined him and they stood there while Ray had a smoke.

Thomas wondered if he was armed — whether that was the way these people behaved. He figured Ray was about five feet ten; shorter than him anyway, but broader. Another gym fanatic. What was it with the East End boys and their pecs?

“Let’s get on with it.” Ray flicked his cigarette and Thomas watched the orange glow as it arced into the shadows. “You coming, or what?”

The main building was a ruined shell and it led out to two more substantial structures. Thomas kept his hands together, like a prisoner, and counted his steps. It helped to have something to focus on. Right turn, flash of moon, left turn, into the building and then a change of footing, broken glass and cobwebs. And that smell? Grease, or engine oil; something industrial.

“Is that you, Ray?”

The voice reached them before the doorway. Charlie Stokes appeared to be alone. It looked like a supervisor’s office, frozen in time from the 1970s; a semi-nude stared down from the wall to remind everyone it had once been April. Thomas tried not to stare back.

“Wait here.” Ray elbowed him in the ribs, making him flinch, and walked over to chat in private.

After a couple of minutes, Ray called out. “Come through, Thomas.”

Ray was seated at a large metal table. Charlie was pouring three slivers of scotch.

“Sit yourself down.”

Charlie waited and then loomed over him. “I know what you’re thinking. Why am I in a dump like this?” He laughed and Ray laughed with him. “They used to make all sorts here. Lathes and drills, then it was parts for conveyor belts — proper machinery. Now, what’s left is potential — posh homes, a casino . . . the works. I’ve had this place for years.”

Thomas pulled his chair in close and felt in his pocket. He waited until Charlie took his place at the table and then slipped out the bug and pushed it until he felt the magnet attach. A piece of piss, until he gripped the scotch and saw that his hand was shaking a little. Ray saw it too and seemed amused. Charlie had emptied his glass and was heading back to the bottle. Thomas covered his glass and shook his head.

“No thank you, Mr Stokes.”

Thomas caught the look they shared and stared blankly past. His heart pounded in his chest. These two blokes weren't strangers.

Charlie rejoined them. “Right. Let's get down to business.”

Thomas sipped what was left to steady his nerves and delivered the message from Natalie, except he had to say it was from Jack: fifteen K for the return of the drugs and to cover any inconvenience.

Charlie smiled. “Let me show you something.”

Ray shifted his chair back, but Charlie shook his head slowly.

“Just Thomas. We won't be long.”

He forced himself out of the chair, shooting a glance at Ray, who didn't meet his gaze.

“It's this way.”

Charlie led him through two more dilapidated rooms, into what must have been the production area. Wooden benches, caked in grease, stood idle. A neon strip light blinked desperately like a cry for attention. Charlie kept on walking.

“Through here.”

Thomas heard a rattle of keys then the shriek of metal as bolts scraped back. Charlie went straight in so he followed him. In front of them were half a dozen plastic kegs, sealed tight, on pallets.

“You know what this is?”

Thomas shook his head, although his instincts told him this was more cartel merchandise held in storage. He stared at his feet, noticing how the cement on one section of the floor seemed newer than the rest. About six feet by three feet — big enough for a coffin.

“I think you do know. Look at it.”

As Thomas lifted his head he felt the sweat gathering at the top of his neck.

“I don't need Jack Langton's poxy half kilo, but why would I sell it back for below the market value? Do you think I'm stupid?”

Thomas felt Charlie's grey eyes reaching into his psyche in search of an answer.

“No,” he yelped. “But Jack will owe you and maybe that'll be useful someday.”

Charlie stared him down; the light went out of his eyes.

“I’m only kidding!” He slapped Thomas on the shoulder. “How did you get mixed up with Jack anyway?”

They left the compound and Thomas stood back while Charlie locked his treasures away.

“I’m a friend of John and Diane Wright’s.”

Charlie leered at him. “Ah, are you Miranda Wright’s bloke? You and Ray have got something in common then.” Charlie’s laughter bounced off the walls. “Come on, I feel like another drink.”

He wasn’t the only one.

Ray had made himself scarce so Charlie poured two drinks and carried them through to the office.

“You’re a photographer, right?”

He nodded dumbly, shocked that Charlie had done his homework.

“Yeah, that’s what I heard. Anyway, cheers.” The glasses collided and Charlie’s — twice the volume — emptied in seconds. “You tell Natalie I’ll accept the fifteen K this time and — like you said — Jack owes me. Word for word?”

“Yes, Mr Stokes.”

“I’ll be keeping my eye on you, Thomas. Mind how you go — you can find your own way out.” Charlie turned his back and the bulky frame stole most of the light.

Thomas walked slowly and deliberately, half expecting Charlie to have a change of heart and come charging after him. He found Ray outside, smoking.

“What did he say?” Ray’s lips pulled on the cigarette.

“He agreed to the price.”

“Did he say anything else?”

“Jack owes him.”

“Jack won’t like that one little bit.” Ray’s grin turned orange.

In the car Thomas noticed his legs shaking. Ray noticed it too.

“He’s a scary fucker, is Charlie Stokes. Natalie thought I ought to come along to look after you, and as a mark of respect, on behalf of Jack.”

Yeah, Thomas thought, but you knew your way around.

Natalie Langton was delighted with the news. Jack owing Charlie didn’t seem to bother her at all. Thomas left them to it, grateful to leave their troubled world behind him.

* * *

He stood in the shower a long time when he got home, trying to rinse away the fear. Later, he rang Miranda just to hear her voice. He didn't talk for long because Charlie's comment about Ray and Miranda was running through his veins like a poison. After a quick update to John Wright, Karl was the final call of the night. He came right to the point.

"I get it now — why you leave me on the periphery."

Chapter 47

Keeping Bob Peterson at arm's length proved easy. Peterson called him, first thing, and explained that he intended to stay in Southampton and have Thomas be his eyes and ears in London. To buy himself some time Thomas promised to visit Ken's flat after work.

He hadn't slept well and the train ride into work was gruelling. It was never a good sign when he needed chocolate to keep body and soul together before he'd even made it back above ground. Everywhere he looked people wore earpieces to cocoon them from their commute, the wires trailing discreetly inside a coat, making it harder to identify if it was a genuine iPod — or worth stealing. The train rocked side to side, crashing his brain against the same thought: Miranda and Ray.

Today was a repeat list of benefits claimants — a mop-up of those they'd missed altogether, and a continuation of surveillance on some of the others.

"Trouble sleeping?" Karl edged into the conversation with more care than he applied to the traffic.

"I thought Jack was intimidating, but Charlie — he's in another league."

"He's smarter too. No criminal record — implicated, but nothing that sticks."

"I dunno how you do it, Karl. It's day and night for you. When did you last take a holiday?"

"Apart from my European break in Geneva, you mean?"

The welcoming sight of the café ended the conversation. Still time for breakfast before Paulette Villers was due at the laundry.

The door had an old-fashioned bell above it. Thomas headed to the counter and grabbed the newspaper. Two fried egg sandwiches and teas ordered, he took the seat with his back to the window so Karl could keep watch on the world.

"Even the news is spoiled," Thomas lamented. "Thanks to you I'm forever reading between the lines now."

Karl fiddled with the salt cellar. “All I did was open your eyes to what was already going on — and you asked me to, remember?”

“I know.” He cheered up a little when the tea arrived and started flicking through the paper. There was no mention of a killer on the run, or a European conspiracy, but he knew they were facts of life.

The sandwiches weren’t long in coming and the magical hit of bread and butter, egg, and sweet sauce were balm to an otherwise shitty day. Thomas was going back over the Bob Peterson situation, in between bites, when Karl’s face brightened.

“Don’t look now, Tommo — I think our luck is changing.”

He waited for Karl to elaborate — which he didn’t. The door pinged and Paulette Villers stood over them.

“I’m ready to talk — tomorrow, at two pm. You know our address. Only . . . can you leave me alone today? I’ve got things to do — private things.” She didn’t hang around.

“What do you reckon?” Thomas squeezed his bread against the plate, smearing yellow and brown together.

“Yeah, I’m up for that.”

“No, I mean the part about leaving her alone today. What is she doing?”

Karl was already reaching for his mobile. “Hello, Ann? How would you like to make an Irishman very happy?” He got up and took the call outside.

The carousel of claimants — Karl’s phrase of the day — gradually thinned out as the hours slipped away. It was Thomas’s turn as the lookout, so Karl practised surveillance on the insides of his eyelids.

“Karl?” Thomas stretched his name out like a yawn.

“I’m not asleep.”

“I wanna ask you something. A straight question without further discussion?”

“Uh-huh.” Karl hadn’t moved.

“Miranda and Ray Daniels . . .”

“Oh, that.” Karl shifted a little in his seat. “Let sleeping dogs lie, Thomas. The past is the past.”

“Any other clichés in your bag?”

“I thought we weren’t discussing this?”

“We’re not. But Charlie Stokes also knew I was a photographer, so I’m wondering where he got that from?”

“I told you he was smart. And as for Ray Daniels, you and Miranda had enough going on and it wasn’t my place to say anything.”

“That’s never stopped you before.” He arced his camera along the horizon. “I’ll be glad when this business with Jack Langton is over.”

Karl didn’t reply. The subject appeared in the frame, so Thomas dropped the subject and got to work.

* * *

Dinner at *Caliban’s* hadn’t been part of the plan but Karl had a point — it was local and they deserved some sort of reward for a hard day’s surveillance. The bar was a tourist magnet again, only this time the coach outside had French number plates.

Thomas followed Karl across the car park. “This’ll be perfect for you. They speak French in Geneva.”

Karl made a pretence of holding his ribs. “Look, I should have told you about Miranda. I know you’ve done a lot for me lately — for Ken. So I’m gonna repay your trust a little because I know how much you love secrets. I won’t repeat myself. Ready? I went to a NATO building in Geneva.”

“Holy shit!”

“The very same. Now, by my reckoning I owe the two of you dinner.”

Inside, Miranda sauntered over and directed them to one of the three reserved tables. At Miranda’s minimal sign language Sheryl brought the menus. “Nice to see a friendly face for a change, guys.” She dealt them out like cards. “Any progress on Janey’s kid?”

Thomas tapped Karl’s boot under the table. “You know her?”

“I know *of* her. By the way, when are you seeing Jack again?”

“Soon. I’m gonna go on my own again.”

They settled for ‘poulet et croustilles,’ as the menu put it, mainly because Miranda admitted she had over-ordered. And, like Karl said, you couldn’t really get chicken and chips wrong as long as it was actually cooked.

Karl hung around longer than Thomas expected. Miranda and Sheryl alternated their company with helping out at the bar. Thomas liked it that way — no space to talk over anything work-related. The weight across his

shoulders lifted as the evening went on. Even when Karl went outside to make a call it didn't disturb him.

"I suppose we should see Ajit and Geena at some point . . ." He tested the water with Miranda.

"Maybe once Jack's out of your hair?"

He made a face.

"No progress with Jacob then."

He shook his head and sought solace in his shandy.

"Eliminate the impossible . . ." She leaned in and kissed him.

Sherlock Holmes had never felt so sexy.

Karl returned with a flourish. "Remind me to buy Ann Crossley some flowers." He glanced at Miranda and carried on regardless. "Our boy Dolan . . ."

"Roland," Thomas corrected him.

" . . . Went to the same olive-coloured door address, collected something and delivered it to . . ." He drummed on the table and then stopped for the punch line.

"Paulette Villers!" Thomas stole his glory.

"Very good, Tommo. Maybe she's gonna hand over some evidence tomorrow."

Miranda squeezed in close to whisper in Thomas's ear. "Shall we go back to yours?"

Chapter 48

The morning's work was just a prelude to the main event of the day. They broke for lunch at twelve-thirty to talk tactics. Thomas was all for bugging Paulette's home, but Karl thought they'd be pushing their luck.

"Domestic surveillance is always more risky. People behave erratically at home — things get moved and knocked about."

That meant relying on naked charm. Thomas laughed at the thought — another title for RT. He wondered how Karl would make use of the information he and Miranda had gleaned about Jack's Spanish operation. Karl had talked in a general way about 'turning' Jack to use him against the Shadow State, but had left out the details.

"How long do you think we'll be there, Karl?"

"In and out in half an hour, tops."

* * *

Thomas parked around the corner with five minutes to go. There was a metallic tang in his mouth and moistness under his arms, and he loved it. They were finally making headway against the monsters. Maybe, by some miracle, Paulette had something that would link Charlie to the attack on Jacob. Yeah, and maybe Bob Peterson would emigrate to New Zealand.

"Remember, Tommo, let me do the talking. And do whatever you can to make her feel at ease."

Thomas immediately took his SSU ID off and thrust it in his pocket.

Paulette was at the door as soon as they knocked — obviously waiting. It looked like a small place for a couple, although someone was big on interior design. Smooth lines and muted lilac tones contrasted with burgundy — not what he'd expected of a potential benefit fraudster.

"Rachel's upstairs. She'll be down soon — she's a bit uncomfortable about all this."

Karl nodded. "We appreciate you inviting us here. It's just a chat, nothing official."

Thomas cleared his throat, but Karl ignored him.

"Okay . . ." Paulette took a deep breath, which didn't stop her trembling. "I'm not working in the laundry — honest."

Karl opened his hands wide, just like the textbooks said to do — non-threatening and inclusive. “We have seen you going there regularly.”

“I have to be out of the house at certain times. It’s somewhere to go. Sometimes I help out a little bit, that’s all. Charlie makes me leave.” She looked to the far wall. “A couple of times I came back early and . . .” There was a *thump* upstairs. “It’s only Rachel.” But she flinched. “You said you’d help us . . . I’ll make some tea — kettle’s not long boiled.”

Karl waited until she was out of the door. “I need to put some pressure on her — don’t contradict me,” he growled.

Thomas felt himself withdrawing into the role of observer. This was another, ugly side to Karl. Paulette was vulnerable, and Rachel so scared she wouldn’t even come downstairs.

The kitchen door opened and Paulette brought through a silver tray, holding it close by the handles, as the mugs of tea slopped on to its shiny surface. Thomas had a flashback to the café after his first prison visit with Jack.

He muttered to Karl, “Ask her about Jacob.”

Paulette put the tray at one edge of a coffee table and doled out the mugs. Tea oozed out from the base of each one across the dark wood. It struck Thomas as strange that she’d gone to the trouble of a tea tray but hadn’t cared about the table.

“Who’s Jacob? Drink up.”

Thomas stared at his milky tea — southerners rarely made a decent brew. Karl drained the cup without pausing for breath, a man on a mission and a dog with a bone.

“Tell us about the times you came home too soon.”

Thomas looked at his watch; they’d need to get back to work soon. The Benefits Investigation Team had its agenda too. He took a gulp of sweet, sickly tea, detecting the unmistakable tang of sterilised milk. He had to squeeze his eyes shut to take it down, like when he was a child at his Gran’s house; Sunday teas as torture.

Within seconds Karl began to sway in his seat. His face was dappled with sweat. “I don’t feel so good.”

Thomas stared at his half empty mug. “What have you done?”

“You’ve got to finish all of it.”

Karl lurched out of his chair and stumbled over the edge of the coffee table, careering into a lamp. Thomas reacted instinctively, letting go of the mug as he rushed to Karl's aid. He heard the smash of ceramic against wood but it didn't slow him down any. Karl was groaning now, struggling to get to the door.

A door opened upstairs and someone rushed down, only it wasn't Rachel. It was one of the toe-rags who'd given Greg a kicking. Thomas dragged the front door open but there were already two men waiting for them.

"It's not my fault — he made me do it!" Paulette screamed behind him.

Thomas felt the fist jar against his back and fell headlong into Karl and out on to the street. He felt woozy but conscious enough to know they were screwed. He closed his eyes and let it happen.

* * *

Play dead. He felt like he was flying, arms dangling in the air. Then he hit the ground and rolled into a cave. Someone sealed the cave up. Maybe it was Joseph of Arimathea. The ground lurched beneath him, only it wasn't ground. His hands touched a smooth wooden surface. *Think, Thomas — think.* He forced his eyes open and recognised the dark belly of a van. His brain stalled as he tried to work out how he'd got there. The body beside him was Karl's; insensible, rasping.

Thomas dug a nail into his own palm. The pain felt dull, far away, but it was something to cling on to. He chased the pain and found it, added a key scrape across his knuckles to bring it home.

What did he know? There had been three blokes and that bitch had set them up. He heard muffled voices behind his head. And a radio. He couldn't make out the words so he eased forward and pressed an ear against the metal panel. All he got for his trouble was a pounding vibration through his skull, so he retreated. There wouldn't be much time. He could only think of two things to do.

He put his hand in his pocket and the raw skin scraped against the seam. Once he'd separated the ID card from the holder he put the card between his teeth and carefully took his boot off. He wanted to sleep now, but he couldn't, not yet, not until he'd finished. The card went in his sock and he put the boot back on, feeling the rounded plastic edges pressing

against his sole. He slid along the floor and his boot tapped something hard. Manoeuvring 180 degrees he felt his way around the spare wheel and dipped into his pocket again for the holder. Down it went, out of sight. He scratched his initials and Karl's into the wooden floor and dragged the spare wheel over a little to cover it. Under the circumstances, it was the best he could do.

Chapter 49

Thomas woke to the sound of banging against the van.

“Wakey, wakey!”

The door retracted and daylight flooded the interior. He struggled to his knees and blinked against the glare, trying to cover his face. Someone — no, it was two people — wrenched his arms forward and dragged him out, smacking his shins against the ground. He cried out and they laughed.

“The other one’s still under — we’ll have to carry him.”

Even with his eyes closed, Thomas recognised Ray’s voice. They walked him, arms out to the sides like a crucifixion, into the hangar-like shell. Ray came around to face him, leering at him in the semi-darkness.

“Surprised to see me?”

The punch, though half expected, doubled him over.

“Get the hood. Oh, for fuck’s sake.”

He saw someone scrabbling about on the ground and the hood was pulled down roughly over his head. The stench of diesel choked him; the stupid bastard must have dropped it on the ground. Time to sleep again.

* * *

He jerked awake and reached forward, but his arms were restrained. He moved his fingers and felt the radiator. A quarter-turn on his wrists and the cable ties dug into his skin. Holding his breath he sensed his own terror, like a presence beside him.

He pushed back with the heels of his boots to try and ease the pressure on his shoulders. It helped a little, but not much. All he could do was wait and try to keep calm.

The sound of footsteps crushing glass stirred him. Someone was standing close by, their breathing steady and rapid — someone was getting off on this. When the hood was wrenched off he saw Ray and Charlie standing over him. He didn’t bother saying anything.

“Time for your medicine.” Charlie tilted his head back and tried to open his mouth.

He resisted, so Ray got handy with his fists again. When he cried out Charlie squeezed his jaw until he relaxed and opened his mouth. The liquid

slithered across his tongue, leaving a chalky aftertaste. When he'd swallowed he suddenly smelled orange peel, so strongly he started coughing.

They replaced the hood.

"We'll have a little chat later."

Through the cloth he felt Charlie's face close to his.

"Come on, Ray, the other one should be ready now — he's far more interesting."

* * *

Thomas breathed in and out in tides, and the world floated around him in darkness. Somewhere beyond, *they* were watching him. Someone was always watching; had been his whole life: the voices from the dark and the one voice that could pierce his defences with a single word.

He was in the water now, swimming against the tide, and the creature — he never looked back but he knew it was there — was gaining on him. Faster and faster he swam, reaching for breath, trying to escape the shadow in the darkness that would overwhelm him. He screamed in rage as it engulfed him, swallowing him whole, fighting, clawing for breath as he slid into its guts.

* * *

Light bleached his world. Two faces came to meet him, but they weren't saviours.

"Let's try again."

A huge hand slapped him hard across the face and he fell away until the wrist restraints bit in, jarring his shoulders. No point calling out — he'd tried that before. One of them spoke and he heard someone else replying with his voice. They wanted to know all about Jack, and Natalie, and it was funny to tell them about Natalie and Ray. But the big one, Charlie, was angry then. And now Ray was angry too.

Charlie's was the dominant voice. "I told you not to get involved with Natalie. Just like I told you not to pick on the kid."

"That ain't my fault — those stupid lads were only supposed to spray the buggy. Anyway it did the trick. Jack's so paranoid now that he's given me more control so I can run things."

Thomas closed his eyes while they argued with one another. How long had he been here? Hours? Days? His brain tried to figure it out, only every thought slithered free. The world had gone quiet again so he risked opening one eye. The faces had gone and there was a bucket not far away, reeking of piss. On the floor nearby were four broken cable ties. He shut his eyes again and slipped away.

“Medicine!”

This time he didn’t resist the road to oblivion. The voices retreated and he began to float again, until he heard a scream, fearful enough to scare the living and the dead. As if in primal response, something stirred deep inside him; coiling, besieging his organs to break free. Another scream and he screamed back, out into the darkness.

He opened his eyes and he was still in darkness. And there was still screaming — his and Karl’s. He called his friend’s name but it made no difference. Someone ran into the room and knocked over a container. It rattled around on the floor.

“Shut your fucking noise.” Ray, again.

He heard the fateful click that could only be a gun. And then his own voice begging for life.

Bang. The wall exploded by his ear, showering him with dust and brick fragments.

“Next time it will be you and then Miranda will be all alone.” Ray’s laughter scorched him, peeling away his defences until there was nothing left but despair

The monster breached the waves and vomited him up on a shoreline thick with oil. He twisted and turned, rolling in the slick as he tried to get free, but every breath drew in more viscous poison. Death would be slow unless he took that courageous step. He leaned into it and fell, face first, into the inky blackness. The smell permeated his skin, rippling through him until it spewed out again.

He choked up the vomit through stinging tears and felt its heat against his chest. He tried to lean sideways to avoid the stench from the hood. Sleep overtook him again.

He dreamt that someone was hitting an old-fashioned dustbin lid with a hammer, and then there was yelling. Someone was telling him his own

secrets about the bugging device and about Karl. And then there was nothing.

The world tilted forward, before he realised he was moving backwards against the radiator. A hand pressed down against his shoulder, then two clicks, and he could move his wrists again.

“You’re safe now. Save Karl.”

Something hard pushed against his foot. He was alone again. He waited a long time, or it seemed that way, until he lifted the hood. His legs throbbed in protest as he rolled forward to his knees, coming face to face with the pistol.

Instinct took over. He staggered to his feet and felt the silencer to make sure it was on properly. As he stumbled towards the doorway where he’d heard Karl screaming, something moved behind him to the left. He turned and fired, listening for the satisfying *thwap*. Whatever it was back there dropped like a stone.

His hands began to tingle the closer he got to the doorway. It didn’t matter how many of them were in there, they were all as good as dead. He saw two silhouettes at the far end of the room, stark against the windows. Point and fire; dead and buried.

More voices came from beyond the building, hidden by torch beams. He stood against them, holding back the storm, and the last words he remembered were, “Put down the weapon and get on the ground — do it now.”

The torches converged on him and he complied. Now he was flying again, flying free.

Chapter 50

Thomas woke from a dreamless sleep. Light filtered through the blue curtains; he figured it was morning wherever he was. His hand felt sore and then he noticed the Tube in his vein. There was no sea and no monsters. As he raised himself to sit up, the mother of all headaches decided to throw a street party in his skull.

When he gazed around the room everything looked unfamiliar, until he saw the armchair in the corner. Despite the throbbing in his head he couldn't help smiling.

"Miranda?" he rasped.

She shrugged off a blanket and rushed to his side, looking like she needed the bed more than he did.

"Can I have some water — and a painkiller?"

"Let me tell them you're awake."

When Miranda left he stretched out in bed — no broken bones anyway, although that hand, with scratches across it and a needle going in, was stinging like a bastard. Miranda returned — with Christine. She handed him a painkiller while Miranda poured some water.

"Well," Thomas tried to see the funny side, "this is awkward." The current and the ex, along with a fractured memory. Not good at all.

"I'll give you two a moment and then someone will come and unhook him." Christine turned back at the door. "Remember what we agreed, Miranda."

He was grateful when the pain subsided a little. Miranda said he'd been there a day, but he couldn't make out when that day might have started from.

"And where are we, exactly?"

"Safe house in Hertfordshire."

A stranger knocked and entered the room. He gave Thomas a cursory once-over, nodded to Miranda and then removed the cannula to the accompaniment of some choice epithets from Thomas.

"Drink as much fluid as you can."

The orderly left while Thomas was still wiping away the blood with a tissue.

"I grabbed some things from the flat . . . once I'd heard . . ." Miranda fetched some clothes out of a wardrobe.

"What did they actually tell you?"

"You're better off talking to Christine."

Walking took more effort than he'd expected. Miranda supported him on the short journey to the main room and left him at the door. He gripped the handle and went inside. Christine had her back to him. Karl leaned over to look past her.

"Ah, Tommo — the man himself!"

She turned aside, revealing Karl wearing a dressing gown. Christine waved a finger at Karl. "Two minutes, and then we need to get everything straight."

Karl mock-saluted behind her back as she left the room.

"Alone together at last. How much do you know about what happened?"

Thomas saw now that Karl was nursing an arm close to his chest. He squeezed his eyes shut to concentrate. "I shot three people . . . fuck! I killed Charlie and Ray." He opened his eyes and looked straight at Karl as the truth hit him. "I'm glad."

Karl had his mind on other matters. "How did you get yourself free? More importantly, how did you get a gun?"

Thomas recounted the few details he had any faith in. Then Karl delivered the killer punch line.

"Evidently Charlie and Ray were already dead. Unless you shot them, propped them up, and then shot them again for good measure."

"I don't understand; they were right by the windows — I couldn't miss them." He stopped then as he remembered the familiar, Scottish voice — *you're safe now*. "Ken Treavey." His eyes widened. "Which explains the gun."

The door handle rattled and Christine returned, this time with Ann Crossley and Bob Peterson. Christine moved over to the dining table. "Shall we?"

They sat down together, a party of five. Christine filled in the blanks — and there were a lot of them. How, when Thomas hadn't come home and

neither he nor Karl had answered their mobiles, Miranda had called the SSU and everywhere else she could think of until she obtained Christine's mobile number.

The SSU ID cards had given them a location, and then Bob Peterson had provided what Christine called *an assault team* to rescue them. Bob smiled then, and Thomas couldn't tell if he was being smug or conciliatory. Bob's team, whoever they actually were, had discovered two very dead people and another one wounded. A thorough search also revealed, as Bob explained, "a significant quantity of chemicals, which I've removed to secure storage."

Karl looked distinctly unhappy. "I'd like to have a wee chat with you about that."

Ann seized the moment and spoke directly to Karl. "A raid was executed at the house with the olive-coloured door — a home chemist had set up business there, for Charlie Stokes. They gave you both Scopolamine," she explained, not that Thomas understood anything from it. "Plus some other compounds. It interferes with memory and renders you open to suggestion."

Christine glanced at her watch. "Let's move on. Knowing we'd be pressed for time, Bob, Ann and I have already agreed an *official* version of events."

Thomas listened without comment to the mixture of half-truths and lies. It was a paper-thin fairy-tale: he and Karl had been looking for someone on behalf of Bob Peterson and stumbled upon a criminal connection, with unforeseen consequences.

The triumvirate of Bob, Christine and Ann had decided that Sir Peter would know nothing about the drug seizure or any connection to the Shadow State. Charlie Stokes wasn't even mentioned by name.

And from the looks of things Bob and Christine had managed some sort of reconciliation — even if only in their working relationship. Thomas sneered to himself; Bob's wife must be thrilled.

Christine didn't mention Ken Treavey either; maybe Bob had left out the finer details. Maybe he needed more painkillers.

"Well . . ." Bob stopped talking and Thomas realised he'd zoned out again. "That seems to be about everything. Any questions?" Bob smiled in Christine's direction and rested his hands on the table, near hers.

It seemed rude to disappoint him. Thomas coughed to get everyone's attention.

"What about the dead people?"

Bob didn't miss a beat. "What dead people? We only found you and Karl there."

Thomas felt the beginnings of a smile. Bob had the drugs and Christine's support and the glory. Yep, three steps ahead, just like he promised. But he was still a tosser.

"I think we'll end it there." Bob left the table. "Christine and I will see Sir Peter. He may want to speak with the rest of you afterwards."

* * *

Thomas sat down at the kitchen table. Miranda was seated opposite, with Karl and Ann either side of them. Four mugs of tea were on the table, untouched, while two rooms away the grown-ups were presumably redrawing the map.

"Is someone gonna say something?" Karl finished stirring his tea and put the spoon down next to it.

Miranda smiled across the table and Thomas suddenly thought about Ray Daniels. "I'm totally lost here. I don't know what we can and can't talk about." He glanced first at Miranda and then at Ann.

Miranda fidgeted. "Listen, if you three need to discuss work I can make myself scarce . . ."

"Karl?" Thomas stared daggers at him.

"The little boy is home now," Ann announced, out of the blue. "I kept an eye on things while you were away, Karl. I forget to mention that we intercepted the van — that was how Bob knew it wasn't just your IDs there — a smart move, leaving a message in the back."

Thomas had heard enough. "I'm going to get some air in the garden. You coming, Miranda?"

Outside, the autumn trees were all browns and copper. The grass was still wet and he trailed a foot across it to feel the dampness against the top of his trainer. The painkillers were doing their job nicely but he couldn't settle. There were things to be said and no easy way to say them.

"Ray Daniels is dead."

Miranda's face twitched for an instant. "Did he suffer? I hope so."

That was unexpected. He didn't push the point; she'd tell him in her own good time — or not. When he explained about Ken's return she suggested they ask for their money back. At least she'd kept her sense of humour.

"So what do you want to do when all this is over?" He threw an arm around her.

"Does that mean you're done with Jack Langton?"

"I dunno." The question unnerved him because he didn't have an answer. "I'm getting cold. I don't suppose there's another way in?"

"There is, as a matter of fact; I'll show you."

They reached a side door.

"You certainly know your way around."

"I remembered from last time."

Her face said it all. He caught the inference straight away. This was where she'd been held in exchange for the papers Yorgi's brother had stolen from him. More inescapable history.

"I'm sorry."

"You weren't to know. Shall we see if Karl wants to cook again?"

As they entered the corridor, Sir Peter was leaving the dining room.

"Ah, Thomas! And Miss Wright."

The combination of bluster and bullshit riled him, but he felt Miranda's steadying hand on his shoulder.

"I wonder if I could speak to you alone for a moment, Thomas?"

He shrugged Miranda's hand free. Who was he to disappoint a willing audience?

* * *

The table seemed larger, but maybe that was because there were only three people in the room; Christine and Bob had made themselves scarce. Karl was already seated at the head of the table, funny but true.

"The floor is yours, Mr Bladen." Karl opened his good hand.

Thomas threw him a glance that said, "really?" Karl nodded. He felt a tremor in his hand and flexed his fingers. "We could have died, clearing up your mess."

"That was regrettable. I knew nothing about it."

“You knew about Ken Treavey though.” He paused, waiting — in vain — for Karl to jump in. He levered himself up. “I can’t do this your way, Karl.” He leaned against the table for support and then eased himself back to freestanding. “Ken was none of my business until you got me involved. Now two people are dead — that I know of — and the trail of evidence leads back to you.”

Karl found his voice at last. “We have photos of Thomas leaving Main Building with a large parcel, along with its dimensions. We have a photo of the Ingersoll key, a match for the ballistics as well as Bob Peterson twice replacing the weapon.”

To Thomas it sounded like a Royal Flush laid out on the table. But Sir Peter’s face suggested he had a killer hand of his own.

“Excellent work, gentlemen. I knew I could rely on you.”

Thomas sat down again; it didn’t make any sense, unless . . .

“You wanted us to find out?” That made even less sense.

Sir Peter raised himself to his full stature. “Are you aware of Eva Fairfield?”

“The Home Office minister.” Karl made it a statement.

Sir Peter stared across the room, as if seeking inspiration. Thomas figured absolution was a more likely objective.

“Eva had a request and she made it very clear I was in no position to refuse. Sidney Morsley murdered a little girl and she wanted justice. Real justice. There was a distant family connection. *Blood for blood.*”

Karl was ahead of him. “But you had your misgivings so you laid a trail for us.”

Thomas shook his head. “It wasn’t conscience, Karl. He couldn’t bear to be under her control — he had too much to lose.” He glared at Sir Peter. “At least it was personal for her, but you — you don’t have a conscience. And why choose Ken?”

“Because of you, Thomas. I knew I could rely on your mistrust, and your loyalty to Karl. I involved Bob Peterson, as a contingency, because — unlike you — he’d do exactly as I told him and not ask questions.”

Thomas’s hand was throbbing again, aching to become a fist. Karl took one look and spoke again.

“And what about the second murder?”

“Eva contacted me again — a series of *incidents* would take the media’s attention off Morsley, to say nothing of the saving to the British taxpayer. Public opinion seems to be on her side.”

“Un-fucking-believable.” Thomas had heard enough. “You really are a monster. I’m going home, Karl. You do . . . whatever . . .” He pushed away the air between them.

“Hold on, Tommo — let’s think this through.” Karl showed no sign of moving.

Sir Peter adjusted one of his cufflinks. “Name *your* terms, Mr Bladen.”

Thomas reached the middle of the room and faced the negotiation table. The bastard was smiling. He wondered if Karl would intervene if he made a move on him. Even Thomas knew he was more valuable where they could see him. “You give Ken Treavey his life back. And this . . . Eva Fairfield? She has to go — within a month. You take care of this, Karl. Or, so help me, I’ll find another, more public way to resolve this.”

He left them to it.

Chapter 51

It hadn't occurred to Thomas that Miranda would hardly have been given directions to the safe house. Ann drove, and he listened.

"Bob asked me to give you this, recovered from the site. He said he hasn't watched it."

Thomas held the DVD between his fingertips, as if it might contaminate him. Someone had written his initials on it in permanent marker.

"Karl has his own and Bob gave him the others, as a show of good faith."

"Others?" he felt a knot in his stomach.

Ann glanced over earnestly. "Charlie Stokes kept meticulous records. Apart from you and Karl there were at least a dozen more victims."

"And the chemist?"

"Arrested and detained."

Thomas fell silent, thinking about a suitable punishment for Roland Dolan and Paulette Villers. They'd each played their part.

Miranda told Ann where to pull over.

"We'll call you in a few days, unless you're fit for duty before then."

"Understood. The sooner I get back to normality the better." Even he smiled at that; this *was* normality.

* * *

There were five messages at the flat, but there was something he had to do first. Miranda assured him she understood when he disappeared into his darkroom with a laptop and some headphones. There were fragments of memory floating around in his head and it wasn't enough. He needed to make sense of everything and the only way to do that was to face his demons.

The footage was grainy with sound — a typical CCTV rig. Ray and Charlie were difficult to decipher unless they got close to the radiator; there must have been a mic on the light fitting. That also explained the constant low hum in the background.

He felt a twinge in his guts when the two figures approached on-screen and force-fed him the poison — the ‘medicine.’ The body remembered. As the sweat prickled his forehead he got up from the laptop to catch his breath. He fast-forwarded until he saw the prisoner straining to get free, screaming about the darkness, the contours of his face briefly visible as he strained forward against the hood.

Ray asked the questions. Sometimes Charlie observed. He seemed to like doing that. He’d prompt Ray in a whisper then stand to one side to watch the whole thing at close quarters, studying the prisoner.

Thomas made notes of the questions and any keywords in his responses. Those he could understand, anyway. He worked through the interrogations methodically, searching for confirmation of a half-remembered dream.

Charlie and Ray, facing off. “I warned you not to get involved with Natalie. Just like I warned you not to pick on the kid.”

Ray had stood his ground, a pit bull to Charlie’s mastiff. “Jacob was a happy accident. Now Jack’s wound tighter than a spring and I’m in his bed.”

Charlie had stormed off, but Ray stayed, squatting down next to Thomas. “Absolute power — that’s the drug, Thomas. I can do *anything*. I could cut you now and you wouldn’t even remember — or choke you.” He grabbed him in a stranglehold and all Thomas could hear was himself choking. Then a gasp of breath as Ray released him. “I own you.” He leaned back and head-butted him, the *crack* smashing Thomas against the radiator.

Ray turned around for the camera and stared back from the grave. Thomas clicked the mouse to pause the footage, matching the gaze of a dead man. It wasn’t justice, but it would have to do.

He watched the rest of the recording with a clinical eye, writing down details as if it were another SSU job. His detachment only faltered again when Charlie had come to see him alone. Once the hood was raised, on-screen, Thomas had a fleeting flashback.

“Ray doesn’t understand, but I do.” Charlie waved the bug in front of Thomas’s face. “I would have picked you up anyway after your interest in Paulette and young Roland. You’re more than a Benefits snooper, though.

Karl, I already knew about, but you . . . the Cartel will be very interested in what you've got to say."

Thomas noted, to his shame, that he answered all Charlie's questions about Karl and their counter-intelligence work. He didn't reveal much, thank God, because he still didn't know a great deal — full marks to Karl on that front. He slipped the headphones off again and rubbed his eyes.

Miranda rapped on the door lightly. "Thomas? I didn't want to disturb you but Karl just rang — I didn't answer it. I'm popping out for some food. I'll be back in half an hour."

He let her know he was okay and checked the time. He'd been in there nearly two hours. When he heard the front door click behind her he ventured out into daylight and rang Karl back.

"How are you holding up, Thomas?"

"I'm fine." He actually meant it. "How's the arm?"

"Sprained, I think. It seems I put up more resistance than was good for me." Karl sighed like a carthorse. "I should never have got you in so deep."

"I'm fine," he repeated, a little sharper than before. "Occupational hazard." He read the silence and knew there was more to be said.

"It's been decided that Ray Daniels is officially only missing. It's useful to have a phantom out there — it'll keep Jack Langton on his toes as well."

Once again, expediency over the truth. Thomas gripped the phone.

"Ray was responsible . . . for Jacob."

"Ah well, justice has been served on that account. He was a dead man walking — Charlie too. Once they'd interrogated us I couldn't have risked compromising other operatives. If it hadn't been Ken, or you, I would have killed them myself."

"Is that supposed to make me feel better?"

Karl didn't answer. It didn't matter; Thomas understood. You could never really negotiate with monsters. Maybe Eva Fairfield saw that as well. Silver bullet, wooden stake, Browning pistol, or counter-intelligence — choose your weapon.

"I'll get my DVD to you. I've made notes as well but it's best to be thorough."

"Your notes will suffice, Thomas; I trust you." He said it like he meant it. "Destroy the DVD — you might find it therapeutic! Be seeing ya."

Thomas smiled. "Soon, I hope."

Time for one more call. He kept it brief and Natalie Langton never knew what hit her.

“It’s Thomas. Charlie Stokes is dead and Ray’s gone. I’m seeing Jack in a few days to give him the news, so you have time to pack if you want to leave.”

He didn’t have to spell it out for her. She begged and pleaded, said that Ray had used her and that Jack didn’t need to know. Both were probably true.

“Please — I can pay you, Thomas; I’ve got money here.”

“I’m not for sale.”

No, but she was. Maybe Karl could use her as a spy on the inside, to keep tabs on Jack when he got out of prison. She took the deal; it was the best offer on the table. He’d text Karl about it later.

By the time Miranda returned with a curry he had plates on the table and *An Inspector Calls* cued up in the player — an old-fashioned morality tale. His hand smarted from snapping his DVD into shards. Karl was right — it felt good.

Chapter 52

Although John had offered to accompany him to Wormwood Scrubs Thomas decided to go alone. Better to say his piece in relative privacy. He watched the swarm of commuters moving through the network, untroubled by the myriad of cameras — overt and covert — or the electronic footprint they were leaving. Maybe the populace was better off living in ignorance; give him the unadorned truth any day.

He picked up a tabloid as he left East Acton Tube and browsed the first few pages while a bus thundered by. Home Office minister Eva Fairfield had decided to step down from her role and seek out new opportunities. He smiled skyward: how noble of her. The article reported that the Home Secretary was saddened by her departure and felt she had made a unique contribution. That was one way of putting it.

His Surveillance Support Unit ID card won him the hands-on treatment again from the prison officers' welcoming committee. He didn't make a fuss; it wasn't like he planned on coming back. He followed procedure and then did the slow shuffle to the visitors' hall to await an audience.

Jack Langton had the same swagger as the late Mr Stokes. Thomas smiled and offered his hand.

"Any news?" Jack blinked a couple of times, as though seeing something different.

Thomas stared, keeping his voice monotone. "Charlie Stokes is dead — there'll be no more trouble . . ."

Jack grinned from ear to ear.

" . . . I haven't finished. Ray Daniels has disappeared."

The tip of Jack's tongue poked out of his mouth, tasting the future. "If Ray's not around, there's a vacancy — if you're interested?"

Thomas's face hardened. "No. I know what he's capable of."

"Well, look." Jack leaned back, fingers laced behind his head like he owned the place. "I owe you, and I'm a man who keeps his word. Name your price."

"Really?"

"Within reason, yeah!" Jack was grinning again.

“Stay away from the Wrights in future, and Sheryl. Not even a postcard. Your word, remember?” Thomas got up to leave. “Because I know everything about you now, Jack — *everything*.”

THE END

Book 4:

SHADOW STATE

A gripping espionage thriller you won't want to put down

DEREK THOMPSON



My thanks to:

Jasper Joffe, Anne Derges, Warren Stevenson, Sarah Campbell and Clive
Aplin.

Author's Note

I know what you're thinking — this is a Brexit book, right? Wrong. *Shadow State* is set in 2004, a significant year for the European Union. Ten countries joined the EU that year, redrawing the map of Europe that had existed since the end of World War II. Cyprus, the Czech Republic, Estonia, Hungary, Latvia, Lithuania, Malta, Poland, Slovakia and Slovenia joined an expanded EU.

The Shadow State of this book's title — which also features in *Standpoint*, *Line of Sight* and *Cause & Effect* — has its origins in Winston Churchill's 1946 speech in Zurich, in which he proposed a United States of Europe. That historical fact was the starting point for the Spy Chaser series, which is of course fiction.

Prologue

Stephen Heick smoothed his suit and closed the door of the safe, returning his PSA-25 pistol to darkness. At five minutes to nine he left his hotel room and joined the slipstream of human traffic downstairs. A tap of his lapel — the enamelled eagle pin was still in place — and he headed along the Thames. Sometimes he liked to see how quickly he could identify a courier as they approached. On darker days, he wondered whether *today* would be the day of his undoing. He picked up the pace, reassuring himself that murder on the streets wasn't their style, not in such a public space. And besides, he was still useful to them, he had connections.

The South Bank heaved with families and tourists and coach parties, bustling beside the Thames for their 'culture fix,' as his British friends liked to put it. Give him Washington DC any day, but London had its charms too, along with the risks.

He spotted the courier straight away — fresh-faced and earnest — an eagle pin high on his suit. They smiled in unison and he thought again how absurd this game was, as they exchanged pleasantries and an envelope slipped into his pocket. He walked on, switching smartly to the right so he could use a tour party as cover. Now he circled round and watched as the head bobbed away through the crowd.

Heick had gone barely twenty yards when he heard a scream. He kept on walking. Forty years in the service had smoothed his conscience to marble. As he grabbed a copy of *USA Today* he thanked the girl at the kiosk and pondered her accent. The Balkans, maybe? He smiled and she smiled right back, unable to tell that he had removed the eagle pin behind the newspaper. Now he could breathe easier.

When he got to Jubilee Park he picked up a coffee and found a prominent picnic table to survey the perimeter. He dropped his paper so he could bend down and check behind him. Clear as a prairie. He lifted the envelope from his pocket and felt along the wax seal. It gave way, revealing a plain business card with one word, handwritten in capitals: CHARLEMAGNE.

He stared at the card for a few seconds, suddenly aware that he was holding his breath. It was time to cash in his insurance policy and make a

call.

“It’s Stephen Heick. I need you to do something for me.”

Chapter 1

Thomas Bladen considered himself a patient man — a natural for the Surveillance Support Unit. If you waited long enough, and kept your nerve, the targets revealed their secrets. The same held true for the people around him, but he thought of himself as a closed book.

Whatever the assignment — Customs, Accident Investigation, Welfare cheats or the military — the SSU were simply the hired help. He'd always preferred it that way, but months spent in the warm bosom of the Benefits Investigation Team had finally started to get on his tits. Thankfully, like all good things, even bad assignments came to an end.

As his sidekick, Karl McNeill, had been quick to point out, there had been no leaving drink or collection for them. *Flush and go*, as Karl put it — another day in the life of the SSU. The BIT had bid them adieu on the Friday and now, Monday morning, that could mean only two things: a team review and finding out who was the next lucky winner.

Christine Gerrard had stipulated an eight-thirty start — boss's prerogative. Thomas was on Liverpool Street station concourse at eight, camera in hand, looking for . . . Well, just looking. The camera lens didn't keep office hours.

He watched the wheeler-dealers and desk jockeys stream out towards the city and the scent of money. And while he still didn't subscribe wholeheartedly to the 'Gospel of Karl', with its pan-European Shadow State pulling invisible strings, he'd seen enough now to admit there was some truth in it. Every minute of every day a battle of numbers and influence raged on, a shifting sandbank of allegiances and conflicts played out in secret. Despite knowing that, Thomas was content to remain on the sidelines — a reservist in Karl's intelligence war, to be called up when required.

Two moody skylines and a deliberately out-of-focus crowd shot later, he walked the short distance to the SSU's London East location — a nondescript, concrete, plain-clothes block. He spotted one of his MI5 colleagues from the first floor ahead of him, and deliberately avoided sharing the lift. What was it with MI5 and their aversion to stairs?

It was eight-twenty when he swiped in on the second floor. No sign of Karl — the lazy bastard — and the office in darkness, like a surprise party. He flicked on the lights and glanced along the two rows of desks. Beyond them, even Christine's room was empty.

She wasn't far behind him, bustling through with a bag in one hand and a rucksack in the other. As she passed he suddenly recalled that smile in different circumstances, long ago.

"I won't keep you." She unlocked her office and set its strip lights humming.

He freed a laptop from his desk drawer and caught up on paperwork. Karl and Ann Crossley — the fourth musketeer — arrived together, trading playful insults. Karl's Belfast brogue sounded brazen against Ann's polished Cambridge tones, where only a hint of Cardiff slipped through.

They both acknowledged Thomas when he turned round. Karl winked. Thomas shook his head. He had lost track of whether Karl and Ann were genuinely on good terms, or if the *other* departments they each reported to had called for greater cooperation. Maybe he'd bring that up in the team review.

Christine called them in at eight-thirty on the dot. She followed her agenda meticulously — on paper as in life. An hour and fifteen of assignment feedback, expenses sign-offs and lessons learned, and even Christine seemed to be losing the will to live. He clocked her checking her watch for the second time.

"Okay, let's take a few minutes. Thomas, would you like to get the coffees? My treat."

A £20 note wafted before him. He wrote the orders on a slip of paper and left them to it, certain that a conversation of a different kind would start up once he closed the door. He smiled to himself. Best let them get on with it. Wheels within wheels.

* * *

Outside, London had lost none of its urban charm. Yorkshire might have been his native land but the capital was home now. Despite Dick Whittington's promises, he'd found that the streets weren't paved with gold. Based on his surveillance experience they were more likely to be covered in

vomit and syringes. Nevertheless, the great city's appeal shone through — resilient and unbowed — like the wrong woman at the right time.

As he strolled along Bishopsgate, taking in the scenery at the firm's expense, a dark sedan drove past and slowed up ahead of him. He kept walking, noting the tinted windows, the number plate and a lack of consideration for the Highway Code. The car's hazard lights started flashing. Out of habit he checked the side road across the street — the logical escape route on foot. The car didn't move. As he drew level, the passenger window descended.

"Thomas Bladen?"

He took it to be rhetorical. There were two men in the front and a woman in the back. Her door swung open. He stepped aside to let her out and she held the door for him.

"Mr Bladen, will you come with us please?"

A smarter man might have walked away. Thomas had always favoured instinct over smarts.

"Who's us?"

"Everything will be explained when we get there."

He got in, expecting her to follow, but she kept hold of the door.

"I'll need your pass, please. It will be returned to you."

He started a list on his mental chalkboard. 1: They knew him by name. 2: They were expecting him. 3: They knew his SSU pass had an inbuilt tracker.

It was all done with precision. As soon as he'd handed over his ID card the door slammed shut, locked, and the car pulled away. He nearly clapped.

The front passenger turned round.

"This shouldn't take long. Sit back and enjoy the ride."

He played the hand he'd been dealt and stayed calm. They dressed well, in suits too good for any agency he knew. Nice car. He took a breath and thought about it. This hardly counted as abduction. Not like the time when he and Karl had been drugged and thrown in the back of a van. *Ergo* — to use one of Christine's words — these people were in a similar line of work and they wanted something.

London merged around him in a tinted wonderland as the driver fed through the one-way system and doubled back into the City, arriving in the banking district.

“Here we are, Thomas — safe and sound.”

He placed the voice midway between reassuring and businesslike. The car idled on double-yellows outside a glass and steel monolith, a monument to commerce. He got out and gazed up at the building. ‘Artesian Shield Investments’ glistened above the revolving glass door.

His new friend guided him up the polished steps and had him sign in, for fuck’s sake — the suit on reception handing him a visitor’s pass. All very slick and he didn’t buy it for a moment.

The waiting room was too plush to be an interrogation room. He figured it was wired for sound and vision, so he sat comfortably and plundered the boiled sweets in a bowl. He considered texting Karl to update him. Then again, what could he expect Karl to do about it? No, he was here by request, more or less, and he’d handle it himself for now.

A glossy ASI brochure yielded few clues. Aside from the greed-is-good *spiel* he noted they had offices in London, Geneva, Washington and Hong Kong. Karl had been to Geneva a few months back and the UN had a headquarters there. He smiled at his own efforts to join the dots and make a familiar shape.

Minutes ticked away. Moving to the door he heard phones ringing and the background chatter of a call centre. He wondered what might happen if he went walkabout but he never got the chance to find out. Once he’d turned the handle and eased it back he heard muffled footsteps and found himself face to face with the front passenger from the car.

“Sorry to have kept you waiting. Is there anything I can get you?”

An explanation would be nice. There was no trace of irony in the voice so he paid him the same compliment.

“Sure.” He passed over the twenty with the three-coffee list. “You can get these delivered.” He didn’t bother writing down the address, certain they knew it.

His host glanced at the list and smiled. “Not a problem — I’ll pass this on. Meanwhile, how about I get *you* a coffee? How do you like it?”

“Bitter, and with a muffin.”

“Coming right up.”

The accent was British but the inflection was mid-Atlantic. Interesting.

One coffee and a muffin later — blueberry, no less — he was back to wondering what the game was. Well, he knew about *the* game, but this was

a new development: polite abduction by appointment.

He tried the door again and ventured into the mezzanine corridor. Someone on the floor below caught his eye and picked up the phone. He turned left and started walking, away from the main stairs.

As he reached the lifts, a man in his late fifties emerged. Another nice suit — pale grey, made to measure. Business must have been good.

“Mr Bladen — Thomas? Sorry to have kept you. Stephen Heick.” He proffered a hand. “I was unavoidably detained.”

“I know just how you feel.”

The suit didn’t rise to the bait. “Let’s take a walk.”

By now he had the accent pegged to US East Coast. Not the brashness of Miranda’s Brooklyn bar manager, Sheryl. These were the softer tones of New England. What troubled him were the eyes.

The suit smiled, as if reading his mind. “You spotted the McNeill family resemblance?” He tilted the ID card. “It’s an interesting story. We can talk in my office.”

“As long as we make a detour on the way.”

At least Heick hadn’t followed him to the urinal. He took a leak, ran his hands under the tap and dried them carefully. A quick check of his mobile phone showed no contact from either Karl or Christine. As if he normally disappeared on the coffee run.

He did his thinking double-time. Karl had only mentioned McNeill senior — that is, Heick — once, when Karl’s father made an appearance at his mother’s funeral in Belfast. Karl hadn’t spoken about him before or since, so he figured a happy family reunion wasn’t on the cards.

Heick took Thomas down a floor and through the hi-tech call centre where traders — if that’s what they were — watched fluctuating share prices. Half the workers sat transfixed by their screens, while the rest were busy transcribing from headphones. Heick offered no explanation, although Thomas knew he was making a point so he paid close attention.

They took another lift up to the third floor.

“Come on in. Take a seat. Another coffee, Thomas?”

The office was large enough to house an additional table and chairs, overlooking part of the city with the Thames slithering behind. Thomas made a play of noticing the three clocks on the wall, showing the local time in London, New York and Hong Kong.

“So what are you, CIA?”

Heick picked up a folder and placed it in front of Thomas before returning to his desk. Thomas could feel the weight of expectation as he lifted the manila cover. Heick didn't speak — he didn't have to. A selection of images — Miranda parking up outside her bar, Caliban's. Thomas and Miranda in a restaurant, and a copy of the recent photo for Thomas's work ID — spoke volumes. He stared at the pages and dug his nails into his hand, to stave off the feeling that the walls were closing in.

“I'll give you a couple of minutes and then we'll get down to business.” Heick left the room.

The file made grim reading. They'd taken a keen interest in his life — especially in London. Names, addresses, pressure points. He nearly lost it and made a call when he read an entry about his previous relationship with Christine Gerrard, but he could hardly expect Karl to arrive with reinforcements. Karl, who was conspicuously absent from the details.

Thomas reached the end of the slender folder and was working backwards when Heick returned, manoeuvring the door with his elbow, coffees in hand. Heick joined him at the table.

“I take it I have your full attention.”

Thomas didn't dignify the statement with outrage or a hot coffee to the face, much as he wanted to.

“I'm listening.”

“I have a message for Karl. He's unlikely to trust me, so I'll need you to convince him when I'm ready to share it.”

Thomas watched a tourist launch in the distance, motoring up the Thames, enjoying their sanitised view of London, all Kings and Queens and the Great Fire. Miranda had taken him on a tour once, when he'd first brought her back to her family from Leeds. Ah, Little Miss Runaway. He held on to the memory and let Heick choke on the silence.

“Let me make myself clear.” Heick captured his gaze. “I can take a bulldozer through your life, Thomas. I click my fingers and everything turns to dust.” He took out his phone. “I need your personal mobile number. And leave it switched on twenty-four hours a day — understand?”

Thomas did as he asked and then went over to the window. He could feel the sweat clinging to his armpits. Heick had him boxed in from all sides, but he needed to check the foundations.

“Why me?”

Heick considered the point for a heartbeat. “You work with Karl. You’re a means to an end.” He checked his watch. “We’re done. You won’t discuss this with anyone.”

The black sedan was waiting outside. Heick shook his hand on the steps, publicly professional.

“I’ll be in touch, Thomas. You’ll get your pass back at the drop-off.”

“Next time just text me.”

Heick’s face didn’t crack.

Thomas got in the car. Same pair in the front, all smiles. He sat back and tried to figure out his options. It didn’t take long.

Chapter 2

Karl and Ann were at their desks when Thomas returned. Karl barely acknowledged him and he was glad. The longer he delayed conversation the more chance he'd have to come up with something better than 'don't tell anyone but I met your dad.'

He strolled past to Christine's door, knocked and went in, closing the door carefully behind him. Christine looked up from her laptop.

"Hi, Thomas. How was he?"

He narrowed his eyes. "Who?"

"Sir Peter." She blinked at him a couple of times.

He smiled faintly. Sir Peter Carroll, Director General of the Surveillance Support Unit — the glorious leader. He ticked an imaginary list. "I'm not sure what you mean."

"Sir Peter told me first thing this morning he'd be sending a car for you — nine forty-five sharp."

He leaned forward, over the desk. "And you never thought to question it, or to let me know?"

"When Sir Peter makes a request, I do what I'm asked."

He took a step back. He had what he needed. "I hope you enjoyed your coffee."

She returned to her screen. "We'll talk later."

He took the hint: dismissed.

Ann Crossley was out of her chair before he'd pulled the door to. There was no eye contact between them.

Karl motioned to join him at his desk. "What do you reckon, Tommo — girls' night out?"

"Did I miss anything?"

"Only the main event!" Karl performed a mediocre drum roll on his desk. "And this week's SSU new assignment award goes to . . . the Metropolitan Police!"

"Blimey! A decent assignment at last. Is this one down to you?" It wouldn't be the first time.

Karl shook his head. "Rumours of my powers of influence have been greatly exaggerated."

"What time are we expected?"

"Two p.m. at Paddington Green police station."

They took an early lunch in The George to beat the striped-shirt brigade. Thomas hunched over his Shepherd's Pie, waiting for an opportunity to talk families with Karl.

"Tommo, do you not think it's incredible that a pub this beautiful has survived the ravages of time and modernity?"

Thomas gazed around, taking in the sienna-coloured wooden panelling and intricate carved ceiling as if he was seeing them for the first time.

"You're a wee bit quiet today — even for you."

"Yeah, about that . . ."

A text pinged on his phone. '*I need to see you — Sheryl.*' Awkward, given that Sheryl was Miranda's bar manager. Happy families would have to wait.

"Karl, how do you fancy a drink after work at Caliban's, and then on to a club?"

"Sounds good to me." Karl beamed.

* * *

After twelve or so years in London Thomas considered himself a bit of a connoisseur when it came to architecture. Historical or modern, every building made a statement and Paddington Green police station's monolithic message was unequivocal: 'Don't fuck with me.' Karl led the way in as if he was no stranger, which Thomas knew might well be the case. If three years alongside the Man from Strabane had taught him anything, it was that anything was possible.

They showed their passes at the front desk and stood to one side. Five minutes later a door buzzed and Sergeant Karen Edwards beckoned them over. She checked their credentials for herself. She seemed irritated, and carried it in her walk, muscling the door to the stairwell without speaking.

Thomas counted her steps and fell in line behind her, leaving Karl to follow at the rear. There was a lingering odour in the stairwell, a blend of floor cleaner and stale coffee.

A steady stream of uniforms filed down the stairs. Some acknowledged the sergeant with a look of sympathy. Thomas thought about his sole friend from childhood, Ajit, now serving with North Yorkshire police. Aj didn't know how lucky he was.

Edwards shoved a double door and it gave with a shriek. "Nearly there!"

A side door led to an open office with a glass pod within it. She rapped on a pane and ushered them inside.

Thomas summed up the bloke at the desk in three words before he even opened his mouth: university, privileged, fast-tracked. He looked like he ought to be back in college, and had the complexion to prove it.

The boss eased back in his chair. "We'll dispense with formalities, shall we? You've met Karen. I'm DI Ferguson. I imagine you know the drill but let me set out my stall. We're two people down and you're here to help. So keep your noses clean, do as you're told and we'll all get along famously."

Thomas caught a waft of aftershave that screamed 'alpha male' and nearly gagged. Even the sarge looked in need of some air.

"Karen can fill you in on the details — she'll be your primary contact. Any questions?"

He stole a glance at Karl. They both knew better than to answer that.

"Fine. Then we'll see you tomorrow at six am."

Karen took her cue when he'd stopped talking. "I'll show you where everything is, starting with the canteen."

* * *

The sergeant stirred another sugar into her tea. "First time I've seen you two. Normally we get them from the West team — you must have drawn the short straw. Hope you don't need a social life!"

"You worked for Ferguson long?" Karl managed to make it sound like an accusation.

"Six months or so. He's not so bad once you get to know him, even if he was fast-tracked in and gunning for glory."

Thomas smiled. Bingo. "And you?"

"Came up from the trenches. Plodded up, you might say!"

“Congratulations, detective sergeant.” Karl gave her a mini salute.

“Yeah, no one had any issues with me being black. It was the Brummie accent they struggled with. Come on, drink up and I’ll take you over to your new home while you’re here.”

It didn’t take a detective to deduce this wasn’t going to be assignment of the century.

“There’ll be a full briefing first thing tomorrow, but the *highlights*,” she mocked the DI, will be surveillance in relation to organised crime — high-value vehicle thefts — and analysis of the mountain of data we’ve been collecting.”

* * *

Although Thomas’s mood lifted a little at the neon *Caliban*’s sign, he couldn’t help thinking about the assignment timetable. Early shifts would not suit Miranda, which meant she’d be keeping well away.

He entered the bar and scoured the room for Sheryl. Miranda stood behind the pumps.

“To what do I owe the pleasure?” Meaning: you never texted me to say you were coming.

He let it pass and leant over the bar to kiss her, drawing a cheer from a corner table.

“All on your lonesome tonight?” He kept his tone flat.

“Yeah, Sheryl phoned in sick today. Reckons she’ll be in tomorrow.”

Karl was at his side. “Can’t get the staff.”

“Tell me about it. You two stopping?”

Karl looked to Thomas.

“Just passing through. Got some work-related training tonight.”

“Right, well, don’t let me keep you.” She poured two shandies and held out a hand for the money.

Karl followed him to the table furthest from the bar.

“You serious about tonight?”

“Uh huh. You have your passport with you?”

“Always.” Karl tapped his jacket pocket.

Chapter 3

Thomas had long ago accepted that life could be contradictory. Forget what the media said, the world was run by private agreements and unseen power plays. What had once seemed like Karl's paranoid delusions had been shown, time and again, to be bang on the money. And now, thanks to Sir Peter Carroll's personal delivery service, Thomas had another interested party to consider: Karl's dad.

He knew the indoor firing range would be the perfect place to talk and relax — another of life's little paradoxes. He just needed an opening.

"You're taking your time. Something on your mind, Tommo?"

Thomas concentrated on the business at hand, rhythmically discharging the Heckler & Koch pistol. When he'd conceded the yellow line to the maestro, he watched in silent awe as Karl decimated the target. Considering how often he'd relied upon Karl's marksmanship in the past, this was rather comforting.

Karl stopped at eight, cleared the chamber and set the weapon down.

"Come on then, out with it."

Thomas rubbed his hands together and then blew on them, as if loading dice with luck.

"How come you never asked where I went this morning?"

"If you need me to know you'll tell me."

If only it were that simple. He tried a different tack, best poker face on.

"You've never really spoken about your dad."

Karl scratched his chin. "Not much to tell. You know he ran out on my ma and me. Reading between the lines, they didn't get on too well. The end."

"And you've never been curious?"

Karl packed the handgun away. "Of course I have. When I started in Intelligence I looked for dear ole dad. I found nothing. Sure, Stephen McNeill had worked in Northern Ireland, more than one job actually, up until he left us. Then he disappeared off the face of the Earth."

Thomas let the man talk.

"I thought . . . well, maybe he'd come to an unfortunate end. The Province could be a dangerous place for foreigners back then, even

Americans. Here's the thing though," Karl snapped the lid shut. "One day someone owed me a massive favour and she found out that Stephen McNeill left the UK for the USA and never cleared Passport Control over there."

Thomas felt a lump in his throat: Karl as a child, fatherless. Jesus, his own dad had never been parent of the year but at least he'd been there.

"His name is Stephen Heick now, Tommo, seeing as you're asking."

* * *

Thomas figured Sheryl would want to talk and he preferred to do that somewhere private, so he waited until he got home. He was double-locking the front door after ten when he heard the beep from his answering machine.

"Just ring me when you get this, Thomas. Please." Sheryl sounded desperate, her ballsy Brooklyn tones strained and vulnerable. She'd rung off by the time he got to the phone. There were a series of messages from her throughout the day.

He thought about ringing Miranda first and decided against it. If she'd wanted Miranda to know, she wouldn't have rung him direct.

Sheryl picked up first time.

"It's Thomas. Is everything okay?"

"Thank God. Where the hell have you been? I've been calling you."

"I've been busy."

"I'll come right over."

"What? Now?"

She'd already hung up.

* * *

Sheryl made it there by eleven and she had a bag with her. He gave her an awkward one-armed hug and tried hard not to make it obvious she wasn't welcome. She sat on the edge of an armchair and stared at her feet.

"So, this is home, huh?"

He went to put the kettle on.

"I'm sorry to turn up like this, Thomas. If there was any other way . . ."

He waited in the kitchen and she followed him out there.

"I had a phone call last night, telling me to expect a visitor today."

He'd already guessed the punchline. "American?"

“Uh huh. He’d done a thorough job of delving into my life. Things no one knows about.

“And Jack Langton?”

“No.” She cupped her hands around her tea. “He wasn’t in the file — unlike you. Is it okay if I stay tonight?”

“Why didn’t you tell Miranda?”

“He said not to. Thomas, they can mess with my residency here.”

“What did he want you to do?”

“Nothing, really. I was to come and talk to you.”

Like he needed the additional pressure.

“You can sleep on the sofa. I’ll get you some blankets.” He would have given up his bed, but he’d been caught out like that once before. And besides, he had an early start.

Chapter 4

Karl waved him down in the street. He looked like a lost soul, standing there at five-fifteen in the morning. Thomas hadn't bothered to check whether he'd been followed here. They already had his life sewn up.

"Well?" Karl chewed it over on the drive to the police station. "Out with it. You're itching to tell me. Where *did* you go with Sir Peter Carroll yesterday?"

No time like the present. Thomas laid it out from start to finish. Karl listened with his fingers together in his lap, taking *self-contained* to a new level. Thomas had expected some kind of a reaction. Instead he got cold detachment.

Paddington Green police station was a blaze of light in the early morning, and already a hive of activity. They made it to the briefing just before the introductions. DI Ferguson lapped up the limelight. Karen Edwards whispered that he'd come in specially and wouldn't be stopping. He preferred to lead from the front, at least for the first ten minutes.

"I'd like to welcome Karl and Thomas, who join us from the Surveillance Support Unit's East office. I know I can rely on your professionalism . . ." He paused for the customary calls of 'floaters' to die down.

As promised, Karen would be their 'handler' — cue more laughter from the thin blue line. Someone asked whether she could handle the both of them and Karen told the bloke to go handle himself. Thomas saw that as a good sign.

Once the ten minutes of team talk were over, people began to disperse. A tall figure crossed the room and proffered a handshake. "Jun Wen."

"Yeah, we're like a minorities unit." Edwards laughed and Jun joined in.

Jun vaulted the elephant in the room. "I'm BBC."

Thomas quickly solved the riddle. "British Born Chinese."

"Got it in one. Right, let's push on."

Jun added some background en route to Karl and Thomas's new home. "The organisation steals high-value vehicles and most get sent out of the

country. Some get broken up and that's an avenue we're starting to investigate." He rattled off details and reminded them to stick to the brief.

* * *

At seven a.m. they were in position, looking at the world through a lens. They had a laptop primed to intercept and record landline calls and their vantage point offered a line of sight to the front of the building.

It was pretty clear by nine-thirty, when Jun brought over a fresh flask and muffins. This was going to be a job with a lot of thinking time. Thomas tried to organise his thoughts before he opened his mouth. Heick — it didn't seem right to call him Karl's dad — obviously wanted Karl's support for something important.

"What do I tell Heick when he gets in touch again?"

"Whatever he needs to hear."

Around ten o'clock a minicab deposited an old man outside the shutters. He jangled a set of keys and unlocked a galvanised door set into a roller. Thomas glanced at his watch. "The criminals get a lie-in then."

"Human rights." Karl left the laptop and came back to the window. "You mind if I make a couple of calls?"

"Fine by me. Don't be long."

Karl wandered off in the direction of the toilet. While he was gone the laptop kicked into life, a ringtone announcing an incoming call. Thomas looked over but stayed at his post. It would all be on disk. The conversation jangled through the computer's tinny speaker — an inquiry about replacement tyres. Thomas smiled. A code so simple that a nine-year-old could crack it. 'Four sports tyres wanted. Urgent delivery.'

A 4x4 drove past the shutters, the sort that Thomas called a fake Land Rover. He photographed it anyway and waited for laughing boy to return.

"That building you visited near Bank is completely legit. Which means," Karl took his place at the window, "it isn't. Although ASI has been a bona fide company for decades."

"I've got to say, Karl, you're taking all this in your stride. If it was my dad I'd want to give him a good lamping."

"Nah." Karl waved a hand in the air, as if he were wiping away a stain. "It's ancient history. Did he tell you he got me into the army? True enough, I have to give him some credit for that. I found out way down the line. As

far as I'm concerned, he's like anyone else in the intelligence community — to be treated with a mixture of respect and suspicion. Incidentally," Karl passed over his phone, "I took the liberty of picking up a couple of ASI unlisted numbers for you."

Thomas copied down the numbers and didn't ask who had texted them. Time to be unpredictable.

The first number went through to another office, so he asked for Heick and said he was looking to invest in European stocks. He could see Karl smiling at his camera. Heick was out so he left him a message. "It's Thomas Bladen. Just wanted to thank you for our informative meeting and I look forward to the next one."

"Do you have a plan, Tommo?"

"Not yet. First I need to know what Heick wants. A tenner says it's not a family reunion!"

Karl sucked a tooth. "Don't be so sure. We're in the same business now, remember. Hey, nice motor."

Thomas moved to the window, just as the Honda CR-V pulled away — the vehicle he'd seen earlier.

"It's the second appearance. Same driver? Twenties or thereabouts?"

"Yeah, I'd say so. Interesting. Yer man at the wheel was on his mobile phone. A pound to a penny he'll be back. Maybe the old geezer inside the building is hard of hearing."

The Honda CR-V returned within five minutes. Only this time, as it pulled up, the shutter was raised. Thomas left the camerawork to Karl and did some surveillance of his own with binoculars. There were shopping bags behind the driver and . . . holy fuck . . . a baby in a car seat.

"Karl?"

"Yeah, I see it." Karl stayed with his camera.

Thomas watched, transfixed, as the vehicle disappeared undercover and the shutter descended. A minute later the driver emerged alone and ran off along the street. Thomas knew the score — an opportunist car theft, and meanwhile some mother was going out of her mind.

"We can call it in, Tommo."

"And how long will that take? No, I'll go now. I have the element of surprise and the old bloke won't want a kidnapping on his conscience."

"What if there's someone else there?"

Thomas was already by the door.

“Wait!” Karl caught up with him. “Put this on.” He slipped a device into his pocket. “At least I’ll hear you.”

“Give me a tracker too. Maybe we can go one better.”

Chapter 5

Thomas made his way down to street level and walked round to the garage. Whispering ‘command and control’ to himself, he marched to the gate. If this was going to work he’d have to be resolute and fast.

He banged on the metal door and waited, checking the street for any sudden arrivals. The old bloke was already speaking as he opened the inner door.

“I don’t want no part of this. I’m just a caretaker—” He stopped when he saw Thomas.

Thomas shoved him backwards and closed the door behind him. “I’ve come for the kid.”

It was dark, and the neon high above cast everything in an eerie bluish light. The caretaker had recovered and was reaching for his phone.

“Turn it off or it’ll be the last thing you’ll do.” Thomas smiled to himself as the bloke capitulated. Okay, he’d exaggerated a bit — the last thing you’ll do *for a while*.

“Who are you?” the guy stammered.

“Someone who can solve your problem.”

The caretaker held out his hands the way you stop a charging dog. “He never said there was a kid in the back.”

Bollocks. Think fast, Thomas. Command and control.

“Okay, it works like this. I take the kid and I walk out, and none of this ever happened.”

“Did Mr Moretti send you?” Now the bloke looked terrified.

Thomas leaned in and smiled. “Mr who?”

The old guy’s legs buckled on the way to the car. Thomas helped him up, roughly, so as not to appear soft. When they reached the car, Thomas saw that the baby was still asleep.

“Right, turn around.”

The old bloke was shaking now, which said something about the sort of people he dealt with.

“Please,” he whispered. “I’ll do anything.”

“Close your eyes — and stay there.”

In less than two minutes, Thomas had photos of nine number plates. He opened the Honda's door and carefully unclipped the car seat. *Gently does it.* Once he'd accomplished that he pushed the tracking device down into the crack between the seats. If he'd had more time he'd have planted it in the office, but he knew when not to chance his luck.

He could hear the guy sobbing and turned to check he was still in position, hands at the back of his head. Poor bastard.

"Give me your mobile number." Thomas set the baby down and tapped the number into his phone. "And you better not be lying to me."

"Please . . . don't tell Arlo Moretti."

"It'll be our secret," Thomas assured him.

He left the bloke sitting on the floor with his head in his hands, whispering 'thank you' like a mantra.

Outside, Thomas rocked his arm back and forth as he walked, hoping to keep the baby asleep. He managed about thirty paces.

"Karl, mission accomplished."

"So I heard. You'd better head back here."

"Nah, too conspicuous. That's why the Bat Cave never had a crèche." Karl laughed like a donkey on nitrous oxide. It helped Thomas take his mind off the tremor in his hands.

He knew Karl wouldn't desert his post so they compromised. He'd play babysitter in the nearest cafe he could find, and in the meantime Karl could contact Karen Edwards.

She rang Thomas while he was still on the move.

"What the bloody hell have you been up to?" she hissed. "You could have jeopardised a city-wide surveillance operation. You still might have."

Thomas bore her scorn stoically. He doubted the mother would see it that way. "How soon can you get here?"

"I'm on my way now — alone, like your sidekick asked. You better have a good explanation."

It was hard to appear nonchalant when an unmarked black Vauxhall Astra sped towards him, blue lights flashing silently at the front.

"Well, get in!" Edwards barked, cursing as he struggled to secure the child carrier on the backseat.

He'd barely closed his passenger door before she put her foot down. The kiddie saw this as the ideal moment to bawl its head off.

“Bloody marvellous. Now, you’ve got ten minutes to tell me what the *fook* is going on.”

All things considered, it could have been worse. Giving her Moretti’s name and explaining that he’d planted a device in the Honda seemed to offset most of her fury. She evidently did her thinking aloud.

“My DI is gonna go mental. The best we can hope for is that they move the Honda on somewhere else and we get another piece of the pie.”

He was pretty sure she meant ‘puzzle,’ but now was not the time to be picky. As her brain rattled around the car he leant back and tried the old Bladen charm on the bairn. A couple of funny faces and some finger play seemed to distract it for a while — him too.

They pulled up outside a police station, where a distraught woman was already waiting beside a couple of uniforms. He got the kid out and passed it to a sea of waiting arms, and then got back in quickly so the mother couldn’t speak to him.

Edwards muttered a few words with her colleagues and then drove off. She stopped a hundred yards up the road and parked, slapping her hands against the steering wheel.

“All credit to you both. But if you think that’s the end of it, you’re very much mistaken. DI Ferguson wants to see you after your shift.”

They ditched the car and Edwards walked him back to the surveillance site. Thomas put the kettle on and gave Edwards and Karl some space. Tea made and a piss later, he carried through a tray and the last of the digestives from the cupboard. Edwards was slapping Karl’s arm and smiling.

“You’re a funny bastard.” She shifted round to rendezvous with the tray. “Thanks, Thomas. I need a cuppa after this morning. I believe one of those biscuits has my name on it.”

He put the tray down near her, grabbed a mug of tea and went over to the window, listening at relatively close quarters for the fifteen minutes she stuck around. She was so quiet back there that, out of habit, he checked his mobile for messages. The first text up was from Sheryl — a simple thank you. That was followed — uncomfortably quickly, judging by the times — with Miranda suggesting they meet up that night if he were free. He did the maths and figured he’d still have time to re-masculate the flat. He paused, mid-thought. Heick might have warned Sheryl off from telling Miranda but

there was no saying he had to. She'd find out anyway and surely it was better coming from him.

"Another vehicle stopping." He set his phone aside and took some photos. It struck him then that it'd be a good thing if there were no official footage of him leaving the target area, especially with a baby on his arm.

"Is it the same driver?" Karl called over, probably for Edwards's benefit.

"Looks like it. This one's an Audi."

"Right, chaps, I'll leave you to it." She brushed the crumbs from her trousers. "I'll pick you up later."

Thomas didn't speak again until the door closed. "Did you manage to get her onside?"

Karl shrugged. "I hope so. Don't get me wrong — we did the right thing. I'm surprised, actually. Time was when you'd sit back and let me take the lead. Miranda must be feeding you something special."

Thomas let it pass. As much as he trusted Karl, Miranda was sacred ground.

By the time the next shift arrived, Thomas had excised any images showing him outside the storage facility. That left things messy, but DS Edwards and DI Ferguson would just have to puzzle it out for themselves. That's what detectives were supposed to be good at.

Chapter 6

It didn't take surveillance skills for Thomas to figure out DS Edwards was pissed off. The odds were that DI Ferguson had given her another grilling, not that she revealed much. No, that joyful conversation was still awaiting them.

She remained in the car, hands on the wheel, staring ahead as if she could see the iceberg. Thomas opted for the passenger seat and left Karl to sit behind. He watched for signs of life and began with an easy question.

"What did Ferguson say?"

She threw him a glance. "DI Ferguson was as perplexed as I am. He wanted to know if you two are on some *other* assignment?"

That killed the conversation for a few minutes. Thomas wasn't sure how to respond and Karl, thankfully, had taken an unexpected vow of silence.

Edwards started again as they sailed through the lights. "The thing is, I can see why you got involved. What troubles me — and my DI — is that you were capable of doing so."

If Thomas had thought Karl would intervene, he was disappointed. The backseat was as quiet as a leatherette grave.

"Ask the baby's mother how she feels."

He could hear Karl chuckling.

"Point taken, Thomas. But it doesn't answer the question." She shut up again.

A couple of uniformed officers gave them a quick round of applause as they went up the stairs. Thomas figured word had already got around the police station. Either that or they were taking the piss.

* * *

DI Ferguson waited in the middle of his office, out of his depth in the shag pile. There were no coffees in evidence. Edwards closed the door and the four of them stood like chessmen in search of a board. Ferguson let go a heavy sigh.

"What were you thinking?"

Thomas could see he was sweating. Karl cleared his throat.

“The child was at risk and we assessed her to be in imminent danger. Section 17 of the Police and Criminal Evidence Act . . . End of story.”

DI Ferguson pointed a finger at Karl’s face. “Don’t be clever,” he snapped.

It had been well worth the call to Ajit before Edwards picked them up.

“Look,” Thomas tried to smooth the ripples, “We had to act quickly in case the car was moved on. We knew there was only one person on site — just the hired help. It gave me an opportunity to plant a device in the vehicle when I took the baby out. I got a name too, from the old guy: Arlo Moretti.”

One look at Ferguson’s face told them this wasn’t news.

“Karen, could you give us a minute?”

Edwards looked embarrassed as she scuttled to the door.

“Sit down, please.” Ferguson’s charm tablets had started kicking in. “Moretti is part of a separate case and isn’t pertinent to this investigation.”

“Does he know that?” Karl chipped in.

Thomas racked his brain for a suitable pincer move, but before he could come up with something sparkling a text came in on his phone.

“Sorry, it could be urgent.” It was, but not in the way he’d expected.

‘You did well, saving a child today. I’m impressed. We will talk again soon.’ No name, except he knew exactly who had sent it. Heick might as well have included the Star-Spangled Banner. He put his phone away.

“You alright, Thomas?” Karl had picked up that he wasn’t.

“Something’s come up,” he announced to the room. “We need to go. Now.”

Ferguson seemed confused. “Right, well, forget about Arlo Moretti and concentrate on the job you’re paid to do. Karen will see you out.”

Edwards was loitering by her desk and made a beeline for them.

“How’d it go?”

Thomas started walking, leaving the two of them to catch up. Karen kept pace with Karl and followed them onto the street. Thomas rounded on her, almost colliding.

“Who did you tell about our little escapade today?”

“Only the DI. I had to. I wasn’t claiming the glory, honest. The DI told me to keep everything under wraps.”

“So why were the uniforms clapping?”

“You’re the first team of outsiders reporting directly to me.”

Karl waited until they were in the car together.

“What’s eating you, Tommo?”

He directed Karl to his mobile and let him check the text. “The way I see it, Karl, either the DI or the sergeant is reporting back.”

“Yeah.” Karl unwrapped a toffee and popped it into his mouth. “Or we’re the ones under surveillance.”

Not a very comforting thought. “Except,” Thomas accepted a hard toffee and sucked at it. “In order to surveil us they’d have to know where we’re working, which brings us back to Ferguson or Edwards. My money’s on the DI — although that could be class prejudice.”

“Either way, Tommo, I don’t like it, not one little bit.”

* * *

They parted company at Kilburn, leaving Thomas with his thoughts. Heick must want more than a message to Karl, so why was he holding back? Before setting off he dug out his personal phone and dialled Miranda, one eye on the rear mirror watching Karl.

“Miranda Wright. Go ahead caller!”

“You’re funny. Can you come over tonight — meet me after work?”

“I can do better than that. Sheryl’s back at work so I can slope off early like a bad old boss.”

“Brilliant. See you in an hour or so. Can you pick up a takeaway, something spicy? Surprise me.”

“Be careful what you wish for, Mr Bladen. See you soon, hon.”

The smile on his face lasted until he noticed Karl was still there, watching him.

Chapter 7

Thomas's spirits lifted at the sight of a Mini Cooper parked up outside his flat. He pulled in behind it, ignoring his neighbour's twitching curtain. He felt the Mini's bonnet — still warm. The aroma of Szechuan prawns hung in the air like a promise. Unlocking the front door he caught the strains of *The Platters* welcoming him home after a fairly shit day, and crept into his flat.

"You made it then." He pushed the kitchen door, just in time to see Miranda lowering a knife.

"That's because I ran all the way."

He put his rucksack down carefully and stood in front of her, drawing her close so they could sway together to *Twilight Time*. He smiled to himself. His day had been closer to *Twilight Zone*.

Miranda struggled a little, but only a little. "Food."

"Nah, let's stay like this forever."

Miranda sighed contentedly. "Then who would eat the banana fritters?"

"Well," Thomas let her go in an instant, "when you put it like that . . ."

He was deeply engrossed in chow mein when Miranda suddenly set her fork down.

"Do you want the bad news or the bad news? Jack Langton gets out of prison soon. I think Sheryl's freaking out and that's why she pulled a sickie. Maybe you could have a word to reassure her?"

He chewed on a prawn. Jack Langton — a scumbag he'd helped to put in prison, and who also happened to be Sheryl's father.

"I, er, did speak with her. Last night. When she came round."

"You *what*?"

He began at the beginning, with the US taxi service, and brought her up to date. She ate while she listened, and when he'd finished the whole story he waited for her to pass judgement.

She took her time. "Why didn't you tell me before?"

"I wanted to tell you to your face, so you could see I've got nothing to hide. Incidentally, I think we should assume it's not safe to talk at Caliban's."

Miranda blinked slowly. “And what about here?” She read his smile. “You bugged your own home?”

“Karl rigged it up.”

“Sounds a bit pervy if you ask me.” She grinned.

“All above board. Just sensors at the doors and sound activated audio.”

She pouted. “Pity. I thought you might have a hidden video camera somewhere.”

He waited until midway through the banana fritters before he let slip that Sheryl had stopped over. Miranda saved her ire for the instigator.

“What does this Yank want — Heinz, you said his name was?”

“Heick.” He rolled his eyes. “He hasn’t exactly told me yet, but it’s all connected with Karl.”

“Well, you tell Karl from me, we’re only a phone call away.”

He smiled. By we she meant the family. How times had changed.

They settled down to watch *Amelie* on DVD. Miranda insisted he was bound to like it as it was all about someone messing with other people’s lives.

She nudged him. “Hey! Don’t nod off, it’s not that bad a film.”

He rubbed his eyes. “It’s not that. It’s been a long day and there’s another one coming up.”

Miranda hit the stop button. “In that case we’d better have an early night, while you’ve still got some strength left.”

He grabbed his mobile on the third ring, almost pushing Miranda off the sofa to get to it. It was an anonymous number, so not Karl.

“Hello?”

“Are you free to talk now?” Heick’s delivery was measured, as if blackmail was part and parcel of his working day.

Thomas glanced at Miranda. “Yeah, I can talk.” He mouthed the words ‘the Yank’ and gestured for a pen and some paper.

“I picked up your message. I’ll remember not to underestimate you in future. But don’t get smart. Let me remind you . . . Sheryl? She can be gone in a heartbeat. And how would Miranda feel about pictures of Sheryl leaving your apartment first thing this morning? Or HMRC looking into her family’s tax affairs. Do we understand one another, Thomas?”

“Completely. I’m listening.”

“Good. For the record, I have no interest in your life at all. Like I said, you are a means to an end. Get me what I want and I will leave you in peace. Fail me and there will be consequences.”

Thomas uncurled his fist and wrote down the details.

“Tomorrow morning, without fail.”

The call died, along with his pride.

“Was that him then?”

He nodded.

“And who the bloody hell does he think he is?”

“Didn’t I say? He’s Karl’s dad.”

* * *

It was a huge ask for Miranda to pick up Karl first thing in the morning. Still, she could have said no, and it meant Thomas had time to prepare. He fixed her coffee and toast at crazy o’clock — it was the least he could do.

He lingered as she sat opposite, crunching her breakfast with a towel wrapped around her head. He leaned across to organise a few blonde strands.

She slapped him away playfully. “No time for that.”

If he didn’t know better he’d say Miranda was enjoying herself. Generally, she steered clear of his day job, but lately the off-the-books work with Karl wasn’t having the same effect.

“You owe me big time for this.” She leaned back and stretched, her chest rising like the dawn.

He planned to pay his debts at the first opportunity.

Chapter 8

Thomas took the tube to Westminster and walked across the bridge, taking in a view of the Houses of Parliament. Possibly he was passing politicians and ministers heading into work. If so, he didn't recognise any of them. And besides, Karl was adamant that they weren't the ones pulling the strings. According to the great man himself, policies were nothing but pieces of paper. Chalk that one up to the Book of Karl.

Heick rang him at eight fifteen and gave him directions to a swanky hotel near the South Bank, the kind where liveried staff hold the door for you and call you *sir* in a way that makes you feel inferior. A neat trick. When he went to the front desk they sent him on to the restaurant. Violin music played through the speakers, or maybe they had a quartet hidden in a corner.

Heick saw him but didn't stir. As Thomas approached he was still attacking a kipper.

"I'm practically addicted to these things. Sit down. What would you like?"

You to choke on a fish bone. Thomas pressed his tongue behind his bottom teeth to crush any hint of a smile. He went for the Full English, on the assumption that Heick was paying. A lesser man might have felt underdressed opposite Heick's perfectly tailored suit and the copy of the *Times* neatly folded on the table. Luckily Thomas didn't give a shit. He couldn't help thinking that had Miranda not trusted him and Sheryl implicitly, the previous evening could have ended very differently.

"Okay, I'm here. Now what?"

"Phones, please."

Heick checked that both devices were switched off. Thomas hadn't considered wearing a wire. As far as he was concerned, this was a social gathering. Stilted conversation followed — London, the British obsession with the weather and a smattering of history, so Thomas wouldn't take him to be a total philistine. After breakfast and coffee, Heick wiped his lips with a napkin, picked up his newspaper and pushed Thomas's phones back across the table.

"Let's take a walk."

The light gleamed across the surface of the Thames, shining like burnished silver. Hapless tourists crowded the souvenir stands, eager to part with their money for keepsakes made in China. Thomas watched it all, strolling beside Heck, waiting for the main feature to begin.

“Are you a political man, Thomas?”

“You tell me.”

Heck smiled. “Your father was a coalminer, am I right? So, I’m thinking left of centre. Though you work for the British government.”

Thomas chose not to be impressed. Sir Peter Carroll had probably passed over his personnel file. “Correct. You could say I’m conflicted.” They shared polite laughter and Thomas thought a little less about pushing Heck in the river to see if he would sink in that expensive suit. “Shall we get on with it?”

“Certainly. As you know, I work in investments — European futures, you might say. It’s in my interests, and those of my government, to closely monitor any developments that could impact on the stability of Europe.”

“To make sure you back the winner.”

Heck unfurled his newspaper and folded it carefully. “I like you, Thomas. You haven’t come out of a box like most of the people I deal with in the community. Honestly? It doesn’t matter who wins — democracy or oligarchy. It’s about who best serves *our* interests. Your government is no different. It’s the way of the world.”

He stopped and leaned against the granite, gazing out over the Thames. Thomas followed his line of sight to St Paul’s Cathedral.

“It’s a beautiful building, controversial in its day but now part of the orthodoxy. That’s what the march of history does, Thomas — it rewrites the rules.”

Heck paused and Thomas waited it out.

“I, er,” Heck faltered for the first time, “don’t have a great track record where Karl is concerned.”

For a moment Thomas felt a pang of sympathy for Heck. It didn’t last.

Heck continued. “I have some information for Karl, only he won’t want it from me. He trusts you though, which is why you need to convince him that it’s genuine. I don’t expect you to understand—”

“The Shadow State?” left Thomas’s mouth before his brain could close it, and the words hit Heck like a punch.

He straightened, never taking his eyes off St Paul's, and recovered with a forced laugh as fake as his composure. Thomas turned to look right at him when he cleared his throat.

"Some also call it a cartel, or a syndicate." Heick's chest heaved. He reached into his jacket. "Give this to Karl and tell him I'm willing to meet with him. You'll have to trust me on this — it's in his interests."

Thomas palmed the card, catching the word *Charlemagne* as he put it safely in his pocket. "The thing is, *Stephen*, I don't trust you. You're like every other clown in a smart suit with a sense of entitlement. You must think I'm stupid. Let me help you. I saw computers at the ASI building tracking technology companies, as you'd expect, for investments. However, ENGAMEL was near the top of at least half a dozen screens and last I heard Michael Schaefer was still a big noise there."

It was a punt, whistling in the wind, but it grabbed Heick's attention.

"Go on." There was that condescending look again, the one that made Thomas want to rearrange his face. "You know Michael Schaefer?"

Thomas felt the world grow colder. "I know *of* him."

Heick leered. "That's where you come into the picture, Thomas. In case you're wondering how you ended up on my radar? One of my associates saw you at the Scavenger weapon presentation."

Thomas dug a thumbnail into his finger to stave off a reaction. He'd read somewhere that the brain could only handle one signal at a time. The Scavenger. It seemed to hang around him like a bad smell. A faulty weapon and an unexplained death, and an insight into how far the Shadow State's commercial interests extended.

On the back foot, Thomas pushed forward. "ASI is some kind of front for funding your *projects* — I get that. Your chauffeur's runner has spent time in the US and you're from, I dunno, Boston? Are we going to do this all day?"

"It's Portsmouth, New Hampshire, actually. What I'm about to tell you is privileged information." He paused, and Thomas could see he was struggling. "Karl and I haven't spoken in a long time, but I have followed his career from a distance."

Thomas leaned back against the granite and let the man tell his story. His mother always said confession cleansed the soul. Heick's soul probably

needed dry-cleaning. Listen and learn, that's all Heick required of him. If it was bullshit, it was well rehearsed.

"Stephen Heick is my real name. McNeill matched my second passport. I invented his life and then chose it over my own. I joined an exchange programme within 'the community,' was posted as an observer, alongside the British Army in Northern Ireland." He squeezed his hands together until they whitened. "I met Kathleen, we married and I stayed on."

"Anti-terrorism?"

"Urban warfare," he said flatly. "I spent a lot of time away on business even before Karl was born. Eventually my superiors reassigned me back to the US."

Thomas read the story like headline news. "Kathleen didn't want to go."

Heick shook his head. "No. She made her choice and I made mine."

"And what about Karl?"

"We agreed, no contact. But Kathleen knew how to get in touch with me and when she wrote that Karl was moving to the mainland, I kept a watchful eye. When I saw he was going nowhere I smoothed his path into the British Army."

Thomas got up. "I believe you. I think." That combination of guilt and arrogance was hard to fake. He didn't bother asking why Heick had chosen to unburden himself to a stranger, it was obvious. He wanted Thomas to pass it all on to Karl. He turned back to the Thames and stared into the water. If Karl thought his mother had stayed in touch with his father, he'd see that as a betrayal, even after she'd died. He already thought his father was a bastard. No contest.

"So I give Karl this card. Then what?"

"If he's smart, he'll want to see me."

* * *

It was close, but Thomas called Miranda first.

"Secret service — Miranda speaking."

"Funny girl. How did everything go this morning?"

"Fine. Karl was surprised to see the new driver, but you know Karl. He takes everything in his stride."

Thomas cringed at the thought of that being put to the test.

“I owe you, Miranda — big time.”

“If you want to pay me back, tell me if I ought to be concerned about you.”

“No, I’m fine. But I think I’ll have a little chat with your mum and dad next time I’m there.”

He judged this would be enough for Miranda to prepare the ground. Next up was Karl, whose main concern was a delivery of fresh coffee and sandwiches.

“I’ll keep a seat warm for you, Tommo. I told the station you’d be making your own way in later. Edwards wasn’t happy but she didn’t want any more grief from DI Ferguson.”

An hour later, Thomas felt as though he’d never been away. He looked back from his camera. “I saw your dad again.”

Karl nodded slowly, as if it didn’t matter. “What does he want from you?”

“I’m to convince you of his honest intent.”

Karl laughed so hard he almost choked on his breakfast. “Well, good luck with that.”

Thomas put the card down on the table.

“He wanted you to have this.” He studied Karl’s face. “Is it some sort of code?”

“More like a warning, Tommo.”

* * *

Thomas worked solidly for an hour before he spoke again, to the back of Karl’s head. “So, what is Charlemagne?”

Karl took a long draw of vending machine coffee. “Not what, who. He was emperor of Western Europe.”

“Sorry, still not getting it.”

Karl sighed and turned to face him. “Remember Engamel — part of the consortium behind the Scavenger weapon?”

Thomas felt his lip curling. That bloody weapon, ghost of assignments past. “Funny you should mention that. Your dad,” he paused to take in Karl rolling his eyes, “said that’s when I came to his attention. One of his contacts was at the presentation.”

Karl rubbed his face. Come on, Tommo — Engamel. The last seven letters of Charlemagne — in reverse.”

Thomas raised his empty cup. “Clever! Hidden in plain sight. So something’s going on at Engamel?”

“You need to think bigger.” Karl sat up in his chair and swayed it from side to side “There is a rumour — unsubstantiated, naturally . . .”

“Or it wouldn’t be a rumour,” Thomas cut in.

Karl pushed a blank sheet of paper out along the desk. “Reports suggest there’s going to be a change in the Shadow State’s senior staff.”

“Should you be telling me this?”

Karl smiled. “I think we’re long past that moral hurdle, don’t you? Let me pander to your love of diagrams.” He drew a clock face, only instead of numbers there were twelve smaller circles and a single circle in the middle.

Thomas shrugged. “And?”

“That’s the trouble with civilians — no imagination. Right, this is the basic power structure of the Shadow State: twelve executives, as far as we can tell — each one with their speciality. Finance, or the military, or what have you.”

“Like ministers in a government.”

“Now you’re getting it.” Karl’s face grew stony serious. “Even unelected bodies need structure, a hierarchy and a sense of legitimacy.” Karl’s pen spiralled above the paper then stabbed the heart of the circle. “Our agents within the Shadow State believe someone is about to progress through the ranks, maybe even to the top table.”

Karl milked the silence, while Thomas imagined a drum roll.

“Charlemagne is the code word for that scenario. And I think that’s why Stephen Heick has crawled out of the woodwork. Any more questions?”

“How long have you got?”

* * *

The stolen car business seemed to be booming. A Mercedes sports model and a Toyota Lexus arrived in rapid succession, each disappearing under the roller gate. Interestingly, the drivers never re-emerged.

“I wonder who’s watching the back entrance.”

“Not our problem, Tommo. We have other matters to concern us.”

Thomas figured he might as well dish out the rest of the bad news. “Miranda told me that Jack Langton comes out of prison soon.”

“Then we’d better get busy to prepare for his homecoming.”

* * *

DS Edwards brought them back to Paddington Green after work. She saved the best till last, when they were getting out of the car. “It’s a double shift tomorrow. Same time start, a five hour break and then back on the case.” Her face suggested this was perfectly normal.

Thomas handed over the data cards from the cameras. *Compliments of the staff*. As he set off for the tube, Karl called after him.

“Where do you think you’re going?” He jangled some keys in the air. “Miranda left you her car. That’s quite some lady you have there.”

Karl asked to be dropped near home and Thomas didn’t ask why. Instead, he drove on solo to Caliban’s, trying to make sense of all the balls he had in the air.

Sir Peter Carroll had tipped off Heick, which inferred a connection between them. Sir Peter still had links to the Shadow State, even though he was now beholden to Karl’s people, so that suggested he had acted on Heick’s instructions.

“But wait a minute!” Thomas spoke aloud to the radio. “How did Heick know about me at all?” He checked the rear mirror and tried to swallow a bitter conclusion: the Shadow State must have taken an interest in him. He thought back to all the times when he’d been on the periphery, little more than a bagman to Karl.

The Mini Cooper pulled up in the car park just as his phone started ringing.

“Did you do as I asked?” Heick’s voice had all the charm of a rat.

“I understand now, about Charlemagne.”

Heick sneered down the phone. “No, I don’t think you do. Set up a meeting with Karl in the next couple of days.” The line went dead.

Sheryl’s smile evaporated when he entered the saloon. She leaned over the bar a little to show off some more of her suntan, but her performance was below par.

“What can I get you?” she asked between chews of her gum.

“Orange juice with ice.”

“Tangy.” She popped a bubble.

He took the glass and left her attitude behind him. He was halfway up the stairs when it hit him like a thunderbolt. She was pissed off with him — *blamed* him — because of Heick’s threats. Maybe she had a point. He stood there, mid-flight, wrestling with a question. Heick could have contacted Karl through Sir Peter, so why involve him?

Two words came to mind before he’d reached the top stair: *scapegoat* and *insurance*.

“Anybody home?” He knocked on Miranda’s office door.

“Who wants to know?”

“I believe I owe you a secret service?”

The door opened. “You’d better come in then.”

* * *

Miranda started the car. “Why can’t we go back to my place?”

“You know why — because it may not be safe to talk there.”

“Then why don’t you sweep it for bugs?”

One sigh was all it took.

“Fine. Walthamstow it is then. At this rate I might as well move in and be done with it.” She glanced sideways and relented with a smile. “Don’t panic, I was only kidding.”

“It’s not that. Sometimes I think I made a mistake, getting so involved in Karl’s world.”

“Huh, it’s a bit bloody late for that! Anyway, I know you, Thomas Bladen — no one can make you do anything you don’t want to. I still have the handcuffs to prove it!”

Chapter 9

Thomas felt his shoulders tense by the second ring. How quickly he'd come to hate calls on his personal phone.

"Yeah?"

"Relax, it's Karl. The 4x4 with the wee kiddie inside — the one you bugged — it's on the move."

"And no one is intercepting it, I s'pose?"

"Course not. They're hoping it'll lead to another piece of the puzzle."

Thomas smiled. "But you're still tracking it separately, as a weekend hobby."

Karl was slow to reply. "Listen, it could be coincidence, but it's on Manor Road now, approaching Canning Town."

Canning Town — where Miranda's brothers owned a breaker's yard. Thomas cut the call and made another.

"Sam, are you expecting delivery of a 4x4 today?"

"Blimey, Thomas, you must be psychic! A bloke rang up late last night and said he was bringing it over for parts — no questions asked."

Thomas rubbed at his temple. "Do me a favour. Close your gates and lock them. Sam . . . SAM! Just listen — when it arrives, tell me if it's a Honda CR-V."

"The geezer didn't say. Hang on. Terry — it's Thomas. You wanna take it?"

Thomas breathed a little easier. Finally, the brains of the operation. Terry was more guarded when it came to business, always had been. Thomas heard him sending Sam out to the gates.

"He's doing it now. What's the problem, Thomas? Do you know something?"

"Why'd they pick your yard?"

"Dunno. Bloke said he was ringing around and the first place didn't answer."

"And did you check with the other breakers?"

"Christ, you're a paranoid sod. Fair enough, the car is going to be dodgy, but we could do with the business. Wait a sec — Sam's back . . ."

Thomas could hear them arguing. From what he could tell the vehicle had arrived and the driver was none too pleased.

“Terry!” He shouted so they’d both hear him. “What’s the car?”

“Lemme get my binoculars . . . It’s a Honda CR-V and it looks in good nick too.”

“Don’t do it. Wait it out.”

“Bloody hell, Thomas. The geezer’s banging on the gates now. He looks well pissed off. Sam — stay out of the way. Fuck’s sake.” The line went quiet, as if a hand were pressed against the mouthpiece. “Still there, Thomas? Sam reckons the driver’s done a runner. And he’s blocked the gates. What do we do?”

“You might wanna sit down for this, Terry. I think you should call the police.”

It took over two hours for a patrol car to turn up. Much as Thomas had expected, the car had false number plates. Sam had climbed the gates and relayed them to him. They were different to the ones he’d captured on film. The police had plenty of questions but their punctuality had given Thomas ample time to coach the brothers.

“Better to plead ignorance than try to lie your way out.” One day he’d try practising what he preached.

The problems started when the rear door was forced. The body bag contained the car thief he’d seen at the storage facility. This was the car syndicate, or whatever they called themselves, cutting loose threads.

He rang Karen Edwards.

“Thomas? I thought you weren’t in until Sunday. What can I do for you?”

To her credit, she listened for at least a couple of minutes before speaking. And she agreed that the car’s legal owner ought to be moved, as a precaution.

“Good work, Thomas.”

He shrugged, phone in hand. “I’m just passing information. Unofficially. I don’t want to get involved.” He smiled for an instant. Since when had that ever stopped him?

A thought hit him square in the face — the caretaker! He searched his mobile’s list of contacts.

“Listen to me. You need to get out of that place. It’s not safe there. You know who I am?”

“Yeah. But I can’t leave. Mr Moretti wouldn’t like it. I have to be here to receive any merchandise.” There was pride in the voice. The silly old bastard felt loyalty to his employer. This was no time to walk on eggshells.

“Remember the bloke who drove the car?”

“It’s been moved and the driver’s been dismissed. Mr Moretti said he’s most particular about that sort of thing.”

Thomas swallowed. “The driver is dead. His body bag was found in the back of the car.”

“I don’t believe you. You’re trying to trick me. Mr Moretti has always looked after me. I’ll be alright.”

Thomas urged him one last time and then cut the call. He stared at the screen for a long time afterwards. This could only end badly.

Chapter 10

Thomas couldn't settle for the rest of the afternoon, despite Miranda's offer of athletic sex and a home-cooked meal. He talked himself out of going to see the old-timer in person, on the grounds that it might ruin the surveillance operation. And so he waited with the phone beside him, even during sex and dinner. He felt he owed the guy that much.

A call came through at six-fifteen. He would always remember the time. At first there was an echoing silence and then the sound of metal scraping against metal. A single breath followed.

"Who are you? I know you rang here before."

Thomas stared at the wall, compelled to stay on the line. *Bang*. He flinched and caught his breath. His mind raced ahead, picturing the old man slammed against the roller gate.

"I'll ask you again, but this time I'll give you an incentive."

He concentrated on the voice, as if it could obscure what he knew was happening. Another bang, sharper than before and then a scuffling, like a heavy weight being dragged across the floor. Partway through, he heard a voice pleading, the same way the old guy had pleaded with Thomas when he'd come for the child. Silence again, and then a heavy click, reminiscent of the hammer on an old-school revolver.

"I'm waiting." The calm facade shattered like a mirror. "You think you can hide from me? I have you on camera."

Thomas's heart sank. Bollocks. Why hadn't he thought of that? Of course they'd have CCTV to protect *their* merchandise. Rookie mistake. He forced himself to focus. What could he bargain for the old man's life? He gambled with the only thing of value he had — a name.

"I know who *you* are, Arlo Moretti." He said the words slowly and deliberately, as if he understood their power. He couldn't have been more wrong.

"Time's up."

"Wait!"

The gunshot filled his head. Moretti's voice quietened, as if he had the phone at arm's length. "Clean it up."

In the silence that followed, Thomas's brain went into overdrive.

"Well," the voice carried a confident edge. "Whoever you are, you're a dead man."

It took Thomas a few seconds to realise he was alone on the line. He put the phone down and flexed his rigid fingers. Rage and helplessness battled inside him. Rage emerged victorious.

He stood there a while longer until the hiss of the water pipes brought him back. Miranda had finished her shower. He gazed down at his hand and imagined a gun. Miranda exited the bathroom with a towel on her head and nothing else.

"How do I look?" She stopped pouting. "What's wrong, Thomas?"

"I just heard a murder." A murder he would struggle to explain to the police, as only Karl knew he'd taken the caretaker's number.

"Tell me what I can do."

He loved her for that, although there was only one person to ring — Karl. There wasn't much to say and he said it quickly.

Karl's was the voice of reason. "I hear you, but you're not responsible, Thomas. Call it in if it makes you feel any better."

"Jesus, Karl. A man died. I'm a witness to it."

"Maybe. He was a liability to them, much like the driver. Face it, they're cleaning house."

"If I let Edwards know, they'll raid the place and that'll blow the rest of the investigation."

"Then you'll have to live with it for now. Can you do that, Tommo?"

He glanced up at Miranda walking off to put some clothes on. "I don't know."

"I'll come over if you wanna talk about it."

"Nah, it's fine, Miranda's here."

"Okay then. Call me if you change your mind. Look, you did your best."

"And what if that's not good enough?"

Karl paused before answering. "You try harder for the next one. Listen, perhaps we ought to speak to Edwards about being moved from the observation site — as a precaution."

* * *

Sleep was a land of nightmares where Moretti's voice whispered from the shadows, morphing into strangers' faces. He emerged as a black-hatted cowboy ready for the draw. Thomas felt the pistol but his arm wouldn't move, fixed at his side as Moretti slowly pulled his six-shooter level, cocked it and . . . *BANG*.

Thomas woke gasping for breath with cramp in his leg. He threw back the covers to massage the pain away. It was still dark. Miranda held on tightly to a sheet.

"Go back to sleep." He drew the cover over her, grabbed his clothes and pulled the door to behind him. Six a.m., and strong instant coffee seemed like a good idea. His phone sat beside him like an unlucky charm. No two ways about it, he'd have to change his number once all this was over.

He leaned back, sipped his coffee and thought about his situation, the top of the chair back pressing below his shoulder blades. He let his arms hang and stared across the dark kitchen. Karl had said learn to live with Moretti's actions. Easier said than done. Even if he wasn't directly responsible for the caretaker's death, wasn't he complicit?

Jesus, he needed a change of scenery. Fortunately, Miranda's parents — John and Diane — had invited them over for the weekend. With a Sunday shift to look forward to, he'd bartered that down to a Saturday afternoon, planning to return to the flat alone afterwards.

Miranda surfaced around nine. Her tousled blonde hair made him want to start looking for hay barns. They picked up a six-pack of beer, a bottle of wine and chocolates — all bases covered. He let Miranda drive his car, and spent the journey — when he wasn't tapping an imaginary brake or shifting in his seat every time the gears cried out for attention — wrapped in thought.

Working for the Surveillance Support Unit had brought him face to face with death before. He'd watched a gun-for-hire, Yorgi, die on the Moors a few feet away — but he'd deserved it. What did this old duffer do, other than keep an eye on a few stolen cars? Thomas thought he knew the answer. The caretaker had let Thomas in and had seen him walk away with the baby. The fact that the police hadn't come charging in didn't cut the poor bastard any slack, or the unfortunate driver.

He rubbed at his neck and touched the sweat under his collar. It wasn't sadness he felt exactly, more a sense of outrage. And there was something else too — fear. These bastards had thought nothing of killing two nobodies. Thomas would be just another minor inconvenience. The thought tingled in his veins like caffeine.

There was a time when he used to think of Karl as some sort of talisman. Bad stuff still happened around Karl, but he had connections, experience. Guns. Thomas's attitude had shifted a little after one of Jack Langton's rivals abducted the pair of them. He'd seen Karl in a new light ever since — a good man, certainly, only not an invincible one. And now he was slipping further into Karl's world. Would he end up dragging Miranda along with him?

'People die every day,' Karl had told him once when he was still unsure about their extracurricular work. 'Only sometimes we can do something about it.'

Well, they'd fucked up royally this time. He'd failed to protect the old guy. So what did that leave? He smiled for the first time that day — it left *justice*. Not the letter-of-the-law, unless he planned on jeopardising the day job. No, he'd have to be smarter than that. He checked his phone for a signal and sneered at himself. Yeah, good luck with that.

Miranda relied on the radio for company as she drove to Dagenham. Once she'd parallel parked with perfection she grabbed the chocs and wine, leaving him the six-pack of beer.

"You can be the masculine hunter." She locked the car and handed him his keys for later.

Going to the Wrights' house always felt like coming home. Back when there'd been no Surveillance Support Unit in his life, and no scumbags like Moretti, or Jack Langton, or Sir Peter Carroll. Except . . . there always had been people like that — only he hadn't known about them. On balance, it was always better to know.

He sighed a little when Miranda twisted her key in the front door, and shifted the beer to his other hand. He used to have his own key.

Diane Wright responded to Miranda's call as only a mother can. "Pizza's on, and a lasagne — we're eating early for a change."

Sam and Terry sat firmly in front of the massive TV screen, mesmerised by a football match with titles in Russian. Thomas didn't ask.

On the far side of the double room John was dispensing plates and cutlery like a pro.

Miranda dug Thomas in the ribs. “Mum’s got him well trained these days.”

John nodded. “She has that.” And then let out a cheer as Thomas brought the six-pack into view. “Good man.”

Thomas followed Miranda through to the kitchen, where Diane perched at a breakfast bar, coffee in hand.

“Shouldn’t be long — all timed to perfection. Everything all right, Thomas?” The female radar ran in the family.

“Yeah, just . . . stuff from work, you know . . .”

She took a slow sip of coffee. “Careless talk?”

He flashed a smile. “Something like that.”

Dinner was a raucous affair. Terry and Sam retold their version of the body in the car, followed by a Dickensian rendition of their statements to the police and their ignorance of how the car came to be parked outside their breaker’s yard. “No need for a warrant, officer, happy to oblige. After *you*. Like Dad always says, you pick your battles.”

Beer, wine and spirits flowed freely as Saturday evening got into full swing. Thomas watched from the sidelines, subdued by the dual tyranny of his mobile phone and the countdown to a Sunday morning shift. And even though neither John nor Diane pushed him about whose body had ended up in the car, or why, he knew them well enough to read their concern. Recent history had shown that whenever his work mixed with the family it usually caused trouble.

At ten p.m. he weathered the chorus of protests and called it a night. Miranda saw him to the door.

“I’ll be thinking of you in my bed.”

“Me too.” He pulled her close and tasted lasagne and Merlot. So much for dessert.

The clunk of the front door reminded him that he was leaving sanctuary for that other, more uncertain domain. He stood for a moment, breathing in the taint of petrol and pretentiousness. Working class made good, writ large in paved driveways and spotlighted faux Corinthian columns. He took a last look and then unlocked his car. Miranda was right — he was a snob.

It took longer than usual to reach Walthamstow, thanks to a three-car pile-up on the A13. Speeding, judging by the tyre marks and the way the debris was strewn across the closed section of carriageway. He recalled an assignment with an Accident Investigation Team — the first time he'd seen a dead body outdoors and the way it had been encased in the wreckage. Framed by an indifferent God, if he still believed in such things.

He put the light out before midnight and plugged his phone in at the wall. It showed its appreciation at two a.m., waking him to share a message from Heick: *'Text me back when you get this.'* Twat. He followed the rules, sent a bleary, one-word reply and turned over.

Chapter 11

London turned down a couple of notches on a Sunday — less traffic, no city commuters and a chance to breathe again. Well, apart from a mobile phone that was practically thundering.

Karl was already on the street, carrying two bags.

“Packed lunch?”

“Funny man, Tommo. More of an insurance policy.”

One look from Karl confirmed his suspicions. Thomas blenched.

“We can’t turn up for work armed.”

“We’re not — I am. And it’s for your benefit. I acquired some intelligence on Arlo Moretti last night. He’s part of a European business network, which is almost certainly a subsidiary of . . .”

Karl buckled up his seatbelt and left Thomas to fill in the missing words: the Shadow State.

“The thing is, Thomas,” Karl sounded like he was stalling, “Moretti isn’t stupid. He may have killed the caretaker before he called you and restaged it on the phone, or even played you a recording, to keep you on the line.”

Thomas kept the speed at just below the limit, heading west.

“If he is tracking my phone then we’re in shit because I can’t switch it off.”

Traffic in the early hours was as light as a feather, but the conversation was leaden.

“You can’t trust my father, Thomas. He’ll use you and then drop you, just like he did with my ma.”

Thomas noted how Karl had left himself out of the equation. Karl pointed to a parking space on the street and the car glided to a halt.

“Who’s taking us to the observation site today?”

“Wen — the DC. Poor sod, having to work the Sunday shift.”

Thomas said nothing as Karl tucked his Browning 9mm deeper into the bag.

DC Jun Wen had put on a suit and Thomas couldn’t figure out who he was trying to impress. He nodded to the DC, clocked the wedding ring with

its Chinese characters, and stifled a smile as Wen covered his hand.

Wen said little on the journey over and Thomas expected nothing less. Surveillance Support Unit personnel were incomers, and fly-by-nights, the ever popular *floaters*. The surveillance tag team they replaced had left behind half a packet of digestives. Thomas reasoned that was probably as good as the day would get. Wen helped himself to a biscuit and left them to it.

There were no calls on the bugged line and only one vehicle to film in three hours of tedium. It was the same set-up as before, with the car passing once and returning after a few minutes. Whoever had replaced the caretaker kept longer hours and stayed out of sight.

Karl sat beside Thomas at the window, hands together, prayer fashion, nudging his lower lip. “We’ll have to talk to Edwards, we can’t stay here.”

“Try explaining that to Christine.”

Surveillance ops had gone badly before, as recently as their last assignment on Benefits Investigations. There, a claimant had impersonated her dead aunt — having wrapped her in plastic — so she could still get her pension and a carer’s allowance. They’d never quite lived that one down with the Benefits Team, or the police.

Towards the end of the shift DS Edwards got in touch.

“Hi, Karen!” Thomas gestured to Karl, who was staring at him from the window. “I thought you were off today?”

“Yeah, so did I, only it didn’t work out that way. I’m coming over to pick you two up. Another team will relieve you earlier than scheduled — special request.”

The two women accompanying Edwards did not look like they’d given up their Sunday voluntarily.

“Malone.” Thomas nodded, recognising her from the SSU’s London West office. A shame he couldn’t remember her first name as well. He passed her the remainder of the biscuits by way of an apology.

Edwards drove as though she’d been on a course, all mirrors and slick gear changes. Thomas had taken the front seat, just in case Karl’s bag spilled open and sparked another work-related incident.

“Where are we going?”

“The, er, mother of the child wants to meet you.”

Thomas looked back to Karl, who had opted for a nap. In forty-five minutes of driving, Edwards talked about everything except the thing that mattered. Two sisters, university, the joys of police training and the holiday she took in Madagascar after her fiancé dumped her. Thomas sat back and listened to the monologue. Maybe Karl had the right idea.

Karl didn't stir until they passed a sign for Amersham, when he yawned like a seal barking at half speed.

"So you moved her then?" Thomas tried his luck.

"Uh huh." Edwards was concentrating now, following unnamed lanes until, finally, the car emerged on the outskirts of a picturesque hamlet.

"Best if we leave our bags locked in the boot," Karl chipped in, grinning to Thomas.

The house had character and the large flowerpots either side of the front door suggested a warm welcome within. That image faded the instant they got out of the car. Edwards made a call on her mobile and someone waved from an upstairs window.

Two police officers met them at the front door. Karl seemed unintimidated by the sight of the holstered Glocks, but Thomas held back.

Smiler number one introduced himself. "DS Baines."

Edwards led the way in and the three of them squeezed past him. Two other officers introduced themselves and one swiftly returned upstairs. The other, on balance, would be the family liaison. She looked as pleased to see them as the others. The mother — the kiddie in her arms a dead giveaway — got misty-eyed, and only the liaison officer's suggestion of coffee managed to calm her down.

Karl excused himself for a piss. Thomas reckoned he was planning to have a nose around the house, either that or he'd recognised the lone officer upstairs and wanted a private chat. Whatever the case, by the time Karl came downstairs the coffee was percolating and mother was playing, well, *mother*.

She started gushing again about their act of bravery while one of the coppers sneered from the sidelines. Thomas understood. Those poor bastards put their lives on the line every day and no one gave a shit about them most of the time, while he and Karl had happened to be in the right place purely by chance.

The woman glanced around her.

“Could I have a minute or two alone with . . . ?”

Thomas knew a pro working the crowd when he saw one. “Thomas.” He thumbed towards his colleague. “And he’s Karl.”

The coppers shuffled off, promising they’d be back in five minutes, and to stay away from the windows. The mother flinched so Thomas tried smiling. *Thanks guys: social skills r u.* Edwards started to get up, paused, and then decided she probably wasn’t welcome either. Thomas didn’t try to change her mind. The atmosphere seemed to settle once the door had closed.

She put the baby in its pushchair and reached for her bag. Thanks to time spent with Miranda, Thomas recognised the Chanel logo, along with an approximate price tag.

“I’d like to express my gratitude.” She’d already started writing a cheque.

Thomas waved her away, but Karl had leaned in a little, the better to read her name upside down.

“That won’t be necessary,” he assured her.

“They wouldn’t tell me who you were or who you worked for, but I knew you weren’t with the police.”

He glanced at Karl, who shrugged his shoulders. Fine — *his* call, then.

“We’re a surveillance team attached to the police.”

She nodded. Her blank face suggested this was as much information as she needed to know.

“Your turn,” Karl sat back down. “Who are you and why did Arlo Moretti want to put pressure on you?”

Mrs Leibowicz — Thomas had spotted her name on the chequebook — looked to the door and laid a hand on the pushchair.

“My husband and I are directors of a pharmaceutical company. In the last year our business went through a few challenges and we needed to negotiate a series of loans. A condition was the transfer of some equity. However, ahead of the fourth loan our fortunes improved unexpectedly, so we cancelled it. But Mr Moretti had been to a lot of trouble to provide the funds and is now insisting on his full equity share. He gave us a deadline to sign it over.”

Thomas read between the lines. They’d sat down to dine with the devil and now he wanted to make sure they picked up the tab. Moretti had a

winning lottery ticket and he wasn't about to let it go.

"Where's your husband now?"

"He's in Slovakia, finalising some business."

A tap on the kitchen door and Edwards appeared.

"I think we've overstayed our welcome, guys. My colleagues would like us to leave."

Karl scraped back his chair against the flagstones.

"I'll meet you two at the door. I just need a quick word with — sorry, what was your name?"

"Barbara."

Thomas followed Edwards out like a shadow, waiting behind her as she swapped pleasantries with the other cops. He wanted to ask them about the Glocks and how they found them compared with the heavier Sig Sauers. But nobody likes a smart-arse.

Karl caught up by the front door. He looked happier than a man who'd started work at six a.m. on a Sunday had a right to be. With his back to Edwards, Karl tapped his shirt pocket.

"All straight, Tommo."

Which could only mean nothing of the kind.

Edwards was more relaxed on the journey back to London, springing for lunch at a roadside cafe.

She left them to it, heading for the ablutions. "Back in a mo."

Karl dipped into his pocket and waved a cheque in front of Thomas's face.

"Ta-dah!"

Two thousand pounds — for doing their day job.

"Karl! You can't accept it."

"Too bloody right I can. Half's yours, anyway. And don't give me that boy scout look. There are always extracurricular expenses. And besides," he turned the cheque round and snapped it to emphasise the telephone number on the back, "Now we have a new lead for Moretti."

Despite the windfall they let Edwards buy them lunch. She had come out well from Mrs Leibowicz's temporary tragedy and was happy to oblige.

"All I'm saying, lads, is that it must be strange going from job to job every few months." She took another bite of meat pie, ignoring the filling that oozed onto the paper plate. "You must feel like temps."

Thomas felt Karl kick his foot under the table. Now seemed the perfect time to mention the scope of their assignment.

Edwards finished her pie and then wiped her mouth roughly with a napkin. "The DI is going to want to know why."

Thomas kicked Karl back.

"Just tell him we have evidence connecting Arlo Moretti to Mrs Leibowicz."

Edwards stared at the plastic tablecloth. "Leave it with me. I'll talk to him when I get back to the station."

Chapter 12

Thomas made a call to check Natalie Langton was home. She told him she'd been expecting him ever since Jack's release date had been confirmed.

"Why don't you come over? The kids are with my mum."

He had to give her credit for consistency. "I'll see you in an hour." He turned to Karl. "We're on. I still don't like this."

Karl opened his case and waved a finger over the surveillance equipment, as though he were picking a chocolate. "It's for the best, Tommo. The phone, the living room and the kitchen. We'll leave the bedroom unmolested — I'm not an unreasonable man, especially if he's been locked up for six months."

Natalie Langton was at the door before the second ring.

"Couldn't you keep away, huh?" Her face fell about a foot when she saw Karl beside him, and then it gave way to fear. "What's going on?"

"Relax, Natalie." Karl took the lead. "We're just here to modify the terms of your agreement."

Natalie flushed an angry shade of red, laced up the top of her blouse and flounced back inside. "I should have known I couldn't trust you." She snatched at a glass and wrestled with the contents — it wasn't a fair fight.

Karl helped himself to the remaining glass, sniffed it and then took a sip. "Your secrets are safe. Why don't you and Thomas have a chat in the kitchen and I'll call you when I'm done." He raised a hand. "I'll be as quick as I can, so play nicely."

Natalie closed the kitchen door with a shove. "What the fuck is going on? Who's the Irish?"

"Someone who'll want to have a chat with Jack. Not about this — they have their own unfinished business."

She scowled at him while he talked her round.

"When you collect Jack from prison, I'll be your driver. We'll even throw in a free limo." He smiled. "I'll claim it back on my expenses."

Karl rapped on the door. "Everyone okay in there? Time to swap rooms."

Thomas couldn't tell if Natalie understood what was going on, but he wasn't about to drop any hints. They moved past Karl and sat on the sofa. Natalie crossed her legs and hunched in, as if to take up as little space as possible. He felt bad for her — it couldn't be easy having a scumbag for a husband. Still, she'd had her chance to leave while Jack was in prison, when he'd confronted her about her affair with Ray Daniels. For good or ill, she'd placed her bet. It always came down to choices and consequences.

She dabbed at her face. "I want to make a new start with Jack."

"You still can." Thomas heard the sound of a small power drill next door, followed by a portable vacuum cleaner. Nice one, Karl.

"So you wanna put my husband inside again?"

He didn't have an answer for that — Karl's department. And maybe she didn't know where Jack got his drugs from, or that a fair proportion of his profits were funnelled to the cartel as one of the Shadow State's many lines of business.

Karl burst in from the kitchen. "Sorted. Let's get out of here. Charmed to make your acquaintance, Natalie."

"Piss off."

"Jack's surely a lucky man."

* * *

"Okay." Karl went through his list for a second time. "I think that about covers everything."

Thomas pulled a little at his tie. "What do I do if Jack checks for a wire?"

"And why would he do that? Fresh out of prison I think he'll have other things on his mind."

"Dunno. Just trying to cover all eventualities."

"You concentrate on the driving, Tommo, and let me take care of everything else."

Thomas picked up Natalie on schedule. She sat in the back, like a princess. If she was nervous she hid it well under her cocktail dress. He glanced back periodically through the rear mirror and she made a point of fixing her pleats.

"You don't know what you're missing."

He forced a laugh and listened to her laughing back. Yes he did — trouble. Theirs wasn't the only car outside Wormwood Scrubs prison, but no one else had a top-of-the-range Mercedes waiting to convey them back to Civvy Street.

Jack was fourth out of the starting blocks. He looked massive, as though his six-month prison sentence had all been an extended visit to the gym. Natalie lowered her window and waved. Then she poured herself out of the car and stood by the door, posed like a mannequin. Jack took his time coming over, every inch the conqueror. Enjoy it while you can, you cocky bastard, Thomas thought — you're about to be colonised.

"Nice motor, Nat, but you needn't have gone to all this trouble."

"It was Thomas's idea." She cast a thumb in his direction.

That was his cue to lower the window. Jack stalled, thinking it through as he stood by the car. Thomas waited it out. It wasn't as though Jack had any better offers and besides, he was on show and he knew it.

"Come on, Jack, let's get you home. Mum's having the kids tonight."

Thomas watched in his wing mirror as a breeze made merry with Natalie's pleats. Jack didn't need a second invitation. He sat by the open window, behind Thomas, breathing in the cool air.

"You looking for a job then, Thomas?"

Natalie let out a nervous laugh.

"Nah," Thomas hit the accelerator. "Just wanted to see you home in style."

"Much obliged."

Thomas flicked on the radio and grinned to himself. *I think you'll find the word is 'obligated'*. He'd half-expected Karl to follow them, even though Thomas had reluctantly agreed to wear a wire. Like Karl had said, "We can't fill the interior with electronics if it's only a twenty-four hour hire."

The sight of Jack's wandering hands in the mirror reminded Thomas to raise the privacy barrier. Ten minutes into their journey he heard a mobile go off and Jack started talking. Back in business. Doubtless Karl would wheedle the details out of Natalie some other time. Not a level of detail he needed to know about, and he was glad of that, it was one for the pros.

Jack rapped on the barrier and made a big show about stopping around Aldgate to buy some champagne, as if Natalie wouldn't have thought of

that. Thomas said nothing, dropped the screen and let the big man have his moment. Natalie was sweetness and light, even when Jack helped himself to the money from her purse. But her mood soured once Jack was out of the picture.

“I don’t know how you sleep at night.”

This from the wife of a coke dealer — among other things. He didn’t give her the satisfaction of a response. Jack couldn’t help being a prick again when they reached their house in Forest Gate, insisting they give Thomas a fifty, once again from Natalie’s purse. Truly a class act.

From what Karl had said, the Langtons would receive a visit the next morning, part of the gradual but inevitable process of turning Jack against his suppliers and associates, who — knowingly or otherwise — were inextricably linked to the Shadow State.

Karl met him at the rendezvous point, forty minutes after delivering Jack and Natalie to their castle.

“Would you believe they were shagging on the sofa five minutes after you left them?”

“Thank God there were no cameras.”

“Well,” Karl winked, “You say that, Tommo.”

Chapter 13

Caliban's had been the obvious choice for a meeting with Heick. Miranda agreed to close the place for a 'private event'. Thomas asked for Sheryl to be present too, so she could meet the man who'd been making her life such a misery. Eight p.m., dress casual, and no recording devices.

Karl seemed more guarded than usual. Hardly surprising, since he hadn't seen his father in years. Thomas drove him there for six-thirty and they played several games of pool where neither of them had any interest in the outcome. Miranda kept score. It helped to fill the time.

Sheryl arrived around seven, watched a couple of games and then had a private word with Miranda.

"You joining us?" Thomas knew her prowess with a pool cue, but he felt lucky tonight.

"Nah, I'll wait downstairs."

Thomas stood by the stairs and listened for the tell-tale sound of a glass. Sheryl took her drink and kept watch at the window, waiting for something to happen. Nothing did for ages. At two minutes to eight by his watch, Thomas conceded the game he was already losing to Miranda and composed himself. One look at his companions told him they were doing the same thing in their own way.

Sheryl moved to the bottom of the stairs. "You better get down here. There's a car outside. Looks like an Audi from the outline."

Thomas led the way with Miranda beside him. Karl followed, a few steps behind.

"Ah, guys — he's not alone." Sheryl's voice crackled.

Thomas turned to Karl and spotted him reach for his armpit and then smooth his sweater instead. Right about where a shoulder holster would sit.

"Old habits, Tommo."

"Everybody ready?" Miranda moved to unlock the door as Sheryl retreated.

Thomas recognised the two strangers from his mystery tour of London's financial district. The woman went in front of Heick and the man behind him. The leader led by example.

“If you wouldn’t mind . . .”

Thomas followed her gesture and spread his arms so Heick’s underling could pat him down for weapons, or wires, or kicks. Karl lined up next. He hadn’t said a word to Heick.

“Merely a precaution.” Heick directed his associate to Miranda and Sheryl, while the man opened his case and went walkabout, scanning the room for electronics. He didn’t take long.

“It’s clear.”

“Fine. Go wait in the car.”

The underlings obediently took their toys with them.

“This is Sheryl.” Thomas brought her forward.

She looked like she was ready to punch Heick out. He seemed to pick up on that.

“I apologise if I caused you any inconvenience. I needed to be sure Thomas would follow my instructions to the letter.”

Sheryl’s jaw hardened. “Screw you.” She turned on her killer heels and strutted towards the bar.

“On the house,” Miranda insisted.

“Well, Karl. Haven’t you anything to say to the old man?” Heick faltered. He looked older than Thomas remembered at the hotel. Maybe his conscience had caught up with him.

Karl took a breath. “This had better be good.”

“Not here.” Heick started for the stairs.

“No,” Karl barked, halting him in his tracks. “We talk here, with witnesses. I’ll not be party to any more of your bullshit than I have to.”

Heick took a scotch and soda at the bar and brought it over, close to his chest. Karl offered him a place at the head of the table and then called Sheryl over to join them.

“You understood my message, Karl?”

Thomas read it as a challenge, even if Karl didn’t.

“Naturally. And?”

“Are you sure you want to do this here, Karl?”

Karl sipped his shandy. “Your choice. Stay and talk, or go. You came to me, remember?”

Heick looked around the table. This was a rigged poker game. Show or fold.

“What did you expect — happy families?” Karl bristled. “It’s a bit late for that, don’t you think?”

Thomas read the bones — time to get down to business. “What does Charlemagne mean?”

Heick swallowed. “You really want me to trust *these* people with this, Karl? There’s no going back.”

“I trust them, so you’ll have to. Your need — my terms.”

Heick smiled then, the bastard smiled. As he spoke he made eye contact with everyone, flitting from face to face to draw them in. Thomas had seen that training video as well. Heick kept the details vague at first, basically a rehash of his private chat with Thomas. But eventually he followed himself down the rabbit hole.

“At its highest levels the Shadow State is no different from any other corporation,” he nodded to Thomas. “There are vested interests — you might call them shareholders. And mechanisms to maintain stability in the organisation when it's under threat.”

Heick took another swig of his scotch. Confession didn’t seem to suit him.

Thomas put his phone on the table. “Can I turn this bloody thing off now? So, some scandal is about to blow?” He elected himself as the designated speaker for the four of them.

“An astute assumption.” Heick turned his grey-blue eyes to Thomas, the way an eagle sizes up its prey from a distance. “Somebody has been approached to fill an existing post . . .”

Karl stirred. “Which means someone else will have to step down, or be knocked down.”

Heick shifted towards Karl. “Instability is something we want to avoid. There would be consequences.”

“Bad for business?” Miranda said her piece.

Heick ignored the glancing blow. “I need an outsider to prevent it from happening by exposing the candidate. She is a Belgian industrialist.”

Karl sniffed. “Standard fare then — recorded conversations, compromising photos, leaked information. Why come to me — to us?”

Heick’s hand twitched. “First, I cannot be implicated. And second, I don’t want to destroy Henriette Voclain’s credibility in the organisation, merely make her unsuitable for the post.”

Karl circled the edge of his glass against the table. “There’s more to it than you’re telling.”

Miranda cleared her throat. “Well, you don’t need to be graphic. A weekend in the country would do.”

Thomas got the reference straight away — long ago, with Christine Gerard and Bob Peterson. Something he didn’t want to dwell on. He followed Karl’s lead. “When are you meeting her next?”

Heick stood up and continued to hold court while he paced around the saloon. “I’ll have to get back to you on that. This kind of thing can’t look too staged. I don’t need to know the precise details, just that I can rely on you.”

“To screw your life up?” Karl banged his glass down abruptly. “Not a problem.”

“Then Henriette Voclain is Charlemagne, your agent in the Shadow State?” Thomas stated the obvious to see how Heick reacted.

“She’s a bit more than that, Tommo.” Karl drove the point home like a blade. “Who approached her? Who should we be looking at?”

Heick edged away, his voice echoing in the empty bar room.

“I can’t give you a name. I don’t have it.”

Thomas made notes, Karl didn’t bother. Maybe this was all old news to him and he only wanted to humiliate his father. Thomas could relate to that.

Heick drifted back to the table. He’d run out of places to go. Thomas did some thinking out loud and surprised himself.

“You’ve been running an agent in the lower echelons of the Shadow State. How long?”

“Years.”

“That’s how you became close to the Belgian.” When Karl made the point it suddenly seemed obvious.

“Henriette.” Heick glared at him.

“And you can trust her?”

“What is this, Karl? Family concern?”

Karl shook his head. “Nah, I’m sure you can take care of yourself. I’m more concerned about the risks to others.”

Heick seemed desperate. “But you are committing?”

Karl looked around the table. Everyone else nodded.

“Right enough. We’re in.”

* * *

The first dull *pop* might have been hail on a window, if the skies hadn't been clear. But Heck recognised the sound immediately and hit the deck. The next one hissed through the air and smashed one of the lights.

Karl pushed Miranda roughly to the floor and warned everyone else to get down. Now they could only listen as thuds peppered the safety glass upstairs.

Heck seemed freaked. He pulled out a walkie-talkie and barked at it. "Are you there?"

Thomas looked over. "Fat lot of good those two were."

The walkie-talkie talked back. "Two individuals in a coupé just sped off. No licence plate identified. Do we follow them?"

Heck took in his companions. "No. Check the area is clear and then come get me." He waited on the floor for the call back, and so did everyone else.

Miranda threw him her keys so he could unlock the door. The two stooges came inside, took one look at the party under the table and said nothing. They didn't have to. It was obvious this hadn't figured on Heck's agenda under 'any other business.'

Heck gathered himself together and smoothed his hair. He made a point of placing Miranda's keys on the table. "I'll take care of this."

"How?" Thomas got to his feet and stood toe to toe with him.

"No need to get the police involved." Heck turned to one of his underlings, who nodded and busied herself on her phone.

Miranda held out a hand for Thomas to go over and hoist her up. "What if they come back?"

Karl moved to the window so he could examine the point of entry. "Warning shots. Upstairs too. They wanted to send you a clear message: they can get to you any time they choose."

Heck tilted his head forward. "Like I said, Karl, I'll take care of it."

Thomas was no poker player, but he knew a bad bluff when he saw one. Heck had been wrong-footed and the more Thomas thought, the more certain he was about it. But first he needed a moment with Karl. He got his attention and suggested they check out the damage upstairs.

“I can’t see the sense in sending Heick a warning, Tommo. Either he’s talking to people or he isn’t.”

Thomas checked out one of the far walls in search of a casing. Karl followed him.

He kept his voice low. “I don’t think Heick’s the reason. This all happened not long after I switched off my mobile.”

“You think it’s Moretti? That’s a bit of a leap.”

“So we keep this to ourselves then? Until we can prove my theory.”

“Roger that.”

They surveyed the damage. Much like downstairs, it was mostly psychological. In the handful of minutes it took to return to the others, Thomas had half a plan. Let Heick take the blame and deal with the practicalities, while he figured out what to do about Moretti.

Miranda barely looked at him. It was either shock or disdain, and he had no cure for either. Heick left one of his people on guard for the night, which felt like more of a PR stunt. It was a smart call though, because Miranda seized on the first opportunity to get out of there. Sheryl was deathly quiet for a change. Something told Thomas this wasn’t a new situation for her. That could be part of the price she paid for being Jack Langton’s daughter. It might explain why she’d been willing to leave her family behind in Brooklyn and set up in the East End of London, near her absent father. Either way, Thomas didn’t push the point.

Heick was contrition personified and Thomas was happy to let him run with it. Karl had humiliated him by forcing him to reveal confidences to strangers and now Thomas had put the boot in further by making him carry the can for the warning shots. He could live with that. But Moretti invading *his* private life? That was another matter entirely.

As they ventured outside Heick reiterated his promises, including fixing the windows next morning. Thomas threw an arm around Miranda. She shrugged it off as though it were a shackle.

“I’m staying with Sheryl tonight.” No goodnight, no ‘call you later.’

He stood there with Karl while two cars departed.

“Go home, Thomas — get some rest for tomorrow.”

“What would you do, Karl?”

Karl gazed over at a streetlight, as if seeking inspiration. “I’d say you have three choices. One: you tell Edwards and DI Ferguson and try to get

Moretti picked up. Two: you bide your time until you can find some way to neutralise the threat, but risk another reprisal. Three: you retaliate and risk an escalation.”

Thomas reached his car and Karl still hadn’t moved. It felt like the perfect metaphor — the two of them standing in the shadows.

“Karl!” He walked out into the light and raised three fingers.

“Understood.”

Chapter 14

Sleep did not come easy, but the Makarov pistol beside him helped Thomas keep the nightmares at bay.

Five a.m. found him sitting alone in his kitchen, sipping coffee and reviewing the previous night. It all added up to a series of bad conclusions. If Moretti had been tracking his phone he should have left it on, or certainly put it back on once he realised. And assuming that to be the case, Moretti must now know where he lived and everywhere he'd been since the caretaker's execution. Stupid.

He'd have to say something to Christine later. It'd give him time to come up with something more plausible than the truth. He reasoned it out on paper with Moretti, Heick and the SSU all circles encroaching on the central ring, which he inscribed T & M.

It could have been the caffeine cramming his veins, or the quiet confidence that three door locks and a loaded handgun provide first thing in the morning. He began to get some clarity. If Moretti was tracking his phone's location he ought to be able to use it against him. The ideas came thick and fast, scribbled on the page.

Him being at the police station hadn't put Moretti off. Maybe Whitehall might intimidate Moretti enough to buy some time. Sir Peter Carroll had fed him to the wolves by telling Heick's people where to find him — he could return the favour. Use Sir Peter as a way of exposing Heick.

Thomas took another glorious lukewarm mouthful of coffee and stared at the page. A plan of sorts stared back at him. Too wired now, he texted Karl to say he'd join him later. Slowly and deliberately, he plugged his personal phone into the charger and switched it on. He read Moretti's text with one hand on his gun: *Next time it won't be the windows.*

What did this guy want? Why wasn't he coming to get him? He reasoned only one other man could explain that.

"Tommo, make your mind up. You've dodged the early shift today yet you're still on the case. What gives?"

"Are you driving?"

“I have to.” Karl called over the sound of the open road. “My driver cancelled on me. What’s bugging you?”

“Why hasn’t Moretti made a move on me? I mean a *real* move?”

“Dunno. Let me think on it. Don’t be too late coming in, or you’ll miss out on the joy that is data analysis.”

“Yeah, right.” Thomas sighed. Yes, the back-end of surveillance — sifting through reams of photos, calls and recordings to make it easier for the pros to do their job. He let Karl go and re-read the text. What was it Heick had said at their first meeting? He closed his eyes and brought it to mind: *‘You haven’t come out of a box like most of the people I deal with in the community.’*

Maybe that was the answer — he wasn’t behaving as Moretti expected. The police hadn’t raided the vehicle store, yet he knew that Thomas knew about the stolen cars.

He tapped the pistol lightly against his leg, composing a text for Moretti on the fly: *I don’t want any trouble. I was told to collect the kid.* This time he left the phone on.

Christine didn’t respond to his call straight away. Ten minutes was pretty good for a call back though, at seven in the morning. Out of habit he listened hard for signs of Bob Peterson tiptoeing round her in the flat.

Thomas dealt it out in stages, asking to meet her at eight-thirty.

“Okaaaay . . .” She stretched the word out, playing for time. “I’ll see you in my office then.”

The Moretti phone was still on the table in front of him. “I’d, er, prefer to meet outside somewhere.” He waited, imagining her mulling it over.

“Fine.” She sounded the opposite. “I’ll see you by Platform One.”

The walk to Walthamstow Central station usually took him a leisurely fifteen minutes. Today, he made it in ten. While the Underground always appealed — Miranda said it was his coalminer genes — the mainline train was direct and faster. Even so, twenty minutes at close quarters, in a carriage filled with strangers, made for a lot of thinking time.

Miranda hadn’t rung him since the previous evening. He mulled over the significance of this and came up with nothing. Three weeks ago, which seemed like a distant dream, they’d been curled up on her sofa watching the 1936 original of *The Man Who Knew Too Much*. He smiled, recalling her

shouting at the TV when a cardigan unravelled and tangled up a roomful of dancers.

“Oh, come on!” She’d thrown her arms in the air, appealing to the unseen referee of cinema.

“It’s just a film.” He’d pulled her back to the sofa.

“Doesn’t mean it can take the piss — even a film has to be credible.”

Life wasn’t that tidy though. And here he was, trying to out-manoeuvre professional bastards on the hoof. He shut his eyes and yawned silently, and tried to conjure some sense out of thin air. Nope. He needed help and it was time to start looking in new places.

A six-minute stop at nowhere junction bugged up his schedule and got him to Liverpool Street after eight. For all he knew, Christine was already in position to watch him exit the gate, with Bob Peterson beside her making plans for the evening. Hard to say what bothered him most about Peterson. Already married, proven untrustworthy, a dirty fighter *and* an all-round shit of a human being — it was a tough call for the top spot.

He figured out the best vantage point for Platform One and then found a good observation spot for that. Wheels within wheels. It gave him little comfort that he was right — Christine was there with Peterson. Perhaps she wanted Thomas to see them together. It saved on conversation. He watched as they kissed — in that desperate, fiery way he and Miranda sometimes did if they knew it would be days before they met again. The way they hadn’t the night before.

Commuters flowed around the pair, barely noticing. He wondered if they’d stay the course. Whether Peterson would ever leave his wife and kids for her — and did she even want that? Eventually he grew tired of being a voyeur, made his way over to Platform One and tried to blend in with the rest of the office infantry.

Christine met her mark at eight-thirty, smiling as though she had a secret. He let her go on believing it.

“Well, Thomas, here I am.”

He fought the urge to check the space behind her for Peterson and they did the polite hug thing that happened when it was just the two of them — a sip from a vintage bottle of Old Times’ Sake. He topped up his caffeine and breakfasted on a muffin while they sat and chatted for a few minutes about

nothing that mattered. She waited it out like a pro, she'd learned from the best, after all.

"I need to go to Whitehall this morning." He took a great gulp of breath. "I thought you might like to come with me."

Her brow furrowed. "I wasn't informed. What time's your appointment?"

He shook his head. "He'll see us anyway."

A smile graced her face. "What aren't you telling me?"

It seemed only fair. He talked about the pick-up by Heick's people, adding his conclusion that Heick must have some hold on Sir Peter for the old man to have instructed Christine to send him out for collection. He could tell that rankled, which made their business breakfast all the more pleasurable.

His mobile phone alerted him to a text. Christine drained her cup nonchalantly and stretched.

"Do you want to get that? I can wait over there." She pointed about twelve feet away.

"No, it's fine. Let's go."

She grabbed his arm playfully as they walked towards the nearest Underground sign.

"There's something different about you today, Thomas."

Chapter 15

Main Building at Whitehall looked impregnable, a citadel of the establishment. Thomas had no plan, other than to gain access, make Sir Peter Carroll squirm a little and suss out what he knew about Heick.

Christine held back at the final street crossing. He waited for her on the other side.

“You okay?” Even now he could read her.

“I’m not entirely sure what you’re up to.”

That made two of them. There was more though, he could tell. It didn’t take much persuasion.

“I’ve never been here — to his office.”

That should have made him feel special, given the handful of times he’d been invited, but instead it made him feel more like a pet.

He went straight up to the desk and stared through the security glass. The guard eventually took the hint.

“Can I help you, sir?”

Thomas heard steps behind him and inhaled the comforting scent of Givenchy.

“We’re here to see Sir Peter Carroll.” He flashed his SSU ID needlessly and Christine copied him.

A few taps of the keyboard and the drawbridge raised a little.

“I have nothing booked. Is Sir Peter expecting you?”

Thomas smiled. The old bastard should have expected a visit the moment he left Heick’s first meeting. Normally he’d feel his shoulders hunching in and remember what it felt like to be called to the front of the classroom. Not today though.

“We don’t have an appointment. However, Sir Peter will want to see us. Tell him it relates to ASI.”

The guard’s chest heaved a little, as though he had better things to do with his time. Other people joined the queue, piling on the pressure. The guard glanced towards a seating area.

“We’ll wait then, thanks.”

It didn’t take long to receive a call back to the front desk. Their escort waited while they each completed a hand scan. Thomas recognised her

from a previous visit and spotted the addition of a wedding ring. He waited until they reached the lift and motioned to the new jewellery.

“You got him to go through with it then?”

“Aye,” she laughed, and the penny dropped.

“I’ve seen you before . . . Thomas Bladen?”

He took a bow. Christine looked less than impressed as he followed her into the lift. He would have introduced her if there’d been any point.

The temperature dipped a couple of degrees when the lift doors opened, and it had nothing to do with the heating. Thomas found himself counting his steps until, three to go, the escort up ahead of him rapped on the door. She cast him the briefest of smiles as he passed.

“Come in!”

He turned the handle slowly, determined to exert control from the beginning. Christine almost collided with him. Sir Peter’s face betrayed confusion as he laid eyes on Thomas’s boss as well.

“Now, Thomas, what’s so important that it warrants an interruption to my schedule?”

He sat down and Christine wavered for an instant before joining him, folding her hands neatly in contrition. He glanced down without comment. Everyone was guilty of something.

“ASI,” he repeated for Christine’s benefit. He could see a tremor at Sir Peter’s temple — a poker tell. It was one of the few things Diane Wright had taught him, from her time as a croupier.

“Artesian Shield Investments.” *And I’ll raise you fifty.*

Sir Peter Carroll’s face reddened, but his jaw stayed taut. Thomas felt like applauding the old man’s performance.

“I can give you the address if you like.” Thomas leaned forward and placed his fingers on the edge of the desk, claiming territory. It struck him then that Heick must have gone off-road by taking Thomas there — *taking* being the operative word. He smiled momentarily. Heick had planned ahead by giving him information to trade, little realising that Thomas and the old man had some history of their own — which had resulted in Sir Peter becoming answerable to Karl’s people. Unless Heick had known that as well.

While he was playing the odds in his head, Christine found her voice.

“Why wasn’t I informed about an arrangement to collect one of my staff by,” she turned to Thomas momentarily, “By an outside agency?”

Staff? Ouch.

Sir Peter stared them down and breathed through his nose, ready to charge.

Thomas changed tack. “We can help get Heick off your back.”

Sir Peter touched his fingertips together. “And what might you want in return?”

He checked his phone, playing for time. The text he’d ignored at Liverpool Street station drained the blood from his face. *‘If you won’t talk to me I can ask Miranda instead.’* He locked eyes with Sir Peter and fought to recover the power of speech.

“Arlo Moretti. Ring me when you know where to find him.” He got up while his legs could still carry him. “You coming?”

Christine didn’t move. “No. You report for duty at Paddington Green. Sir Peter and I aren’t finished.”

He closed the door behind him, stumbling along the corridor. Fear and rage went with him. No one threatened Miranda.

Karl picked up on the third ring.

“Records Department.”

“Funny boy. I’m on my way — about to head into Westminster tube. I’m making plans for Moretti, but I could do with some help.”

“Sure. We’ll talk. We need to find him first though.”

“Already on it, in a manner of speaking.”

* * *

When he arrived on site the desk sergeant wasted no time in picking up the phone. DS Edwards appeared downstairs and practically pulled him through the door.

“Where the bloody hell have you been? My DI is on the warpath. Have you spoken with Karl?”

“Not yet, why?”

“You’ll find out soon enough.” She trotted up the stairs and led all the way up to the fourth floor. “Welcome to your new home — the wonderful world of Information Management.”

Maybe the door had been over-oiled because when she pushed, it slammed against the wall. She didn't seem to notice, or care. Karl sat behind a barricade of files.

"Has Karen given you the bad news?"

Edwards cut to the chase. "The safe house received a parcel — a wreath — delivered by cab, paid cash in hand. The Leibowiczs had to be moved, the shit has hit the fan and now DI Ferguson is searching for a leak."

"Any ideas?" He bluffed, having only one idea himself: his bloody phone. Bollocks.

"Ferguson wants to see you ASAP. I managed to stall him but he's steaming. I'll give you a few minutes so Karl can explain the set-up here." She turned on her heels and managed to slam the swing door in the opposite direction.

"This thing here . . ." Karl explained very slowly, "is a com-pu-ter."

Chapter 16

DS Edwards returned in seven minutes — Thomas noted the clock. She gave them no prep en route to the DI's office. It was already crowded when they got there.

Thomas recognised one police officer from the safe house, plus a stranger who evidently outranked Ferguson. By the looks of things she ran the show, having made herself comfortable behind his desk. She paused, post sentence, when they entered the room.

“Give me a reason not to turn this over to Professional Standards for investigation.”

It was an open question with no takers.

Karl grabbed a spare chair. Everyone else kept to the edges of the room.

“I understand our surveillance colleagues here have already exceeded their remit?”

Thomas turned to Ferguson, who kept his reddened gaze on his desk. So Ferguson had ratted them out to his DCI.

Thomas tested the water. “With respect, we not only rescued a child, we also acquired useful intelligence about vehicle number plates.”

The DCI glowered. “Most of which we already had. Plus, you trespassed on private property to get the information, which puts using it on very shaky ground.”

“And what about Moretti?” Karl joined the fray.

The DCI seemed to consider the point for about five seconds. “Circumstantial. Just a name you heard.”

“Hang on — what about Mrs Leibowicz?”

The DCI cupped a hand to her ear. “I'm sorry? Did you say you'd taken a statement? What's that? No, because you're not police officers, just some have-a-go heroes with a camera?” She waited for her own punchline. “That's right.”

Thomas momentarily considered telling her about the phone calls he'd received, or the caretaker's death, or the contact number Mrs Leibowicz gave Karl. It took just a moment to give up on the idea because, despite her gender, she was a prick as well.

The DCI asked about the fiasco at the safe house and Thomas and Karl played dumb, as have-a-go heroes are wont to do. Finally, she kicked them out of *her* office and made sure DS Edwards knew to return once she'd delivered them back to the information room.

* * *

Thomas and Karl worked for two hours with barely a word between them. Karl had donned reading glasses — always a sign that he was flagging. There were no jokes now as they data-mined for gold. Thomas sifted surveillance reports for key information and then added them to a database, along with a file, page and paragraph reference, for subsequent crosschecking. As he worked through the files he could almost hear his subconscious mind grinding down recent events to separate the wheat from the chaff.

“Alright, let's say the caretaker is dead.”

“Huh?” Karl looked over, removed his glasses and massaged the bridge of his nose. “I think that's a given now, Tommo.”

“Then who's to say he didn't pass on the number plates to me? Speaking of which, how come they didn't have all of them already?”

“Who knows? Maybe there was a gap between shifts, or the plates could have been changed. Never mind that.” Karl stood and cricked his neck. “Your proposal has legs, but it still doesn't explain away the safe house incident.”

“I've thought of that. Couldn't you ring Barbara Leibowicz and convince her to admit some kind of slip-up with the address? It would get DS Edwards out of the shit, even if it does mean helping DI Ferguson in the process.”

“And she'd do this *why* exactly?”

Thomas blinked slowly. “Because you'll tell her that Moretti will be dealt with soon.”

“And on that note, I think it's time for coffee. Why don't you do the honours? I have a very private phone call to make.”

It shouldn't have come as a surprise to Thomas to get another text from Moretti. Thankfully, having Karl only a desk away lessened the blow.

'Don't talk to the police.'

He called Karl over. “I need to stall him until we can find him.”

Karl's eyes narrowed. "We know Mrs Leibowicz is safe now, right?"

Thomas nodded. They'd moved her within an hour of receiving the wreath. "Moretti knows everywhere I've been since he killed the caretaker. The bastard must be following me around on a map." His next thought was Yorkshire — take off to the Moors, away from Miranda and everyone else, and wait for Moretti to come find him. He stared off, haunted by Yorgi the hitman's face when he'd shot at him out on the North York Moors.

Karl coughed. "Tommo, you need to say *something* to him."

He went with the truth and changed the sequence of events.

'Mrs Leibowicz paid me to get the child back. She doesn't want me to talk to the police.'

The reply came quickly and in capitals.

'WHY ARE YOU AT THE POLICE STATION?'

Karl opened his hands, empty of ideas. Thomas fell back on the truth again.

'I temp there.'

And then there was silence.

Karl sat shoulder to shoulder with him, fixed on the phone. "You realise that he doesn't have a plan. Not for you."

"Beyond killing me, you mean?"

"That all depends on the risk you pose. If you work for Mrs L that makes you a known quantity, an employee — low risk. Not safe exactly, but containable, since Mrs L hasn't said anything herself yet."

Thomas followed Karl's logic. "Or an armed response team would be breaking down his door by now."

"Well, wherever that door happens to be . . ."

Confession time. "I've asked the old man to find Moretti for me."

"And why would the Director General of the Surveillance Support Unit," Karl mock-saluted, "Get out of his chair for you?"

"I've promised him some leverage on Heick. It's win-win."

Karl smiled. "You're thinking like a pro, Tommo. Any more of this and we'll have to think about signing you up officially."

"Let's hope it never comes to that."

Chapter 17

It all made some kind of sense in Thomas's head. Wrap the thread around Heick, Sir Peter and Jack Langton, manoeuvre them near Moretti and then pull tight. That way, he figured, one of them would sort Moretti out once and for all. But he couldn't help wondering how dark a shade of grey he'd have to go in the process.

Karl tried making conversation again. "Are you sure you're okay with this?"

Thomas didn't bother responding. Jack Langton was a means to an end. All he had to do was convince Jack that Sheryl had been the real target at Caliban's, and Jack would complete the picture for himself. Newly out of prison and with a power vacuum — thanks to the untimely death of his rival, Charlie Stokes — a narcissistic prick like Jack couldn't help but see everything centred around himself.

From the little Karl had revealed, someone on his side of the house had already made contact with Jack and offered him some sort of deal. That was all off limits to Thomas and he was happy to be kept in the dark. If you didn't know then you didn't have to lie.

Jack would think himself lucky at first, and then he'd think himself clever, and by the time he'd cottoned on that he had the shitty end of the deal Karl's people would own him. All the more reason for Thomas to get in *now* and use Jack's paranoia to their advantage. If politics was a dirty game, counter-intelligence was positively toxic.

"I'll be around the corner, Tommo. I'll call you after fifteen minutes, as per. Stick to what we agreed."

Natalie Langton answered the door, and spoke from the heart.

"What the fuck do you want?"

"I need a private word with Jack."

She held the door, thinking it over. "You better come in then." She turned around and left him standing there.

"It's for you — it's Thomas."

He followed the sound of a chair screeching back, through the kitchen and out to a conservatory. Jack had a property newspaper spread over a

glass table, red pen marks around several ads. Jack waited until Thomas was at arm's length before he stood up, forcing Thomas to back off a little. Jack proffered a hand.

"I didn't expect to hear from you again — I don't need a driver. Scotch?"

Thomas declined, drawn to the properties Jack had ringed on two pages — not one of them under £400k.

"I can't make you out, Thomas. One minute you're visiting me in prison and laying down the law," he seemed to growl the last few words, "And then you show up as my chauffeur when I get out of the clink. I dunno what your game is."

He gave Jack about a minute's silence, in a pretence of respect, before he aimed for the bullseye.

"Something happened at Caliban's recently." He could see Jack shift slightly. "Someone took a shot at the windows — several of them. Sheryl was there." He watched Jack's arms drop limply by his side and followed his gaze to the closed door.

"You got a name?" Even that sounded like a threat.

"Not yet. I'm working on it."

"When you find out who's responsible, you come to me. Understand?"

"Yes, Jack." He judged it safe to sit down, although he perched on the edge of the seat.

Jack took a breath that sucked most of the oxygen out of the room. "I owe you for sorting out Charlie Stokes while I was in prison. It's helped me grow my business." He prodded the glass table, which rocked on its uneven legs. "I've you to thank for this. I'm moving up the ladder so it's time to get something more fitting. But if you ever cross me . . ."

Thomas felt his mouth turn to sand. He swallowed, remembering how he'd had to clench his guts to play Will Scarlett in a school drama.

"I thought you'd want to know."

Jack looked at the door, audience over. Thomas closed it after him and saw himself out. As he opened the front door to leave, Natalie Langton called behind him.

"Don't come back!"

She stumbled inside, glass in hand. Thomas's phone started ringing.

"Tommo. Time to move." Karl spoke in staccato.

“Relax, Karl. I’m walking round now.”

“Well, start running, someone’s breaking into your flat.”

* * *

Karl shuffled across to the passenger seat. “You drive. I need to call someone.”

Thomas over-revved the engine and spun the wheels as the car screeched away. Karl kept his voice low. Thomas picked out his address and the word ‘urgent’ — that was as much as he needed. Hard to tell what pissed him off more — that Karl had been personally monitoring the security system he’d helped set up in the flat, that Thomas’s own mobile had been second on the contact list, or that Moretti had the sheer bloody arrogance to invade his personal space. This was worse than the incident at Caliban’s — another line crossed that could not go unpunished. Twenty minutes at the wheel seemed like a lifetime, but finally a road sign read Welcome to Walthamstow. He parked up a few doors away.

“I’ll take the back.” He threw Karl his keys and didn’t wait for an answer. He jogged round to the alley behind the flats, conserving his energy for whatever — and whoever — lay ahead. He slowed at the alleyway, scouring the ground for anything to use as a weapon. The best he could find was half a house brick, which nestled comfortably in one hand.

Moretti was obviously behind the burglary, and equally obviously he’d have sent a lackey to do the job. Thomas curled his fingers tighter around the brick at the thought, scraping his nails on the surface.

He crept up the metal steps, noting the damaged window frame. A good forced entry, had it not been for his hidden security system. About the time he realised the folly of handing Karl all his keys, he heard the inside bolt on the door drawing back. He froze and tensed his brick arm.

The door opened and he made a split-second decision, settling for a fist in the face. No point risking a charge of Actual Bodily Harm when a surprise punch in the mouth ought to do the job.

The burglar went down without a word, his head smacking against the kitchen linoleum with a satisfying *thwack*. No blood by the looks of things, fortunately. No bags, either. Thomas stared at the prone body until he heard Karl’s voice in the distance.

“You okay, Tommo?” Karl appeared at the other end of the kitchen.
“Jesus, will you put that down!”

Thomas dropped the brick behind him, and it bounced away, the thuds reverberating at each step. He dragged the body inside a little so he could close the door. A quick search of the mystery man’s pockets revealed a car key and some money, a few small tools, and the remnants of some electrical wire.

“What do we do with my visitor?”

Karl did his sphinx impression. “Transport’s on its way.”

Thomas didn’t ask.

Chapter 18

After minutes spent staring down at the unconscious man, Karl's mobile trilled into life. Now came the tricky part, carrying a dead weight, figuratively speaking, down the steps. A van with blacked out windows backed down the alleyway to receive the patient. A woman exited from the rear.

"Hello again, Thomas."

"Teresa." He nodded curtly and avoided looking at Karl. Hadn't the two of them once been involved, or was that another assumption encouraged by Karl? Whatever the case, she and Karl had little to say to one another. Once the *patient* was on board the van didn't hang around.

Thomas and Karl stood in the alley, watching the dust settle.

"Fancy a cuppa?"

Thomas was halfway up the stairs when he smelled burning. By the time he reached the kitchen he heard something popping and the air was acrid. Running through to the living room he confronted a column of flame from the plug socket up to his beloved photographs.

Karl was a step behind him. "You deal with this and I'll check the other rooms."

Thomas quickly flicked the socket switch and then grabbed a towel to smother the flames on the wall. It didn't take a genius to see that the intruder had rigged up a plug-in air freshener as a fire-starter. Now he wished he'd bounced him down the stairs instead.

"Tommo! There's more of them. You better cut the power. Fuck, this thing's hot."

He tripped the mains circuit breaker and returned to the wall, staring up at the damaged frames in the dimness. Heat throbbed in his fingertips. Karl's pocket torch flickered at the edge of his peripheral vision.

"I found two more IEDs." Karl's voice grew louder. "That's Improvised Explosive—"

"Devices," Thomas beat him to the punchline. He hadn't taken his eyes off the wall.

Karl knelt down and extracted the charred unit from the plug socket. “Cunning bastard. These would have gone off at different times. Not lethal, but they make a hell of a mess.”

“Psychological warfare.” Thomas lifted off a photo of Miranda, feeling the warmth in his palms. He wiped the smudged glass, felt the crack, and peered through time at a younger Miranda, languid in sunlight, on a summer’s day at Golden Acre Park in Leeds.

“Picture frames can be replaced, Thomas.”

He carried the frame through to the kitchen and then switched the power back on. Moretti would know by his phone that he was back home. Anger brought clarity.

“I’d better stay here tonight. When he realises his messenger has disappeared he might think about sending someone else.”

Karl sat down. “I’ll stick around as well. Two fists are better than one. What’s for dinner then, Chinese or Indian?”

Thomas cracked a one-second smile for effort. Good to know Karl had his back, and all for the price of a balti. He passed Karl a twenty and told him to let himself back in. He’d started dialling before the door slammed.

“Sir Peter Carroll, please. Yes, I know what the time is. Thomas Bladen — would you like my ID number?” Apparently not.

Sir Peter took his time picking up. Thomas hit the ground running.

“Where will I find Moretti? He tried to burn my home down. I know about you and Heick, and I also know the name of Heick’s *contact* in the Shadow State. The one who’s moving up their ranks.”

He imagined Sir Peter sitting up straight in his chair like a general. “I’ll have the information for you tomorrow — by noon.”

The old man had sounded jittery. Maybe Moretti was harder to trace than expected, even for the head of the Surveillance Support Unit.

Thomas rang Jack Langton next.

“It’s Thomas. The bloke responsible is called Moretti and I’ll have his address tomorrow.” Jack gave him a mobile number to add to his collection.

Heick was last on his call list. Thomas kept to the golden rule of only telling people what you needed them to know — that he knew who had ordered the shooting and that he planned to take care of it. He deliberately faltered and Heick grabbed the bait like a shark.

“If you need assistance, let me know. How is Karl?”

He pictured Karl shaking his head slowly. “I’ll be in touch.”

Karl returned with the balti bounty. Thomas reassured himself there wouldn’t have been enough time to collect the food and make himself a spare set of keys, and in any case Karl could have done that after a previous break-in, when he’d had the door replaced.

He dished out the calls with the food. Karl didn’t ask what the plan was — no need. Moretti had threatened Thomas’s life and Miranda’s, and now that threat had to be neutralised.

“What else?” Karl shovelled in his food with all the gusto a former squaddie could muster.

Thomas reached for a notepad. “Right.” He scribbled some shapes and drew arrows to the centre of the page where he wrote Moretti — underlined. “I want Mrs Leibowicz to call Moretti on whatever number she has for him and I want *that* number tracked. Can you get that sorted?”

“Consider it done. I still have her cheque. I’ll ring her now.”

“I need her to . . .” Thomas stared across the room to where he’d hung Miranda’s picture. “Tell her to convince Moretti she’s had a rethink and now she wants to sign the papers.”

“What’s your logic?”

Thomas clattered his fork against the plate. “Element of surprise. First I want to deplete Moretti’s manpower and then I’ll send in Jack. Okay, one last call to make.”

Karl took the hint and cleared the plates away to the kitchen.

“Alright, Terry? It’s Thomas. Are you busy for the next couple of days? I need a massive favour.”

Chapter 19

Thomas reached Kings Cross St Pancras station by seven-thirty. True to his word, Karl had not only rustled up breakfast he'd also managed to get a repair team in early, to make the flat secure again. Thomas had left them all to it.

The station concourse was wall-to-wall commuters and that dull vibrating hum of hundreds of people living within their own heads like rebellious ants. Terry met him behind the information kiosk. He needed a shave. Thomas reckoned Terry wasn't a morning person.

"I'll just get my ticket and then we'll talk."

Terry stood with him in the queue, chaperoning him to the ticket counter.

"Open return to York please." Thomas tried not to wince when he heard the price. Now he understood what Karl meant by expenses. Money extorted and ticket extracted, he returned to the melee of passengers, well-wishers and pickpockets.

"Okay, Terry, here's everything you need to know." He passed over a jiffy bag. "Thanks a million. If you run into trouble, ring me — day or night — and me or Karl will sort it out."

Terry took out what he needed and then added the jiffy bag to his rucksack. For once, the fast train to York left on time. Thomas hoped it was a good omen.

* * *

Right around the time the York train cleared Peterborough a text winged its way to Moretti like a bullet.

'You made your point in Walthamstow. Let me make mine. Your man won't be returning.'

Even Moretti's fastest response would leave an hour's gap to clear York and head for Pickering. Maybe Moretti had people on the inside. It was one of Karl's pet theories, given how DI Ferguson had been so keen to place Moretti beyond the scope of the current investigation.

Karl provided a DIY update by phone. "The back door and window would stop an elephant. I'm on my way to the police station. When will I

see you?”

Thomas allowed himself the luxury of a smile. “In about forty-five minutes, once Terry is clear of Peterborough. I’d better ring Ajit now.”

For some reason, Thomas always found it hard to lie to Ajit. Even withholding the truth, which his mother had assured him was not a sin, somehow violated their friendship. Despite being a solid fifteen stone two of North Yorkshire police sergeant there was a touch of the innocent about Ajit. He’d had that rarest of things — a normal upbringing. And now he was settled with Geena and the baby. Ajit represented that *other* road Thomas might have travelled down, had he not got into a conversation about photography with Sir Peter Carroll in a civil service lift. Yep, considering everything since then, lifts ought to carry a safety warning.

“Aj? All right, mate? You free to talk?”

“Bloody ’ell, Thomas Bladen! I thought you’d changed your identity and gone into hiding.”

He gave Ajit a moment to laugh at his own joke. Fair enough, it had been a while.

“Are you coming up to see us, like?”

Time to close the door on the puppy’s cage. “Not exactly.”

Ajit took it all in without comment.

“It’s only for tonight, so Terry can sleep safe.”

“He could stay over at ours, I suppose.” Ajit didn’t sound too convinced.

He let him off the hook. “Nah, it’s fine. Just leave the phone he’ll give you in your locker at the police station overnight. He’ll call you when he’s in Pickering. Thanks, Aj.”

He cut the call and turned the cogs in his brain another notch. So far so good.

Karl had coffee and muffins on standby in the information room. Stewed caffeine had never tasted so good.

“Operation Takedown is on track then?”

He sampled a muffin. “I think so. When is Mrs L ringing Moretti?”

“Once I get word that the trace is set up. In the meantime, let’s gather some information for our hosts!”

* * *

DS Edwards came to check on their progress around eleven-thirty. Thomas could sense her wariness around them now. Maybe the coppers had all decided to close ranks, what with Professional Standards sniffing around. He could hardly blame Edwards, even if she had happily taken the credit for the child rescue escapade. The last Thomas had heard on the subject, Mrs L had admitted contacting Moretti from the first safe house, in a moment of panic. Edwards hadn't seemed entirely convinced but a written statement was on its way, keeping Professional Standards at bay and putting everyone else in the clear. The only fly in the ointment was Edwards's unwillingness to let the matter rest.

She helped herself to a muffin from the bag. "What I don't get is why she waited until now to say something about it. And then there's the mystery of how someone managed to trace the call."

She meant Moretti of course, but his name didn't feature in the paperwork. In the developing case file an oblique reference cited him as 'a person of interest.'

Thomas stopped listening to Edwards and Karl bonding over carbohydrates. It all played out in his head like stepping stones, each one leading him inevitably to the next, while he tried not to think of the final destination. Moretti would send people up to Yorkshire after the phone, so Terry would have to box clever until Ajit took it into protective custody. Meanwhile, Jack Langton had been primed to slip his chain, eager to deal with Moretti in order to demonstrate that prison hadn't diminished him. Quite the opposite — he was expanding his business and protecting his interests. Jesus, this had become complicated. The stepping stones ended at Arlo Moretti. Two men had died at Moretti's command and he'd indirectly threatened Miranda. Thomas couldn't decide which was the greater crime.

"You okay there, Thomas? You went very quiet." DS Edwards shared Karl's habit of talking and eating at the same time — never an attractive feature in mixed company.

He looked up, blinking at the neon strip light.

"I was just saying to Karl, you two seem to have a knack for being in the right place at the right time. Anyway, I'll be seeing you."

Karl saw her to the door.

"Tommo, I know what you're going through. A decision like this can weigh heavily on your conscience. My advice? See it as a form of natural

selection.”

He found that strangely comforting.

Sir Peter played it to the wire, ringing in at ten to twelve. He relayed an address in London’s Docklands — a palatial apartment overlooking the past. It didn’t impress Thomas. Like he told Karl, nouveau riche, new developments, new respectability, same old shit.

Karl’s people confirmed the active trace on Moretti’s mobile. Now it was all a question of timing.

Chapter 20

By five p.m. all the pieces were in place. Jack Langton picked Thomas up outside Mile End Underground station. Close enough to Caliban's to make Jack think he'd just come from there, and far away enough for Jack not to have visited.

Jack arrived in the back of a Merc — he must have liked the chauffeur idea. He'd taken on some new muscle too, judging by the bad-ass brothers in the front. They looked like Jack's steroid buddies — the black guy gestured to the rear door, while the white guy beside him amused himself by cracking knuckles. When it came to savagery, Jack Langton was an equal opportunity employer.

Thomas was no expert, but if he were to guess, he'd say live wire Jack had been sampling his own cocaine.

"No one fucks with me — nobody." Jack faced up to Thomas, close enough for him to spot flecks of residue. He drummed out a rhythm on the leather seating. "After tonight I'll be taking on new business. Sure you don't want to join me, Tommy? You're practically part of the firm as it is!" Jack rocked with laughter and the thug duo up front seemed to enjoy it too.

Not for the first time, Thomas wondered if this really was the best way of solving the problem. He felt his phone buzz against his leg, cut out and then start buzzing again: Terry had passed on the phone to Ajit. Thank God for that.

When they got out of the car, Jack was still breathing like a racehorse. If Mrs Leibowicz had followed the script, Arlo Moretti would be expecting a courier. Karl had passed on a business card for SCS Couriers. Thomas knew it tied into Mrs Leibowicz's call to Moretti. Clever Karl.

Thomas led the way with Jack behind him and the steroid twins bringing up the rear. He pushed the button and held up the card to the camera, playing himself — a reluctant messenger. On the way in he turned, had a pretend conversation and held the door for the three amigos, who were all dressed immaculately. Thomas took the lift alone to the third floor and produced a DL sized envelope from his pocket with Moretti's address

handwritten. The pages inside were blank, but by the time Moretti realised that he'd have something else to think about.

The lift was slow and quiet — perfect for too much thinking. He could still back out now and leave Jack and his goons to pummel the door down. Would that make him any less complicit? He withheld judgement. The lift came to a slow halt and the door swished open. Showtime. He exited the lift, counting the steps to Moretti's pad.

He heard rousing classical music as he reached the front door. It sounded celebratory. All things considered, *The Surprise Symphony* might have been more appropriate. The doorbell was stiff, as though Moretti received few visitors. Maybe he didn't have many friends. Enemies? That was a different matter, they were forming a line — and about to make a house call.

Moretti opened the door wearing an apron. Something smelled delicious, probably like every other last supper. There wasn't a hint of recognition on his face and that made it easier.

"I'll need you to sign it for it."

"Wait here." Moretti left him standing and Thomas watched him search for a pen.

He never made it back. Jack's men shouldered Thomas aside as they went in, single file. Thomas couldn't see everything but when he saw the gun in Jack's hand as he passed, he knew he'd seen enough. "Sit down." Jack levelled his gun.

For one horrible moment Thomas thought Jack was going to shake his hand as he left. Thomas shifted position to put a foot out to block the door, and whispered through the gap. "Before you're done with him I want to know the name of the caretaker and where the body is. You've got my number."

Jack's eyes widened, as if he were seeing Thomas for the first time. He grunted by way of a reply and then slammed the door. Thomas started walking and tilted his head down to make sure Karl's wire received him loud and clear. "If you or Heick plan on getting to Moretti, you'll need to be quick."

Somewhere behind him Thomas heard a door bursting open and the splinter of wood. He kept on walking. Outside, the deluxe glass-fronted apartments sparkled, reflecting silvery traces in the Thames. Thomas pulled

the wire clear and headed off to find Canary Wharf Station. As expected, Karl was waiting for him in the ticket hall.

“Rough day at the office?”

“A confusing one. I thought Moretti might have recognised me, but I was just another face.” He thought about that for a moment. “Course, that’s a good thing. I heard a commotion on my way out. It never occurred to me that Heick may already have had a team on site — they *were* Heick’s people going in after Jack, right?”

“You almost sound disappointed. Come on now, Tommo, you didn’t really want Jack to execute him?” Karl looked perplexed.

“I s’pose not.” He wandered over to the ticket machine. “But I want him to leave Miranda and me alone, and then there’s the business with the caretaker.”

“Captured on the wire and noted. Heick will ask your questions and you’ll have your answers, and more besides.” Karl dug out his Oyster Card. “What?”

“I dunno, Karl. How do you square the fact that he’s your dad with . . . well . . . everything else?”

Karl shrugged and Thomas let the matter drop. But he knew Karl well enough to realise it would be another reckoning for another time.

“Fancy a shandy, Tommo?”

“Yeah, why not? I’ll give Ajit a ring first — thank him for looking after the phone, and then tell Terry he can come back first thing tomorrow.”

“Sounds like a plan.”

“Alright, Aj? How’s it going?”

It took one sentence to work out it was not going well at all.

“What do you mean he never got in touch? Well, why didn’t you bloody ring me?” He felt the panic rising up his face and as it subsided it drained down to his feet. Terry had been out there for hours, alone.

Karl didn’t waste words when he heard the news. “Ring him, see if he can talk.”

Thomas swallowed. Miranda was going to go ballistic. No one picked up.

Fuck. He was sweating now, toying with the idea of going back to Moretti’s apartment.

“No need, I’ll ask *dad*.” Karl made the call. “Uh huh. Right. Send the details over. Ask him about the phone he’s been chasing — quickly. I’ll wait.”

Even Karl twitched at the scream in the background.

“Two of them? He what? Well, he’d better call them off, otherwise I’ll come and dislocate the other shoulder.” Karl snapped the phone shut, his jaw rigid. “Two men — a thousand pounds each to catch up with your phone. You better ring Miranda and the family.”

Chapter 21

Thomas paused in his tracks when he saw the Mini Cooper. A glimpse of Miranda at the wheel evoked a mixture of desire and regret. Her face told him to add disgrace to the list.

“Get in.” She managed a half-nod to Karl as he opened the back door. “What are you gonna tell Mum and Dad?”

Thomas looked to Karl to deflect her stare.

“The good news is that the two geezers aren’t pros — they’re hired hands looking to earn a few quid.”

Thomas read the small print: unlikely to be armed. In a word, chancers. Miranda ignored Karl and spoke directly to Thomas.

“*You* chose this life, not us. You know that Terry and Sam will do anything for you, but you can’t keep doing this.

He conceded the point without a second bout. “I’ll sort it.”

In the silence that followed, Karl did the thinking for everyone.

“Terry must have had a reason for not passing on the phone. Maybe he couldn’t find your friend, Ajit.”

“He could hardly miss him.” Miranda cracked a smile.

Thomas breathed a little easier. “So maybe Terry couldn’t get to Ajit. If he’d hung around too long in York — even if he’d stuck with the crowds — they might have eyeballed him. Plus, there aren’t many ways of reaching Pickering. And not much cover when you get there.”

“What I don’t get, Tommo, is why Terry didn’t switch the phone off, assuming he realised someone was on to him?”

Thomas’s heart sank. Because he’d told Terry not to. That was the whole point. Jesus, he’d even supplied a charger for the train. Stupid, stupid, stupid.

Karl leaned forward. “If they had him, Moretti would have mentioned it while Jack Langton was rearranging his arms. So where would he go?”

“London.” Miranda’s voice could have cut steel.

“He gave me the all-clear signal though.” Thomas made a show of checking his phone. “About an hour ago.”

“Probably trying to buy you some time. Right, not a word please.” Karl took his own phone out. “Hey, Christine, it’s Karl McNeill. Listen, can you get a phone triangulated ASAP. Unofficial channels. Sure, let me give you the number. Uh huh. Yeah, that’s right, it *is* Thomas’s. London, I think. No, that’s fine. I can deal with it. I’ll await your call. Thanks, I owe you.” Karl lowered the phone. “She said about twenty minutes.”

Miranda glowered. “Why has Christine still got your personal phone number?”

“Now is not the time.” He didn’t need to look round to know Karl was grinning behind him.

Chapter 22

Thomas noticed the front door was ajar before Miranda had stopped the car. His first thought was that Terry had gone there, but if so the two geezers following him were unlikely to have made it out again. No, the door was for him. Miranda folded her arms. He got the message.

“Stay here, Karl. I’ll do this on my own.” It wasn’t bravado, just basic human decency. Family was family, after all, even if they weren’t his blood. He announced himself as he pushed the front door.

“We’re in here.” Diane’s voice gave nothing away. Inside, John, Diane and Sam were lined up on the settee, ready to pass sentence.

John looked up. “What can you tell us?”

Thomas sidestepped an apology and laid out the facts. Moretti — he didn’t name him — had been taken out of the picture, but the two blokes after Terry were hired hands who didn’t know that. They were too busy tracking a phone that Terry was supposed to have passed on in Yorkshire. Thomas got the point in, not to stitch Terry up, but rather to show that there’d been a plan — even if it had all gone to shit.

No one asked ‘what next’, which stung him because it implied they didn’t expect an answer. For now, it was a waiting game. Their coats were piled in the armchair opposite and a sports bag lay by John’s feet.

“Someone is trying to trace the phone’s last position.”

Diane nodded slowly, eyes on the ground.

“This is bullshit.” Sam rose a little from his seat and then thought better of it. “We should be out there, looking for Terry.”

“Easy, Sam.” A mother’s voice made all the difference.

Thomas waited with them, in the middle of the room. It reminded him of hospital corridors and bad news.

Miranda creaked the door as she spoke. “Everybody up. Karl’s got a fix for the last call — Canning Town.”

The settee sagged with relief, and so did Thomas. Terry had gone to the breaker’s yard. In the past, Thomas had gone to the Moors — Terry knew how to play to his strengths on home ground.

John got up and the others followed in his wake. “We’ll take three cars. Miranda, you go with Karl. Sam, you’re with me.”

The three cars moved out in convoy. The message was clear: mess with one of us and you take on all of us.

* * *

Diane drove. If Thomas thought he’d got an easy draw, one look at her face told him otherwise. After six minutes the silence got to him. No one needed that much concentration on the A13 to Canning Town.

“He’ll be okay, Diane, I promise.”

She didn’t look convinced. “When you joined the family you promised to look after Miranda, so Sam and Terry became your brothers. But you’re the cause of all this trouble. Well, not you — what you *do*.” She glanced his way, watched him open his mouth to speak and cut him off. “I know you saved the kiddie from the stolen car. That doesn’t square things though. You can’t keep doing this, Thomas.”

Now where had he heard that before? He wiped a hand over his face.

“When you become a parent, Thomas, it changes everything. John and me, we had a very different life before . . . me working at the casino, parties, trouble. Schemes and dreams.” Her voice was monotone, finding no pleasure in remembering. “You have to make a choice about what matters and in the end family comes first.”

He watched her shoulders tense.

“There is nothing I wouldn’t do for my family. Nothing. So you better hope Terry is safe and sound, or that pair of bastards won’t be walking out. Do we understand one another?” She fell silent again. There was nothing more to say.

The breaker’s yard gates were still locked. If he was there, Terry must have climbed in. Sam left his motor running, freed the lock and then the convoy drove inside. The jumble of headlights splayed like search beams.

“It’s alright, Terry!” John called. “We’re here now. You stay put till I tell you.”

He bent down to his sports bag and Diane moved beside him. When she straightened she had a shotgun nestled in the crook of her arm.

“In case of rats.” She hinged the barrels forward and inserted two cartridges. Her face tightened as she snapped the weapon closed.

Karl was busy keeping watch. He whistled to attract their attention and pointed towards an alleyway running between stacks of vehicles. In the distance, metal creaked.

“Thomas.” Karl invited him centre stage.

“Right!” Thomas bellowed, edging forward out into the light beams so that his shadow became a praying mantis before him. “This is how it works. You come out now and we can sort this peacefully.” He looked back to see John delving into his bag again. “Do it now!”

Diane emphasised the point by emptying a shotgun barrel into an abandoned car door, shattering the window.

“Bloody ’ell, Mum. That was stock.”

“Alright,” a voice squeaked in the distance. I’m coming out. I’m unarmed.” Walking and cowering, he hobbled his way towards them, hands high above his head as if he expected the sky to come crashing down. He made it to thirty feet from the cars.

“On the ground.” John took a step. One was enough.

Chapter 23

The bloke followed the script and lay down obediently. John placed a foot on his neck. “Right. Don’t fuck me about.”

“Ned, for Chrissake!” The body on the ground started coughing.

Karl moved towards John. “It’s okay, I’ll get the dog out the car and flush him out.”

“Ned! They’ll send a bloody dog for you.”

“Wait.”

The voice was nearer than Thomas expected and came from a pile of cars off to the right. The brown suit trembled as he walked towards them, arms limply at his side. All it took was one look from John and he joined his companion, face in the dirt.

A look passed between the family. No one wanted to make the call.

“Terry, it’s Thomas. You coming home tonight or what? Terry!” The sound carried through the yard. He glanced back at John, who looked capable of snapping the bloke’s neck without a second thought.

A door lurched open, four cars up. Terry emerged and clambered down. He took his time about it. Even in the half-light he looked a little rough around the edges.

A cricket ball had lodged in Thomas’s throat and he had to force the words out. “Jesus, Terry, you scared the shit out of me.”

As Terry drew closer, Thomas noticed the abrasions and bruises.

“They saw me in York and tried to take the phone, but I wouldn’t let ’em ’ave it. The battery died — bloody train’s electrics didn’t work coming back.”

“Are you hurt?”

“Nah.” Terry came over all coy in front of his family. “Only a few bumps and scrapes. I gave as good as I got.”

He passed the phone over and Thomas took it in a stranglehold. He walked it over to the bodies on the ground and dropped it close to their faces.

“Look, mate, we’re just trying to make a living. This fella rings us from London — Italian, like. He gives us the information, says he’ll even direct

us, and it's worth two grand, plus expenses, to get the phone and its owner. He wires us five hundred pounds as an advance and tells us to get down to York. It were nothing personal."

Thomas felt the heat in his cheeks, relief and shame in one furious wave. Not professionals, a couple of chancers from Yorkshire by the sounds of it. And why intercept Terry at York? Because that was the station for Pickering — where *his* family lived.

He stepped back, his chest rising and falling like an engine with nowhere to go. When he saw a scaffold pipe nearby he grabbed it and stomped back to the others. He raised the pole in the air in front of the two blokes and squeezed it until his knuckles ached. He couldn't remember rage like it, making his blood pump and clouding his thinking. With a guttural grunt, he drove the pole down and smashed his phone, splintering pieces by the prisoners' heads. They screamed. Good.

"The signal's dead. You found nothing. Understand?" There were no arguments. "Get a new phone number, in case he ever tries calling you again. And don't come back here. Stick to . . ."

"Doncaster."

Fuckers. That explained how they were on to Terry so quickly. They could have been waiting for him at York. He started walking, dragging the pole behind him. The first car he came to paid the price. Once he'd begun knocking seven bells out of it he didn't stop until he'd hammered out his frustration and traded it for a couple of blisters. Finally, with the sweat pooling at his back, he launched the pole through a car window. His eyes prickled with the exertion. At least, that's what he told himself.

When he turned to re-join the others, Miranda was close by, watching him.

"All better now? Look, Thomas, it wasn't your fault you know."

"Who else's then?"

She sighed. "Show me your hands" She cupped them and examined them, like a palmist reading his future. "Your skin's so soft — like a girl's." She squeezed gently.

"Give over."

John had stopped using one of the prisoners as a footrest and brought them to standing. Diane made them empty out their pockets. Karl was taking notes.

John flashed a thumb backwards. “What do you want to do with them?” Sam had the shotgun trained on the pair. Thomas hoped Diane had unloaded the other chamber. He remembered Sam shadow boxing once and accidentally punching a wall.

Thomas looked at Ned. Another mug doing someone else’s bidding.

“We’ll drop them off at the nearest station. Then they can head into London and fuck off back to Doncaster.”

Diane had started returning their personal effects.

“No, no,” Karl insisted. “Not the phones.”

Miranda passed her car key to Thomas. “Don’t be long. Mum and Dad will probably want to have a chat when you get back.”

Karl rode up front and the two blokes sat in the back seat. If anything they looked more worried now, as if they might be disappearing to a landfill site.

Thomas got the last word in at Canning Town station. “Forget you were ever here, and you better hope we do the same — Ned.”

* * *

They waited with the engine running until their passengers had scurried into the station complex. Thomas swung the car wide for the short drive back to the breaker's yard. “Right then. Time for my bollocking.”

“You can hardly blame them, Tommo. But hey, regardless, you did what you thought was necessary.”

Good point, Thomas couldn’t argue with that. And from one who knew what that felt like. Karl checked his phone.

“Hang on. One missed call — under H.”

Thomas made a dash for the moral high ground. “Come on. You must feel *something* about your dad turning up after all this time?”

“Sure. Given what we know about him, Tommo, he could be a useful asset to my organisation.”

“Even if he’s retiring from all this?”

Karl yielded a sad smile. “The first lie they tell you is that they’re the only ones you can trust. The next is that it’s possible to step away. No one ever retires. There’ll be a call someday, or a favour, or some shit-bag intruding upon your carefully managed life.”

“We’re nearly there.” Thomas tried to lift the mood, but Karl already had the phone pressed to his ear.

Karl didn’t speak again until they’d parked up outside the yard.

“We have a dilemma.”

Thomas noted the ‘we’ in the sentence and didn’t interrupt him.

“Heick got the information you wanted. The caretaker for the stolen cars — he was called Theo Pritchard. And . . . uh . . . well, Moretti says he didn’t pull the trigger. His alibi is that he was talking to some bloke on the phone when it happened. And he had no idea, your honour, that the gentleman with him was carrying a firearm.”

“Where’s the body?”

“Well, that’s the point. How would he know, if he wasn’t involved?”

Thomas opened the car door, reluctant to keep Miranda and her family waiting any longer. “Ring Heick back — have him ask more forcefully. Lock up when you’re done.” He tossed Karl the key.

The family were seated around a burning brazier, on crates, an office chair and an old deckchair.

“Everything go to plan?” Miranda cupped her hands for her key.

He opened his empty hands and gestured back towards the car. “Why wouldn’t it?” Now did not feel like the time to play top dog.

“I dunno.” Miranda’s eyes flickered with the flames. “I wasn’t sure if you’d snuck a piece of scaffolding in the boot.”

The whole family erupted into laughter and Thomas stood there and accepted it like a man.

Diane took pity on him. “There’s tea in the pot, love. You look like you could do with a cuppa.”

He helped himself. Miranda made space on a milk crate and he sat close, his thigh pressing against hers.

“Look, I just wanna say, I appreciate everything you all did — especially you, Terry.”

“And what about this Italian geezer?” John kept his mug close and stared into the fire.

That was a tough one to answer. Jack Langton’s welcoming committee hadn’t finished the job before Heick’s people got hold of Moretti, so what *did* happen next? Heick wasn’t the police. True, he had passed on the

information about Theo Pritchard, but he was hardly going to turn Moretti over to the boys and girls in blue.

He chewed it over. How to point Edwards towards Moretti? Maybe Karl could provide some proof — a photo of Pritchard as a starting point, only with no one else in the frame. He smiled. Had it come to that now — fabricating evidence?

Miranda nudged him and he looked up to see Karl standing there.

“When we get back to Dagenham I’ll leave you good people to it. I have a car on the way there to collect me — special delivery.”

“You stopping at mine then?” Miranda pushed her thigh against his.

Thomas gave her a sideways glance. It was the perfect end to a far from perfect day.

Chapter 24

It was late when they reached Miranda's flat, but Bow was still lively. She let him open the door and then squeezed past, slinking her way to the end of the hall and easing out of her boots.

"Remember to bolt the door."

He smiled. Like he'd ever forgotten. But tonight, spooked by their adventures at the breaker's yard, he stuck his head back out and glanced in both directions. The coast was clear, unlike his conscience. He closed the door, double-locked it and then bolted it. The monsters would have to try harder tonight.

Miranda stood in the middle of the room, eyes closed, arms by her side. He dropped his coat to the floor and took his place before her, pulling her towards him, tight against his groin.

"Why, Mr Bladen," she mocked, "I do believe something's come between us."

He stood his ground and held the moment, tasting her skin, breathing in her scent like cool oxygen, and only easing back a little when he felt her fingers exploring his torso and feeling for buttons. Maybe they both needed a release of tension, or maybe their hormones were in synch, but they made it to the bed with few clothes left. No words, no deeper meaning, no justifications.

"What?" she looked down at him, and he gazed up, smiling, watching the light and shadow in her bedroom play across her breasts.

"We should definitely do this more often." He raised his head and licked the sweat from her.

"Well, we could," she slid herself free, despite his protests, and laid alongside him. "If you weren't always *on call*."

He didn't react. It was a statement of fact. But that didn't mean he had to like it.

"One sugar, thanks." She leaned over and sucked at his nipple with a *pop*, and then headed off to the bathroom, pausing at the doorway to turn and check he was still watching her. And who was he to disappoint a lady?

"Tea!" she insisted, laughing as she disappeared across the carpet.

She came to find him in the kitchen and he stared at her, open-mouthed. She surely was a fine piece of woman.

“You’re drooling.” She looked him up and down, smirking at his embarrassment.

Her body was cold to the touch so he did his best to warm them both up again. Then they sat there, enjoying tea, like a latter-day Adam and Eve. He didn’t bother looking at the time. It was probably late. He didn’t care. Sure, Heck and Moretti and all the other bastards would soon occupy his thoughts but right now, this minute, every one of them could just stay where they were. All it took was the right naked woman and a decent cuppa.

* * *

He woke to the sound of his work phone buzzing and tried not to respond. He lasted a full thirty seconds.

“Yeah.” He tried to ignore Miranda playing peek-a-boo with a sheet, even though he was fighting a losing battle.

“Morning to yer, Tommo. I’ve been thinking. We ought to speak to Edwards today, now that I have a printed image of Theo Pritchard we can use. But first we ought to check out the location of the body.”

Heck must have come up with the goods then. “Ah . . . okay. What time can you pick me up?”

“I’m already parked, not far away.”

Thomas pressed a hand over the phone. “Karl’s here,” he whispered.

“Well, invite him up then. I wouldn’t want to keep you two apart.”

“Miranda says . . .”

“I heard, Tommo. I’ll, er, give you a few minutes to get yourself organised.”

Call ended, his first words were, “Are you gonna put some clothes on then?”

Miranda didn’t complain, and somehow that was worse.

Karl gave them a full fifteen minutes before making two tentative rings on the bell. Miranda, now in jeans and a sweatshirt, stared at Thomas and blinked a couple of times. He took the hint and got the door.

Chapter 25

Thomas didn't ask where they were going. It was enough to know why. Karl seemed so absorbed that Thomas left it several minutes before he spoke, instead turning his eye into a camera lens. Teenagers clustered around a bus stop while one of them tried to light a cigarette; an old woman slumped in a doorway, semi-conscious, an arm draped limply over a clutch of carrier bags; a child exploding with laughter as she pointed at a threadbare cat on a windowsill. A succession of scenes, everyone a split-second slice-of-life shot, begging to be captured on black and white celluloid by a latter-day Garry Winogrand. He wondered momentarily if Karl's encyclopaedic knowledge extended to photographers and decided it was a pub conversation.

"So, what will happen to Moretti?"

The car slowed. "That depends on how useful he is to Heick. What were you expecting?"

Thomas felt the weight of that look again. The one that made him feel like a complete amateur in Karl's world of counter-intelligence and expedience. It was a good question though and he took his time thinking it through, concluding that his idea of justice and Heick's were poles apart.

"I'd expect Moretti to be removed from the equation." He listened to himself and it sounded unyielding and callous, but he meant every word.

Karl nodded. No objections there. "I know you'd have preferred to leave him to Jack Langton's tender mercies. It's more complicated than that, though."

Thomas smiled. Karl ought to have that printed on a card. He understood the subtext all too well, hard won over the three years they'd worked together. An intelligence war, fought with information and influence. Right and wrong, ally and enemy — a fluid demarcation line, depending upon that elusive objective: the greater good.

"Here's how I think we should do this, Tommo. Scope the area, get confirmation of Moretti's inadmissible admission, and then let someone else discover the body."

* * *

The burned out shell of a caravan marked the transition from heathland to wasteland. Thomas gave up counting abandoned tyres at eleven, while Karl drove on down the track where fractured tarmac had given way to bare ground and a few half-arsed attempts at filling in the potholes with ballast. Karl kept the car in low gear. Thomas figured he was either trying to save his suspension or searching for something specific. Or both.

“There.” Karl tapped the brakes and the car stopped in a flurry of dust.

To the right of the track a stack of wooden pallets had been topped with an old mattress. If Thomas had to guess, he’d say children had built it as a landing point from the grassy bank. It looked like a modern art installation: deconstructed futon.

Karl hadn’t moved. “Yer man could be over there somewhere. Put some gloves on.” He pointed below the dashboard.

“Could be?” Thomas covered his hands in blue latex and lifted the binoculars from their case on the back seat.

“Moretti didn’t know for sure. And believe me, Jack Langton asked!”

Karl’s laughter got under Thomas’s skin, but his Belfast buddy had said something interesting.

“How’s that?”

Karl rubbed his forehead. “From what I *gather*, Heick let Langton and his people have a minute or two with Moretti before intervening. It got him talking and it gave us Theo Pritchard’s name and this location. It also meant Langton managed to warn Moretti off any further action where Caliban’s is concerned, even if he did realign Moretti’s shoulder in the process.”

Thomas waited for the sucker punch.

“And of course,” Karl sighed, “Heick and his people came in looking like rescuers, so naturally Moretti would be a bit more obliging, at least in the early stages.”

Karl stopped talking once Thomas opened the passenger door. Thomas had heard enough. He closed the door quietly and went around the front of the car, across the track, carefully picking his way between the broken glass and the dogshit in a wide arc from the pallets. If this was a crime scene he wanted to keep as far away as possible. He suddenly remembered a song played at primary school — *An English Country Garden* — but his smirk didn’t last when he thought about what he was doing there. Theo Pritchard had been no harm to anyone, and this was no fit resting place for him.

Conscious that Karl was watching, Thomas took a run-up to climb the earth bank. Below him, on the other side, trees, bushes and discarded electrical goods formed a dense and foreboding thicket. He scanned the terrain, what he could see of it, and sidled along the bank, scuffing the ground to obliterate his shoe prints.

He worked methodically, sweeping the lenses at a measured speed and then returning to the starting point to lower the angle, shoulders rigid. Karl's car horn jarred him and made him start a line again, but he didn't falter. He owed Pritchard that much at least.

From his vantage point there was little to see. No corpse as such, not even a limb on show. But the broken foliage he'd picked out drew his gaze downward and after some retuning he saw what appeared to be rubber sheeting or tarpaulin. He moved position to view it from a different angle, confirming it as the underside of a carpet. Judging by the depth and distance from the bank, two people must have swung it to launch it that far in — there was no way to have carried it without causing some disturbance. His gut instinct told him there was a body down there. He raised a hand and turned to Karl, and then made his way back to the car.

"We'd better tell Edwards to bring out a dog unit as well."

* * *

The hour and a half wait passed slowly, interrupted only by a couple in an estate car who opened the rear door to eject a small refrigerator before nonchalantly closing up again and driving off. Karl paid them no attention, but managed a couple of photographs of a passing buzzard. Mostly, the radio filled in time. DS Edwards arrived with flashing blue lights and a police van behind her.

Thomas and Karl stayed put while she got out and spoke to the copper in the van.

Karl watched the scene through his wing mirror. "That is one angry looking dog."

Edwards sent the one man and his dog out towards the pallets and then came over.

"Mind if I join you, gentlemen?"

Thomas stretched to unlock the back door. Edwards got in and pulled hard, sealing out the unfolding drama.

“I can’t help thinking you’re giving me a trail to follow, piece by piece. Am I right?”

“Hang on a minute.” Karl sounded genuinely aggrieved. “We’ve acted in good faith, passing on information received.”

“Yeah, but from where? Look at it from my position, boys. I’m the one who has to explain this to my DI.”

Thomas saw Karl reach for Theo Pritchard’s photo, hidden in an envelope on the inside of the driver’s door. His arm was halfway across when the dog started barking, out of sight.

Edwards stirred. “Come on. You can do the preliminaries until the forensic team gets here.” She pulled out her phone, still walking, and made the call.

Thomas waited for Karl to emerge and they followed in Edwards’s wake together.

“This place was a bona fide dump, and then it became a travellers’ camp.” Karl started taking pictures of the pallet tower. “So the council built up the embankment to stop it happening again.”

Thomas looked to the distance. That explained the massive boulders dotted about, as if some glacial disaster had befallen High Wycombe. Edwards called from the top of the embankment — the dog was kicking off again. Thomas was first up and stood beside Edwards, getting his breath.

“I’m not stupid, Thomas. Even if I don’t know what the *fook* is going on. You take whatever footage you need to and remember that I didn’t stand in your way.”

He descended into the undergrowth, hearing Karl behind him. As they neared the canine commotion the copper with the dog thrust his arm out to stop them in their tracks.

“Give us a sec — he gets a bit lairy sometimes. It’s all the excitement.”

Thomas nodded. Ajit had told him similar tales of the North Yorkshire public, and one or two coppers, coming a cropper when police dogs were brought in at close quarters.

The copper dragged his dog aside, still up on its back legs and straining to get at the rolled up carpet. Thomas could see the outer edge of the pattern now, red and brown like blood. He heard Karl’s camera bleeping and got involved, moving around to photograph the site from the other side. A lazy

swarm of flies hovered around him, drunk on the stench of death. He did his best to ignore them, until one landed on his face.

“I can’t see anything useful here, Karl — you?”

“Hmm, probably not. No ground disturbance so they must have hoiked the body from the embankment.”

“Which means two people.” Thomas tried out his theory for comment.

“One could have been the driver of the 4x4 they tried to palm off on Terry and Sam. Right, I’m done. Shall we get out of here, Tommo?”

“Yeah. One thing. Why such an amateur job, you know, if Mr M is . . . ?”

Karl cut him off. “Let’s talk about this in the car.”

Edwards passed them on their way back up over the embankment. She went down into the jungle and had a few words with the dog handler. Thomas waited for her. She didn’t stay long.

“Would you two like a peppermint? That bloody smell gets right in my gullet.”

Karl received Thomas’s camera and traded it for the brown envelope. Thomas lifted the seal and Pritchard’s photo stared back at him across time, and death. Poor bastard.

“This should help you confirm the victim’s identity. We believe he’s called Theo Pritchard.”

She looked at it for a few seconds and then passed it back. “You keep it, and be sure to include it in the evidence you’re *supposed* to be analysing at the station. I’ll see you both there.”

Karl blew out a breath, as if to say ‘now that’s gratitude for you.’

Chapter 26

Thomas kept his mouth shut until Karl had driven to the end of the track.

“Explain it to me then. Why does this Europe-wide Shadow State employ such total amateurs?”

Karl crunched up a gear. “It doesn’t. Everything’s well-ordered in the upper echelons of power — probably no different from your average corporation or government. Lower down the food chain it’s a different story — as brutal as any battlefield.”

Thomas turned that around in his head. “Then how do people *progress*?” He pulled out a notepad.

“Same as in our business. Someone spots your potential and they approach you. Or else you claw your way into a position of power until you can’t be ignored. I suppose there are other ways . . .”

Thomas grinned back. Like him, Karl meant, who happened to get in a lift one day with a camera, when Sir Peter Carroll was in the building.

“I wish you’d told me all this three years ago!”

“Why, would you have believed me? Nah, you’d have had me pegged as a conspiracy nut job. You had to see it for yourself, same as I did.”

Thomas snorted. “The Zen of Counter-Intelligence?”

“Maybe, something like that. Now, when we get to the police station just busy yourself for a good ten minutes. Go play with the truncheons or something.”

* * *

Thomas grabbed a coffee, found a table in the corner of the police canteen and scratched at his notebook. Time to kill meant time to think. He drew overlapping circles, adding initials to the middle segments. AM — Arlo Moretti; JL — Jack Langton; and SH — Stephen Heick. Different names but the process remained the same. Mentally revisit the connections to get a more complete picture. Running through the names sometimes prompted other ideas and associations. He thought about Mrs Leibowicz, whose stolen vehicle and abducted child had been the catalyst. An unbroken blood-red line ran from her to a body in the undergrowth, and another in the back of a 4x4. All the more strange that Karl hadn’t focused on how central

she seemed to be to their activities. He stopped doodling. Unless Karl's people were protecting her from the fallout?

He wrote down *chemist* and added a question mark. Hadn't she said something about a loan from Moretti that they couldn't refuse? He slapped the notebook shut at the sound of voices. A bunch of uniforms entered the canteen, stared over at him and then picked the table furthest away. They looked and sounded like they'd left Hendon Police College the previous week. He finished his coffee and checked his watch. He felt old.

Karl didn't acknowledge him straight away, he was busy staring at a blank screen with a phone in one hand.

"Hi. I'm waiting for IT."

Thomas sniffed the air and caught the metallic tang in his nostrils. He thought about switching on his monitor and decided to listen to Karl instead. Reading between the lines, there'd been some sort of computer meltdown. Thomas had a hunch that the bad luck fairy might have a Celtic accent.

Karl appeared to concentrate as he repeated a few key phrases and pretended to write something down. Thomas knew a good performance when he saw one. He had done that in the past as well, pacing replies for authenticity.

"Yes, something electrical. Okay, I'll try that. No, I'll speak with Detective Sergeant Edwards when she gets back. I understand. Luckily I saved some of the information. No, I agree, it should have been uploaded to the HOLMES2 system . . . I'm still waiting for my access. No . . . yep . . . Surveillance Support Unit. Uh huh. That's why we were organising all the data first." He waited a long time after that and then calmly replaced the receiver.

"Problem?"

Karl tilted his head side to side. "That depends on how you look at it. We'll need to recreate some lost data — wait a sec," he countered Thomas's accusation of *prat*. "Luckily I saved everything to a memory stick."

Thomas soon conceded the genius of Karl's plan. The data would have to be input retrospectively, making it much easier to slip in a surveillance photograph of Theo Pritchard, as well as some location shots where the body was found and any other breadcrumbs Karl wanted to scatter.

“We’ll need to use your computer, Tommo. Mine’s a tad frazzled. And remember to create a Nominal Record for Arlo Moretti. I don’t give a shit what DI Ferguson says, Moretti’s name came up in the investigation . . . *somewhere*,” he shielded his eyes and pretended to scour the room. “It would be a dereliction of duty if I started filtering information.”

“Perish the thought.” Thomas booted up his own machine, which had miraculously escaped the Karl McNeill electrical virus.

* * *

DS Edwards was all smiles when Thomas and Karl saw her next. The discovery of a body and its identification, thanks to a timely and anonymous text from Karl even had DI Ferguson in a good mood, apparently. Drinks all round, he’d promised Edwards, which even extended to her temps.

Thomas set the agenda. “We’ll stay for the one drink and then piss off.”

Karl nodded, saving the file and then closing the computer down with a flourish. “Done.”

Edwards and Ferguson were already down at the front desk. A gaggle of unknowns loitered with them. This would be the wider team, who’d gone out of their way to have nothing to do with the visitors. Thomas had become used to it by now. Floaters, temps, cheap labour — he’d heard them all. Out of the mouths of babes and sucklings, as his mum used to say. He smiled at their feeble banter. Yeah, and idiots.

The Dickens Tavern already heaved with drinkers, and most of them had suspiciously short hair. Thomas had never been to a coppers’ pub. Unlike the military pub that Karl liked to frequent, with its proud collection of regimental insignia, this place was wall-to-wall anonymity. Ferguson’s party gravitated to the bar, jostling with another team on the way.

“My shout for the first round.” Ferguson held a folded fifty in the air like he was wielding Excalibur.

Edwards was the real star of the show, handling praise and questions from her colleagues with a deftness that impressed Thomas. She made a point of raising her G&T in their direction, which felt like high praise indeed.

“Are you and Heick on speaking terms now?” Thomas leaned in to try and counter the din.

“You know me, Tommy Boy. Whatever gets the job done.”

Thomas noted the hollow tone and chose not to pick him up on it. “Can you do me a favour?” He didn’t wait for an answer. “Find out more about Moretti. I need to know whether to install sprinklers at home.” He laughed silently, as if trying to convince himself.

Karl shook his head. “No need. I can promise you that Moretti will have been warned off any more interest in you, Miranda or her family.”

As answers went, it only generated more questions. They stayed the obligatory twenty minutes, nudged their way to the bar and then said their goodbyes. Edwards oozed gratitude. It was painful to watch.

“Ta-ra, lads. I’ll see you boys tomorrow.”

Cue a round of catcalls and an insinuation of a three-way from the rest of the gang. Thomas had half a mind to get their number plates and ring them in to traffic. He couldn’t help wondering, as they left the Dickens behind them, if this was the best of times or the worst of times.

Karl insisted he would have driven Thomas home, only he had other matters to attend to. Thomas knew not to push the point and settled for a drop-off along Euston Road. Karl didn’t ask either.

Chapter 27

Thomas found a phone shop still open, not far from Euston Station. The girl at the counter, fresh out of charm school, gave him her full attention after thirty more seconds of chewing gum. Judging by her bored expression as she moved to the cheap end of the counter, she'd sized him up as a technophobe. It was almost worth the hit on his credit card to see the look on her face when he asked for a Sharp mobile because of its 1.1 megapixel resolution camera. After all, this was 2004. And besides, Karl's expenses budget could take the pain.

His first text was to Karl: *New phone no. Thomas. Kosovo Girls Brigade*. Karl would recognise the sign-off as proof of identity, from the early days of their off-the-books partnership. Karl was the elephant of counter-intelligence.

He used the journey to Walthamstow, once a train bothered to turn up, to program in his clutch of numbers. Miranda and her family took the four top spots, followed by Karl, Ajit and Geena, and then two for the family in Yorkshire. Finally, out of sheer bloody-mindedness, he added in Christine Gerard's number — good bosses were hard to find. A shame he didn't have Heick's number now and vice versa, but Karl could fix that and probably would. He started thinking about how many times he'd changed his phone number in the past three years and gave up at five.

A brisk walk through Walthamstow cleared his head. Life's tapestry wove and unravelled around him — lovers rowing in the middle of the street, *boys* who confused their cars with mobile discos, and those people who really interested him, the ones whose faces held secrets. He crossed the street and looked over to see a woman in the burger bar window, pensive as she waited and watched behind the glass. He itched to take a picture of her with his new phone but she'd have reacted to him and shattered the moment. Karl was right, surveillance became a way of life.

Crossing Forest Road, and with no sign of a forest for miles, he took Winns Terrace to skirt the edge of Lloyd Park. A front door opened ahead of him and he counted the seconds until a large black Labrador came bounding to the gate with its owner in tow. Thomas nodded to the pair,

missing the half-hearted pleasantries by several feet. Like the song said, there was no place like home.

His nose twitched as he went indoors, recalling the smoke and the charred skirting board. He switched the lights on and went from room to room, checking the plug sockets again. He reached the kitchen last and unlocked the back door. A tin of paint sat outside, sporting a stick-on bow. Nice one, Karl.

No point ringing his oppo now if he was out on manoeuvres. He dropped his keys in the wooden dish so he knew where to find them and tapped the answering machine — one message.

“Hello, Thomas. It’s Sir Peter. If you get this message before ten o’clock, please call me. Here’s my number . . .”

Even though it felt like the old man had invaded his private space, he was intrigued — and amused too at the notion of someone so insecure that they needed to refer to their own title. He wrote the number down carefully and then added it to his phone. Flicking back through the pad, as he’d hoped, he picked up Heick’s number — and Sheryl’s. Quite a collection now. The clock read eight, no matter how hard he stared at it. Well then, what did he have to lose?

“Ah, Thomas! I’m glad you called. I wonder if you’d care to join me this evening at the Victory Club? I can send a car for you.”

He thought about replying, *What, like last time?* but didn’t.

“Shall we say forty-five minutes? And Thomas, shirt and tie if you please.”

The cheeky bastard.

Half an hour later, having ironed two shirts and hung one up in the wardrobe, he put on the shirt and tie Diane Wright had given him last Christmas and waited by the window. How many times, he wondered as he stared at the street, had Miranda stormed out that door or been there waiting for him?

A woman walked past with a kid firmly clasped by the hand. Funny time for a stroll. He recognised her as a neighbour, a few doors up, but no names. Hers was the face at the curtain when he’d dared to park in her spot. Ah, Southern friendliness. So different to Yorkshire. Somehow, the bigger the town the more small-minded the inhabitants.

The car arrived early, pulled up in the street and left the engine running. He clocked it through the curtain and smiled. Sir Peter had sent the Daimler, along with his personal driver. Thomas grabbed his wallet, keys and new phone off the table, having finally decided to forgo wearing a wire. Then he locked up with all the diligence of a burglary victim and went out to the car.

Sir Peter's driver, Phillip, acknowledged him with a nod and did Thomas the courtesy of not opening the door. Thomas got in the front beside him. He took a breath, loosened his tie, and eased back into the leather seat, running a hand along the wooden panelling. How the other half lived.

"It's been a while since Southampton."

Thomas stirred, surprised that the chauffeur remembered. It had been a dash down to the SSU's hub on the south coast, also at the behest of the old man, so he could spar once more with Bob Peterson. He suddenly wondered if Peterson would make an appearance at the club. It could make for a very interesting cabaret.

"Any clues why I'm here?"

"I do the driving, that's all. Now, would you prefer the direct route or the scenic route?"

When it came to London and history, Phillip really knew his stuff: Romans, Normans, churches and bridges. Thomas tried his luck when his tour guide was in full flow.

"Have you ever driven to the ASI building at Bank?"

He wasn't expecting a proper answer — nothing verbal, anyway. The running commentary died like a bad stand-up routine and it took Phillip a moment to recover. When he spoke again his tone had changed, as though he had mentally reclaimed his chauffeur's uniform.

"I'll take Tower Bridge. It's particularly beautiful in the evenings. Opened in 1894."

Thomas had his answer. And why would Sir Peter need to visit ASI? To see Stephen Heick, of course.

A mile or so beyond the southern end of the bridge, the Daimler snaked through the backstreets and slowed behind a Bentley and a Jaguar. When it came to their turn the drivers each got out and opened the passenger door like a liveried servant.

"Listen, about earlier . . . sometimes I speak without thinking."

Phillip indicated to the kerb. “I doubt either of us believes that for a second. The thing is, *Thomas*,” it sounded like a compliment, “we’ve each got our job to do.”

Thomas counted seven black and white tiled steps as his shoes slapped against them. The inner double doors were inlaid with glass and the brass push plates gleamed. He eased one door inwards and immediately inhaled cigar smoke. A white-gloved concierge glided towards him before he'd taken a fourth step.

His name and identity confirmed — the old-fashioned way — Thomas was accompanied through another door. The inner sanctum put him in mind of the stately homes his mother insisted on taking him to as a child — plush carpets and oak panelling as far as the eye could see. They navigated a path between high-backed leather chairs grouped around tables, arriving in a corner of the room with two chairs — one of them empty.

The concierge presented Thomas by name, as though he were a raffle prize. Sir Peter emerged from the leather, impersonated a benevolent smile and invited him to sit down.

“Have you eaten? I’ll ask the staff to bring you something.”

The *staff* waited patiently. Thomas considered asking for a club sandwich, just to be difficult, and settled for steak and a tonic water. He figured it was all going on someone else’s bill. Sir Peter requested a cigar and another single malt.

Thomas admired the Victorian lighting. “Nice place.” He knew he was expected to ask why he’d been summoned, but why give the old man the satisfaction?

Sir Peter lifted the remnants of his scotch, and it glowed amber. “We had an arrangement. I gave you Signor Moretti,” he let out a heavy breath, “and in return — in a manner of speaking — you’re going to give me Stephen Heick.” He sipped slowly.

The concierge entered the room from another door, catching Thomas’s attention. He waited until the tonic water rested in his hand and the embroidered napkin lay on the table. This seemed too easy, slow-feeding the old man information that Heick wanted him to have anyway.

“Heick got to Moretti and still has him, last I heard.”

Can a man look pleased even when he isn’t smiling? Sir Peter glowed like his scotch. Thomas nodded, the enemy of my enemy, and all that.

“Secondly, Heick is involved with . . .”

Sir Peter raised a chastening finger and Thomas held his tongue.

He received his steak sandwich and took a bite, wiping his lip with the napkin. Victory indeed. He chewed thoughtfully, watching as the concierge detoured to another table where someone else had made eye contact.

“Go on,” Sir Peter commanded quietly, tilting forward a little.

“Henriette Voclain.”

“Impossible!” Sir Peter scoffed.

“Then I’ll have to get you some evidence.”

Sir Peter reached into his blazer pocket and then placed a plastic card on the lacquered table.

“For any sundry expenses.”

Thomas smiled. He’d seen that trick before: a traceable bank card.

“I don’t think so. Remember the last time?”

Sir Peter tilted his glass. “So it was you who copied the bank card for Ken Treavey before he disappeared?”

Thomas played inscrutable and stuck to smiling on the inside.

“I congratulate your resourcefulness. Let me reassure you, Thomas, I have no interest in monitoring your activities — quite the opposite, in fact. I want a clean pair of hands.” Sir Peter downed his second glass in one sitting. “Excellent. You say Heick has a personal connection to Henriette Voclain — show me proof. Something I can use against him. Do that for me and I will not forget it. Now, if you’ll excuse me.” He stood up and toyed with a gleaming cufflink. “Enjoy your sandwich. Phillip will be outside when you’re finished.”

Thomas watched him leave through the main doors and shifted his seat round a little to take in the room. He sat back and enjoyed his sandwich, along with the stares from his fellow guests, and fantasised about putting his feet on the table. He watched them watching him, in a mutual exchange of contempt, and pocketed the bank card.

Chapter 28

Lying awake at six-thirty Thomas reflected on his meeting at the Victory, which he now knew — from the brass plate by the door — was the name of a single room. He replayed salient moments in his head: Sir Peter pausing to speak to someone on his way out, the clatter of his knife against the plate and the hushed disapproval as he stood up and collided with the table. As he'd left to collect his Daimler and driver he came face to face with one of Sir Peter's confidantes as she emerged from her chair — Eva Fairweather, a former Home Office minister he'd crossed paths with before. Her sour expression left him in no doubt that she was the unforgiving kind. As Karl might have put it: *unfinished business and another story for another day*. He'd turned to close the double doors behind him and peered back through the antique glass. A final glimpse at the unwholesome combination of the wealthy and powerful with the young and available.

Still in bed, he rang Karl to check he'd received the text from the new number. Karl sounded like a bear clinging to its cave.

"Huh — that you, Tommo?"

"Another late night? Shall I pick you up for work?"

"Aye, that'd be grand. See you around eight. G'night till then."

It seemed only fair to make Heick his next call — shame he had to leave a message.

* * *

Karl flopped into the car and rubbed his eyes, as if he couldn't quite believe it was daylight. Thomas got in first with a summary of his evening. Karl listened and yawned, quite the multitasker.

"So our Great Leader thinks you're pissed off with Heick."

Thomas chewed an imaginary wasp. *Thinks?* Too right. Heick had manipulated him from day one.

"You're the expert, Karl, what would be enough to expose Heick and finish his career?" He'd swear in a court of law that a light shone from Karl's eyes.

"Well, the tried and tested routes are something compromising in the bedroom, accepting money, drug-taking, or that perennial favourite —

being seen with the wrong people. A.k.a. guilt by association.”

Thomas squeezed the car past a bus. “Why can’t we use the truth? Show Heick and Henriette together?”

Karl made a face. “I don’t think lunch with my new stepmother is going to rock the Shadow State to its core or see Heick and his lady sent into exile. Still, capturing an intimate dinner might be enough to convince Sir Peter.”

Karl gave up and went to sleep, leaving Thomas to his thoughts. It was obvious, really, all he had to do was ask Heick for his schedule and surprise him. He glanced at the time. Jesus. Nearly half an hour to travel a couple of miles, and all so that Karl could have an extra nap before work.

Thomas zeroed in on a parking space and spotted DS Edwards. He tooted his horn and woke Karl from the dead. Edwards caught up and waited patiently as Thomas parallel parked with infinite — and according to Karl, anally retentive — care.

“Good weekend, Karen?”

“Not so’s you’d notice. The body has been IDed as Theo Pritchard. His granddaughter is coming down to see me later today. She’d reported him missing when he hadn’t been in touch after forty-eight hours. Needless to say, apart from logging it on the system, my colleagues at Enfield hadn’t looked into it.”

Thomas could see it bothered her, which impressed him. They all went in together and straight up to the canteen, where he bought her a coffee. While they were sitting at the table, with Karl hunched over his caffeine kick-starter, Thomas made a proposal.

“Listen, Karen, when you speak to the granddaughter it wouldn’t hurt to tell her a white lie — that Theo had helped provide information about the vehicles, once he realised the business was bent. It’s kinder, don’t you think, than letting her find out he was knowingly working for a crime syndicate?”

She snapped to attention. “Why do you call it that?”

“Seems to me that stealing high-end cars and shipping them off requires planning and finance. I’d call that a syndicate, wouldn’t you?”

Karen returned to her coffee. “Maybe. Just don’t let my DI hear you talk like that. He’s still pissed off about the possibility of a connection with Arlo Moretti. Mr Moretti is a successful businessman and a philanthropic

pillar of the community, apparently. Anyway, I'd better go and face the flak again. If you're both very good I'll pop in at lunchtime."

Karl perked up by the time they reached the information room. Thomas set up the software and divided the stack of DVDs. At a rough guess it would take several hours to get through the Automatic Number Plate Recognition recordings to try and isolate driver images from the stolen vehicles.

* * *

"You know what, Tommo?"

Thomas clicked the pause button and looked over expectantly.

"You did a good thing this morning, restoring the reputation of Theo Pritchard."

"Yeah, well, it doesn't hurt anyone . . ." He let the sentence go before he reached the part about still feeling responsible for Theo's execution. "Do you think I should ring Heick and set up another meeting?"

"Makes sense." Karl arched his shoulder blades over the back of his chair. "Try and see him soon though because Henriette's coming to town."

Thomas opened his hands, inviting Karl to share. For some reason Thomas couldn't fathom, Karl wasn't happy about it.

"Data, Tommo. It all comes down to data. We're looking for drivers — that's data. Henriette Voclair books a flight to the UK in her own name — more data. It used to be that the trick was getting information. Now it's about sifting a sea of information for gold and then making something of it."

While they were taking a quick break Thomas texted Heick, asking for another meeting. When he was done, he did some more sifting.

"Why do you really think DI Ferguson won't go near Moretti?"

Karl swivelled side to side in his chair. "You tell me, Tommy Boy."

"Moretti probably has friends in high places. Isn't that how the Shadow State works?"

Karl's face turned to granite. "I can see you're bemused by *the rules*, but never lose sight of what's at stake here. A shipment of stolen cars and a few kilos of cocaine are the tip of the iceberg. They're just revenue streams." He shifted position. "Think about all you've experienced these past three years — you've seen what goes on. Right at the top, these

faceless power brokers are after one thing: dominion over a new Europe. Charlemagne is an incredible opportunity to inflict some damage against the Shadow State.”

Thomas picked him up on a point “And you know their names?”

Karl laughed. “Me? Not exactly. I could hazard a good guess about some of them though.” He see-sawed his hand in the air. “However, believing something is not the same as proving it. Which brings this interlude neatly back to Mr Moretti.”

Thomas couldn’t tell if it was the three hours of screen time or the conversation, but his head was throbbing. “When are we lunching?”

Karl broke a chocolate bar in two and chucked half across. “May as well wait for Edwards. What’s your tally?”

Thomas killed the screensaver and checked his list. “Eleven images of varied quality — three of the poor bastard who took the baby and other, unknown faces. Incidentally, what happens when the vehicles are moved on?”

“Not our problem. Well, not unless Christine Gerard says so.”

DS Edwards arrived at twelve-thirty, which was fortunate as Karl was awake again by then. She’d brought fresh coffees and sandwiches in cellophane.

“The DI allowed me to canonise Theo Pritchard when I saw his granddaughter. Ferguson told me afterwards that the information Pritchard gave us matched the data you recently added to HOLMES2, so full marks for that. Theo didn’t have any previous record. He seems to have lived a blameless life, apart from a misunderstanding with a Slovakian traveller — a mix up with their cases — a few months back. Poor sod. All it takes is one bad choice, eh? So, what’s the progress, chaps?”

Thomas reeled off the numbers, pausing to catch Karl’s eye. He’d heard it too — Slovakia, where Barbara Leibowicz’s husband had been during her car theft. Edwards repeated her thanks and left them to it.

“We got it wrong.” Karl stopped talking to answer his phone.

Thomas’s phone joined it in a duet and they each moved to a separate corner of the room.

“It’s Stephen Heick. Come up to my office after work. I’ll wait.”

Chapter 29

Karl had remained tight-lipped about his phone call. Only now, as he dropped Thomas outside the ASI building, did he venture an opinion. “I’m starting to wonder if this whole car ring is bollocks.”

Thomas would have engaged with Karl’s insightful commentary, only he didn’t want to keep Heick waiting.

“I’ll see you back at Liverpool Street.”

“Seriously? In the office?”

“Yeah, why not. I’m sure Christine will be pleased to see us.”

“I’ll try to match your parking skills.”

* * *

Heick was waiting in the lobby. Thomas figured someone had phoned up as soon as he stepped out of the car. Heick kept to a handful of words until they reached his office.

“I had to release Moretti — it wasn’t my decision.”

Thomas mentally ran through the implications. Moretti knew where Caliban’s was and where Thomas lived. He breathed rhythmically, forcing his lungs to obey him and not the hammering in his chest. It was a short fight.

“Where is he?”

“Gone to ground.” Heick raised his hands, arms outstretched. “I’ve contained him, made him aware of the consequences if he bothers you again.”

“*Bothers?*” Thomas felt the red mist descending. “He shot up my girlfriend’s pub and tried to burn me out.” He could see Heick wasn’t going to budge so he pulled out a notepad. “All right, let’s get down to business.”

Heick’s jaw slackened in relief. For about five seconds.

“ . . . Because the terms of our agreement have changed a little.”

Half an hour later, Thomas had more information and less understanding. He took a detour along Threadneedle Street to walk it off, past the Bank of England and three hundred years of history and privilege. He lingered there, oblivious to the rain that spattered the pavements and the commuters who scurried for cover, as disparate ideas fell into place.

1) Henriette Voclain was coming to London in a few days. Heick had always known this, which explained his strong-arm tactics. Ergo, Heick must have planned an escape route too.

2) Heick hadn't given a shit about Moretti before, so either Moretti cut a deal with him, or had since proved to be useful in some other way. This was not good news.

3) He and Karl needed a plan, and fast.

4) And this was the biggest migraine candidate. The Leibowiczs, Moretti and the late Theo Pritchard all linked back to Slovakia — why? Scratch that, it didn't matter. Something for Karl to chew over. He was asking the wrong question. What mattered wasn't why the Leibowiczs wanted to use Shadow State money, but why they couldn't have got it anywhere else. Pharmaceuticals. One word that meant a lot of different things.

* * *

Thomas wasn't surprised to find Karl, Christine and Ann together around a table in the office. He waited for Karl to say his piece in public, so he knew what was up for general discussion. Moretti was on everybody's radar now. And there was more. The Leibowiczs had gone missing.

Christine shook her head. "You should have come to me earlier with this, Karl. We're on the same side, remember?"

"I wasn't aware that Arlo Moretti was anything more than a small cog in the machine."

Thomas's eyes widened. This was a rare admission.

"Of course you weren't," Christine acknowledged. "And that's why we need to work as a team and pool our resources."

Thomas waited to see if Karl planned on pooling the Heick situation. It didn't happen. Or perhaps they'd agreed not to discuss it in front of him. He'd barely sat down when his shiny new phone started ringing. He took it as read that no one would object. After all, they worked as a team, didn't they?

"It's me." Miranda struggled for breath. "You better get over here. Jack Langton's been shot."

Chapter 30

Thomas drove and Karl did his thinking aloud.

“We have to assume Moretti’s responsible, or . . .”

Thomas waited it out.

“ . . . We have a much bigger problem on our hands.”

“Well, what’s worse than being shot by a known scumbag?”

Karl rubbed at his nose. “Being shot by an unknown scumbag. Chances are, Moretti wanted revenge for Jacko’s visit to his apartment.”

Thomas gripped the steering wheel. “Miranda and Caliban’s . . .”

“No, no,” Karl insisted. “Heick would have given him an ultimatum — you’ll all be on the protection list. If Heick has let Moretti go, you can be certain there’s a purposeful connection there now.”

The lights were off at Caliban’s — no neon welcome today. Karl hadn’t finished talking as they got out of the car and he stopped Thomas by the door.

“Listen, Tommo, Jack Langton is useful to my organisation.”

“You mean he’s providing intel about his international supply lines.”

“True, but it’s not just that. His house is bugged, as you well recall. We can’t afford to lose him or destabilise his business — not yet.”

Thomas pushed past him. So Jack Langton was a commodity himself now — another route into the Shadow State from the lower levels. No matter that he was a dealer and a thug, as long as he served his purpose. Thomas steeled himself for Karl to say the three words he despised: the greater good. Maybe Karl was more intuitive than he gave him credit for, this one time.

“Are we going in, Tommo, or what?”

Or what seemed to be the order of the day, as the doors were locked. Thomas gave a half-hearted wave to the camera at the side door, imagining Sheryl watching him. He counted the seconds until he heard footsteps on the other side of the door.

She didn’t speak and that surprised him. It was fast turning into a day of surprises. He couldn’t figure out if it was the shock news of the shooting

or misplaced loyalty for the secret dad who'd once used her home to package up some of his drugs for resale.

Even Miranda seemed subdued. She draped herself around him for a second before disengaging and pulling down the shutters.

"Mum and Dad want you to go over tonight — you too, Karl, if you're free. They think you ought to see Natalie, or at least talk to her. We can leave now."

He didn't bother taking his coat off. It didn't sound like it was up for discussion. At times like this it was hard to tell which parent she took after. Miranda grabbed her coat and bag from behind the bar.

"You coming to Mum and Dad's then?"

Thomas caught a glimmer of Karl's face and made his choice. "Nah, we'll see Natalie first. Meet you later."

"Suit yourself." She stayed out of kissing range as she passed him.

* * *

Back on the road and heading northeast from Bow to Forest Gate, bumper to bumper, felt like a punishment. A mere four and a half miles on the map meant sod all to the mass of commuters surging out of London with them.

"Thanks," was all Karl said for the first ten minutes.

It was no great surprise that Heick rang while they were stuck in traffic. In Thomas's experience bad luck was like buses — like the one in front that blocked the view, actually. Heick was succinct.

"ASI building. Eight-thirty. Tomorrow. Alone." Heick cut the call.

Karl lowered the window, as if to let the spectre of Heick drift free. "What a charmer. You can see why my ma fell for him."

Thomas changed tack. "Any tips for tomorrow?"

Karl leaned forward and rolled his shoulders. "Only one. Watch your back."

* * *

Thomas spotted one of Jack Langton's muscle from the raid on Moretti's apartment. The bloke looked like he'd take a few seconds to squeeze out of the car parked outside, but God help you when he did. They traded nods and the big guy lent to one side to whisper unsubtly into a

walkie-talkie. He must have received instructions because he gestured for Thomas to come over.

“Nat’s inside — and so are the police. You can go in.”

Karl arrived a few steps behind Thomas.

“Cops are here — family liaison I s’pose.”

Karl followed him up to the door. “Don’t be so sure.”

Thomas wasn’t in the mood to play twenty questions so he ignored him and rang the bell. Although he hadn’t expected Natalie Langton to answer it herself, he hadn’t expected to see one of Heick’s people on the other side either — the same woman who’d confiscated his ID card at Liverpool Street.

He could tell she was flummoxed, but she was also a pro and recovered in a handful of seconds. He counted them out and waited for her.

“You better come inside.” She drew the door back.

“Thomas Bladen,” he proffered a hand. “I’m a friend of Jack’s. And this is Karl — he’s a friend of mine.”

She didn’t take up the offer so they walked in.

“I’m Augustine,” she called after them as she closed the door.

Natalie was out in the conservatory. She flicked her eyes at him momentarily and then returned to staring at her feet. As he stood over her he could hear the children in a nearby room, and then an older voice trying to quieten them. A grandparent, probably.

“What happened, Natalie?” He figured he’d start big and then narrow it down, depending upon what she chose to tell him.

“You want a drink? I’m having one.”

She got up and walked back to the kitchen. The bottle was waiting on the counter. Thomas was surprised he hadn’t noticed it coming in. He had noticed other things though. *Augustine* appeared to be there on her tod, if you didn’t count Lurch out front in the car, and he reasoned that *he* was more for show and to keep the family onside. Where were the police then?

Natalie returned with a tall glass, parading it in front of her like a religious procession. He held his tongue until she’d sat down again and taken her medicine.

“Where’s Jack now?” It was an open question and the leading candidates were *hospital* and *morgue*.

Augustine cleared her throat. “Mr Langton is in a private facility — for his protection.”

“They won’t let me see him.” Natalie teetered on the edge of her drink and then dived in again.

“He’s receiving the best care available.” Augustine’s tone suggested they’d been over this a few times. “As soon as the doctors say he’s well enough . . .”

Thomas leaned across and touched Natalie’s hand with his fingertips. “What can I do to help, Nat?”

“Can *you* speak to them? I know you’ve helped us out once already . . .”

Augustine looked up sharply.

“ . . . But I don’t know who else I can turn to, what with Ray still missing.”

Thomas held his nerve and rode it out. Jack Langton’s second-in-command, Ray Daniels, was missing all right — missing a pulse. Not that Natalie would ever learn that. He could see Karl rolling his eyes. Another tale from the dark side that Thomas wouldn’t forget in a hurry.

“I’ll see what I can do. Leave it with me.”

Karl stood up. “Perhaps Augustine has a contact number?”

She had, but she didn’t look very happy about it. On the way out Karl stopped at the door and glanced up the stairs.

“They can come down now.” He tapped Augustine’s card against the doorframe and then left Thomas to follow in his wake.

Karl looked sullen in the car.

“Problem?” Thomas started the engine.

“Another one, you mean? I was just wondering how long it will take them to find the bugs we put in the house.”

Thomas headed towards Ilford, for a bit of variety, so he could pick up the North Circular Road and travel on to Dagenham. He glanced at the clock. Hopefully there’d be something to eat when they got there.

He checked the rear-view mirror again. “Anyway, Karl, why would Heick’s people want to sweep Jack Langton’s home for surveillance?”

Karl was a second behind him. “That’s easy, Tommo — same reason he’s in a private *facility*.” He made speech marks with his fingers, the same

way Christine Gerrard had done once and they'd never forgotten it.
“They’re protecting what is undoubtedly now one of their assets.”

“Hmm . . . I sense a custody battle.”

“Or there’s always the wisdom of Solomon — we simply cut him in half.”

Chapter 31

Diane Wright met them at the front door. As usual, her smile put Thomas at ease. This was the place — barring that one time when John Wright had passed him a gun and demanded justice for Miranda — that nothing bad ever happened. Having Karl there completed the set.

“We waited for you. Sam and Terry are practically eating the tablecloth. How did it go at Jack’s?”

He smiled. Very clever. Start off easy and then go for the jugular.

“We don’t know where he’s being treated.”

“Heick arranged it. Trust dear ol’ dad to take care of everything.” Karl went in to join the family.

“Make yourself at home,” Thomas muttered but Diane shushed him.

“From the little that Miranda has told us, it can’t be easy for Karl.”

He didn’t comment. He was too busy thinking about his fire damaged living room wall.

Miranda’s brothers gave a cheer when Thomas entered the room and even John held up his cutlery to make a point. He sat beside Miranda, weathered the jeering, and watched as Karl disappeared with Diane into the kitchen.

The stacks of foil tins made him think of a bullion robbery and even with two trays it took a couple of journeys. Thomas wasn’t a religious man — he left that to his mother — but he blithely considered that if the Last Supper had been a Chinese meal then history might have played out a lot differently.

He enjoyed the busy chaos of the dinner table with tins of Oriental deliciousness moving to and fro around him. Miranda chose for him, which was no great hardship.

Karl seemed to pick his moment when he announced, “I think it’s only fair to tell you that Moretti is back out on the streets somewhere.”

John Wright’s face gave nothing away.

“I’m sure you did your best.” Diane held up a bottle of white wine, which Karl declined.

“Heick reckons he’ll have gone to ground.” Karl seemed to be struggling for a silver lining.

John helped himself to a large portion of chow mein and then took a sip of lager. “Everyone up for a game of cards later?”

Thomas caught his eye and raised an orange juice in thanks. Now he knew beyond doubt that Karl had been accepted as one of the clan. It would also be an opportunity to see Karl out of his element.

After dinner Sam collected the plates while Terry rounded up anything left in foil tins, which wasn’t much. It would all find its way into the microwave at the breaker’s the following day. As Thomas had heard Terry say many times: pizza, Chinese and an Indian all improve with age.

John sat and finished his drink. When he was done he took a breath and looked across the table. “Thomas, Karl — can I have a private word?”

They followed him to his office off the passageway. John pushed the door and flicked on the light, throwing their shadows against the magnolia wall. The room looked tidy and functional, as if nothing ever happened there.

Thomas had never asked about John and Diane’s business in all the time he’d known Miranda. She had once joked that her parents’ approach to commerce was that anything was fair game unless it involved drugs, weapons or porn.

John nodded for Thomas to close the door. Karl followed his gaze and spotted three framed photographs up above the door.

“My, my, John! Is this Thomas in his youth?”

John didn’t reply. He had other things on his mind. “All I want to know is whether my family are at risk.”

Thomas remembered sitting opposite John at that very desk when a gun had slid across.

Karl took his time answering, although Thomas was certain he’d already thought through the probabilities.

“I doubt it, John. Saying that, this might be a good time to take a holiday.”

“Really?” Thomas nearly choked on the word.

“It removes an element of risk. Makes the situation easier to manage.”

Thomas felt his jaw sagging. “And what *is* the situation?”

“Come on, lads.” John’s gravelled voice seemed to rumble across the room. “Let’s not fall out. I’m sure I can sort out a trip for a few days . . .”

“Best make it a week — or more. Sooner the better,” Karl interjected.

Diane knocked on the door. “The card table’s ready.”

“Lovely!” John called out, stepping past Thomas and Karl. He paused at the door handle. “Not a word to them,” he insisted, holding the door open.

* * *

Karl made an interesting subject. Thomas could have happily taken notes. He didn’t bother looking for Karl’s *tell*, which was probably why he was no great shakes as a poker player himself. No, it was far more interesting watching Karl interact with the family, attuning himself to the banter and the goading. He took the knocks in good part, but it was clear — to Thomas anyway — that Karl wasn’t used to happy families. Something else they had in common until Thomas had made it to London.

John broke with tradition by starting a conversation mid-game.

“Oh yeah, I forgot to mention. I’ve got the offer of a free villa in Spain. Can’t hang about though — what d’you all reckon?”

Thomas ignored Miranda tapping his foot under the table.

“Come on,” John went on a charm offensive. “When was the last time we had a holiday as a family?”

Terry signed on board, so Sam naturally fell in with his older brother. Diane simply nodded. The only defaulter was Miranda.

“I can’t leave Sheryl to run the bar on her own.”

Thomas toyed with one of his poker chips, putting it down again when Diane pointed a finger at him.

“Why not shut up shop and bring her with us then?”

Ouch. A little too eager.

Miranda pushed her foot down on Thomas’s. “I’ll think about it, Dad.”

“Well, don’t be too long. I need to book all the flights and that.”

Miranda rounded on him. “What about you, Thomas? Fancy a holiday?”

“Er, nah, I already asked Thomas — he’s got too much work on.”

Thomas understood now why John was so shit at cards. Miranda’s face looked like it could sour milk. Thomas upped the ante by two green chips,

in an effort to distract everyone. Sam bought it, anyway.

Karl moved his chair back. "If someone can point me to the little boy's room . . . Miranda, you wanna play this hand out for me?"

Everyone around the table placed their cards face down. Miranda took Karl's seat, almost before he'd got up, and play resumed. When Karl returned, phone in hand, Thomas knew it wouldn't be good news.

"We need to leave, Tommo. Moretti's been seen near the Leibowicz's' home. He left a pig's head on their doorstep."

"Shit. And are they . . .?"

"Miles away, safe and sound. DS Edwards let me know. She reckons she might even get a detailed statement out of them this time."

Thomas didn't bother asking why this necessitated them having to cut and run. All in good time. Sam started humming the theme tune to the 1960s Batman TV show until Miranda gave him an icy stare. Maybe that was why the room had gone cold.

"Sorry about this. I'll call you, Miranda."

Diane saw them to the door. There were no other takers for the job.

"Don't do anything stupid. That goes for the pair of you."

Chapter 32

“Where are we going?” Thomas played the reluctant passenger faultlessly.

“Off to meet a friend. Karen Edwards has asked to see us.”

Thomas glanced sideways at Karl. “On the level?”

“Not exactly. I think we’ve proven our worth to her and she needs a favour.”

* * *

London at night-time is a capricious creature — you can leave privilege and enter squalor along the same street. Thomas liked to think of it not as one sprawling city, but more like the ghosts of the villages it had slowly consumed over the centuries. It was less about geography now though, simply pockets of self-interest and influence. The West End’s bright lights faded very quickly to darkened alleys and chained gates, where battered signs warned you that guard dogs patrolled the area. Only in pairs, mind.

Nevertheless, if you knew where to go there were oases in Sodom. Karl, the human coffee pot, had no trouble finding a parking place close to an all-night cafe, where DS Karen Edwards was already waiting. She looked ill at ease, hunched over the table and nursing a mug of tea. Thomas reckoned there’d be enough going on in that place to fill a police notebook. It didn’t take Sherlock Holmes to spot the potheads in the corner, supping at espressos, or the rent boy trying to sweet talk a would-be punter into taking him home for the night over a plate of chips.

Edwards brightened at their arrival and passed Karl a fiver.

“Whatever you fancy.”

Thomas yawned. Bed seemed like a nice idea, whatever time it was. He opted for a hot chocolate and stared in astonishment as Karl ordered tea and toast. Karl — who hadn’t exactly restricted his calorie intake of Chinese food.

“What? I’m a growing lad, so I am.”

They joined Edwards at the table.

“So here we are. What can we do for you, Karen?”

Thomas watched the two of them play professional relationships together and went through a tick list in his head: maintaining eye contact —

check; mirrored body language — check; building rapport — check. Karl regurgitated their last comms skills course at breakneck speed.

Edwards added sugar to her tea. “I don’t expect you to tell me what’s going on — I imagine you can’t really do that.”

Thomas smiled encouragingly. He couldn’t tell her what he didn’t know.

“I believe you, though, about . . .” She bent down to her mug and hissed, “Moretti. Ferguson doesn’t want to know — I don’t care why.” Her face didn’t agree with her. “Theo Pritchard’s granddaughter is alone in the world now. Her mum died when she was nineteen.”

This was personal to Edwards. Thomas couldn’t fathom why. Maybe there didn’t have to be a reason. He left the spotlight to Karl, intrigued by what he’d have to say.

Karl crunched his toast thoughtfully and then slurped his tea. “If we can help you, we will.”

Edwards froze for a moment. “Then help me get the bastard.” She glanced at them both and left her well-sugared tea behind as she walked out the door.

Thomas listened intently but the noise levels around them hadn’t changed. No one else was interested. Too wrapped up in their own tragedies, he reasoned. He stared into the remnants of his hot chocolate.

“Is this how you do it, Karl? A favour in advance and then they’re in your debt for the future?”

Karl stiffened. “You’ve got me all wrong, Tommo. Didn’t I tell you long ago that we’re not so different?” He clapped his hands, drawing attention from the tables around them. “Come on, drink up, there’s work to be done.” He led by example, grabbing the last piece of toast for the journey to the car.

* * *

“I wonder how you write up a pig’s head on the doorstep?” Karl parked up a few houses down from chez Leibowicz. “I take it you have your emergency kit on board?”

“Of course.” Thomas reached under his seat and felt for one of the two plastic cases. “Visual surveillance, rather than audio?”

“Yeah, back door I think. In case someone pops home.” He winked. “If you do the honours I’ll keep watch.” As Thomas closed the door Karl gave a small salute. “Good luck! We’re all counting on you.”

“Twat.”

Thomas crossed the road, scanning the street around him. Underneath its veneer of respectability suburbia gave off an air of quiet desperation. He imagined all the local papers would cover the pig’s head story, unless someone managed to hush it up. Not good for the house prices, or the core demographic.

The thick cloud cover and sparse street lighting bathed everything in muted beige. Perfect for night work. He pushed the gate and it glided open without a sound, and trod across the manicured lawn to avoid the gravelled path. Nearing the alley along the side of the house he breathed in a whiff of creosote, which clung to his nostrils until he returned to the car. At the rear of the house he worked out sight lines to the back door and chose a crevice in the rockery, digging the tiny camera in before covering it with dirt and moss. He took out a mini torch to do a final check of his handiwork and then made some final adjustments to camouflage the camera better. Job done.

Karl had the radio on while he sat in the dark like a statue. Thomas got back in without disturbing him.

“I don’t see anything,” he whispered.

“Try these.” Karl passed a pair of night vision goggles over without moving the rest of his body.

Thomas found the rogue car with ease. “Oh yeah. Looks like one of them is asleep.” He handed them back.

“Amateurs,” Karl sneered. “They’re on someone’s payroll though.” He picked up his mobile. “Hey, Karen — it’s Karl. We’re outside the Leibowiczs’ place. Just on the off chance. You couldn’t send a patrol car down this way, could you? Preferably from the top end of the street? Yeah, some sort of Volkswagen. Thanks. See you tomorrow.”

“You do wanna stick around?”

“You know me so well.”

Ten minutes later a marked police car appeared over the horizon and made a beeline for the VW.

“This is going to be interesting.” Karl settled into his night vision goggles. “I spy, with my little eye, something beginning with DI.”

“Ferguson?” Thomas held out his hand for the goggles.

“The very same.” Karl passed them over. “You weren’t paying full attention — not like you at all. And that’s DC Wen, if I’m not mistaken.”

Thomas changed his mind and started the car. Karl was rarely mistaken. It seemed only fair to alert Karen Edwards, although Ferguson’s true intentions were anybody’s guess. Correlation was not causality, as Karl assured her down the phone. Thomas determined to write that down somewhere, in case he ever needed a mantra. What he really needed right now though was his bed.

Chapter 33

Ajit had once mentioned that in his experience as a copper every burglary victim said the same thing — once a home had been breached it never felt the same again. Thomas thought about that as he turned over in bed and nudged the Makarov pistol with his knee. It would take time to reclaim the space. Intellectually he knew the flat was more secure than it had ever been, but the fact that it took a Russian semi-automatic to make him feel safe at night did not sit well with him. Small wonder he was out the door next morning by seven o'clock.

He reached the City by eight and indulged himself in the fantasy life of a photographer, walking from Liverpool Street to 30 St Mary Axe, to pay homage to the Gherkin. It dominated the historical buildings surrounding it, rising above them like a fifties' sci-fi rocket ship. He'd been there on the day it opened, earlier in the year, and several times since. There were always other cameras to keep his company.

Two phone calls on the move later, he reached the ASI building. He joined the slipstream, which took him as far as the front desk where he signed in and was once again deposited in the waiting room. At least he could pick up more sweets for Karl.

Heick was prompt, coming to collect him in a handful of minutes. He led Thomas across the floor again and Thomas wondered whether everyone on site was part of the game. He smiled, imagining some poor bastard joining a finance house only to discover it was all a cover for an intercept station. Then again, and his smile faded at the thought, hadn't his 'straightforward surveillance role' — he'd never forgotten that from Sir Peter's interview — turned into an eternally looping intelligence Mobius strip?

He waited until he and Heick were alone in the lift together. "So, you never got round to telling me who you work for."

Heick let the lift doors close and then threw him a bone. "I'm sure Karl could find out, if he wanted to. These days it's the Bureau of Intelligence and Research."

There was coffee set out in Heick's office and Thomas didn't stand on ceremony.

"What's the news on Moretti?"

"Still missing." Heick joined him at the glass table. "You mentioned a change to our terms."

Thomas held his breath and remained still. It helped him concentrate. Heick seemed pensive. Thomas stopped at seventeen and started talking.

"We know about the Slovakia connection between Moretti, Mr and Mrs Leibowicz, and the man Moretti had killed. We don't know the details yet."

Thomas took a slug of coffee. Maybe Karl had been right the previous night. Maybe they'd wandered into a turf war at the lower end of the Shadow State food chain. Nothing more, nothing less.

"And?"

Thomas smacked his lips as another hit of the dark stuff made his nerve endings sing. "And I don't believe in coincidences. Never have. You let Moretti loose — I'm not interested why." He almost laughed at the boldness of his own lie. "Maybe you wanted Jack Langton dealt with at arm's length. He could already be dead and buried for all I know."

"He's not." Heick cut across him like a Sunday driver. "As a matter of fact he asked for you when I spoke to him this morning. Seems you did some work for him not so long ago?"

Thomas felt his face reddening and sought escape in his coffee. "What does he want?"

"To see you — privately. I can take you there now. It's not far. Once we've concluded our business here, of course."

Heick went over to his desk, unlocked a drawer and lifted out a sheet of paper. Then he locked it and placed the key in his top pocket.

"I've gotta tell you, Thomas, you've impressed me so far. But I'm really not sure if you're equal to the task — either of you."

"What choice do you have?"

Heick laughed and carried the piece of paper over. Thomas read it twice and it was no clearer the second time.

"The Asterion Hotel near Tower Hill." He stared blankly. "I'm sure I can find it." He worked through the numbers. "The first date is in eight days' time. Is this what everything's been about?"

Heick sounded contrite. “I should have gone straight to Karl. I had to be sure though. That’s why I needed you to secure his involvement. That piece of paper is extremely valuable if you know how to use it.”

“Well, let’s talk about that.” Thomas set the coffee down and drew himself back in the chair. “I’m not after money. You’ve taken an uninvited interest in my life and the lives of those around me. I want my anonymity back — and theirs. Sheryl, Miranda, her family. Karl too.” He took it as read that Heick wielded that sort of power.

“Agreed. When the job is complete I will turn over my files to you.”

“What about copies?”

“I don’t keep electronic records for unofficial projects.”

Thomas decided to trust him, on that point at least. Karl had said that the Shadow State had a similar policy. “Then tell me what you need.”

Heick filled in more details and then phoned for a car.

* * *

It was more of a clinic than a hospital, though the effect was the same. Once those doors glided back together to seal off the outside world you were in no doubt you’d entered a private domain. The floor gleamed and the subdued lighting conveyed an immediate sense of calm. Thomas had noted three floors on the display. A fourth floor lift button suggested a deeper level of exclusivity. The men and women working there were attractive, as if the elite clientele required beauty around them as part of their treatment. Unless they provided extra services.

The suit outside the private suite at the end of the corridor stood up to greet Heick. Thomas looked for — and noticed — the bulge in the lining of his jacket. They were taking no chances with Jack Langton’s safety.

“You can go in.” Heick eased the door handle down.

Jack was in better shape than Thomas expected, propped up on pillows and watching television.

“Good to see you, Thomas. What, no grapes?” Jack laughed to himself. “Pull up a chair.” He seemed enthralled with the satellite sports channel until Thomas turned the chair away from the screen — all the better to see him.

“So how are you, Jack?”

“Yeah.” He moved the arm in a sling out a short distance and then winced. “Getting there. I was bloody lucky really.”

“What happened?”

Jack froze for an instant and stared at the screen. Only Thomas could see his eyes weren’t following anything.

“What?” Jack recovered his senses. “Oh, just wrong place wrong time. My new friends are taking care of me now.”

Thomas read between the lines. The old friends being Karl’s contacts who had already started the process of turning Jack against his suppliers. Thomas took out his notepad and wrote across one of the pages: *Don’t say anything important — room might be bugged.*

Jack’s eyes widened. Thomas figured he was starting to realise he’d jumped from the frying pan. Jack gestured for the pad and added a line below: *Am I in danger?*

Thomas ignored the pen in front of him. “When do you reckon the doctor will let you out of here?”

Jack looked distinctly green around the gills. “Er, not sure yet — they’re keeping me in for observation.”

Thomas grinned. Got that right, mate. “Nat and the family are fine. Someone’s with them now, making sure they’re okay.” He pointed to the door and Jack opened his mouth wide, bearing his teeth. “I’ll give them your love, shall I, Jack?”

As he got up to leave, Jack grabbed his wrist with his good hand. Thomas waited as Jack scrawled another line: *Please help me.*

Why?

Jack grew frantic now, adding a feverish note that Thomas had to concentrate to decipher: *Got a meeting — could make us both rich if I get out in time. My contact introducing me — someone influential.*

Thomas felt a lump forming in the pit of his stomach and scrawled back: *Is she Belgian?*

Jack stared up and nodded as if Thomas had just pulled off the world’s greatest card trick.

“Right then, Jack, I’d better be off.” He tore out the page and handed it back, turning the chair round to face the television. Jack didn’t bother trying to return the note, he knew the score. He’d already started eating it when Thomas reached the door.

“Don’t forget your old friends, Jack.”

Jack stopped chewing long enough to mouth a one-syllable reply.

Chapter 34

Heick walked Thomas out the building and kept schtum until they reached the street.

“You know the venue and you know the date. It has to be done that week — enough evidence to expose me without endangering or humiliating Henriette. Understood?”

Thomas nodded. Poor bastard. Heick sounded less sure of himself than ever.

“And you don’t want to know—”

Heick scratched at his lapel. “I don’t want to know *anything* until it’s all been done and you present me with the footage.”

Thomas supposed he should have been surprised when a thick white envelope emerged from Heick’s suit. It felt heavy, as if it held a thousand secrets.

Heick’s arms fell down by his side. “Additional information and expenses.”

Thomas didn’t ask. He knew how to take a hint.

* * *

By the time Thomas reached Paddington Green police station he finally felt he understood the bigger picture, and how he’d unwittingly set events in motion when he rescued Barbara Leibowicz’s baby from Moretti’s people. Although he hadn’t quite figured out the pecking order between Barbara Leibowicz, Moretti and Jack Langton. In the end, what did it matter who was the bigger scumbag? No, but what *did* matter was a tenuous thread from Leibowicz to Moretti to Heick, and one from Jack Langton to Henriette Voclain and Heick. If she really was being offered a promotion within the Shadow State, she must have already proved her candidacy over the years. And now, thanks to Heick, she was also on Karl’s radar too. Heick must want all bases covered.

He pushed the door and smiled to the desk sergeant, who turned her nose up at him and his SSU ID as she clicked the buzzer. And a lovely day to you too, Officer. Thomas’s brain was still fitting the pieces together while he took the stairs in twos. Hadn’t Sir Peter Carroll been quick to dismiss the

possibility that Henriette and Heick could be involved together? He was still pondering the ‘why’ when he met Karl coming down, coffees in hand.

“Are you psychic, or is Christine tracking my ID card again?”

“Your paranoia does you great credit, Tommo.”

Thomas smiled. That was true, and Karl hadn’t given him a straight answer. Safely inside the information room, Thomas swapped a bulky envelope for a facsimile of a coffee and a small packet of biscuits. Karl ran the envelope under his nose, as though it were a cigar.

“I’ll play mother, shall I?” Karl broke the seal and ran his thumb over the edge of the banknotes. “Fifties and twenties . . . I’d estimate, maybe four grand.”

Thomas was past being impressed. “Good. We’ll buy some new surveillance equipment. And we’ll need to book a room for a week at the Asterion Hotel. Let me explain . . .”

Thomas talked and Karl made notes — a role reversal. But Karl, being Karl, not only asked questions, he asked the right ones.

“Where do the meetings take place and how do we know who’s attending?”

Thomas paused then, because the spectre of Jack Langton was on his mind. And there was no time like the present.

“How long ago did you first connect Jack Langton to the Shadow State?”

Karl ran a hand lightly over his mouth. “Look, Thomas, you have to understand . . .”

“Jesus, Karl. Come on — two years? Three?”

Karl put his pen down. “Remember when we first got acquainted in the service — properly, I mean. And how I had you figured as another spy within the Surveillance Support Unit?” He pressed his hands together. “Well, of course I checked you out. Yes, all right, and the lives of those around you. Standard procedure. Then I came across Jack Langton — practically a friend of the family and he’s a dealer.”

“So you investigated him as well?”

Karl tried a Celtic charm offensive. “Come on, Tommo, he’s not exactly mastermind material. Obviously he had contacts from somewhere . . .”

“Is it true that every assignment we get is deliberately chosen by you and Christine?”

Karl’s patience had worn thin. “Thomas, what do you think we do here?”

“Honestly? Sometimes I have trouble telling.”

“Let me paint you a picture. The Shadow State is a threat to whatever passes for democracy in Europe. A network of industrialists and politicians and military . . .”

Thomas swallowed some coffee. It tasted bitter, which seemed appropriate. “I’ve heard this speech before.”

“What do you want me to say? I *used* you? All right, I did. I’ve been pursuing a lead and in a few days’ time that will take us directly to Henriette Voclain, who — Heick tells us — will be given higher office.”

Karen Edwards’ heavy footfalls approached the door. Karl scooped up the envelope and shut it in a drawer.

“Hey, lads, I just wanted to let you know that DI Ferguson called me in about the Leibowiczs. It’s all legit apparently, only I’ve been kept out of the loop because of my association with you two.”

Thomas laughed. An internal turf war — the stupid bastards.

“Give her the camera code, Karl. We owe her that for Theo Pritchard.”

Karl took out a piece of paper from his wallet. “Log on to this website and you can configure the device to alert you when someone goes to the Leibowiczs’ back door. Chances are, you’ll get there first.”

“Thanks.” She looked genuinely moved.

Thomas had come up with another idea. “Can you get us the address for Pritchard’s granddaughter?”

Karl rolled his eyes. “You are a total boy scout.”

By five o’clock Thomas had packaged up a thousand pounds in fifties and sent it anonymously from the nearest post office. It was the least Heick’s money could do.

* * *

Apart from a slice of the cash for Karl’s expenses, Thomas kept hold of the envelope. He figured he had other debts to settle.

“I appreciate the gesture.” John Wright accepted the two grand without counting it and placed it in his office safe — Thomas did the decent thing

and turned away at the crucial moment.

They rejoined the family in the front room and Thomas listened to their Spanish holiday plans — a three-hour Stansted flight to Alicante, followed by a seven-seater road journey from the airport. Having been on a couple of holidays with the clan in the past, he felt a pang of envy.

Miranda seemed to have lost her membership card for their glee club. They'd already rowed about the trip the previous night when he'd misjudged the situation by offering to cover her losses from the bar. It turned out that not only did he not understand women, he also didn't have a scooby about how much a successful bar could turn over in a good week.

He sat, watching Miranda as she observed the chatter around them. And even wondering if she'd packed the green bikini that he really loved seeing her in failed to lift his mood. He played the part, determined not to ruin the buzz for everyone else — an Oscar winning performance, unless you counted Miranda on the judging panel.

Once upon a time, after witnessing someone being shot — even though the bastard deserved it — Christine had referred him to a counsellor. The good doctor had asked him whether he compartmentalised his feelings and he'd laughed at the question. Didn't everybody?

After John and Diane had confirmed their Spanish trip, Thomas arranged for an artist friend of Jack Langton's to look after them over there. John Wright had the details. They were cutting it fine though, leaving only a day before his own excursion with Karl to the Asterion. He stayed over at the house so he could see them off first thing in the morning. Sheryl would meet them at the airport. He'd have preferred to have them all together from the get-go but he could hardly give out orders.

Miranda and her brothers went to their bedrooms, leaving him with John and Diane. He went through their itinerary again.

"And no one else knows where you're going?"

"Straight," Diane insisted. "Anyone who does know we're away thinks we're in Portugal. Like you said."

He smiled. He'd done the research and given them flight times and enough pre-holiday tittle-tattle to convince a jury.

"You want a drink, Thomas?"

"No thanks." He waved the idea away.

John poured himself a brandy, took a sip and then passed it over to Diane. There was something touching in that, romantic almost. Diane swirled the glass and peered into it, as if she could read the future.

“You gonna be alright, Thomas?”

“I’ve got Karl. Nothing bad ever happens around him.”

Their smiles didn’t outlast the brandy vapour.

“Miranda knows she can contact me at the Asterion, on my new mobile. I’ll be fine.” Except, right that moment he didn’t feel fine. He could always talk to John and Diane about anything except his job, and he saw no good reason to break with tradition now. So he swallowed it and said goodnight.

He knocked on Miranda’s door before turning the handle. It wasn’t locked.

“Any thoughts on where I should end my tan?” She stepped out of the ensuite bathroom and let her robe fall open.

“Why don’t I just show you?”

Chapter 35

“How is this going to work, exactly?” Thomas pored over the hotel plans.

“There are conference suites on the first and second floors. Ms Voclain will be staying on the fourth floor — room four-three-nine.” Karl tapped a ruler against the paperwork.

“You hacked into the hotel system?” Thomas raised his coffee cup.

“Well, I had help from Heick. I’m not a gambling man but I’ll wager Heick’s organisation—”

“The Bureau of Intelligence and Research,” Thomas cut in.

“So he tells *you*! Heick’s outfit either financed the hotel, or they own it — same thing to all intents and purposes. Security’s tight around the conference rooms where the formal business meetings are held. They’re absolutely out of bounds to us.”

“Pity.”

Karl lifted his makeshift paperweights and the plan scrolled in from both sides. “Don’t you worry about that. I may have managed to call in another favour.”

“Would that be Teresa again?”

“No comment. Anyhow, we go in tomorrow — Heick has set everything up. All we do is receive the images. Did I mention he’s vetoed any sound recordings?”

“You what?” Thomas stared incredulously.

“He wants to undermine Henriette and himself, not betray other Shadow State members. They have long memories and an even longer reach. So it’s exposure by association.”

“And you’re gonna accept that?”

“For the time being. Right, let’s check the equipment one more time.”

Thomas had always respected *thorough*. He opened the case and carefully moved the devices, placing them on the table in the same pattern and with approximate spacings. It wasn’t exactly an Aladdin’s cave for spies: three micro cameras, a couple of tracers, two RF detectors and a couple of anti-intrusion devices. Thomas held out his phone for inspection.

“Do you want to test it one more time, Karl?”

“Why not.”

A simple modification — according to Karl, anyway — enabling a person to take a call and have the phone’s camera work at the same time, and without it showing on screen. Best of all it filmed automatically for the duration of the call, for side-on surveillance.

Thomas picked up Karl’s call and walked around the flat in conversation, taking in his photographic wall gallery. Perfect. After okaying the footage, he powered down the phone and double checked that he’d packed the charger in one of the bags.

“We’re all set for tomorrow then. Incidentally, are you bringing any personal equipment?”

Karl shook his head. “Lizzie and Robert aren’t coming on this trip.”

No Brownings then. Thomas wondered if he ought to tell Karl about the Makarov pistol already wrapped in a sweatshirt and stowed away.

* * *

There was no cover story. For the duration of their stay they’d work days at the police station and spend the evenings at the hotel, unless something interesting came up. DS Edwards had allowed them some leeway — split shifts if needed — as long as the data and evidence analysis didn’t suffer. Perish the thought.

They left Thomas’s flat and travelled to the Asterion by tube. Thomas insisted they pay by cash to prevent anyone tracing an Oyster Card. Likewise, they left their SSU IDs behind at the flat, relying instead on the temporary Met Police passes that Edwards had allowed them to carry. They wouldn’t be mistaken for coppers, but they were obviously police staff of some kind.

Heick had set the rules in stone and the first one was no contact. They knew which room was Henriette’s and Heick had already trained a hidden camera on the door. So far so good, but Thomas wondered what Heick *wasn’t* telling them.

Tower Hill station was awash with tourists and over-enthusiastic tour guides offering cheap deals to unwary travellers. They muscled through, two bags apiece, and walked the short distance to the Asterion. It wasn’t hard to find — the collection of flags of the world on the roof was a bit of a clue.

Thomas checked in first, making sure his temporary pass saw daylight. He leant against the reception desk casually, as Karl went through the same rigmarole, and noted the business conference signage and the list of sponsors. Among them were a smattering of global brands and a few unknowns such as ASI. Except, now he knew *all* about ASI in a way that many of their investors never would. It didn't rile him as much as he thought it might. Karl had long since explained that the Shadow State had infiltrated most major institutions at some level. Chances were that the majority of the delegates were simply there for the usual reasons: conduct business, make contacts, plunder their expense accounts and enjoy illicit sex with strangers.

The support staff behind the rope looked like they carried more than a marketing degree for comfort. In the few minutes it took to sign in and receive their room key no one arrived to go through the magic doors.

Up on the fifth floor it was business as usual, albeit with a polite notice that one of the two restaurants was unavailable for the week due to a private conference. Regrettably, that meant another reason for Thomas and Karl to be away from the action. Guests were also advised that floors one to three were out of bounds unless you were a designated gold visitor. Thomas wasn't impressed. Shakespeare had it right: "All that glisters . . ."

Their shared room was surprisingly spacious. Thomas claimed the bed nearest the window, so he could catch a glimpse of the Tower of London. He unpacked methodically, moving the balled sweatshirt on to the bed with infinite care.

Karl held a finger to his lips, took out his RF detector and went walkabout around the room, checking gaps and closed spaces, and finally standing on a chair to wave the detector under the lights and the smoke detector.

"All clear. Let's hope they don't have a firearms detector on the premises. You better put that in the room safe while I use the little boys' room."

* * *

By the time they returned to the hotel that evening, after a hard day's analysing, the atmosphere in reception was very different. Thomas spotted two guests heading for the roped off area, and loitered for a moment on the

pretence of checking his pockets. He glimpsed a sharp-suited woman pulling out a portable scanner to verify identities. No way would he and Karl be able to get in there if they weren't on the database.

Thomas changed for dinner upstairs, prompting comments from Karl about whether he ought to add a monocle. Karl's concession to the hotel restaurant was a pair of shoes rather than trainers, and to moisten down his hair: one hundred percent style.

Thomas scoured the menu to see what he could squander Heick's money on. "I still don't get it. We have a visual on the fourth floor room and this place is tighter than a drum, so how the bloody hell can we use any of the other devices?"

"Not sure. Now, what say we break the bank and try a Belgian shandy as a treat?"

It didn't take Thomas long to figure out the game. Karl became unfeasibly loud and boorish for a sober man. He'd also managed to attract attention from the restaurant staff and a maître d', who hovered nervously by the kitchen. Thomas knew their money was good though, so the staff would have to put up with them.

The rowdiness continued to the very end of the meal, culminating in Karl licking his dish, giggling, and then accidentally letting it slip to the floor where it become a jigsaw puzzle. Thomas dropped a tenner on the table, muttering to Karl that it would be coming out of his wallet, and steered his seemingly inebriated colleague to the lifts.

He figured Karl knew he was pissing in the wind when he pushed the first floor button, although the security staff facing them as the lift doors opened was a surprise. Karl tried to stagger out abruptly and was returned with some momentum.

"This floor is out of bounds, sir."

Karl slammed into Thomas and waved as they tried their luck on the floor above. Same story without the shove.

"Fourth floor, I think." Karl hit the button.

The moment the lift doors opened again he set off in earnest. Thanks to the floor plans, Karl knew his way around and quickly navigated the corridors until he pointed to room 430.

"Aha!" he stepped smartly towards a console table, three rooms down, which seemed to have no business being in the corridor. As he passed it he

grabbed a statuette and kept on walking.

Thomas followed him and they took the stairs up to the fifth floor. Back in their room, Karl opened his jacket.

“It looks genuine. Pity. Still, needs must.” He rested it on a pillow and went to his bag for his miniature tool kit.

Thomas put the TV on and flicked around until he found a football match. It was clear Karl didn’t want to be disturbed. By half time Thomas had decided to either go for a walk around the hotel or suffocate Karl with one of the pillows. Either would be preferable to the grunts and sighs and the interminable *scrape scrape* as Karl worked away at the ceramic with the smallest of tools to create an opening big enough for a miniature camera. He managed to convince Karl to take a break and have a brew, and then helped out by holding the statue steady so that Karl could position the device inside and glue it into place. That was twenty minutes of his life he was never getting back.

After testing the field of vision it only remained to take another stroll down to the fourth floor, the statuette under Karl’s jacket and Thomas bringing up the rear with some fast acting glue. Once the shepherdess was back in position, and unlikely to ever leave it again, they called it a night.

“One down, Tommo . . .”

Chapter 36

Henriette Voclain arrived on the third day. Close up, she was exactly how Thomas had imagined. Her clothes wore her and they seemed to enjoy the experience. It was easy to see why Stephen Heick had fallen for her. She could have given Diane Wright a run for her money in the older woman stakes.

They almost passed her in the lobby, only Karl stalled. So Thomas had taken the lead, waiting until she turned to enter the magic kingdom with all the other golden ones. Karl didn't speak until they were out on the street, heading to Tower Hill tube station.

"It's a funny thing, seeing her in the flesh. Different to a photograph or film footage. She seemed . . . I dunno . . . vulnerable? Kinda makes me wonder if she bit off more than she could chew?"

Thomas understood he wasn't required to answer. Karl soon saved him the bother anyhow.

"Nah, there's more to this, Tommo. Heick's made it all too easy for us. We just turn up and collect the evidence. Why does he even need us at all?"

"Got me." Thomas shrugged.

* * *

DS Edwards was all smiles come eleven o'clock when she made her customary appearance in the information room. Mr Leibowicz had been caught on camera at home in the early hours, giving her the opportunity to have him picked up by the local police. Since then, she and DC Wen had brought him in for questioning.

"Of course, the thing is," she rattled a bag of muffins in Karl's direction, "All we have is a tenuous connection with Moretti. On paper, they're the victims."

Thomas clocked the way she looked at Karl. Not quite affection, more like familiarity.

Karl nodded. "Find Moretti and we strengthen the connection."

Edwards placed the bag down and left them to it.

"Simple as that?" Thomas tossed him a muffin, which Karl caught left-handed and then held it aloft like a trophy.

“Simpler, in fact. Our good friends in Slovakian Intelligence have already provided information—”

“Then why didn’t you tell me?”

“Because I don’t know the details. Jesus, Tommo, How many times? I’m like you — a spy chaser — only I have another badge. I’m not told everything and, frankly, I don’t need to know everything. What is it now, Lassie?”

Thomas had started worrying away on a piece of paper. Why would Leibowicz go back to the house now? He tapped at the page and the harder he thought the slower he tapped. Jack Langton’s meeting, *thud thud thud*. Arlo Moretti, *thud . . . thud . . . thud*. Stephen Heick. *Thud thud thud*.

“What room is Heick staying in?”

“Dunno, Tommo. Maybe he’s not even here at all — you met him south of the river before.”

“No.” Thomas held up both hands to quieten Karl’s chatter. He was on the brink of something. “Heick won’t want to be far from Henriette. Where are the best rooms?”

“Seventh floor. What’s your point?”

“I don’t know. I can’t quite get my head around all this.” He blew through his hands. “Okay, let’s take a step back. Jack Langton talked about an introduction to Henriette — how would that work?”

“Well, she’ll not want him to meet her friends from the off, so I’m guessing a private meeting to see if he’s made of the right stuff — like an interview.”

“And far from prying eyes — ours.”

“I’m on it.” Karl fired up his laptop and keyed away as if his life depended on it. “Hmm . . .” He triple-tapped his keyboard. “No Heicks listed, unless he’s in under another name.” He looked up. “You don’t think . . . ?”

“You did say he was a shifty bastard.”

More tapping. “Got him. Stephen O’Neill, probably to match his passport. Room 702. Lemme see now.” Karl searched through his bag and pulled out the floor plans. “Opposite 711. Now all we need is a way to get in there, rig up a camera, and stop anyone else using the room.”

Twenty minutes of silence convinced Thomas that they needed an alternative plan. When his phone rang it was a welcome change from thinking. Natalie Langton gave him the good news — Jack was being released from hospital and she expected to see him that night. It was the *night* that did it, triggering that instinct he'd come to rely on, the one that smelled trouble.

"Jack's coming home tonight."

"You don't sound convinced, Tommo."

"Lemme ring him." He didn't wait for a decision.

"Hey, Thomas. Yeah, I'm getting there. They let me out so I can attend that meeting. Are you still in?"

Dear God. Jack thought they were potential business partners.

"I'll ring you later, Tom. Have you changed phones? Only your number's withheld."

* * *

Sometimes there was no plan beyond marshal your forces and make it up on the hoof. Thomas got in the lift and pressed seven. Karl hadn't tried to talk him out of it. Why would he? It wasn't as if they had any other options.

Heick opened the door cautiously, half checking it with his shoulder. "What do you want?"

"I need to talk."

Heick opened the door and pulled him in. Thomas heard the click of a safety catch and then Heick holstered the weapon. Nice.

Thomas kept it brief and to the point. He told Heick he'd heard that the room was compromised. Heick didn't put up much of a fight about it. Thomas pulled out his trusty RF detector anyway and offered to do a sweep. Heick immediately backed down and Thomas followed his gaze to the clock — no time for big changes. That left two rooms available without any great upheaval — his and Karl's, or Henriette's. No contest. Thomas left him to it.

* * *

Thomas sat and watched them all as they either passed the statuette or approached it, on their way to Henriette's room. Sometimes alone, sometimes in pairs. Without sound to rely on he formed judgements, each

one as random and instantaneous as the next. This woman an accountant and that man a politician. They could be nobody of significance, except every one of them paused before they knocked on the door, as if they understood the line they were crossing.

“What do you think really goes on in there?”

“Some will be first time introductions. Others are there to talk terms. You ever heard of multi-level marketing? Cleaning products and the like? You earn from the sales of the people below you — so you build up . . .” Karl grasped for the words.

“A pyramid?”

“I was gonna say an organisation. Close enough though. Everyone wants to go up a rung and get closer to the big chair. Here’s the thing though. I think Henriette’s got so close that she realises there’d be no turning back. Can you imagine the crisis if someone in her position tried to walk away, knowing what — and who — they know?”

“So why is she meeting her organisation then?”

“Maybe she’s funding her retirement.”

Thomas took the late shift — one till two in the morning. He’d stared at that closed door for so long he was starting to imagine shapes in the paintwork. The silhouette brought him to his senses and he waited eagerly for the short appointment to end. Fifteen minutes later the door opened again and he watched Sir Peter Carroll on screen.

Karl didn’t take kindly to being woken up, even if he did acknowledge the significance. He stood over the table and scratched his groin through his boxers. “Well, I never knew that — I thought Our Leader was better connected within the Shadow State, but Heick said she’s only been approached for higher office.”

Thomas put his hands together in prayer. Either she’s lying or he is. My money’s on her. In which case, he’s being played.”

“Maybe they’re both playing each other.”

* * *

Edwards wore it well when both Thomas and Karl phoned in sick the next day. Karl took a call in the bathroom and it hardly occurred to Thomas to go through his things. My, how times had changed. When Karl emerged,

phone clamped to his ear, he announced he was going out for a couple of hours — on business.

“I think we both need a little downtime.”

Thomas surfed the web and then flicked through the TV channels, settling on a news station. As the ticker tape of scandals and disasters played out along the bottom of the screen, it seemed to him that lately he’d been living in a bubble. Time for coffee.

He’d just polished off the last of the biscuits when the tap tap at the door and a cry of ‘room service’ brought him out of his sugary haze. He pressed his eyes to the spy hole and opened the door at the speed of light.

“Miranda!”

“*Buenos días!*” Her Spanish accent was good for someone who hadn’t caught the plane. She closed the door behind her and took a step closer. “Remember me?”

“What are you doing here?”

“Working the early shift in the conference suite. I’ve been here since the day before you arrived. Now, are we gonna stand here talking or would you like to come down to the basement and help me out of this uniform?”

He switched the intruder detector on and followed her out.

Chapter 37

Sneaking down to the staff rooms reminded him of the old days in Hyde Terrace, Leeds — creeping around the bed-sit to outsmart the landlady, who lived in the building.

“We’re in here.” She swiped the door card and led him by the hand.

He’d once told Miranda that she had a touch of the witch about her. A day apart felt like a week — when things were good between them, anyway. Every time he had her figured out she managed to turn the tables. Like now, closing the door so that the side lamp turned her hair to gold.

They didn’t waste time with words. Maybe it was the buzz of somewhere new, or the sheer delight of seeing her at the hotel, but it was the most intense sex he could remember. He could still feel his insides trembling as he lay on the bed, watching her change her laddered stockings.

“Come on, up you get.” She fixed her hair in the mirror. “We can’t stay here forever.” She smiled then, as if the thought had crossed her mind.

He was mid pee when she barged in the bathroom.

“Sorry, your phone went off. I thought it might be important.”

He checked. It was.

“Shit. My room’s breached. Gotta go.” He dragged on his clothes in a frenzy, jammed trainers on his bare feet and broke into a run. Miranda was a heartbeat behind him.

She pulled at his arm. “This way. Service lift.”

He counted the seconds as the display changed, running scenarios through his head. Heick or Voclain doing counter surveillance, Jack Langton settling a score with Karl. None of them played out well. And where was his gun? Safely in the room safe. Idiot.

When they exited at the fifth floor he kept Miranda behind him and moved cautiously along the corridor. Their room was closed but he could see the indentation where something had hit the catch. He held his breath and pressed an eye against the paintwork.

“You give them to me and maybe I let you live.”

The voice chilled him. Moretti — in his room, and there was only one person he could be talking to. He leaned back and mouthed Moretti’s name

to Miranda.

"I can buy you a couple of seconds," she whispered, straightening her uniform.

Thomas moved behind her, coiled like a spring.

"Room service." She tapped on the door. "Room service!"

"Go away."

The voice was so strained Thomas couldn't even tell if it was Moretti or Karl. Miranda glanced round to Thomas, who nodded for her to try again. As she turned back to face the door he noticed her palming something.

"Room service. I have to get a signature for this Yorkshire Hotpot or I'll get in trouble. Sign please, or I'll need to fetch the manager."

Thomas smiled — smart.

"All right." That was Moretti, definitely under stress.

Miranda took a large breath as the door handle slowly turned.

"Give it to me then."

She did as he asked — with pepper spray — and didn't stop when he screamed. Thomas charged the door and sent Moretti sprawling.

"Gun!" Karl moaned from the corner of the room.

Moretti frantically wiped at his eyes with his free hand, and reached over to try and retrieve the gun. Thomas gave him a swift kick in the bollocks, and beat him to the drop.

Karl looked like a car had ploughed into him. The fire extinguisher on the floor was a bit of a giveaway. It explained the doorplate as well.

"Jesus, Karl, what happened? How did he find us?"

"Well . . ."

Miranda helped Karl sit up. He didn't seem surprised to see her.

"I sort of lured him here, using your old phone number — after I'd rescued your SIM card from the scrapyard, courtesy of Terry." He pointed vaguely across the room. "I texted him and said I knew where the Leibowiczs were hiding." Karl coughed and spat some blood into his hand. "Then I reset the device at the door, in case we were both out. I miscalculated — didn't realise he was already in the hotel. He surprised me on my own — can you believe that?"

Thomas let the accusation slide. Moretti hadn't moved and he soon saw why. Miranda had the gun trained on him — on a part of him, anyway.

"You shot up my pub, you bastard."

Thomas reached out and steadied her arm. "I think I'll take that now." He pulled out his phone with his free hand and passed it to her. "Call number five — do it in the bathroom. Tell him everything."

Heick took a few minutes to get there. Thomas had supposed he'd come with backup but he arrived alone. As he entered the room, Heick's eyes flickered from Karl to Moretti, as though he were making a choice.

"Hey," Moretti sneered, "we have a deal. If you want what I have . . ."

Heick pointed to Thomas and Miranda. "You two, out. I'll call you when I'm ready. I'll take care of Karl." Heick held out a hand for the gun.

Karl nodded obligingly. Miranda threw Thomas a 'what the fuck?' gesture and followed him out.

"Is that it then?"

"Come on." He strode out and took the stairs down to the fourth floor. It was a hunch, nothing more, that Heick would have a backup of all the camera footage taken from opposite Henriette's room. If that were true, the receiver would probably be in the room itself. Only one way to know for sure.

* * *

He collected a fire extinguisher by the lifts and marched along the corridor, right up to the door below the camera. Miranda followed him and then backed off a little when she understood. He swung behind him and then twisted to put his full bodyweight behind the blow. The extinguisher crashed against the doorplate, which offered little resistance. They went inside.

"What are we looking for?"

He gave her the briefest of smiles. "It'll be a small unit," he shaped space with his hands, "Probably black — and connected to a power supply."

While Miranda searched the room methodically he pulled up a chair and pressed it against the door, feeling above it for a wire.

"Gotcha." The camera was well fitted, recessed into the plaster and papered over. He scratched with his fingers and then scraped away with a key.

"Here." Miranda threw him a penknife and he caught it one-handed.

He realised, as he dug the camera out, that what he was doing served no purpose other than as a wanton act of vandalism. That would do for now.

“It’s not here.” Miranda stood in the middle of the room, hands on her hips. I’ve checked every socket — unless it’s powered by batteries?”

“No, batteries are fallible.” He got off the chair and looked to the door. “Where better than Henriette’s room? We’ll need to be quick.”

“She could be in there though.”

“Well, she’s about to get a rude awakening.”

He moved the chair back and picked up his trusty lock-extinguisher. Miranda held the door open and watched him as he retreated a few steps for a run-up.

Meeting the door head on, he powered through and landed on the carpet. Miranda went straight to work and found it in the wardrobe. He knew what was coming even if she didn’t, and tossed her the camera.

“Improvise.”

The security staff piled through the door and onto him.

Miranda’s voice warbled. “There was a message for Ms Voclain and as I arrived, I found this man here.”

“Well then, you’d better give it to me.” Henriette Voclain appeared at the doorway. She looked imposing, especially to Thomas who now found himself in a double arm lock. “I’m waiting.”

Thomas stopped struggling. “I have a message too: *Charlemagne*.”

Henriette paled. “Go,” she commanded Miranda, who scuttled out without looking at Thomas. “Leave us,” she told the security staff, who knew when to take an order.

Thomas felt the blood rushing back to his hands and he started to breathe again.

“Sit down.”

He did as she asked. “Stephen sent me.” He reasoned that she’d be carrying a gun and also that she was seated too far away for him to land a punch on her. Ordinarily he wouldn’t hit a woman, but it had been a difficult day and he was willing to make an exception in her case. Hard to say why exactly, apart from his predicament.

He moved a hand towards his pocket and her gun flashed in his peripheral vision. Good call. He froze for an instant. “My phone. Call it — number five in my list.” He took it out very carefully with a thumb and index finger, and lobbed it on to her bed.

She edged around it, her gun trained on him all the time, and reached over to look at the screen. He thought about rushing her but why risk it? Besides, he'd told her the truth — after a fashion.

Lady luck smiled on him. The phone rang and she read the screen. He saw her adjust the volume.

"Thomas, are you there? Get up here."

She glowered and cut the call.

"Satisfied now?"

She threw him back his phone. "We'll go together." She kept the gun hand in a pocket, hoodlum style, and gestured to the door. Outside, the two security staff started walking towards them.

"No one is to enter." She breezed past within touching distance of Thomas.

They took the lift. Thomas tried to imagine how the pieces could be put together. He wondered how Heick would feel when they showed up at the door. He didn't have long to wait. Thomas knocked, partly to delay the inevitable. A conversation dried up as the door opened wide.

Heick's jaw slackened about a foot and so did Moretti's. Then a light seemed to glimmer in his eyes, as though he'd been handed a lifeline. Thomas stepped over to Karl.

"Are you okay?"

"I've had better days. No bones broken though, from what I can tell."

Heick stared daggers at Thomas. "Why did you bring her?"

"I caught him in my room." Henriette was on the offensive.

Moretti laughed — a jackal's cackle. "He's with the police."

Thomas held out his pass for Henriette to see. Although it didn't make him a copper, it agreed with Moretti.

Heick turned to Henriette. "In your room?"

"He was there with one of the staff. I sent her away."

Thomas saw that Heick got the picture, even if he didn't understand what it looked like yet.

She turned her attention to Karl. "And who is this?"

Thomas caught the way Heick looked over without saying anything. Interesting. "He's with me. And your *associate* here did him some damage."

Karl staggered to his feet. "Come on, Thomas. We're getting out of here."

Moretti leaned back against the wall and lit a cigarette. "The next time I see you both, I'll kill you, with or without orders." He took a drag, made a gun shape with two fingers and then blew out a smoke ring.

Thomas stared Moretti down. "Not if I see you first."

Karl waited by the door while Thomas collected their equipment and grabbed some clothes. Last and not least, Thomas emptied the safe, weighing the gun in his hand before stowing it away.

Heick answered his phone. His face suggested it was bad news. "What do you mean *gone*?"

Henriette stood in protest as Thomas ushered Karl out, but Heick shook his head. Thomas understood. Heick wasn't bothered because he had the backup images on the camera's receiver. At least, he used to.

Chapter 38

They hailed a black cab outside.

The cabbie took one look at the hotel front, and their bags, and sniffed money. “Where to, guvnor?”

“A bar called Caliban’s — in Bow. Head for Burdett Road and I’ll direct you when we get there.” Thomas held the door, eased Karl inside and shoved the bags in after him.

Thomas was pleased that Karl didn’t question his logic. After all, where else would Miranda go if the family were away in Spain? The bar was closed up and it had several places to hide. For all Thomas knew she had a weapon there too, after Moretti’s firearms display.

Twenty minutes later, Thomas stood in the pub car park next to Karl. They hadn’t spoken during the cab ride so Thomas figured he’d make up for lost time.

“What the fuck happened back there? One minute we were in control and the next . . .”

“Politics and expediency, Tommo — same as ever. Moretti might be a killer but he’s also an asset to the Shadow State *and* he has information to trade.”

“So he walks away scot free?”

“Not exactly. Before you showed up again Heick discussed getting him out of there in return for something useful on Barbara Leibowicz.”

Thomas thought back to Moretti’s parting words. “You think she’s the one giving the orders?”

“Maybe.”

Thomas let it slide. He could see Karl was fading. They crowded the side door together, bags at their feet. Eventually he heard the click of the microphone and a familiar voice.

“You took your time.”

Upstairs, Miranda put the coffee on and served up an admission.

“Stephen Heick asked me to work the conference area so I could be his eyes and ears. He couldn’t be seen in there.”

It made sense. Catching him with Henriette Voclain was sufficient. Catching him with the other delegates might look like he was plotting

against her and the Shadow State. It still stuck in Thomas's throat.

"And you didn't think to say?"

"He made me a very attractive offer not to. Caliban's has been struggling for a while—"

"Again, you never said."

"It's my business. Anyway, that's not the whole of it. He also discovered Sheryl is Jack's daughter . . ."

Thomas shook his head slowly. It always came down to who knew what. Scumbag.

"How did it work?"

"We were walking recorders."

"We?"

Sheryl emerged from the back room. "Hi. I could hardly say no and I wasn't about to leave Miranda to the wolves. Security was very tight going in — pat downs and some sort of gizmo at the door."

"Radio Frequency detector," Thomas corrected her.

"Like I care." Sheryl poured herself a coffee. "Heick made arrangements with one of the kitchen staff and left equipment for us in the kitchens. We put it on each day and took it off at the end of a shift."

"Shit. No receiver?"

"You mean the black box? I took it when Miranda came down. I thought maybe it was a recharger or something."

Karl was already firing up the laptop.

The footage was all first person. The invisibility of a name badge and a uniform meant that conversations flowed around them. Plus, unlike the camera on Henriette's door, there was sound.

"Jesus." Thomas wound the footage on. "This could take hours."

"Not necessarily, Tommo." Karl stirred back into life. "We have specialist recognition software back at the office."

"I'll go. You rest here, Karl." He took out the Makarov and passed it to him. "Always have a Plan B." He packaged up the recorders, receivers and the laptop, and then he nodded for Miranda to follow him to the stairs. "You know the drill. I'll ring you when I get there. Anything wrong and you use the codeword."

"Butch." She gave a thumbs-up. "And what will you do?"

"I'll come back and kill 'em."

She kissed him hard — correct answer.

* * *

Thomas made sure his phone was on and jumped the first bus that came along. Once he got near spitting distance of Mile End tube he travelled on the Underground and surfaced at Liverpool Street. There was no welcoming committee, but he walked at twice the pace of everyone else around him. He rang Christine as he approached the building and she came out to collect him.

“My ID card is at home.”

“Just as well. People are looking for you. I’ve had calls from Sir Peter Carroll and an American who said he was given my number.” She did not look pleased about it.

“I need to use the editing suite.”

“Fine,” she snapped. “I’ll come with you.”

As they walked past their office to the room next door he thought about filtering the truth and decided against it. He’d tell her everything. He didn’t expect to find Ann Crossley at one of the two large screens.

“Alright, Thomas?” She didn’t look round. “Just finishing up with the outside footage.”

He glanced over her shoulder to see the Asterion — same hotel — staring back at him. He took a seat at the other screen. Christine sat beside him, waiting.

Ann swivelled her chair to face him. “I’m about done, so if you needed a hand . . .”

“Why not?” He passed her the second black box.

Over the next hour and a half the image recognition software identified thirty-five individuals, storing a snapshot of each one in a separate file. Not quite mug shots but close enough. Anne copied her outside broadcast file and between them they cross-referenced fifteen people for definite and another five probables. Ann also turned out some sterling work identifying several complete vehicle number plates and a couple of partials.

Thomas turned his attention to the hotel corridor footage. Henriette’s room had received callers at all hours — occasionally Heick. For the cameras, Thomas decided. She would also leave after midnight and return in the small hours — to Heick’s room, no doubt. Karl’s statue-cam was

motion triggered. Naturally, the faces matched those on the door camera. Heick could be seen at the end of the corridor waving them off or meeting them afterwards.

He sensed the buzz in the room, although he couldn't tell why.

"What am I looking at?"

Ann joined them as the image tiles streamed across the screen, each one framing Heick and a new friend.

"Proof that Heick knows many of Henriette Voclain's contacts." Ann pointed to the screen's twelve squares.

He shrugged. "I still don't get it."

Christine laid a consoling hand on his arm. "You think *she* knows that he knows them?"

He laced his fingers and rested them on his head, eyes closed. When he opened them a few seconds later, he could see daylight again.

"Make copies for your respective agencies, plus a set for Karl. And then I'd like a little privacy."

Christine looked at him quizzically. "What are you going to do?"

"You're better off not knowing."

* * *

He closed the door and stared at the large screen with just two faces showing: Stephen Heick and Henriette Voclain. Side by side it was hard to decide which one he trusted least. Maybe they weren't even a couple at all.

He clicked Heick's face off screen and keyed up anyone who'd seen her for a private meeting, including Sir Peter Carroll. Fourteen people, not counting Heick, Moretti or Jack Langton. Perhaps the rest of the party were too far down the food chain, or too high up.

Now there was a thought. It still rankled that Moretti and Leibowicz seemed untouchable despite everything now known or suspected. He swallowed the bile and focused on the work, using the software to create a sequence of Heick waiting along the corridor, Heick outside the door, Heick going in, Heick leaving and then Henriette leaving. Heick had made it easy for him with the same suit and a white shirt every time. Funny that. He saved the series of clips as a single indivisible file and printed stills. Five sets, including one for Heick and one for Sir Peter Carroll.

It struck him then that the room's position, mid-corridor and with no natural light, meant that every frame was lit the same. An idea arose — a gift from the gods of retribution and subterfuge. He had the means at hand to set this Shadow State Chapter — or whatever they called themselves — against one another. All he'd need would be the names and contacts from the conference, and Ann and Christine were probably working on that. He wouldn't even have to limit sharing the carefully doctored set of pictures to Henriette's visitors. Get it right and everyone would think everyone else was colluding in private. And perhaps that was what Heick had wanted all along — to destabilise Voclair's entire organisation. Wanted or not, he was going to get it.

Chapter 39

Thomas rapped on the office door. Christine looked flustered. “I had to tell Sir Peter you were here.”

He understood. No offence taken. Everyone had a chain of command. Well, almost everyone.

“Give him these.” He passed over some prints and a disc. The other sets followed.

He held up a final disc so that it glistened under the lights. “I want you to keep this one safe for me.” He had a feeling he might not be back for a while.

She took it and nodded. “I promise.”

“Good. One more thing. I need their names and addresses when you have them.”

He walked outside, carrying an envelope for Heick. He didn’t have far to go — Heick was waiting for him.

“I thought I might find you here.”

“After Sir Peter called you, you mean? Anyway, I’ve done as you asked — this is a copy of what I sent him.”

He offered Heick the envelope and followed him to the car. This time there was only one person inside: Henriette Voclain. Thomas got in the front and waited while Heick tapped his sat-nav for the route to Caliban’s.

“You must find all this very strange, Thomas.” She made his name sound exotic.

He figured she still had him pegged as a novice and saw no reason to disappoint her.

* * *

Heick eased out into traffic and kept his thoughts to himself. Henriette did the talking. It read somewhere between self-justification and confession. Maybe she found it healing. Thomas listened but it did nothing for him. She insisted she’d been a plant at the beginning, years before, a European politician working for the Americans to make the world a safer place. Heick didn’t contradict her, which painted him as a seducer.

“It was inevitable, with the right information, that I would—”

“Rise through the ranks?” He played the game.

“Oui, c’est ça.” She sighed. “But now my priorities have changed.” She smiled in Heick’s direction.

Thomas didn’t buy it, but now was not the time or the place. He called Miranda from his mobile as they approached Caliban’s.

“Everything okay?”

“Yeah . . .” She didn’t sound quite convinced. “Karl did a recce and there’s a car outside with two of our American friends. They’ve stayed put. I managed to rein Karl in.”

“I’ll see you soon and I’ll be bringing company.”

Heick opened the boot and took out a folder, keeping it close to his chest. “Yours, in exchange for my recorders.”

Thomas made the trade. “Shall we?” he walked towards the swing doors at the front.

Karl unbolted the doors and stood back. Heick wouldn’t look him in the eye.

“I’m sorry, Karl. You have to understand—”

Karl went to join Miranda and Sheryl. “Save it. I understand all right.”

Thomas knew he wouldn’t get satisfactory answers. That wasn’t how these things worked. “I want Moretti, or the evidence to put him away.”

Henriette spoke up. “I know what he did to the old man but you can’t have him.”

“He had a name — Theo Pritchard.”

“Moretti will be punished. I assure you of that.”

“Hey!” Heick’s gaze fixed on the bar. “How about we have a drink? On me.” He took out a fifty and laid it on the table. “Champagne, I think.”

Miranda walked off and Sheryl followed her.

Thomas took hold of Henriette’s arm and whispered, “You know he’ll never let you step down? Whatever he tells you, you’re his golden ticket — an embedded agent at the heart of the Shadow State.”

Heick glanced over at them and stiffened.

Thomas went for broke. “How long do you think it will take them to discover *agent Charlemagne* is sat among them?” He left her standing there.

Miranda brought over a magnum of champagne and held out her hand. “I need another fifty and I’ll be keeping the change.”

Heick didn't flinch. He was too busy avoiding Henriette's gaze. Sheryl did the honours, handing out the drinks as though it were a celebration. Heick raised his glass.

"On behalf of the American government, I want to thank you." He sounded like he meant it.

A second later, Sheryl raised her glass. "And on behalf of the American people, go fuck yourself."

Karl took a sip. "Now that's something I'll drink to."

Henriette went over to Karl and held out her hand. He took it and it seemed to Thomas, for a moment, as if there was a truce in the trenches. Looked at from another angle they were both working for that safer world, only they had different ways of going about it.

She came to Thomas next and he started for the door, so naturally she had to follow him.

"However you were planning to compromise me, *do it*," she whispered, taking his hand and holding it so tightly he felt her pulse.

"Give me Leibowicz then." If he'd learned one thing from Karl it was when to compromise.

She nodded a fraction of an inch and then kissed him three times, alternating cheeks, like a native.

Chapter 40

The phone made it to the second ring. “Thomas? Are you there?”

He moved Miranda’s feet off his thighs and waited until she’d turned the volume down on the telly.

“Sir Peter.” He could hear voices echoing behind the old man, somewhere cavernous indoors. He shifted so that Miranda’s mock salute wouldn’t distract him.

“I have a friend here from Europe. She’d very much like to see you — without our American friends.”

“Where and when?”

“My driver brought you last time.”

He glanced at the clock. “I’ll be there as quickly as I can.”

“Very good. We’ll see you then.”

Miranda had already switched the TV off. “Problem?”

“Not at all. I’ve been summoned to the Victory Club. Fancy coming along? I’ll go put a shirt on. Can you ring Karl?”

She dialled the number before he was out of the room. “Sure you wouldn’t rather go with him?”

Thomas called behind him. “He’s coming too, if he’s around.”

“Hi, Karl. Thomas got a call from . . .” She paused, uncertain what to call him. “*Sir Peter.*” She spat the words out. “We’re heading to . . .”

“The Victory,” Thomas called out, loud enough for Karl to hear. He reappeared at the doorway, bare-chested.

Miranda held the phone away from her ear. “He says he’ll meet us there.”

“I’d better give him directions.” Thomas took a step towards her.

“He’s laughing now, says he’ll see you on the steps.”

* * *

Miranda drove while Thomas navigated, using directions he’d previously written down. He’d built up quite a collection by now, plotting out at least two different routes to each destination.

“Karl would be proud of you,” she joked.

“It was his idea.” He flicked over the page, following the list of landmarks — some drawn — as the A406 road clockwise became Newham Way. Traffic flowed nicely, rewarding his decision to avoid cutting through the city.

It seemed to him that even this part of London had become part of his personal landscape — Canary Wharf, where Moretti had holed up in his swanky apartment; the Isle of Dogs beyond it, where he and Miranda had once nearly bought a flat together; and now the Victory, which could live up to its name if Henriette Voclain gave up the Leibowiczs.

Miranda caught his eye. “It’s funny, don’t you think, that your boss rang *you* and not Heick.”

He thought about that for a moment. Clever Miranda. Heick wasn’t part of this, so Henriette had aligned herself with Sir Peter. He was *her* Plan B.

Miranda parked up in a side street — no stately arrival for them.

“You’d best put that in the boot — in case there’s any car crime around here.” Miranda gazed down at his feet, where the pistol lay, still wrapped in the sweatshirt.

He took her advice. As they rounded the corner he spotted Karl at the bottom of the steps.

“Blimey, you got here quickly.”

“Motorbike.” Karl brought a helmet from behind his back. He looked a little rough around the edges.

“Since when do you ride a motorbike?”

“There’s a lot about me you don’t know.” Karl turned to Miranda. “May I say, you look very fetching.” He took her hand and bent forward to kiss it.

“And you can cut that out.” Thomas pulled her away a little and her hand slipped free. Although he had to admit she looked the part. “Shall we?”

* * *

The two door staff ushered them over to the visitors’ book, resting on an antique desk. Karl placed his bike helmet next to it. One of the staff waited with them while they signed in, while the other disappeared through the doors.

“Nice architecture.” Karl tapped a foot against the immaculate black and white floor tiles.

The wanderer returned, picked up the helmet and exchanged it for a token.

“Twenty-three — my lucky number.”

“Sir Peter will receive you in one of the visitors’ rooms. If you’d like to follow me.”

The party of three followed the porter. Thomas took him to be ex-military — precise, well-rehearsed movements. It reminded Thomas of Karl’s favourite pub, where every man and woman had a regiment or squadron to their name.

A stag’s head gazed out above the first set of stairs, glass-eyed and indignant. It seemed to Thomas to sum up everything he loathed about the ‘establishment.’ History, tradition and status were synonyms for the bullshit the rulers used to maintain power. And speaking of which . . .

Miranda nudged him a millisecond before the next set of steps, giving him enough time to grab the banister. The porter was too far ahead to notice. Karl humming the first few bars of ‘We’re off to see the wizard’ only added to what was fast becoming a surreal evening.

It played out like a bad sitcom. White glove off to tap on the oak door. Glove back on and brass doorknob turned so the door could screech inwards. The porter went in first and announced them, then beat a retreat.

Thomas crossed the threshold to find Sir Peter Carroll and Henriette Voclain one side of a marble table. Two empty seats had been left opposite. Sir Peter waited until Karl had grabbed a spare chair from the edge of the room.

Henriette smiled. “You are surprised to see the two of us here together, Thomas?”

“I take nothing at face value.”

“Très sage.”

“She thinks you’re very wise.” Miranda translated for him, looking distinctly unconvinced.

“Sir Peter . . .” Thomas felt for an opening move.

“Pierre, surely?” Even now Karl couldn’t resist being a prick.

Thomas watched the old man’s face twitch and relished the moment. He read the tensions in the room like semaphore. Sir Peter could have made

Karl feel small with a few well-chosen words, so why hadn't he?

Thomas tried again, distancing himself from playtime. "Thank you for agreeing to see us."

Henriette seemed more conciliatory. "I approached Sir Peter for this meeting because I wish to come to an arrangement. I will give you Barbara Leibowicz." Her gaze moved along the table. "Karl, I am offering my services to your people. Sir Peter has assured me I can trust you."

Karl's eyes never left hers. If he felt shock it didn't show. "And you're willing to betray your organisation?"

Her mouth twitched, somewhere between a smile and a sneer. "I prefer to think of it as providing valuable information to avoid an escalation."

She never said what she wanted in return, but Thomas filled in the blanks for himself. It all added up to . . . a better deal than Heick was offering.

"It's quite a coup, Karl, and I recommended that Henriette came to you personally." Sir Peter unfolded his hands. "We're on the same side now."

Karl didn't reply. He turned to face Thomas, inscrutable yet easy for his friend to understand. Such a breakthrough couldn't be dismissed, despite the risk of counter-infiltration — Karl's preferred term for a double agent. Finally, Karl took a slow breath and faced them across the table.

"I'll advise someone more senior of your proposal and we will contact you through Sir Peter."

"I'd rather go through you — or Thomas."

Thomas knew a fishing expedition when he saw one.

"As you wish. It'll have to be me then, because Thomas is a civilian."

Henriette's confusion nestled at her brow. There was a time when Thomas would have felt insulted. Now it was a badge of honour. Henriette reached into her Gucci bag and retrieved a folded piece of paper.

"You'll find Barbara here. She won't be expecting you."

Thomas read it and passed it to Karl.

Sir Peter relaxed his shoulders. "Well, I think that concludes our business tonight."

"So, we have an accord?" Henriette held out a manicured hand.

Miranda took it, looked her dead in the eyes and said, "Plus ça change, plus c'est la même chose."

Henriette's smile flared and faded while Thomas tried to remember what he'd heard so he could ask Miranda about it later. Henriette gave his hand a double squeeze. He recalled the Morse Code dot-dot pulse for the letter 'I' and promptly forgot about it. Sir Peter offered a hand to Karl, stiff and formal, as befit a meeting of two former adversaries. It was a wonder he didn't click his heels.

They showed themselves out. Miranda nudged Thomas on the stairs, checking whether Karl was okay.

Karl passed them and made a call. "Meet us at this address . . ." He came straight to the point when they reached the street. "Tommo, are you carrying?"

"He is." Miranda answered for him.

"Good. That makes two of us. Let's get to it then. Er . . ."

"My car." Miranda jangled her keys. "And just for that you can sit in the back."

Chapter 41

“Wait a second, I need to turn the page.” Karl followed a reading light velcroed around his head.

Miranda followed the instructions faultlessly. The road trailed off into veins, each one more remote than the last. Finally, Thomas motioned to a patch of rough ground and Miranda eased the car over.

“Perfect spot for a place in the country. By my reckoning it’s somewhere on the right in the next hundred yards or so — look for a track.” Karl snapped the road atlas closed.

Thomas checked his phone — a single bar’s worth of signal. “I’ll tell her we’re coming. We don’t want any surprises.” He closed the car door behind him and heard Karl muttering. Barbara Leibowicz must have been wearing her mobile. He had to repeat himself a couple of times to be understood, but he knew exactly which button to push: Moretti. Leibowicz joined the dots for herself and he let her keep the picture. He’d proved his worth already so she had no cause to doubt him. He even told her they were only a few minutes away.

The Mini Cooper edged along the lane until Miranda spotted a gap in the tree line on the other side of the road. She crossed over, negotiated the dip and crawled up the track that ran for a quarter of a mile. Karl had been right, an ideal place to lie low.

Karl gripped the front seat headrests. “Nice and easy.”

“What’s the plan?” Thomas rechecked his pistol for the second time.

“Simple. We contain the situation until the cavalry arrives.”

The car’s full-beams picked out the house behind an old five-bar gate that had three bars remaining. Thomas judged it to be an early 1900s’ property, high roofed and thick beamed, with eight small panels at the top of the front door. The downstairs lights were on. The best vantage point, upstairs, was shrouded in darkness. Miranda steered to the rim of the track to angle her lights towards the door.

A shape flashed across the glare to the right, a momentary stick figure leaping into the darkness. Seconds later a shot rang out, exploding one of the headlights.

“Change of plan!” Karl yelled, although Miranda had already thrown the car violently into reverse, screeching back around the bend.

“Stay here.” Thomas stated the obvious as he heard the unmistakable sound of Karl slipping a Browning 9mm from a shoulder holster.

They sat for a moment with the lights out, engine humming, waiting.

“Shotgun.” Karl eased the back door open. “I’m thinking *amateur*.”

“Tell that to my insurance.” Miranda’s laughter sounded forced.

“Unless there’s another path out, they’re trapped.” Thomas held the Makarov snug in his hand, caught between loyalties.

“Go,” Miranda insisted. “I’ll be fine.”

* * *

Karl opened the door and then clicked the reading light back on at his forehead. “I’ll draw his attention on the other side. Get around behind him and try not to shoot him.” Karl disappeared into the undergrowth.

Thomas followed suit to the left, turning briefly to see Miranda hunkered down in the car. He focused on the job at hand, trying to keep up with Karl’s LED firefly as he felt his way across the wasteland, filling his lungs with the stench of mud and decay.

Karl’s glow flickered erratically through the trees, an predictable target. Thomas heard movement up ahead, near the house on Karl’s side.

“Don’t come any closer.” The guy sounded wired, ready to snap.

The blue light took no notice and Thomas picked up the pace, closing ground for a pincer movement, catching glancing blows from holly branches as he went. He felt the damp between his toes now and the soft sucking of mud against his shoes.

Another warning call preceded a second gunshot. The blue light blinked out of existence. Thomas held his breath and fought his way through the undergrowth. A single barrel weapon, he reasoned, probably an antique. If he could get close by the third shot he might be able to rush him. He saw the light dance crazily through the woods now at impossible angles, and braced himself for a spring into the unknown.

A car revved, threw on its one headlight and charged up the track. Thomas started running in earnest, reaching clear ground in time to see the Mini Cooper hit the gate at high speed, obliterating it. The shooter rushed forward and levelled his weapon towards the car, but Miranda kept coming,

throwing the car into a handbrake turn at the last minute to send the gunman flying.

Thomas clambered over the fence as Karl reached the vehicle. Miranda waved from the car to show she was okay, which was more than could be said for the paintwork. Karl checked the body.

“Out cold, but he’ll live.” Karl spotted the shotgun nearby and searched the gunman’s pockets for ammo. He held out both to Miranda. “Just in case he wakes up.” Karl managed to make it sound like a threat.

The key to surveillance is not being seen. Thomas remembered laughing at that on the induction seminar, especially as he’d already been working at the SSU for a month by then. ‘Do not put yourselves at risk and, above all, do not make the mistake of identifying too closely with your assignment team.’

Thomas held out his hand and Karl tossed him the door key. “This doesn’t make any sense. We told her we were coming — and why.”

“Maybe she doesn’t believe us. Or she has something to hide.” Karl gestured towards the door. “Let’s get this over with.”

Thomas crept up to the letterbox. “Barbara, it’s Thomas. I want to come in and talk. I need to make sure the baby is okay.” It was the best he could think of. He turned the key and the door rattled open. “Barbara?” He felt for the light switch to illuminate the stairs.

Karl turned bloodhound and slipped past to check the downstairs rooms. It didn’t take him long to return. He blew out a breath. “The only way is up.” He took a step forward.

“No, you’re alright, I’ll take this,” Thomas whispered, mounting the first stair. “Barbara!” he called out. “We’re coming up. It’s only Thomas and Karl. Your husband gave us his key.”

“Where’s Jacob?”

He advanced up the stairs, sideways on, checking through the banisters above.

“He’s, er, downstairs. We had a little misunderstanding, but it’s all sorted out now. Barbara?”

He reached the landing and Karl joined him. Thomas counted four doors. Karl pointed to himself and then splayed two fingers towards the front room. That left Thomas the bathroom — unlikely with a baby — and the back bedroom.

“Karl,” he hissed.

Karl stopped in his tracks.

Thomas pointed to the fourth door with his gun hand. “Barbara, we need to make sure the baby is safe. We don’t want to scare it, do we?”

“Ivana’s sleeping.” Barbara’s voice wavered.

Thomas turned the handle gradually, until it clicked. “In that case I’ll just . . .” He pushed the door at arm’s length and it arced in a couple of feet.

A gun fired and Thomas instinctively dropped to a squat. Glass fell to the floor somewhere in the room. The baby started bawling its head off. *Shit or bust*. He sprang up and rushed the gap, flinging the door back.

Barbara Leibowicz huddled in a corner with the baby, on the far side of the bed, with a duvet and pillows around them. The pistol wavered in her hand.

“Don’t.” Thomas aimed the Makarov at her head. He didn’t stop to ask himself if he’d pull the trigger, he’d walked that road a long time ago. He edged along the wall, weapon still trained on her, aware that Karl had entered his peripheral vision.

“Come on, Barbara, be sensible — look at what you’re doing to . . . Ivana.”

“You can’t take her,” Barbara wailed, briefly drowning out the baby’s caterwauling. “She’s mine now — she needs me.”

Buoyed up by Karl’s marksmanship, Thomas gradually crept round beside Barbara and prised the gun from her hand. On the far wall, close to the door, an antique sampler, proclaiming ‘There’s no place like home’ sported a bullet hole in the embroidery.

It took a moment for Thomas to register, and then the sickening realisation hit home. Barbara’s words — *mine now* — could only mean one thing. After all, hadn’t Karl always insisted that the Shadow State traded in any commodity that was profitable? From that grim conclusion other pieces fell into place. The driver and Theo Pritchard had both seen the baby, and paid a heavy price. Thomas turned to Karl. “What do we do?”

Karl flicked his head back. “Not our problem — the cavalry is here.” Karl swiftly holstered the Browning as DS Edwards puffed her way up the stairs.

“Alright, lads? Everything under control?” Thomas pocketed the Makarov and put Barbara Leibowicz’s handgun on a shelf, as far away from

her as possible.

Edwards surveyed the scene. “Barbara Leibowicz, I am arresting you on suspicion of kidnapping, contrary to the Child Abduction Act 1984. You do not have to say anything . . .”

Karl shook his head. “Slovakia.” He grabbed the weapon off the shelf. “Come on, Tommo, we’re out of here.”

“Wait!” Barbara’s face lit up like a tallow candle and she pointed a damning finger at Karl. “I paid him by cheque. He’s part of it.”

“What, this?” Karl pulled a near pristine cheque from his jacket and passed it over to Edwards. “I needed her trust to get her mobile number.”

“No!” Barbara screamed, clinging to the child.

DC Jun Wen entered the room and it took a further officer up there before Edwards came down again with the baby in a blanket. DI Ferguson met them at the bottom of the stairs.

“We found two of them outside — an ambulance is on its way for the male and we’ve got the female in handcuffs.”

Thomas cringed. “Blonde hair, fitted dress and a pissed-off expression? She’s with us. You’d better come back and de-arrest her.”

Chapter 42

Thomas drove the three of them back to London. He didn't say much — no one did. Miranda seemed to have got over her brush with the law and Karl assured her that he would make good on the car damage. But all Thomas could think about was the harrowing look on Barbara Leibowicz's face when she knew there was no way out. A prison sentence would be the least of it.

"When did you know about the baby, Karl?"

"I didn't — not until you made the connection at the front door."

Thomas fessed up. "A shot in the dark, playing for time."

"Well, your powers of deduction must be improving. Anyway, when we left Sir Peter's club I phoned Teresa and asked her to liaise with Edwards. That way we could be traced by my phone."

"Or mine?"

Karl just smiled.

* * *

Thomas didn't hear from Heick for three days. Southampton was high on the list of all the places he never wanted to see again. Even so, this invitation was worth the risk of accidentally running into his boss's boyfriend — the still married Bob Peterson.

Miranda drove her newly refurbished Mini. It seemed only fair to bring her along for *closure* — as Sheryl had put it. Plus, Bob Peterson didn't have a marker on her car's number plate if seen in the Southampton area.

Karl occupied the back seat and the middle ground. In the three days since the Leibowiczs had been *neutralised* he hadn't spoken against Heick or Voclain. He was quieter, more self-contained. Miranda put on his Creedence Clearwater CD in the car, but even *Cosmo's Factory* failed to bring him out of himself.

Heick and Henriette met them at the port. The evening light lent the ferries a romance they didn't deserve. They moved like dinosaurs, edging around one another, or else they sat off shore, waiting.

Thomas had saved the details for Miranda. He thought it'd be better hearing it from Heick, who passed her the night vision goggles and directed

her attention to a floating behemoth.

“Moretti is on there. It’s how the stolen cars are shipped. The ones the police didn’t get to.”

Miranda’s gaze turned fiery. “Sorry, how is that a punishment?”

Heick stared silent questions at Thomas, who calmly stood and waited. Waiting could still solve most of his problems.

“He’s been drugged and hidden in the back of one of his own vehicles. Kinda poetic justice?”

“Kind of sod-all justice.”

“No.” Heick held up both his index fingers. “You don’t understand. The trip takes weeks and he’ll arrive in the Middle East with a fake Italian passport, a little money — not enough to travel on — and a mobile phone. He’ll have to work his way back through the traffickers — it will inconvenience him greatly.”

Thomas thought about the footage he’d sliced and diced in the office a few days before.

“Unless he knows some of your international contacts, Henriette?”

“Ce n’est pas possible.” She spoke in French to Heick, flushed with indignation.

They parted company for what Thomas hoped would be the final time. As Henriette extended her Belgian civility to Karl, Thomas wondered whether Heick had revealed the family connection. Miranda withstood her bonhomie with all the grace of an angry cat. Finally, Henriette crossed the tarmac to Thomas, who still had an eye on the ferry out in the growing darkness.

She gripped him by the shoulders and as she kissed his cheek she whispered, “I’ve kept my word — keep yours,” adding, “L’honneur est mieux que les honneurs.”

He repeated the phrase in his head, so that Miranda could explain it later. Heick seemed short on goodbyes. There was a moment where it looked like he might try and connect with Karl, until Karl turned away to chaperone Miranda to her car.

“Don’t change your number, Thomas. I may need to call you some time.”

“I’ll bear that in mind.”

* * *

Miranda dropped Karl off before they headed on to Thomas's flat in Walthamstow. She translated Henriette's fortune cookie wisdom — honour is better than honours — and he resolved to keep it in his wallet.

The following day he received a text and went back to the Asterion Hotel to collect an envelope. He passed the additional evidence on to DS Edwards. Bye bye, Barbara Leibowicz. Not in the same league as seeing Moretti's head on a pike but still a victory.

Thomas decided he wouldn't ask Karl, Ann or Christine how they planned to use the footage from the hotel. Some mysteries were best left unsolved. Besides, he'd cut the image sequences so many different ways it needed a spreadsheet to keep track of them. He imagined every identified person on the list receiving material that suggested they or others had held secret talks with Heck, or Henriette or any other delegate.

It was enough to imagine the shit-storm it would cause and the damage it might do within the Shadow State. There was some justice in that. Heck had used Miranda and Sheryl to covertly film the attendees downstairs as an insurance policy, in case Henriette tried to back out of joining the Shadow State's inner circle. In the end, she'd been another of Heck's investments. Meanwhile she, in turn, had sanctioned the release of that information to undermine them both. Frankly, they deserved each other.

Miranda stayed for three days and life regained some sort of equilibrium. But there was one thing left for Thomas to do: the right thing. He'd always understood the value of information, although not necessarily its power. The discussion with Karl at the hotel about things being *hidden in plain sight* had set him thinking. What else was staring him in the face? A web search on Asterion identified him as the consort of Europa. Thomas figured Heck and his European cronies still got a kick out of that. As for Charlemagne himself, one unusual fact leapt from the screen. No one knew for certain where he'd been born — Aachen or Liege. So, what if the agent Charlemagne also had two origins - Henriette Voclain *and* Stephen Heck?

Thomas waited until Miranda went out and used his old SIM card one last time. He kept it brief, made his pitch and killed the call. Heck had no time to deny it and anyway this wasn't about the truth. It was about information and leverage.

Its final mission completed, Thomas removed the SIM and despatched it with a hammer. “Let’s see you track that,” he sneered, sprinkling the pieces into a metal wastepaper bin. Heick’s intelligence file on him and a generous helping of lighter fuel completed the recipe. He set the bin at the top of his backdoor steps, propped his kitchen door wide open and fetched out some safety matches.

The fading sky above Walthamstow bled into evening. He lit the beacon and watched it erupt into flame, releasing a column of black smoke into the neighbourhood. Theo Pritchard dominated his thoughts and he stayed there until Miranda arrived home with a takeaway.

Chapter 43

It was late but Heick took the call.

“Arlo, stay calm. You crossed the line with the Brits. I warned you. I’ll take care of it — I’ll send a helicopter for you. Call me when you have the information and then wait for my instructions. Keep the passport close.”

* * *

Heick had prepared for all eventualities. He flew down to US Naval Station Rota, in the Cadiz Province of Spain, courtesy of Sir Peter Carroll. Sir Peter called it a ‘farewell gift.’

On arrival, two strangers in combat fatigues met him on the tarmac. They saluted and awaited instructions. They didn’t ask questions. He told them he’d brief them in the air and had one of them take his case.

Moretti telephoned again and gave Heick the name of the vessel, something he already knew. Heick assured him a helicopter was on its way with the money.

The two strangers, whose names Heick never asked, came to collect him when everything was ready. They offered him the case but he didn’t want to touch it again until he had his gloves back on.

“And what about . . . ?”

“It’s on board, sir.”

He began to relax once they were airborne. His companion didn’t speak and merely pointed downward as the information came through his headphones. Heick nodded and braced himself as the side door opened, even though he was tethered to the inside of the helicopter. The roar of the rotor blades and the rush of salty air sharpened his senses.

Below, a small figure had climbed out to the rear of the vessel, behind a swathe of vehicles and containers. Heick drew a circle in the air with his gloved finger and the helicopter banked to arc around.

“I’ll do it myself.” Heick picked up the rifle and held it snug against his shoulder. It had been a long time. He breathed in aviation fuel and saline as the vessel beneath them powered through the sea, unable to escape.

He didn’t hesitate when Moretti entered his line of sight. One clear shot to the head and the job was done — a clean kill, into the water. He

motioned to the case and then pointed down. There were two people out now, cowering in the gap between containers.

The Samsonite case bounced a couple of times without rupturing. Heick didn't wait around to see if they'd take the money — that was a given. He signalled to leave and then turned his back on his companion momentarily to whisper to himself, as if in prayer.

"I kept our boy safe, Kathleen, like I promised."

* * *

For once the poker table was adorned with cash. Karl had brought along a grand and divided it up at the start, just for the hell of it. Eight people crammed around the table, watching the game. Miranda coughed a little and leant back to try and see what Thomas was holding.

"Hey!" John insisted. "We brought you up better than that."

She blushed and hung her head. Thomas let it pass. He had other things to think about, especially when his mobile went off. A chorus of abuse circled the table like a Mexican wave.

"Fuck's sake, Thomas. Can't you leave your work alone for five minutes?" John grinned to soften the blow.

"Sorry. Cards down, everyone. I *have* to take this." Thomas tilted his head to Miranda. This was the call he'd been expecting. He retreated to a far corner of the room and hit the button, listening hard to make sure he heard it right above the noise of the engines.

"It's Heick. It's done. Goodbye, Thomas."

The call cut before he could offer his thanks, which was just as well. He held his phone up high so they could see him switching it off and made his way back to the table. "Now, where were we?"

"We were waiting for you, Tommy Boy."

"In that case, I'm in."

Karl shook his head gently. "Nah, you're bluffing. I can smell it."

Miranda touched Thomas's hand and smiled, looking over to Karl. "You should know by now — he never bluffs."

THE END

Book 5: FLASHPOINT

A gripping espionage thriller you won't want to put down

DEREK THOMPSON



Dedicated to Anne Coralie.

AUTHOR'S NOTE

On 7 July 2005, a series of coordinated terror attacks on London's public transport network devastated the capital. Ethnicity, religion, wealth — or the lack of it — none of that counted. If you found yourself at the wrong time and place on that terrible day, there were no grounds for appeal. After 7/7, whether you were a born-and-bred Londoner, a resident, a visitor, an ex-pat, or anyone else with the good fortune to know the *Big Smoke*, London would never be quite the same again.

Much of the Spy Chaser series takes place in London. Although this book starts in July 2005 and makes reference to what happened then, the plots and characters are, as always, my own invention and purely fiction.

Prologue

Thomas Bladen waited, camera trained on a patch of ground illuminated by a Harlow streetlight. This was easy money, providing back-up surveillance in case the target detoured along the alleyway. Statistically less likely, but Karl — who ran the operation — liked to cover all eventualities.

He held the camera steady and leaned back to check the surrounding area. Cocooned in his car he saw nothing moving outside, only litter turning lazy pirouettes to the tune of background traffic. That was surveillance: one hundred per cent focus and ten per cent activity. The perfect job for voyeurs with a high boredom threshold.

A walkie-talkie bleeped through his earpiece and Karl McNeill's Belfast brogue broke through. "He's coming your way, Tommo. Try not to chop his head off."

Funny man. Thomas counted the seconds, poised for the finale, and followed him through the lens, capturing his escape on an SD card.

A suit emerged from a housing estate — expensive, incongruous at so late an hour — with a leather document case under one arm. The target walked confidently, but not too confidently. A man without fear in a strange neighbourhood was either brave or stupid — or armed.

Thomas completed a batch of pictures to the event horizon and then called in. "Target is clear. Okay to stand down now?"

"Sure, we're done. You can go home to Miranda like a good civilian."

He didn't give Karl the satisfaction of a response, but mouthed *bollocks* in the gloom. Then he switched off the walkie-talkie, clicked on his seatbelt and rolled Miranda's Mini Cooper forward, following the nightwalker. A few yards ahead he heard a cry, somewhere between pain and anger. He swung the Mini into a space and slipped out, moving alongside parked cars for cover.

It looked like a tug of war with a difference — the suit on the ground, hanging on to the case while a stocky knuckle dragger rained down blows on him.

"Give me the fucking case or I'll batter you."

Clearly, the thug hadn't understood the importance of the gap between threat and consequence. Thomas didn't waste time enlightening him. Instead, he came up behind him, side on, and swiftly locked his foot into the back of the guy's knee. The thug collapsed like a derelict building, stumbling forward before he hit the pavement.

The man in the suit found a new lease of life and a new vocation, beating the shit out of his attacker. Thomas only intervened when it became clear that the original assailant had struck his head on the way down.

He hauled the suit back a couple of feet. "That's enough."

The suit flattened down his hair and wiped blood from his face. "Search him!"

Thomas didn't usually do requests but he figured the bloke had had a bad night so far. The knuckle dragger groaned, more air than words, and offered no resistance. Thomas felt in his pockets and pulled out a wallet. He covered the card with his palm and offered the suit a bunch of banknotes.

Thomas pocketed the wallet. "Mind if I keep it as a souvenir?"

The suit grinned, his bloody gums glistening under the light. "Sure. Here," he separated a twenty and passed it over, "for your trouble."

"Cheers, mate. Do you need a lift?"

He shook his head. "My car," he spluttered and then spat out a gob of bloody phlegm on to the prone body. "It's just up here."

Thomas played Good Samaritan and helped him to his vehicle. Once the car pulled away, he got back in touch with Karl.

"There's been a development. Target intercepted. Target liberated. Assailant down. I have a wallet for fingerprints. I'm gonna ring an ambulance."

Karl gave it a moment's thought. "No, don't do that. I'll ring in a couple of minutes, give you time to get clear. Meet me on Cross Street, as before."

Thomas returned to the man still on the ground. He checked for breathing, moved him into the recovery position and then stuffed the twenty into the bloke's back pocket. "Ambulance is on its way."

Karl was already at the rendezvous point. Thomas passed him the wallet, card and all.

"This shouldn't happen, Tommo. They're getting information from somewhere."

Thomas opened his mouth, but Karl saved him the bother.

"I know, I know — *again*." He opened the wallet and teased out the card with his gloved hand. "It's a phone number."

Thomas didn't bother asking. Need to know, and he didn't. Instead, he recited the car's number plate, NATO alphabet style, to Karl's delight.

"See, that's what I love about you, Thomas. When it comes to surveillance you're *never* off duty. Until tomorrow then, in the day job."

Thomas basked in Karl's approval as he headed back down the M11 motorway, leaving Harlow for Walthamstow and home. This time he hadn't asked Karl who the job was for, or why that mattered. It always came down to the same answer, anyhow: *because somebody needed it done*. Karl usually put it differently, referring to the ongoing intelligence war or his current slogan — *making a difference*. Lately, Thomas was less sure how you decided that. Still, as long as he kept the world of counter espionage at arm's length from his private life, he was willing to play a part.

Miranda called out from the living room as he shut the front door behind him. "Karl rang and said you were on your way. Kettle's boiled — one sugar, thanks. How did the world saving go?"

He pushed open the door and set his camera bag down carefully, his face lit with a smile. "We should be okay for a few hours." The wall clock read eleven forty-five. *Nicely done*. By the time he'd made the tea, Miranda had relocated to the bedroom. He took the mug through, his coat still zipped tight.

Miranda reached for her tea. "You not stopping?" Her impish smile lasted until he took off his coat, removed the Makarov 9mm pistol from his pocket and closed the bedside drawer. She didn't comment because this wasn't news.

He glanced at his watch and loosened the strap, rubbing the red imprint on his wrist. "Still a few minutes left of Wednesday."

Miranda put her tea down and edged along the bed. "Well then, it'd be a shame to waste them."

Chapter 1

Thursday 7 July 2005 began better than most weekdays for Thomas. He left Miranda in bed, took the train from Walthamstow Central to Liverpool Street and made it into work before eight o'clock, dodging the rain and beating Karl by five minutes to earn himself a coffee at his partner's expense.

They didn't discuss the previous night's activities. It was 'off the books' work. Most Surveillance Support Unit staff had their allegiances within the intelligence community. Jesus, it gave Thomas a headache keeping up. The last time he'd pieced the jigsaw together, Karl McNeill had links with NATO, Ann Crossley reported to Royal Navy Intelligence, and their boss, Christine Gerrard, retained ties with the Foreign & Commonwealth Office. Not so different from the day job, where the SSU provided temporary support for government and law enforcement departments, earning them the nickname of 'floaters.' That was one explanation anyway.

Thomas considered Karl's nickname for him — *the civilian* — a badge of honour because his allegiances were personal rather than political. Not that it led to neutrality. When Thomas first learned of the secret war against the Shadow State he became a reluctant member of the resistance, foolishly thinking he could cooperate on his own terms. Three years on and sometimes, like that morning, he wondered what had really changed. The pan-European cartel of politicians, industrialists and military leaders still pursued its own vision of a United States of Europe without so much as a ballot box. And while it seemed to him to be a war largely fought with numbers and data and backstreet diplomacy, there were casualties. People suffered and people died, and all in the name of power or freedom or commerce, depending upon your vantage point. Still, there were probably stranger ways to make a living.

An hour passed in a fog of vending machine caffeine, paperwork and bureaucracy. In the absence of any official surveillance assignments it was a necessary evil after a four-week stint as a courier for the Treasury. But contrary to popular belief, no one ever died from boredom.

Around nine o'clock that morning, the world slipped irrevocably into chaos and London changed forever.

Karl lurched forward in his chair and barked, "Over here — look at this!"

Thomas and Ann converged at Karl's desk, where the BBC website filled the screen. The conflicting reports of a train crash or an explosion near Liverpool Street on the London Underground were only the beginning. Within minutes a second report came in of an explosion in a Piccadilly Line tunnel, between Russell Square and Kings Cross. Either the power grid had failed catastrophically or London was under attack.

Ann returned to her desk, took out a small radio and clung to it. Headphones on, she started making notes. Thomas heard her gasp as a third news report onscreen referred to another explosion, this time at Edgware Road tube station. He sat beside Karl and confined himself to the role of observer, watching life play out like a horror film, underlined by news-ticker updates of numbers to call and sound bite guesswork. He felt sick to his stomach yet unable to move, compelled to bear witness.

The Metropolitan Police declared a major incident around nine thirty and at nine forty-seven the unthinkable happened — a bomb detonated on the top deck of a bus in nearby Tavistock Square. Within seconds of the announcement a claxon sounded in the building, a piercing intermittent shriek. Christine ran from her office towards the main door, to be met by an Asian woman who swiped herself in.

Thomas glanced up at their MI5 colleague from the first floor below: Rupee Tagore. For the first time he realised that MI5 were able to enter the SSU's suite of second floor offices any time they wanted.

Rupee spoke to the room. "It's a security lockdown. Stay away from the windows." She looked to Christine and shook her head slowly. "It's bad out there."

Karl turned to Thomas, ashen faced. "It's war, Tommo."

Rupee's walkie-talkie crackled for attention. "It's secure up here." She stared across the room, her words devoid of emotion.

After a few minutes the incessant alarm ended. Thomas grabbed his mobile but the signal was dead. He tried his work mobile — same deal. "Maybe they've shut the system down as a precaution?" No one seemed to be listening.

Christine came out of her stupor. "Leave the landlines clear." She turned and walked back to her inner sanctum at the far end of the room. Rupee followed and closed the door.

Karl lifted a handset. "Desk phones are dead too. Maybe the comms are routed through the tube tunnels, could be the phone network is overloaded."

Thomas embraced the isolation and kidded himself he could cope through detachment. He watched Karl attempt to update a report, staring blankly at the screen. He reasoned this would all be horribly familiar to Karl, having grown up in Northern Ireland. He recalled Karl once telling him about an explosion he'd witnessed at close quarters. Across the room, Ann was still worrying out feverish lines of text, presumably for a private meeting somewhere else.

Outside, London continued to be tested. First the tube shut down, and by eleven fifteen the bus network in central London followed suit. Without public transport, London was paralysed.

The feeling of cold dread hadn't left Thomas. It oozed from every pore, clinging to his clothes, to his thoughts. He'd moved back to his own desk and computer, looking for answers in his screensaver. It didn't have anything to tell him, so he slipped past Karl and went to the gents. He dabbed water on his face and caught his reflection, finally voicing the thought that plagued him. "What's the point of everything we do here if it doesn't make us safer?"

He returned to the office with vending machine coffees for Karl and Ann. It was the best he could do. He eased a cup on to Karl's desk. "Are you okay?"

Karl sipped substandard caffeine and took his time answering. "The Shadow State can't be behind this. So have we spent all this time watching the wrong enemy?"

Thomas took it for a rhetorical question. He'd been part of the secret war for three long years now and in that time he'd encountered treachery, deceit and violence, though nothing on this scale and as indiscriminate. No, *these* people didn't give a fuck about individuals.

Christine opened her door. She spoke quietly, as if she already understood they were mourning. "Can you all come in, please?"

They filed in and each found a space. Thomas noted how Rupee had taken up residence seated in a corner of the room.

Rupee tapped a pen against the arm of her chair, the way a cat flicks its tail. “There’s no identified threat to this building but please be vigilant. The Shadow State may try to exploit this atrocity.”

Thomas joined the dots. Rupee — Ms MI5 — must be another link in their circle of allies. He found the nearest chair and sank into it. All these players in the so-called intelligence community and somehow no one saw this coming?

Christine glanced over at him before reading her notes. “There will inevitably be changes to meet this new situation.”

Situation? Everyone else nodded at her conclusion. Thomas felt his shoulders harden. Better to be a civilian than to see the world as they did. He saw an exit and took it. “I’ll go back and monitor the news.”

No one tried to stop him. When they emerged several minutes later, Karl walked past and sent him an email, desk to desk: I never thought I’d say this but I need a drink after work. You free?

Meaning, are you meeting Miranda? Thomas figured he could do both, committed himself to one drink at the Swan, and waited out the minutes and hours of the worst day in living memory.

The commuters that spilled out around Liverpool Street after five pm fell into two camps — the watchful, and those vacant faces completely overwhelmed by the day’s events. The cocktail of fear and suppressed rage was palpable, as was the silence shrouding the capital. People meandered aimlessly, some in a fruitless search for public transport, others seeking safety in numbers. Traffic crawled along those roads still open and emergency services were everywhere, dashing about relentlessly. The human silence got to Thomas the most, as if the whole city had nothing left to say.

He thought twice about entering the packed pub and then realised it didn’t matter where they went or what they did. It lent him a sort of calm. It was the same way his gran had talked about her life during the Second World War. Even living in fear you could still *live*, she’d reminisced.

Karl squeezed through the pub doors and steered a course to the pumps, turning to Thomas when they reached their destination. “Those poor bastards can’t face the journey home.”

Thomas grimaced. *Much like us then*. With no chance of a table, they settled for a patch of wall space to lean against, drinks in hand. “You

working tonight, Karl?”

“I wouldn’t have thought so after today.” He didn’t elaborate. “Might visit the club later. You interested?”

Thomas’s senses twitched at the thought of the gun club. It had been a while, and handling a weapon had never seemed more appealing. He could sense Karl’s anticipation, but he had more pressing loyalties. “Not tonight. Another time.”

After he left Karl he walked from Liverpool Street to Miranda’s bar, *Caliban’s*, covering the three-mile distance in an hour. He kept to a steady pace, numb to whatever the weather threw at him and only dimly aware of his surroundings. Somewhere along the way he crossed the line where the City gave way to London’s East End — invisible unless you grew up on the far side of the divide.

Those familiar streets, where Miranda lived and worked, were the backdrop to so much of his past. Tonight though, he was a stranger, pausing at the neon *Caliban’s* sign to wonder how much greater the pain was for born-and-bred Londoners. He gave the saloon door a sharp push and crossed the threshold. Sheryl, Miranda’s bar manager, watched the clientele watching him. He recognised one or two regulars. The many others looked like strays, drawn in by the need to be around other people.

Sheryl let him reach the bar and then took aim, every jagged syllable sharpened by her Brooklyn accent. “Hey, where have you been? Miranda’s been waiting for your call, you selfish asshole.”

He faced her and took it like a man. A man who didn’t give a shit what she thought. He cut to the chase. “Is Miranda upstairs?”

Sheryl didn’t say anything but her face passed on a message. He took the hint and headed for the stairs, climbing them in twos. Miranda’s office door was closed. He rapped twice.

She took her time. “Who is it?”

Who the bloody hell was she expecting? “It’s Thomas.”

He counted six seconds before she opened the door. They felt longer. The door eased back with her fingers still at the handle.

“You didn’t ring me.”

He traded an apology for an explanation. “The phones were down and then there was too much going on.” It felt weak, even as he said it, but it was all he had.

She opened her mouth and bared her teeth. "Going on? For all I knew you were dead. At least Karl rang me after you left the pub."

Bloody Karl, sticking his oar in, again. He touched her shoulders and felt warm flesh against his fingertips. "Look, I'm sorry." He forced the words out before he could wrap them in emotion.

"Jesus, Tom, you could have died."

That was the money shot, the salient fact that had circled him all day like a scavenger. Despite his training and experience, it could have all come down to a random, split-second decision to go into work later or take the wrong train across central London.

He realised he'd been holding his breath. Either Miranda was trembling or his hands were shaking, he couldn't tell which. He pulled her close, willing himself to say something that mattered. Trouble was, he'd run out of words that meant anything.

Miranda freed herself and put some distance between them. "Listen, Thomas, I know this is a bit sudden . . . I've thought about it a *hell* of a lot today, and we have talked about it . . . before . . . Oh, sod it, I'm just gonna say it. Will you marry me?"

The words fell at his feet, an untimely gift he didn't know how to return. "You want to get married because a bomb went off?"

Her face turned to stone, her gaze to ice. "You know where the door is."

He closed it carefully behind him. Sheryl started for the stairs as soon as she laid eyes on him. He saw no reason to detain her. A considerate man would have gone back and made amends, or headed home and let his family know that he was safe. Thomas did neither of those things.

Karl picked up on the second ring. "Hey, Tommo, I didn't expect to hear from you again tonight."

That made two of them. "Change of plan. You still on for the club?"

"Absolutely. Do you have your passport?"

Thomas pressed a palm against his jacket. "Always. Now, where do you want to meet?"

Chapter 2

Thomas still recalled that first night out with Karl and his cryptic insistence to 'bring your passport.' Things didn't settle any when he realised it wasn't a strip club or a casino but an exclusive, invitation only, shooting club. The sort frequented by police officers and the military and intelligence services. It had become a regular haunt with Karl. Two friends shooting the breeze, and a range of firearms.

He always told himself it wasn't a macho thing and that the concentration and coordination brought a sense of calm. If you forgot about the weapons, the ammunition and the aroma of hot dust that lingered in your nostrils. Tonight, he needed the whole package. So there he was, waiting for a lift, kicking his heels and trying not to think of Miranda. No good would come of that.

Karl's car pulled up, smooth as satin. "Taxi for Bladen?"

He got in and buckled up. "Cheers, Karl. I thought you might have already left."

"Nah. I've been driving around and thinking too much. Seems like the whole of London is in mourning."

"Yet here we are."

Karl negotiated the streets without his usual commentary.

Thomas reached for the radio and then thought better of it. They already had the news and their own way of coping with it. "How could this happen, Karl?"

There was barely a two-second delay. "Maybe somebody dropped the ball. Or the terrorists weren't on the radar at all, which is a far scarier scenario." They stopped at a set of traffic lights and he turned to Thomas. "Those who've served in the armed forces understand that the world has never been a safe place. Security demands constant vigilance." He broke off from his speech when the lights changed. "Anyway, what changed your mind about tonight? I thought you were seeing the fair Miranda after you left me at the bar?"

"Yeah, she said." He waited for a comment that never came. "I walked to Caliban's, thinking it would clear my head. It didn't."

Karl jabbed at the windscreen. “Take a look out there, Tommy Boy. Everybody’s hurting, so why should you be any different?”

He sighed. “I know. Thing is, when I got to Caliban’s, Miranda proposed.” He paused for the punchline. “She caught me off guard. I wasn’t ready and I sort of dodged the question.”

Karl shook his head slowly. “Never figured you as stupid. She’s put up with a lot of shit over your work these past years. When is the right time?”

Thomas nodded. *Mea culpa*. “I s’pose I wanted to pick the perfect time and do things properly.”

Karl sighed. “Take it from me, there’s no such time. Seize the moment because it can all disappear in a heartbeat.”

Thomas didn’t speak again until they’d cleared the heavy metal door at the club. Karl paid for them both — a rare treat — and selected a Browning. Thomas wasn’t surprised. Karl had his own pair stashed away somewhere in his private collection.

Karl squared up to the paper enemy first. Thomas noticed how little time his partner took to enter ‘the zone,’ as Karl had once called it. Two or three breaths and he was good to go. His face relaxed and the staccato of the first two shots morphed into a slow and steady rhythm while he emptied the magazine. Salvo over, he checked the weapon, set it down and then removed his ear defenders. “That’s better. You’re up.”

Thomas put on the defenders and adjusted his safety glasses. He picked up the Browning in his right hand and it felt at home there. He lifted a fresh magazine from the case and ran his index finger down to check the top shell was aligned. He clicked the magazine in place with the heel of his left hand and then released the slide. Breath followed breath.

He faced the human silhouette, raised the weapon and cupped his gun hand. It seemed a long time at the firing line, but he wasn’t in any rush. He took the first shot with his breath held, so he could feel the release with the second, pumping twelve rounds into the torso. The thirteenth, he loosed at the head. Unluckily, it missed.

Once he’d secured the weapon and declined Karl’s offer of a second magazine or other *equipment* to play with, they returned the case and moved on to the next phase of their evening. It had always struck Thomas as odd that an indoor firing range should have a café, and stranger still that Karl liked to call it the bar.

He took Karl's order and went off for supplies, passing a few regulars that he recognised by sight. One or two nodded in his direction and he considered that an achievement. In three years of coming there, only one person had ever introduced herself — Teresa. One of Karl's colleagues outside the SSU and, for a while anyway, maybe more than that. Tonight, she was nowhere to be seen.

Thomas sat down and tried a distraction technique on Karl, snacks and talk together. "What do you think will happen now?"

Karl stared at a pastry. "Hard to say. The UK's no stranger to terrorist threats, of course, over in the Six Counties or here on the mainland. But this is different, if the rumours turn out to be correct. There has always been a presumption of a Covenant of Security . . ."

Thomas frowned in lieu of a question.

Karl gestured with his hands, circling space. "Basically, a *community* does not attack the society that peacefully coexists with it. Then again, after the Madrid bombings back in March, the rules of engagement have changed."

"You seem remarkably well informed."

Karl bit off a piece of his pastry. "I do my research."

* * *

Thomas got home and found the answering machine flashing wildly for attention — a predictable list. Mum first, followed by his sister, asking why his mobile hadn't picked up. A reminder that he'd changed the number again without telling them. Then Ajit, the only friend from Yorkshire he stayed in touch with, checking he was okay and reminding him that he hadn't heard from him in weeks. After that, Pat had rung a second time, more insistent, telling him in no uncertain terms what a terrible brother — and son — he was on a day like today. No call from Miranda though, which was a mixed blessing.

The clock read *late*. He worked through the call backs, counting on no one wanting chapter and verse after ten pm. Ajit was first on his list and Geena picked up. She didn't waste time on niceties.

"What the bloody 'ell are you playing at? It's been on the news non-stop. I bet Miranda were frantic." She took the hint from his silence.

“Anyway, Ajit’s had to go in and cover a shift. I’ve always said the police is his first family.”

A child caterwauled in the background. Thomas tried counting the months and gave up. He could add being a shit godparent to the list.

Geena’s voice backed away. “Ah bloody told you not to touch that. There, there, sweetheart. Stop yer bawling and Mummy’ll clear it up.” She returned to the phone. “Gotta go, Thomas. Parenthood calls. In’t it about time you and Miranda—”

He cut her off with, “Goodnight, Geena,” and put the phone down.

Chapter 3

Thomas picked up a text three days later from John Wright. It surprised him on two fronts — that it had taken so long and that Miranda’s dad had been cast as peacemaker: Alright, Thomas? Fancy a game of cards at ours on Friday? Seven for seven thirty, and bring some cash. Cheers, John.

He texted back to confirm, rather than risk a friendly interrogation. He had no qualms about going. Aside from the gun club his social life had cooled a few degrees since Miranda raised the drawbridge.

Meanwhile, the days were no better. SSU assignments had often felt like the flotsam and jetsam no other government department wanted to sully its hands with and the current role had sunk them to a new low. According to Christine, the word from on high was short-term assignments only, in readiness for organisational changes. None of which had prepared Thomas and Karl for a stint as temporary National Health Service drivers, couriering patient samples to pathology labs around London. As Ann Crossley put it in an uncharacteristically successful attempt at humour, “Jobs for the boys.”

He navigated around London’s teeming streets, past closed tube stations and herds of commuters on foot. The capital coped, it always did, despite reactionary newspaper headlines, and feverish updates on TV with cutaways to police investigations and shots of ambulances on the day of the tragedy. Some bright spark had said it with graffiti, spraying ‘Make Love Not Terror’ on a railway bridge.

Although London had been home for years he’d considered taking a few days to get back to his native Yorkshire and the moors — clean air, no crowds and some distance between him and that ever-present pall of sadness. Christine made the choice for him by cancelling all leave indefinitely. After all, those shit samples wouldn’t deliver themselves.

Wednesday evening, Thomas met Karl at the Swan. It felt strange them each working solo, and stranger still not to be behind a lens or between a pair of headphones.

Karl slurped his shandy and smacked his lips, the way Thomas hated. “I must know every set of roadworks from here to Marble Arch. How are you finding doing a proper job?”

Thomas pretended Karl was an original thinker. “Never thought I’d miss working in the shadows so soon.”

Karl lowered his glass again. “Yeah you did. It’s been, what, three years since you joined the SSU?”

He smiled. Karl knew full bloody well. “Give or take. Any evening work coming up?”

Karl pulled out his phone, checked the screen and then stuffed it back inside his jacket. “I’ll ask. Maybe tomorrow. Don’t make plans.” His eyes seemed to search for clues.

Thomas saved him the bother. “Not a word from Miranda. Although John’s invited me over on Friday.”

“Yep.” Karl crunched some crisps, missing his own fingernails by millimetres. “Me too.” He paused, mid onslaught. “That all right with you?”

Thomas nodded. Why not? Less chance of a bollocking in front of company.

Karl’s text about private work came through on Thursday, mid-morning. After that, a day spent driving a van around London was just a prelude to the main event. The details were minimal, even by Karl’s standards — a pick-up time near the flat and a destination: Harlow. Again.

Thomas kept to the schedule and met Karl along the street at nine forty-five exactly. Their journey north on the M11 left plenty of time to talk. Thomas got straight to the point. “Why are we back in Harlow?”

Karl made no response at first, which said everything important. “We’re outdoors tonight. I’m on camera work and you’ll be using a directional mike. Instructions in the glove compartment. You can still follow instructions?”

Thirty minutes later they parked up by a row of densely planted pine trees, at the edge of a wood.

“Here’s how this works, Tommo. I’ll take the long way around and I want you to stay parallel to the path.”

Thomas nodded, waiting to make sure Karl had finished talking. “Who the hell meets in the woods at night?” He flexed his gloves and felt for the Makarov pistol in his pocket.

Karl smiled and opened a hand, inviting Thomas to work it out for himself.

“Really? We’re staking out a cruising spot?”

Karl opened the driver's door. "We'll talk about it later if you're that bothered. Meantime, we only have a narrow window of opportunity here."

Thomas gripped Karl's shoulder. "Hang on, we're . . . What? Collecting evidence for blackmail? That's pretty sleazy, even for us."

"You picked a hell of a time to develop a conscience about surveillance work. Look, Tommo," Karl spoke through gritted teeth, "We don't get to pick and choose assignments. Either do your job or stay in the car." He shrugged off Thomas's hand and slipped outside.

Thomas shut the door behind him and stepped into the unknown. He set his headphones asymmetrically, one ear uncovered so he could also hear his surroundings. Twenty steps through the pines he heard a fox's unholy scream somewhere in the murky distance. He waited until he had his breathing back under control and then moved close to the path.

He told himself that he had no issues with consenting adults meeting in the woods at night, whatever their persuasion. After all, he and Miranda had once found an alternative use for a phone box, one wet and steamy night in South London. Even so, this job didn't sit well with him.

Once he heard voices through the headphones, all mental chatter ceased. He dropped to a crouch and arced the microphone slowly to locate the source. Now he had a fix on the sound he could ignore the path and let the signal strength guide him. He heard two voices, speaking low and quiet, and then . . . nothing. A new voice, coy at first, approached one of the men and started talking *business*. And that's where it all went haywire. The way Thomas read it, the third man was expected, unlike one of the others. Someone kept asking for 'my stuff,' over and over, and then came the unmistakable melody of violence.

Karl's voice suddenly called out in the distance.

Thomas figured he'd heard enough. It took two seconds of deliberation. "Sorry, Karl," he whispered to the darkness, straightened up and headed towards the noise. Snooping on shaggers was one thing, but standing idly by to record a beating was not in the job description.

He reached the path, relying on his appearance being enough to stall them, and shouted for good measure. The mike told him it had made sod-all difference so he started running. He hadn't figured out a plan. That could come later. Only . . .

Like every head-on collision, there was barely time to register the other party. In this case, a man-mountain with a gash on one side of his face. The body slam sent Thomas backwards, over a tree root. The human cannonball stopped and turned for a moment, as if considering a rematch, and then reached down to the ground. Thomas figured the bloke was looking for a branch as a weapon, and scrambled to get to his feet. The assailant changed his mind and sprinted across the path, into the pines.

Thomas blinked a few times to try and focus, and then felt the lump at the back of his head. He bent down to retrieve the smashed mike and pondered his next move. Two more blokes still out there, unlikely to welcome his appearance at their evening tryst. He felt inside his pocket for the Makarov. It was gone.

He snapped on his torch and frantically combed the ground. It didn't take long to pick out a gargantuan footprint next to a small indent in the ground. *Bollocks*. Panic started to set in. Had he left prints anywhere on the gun? For a moment he was torn between the desire to get the fuck out of there and the need to complete the job. No mike now, but maybe his own testimony would help Karl.

A few yards on, the only useful information he'd picked up was how much his head hurt. A figure approached with one arm at his side with what looked like a length of rope.

Karl's whistle cut through the night air. "Here, boy. Come on. Enough walkies for tonight. Let's get you home." He set eyes on Thomas, half in the shadows, shook his head and kept walking. "Come on, boy, back to the car now."

Thomas took the hint and worked his way around, waiting for the car to start before he emerged and got in.

"Well, so much for operation entrapment . . ." Karl saw the state of Thomas and his face fell. "Jesus, what happened to you?"

Karl listened to his confession but offered no absolution. "Stupid. Stupid." He banged the steering wheel. "Think. When did you last fire the gun? If it surfaces publicly with your prints on it we'll need an explanation."

Thomas's head was throbbing now, inside and out. He closed his eyes to concentrate. "I, er . . . maybe out on the moors? That time I shot Yorgi." He felt his lips curl. *You never forget your first time.*

Karl deliberated on their next move during the drive back down the M11. “Best case scenario, it’s been taken by an opportunist who wouldn’t want to be placed at the woods either.”

Thomas pencilled details into a notebook. Height: six two, maybe. Build: like a brick shithouse. No accent. Distinguishing features: reddish beard, cut or rash on one cheek. A useless witness statement. He looked up. “And the worst case?”

Karl’s answer was already in the barrel. “The guy you bounced off is in the Security Service, he runs a print found on the gun, and we’re in a world of shit.” He carried on thinking out loud. “I suppose we could say you found the gun in situ, although us being there at all is harder to explain. How many shells in the magazine?”

Thomas touched the back of his head and his nerve ends screamed back. “Four, I think. Did I mention the mike got trashed?”

“I’ll get it looked at to see if anything is recoverable. You understand I need to report this, in case of repercussions. Say nothing to anyone. Not even . . .” Karl saw the look on Thomas’s face and left it there.

Chapter 4

Friday kept Thomas busy. He didn't stop until nearly two pm, when someone at Barts Hospital made him a cup of tea. He sat in the staff room, tea in one hand and a biscuit in the other, looping the previous night's events through his brain. No word from Karl yet, which he read one of two ways, depending upon his mood.

A TV in the corner of the room was set on BBC News 24. The latest update from the events of 07/07 washed over him with no respite, like a dam breach. He sat there and took it full force. Worse was to come.

'News just in . . . an unnamed government minister was involved in a security incident last night. No one has been harmed. There's no official statement but an unconfirmed report suggests a weapon has been recovered from the scene. More on that story when we have it.'

Thomas was halfway across the room when his mobile rang.

"Have you seen the news, Tommo?"

He put his cup down and headed for the door. "Uh-huh. What can you do?"

"What can *I* do?" Karl sounded rattled. "I'll make some discreet inquiries. This could be out of my hands. I'll catch you later."

It seemed natural to ring Miranda, although he hadn't expected Sheryl to pick up instead. "Hey, Thomas. She's not here. I'll tell her you called. Goodbye."

What it was to be popular.

Karl sent through a text later that afternoon: See you at John & Diane's. Try not to worry. Thomas laughed when he read it. Unofficial surveillance on a government minister, possession of an illegal handgun, probable end of his career — if you could call it that — and the threat of prosecution. Yeah, nothing to worry about there.

At a quarter to five a call came through from Christine. She may as well have texted. "Come to my office after your shift."

Perhaps he should have been surprised to find Karl already there, only lately nothing surprised him. Christine's face had all the charm of Medusa.

She sat back from her desk and slapped her skirt, like a teacher calling the class to attention. “Well, Karl?”

Thomas felt a momentary, nostalgic inclination to glance down at her legs. One look at her face killed the impulse. Neither he nor Karl had sat down. It didn’t feel like that kind of meeting.

Karl cleared his throat. “We arrived on schedule and followed the brief. Everything went to plan until the rogue arrival. Then it all fell apart, as detailed in my report.”

Christine turned her gaze on Thomas. “And what have you got to say?”

He counted to three in his head. “It’s all down to me. The bloke came out of nowhere . . . well, you know the rest.”

Her nostrils flared. “And who authorised you to carry an unlicensed firearm? Karl?”

They stood together, mute.

Christine hadn’t finished. “Karl, we pay you well to manage these small-scale assignments under the radar. We expect professionalism.” Her shoulders seemed to rise. “I’ll look into damage limitation, but if you have compromised this operation — either of you — you’re on your own. Do I make myself clear?” She looked as though she’d already made her mind up about the outcome. “Needless to say, payment is withheld until we know where we stand. That’s all.”

They took their cue from the single glance to the door. Thomas waited until they were down in the car park. “Why didn’t you tell me we were working for Christine?”

Karl blinked once. “Would it have made any difference? Listen, Christine might still be able to salvage this.”

Thomas opened his car door. “How do you figure that then?”

“Simple. Burn the operation. Approach the minister to exchange the footage for the weapon. It’s what I’d do.”

He found little consolation in that.

Thomas took pole position on the A12 heading out of London. He reflected on the TV news item and two facts emerged. Whoever had interrupted the alfresco assignation had known about the minister *and* alerted the media to the gun. Logically, that pointed to the Security Service. In which case, who was the third man?

He pondered the possibilities on the car crawl to Dagenham, once part of Essex and long since engulfed by London — now neither fish nor fowl. Even with Friday traffic he made it to John and Diane's ahead of schedule. Thomas parked up at six forty-two and noted the time. He sat there, mulling things over, until Karl tapped on the window. Startled, he made an involuntary move for the gun he no longer had. Karl managed a weak smile on the other side of the glass.

"We going in or what, Tommo?"

Diane welcomed them according to their status. An in-law's kiss for Thomas and an earnest handshake for Karl. Thomas read her face for clues about whether Miranda had spilled the beans and came away empty-handed. It didn't help that Diane was a consummate poker player.

Inside, Terry and Sam, Miranda's brothers, sat glued to a news channel. Thomas left Karl behind with them and sought out the kitchen. Diane wasn't far behind.

She picked up an empty mug. "You making?"

His smile echoed back across the room. "How's Miranda doing?"

She pulled two teabags from a tin. "You can ask her yourself when she gets here. If you two are talking, that is."

He squeezed the life out of his teabag and then added sugar before the milk, stirring like crazy.

"She won't be long." Diane took the milk carton from him. "Sheryl's coming too. They're gonna bring over food from the pub that needs using up." She read him like a poker *fish*. "Sheryl's very loyal where Miranda is concerned." Diane turned back at the doorway. "So how is work at the moment, or can't you say?"

The tea tasted sweet, unlike his mood. "It's . . . complicated."

Diane nodded and went to rejoin the family. Thomas had spotted John's absence on his way in and figured he'd be in his office, but John didn't like to be disturbed. It was a better option than playing happy families though.

Thomas knocked twice and announced himself.

John invited him in. "Good to see you. I gather you're in the doghouse again with Miranda!" John held his hands up. "She don't need me to fight her battles." He eased the chair opposite with his foot. "Park yourself."

They sat for a moment, saying nothing, and then John opened a drawer. Thomas had a flashback to three years before when John had passed a gun

across the desk.

John caught the look on his face and laughed. “Just a bottle this time. Yeah, funny looking back. Not so bloody funny at the time though.” He played magician again and fetched out two glasses.

It would have been rude to decline.

“Never really tried this stuff before. I know you like it so I thought, why not? It’s not bad actually.”

Thomas took a sip and waited for the ball to drop. It didn’t take long.

“You seen much of Jack Langton lately?” John asked.

He let the Southern Comfort linger on his tongue. “Do I need to?”

John smiled. “You’ve always been quick on the uptake. As you know, we don’t hear from Jack anymore.” He raised a glass to Thomas, who had fixed things that way. “But he left a message on my office phone. Said he’d heard a rumour about Sheryl that concerned him.” John let it sit there between them.

“I’m listening.” He watched John’s face redden under the light.

“Jack reckons Sheryl’s gone and got married on the quiet. Only thing is, he put some of his business assets in her name — a while ago. And he wants to protect his interests.”

They sipped their Southern Comforts and John Wright continued.

“So I think Jack is really asking if you could find out whether it’s true and then check the geezer out — like you’ve helped him before. You know Jack. He never does things the easy way.”

Thomas glanced at the ceiling. And now of course, Karl’s people had professional scumbag Jack Langton’s *business* interests on the radar. He took a long, slow breath and then nodded. He couldn’t help noticing how every problem he tried to solve ended up as a more complicated one further down the line.

John shifted in his chair. “Jack has nothing to go on, not even a name.”

He settled on, “Leave it with me,” and took his drink with him to the front room.

The boys were watching a football game with the sound down, and what looked like Russian titles on screen. Clearly, the pirated cable TV business was thriving. More significantly, Karl had the remote control. Now that was acceptance into the clan.

Chapter 5

Terry looked over to the bay window and then turned back to the football. "Sis and Sheryl are here."

Diane led the charge. "Can you give us a hand, Thomas?"

They met the delivery team at the door and welcomed in the aroma of chicken and chips. Miranda passed him a metal catering tin.

"Well, don't just stand there. Chop, chop!" She flashed a smile in his direction and returned to her car.

By the time he'd deposited the goods in the oven, Sheryl was standing beside him. He knew her perfume, but not her motives. Or the company she kept.

She placed a forest of salad on the table, gave her gum a couple of chews and popped a bubble. "Miranda says I ought to cut you some slack, on account of you doing a difficult job right now."

He was halfway through finding an answer when Miranda and her mum entered the kitchen, carrying dessert and wine. Miranda glanced to each of them and then turned her charm level to maximum.

"It's great to see my two best friends getting on so well."

Sheryl popped again. "Isn't it though? Thomas and I were just saying how all the good men are gone these days." She stared, daring him to risk humiliation or fall in line.

He was never very good at making easy choices. "And I always thought you preferred bad boys rather than good men."

She stalled for a moment. Only a moment. "Honey, in my book it can be hard to tell the difference."

Dinner was a raucous event. Arms reached across in a frenzy of food grabs and exchanges, and he and Miranda fought over the last onion ring. It struck Thomas that he was lucky to have this many people in his life he could count on. He raised a toast to family and friends, and took it on the chin when Terry told him he was going soft.

When the time came for poker, the sense of community disappeared like a politician at a polygraph convention. It was every woman and man for themselves. Combat with casino chips. Diane worked the house. She

dealt slow and easy, pausing before the last deal to look over at her youngest son, Sam. He had a smile a mile long.

“Well, go on then, Sam.”

He took a deep breath. “I have an announcement. I’m going to Australia for a month.”

Thomas scanned the faces around the table. Clearly, this was news to some. Miranda looked pained and he could understand why. Sam had a good heart but no filter against the world. His older brother, Terry, was the guiding hand in their business dealings — the breaker’s yard out Canning Town way and those undiscussed trips across the Channel. Sam had only seen two pub gigs before deciding to invest two grand in a band, coincidentally fronted by a pretty brunette, even though the taxman had been baying for his blood.

Karl picked up on the tension. “You not fancy it down under, Terry?”

Terry messed up Sam’s hair. “Me? Nah. Junior can take care of himself this time.”

John popped a can of beer. “So we was wondering, gents, if you two could rig up some security at Sam’s flat. Like you’ve got at your place, Thomas.”

Now the evening made more sense. Family announcement, bridge building and rewiring job. John was nothing if not economical with his time.

“Sure. Let me know when’s good for you, Sam, so Karl and me can pitch up at your place. Actually, it might be better to do it once you’re out of there.”

John downed a mouthful of lager. “Right, that’s sorted then. Let’s play some cards! Come on, Di, last card and then it’s ammo time!”

John’s proficiency with the lingo failed to match his poker skills. He wasn’t a bad player, just not a very good one. Thomas had watched him over the years and he was impetuous, taking poorly calculated risks when he thought he could bluff it. Funny really, because away from the table he was Mr Shrewd.

Thomas felt a sharp nudge from Terry.

“You picking up or what?”

He lifted his cards from the table, widened his eyes for effect and flicked in a couple of poker chips, adding two quid into the mix. Last of the

high rollers. It always gave him immense pleasure to watch how the others played, the way their faces revealed their intentions or masked them. And the furtive glances across the table that suggested temporary alliances or rivalries. Sad to say, Miranda's face wasn't returning his call tonight.

Sheryl had hardly strung a sentence together all evening and her human clam impression looked set to continue. So Thomas singled her out. He waited until he caught her gaze while she did a circuit of the opposition.

"So, what's new in your life, Sheryl?"

A couple of people coughed, in surprise or outrage. Thomas had broken the eighth commandment: Thou shalt not make small talk during poker. John fiddled with his cards, smiling softly. Thomas figured John would let it slide because he wanted a resolution too. Jack Langton might be almost out of the picture but it made sense to keep him sweet if they wanted that to continue.

Sheryl peered over her cards, holding them close to her chest. A living metaphor. "I'm still waiting for a millionaire to sweep me off my feet. Guess that's men for you — no sense of timing." Her eyes wandered to Miranda and then back to Thomas. "What about you? What are you waiting for?"

Thomas felt the heat at his face and retreated to his cards. A queen and a pair of sevens, and nothing else to crow about. But he'd never been a quitter. He reached for a couple more chips. "I'm in."

He equated poker with politics. Winning was a matter of choosing your battles, reading other people, playing the odds and having the muscle when it counted. Both sports took patience and guile. He only had the stomach for one of them. However, two hours on he'd been cleaned out — in one sense, anyway. There were gains of a different kind. Sheryl's deflections suggested she either knew about Jack Langton's interest in her personal life or it was a hot topic at the moment. Sam's trip halfway around the world meant he'd need to make more of an effort to see Diane and John. Whatever his standing with Miranda, and only a daily barometer check could tell for sure, he was still a surrogate son.

Round about eleven, Karl gave Thomas a prearranged signal, a look that conveyed a handful of sentences without wasting a word.

Thomas took the hint and stretched his arms back. "Time I was leaving." He withstood the critics and said his goodbyes.

Karl then made his own excuses. Miranda, Thomas noted with a mixture of disappointment and disdain, didn't budge. It was left to Diane to suspend the game and see them out.

At the front door she laid a hand on Thomas's shoulder. "You know what Miranda is like. She'll come around in her own good time. I'll remind Sam in the morning to sort out a day for wiring up the flat. Or he can leave you a spare set of keys."

Karl didn't speak again until they reached their cars. "Thanks, Tommo. I never like to outstay my welcome. I've been thinking — about the surveillance we ballsed up."

Thomas smiled at the 'we.'

"Maybe I can run a picture of the third man past some friends, if I still have any. See what floats to the surface?"

Thomas drew his own conclusion: Karl kept copies of his work too.

Chapter 6

A week later, on the twenty-first of July — two weeks to the day since the 07/07 bombings rocked London and the world — Thomas and Karl were back at their Liverpool Street base at lunchtime, watching another nightmare scenario unfold outside. Three Underground trains and one double-decker bus were targeted again, but mercifully this second wave of terrorist attacks failed to cause significant damage or injury. Except it didn't take physical suffering to cause trauma.

This time Christine sat out in the main office with them, a spare chair pushed up against Ann's desk. When he looked back on that time, Thomas recalled how Christine's thoughts seemed to be somewhere else. Had he known the location, he might have taken a different course of action.

At five o'clock, Christine thawed a little. "Anyone fancy staying on for a while? Chinese takeaway — my treat." She reached into her wallet and pulled out a fifty. "Karl, Ann, why don't you keep one another company?"

Karl met her outstretched hand and waited for Ann by the door. Once they were gone, Christine made a beeline for her office. Thomas listened to her rummage in a filing cabinet, returning with two bottles and a corkscrew.

She passed him an unopened malt whisky. "An old present from Sir Peter. For a special occasion."

The corkscrew slipped in her hand and he thought about intervening, but remembered her disapproval of his Galahad tendencies. He'd never forget her changing her Merc's flat tyre on a point of principle, one summer's drive long ago. She'd emerged from a crouching position, smudged and bleeding, with a look of pure triumph on her face. "Done," she'd declared, as if it had ever been in any doubt.

He gave the bottle cap a sharp twist. "What's the occasion?"

"Does there have to be one? We're a good team, the four of us. And days like today bring that back into focus." She extracted the wine cork with measured ferocity. "We hardly talk these days. How are things with you and Miranda?"

"Not so great." He saw no reason to lie. The two women hadn't spoken for a long time, which suited everyone.

“Sorry to hear that. This job plays havoc with a private life.” She paused and looked up, as if daring him to ask whether Bob Peterson was still in her life with his wife in the background.

No sale today. He swiped out with his ID card and went to the office kitchen in search of glasses or cups. On his way back, with a collection of kitchenware in a cardboard box, he picked up Karl’s text: WTF? He was still smiling when he closed the main door behind him.

She held out her hand for a glass. “Good news?”

“Just Karl being a dick.” He glanced at the computer screen and clicked off the news. “Is everything alright with you, Chrissie?” He’d shortened her name during the year they spent as a mismatched couple, when Miranda had abandoned him for a job in Bermuda.

He still liked to use *Chrissie* from time to time to test her mood or to goad her. Sometimes it amounted to the same thing. Today, he was on good ground.

Judging by the label, the wine looked expensive. She took a tiny sip. “Do you ever wonder what you might have become, if you hadn’t met Sir Peter in the lift and started talking about photography?”

He poured himself an angel’s share of whisky and revelled in its warmth. This was a conversation they’d had several times with no resolution. In practical terms he’d never have met Christine, or Karl, or any of them. And yet, knowing what he knew now, Karl’s *professional* interest in Jack Langton’s business dealings may have moved through Sheryl to Miranda and then to him. This way, at least he’d stayed the right side of the lens.

She was still waiting, gently moving her chair from side to side. Watching him watching her. He enfolded his glass and shrugged.

“I suppose I made my choice the first weekend I worked for Sir Peter. Surveillance by the sea! Did I ever tell you about it?” He knew full well he hadn’t. “I drove down to Brighton in the early hours to film a politician. He wasn’t well known, three years ago.” A thought landed on his desk. The Babes in the Wood escapade with Karl wasn’t so different, give or take a chromosome. He stared into his drink. “You sure everything’s okay?”

A lift door pinged outside. The takeaway team had returned. Ann swiped in and held the door for packhorse Karl.

“Tommo, make some room and ready the plates, there’s a good lad.”

“Bloody hell, Karl, that was quick.”

“All down to intelligence. The trick is to ring first and then collect, and promise a tip if it’s quick.” He eased down two bulging bags of Sino-deliciousness and then extracted a fistful of currency from his pocket. “Christine, here’s your change.”

Food and drink were swiftly relocated to a spare desk, which they surrounded. The inevitable topic of conversation was the latest terror threat and hypothetical responses.

Karl’s solution was stark. “Shoot to kill. Simple as.” He crammed in a forkful of chow mein. “They’re willing to die for a cause? Fair enough.” The audience needed convincing. “Listen, people, unlike you desk jockeys,” he smiled to soften the blow, “I’ve been on the front line. The rules of engagement are pretty unambiguous. You pose a threat, you will be dealt with.” He held on to the metaphorical mike. “Every one of you has picked up a gun. In a given situation you’d do it without hesitation.”

Ann stabbed her fork into a water chestnut. “True. But I prefer not to think of it.”

Christine waited until Thomas and Karl had cleared away the debris of the meal. “I won’t be around tomorrow, so use the opportunity to get all your paperwork up to date. Be here at eight on Monday. No excuses.” Her gaze lingered in Karl’s direction.

Ann went over to a window, opened it and lit up a cigarette. Thomas looked on, incredulous. In three years he’d never known that she smoked. Come to that, he still knew next to nothing about her.

Just before lights out and lock-up, Christine faced the three of them. “I just want to say . . .” She stopped, as if she hadn’t considered the rest of the sentence. Only Thomas knew her better than that.

“You’re a good team. *We* are a good team.”

Karl placed a hand at his heart and leaned back a little. “Back atcha, boss.”

Chapter 7

Monday morning at seven thirty, Thomas trudged out of Liverpool Street station complex, still half asleep. He reflected on Thursday's team meal and the 'last supper' vibe. Coupled with Christine's absence on Friday and a mandatory early start today, it all added up to one thing — trouble.

He reached street level and stepped into the road to outpace the pedestrian herd, preferring to take his chances beside the kerb. And yes, he was looking out for strangers wearing rucksacks while simultaneously realising that everyone was a stranger. The fun didn't stop there. As he entered the building the lift was already taken so he opted for the stairs and immediately encountered a rabble making their way up to the second floor.

He took his turn, following the invaders until they reached the main office door, which he noted was wedged open.

Karl met his eyes through the melee. "Welcome to the party. I take it you haven't heard? I'm surprised Ann Crossley hasn't stood at the door handing out invitations. The coach will be here at eight fifteen, ready or not."

Thomas counted heads. It felt like the Christmas gatherings of childhood, where friends, neighbours and uninvited family crowded your home. He glanced around to see if he knew anyone. All the chairs were occupied, apart from Karl's, and some of those bastards were perched on the edge of his desk. He detoured to Karl's chair, which was covered in hazard tape, and the man himself squeezed in to cut the tape and sit down.

"Jaysus, Tommo. They've cleaned us out of milk chocolate."

"Where's Christine?" He breathed a little easier when he saw her head through the glass panel at the end of the room. His peace of mind lasted a full four seconds, until he saw another head beside hers. Bob Peterson. "What the fuck is he doing here?"

Karl winked. "Came up last night, so my spies tell me."

Thomas noticed Ann muscling through.

She nodded curtly, among guests. She was in her element and it felt toxic. "Morning, chaps. Seems to be a good turnout."

He managed a headcount of twenty plus, crammed in together. “They’ve made Liverpool Street one of their pick-up points. Is that insensitive or moronic?”

Karl slipped a Twix finger from its wrapper and broke it in two. “According to Ann here,” he passed her the other half, “The Old Man did it deliberately as a show of strength and two fingers to circumstance.”

She blushed. “That’s only what I’ve heard.”

Yeah, Thomas thought, but her hearing was pretty good and she knew where to stand. Ann went off to mingle and it struck him then how many faces she seemed to recognise and respond to. Polite chitchat, oiling the wheels of office politics. That one was going places, no doubt about it.

Christine left the safety of her office with Bob Peterson bringing up the rear. Karl felt it his moral duty to point out the metaphor, or analogy, or whatever it was. Thomas told him to piss off. He no longer had designs on Christine — that was ancient history. But he still didn’t want to see her with an asshole like Bob Peterson.

Bob raised his arms and clapped three times to capture everyone’s attention. When he was done applauding himself he stepped back to give Christine centre stage.

Karl leaned across and whispered in Thomas’s ear. “What a prick.”

Christine spoke above a sea of heads. “The coach is downstairs. Everyone, quick as you can please.”

Outside, the coach idled, its engine chipping away at the ozone layer. Thomas spotted their MI5 neighbour, Rupee Tagore, already on board. She gave him a cursory wave, like royalty. He filed that in his head for later.

Thomas noted the destination read PRIVATE, which seemed about right. The very front and rear were already filled, leaving the no man’s land of the middle vacant. He smiled as another metaphor flicked at a synapse. Two seats at the very front, no doubt set aside for Christine and Bob, had ‘reserved’ cards across them.

He was about done sneering when he noticed two colleagues from the SSU’s London West team — Iqbal and Malone. Not work friends exactly, as he’d never bothered to find out their first names, and renowned for being another dynamic duo. She was Irish, *proper* Irish as Karl had once said, from the Republic. All Thomas could say about Iqbal was that he was a British Muslim. So much for intelligence gathering.

Malone waved a hand. "There's two behind and one across from us." She smiled and Thomas found himself smiling back.

Once they were seated, Iqbal leaned across. "Where's the rest of your team?"

Ann fielded the question. "Still on loan. I don't think we'll ever see them again."

Karl joined in. "Well, maybe today. But how will we recognise them?"

Thomas left them to it and stared out the window, watching commuters pass along the street. London life seemed to have found its mojo again. For the lucky ones, anyway. He heard the hiss of the hydraulics and looked along the aisle, stretching his neck to catch a glimpse of Christine. Then he sat back to enjoy the ride.

Half an hour later, after detouring for a pick-up at Clerkenwell, being overtaken by bicycle couriers and babies in strollers, the coach crossed the Thames. They rounded Parliament Square Garden and for a moment, Thomas wondered if Sir Peter had arranged a tour of the Houses of Parliament. But the final destination turned out to be the Queen Elizabeth II Centre nearby.

The fleet of coaches decanted with military precision. By his reckoning, Thomas figured the headcount came to around three hundred people.

Ann interrupted his conversation with Karl, pausing to wave to someone she'd recognised. "I make it nearer four." She stepped lightly, at ease among the wider SSU family.

After the obligatory queue to get into the conference building, the name checks against an electronic list and the ceremonial issuing of a temporary badge, Thomas steered Karl to one side so they could people watch together.

Ann floated beside them. "Any sign of Christine?"

Thomas took in the hordes again. "Nah. Bob's done a flit too." He regretted it immediately because he knew Karl would use it as a set-up line.

"Best check the cubby holes then."

Ann straightened her badge. "Bob's not so bad — workwise, I mean." She stared right back at Thomas. "It's Christine's life. Right, Karl, you go rustle up three coffees. I need a wee."

The masses carried their complimentary coffees into the conference room, where instrumental music set the tone, understated but stirring.

Karl nudged Thomas. “Sounds like the Elgar playlist. I never knew we had a theme tune.”

Thomas swatted at Karl’s face. He wasn’t in the mood. His eyes flickered over a sea of heads. Where the bloody hell was Christine? He saw Bob Peterson arrive alone and amble down towards the front. No doubt his Southampton team had saved him a cushion.

The music lowered with the lights. When the eclipse had passed, Thomas spotted three figures at the edge of the stage. Hard to pick out faces so close to the curtain.

Sir Peter Carroll, director general of the Surveillance Support Unit, stood behind the rostrum, bathed in lilac light like a pork chop in a supermarket. He waited, centre stage, ready to make his address. Thomas silently counted him in.

The Old Man cleared his throat and approached the mike. “Ladies and gentlemen, I want to thank you for attending today. I know some of you have had long journeys to be here. I need hardly remind you of the recent events that have necessitated this gathering.” He worked the room like an old time preacher, every sentence and pause delivered flawlessly. When he stopped speaking, the room held one collective breath, waiting for him to continue.

“We have been called upon to play our part in the nation’s response to seven-seven. Requests have been made at the highest level to secure our services.”

Thomas noticed rows of people unconsciously leaning forward, as if mesmerised. Having seen Rupee on the coach it wasn’t hard to guess the punchline, especially as Karl had written it down and shown it to him.

“Therefore, with immediate effect, our department will be at the disposal of the Security Service. Those of you on high priority assignments — some of whom could not be released today due to operational needs — will conclude them as soon as is practicable. Your managers will discuss individual cases.” He paused, and the lighting changed to three beams of red, white and blue. “We may work in the shadows, but we are now on the front line.”

Spontaneous applause erupted from the front rows and rippled backwards like a shockwave. Ann, seated to Thomas’s right, was ahead of

the curve and he reasoned there was little value in dissent. He leaned to his left as the happy clappers got into their stride.

“Karl, own up, did you know this was coming?”

“Not guilty, Tommo. It’s news to me too.”

Sir Peter drank in their approval for what seemed an eternity before raising a hand. He sighed the words, “Thank you,” and glanced off stage. “There will be some organisational changes and we will try to combine adjacent teams wherever possible.” The lights reverted to lilac. “Now, as part of that process it gives me great pleasure to introduce our new acting deputy director general of the SSU, Ms Eva Fairfield.”

He opened a welcoming arm to the right wing, which Thomas found strangely apposite.

“Many of you will recall Eva’s sterling work at the Home Office.”

Thomas felt the blood drain from his face. Eva Fairfield. He and Karl had brought her down from her lofty tower, following the untimely deaths of two child killers. Not something she’d have added to her CV. Sir Peter had also been implicated up to his university tie. Thomas felt the air move and Karl leaned in to whisper, “Fuck.”

Eva approached the mike and seemed to sweep across the audience. Thomas wondered if she was looking for anyone in particular. She delivered a Churchillian speech, concluding with her eagerness to play a lead role and make things happen. Thomas figured that was probably what she thought the last time their paths had crossed, when she’d instigated capital punishment by proxy.

Sir Peter moved in close for the charm offensive and they stood together on stage — the world’s least funny double act. Thomas glanced to his right and, sure enough, Ann was adding to her notes. He expected nothing less from her, or better.

A Q&A session used up twenty minutes of oxygen with very little return, mostly so the suck-ups could make themselves known. A final round of polite applause led to lunch and a chance to meet other teams. Thomas continued the hunt for Christine and steered well clear of Sir Peter and Eva. It seemed to him that the event was in need of a good photographer. Ironic, given all the surveillance staff present.

By two thirty they’d endured a mini-lunch and more presentations from underlings, including Bob Peterson’s attempts to make merry with a slide

pack. Someone from MI5 did the closing speech. She spoke in generalities, adjusting her glasses while she jogged through a well-prepared list. No one applauded now. The coaches left by three.

Thomas moved pieces of information around in his head, hoping to form a picture. Christine had covered assignments personally before, at short notice. This felt different. Not a word that morning, not even eye contact. Was it worth risking a call to Bob Peterson? He smiled to himself as traffic regrouped around them. He could always ask Mrs Peterson.

Chapter 8

Thomas cornered Ann about Christine when they stepped off the coach at Liverpool Street. He figured she had to know more.

She blushed but held her composure. “Well, all the XO’s stayed on.” She pushed past him to go inside.

Karl caught up on the stairs. “Tommo, I’m surprised the Old Man never sought you out today. What with you being one of his favourites.”

Karl and Ann enjoyed the joke. Thomas let it slide. So what if he had been interviewed personally by the Old Man and still got the occasional summons to Whitehall for menial jobs? Eva’s seat at the top table would surely put an end to that.

Rupee was waiting in the office. Iqbal and Malone followed them up. Thomas assumed the rest of the London West team had been reallocated elsewhere.

Rupee drew first blood. “Hi, again. I’ll be your liaison point for assignments with—”

Iqbal wasn’t feeling the love. “So MI5 is in charge of us now?”

She stared him down. “Absolutely not. Your chain of command is unchanged. Well, apart from . . .”

Thomas followed her gaze to Ann, whose blank expression told its own story. Somebody hadn’t received the memo.

Rupee took the hint and threw an arm around her, like a hostage taker. “Ann, why don’t we go and have a chat in the back office?”

Karl filled the void by conjuring up four vending machine drinks of indeterminate origin and Thomas made their new teamies comfortable around a spare desk. While Karl went back for biscuits, Thomas tried to bond, which was hard without knowing their first names.

Malone cupped her plastic cup like a crystal ball. She smiled suddenly and lifted her head. “Most people call me Molly — you know, Molly Malone. It’s not my *actual* name. I’ll write that down for you.”

Karl dumped an assortment of sugary snacks on the desk. “What are we doing here?”

Thomas passed him a piece of paper: AOIFE. “It’s an intelligence test. Pronounce that.”

Iqbal had evidently seen the trick before. He sat back, took a bite of chocolaty goo and watched the show. Karl narrowed his eyes in concentration. Thomas assumed he was trying to recall Gaelic for Beginners. It took a few moments.

“Ee-fa,” Karl announced with a flourish.

She clapped. “Sure, Malone is fine. Or Molly. It’s mainly family use my real name.”

Iqbal relaxed and offered a handshake. “I’m Fareed — to my friends.”

Karl took another hit of caffeine. “Well, us you know. Question is,” he looked over to the back office, “what don’t we know?”

Thomas’s coffee was still warm when Rupee and Ann left their sanctuary. Rupee made a beeline for the door in as few words as possible.

Ann waited until the door closed and then took a huge breath, as if she might burst into song. “Sir Peter has asked me to head up the team while Christine is away.”

Thomas sensed the glow around her like a heat haze and he always liked to oblige a lady.

“If you’re in charge now, where is Christine?”

“I don’t have that information.”

Her face told him nor would he.

Christine’s desk phone rang. Ann flinched for a moment and then rushed back to answer it. She didn’t bother returning across the threshold.

“Thomas, Karl, you need to get over to Whitehall. Now.”

* * *

They made it to Main Building just before the rain came down.

Thomas sheltered outside, searching for his ID. “Maybe she’s on an assignment and the Old Man has some answers for us.”

Karl scratched his neck. “Why would he bother?”

Inside, they took turns to identify themselves by ID and hand scan. One of the security staff was already standing by to escort them.

It didn’t take a detective to notice Karl’s unease. Thomas clocked him taking in their surroundings like a newcomer. Karl fascinated him in the way that a magician captivates their audience. Not the tricks, although Karl

had pulled off a few of those in the past three years. No, the man himself, usually so in control of the magic around him. Unlike now.

The lift doors closed and the escort cast a glance to Karl. “Armed forces, am I right?”

Karl’s face lifted. “Yeah, army. You?”

“Marines.”

Thomas knew he wouldn’t feature in the conversation. Maybe he carried himself a different way, or — as one of Karl’s colleagues once said — he smelt wrong. Whatever the case, he’d never been mistaken for Queen and Country. He passed the time in his head while the lift climbed to the top floor. The other two talked in military staccato, swapping geographical locations and tours. Thomas wondered if they’d start comparing tattoos.

When the lift doors opened again, the bubble burst and all banter ceased. Thomas walked behind them, measuring the journey in easy steps — two parts déjà vu, and one part vague interest that the Old Man had sent for them both.

The marine knocked twice and then turned. The light flickered across his face, illuminating faded scars and thread veins. This was a man that life had fucked with and come off second best. Thomas would have put money on the two of them saluting, but Karl opted for a handshake.

Karl faced the badge. “Glad you made it to the other side, Andy.”

“You too, Karl.”

The ex-marine marched by and filled the corridor. Thomas stood aside.

Karl reached for the door handle. “Shall we?”

The door swung in and Thomas took the lead. His eyes delivered a punch to his guts. Eva Fairfield faced them across the desk like a chess champion. She skipped any pleasantries and nodded to the two chairs she’d prepared earlier.

Thomas sat down and gave the room the once over. Nothing had changed. The oil painting of Churchill still hung on the wall, casting judgement. A spitfire paperweight sat on Sir Peter’s desk, serving no purpose other than to take up space. Sure, he’d got it from his first appearance there — Sir Peter was a man who valued tradition. When he wasn’t entangled with the Shadow State, anyway. Or maybe that was just a different tradition — of commerce and expediency before democracy.

The look on Karl's face told Thomas all he needed to know. This meeting wasn't on the radar.

Karl sounded unsure. It didn't suit him. "How did this happen?"

Eva's pupils grasped for light. "How? You put me here." Her eyes fixed on Thomas. "When you forced me to leave the Home Office."

Thomas was having none of it. "Are you for real? You caused — no, *arranged* for — the deaths of two people. You, a government minister." He nearly said *ex-minister*, but now was not the time for smart remarks.

Eva glanced at Karl and her face seemed to soften, as if she'd found a cleft in their defences. "They were child killers. Who's to say how many children I've saved?"

Karl slouched a little in his seat — a classic conciliatory posture. Thomas didn't buy it for a second. What was it Sun Tzu said in the Art of War? A smile danced upon his lips. *He who knows when he can fight and when he cannot will be victorious*. He wondered what Karl had in mind. He didn't have to wonder for long.

Eva huffed. She sounded disappointed. Maybe she'd been expecting more opposition from them.

Thomas threw her a lifeline, softly spoken. "What do you need from us?"

She smiled at that and he smiled back. Need implied assistance, rather than obedience.

"Two weeks ago, I received an invitation to work alongside Sir Peter. I suppose he felt he owed me. I certainly did. Now I find he has taken an unspecified leave of absence, for personal reasons. And I'm left with this poisoned chalice."

Thomas felt his skin prickle. First Christine and now Sir Peter. Then he realised Eva hadn't finished. He tuned back in.

"Frankly, I need eyes and ears around our MI5 colleagues. The new arrangement is not an entirely amicable one."

Karl nodded as if he were taking mental notes.

"I know I can rely on the two of you because we hold one another's secrets. And now this office is mine I can access your sealed file, Karl. You'll probably know about it if I do but by then . . ." She clapped her hands as if crushing a moth. "Well, I'm sure there are things you'd rather I didn't know." She shifted her gaze. "And as for you, Thomas, there'll be

something of interest in your file. There usually is. Maybe in your personal life?" She leaned on one arm of her chair and cupped her chin. "That will be all. For now." Thomas had reached the door when she stirred again. "One more thing. The executive order that keeps the two of you working together? I could easily override it. Do we all understand one another?"

Karl swallowed. "Crystal clear, ma'am."

Andy was waiting by the lift. Karl used the ten paces to good effect.

"It's this simple, Tommo. She needs us more than we need her. If she becomes obstructive, we burn her. Okay?"

Thomas didn't think he needed to reply.

Chapter 9

It took less than a week to realise that working alongside MI5 would be no bed of roses. While Karl's assertion that, "We're playing with the big boys now," was factually accurate, it was still MI5's game and their ball. No surprise that SSU personnel were assigned all the shifts deemed 'supplementary,' which equated to 'nothing expected to happen.'

One week on, Eva had kept her word, leaving the two of them intact as a team. In return they had started looking for sympathetic and unsympathetic colleagues across the divide. So far the list was heavily stacked against them.

Life revolved around secondary surveillance of homes, workplaces and meeting places. When not in the field they swapped their cameras for telephone records, Automatic Number Plate Recognition data and photo searches. They were adrift in a sea of information. On the upside, Molly and Fareed started to feel like part of the team. Which was just as well because their MI5 chums preferred their own company.

After a week and a half — Day Eleven on Thomas's calendar — Ann called Karl and Thomas back to Liverpool Street after their shift. Four thirty in the afternoon, having battled against the swathes of office staff keen to escape the heat and sweat of the city.

They passed the neglected vending machine and pushed the double doors. The first thing Thomas noticed was the absence of Christine's scent. In its place he detected a faint odour of body spray. It summed Ann up perfectly — functional and inoffensive, it did the job. The back office had changed in small ways — chairs now evenly spaced around the circular table, a desk clear of any distractions and adorned with Ann's legendary stationery set. A cynic might wonder whether Ann ever expected to vacate the room.

Karl hadn't quite got on board with Ann running the show. "No Rupee today? Perhaps she'll let herself in later."

Ann finished sorting through paperwork. "Actually, I thought it best to delay her. Please sit down." She carried across a notepad, her thumb against the cover to keep its secrets. "There's no easy way to say this. There's a

rumour circulating that Christine has left her post and defected to the Shadow State.” She glanced at the empty fourth chair, as if it might have answers.

Thomas gave it a second’s consideration. “Bollocks. I don’t believe it.”

Ann flattened her hand on the notepad. “I’d be inclined to agree, except that no one has heard from her.” She paused. “Not even Bob Peterson. He got in touch to corroborate what I’d been told.”

Thomas bit at a thumbnail. “Which is?”

“Someone very like her was seen — briefly — in Bonn. She managed to elude any good cameras and what we do have is at best inconclusive. She’s not a field agent so why would she be in Germany?”

Karl cast a thin smile. “It’s a bit early for Oktoberfest.”

Thomas shut him down with a look and met Ann head-on. “Who says so?”

“You must appreciate I can’t tell you that.”

He tilted back in his chair. “You buying this, Karl?”

Ann leaned in to close the gap, casting her shadow across the table. “How well do you really know Christine? You think because you’ve slept with someone that makes them trustworthy? I’ve found the opposite to be the case.”

Touché. For once, he was speechless.

Karl wasn’t. “We need to be sure, one way or the other, because of the consequences.”

She flipped open her notepad with a flourish. “Agreed. Only I can’t sanction any activity I’d have to account for officially. Probably best you don’t either.”

Thomas ran his hands over his face, the way a child plays hide and seek badly. The world still waited beyond his fingers. “Why would she, knowing what she knows?”

Ann’s smile blended condescension and pity. “Precisely that, because of what she knows. Maybe she’s been offered a better deal — more money or influence. Or maybe they have something on her.” She glanced down her list. “What did she say that day we had the Chinese meal? She seemed keen for the two of you to be alone.”

He racked his brains. “Nowt, but she was bothered about something. I can always tell.”

Ann tore out a couple of pages and passed them to Karl. "It's hard to be objective when you've had a close personal connection."

He didn't have an answer for that. Not one that wouldn't have wounded Ann, and right now she and Karl were the only other people invested in finding out the truth about Christine's disappearance. "So, what do we do?"

She nodded to Karl, who followed her notes. "Christine left her work mobile in her desk, along with her ID card. Her personal mobile has been off since the conference."

Thomas clutched at a straw. "What about her flat?"

There was that smile again, the one that made his knuckles ache. "I thought you two could take a drive over there. I've written down her new address and phone number."

Karl showed him a page and he read the Hampstead address. Serious money, which would never have come from a civil service salary.

"If we treat her as a possible missing person, what about local CCTV and traffic cams? Can you call in any favours?"

Ann shook her head. "I'd have to sign off a request. And no police involvement, obviously." She shot a look Thomas's way, conscious of his friend Ajit serving with the North Yorkshire Police.

They faced one another in silence, all talked out and all avenues explored. Ann checked her watch and sat back, squarely on the fence.

Thomas got up first. "Give Rupee our regards." He meant it.

Chapter 10

Thomas switched his phone back on by the lift and a text flashed up: Dinner? Mx.

Karl read over his shoulder. “I, er, hate to burst your bubble but we need to get going.”

Thomas was still concocting an apology to Miranda when Rupee passed by. She looked surprised to see them. After some hasty re-editing, Thomas went with: Sorry. A work thing came up. I’ll call you when I’m done. Tx

He slipped the phone into his pocket on the journey down. By the time they reached the outside world another text had arrived. He had expected Miranda to reply with a putdown or a come-on. He was wrong on all counts.

A summons by text surprised him, but the sucker punch was the name at the end: Francesca Gerrard. Christine’s mother. An unexpected displeasure, although it might shed light on her daughter’s whereabouts. He passed Karl his phone, postponed their jaunt over to Christine’s flat, and caught the train back to Walthamstow for his car. He confirmed to Mrs Gerrard on the way.

Twin voices duelled in his head. The cynic insisted that if Francesca had anything to say she would have done it over the phone. The optimist thought she had her reasons for wanting to tell him face to face. Cynic and optimist — he figured he needed them both tonight.

Francesca required careful handling. They’d never seen eye to eye when he and Christine had been involved — coincidentally, the same year that Miranda spent in Bermuda. The drunken pass Mrs Gerrard had sent his way that Christmas he spent at the big house hadn’t helped matters. Thinking about it now, while he drove out of London, still managed to bring blood to his cheeks. Francesca innocently offering to show him some of the other rooms while Christine went out for a ride. Like a chump he’d let her play tour guide, balancing her prejudices with a glass in her other hand. Oh, she’d laid it on with a trowel — the paintings, the history and the antiques fit for nothing but gathering dust. And then the view from an upstairs room

that he just *had* to see, a view with a difference. Maybe she tried her luck with all of Christine's boyfriends, or maybe it had been a test. She'd stumbled, flinging her arms around him for support, pulling him into a whole heap of trouble. Naturally, he'd set her straight and tried to make a joke of it. *Mind how you go, lass, people will start talking.* She probably didn't even remember now, but he'd never forgotten. If it was true that your life flashed before your eyes it was a highlight he hoped to skip.

The car squeezed through the gates to the estate and Thomas unconsciously hunched in. It could have been the weight of the chip on each shoulder. He dropped the car down to second gear to take in the grounds on his way to Gerrard Hall, as he still thought of it. Not quite rolling hills but more land than a Sunday football league would ever see. Enough to entertain the horses and keep Francesca insulated from the real world. Some poor bastard had even manicured the grass this far out from the house. Either that or they'd brought in some rare breed of sheep to do the job, no doubt funded by an EU grant. He laughed at his own disdain, aware that he was already psyching himself down for the reunion.

He took his time coming up the driveway. One of the staff waited at the great door, watching his car stain the gravel. A perfect, condescending statue until he slammed the car door behind him.

"This way, sir. You are expected."

Thomas fell in step, through a side door and along a bare corridor to a reception room. The oak-panelled door was already ajar and he pushed it slowly, a final delaying tactic.

Francesca Gerrard occupied half of a two-seater sofa, so naturally he sat elsewhere and waited for her to come to life. She wore a long string of pearls, probably the same ones as the last time he saw her. And when was that now? Years, it seemed. She must be desperate to ask for the help of a prole. Christine's father was a different matter entirely. They'd at least been civil with one another. Thomas knew that he worked for the Foreign Office, which was also where Christine's loyalties lay outside of the Surveillance Support Unit. No sign of Pater today though. Interesting.

Mrs Gerrard toyed with her pearls. "Thank you for coming, Thomas. I realise my message must have seemed a little cryptic." She paused and gave him a paper-thin smile.

In the silence that followed he asked himself questions. How did she get his number? That was easy — Christine. So why would she want her mother to have it? And the third strike, what was so important to tell him that she couldn't trust to a phone line? He heard music, echoing from another room. Classical or baroque, but either way beyond his comprehension. Christine had tried unsuccessfully to instil a little culture in him during their mismatched year together. He'd learned two things — caviar was a taste he'd failed to acquire and Grieg got her juices going. So much for finishing school.

He sat on a single chair, facing Francesca across an antique coffee table, studying how she handled her beads. Almost like a rosary.

"Thomas, I need your help. That is, I would like your assistance."

A soft rap on the door reintroduced the butler, carrying a tray. He made himself useful and then made himself scarce. Francesca poured the tea into china cups and then took a breath.

"I want you to find my daughter. Naturally, I will pay you."

He rolled the word 'naturally' around on his tongue and found it bitter to the taste. "Surely your husband is better placed, working at the Foreign Office?" He smiled then, more at his own moral failings, because although he'd said the right thing, what he really wanted to know was how much his services commanded.

"Edgar has tried official channels — discreetly, you understand."

He understood perfectly. "You think she's at risk?"

And there was her smile again, sharp enough to cut skin. "I think you may have more success than Edgar."

His next sentence left his mouth before he'd cleared it for take-off. "Maybe she doesn't want you to know where she is."

"Perhaps so. That's what I need you to find out."

He poured in a little milk and said nothing when she added lemon to her tea.

"Tell me everything you know."

Notebook at the ready, he took dictation. And when she'd talked herself out, he asked about the things he needed to know. Christine had missed her twice-weekly calls since the day before the conference. There'd been no activity on a bank account she shared with her mother, but Francesca couldn't say about any other finances.

Her eyes flashed. "I don't care whether it's connected with her work, or if it's a private matter." And by the glower on her face, she wasn't a fan of Bob Peterson either.

He gulped down his tea. "I'll be in touch."

"Here." She waved a folded piece of paper. "My personal number at the house. You have my mobile from the text. I don't suppose you'd take a cheque?" She smiled again, back on her lofty perch.

He edged the divide and took the number. "Cash only."

She retrieved a bag from beneath her chair. "I thought you might say that."

It looked ugly on the antique table, as out of place as he felt. He paused and stared at the unopened bag, wondering how he was going to pull this off.

Francesca tapped the bag twice. "Five thousand now and another five when I know where she is."

He picked up the bag and saw himself out. There were no footsteps behind him.

Chapter 11

He rang Miranda from the grounds, staring at a horse and rider galloping in the distance. His call went straight to message so he didn't bother leaving one. Only a fool would feel pissed off that her life didn't pause for his work, but that never stopped him.

In contrast, Karl picked up on the third ring. "What's the score, Tommo?"

Five thousand. "Mrs Gerrard is in the dark as well. She's concerned, though. And wants me to investigate on her behalf. She's, er, paying me ten grand to do the job."

"No offence . . . why you?"

Thomas heard a buzzard's cry and looked up to see crows mobbing the raptor.

"Tommo, you still there?"

"Yeah, I'm thinking." Why choose someone you can't abide? Because *he* wouldn't spare her feelings and what she wants is information. "Christine's dad drew a blank with his Foreign Office contacts."

"Is she worried?"

"Hard to say behind that supercilious veneer and the Botox. What do you wanna do about Christine's flat?"

"I'm up for it if you are. I'll need to pick up some night vision kit first."

Thomas checked his watch. "It's at least an hour till sunset."

"True. We're making a detour first — back to the infamous woods. I'll meet you there."

An hour or so on the road failed to take the edge off Thomas's mood. Problems wheeled around him like crows, so when he stopped — and found Karl hadn't arrived — he pulled a notebook from the glove compartment and picked through the carrion.

1. Miranda was definitely off the boil since 07/07, even if they were talking again. He could only see one way to make amends, and was he really ready for that?

2. Speaking of matrimony, Jack Langton was still waiting to discover Sheryl's marital status. He wondered how little information Jack would be

content with.

3. One word: gun. The biggest problem was also the one he had absolutely no control over.

4. Christine's disappearing act. At least they'd make a proper start on that tonight.

He drew a circle for each point and tried to figure out where they overlapped. He'd always loved Venn diagrams at school because even complicated relationships made sense as pictures. Maybe all photographers were visual learners. He played with the circles on successive pages, but the only common factor was him. Only not as common as Francesca Gerrard thought.

The unmistakeable sound of Karl's old Ford broke through Thomas's mental deadlock. He could never understand what Karl did with his money. The SSU's civil service wages aside, Karl's off-the-books work should be lucrative. Yet he refused to give up that bloody Ford. Karl reckoned the blessing with his car was the availability of replacement parts, and the curse was how frequently he needed them.

Karl parked in behind him and Thomas spotted the two-fingered salute in his rear mirror. Time for business. Thomas resolved to play it cool. He lasted a count of twelve before Karl got out to join him.

"I give up, Karl. Why are we here?"

His oppo smiled again. "I got to thinking about the *incident*. Before you were rugby tackled by Captain Redbeard, I'd been watching the target he was with, and then of course the other guy turned up. Anyway, our ministerial friend is a nervous smoker when he's out at night . . . er, socialising."

Thomas got it straight away. The weight lifted a little from his shoulders and took the corners of his mouth with it. "So we're looking for a cigarette butt?"

Karl answered by passing over latex gloves, some evidence bags and a pair of tweezers. It didn't take them long to find Karl's original vantage point, thanks to two twigs planted in the dirt to form an apex, and from there an easy line of sight.

"Luckily for us, they waited right by the path. Unluckily for you, it's a hands and knees search. Watch out for old condoms and fox shit."

Thomas worked methodically, crawling around in the dirt and dried grass while Karl called the shots. He moved like a hesitant tortoise, radiating out in clockwise rings. A dog walker passed, took one look at him on all fours, and hurried along without saying a word.

It took nearly an hour to complete the search area, based upon Karl's estimate of a lazy throw. But all credit to the Celtic Detective because by the end of the search, Thomas had recovered three dog-ends, one bearing lipstick. The way he saw it, anything was possible.

He rechecked the seal on each bag when they got to Karl's car. His nose twitched at the spectral tang of spilt orange juice that wafted up behind them.

"That was good work, Tommo. Chances are we have two lines of inquiry — DNA and fingerprints. Once we get a confirmed hit, we're in business."

Thomas blinked a couple of times. "Am I missing something? Surely you photographed the bloke. Isn't that enough?"

Karl shook his head. "Ah, Tommo, you've misunderstood the game. We need to substantiate what we know, so we can approach him with a credible—"

Thomas's head started to throb. "Don't we need approval for this?"

Karl licked his lips. "Christine's not here. Ann may not know anything. And maybe we don't want to tell her." Karl tapped his fingertips together. "Think of it as modern diplomacy. We make sure of the evidence before we make contact, keep the photographs in reserve and go a more formal route."

Thomas felt a knot forming in his stomach. "I'm listening."

"I think you're already ahead of me. The Home Office controls the National DNA Database, and the IDENT1 database for fingerprints. Now, who do we know with Home Office connections?"

Thomas's mind swam in a haze of Vitamin C. Why would Eva Fairfield help them? Simple. Because she wanted to return to the Home Office and Karl would persuade Sir Peter to pull the strings on her behalf, when he returned to Whitehall.

Karl took a bag of sweets from his driver's door and held them open. "Well?"

Thomas rubbed his temples and reached for the barley sugars. "Alright. Make the trade. It'll be better coming from you."

“My thoughts exactly.”

After a quick conference with a London street guide, Karl followed Thomas down to Christine’s flat. They left Karl’s Ford a couple of blocks away, there were no supermarket car parks in Hampstead. Even the global burger outlet had been forced into a makeover to avoid offending the locals. With Karl beside him, Thomas did a quick circuit to get a feel for the area, and decided he didn’t like it. He’d visited her old flat in Highgate several times in the past, sometimes just sitting outside. But he was a reformed character now.

They parked up at the rear of the flats and Karl brought out the bag of sweets.

“Just like old times, eh, Tommo, before we started playing with the big boys?” Karl unwrapped a barley sugar as if it were priceless parchment. “So, er, what do you reckon one of those flats cost?”

Thomas changed the subject. “When will you speak to Eva?”

“I thought you didn’t want to know.”

He didn’t. He just wanted it resolved quickly. Time for another detour. “What exactly are we waiting for?”

Karl lifted a night scope to his face. “Providence.”

Thomas lumped providence in with coincidence. He believed in neither. Luck occasionally, randomness often and purpose frequently. No question, Karl had something up his sleeve. Chances were he’d taken a phone call on his drive over, or already had someone in place, watching the flat from another angle. Karl always had another angle.

Karl’s night scope stopped moving. “Gotcha! Torchlight in the upstairs window.”

Thomas zipped up his jacket, eager to work off some frustration on a stranger.

“Whoa there, he may have back-up.”

He liked how Karl had drawn the same conclusion — a male intruder. “What’s your plan?”

“Call the flat and let’s see what he does. Here’s the info Ann gave me.”

Thomas thumbed the numbers and paused to look up at the window. He pressed the call button and held the phone close, hoping for the impossible — for Christine to pick up and explain herself. After four rings he cut the call and counted to one hundred before calling again.

Karl gave a running commentary. “I can just make out . . . interesting. I reckon he’s looking for us. You better get a move on, won’t be long now.”

Thomas was out the car and running, risking a second redial while he turned the corner to the street out front. He almost tripped over when someone picked up the receiver.

“Hello?” The voice was clipped, not wanting to give anything away.

Thomas held his breath while a car drove past. If he’d been smarter he would have covered the mouthpiece instead.

“Are you outside?”

He cut the call and then rang Karl. “I’ve spooked him. He might stay put.”

“Nah, he’d be trapped. If he’s got any sense he’ll try to make a break for it.”

Thomas found a good surveillance spot across the street and waited in the shadows. He watched a man emerge and close the front door behind him, pulling to check it was shut properly. A light above the doorway told Thomas all he needed to know and more than was good for him. It took a bucket of restraint not to rush over and smash Bob Peterson’s face in.

Peterson walked along the street and got into a Renault Clio, not the 4 x 4 he used to drive — the one Thomas had seen him in with the wife and kids. Thomas was halfway up the street on his way back to Karl when he heard the car start up behind him.

A couple of minutes later, Thomas and Karl sat in his car, eating barley sugars and staring at an empty flat.

Thomas recapped the way Peterson had carefully closed the front door. “And no gloves, so no concerns about being ID’d there. I can’t believe she’d be stupid enough to move in with him.”

Karl threw him a look. “Let it go, please. If Bob’s also searching for her, he may know more than we do.”

Sometimes Thomas hated logic, especially when it made sense. Firstly, if Peterson had a key he was probably living there, at least part-time. No doubt Karl would check the electoral register, if he hadn’t already. Secondly, Peterson had searched the love nest by torch, so he expected it to be under surveillance. Thirdly, if Peterson was sneaking around in secret, he must be living somewhere else and that would likely be . . . drum roll . . . with his wife in Southampton.

They'd divide and conquer. While Karl tried negotiating with Eva Fairfield in Whitehall the following day, Thomas would take a trip to Southampton and see how cooperative Bob Peterson felt with an SSU colleague on his doorstep.

Karl checked his watch and wrapped up the sweet bag, fastening it with a rubber band. "Playtime's over. You've never liked Peterson, eh?"

Thomas snarled at the understatement. Peterson had made merry with Christine on a training session, and compromised himself with the Shadow State — until Thomas and Karl showed him the error of his ways. He displayed all the trustworthiness of a hungry pit bull. "What can I say? The man's a shit."

Karl smiled and clapped softly. "Another gem of Yorkshire wisdom. Okay, I'm outta here. I'll walk to my car. See you tomorrow around one o'clock with Hansel and Gretel. And remember . . ."

Thomas mock-saluted. "I know. We're playing with the big boys now."

Chapter 12

Maybe ringing Miranda at the wrong side of midnight wasn't Thomas's brightest idea, but it beat turning up at her flat unannounced. He'd tried that before with mixed results. He gave up on her landline, noting her answering machine was switched off, and moved on to her mobile. Eventually, she picked up.

He skipped the subtleties. "It's me. Where are you?"

It could have been static or the sound of hackles rising. "None of your business. Don't come round to the flat. I mean it."

He slammed the phone down with a *crack* and watched a shard of plastic dive across the table for cover. While searching for tape to repair the handset he found a bottle of Southern Comfort in need of company. One glass was sufficient — he wasn't his dad for chrissake — enough to occupy his mouth while his brain did some thinking. He knew Peterson's address from days of old, and reasoned that Uncle Bob still worked out of the Southampton SSU building, off Brownhill Way. An eight am visit ought to catch him before he left home.

The only fly in the ointment could be Peterson's previous party trick, where he'd had Thomas's car added to the police database for a vehicle stop if seen in the area. No problem. He could nip over to Miranda's, first thing, borrow her car with his spare key and leave his there instead with an apology and some chocs in the boot. Like Karl always said, every problem had a solution. Or at least an outcome.

Before he surrendered to tiredness, he did his customary walkthrough to check every window and door. Sleep came quickly, and it brought company.

Thomas had read once that you could remember your dreams if you told yourself to, last thing at night and first thing on waking. It was supposed to take about two weeks, tops. The crazy thing was, it had worked. Too well. More often than not he recalled his nightly forays and they followed him around during the day.

The homemade movie in his head deserved an award. He'd been looking for a path through the woods in search of Christine, clawing his

way through the thicket until his fingers bled. Finally, he broke through to discover an overgrown path. Instinctively, he reached down, pressing his hand to the earth. The moment he touched the handle he pulled the Makarov pistol free and raised it like Excalibur. Armed, he travelled the path as it meandered and doubled back on itself, leading him to a gingerbread house in a clearing. He opened the door with his left hand, the gun still in his right, expecting to rescue Christine. The last thing he remembered, as the door swung wide, was Miranda standing in front of him. She smiled that enigmatic smile of hers — the one that could reignite the sun for him — and asked, “What kept you?” He woke up happy and silenced the alarm on its second ring.

He was still doing replays in his head while he crunched his way through breakfast toast and grabbed one of the three shirts hanging on the door. He laughed aloud. Gingerbread house — bloody Karl with his Hansel and Gretel. Maybe he wasn’t far off the mark. Fareed and Molly did have a touch of the Babes in the Wood about them.

The middle drawer of the sideboard supplied a card for Miranda. A simple Thank You, only not spelt out in flowers like the cards you sent after a funeral. He wiped his hands again on a tea towel and then penned a short note, mentioning the box of chocolates he planned to pick up at the nearest petrol station.

He made it out the door at a quarter past six, running late but with a Plan B if Bob had already left by the time he reached Southampton. A showdown at the local SSU office would still do the trick. As long as he made it back up to London for the one o’clock shift, the day could throw what it liked at him.

The petrol station had a reasonable selection — at unreasonable prices. He went all in for a five quid box. Desperate measures for desperate times. He made it to Bow, in the heart of the London Borough of Tower Hamlets, around seven.

Bow was London in microcosm, a shifting blend of the past and the present that still fought for custody of the future. Miranda loved to tell him about the Suffragettes’ office in Bow Road, and the various haunts of the Kray twins like the Blind Beggar pub. He *got* it, the way history had survived in the fabric of grimy buildings and the folklore of families who’d lived there long enough to pass on the stories. People’s front doors were

locked now and lovable cockneys were in fast decline, but the area had life in abundance. He wondered how much of that local character would survive once the Olympic developers got their pens out.

He was still romanticising the East End when he pulled into Miranda's parking spot. The one that didn't have a car in it. Bollocks. He got out and looked around, scratching his head like a child encountering algebra. Where was she? He didn't have time to play games, so he reversed the car out in a hurry and then slammed it into first like a getaway driver. Only he couldn't help thinking that she'd been the one who got away.

The only positive thing about the two-hour drive to Southampton was not being stopped by the police. So either Bob Peterson had taken his number plate off their computer, or lady luck was smiling on him. He turned his mobile on, in case that extended to Miranda, but even lady luck had her limits. He wasn't sure he wanted to face Peterson at work, and give that smug bastard an audience. There were still a few minutes before nine. Worth a gamble.

His heart did a happy dance at the sight of a silver Clio on the Petersons' drive with a 4 x 4 behind it. He parked up and strolled past a few houses, each one an identical new build, down to the fencing and the glass panels in the front door. A regular happy families theme park. Even the doorbell sounded cheery.

A curly-haired woman opened the door and immediately tried to prevent a child from escaping. She reminded Thomas of a librarian. That could have been the glasses.

"Yes? Can I help you?"

"Is, er, *Robert* available? I work in one of the London offices." He didn't elaborate.

She nodded and loosened her grip on the door. "You'd better come in." She closed the door behind them and called out, "Bob, it's for you. One of your work colleagues." The last word seemed to catch in her throat.

Bob Peterson emerged from a back room. He stared open mouthed for a couple of seconds and then regained his composure. "Come through where we can talk."

"Right," Mrs Peterson said sharply to the child attached to her side. "Let's get you and your sister ready, shall we, seeing as we're already running late."

She threw a weary smile at Thomas and he pretended he understood her woes. He passed along the corridor, noting the scuffmarks on the wall made by a child's bike. Peterson stood by the glass patio doors. All credit to him, he was ice cool now. The back room looked like a toy box had exploded in it and Thomas picked his way carefully across the laminate floor.

"I can give you fifteen minutes, Thomas, and then I have a conference call. Grab a seat. Do you want a coffee?"

Thomas blinked a couple of times. This guy had balls of steel. He declined the coffee and would have settled for a staring contest, if he hadn't been on Bob's meter.

Bob smiled. The fucker was asking for a punch in the face. "I must admit I didn't expect you to come to my home. I'm getting a divorce, not that it's any of your business. We're staying together until everything's sorted out — for the kids."

Pawn to king four. Thomas took his turn. "I saw you last night at the flat in Hampstead."

"I know. When you rang the second time I knew you'd be waiting outside. It's the first opportunity I've had to go to the flat since—"

Thomas cut him off. "What did you find there?"

"A suitcase is missing, and some clothes. I can't be sure about anything else. But she does have two passports. How did you know I'd be there?"

Thomas did his best impression of inscrutable, which was usually pretty damned good. "Ways and means."

Peterson checked his watch. "Look, Thomas, it's obvious she wasn't taken from the flat — she set the security code on her way out. Why don't we pool our resources and put the past behind us?" Bob's hand hovered in no man's land.

In the absence of a better option, Thomas took the deal. "There's a rumour circulating that Christine has switched sides."

"That sort of rumour can be dangerous. Maybe Sir Peter can help us?"

Yeah, good luck with that. "He's on compassionate leave."

Peterson looked perplexed.

Thomas threw him a lifeline. "Could you track her mobile?" He didn't wait for an answer. "Well, I'll be off. People would expect us to be at one another's throats. Perhaps someone's counting on it."

Peterson's eyes narrowed. "Let's disappoint them then. I'll make inquiries about those rumours."

"Best to pass on anything via Ann Crossley — she's acting exec now."

"It's good to know Christine still has friends."

Thomas took his cue and shut the door. He passed a side room and glanced through the doorway. A pile of boxes were stacked along one side of the room, like the remnants of a life.

He got back to his car and checked for messages. Still radio silence from Miranda. Nothing from Karl either. He figured a text was the safest option and asked Karl for an update. He was pulling into a motorway services for an emergency coffee when a response came in.

"Hey, Tommy Boy, how was your trip?"

"He wants to share information so I've routed him through Ann."

"Makes sense. He has more reason to speak with her than with the likes of us. Okay, first the good news. I put a proposal to Eva Fairfield and she is free tomorrow. Now the bad news. She'll only talk to you." Karl yawned, long and loud. "Is it me, Tommo, or is life conspiring against us?"

"No change there. I'll see you later. Bladen out."

Coffee, sugar and carbs sharpened his wits. The Zutons were wrong — there was no such thing as too much thinking. It was the right sort of thinking that mattered. He could still be in London with time to spare, and he knew exactly what to do with the surplus.

Okay, the morning's car swap hadn't worked out, but he'd managed to avoid a row with Miranda over the phone. And as far as she knew, he'd kept his distance. It'd be a shame to waste the chocs — especially on Karl — so what harm could there be in a quick stop at Caliban's? A bag of crisps, a large slice of humble pie, and he'd be on his way. That was the beauty of self-talk. You could make yourself believe any old shit.

When he entered the car park the twelve o'clock news had just begun. No sign of Miranda's blue Mini Cooper, only Sheryl's Fiat. Inside the bar, a handful of customers complemented the skeleton crew. Sheryl made all the right gestures, but her act was distinctly second rate.

He counted heads as he walked over. "Where is everyone?" he said, when what he meant was 'where's Miranda.'

"The stampede is due within the hour." She struggled to laugh at her own joke. "Actually, we're closing for a few days after today. You wanna

take some food with you? Better you than the bin.” She was all heart.

“Sure.” He waited while she went through to the kitchen and leant his back against the bar, resting his heel on the foot rail. How did it come to this? Caliban’s looked like it’d had the guts kicked out of it. It could use a makeover, much like the daytime drinkers dotted around the saloon — drowning men clinging to flotsam.

Sheryl returned with three packages in tinfoil. It made him think of her scumbag father, Jack Langton, who’d wrapped his drugs in a similar fashion. Just before Thomas got him arrested — and banged up — for possession with intent to supply. Happy days.

“Listen, Sheryl, any chance of a chat some time? Not here.”

She blushed, which was a first. The tough girl from Brooklyn had her limits too. “I can’t talk about Miranda.”

He cut her deadpan. “That’s not a problem,” he lied. “It’s about you. I’ll be in touch.” He scooped up the takeaway and headed off to see Karl. At least the detour hadn’t been a total waste of time.

Chapter 13

Karl, Fareed and Molly were already at the North London rendezvous for Rupee's briefing. Thomas was the only one with a packed lunch. Rupee gave them a rundown of objectives.

"Your target is a community centre — whoever comes and goes, and when. It's a low priority assignment—"

Karl pulled a piece of chicken from his mouth. "—that requires four of us."

She paused, as if inviting further comment, and then continued. "As I was about to say, two up in the building — map here, I'll take you over. Two on the ground, and obviously you'll switch cars and positions as required. Your MI5 counterparts will relieve your shift at ten tonight. Any questions?"

Molly stopped twiddling her pen. "When you say 'low level,' how long has this location been under surveillance?"

Rupee shrugged. "I know as much as you do. To be blunt, if it was high value we'd be using our own people — no offence. One more thing," she looked back at Karl on her way out, "don't screw this up!"

Karl wiped his mouth on a serviette with all the finesse of a toddler. "We'll take the car first."

Molly glared. "Not if you've been eating greasy food with your hands."

Karl did an impression of 'dejected' and then turned to wink at Thomas.

The first three hours of surveillance was always the worst. Until the next three, anyway. Thomas kept watch from a boarded up window, using a gap between the planks. He sat on an old bar stool, his lens trained on nothing in particular, breaking off every few minutes to glance across at Karl's camera, which seemed to range far and wide.

"Anything of interest?"

Karl murmured his discontent by way of a reply.

Thomas lowered his lens. The community centre had once been a school, Victorian judging by the state of the brickwork. Still surrounded by ancient railings that were probably more paint than metal.

“What about you, Tommo? See into any rooms?”

“Only a couple clearly. Beautiful carpet, could be a prayer room. The other room is set up like a tribunal or a court martial. Bring back any memories?” Always worth a go for cheap entertainment, goading Karl about his army past.

“Ha ha. It’ll be for a sharia court, like the tabloids keep warning us about.”

“Bollocks.”

Karl grinned and snapped a rich tea biscuit in two. “That’s *tabloid* bollocks to you, my friend. I know you see me as a philistine, even after all this time. Not guilty. I’m just not bound by your tongue-tied political correctness. See the sign below?”

Thomas did him the courtesy of acknowledging it.

“If it said ‘Islamic Centre,’ some Little Englanders would be up in arms about it, so instead it reads ‘Community Centre’ for an Islamic community.”

“What’s your point?”

“There is no point. It’s all semantics. We live in a world that favours a pretence of civility over . . . the truth.”

“And the truth is you’re bored.”

As their turn indoors drew to a close they’d amassed images of two families entering the centre, one man standing by a side door for a smoke (who Karl insisted was an Imam) and the number plate and driver of a delivery van.

After a further two hours in the car, brightened only by occasional radio contact with their colleagues indoors, Karl invented better ways to acquire intelligence.

“It’s obvious, really.” He counted the steps out on his fingers. “Disable the CCTV, in through a window, rig up sound and vision in the main office and meeting room, back out again, and then finally smash the window. If you really want to stir it up, leave some far right magazines on the floor.”

Thomas’s mouth opened about a foot. “Unbelievable.”

“Don’t misunderstand me, Tommo, I’m talking hypothetically here. However,” Karl paused for dramatic effect with one finger still in the air, like an am-dram detective. “It cannot have escaped your attention that Fareed could walk through their front door without raising suspicions.”

Thomas grabbed another barley sugar to avoid saying anything he'd regret. Time took its time, stretching moments across the silence until there was something to be said. They fell into an easy rhythm, one alert while the other mused or rested. Or snored. Jesus, how Karl could snore.

The next voice they heard was Fareed's. "Foot patrol from Eagle's Nest." He paused, as if imagining the laugh it would give them. "You swapping over?"

Thomas rubbed his eyes on cue and checked his watch. Only ninety minutes left, hardly worth it. He looked to Karl, who shook his head.

"Crow's Nest from flat foots, nah, you're fine. We'll rough it." He strained to make sense of Karl's hand gestures. "Oh, right, we're gonna park up round the back of the building for a change of scenery."

Karl brushed innumerable crisp crumbs from his coat. "D'ya reckon those two are . . . you know . . . ?"

Dick. "You really are a simple soul. Go on then, enlighten me. Why are we staying in the car?"

"Elementary, my dear Thomas. It's sundown soon, which means the sunset prayer will follow. I thought I'd save you a photographer's dilemma about whether to intrude."

However well meant, it pissed Thomas off. It implied a lack of objectivity. He started the car, crunched the gears and went in search of a new vantage point.

Molly's voice reminded Thomas of a girl he met in Whitby once on a family holiday. He wondered what it did for Karl.

"Hello? Word's come through that there'll be no relief team. Apparently something else has come up, so we're finishing at nine thirty. How about a quick drink after our shift?"

Thomas ignored Karl's salacious mime act. "Yeah, go on then, I think we've earned one. We'll meet you down by the other car."

Molly called back at twenty-five minutes past. "People are still trickling out the front. How's it looking where you are?"

Thomas peered across at the building. "Quiet as the grave. Chalk that one up to Karl." He froze, still as a cat. A door opened and, for a moment, light glinted off a pair of running shoes. Then the light cut out and the door slammed. The figure walked to the railings and clambered over a gap in the spikes. "What do you reckon?"

Karl surveyed the scene. “Tommo, it’s your call.”

“Listen, Molly, we have an unknown target going off-site. We’re gonna follow him. Get the car and come round.”

The plan was rougher than a cat’s tongue. A quick round of rock-paper-scissors left Karl with the short straw. He’d pursue him on foot and Thomas would follow in the lead car as the coordinator.

Two cars and another two people on foot, with a mixture of long roads and guesswork, and they’d tracked the target for more than a mile.

Karl was quick to pass judgement. “Suspicious as fuck. He’s walked past several bus stops and he ought to get money back on his compass.”

It crossed Thomas’s mind that this could be construed as harassment, but he quickly soothed his conscience. They weren’t the police and they had no plans — or powers — to stop the guy. His behaviour was mysterious and Thomas really hated mysteries. So he was one hundred per cent with Karl on this — observe, acquire intelligence and then analyse it.

Molly’s voice was shrill with excitement. “He’s slowing down. There’s a car opposite, some sort of fast food outlet. He’s gone straight over . . . he’s getting in.”

Thomas had already driven past the target. “Just note the number plate and the make of car. Karl — you getting this?”

“Yep, I’m on it. Driver and any passengers. Fareed — coming your way soon.”

One of Karl’s little nuggets, based on his assertion that you always spotted more information than you were looking for, was start with the primary objective and build out from there. In the pub, they pieced together four datasets.

Thomas wrote everything down while Karl asked the questions. A black Vauxhall Astra, two male occupants, one black and the other white. The target got straight into the car, so must have been expected and he knew where to find them.

Karl seemed to enjoy holding court. “Number plate was oh-five, so it’s a new car and very clean.” He nodded to Molly.

Fareed finished his juice. “I gotta be getting home. Alright if I take the car, Molly?”

Thomas watched him leave and then said what he thought everyone was thinking. “He seems nervous. Is it, you know, sensitivities over what

we're doing?"

Molly laughed. "He wants to get home to pray, you idiot. Usually we find a way to accommodate him, but a pub isn't exactly the place. I wouldn't fancy getting down on this carpet! Right, come on boys, what exactly do you plan to do with this information?"

It was Karl's turn to look uncomfortable. "Where did you work before the lure of the Surveillance Support Unit?"

She turned her head to one side, as if listening for the subtext. "Are you asking me if I worked for G2 Intelligence in the Republic of Ireland? If so, the answer's no and frankly, I'm affronted. And I'm sure you've realised that *my* nationality doesn't win me friends with MI5 either."

Thomas looked to Karl, who let out a weary sigh. "You need to be a British citizen to work in MI5 or MI6. So that's why we're working on low-level surveillance targets?"

He threw it out there, like a ball to the crowd and Molly made the catch.

"That could explain Fareed and me, seeing as we work so closely together. What about you two though?"

Karl crunched down on a handful of crisps and avoided Thomas's gaze. Karl was a locked box mystery all of his own, but Thomas was in no doubt about his ability to piss people off. It stood to reason that word got around.

"You, er, about ready, Tommo? We'll drop Molly off at her car."

Of course it was stupid, ringing Miranda on hands-free while he drove home to Walthamstow. And maybe a detour through the mean streets of Bow wasn't smart either. It was nearly half past eleven when Thomas sat there, parked in Miranda's space, trying to fill in the blanks. First Christine and now Miranda . . .

His hand wavered over the phone for a few seconds. "It's Thomas. I need to know the location of a mobile phone. Connected to Christine?" He paused for effect. "Could be. Sure, grab a pen — I'll wait." He could hear a woman's voice in the background, complaining about the hour. "Okay, here we go." He read Miranda's number out, slowly and carefully, each digit a bead on his personal rosary. "I'll ring you tomorrow. And don't forget about the other thing. Goodnight, Bob."

Chapter 14

Thomas had a second coffee at breakfast. There were so many plates spinning in his head he wondered which would fall and shatter first. Enthused by caffeine, he took another stab at his notepad.

Bob Peterson and Karl were already on the case to track down Christine, and maybe Bob could find out where Miranda was spending her evenings. If it had been with her family he figured someone would have called by now. He scribbled two names and wrote in the line below: gun. Karl was taking care of that too, apparently, although he'd heard nothing more.

Sod this, he needed to get out and do something. He unplugged the mobile from its charger and headed back to Bow. By eight am he stood at Miranda's front door, pressing his face against the glass to check for signs of movement. He felt in his pocket for the spare set of keys and pressed a sharp edge against his thumb. He could try letting himself in, only he wasn't sure he'd like what he found.

Diane was the soft option. With a family so close, who better to know Miranda's whereabouts than her mother? On the phone, Diane went straight for the jugular. She didn't bother being evasive.

"No idea. Miranda wanted some time to herself." She didn't add 'away from you' because she didn't have to. "And what with the pub being closed . . ."

His silence registered in decibels.

"You didn't know?"

"We, er, haven't spoken properly for a while."

"Right." Diane gave the single word a razor's edge. "Maybe you're better off talking with Sheryl."

He ditched the call and took her advice. No time like the present. It would have been too much to hope that Miranda had holed up at Sheryl's. He toyed with ringing ahead but why spoil the surprise? Besides, he had other business to discuss with Sheryl.

One leisurely ring on the doorbell and then he listened out for footsteps. The door pulled open to the extent of a chain.

Sheryl tried her little miss flirtatious routine, only it didn't play so well in a full-length tartan dressing gown. "Thomas? Oh, hey, what can I do you for?"

"You could start by letting me in. We need to have a chat."

Her eyes widened. "This isn't a great time. Why don't you call back in an hour or so?"

His bullshit detector sounded in his head like a fog warning. "Is Miranda here?"

"No. She took off a couple of days ago."

His patience ran like sand. "Are you gonna let me in or do I have to do it myself?"

A familiar voice boomed behind her — Miranda's brother, Terry, who'd managed to get half-dressed. "Not a good idea, Thomas."

Sheryl eased the door forward and slipped the chain. "Come in, why don't you?" She walked back in, past Terry, slapping his buttock on her way through. "I'll leave you boys to talk while I throw something on."

Terry dragged a T-shirt over his head.

"Sorry, Tel. I didn't know."

Terry nodded in lieu of an acceptance speech. "You want some toast?"

Thomas sat with him, trying to find something to say. Terry was as close to a brother as he'd ever get, but some things even brothers don't discuss.

Fortunately, Sheryl was a fast dresser. "So," she stood behind Terry's chair, as if he were cover, "you're here. What do you want?"

He glanced to Terry, who crunched away at his breakfast without a care in the world, Sheryl's hand resting on one shoulder. So be it.

"Jack Langton has taken an interest in your life again."

She went her usual route of deflection masquerading as wit. "Is it all those Father's Day cards I never sent?"

"Jack wants to know if you're married." His gaze flickered from Sheryl to Terry and back again. Terry didn't react at all, but Sheryl seemed to grip a little tighter.

"You tell him it's none of his goddamn business."

Everyone laughed. They all knew *that* wouldn't fly.

"Thing is, Sheryl, it's to do with his business. Seems he signed over some interests to you a while ago — I don't have the details."

Her face paled. “Can he even do that without my agreement?”

He shrugged. With the right lawyer Jack could probably do anything. “Jack simply wants to protect his interests.”

She arched an eyebrow. “Oh really?” And then she smiled. “I get it now. For richer or poorer. Hubby might share in my bounty.” She pouted. “Well, yeah, of course I’m married. Jack wasn’t exactly forthcoming in the parenthood stakes, or child support come to that. When I came over from New York I had to make my own arrangements.”

Terry’s hand reached up to hers.

“Is that judgement on your face, Thomas? Hey, I did what I had to do — just like dear old Dad. I am still married by the way, although I haven’t seen him in a long time. He could be anywhere. All very amicable. He usually calls me on our anniversary.”

Thomas said the unthinkable. “Maybe it’s time you got divorced.”

“What, just to keep Jack happy? No fucking way. How about, instead of being his errand boy, you help get him off my back for good. Can you do that, Tommy?”

He grimaced. She knew he hated *Tommy*.

“Couldn’t I sign some papers for Jack and then deny any connection with him? It’s not as if there’s anything to prove we’re related.”

Terry chose that moment to come to life. “Apart from DNA.”

Thomas saw the same sallow light of recognition on their faces. Shit. Something else to deal with. “What’s with Caliban’s being closed?”

“Cash flow. Caliban’s is haemorrhaging money and Miranda won’t let the family bail her out. She said she needed some space to think things over.”

“Her phone’s not picking up.”

She nodded. “Tell me about it.”

He drew his own conclusions — time to be going. He took a piece of cold toast with him. Terry remained in the kitchen. Sheryl followed him to the door.

“You find my husband and I’ll talk with him, see if he’ll write some sort of disclaimer. But divorce? Not a chance. Kwame is my safeguard.” She stared hard, watching his reaction. “I’ll text you what I know on one condition. No cloak and dagger involvement. Use some other way to find

him. The people in your line of work have messed with my life enough already.”

Chapter 15

Back on the road before nine thirty, and the text came through before ten. Even as he drove to Dalston, to see a West Indian private detective he knew he could rely on, an idea was cooking in his head. That was the thing about inspiration or insight or whatever the hell you wanted to call it. It never came in through the front door. Some random association or a left field comment and *bingo*. Nice one, Terry. Now he just needed a way to put it all together.

If he was honest with himself, he never felt entirely comfortable in Dalston. It was vibrant and happening, and every other superlative the posters laid claim to, but he felt like a stranger there. He was used to being treated with suspicion — that sort of went with the job. Only here, on the street, his first thought was whether his car would still be waiting for him and the next was whether he'd say something out of place or act like a stupid white person.

The peeling mirror film from Thurston Leon's premises reassured him that nothing had changed since his last visit. Inside, a middle-aged woman sat with her handbag clasped against her thighs. In default of the evidence, Thomas guessed her reason for being there was an absent husband.

He copied out the salient points from Sheryl's text onto a weathered notepad, sponsored by a local dry cleaner's. The yellowing paper made him wonder if the sponsor was still in business. He completed a précis of the facts and locked eyes with the woman opposite, who had been caught out reading his notes. He smiled at their mutual discomfort and then got up and walked over to the secretary.

She busied herself until the last second of his approach. Her vacant expression told him that she hadn't remembered the previous times he passed through that door. No reason why she should, although Thurston Leon might have a different take on things.

He felt like a complete dick taking out twenty pounds from his wallet and pushing it across the desk. It got her attention.

"I'd appreciate five minutes of Mr Leon's time."

"Someone's before you, or hadn't you noticed?"

He lifted his hand from the twenty and its edge rose up like a tongue. She left him standing, knocked on the glass door and went inside. Thurston's mellow voice eased through the crack in the open door.

"I'll set my watch. Five minutes."

Thomas took his cue and touched the glass panel, pushing gently to save on seconds. The secretary left them alone.

Thurston smiled, and Thomas offered a hand. "Well, well, trouble's in town again. What you want this time?"

Thomas passed him the details. Thurston read the name in the first line.

"What did he do? What you *think* he do?"

"Nothing." Thomas stared longingly at the coffee machine and inhaled.

"Then why you want him?"

"His wife needs to speak with him — about money."

Thurston roared with laughter and pulled a mustard coloured handkerchief from his pocket to dab his face. "Leave it with me." He eyed Thomas expectantly and only relaxed when two hundred pounds materialised.

Thomas reached for the door. "She'll ring you tonight." He didn't waste any more time on chitchat. He had other fish to fry.

Back in the car he called Sheryl and gave her Thurston's number.

She sounded unconvinced. "Look, Thomas, I don't want to cause Kwame any trouble. He has his own life, without us gate crashing it. Let alone Jack."

"I'm working on something. It'll give you leverage and buy some time to get the legal situation sorted out." He meant divorce and he knew that she understood.

"Promise me no harm will come to him."

He'd made it a rule not to lie to friends any more. "I will do what I can. Any word from Miranda?"

"Nope. You might have more luck with John. Every girl is a daddy's girl at heart."

Great, another trail to follow. Time check: ten thirty. Still some breathing space before the day shift. Karl picked up before Thomas had thought of an opening gambit. That only left the truth.

"Karl, where could I get DNA matched from two samples?"

“You want to double-check the minister’s DNA privately against the national database?”

“No. I want to prove paternity for Sheryl. Know any friends with a lab?”

Karl’s long pause suggested controversy. “I . . . *may* know somewhere we can go, but I don’t see how . . .”

“I’m working on it. I’ll catch you later.”

“Understood. Tommo, remember Eva Fairfield wants to see you.”

“Uh-huh.”

Eva’s enthusiasm surprised him. Unlike Sir Peter, who usually demanded Thomas’s presence at Whitehall, she leapt at the chance to meet in the real world. She didn’t travel far though — a brasserie bar that doubled as a café, a short walk away from the Apollo Theatre in Victoria. Parking, naturally, was a complete mare and he made it with seconds to spare.

She’d waited outside. Calm, that was the word. Staring along the street at nothing in particular, as if life had already shown her everything it had to offer. He walked the last five yards with a hand raised, in a half-arsed attempt at a greeting. She could have been made of stone.

Their eyes met at close quarters and then she turned and entered the café, leaving him to follow in her wake. She navigated the shadowy interior with ease. As soon as she sat down a waiter zeroed in, all smiles and attentiveness.

“How lovely to see you again, m’lady.”

Thomas took the seat facing her and waited for the staff to depart.

“Karl said you wanted to see me.” He didn’t bother adding what she already knew. While she played inscrutable, he gave his attention to the menu and decided the gâteau sounded inviting. A shame there were no pictures.

“Mr McNeill assured me it would be to my advantage.”

Eva raised two fingers, like a papal blessing. It took him a moment to realise she was summoning the waiter.

She gave her order with a Latino flourish, as though she were born to the language. “An Americano and some Bruttiboni, if Agata is still making them.”

The waiter basked in her words and looked to Thomas in the afterglow.

He managed to keep a straight face. “Black coffee and a piece of gâteau, thanks.”

Despite it being a busy café, Eva’s order managed to jump the queue. By contrast, she took her time, as if she knew that Thomas was on the clock.

“I’ve never quite understood your moral compass, Mr Bladen. You had the opportunity to expose me when we first met.”

He drew on caffeine’s restorative power. “Along with the evidence.”

She took a shallow sip of coffee and waited until she had his full attention. “Indeed. You were outraged, and yet you settled for my departure from the Home Office.”

He moved on to the gâteau, wondering whether she’d talk openly about the two child killers who’d received her brand of summary justice.

He kept his voice low. “Karl helped me appreciate the bigger picture. We could afford to lose one,” he thought carefully about his next word, “over-zealous judge. Far more important to protect Sir Peter and the SSU’s reputation.” It nearly killed him to admit it.

She moved one hand over her wrist and brandished a silver watch. In the subdued lighting he could still make out the Rolex brand. Maybe their time was nearly up.

“Mr McNeill said you had information to exchange?”

He nodded and then abruptly excused himself for the gents, allowing her a joke at his expense. The cubicles were all empty — he checked — so he loitered by the sinks.

Karl answered on a count of four and did his thinking aloud. “Assuming she’s recording everything, it’s better to position yourself as a pawn. We didn’t choose the job at the woods — Christine came to me. Look, Tommo, whatever you decide, don’t be late for work. My hunch is that our man will go walkabout again.”

Eva’s coffee had hardly been touched, but he noticed her Blackberry out on the table. He figured it wasn’t a conversation starter. She took a deep breath, all smiles, and he let her have her moment.

He plunged a fork into gâteau, savouring the blend of cream, carbohydrates and sugary goodness, and remembered not to speak with his mouth full — just like his mother taught him. Time to pay the piper.

“Karl and I were given a private surveillance request on a government minister. The operation was interrupted so we need to confirm his identity.”

He could feel her eyes boring into him. She was hooked. It only remained to reel her in. He lifted his coffee and nearly sipped it, lowering it at the last moment as if his disclosure was an afterthought. “The *unofficial* request came from a senior level. The surveillance location and the specific circumstances . . .” Now he took a slug of coffee and gulped it down for effect. “Well, they suggest the individual may already be on the fingerprint and DNA databases.”

Her fingers caressed the edge of the watch face. “How long has Sir Peter been running private surveillance operations out of Whitehall?”

Gateau time again. She’d made her own assumption and who was he, a mere minion, to tell her otherwise? “I don’t know. I’ve been at the SSU for three years and this wasn’t the first time.”

“What happens when you’ve named your man?”

He smiled, recalling Karl had a special term for this information horse-trading. He called it ‘approaching the truth diagonally.’

“We contact the minister with the evidence,” he looked directly at her and blinked a couple of times, “then exert influence when the need arises.”

She let go of her watch. “Very well then. Karl has already given me the samples, so once I divulge the identity I expect to be kept informed.”

He gave her a quizzical look. The sort that said, ‘Then why am I here?’

She read him well. “I thought we could make a fresh start, Thomas.”

He didn’t like his name mentioned. It was usually for someone else’s ears. Two could play at that game.

“I do understand, Eva. About why those men had to die.” He counted the seconds. “Sidney Morsley, wasn’t it? The first one, I mean. I’ve got the other name written down somewhere.” He finished his coffee and the gateau. “Anyway, I must be going.” He dug a fiver out of his wallet.

“That’s not necessary, Thomas.”

“I insist. Seems only fair, as we’re working together on this.”

They went through the pretence of a handshake and then he gladly left the shadows for the clarity of daylight.

Chapter 16

Central London, he reflected on the walk back to the car, hid a million faces in plain sight. Each one carrying secrets. Christine could be out there right now, in some anonymous office block, and he'd never know. She might even be watching him. It didn't occur to him that someone else might be instead.

Still a few minutes left on the parking meter so he sat there and tried to close the city out. He texted Miranda, dropping another pebble into darkness. There were no ripples and no echo, just the emptiness of a blank screen. Karl was more appreciative, promising a burger and fries as a reward for his efforts.

"Or maybe a kebab, Tommo. I've found this new place, within walking distance from work."

One more call to make. Natalie Langton's voice could have soured milk. He hadn't visited her in months, not since Karl's people got involved after Jack's release from prison. Karl had rigged up surveillance in the Langtons' house. Natalie hadn't so much agreed to it as put up with it, helped to the decision by Thomas finding out about her affair with one of Jack's *trusted* associates. Before the guy disappeared, of course.

As for Jack, that poor bastard had never even heard of the Shadow State before he left prison, even though he'd been dealing with them for years. *Dealing* being the operative word. Just one of Jack's many business side lines, strictly lower level stuff until recently when he made some new connections. Jack didn't give a shit about international politics and power plays though. Any commodity or interest was up for grabs, as long as it was profitable. Small wonder Sheryl kept her distance from dear old Dad.

Thomas still couldn't figure Natalie out. She enjoyed the good life, he got that. And since Jack's nearest rival, Charlie Stokes, had shuffled off his mortal coil, business of all kinds had been very good indeed — according to Karl. But Natalie, well, her loyalty to Jack hadn't wavered, even after he put prison life behind him. Maybe she still loved him, in her own way, and that's why she stayed. Karl reckoned if she were smart, she'd have been squirreling away funds for years. Cunning would be a better word.

She took the call and heard him out. All he wanted was a five-minute chat, when he popped over with some news for Jack — at a time when Jack was certain to be out. Better for everyone that way. Tomorrow at nine thirty then, when Jack hit the gym.

“Thanks, Nat. One more thing. I need a sample of Jack’s DNA.”

“You what? How am I supposed to do that — stick a needle in him when he’s not looking?”

“Not quite. I’m sure you’ll think of something. Ring me if he changes his plans.”

Even on the back foot, Natalie Langton was a force to be reckoned with. Thomas covered the bases by having Karl follow Jack to the gym, in case she’d thought about double-crossing him. He sat in his car, a short walk from the house, and waited for Karl’s call.

“Green to go, Tommo. He’s just gone in. I’ll call you when he leaves.”

“Is there a back door, fire exit?”

Karl muttered down the phone. “Probably. Jack still needs his car though and it’s parked out front. On you go.”

Thomas started walking. He wondered how Jack’s neighbours would feel about having a drug trafficker in their midst. Karl’s contacts had pulled strings to keep Jack’s ‘intent to supply’ conviction out of the local papers. Now, Jack appeared to be a model citizen and entrepreneur, the sort who put the bins out on the right day and always paid the taxes he couldn’t evade.

Natalie was short on pleasantries when he rang her. “I’ll give you five minutes.”

“I’ll be there in two.”

She met the doorbell ring and opened the door no more than eighteen inches. Like an encumbered dog walker, a plastic bag dangled in her hand. Thomas cupped the bag. It felt cold to the touch.

Natalie sneered at him. “It’s been in the freezer. Take it and piss off.”

The door slammed, narrowly missing his fingers. Under the circumstances, there was only one person to ring.

Ajit answered his mobile immediately. “Alright, Thomas? What, er, can I do for you?”

He fired up the Bladen charm. “Hi, Aj, bit of an odd question for you. How long will a sample of male DNA stay viable once it’s started defrosting?”

Ajit paused before answering, the sort of unexpected silence that made Thomas clasp the phone to his ear for clues.

“Look, I’m sorry, Thomas. I can’t speak right now.”

He heard the youngster kicking off in the background. “You changing a nappy? Don’t worry, I’ll call back later, seeing as you’re at home.”

“No, don’t do that,” Ajit snapped. “I told you, I’m busy.” Another pause with no sound at all, like a hand clasped over the mouthpiece when someone else is feeding you lines. “Leave it with me, okay?”

“Nah, you’re alright. I’ll figure it out.”

“Sorry . . .”

Thomas let him chew on the rest of his sentence. He got in the car and stared at himself in the mirror, grinning at his reflection. “Now who’s being paranoid?” He deposited Jack’s deposit in the driver’s door and rang Karl on the move.

“Where are you? I’ve got Jack’s DNA.”

“That must have been hard to come by.”

“Funny man. Where do you want to meet? Only we don’t want it thawing out.”

“Relax. Even air-dried is fine. We’ll meet you outside your flat. I’m bringing a friend from a lab — he owes me a favour.”

Thomas ended the call, wondering if Karl had really just suggested using a hairdryer.

Karl arrived in Walthamstow ten minutes after Thomas. His passenger looked like he’d been interviewed for the lab job by his photo alone — pale complexion, round glasses, soft shoes and an ironic tie. If his scientific prowess were as on the money as his appearance, they’d have nothing to worry about.

After years in his company, Thomas sometimes thought Karl was incapable of surprising him. Wrong again. Karl’s passenger took the sample bag and sealed it in a container, and then Karl passed him the keys.

“You take my car. I’ll pick it up from you later at the lab.”

On a good day, Thomas enjoyed data analysis. The training called it systematically sifting for patterns, but the reality was more like panning for gold. And grains of gold at that. Somewhere, in that sea of big data the public got so worked up about, the right grains of small data — numbers,

letters and pixels — could be isolated and rearranged to tell a story. First you had to find them.

Christine had left the flat of her own volition — she had taken some clothes and there was no disturbance there. That implied she'd planned her disappearance. She hadn't told Bob, or communicated with him since, so either he was no longer important to her (oh, happy day), or she had a specific reason for not involving him.

Thomas noted the points under 'knowns' and made a separate list of 'unknowns:'

How did she travel from the flat?

Where did she go?

Why did she keep it a secret?

Two hours of data prospecting turned up absolutely nothing. To all intents and purposes she had vanished off the face of the Earth, or at least Hampstead. To his credit, Bob had managed to requisition copies of London Underground CCTV for the ticket halls within a one-mile radius.

Karl stood up from his desk. "Fair play, Tommo, Bob's gone out on a limb for this. Given the current climate." He attempted to touch his toes and then stretched. "Facial recognition hasn't even blinked. Unless she wore a burqa."

"Not funny." Thomas tossed Karl a pound coin. "Coffee with sugar, thanks." Then he thought better of it and got up to join him.

After two hours of solid screen time the mechanics of two vending machines seemed mesmerising. They stood together, chewing the fat while they waited for sustenance.

"People don't vanish into thin air, Karl. We're missing something. We'll widen the parameters and get a list of cab companies in a five mile radius."

Although Karl nodded, his face didn't share Thomas's confidence. "Let's work backwards for a moment. If Christine was in Germany, how did she get there? The camera network on the Channel Tunnel is too good. Maybe she flew indirectly. Whatever, she'd need a passport or a national ID card. Bob Peterson told you her passport was still at their love nest . . ."

Thomas's face hovered above scalding coffee, breathing in its thermal current. "Bob said she had a second passport. No saying whether it's in her name though."

Karl broke off a third of his chocolate bar and offered it, by way of a reward. “Whatever she’s doing, if it’s legit, Sir Peter would have to sign it off. Why aren’t we talking to him?”

Thomas laughed, and took a deep dive into his coffee. He felt his nerve endings singing hallelujah. The chocolate was a mere encore. “I don’t fancy our chances with an access request for his home phone.”

Karl slurped the top of his chocolate like a greedy child. “I bet his chauffeur knows it.”

Thomas raised a coffee cup salute. “And you know him.”

“Our paths have certainly crossed. You stick with Carry on Cabby while I nip outside and make some calls.”

Twelve taxi companies, meticulously copied and pasted into a document, and then plotted on a map that Thomas had printed off. He pinned the epicentre — Christine’s flat — and stared hard at the random scattering of cab offices. If Christine were as smart as he knew her to be, she’d have used a cab firm further out than the local ones. It made sense to work his way in, although he’d check them all anyway.

Given the security climate, the cab offices couldn’t do enough to assist when he rang them. Maybe it was the word ‘surveillance’ that ticked the box. He tweaked his list, popped in to give Ann an update, and then grabbed his jacket. He opted for an old photograph of Christine that he’d kept at the back of a drawer. A naturalistic image, the sort he always favoured over anything posed, taken outside a Holborn pub. Less formal than her ID card. He wondered why he’d kept that old photo in his office drawer and told himself it didn’t mean anything. Unlike the picture of Miranda in his wallet.

Chapter 17

Chrysalis Taxis thought itself a cut above the competition, judging by the faux marble panelling on the narrow square columns that framed the entrance. A spotless foyer, a carpet on intimate terms with a vacuum cleaner and, if Thomas's ears didn't deceive him, classical music wafting in from the high window — none of the populist stuff you could hum along with. He straightened his jacket and entered the open doorway, feeling underdressed.

A moonlighting academic studied his approach to the double-glazed serving hatch. She slid the glass back, framing herself in gleaming aluminium. "How may I help you?"

He smiled. Given it was a cab office, this query seemed self-evident, and yet it wasn't. He flashed his ID card to keep his smile company. He hated waving ID around, too reminiscent of those arseholes in restaurants who insisted on debating in front of an audience *which* card to use. Still, needs must and it cut out several sentences. The ones he'd suffered at three other cab offices. He pulled out Christine's photo. It was starting to look tired.

She peered through her glasses at Christine immortalised in a nine by six. "What leads you to conclude she used our services?"

She had diction to die for, but he wasn't in the mood to pay compliments.

"This woman requested a pick-up from a location in Hampstead." He passed a note to her with some dates on it and waited while she checked a ledger.

The note came back faster than a lie. "I can't be positive. We had a cash customer who rang from a call box. Ordinarily, we prefer card payments. Only she gave no cause for concern."

Yeah, cash had that calming effect. "And where did she ask to be taken?"

"May I see your identification again?"

He never refused a lady, even one making notes. Someday he'd have to speak to Karl about getting fake ID.

She went back to her ledger. “The woman in question,” still no names, “was conveyed to London RAF Northolt.” She looked back at him and pressed her lips together. That was all he was going to get.

Years in surveillance had taught him how to read what *wasn't* being said, what Karl called ‘the spaces in between.’ Most people, when they saw a government ID, broke into a sweat or tried to obfuscate. Yeah, that was the word. The academic wasn't fazed at all by him, or the questions. And she was holding back.

He played his last card. “Can I talk to the driver?”

Her face relaxed, like a teacher's when a pupil finally understands long division. “I'll ask him to telephone you if you leave a number.”

“Better that I ring him. It's an active investigation.”

She cast an eye to a driver sitting on a couch in the corner, reading a broadsheet, and then desecrated a business card. Thomas checked the details before leaving. He was halfway out the door when he remembered what he'd forgotten. “Remind me, when does your ledger say she left for Northolt?”

His phone was at his ear after three steps on the pavement. Maybe the guy in the office was the driver and maybe he wasn't, and maybe London RAF Northolt wouldn't tell him to fuck off. But why risk blowing their only lead? Especially when someone else could add an air of authority. He told Bob Peterson the good news and signed off, before updating Karl.

Twenty minutes into the traffic crawl back to Liverpool Street his mobile phone screamed from its cradle.

It only took one shrill word to recognise Pat, his sister. “Thomas?” The name hung in the air, as if she'd stopped breathing.

“I'm here. Is everything alright?” His mind conjured scenarios involving her idiot husband, or the kids.

She breathed again, gulping for air. “Oh, Thomas. Someone came round the house — for you. They left an envelope. Said I was to call you.”

He heard her holding back tears, a sound he remembered from childhood when their dad had come home drunk. “Did they hurt you?” His knuckles whitened under a choke hold on the steering wheel.

“No, but they know where I live and they know about you. I swear I never told them a thing.”

He pounded the dashboard. “Bastards. What did they want?”

“The note says ‘stop looking for Christine.’ I don’t understand . . .”

He flicked the indicator and heaved left. “Hold on, I’m parking.” He hit the hazard lights. That about summed his job up — a hazard to everyone around him. He closed his eyes for a moment to shut the world out.

“Tommy, are you still there?”

She never called him that. Not unless she was panicked.

“I’m here. Is Gordon with you?”

“He’s away at a sales conference in Harrogate.”

Of course he was. Thomas pushed his hands together to focus, the way his mother used to pray. “Okay, this is what I want you to do. Grab a bag and take the kids over to Ajit and Geena’s. Straight away.”

“Mum and Dad’s house is only streets away.”

“No. Ajit will know what to do. Tell him what you told me.” He was buying time and he knew it. “Ring me in half an hour. I promise I will sort this out.” He nearly added ‘somehow’.

She got off the phone sounding reassured. He pulled his hands apart and felt the circulation return to his fingertips. The outside world pressed at the windows again. Why Pat? Because she was his pressure point. Because Miranda could take care of herself and she had her family in reserve.

He glared at his own reflection and picked up the phone, unable to shake the sound of Pat’s voice — frightened and alone, paying the price for his choices. His mouth curled into a cynical crescent. Time to ring Bob Peterson again, now they were on the same team. A phrase he never expected to enter his vocabulary.

The call to Bob’s work mobile came back as out of service. Bob’s home line rang eight times before a woman picked up. Mrs Peterson was short on pleasantries, even after he’d introduced himself. Or because of that.

“He’s not supposed to talk to you.”

Thomas heard someone else grab the receiver.

“Bob, they’ve been to my family to warn me off. They must have access to my file.”

Bob Peterson’s voice was devoid of emotion. No swagger now. “I rang Northolt. Not long afterwards I got a call telling me I’d been suspended for a possible abuse of authority. It came from the top. No contact with your team, and you in particular.”

“I’m sorry, Bob.”

“I know.” He sounded like he meant it. “If you ring me I’m to convince you to desist, in case you compromise an operation. Maybe they’re right. Perhaps it’s time you got back in your Porsche and carried along the *strasse*. Goodbye, Thomas.”

He stared at the pale sky and felt his sympathy for Bob ebb away before the first set of traffic lights. What was all that bollocks about driving a Porsche? Not on these wages. And anyway, who gave a shit about cars — apart from Miranda’s brothers? Maybe Bob couldn’t resist a final flourish of cleverness. Or maybe . . . He threw an idea in the air and let his brain look for connections. Didn’t Sam say something about a new Porsche 911 coming out? And 911 was the US emergency services number, and the date of the terror attacks on US soil. Nah, too American. Unless Bob was implying the Yanks were involved? Jesus, his head was throbbing.

In the absence of a paracetamol he tried a natural cure. “Karl, are you by your computer?”

“Where else would I be?”

“What can you tell me about Porsche? It was something Peterson said. And a particular *strasse*?”

A few painful clicks of the keyboard followed, like a horse trying to touch type very slowly. “They produced a WWII tank design that never got built.” Karl huffed down the phone. “Hold on, erm, headquarters is in Stuttgart, Baden-Württemberg. There’s a Porsche museum there too.”

The clouds began to lift from Thomas’s mind. “Bingo. A fiver says that’s where Christine flew to from Northolt.”

Karl hadn’t finished mega-tapping. “Hold on a sec. Nothing obvious for a particular *strasse* but,” he paused, alerting Thomas that a magic moment was due, “the airport code for Stuttgart is STR, so that sounds like confirmation. Is Bob following this up?”

“Unlikely. He’s been suspended for contacting Northolt.”

“Oh well, collateral damage. It could have been worse — one of us instead. We’d better tread carefully.”

Thomas started the car. “There’s something else. Someone tried to get to me through my sister, with a warning to drop the search. I’ve sent her to Ajit’s for safety.”

“Tommo, I don’t like this at all. Get here when you can, we need to regroup. Hold on . . . Ann says Christine’s mobile pinged — on the

outskirts of Pickering, Yorkshire. The signal's dead again now."

Twenty minutes later on the road to Liverpool Street, Pat rang back. She sounded calmer. "I'm with Ajit and Geena. Ajit contacted Gordon and he's coming back today. Someone wants to speak with you."

One breath was all it took. Weird to think that he knew Miranda from a lover's sigh.

"It's me. Lost for words?" Her voice rang in his head like a bell, though maybe not a church bell. "I've been up here a few days — all that can wait though. I told Pat to refold the note and envelope and seal it in a freezer bag. Ajit reckons it's a gummed envelope, so with any luck . . ."

"Saliva."

She laughed. "That's what I thought. I can courier it overnight or bring it myself, now that I've finished my tour!"

He hit the brakes hard as a set of lights changed against him. "In person would be great. Ring me when you know what time your train gets in." He was still thinking of something clever to say when Ajit took the phone.

"Right, Thomas. I can't see as how an offence has been committed. No threats were made. It were only a request to stop what you were doing. Granted, it must have seemed a bit sinister at the time."

An idea fired in Thomas's brain. "Aj, could you do me a massive favour? Can you get a police sketch artist to put something together from Pat's description of the bloke at her door?"

"Hmm, maybe. And what are you gonna do with it?"

"See if I can track the bastard down."

By the time Thomas made it to the underground car park, his head was spinning. Miranda had been in Pickering for days, doing God knows what. Someone must have accessed his file for Pat's address, and Christine appeared to be in the same vicinity. Ironical that Ajit once called him '*one of those clandestines*.' Those days seemed to be long gone.

The lift stopped on the first floor and Rupee got in.

She smiled. "Hi, I was hoping to catch up with you at some point."

He figured it had less to do with the coincidence fairy and more to do with the CCTV by the lift, or the tracer in his ID card.

"So, Thomas. Any progress looking for Christine?"

He smiled back. The word 'subtle' hadn't made it into her dictionary. "Ann Crossley has all the details. You're already heading that way."

She left him behind at Karl's desk like a bad smell. No surprise that Ann's office door closed firmly against intruders. Karl got up and returned with two coffees.

"Is your sister okay now?"

He nodded. "Yeah, thanks. Ajit knows the score and he'll keep an eye on her." The blend of coffee, milk solids and an anti-caking agent bathed his neurons in a tide of bliss. "Apart from supporting the hypothesis that Christine went to Germany, how does Stuttgart help us?"

Karl gave him the signature look, midway between enigmatic and a dog looking for treats, which meant he was missing the point. "Wrong question, Tommo."

He drank from the frothy cup of wisdom and tried again. "Why would Eva suspend Bob Peterson for asking about Northolt?" He scrutinised Karl's face for clues. "Assuming it was Eva."

Karl cricked his neck at alarming angles. "Eva Fairfield is definitely not connected with the Shadow State. Neither is she part of our alliance. So why should she give a shit about Northolt?"

Thomas thought it over and it went one of two ways. Either someone at Northolt had complained about Bob's request for passenger logs and she'd followed protocol or . . . He traded a question for a question. "It wasn't her decision?"

"I think the Home Secretary has better things to do with his time. Maybe our glorious leader reached out from his sickbed, or family crisis, and pulled Eva's strings."

Thomas opened his hand to Karl. "Only one way to know for sure."

Chapter 18

Seven thirty in the evening at Kings Cross Station the day's heat still clung to the air. Thomas watched the travellers and drifters crisscross his line of vision, tracking them at random until his attention returned to the platform indicator. Miranda's train had been scheduled to arrive fifteen minutes ago. Karl stood a few feet away, awaiting the letter and an artist's impression of the bastard involved.

Thomas hadn't asked how Karl planned to check this DNA, whether it would be another favour owed to Eva Fairfield or to his lab buddy. Some secrets didn't need sharing. He scanned the board again, as if the act of looking would magically conjure a change. Fat chance of that.

The idea that someone could threaten his sister, even psychologically, and think him powerless to respond, gnawed away at his insides. Hard to say which he was looking forward to more — Miranda or the evidence. He pegged it at a sixty-forty split.

Eventually, the arrivals board updated and an apology spilled from the tannoy. He moved position and then stayed perfectly still until he saw Miranda's blonde hair bobbing through the crowd. She'd had her hair cut and he wasn't sure if he liked it. She spotted him, and touched her shortened locks as if to emphasise the change. She knew him so well.

She stopped about three yards away, waiting for him to take a few steps. Jesus, were they doing this now? He started a slow walk and she began to move again.

A smile spread across her face. "Mr Bladen, I presume?"

He'd always found a part of her unfathomable, and liked it that way. And knowing that she'd spent time away on a secret trip to Yorkshire and breathed in the moors he'd known as a boy, well that just added to the mystique. There was definitely something about her, a changeling returned in place of the old Miranda, a force of nature. He stopped thinking when she kissed him softly on the lips.

"What the bloody 'ell have you been doing in Pickering?"

She kissed him again and then breathed against his neck. "Getting my head together and trying to understand you. I knew I wouldn't be bothered

by you up there because, let's face it, you were hardly likely to drop by."

He nodded, fair point, and swung an arm around her shoulder to guide them both towards Karl. As they drew close to him, Miranda raised a plastic bag.

"You'll be wanting this."

Karl peered inside. "Thanks, Miranda. Good to have you back. The boy here has been insufferable."

She suddenly threw off Thomas's arm and swung round to one side.

He twisted round to face her. "Everything alright?"

"Yeah. I must be tired — or paranoid. Thought I saw a camera flash out the corner of my eye, and then someone staring."

He tried the Bladen charm to distract her, while signalling Karl with his eyes. "Must be your new hairstyle."

Karl nodded to one of the exits, but he couldn't resist another peek inside the bag. He opened the envelope containing the sketch. "Tommo, I'm not sure we'll need the saliva analysed." He took a long, slow breath. "Miranda, did you look at the drawing on the train?"

"Nah, didn't want to attract attention on the train. Besides, when I took it into the loo I saw it had been sealed."

Karl beckoned them over to somewhere with better light. "Well, it ain't sealed now. Look familiar?"

Karl pulled the sketch out and Miranda froze at the sight. An uncanny likeness of someone she hadn't expected to ever see again.

Thomas felt his knuckles whiten. "That's Nicholas, one of Sir Peter's old stooges." Not just any stooge but one who'd once abducted her, when he'd followed a tracker on Thomas's car and picked up the wrong driver. "I want his work address by tomorrow morning, first thing."

Karl conceded without protest. "Meeting adjourned then?" He folded the top of the bag over. "I'll leave you good people to your own devices. Welcome home, Miranda."

Thomas watched Karl distance himself, only to begin a wide arc around the station hall. He turned his attention back to Miranda. "You definitely reckon someone was photographing us?"

She shrugged. "I can't be certain. It's been a long day."

"Yeah, course it has." He'd been delaying the inevitable. "Do you want me to drop you off at Dagenham? Your family must have thought you left

the country.”

“I did — I went to Yorkshire! Actually, your place will be fine. You’ve got a good shower. Ajit and Geena’s place was lovely for a night, but I still can’t get the smell of toddler out of my nostrils.”

“You stayed with them?”

“Well, hotels were out — I’m sure Karl knows how to trace bank cards. Same for the cashpoint.” She stared at the creases in his forehead. “I went to ground, okay? Stupid, maybe, but I thought . . . I dunno, talk to people you care about and get a better insight into what makes you tick.” She changed topic. “Pat put me up for a night.”

He did the maths. That still left one night. “Jesus, please tell me you didn’t stay at Mum and Dad’s?” He could feel beads of sweat in all the uncomfortable places.

“I had some cash on me and stayed in a York B&B that wasn’t fussy about the residents. Or the decor, as it turned out.” She passed him one of her bags and started walking. “I did see your parents though. Pat spun them a line about me being in the area for a licensee’s conference. I don’t suppose they even remember about Caliban’s. Anyway, Pat stayed for about twenty minutes and then left me there for tea and cake.”

He smarted. So much for family and friends. Not one phone call from any of them.

“Blimey, relax. I didn’t ask them for your hand in marriage or anything!”

He never could resist her laughter, even at his own expense. “And did you find what you were looking for?”

She stalled, searching in some secret place he would never reach. “I think so.” She stepped ahead of him abruptly and dropped her bag, blocking his path. “Look, Thomas, I’m not expecting you to change, or stop doing what you do. We’re way past that. But I want commitment. I deserve that.”

His shoulders tensed. “And what if I can’t keep you safe?”

“Fuck off, Tom. When did I ever say I needed you to protect me? And what? You don’t believe the other lot know all about us? Besides,” she grabbed her bag from the tiles and jabbed him gently in the ribs, “what makes you think you’re so important?”

When they reached his car she suffered in silence while he walked a circuit around the vehicle and checked the obvious places to hide a tracker.

Satisfied, he dumped the bags in the boot and, with exaggerated chivalry, opened the passenger door for her.

“Thank you, Sir Galahad. Go on then, what’s the latest with Christine?”

His briefing concluded long before they reached Walthamstow. It helped to talk about it. Plus, she enjoyed hearing about Bob’s suspension. He told her about Germany and that left Ann Crossley, but she was strictly by the book — and one without the pages folded down. Even Karl seemed out of ideas, bar one.

Miranda played devil’s advocate. “Could Karl be delaying contact with Sir Peter to protect his asset?”

He chewed it over and spat it out. “Nah, I can’t see it.”

“Or maybe you don’t want to.”

Although Thomas refused to believe in coincidence, he accepted that life sometimes played bad jokes. Karl rang up with news that Nicholas now occupied a desk in Southampton — Bob Peterson’s stamping ground.

“That should mean Peterson can get you into the building. Different department though.”

Karl’s ‘few words’ mantra was maddening. Another department could be anything from intelligence agency to humble civil servants’ outpost. No point asking because Karl wasn’t telling.

“Bob is still suspended.”

Karl spoke as a man who enjoyed the luxury of detachment. “True, but I’m sure he needs to pop into work to return some keys or a phone.”

“You mean the mobile that’s out of service?”

“Just get to Southampton tomorrow morning and try not to make a scene. G’night.”

Miranda rustled up tea and toast while Thomas rechecked the route. “So exactly what are you gonna do when you’re face to face with this Nicholas geezer?”

He smiled, feeling the corners of his mouth reach up into his cheekbones. “I’m going to make him a proposition.”

Chapter 19

Two hours plus on the M25 and M3 motorways made for a lot of thinking time. He used it wisely. Nicholas acting as the courier at Pat's door led straight back to Sir Peter Carroll, which also explained why she'd been targeted. The problem with that pearl of insight was that Sir Peter also knew him well enough to know it would only spur him on.

He reached into a bag of sherbet bonbons that had lived in the driver's door for longer than he cared to think about. Karl called him a spy chaser because he had a knack for forcing them out into the open. So what if . . . and it felt like treachery even to suggest it . . . what if Christine was compromised and they needed someone she trusted to flush her out?

Even at seven fifteen in the morning he expected Karl to be on active service.

Karl answered the phone with a yawn. "Yeah? You on the road, Tommo?"

"Uh-huh. Listen, I've been thinking. Only four people we know could have accessed my file for Pat's address: Sir Peter, Christine, Bob Peterson and Eva Fairfield. If someone else was behind it, it's *statistically improbable* they'd have used someone already known to us. No one's that unlucky."

Karl laughed. "I have a feeling Nicky boy is about to be. Hey, remember I nearly shot him on the moors?"

That raised a smile. "And then there's Christine's mobile blipping on the radar at just the right moment. If Miranda hadn't already been up there, I'd have probably headed north and made a search. Hold on a second . . ." He clocked the police car some distance behind him, blue lights flashing, and wound down the window for sirens. Anyone with access to the police's Automatic Number Plate Recognition database could find him without difficulty. The BMW's throaty roar cut through traffic like a sabre and passed by. "Sorry, cop car going past. Where was I?"

"Fumbling in the dark. Stick to what we know — or think we know. Christine wasn't bundled onto a plane at Northolt . . . what if Sir Peter had a seat next to her? Maybe that should be our line of inquiry."

“Careful though. Look what happened to Bob.”

“I’ve got better friends.”

“Let me try Nicholas first. Bladen out.”

Bob Peterson was as good as his word, waiting in his car near the slip road into the motorway services. Thomas stopped beside him and lowered the passenger window. “I’ll follow you down.”

Bob had dressed for the occasion, his pinstriped shirt an instant irritation for Thomas. He caught a glimpse of Bob’s watch as well, a classic example of what a man with too much money and not enough taste would wear. It struck him for an instant that Bob might be playing him for a fool. He sucked on a bonbon and decided Bob had nothing to gain from it. Besides, he knew where Bob lived.

Thomas parked up and waited for Bob to get out of his car. They walked in together, the stony-faced brothers.

Bob Peterson pushed the glass door and held it open. “You’ll need to sign in.”

Showtime. The reception staff, who all looked as if they’d spent time in uniform, acknowledged Bob at the desk. Thomas flashed his SSU ID and added a line to the visitor’s book. Nothing high-tech about this building and evidently no marker against Bob Peterson’s ID. Maybe they relied on gentlemanly conduct when it came to management.

They passed through the foyer and Thomas glanced at the list of building occupants — Department for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs; Her Majesty’s Revenue & Customs; Maritime & Coastguard Agency. He smiled to himself. Maybe search and rescue was his forte — when all this was over he could always ask for a job. What interested him more were the empty name slots on the third and fourth floors. A pound to a penny that was where Bob’s SSU team lived.

“I’ll take you up,” Bob called behind him.

Thomas glanced at his watch. Karl would be on his way to meet Eva for the database results. They climbed the stairwell in silence. He’d expected Bob to leave him outside. But Bob still had a surprise or two up his sleeve.

There was no sign at the door. Thomas tapped on the reinforced glass. The first face to arrive read their ID cards, brandished like credit cards in a busy bar scrum. Only this time a speedy service was guaranteed.

Thomas had the guy pegged in five words: middle aged (he counted that as one), poor sleeper, sedentary lifestyle. As they watched him retreat for instructions, Thomas could hear Bob's nasal breathing like a rush of wind, unsuccessfully trying to induce calm. After a silent count of ninety, the desk jockey returned and unlocked the door.

"Can I help you?"

Bob cleared his throat. "We are here to see Nicholas — he isn't expecting us. We're here on behalf of Sir Peter Carroll."

The underling shrank at the name. "Come in. Please have a seat."

Thomas raised his eyebrows at Bob, who risked a smile. The other staff barely looked up from their computer screens. A door opened at the far end of the office, past banks of desks and a lot of empty space where cables poked up from the floor in readiness for yet more desks.

Nicholas hadn't ventured out of his office. Thomas figured that if he were smart, he'd be looking for an escape route. Then again, Nicholas had no reason to suspect Thomas had him pinned for any Yorkshire house calls. And if he remembered Bob Peterson from their previous encounter, three years before, he'd have him down as one of Sir Peter's men. Ergo, Nicholas was probably still deciding how to play the situation.

Miranda's mother, Diane, could sometimes be persuaded — usually alcohol was involved — to tell a few stories about her days as a croupier. She reckoned everyone had their signals, broadcast non-stop. Study the person enough — it didn't usually take long — and they were clear as semaphore. She said it had helped her interact with the punters and kept the money flowing to the house. Part croupier and part therapist.

Thomas thought about that and studied Bob's face in the last few seconds before they reached Nicholas's domain. Why hadn't he seen it before? Bob's jitters had nothing to do with his job. Christine had been missing for days and this was entirely personal. And now Thomas had given him Nicholas on a plate.

Nicholas was the same suave bastard Thomas remembered. The right school, the right tie — well, he was at least wearing one — and that unstated sense of entitlement that made Thomas want to rearrange his features.

Bob closed the door behind them and their quarry got up from behind his desk. Nicholas made it to the centre of the room. "What can I do for

you, gentlemen?”

Bob answered him with a left hook to the jaw. No preamble, no warning. Nicholas hit the deck in freefall like a crash dummy.

“Where’s Christine?”

Nicholas blinked a couple of times and spread his hands on the carpet, as if checking the ground would support him. Bob was still breathing red mist.

“I’ll ask you one last time and then I’ll let Thomas have a go.”

Thomas felt himself warming to Bob by the second.

Nicholas pushed himself to sitting and rubbed his jaw. He looked more pissed off than afraid. “I simply followed orders.”

Bob looked eager for round two, but Thomas had a better idea. He gestured to the door. Bob took the hint, and waited outside like a sentinel. Nicholas’s eyes widened when Thomas leaned towards him.

“Maybe you’re incidental in this and maybe somebody picked you for the job. Either way, you are in a very precarious position — you need friends. Be smart. Contact Sir Peter and tell him—”

“I wouldn’t know how, honestly. They sent me up to Yorkshire on standby. I collected the envelope and delivered the message. That’s all.”

Thomas leaned against the edge of the desk and smiled. “Well, not quite. You’re forgetting Christine’s mobile phone.” An educated guess. He went over and offered a hand, pulling an incredulous Nicholas to his feet. An encore to Bob’s lefthander was tempting, but he was on a schedule. “Get a message to Sir Peter. Tell him if we don’t hear from Christine in the next seventy-two hours all agreements are void. He’ll understand.”

He took a step towards the door and turned. “What did you do with her phone?”

Nicholas fussed with his tie. “An anonymous text gave me a collection point.”

“You work in intelligence, you’ll figure something out.”

Nicholas said nothing. Thomas didn’t need him to. It seemed like Sir Peter was pulling the strings from every angle. Thomas grabbed the door handle. “One more thing. If you ever go near my sister again, I’ll break your arms.”

Thomas and Bob Peterson walked back along the office together, brothers-in-arms, serenaded by speed typing and no human interaction.

Thomas half expected security to meet them at the door, but this was the civil service and decorum remained the order of the day. He waited in the stairwell while Bob popped in to see his own team.

They parted company in the car park. Thomas couldn't resist complimenting Bob on his southpaw punch, especially for a right-hander.

“I'll be in touch when we have something.”

Bob nodded curtly. “Make it count.”

Chapter 20

Thomas reflected on his progress during the drive back to London. Not too shabby. Bob was onside, Nicholas had as good as confirmed Sir Peter's involvement and got smacked in the mouth.

He hit the hands-free and left a message on Miranda's mobile. No hearts and flowers, a midpoint between affectionate and salacious — the way she liked it. He couldn't help wondering how his folks had received Miranda solo, and without warning. Oh to have been a fly on that wall.

The gods of Traffic found other mortals to torture, and left him free to glide into North London not long after noon. Karl confirmed lunch would be waiting, along with Molly and Fareed for another thrilling instalment of community spying.

It might have been his imagination but the police seemed out in force today. He hoped it was a readiness test rather than a response to a threat, and thought back to DS Karen Edwards and DC Jun Wen at Paddington Green police station. One temporary assignment among many, and pub promises to keep in touch rarely survived after closing time. Even so, two good coppers. A shame about their idiot boss.

The three musketeers — Karl, Molly and Fareed — were waiting upstairs at the rendezvous site, although Fareed didn't look all-for-one at all. A new face was holding court, another sharp suit with an agenda.

"Look, it's your choice, Fareed. All I'm asking you to do is go into the community centre, drink tea, and pretend you're interested."

Fareed glowered. "I am interested. This is *my* community."

Thomas went and stood with them, four against one.

The new suit helped himself to some peanuts and shovelled them down. "Sure, sure. So make some friends there and, you know, 'connect.'" He traced speech marks with his fingers and Thomas felt a little part of himself die. "Here's a mobile phone with preloaded pics of a wife and two daughters, plus some texts, in case there's an opportunity to get especially friendly with anyone."

Karl's patience showed signs of exceeding its safety limit. "Sebastian, hold on a second. We're not trained for this kind of fieldwork. We do

surveillance — it's on the badge."

The suit squared up to Karl, with about a five inch height advantage. "I can hardly go in myself — I no speaka da language."

Molly laid a hand on Fareed's shoulder. "You don't have to do this. There's nothing to prove here."

"No, I'll do it. But this is the last time."

Fareed went in after an hour. He'd practised a few lines over the radio with Karl, and waited until more people entered the building. From the car, Thomas and Karl watched him approach the front gate and put a phone to his ear.

Karl nudged Thomas. "Nice touch. Probably had Molly call him from the crows' nest so he can go in mid-conversation."

The second Fareed disappeared through the doorway, Thomas ranged his lens over every window he could see.

Karl spoke quietly, a minimal distraction. "How did you get on at Southampton?"

Thomas kept the sight to his eye. "Better than expected. Bob punched Nicholas's lights out and all roads seem to lead to Sir Peter." He lowered his arm and blinked to refocus.

"Come on now, aren't you warming to Bob — just a teensy bit?"

"I wouldn't go quite that far. Poor bastard — they're running rings around him and Christine's still missing."

Karl knew when to take a hint. "I'll try to reach his chauffeur again. Failing that, there's always Mrs Gerrard. Or is it Lady? I forget how it works with titles."

Thomas passed him a bonbon. "Fareed's been in there for nearly fifteen minutes."

Karl pulled a road atlas out of the passenger door and idly flicked through the pages. "It's a community centre for chrissake. What's the worst that could happen?"

"Says the man who avoided the Irish community centres in London."

"Catholic and Protestant divide, Tommo. Plus, I had other reasons to keep to the shadows. This is different."

Thomas pretended to ring a small bell. "Hello? Sunni and Shia?"

Karl clicked the radio and adjusted his headset. "Fuck. I hadn't thought of that. Crows' nest from ground team. Are you receiving? Any sign of our

man?”

“Not in the past few minutes. I’ve seen our wandering target though. I’ll keep you posted. Molly out.”

The radio silence lasted ten minutes. Karl closed the road atlas and pressed his hand on it, as if he were taking an oath. “I’m gonna stretch my legs and call Ann for an update. Fingers crossed, eh, Tommo?”

Thomas crossed his arms instead. “What, like my gun?”

“I wondered when you’d ask. We are meeting the minister tomorrow at St James’s Park. Didn’t I tell you to trust your Uncle Karl?” Karl ambled away, flipping the finger behind his back. What a child. Alone, Thomas cranked the driver’s side window open a touch and listened to summer. One of the delights of photography — and surveillance — was that delicious sense of place and presence. Sounds, colours and scents all conspired to fix a moment in memory as it played out around you.

He laughed at his own thoughts and shielded his eyes against the sunshine. Distant lawnmowers thrummed like wasps, and some dickhead revved up an engine further along the street. Jarred back to reality, he peered across the heat haze of the tarmac and picked up a lens, breathing in the sweet smell of cut grass.

While he observed nothing happening at the community centre, an idea burst into his head. Telephone time. “Alright, Ajit, you free to talk? No need to explain about Miranda, it’s fine mate. You two looked after her and that’s good enough for me.” He let Ajit enjoy a moment of contrition and then offered absolution. “Aj, could you do me a massive favour? Yeah, I know — *another* one. I want to report a missing person anonymously. According to her mobile phone she was in Pickering.”

Ajit coughed out a strangled breath. “Is this connected with your sister?”

He raised the car window and ignored the question. “It’s my boss, Christine.” He knew not to interrupt a police sergeant in full flow and let Ajit talk himself out.

“Okay, Thomas, just so we’re clear, is this Christine actually missing?”

He bit at a thumbnail. “Definitely. Her partner is very concerned . . .” He let the sentence hang in the air.

“There’s more to it though.”

He watched Karl rounding the corner and decided to call it quits. “Tell you what, Aj, leave it for now. Sorry, I’ve gotta go. Cheers, mate.” There was nothing left to say so he kept it that way.

Karl tapped on the window and Thomas unlocked the doors.

“Ringing the wife, Tommo?”

“Surveillance’s gain is comedy’s loss. Nah, I considered reporting Christine as missing to see what crawled out of the woodwork, but Ajit—”

Karl nodded. “He does things by the book.” The radio bleeped as he got in. He treated protocol with his usual disdain. “Go ahead, Molly.”

“We may have a situation. Fareed and our target together — moving down the far-left staircase. Shit, lost them. I think someone is coming out . . .” She stopped, wrong by fifty per cent.

The target emerged from a fire door and held it open. Fareed soon followed. Thomas shifted his focus but the angle and distance conspired against him.

Molly’s voice didn’t waver. “They’re making headway. Suggest one of you follow on foot and the other stand by in case they get into a vehicle.”

Thomas handed Karl the car key and then dialled her on his mobile. “Molly, you reading me?”

“Loud and clear.”

They had a few yards’ lead on him and he deliberately held back. Molly’s voice crackled in his earpiece.

He started a commentary. “I still have eyes on them. Hold on, they’re turning right — that’s the third turning from the old school.” He picked up the pace.

“That’ll be Murchley Road,” Karl chimed in.

“How the hell did you—?”

“Molly patched me in.”

Thomas slowed at the corner and spotted the two men crossing over before they disappeared from view. He fixed his gaze on the lamppost nearest them and started counting. Each step lent certainty to his movements. He missed the cold comfort of the Makarov pistol and remembered how he’d laughed at Karl’s warning that he’d one day come to rely on it.

A few paces from the lamppost he saw the newsagent’s sign and weighed the odds. Not a typical place for an ambush. Even so, he felt his

fingers moulding around his house keys. “I’m still around but I’ll stop talking.”

He checked his other pocket for change and gave in to a sudden craving for chocolate. The newsagent’s door was festooned with stickers and leaflets that blocked the view. He pushed it with his forearm. The door beeped when he crossed the threshold. A girl at the counter looked up from her magazine and gave him three seconds of her time.

It may have said newsagent above the door but it felt more like a supermarket in miniature. Two sets of shelves ran to the back of the shop, splitting the space into three narrow walkways. They must have been a bastard to stock. He did his best stage audition of nonchalance and listened hard for voices.

Fareed and the target were standing at the far end of the left-hand aisle. Thomas glanced once, pretending to browse the dairy section. Then he turned around and zeroed in on the first thing in view — a tin of peas — and selected the small one because it fit neatly into his hand. He wasted time at the counter choosing chocolate and deliberately asked for more change as a stalling tactic, hoping Fareed had seen or heard him. As the girl made the sale and dug out the extra coins, Thomas noticed her gloves. He thought it strange, as the shop wasn’t that cold.

He checked out the newspaper headlines in the rack, thankful that none said anything about handguns, and then opened the door. He moved at a leisurely pace, peas and keys in his hands. A few steps on he heard someone call something out — “Ya ka-lib.” It didn’t sound complimentary so he kept on walking.

Karl tracked his return to the car through mimed binoculars. “How did you get on?”

He passed him the peas and shared the little he’d discovered. Then they played the waiting game that lay at the heart of all surveillance work. It left too much time for thinking.

Thomas spoke aloud to quell his thoughts. “Why don’t we take a drive around the streets. Molly?”

“Uh-huh. Gets my vote. I can cover the front from here.”

Karl started the car. “Thomas will keep you connected on his phone.”

He directed Karl to take an earlier right turn so they could approach Murchley Road from the other end. The pavements were empty, apart from

two kids passing a football back and forth, under the watchful eye of an elderly man. They left the ball and stood motionless when the car passed and then the man ushered the children away.

Thomas turned his head to watch them go inside. “Maybe we look too much like coppers.” Neither of them enjoyed the joke. “Go across the main road and then loop back in a couple of blocks.”

The quiet streets seemed sinister. Thomas felt like an outsider and asked himself questions he didn’t want to answer. Fareed could be behind any of those doors and they’d never know. He gestured for another right turn.

Karl hadn’t said a word — he didn’t have to. If Fareed didn’t turn up soon or make contact, they’d have to call it in. And nobody wanted that.

The car stopped at a junction, just as the target crossed to the other side of the street. Another of life’s bad jokes. He glanced over as he stepped into the road, and then a second time when he reached the other side.

“Bollocks, he’s made us. Take a left, Karl. We won’t give him the satisfaction of a third viewing. Molly, we’re coming back the long way to the lookout. You’d best get our ‘handler’ on the blower. I think the shit’s about to hit the fan.”

Chapter 21

Molly waved an empty mug at Thomas. “Thanks a million, just the one sugar. Alright, so Rupee’s heading over with Sebastian.”

Thomas wandered off to the kitchen, filled the kettle and flicked the switch. No doubt about it, this base was a step up from their usual dives — a mini oven, the obligatory microwave, a small fridge, and even a backroom fitted out for the big sleepover. The first and second floors sat above an old factory unit now reimagined as a media start-up. At least, that’s what the sign outside said.

Out the window, he watched two cars pull up in the back yard. He’d expected Rupee and Sebastian to arrive together, but seeing Fareed get out of Sebastian’s car blindsided him. Maybe Fareed was playing another game altogether.

Sebastian led the arrivals. Fareed looked as though he’d already been through the wringer before their debrief. Rupee had a face like thunder. Thomas figured they were about to enter monsoon season.

Molly glanced over at Fareed and then resumed surveillance from the window, cool as a breeze. “No further activity since the target returned to the community centre.”

Fareed’s smile enjoyed a brief existence. “He’s called Emjay. At least, that’s what he told me.”

Rupee made the first incursion. “Why were you there, Fareed? That’s not part of your remit.”

Fareed stared blankly at Sebastian, who went into negotiator mode.

“Look, I think we all need to see the bigger picture. I spotted an opportunity for better intelligence gathering—”

Rupee blocked him. “What the hell did you expect to accomplish, and where was the risk assessment?”

“It’s a community centre, okay? And he has been there before.”

Rupee squared up to him. “You what?”

Listening to the two of them play top trumps with their experience and position, Thomas reasoned they were probably equal-sized cogs in the machinery of intelligence. Although that didn’t mean they were the same.

It would have been rude not to ask and Ma Bladen had always taught Thomas manners. “Sebastian, who are you with? You’re not part of the SSU so is it MI5 or MI6?”

A flicker of the eye — a poker tell, suddenly seen and quickly forgotten. Unless you’d studied under Diane Wright in the Dagenham bear pit of Texas Hold Em. He smiled. Sebastian belonged to neither service — he’d stake money on it.

For a man in such a sharp suit, Sebastian seemed to have lost his edge. “I’m not here to satisfy your curiosity. You should be answering my questions. Who fucked up?”

Thomas caught Karl’s momentary grin. No doubt about it, posh folks swearing never ceased to amuse, as if they were so fired up they just couldn’t help getting down with the *people*. He stood with Karl to wait for a lull in hostilities.

When Rupee and Sebastian were done accusing one another, Fareed presented his version of events. While he didn’t accept full responsibility, he owned the decision to go in without a risk assessment. Thomas didn’t need to be a country boy to recognise the whiff of bullshit in the room.

Fareed put a positive spin on it. “One of the people at the centre invited me along on an errand, so we could talk further. Thomas followed me to a shop in Murchley Road — our agreed protocol.”

Thomas glanced skyward. All for one. “The shop is another site of interest, although static surveillance would be problematic due to the location and the tight-knit community.” He stopped talking, figuring he’d given Fareed enough breathing space.

“Thanks, Thomas. We went to a nearby house. There may be useful intel there. I’ve been invited back to a discussion group. I think it’s a try-out to gauge my politics.”

Sebastian and Rupee made notes.

She spoke first. “What was your cover?”

“I told them I’d been a teacher and that’s true. A third party at the house spoke about the state of the world — what you’d expect: the plight of Iraq and Afghanistan, brothers and sisters in the West.”

Thomas thought Fareed looked faintly embarrassed, and then he corrected that to *judged*. He wasn’t surprised when Karl took aim at the elephant in the room.

“Did anybody discuss the bombings in London?”

Fareed shook his head. “Not really. They said the community felt under threat. Emjay deferred to the other guy.”

Sebastian stared at Fareed, skipping his last sentence. “And no one mentioned jihad?”

Karl choked on a breath. “Do you even know what the word means, Sebastian?” He opened a hand in invitation. “Fareed?”

“It means struggle, and that includes the struggle to be a better person.” His voice dipped. “After a few minutes I made my excuses and left.” He held up the mobile Sebastian had supplied. “They have this number.”

Sebastian waved his hands in front of his chest. “You keep it. A stranger’s voice might tip them off. We’ll monitor the calls.” He turned to Thomas and Karl. “Now, suppose you two clowns tell me why you interfered in Fareed’s work and why I shouldn’t kick your arses back to Liverpool Street.”

Karl made a move forward and Thomas grabbed his shoulder.

“Me and Tommo went to support a colleague. We stayed in constant contact with Molly at base. Where were you, Sebastian, after you sent him in to do your dirty work?” He took a breath and glanced down at his feet, an act Thomas had seen before. “Even if someone recognised us — if they did — Molly could still work on the ground with another partner and the three of us can work up here in shifts.”

Sebastian took a step forward. “When I want your suggestions I’ll ask for them.”

Rupee tapped him on the shoulder. “Can we talk in private?”

The grownups went off to another room.

Karl held court and posted Thomas as lookout. “Right, people. We need to decide what we reveal about our jaunts to the kebab house.”

Fareed scratched the back of his neck. “Why tell them anything?”

“Tommo?”

“He has a point.”

Molly’s voice was so quiet it commanded attention. “You’re all missing something. How else do you explain about being recognised?”

The three men exchanged looks of stupidity.

Karl broke off a piece of biscuit. “I’ll go and break the bad news.”

It didn't take long. A few minutes of Judas talk and Karl returned with company. The spring thaw had arrived.

Sebastian checked his watch as he re-entered the room. "In light of Karl's information I'll review the rosters. Let's wrap it up for today."

Later, in the car, Thomas asked Karl the sixty-four-thousand-dollar question. "What did you tell them?"

"Enough to get us off the hook. How we'd followed Emjay to a car that's registered to the Foreign Office. I'm not convinced it was news to Sebastian, but Rupee looked ready to pop a vein."

"What did Sebastian say?"

"Good question, Tommo. Not much. He never commented on Emjay, or whether he works for the FCO."

"Conclusions, maestro?"

"You might wanna sit down for this."

Thomas looked around for effect. "We're in a car."

Karl held out a hand for a bonbon, a sure sign he was pleased with himself. "Don't quote me on this." He took a couple of exaggerated slurps. "I think Emjay is a Foreign Office mole in the community centre."

"So we've really blown it then. Ann will be delighted."

"Not sure we have, actually. My educated guess? Sebastian is also FCO and Emjay is under surveillance — a joint operation with MI5."

It almost seemed a shame to scratch Karl's perfectly faceted explanation. "There's one thing wrong with this picture . . ."

"I know." Karl slurped again. "The Foreign & Commonwealth Office doesn't run its own surveillance teams — MI6 usually does that."

Thomas reached into the bonbon bag for himself. "An inter-agency turf war. That's won't look good in our report." He read Karl's Cheshire Cat grin. "Which is why it won't be in it, and why Sebastian will do his utmost not to drop us in the shit."

"Is that not a shining example of cooperation between departments? And on that note, I'll let you get home for your beauty sleep. We must look our best for the minister tomorrow."

* * *

Happiness, Thomas decided as he parked up outside the flat in Walthamstow, was blue Mini shaped. Miranda's car bonnet felt cool to the

touch, raising expectations of a freshly cooked meal. He opened the front door and inhaled the smell of paint instead.

“I’m in here,” she called.

He followed her voice to the bedroom. Dungarees and a T-shirt had never looked so good, accessorised by a cute paint smudge on one cheek. The previous night a burgundy colour scheme had been a throwaway idea. Now it was done, he gave serious thought to wrestling her onto the plastic sheeting to show her his appreciation.

“Bloody hell, Miranda. You didn’t have to do all this.”

“I wanted to. Besides, I couldn’t help myself when I got your flowers — a nice touch.” One look at his face broke the spell. “Oh, bollocks.”

Bollocks indeed. He shifted into work mode instantly, questioning her about every aspect of the delivery — how they’d been left on the doorstep, the state of the original packaging, and whether anything raised her suspicions. A card on the kitchen table was blank but for a small ‘x’ in the bottom right-hand corner that barely indented the surface. A magnifying glass revealed no fingerprints. He thought it through as he went round the flat, rechecking the door locks and the windows, and then rang Karl.

“Okay, Tommo, do you feel that you might need protection tonight?”

“Nah, I think the threat is purely psychological.”

“Fair enough. Maybe keep your tin of peas handy . . .”

Thomas laughed. “Very droll. Before you go, any update on Jack’s paternity test?”

Karl took a long slow breath down the phone. “I thought you knew. I had my pal contact Sheryl directly. Need to know . . . Sleep tight.”

Thomas wandered through to the kitchen, where Miranda had laid out the ingredients for dinner. Steak appeared to be on the menu, along with a fine bottle of red.

He moved behind her, snaking his arms around her waist. “You cooking? Nice one.”

“Guess again. I shopped, you cook. Besides, I need to get cleaned up.” She unhooked one of her dungaree straps and pouted, enjoying the look of anticipation on his face. “Come on, chop chop. I’ve worked up an appetite.”

Watching her step out of her dungarees on her way to the shower, he knew just how she felt.

Chapter 22

Thomas woke in the early hours of the morning, still thinking about the flowers. Someone had wanted to see who was at home, probably for pictures. He gazed around the front room where they'd slept to escape the smell of emulsion. No two ways about it, he'd be much happier when he got his gun back. He shifted towards the side of the mattress and felt Miranda clasping his thigh.

With great reluctance he unpeeled her fingers. "Go back to sleep. I'll be in the kitchen." He felt around in the half-light for a pen and paper, carefully closing the door before he flicked on the light. Jesus, that hurt. Once his eyes had adjusted to the glare he sat down and tried organising his thoughts in ink.

They'd come no nearer to locating Christine since the day she disappeared. Well, they knew where she'd *been*, and hopefully Karl had already put the wheels in motion to follow up the German connection. He squeezed the pen as he thought about that shitbag, Nicholas, turning up at Pat's front door. Given the timing, someone must be monitoring their progress. That'd explain the intimidation by flowers as well, maybe even Miranda's paranoia about a photographer at the station.

He stared at the page for inspiration and circled the pen, drawing and redrawing the same overlapping rings. Mrs Gerrard bothered him. Nothing new there, but why offer him money for something he would have done anyway? More to the point, why tell him nothing? Surely to Christ she must have some idea about her daughter? He smiled, imagining his mother's horrified face at his sacrilege. Swearing she could just about cope with, but not taking her Lord's name in vain!

The kitchen door eased in. "You do know you've been talking to yourself?" Miranda sat down and flattened her hair. She picked up his pad of empty circles, sniffed noncommittally and then handed it back. "How about ringing up Christine's mother with an update? You might get a reaction or something."

He smiled at the voice of common sense. "Any other wisdom on offer?"

She got up, flicked on the kettle and moved a couple of coffee mugs out, ready for service. “Even Karl, despite his connections, has drawn a blank with Christine. Maybe she doesn’t want to be found — for reasons of her own.”

He gave her idea the two seconds he thought it deserved. “Christine, a defector to the Shadow State? Not in a million years.”

She shrugged, so be it. By the time she’d fetched out milk and coffee, the kettle had boiled. She passed him a morning pick-me-up. “Talk me through your meeting with her mother.”

He grabbed some shortbreads from the drawer, sipped scalding coffee, and took her step-by-step through his visit to Gerrard Hall.

“And she wasn’t frightened for her daughter?”

He figured Francesca wouldn’t know a genuine emotion if it bit her on the arse. But no, not scared. Concerned, maybe. As if Christine might have got herself mixed up in something . . . He hugged the coffee mug until his fingers pleaded for mercy.

She broke off half a shortbread. “Maybe she’s done a bunk with Sir Peter to start a new life, but it’d be harder for him to stay off the radar!”

He let her have the last laugh. “Maybe.” Something else on Karl’s to-do list.

Thomas was dressed to impress by six am. An Oxford shirt and tie — chosen by Miranda, naturally.

She stood behind him, admiring her creation. “You scrub up rather well.”

He tried not to fidget while she adjusted his tie so it didn’t look like an afterthought. “Let’s hope so. I’m on a charm offensive today.”

She slipped her fingers between his shirt buttons, the heat from her hand spreading across his torso. “Reckon you’ll get your gun back?”

“Karl thinks so.” He had a hard time convincing himself.

She dusted him down and nodded at the mirror. “You’ll do. Give me a ring to let me know how you got on.”

He thought about the flowers again. “Listen, don’t hang around the flat today. Why don’t you go and see Sheryl?”

“And spy on her for you?”

He touched his wounded heart. “That’s harsh! I’m thinking of Sheryl. Jack’s never denied being her dad — well, except maybe to his wife — but

seeing it in black and white is different. She might appreciate a friend.”

She rewarded his chivalry with a kiss. Her mouth was minty fresh, a clean-living taste at odds with his inclinations. No time for that now. He had monsters to face.

Karl’s dulcet tones accompanied him by phone on the walk up to Walthamstow Central tube station. “So the way I see it, Tommo, yer man from the ministry is keen to eyeball us. I shouldn’t wonder if we’ll end up on photos in a file.”

Thomas scowled, remembering when an American agent had shown him a similar file and what he had to do to get it shredded. “No way of avoiding it, I s’pose, unless we meet more formally?”

Karl laughed down the phone. “I shouldn’t have thought so, Thomas. We’re unlikely to receive an invitation to the Houses of Parliament, or tea with MI5 at Thames House.” Karl rustled a packet of something. “Nah, a public place is a long lens photo opportunity. Which is fine, because that’s what we’re doing as well.”

“Come again?”

“Oh, didn’t I mention it? Ann is leaving behind the comfort of her desk to do our camera work. Personally, I think she enjoys the intrigue.”

They’d run out of things to say by the time Thomas joined the funnel of happy commuters swarming into the ticket hall. He felt part of the crowd and hated the feeling, reduced to just another tie with sensible shoes, only with a rucksack instead of a man bag or a briefcase.

A packed platform made it easier to blend in, but his rucksack earned him a few uncomfortable stares. He knew the score, making enough eye contact to suggest he wasn’t a threat without actually starting a conversation. All the time watching them watching him. The drone of an approaching train interrupted his mental meandering. He’d always sought sanctuary in details. Karl reckoned he ought to call his autobiography *The Joy of Pixels*.

After the doors slid shut he slipped a small book from his pocket — *The Art of War*. Years before, Karl told him it had been found on the body of a hitman, Yorgi, whose acquaintance they made on the last day of his life. Soon after, Thomas purchased the book to get inside Yorgi’s head. Funny that, trying to understand a dead man.

A hipster joined the train at Highbury & Islington, nodding appreciatively as he eased past. Thomas flicked to a random page and resisted the urge to explain non-verbally that no, they were not best buds. Sun Tzu, renowned general and strategist, had a lot to say about outwitting the enemy without fighting. Easy words if you weren't staring down the barrel of a gun. He gave up on battle philosophy and focused on a commuter's newspaper. After half a paragraph of plucky British spirit, St James's Park couldn't come soon enough.

The Victoria Station interchange was rammed solid with people. He found it strangely comforting. London had found its rhythm again, the chaotic day-to-day normality a bigger fuck-you to the hate mongers of all persuasions than any political statement.

He weaved through the worker ants blindly following their scent trails, to await a Circle Line train for St James's Park station. Some semi-clad lovely stared out from an advertising spread with a smile like Portland cement and a vacant expression for all eternity. He reckoned she'd been captured on celluloid by a Nikon, maybe the D2X he'd read about. His eyes wandered to the expensive perfume bottle in her hand, an empty promise that looked cheap by comparison. The whole set-up some ad-man's construct, as genuine as a manifesto.

Leaving the next station, he made the ascent to the real world. Karl stood at the other side of the barrier like an anxious war bride. No coffees today though, Thomas noted. They'd surely earn them by lunchtime.

Karl moved at a pace, steering them round to Queen Anne's Gate and then across Birdcage Walk to the park. He stopped abruptly at the Boy Statue, admiring the sculptured marble while a family of tourists passed. Thomas concluded they were Japanese because of their Fuji cameras.

Karl spoke into a mike by his collar. "We're on the plot, Ann. Are you in position?"

"Fully embedded, over."

Karl smirked to Thomas and pulled back his shirt to reveal the off-switch. "Okay, Ann, they should be calling soon."

Thomas felt his jaw slacken. "You gave them your phone number?"

"Under the circumstances, that was the least of my concerns. Besides, I have *many* numbers."

As if by magic, or more likely surveillance on his phone's location, Karl's mobile tringed. "Good morning." He kept his tone on the abrupt side of professional. "We're in the park."

Thomas looked around them out of habit.

"The Blue Bridge? Certainly. Thomas and I will see you there."

Karl's face said it all. They had as much likelihood of eyeballing the minister on the bridge as Thomas had of becoming Mayor of London. This was a dummy run to make them visible and put them under pressure.

Hordes of happy snappers were already loitering on the bridge, as though they'd never seen a goose before. Karl passed Thomas an envelope, which he carefully stowed in his rucksack. They played at sightseers, letting the ragtag ebb and flow of people drift around them.

Karl and Thomas leaned towards the water so that a murmured conversation with Ann would seem like everyday chatter.

"You better get ready to move, Ann."

"I have my running shoes on, over."

Thomas raised an eyebrow. Ann did spontaneous humour — who knew? After a handful of minutes he began to wonder if it had all been a waste of time. A second call proved him wrong.

"We're waiting for you at the bandstand."

Karl didn't falter. He'd obviously studied a map because he pointed it out for Thomas and then set off at speed. Karl played at tour guide. "An interesting choice, psychologically speaking. The bandstand is only up in summer. Seems apt somehow — a temporary location for temporary diplomacy."

The security officer from the woods wasn't hard to find in a crowd. Thomas made it a rule never to forget someone who'd body-slammed him. The minister stood next to his minder, very still. Karl mumbled a final comment to Ann and then clicked off the mike.

As they zeroed in on their hosts near a striped gazebo, the thing that struck Thomas was how small and insignificant the minister seemed. While the man-mountain security guy owned the space, the other bloke looked lost. Or maybe he just had more to lose.

Karl edged around to face them, shook hands nicely and introduced Thomas. He nodded and stayed one pace behind Karl, as they'd arranged. The minister's escort gestured to one side and they found a quieter spot in

the open, ideal for photography. A silent standoff lasted for a few seconds with all the discomfort of a blind date minus the promise.

Karl made the first move and handed over a manila envelope. “That’s all the photographs, such as they are, plus the SD card. You’ll also find your cigarette butt that Thomas recovered from the scene.”

The minister became coy. “Maybe I smoked more than one?”

“If you did, we never found them. And just to show goodwill, there’s something else for you.”

Thomas gave the second envelope to the MI5 officer. “Counter intelligence on the blackmailer.” He tried to look convincing. No mean feat as he had no idea what information Karl had dug up or what would be done with it. “Use it with discretion.”

The MI5 bloke cracked a smile. At a nod from the minister he lifted a jiffy bag at chest height and held it close for the finale.

Now the minister took a small step forward. “I need to know who requested surveillance on me. I don’t propose to take any action — for the moment. But I think I’m entitled to know who my enemies are.”

Thomas saw an opportunity and grabbed it with both hands. “His name is Nicholas. He works out of the Shared Services building in Southampton, fourth floor. Not sure which department — should be easy enough to find out. For what it’s worth, we didn’t know who you were, that night in the woods. The job got assigned and we carried it out.”

“Then how did you trace me later to organise this exchange?”

“You don’t really expect us to answer that?”

Security bloke grinned and then carefully transferred the jiffy bag to Thomas’s waiting hands. “Returned as promised.”

The still point lasted a breath. Karl and his MI5 counterpart shook hands again and then each side withdrew, the status quo preserved. Karl was in touch with Ann before they’d made twenty paces.

She met them in a park café with three large coffees waiting. A silver camera case rested at her feet.

Thomas stared in admiration at what might be inside. “What did you shoot with?”

Ann’s poker face softened. “A Nikon. 300mm.”

He sat down, dumbfounded. “You must have been saving up.”

She tilted her coffee to him. “Every week, in a special jar.”

Karl went to the counter in search of snacks. Ann suddenly cupped a hand to her left ear.

“Say again, Bob. Uh-huh. Thanks. Ann out.” She removed an earpiece and felt in her ear with her little finger. “Don’t look so surprised, Thomas. Bob Peterson is one of us now.” She paused until Karl rejoined them. “The two targets from the park went to Horse Guards Road.”

Karl handed out chocolate muffins. Thomas figured it’d be the closest they’d get to a commendation and wasted no time. “Is the minister a potential threat or a potential asset?”

Karl jumped in quickly while he was still eating. “Neither. I have him down as neutral. Now he has control of the incriminating evidence, I doubt we’ll hear from him again.”

The light seemed to flicker in Ann’s eyes. “However . . .”

“Sure.” Karl took a mouthful of coffee. “As we completed a background check on the blackmailer, it made sense to delve deeper. He’s an attaché for a non-EU country and could provide intelligence in the future, with the right leverage.”

Thomas didn’t bother protesting civil liberties — that ship had sailed soon after he joined the Surveillance Support Unit. It didn’t mean he had to like it though.

When they reached Liverpool Street, he went straight to Ann’s back office, eager to see the Makarov again. This would be better than Christmas 1986, when he’d already seen his new bike because he’d found a duplicate key for the padlock on the shed.

Thomas went to work on the packing tape and then gently slid the bubble-wrapped package out of the jiffy bag, just as Karl arrived for the big reveal. He touched a jagged piece of metal and felt the ghost of Christmas present flipping him the finger. They’d returned his gun alright, only in pieces — and many of them seemed to have lost a fight with a hydraulic press.

He held up half of the grip and rubbed his thumb lightly over the crack that led to the circled star design. “Bastards.”

Karl was sanguine. He could afford to be. “You can’t blame them. We trespassed on their patch and humiliated MI5. Only natural they’d want to return the favour. Your new challenge is how to dispose of a broken gun!”

Ann reached for *sympathetic* and missed it by a country mile. “Perhaps you could have part of it made into a key ring.”

He ignored her and thought about getting the whole thing dusted for prints, before deciding to look up gun amnesties on the web instead.

Ann reclaimed her chair, placing her camera case on the desk. It hid half her face, which struck Thomas as a perfect metaphor for management.

She finished shuffling paperwork and set the case down. “Unless you have a better plan, Karl, I think we need to focus on Sir Peter Carroll.”

Chapter 23

Finding Sir Peter's chauffeur wasn't a problem. They knew exactly where to find him — at Whitehall. Getting access though, that would be a different matter. Karl had vetoed doorstepping the garages there, so that meant returning to Eva Fairfield, who was still in the Big Chair.

They entered Main Building, Whitehall, with only the semblance of a plan. Arrive at the desk, confirm their IDs and then ring up for the boss. Eva's line was busy — probably brightening someone else's day — so they were directed to the no man's land of comfy seats, highbrow newspapers and a digital newsfeed. Karl sat on Thomas's far side. He seemed distinctly shifty.

Thomas found a broadsheet crossword for him and handed it over. "You alright?"

Karl took out a fancy pen, clicked it three times and leaned back to glance over Thomas's shoulder "Yeah. Seen someone I recognise, only I'm not sure where from."

Thomas smiled. In three years he'd only managed to piece together fragments of Karl's career — serving with the British Army in the Balkans and Germany, joining the Surveillance Support Unit, counter-surveillance, and a hint of something with NATO intelligence.

He nudged Karl. "Which one?"

Karl kept his head down. "The lanky bastard with his back to us when we got to the desk. I don't think he saw me. Now, watch the TV like a good boy."

Ten minutes of the War on Terror with maps, vox pops and horror stories, and Thomas felt ready to go walkies. He gathered his thoughts. There was a lot riding on today.

Unusually, Karl had handed him the reins before they'd left St James's Park tube station. "It's your call, Thomas — run it however you see fit."

Naturally, Lurch was the one to come over. He towered above them, even once they stood up. "The acting director general will see you now, gentlemen." He froze for a moment and then his face broke into a broad

grin. “Karl, yeah?” A massive hand came forward and Karl met it halfway. “It’s Liam — Beanpole. In Germany?”

Karl’s face smoothed out. “Course it is. How have you ‘bean’?”

Liam laughed and walked them back to the desk. “We all wondered what happened to you. Rumour was you’d been discharged from the army after a fight. Someone else reckoned you’d moved across to Intelligence.”

Karl did his sphinx impression, which Thomas had seen many times.

“I always said that was bullshit. Turns out I’m right and you’re a floater. No offence, Karl, but you were a bit too *lively* for MI5 or MI6. I’ve been told to sign you through and you make your own way up.” He shook his head. “Karl McNeill, after all this time.”

Formalities over, Thomas followed Karl to the lift.

“Jesus, Tommo. I dunno what’s so amusing. Everyone has a past.”

“Yeah. But not like yours.”

Whichever building Sir Peter Carroll was based in, he always managed to get an office on the top floor. Thomas had met him in State House on High Holborn, in Adastral House in Theobalds Road, and latterly at Main Building, Whitehall. Three places in three years. Thomas reasoned that the Old Man used up goodwill quickly. Maybe that was why his leave of absence hadn’t ruffled any feathers.

They walked briskly along the carpeted corridor. Thomas paid little attention to the door signs. Mostly unfathomable letters and numbers, although the CIA liaison office was still there. Karl stopped at Eva’s door and gestured to Thomas.

“After you.”

Thomas knocked softly three times.

Eva’s voice had lost none of the charm it never had. “Enter.”

Two empty seats greeted them. Thomas felt it was a good sign. She watched from across the desk with the intensity of a kestrel.

Thomas made the first move. “We’ve brought you an update.”

“And it takes two of you to do that?”

Like the man said, his call. “We have different kinds of information, ma’am.”

The kestrel’s eyes shimmered. “Tell me more.”

Karl summarised the situation around Sebastian and Rupee. It sounded like standard fare — interdepartmental rivalries and a tug of war to see who

was top dog. Eva didn't seem surprised about Foreign Office involvement, but she hadn't become a judge by being transparent.

She tapped a pen on a blank page of a notepad and looked over to Thomas and Karl. "Coffee?" She made a call and then wrote a few lines in blue ink.

Thomas listened as Karl delivered a masterclass in information sharing, picking up where he'd left off to lead Eva into murkier waters.

". . . And we *seem* to have uncovered plans to put Foreign Office intelligence teams in the field." That all-important word was the hook. Nothing definite, everything implied.

Thomas smiled on the inside. Karl — one clever bastard. Now they were back on her Christmas list. Naturally, Eva wanted proof and expected them to acquire it. No doubt she'd use any evidence as collateral to speed her return to the Home Office.

All talk fell silent when the coffee arrived. Thomas still hadn't worked out what his script was, now that Karl had spilled all the best beans. He stirred his coffee, dissolving a single sugar cube into nothingness. Eva sat opposite him, held in suspension by the swirling spiral in his cup.

One subject remained untouched — their reason for coming. The one they wanted Eva to know as little about as possible. He lifted a spoon and tapped his cup, capturing her attention. Time to pay the piper. He took a sip of sweet coffee and cradled the cup while he spoke.

"We're still keen to locate Christine Gerrard. There has been no communication since the conference. We think it's connected with Sir Peter's leave of absence."

Eva studied him. "Why should that concern you, or me?" Her face showed a total absence of curiosity.

Karl spoke softly. "Your call, Thomas. She'll end up on one side or the other — at least this way we get there first."

Now Eva paid attention. Secrets — the lifeblood of surveillance, addictive as heroin and as dangerous. Thomas set his cup down on her desk, beside the tray.

"You really don't know what's going on, do you?"

She sat rigid, feigning indifference while every nerve, every sinew suggested the opposite. "Why don't you tell me?"

He licked his lower lip and brought his hands together, like a priest about to violate the sanctity of confession. “There’s no turning back.”

Eva’s hands rested on the desk, open and receptive. Her head seemed to rise out of her shoulders. “I want to know.”

Who was Thomas to disappoint her? He thought back to when he’d been on her side of the conversation, three years ago, talking to Karl through the looking glass. Best to do things in stages. He started with Churchill’s post-war speech in Geneva, calling for a United States of Europe, telling her she could verify it online. The rest, she would have to take on trust, as he had at the beginning.

He named the Shadow State the way a scientist describes a disease, with respect and loathing. She didn’t challenge or even interrupt him as he gave her a personal overview of the Shadow State’s reach and what it was capable of. Maybe she recognised the bitter voice of experience. He hoped so. Whatever the case, she carried on taking dictation, while he concluded with the ongoing counter-intelligence war against the Shadow State. He threw in Christine’s name like an afterthought, along with the defection rumour. Eva could join the dots for herself now.

When he stopped talking, she looked upon them both with starry-eyed awe. It was a wonder she hadn’t applauded. “And what about Sir Peter?”

Now Karl spoke, delivering his lines with clinical indifference. “As far as we know, Sir Peter isn’t on anybody’s side. Best we leave him out of it.”

Eva nodded and a thin smile slithered across her face. Thomas caught the inference. She was on the inside now, which was probably how Jonah felt at first.

When she spoke again her voice took on that haughty tone that never failed to provoke him. “And the two of you, naturally, are ‘on the side of the angels?’”

He let it slide, recalling his mother’s words that Lucifer was an angel too, and guilty of the sin of pride. No matter. Eva would go the same way as Jack Langton — believing herself a player and then quickly realising she was merely a dispensable piece in a treacherous game.

When Karl spoke again, Thomas almost wished he hadn’t. “Thomas acts as my support — all his instructions come through me.”

“And you want me to believe that members of the judiciary — the government even — are also part of this . . . this . . . ?”

Thomas let her test his response. “Shadow State.”

Eva clasped her hands together, as if she’d caught a fly. “So, what happens now?”

Karl came right in. “Someone will contact you when they’re ready.”

Thomas translated the sentence in his head to: when they have a use for you. He placed his cup on the tray and let the gesture speak for itself. With the conversation over, that left one small but essential detail. He reached for a handshake across the desk, noting how she barely moved. A classic power play from someone out of their depth.

Karl waited until Thomas had opened the door before doing the one-arm stretch. “Thank you for your time today, ma’am, and welcome to the fight. Would your chauffeur be able to drop me somewhere? I need to report our meeting today, if you take my meaning.”

Eva’s wolverine smile sealed the deal. She’d picked up the phone before they were out of the office. “Incidentally,” she pressed the phone handset against her shoulder, “what are we called?”

Karl didn’t miss a beat. “The Alliance.”

They stood in the street for a couple of minutes before Sir Peter’s chauffeur-driven Daimler, minus its owner, glided up to the kerb.

“Listen, Tommo, this is something better done alone. Can you make your own way?”

Chapter 24

Miranda could be a woman of few words: Her text message read: DNA confirms Jack is Sheryl's Dad. More confirmation than newsflash, it still put a spring in his step. Now Sheryl had some leverage over Jack if he took too much interest in her life. Thomas smiled at his own hypocrisy. Here he was, helping Sheryl get evidence while simultaneously acting on Jack's behalf. He sent a text back to Miranda, suggesting dinner after his surveillance shift. He figured he'd go upmarket, maybe take her back to the French bistro they visited a while back, near the modern art gallery. Yeah, she'd like that.

He never made it to Westminster tube station, due to a security alert. Despite the presence of the British Transport Police and a plethora of hi-vis jackets outside, a small crowd thought standing behind a strip of hazard tape would protect them.

Thomas muscled his way through and flashed his card. "Anything I can do to help?"

Two coppers exchanged glances. One of the women gave his ID card two seconds of consideration. "This is only a precautionary measure. Thanks, anyway."

It made a change from being called a floater.

The half-mile walk to nearby Embankment tube station, the next stop on the line, should have taken ten minutes. He stretched it to fifteen, slowing his pace as he made his way along the Victoria Embankment beside the Thames. A group of people had gathered around a newspaper stand. According to the headline the IRA had officially ended its armed campaign. A few bystanders — students by the look of them — launched into an impromptu version of John Lennon's 'Imagine'. He didn't linger for the second chorus.

Ann Crossley's call came through outside the Underground station. Her words rattled off like a Gatling gun. She definitely wasn't feeling the love. "Thomas, where the hell are you?"

"Embankment. I'm on my way in."

"Good." The line went dead.

Karl had a little more to say when he rang him, but not much. “Wait for me outside. And when we’re in with Ann, let me do the talking.”

Curiouser and curiouser. He spotted Karl from the top of the escalator at Liverpool Street, hands in pockets, lost in thought.

“Should I ask?”

Karl sighed. “No need. You’ll find out soon enough.”

Thomas swiped them into the building and called the lift. Now seemed the perfect opportunity to update him on the Jack Langton front. Karl had ‘indifference’ off to a fine art.

Second floor: double-dealing. Please mind the closing doors. He swiped again and coded in the magic numbers. He glanced along the two banks of empty desks, recalling those colleagues who’d stayed briefly before moving on to better things.

Karl pushed past him and took the last few steps to Ann’s inner sanctum. He knocked, somewhere between deferential and world-weary, leaving Thomas to hasten after him.

Two chairs had been placed across from Ann’s desk. This was getting to be a habit.

She didn’t take prisoners. “Close the door and sit down.” Thomas took his time and she started without him. “Tell me, Karl, how could you be so bloody stupid?”

She read Thomas’s expression and enlightened him. “Karl spoke to Sir Peter Carroll’s wife to apply pressure.”

Karl made his points on his hand. “Yeah, so now we know Sir Peter can be contacted. Which means it’s his choice to keep us at arm’s length.”

Ann was having none of it. “You’ve crossed a line. Sir Peter cooperates with us on the strict understanding that we never involve his family.”

Karl gave her a face-full of attitude. “Well, maybe it’s time we reviewed that *agreement*. Come on, Ann. This is about Christine. You’d have done the same in my position.”

“That’s just it — I wouldn’t.” She broke eye contact momentarily. “Consider yourself suspended with immediate effect, pending investigation. You’re on your own, Karl. Stay out of harm’s way.”

Thomas bristled. “Well, not quite on his own.”

She blushed. “I’m more sorry for you, Thomas. You’re also suspended. I’ll need your ID passes.”

Karl threw his down like a bad loser. Thomas placed his ID on the desk, face down.

She collected the IDs and locked them in a drawer. “My hands are tied, Karl. Take some advice from someone who has your best interests. Don’t go home tonight and get yourself a new phone until this blows over. If word gets out, some people will be very interested in finding you. Here.” She passed him a business card, with a handwritten phone number on one side. “Text this number with your new phone.”

Outside, Thomas spotted a black Vauxhall Astra across the street, hazards on and engine running. As subtle as a telegraphed punch.

Thomas was still noting down the car’s number plate as it took off at speed. “Same model as the Foreign Office vehicle by the kebab house. Do you wanna check it out?”

Karl placed a consoling hand on his shoulder. “Blessed are the poor in understanding. Remember when Ann said about me being on my own? She wasn’t speaking figuratively, Thomas. For the time being I am *persona non grata*. As far as the Alliance is concerned, I don’t exist. No contacts, no protection, nada.”

“We’d better find you a bed for the night then.”

Miranda took it better than Thomas had expected. Dinner for three then. She suggested Karl stay at Sam’s flat, adding that it was a pity he hadn’t got round to rigging up the security.

Karl found the cheapest shops around Liverpool Street and bought a week’s worth of clothes. He also tried his ‘subsidiary’ cash card and found it blocked. Transaction Not Permitted. That about summed it up. They stood together, staring at the glass.

Karl picked his own pocket and pulled out a scrap of paper. “Hold on a second, Tommo.” The two number plates tallied.

Thomas saw it two ways. Either the FO wanted them to ‘FO’ and leave Emjay alone, or they wanted to make contact. He thought about that as he carried half the shopping down to the platform for a Walthamstow Central train. Something else bothered him.

He’d learned to choose his moment with Karl. “What did you say to Sir Peter’s wife?”

Karl shifted focus from the train map. “I cut to the chase and said we needed proof that Christine is safe. I told her she had forty-eight hours to

ring me.” He stared at the tunnel. “That’s sufficient time to come up with something.”

Thomas gestured to the approaching train, picked up the bags and edged along the platform. He waited again, until Karl was halfway into the carriage. “How does that merit suspension?”

Karl moved to one side and faced him. “That’ll be on account of what I said after that: ‘Remind Sir Peter that I keep his secrets.’ It’s fair to say that Lady Carroll had her own interpretation and wasn’t best pleased.”

* * *

They sprung for a cab at the station. Five minutes later, Thomas unlocked his front door and picked up the post, still holding half of Karl’s shopping.

Karl shuffled past and made himself comfortable on the settee, calling out, “Have you a suitcase I can borrow?”

He ignored him and entered the room, ditching the bags by Karl’s feet. He had something more pressing to attend to. A standard DL envelope bore his name and address and a local postmark. Nothing untoward when he felt along the edges, fairly flexible to the touch with an insert of thicker material. He grabbed a paperknife, aware that Karl had a ringside seat. Inside the envelope were a handwritten note and three photographs, two candid shots of Miranda picking up flowers on the doorstep and one of poorer quality, taken at Kings Cross St Pancras station. It turned out Miranda wasn’t paranoid after all. A note read: ‘I know you.’ He stared at the line for a few seconds and then passed note and photos over to Karl. “This is the sort of thing you would do.”

Karl didn’t reply. He didn’t have to. Textbook intimidation. All in the mind. Set them running to see where they ran and what mistakes they made. Thomas made a mental inventory — it didn’t take long. No forensics, no specialist contacts, no access to databases and no weapons. They’d been cast adrift and now the sharks were circling.

“I’ll move Miranda, as a precaution. Stands to reason they know her home address.”

Karl finished cutting clothing tags with his Swiss Army knife. “No offence, Tommo, but why would the FO be so interested in you?”

It was Thomas's first laugh of the day. "I'll go make the coffee and think on it." He set everything up in the kitchen the way he liked it. Coffee mug handles aligned, coffee granules first and then the milk, and then the kettle on to give the milk time to absorb some of the good stuff.

He took his notepad from the drawer and committed one thought to paper. Christine's father held a senior role in the Foreign Office. He read the sentence over and over, like a charm, like something he could conjure the truth with. Sir Peter and Edgar Gerrard met at university, so Christine had told him. He scratched the line out and drew a rough circle, writing Christine's name beside it. And then one for Sir Peter, followed by Edgar, each overlapped intersection their connections. He sighed like a draught horse breathing its last. There was no logic to it.

Karl muttered behind him. "If that's instant coffee, you should get your money back."

He looked at the coffee mugs, each with a layer of brown coffee-milk sludge at the bottom. "I'm still trying to make sense of this. It's doing my bloody head in, Karl. We're missing something."

Karl re-boiled the kettle. "If the Foreign Office are so keen to send us a message, we ought to send them one back."

"How?"

"Simple." Karl made a show of checking his watch. "If Emjay sticks to his routine we'll know where to find them later. But we've time for a coffee first and then we'd better get me billeted at Sam's."

Thomas had never visited Sam's place before. To him Sam was still Miranda's thirteen-year-old brother, eager to see his sister after her runaway act to Leeds. The flat retained a touch of the adolescent about it. A large photograph hung opposite the radiator in the hall, a bright blue sports car driving around Brands Hatch racing circuit. Thomas remembered getting that shot and Sam over-steering the car a couple of seconds later and nearly coming a cropper. Sam said he'd nearly shat himself at the time. Thomas smiled. He'd never seen the photo blown up to a forty-by-thirty. Not bad.

Karl found space for his things and then went through 'the plan':

1. Buy a new phone and text Ann.
2. Drive over to the community centre and keep watch.
3. Follow Emjay and intercept him at the rendezvous.

It looked foolproof, on paper.

Chapter 25

Karl's car was out of bounds so Thomas did the driving. He preferred it that way. It left him in control, relatively speaking. They scoured the nearest mobile phone shop until Karl found a model Thomas could afford.

They rang Molly first. She could hardly contain her surprise.

"What's going on? All we've been told is that we're two down tonight. We thought you'd been assigned somewhere else."

Thomas smiled. They owed Ann Crossley a drink. According to Molly, Fareed had followed their example and set up camp at the rear of the community centre, while she covered the front from on high.

"So, guys, do I tell Fareed you're joining us tonight after all?"

Thomas started driving. Having two cars gave them a clear advantage, only Karl didn't seem so keen. Thomas waited while the call died of natural causes.

"Surely you still trust him?"

"Don't even go there, Tommo. I want the target — Emjay — to see that Fareed is following the routine. It has to look like business as usual."

Thomas held up a hand. Enough said. It looked like Karl was calling the shots again.

* * *

An inferior observation point was better than nothing. They watched as Emjay closed the door behind him. It seemed to Thomas that he was less cautious tonight. Maybe he'd heard about their suspension on the intelligence grapevine. If so, he was in for a surprise.

Fareed sat perfectly still until Emjay reached the end of the street. Thirty long seconds while Thomas's finger ached to turn on the ignition.

"Come on, Fareed," he whispered to the night air.

Fareed's car moved off with all the urgency of an hourly paid temp. Karl, meanwhile, tapped the inside of the passenger door, counting to a rhythm in his head that Thomas couldn't fathom.

"Anytime today, Karl."

His partner smiled. "Patience is a virtue." He stopped tapping and pointed at the windscreen. "Tally ho!"

“Finally.”

The engine roused into life. Thomas took a side road and let Karl navigate to get there in plenty of time. They circled the block a couple of times, once from each direction, checking for cars with passengers. All clear. Across the street, the only people bathed in the neon of a kebab house were the staff and two customers, young enough to think that a romantic dinner meant a döner kebab with stringy chips.

Thomas found a space, cut the lights and hunkered down, ready for the main event. It played out in stages. First, the Foreign Office duo arrived and parked up on the same side of the street, a few cars ahead of them. No one got out. Now they were all playing the waiting game.

When Emjay finally appeared, Thomas did the maths and calculated he took fifteen minutes longer than usual. More interestingly, Emjay carried a small rucksack. Thomas told himself there was no reason to jump to conclusions and then ignored his own advice. What was it their diversity course said? *Everyone is racist to some degree. That's why it's important to challenge your own prejudices and not let them cloud your judgement or dictate your actions.*

Emjay strolled along the street like he didn't have a care in the world. This guy was good. He paused outside the kebab house to check his phone and then went inside. Thomas noticed Fareed slowly passing, and Emjay noticed too. He raised a hand casually and carried on talking to one of the staff at the counter — the cocky bastard.

As soon as Emjay set foot outside, the Foreign Office car emptied out. Two men emerged, dressed smart casual. For a moment it was all smiles and handshakes, and then a 'friendly' hand landed on Emjay's shoulder, encouraging him across the street and into the car. Only Emjay had other ideas.

One of the two men stood directly behind him, shutting him down. At first Emjay seemed to comply — it wasn't as if he had much choice — but as soon as they were halfway across the street one of the two smart casuals did something not very smart at all — tried to open Emjay's rucksack — and ended up with a face-full of kebab. A scuffle quickly escalated. After trading blows, Emjay lost the battle of numbers and was half-walked, half-dragged over to the pavement.

Thomas and Karl exchanged a knowing look, jumped out the car and raced towards the commotion. Thomas got there first and chambered a fist. One of the two men thrust his arm out and Thomas jerked back, hand extended, expecting pepper spray. But it was only an ID card.

A palm obscured everything on the ID, bar the photograph. "Security Service. This man is being detained."

Karl made space for himself. "Oh really? Last I heard, MI5 doesn't have powers of detention or arrest, so take your hands off him."

The Foreign Office stooge facing him stood his ground. "You'd do well to stay out of our business."

Karl advanced and the man took a lazy swing at him. Big mistake. Karl sidestepped, blocked and turned in one fluid movement, executing a hip throw to slam him to the ground. The other man gripped Emjay's shoulder, and he twisted underneath to bring his assailant round. Thomas stepped in to finish the job. Two down and none to go.

Emjay backed away, looking for an exit.

Karl put up both hands. "Come with us and we'll keep you safe."

"And who the hell are you?"

Thomas looked him dead in the eyes. "I think we're past that, Emjay, don't you?"

Fareed appeared by their car. "It's okay. You can trust them."

Thomas saw his chance and went for the person he'd floored. He grabbed him by the scruff of his neck. "Where's Christine?"

He spluttered a reply. "You're making a big mistake!"

Footsteps came running towards them and Thomas turned to face one of the kebab house staff who'd made it as far as the middle of the road. "I've called the police — you better break it up."

"Tommo, car keys — now!"

* * *

Thomas slammed the passenger door behind him, seconds before Karl hit the accelerator. He turned to Emjay, his heart banging against his ribcage.

Their passenger seemed remarkably calm in the backseat, his rucksack held securely on his lap.

Thomas played it straight. “Do you want to let anyone know you’re safe?”

Emjay hugged his rucksack a little tighter. “No, but I’ll need a bed for the night.”

Thomas glanced to Karl. “Not a problem.” Although Miranda might not be too happy about stashing a stranger at Sam’s place. And that was the salient point. Emjay was an unknown quantity, of interest to all parties. Now they could observe him at close quarters.

He rang Miranda and kept his voice low, but not too low, aware that Emjay would probably hear every word. “So if we’re still on for dinner, there’ll be one extra body.” He turned to Emjay and gave him the thumbs-up. All sorted.

“Make that two. Sheryl and me will meet you at Sam’s flat. I’ll order some food on the way.” Her voice dropped and then a breath seeped into his brain. “Will Butch be there?”

Butch. Their code word for trouble, from the day back in Leeds when Thomas punched a lecherous photographer’s lights out. Good times. He cradled the phone closer. “Nah. We’ll be fine. Safety in numbers.”

After giving Karl directions to Sam’s place, he checked in with Fareed, who decided to stick around after the Foreign Office boys left the scene and waited for the police.

“I waited with the kebab house staff and gave them the number of a black Astra to play with. ‘It could have happened to anyone, officer, and in this area too.’”

That left a phone call to Bob Peterson. It seemed the decent thing to do, in a day that had left decency behind. Bob offered his condolences on their suspension and sounded like he meant it, but had nothing new to report. Finally, Thomas thought, he and Bob had something in common other than a tangled history with Christine.

Emjay leaned forward. “Why are you helping me?”

Karl spoke over his shoulder. “We can help one another. Let’s start with the basics, Emjay. Why are you spying on a community centre?”

Chapter 26

Ten miles on the road covered a lot of other ground too. Emjay disclosed he'd worked undercover operations with the Foreign Office for the past year, which Thomas thought he was underselling. After that, they played questions and answers. Emjay said as few words as possible.

Thomas knew the game well and sensed he was playing against a pro. He may as well have shouted down a well. "Where were they taking you? What do they want to hide?" He tacked on Christine for effect, although he was fairly confident that Emjay — who ran the full emotional gamut from A to B — knew nothing about her.

In one of his chequered tales of army life, Karl had once told Thomas about interrogation techniques. He'd said that sometimes you needed to throw out the rulebook and make it personal. According to Karl, everyone had a pressure point. Thomas wondered what Karl's was.

"Where will you run to, Emjay?"

Their passenger took a silent count of six, Thomas observing him all the while. "I plan to disappear. I've made preparations. I need a place to lie low for tonight, and then I'll collect my things and go. I will make it worth your while."

"So the Foreign Office doesn't trust you." It came out of nowhere, a flawed conclusion midway between guesswork and lazy logic. Throw enough mud and something will stick.

Emjay glanced at the locked door. "After seven-seven, my loyalty has been questioned."

Karl piped up from the driver's seat, "And we know how that feels."

His eyes blazed. "I doubt it. I've been assessed as a possible security risk by my own country. Despite my work record, I am under scrutiny."

Emjay didn't know the half of it. Thomas watched Karl take a breath. Speech time.

"Listen, I, er, I know some people who could protect you."

Emjay laughed like a condemned man. "And who would protect me from them? I know too much. It would suit all sides if I disappeared — one way or another. This way, it's my choosing."

Thomas caught sight of a phone box. “No calls when we get there.”

“I’m not stupid.”

Karl slowed for the lights. “Good. Then you understand what we’re taking on by helping you.”

“You will get your money tomorrow.”

Karl shook his head. “Expenses aside, it doesn’t work like that. We need something more valuable — information for leverage. We help you, and your information helps us.”

“To find your friend.”

Thomas took a turn at silence. He watched London life flow around them, glimpsing snippets of stories he’d never comprehend. As the faces blurred in with the incessant traffic he mentally replayed the past hour’s events, smiling as he recalled the satisfying sound of a punch connecting. He wondered how the Foreign Office boys felt about helping the police with their inquiries. When he tuned in again, Karl was in full flight.

“So why that particular community centre, Emjay?”

“Rumours. Concerns about individuals already on file. My job was to ingratiate myself and make the right noises so I could get invited to house meetings. Much like your colleague, the *teacher*?”

Thomas and Karl left the question hanging.

In an unprecedented feat of coordination, the Chinese food turned up five minutes after their arrival, followed by Miranda and Sheryl ten minutes later. Emjay clammed up in front of the women, speaking only when spoken to, like an unwelcome guest. Thomas put it down to religious sensibilities. It didn’t matter. He got what he needed from the first moment Emjay laid eyes on her. Guilty as charged. Maybe that was why Miranda and Sheryl didn’t stay long after the meal.

Thomas left Karl to babysit and followed them out to the car. “You know you don’t have to go.”

“I can see you’ve got work to do. I just wanted to put in an appearance and count Sam’s cutlery! Your new friend doesn’t say much, does he?”

Sheryl gave him an awkward one-armed hug — awkward for him, not her. “You take care now, Thomas. And thanks again . . . for everything.”

He walked around the vehicle, looking for trouble. Then he had an idea. “I don’t suppose you’d swap cars for a day?”

Miranda tensed up. “As long as there’s no chance of being followed because they think it’s you.”

It had only happened once, but it ended badly. He looked from Miranda to Sheryl and back again, pleading his case. “You should be fine.”

She relented with a sigh. “Alright. I can always leave it parked outside Sheryl’s for a couple of days.”

Sheryl frowned. “Thanks a lot.”

He led them to his car and switched keys. “You know the drill when you get home. Don’t answer the door and if you have any concerns at all, call me. Any time.”

“Relax, I’m at Sheryl’s tonight and Terry’s coming over.”

Sheryl smiled. “Yeah, for extra muscle.” She got in the car and wound down the window, cupping a hand to her ear. “Don’t mind me.”

“Listen, Miranda, when all this is over, p’raps we can get away for a few days.”

Sheryl lowered her hand. “Holy shit, you really are worried.”

He walked Miranda round to the driver’s side and watched until the car disappeared from sight. One thing less to worry about for the time being.

They put Emjay in Sam’s bedroom. Karl reasoned it was furthest from the front door and easier to defend. That left the spare room, which they tossed a coin for and Thomas lost. Everyone turned in early and last thing at night, before bed on the sofa, he propped a chair against the front door. It wouldn’t hold anyone back but it might give them early warning of the lock being picked. Always assuming the danger came from the outside.

Thomas woke to find Emjay standing in the doorway. He wondered if their guest had already tried the front door and found it double-locked.

“I will need your help to collect some things today.”

He felt for the keys under the blankets. “Things?”

“I keep a bag in storage: passport, money, clothes. Like an insurance policy. In my line of work you need to look after number one because no one else will. In return, I will give you more information you can use.”

Thomas ran through the briefing for a second time over breakfast coffee. “If we get separated for any reason, don’t come back here. We’ll meet at Caliban’s — the pub I told you about. I’ve written down the details.” He couldn’t help thinking that Emjay already had his life unpacked.

Karl covered the finer details. Walk separately, with Thomas out in front and him at the rear. Any concerns at all and Emjay should head off without warning. Thomas would go in to collect the bag, while Emjay stayed outside with the padlock key.

Thomas drained the dregs of his coffee mug. "And where is this luggage storage place, exactly?"

"Near Marylebone Station."

Of course it was. On the far side of London. They opted for the car, rather than public transport. Fewer cameras, according to Karl. Thomas wasn't sure he believed that, but the car put him in control again and that was how he liked it.

He drove towards Limehouse and then clung to the A13 for comfort, creeping through Whitechapel before entering the belly of the beast, the City of London. Karl picked his moment to ring Ann on his new mobile.

"Where are you, Karl? I've had an interesting conversation with someone from the Foreign Office." She went silent and another voice came down the line.

"Do the right thing while you still can. Hand him over, unless you want to face a kidnapping charge. We can still settle this amicably."

Karl upped the volume for Thomas's benefit. "Kidnapping? No way. We chanced upon a man being assaulted, so we intervened. Coincidentally, we found out he'd been spying on a community centre for the Foreign Office, would you believe? Anyway, we dropped him off at the bus stop and that's the last we saw of him."

The line quietened, apart from muffled voices in the background.

Karl made the decision for them. "We'll see you in a few days, Ann, for our suspension interviews. McNeill out."

Thomas punched him on the arm. "Why the bloody hell did you mention our suspension to the Foreign Office?" He could see Emjay taking notice in the mirror.

"Elementary, my dear Thomas. It disassociates Ann from our actions. And it keeps the line open a little bit longer, in case they're triggering the call location."

Thomas caught up. Standard procedure. Triangulate the call and then check the ANPR cameras in the vicinity for his car number plate. Except they'd be looking in the wrong place because he couldn't afford a metallic

blue Mini Cooper S. Unlike Miranda. He put his foot down and sliced through the traffic.

Like a dog sensing its mistress, Emjay started getting twitchy when they neared Regent's Park. Thomas circled the streets to find a parking meter, cruising along the permit zones that had infested London's roads. He saw a car park and kept on driving — too contained. He found a meter and filled it with two hours' worth of change. Aim for the best outcome and plan for the worst.

They walked in formation, Thomas gripping the luggage security code in his left hand like a talisman. He couldn't shake the feeling that it was all going too well. Glancing behind, he saw that Emjay had that spring in his step again — maybe he could taste his freedom.

A mother waited at the far side of a zebra crossing, while her child picked up a toy from the ground. Thomas watched how they interacted together and the way the mother gripped her child's coat. All present and correct, although he couldn't help thinking that the swearing would be a nice touch for a decoy, along with a stunt child.

He enjoyed the heightened state of vigilance. It connected him to the world around him. So different to surveillance where he observed life from a distance, always once removed. A crowd swarmed ahead of him, waiting to enter Madame Tussaud's waxworks. He slowed down to ease past them, flanked at the roadside by a fleet of coaches that were flooding the streets with more people, suddenly aware of how narrow the space had become . . .

"Tommo!"

He turned back to Karl's voice. Emjay had gone. Bollocks. They stood together, caught up in the melee and blindsided, looking for threats. Or anyone out of place. Or a man running.

"Honest to God, Thomas, he just took off. No one snatched him. It happened so fast. It's like he saw his moment and vanished."

Thomas rubbed the piece of paper between his fingers. "Let's get the job done. He'll find us when he's ready."

Chapter 27

The sign read: *‘Luggage storage — secure — reasonable rates.’* A sprawl of people milled about outside with their cases and bags, like survivors from some disaster. Thomas counted four languages and understood none of them. He set his gaze at the door, strode forward and the crowd parted like the Red Sea.

Inside, a neon strip light flickered intermittently. He made it six inches inside the door and joined the line. A German couple in front were busy moving possessions between two bags. One for storage and one for keeps. The guy’s designer T-shirt advertised his gym arms to everyone except his partner, who was more interested in reapplying her makeup while he played porter. Ahead of them, a gaggle of Japanese visitors gesticulated wildly, in the midst of some intense debate. The quiet ones were easy to spot and all the more fascinating for it. He lost himself in the finer points of observation, assessing their mood and intent against the rest of the group. He smiled momentarily. What was it the counsellor had said, after a Shadow State mercenary shot him? *Often, when we make judgements about others we are really judging ourselves.*

Eventually a space came up and he reached the long counter with the air of a desperate man. “One to collect, please.” He made eye contact, with a fleeting thought. This would be the perfect cover for a quartermaster’s store.

The man staring back at him looked like a textbook case of sleep deprivation. His chequered shirt showed at least two different food stains, possibly mustard and brown sauce, while his eyes had the hollow gaze of someone who worked extra shifts to meet the rent.

“Have you got your security code?” Mr Customer Service sounded like he didn’t give a shit one way or the other, but for his outstretched hand.

Thomas smiled and passed it over. The sleepwalker read it carefully, keyed the characters into a terminal and then returned the slip of paper. “Wait here,” he mumbled and disappeared through a large red door marked ‘Staff Only’ — written in marker pen by someone in a hurry.

In the no man's land between the counter and the red door a conveyor belt took bags and cases through a scanner. Someone picked them up at the other end and moved them into storage. Thomas watched as the belt juddered to a halt and a supervisor homed in on her underling so they could look at the screen together. After a brief consultation they looked round to the hapless customer and the woman bellowed, "No electricals!" She hauled the case off the line and slammed it back on the counter so the owner could sift through and remove the offending item.

Thomas stared at the red door. One minute became two and then three, and all the while he could sense the frustration building in the queue behind him. Even if he couldn't translate the specifics, being pissed off sounded the same in any language.

Finally, the red door opened and a man emerged with a leather sports bag. He held it stiff-armed, like a butler bringing a tray. The heavy-duty padlock glinted under the neon. Thomas wondered if the bag had an anti-tampering device, but figured it would have registered as something electrical.

Sleepyhead placed the bag below the counter. "Now I need to see some photographic ID."

Thomas nodded and handed over his driving licence, convinced it didn't have to match the depositor's or Emjay wouldn't have used him. *Used* being the operative word. Thomas picked up the goods, passed the guy a couple of quid to perk him up a little and then muscled his way through the tail end of a queue that now blocked the exit. He held the bag casually, reassured that Karl was out there somewhere.

His phone went off as soon as he met daylight, number unrecognised. He hoped for Emjay, but Karl made for a decent second prize.

"Head back the way we came. Cross the street and walk up, against the one-way system. I'll be waiting."

He followed the plan, past the No Entry sign and along the leafy side street, past the spotless facades of three-storey houses. A different world. Up ahead, Karl leant against a tree by a familiar black car. Drawing closer, Thomas noticed the driver slumped against an unlocked door.

Karl wagged a new camera in one hand. "I approached from the top end, an educated guess. Once I spotted the car it seemed rude not to

introduce myself.” He offered the camera. “It’s better than the toys we get to play with. Take a look at the SD card.”

The digital haul included Miranda outside the flat and a crowded station hall. Thomas completed his review and handed it back. “I don’t get why this bloke would stick around if Emjay is on the outside now.”

Karl shrugged. “The usual — money, or maybe he still believes Emjay is on the level.”

“And you don’t?”

“There are levels of ‘on the level’! We can’t be certain about Emjay’s end game. I thought I might stick around for a while and see if anyone else turns up. You go on. I can look after myself.”

Miranda’s Mini sat pristine by its parking meter. Thomas inspected the tarmac and pavement for signs of disturbance and then checked the car for a tracker. All clear, although that left a few possibilities:

1. Emjay carried a tracker on him, knowingly or otherwise.
2. Emjay planned his vanishing act, so the driver had to have already been in the area.
3. They were better at this than him and Karl.
4. It had all been a lovely coincidence.

In his experience, coincidence was usually the intersection between one person’s meticulous plans and another’s lazy thinking. Nah, there were too many loose ends. Best to regroup, especially with Emjay an unknown quantity and out there somewhere.

He drove round until he found his way back to the one-way street. Karl had moved down a few yards, taking photographs of houses. Meanwhile, the driver of the Astra was still napping. Thomas beeped the horn and wound down the window. “Change of plan. Better we dig in at Caliban’s and await Emjay there.” He paused, remembering what Miranda had said. “Strength in numbers.”

Karl lowered the lens. “Right-oh. What do I do with this camera?”

Thomas raised an eyebrow. “What camera?” He unlocked the car boot and Karl stashed his new toy. “Where’s the nearest Underground station?”

Karl licked a finger and held it up to a non-existent breeze. “Baker Street, I think. Or Marylebone.”

“Fine. I’ll drop you off with the bag and you make your own way. I’ll see you there”

“What are you going to do?”

Thomas gave it a moment’s thought. “Even the odds.”

Chapter 28

Thomas understood the illusion of choice. Once you set your mind on an outcome, or on preventing one, how much choice was there? Action or inaction, fight or flight. He was still getting his head around their situation when the City gave way to east London. Sure, he could have driven Karl to Caliban's but some decisions are best made alone.

Emjay had gone to ground and Karl's allies had turned their backs on him — he couldn't even go home for the time being. Under the circumstances, there was only one call to make.

"Jack, it's Thomas. I have the information on Sheryl you wanted." He let that gem gleam for all of three seconds. "And I need a couple of things — I can't talk on the phone. You, er, got one for John once, remember?" Of course he'd bloody remember procuring a gun. But just in case, he added, "Brownings."

He heard Jack's intake of breath down the phone and then the slow release like a distant squall. "Come over in an hour and bring three k — each. Small notes."

He swore in a whisper. He was at least a grand short. "I'm not sure I can raise six grand in an hour."

"This is business, Thomas. I'm already doing you a favour."

"I know, Jack. I'll see what I can do."

Next stop, Dagenham. He thanked his lucky stars that he'd entrusted Mrs Gerrard's money to Miranda's parents, rather than Karl. He called ahead and told them the truth. The money would be ready for him.

John and Diane came to the door together and drew him inside. Clearly, they'd been talking.

Diane spoke first. "How can we help?"

He stashed the cash in his jacket pocket. "You already have."

They didn't ask about Miranda's safety — no need. They'd all played this game too often, only this time he couldn't tell who the real enemy was: MI5, the Foreign Office, or some jihadist group? Or the person they were probably all looking for.

Diane straightened his jacket. "Why didn't you come to us first?"

“I hoped I wouldn’t have to.”

“Wait here.” John disappeared into his office and returned with an ornately carved cigar box.

Thomas lifted the lid, expecting to stare at a 9mm automatic. Instead he saw money — a block of ten-pound notes.

“John, I can’t take this.”

“Consider it a long-term loan then.”

Diane clucked. “Or a dowry . . .”

John cast her a withering look that ended with a smile. “It’s all legit, Tom, honest. Try not to shoot anyone . . .”

Diane finished the line. “. . . Unless you have to. Look, you better get a move on.”

* * *

His thoughts circled in his head, like a roulette ball deciding where to drop. Maybe sourcing weapons from Jack Langton was an over-reaction. Karl would call it a sensible precaution. Even Emjay couldn’t be specific about the threat. Poor sod, caught between two sides that would both prefer him out of the picture. A man like that had better sleep with one eye open.

The money felt heavy in his jacket, like a dark secret pressing on his conscience. He wondered if Mrs Gerrard had marked her notes, and how she’d feel about their use. Not that he expected *her* fingerprints to be on anything as dirty as money.

As he’d hoped, Natalie Langton’s car was nowhere to be seen. He parked up, unlatched the gate and trod the short path. An expensive children’s toy lay discarded in the front garden. God help the urchin who fancied his chances taking that.

The nameplate by the door, Xanadu, still raised a smile. Nice one, Natalie. Jack answered the door with a cut glass tumbler for company. Whisky or brandy, Thomas never could tell the difference unless it was under his nose. Jack’s other arm boasted a bracelet thick enough for bullion, ending with a cigar in his hand.

Jack held the door wide open. “We’re in the back. I’ll follow you.”

He walked through a fine cloud of cigar smoke, breathing Jack’s aftershave behind him and stifling the urge to clear his throat. Finally, he coughed, mostly to distract himself from the bugs placed in the house after

Jack got out of prison. Too late to worry about being on camera now, but at least the conservatory was clear.

This was Jack's big moment, so he let him play it like a king, and closed the door after him like a servant. Jack nodded to the empty chair.

"Your call surprised me, Thomas. Yeah, you're bit of a dark horse!"

Thomas skipped the drink on offer, and watched Jack pour the contents of the spare glass into his own. He got straight down to business, stacking six thousand pounds on the glass table. The queen glared up at him for his impudence.

Jack sat back and watched, savouring his drink, the tip of his cigar glowing orange like a warning light that Thomas couldn't afford to heed. Jack took his time. His home, his rules. After an uncomfortable silence he reached under a cushion and placed a carrier next to the cash.

Thomas instinctively donned gloves and waited for Jack's approval before reaching over and ripping at the plastic and tape. Smart man, Jack, not to lay a finger on either of the weapons. And still he hadn't gone near the money.

Thomas eased the pile of notes towards him. Jack raised a palm.

"Just so you know, each magazine is a few bullets light. Short notice — I had to take what I could get. You in trouble, Thomas?"

"I'm not sure yet. This is my back-up plan."

Jack smiled the way the serpent must have charmed Eve. "When you've sorted your bit of bother you should come and work for me. I'd pay you well."

By way of a reply, Thomas slipped one of the Brownings from its bubble wrap and cradled it in his right hand. Satisfied with a brief communion, he repackaged it and then stashed both guns in his rucksack. No need to check the other weapon — Jack's word was his bond.

Jack wasn't done with his presents. "I also got you this, on the house!"

Thomas took the shoulder holster. "Cheers, Jack." He examined the stitching on the leather. It looked like it had seen some action. Shame there wasn't a vest to go with it.

"I've never liked the look of them myself — too fussy. Then again, I usually have other people to handle that sort of stuff for me. You remember Ray?" Jack swung his glass in the air, like a hypnotist. "He loved all that

gunfighter shit.” He stopped reminiscing and stared Thomas right between the eyes.

Thomas felt a furnace building in his guts.

“Funny how he left without a word. Never heard from him again. There’s nothing you need to tell me about that, is there?”

Thomas shook his head, as if that might banish the memory of Ray’s corpse being removed in secret, or the lie he told Natalie Langton about her deceased lover.

Jack refilled his glass. “That other matter you came here for?”

“Yeah, of course.” Thomas wished he had that drink now. “I’ve looked into Sheryl’s personal life, like you asked me to. Turns out she did get married a while back — for legal reasons.”

Jack tapped his head with an index finger. “She’s a smart girl.”

“Yeah. It’s all ancient history. Apparently they parted company not long afterwards and she doesn’t know where he is now.”

Hackles rose. “What, she’s still wed? I’m not happy about that.”

Thomas pretended he cared, making the necessary noises to soothe Jack’s ego. “I talked to her about it. Best to get the truth at source. She reckons the guy is a decent bloke and won’t come looking for a handout.”

Jack pursed his lips, as if his whisky had suddenly turned rancid. Then his chest heaved and his eyes softened. “I’ll talk to my lawyer about it. You sure I can’t get you a beer or something?”

Thomas watched him take a cigar from a glass shelf and begin to unwrap the cellophane in small, delicate movements.

Jack stopped abruptly, his dark eyes leeching the light in the room. “I’ve always been a dealmaker, ever since I was a nipper. Set myself up in business when I was ten, selling sweets from a break-in. Now look at me.” He extracted the cigar and inhaled. “You religious, Thomas?”

He played it straight. “Nah. Mum was — *is*, I s’pose. Not me though.”

Jack stared into his empty glass, the one that had held a double measure. “I’m not a bad man, Thomas, but I have done bad things.”

Thomas ran through a tick list in his head: storing cocaine at his daughter’s flat and then dealing it, importation of drugs, tax evasion — naturally. Violence, threats, and joining the Shadow State’s supply chain. Jack was already paying the price for that, now that Karl’s people had him by the balls.

“I dunno, Thomas. I must be getting old, or paranoid . . .”

Thomas laughed on cue. “Surely not?”

“Lately I’m looking over my shoulder. Wondering if it’s time I got out of this game.”

Thomas decoded the hollow smile. Poor Jack, pinned in position like a museum exhibit. Few got to walk away from the Shadow State — only Henriette Voclain came to mind and she’d had help from the Americans. Karl’s people would never let an intelligence asset like Jack off the hook. “Weren’t you talking about moving house a while ago?”

He nodded slowly and sighed. “Let’s just say someone convinced me it wasn’t in my best interests. Well, I won’t keep you.”

He shook Jack’s hand, feeling the sweat inside his glove. Walking out to the front door it was hard to decide what was more dangerous, two loaded Brownings or Jack Langton’s newfound introspection.

“Funny thing, Thomas. Sometimes I think I had more freedom in prison.” Jack rubbed at his temple. “In here.”

Thomas took a glove off and shook hands again. “You’ll be alright, Jack.”

“Will I?”

He left Jack to figure out the answer for himself.

Chapter 29

Thomas rang the landline at Caliban's. It was out of service. He drove a little faster and rang Karl instead.

"Where are you, Tommo?"

"About fifteen minutes away. I've managed to pick up some *equipment*. Any update?"

"Nah, still waiting for Emjay to appear. And before you ask, no, I haven't tried forcing the lock on his bag. See you in fifteen."

* * *

The sight of Caliban's should have reassured him, but it didn't. The façade looked tired and the unlit neon suggested a promise it would never deliver on. Much like life. He winced at the sight of his own car, alone on the tarmac, like an advert to the world.

He parked the Mini at the far side of the car park, conscious of escape routes and scenarios he'd played out in his head. Caliban's remained the best option. He knew the layout well and the building was secure — Karl's definition of a secure environment. Secure being a relative term.

Molly and Fareed arrived together, five minutes later. Thomas did the introductions to Miranda and Sheryl, who both seemed unimpressed.

Karl suggested the two of them talk somewhere more private, so they left the others to mingle and headed for the upstairs pool table. Karl spun a lazy cue ball. "Emjay is definitely short of friends. I, er, took a threatening phone call on the landline. The usual stuff: give him up if you know what's good for you."

Thomas felt his skin tingling. "Jihadists?"

"Not unless they went to Oxbridge. I'm thinking some chinless wonder on our side of the fence." Karl imitated a chinectomy for effect.

"Foreign Office?"

"That'd be my guess. The exposure of a mole in the middle of an MI5 operation leaves everyone with their pants down. Very bad for the war effort. And chilly."

Thomas wasn't in the mood for jokes. "So, what, they cart him off in a blacked-out van and he's never seen again?"

“Maybe. More likely he’s on a tight leash for the rest of his life.” Karl paused for dramatic effect. “However long that happens to be.”

“But you’re willing to cut him a different deal.”

“The way I see it, Tommo, he’s a free agent. No laws broken, none that matter. It would suit both sides just as well if he disappeared off the radar. The lesser of two evils.”

Thomas scudded the cue ball towards a corner pocket. It struck the cushion and floundered by the jaws. “You think you can turn him?”

“I can try. He must know plenty we could bargain with. Surely Christine is worth that?”

Now seemed the perfect time to give Karl his Browning. He unwrapped it sombrely and slipped the magazine free. “Less than full.”

Thomas shrugged. “Three grand a piece doesn’t go far these days.”

“Ouch. I’ll make it up to you sometime.”

Thomas heard Miranda calling them down. “Tell you what, Karl, keep everyone safe and that’ll be good enough for me.”

Karl saluted. “Understood.” He tapped his jacket lightly.

Thomas led the way. Guns as safety devices. Jesus, what a world they inhabited. Downstairs, factions were the order of the day. Miranda and Sheryl had staked out the bar area, while Molly and Fareed huddled around a large table in the centre of the room. The pair looked over and then carried on talking.

Everybody jumped at the buzzer. Sheryl checked the monitor behind the bar. “Pizza’s here.”

Thomas looked at the lined image of a deliveryman, his face obscured by a motorcycle helmet, shuffling from foot to foot. A moped with a liveried box on the back sat behind him. “What do you reckon, Karl?”

He pointed to the main doors. “Someone let me out and I’ll circle round.”

Fareed unbolted one of the doors carefully, while Sheryl reached for the intercom. Order confirmed, she headed down the back stairs with Thomas at her side, the gun pressing against his body with every step.

Sheryl pushed the release bar on the door and the deliveryman cranked back his visor. Roland Dolan. Former employee of Charlie Stokes, Jack Langton’s late rival. One look at Roland told Thomas it wasn’t a happy reunion.

Sheryl held a fiver in the air. “For you. I’ve paid by card already.”

Roland trudged over to his bike, returning with four large pizza boxes. He dumped them in Thomas’s waiting arms and snatched away the fiver. “Bon appétit,” he sneered and then revved up the 50cc engine to leave a cloud of exhaust in his wake.

Thomas stared at Karl, out by the edge of the car park, working his way back to the front of the building. All clear, then. He passed the pizzas to Sheryl and rushed up the stairs to meet Karl in the saloon bar.

“And?”

“Nothing to report, Tommo. A nice touch though, ordering from Jack Langton’s pizza outfit!”

“Huh? I thought Charlie Stokes . . .”

“Ah, Jack’s empire has expanded considerably since Charlie shuffled off his mortal coil. Jack has been allowed to take over several of Charlie’s interests and properties. He is their prize bullock, after all.”

Thomas felt his collar constricting. “Yeah, about that . . .”

Miranda’s dulcet tones cut through the air like a hatchet. “Oi, if you spies want feeding, you better start helping out. We’re not your bloody servants.”

Thomas spoke to Karl before they reached the table. “The landline is down.”

Karl put on the smile that Thomas called his Sunday best — the one he wore for other people’s benefit. “Yeah, I know. I checked it earlier.”

Emjay’s call had Thomas scrabbling for his mobile. He clicked his fingers and nodded to the others. Showtime.

“Is everybody there?”

Not the opening line Thomas had expected.

“Where are you, Emjay?”

“Not far. Did you get my bag? I looked for you but I couldn’t find you.”

Thomas shot a look to Karl. “We have it. How soon can you get here?” It started to feel like a hostage negotiation, though he’d be hard pressed to say which of them was the hostage. He listened hard and the thing that surprised him was how quietly Emjay breathed.

“As soon as I can. I need to make sure I’m not followed.”

“Okay. The pub’s side door has a security camera. Ring me back when —” The call dropped.

A few minutes later, Emjay rang again.

Thomas got up, announced, “He’s here,” and went downstairs.

Emjay slipped past him without invitation. “Can I smell food upstairs? Great. I’m starving.”

Thomas caught the look on Fareed’s face when Emjay spoke.

“As-salāmu alayka.”

Emjay took a seat next to him and lifted a slice of pizza warily.

Fareed looked affronted. “The pizzas are vegetarian. There’s nothing *haram* in the food.”

Emjay took a bite. “And yet we are in a drinking house.”

Sheryl’s head lifted. “Hey, no one’s keeping you here. You can leave at any time.”

“When it suits me, that’s what I intend to do.”

Thomas noticed the rucksack over Emjay’s shoulder and had that thought again, the one that made him cringe. He tried to build bridges instead. “Everything went to plan with your luggage.” *Give or take Karl assaulting a driver and stealing his camera.* “We never saw anyone acting suspiciously.”

Emjay took the bait. “They were too busy following me. Fortunately, I am good at my job.”

* * *

By the time Thomas and Miranda cleared the plates away, Emjay and Fareed were immersed in private conversation. It sounded like Arabic, so he left them to it. Karl seemed content to watch from the side lines.

Out in the kitchen, Miranda washed the plates and passed them across for drying. “You haven’t got this one figured out, have you?”

“Not quite. We’ll be okay, Karl’s here.” He stopped short of telling her they were both armed. “Alright if I borrow your office for a private chat with Emjay? I can give him his bag as well, then he has less reason to hang around.”

She pulled a key out of her jeans. “The bag’s under my desk.”

Thomas called Emjay over and started walking. By the time he unlocked the door, there were footsteps behind him. He clicked on the light,

and waited at the threshold until it blinked into life. “Your stuff is in here. We haven’t touched it.”

He placed it on the desk, making no comment when Emjay checked the lock.

Emjay pulled out a stash of banknotes from his inside pocket. “I’m grateful for what you’ve done — all of you. Here’s a thousand pounds, as a token of my gratitude.”

Thomas suddenly felt as if somebody had walked over his grave, but he couldn’t say why. Emjay reached for the door.

“I have to be somewhere by nightfall. I need you to contact the Foreign Office, misdirect them. Both sides will come looking for me.”

Thomas grabbed the door handle. “See, that’s what I don’t get. How could the people in the house know about you?”

Emjay laughed. “Simple. I told them. Not my *actual* job, of course. No, I’m a humble clerk with the Foreign Office, censured because of my *culture*.” He let the echo of that loaded word fade. “Then I mention that I’d heard the community centre is a place of interest, wait for their inevitable outrage and let them talk me into trying to find things out for them.”

“And this is all sanctioned?”

Emjay moved Thomas’s arm aside to open the door. “Asks the man who is under suspension! Did you have official approval for all your activities?” He answered his own question. “Of course you didn’t. Now, I want to go through my bags. In private — nothing personal.”

Thomas pulled the office door closed and locked it. “None taken. You can use the gents downstairs. I’ll stick a couple of chairs in there.”

Once Emjay was out of the way, talk flowed more freely. Thomas gave Karl the good news about contacting the Foreign Office and delegated it to him. Assuming Caliban’s wasn’t already under surveillance, that would remove one headache. Which left . . .

Molly skewered the donkey’s tail. “And what if the jihadists are also tracking him?”

Everyone avoided looking in Fareed’s direction, except Karl.

“What do you reckon, Fareed? Could they have traced Emjay here?”

Fareed’s eyes narrowed. “From the person I saw, they’re strictly amateurs. The only way they’ll find us is if Emjay led them here.”

A loud handclap drew their attention to the doorway. “Exactly, Akhee, and why would I do that?”

Fareed retreated into his chair and then his expression changed, the way a man’s face changes when he knows the answer to a question no one has asked. “Nice trainers.”

Emjay glanced at his own footwear. “Perfect for running!”

Thomas took a good look. Okay if you liked purple and gold, but a bit gaudy for his taste. Expensive looking too. Then again, Emjay had money to burn.

Bang. It sounded like a firecracker. Thomas had it pegged as a small calibre weapon. Everybody hit the deck. Karl crawled across the floor like a squaddie, towards the sound beyond the saloon doors. As he reached his destination, smoke started to curl under the door, so he backed up a few feet. He waved behind him and Thomas crouched low, taking his signal to check out the other entry points.

Miranda followed him, which he took as a vote of confidence. He checked the gents and she checked the ladies, and then they entered the kitchen together. Two narrow windows high up the wall were undamaged but wisps of blue-grey smoke already seeped past the flagstones.

He grabbed one side of a stainless steel preparation table that gleamed under the neon. “Give me a hand.”

Between them they lifted and shunted the table hard against the door. Miranda understood his intent and started picking up anything that looked heavy — pots, pans, even a stack of plates — to add weight to the table. It would slow down a forced entry and buy them some time.

Returning to the saloon, he found Sheryl, Fareed, Molly and Emjay under the table. Molly had her phone out.

“Leave it off,” Karl screeched. “They may not know who’s here and who isn’t. Best to keep it that way.”

Thomas still wondered who ‘they’ were, but now was not the time for open discussion.

Emjay crouched over his bag with the small rucksack fastened to his back. He flinched as a loud *pop* erupted somewhere outside. “If I go now, they may leave you in peace.”

Thomas looked to Karl, who shook his head. “We’d be throwing you to the wolves.”

Fareed glanced at Emjay. Thomas couldn't see what Emjay mouthed back, but the look on Fareed's face did not require analysis. He wanted Emjay as far away as possible. "Let him go. It's what he wants."

Emjay started moving towards the door by the back stairs. Karl stayed put, so Thomas did the decent thing and went with him.

Thomas knew that memory was a fickle thing. In the heat of the moment you missed things and then seconds, minutes or even days later, clues filtered through to the conscious mind. Thoughts you'd forgotten, or couldn't accommodate.

Emjay dipped and shifted the bag to his other hand. An almighty bang went off somewhere near the gents. Thomas heard the explosion and someone shouting behind him, as Emjay raced down the back steps. He went after him to cover the back door. No smoke there.

Thomas braced against the door release and waited for a signal. One shove and Emjay was away through the gap, running for his life.

Chapter 30

Thomas wrenched the door back into place and snapped the bar up to lock it. He could hear the sound of gushing water when he reached the top of the stairs and shouted across the saloon. “Karl, what’s our status?”

“Under siege!” There was an edge to the voice. Karl was in his element, weapon drawn, hunched down and ready for combat.

Thomas did his thinking freeform. He remembered the first — and only — time he took Miranda to a professional rugby match. She couldn’t get excited because nothing made sense. It was all moving wallpaper to her. Now he knew how she felt, so he drew on experience. Only a fool would try to breach the main doors and they’d struggle to get through the windows. Not since the Americans fitted bulletproof glass after a previous debacle.

It seemed as if everyone held their breath, waiting for the monsters. All Thomas could hear was running water and the hiss in his head, while his mind hovered on the edge of something important. The water . . .

He caught Molly’s eye. “It’s a con.” He stood up, unfazed by Sheryl’s insistence that he ‘stay the fuck down.’ Even Karl looked surprised. “I checked the toilets before Emjay went in to sort through his gear. No broken windows.”

Karl got it. “Anyone hear glass break before the explosion?”

No one answered. There was only one logical and bitter conclusion. Emjay had placed a device in there, something to occupy them while he made his escape. Or a way of taking people out of the equation.

Fareed stood and brushed dust from his trousers. “He’s played us all. There’s no one outside.”

Molly stared at him indignantly. “Then what about the jihadists?”

Fareed’s face contorted. “There are no jihadists. Emjay, he told us what we wanted to hear, just like he did with the radicals at the community centre and his Foreign Office handlers.”

Molly helped Sheryl to her feet. “Well, what does he gain?”

Everyone looked to Fareed, who’d finally found his voice.

“Isn’t it obvious? Money. Each side paid him to infiltrate the other and they got the story they already believed.”

Karl stashed his Browning. “When did you figure all this out?”

Fareed clasped his hands together. “I had suspicions. Things he said in Arabic that no one else would understand, taunting me. Thomas — he knew where you live.”

“Bastard. He must have been on to us from the first time we followed him to the car. He outplayed us all.”

Miranda went for Fareed’s jugular. “So why let him go?”

“He spoke the names of my wife, my daughter and my son. An unbeliever without fear or faith — we are better off without a man like that. Let him crawl away into the shadows. He is not even a true Muslim. His trainers are *haram* — forbidden. They are lined with pig skin.”

Thomas felt massively out of his depth, but that didn’t stop him talking. “How do you know?”

Fareed spat out a reply. “Why wouldn’t I if my faith matters to me?”

Miranda shook her head slowly and Thomas took the hint: move on.

“We’d better turn off the water — Miranda, where’s the stopcock?”

She started walking, and then cast a glance back to Karl. “I take it someone will foot the repair bill for the damage, or would you prefer I speak to my insurers?”

Karl raised a hand in submission. “Sure. I’ll find a way to take care of it. You sort the water and then I think we ought to get out of here. Like Fareed says, nobody’s coming. Maybe that was always Emjay’s plan, until we forced him to improvise. He disappears and no one loses face.”

Sheryl stood alone. “How do we know there’s no one outside? Emjay may be gone but we’re still here to talk about it. Aren’t we a loose end?”

Thomas weighed up the odds. “Back door is safest. It’s the route he left by. Let me sort out the leak first.”

Not everyone looked convinced.

Karl threw his opinion into the ring. “Well, we can’t stay here all day.”

A quick show of hands and the party of six moved towards the back stairs. Thomas pushed the heavy door of the gents and the world punched back. The blast inside the room slammed the door into its frame, sending him reeling. He heard smaller blasts outside and a car engine’s whine, screaming to fever pitch until it collided with the door downstairs and splintered the wood.

He'd make more sense of it later. But in those critical seconds he relied on instinct and adrenaline. He reached the top of the stairs to see a monster, clad in black with a horse's skull, smashing through what was left of the fire door. Someone shouted or screamed — he couldn't tell which — and then he realised it wasn't a person, but a gun. The bullet screeched past, searing the air. He didn't have to reach for his Browning, it was already in his hand. He used it with clinical precision — no deliberation, no mercy.

A single shot would have been enough to send the target down. Instead, Thomas pumped another three bullets into his chest. As the figure crumpled backwards to oblivion, Thomas noticed the purple and gold trainers.

His senses hit him like a dam breach, searing the memory into every sinew so that it remained a part of him. This was the nightmare outcome, the end game for anyone who picks up a gun. He tightened his grip to stop the Browning twitching and stood like a statue, keeping watch over the dead. The others gathered around him in silence at the top of the stairs. There was nothing to say.

The next thing he registered was Miranda's touch, easing his gun arm down.

"For better or worse," she whispered.

He felt for the holster and sheathed the weapon, his eyes on the corpse all the while. It felt important to see it for what it was.

Karl moved to Thomas's other side and for an instant it felt as if their presence was the only thing holding him up.

"Nice work, Tommo. We're all indebted to you. Lucky you took preventative measures."

Except it wasn't luck. He assessed the threat and took steps to counter it. Something Emjay hadn't bargained for. Just how Karl would have done. So what did that say about him?

Fareed broke the spell. "Now what?"

Molly spoke quietly. "Miranda, why don't you and Sheryl turn off the water now? I'll move the car."

Thomas turned to Fareed and Molly. "Someone needs to check his pockets first." He stood aside and they went together.

He felt the gun against his ribcage like a dead weight, anchoring him to the spot. "Karl, ring Teresa to come and take care of this. I know what she

said. This is what *I'm* saying. If we have to ring the police it will be very messy and very public. You can give her ten minutes to decide.”

He watched his colleagues reach the body and go through the pockets methodically, depositing the spoils to one side and covering their hands before rolling the body over. He became the observer again, losing himself in details.

Molly retrieved something and stood up. “Passport. Hold on a second.” She used a pencil to ease the pages back. “It’s his picture but there’s a different name.”

Karl edged closer to Thomas. “He’ll have planned on leaving the country after dealing with us.” He tutted. “Someone supplied the passport — real or otherwise.”

Fareed extracted a wad of bank notes. “Must be several thousand.”

A sickening sense of dread settled in Thomas’s guts. He took out the thousand that Emjay had given him and checked for a highlighter mark — fourth character on the fourth banknote. A garish yellow stain told him all he needed to know.

“Emjay gave me this . . . it’s from the money I paid Jack for the weapons. Get someone to check on Jack, Natalie and the kids.”

Karl didn’t question it. He knew the score. Jack wouldn’t have given up six grand without a fight.

Molly held up some keys. “Car,” was all she said before squeezing through the remnants of the fire door.

Karl went off to phone a friend. Always assuming they still had any.

Chapter 31

Molly climbed the stairs, holding the passport away, as if it were contaminated. Fareed followed, lost in thought, a clutch of Emjay's personal effects in his hand.

Thomas waited till they reached him. "Show everything to Karl. We'll take the passport and the money — as evidence."

He vaulted down the steps and zeroed in on the discarded gun. He'd seen bodies before, accident investigations mainly, but never one where he'd been responsible. Death seemed unfathomable when you watched it happen — a living, feeling human being reduced to lifeless flesh in the time it takes to pull a trigger. He picked up the weapon and stared at the mask, aware that his two colleagues were watching him. He knew what he had to do, even if he didn't know why. Confirmation maybe, or some primal need to look death in the face and then walk away.

He gripped the plastic mask and it crackled in his hand as he eased it over Emjay's forehead. A vacant expression, staring glassy-eyed into the void. It would have been over in seconds. Or maybe Thomas just wanted to believe that. Stupid really, but he felt like saying a prayer, only he couldn't think of anything. So he pulled the mask back down and pocketed the gun, sticking to the details.

He sat at the table, counting a dead man's money, until Miranda carried a tray over from the bar.

"I think we could all do with a drink."

He nodded and went in search of Karl to offload the weapon, finding him upstairs by the pool table. "It's a Colt, serial number's gone." He placed the gun on the baize and picked up a ball. "What's the situation?"

Karl scratched at his chin, already in retreat. "Teresa took my call and said she'll get back to me."

Wrong answer. "I'm serious, Karl. Five minutes gone. She supports us here or I deal with it my way." He slammed the ball against a cushion and snatched it up on the rebound, squeezing it tightly so he could feel something.

"Tommo, you're not thinking straight."

“Mate, I’ve . . . killed a man.” It didn’t get any easier saying it out loud. He saw the look in Karl’s eyes, somewhere between pity and understanding. “Today is not a day for compromise.”

“I know how you feel, believe me. I’ve been there.” Karl’s mobile rang. “Gimme a second.” He turned and walked a few paces then hunched forward. It didn’t look like good news. “No, I understand. Thanks for letting me know.” He turned and shook his head. “Emjay killed Jack Langton. Tommo, he must have followed you there. It’s all captured on surveillance in the front room. Jack went down fighting.”

There had been no word about Jack’s wife, Natalie, or their children. Jesus, it was some day when that counted as good news. They went back downstairs and sat at the table with the others. Thomas noticed how no one looked him in the eye. Meanwhile, the elephant in the room was still lying at the bottom of the steps.

Miranda handed out a cache of bottles. “The pumps are off.” She passed one to Fareed. “It’s lemonade. I wasn’t sure if you’re, you know, devout.”

Fareed took a sip and found his voice. “So what *are* you two?”

Karl’s phone bleeped. He glanced at his phone. “Thomas, it’s sorted.” Then he stared at Fareed. “What kind of a question is that? We’re Surveillance Support Unit.”

“Yeah, but you’re not, are you?” He pointed with the bottle. “Since when did we carry army issue weapons?”

Thomas stared him down. He wasn’t in the mood for show and tell.

Karl took a bottle of shandy and smiled briefly when he read the label. “Let’s be grownups here. Forget what you think you know about Emjay and the Foreign Office, jihadists, and MI5. Yer man down the steps was a killer, pure and simple.”

Thomas blinked and let the words slam into him. Nothing simple about it.

Karl slapped his palm against the table. “We did what we had to do, and that’s fine, but some serious shit’s gonna land unless we’re smart. It’d be much better if a colleague removes Emjay’s body and we take no further part in this. That way, this stays buried — Official Secrets Act and all that.”

Molly and Fareed traded glances. Finally, Molly took a stiff gulp of premium German lager and glanced up at the ceiling.

“Okay, okay. Agreed. This is someone else’s problem. Fareed?”

He locked eyes with Thomas. “I still don’t like it. But as long as there’s no comeback, I think I can live with it.” He smiled sheepishly at his unintended joke.

Thomas took a slow, steady breath. He couldn’t put it off any longer. “Sheryl? Can I speak with you in private?”

She looked up, as if from a daydream, oblivious to what awaited her. He wondered how she’d cope with the news. It bothered him more than he’d expected.

Miranda read the tension and followed her. He let it ride. They stood behind the bar, the three of them, like a bad play. He was still searching for the right words when she threw him a bone.

“It’s Jack, isn’t it?”

He nodded slowly and touched her lightly on the shoulder. “He’s dead. I’m sorry. Emjay . . .” He glanced to the doorway that led to the steps. “He got to Jack before he came for us.”

Her face tightened. “Then you did the world a favour.”

He chose not to tell her that it didn’t feel that way. She flinched and rubbed her forearms, closing herself in.

“I’d better go see Natalie. There are things to discuss.”

He couldn’t tell whether she was talking to herself.

Miranda blurted out, “Are you sure that’s what you want to do?”

He saw how Sheryl stopped her with one look. Grief could do that.

“He was still my father.”

Miranda put her arms around her and Sheryl endured it for a handful of seconds before she struggled free.

“I’m fine, really. The life he led, I always knew this day would come. I guess I hoped we’d have a better relationship before then.” Her eyes filled and she wiped them with the back of her hand. “Can you unlock the front doors? There’s nothing left to fear.”

Miranda took a step forward with her but she kept on walking.

“You stay here. I’ll be fine.”

He turned to Miranda, still searching for something to say, when his phone buzzed.

Chapter 32

Francesca Gerrard had impeccable timing. “Thomas, I want you to stop looking for Christine. It’s not important now. I can’t talk because I’m needed at the stables.” Her voice dropped a couple of notches on the volume. “*Visitors*. Naturally I’ll still pay you. I do hope you’ll understand.”

He skipped a cryptic reply and settled for, “I’ll be over for my money.”

“Yes, that’d be fine, Thomas. Goodbye.” The call ended.

He gave Karl the lowdown. “Can you handle things here when Teresa arrives?” He took it for granted she was already on her way.

“Sure. Anything else I can do?”

“I’ll text you.” He turned to Miranda. “Gotta go. You coming along?”

Her eyes sparkled. “Lemme just nip up to my office.” She held out her hand for her key. “I won’t be long — I’ll see you outside.”

He went out the front way, leaving Karl to organise Fareed and Molly into a welcoming committee for the body snatchers.

By the time Miranda joined him in her car he’d received a text back from Karl, with a name and contact number. “Here.” He passed her the phone. “Can you ring and arrange a meeting? I’ll tell you where. We may need back-up.”

There was a dark irony. Out of all the agencies circling, the only person he could trust — probably — was someone he had no history with.

Miranda made the call and swapped a few details. He mostly tuned it out. There wasn’t room in his head for two conversations. The image of Emjay spread out on the ground had burned into his brain. He revisited it mentally, like a crime scene photographer, narrating his examination of the corpse.

Miranda screeched. “Slow down. Take the second right for the sports field. I’ve told her to look out for a blue Mini.”

He parked up at some sports pitches. They sat and watched a rugby game to kill time, avoiding conversation until she crossed the divide.

“Remind me again, is this rugby union or rugby league? I forget the difference.” She undercut it nicely with a smile, softening him up for a punchline. “What’s your plan?”

He pressed the shoulder holster against his side. “Try not to kill anyone else?”

“You can’t blame yourself, Thomas. Any of us would have done the same thing in your position.”

He stared past her. An interesting choice of words. And what was his position? “Maybe. I was the one holding a gun though.”

The reds had the upper hand over the greens, or maybe it was the other way around. He lost track and they became colours that collided together like the thoughts in his head. He’d killed a man back at the bar. Four bullets in the chest. No deliberation. No mercy.

“Would it help to talk about it?” She backtracked immediately. “Well, not help exactly. I mean . . .” She tried again. “How do you feel?”

He paused because he knew the next words out of his mouth might define him in her eyes forever. “Honestly? I feel conflicted. Although I wish it hadn’t come to that, I’m glad I was able to put an end to it.”

She touched his hand. Subject closed, for now.

He checked his watch again and then noticed Miranda’s foot resting on something. “What’s in the plastic bag?”

She smiled enigmatically. “For my protection.”

He sighed. “There’s no need. Francesca Gerrard as good as invited me. No more searching for Christine, she said — it’s over.”

“So why are you still armed?”

A good question, from the queen of good questions. He conceded the point with a murmur. Why? Because something still didn’t feel right and he trusted his instincts. If Christine had been found — or found her way back — why hadn’t Bob Peterson been in touch? Meantime, Sir Peter was still out of reach. However he played it in his head, nothing added up.

A yellow Citroen approached and flashed its lights once before parking on their left. Thomas watched Rupee as she climbed out of her car and lifted a shoulder bag from the passenger seat. Miranda flicked a button to unlock the back door.

He waited until she got in. “Rupee, this is Miranda.”

She reached back to shake hands. Instead, Rupee passed them two earpieces. “It has a good outdoor range.”

Miranda shot Thomas a glance and tried her earpiece on, settling the mike under her collar. “Testing, testing.”

Rupee had one more surprise. “This is for you, Thomas. If you wouldn’t mind.”

He undid his jacket to set the covert body cam in place and then trailed the wire round to his back pocket for the battery pack. “Evidence gathering. Karl’s idea?”

Rupee didn’t answer but her face said plenty. So even with a corpse on his hands and a Foreign Office scandal ticking away, Karl managed to think ahead. It was a wonder MI5 hadn’t snapped him up years ago.

He started the car and mentally plotted a course to *chez* Gerrard in Ampthill, Bedfordshire. Rupee caught his eye in the mirror.

“I was surprised to hear from you. I’m not really sure why I’m here.”

Miranda met his gaze for an instant. Her face suggested she was asking herself the same question.

“Karl’s got his hands full and we’re short on friends, so you’ve been bumped up the list. I think Christine needs help. So does her mother.”

Bedfordshire was just as he remembered it, safely on the far side of Hertfordshire to avoid the lava flow of London’s expansion. Christine had told him proudly of the county’s Norman legacy. He imagined Francesca still got a kick out of it too, drawing on the past to bolster her sense of entitlement. And what about the present? What was he walking into? He stretched his left shoulder back and felt the extra kilo of a Browning pulling against him.

Rupee didn’t speak again until the ‘Welcome to Ampthill’ sign. “How do we get in?”

“Simple. We ring Francesca. We’re expected, sort of. If we’re stopped at the gates, you have ID so that gives us *some* credibility.” He was winging it now and he knew it, trusting that he would somehow deal with whatever they encountered. *Yeah, that had worked out well so far.*

Rupee stretched towards the front passenger seat. “Miranda, we haven’t been properly introduced. I’m with the Security Service.”

She gripped Rupee’s hand like a navy. “I’m with him.”

He left them to make small talk and reached for his phone.

“Karl, are you free to speak?”

“Sure, Tommo. Teresa and her team left a few minutes ago. They did their own sweep, everywhere else is clear. I had to give them the phone, sorry about that — they had bigger friends. Not the passport though, or the

cash. Thanks to Molly's collusion. Hold on a second . . . right, Fareed wants to know what they should do now? I reckon they ought to see Ann and give her their version of events."

Thomas knew Karl meant their version of the truth. "Makes sense. Listen, I'm nearly on site with our guest on board."

"Well, you take it easy. I'm in Teresa's good books again, which means back-up is available should you need it. Watch out for the roadworks at Dunstable Street! McNeill out."

Thomas blew a breath. Sure enough, Dunstable Street was his next reference point. The cunning bastard must be tracking their progress, which meant Miranda's car had one of Karl's tracers fitted. The look of indignation on her face suggested she'd realised it too.

He turned up the dial on his charm. "Miranda, you've always had a good telephone voice . . ."

He only caught one end of the conversation. Francesca Gerrard was a talker, suggesting she wasn't alone. That, or she liked the sound of her own voice. He mouthed a thought to Miranda, who glared at him and held the phone from her ear.

"Mrs Gerrard, Thomas wondered how many riders you had today?"

"Oh, call me Francesca, please. Four would be typical, although only two use the grounds at a time."

He nodded — message received — and fed Miranda another line.

"In that case, we'll see you at the stables."

The line went silent for a moment. "I wouldn't dream of it. I'll walk the stallion out to the folly so you can see how he moves."

He hoped Francesca Gerrard understood subtlety. If she'd read him right she had just given away the strength of the opposition.

Chapter 33

Thomas didn't say much more until he slowed the car down at the open gates.

"Welcome to Wonderland."

Barely through the pillars of judgement, he spotted a conspicuous dark suit by one of the beech trees. The *overt* security had a radio to his face as they passed, but didn't move position. Not even when Miranda waved.

The grounds had grown bigger since his last visit. The distance between the gates and the house seemed insurmountable. He took a couple of controlled breaths, like on the firing line, and edged the car along the tarmac. He noticed Miranda scoping the terrain.

"This could have all been yours! You nearly did well for yourself."

Funny girl. He held his tongue until the phrase 'while you were in Bermuda' evaporated. He indicated, out of habit, and followed a tributary path barely wider than the car. A cylindrical structure sat at the top of a shallow mound, the domed pink roof reminiscent of an oversized saltcellar, or something more phallic.

He stopped the car and cut the engine, suddenly inspired by a mixture of chivalry and forward planning. "Miranda, I want you to stay here."

She gave him a withering look. "Yeah, like *that's* gonna happen."

Rupee bristled. "Unbelievable, Thomas. You're not her superior."

Miranda grinned. "Got that right!"

Francesca Gerrard made her way towards them on horseback, another suit forced into the role of stable boy. Thomas watched their approach. Francesca's demeanour struck him as odd, more inconvenienced than threatened. Coupled with the lack of intervention at the gates, this didn't seem like a hostile takeover.

They got out of the car slowly, all smiles. Thomas made the first move and reached up to take her hand. "Mrs Gerrard — Francesca — it's lovely to see you again. He certainly is a beautiful animal."

The suit moved back, sizing them up. It all felt staged, like the start of a chess game where opponents meet with a single objective: annihilation. Francesca descended with practised ease.

He nearly applauded. “So, this is Samson. Your daughter has certainly been good at keeping secrets.”

She made a face, which caused him quiet delight.

“Now, Mrs Gerrard, we did discuss our fee . . .”

She spoke through gritted teeth. “Five thousand.”

Thomas noticed Miranda moving in his peripheral vision. She stepped lightly to one side before she spoke.

“How many hands?”

The horse reared up like a Porsche logo photoshoot, its shrieking cry scratching the air. Francesca gripped the halter to force it down. The suit panicked and reached into his jacket.

Rupee shouted, “Gun!” which gave the horse a second chance to play wild stallion.

Amid the chaos the suit suddenly stopped moving, transfixed by the two wires protruding from his chest that linked him to Miranda’s Taser.

Francesca snorted. “Really! You’ll scare the horse.”

Miranda’s lip curled. “Then he’d better stand very still.”

Rupee searched the stranger without any obstruction. Thomas figured the threat of 50,000 volts made a powerful case for cooperation. All Rupee found was a radio set. “That’s all he has. He’s not armed.”

Thomas turned detective. “What is going on?”

Francesca didn’t answer, other than to glance towards battery boy. Thomas took the hint — not in front of the hired help. And come to think of it, hired by who? He decided there was no value in taking an extra body back to the house.

“Someone needs to stay with him.”

Francesca pulled a key from her pocket. “The folly is quite comfortable. It has two rooms and all the facilities.” She sounded like an upper-class estate agent.

Thomas looked to Rupee. “It’ll have to be you.”

Miranda held out the Taser to her for a swap over. Then she reached into her bag and pulled out some cable ties. The suit looked terrified. His face told a story: this wasn’t what he signed up for.

With Rupee and her prisoner safely installed, Thomas waited until he heard the lock click and then adjusted his earpiece. “Unless you hear from

me first, don't open the door. And if anyone else tries to come in, only shoot if you have to." He took it for granted she was carrying.

Francesca and Miranda had walked on ahead, the horse between them like a mediator. He held back a pace to see what they'd talk about.

Miranda stated the obvious. "Christine's at the house then?"

Francesca stroked the horse's shoulder. "I couldn't tell you before. I didn't want to be disloyal to Edgar."

Thomas connected the dots. "So what's changed?"

She swallowed and then her words came out at a whisper. "I found out about the private talks, what they're here to talk *about*." She glanced over her shoulder. "Oh, I know you think I'm a vacuous woman, Thomas, but looks can be deceiving."

He couldn't help contrasting her formality in front of Miranda with her informality when she'd been filled with Christmas cheer and champagne cocktails. He played to his strengths and stayed silent. It didn't take long.

"I promise you, Christine really *was* missing. She wouldn't say where, but I expect she was over in Europe."

He tasted bile. Spoken like a true isolationist.

"She came back two days ago at the dead of night with—"

The reference to Europe did it. "Sir Peter Carroll." He tried not to choke on the name.

She nodded and the horse nodded with her. In other circumstances it would have been comical, only no one was laughing.

"I've never cared for that odious man. Even if he and Edgar do go back a long way."

Do they now? "So who are the other visitors?"

Francesca smiled slowly, her eyelashes batting him away like an unwelcome insect. "Thomas, even under these circumstances, surely you must understand? Confidentiality is *essential*."

He withstood her scorn and did some mental arithmetic. Two security staff passed meant another two to come. And why have them at all if they weren't armed?

Francesca led the way to the stables. No prizes for guessing who was in charge this close to home. Predictably, a dark-suited nobody stuck her head out the moment they entered the stable yard. The way Thomas saw it, there were two types of horseshit in abundance here.

Lackey number three was muscular and heavy set. She didn't look as if she needed a weapon. Ex-forces probably, and a sergeant or a corporal at that. He suddenly remembered Karl telling him that a corporal was sometimes known as a *Full Screw*. It helped lift his mood.

She ambled towards them and nodded deferentially to Francesca. "Can I help you, madam?"

Francesca played it ice cool like the lady of the manor she was. "Here, take Samson." She handed the reins to Miranda, who led him to one side.

"Mrs Gerrard, your instructions were not to admit . . ."

It was all the invitation Thomas needed to give the Browning some air. The Full Screw, if that's what she was, had the good sense not to push the point. Her composure, when faced with the weapon, reinforced his notion that she'd seen a British Army issue, thirteen-cartridge, semi-automatic before — only from the user's end.

She did not take kindly to being escorted into the stables to be roped and gagged while Thomas looked on. Afterwards, as Francesca opened a side door into the house, Miranda pulled Thomas back.

"Mrs G said something very odd back there to the woman we were hog-tying. After I'd done my dominatrix bit she tested the ropes and the makeshift gag, and asked her to keep quiet. Then she whispered an apology and promised to pay her extra. She also told her it wouldn't be for long."

He was whispering, "*What the fuck . . . ?*" when Francesca popped her head back out the doorway.

"Shall we get this over with, Thomas?"

A thought landed in his brain with a dull thud. If the security staff was Mrs Gerrard's, that would explain the lack of firearms. What it didn't explain was why you'd want low-level security watching for intruders. He caught up with her and blocked her way.

"What did you bring me here to do?"

Sunlight glinted off her antique brooch. "I believe you came of your own volition."

He could see she was already getting her story straight.

Miranda spun Francesca around to face her. "How about I scream the place down and then ring for the police?" She held up her phone, ready.

Francesca's face fell like a chunk of glacier taking a dip.

"Right. So let's stop fucking about, shall we?"

He had to hand it to Miranda, she always knew the right thing to say.

“They’re . . . they’re all down in the cellar. He’s there with them of course, acting as an intermediary.” Her face lit up. “I doubt Whitehall would approve.” She waved her hand at the corridor, as if dismissing one of her staff. “You’ll understand when you get there.”

Chapter 34

Thomas knew the way. Christine had once given him a private tour. He decided not to share that piece of information with Miranda. He felt a moment of trepidation when they reached the cellar door. Downstairs, he knew, were copious bottles of wine, large spiders, and two separate rooms. One had been converted into a washroom and toilet, while the other, much larger room, was the one Christine insisted her father used for Masonic meetings.

As he slowly turned the handle, Miranda nudged past him and pushed the door. It lurched inwards and a flourish of footsteps echoed below, drawing closer. They met him at the dogleg on the steps. Miranda let a can of body spray do her talking, but he was wise to it and managed to shield his face, striking out wildly with a cosh. Thomas took a blow on his left shoulder and came back with a fist, but Miranda got to him first. After that, with two on one, it was a done deal and suit number four hit the deck hard.

Thomas looked to Miranda. "Maybe you should go back upstairs to Francesca, in case she does something stupid."

Miranda grinned for an instant and then her face hardened. "What about him?" She glanced at the crumpled heap. "And what about you?"

He thought for a moment. "Have you got any more cable ties and something we could use as a gag?"

* * *

The countdown commenced in his head. At forty-five he noticed the missing bottles of wine. At twenty-eight he heard muffled conversations and felt for the cosh in his pocket. Somewhere in the back of his mind Karl cracked a joke about the corridors of power. The voices grew louder beyond the cobwebs and the faded brickwork, where dust seemed to hang in the air.

When he reached the door, at fourteen, Christine carefully pronounced the words, 'memorandum of understanding.' He smiled at the irony. Right then, he understood nothing at all.

He waited, holding his breath while she spoke. She sounded calm and business-like. She could have been running a review meeting back at the SSU. In the absence of any better plan, he knocked twice and turned the

great iron ring that served as a handle. The door was stiff but yielded under pressure. Then again, didn't everything?

Inside, six people sat around a circular table — a piece of furniture he hadn't seen there the previous time. Christine was positioned just behind Sir Peter with an old-fashioned typewriter on an occasional table. And looking around the room, what an occasion it was.

The party of seven all turned towards Thomas. He clocked each of them in turn. Christine stared, as if she couldn't quite believe he was there. And something else too. Fear, maybe, of what he'd say or do? She could rest easy. He was all out of ideas. Miranda had called it right. Christine was no hostage. She'd gone to ground deliberately, hiding out with the monsters. Sure, she must have had her reasons, but in that instant he hated her for the lengths they'd gone to on her behalf. Jesus, it could have been one of them on the slab instead of Emjay. And all for information they never needed.

When he'd seen enough of her face, he turned his attention to Sir Peter Carroll, director general of the SSU, and the Alliance's mole in the Shadow State. He couldn't even articulate what he felt about him. Edgar Gerrard, Christine's father and a big noise in the Foreign Office, was seated next to him, perfectly poised apart from the beads of sweat on his forehead. Thomas wasn't part of their agenda.

The rest of the line-up comprised some unknown pinstriped bastard, a senior military figure festooned with service ribbons that were a barcode for valour, and a woman that Thomas thought was in the government, although he couldn't swear to it.

And lastly, a blushing woman with plenty to blush about: Henriette Voclain, a major player in the Shadow State's hierarchy. She was as big a surprise as Christine. The last Thomas had heard, she'd opted for a new life in the USA. Either he'd been misinformed or someone had found a way to bring her back into the game.

No one said a word. Henriette flinched, which prompted a steadying hand from Sir Peter. What a gentleman.

Thomas wondered how much the body cam could pick up. From his vantage point, he noticed the papers strewn across the table — rough drafts by the look of it, some with crossings out and side notes. Others contained short paragraphs that looked like clauses in a contract.

Sir Peter broke the deadlock. Maybe he felt more confident for having two people on the payroll present. He offered up that condescending cat and mouse smile that dared Thomas to think the unthinkable.

Jesus. He felt his guts tighten. Unless Henriette had come out of retirement to switch sides, there were two factions at this round table. No wonder Christine and Sir Peter had gone to ground. He got it like a blade. This was how nations were forged and their destinies determined. Not by conflict or colonisation. No, they were just the consequences of decisions made in secret meetings like this one.

“You’re early,” Sir Peter paused, “Thomas.” One word of recognition from him and the rest of the room breathed again. “I think you’d better wait outside until I’m ready for you.”

He straightened. “I’ll be upstairs, sir.”

Edgar Gerrard looked about to shit a brick. Thomas closed the door behind him.

He reached the body on the steps, cut the ties and helped him to his feet. Another hired hand following orders. “You can go outside now. It’s over.” He left him there to make his own decision.

Francesca and Miranda were enjoying tea and silence in a side room. They both seemed surprised to see him. Miranda removed her earpiece and mike.

“I’ve checked in with Rupee. Everything’s fine there.”

He nodded and then turned his attention to Francesca. “You got what you wanted — I crashed the party.”

She set her tea down. “You understand nothing. Come with me.”

He and Miranda followed her through to the kitchen, where she unlocked an old larder door. It seemed an odd time to play sardines.

Francesca pointed to a space at the end, behind the shelves, just big enough for a chair. Beyond it, near the skirting board, a small air vent conveyed the tinny echo of voices. Sir Peter was still holding court. Thomas stared at her blankly.

“You still don’t get it, do you?”

They walked out again.

“Enlighten me.”

“I see so little of Edgar lately that I started taking an interest in his work. The work he brings home. After *London*,” she didn’t feel the need to

qualify it, “he has held several meetings downstairs.” Her face froze for a moment and Thomas couldn’t tell whether it was arrogance or Botox. “These talks are about sharing intelligence on terrorism. And perhaps more than that.” Her smile rose like a fever, only he was the one sweating.

If what she said was correct, the price of exposure could be catastrophic — for *both* sides. Few would understand a willingness to sit with the opposition. “You’re playing a very dangerous game, Francesca. Do everyone a favour. Lock the door and forget this ever happened.”

Rupee radioed in. “Thomas, there’s a helicopter coming in to land. What do you want me to do?”

He reached for his phone to call Karl and then thought better of it. This party was over, bar the clear up.

“Nothing. Let your guy go. Actually, scratch that. Walk him over. I think we’re done here.”

Francesca required a prompt for the five thousand. He told himself that he didn’t need her charity, but she could afford it and he’d kept up his end of the bargain. Even if he had been chasing ghosts so the *realpolitik* could go on unhindered.

Outside, he smoothed down his jacket and tried to look like a model employee, as if his role as an escort had always been part of the deal. The helicopter idled on the ground, its rotor blades circling lazily. The group emerged and Thomas walked ahead of them with Miranda at his side, carrying a five-grand bag.

He turned to look at them together for a final time and it was as if a spell had been broken. Now, in the harsh light of day, they reverted to their factions, shaking hands with stiff, formal gestures. Deadpan faces all round. Funny to think they might have made history and no one would ever know. Terrorism the common enemy, and cooperation for the greater good. A long shot worth taking.

Rupee appeared across the way, walking slowly with her suited companion. It took a moment to notice the other suit from the gate, making his way towards them at speed. Thomas locked eyes with him. A moment, nothing more, and then the suit stopped in his tracks.

Afterwards, Thomas would put it down to the guy’s finger reflex, an unconscious *tell* — the sort of thing Miranda’s mother called at a poker

table if you weren't concentrating. Or maybe it had been a really shitty day and the guy just had it coming.

The lone suit reached to his back pocket and swung his arm round in a wide amateurish arc. Thomas slipped the Browning free with ease and loosed off a shot. Metal struck metal, ringing in his ear like a wake-up call from the abyss. Rooks scattered and time recoiled as the target shrieked and slammed to the ground. Thomas charged at him, primed for a second shot and hoping he wouldn't need it.

The suit squirmed on the ground, gripping his shoulder as he growled in pain. Thomas spotted the weapon by his feet — good call. He kicked it to one side and leaned over his quarry, breathing again.

"Who are you here for?"

Thomas heard Sir Peter's voice in the background and the casualty gave himself away again.

"Who sent you?" His gun moved over the suit's other shoulder, hanging above it like the sword of Damocles. It was a bluff, but a good one. "I won't ask a second time."

"Ed-gar," he snarled.

Thomas picked up the rogue weapon carefully and slipped it into his pocket. Maybe Karl could run the prints through a database. Like the man said, never off duty. He turned to Sir Peter, who was a few steps ahead of the others.

"Looks like someone intended a different outcome. I'll leave that with you. Miranda, we're leaving."

Sir Peter stalled, no longer quite so imposing. "Wait, surely you're in charge here?"

Thomas shook his head. "I believe this is one for the Security Service." He raised a hand. "Unless . . . Rupee, you coming with us?"

She drew level with Sir Peter. "I think I'll stay on, thanks. You're cleared to go."

The helicopter whooshed into life. He wondered which dignitaries would climb aboard, grateful to make their way out of that last minute clusterfuck. He didn't stick around to find out.

Miranda made a show of swinging the moneybag. "I thought it would be heavier."

He kept his earpiece and mike in until they reached the Mini. No one needed his help this time. He figured Rupee and Christine were about to become even better friends. Deals to be done.

Miranda left the bag at his feet. "I'll drive. Get in."

She slowed down when the helicopter banked in front of them and headed north. "Was I seeing things back there or was that Henriette Voclain? I thought she—?"

"Retired? Sort of." He sucked a tooth. "Maybe no one in this line of work ever really quits." He thought about that for a moment.

Miranda brought him back down to earth with a thud. "What about the camera footage? It could be deadly in the wrong hands."

She had a point. Come to think of it, deadly in anyone's hands. He pulled the wire from the battery pack, extracted the memory card and snapped it. "Must have got broken in the scuffle downstairs."

Miranda took a sharp right out the gates, another car in the slipstream of traffic. "Sensible move, although Karl might not see it that way. What are you going to tell him?"

He smiled. "Whatever I need him to know."

Chapter 35

He spent the night alone by choice, anticipating ghosts. A glass of Southern Comfort beside him, an empty chair opposite and a candle to see by, he sat and gazed into the flickering shadows.

The memory that came to haunt him wasn't of Emjay or Jack Langton. He thought about himself at fifteen, taking their old cat to the vet's to be put to sleep. His mother had been too upset to do it. Dad had been oblivious to its suffering.

That evening he had come home and written in his diary — the one he burned soon afterwards: *I'm not sure I like who I've become*. He thought about that and imagined his teenage self casting judgement now.

"Me neither," he called out to the darkness. "But I will learn to live with it."

There were no monsters in his dreams. He woke in the dark, adrift and at peace. He used to worry about crossing the line, only now he saw it differently. He never looked for trouble, trouble found him. And when it did he'd meet it measure for measure, every time.

The seven am alarm roused him. He switched on the radio and caught up with the world. It was still a mess. He ate his toast at the table, facing a shirt and trousers that hung on the back of the kitchen door. It was an important day and he wanted to look his best. He checked the time. Karl had said eight thirty at the top of the escalator, Liverpool Street station, but he'd probably be late. Some things never changed.

He finished breakfast and washed up. Maybe suspension would be good for him. More time with Miranda. Perhaps a trip up to Yorkshire together. Yeah, maybe . . . He walked the long way round to the Walthamstow Central tube station, beside Lloyd Park, under the cover of trees, and then across Forest Road to Hoe Street — Karl's second favourite street name. Walthamstow thronged with cars and human traffic, all with somewhere else to go.

The Victoria Line platform was stuffed with commuters joining the terminus. He envied them a little. They had no idea about the bigger picture — the power brokers intent on shaping the future to their own ends, and

those, like him, who opposed them. A train arrived and the crowd surged as one, filling every spare inch. Humanity at its indifferent finest. It crossed his mind then that this could be the day, *the* day, when it all came crashing down around him.

He noticed a woman who'd won the seat lottery. She was reading a Bible, held in front of her like she was making a point. It had seen better days. She looked up at him, the way people seem to know when they're being stared at. Then she smiled softly, as if she understood something far beyond his grasp. He knew what that felt like. Only in his version of good and evil the rules were different. Good people would sit down with the Devil and sometimes the means were an end in themselves.

* * *

Karl made it to the head of the escalator five minutes late, redeeming himself with coffee and muffins — the way to a good man's soul. He shifted to one side for a platoon of schoolchildren. "Well, Tommo, how are you feeling today?"

He found an answer in the coffee. "Resolute."

Fareed and Molly were at their new desks, having transferred to the SSU's London East team — at Ann's request, according to Karl. They bobbed up from their screens and nodded. Thomas could only imagine the paperwork now the Foreign Office had been caught with its trousers down, running its own intelligence operation. That was assuming someone hadn't found a way to suppress that little nugget. Either way, it was someone else's problem today.

He rapped on the far door, two long and two short. Thomas figured that Karl got the gag — MI in Morse Code — because he started laughing. Ann welcomed them in, as much as her social skills allowed. She took the third seat at the round table, and waited for them to join her.

"I'd like your reports completed."

Karl's forehead crinkled like a fault line. "Not suspended then?"

"That's up to you. I have some leeway as your *acting* manager. Whatever we decide, reports today please. It's been suggested you each take a few days, in light of recent events."

She paused, inviting comment. They disappointed her.

“If it helps, a four-strong surveillance team has been requested by our MI5 colleagues for tomorrow.” Her mischievous smile caught Thomas off guard. “No pressure, boys.”

Karl’s eyes bored into him. “Tommo?”

He figured Yorkshire could wait a little while longer. “We’ll take it.”

Ann’s phone buzzed on the table. She read the screen. “There is one other thing . . .”

He heard the catch on the outer door and didn’t bother looking up. Not even when he recognised the footsteps. Christine always knew how to make an entrance.

She stood by the door, mobile in hand. “This is just a flying visit. My project hasn’t concluded yet.”

A range of comments filled his head. He went with none of them.

“Could Thomas and I have a minute?”

Ann and Karl didn’t need a map. Christine took their place at the table. And then there were two. *Déjà vu*. He saw no reason to make it hard for her, or easy for that matter. So he waited it out instead, counting the seconds in his head.

Contrition was the dish of the day. “I owe you an explanation.”

“No. You don’t.”

“I knew the team would look for me, especially you. And I couldn’t risk you interfering, not with so much at stake. We needed time to complete the talks, so I had to make sure you were obstructed and challenged at every turn.” Her face softened. “I’m still not clear how you found me.”

He played it deadpan. Francesca Gerrard could fight her own battles or dig her own grave.

She rubbed her hands together, even though the room temperature was an even sixty degrees. “What have you told Karl?”

“Nothing. I’ll leave that to you.” He was out of smart remarks. It made a kind of sense, to unite against a common enemy, although he wondered how that would play out in the real world, especially after Sir Peter nearly took a bullet. Again, not his department. “What about Bob?”

“He can’t ever know.”

“And you can live with that, Chrissie?”

“I have to, in order to keep him safe.”

He almost smiled. She’d said the same to him once.

Ann knocked on the door. "Sorry to disturb you." She held up her phone needlessly. "Thomas has been called to Whitehall."

Christine reached forward as he stood up and touched his sleeve. "You're better off on the outside."

"I've never doubted it." He closed the door behind him.

Chapter 36

Karl insisted on accompanying him to Whitehall, even though he wasn't invited. "I'll hang around outside. Might even take some pictures with my *new* camera. Good to see Christine back safe and sound. Well done." He gave him a two-fingered salute — the good kind.

"You're not going to ask me, are you?"

"No need, Tommo. You'll tell me in your own time — or not."

He rode the lift on his own, wondering who'd be in the magic chair. It was fifty-fifty and Ann hadn't clued him in. He knocked twice and crossed the threshold.

Eva hadn't vacated the throne. Her humility was still a work in progress. "Thomas, I thought you'd like to be the first to know that I'll be leaving the Surveillance Support Unit in a few months, once the new arrangements have bedded in. An opportunity has arisen to return to the bench as a judge."

His laughter came without warning. That was how this game played out at the top table. Everyone used what they knew and who they knew to get what they wanted.

She advanced an A4 piece of paper across the desk, face down, and started speaking before he'd turned it over. "I'm not entirely sure what you've been up to, but you've made new and influential friends."

Somehow, he doubted that.

"You've been offered a transfer to the Security Service — more money and fast track development."

MI5 welcoming someone from the SSU — now he'd heard everything. He read the letter. There was no small print, but that didn't mean it wasn't there. "And Karl?"

She shook her head. "I did ask them. There's too much bad blood there — that's all I was told. You don't have to decide today. I wouldn't leave it too long though. No one's star rises forever and this would be a good career move."

He eased out of his chair at the 'c' word and remembered one of his own. "I think they've mistaken me for someone else. I'm a civilian."

* * *

Karl stood outside Main Building, a short distance away from the smokers, shuffling his feet. “You turned them down, didn’t you?”

“Jesus, you really do work in intelligence. Is there anything about me you don’t know?”

“Lines of communication, my friend. Did I mention that I’m Eva’s handler now? I must be going up in the world. What’s it to be then, Thomas, back to the office or coffee in the park?”

He felt for the ring box in his pocket. “I’ll see you back at base. There’s something I need to do first — a prior engagement.”

THE END

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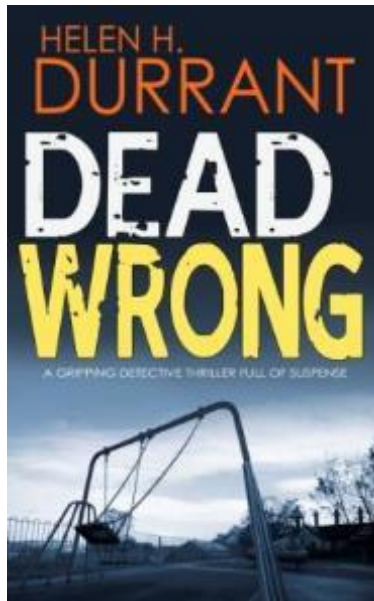
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First a shooting, then a grisly discovery on the common . . .

Police partners, DI Calladine and DS Ruth Bayliss race against time to track down a killer before the whole area erupts in violence. Their boss thinks it's all down to drug lord Ray Fallon, but Calladine's instincts say something far nastier is happening on the Hobfield housing estate.

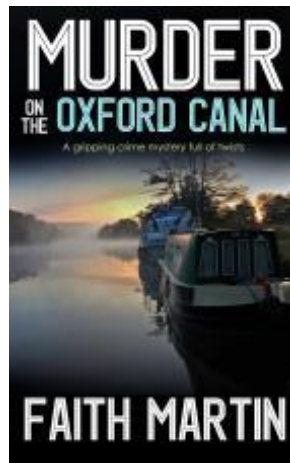
Can this duo track down the murderer before anyone else dies and before the press publicize the gruesome crimes? Detectives Calladine and Bayliss are led on a trail which gets dangerously close to home. In a thrilling finale they race against time to rescue someone very close to Calladine's heart.

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MEET DI HILLARY GREENE, A POLICEWOMAN FIGHTING TO SAVE HER CAREER.

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Then a bashed and broken body is found floating in the Oxford Canal. It looks like the victim fell off a boat, but Hillary is not so sure. Her investigation exposes a dark background to the death.

Can Hillary clear her name and get to the bottom of a fiendish conspiracy on the water?



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A NEW CRIME THRILLER WITH A COMPELLING DETECTIVE WHO WILL STOP AT NOTHING TO AVENGE HER DAUGHTER

THE DETECTIVE DI Nikki Galena: A police detective with nothing left to lose, she's seen a girl die in her arms, and her daughter will never leave the hospital again. She's got tough on the criminals she believes did this to her. Too tough. And now she's been given one final warning: make it work with her new sergeant, DS Joseph Easter, or she's out.

HER PARTNER DS Joseph Easter is the handsome squeaky-clean new member of the team. But his nickname "Holy Joe" belies his former life as a soldier. He has an estranged daughter who blames him for everything that went wrong with their family.

THEIR ADVERSARY is a ruthless man who holds DI Galena responsible for his terrible disfigurement.

The town is being terrorized by gangs of violent thugs, all wearing identical hideous masks.

Then a talented young female student goes missing on the marsh and Nikki and Joseph find themselves joining forces with a master criminal in their efforts to save her. They need to look behind the masks, but when they do, they find something more sinister and deadly than they ever expected . .

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THE SETTING The Lincolnshire Fens: great open skies brood over marshes, farmland, and nature reserves. It is not easy terrain for the Fenland Constabulary to police, due to the distances between some of the remote Fen villages, the dangerous and often misty lanes, and the poor telephone coverage. There are still villages where the oldest residents have never set foot outside their own

farmland and a visit to the nearest town is a major event. But it has a strange airy beauty to it, and above it all are the biggest skies you've ever seen.

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Perfect for fans of Rachel Abbott, Robert Bryndza, Mel Sherratt, Angela Marsons, Colin Dexter, or Ruth Rendell.

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Glossary of English Slang for US readers

A & E: Accident and emergency department in a hospital

Aggro: Violent behaviour, aggression

Air raid: an attack in which bombs are dropped from aircraft on ground targets

Anorak: nerd (it also means a waterproof jacket)

Artex: textured plaster finish for walls and ceilings

A Level: exams taken between 16 and 18

Auld Reekie: Edinburgh

Badger-baiting: illegal sport where badgers are drawn from their setts and killed by dogs

Barm: bread roll

Barney: argument

Beaker: glass or cup for holding liquids

Beemer: BMW car or motorcycle

Benefits: social security

Bent: corrupt

Bin: wastebasket (noun), or throw in rubbish (verb)

Biscuit: cookie

Bloke: guy

Blow: cocaine

Blower: telephone

Bob: money

Bobby: policeman

Brass monkeys: cold, as in cold enough to freeze the balls off a brass monkey

Brown bread: rhyming slang for dead

Bun: small cake

Bunk: do a bunk means escape

Burger bar: hamburger fast-food restaurant

Buy-to-let: Buying a house/apartment to rent it out for profit

Charity Shop: thrift store

Carrier bag: plastic bag from supermarket

Care Home: an institution where old people are cared for
Car park: parking lot
Chat-up: flirt, trying to pick up someone with witty banter or compliments
Chemist: pharmacy
Chinwag: conversation
Chippie: fast food place selling chips and other fried food
Chips: French fries but thicker
CID: Criminal Investigation Department
Civvy Street: civilian life (as opposed to army)
Cling film: plastic wrap for food
Clock: punch
Cock and bull: made up/ nonsense
Cock up: mess up, make a mistake
Common: an area of park land/ or lower class
Comprehensive School (Comp.): High school
Cop hold of: grab
Copper: police officer
Coverall: coveralls, or boiler suit
CPS: Crown Prosecution Service, decide whether police cases go forward
Childminder: someone who looks after children for money
Council: local government
Dan Dare: hero from Eagle comic
Deck: one of the landings on a floor of a tower block
Deck: hit (verb)
Desperate Dan: very strong comic book character
DI: detective inspector
Digestive biscuit: plain cookie
Do a runner: disappear
Do one: go away
Doc Martens: Heavy boots with an air-cushioned sole
Donkey's years: long time
DS: detective sergeant
ED: accident and emergency department of hospital
Eagle: boys' comic
Early dart: to leave work early
Eggy soldiers: strips of toast with a boiled egg

Enforcer: police battering ram
Estate: public/social housing estate (similar to housing projects)
Estate agent: realtor (US)
Falklands War: war between Britain and Argentina in 1982
Fag: cigarette
Filth: police (insulting)
Forces: army, navy, and air force
FMO: force medical officer
Fried slice: fried bread
Fuzz: police
Garda: Irish police
Geordie: from Newcastle
Garden Centre: a business where plants and gardening equipment are sold
Gob: mouth/ can also mean phlegm or spit
GP: general practitioner, a doctor based in the community
Graft: hard work
Gran: grandmother
Granny flat: self-contained part of house used as accommodation for elderly relative
Habdabs: extreme anxiety
Hancock: Tony Hancock, English comedian popular in 1950s
Hard nut: tough person
Hare coursing: illegal (in the UK) country sport involving the pursuit of hares by greyhounds or other dogs
HGV: heavy goods vehicle, truck
HOLMES: UK police computer system used during investigation of major incidents
Home: care home for elderly or sick people
Inne: isn't he
Interpol: international police organisation
Into care: a child taken away from their family by the social services
Iron Lady: Margaret Thatcher, applied to any strong woman
ITU: intensive therapy unit in hospital
JCB: a mechanical excavator
Jerry-built: badly made
Lad: young man

Lass: young woman

Lift: elevator

Lord Lucan: famous aristocrat who allegedly killed his children's nanny and disappeared in 1974. Has never been found.

Lorry: a truck

Luftwaffe: German air force

Miss Marple: detective in a series of books by Agatha Christie

MOD: ministry of defence

Mobile phone: cell phone

MP: Member of Parliament, politician representing an area

Naff: lame, not good

National Service: compulsory UK military service, ended in 60s

Net curtains: a type of semi-transparent curtain

NHS: National Health Service, public health service of UK

Nick: police station (as verb: to arrest)

Nowt: nothing

Nutter: insane person

Nursery: a place which grows plants, shrubs and trees for sale (often wholesale)

Old bag: old woman (insulting)

Old Bill: police

Owt: anything

Pants: noun: underwear adjective: bad/rubbish/terrible

Para: paratrooper

Pay-as-you-go: a cell phone you pay for calls in advance

PC: police constable

Petrol: gasoline

Pillbox: a concrete building, partly underground, used as an outpost defence

Pillock: fool

Piss off: as exclamation, go away (rude). Also can mean annoy.

Pissing down: raining

Playing field: sports field

Pleb: ordinary person (often insulting)

Portakabin: portable building used as temporary office etc.

Post: mail

Planning Department: the local authority department which issues licences to build and develop property

PNC: police national computer

PSNI: police service of Northern Ireland

Prat: silly idiot

Premier League: top English soccer division

Public Analyst: scientists who perform chemical analysis for public protection purposes

RAF: Royal Air Force

Rag: newspaper

Ram-raiding: robbery where a vehicle is rammed through a shop window

Randy: horny

Recce: reconnaissance

Red Adair: famous oil well firefighter

Resus: resuscitation room

Right state: messy

Ring: telephone (verb)

Roadworks: repairs done to roads

Roofie: A Rohypnol tablet, used to knock people out

RSPB: Royal Society for the Protection of Birds

RTC: road traffic collision

RV: rendezvous point

Royal Engineers: British army corps dealing with military engineering etc.

Rugger: rugby (posh American football)

Sarge: sergeant

SCO19: Specialist Crime and Operations Specialist Firearms Command

Scrote: low life

Semi: Semi-detached house, house with another house joined to it on one side only

Shedload: a large amount

Shout the odds: talk in a loud bossy way

Sixth-form college: school for high school students in final two years.

SIO: senior investigating officer

Skip: a large open container used for building waste

Slapper: slag

Smackhead: heroin addict

Snout: police informer
SOCO: scene-of-crime officer
Sod: an annoying person
Sort: to do or make
Solicitor: lawyer
Sparky: electrician
Spook: spy
Squaddie: a soldier of low rank
Stunner: beautiful woman
Super: superintendent (police rank)
Surveyor: someone who examines land and buildings professionally
Sweeting: endearment, like sweetheart
Tabloid: newspaper
Tea: Dinner (Northern English)
Tea towel: drying cloth
Till: cash register
Tip: a mess
Tipsy: a bit drunk
Top himself: commit suicide
Torch: flashlight
Totty: attractive woman
Trumpton: derogatory name for the fire service, often used by police
Tutor: university teacher
Tower block: tall building containing apartments (usually social housing)
Upmarket: affluent or fancy
Wacky baccy: cannabis
Wally: silly person
War Cry: Salvation Army magazine
Wash: the washing machine
Water board: company supplying water to an area
White van man: typical working-class man who drives a small truck
Widow's weeds: black clothes worn by a widow in mourning
Wilco: will comply i.e. yes
Wool-gathering: daydreaming
Yellowbelly: native of Lincolnshire
Yob: a rude or aggressive youth or person

Yorkie bar: type of chocolate bar